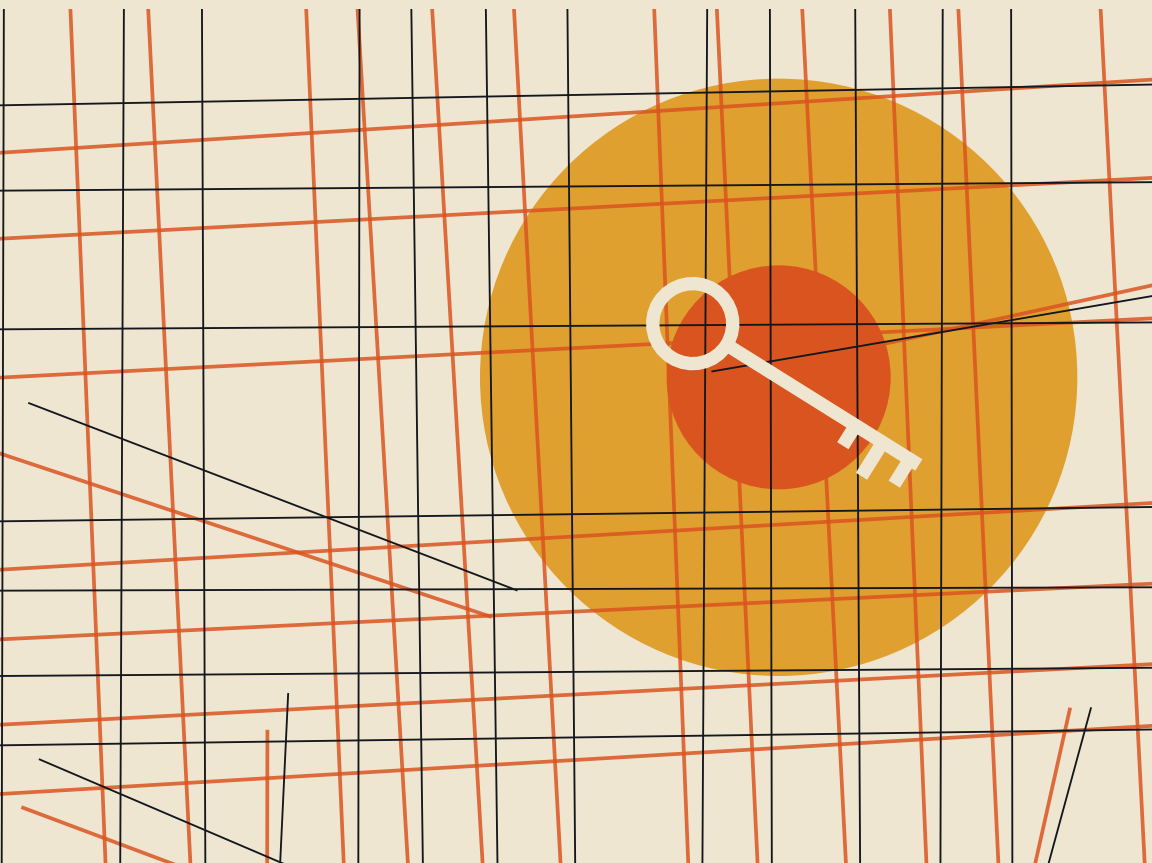

GAJENDRA THAKUR



THE OTHER SIDE OF MEMORY

A COLLECTION OF 98 SHORT STORIES

VIDEHA

THE OTHER SIDE OF MEMORY

A Collection of 98 Short Stories

Gajendra Thakur

Translated from Original Maithili into English by the author himself

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The Other Side of Memory · 98 Short Stories

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CONTENTS

Stories 1-98 · Title and Opening Page

NO.	TITLE	P.
1	Two Janakpurs	5
2	The Forgotten Disputation	11
3	The Pond of Time	17
4	The City of Letters	24
5	The Final Annotation	30
6	The Map That Kept Growing	37
7	One Writer, Two Births	44
8	A Dictionary of Memory	50
9	The Zero Chapter	54
10	The Copyist	60
11	The Third History	67
12	The Translator	76
13	The Nameless Deity	85
14	The Path of Time	96
15	The Lineage of Mirrors	108
16	The Invisible Book	118
17	The Seventh Direction	133
18	The Last Reader	144
19	The Incident at the Pond	158
20	Night at the Court	172
21	The Stolen Idol	190
22	The Shot at the Border	208
23	The Marriage Dispute	226
24	The Flood Boat	251
25	The Painter's Death	259
26	The Old Lawsuit	281
27	The Night of the Fair	308
28	The Hero's Tale	338
29	The Last Meal	361
30	The Poet and the King	380
31	The Accident at the Turn	394
32	The Prize for a Lie	411
33	The Village Fire	426
34	Across the River	441
35	The Mason's Fall	459
36	The Old Photograph	471
37	The Voice in the Night	482
38	Whose Fault?	492
39	The Scent of Makhana	505
40	Yellow Flowers	516
41	The Afternoon Table	527
42	Kohl	537
43	The New Curtain	542
44	Fragrance	548
45	The Silver Bowl	554
46	Drying Her Hair	559
47	White Flowers	565
48	A Small Party	570
49	The Silken Scarf	575

No.	TITLE	P.
50	Rain at the Window	580
51	The Taste of Lemon	586
52	The Pink Cup	591
53	The Scent of Sunlight	596
54	The Earring	600
55	Red Nail Polish	606
56	The Sheer Curtain	613
57	Cardamom	620
58	The Flower Vase	629
59	The Dry Kamala	637
60	The House of Sand	650
61	The Sound of Bamboo	665
62	The Dusty Footpath	681
63	The Empty Pond	700
64	Erosion	716
65	The Scent of Earth	732
66	The Roofless House	750
67	The River Spoke	771
68	The Cave-In	790
69	The Field of Kans Grass	806
70	The Dust of Tirhut	827
71	Three Graves	850
72	The Marks of the Flood	867
73	The Abandoned Well	889
74	Dried Maize Leaves	902
75	The Last Boat	921
76	The Tree Stump	939
77	Smoke	954
78	The Silent Village	963
79	Between Three Years	973
80	The Reason to Return	982
81	The Sisters	992
82	The Old Doctor	1002
83	House Number Five	1010
84	The Photo Album	1016
85	A Decision	1022
86	A Friend's Daughter	1029
87	The Bus Stop	1035
88	After the Marriage	1041
89	Mother's Friend	1046
90	The Letter That Was Never Sent	1051
91	Two Cities	1057
92	Twenty Years Later	1063
93	Aunt's House	1071
94	The Red Trunk	1078
95	The Music Teacher	1086
96	A Separate Road	1092
97	The Lost Year	1098
98	The Final Journey	1103

Two Janakpurs

When Amresh Jha arrived in Janakpur, the first thing he bought was not a bottle of water, not prasad, not flowers - but a paper map.

Outside the railway station, religious pictures, booklets on Janakpurdham, bus timetables, and brightly coloured maps hung from a small roadside stall. Amresh had long been accustomed to finding his way on paper. Two months before her death, his mother, Kamala Devi, had handed him an old envelope and said, "If you ever go to Janakpur, go and see my house once. If you cannot find the house, at least see the road by which I used to go to school."

There was no complete address on the envelope. In black ink it said only: "The lane behind the old Kanak Temple, left at the big peepal tree, across Chunariwali Gali, the third door from the corner of the pond." A small brass key had been taped beneath the words. Amresh had asked his mother many times what the key belonged to. Kamala Devi would smile each time and say, "Let the door be found before the key."

The stallkeeper folded the map and handed it to him. Printed at the top were the words: "Janakpurdham City Map - wards, main roads, temples, ponds, public buildings." The moment Amresh opened the sheet, he stopped short.

There were two cities on the same page.

The Janakpur drawn in black lines was precise - ward boundaries, broad roads, squares, schools, a hospital, the railway station, ponds. But over it spread another shape in faint ochre lines. That shape had no ward numbers. Instead, it bore names such as "the big peepal tree," "Sukhdev's well," "Chunariwali Gali," "the turn where three bells can be heard," "the edge of the old pond," "a wooden bridge stood here," "Madhavi's veranda," and "the children's playground." The ochre Janakpur had slipped slightly to the southwest of the black one, like the shadow of the same city creeping along a wall as the day declined.

"What is this second colour?" Amresh asked the stallkeeper.

The man pushed his spectacles up onto his forehead and examined the map. "Ah! How did this old printing get here? This is the map from the memory survey."

"Memory survey?"

"Some years ago, the old residents of the city were asked how they used to go from their homes to the temple, the market, the pond, the school. People drew the routes as they remembered them. Later, the survey people laid all those lines over the black map. They used to say: one city on the ground, another in people's minds."

The stallkeeper laughed. "It was not meant for sale. My son brought home a bundle of old papers. If you like, I can give you another, clean map."

Amresh fixed his eyes again on the ochre lines. There was the "big peepal tree." There was "Chunariwali Gali." There was the "corner of the pond." All three clues

from his mother's envelope existed in that second Janakpur; not one appeared in the black one.

"No," he said. "Let me keep this one."

Amresh spent the first half of the day in the black Janakpur. He found the new gate of the old temple his mother had named. The road behind it was now divided in two. Where the big peepal tree had stood were a chemist's shop and a two-storeyed house. No one knew the name Chunariwali Gali. A paan seller said he had kept his shop there for fifteen years and had never heard such a name.

Amresh could locate himself exactly on the black map, yet with every step he seemed to move farther from his mother's Janakpur.

By noon he had reached the ward office. When he asked about an old house, a clerk turned the pages of a register. Kamala Devi's natal family entry - "Jha, originally of Saurath, resident of Janakpur" - appeared in several old tax registers, but the house number had later been changed. When the road was widened, the boundaries of many houses had been redrawn. Showing him a page in a thick file, the clerk said, "Old number 47-A. This section is now divided into 127, 128, and a public road. If the house still exists at all, you will not find it in its old form."

Amresh touched the brass key in his pocket. Its small teeth were worn down. For the first time it occurred to him that his mother had perhaps known the door would not be found. Then why had she given him the key?

Outside the ward office, he opened the map again. The black lines told him where he stood in the present; the ochre lines seemed to ask him a question. He turned toward the ochre "big peepal tree."

According to the map, the chemist's shop stood where the peepal tree had been. Yet beside the shop's rear wall, a thick root protruded from the ground. Cement had been poured all around it, but part of the root remained black, smooth, and rounded. The shopkeeper said, "There used to be an old tree here. It was cut down when I was a child. The root was never taken out."

"Where would Chunariwali Gali have been from here?" Amresh asked.

The shopkeeper did not answer at once. An old woman selling vegetables across the way had overheard him. She stopped the scales in her hand and looked at Amresh's map.

"Chunariwali Gali?" she said. "Whose house are you looking for?"

"Kamala Jha. Her father's name was Shivkant Jha."

The old woman's eyes narrowed slightly. "Kamli? The one who walked so fast? Always ahead of everyone on the way to school?"

Amresh's throat went dry. "She was my mother."

The old woman said to the girl sitting beside her, "Mind the stall for ten minutes." Then she took the map from Amresh's hand. "This paper is all right, but do not read it as though it were the ground."

Her name was Savitri Devi. Leaving the main road, she led Amresh into a narrow lane. The actual lane did not turn in the direction in which the ochre line bent on the map. Amresh stopped.

"The map says left."

Savitri Devi laughed. "It was left in those days. The road is no longer straight."

"The road changed?"

"The road changed, and people's eyes changed too. Look here."

She stopped before a cloth shop. Under the awning, one old wooden post survived; the rest of the shop was new. "Chunaris used to be dyed here. The lane may have had some other official name on paper, but everyone called it Chunariwali Gali. Your mother used to go to school by this way."

Amresh placed his finger on the ochre words "Chunariwali Gali." On the black map, a broad road occupied the same place, now named after a new political figure.

At a turn farther on, Savitri Devi stopped. "Listen here."

Amresh stood silent for a few moments. From far away came the bells of a temple - twice at first, then, after a short interval, a third time.

"The map says, 'the turn where three bells can be heard,'" Amresh said softly.

"Yes. You see? The distance on paper can change; the distance of sound changes too when buildings rise. But people used to recognise this place by that sound."

The ochre Janakpur no longer seemed magical to him. It was not a city of measurement; it was a city of people's routes, smells, sounds, shade, habits, and relationships. Yet one question remained: whose memory had made the ochre Janakpur on this map? Everyone's? Or that of one person?

Savitri Devi said that she too had drawn her routes during the memory survey. "They gave each of us a separate sheet. They said: from home to Janak Temple, from home to school, from home to the market - close your eyes and draw it as you remember it. Later they put all the lines together. Who knows whose line went where?"

"Did Kamala Devi submit one too?"

The old woman thought for a moment. "She was no longer living here then. But the survey people did send sheets once to old families who had settled elsewhere as well. I seem to remember seeing Kamli's name on the list."

A new urgency suddenly rose within Amresh. If one of the lines in the ochre city had been drawn by his mother, which line was it? He was no longer merely looking for a house; he wanted to know how Kamala Devi had remembered her Janakpur.

Savitri Devi gave him the name of a municipal library employee - Madhav Lal. For several years the old survey papers had been kept in the library storeroom.

The library occupied half of an old mansion. Madhav Lal was a thin elderly man who nodded as soon as he heard Amresh's question. "The memory maps? People have forgotten that project now. The report was never published. The budget was stopped. But the original sheets were not thrown away."

He brought out two dust-covered boxes from inside. A year was written on each lid. Within lay papers from different families, serial numbers, brief notes, lines in coloured pencil, and, here and there, circles drawn by trembling hands.

Amresh began turning the pages one by one while Madhav Lal went through the list of names. About half an hour later he said, "Here it is - Kamala Jha, Darbhanga address, respondent number J-27."

The sheet was placed before him. Amresh recognised his mother's handwriting at once. These were not the trembling letters of her final years on the envelope; they were straight, quick, and tilted slightly forward.

Kamala Devi had drawn three routes. The first, from home to school. The second, from home to the temple. The third, from home to the pond. What was strange was

that all three did not begin from the same point. On the school map, "home" stood near the big peepal tree. On the temple map, "home" lay inside Chunariwali Gali. On the pond map, "home" was nearly two lanes away from both.

Amresh looked at Madhav Lal. "Was this drawn incorrectly?"

Madhav Lal smiled. "Who is to make the scale by which errors in memory are measured?"

In one corner of the sheet was the surveyor's note: "Respondent said: if you ask me where home is, there are three answers. Father's house, Mother's courtyard, and the doorway through which I went out."

Amresh read that line for a long time.

Certain familiar facts from his mother's life returned to him. Kamala Devi's marriage had not been against the family's wishes, but it had taken place in haste. After the wedding she moved to Darbhanga. Her ties with her natal home did not break, but they slowly thinned. When Amresh, as a child, would ask to visit Janakpur, his mother would say, "Someday." He understood that "someday" differently now: home had not survived in one place, and perhaps Kamala Devi had been unable to decide which home to show her son.

There was also a fourth sheet in J-27's papers. The question read: "One place in the city that no longer exists, yet still exists for you?" Kamala Devi had written: "The afternoon shade on Mother's veranda. It has no address."

Madhav Lal said quietly, "The ochre city you see on the composite map is not an average of everyone's lines. In places where many people gave different locations, all the lines were retained. That is why the same peepal tree appears in two places, and the same pond in three shapes. Later the project team said it was not a scientific map. So the printing was stopped."

"But it isn't false either," Amresh said.

Madhav Lal did not answer. He simply slipped the J-27 sheet into a transparent sleeve and pushed it toward him.

Evening was beginning to fall. Amresh went back to the neighbourhood with Savitri Devi. This time he looked less often at the black map. He walked with the three lines of J-27 held in his mind.

The probable site of the old house was now divided into three parts - a cloth warehouse, a family's new house, and a public road running between them. Savitri Devi said, "Kamli's mother's veranda may have been here." She stopped beside the outer wall of the new house. An old stone slab, half buried in the earth, lay against the wall.

"Did this belong to that house?" Amresh asked.

"I cannot say. Many houses in this neighbourhood had slabs like this."

Amresh liked the answer. He had spent the whole day searching for proof; for the first time, uncertainty did not disappoint him.

A woman came out of the new house. Savitri Devi introduced Amresh. When the woman heard that he was Kamala Devi's son, she went inside and brought out her mother-in-law. The old woman was very aged. The moment she heard Kamala's name, she said, "The one who was so good at mathematics? The girl who used to circle by the pond on her way home to escape her mother's scolding?"

Amresh burst out laughing. All her life, his mother had told him that she used to come straight home from school.

The old woman laughed too. "No mother tells her son every truth."

She went inside and returned with a small piece of an old wooden doorframe. "When the houses were demolished, some wood was left behind. I cannot say whose house this came from. But I did not feed it to the stove. It looked like wood from an old threshold."

Amresh took out the brass key and laid it on the wood. There was no proven connection between the two objects. The key opened no lock. The wood established no door. Yet in that moment he heard his mother's words again: "Let the door be found before the key."

Perhaps the door was not made of wood.

"Do you recognise this key?" he asked the old woman.

She turned the key over in her hand. "It could have belonged to an old trunk, a cupboard, anything. Kamli's mother had many keys like this. But I do not know which lock this one opened."

Amresh put the key back in his pocket. His urge to discover its use suddenly diminished. The key was no longer evidence; it was a question - and a question had its own value.

Before catching the night train, he went once more to the stallkeeper. The man recognised him from a distance. "Did you find the two Janakpurs?"

Amresh unfolded the map. From a day's folding and unfolding, a white crease now ran through its centre. The black city and the ochre city seemed to have slipped apart on either side of that line.

"I found a road," Amresh said.

"The black one or the ochre one?"

Instead of answering, Amresh folded the paper slowly - first north to south, then diagonally. The fold fell in such a way that the ochre "big peepal tree" came close to the chemist's shop on the black map, "Chunariwali Gali" touched the edge of the new broad road, and the "corner of the pond" slipped behind a modern building. The two Janakpurs did not coincide perfectly. Some lines still crossed one another; in places, blank paper remained between them.

In those blank spaces, Amresh remembered his mother's handwriting: "The afternoon shade on Mother's veranda. It has no address."

Sitting in the railway station waiting room, he opened the map on his lap. Around him, people asked about their destinations, guarded their tickets, and children chattered. The black map told Amresh which ward he was in. The ochre map told him how many songs, how many bells, how many patches of shade away someone's home might once have been.

Amresh felt for the key in his pocket. It was still with him. He did not place it anywhere on the map, did not mark any point. He simply folded the paper again and put it away with the envelope.

When the train moved, the Janakpur outside the window slowly began to recede. The black city on the map corresponded to that visible geography. The ochre city could be seen nowhere outside.

But when a distant temple bell sounded three times, Amresh suddenly understood where the other Janakpur was. It was not shut inside the map, nor did it exist only in his mother's mind. It lived in the paths that moved among people, paths whose distances were measured not in footsteps, but in remembrance.

Amresh ran his finger along the fold in the paper. The two cities remained separate, yet along that thin crease they touched each other.

The Forgotten Disputation

Nilima Jha had learned to recognise rain by the smell of old paper. Even when the sky outside was clear, if the smell in the archive room suddenly grew heavy, she knew the humidity had risen and it was time to check the window joints again.

She repaired paper in an old manuscript collection in Rajnagar. Her work was less about reading authors' names than preserving the bodies of pages - securing an insect-eaten corner, laying a strip of tissue-thin repair paper across a torn fold, drying a place where ink had spread, and mending a page split in two so that the join remained visible but the wound would not tear again.

One morning in the monsoon month of Sawan, water seeped through the back wall of the storeroom. The staff were shifting boxes. Nilima lifted a small wooden casket from a lower shelf. Its lid had swollen; on the top, in blurred ink, only the word "Disputation" could be read.

Inside lay a thirty-two-page manuscript wrapped in cloth. The paper was thick, grey, and brittle at the edges. On the first page, within a red border, was the title: "A Consideration of Water Rights." Beneath it, in Sanskrit mixed with Maithili, it was written that two scholars at the Kamala Ghat chatuspathi had held a disputation over the right to obstruct the course of water.

Nilima laughed when she read the title. The collection contained many manuscripts with names of that ponderous sort. But after two pages her laughter stopped.

The first side in the disputation argued: whoever owns the land owns the right to block the channel. The second side asked: if the water from that channel crosses five fields to reach a sixth, how can ownership of the water's route be decided by a land deed alone?

Then came question after question. Who cleans the channel? Whose field will be flooded if it is blocked? Whose soil will be cut away if it is opened? Who receives the benefit? Who bears the burden of maintenance? If everyone's water passes through the boundary of one household, are the rights of boundary and flow the same thing, or two different things?

What surprised Nilima was not that an old manuscript concerned a dispute over water. What surprised her was that neither side seemed intent on defeating the other. From time to time the "presiding scholar" seated between them would stop the argument and say, "First make the question clear."

A date was written on the final page - Samvat 1891. Beneath it were two names: Pandit Ratneshwar and Pandit Shivdatt. Nilima pencilled a question mark beside the names. She did not remember seeing either in the collection's old catalogues.

That afternoon Devesh Mandal came to the archive. Devesh was Nilima's maternal cousin and worked as an accounts assistant in the Kanakpur panchayat. He needed a copy of an old land map.

"Has the quarrel over the channel started again in Kanakpur?" Nilima asked while searching for the map.

In a tired voice Devesh said, "It is no longer just a quarrel. Two hamlets are facing each other now. An old watercourse used to pass through Ramlochan Babu's land. He has blocked it. He says it is his land. The farmers beyond it say that when the rains come, water will stand here while the paddy over there dries."

Nilima involuntarily looked toward the manuscript lying on the table.

Devesh caught the glance. "What did you find?"

"An old debate. The questions here are almost the same."

Devesh asked to read it. Nilima put gloves on him and showed him only two pages. He read slowly, then his eyes lit up. "This is remarkable. People were thinking about this two hundred years ago!"

"First we have to determine what the manuscript actually says, and how old it truly is," Nilima said. "A date written on paper is not proof."

Devesh nodded, but on his way out he photographed the title page with his phone. Nilima did not stop him at the time. Later she understood the weight of that small indulgence.

Two days later, a photograph was circulating through Kanakpur's messaging groups - the first page with its red border. Beneath it someone had written: "A two-hundred-year-old disputation from Mithila proves that no one has exclusive rights over a shared watercourse."

That evening Devesh called, his voice anxious. "Didi, I only showed it to the mukhiya. His son forwarded it. Now everyone is asking for the whole manuscript."

Nilima's first reaction was anger. Her second was fear. Her third - shame. Day after day in the manuscript room she preserved the broken joins of paper; today a half-read page was racing among people as though it were a complete verdict.

She did not go home that night. She opened the archive's old catalogues, donation registers, and the surviving records of the chatushpathi. There were three ledgers from the Kamala Ghat chatushpathi from around Samvat 1891. Names of students, grain donations, subjects of study, festivals, guests - much had been recorded. But there was no pandit named Ratneshwar. There were two Shividatts, and both were students.

Nilima called her colleague Jagdish Babu. He had worked in the collection for thirty-five years and had an extraordinary eye for recognising handwriting.

Jagdish Babu said as soon as he saw the manuscript from a distance, "The red border is in an old style, but this binding looks later."

He held the page under slanting light. The words of the two supposed speakers were written in different inks, but the slope of the letters, the tail of the 'r', and the belly of the 'k' were all from the same hand.

"Two scholars, one hand?" Nilima asked.

"There may have been only one scribe," Jagdish Babu said. "A copyist could have written down a disputation he heard. This proves nothing by itself."

Nilima liked that caution. Evidence did not deliver a quick verdict; it multiplied the questions.

For the next three days they checked references within the manuscript. At one point it mentioned "the eastern embankment of the new royal road." A road under that name appeared on old maps of the chatushpathi only in much later records.

Elsewhere, a commentator was named whose book was said to have been printed many years after the date written in the manuscript.

Nilima's suspicion deepened, yet the date on the final page still held her back. Why had a date been written there? If this was deception, who had benefited from it?

Meanwhile, the dispute in Kanakpur intensified. Ramlochan Chaudhary refused to remove the brick embankment he had built through the middle of his land. He said the old channel had silted up long ago; people now wanted to cut through his field for their own convenience.

On the other side, seven farmers, including Mahendra Mandal and Phulkumari Devi, said that after the channel was blocked, the first heavy rain had carried water right into their courtyards, while irrigation water could no longer reach the fields beyond Ramlochan's embankment.

The panchayat scheduled an open meeting for Saturday. Devesh called again. "Everyone wants you to bring the manuscript. Let the old disputation be heard."

"At this point I cannot even say that the disputation actually took place," Nilima replied.

"Then come and say that too."

Nilima remained silent. She understood that the people of Kanakpur were not looking for a manuscript; they were looking for proof. One side wanted to turn the old paper into a weapon for its position; the other wanted to prove the paper a forgery and make the whole question disappear.

On Friday evening, Nilima obtained permission to open the binding. A thick strip of paper, added at the back during an earlier repair, was slowly lifted. Beneath it lay a narrow portion of the original page that had been covered over.

In very small letters it read: "Imagined dialogue for practice in disputation." Two words after that were blurred, and then came a clear line: "So that the students may learn the order of questions."

Nilima leaned back in her chair. Jagdish Babu took off his spectacles and placed them on the table.

"Then it never happened," he said.

Nilima read the page again. "There is no evidence that a public disputation took place. This was a teaching exercise."

"The date?"

"It may be the date on which the exercise was written. Or it may be a later copy."

"And the two pandits?"

"They may be invented characters."

Jagdish Babu laughed softly. "This will greatly disappoint people who want to hear a particular thing."

Nilima reopened the pages in the middle of the manuscript. The questions remained the same - land, flow, harm, benefit, maintenance. The historical prestige of the paper had suddenly diminished; the questions still stood before her.

On Saturday, the veranda of the Kanakpur panchayat was crowded. Some people held up their phones to take pictures; others pressed forward to see the old paper. Nilima had not brought the manuscript itself. In accordance with conservation rules, she had brought a high-quality facsimile and her notes on the examination.

Opening the meeting, the mukhiya said, "Today we will hear the land papers, the survey, the old course of the water, and this old disputation."

Ramlochan Chaudhary spoke at once. "First it should be said whether this paper is authentic or not."

Mahendra Mandal objected. "If it is not authentic, why is it kept in an archive?"

Nilima raised a hand to stop both of them. "Not every paper preserved in an archive records a historical event. There are student exercises, copies, unfinished drafts, stories, accounts - all kinds of documents."

The noise on the veranda subsided.

Nilima explained, in order, how the manuscript had been found, what the handwriting showed, the later references within it, and finally the hidden line they had discovered under the repair strip. She said plainly, "According to my examination, there is no evidence that the disputation described here actually took place in public. The indications are rather that it was an invented dialogue prepared as an exercise for students."

For a few moments there was complete silence. Then Ramlochan's nephew laughed. "Then the matter is over. They were trying to claim my uncle's land with a false paper!"

Mahendra's face fell. He looked angrily at Devesh. Devesh lowered his eyes.

Nilima had thought that once she had said this much, her work was done. But then Phulkumari Devi, who had been sitting at the back, stood up. Dried soil from the fields clung to her sari.

"May I ask one thing?" she said, looking at Nilima. "Are the questions in the paper false too?"

Ramlochan's nephew said, "If the story is false, everything is false."

Phulkumari did not look at him. "I am asking: is it false to ask who used to clean the channel? Is it false to ask whose water will be stopped if it is blocked? Is it false to ask who receives the benefit and who will do the maintenance?"

Before Nilima could answer, the mukhiya said, "The questions can certainly be asked."

For the first time, Ramlochan Chaudhary spoke in a somewhat softer voice. "Ask them. But look at my land papers too."

That sentence changed the direction of the meeting. The demand that the old manuscript be treated as a "verdict" fell away; its four questions were written in one corner of a sheet of paper.

The first question: where had the old channel run? The panchayat surveyor opened an old map. The boundaries of the plots were clear, but the watercourse was shown by a dotted line passing through the middle of Ramlochan's khesra and then turning south.

The second question: who was harmed by the obstruction? Seven farmers gave their names. Ramlochan said that if he did not build the embankment, the rear of his house was eroded during the rains. Two young men from the panchayat undertook to measure the slope of the water the next day.

The third question: who used to clean the channel? This produced the greatest argument. Mahendra said, "Our grandfathers did." Ramlochan said, "People from our

household supplied labourers." Phulkumari intervened: "Then write both. Write separately what each person remembers."

Nilima listened. She remembered the presiding scholar in the manuscript: "First make the question clear." But she did not quote the line. It was no longer necessary.

The fourth question: if the channel were reopened, who would share the burden of maintaining it? This time the silence was long. For this question concerned not rights in the past, but labour in the future.

Ramlochan Chaudhary drummed his fingers on the table. At last he said, "If the survey establishes that the old channel ran through here, and if the panchayat makes some other arrangement to prevent my house from being damaged when the embankment is cut, I will not block it completely. But the burden of cleaning it will not be mine alone."

Mahendra rose at once to answer, but Phulkumari motioned him to sit down. "The fields that receive the water will contribute labour. The share of the house that is protected should be recognised too."

The meeting made no final decision about the land that day. They agreed to open a narrow section of the embankment for three days and observe the movement of the water. Responsibilities were assigned for recording the survey, the slope, and the risk of erosion.

As people began to rise, Devesh came over to Nilima. "Didi, I made a mistake."

"By sending the photograph?"

"By letting a half-read thing travel as if it were the whole truth."

Nilima said, "That is the difficulty with paper. Half a page often travels faster than anyone's wish to know the whole."

As Phulkumari was leaving, she turned back. "What was the final decision in that old manuscript, then?"

Nilima smiled. "There is no complete decision. At the end the presiding scholar writes the questions down again."

Phulkumari smiled too. "Then the writer was wise. If he had written a decision, people would have fought over it. He left the questions instead."

On Monday, Nilima returned to the archive and changed the catalogue note for the manuscript. It had previously read: "Kamala Ghat Disputation, Samvat 1891." She did not strike out the old entry; she preserved it and added a new note: "Strong indications that this is an imagined dialogue prepared for instructional practice; no independent evidence for the public disputation described."

Below that she briefly listed the four questions, but she did not name the dispute in Kanakpur. It did not seem right to turn an archival paper into a memorial of a present quarrel.

Three days later Devesh came again. This time he carried no government file, only a page from an ordinary school exercise book.

"Phulkumari Devi gave me this," he said.

Four questions were written on the page in different hands. The first line, in thick letters: "Where will the water go?" The second: "Who is harmed if it is blocked?" The third: "Who will clean it?" The fourth: "How will benefit and burden be shared?"

There was no one's name beneath them. No Ratneshwar, no Shividatt, no presiding scholar. Only a crooked line drawn in a child's pencil along the margin, as though marking the course of a stream.

"After the meeting, the schoolteacher asked the children to draw the route of water through their village," Devesh said. "This page is from that exercise."

Nilima did not take the page in her hand. She looked instead at the old manuscript on the table, whose repaired tear at the back had now dried.

It was possible that the two-hundred-year-old disputation had never taken place. It was possible that its two scholars had never existed in anyone's life. And yet the questions set down in a student's exercise had crossed the age of the paper and arrived here - not as a verdict, not as proof.

Nilima raised her pencil to write the date in the corner of the new page, then stopped. This page did not belong to the archive; it belonged to Kanakpur's present.

She returned the page to Devesh and said, "Keep it where the course of the water is being measured."

Devesh asked, "Not with the old manuscript?"

Nilima shook her head. "No. The old paper will remain here with its mistake. Let the new questions remain where their answers will keep changing."

Outside the window, clouds were gathering again. Nilima rose to close the archive window. On the table, the pages of "A Consideration of Water Rights" lay still; in Kanakpur, not very far away, the course of a stream was being measured.

The Pond of Time

Eight years later, Mridula stood beside the pond at her maternal home as though the years in between had been dropped somewhere along the road.

Dawn had not yet fully spread. The eastern sky was a pale grey, and the water of the pond silently held that greyness. Three old steps on the western ghat had gone green with moss. As a child, Mridula used to sit on those steps and count the tiny fish. New concrete houses now cast their shadows along the banks, but over the middle of the pond the sky was still open.

She held a small brass water-pot in her hand. The night before, Janaki Mami had said, "You needn't bathe at dawn, but do go and see the pond. The last time your mother came to this ghat, she sat here with me for a very long while."

Mridula's mother had died three months earlier. After the shraddha rites, there still remained the work of going through the house papers, the old utensils, clothes, and the locked rooms. Mridula's job in Darbhanga, her son Aditya's studies, and the routines of everyday life had pushed grief into the spaces between small tasks. But after coming here and spending a night in her mother's courtyard, grief had returned to occupy her whole body.

She went down to the first step and bent to fill the pot. The water was perfectly still.

And then, instead of her own face, she saw an old woman.

Mridula's hand stopped in mid-air.

The woman's hair was half white. She sat on a wooden cot in an unfamiliar courtyard. Two cups of tea stood before her. A girl - no, a young woman of twenty or twenty-two - was laughing as she said something. The older woman laughed too. Somehow Mridula knew that the old woman was herself.

The scene was not in the depths of the pond but on its surface; yet in place of the sky there was a house. Pillars of a veranda, a tulsi altar, a blue clock on the wall. Mridula recognised the young woman's face - Taru, Nachiket's daughter. Taru, now twelve, was grown up there.

For a moment the scene felt so intimate that something softened inside Mridula's chest. Then her eyes moved to the photographs hanging on the wall behind the cot. Three photographs. In one were Mridula and Nachiket. In another, Taru. The third frame seemed empty; perhaps light was falling on the glass. Aditya was nowhere.

Mridula jerked backward. The pot slipped onto the step with a clang. The sound shivered through the water, and everything broke apart.

Now the surface held her present face - sleep-heavy eyes, hair fallen across her forehead, her mouth open in fear.

She sat on the step for a long time. She touched the water with her palm. It was ordinarily cold. A tiny fish darted away from the edge. Above her, an egret flew past.

"Tiredness," she told herself. "I didn't sleep last night. The eyes see what the mind is thinking."

Yet all that day Taru's grown-up face would not leave her mind.

Nachiket's proposal had remained open for three months. It was less a formal discussion of marriage than an understanding slowly taking shape between two adults. Nachiket worked at a branch of a cooperative bank in Madhubani. His wife had died five years earlier. Taru was his only daughter. Mridula's husband, Vimal, had died in a road accident eight years ago. Aditya had been seven then; now he was fifteen.

At first, people in both families saw an easy solution: "They're both alone, and both have children. Life will go on." The sentence irritated Mridula. Life was not merely something to be kept going. And a child was not something to be added as an afterthought with an "and there's a child too."

Nachiket seemed to understand that. He had said, "Don't decide in a hurry. Let the children get to know each other first."

That was one reason Mridula had not given a definite answer either. She liked Nachiket - his measured way of speaking, his orderly habits with accounts, and the fact that he did not hide his dead wife away. But liking someone and spending a life under one roof were not the same thing.

Aditya had never spoken a full sentence on the subject. "It's your life," he would say, and then open a book.

That afternoon, while opening her mother's locked room, Mridula found two of Vimal's letters in an old trunk. They were from the first year of their marriage. Vimal had gone to Patna for training. In one letter he had written, "A house becomes a home when you want to return to it." Mridula folded the page and slipped it back into the same envelope.

In the evening Aditya called from Darbhanga. He had been unable to come to his maternal grandmother's house because of his examinations.

"Mami said you spent the whole day going through things," Aditya said.

"Yes. Your grandmother wrapped everything in paper. Even broken cups."

"The one with the green rim?"

"I found that too."

For a few moments neither spoke. Mridula wanted to tell him about the pond, but the idea sounded ridiculous even to her.

"Aditya," she said at last, "what do you honestly think about Nachiket Babu?"

The silence on the other end lengthened.

"Have you already decided?"

"No."

"Then what should I say?"

"Whatever is in your mind."

Aditya said slowly, "I don't think he's a bad person."

"But?"

"But if you get married, where will I live?"

Mridula was startled. "With me."

"Where? Madhubani? Darbhanga? His house? Will I have to change schools? Where will Papa's books go? And what will Taru call me? What will I call her?"

The questions were so ordinary that Mridula felt ashamed. For three months she had been thinking about marriage in large words - love, companionship, society,

loneliness. Aditya was thinking about it in terms of rooms, books, and what people would call one another.

"No one will force you to call anyone anything," she said.

"You say that. But people will."

"Let them."

Aditya laughed faintly. "You really do believe yourself when you say you don't care what people think."

The sentence stung Mridula, because it was not entirely wrong.

That night she wrote Nachiket a short message: "I feel it may be better not to take this further. It could be difficult for the children." She stared at what she had written for a long time, then sent it.

Nachiket replied half an hour later: "All right. Whatever feels right to you. But if you think it appropriate, perhaps all of us should sit together once and speak openly. Not to change the decision - only to remove what is unclear."

Mridula did not reply.

The next morning she deliberately went back to the pond.

This time she was angry with herself. "Let us see what I saw yesterday," she said inwardly. "Today the eyes can play their game again."

The water was not as still as it had been the first morning. A light wind moved across it. She waited on the steps. After a while the surface smoothed itself out.

Once again, her present face disappeared.

She was in a flat in a multi-storey building in a small city. She was around sixty. On the table lay an award plaque, two books, and a pair of spectacles. Tall apartment blocks rose beyond the window. The room was clean, orderly, bright. On the wall hung a photograph from Aditya's graduation ceremony. In another, Aditya stood in some foreign city with a wife and child. Satisfaction rested on Mridula's face - perhaps she had been promoted at work, perhaps she had lived life on her own terms.

Just then a phone rang within the vision. The older Mridula picked it up. "Aditya" was visible on the screen. She smiled, but the call ended. Perhaps the time difference, perhaps he was busy. The older Mridula set the phone down again and went to the window. She did not look unhappy. But there was no other voice in the room.

At the edge of the pond, Mridula held her breath.

There was nothing frightening in this scene. It was not a bad life. Many people might have called it successful. Aditya's life had moved forward along its own path. Mridula was independent. Then why did she feel an emptiness inside her chest?

Before she could finish the question, a leaf fell onto the water. Circular ripples spread outward. The walls of the apartment bent, the photographs broke apart, the old face stretched long. Then there was only sky.

This time Mridula did not run. She remained seated on the third step.

"Yesterday, one life. Last night I made one decision. Today, another life," she put the pieces together in her mind.

At once she almost laughed at her own thought. Could sending a message declining marriage alter the doorways of the universe? And if it could, how had the pond come to know?

Janaki Mami's voice came from behind her. "Arguing with the pond first thing in the morning?"

Mridula turned. Mami stood there holding a leaf bowl. She had brought rice for the birds.

"Mami, was there some story about this pond?"

"Every pond has stories."

"Something about seeing time and all that?"

Janaki Mami looked at Mridula closely for a moment, then sat down on the steps. "Your grandmother used to say this was the 'Pond of Time.' We children were frightened of it."

Mridula's body tightened. "Why?"

"Because Grandmother used to frighten us by saying that if we stared at our own faces for too long, we would see ourselves old." Mami laughed. "The children would run away within two minutes."

"Did anyone ever really see anything?"

"Who doesn't?" Mami threw a few grains of rice into the water. "When the water is still, you see the tiredness under your eyes, the lines on your forehead, the tree behind you merging with your face. Then someone says, 'I have grown old.' After that they add their own fears, their own desires. What can the poor pond do?"

Mridula said nothing.

Mami continued, "But your mother used to say one thing. The water doesn't show the future; it holds the present still for so long that people mistake it for the future."

"How did she know that?"

"You should have asked her. What do I know now?"

Mami's easy answer did not comfort Mridula. Instead it raised another question. If the pond merely showed the fears and desires of the present, why had she seen Taru grown up yesterday? Why had Aditya been absent? Why today the city apartment, the award, the telephone?

She wanted to look a third time. After Mami left, she waited a long while for the water to become still. The sun rose higher. The pond was blue now. Mridula bent over it. This time she saw only her own face.

She could not tell whether she was disappointed or relieved.

Nachiket called in the afternoon.

"I read your message," he said. "I only want to say one thing. Taru is frightened too. She thinks that if we marry, someone will take her mother's place. The more I tell her it won't be like that, the more she feels I'm trying to persuade her."

Mridula stood by the window. In the courtyard, Janaki Mami was turning papads in the sun.

"Aditya thinks his home will change," Mridula said.

"Then perhaps we have spoken too much about marriage and too little about home."

The sentence stopped Mridula.

Nachiket continued, "I have work in Darbhanga on Sunday. If you want, the four of us can sit together and talk. Whatever the decision is, it can remain as it is."

Mridula did not answer at once. She remembered the two visions in the pond. In one there had been companionship, but Aditya was missing. In the other Aditya's photographs were there, but distance had entered the daily life. Both visions seemed

to show the price of a decision. But perhaps the price was not fixed. Perhaps her own mind was choosing the worst possible outcome each time.

"Sunday," she said. "Let's sit down together."

After ending the call, she read again the message she had sent: "I feel it may be better not to take this further." She did not delete it. She let the old mark of the decision remain.

The Sunday meeting took place at Mridula's house in Darbhanga. Janaki Mami had also come with her for two days, but she deliberately went to visit a neighbour. "Why should a fifth pair of ears be present in a conversation among four people?" she said with a laugh.

Nachiket arrived on time with Taru. Taru carried a blue bag with her sketchbook inside. Aditya came out of his room and joined them in the sitting room, but his face bore the careful expression of someone about to sit an examination.

The first ten minutes disappeared into tea, school, examinations, and the weather. At last Mridula opened the subject herself.

"We made a mistake," she said. "We talked about marriage, but not about what everyday life would actually look like if the marriage happened."

Nachiket nodded.

Mridula looked at Aditya. "Ask again the questions you asked me."

Aditya looked uncomfortable. "Here?"

"Here."

Slowly he began: "If you get married, where will I live?"

Before Nachiket could answer, Mridula said, "No one has decided that yet."

Taru immediately asked, "Will I have to change schools?"

Nachiket looked at her. "I had assumed that perhaps, later, we would all live in one place."

"When?" Taru asked.

Nachiket was silent.

Aditya's second question: "What about Papa's things?"

Mridula said, "They will stay where they are. If we ever move house, nothing will be taken away without your agreement."

Taru was twisting the strap of her bag. Suddenly she said, "I'm not going to call Mridula Aunty 'Maa.'"

For a moment the room became so quiet that the bell of a cycle-rickshaw could be heard from the distant road.

Mridula looked at Taru. The girl's eyes were trying to appear hard, but the fear inside that hardness was plain.

"All right," Mridula said.

Taru had perhaps been prepared for an argument. The simple answer unsettled her. "All right?"

"Yes. You had one mother. Her name and her place remain in your life. If one day you want to invent some new word for me, you can. If not, call me 'Mridula.'"

Aditya smiled for the first time. "Then can I call Nachiket Uncle just 'Nachiket'?"

Nachiket laughed too. "First we'll see whether I can be released from 'Uncle.' Then we'll decide."

The laughter was brief, but it changed the air in the room.

After that came the practical questions. School. Jobs. Weekdays. Holidays. The two houses. Expenses. Elderly parents. Taru's art classes. Aditya's cricket practice. Mridula's mother's house, which she did not want to sell immediately.

Some answers were not easy. Nachiket could not leave his job in Madhubani. Mridula's school was in Darbhanga. Both children were in the middle of their studies. The idea of one house looked good on paper; in daily life it was difficult.

"So marriage doesn't mean that from the next day everyone has to be under one roof?" Aditya asked.

Nachiket said, "Not necessarily. People may laugh at us, but those people will not be the ones running to catch the school bus for us."

Mridula remembered Janaki Mami's words: people add their own fears, their own desires.

By the end of the meeting no wedding date had been fixed. Instead, three things had been decided. For the next two months, the two families would spend time together twice a month. The children would not change schools. The decision to marry would not depend on the children's permission, but their fears would not be ignored either.

"And one more thing," Mridula said. "If we marry, both houses will remain as they are for the first year. We will work out where to stay on weekdays and holidays by trying it in practice. No child will have to leave their home in a single night."

Nachiket thought for a long time. "That will be expensive."

"Yes."

"And exhausting."

"Yes."

"But possible."

Taru opened her sketchbook and began drawing something. Aditya looked over with interest. "What are you drawing?"

"Two houses," Taru said. "A road between them."

"Don't make the road too wide," Aditya said. "Otherwise it'll take the whole week just to get there."

Taru looked at him and smiled.

In that moment Mridula saw no future at all. She saw only four people breaking a difficult possibility into small, practical questions. For the first time it occurred to her that perhaps a decision was not merely the choosing of a future; it could also mean making rules for the future.

Three days later, Mridula went again to her maternal home, this time to finish the paperwork concerning her mother's house. In the evening she placed Vimal's letters, her mother's broken green cup, a few photographs, and two saris in a separate trunk. The remaining things would be distributed among relatives and neighbours. She postponed the decision to sell the house for six months.

Before she left at dawn, Janaki Mami asked, "Won't you go to the pond?"

Tying her shoes, Mridula said, "I will."

"What will you see today?"

Mridula smiled. "Water."

This time a light mist lay over the pond. The steps were wet. Mridula went down carrying the same brass pot. Her face looked slightly crooked on the surface because the wind from the previous night had not yet fully died.

If she wished, she could have waited. The wind would stop. The water would level out. Perhaps she would again see an old face, a house, an empty room. Perhaps nothing at all.

Mridula stopped on the first step. For a moment a powerful desire rose within her – just once. Let me see what the pond shows now, after Sunday's meeting. Taru? Aditya? Nachiket? Her own elderly face?

She plunged the pot into the water.

Circular ripples spread in every direction. Her face broke apart into pieces of sky, tree, Mridula's brow, and light.

She filled the pot and climbed back up.

Janaki Mami was waiting near the gate. "Did you see anything?"

Handing her the brass pot, Mridula said, "I disturbed the water before I could see."
"Why?"

Instead of answering, Mridula turned once to look back at the pond. The wind had risen again. Not a single face remained steady on the surface.

"Because today I don't have to choose one life," she said softly. "Today I have to live the first day of whatever life we make."

Janaki Mami said nothing. She poured the water from the pot over the tulsi plant in the courtyard.

Mridula crossed the gate and came out onto the road. The sound of a bus was approaching in the distance. In her bag were Vimal's two letters; on her phone was Nachiket's message; and there was Aditya's school timetable. The three did not fit neatly together, yet for now her life was made of precisely these things.

Behind her, the first clear ray of sunlight fell on the pond. The water flashed, then trembled in the wind. On that surface, no place remained still enough for the future.

The City of Letters

Nirupama Karn returned to Siddhpur, and the first thing outside the station that seemed changed to her was not the clock tower. The clock tower was as it had always been: four-faced, grey, and leaning slightly. What had changed was the new map hanging beneath it.

On the map, the streets had numbers instead of names—1, 2, 3, 4—and a thick red line ran straight from the station to the municipal office. Nirupama laughed involuntarily when she saw it. Even in childhood, the idea that any line in Siddhpur could remain so straight had seemed impossible to her.

The municipality's map cell had invited her to prepare a new map. The autumn book fair was approaching; thousands of visitors would arrive from outside, and for the past two years there had been complaints that people lost their way in Siddhpur's old wards. The municipal chief's order was simple: "We need a map that everyone can understand."

Nirupama worked in urban planning in Delhi. Straight roads, the sequence of intersections, measurements of distance, the gradient of drainage—these had become the language of her everyday life. It had been twenty years since she had left Siddhpur. There, her father, Hemkant Karn, had made road signs. After his death, the old house had been let to tenants; Nirupama had returned once or twice only to settle paperwork, then gone away again.

At the municipality, the head of the map cell, Shashibhushan Yadav, showed her three thick bundles of registers. The first contained visitors' complaints, the second old maps, the third proposals for changing road signs.

"The problem isn't the names," Shashibhushan said. "We changed the names, and people still get lost. We gave the roads numbers; they still get lost. Some say the library lies to the right from the very same square, others say it lies to the left. Both sides insist they are right."

Nirupama turned the pages of the register. The complaints did indeed have a strange similarity. "I turned from K-Path onto Sha-Path and couldn't find the library." Another person had written, "From the same place I reached it without difficulty." A third: "The road curved round and brought me back to the same clock tower."

"Show me the old map," Nirupama said.

From a drawer Shashibhushan took out a thick sheet of paper wrapped in cloth. It was a reconstruction map from 1935. After the earthquake, the central part of Siddhpur had been laid out again. Seen from above, the streets formed the shapes of Devanagari letters—क, ख, ग, म, भ, ल, ष, क्ष, ज्ञ. The letters were not complete: in places there was only half a curve, elsewhere a single upright stroke, elsewhere two roads met to form a conjunct consonant.

Nirupama remembered the clock tower of her childhood. Her father had once taken her to the top and said, "People down below see roads; from above, you see

letters.” That day she had recognised the “म,” but had taken the “क्ष” for a tangle of two ponds and three lanes.

“Who designed this plan?” Nirupama asked.

“An engineer named Damodar Lal,” Shashibhushan said. “They say he wanted to build a city of schools. Children would learn letters by looking at the map from above. But all that is history now. What I need, before the fair, is a fixed map.”

“Fixed?”

“One that doesn’t change with the reader.” There was a tired laugh in Shashibhushan’s voice. “People here say the city listens to language. I can’t write that sort of thing in an official report.”

Nirupama did not dwell on the remark. To her, the problem looked like a matter of old crooked roads and bad signage. She asked for three days to conduct a field survey.

On the first day, Ramji Mahato from the municipality accompanied her. He had been born in Siddhpur. Nirupama wanted to measure the distance from the station to the old library. She checked her watch, switched on her step-counting device, and said to Ramji, “You walk ahead, the way you always do.”

Ramji left the clock tower, followed the rounded belly of the road shaped like “क,” then entered a lane that rose like the middle tooth of “म.” He did not ask anyone for directions. Eight minutes later, the library stood before them.

Nirupama drew the route on her map. “Now I’ll walk.”

She turned back toward the station. This time she followed the signboards—“K-Path, Section 2,” “M-Path, South,” “Sha-Junction.” Her training had taught her to think in sequence, direction, and distance rather than names. In her mind she repeated the directions in the administrative Hindi used in most of her professional paperwork.

After K-Path, she could not find the lane Ramji had taken. Three spice shops stood pressed together where it should have been. Nirupama turned back. The clock tower was not where it ought to have appeared. The needle of her compass pointed north, but that north did not agree with the north on the map.

“Where did that lane go?” she asked Ramji.

Ramji looked toward the spice shops. “Which lane?”

“The one we used eight minutes ago.”

Ramji frowned. “We came through here.”

“There are shops here.”

“The shops have always been here,” Ramji said matter-of-factly. “You have to take the way through the middle.”

Nirupama looked between the three shops. The gap between two walls was less than the width of a hand. No person could pass through it.

Ramji said quietly, “What language are you reading in your mind?”

Nirupama laughed. “Does the street change with language?”

“I’m not saying the street moves. But here, the path has to be read.”

Nirupama did not argue. She devised a second test.

The next day three people gathered beneath the clock tower. Malati Jha sold vegetables, and Maithili was spoken in her home. Pasang Lama was a bookbinder; his family had settled in Siddhpur long ago after coming from the hill country of Nepal,

and he read in Nepali. Ravindra Kumar was a clerk in the district office and did his everyday reading and writing in Hindi. All three had to reach the same place—the old library.

Nirupama sent them off separately, five minutes apart. None had a chance to watch the others. Each carried the same small map, on which only the shapes of the letters and the destination had been marked.

Malati went first. Nirupama followed at a distance. At the curve of “भ,” Malati suddenly turned left, where Nirupama had seen a wall the previous day. Today there was a narrow lane there, with mud houses on either side. In ten minutes they reached the library.

Then Pasang set out. He never reached “भ” at all. He moved upward along the upright stroke of “ल,” descended a flight of steps, crossed the cloth market, and came to the library’s rear gate.

Ravindra’s route was a third one. At the junction of “ष,” he turned right, crossed an open square, and emerged in front of the library.

All three journeys took almost the same amount of time. Nirupama drew the three lines on her map. They crossed one another at places where, on the ground, no crossroads existed.

“How did each of you read the directions?” Nirupama asked.

Malati said, “I didn’t count the letters. I thought, ‘toward the library,’ and the way kept becoming clear.”

Pasang said that he had read the marks on the map by linking them with Nepali words. Ravindra said he had followed the sequence of the paths. Each was surprised to hear about the others’ routes, but, like people born in Siddhpur, not excessively surprised.

That evening Nirupama climbed the clock tower. From above, the city was still. The “क” was where it had been, the “भ” where it had been, the “ष” where it had been. Clothes dried on rooftops, a heron stood by the pond, and in the distance smoke rose from a train. If the roads were changing, why could she not see the change from above?

Through her binoculars she looked toward the part of “भ” where Malati had turned left. A lane could indeed be seen between two houses. Whether the spice shops had stood there the day before was impossible to determine from that height.

As she came down the tower stairs, an old saying of her father’s returned to her: “The eye sees the shape of a letter, but the mind makes the path of the word.” As a child Nirupama had not understood what he meant.

On the third day she went to her old house. The tenant was away. In the back room, some of her father’s belongings still lay in a trunk—a wooden measuring rule, bowls with dried paint, an iron compass, and small strips of cedar on which different Devanagari letters had been carved. Nirupama picked up one strip. It bore the letter “र,” and on one side her father had drawn three arrows in pencil.

At the bottom of the trunk she found an unfinished map wrapped in cloth. At the top, in her father’s handwriting, were only the words: “Road-sign test.” The map carried three kinds of lines—red, blue, and green. No language was named. There were only three short phrases: “As Mother used to say,” “As the office writes,” “As the bazaar hears.”

Nirupama stared at those three phrases for a long time. Even after leaving Siddhpur, her mother had never stopped speaking Maithili at home. In the bazaar, her father changed his speech according to the customer. Nirupama had gone away after school and, little by little, had begun even to ask for directions in another language.

In one corner of the map her father had written: “Three paths of the same person.”

Nirupama did not close the trunk. She put the strip bearing “ॢ” into her bag and, as evening fell, went to the clock tower. This time no assistant was with her. Her destination was her father’s old sign shop, long closed, in the western part of the city.

First she repeated the language of the office in her mind—west, Section Five, Path Twelve, next junction. The route brought her near the cloth market. From there, the old front of the shop could not be seen.

She returned to the clock tower. This time she recalled her mother’s voice: “Come down from the clock tower, hold to the belly of M-Path, then turn left by the peepal tree.” The words came into her mind in Maithili. She began to walk.

The belly of M-Path seemed shorter than before. She found the stump of the peepal tree, which did not appear on the city’s new map. A lane opened to the left from there. Five minutes later she stood before her father’s closed shop.

The paint had peeled from the wooden signboard, but the lettering remained: “Hemkant Road Signs.” Nirupama did not open the lock. She did not even have the key. She simply stood before the door.

For the first time, she felt afraid. If the city changed its paths according to language, then someone who forgot their first language could truly lose certain places. And if the city were measured according to a single language, some lanes could fall outside the map for readers of another.

Only four days remained before the fair. Shashibhushan wanted one map. Nirupama had three maps, and her father’s unfinished map was a fourth question.

The next morning she altered the test. The destination was no longer the library, but the municipal field. She had the same person walk the route three times—Ramji Mahato. The first time she told him, “Walk as you think at home.” The second: “Read it in your mind as you write an application.” The third: “Walk as you would explain the way to an outsider.”

Ramji reached the field by a different lane each time. During the third journey, he stopped of his own accord. “I’ve never seen this before,” he said. Before them lay a small square with a dry well in the middle.

Nirupama marked the ground with chalk. “Go back from here.”

They retraced ten steps, then came forward again. The well had not disappeared; but the square now looked like a long lane, with the well standing off to one side. Distance, direction, house numbers—none had become wholly impossible; only the joins had changed.

Nirupama understood that Siddhpur’s marvel was not that houses rose and moved elsewhere. The marvel was that the connections between its letter-shaped streets were not fixed. The language a reader carried within determined which curve of “क” became one road, which tooth of “म” became another, which joint of “व” became an intersection.

The city's bricks remained still; the journey changed. Yet the journey changed enough that, in the end, the geography itself seemed different.

That evening Nirupama drew three maps on transparent sheets. The first recorded the tests with Maithili readers, the second with Nepali readers, the third with Hindi readers. When she laid the three over one another, the city's letters became a thick, blurred web. Some paths were common to all three, some to only two, some to just one.

Shashibhushan clutched his head when he saw them. "You want to give this to visitors?"

"No," Nirupama said. "This is for me."

"Then what is for the visitors?"

Nirupama opened another sheet. It did not contain a complete map of the city. It showed only the principal entry points, the clock tower, three public places, and a few letter-junctions. At every junction she proposed three small direction boards—identified by language, not by number.

"One line cannot save everyone," she said. "We'll give three valid reading routes. At each junction, people will follow the arrow for the language in which they read. The fair volunteers will also be taught all three ways."

Shashibhushan was silent for a while. "And what about a language that isn't among these three?"

"The main road is stable as far as the clock tower. From there, a local guide."

"This isn't a complete solution."

"Neither is the city a complete letter," Nirupama said. "So many of its lines are unfinished."

Shashibhushan looked at her as though that answer would be difficult to put into a report. But the fair was close. The proposal was accepted—temporary signs first; if the trial succeeded, permanent boards later.

For three days the signs were made. Nirupama adopted her father's old method: thick letters, small arrows, different colours. She did not assign a separate colour to each language, because from a distance the meaning of the colours could become confused. On every board, the language name was written clearly, with the corresponding arrow beneath it.

The day before the fair, they held a rehearsal. Fifty volunteers set out from the station in separate groups. Nirupama stood at the clock tower taking notes. The Maithili-reading group went through the old bazaar; the Nepali-reading group took the river-side route; the Hindi-reading group followed the broad administrative road. Every group reached the field. Their times differed by only two or three minutes.

Shashibhushan was pleased. "At least now I can write in the report that a system exists."

Nirupama laughed. "There is a system, not fixity."

That evening, while making a final inspection of the signs, Nirupama reached the "३" junction. It was the most difficult join in the city. Five lanes, a small temple, two old courtyards, and a public tap were clustered around the same place. The new board had three lines—Maithili, Nepali, Hindi—and beneath them an empty strip of wood, because the carpenter had cut it longer than necessary.

A boy of ten or eleven stood there with his grandmother. The grandmother's speech sounded familiar to Nirupama, but it was not Maithili. Looking at the board, the child asked, "Where is our language?"

Nirupama asked his name. The boy said, "Chandan. We speak Angika at home."

Nirupama paused. Angika had not been included in the official test. She could have asked the child to choose one of the three lines.

But the wooden strip bearing her father's "र" was in her bag.

"Look at these letters the way you read at home," Nirupama said. "You want to go to the fairground, don't you?"

Chandan nodded. He looked toward the middle curve of "न," then suddenly started toward the courtyard behind the temple. His grandmother followed. Nirupama went with them.

Beside the temple wall, where earlier that day Nirupama had seen only a tulsi platform, a thin path opened between two houses. It was so narrow that the map had not counted it as a street. Yet five minutes later it emerged directly at the northern gate of the fairground.

Chandan laughed and said to his grandmother, "This seemed like the short way to me."

Nirupama turned and looked back at the path. The temple wall, the tulsi platform, the two houses—everything was still. Only the relation between them seemed new.

She took a pencil from her bag. Her hand moved to draw a fourth line on the map, then stopped. To fix the route of one Angika-speaking child as "the Angika route" would be as hasty as having first treated three languages as the whole city.

With the pencil, she placed only a small dot beside the "न" junction, then folded out the blank margin along the right-hand side of the paper, leaving it broader.

The fair opened the next day. Beneath the clock tower, visitors stood with maps in their hands, read the language boards, and followed different arrows. From above, Nirupama looked again at the streets. The Devanagari letters were the same as before, yet no two journeys joined those letters into exactly the same word.

In her hand was her father's wooden "र" strip. Beneath its three arrows, Nirupama did not draw a fourth. She left only a small blank line.

Below, at the "न" junction, Chandan entered the crowd holding his grandmother's hand. For a moment he was visible; then some narrow turn between the houses swallowed him.

Nirupama opened the margin of the map. The wind fluttered its blank space—the place where the city's next path had yet to be written.

The Final Annotation

At the Mithila Manuscript Conservation Centre, Raghunandan Sah did the kind of work in which people rarely read his name. Exhibitions displayed the names of scholars, editors, and donor families; but the hands that joined the fibres of insect-eaten paper, opened broken stitching and bound it again, and protected ink from water usually remained recorded only in the registers at the back. Raghunandan did not particularly mind. To him, the body of a manuscript was its own identity.

One afternoon in Bhadon, the Centre's director, Vidyadhar Mishra, called him into his room. A thick manuscript wrapped in blue cloth lay on the table. As the cloth was opened, a mingled smell of old paper, neem leaves, and dust rose into the room.

"This is the Discernment of Evidence," Vidyadhar said. "It was found in an old house in Rajnagar. According to the note on its final page, it dates from the end of the seventeenth century. The university is preparing a special issue on it. It must be conserved first."

Before lifting the manuscript, Raghunandan washed his hands, dried them, and then laid it on a thin cotton cloth. The outer binding was later—a red cloth cover with two small brass bosses along the edge. The stitching inside had been replaced at least twice. The corners of several folios had been eaten into rounded hollows by insects.

Vidyadhar opened one folio. Dense lines of Sanskrit-inflected Maithili prose filled the middle, with a small annotation written in the margin. "My article is on this annotation," he said. "A later reader has written an objection to the conclusion of the main text. Look—the hand is different, and so is the ink."

Raghunandan brought a magnifying glass close. The marginal line was indeed in another hand. The letters were slender, the tail of the "ra" long, the joining of "sha" in an older form. The annotation read: "Who heard the question before the answer?"

"A beautiful line," Vidyadhar said with a smile. "I take it to be an eighteenth-century critical annotation. First the principal text, then the response—that is the natural order."

Raghunandan said nothing. His attention was not on the letters but on a tear in the paper. Just beneath the annotation ran a faint narrow line, as though the edge of another piece of paper had been pressed inside the folio.

He closed the folio. "The stitching will have to be opened first."

Vidyadhar said at once, "The textual portion must remain safe. We need the facsimile for the special issue within two weeks."

"A manuscript does not open in haste," Raghunandan replied. "The faster we open it, the longer we may regret it."

The conservation room lay on the northern side of the Centre. Its windows were covered with fine mesh; inside stood a long table, soft brushes, cotton, thread, small bowls of adhesive, and two adjustable lamps. On the first day Raghunandan did nothing but count the folios. There were one hundred and forty-two. The

numbering broke at seven places. Three folios were of a different size. Five bore watermarks unlike those on the rest.

His assistant, Naval Kishore, asked, "Did you read the annotation?"

"Read the paper first," Raghunandan said. "The letters come later."

His father, Harinarayan Sah, used to say the same thing. Harinarayan had been a bookbinder, not a scholar. Yet from childhood Raghunandan had watched him take a torn page in his hands and say, "This manuscript has lived twice," or, "This binding was not born with it." As a child, Raghunandan had not understood how paper could speak.

On the second day he opened the stitching at folio twenty-seven, where the annotation appeared. When the folio came free, he stopped in surprise. It was not made from a single sheet of paper. The broad central portion carrying the main text was one paper, but the narrow strip on the right, bearing the annotation, was another. The two had been joined so neatly that the seam was almost invisible while the folio remained inside the binding.

Naval whispered, "A repair?"

"Possible," Raghunandan said. "But the question is: a repair from when?"

He examined the fibres of the two papers under oblique light. The fibres in the main portion were short and dense. Those in the narrow strip were longer, with tiny particles like rice husk scattered among them. The main sheet bore part of a circular watermark; the strip had no watermark, but its surface showed older abrasion.

Most intriguing were the holes. A round insect tunnel began in the main sheet and continued into the strip, but inside the strip there was another, older repair around that same hole. In other words, the strip had already been insect-damaged before it ever became part of this folio.

Raghunandan laid the folio flat on the table. The letters of the annotation ran almost to the strip's outer edge. Whoever had made the join had not cut away a single letter of the note; on the contrary, the lines of the main text curved around it as though the writer had known the annotation was already there.

"Was the main text written later?" Naval asked.

Raghunandan did not answer at once. "For now we can say only this: the strip had a life before the main folio. When the writing was put on it is a separate question."

Vidyadhar was informed. He came into the room, examined the strip, then took off his spectacles and wiped them. "Old paper could have been reused later," he said. "Someone may have patched a torn folio with an old scrap and written the annotation on it afterwards."

"That is possible," Raghunandan said. "Which is why we need to look at the ink."

The Centre had no instrument that could date ink precisely. But its behaviour under different kinds of light could be compared. The carbon-based ink of the main text remained nearly uniform. The ink of the annotation had turned brown, and around some letters the paper had thinned from the action of iron.

Raghunandan did not favour cutting a sample. He asked the university chemistry laboratory for a non-destructive light examination. Three days later Dr Saroj Chaudhary arrived with a small instrument. Her field was not literature but the comparison of old pigments and inks.

Saroj examined five points in the main text and then five in the annotation. “I will not give you a date,” she said plainly. “From this I can only say that the mixtures are not the same. The annotation has a higher proportion of iron-based components; the main text is predominantly carbon ink.”

Vidyadhar asked, “Which is older?”

“The chemistry cannot establish the sequence from this alone,” Saroj replied. “Look at the paper and the order of writing.”

Raghunandan was inwardly pleased. He trusted people who knew the limits of their instruments.

On the fifth day another clue appeared on the back of the strip carrying the annotation. On its reverse was a faded red stain—not straight, but curved. Naval thought it might be part of a seal.

Raghunandan shone oblique light across it. Two letters survived within the stain: “...math...” There was no corresponding stain on the back of the main sheet. Had the strip originally formed part of this folio, the seal should have crossed both papers.

“This was once part of another document,” Raghunandan said.

Vidyadhar frowned. “Then how did its writing become an annotation on the main treatise?”

From that point, the question became genuinely interesting.

Supriya Jha, who taught textual criticism at the university and was co-editing the special issue with Vidyadhar, came to the conservation room and read the paragraph beside which the annotation appeared. The subject of the paragraph was the sequence of evidence. The writer argued that if the order of question, evidence, and answer were disturbed before judgment, the shape of truth itself could change. Its final sentence read: “An answer is admissible only after the question.” In the margin stood the annotation: “Who heard the question before the answer?”

Supriya read the main sentence once, then the annotation. “If the annotation came first,” she said, “it is possible that the writer of the main text was composing an answer to it.”

Vidyadhar immediately said, “Or it may be coincidence.”

“Coincidence is possible too,” Supriya agreed. “But look at the arrangement of the lines.”

On that folio, almost every line of the main text was of roughly equal length. Only the two lines beside the annotation were unnaturally short. The writer could easily have carried the words into the next line, yet had left clear space around the writing on the strip—as though the decision had been not to erase the older words, but to preserve them.

Raghunandan opened folio twenty-eight. There the main text extended normally across the full width. The same was true of folio twenty-six. Only on twenty-seven did the words bend around the annotation.

“If the repair were later, the main text would have been cut,” Supriya said. “Here the main text is making room for the annotation.”

Vidyadhar looked toward the window. Rain had begun outside. “One folio does not reverse the chronology of an entire work.”

Raghunandan agreed. He was wary of the seduction of evidence. The moment people encountered an unusual discovery, they built an entire story around it; the manuscript ceased to be an object and became a wish.

He did not open the stitching of the remaining folios. He merely examined their edges. On folio fifty-four he found another narrow strip of the same kind. This one carried two old letters unrelated to the main text, later rubbed almost away. On folio one hundred and three there was a third strip, blank. The paper of all three resembled the strip bearing the annotation.

Raghunandan inferred that whoever made the manuscript had reused narrow strips from old, discarded documents to widen sheets of paper. There was nothing extraordinary in that. In an age when paper was costly, putting old fragments back to use was natural.

But then the question remained: why did the writing on this particular strip happen to correspond so directly to the thought of the main text?

Supriya read the colophon at the end of the manuscript. It gave the Samvat year in which the copying had been completed and named the scribe's teacher, "Shridhar Upadhyay." The beginning of the main text did not name its author. In the special issue, the work was being treated as a composition by Shridhar, because later catalogues had generally attributed it to him.

"What if this is only a copy?" Raghunandan asked.

Vidyadhar said, "Every manuscript is, in one sense or another, a copy of a text."

"No," Raghunandan said. "I mean: what if the present main text was recast after someone saw this older annotation?"

The room fell silent.

The implication was not merely a change of date. The introduction to the special issue had already been drafted around the phrase "the original treatise and its later critical tradition." If the annotation came first, then the word "original" itself began to waver.

Supriya called for the university's old manuscript catalogues. For two days she compared names, opening lines, and closing lines. The title *Discernment of Evidence* appeared nowhere before the nineteenth century. But three catalogues mentioned a lost manuscript called *Question Commentary*. Its description said only: "A slender manuscript on questions and answers, from a monastic collection." The author was unknown.

Raghunandan remembered the red stain on the back of the strip: "...math..."

Vidyadhar said, "A matching word proves nothing."

"It proves nothing," Supriya replied. "But it changes the direction in which we search."

That week Raghunandan went through uncatalogued fragments kept in the Centre's storeroom. Many were pieces from which no complete manuscript survived—sometimes recovered from inside old bindings, sometimes left over from earlier repairs. After opening three boxes, he found a narrow fragment whose paper resembled the annotated strip. It bore only half a sentence: "...without hearing the question..."

A shiver ran through him, but he resisted the temptation to join the fragment at once to the annotation. The size did not match. The handwriting was not fully the same either. He made a separate facsimile and entered its source in the register.

"Aren't you disappointed?" Naval asked.

"Why?"

"If it isn't a fragment of the same manuscript?"

Raghunandan laughed. "I do not join stories. I join paper. The rules are different."

That night at home he remembered his father. Once, while repairing a marriage register, Harinarayan had rebound an old page upside down. The village pandit had scolded him sharply. Harinarayan had quietly opened it again and corrected it. Later he had told Raghunandan, "I may disturb the order of pages; but if people long ago had already disturbed it, my certainty would be the greater danger."

For the first time, Raghunandan understood that his father had not been speaking only about bindings.

The next day he examined the join of the annotated strip again. The adhesive used there differed from that in the present binding. Along the inner edge of the strip were two minute needle holes that did not correspond to the stitching of the current folio. The strip had therefore once been sewn into another manuscript.

There was one more thing. The writer of the main text had begun his line immediately after the final letter of the annotation, but beside that letter lay a very fine scrape. It was as though the edge of the old strip had first been trimmed smooth, then joined to the new paper, and only afterwards had the main text been written.

Supriya said, "The physical sequence appears to be: old writing on the strip; trimming of the strip; joining it to the main paper; then the main text. At least on this folio."

This time Vidyadhar did not object. He remained seated in his chair. After a long while he said, "For thirty years I have taught two quotations from this work. My teacher called it an original treatise by Shridhar. If it turns out to be a later composition..."

For the first time Raghunandan heard in his voice not the scholar, but the student.

Supriya said gently, "Being later does not make it lesser."

Vidyadhar smiled, but it was a tired smile. "That is easy to write in an introduction. Harder to accept in one's own life."

The special issue was not cancelled, but the introduction was put on hold. The university invited two outside specialists—one in the history of paper, the other in palaeography. They examined the folio on separate days. The paper specialist said there was substantial physical evidence that the strip predated the main sheet, though a definite century could not be assigned without more extensive testing. The palaeographer found that the letter forms in the annotation accorded with an earlier scribal tradition than those of the main text, but added a caution: a later writer might also have imitated an older hand.

Raghunandan found relief in such caution. Evidence endures better when its limits remain visible around it.

Yet the decisive clue came from the manuscript itself. In the main text on folio twenty-seven was the word "aforementioned." Supriya had first taken it in the

ordinary sense of “said earlier.” But when she reread the entire chapter, there was no preceding statement in the main text to which “aforementioned” could refer. Only the marginal sentence raised the question that the lines following it proceeded to answer.

“Aforementioned—what?” Naval asked.

Supriya pointed to the annotation. “Possibly this line.”

If that was correct, the principal writer had not merely preserved the older note; he had treated it as though it were the opening sentence of his own text. What had long been taken for a later annotation might have been the initial provocation from which the present work arose.

A strange picture formed in Raghunandan’s mind: once, an unknown reader writes in the margin of some lost manuscript, “Who heard the question before the answer?” Years pass. The original manuscript perishes. Only the narrow strip from its margin survives. Another writer finds it and does not throw it away; he joins it to the edge of new paper and writes an entire meditation around that single question. Centuries later, people call the newly written portion the “original” and the older question an “annotation.”

It was a beautiful picture, but Raghunandan did not mistake it for proof. In his conservation register he wrote: “Strong probability that the written strip predates the main text. Original source unknown. Present relationship between text and annotation requires reconsideration.”

Vidyadhar read the entry and said, “Why don’t you simply write, ‘The annotation is older?’”

“Because that is all the paper tells me,” Raghunandan replied. “If I say the rest, I too shall become the main text.”

The special issue appeared three months later under a changed title: *Discernment of Evidence: Text, Pre-Text, and an Old Marginal Line*. Vidyadhar had removed the first paragraph of his introduction. In the new version he wrote that the present form of the treatise might be in dialogue with an earlier tradition of questioning. Supriya contributed a detailed essay on the sequence of the annotation, the differing papers, and the word “aforementioned.” Raghunandan’s conservation report was printed at the end as well, without ornament—only measurements, fibres, joins, holes, and descriptions of ink.

On the day of the exhibition, the manuscript was displayed open beneath glass. The original plan had been to show the main text at the centre and the annotation at the side. Raghunandan suggested one small change.

Beside the folio they placed a large facsimile of the strip carrying the annotation, separately. Beneath it there was no date, only three lines: “This writing was present on paper that predates the main text of the present folio. Its original source is unknown. The present treatise may have been written in response to this line.”

Visitors lingered longest before that narrow strip. Some read the main text first and then the annotation. Some read the annotation first and then the main text. Two students argued over which ought to be called the “original.” An elderly pandit stood silent for a long while and said only, “The line from the margin has come into the middle.”

As the exhibition was closing that evening, Vidyadhar came to Raghunandan. “Your name has been added to the display label,” he said.

Raghunandan laughed. “Leave the name. Check whether the glass has been properly closed.”

Together they checked the edges of the case. Inside, the folio lay still. The dense lines of the main text grew thinner as they approached the right margin, as though they were still making room for that older sentence.

Before the lights were switched off, Raghunandan read the annotation once more: “Who heard the question before the answer?”

This time it did not seem to him an objection written against the principal treatise. It seemed a question whose answer had been written centuries later, after which people had forgotten that the question came first.

He noticed a fine line of dust on the exhibition glass. He took out a cloth and wiped it away. He did not touch the folio inside. Along the right edge of the page, the old strip remained where it was—not last, not first, but at the point from which the whole manuscript had to be read again.

The Map That Kept Growing

In the back room of Darbhanga's old district archive, Ramapati Jha's desk was not large enough for the whole map of the district to be spread across it. So he pushed two tables together, covered the gap between them with a thick sheet of paper, and began. The objective had been stated simply: "A historical map of the settlements along the Kamala and its old channels, from 1900 to the present."

The map was being prepared for the district museum's centenary exhibition. The director, Maheshwar Babu, had told him, "At a glance, people should understand where the river was, where the villages were, and how the roads grew." Ramapati had smiled. In history, the phrase "at a glance" had always seemed suspect to him.

During the first week he worked through government survey books, old land-settlement records, railway maps, and flood reports. He marked the river in blue, roads in black, settlements with red dots. The map looked beautiful. Two days later, his own map began to look like a lie. The reason was Bholaram Mandal, the first visitor who came to the archive.

Bholaram was past eighty. In his hand he carried an old brass box containing two land papers and a folded wedding letter. He placed a finger on the map and said, "Our old hamlet stood here." Ramapati looked. On the government map, that place lay in the riverbed.

"From what year?"

"It had been settled before I was born. Half of it went in the flood of '54, the rest in '57. Afterwards everyone came and settled here." He slid his finger toward the right-hand side of the map.

"Any paper?"

Bholaram opened the wedding letter. The directions for reaching the groom's house read: "East from beneath the peepal tree, behind the old monastery, Bhelwa Tola." On the government map there was no peepal tree, no monastery, no Bhelwa Tola. Ramapati cut a small piece of paper and attached it to the edge of the map. On it he wrote: "Bhelwa Tola — oral testimony; mentioned in wedding letter; location approximate." The paper projected beyond the original map.

The next day Sukanya Jha arrived carrying a 1932 land-revenue receipt from her grandfather's trunk. The boundary of a field on the receipt was described as "Little Kamala." That name appeared nowhere on the government maps available to Ramapati. Then an elderly boatman told him that in the rainy season the main channel swung westward, while in winter people crossed the dry eastern channel. If he drew only one river, half the history would disappear.

Ramapati attached another strip below the map: "Monsoon channel." Beneath that he added: "Winter crossing." Within three days the map had begun to hang off the tables.

One evening his assistant, Meena Karn, said, "Ramapati Babu, everything will not fit on one sheet. We could make transparent layers and place them one over another."

Ramapati thought for a while. "Then who will see, at a single glance, the route that existed at one time and not at another?"

"Use different colours."

"We will run out of colours."

Meena laughed. "Is history larger than colours?"

"History is larger than people's claims."

After saying it, Ramapati himself fell silent. He had realised that the work was no longer simply about finding an old river. Every mark added to the map was tied to someone's house, someone's field, someone's route, someone's displacement.

Two weeks later word spread that the archive was making a "map of vanished villages." People began to come. Someone would say, "My grandmother used to perform Chhath beside this pond." Someone else would say, "This road came later. Bullock carts used to pass through this bamboo grove."

An elderly washerwoman, Phoolkumari Paswan, frowned the moment she saw the map.

"Where has the path gone?"

"Which path?"

"From the washermen's ghat to the market."

Ramapati said, "It isn't on the government map."

Phoolkumari laughed. "Did government officers go to wash clothes?" Laughter rose in the room. Ramapati laughed too, but immediately picked up his pencil.

Phoolkumari explained that women from four households used to carry bundles of clothes on their heads at dawn, walking along paddy ridges, through a clump of bamboo, and past the edge of a private field to reach the ghat. A man's bullock cart could not use that way. The revenue survey gave it no name. Yet for fifty years it had been a regular path for the women.

On the left edge of the main map, Ramapati attached another strip. He drew a fine dotted line and wrote: "Women's path to the washermen's ghat; oral memory, three testimonies."

Phoolkumari said, "Why three? There were four of us."

"The fourth witness?"

"My elder sister died. But the path was hers too."

Ramapati struck out "three testimonies" and wrote instead: "Three living; remembered by four." Meena looked at him but said nothing.

By the end of the month, the map had left the table and climbed onto the wall. When one wall filled, it moved to another. To show the old turns of the river, Ramapati drew the floods of 1912, 1934, 1954, 1987, and 2004 on separate strips. He drew thin arrows for the movements of settlements. Where a village had shifted three times, there were not three different names but the same name in three different places.

When Maheshwar Babu came for his first inspection, he stopped at the doorway.

"What is this becoming?"

Ramapati answered not with pride but with exhaustion: "A map."

"It has eaten the room."

"The room became too small."

Maheshwar Babu took out the original proposal. "Four feet wide, six feet long. One museum wall."

"The present can fit into that much."

"I don't want a map of the present. I want history."

"History is what is making it grow."

Maheshwar Babu lifted one of the strips. "People come to an exhibition, not to sit an examination. Condense it."

That word was not difficult for Ramapati. Selection was, after all, the historian's work. Not every record could enter a book; not every name could remain in an article. Yet when he imagined taking scissors to the map, the first thing he saw was Phoolkumari's dotted path, then Bhelwa Tola, then "Little Kamala."

"Give me a few days," he said.

Maheshwar Babu left. That night Ramapati sat alone before the map. Under the room's electric light, every join in the paper was visible. The map looked less like a single object than a stitched coverlet: here government blue ink, there Ramapati's red pencil, elsewhere dates written by Meena, elsewhere interview numbers.

He wondered whether this was merely his own stubbornness. If the map ceased to be useful, could one say history had been preserved—or only that paper had multiplied?

That night, for the first time, he tried to make the map smaller. He took a fresh sheet. The main river, the main roads, the principal villages. Then five of the old villages. Three of the old paths. Two flood years. Within half an hour, a beautiful map had appeared.

Ramapati looked at it for a long time in silence. The map was not wrong. That was precisely what disturbed him more. A wrong map could be caught. If an incomplete map was beautiful, people forgot that it was incomplete.

He folded the new sheet and put it in a drawer.

The following week Meena came with a proposal. "Make one main map. Give everything else a number. Whoever wants to see more can open the register."

Ramapati said, "Then in the exhibition Bhelwa Tola will become only '17'."

"But its full account will survive."

"It will survive, but it will not be visible."

Meena placed her hand on the table. "The insistence on showing everything at once can also be a kind of falsehood."

Ramapati looked at her. The remark hurt because it could be true.

Two days later he went out to the villages. Trusting paper alone had begun to seem incomplete. Meena accompanied him with a thick measuring tape, a register, and copies of the old maps.

Their first stop was the place where Bhelwa Tola had once stood. There were sand, reeds, and two new houses there now. Walking with them, Bholaram suddenly stopped.

"There was a peepal tree here," he said.

"Any trace?"

"No."

"The monastery?"

"The river took it."

"The houses?"

"The river took the place of the houses. I brought the name with me."

He pointed toward his present hamlet. Small plaques on the gates of two houses there read: "Bhelwa." Ramapati wrote in his register: "Place lost, name relocated."

Then Phoolkumari took them to see the old women's path. Half of its course now passed through masonry houses. She stopped before a wall at one point and said, "We used to go straight through here."

"And now?"

"Now we go around."

"Then how do I draw the old path on the map? Through the wall?"

Phoolkumari said, "Where was this new wall on the old path?"

Ramapati burst out laughing. The simple answer opened the whole difficulty before him. He had been placing objects from different times on the same sheet, then asking how they could all fit together at once.

After that journey, the map did not become smaller. It grew larger.

Ramapati decided to separate chronological panels for the same stretch of land: 1900-1933, 1934-1953, 1954-1986, 1987-2003, 2004 onward. On each panel, river, settlement, path, public place, and oral memory would be shown separately.

The problem was that once one panel was finished and the next attached beside it, comparison required lines of relationship between them. A family displaced in 1954 needed an arrow from one panel to the next. A pond that had been filled and turned into a market had to have its two forms connected. A footpath that became a road needed its changes of name shown.

The paper began to grow again. First it filled the room. Then the corridor.

One day Shambhu, the archive attendant, stood with his broom and said, "Babu, where am I supposed to sweep now? History has occupied all the floor."

Meena burst out laughing. Ramapati tried to gather the papers, but whenever he folded them, a relationship line broke at the fold; whenever he turned them, another line stuck to itself.

At last they took over the empty conference room. The map was spread across the floor. People left their shoes outside and walked inside in socks. To get from one corner to another, they had to walk around the map.

Maheshwar Babu came again.

This time he was not angry. He stood for a long while, looking silently. Then he said, "You understand, don't you, that this cannot hang on a museum wall?"

"I understand."

"Then?"

"Now I want to understand why it keeps growing."

"The answer is obvious. You keep adding everything."

Ramapati said, "Not everything. Only what can be supported by evidence."

Maheshwar Babu bent over a thin arrow. "What is this?"

"The displacement of a family."

"And this?"

"An old name of a road."

"This dotted line?"

"A women's path."

Maheshwar Babu straightened. "And you don't have the courage to remove any of it."

"That may be so."

"For a historian, that is a problem."

"Yes."

It was difficult for Ramapati to say that "yes," but after saying it he felt relief.

That night he did not take the map home. When he reached home, his wife Vimala brought out a photograph from an old trunk. It showed Ramapati's mother in the days after her marriage. Behind her stood a mango tree, an earthen courtyard, and a low wall.

"Do you recognise this place?" Vimala asked.

Ramapati turned the photograph over. On the back, in his mother's handwriting, were the words: "Belahi, 1961."

Ramapati was startled. Belahi was marked on his map, but the present Belahi lay three kos east of the place shown in the photograph.

The next day he reopened the old land-settlement records. On one receipt he found "Belahi Western Tola." A flood report from 1968 stated: "Complete erosion; families resettled on higher land to the east."

Ramapati's mother had spoken very little about this. As a child, whenever he heard her say "our old Belahi," he had taken it for the ordinary nostalgia of the elderly.

He added a new strip to the map.

Meena asked, "Whose testimony is this?"

"My family's."

"Then do the rules change?"

Ramapati immediately understood the question. If he required three testimonies for someone else's memory, why should one photograph suffice for his own mother's?

For three days he searched for further evidence of Belahi. He found a resettlement list, a school admission register, and statements from two elderly residents. Only then did he attach the strip.

His hand did not tremble when he fixed the strip in place. But as he wrote the label, he realised for the first time that impartiality was not distance; it was the strength to apply the same rule to one's own home.

Bhadon returned. Water began to drip from one corner of the roof. The map lay spread across the conference room. The first drop did not fall on the paper, but just beside it. Shambhu ran to call Ramapati.

Everyone began lifting the map together. The old problem returned: it had grown too large to fold at once. Wherever they folded, a chronological panel broke; wherever they turned it, a relationship line stuck.

"Cut it!" Shambhu shouted. "Save it in pieces!"

For a moment Ramapati looked at the scissors. Then he said, "Open the joins. Don't cut."

Meena understood at once. Together they identified the original joins. The paper came apart piece by piece—river panels, settlement panels, path panels, displacement panels. Within half an hour the whole map had been secured in boxes. The rain grew heavier. On the empty floor there remained only pencil dust and tiny fibres of paper.

Ramapati stood looking at the vacant room.

Suddenly he understood: the map had not really grown as large as the land. It had grown as large as time. His attempt to hold the many times of the same landscape upon a single surface had forced it to spread.

The next day he and Meena drew up a new plan. For the museum wall there would be a main map four feet wide and six feet long. This time, however, it would not be called the “complete map.” Its title would be: “Entrance Map.”

The main map would not contain only fixed markers. Beside each place there would be a small number. The number would open into a chronological panel, a testimony register, a photograph, an old name, a line of displacement. In the next museum room, the strips from the original growing map would be laid out in order. Whoever wished could go inside.

Maheshwar Babu read the plan and said, “So at last you have made a small map.”

Ramapati replied, “Not small. A doorway.”

“And the large one?”

“It isn’t a house. It is a road.”

Maheshwar Babu smiled. “You have become less of a historian and more of a carpenter.”

“A doorway needs a carpenter.”

On the day the exhibition opened, visitors first stopped before the main map. The colours were clear, the river distinct, the present roads easy to follow. But everyone could also read the warning printed in one corner: “This map is only an entrance; see the separate chronological panels inside for the landscape across different periods.”

Many read the warning and moved on. Some went inside.

Bholaram took his grandson by the hand and led him to the panel for Bhelwa Tola.

The boy asked, “Was our house here?”

“Our old house.”

“I never lived there.”

“You have lived in the name.”

Phoolkumari found her dotted path. Beside it the museum had added a new description: “No physical trace of this route survives in the present; reconstructed from users’ memories.”

After reading it, she said, “That language is too heavy.”

Ramapati laughed. “Tell me your own words.”

Phoolkumari said, “Write: ‘The path we took at dawn carrying clothes.’ That’s all.”

Ramapati took out his pencil. Beneath the printed label, on a temporary slip of paper, he wrote those words.

Toward evening, when the crowd had thinned, a small boy reached the farthest edge of the chronological panels. There the paper ended and the wall began.

The boy asked, “And after this?”

Ramapati said, “After what?”

“The map.”

Ramapati was about to answer when the boy’s mother said, “Come, it’s getting late.” The boy left. The question remained.

Ramapati attached a blank strip to the final edge. He drew no river, no road, no village on it. He wrote only the date and one sentence: "From here onward, evidence will continue to arrive."

From a distance Meena saw it and asked, "Will you make it grow again?"

Putting down his pencil, Ramapati said, "Not if the landscape changes. But if our understanding changes, yes."

The museum closed. In the main gallery, the small map hung quietly on the wall. In the inner room, the chronological panels stretched across the floor, tables, and low platforms far into the space. Outside, the city remained within its present shape; inside, its past kept moving across the paper from one boundary toward another.

One Writer, Two Births

Anagha Karn first received the news not by telephone, but by post. The thick yellow envelope bore the seal of the Kamala Katha Parishad. She assumed it was the formal letter concerning the award; two months earlier, her story “The Line” had been chosen as the year’s best short story. But her hand stopped as soon as she read the first sentence inside: “The honour is being held in abeyance because the text of the submitted story corresponds word for word with an unpublished Tirthuta manuscript dated approximately 1826.”

Anagha read the letter a second time. Her eyes remained fixed on the words “word for word.” The accusation of plagiarism had not been made explicitly, yet every phrase pushed in that direction. The Parishad had asked for her explanation within seven days. Enclosed were two pages of comparison: on one side a blurred photograph in the Tirthuta script, on the other its Devanagari transcription. At the top was written: “Govinddas Chaudhary, Illustrations of Household Conduct, pages 42-44, circa 1826.”

That night Anagha did not open her own story. She opened the transcription. Its first sentence read: “On the third day after the partition, a bamboo stake was driven into the middle of the courtyard.” It was her sentence. Then came: “At dawn Dhaneshwari saw that the narrow path to the pond had been blocked on this side of the stake.” That too was her sentence. The third, the fourth, the fifth - all of them. Where Anagha had written, “Water does not belong to the inside of a house,” the same five words stood there as well. The story contained 637 words; the Parishad’s comparison sheet stated that, once spelling was normalised, all 637 of the 637 words were identical.

Anagha remembered the night she had written the story. Examinations had ended at the school in Rajbiraj. The students had gone home, and she was sitting in the empty classroom counting answer scripts. Outside, June rain was falling. Suddenly she remembered her grandmother’s courtyard at Naruar in Madhubani district - the narrow lane leading to the pond, the bamboo screen, the wet earth of morning. She had opened her notebook and written the first sentence. The story was complete within two hours. Never before had writing come to her with such ease. It had seemed that a scene buried within her for many years had found its own way out.

Two days later Anagha reached Darbhanga. The Parishad’s secretary sent her directly to the manuscript conservation room. There were the smell of paper, manuscripts wrapped in cloth, and subdued light. The conservator, Mrinalini Devi, placed a slender manuscript on the glass table.

“This manuscript was catalogued only this year,” she said. “A family donated it. It has never been online, nor has it appeared in a printed catalogue.”

Anagha’s first question was not whether the manuscript was genuine. She asked, “How could I have seen it?”

Mrinalini Devi put on her gloves before answering. “Directly? There is no evidence that you did. For the last fifty years, the manuscript’s last known location was a locked chest. But that is not the only question.”

She opened page 42. To Anagha, the lines of Tirhuta letters looked almost like drawings. Beside them lay the conservation room’s Devanagari transcription. The story was not titled “The Line.” Above it, in small letters, was written “Third Illustration.” The name Govinddas Chaudhary appeared at the beginning of the manuscript. After the story, two lines had been added in red ink: “If a woman’s obstinacy is allowed a place in the division of a household, the boundary will not hold. Therefore the limits must be made clear from the very beginning.”

For a long time Anagha stared at those red lines. Beneath her published story, the jury’s comment had read: “A subtle story of a woman’s invisible right to a shared waterway; the boundary drawn through a household becomes a question before communal life.” After the same 637 words, 1826 had produced “a woman’s obstinacy,” while 2026 had produced “an invisible right.”

“Did Govinddas write this story against the woman?” Anagha asked.

Mrinalini Devi shrugged. “It is not yet certain whether the red lines are in his hand or that of a later reader. The paper appears to be from the same period; the ink is somewhat different. But the manuscript as a whole is arranged around illustrations concerning household division, field boundaries, debt, marriage, and inheritance. It is clear that the story was read here as a warning.”

Anagha said quietly, “I saw Dhaneshwari saving the path.”

“Then we have found the first difference,” Mrinalini Devi said. “Not in the words, but in the eyes.”

The Parishad met that evening. Five members sat around a circular table. One of them said plainly, “A coincidence of more than six hundred words is impossible. Whether knowingly or unknowingly, the text is old.” Another member said, “Our question is not merely one of plagiarism. If this is an old story, how can an award for original writing be given to it?”

Anagha described her writing process to them: the notebook, the rain, her grandmother’s courtyard. She showed them the old date on her telephone – the file from the night the story was written, and its first draft, which, astonishingly, contained very few revisions. In every version, the sentences stood in almost exactly the same order.

One member laughed. “That strengthens the suspicion. A text already held in memory comes out with fewer revisions.”

For the first time, anger rose in Anagha. “Are you saying I am lying?”

“No,” the chairperson said. “We are saying that memory itself may be a source.”

That sentence kept Anagha awake all night. At dawn she took a bus to Madhubani.

At Naruar, her grandmother’s house had changed by half. The old earthen veranda had become a masonry room; the path to the pond had been widened; the bamboo screen was gone. Her grandmother had died seven years earlier. Vimala Mami, her maternal uncle’s wife, kept the keys to the old trunks.

Without mentioning the story, Anagha asked, “Did Nani teach me Tirhuta when I was a child?”

Vimala Mami laughed. “Teach you? You used to run away after two letters. But yes, she showed you the old script. She used to say that if you could not read the letters, half the things in a household would remain locked away.”

Mami brought down three old cloth bags from the room above the veranda. They contained scraps of cloth, wedding invitations, copies of genealogical records, medicine slips, and school notebooks. In the third bag Anagha recognised her childhood handwriting - enormous ka's, crooked dha's, and flowers drawn in between. On the cover, in her grandmother's hand, was written: “Script Practice - Anagha.”

The first ten pages were the alphabet. On page eleven stood a sentence: “On the third day after the partition, a bamboo stake was driven into the middle of the courtyard.” Anagha's breath caught. On the next page was a copy of the sentence in her childish hand. Then: “At dawn Dhaneshwari saw that the narrow path to the pond had been blocked on this side of the stake.” Again, a child's copy beneath it. There were fourteen such lines in all. The story was not complete. In the middle, Anagha had drawn a boat in red pencil; after that, arithmetic sums began.

“Where did Nani copy these from?” Anagha asked.

Vimala Mami could not remember. “She had many old papers. Whatever she found, she used it to make you practise letters.”

On the last page of the notebook Anagha found a note by her grandmother: “Govind Babu's story - the version heard from Mother.” There was no date and no manuscript title. Who was Govind Babu?

The words “heard from Mother” did not resolve the questions; they opened a third path. If Anagha's grandmother's mother had heard the story orally, the 1826 manuscript was not necessarily its sole source. And if Anagha herself had copied fourteen lines in childhood, then her “independent” memory was not entirely independent either.

She took the notebook back to the Parishad. The chairperson looked at the fourteen lines and said at once, “Now we have a direct link of contact.”

“Fourteen lines,” Anagha said. “What about the remaining 623 words?”

No one answered immediately. One member said, “Childhood memory can be far deeper than we expect.”

Mrinalini Devi, who had been invited to this second meeting, spoke softly. “There is something else here. The fourteen lines Anaghaji copied match the 1826 text word for word. But her grandmother wrote, ‘the version heard from Mother.’ That suggests she also knew the story as an oral form, not only as something seen in a manuscript. If an oral tradition preserved 637 words verbatim for two hundred years, that raises a different kind of question; and if the grandmother's note is incomplete, then we can only infer.”

The Parishad wanted a decisive answer. Literary institutions have little liking for “possibly,” “perhaps,” and “the evidence is incomplete.” Give the award or withhold it - two houses, with a line between them.

Suddenly Anagha remembered her own story. After the household partition, the bamboo stake had blocked the path to the pond. On the Parishad's table there was another stake: “original” on this side, “copy” on the other.

That night, for the first time, Anagha tried to read the 1826 story through the eyes of its own time. She read the illustrations before and after it in Govinddas's manuscript. In one, the younger brother used a well behind the house, but after the partition the elder brother closed his way to it; the author prescribed a solution: dig a new well, do not break the boundary. In another, a daughter-in-law shared fruit from a tree at her parental home in her marital household; the accompanying comment emphasised the limits of property. In that sequence, Dhaneshwari's removal of the bamboo obstruction seemed less a defence of a shared waterway than a breach of an established division.

Then she read her own story through the eyes of readers in the present year. In villages now, old narrow paths were increasingly being blocked by masonry walls, new houses, motor roads, and private gates. The informal routes by which women reached ponds, wells, temples, and fields were rarely recorded on maps. When Dhaneshwari said, "Water does not belong to the inside of a house," a reader in 2026 heard in the sentence a claim to a shared resource.

Govinddas may have seen discipline; a modern reader saw a right of access.

Strangest of all was the final sentence: "At dawn the stake stood where Dhaneshwari had planted it in the night; the path, though narrow, remained open." In the 1826 manuscript, the red comment turned this ending into a warning - once a boundary was loosened, it would no longer remain firm. In Anagha's modern reading, the same ending offered relief - a household could remain divided without requiring the path to be closed.

The words were identical. The conclusion had reversed itself.

On the third day, Mrinalini Devi called Anagha back to the conservation room. She had noticed a small detail on the manuscript's opening page. In his introduction Govinddas had written: "Those stories heard in the conduct of village life, I have bound here into useful forms." At least some of the illustrations, then, were not entirely original compositions of his, but written forms of stories he had heard. Whether the "Third Illustration" belonged to that category was not clear, but the possibility was open.

Anagha did not laugh. Nor did she feel relieved. "Then who is the author?"

Mrinalini Devi said, "Perhaps that question is not as simple as the first line makes it seem."

"The prize committee will want a name."

"A catalogue wants a name too," Mrinalini Devi said. "In my register I have to make a box - author, scribe, source. Sometimes the text does not fit inside the box."

At its final meeting, the Parishad considered three proposals. The first: cancel the award. The second: let the award stand and close the matter as a "coincidence." The third: defer the decision and republish the modern story with a clear account of the older text.

Anagha listened for a long time. At last she said, "I leave the decision about the award to you. But if my story is printed again, the old text must not be concealed. Nor should it say that I 'rewrote' Govinddas's story. Write only what we know: I copied fourteen lines in childhood; the source of the remaining text has not been established."

One member asked, "Do you still claim authorship?"

Anagha was silent for a moment. “When I wrote it, the story was born within my experience. Now I understand that my experience also contained a text I no longer remembered. My claim is no longer as clean as it seemed before.”

The Parishad could not withhold the prize money. Its rules allowed an award to be withdrawn only in a case of established plagiarism, and plagiarism had not been established. But the ceremony changed.

Instead of Anagha's story being read from the stage, two pages were displayed: on the left, the Tirhuta page of 1826; on the right, the Devanagari text of 2026. Between them was a small card: “Word sequence identical; source relationship incomplete; readers' meanings differ.”

The first question in the hall came from an elderly teacher. “If the words are the same, in what sense is this a new story?”

A college student rose to answer, although the question had not been addressed to her. “Before I read the old comment, Dhaneshwari was saving the path for me. Now, after reading the comment, I understand that the writer may have regarded her as being in the wrong. But I am still with Dhaneshwari.”

A farmer seated at the back said, “When I read both, I see the stake more clearly than Dhaneshwari. If land is divided, where will the path go? That problem still exists.”

A linguist stood and began speaking about “authorial intention.” A lawyer asked for the definition of “originality.” Anagha sat on the stage and listened to them all. It felt strange: the story that had emerged from her in two hours was now becoming twenty different stories in the hall. Not a single word had changed.

After the ceremony, Mrinalini Devi took her to see the new display in the conservation room. Inside the glass lay a page from the old manuscript. Beside it was a facsimile of Anagha's first handwritten draft. Mrinalini Devi had placed a separate identifying card beneath each.

The card beneath the old page read: “Govinddas Chaudhary - compiled/written, circa 1826.” The card beneath the new page read: “Anagha Karn - independent writing from memory, 2026; possible childhood contact with an earlier text.”

“‘Independent’ and ‘possible contact’ in the same line?” Anagha asked with a smile.

“In human memory, both can exist together,” Mrinalini Devi said.

Inside the case, the red-ink comment at the end of Govinddas's page shone faintly: preserve propriety, keep the boundary firm. To the right, beneath the final line of Anagha's draft, there was a small pencil mark of her own - on the night she wrote the story, she had absent-mindedly drawn what looked like an open gate. She could no longer remember why she had drawn it.

She leaned closer to the glass. She could not read the Tirhuta letters, but she now knew the Devanagari transcription by heart. It seemed to her that Govinddas, sitting two hundred years away, and she, while writing the same line, had not been writing the same story. Govinddas's Dhaneshwari loosened a boundary; Anagha's Dhaneshwari kept a path alive.

A group of students entered from outside. One boy read the red note on the old page and said to his companion, “Look, in those days they thought what she did was wrong.”

His companion looked at the pencil mark like an open gate on the page to the right and replied, “The story is in the middle. Wrongness and the path - those are things written at the edges.”

Anagha said nothing. She looked once at all three: her childhood copybook, the 1826 manuscript, and the 2026 draft. The first contained fourteen lines, the second 637 words, the third the same 637 words. On the surface of the glass, the reflections of the students fell across all three sheets at once.

The words inside remained still; the faces kept changing.

A Dictionary of Memory

Malati Mishra had grown old writing down the meanings of words, but for the first time she became afraid not of meaning, but of forgetting. In the upstairs room of her old house in Darbhanga lay four decades' worth of notebooks, slips, and reference books. They held Maithili words that were slowly vanishing from the speech of the new generation. After retirement, she wanted to gather them in one place and complete an extensive dictionary.

One morning she stopped at the word "osara." Its meaning was perfectly clear to her: a roofed place for sitting, attached to the open inner-front portion of a house. But the scene that always rose with the word - her father's low wooden seat, a brass lota, rainwater, the wet end of her mother's sari - was incomplete that morning. She could not remember whether the object in her father's hand had been the lota or a fan.

On a blank page of her notebook Malati wrote: "Osara: a roofed, open part of a house where people sit, guests stay, and household work may also be done." The definition was complete. Beneath it she wrote: "My memory: Father sat here in the evenings reading the newspaper."

As soon as she had written the line, she felt relieved. The scene was now on paper; if her mind forgot it, the word would remain.

From that day Malati added a new section to her dictionary: "Memory." Beneath "aripan" came her mother's fingers coated in white rice paste; beneath "khoinchha," her sister's farewell; beneath "pond," a Jeth afternoon; beneath "dalan," her grandfather's cough; beneath "hearth," her mother's eyes turning red in the smoke. The dictionary suddenly became personal.

Within three months the entries had grown. Where a word had once occupied two lines, it now filled half a page. Malati felt she was no longer writing words but building little rooms of her own life.

When her daughter Ranjana came from Delhi and saw the notebooks, she was startled. "Ma, is this a dictionary or an autobiography?"

Malati laughed. "If I don't write the life behind a word, the meaning will dry out."

Ranjana read the page for "aripan." "You have told me this scene before too - Nani making a lotus at the doorway."

Malati answered at once, "Yes, it was a winter morning."

Ranjana asked, "What colour sari was Nani wearing?"

It was an ordinary question. Malati's mouth remained open. She could not remember the sari. She remembered the line in her notebook - "winter morning, doorway, lotus, rice paste" - as though the actual scene had retreated behind those four words and become blurred.

That night Malati read the "aripan" page again and again. The more she read, the more clearly she saw the sentence she had written, but not the movement of her mother's hands. She could not tell whether writing had diminished the memory, or

whether the memory had already been fading and that was why she had needed to write it down. Yet the fine distinction between those two possibilities gave her no peace.

The following week she devised a small test. A word from childhood suddenly returned to her - not "sikahar," not "maraiya," but "kanail." The instant she heard it inwardly, her grandmother's garden, white flowers, and the fragrance of evening rose together.

Malati deliberately did not enter the word in the dictionary. On a blank slip she wrote only the letter "K" and put the slip away.

For seven days she tested the memory. The fragrance was sometimes faint, sometimes strong; her grandmother's face shifted too, but the scene remained alive. Meanwhile, whenever she read the written memory beneath "khoinchha," what came to her was no longer the actual sound of her sister crying at the farewell, but the notebook's final line: "There was rice in the edge of the yellow anchal."

Malati became frightened. She closed the notebook.

For two days not a single word was written. On the third, an old university colleague, Dr Archana Jha, telephoned. The publication committee wanted the manuscript. "For four years you have been saying the final revision is under way. If these words are not preserved now, where will we find the sources five or ten years from today?"

Malati looked toward the notebooks stored in the room. The question was fair. The words were not hers alone. She had gathered them from the speech of elderly village women, old artisans, farmers, genealogists, and singers. She could not hold all of them back because of a fear of her own.

She resumed work, but this time changed the rules. Personal memories would be kept brief. Meaning, usage, and source would receive emphasis. The "Memory" section would appear only where the meaning seemed incomplete without it.

After that rule was adopted, the dictionary grew quickly. Twelve hundred words, then thirteen hundred, then fifteen hundred. The pile of loose papers diminished while the main manuscript thickened. Malati felt satisfaction: the words that had been scattered were coming into order.

But strange changes in her private memory increased as well. She could recite the definition of "dalan" word for word, but no longer knew from which corner her grandfather's cough used to come. She could explain three local usages of "pond," yet the ghat where she and her sister descended on Jeth afternoons had become uncertain. She had written down the method of constructing a hearth, but a question as simple as whether her mother's hearth had stood on the eastern or western side of the house stopped her.

Ranjana came again, this time bringing her daughter Ira with her. Ira was in college and took an interest in her grandmother's work. One day she asked, "Nani, how have you remembered so many words?"

Malati said, "Now the paper remembers them."

Ira laughed. Malati did not.

Ira began arranging the notebooks in order. She found an old slip with only "K" written on it. "What's this?"

At once the fragrance of kanail rose inside Malati: her grandmother's garden, dusk, white flowers, wet earth. Seven months had passed, yet this unwritten memory was more alive than the memories she had written down.

"Nothing," Malati said, taking the slip back.

Ira asked, "Did a word get left out?"

"Deliberately."

That evening Malati told Ira of her fear for the first time: the more words she wrote down, the more the written definition seemed to remain in place of the actual scene.

Ira listened carefully. She did not begin explaining causes. She asked only, "Then if you do not write them, will the words survive?"

Malati gave no answer.

The next day Ira came with a proposal. "You write the meaning. But don't write the memory alone. For every word, add the voice of someone whose life contains it."

At first Malati thought of refusing. The dictionary was her discipline; if personal stories were added, its size could become uncontrollable. But Ira played three short audio recordings for her. Neighbouring Vimala Devi spoke of the word "soop" together with the rhythm of winnowing grain. Shambhu Kaka from the lane opposite described "dalan" not as a place for guests, but as a place for the village council. A teenage girl connected "aripan" less with marriage than with a school drawing competition.

Malati understood: behind a word, her memory was not the only memory.

She created a new marker in the dictionary: "Living Usage." In this section the person, place, and context would be recorded, but Malati would not insert her own story everywhere.

The work slowed again, but the dictionary's voice changed. Beneath "pond" appeared three uses from three villages; beneath "khoinchha," Chhath joined the context of marriage; beneath "dalan," there were three separate examples - village council, guests, and drying grain.

Malati's private memory continued to diminish, but the words were no longer shut inside a solitary box in her head.

One day Archana Jha came to see the manuscript. "Along with a dictionary, this has become a small archive of lived life."

Malati said, "A word does not remain inside a single meaning."

Turning the pages, Archana stopped at "hearth." "Will you keep these lines of memory?"

Malati read her old sentence: "Mother's eyes red in the smoke." The line was entirely familiar to her, yet the scene now seemed like a story from someone else's house. She lifted her pencil. She did not cross the sentence out. Beside it she made a small note: "Personal recollection; impossible to verify."

Archana smiled. "Verification of memory?"

Malati smiled too. "One can ask for the source of a word. Not of one's own eyes."

The manuscript reached its final stage. Ira was preparing the index. One evening she said, "Nani, the entry for 'osara' is very short. The other old-house words have three or four examples."

Malati's hand stopped. "Osara" - this was the first word because of which the whole dictionary of memory had begun.

She opened the page. Her handwriting from four years earlier was clear: "A roofed open part of a house... Father sat here in the evenings reading the newspaper."

She closed her eyes. Her father's face did not come back completely. The brass lota or the fan - still no answer. But suddenly one thing became clear: it had not been her father who read the newspaper. Her mother had read it. Her father had listened. She remembered that whenever her mother stumbled over a difficult word, her father supplied the meaning without even looking at the page.

With a trembling hand Malati lifted her pencil to strike out the old sentence, "Father... read the newspaper," then stopped. What if this new memory too changed four years from now? Which sentence could she call "true"?

Ira was sitting opposite her. "What happened?"

Malati said, "Now I remember this scene differently."

"Then write both."

For a long time Malati looked at the page. Then she left the first line untouched. Beneath it she wrote: "Later recollection: Mother read the newspaper; Father listened. Four years between the two recollections."

Ira read it and remained silent.

Malati left the next line blank. "No more personal example."

"Why?"

"I will use this word once."

The two of them went downstairs. The old osara at the front of the house was still there, though a pile of new bricks occupied one corner. The evening light fell across half of a pillar. Malati sat on the low wooden seat. Ira sat beside her.

Vimala Devi passed along the lane in front and asked, "Why are you sitting here?"

Ira answered naturally, "The breeze is good on the osara."

Malati looked at her. Ira had not opened a notebook in order to say the word "osara."

After a little while Ranjana called from inside - tea was ready. Ira began to rise, but Malati caught her hand and made her sit down again. Evening was settling across the sky in front of them. She still could not remember what had been in her father's hand; nor could she remember what colour sari her mother had been wearing.

But the breeze on the osara truly was good.

Malati did not repeat the meaning of the word in her mind. She simply remained sitting there for a while.

The Zero Chapter

On a rainy afternoon, water from the ceiling was dripping at one spot in the back room of the district library. Sudha Jha sat among piles of old books, attaching small paper slips to those that would be placed before the committee the following month for repair, rebinding, or withdrawal. Her task was straightforward: if the pages were complete, have the book cleaned; if the binding had come loose, have it rebound; if half the book was missing, set it aside.

A thin volume with a faded green cover came into her hands. Its title was *Twelve Rooms*. Author: Shashibhushan Mishra. Year of publication: 1978. The last date on the lending slip was seventeen years old. The borrower's name had by now faded into illegibility.

Sudha pressed the cover lightly. The thread along the spine had broken. As she opened the book, a thin sheet of paper slipped out from between the front leaf and the title page. She assumed it would be an old receipt or someone's note. But at the top, in bold letters, were the words:

CHAPTER ZERO

Sudha laughed. The table of contents listed Chapters One through Twelve; there was no mention of Zero. Nor was there any page number at the bottom of the sheet.

She began to read.

The first line said: "Numbers tell the order of time, not the order of causes."

The second: "If you read this story only from 1 to 12, you will understand what happened. If you wish to understand why, begin with the chapter in which an object is returned; then look for where that object first appeared."

The third: "The same object acquires a different meaning in different hands."

And the final line: "One order in this book belongs to the author; the remaining orders are made by the reader's questions."

That was all. There was no list. No instruction such as "12 to 4, then 9."

Sudha turned the page. Chapter One was where it should have been: "The Locked Room." Chapter Two: "The Key." Three: "The Sacks of Paddy." Four: "The Nurse's Shoes." Five: "The Paternal Aunt's Bowl." Six: "The Crack in the Wall." Seven: "The Red Thread." Eight: "The Empty Cot." Nine: "The Money Order." Ten: "The Southern Veranda." Eleven: "The Name Was Struck Out." Twelve: "The Key Returns."

The rain grew heavier. On the table before Sudha lay the withdrawal slip marked: "Low use." Suddenly it seemed too early to place the book on the withdrawal list.

She read Chapter One. The story began in the house of a joint family. After their father's death, the elder daughter, Sarita, tied the key to the grain room into the end of her sari. Her younger sister Meera wanted to continue her studies; a paternal aunt lived in the house; two younger brothers worked the land. At the end of Chapter One, Sarita left for Darbhanga at dawn without telling anyone and took the key with her. To the family, this appeared to be the first betrayal.

Sudha naturally moved on to Chapter Two. There was a quarrel over the key, accusations, Meera's tears, bitter words from the paternal aunt. Chapter Three concerned the sale of paddy. In Four, Meera was in the city for nursing training. The story moved along like an ordinary family novel.

But Sudha's attention returned to Chapter Zero: "Begin with the chapter in which an object is returned."

She opened Chapter Twelve directly.

In that chapter, thirty years later, there was a wedding. An elderly Sarita placed the old brass key in her niece's hand. The house was now half concrete and half old; the grain room no longer existed. Laughing, the niece asked, "What can this open now?"

Sarita did not answer. A faded remnant of red thread clung to the hole in the key.

Sudha stopped. The second instruction from Chapter Zero: where had the object appeared before?

The key had appeared in Chapter Two. But the red thread was in Chapter Seven. She opened Seven.

In Chapter Seven Meera was living in the nurses' hostel. She had not yet received her first salary. Sarita had come to visit her. There was no key tied in the end of Sarita's sari; instead there was a red thread, which she tied around Meera's wrist. Their conversation was incomplete. It became clear only that the training fee had been paid from "the household paddy," but who had sold the grain, and with whose permission, remained unstated.

Sudha reopened Chapter Three. When she had read the novel chronologically, she had taken this chapter as evidence of Sarita's harshness. Now one small sentence flashed before her: "Three sacks of paddy were loaded onto a cart in the night, but nothing was entered in the account register until the following week."

Earlier, the sentence had seemed to hint at theft. Now it could be hinting at the training fee.

Could be - Sudha repeated those words to herself. The book did not settle the matter. Merely changing the order altered the possible cause.

At closing time that evening, the assistant librarian, Lalita Devi, came into the room.

"All this time on one book?"

Sudha showed her Chapter Zero.

Lalita read it and said, "The writer is making the reader wander."

"What is wandering?"

"What you read first is no longer first."

Sudha laughed. "The pages are still where they were."

Lalita turned the book over in her hands. "But in your mind, Chapter Twelve has become the doorway."

After that remark, Sudha went home, but she put Twelve Rooms into her bag. Taking a damaged book home was not against the rules; she often carried books out so that a binder could measure them the next day.

After dinner, she opened the book again. This time she did not follow the key but the red thread: Seven to Four, Four to Nine, Nine to Five.

In Chapter Four were Meera's nursing-school shoes - stiff and black, disliked by everyone at home. In chronological reading, the shoes had seemed merely a sign of her new life in the city. But in Chapter Nine, on the corner of a money-order receipt, the word "shoes" was written. The sender's name was not Sarita's but the paternal aunt's.

In Chapter Five the aunt took a small silver bowl to the market to sell, yet on returning home told the family it had been stolen. In chronological reading, this had looked like her lie. In the order of the red thread, the lie became secrecy used to gather money for Meera's education.

Sudha began writing a sequence in pencil on the page: 12 -> 7 -> 4 -> 9 -> 5.

Her hand stopped.

Chapter Zero had never told her to write down an order. It only created questions. These numbers were her own answer.

The next day, a young man named Nachiketa came to return a competitive-examination guide. His eye fell on Twelve Rooms lying on Sudha's desk.

"Is that a novel?"

"Yes."

"Is it good?"

Sudha did not answer immediately. "Read Chapter Zero first."

Nachiketa laughed. "A book that begins with zero?"

"Read it and tell me."

He took the book away. Three days later he returned. Sudha was curious.

"How far did you read?"

"All of it."

"In what order?"

"One, two, three... twelve."

Sudha blurted out, "Chapter Zero?"

"I read that too."

"Then you didn't change the order?"

"Why should I? The writer says the reader's question creates the order. My question was: why did Sarita leave the house? Reading by date, I understood it little by little."

Sudha showed him the sequence she had pencilled.

Nachiketa said, "You followed the objects. I followed the person."

He opened the book to Chapter Eleven. "Did you read this early?"

Sudha had not.

In Chapter Eleven, the paternal aunt's name was being struck out from the land papers of the house. Sarita did not object. Instead, she quietly signed. In Nachiketa's reading, after this chapter, all of Sarita's earlier generosity became doubtful.

"If Sarita sold the paddy for Meera's education," Nachiketa said, "why did she remain silent when it was time to protect the aunt's share?"

Searching for an answer, Sudha reopened Chapter Five. Until yesterday she had seen the aunt's sacrifice there. Now another question arose: what had the family given her in return for that sacrifice?

Changing the order of the same book did not absolve Sarita. It merely altered the shape of her guilt.

Sudha took the book back from Nachiketa, but the pencilled sequence 12 -> 7 -> 4 -> 9 -> 5 now made her uneasy. Those five numbers looked like her rule imposed upon the book.

She picked up an eraser and rubbed the sequence away.

That afternoon the committee met. Twelve Rooms was on the withdrawal list. The chairperson, a retired headmaster, said, "No one has borrowed it in seventeen years. The binding is broken. We need space for new books."

Sudha said, "Put it on the repair list."

"Any special reason?"

Sudha opened the sheet of Chapter Zero and showed it to him. The chairperson lowered his spectacles, read it, and said, "This is just the writer's trick."

"A trick perhaps, but it is part of the book."

"It isn't in the table of contents."

"It is still printed."

Another committee member, Ramlochan Babu, said, "What if a page from another book was inserted by mistake during binding?"

Sudha showed them the paper, typeface, and printing. All matched the same edition. Yet she felt less need to prove its authenticity than she might have expected. The question was not what the sheet truly was, but what it did.

The chairperson said, "What is the point of keeping a book if no reader takes it?"

Sudha pushed Nachiketa's lending slip forward. A new date had been added after a gap of seventeen years.

"One reader."

Then, in a calm voice, Sudha said, "One reader can change the order of a book. A library list can too."

The chairperson smiled. "No philosophy. We are short of space."

This time Lalita Devi spoke. "Once it is rebound, it will be slimmer. Keep it."

The committee placed a tick beside "Repair."

When the binder, Naseem Ansari, saw the book, he said, "The Chapter Zero sheet is separate. Where should I put it?"

"Where it was."

"Between the title page and Chapter One?"

"Yes."

"If I stitch it in, it won't fall out again."

Sudha thought for a moment. She had noticed the sheet precisely because it had fallen out. If it were stitched in, every reader would see it more easily. Would that alter the writer's hidden game?

She examined the edge of the sheet. There were two old holes - which meant it must once have been stitched in, and had later come loose when the thread broke.

"Use the old holes," she said.

Three days later the book returned with a new cloth spine. The old green cover had been retained; only the thread inside had been replaced. Sudha did not attach a new lending slip. She preserved the old one, on which the seventeen-year silence remained plainly visible.

She was about to place the book back on the shelf when Nachiketa returned.

"I've realised something," he said.

“What?”

“After reading Chapter Zero, I saw the chapters in a different order. But on the third day I understood that I had seen that order because of my own question. The book did not give me an order.”

Sudha said, “There is a difference.”

“A great one.”

“How great?”

Nachiketa thought for a moment. “If the book gives the order, the responsibility is the author’s. If I choose it, the responsibility is mine.”

The sentence stayed inside Sudha.

That evening her younger sister Seema telephoned. The two of them had not spoken properly for two months. The quarrel had begun over something very small: in whose house their mother’s old trunk should remain. In Sudha’s mind, the sequence of events had settled itself firmly: Seema had first demanded the trunk; then she had raised her voice; then she had cut the call. In that order, Seema was at fault.

As soon as Sudha answered, Seema said, “Didi, you keep the trunk. I only want copies of the letters from Baba that are inside it.”

Before replying, Sudha remembered Chapter Zero. She began to rearrange the pages of her own life: their mother’s death; hospital bills; Seema’s months of caregiving; Sudha’s late arrival; the trunk; the quarrel.

Changing the order did not make Seema innocent. Nor did it make Sudha innocent. But the “first event” changed.

Sudha said, “Not copies. I’ll give you half the letters.”

Silence on the other end.

“Half?”

“Those Baba wrote to you are yours. Those he wrote to me are mine. The ones addressed to Ma, we’ll read and decide.”

Seema laughed softly. “But the trunk is only one.”

“Let the trunk remain one.”

When the call ended, Sudha felt both satisfaction and doubt about her answer. Was she forcing the rule of a novel upon life? Chapter Zero was, after all, a page in a novel, not a scripture.

The next day she opened Twelve Rooms again. This time she deliberately began with Chapter One. To her surprise, Chapter One was no longer what it had once been. The words were the same, the order the same, but eyes that had already read Twelve, Seven, Nine, and Eleven had altered the first scene.

Sarita leaves at dawn carrying the key. The first time Sudha had seen her as a thief. The second time, as a protector. Now, on the third reading, she appeared simply as a woman leaving the house after doing some things right, some things wrong, saying some things, and leaving many things unsaid.

In this third reading Sudha understood the real device of Chapter Zero. It was not instructing her to change the order of the chapters. It was weakening her faith in the word “first.”

That afternoon a teenage girl came to the library. In the lending register she wrote her name as Ruchi Kumari. She asked for a storybook - “not very thick.”

Sudha took out Twelve Rooms.

Ruchi looked at the contents page. "Twelve chapters."

"Thirteen."

"It says twelve here."

Sudha opened the thin sheet after the title page. Ruchi read "Chapter Zero." Her eyebrows lifted slightly.

"Then where should I begin?"

The answer "With Twelve" came immediately to Sudha's tongue. Then she stopped herself.

She placed the book back in Ruchi's hands. "Wherever your question begins."

Ruchi thought for a moment and opened Chapter Eight: "The Empty Cot."

Sudha said nothing.

Outside the window, rain had begun again. The old stain on the ceiling above the shelves was still there, but today no water was dripping. Ruchi read two pages of Chapter Eight, then suddenly turned to Chapter Five. After that, Eleven.

Sudha wrote the date on the lending slip. There was no column for order.

She left the blank space blank.

The Copyist

Two lanes in from Darbhanga's old high road stood the "Folk Manuscript Conservation Room." Half the letters on the outer gate had flaked away, but inside, the smell of dust, the brittle whisper of old paper, and the slow turning of a fan were enough for Sudhindra Das to understand on his very first day that this was no place for hurried work.

Sudhindra's true profession was writing letters clearly. His father had written wedding invitations, shop signs, and sometimes school certificates by hand. Sudhindra knew typing too, but he had never been able to abandon the rhythm of the hand. He was appointed to the conservation room as a "copyist": he would read old manuscripts and prepare clean copies so that researchers would not have to touch the original paper again and again.

In his first week he was given a slender manuscript wrapped in cloth. A small slip on top read: "Songs of Seven Courtyards. Estimated Samvat 1966. Writer/compiler: Ramdulari Devi; name on final page."

The officer in charge, Ishan Jha, looked at him over his spectacles and said, "This is a difficult manuscript. It is in a woman's hand; lines of songs, household accounts, children's names, measurements for dishes - everything is tangled together. Write only what is clearly visible to you. Do not guess."

"And what cannot be read?"

"Leave a blank. You may write 'unclear' in brackets. But do not improve it according to your own judgment."

Sudhindra smiled. "I do not suffer from the disease of correcting things."

Ishan Jha laughed. "The copyist's first disease is correction."

The first page of the manuscript bore a turmeric-yellow stain. The edge of the second had been eaten by insects. On the third page the songs began. Some lines were clear:

*"Leaving her father's veranda,
along the narrow path the daughter went..."*

The initial letter of *gel* - "went" - was very clear, but the rest of the word was blurred. Sudhindra bent closer. For a moment it looked like *del* - "gave" or "was given" - then again like *gel*. Without moving the thin glass strip that protected the page, he tilted his head. Was one ink-stroke forming the belly of a *g*, or the upright of a *d*? It was difficult to be certain.

In his working notebook he wrote, "along the narrow path the daughter went," and placed a tiny dot beneath *gel*. It was his private sign: check again.

At the end of the day the work stopped. The original manuscript was wrapped in cloth and returned to the iron cupboard. The key remained with Bhawani Babu, the oldest employee in the conservation room. His work was to join torn edges with Japanese paper, remove dust, and flatten pages. He used to say, "Paper too is a body. Touch it too much and it hurts; do not touch it at all and it decays."

The next morning Sudhindra came back to the same line. His hand stopped.

“Along the narrow path the daughter was given...”

He no longer felt certain that he had seen gel the day before. Today the letter was unmistakably d: a thick upright stroke, a small curve. There seemed no reason to doubt the reading del.

He turned to his working notebook. There was yesterday's gel, with his dot beneath it.

“Did I read it wrongly?” he asked himself.

At noon Bhawani Babu came in. Sudhindra showed him the page.

“Was this gel yesterday, or del?”

Bhawani Babu narrowed his eyes at it for a long time. “Del.”

“Yesterday?”

“How could I remember so many letters from yesterday?”

“The ink looks almost fresh.”

“Old ink changes with the light too.”

It was an ordinary answer. Sudhindra let the question go.

That day, on page five, he encountered the line: “She weeps, measuring the threshold of her marital home.” The p in napi - “measuring” - was half erased. At first Sudhindra read it as nachi - “dancing” - because, although “dancing and weeping” sounded strange in the rhythm of the song, it was still possible. Looking more carefully, he thought he could make out the bowl of the p. He wrote napi.

The next day, the p in the original was unusually clear.

Now he became suspicious.

From the third day onward, he kept a private register: page number; the letter he had seen in the original; his transcription; his doubt. He did not photograph any letters, because photographing the original manuscript required permission. Instead he described their shapes: “upright broken,” “lower curve absent,” “right-hand dot possible.”

Within a week he found five places where, on the following day, the original came to agree with Sudhindra's transcription - even though the reading had not been clear on the first day.

It did not feel like a miracle; before miracles there is usually an office. Sudhindra first doubted his memory, then the light, then wondered whether the removal of dust might be making the letters clearer. But why were all the changes in precisely the letters he had chosen?

He thought of conducting a test, but experimenting on the original manuscript seemed to him an offence. So he selected a place where little meaning would be lost. On page twelve, a song contained the line:

“The sister-in-law took the kaner flowers...”

The r in kaner was blurred. It could also have been read as kanel, which meant nothing. Sudhindra did not deliberately write kanel in the transcription. He did not have the courage to break the rule. But he wrote the r of kaner with an unusually wide flourish, giving it the distinctive curve of his own hand.

The next morning, over the blurred r in the original, there was a small curve in new, dark ink.

The curve was not in Sudhindra's hand. But it bent in the same direction in which Sudhindra had curved the letter in his copy.

A shiver ran down his back.

"Is the original looking at my copy?" The thought was so foolish that he laughed at himself. The laughter stopped at once.

That night, when he went home, he spoke to his mother about Songs of Seven Courtyards. His mother, Phulkumari Devi, had sung at weddings until the 1990s. Her knees hurt now, so she sat on the veranda listening to younger daughters-in-law sing and occasionally interrupted them: "That line is not sung like that."

Sudhindra asked, "Ma, have you heard 'along the narrow path the daughter went'?"

Phulkumari immediately sang the next line:

*"Behind her the mother stood,
ahead the daughter went."*

Sudhindra's attention fixed on the word "went."

"Not 'the daughter was given'?"

Phulkumari looked at him as though he were proposing to put salt in the rice instead of jaggery.

"Who gave the daughter to whom? In the song the daughter walks by herself. At a farewell people may go on talking of giving and taking, but the woman in the song goes on her own feet. It is gel - 'went.'"

"Could it be del in some places?"

"People change things as they sing. But my grandmother sang gel."

Sudhindra fell silent. The first change in the manuscript was suddenly no longer a grammatical slip. A single letter had altered the woman's action. Gel: she herself went. Del: she was given away by someone.

The next day he examined the original page again. The d in del was certainly in newer ink. Amid the brownness of the old letters, its blackness shone separately.

He wanted to tell Ishan Jha, but he did not want to make an accusation without proof. He observed that Bhawani Babu rarely handled the original manuscript during the day. His work was usually done in the evening, after the reading room had emptied.

That Friday Sudhindra made the excuse that he needed to check two pages of his transcription again. It was past seven in the evening. Ishan Jha had gone home. The cleaner swept the floor and left. Sudhindra remained in the small room at the back, where mesh racks were kept for drying paper.

At around eight o'clock, the lock of the cupboard clicked.

Bhawani Babu took out the manuscript.

Sudhindra watched through the crack.

Bhawani Babu placed Sudhindra's clean transcription on the table. He opened the original page. He took out a fine brush, extremely thin ink, and a magnifying glass. Reading the line in the copy, he began retracing tiny strokes over the faded letters of the original.

Sudhindra stepped out.

Bhawani Babu's hand froze in the air.

For a long time the two looked at each other.

"What are you doing?" Sudhindra did not raise his voice.

Bhawani Babu lowered the brush. "What I have been doing for twenty years - saving letters."

"By looking at my transcription?"

"Your writing is clear. What you read, I use as a basis for restoring the vanished strokes."

"You are adding to the original what is not there."

"It was there. It has faded."

"What proof is there?"

Bhawani Babu was silent.

Sudhindra opened page three. "This was gel. On the first day I wrote gel. Why did you later make it del?"

Bhawani Babu took off his spectacles. "Your transcription said del."

Sudhindra was startled. His first working notebook did say gel, but in the first clean draft he had indeed written del - on the morning when the original itself had appeared to read del. He had later corrected it back to gel, but Bhawani Babu must have seen the earlier draft.

"You transferred my mistake into the original."

"I did not know it was your mistake. You are the copyist. Your work is to read."

"My work is to follow the original. The original is not supposed to follow me."

Bhawani Babu laughed wearily. "Original? Sudhindra, when this manuscript came into my hands, the edges of thirty pages were broken. Before that someone had used paste, then someone had retraced letters in red ink, someone had added words in pencil. What looks 'original' to you is itself the result of many hands."

"So mine should be added too?"

"I am not adding your hand. I am completing the letters."

"And the letters you complete wrongly?"

Bhawani Babu gave no answer.

That night they remained seated on opposite sides of the table. The fan was off, because strong air could not be allowed near an open manuscript. Dogs barked on the road outside. Inside, the smell of paper grew dense.

Bhawani Babu said slowly, "There is an exhibition next month. Ramdulari Devi's great-granddaughter is coming from America. Her family donated the manuscript. The director has said it must be made 'readable.' People do not donate so that they may look at soot-black marks and holes behind glass."

"So if something cannot be read, we make it look as though it can?"

"If we do nothing, these letters will disappear completely in five years."

"A faded letter and an invented letter are not the same thing."

Bhawani Babu closed his eyes. "You are new. When one saves old things, purity is sometimes a luxury."

Sudhindra was angry, but Bhawani Babu did not look like a thief to him. The man had spent thirty years joining torn paper. Perhaps, to him, a clear letter was an act of mercy. But mercy too can alter things - Sudhindra understood this for the first time.

The next day he told Ishan Jha everything.

Ishan Jha was silent at first, then sat down holding his head.

"I said explicitly: nothing in ink on the original."

"Did the director say anything about the exhibition?"

"Making it readable means support, cleaning, proper lighting. Not rewriting the letters."

"Bhawani Babu says he has been doing this for twenty years."

Ishan Jha's face changed. "Twenty years?"

The cupboard key was changed that day. But Sudhindra's problem was not solved by changing a key. On page three, del was now in the original. On page five, napi was clear. The r on page twelve shone in new ink. If all those new strokes were now erased, the original would be damaged again. Reversing bad conservation could itself become another injury.

Work stopped for three days.

On the fourth, Ramdulari Devi's great-granddaughter arrived earlier than expected. An elderly woman named Anupama Chaudhary, hesitant in speaking Maithili, she had brought several letters from an old family trunk for the exhibition.

Ishan Jha told her the entire story.

Anupama looked at the manuscript for a long time. Her eyes stopped on del.

"My grandmother used to sing this line," she said softly.

Sudhindra asked, "How?"

Anupama closed her eyes and hummed: "Along the narrow path the daughter went..."

A shiver passed through Sudhindra again, but this time it was not the thrill of mystery. It was the force of evidence.

Bhawani Babu was present too. His face remained lowered.

Anupama said, "I cannot say that Ramdulari Devi herself wrote gel. Songs changed from household to household. But I can say that in our family it was gel."

Ishan Jha said, "Then we will state in the exhibition that there are later interventions in the original."

Bhawani Babu suddenly spoke. "Then people will think the manuscript is fake."

Anupama looked at him. "Why fake? When wrinkles came onto my grandmother's face, did she become fake?"

No one answered.

The exhibition was not postponed. But beside the manuscript a small notice was placed: "Earlier and modern interventions are present in the manuscript. The present form of some letters does not necessarily represent the original writing with certainty."

The sentence gave Sudhindra half satisfaction and half dissatisfaction. His own transcription too was hidden inside the phrase "modern interventions."

He resumed work, but changed his method. He now created three sections: "What is directly visible," "Possible reading," and "Oral form." If only half a letter survived in the original, he wrote only half and placed the rest in brackets. If the living form of a song differed, he recorded it separately.

Ishan Jha said, "This transcription will become difficult to read."

Sudhindra replied, "The original is difficult."

Bhawani Babu stayed away from work for several days. Then one morning he returned quietly. He carried no brush box, only his spectacles and an old cloth bag.

He sat beside Sudhindra.

"Show me page twenty-seven."

On page twenty-seven, half a song had been eaten by insects. In one line only four letters survived: "...house not..." Sudhindra had left the space for the possible reading blank.

Bhawani Babu said, "It could be 'not my house.'"

"It could."

"Will you write it?"

"Under Possible Reading."

"In the main line?"

"No."

Bhawani Babu kept looking at the page. "Earlier, I would have filled it in."

"I know."

"When I see an empty space, my hand itches."

Sudhindra smiled. "Mine too."

They both laughed. The tension had not disappeared completely, but their voices had grown lighter.

Time passed. They approached the final pages of the manuscript. There were fewer songs there and more household accounts: "two seers of rice," "a quarter seer of ghee," "the younger one's fever," "letter from Pachrukhi." Ramdulari Devi's life suddenly descended from poetry into the everyday.

On the penultimate page there was a sentence, half of it faded away:

"What is written will remain; what ... will ..."

Sudhindra brought the magnifying glass close. Of the word in the middle only two upper curves survived. The final word might have been badalat - "will change"; perhaps bhulat - "will forget / be forgotten"; perhaps chalat - "will go on."

Bhawani Babu sat beside him.

"What do you make of it?" he asked.

Sudhindra looked for a long time.

"Nothing."

"Nothing at all?"

"Not nothing. There are three possibilities."

"Then write all three."

"I will put them under Possible Reading."

In the main transcription Sudhindra wrote:

"What is written will remain; what [...] will [...]"

Between the brackets he left the spaces blank.

Bhawani Babu watched the tip of his pen. "Does leaving a blank no longer feel difficult?"

Sudhindra said, "A blank space is something to read too."

A few days later, the manuscript was displayed in a glass case. Visitors read Ramdulari Devi's name, looked at the lines of songs, and noticed the stains along the edges. Sudhindra's full transcription was not displayed beside it; only a printed extract was shown.

A student came to the conservation room for research. Reading the line on page three, he said, "Here it says 'the daughter was given.'"

Sudhindra said, "That is what is on the original now."

“What do you mean?”

Sudhindra showed him the three sections of the transcription: Directly Visible, Possible Reading, Oral Form.

The student asked in surprise, “Then which one is the real one?”

Sudhindra paused before answering.

Bhawani Babu, who was examining the edge of a torn sheet nearby, said softly, “That question used to seem very easy to me.”

The student did not laugh. He bent closer over page three.

That evening, after everyone had left, Sudhindra turned through the final transcription again. He looked at his own clean lettering. Once he had taken pride in it: every letter the same height, every stroke at the same angle, no trembling anywhere. Now he understood that clear lettering too could be dangerous; people trust clear things too quickly.

He opened the final page:

“What is written will remain; what [...] will [...]”

The original manuscript was inside the glass case. Under the exhibition light, in the middle of that half-erased sentence, Sudhindra could see an extremely fine dark line. Perhaps it was old. Perhaps it was one of Bhawani Babu’s earlier interventions. Perhaps it was an illusion made by the light.

Sudhindra rose and went close to the glass. He could have guessed. By now his hand had learned the habits of Ramdulari Devi’s lettering. Filling in one word would not have been difficult.

But he returned to the table.

The empty brackets in the transcription remained exactly as they were.

That night, in the original manuscript, many letters had already followed the copy. But one place remained where, instead of commanding the original, the transcription preserved the original’s old inability to speak.

Sudhindra switched off the lamp. In the darkness, the empty brackets could no longer be seen, but he knew there was nothing written there.

And this time, the unwritten thing was the most exact copy of all.

The Third History

In every district's old public buildings there is almost always a room where, in the name of history, one first encounters dust and only afterwards the files. There was such a room in the rear building of Madhubani district's Culture Office: iron cupboards on every side, two tables in the middle, and a termite-eaten floor beneath the window. Manikant Mishra's task in that room was not to write history, but to write the plaques on which history would be inscribed.

The government was preparing a "Centenary Memorial of the Night of Grain" at Belwaghat. A hundred years earlier, on one night during the famine of 1927, paddy had come out of the Belwaghat granary. How many people had gathered, who had opened the granary, whether the grain had been looted or distributed, whether anyone had died - on all this there was little documentation. But there were many stories.

The memorial committee wanted four lines to be carved in stone. Manikant's task was to read every source and make four lines out of them.

Four lines.

Perhaps the most difficult measure in history is four lines.

The first dossier belonged to the "Belwaghat People's Memory Committee." It was tied in red cloth, with bold letters on top: "The Night of Grain: The True History of the People's Uprising." Inside were a thirty-five-page booklet, eight interviews, three photographs, and, at the end, a demand that the memorial should bear a statue of Phulkali Devi.

According to that history, in the famine year the royal estate's granary was full while the village starved. Phulkali Devi, a widowed farm woman, gathered the women at night and broke the chain on the gate. Her famous words were: "The grain born of the earth shall not be kept from a hungry mouth." The women then sent grain first to the homes of children and the elderly. The estate officials fled. By dawn, the village had seen "justice in grain."

The booklet cited the source of those words as: "Sarju Mahato, eyewitness, interview 1962."

In the margin Manikant wrote in pencil: "Age in 1927? Check."

The second dossier was wrapped in green cloth. "Belwaghat Royal Tradition Trust." Its title was: "The Night of Giving: Truth and Falsehood." According to this account, the granary during the famine was not the royal family's private store but a public relief reserve. Its manager, Raghunath Babu, had himself opened the gate and said, "The grain born of the earth shall not be kept from a hungry mouth." As the crowd grew, order broke down, but there had been no uprising. Phulkali Devi's name had been added by later folklore. The Trust demanded that a bust of Raghunath Babu be placed at the memorial.

The source given for the famous sentence was: "Harinarayan Babu, son of the then munshi, family memoir, 1971."

Manikant placed the red and green dossiers side by side and stared at the sentence for a long time.

“The grain born of the earth shall not be kept from a hungry mouth.”

Each history called the other a lie. Yet the hero of each history spoke exactly the same words.

Manikant was not a historian. He had studied Maithili at university, then worked as a proof-reader in a publishing house, and afterwards joined the Culture Office. His particular gift was that he quickly noticed repeated words inside a document. If “therefore” appeared three times on one page, his eye caught it. If a name was spelt in two different ways, he could not rest.

He opened the interviews in the People’s Memory booklet.

Sarju Mahato had said, “I was twenty-two that night.”

If he was twenty-two in 1927, he would have been fifty-seven in 1962. Possible.

Near the end of the interview Sarju said, “Phulkali Didi herself first struck the lock with a sickle. The lock did not break. Then the blacksmith’s hammer was brought.”

In Harinarayan Babu’s memoir in the Royal Tradition booklet, the account read: “Raghunath Babu himself first struck the lock with his cane, but the lock did not open. Then the blacksmith was called.”

Another similarity.

People’s Memory: Phulkali Devi gave the first measure of paddy to the mother of an orphaned child.

Royal Tradition: Raghunath Babu gave the first measure of paddy to the mother of an orphaned child.

People’s Memory: at the end of the night, Phulkali Devi sat on the threshold of the granary, looking at the empty measure.

Royal Tradition: at the end of the night, Raghunath Babu sat on the threshold of the granary, looking at the empty measure.

Manikant pushed his chair back.

“Not two histories,” he said softly. “One story, two heroes.”

The next day there was a joint meeting. Kamala Paswan represented the People’s Memory Committee - she was the daughter of Phulkali Devi’s granddaughter. Aditya Narayan Singh represented the Royal Tradition Trust - he was Raghunath Babu’s great-grandson. In a perfectly civil manner, each regarded the other as “the heir to a lie.”

The District Magistrate’s representative said, “We do not want a dispute. Reach agreement on the facts.”

Kamala Paswan spoke at once. “The facts are clear. Hungry people opened the granary. A woman led them.”

Aditya Narayan smiled. “If the facts were so clear, they would be in the records. The royal estate has a relief register.”

“Does the relief register say that paddy was distributed?”

“Some pages were destroyed in a fire.”

Kamala laughed. “The fire ate only the useful pages?”

The meeting grew heated.

Manikant opened both booklets and read out the identical sentence.

The room fell silent.

He asked, "The two sides cite different sources. Then how are the words exactly the same?"

Aditya said, "Perhaps it became a common saying."

Kamala said, "Phulkali's words were later put into Raghunath's mouth."

"Or Raghunath's words were later put into Phulkali's?" Aditya replied.

Manikant said, "At the moment I am not taking anyone's side. I am only saying that we must trace the journey of these words."

At the end of the meeting he was given one week.

On the first day he went to the district archive. The police daily register for 1927 mentioned Belwaghat: "Night-time gathering of villagers at grain store. Store opened. Approximately 134 maunds of paddy removed. Situation calm by morning." That was all.

No Phulkali. No Raghunath. No violence. No charity. No uprising.

The tahsil account register recorded a shortage of paddy that same week. In the column for cause were only two words: "village distribution."

Whether "distribution" had been voluntary or under pressure - the record was silent.

Manikant searched old newspapers. A weekly published from Darbhanga carried a short report: "At Belwaghat, grain from a granary was brought out for famine sufferers. Administration investigating." By whom - not stated.

A second paper said: "Grain distributed under pressure from the crowd." A third: "Prudent action by the local manager."

One event, three short sentences, three directions.

Manikant's work became more difficult, but also more interesting.

He asked for the original paper of Sarju Mahato's 1962 interview. The People's Memory Committee produced only a typed copy. "The original was at Kamala Didi's maternal uncle's house and was damaged in a flood," he was told.

The original of Harinarayan Babu's memoir? Aditya said, "It was in a family manuscript. A copy was made later. The manuscript was stolen."

Manikant scratched his head. Both originals were absent.

He went to the village.

Belwaghat now spread along both sides of the road. Half a wall survived where the old granary had stood. Fencing was being put up for the government memorial. Outside the enclosure, an elderly tea-seller named Ramautar Yadav said, "When I was small, there used to be a play."

"What play?"

"The Night of Grain."

The cup of tea in Manikant's hand stopped midway.

"When?"

"Around Independence Day. At the school. My father used to take me to watch."

"About Phulkali Devi?"

Ramautar thought. "There was a woman character. Her name... Phulo? Phoolmati? And there was a Babu too."

"Raghunath?"

"Could be. What I remember best is that they built a large granary out of bamboo. The children filled it with straw instead of paddy."

"Do you remember any line?"

Ramautar laughed. "Such an old thing! But at the end everyone together said something like - the grain of the earth, a hungry mouth... something like that."

Manikant counted the money for the tea twice before paying.

The village middle school was now a concrete building. When the headmistress, Rekha Kumari, heard his story, she said, "An old play? There may be something in the storeroom. Last year when the roof was repaired, two trunks were brought down."

Opening the trunks was not simple. The first contained old sports certificates, torn maps, wires from science exhibitions. The second held school magazines, attendance registers, and handwritten booklets wrapped in cloth.

On one of them was written:

"THE NIGHT OF GRAIN" - a school play. Writer: Chandrakishor Lal, assistant teacher. First performance: 15 August 1948.

Manikant's hands suddenly went cold.

Rekha Kumari looked at his face. "What happened?"

"Perhaps four lines will now demand eight."

The play was twenty-eight pages long. Characters: Phulo - a widow of the village. Raghuvar Babu - manager of the granary. Sarju - a young farmer. Hariya - the munshi's son. The blacksmith. The mother of an orphaned child. The crowd.

Manikant turned the pages.

Scene Two. Phulo: "The grain born of the earth shall not be kept from a hungry mouth."

Scene Four. Phulo strikes the lock with a sickle; it does not break. The blacksmith brings a hammer.

Scene Five. Raghuvar Babu tries to restrain the crowd, then orders that the first measure of paddy be given to the mother of an orphaned child.

Final scene. Raghuvar and Phulo sit on opposite sides of the threshold; between them lies the empty measure.

Manikant closed the play.

Both histories were here. Half and half.

Rekha Kumari said, "Then the play was based on history."

"Possibly."

"Then what is the problem?"

Manikant reopened the cover. Inside, in the writer's own hand, was one line:

"Inspired by local memories of the famine; characters, dialogue, and sequence of events invented for educational purposes."

Manikant read the line three times.

"The problem," he said, "is that fifty years later people began to treat the play as evidence."

But that alone did not complete the work. The play was from 1948; the event from 1927. It was possible that Chandrakishor Lal had written the play after listening to eyewitnesses. Even if he had given it a fictional form, the play might still have preserved the core story.

Manikant examined the school's 1948 register with the headmistress. Chandrakishor Lal's name was there. Address: near Jhanjharpur. There was also an entry: "Special programme - play on famine memory."

On the back of the play's final page, faintly in pencil, was written: "Story-seed adapted from the 1936 'Village Drama Collection'?"

Whether the question mark belonged to the author himself or had been added later was unclear.

Now the third history too ceased to be stable.

At Darbhanga University Library, Manikant searched for the Village Drama Collection. He found a rare booklet of that title from 1936. Inside was a play called "The Threshold of Grain" - setting: "some village"; characters: "widow," "keeper of the store," "blacksmith," "mother of a child."

The famous sentence was not there word for word, but the structure was familiar: famine. A locked granary. A woman's insistence. The manager's opposition. The blacksmith. Distribution of grain. At the end, an empty measure.

Chandrakishor Lal may have read this play and combined it with local memories to write *The Night of Grain*.

Manikant's notebook was now covered in a web of arrows: 1927 event -> ? -> 1936 published play -> 1948 school play -> 1962/1971 memories -> the two later histories.

But the question mark occupied the largest space.

He read the preface by the author of the Village Drama Collection. It said: "These dramatic seeds are drawn from various famine tales of Bihar and are not based on any single event."

So the 1936 play could not be securely tied to Belwaghat.

Manikant remained in the library until dawn. Earlier he had thought that the third text would prove both histories false. Now the third text established only that the detailed scenes in both histories - the sickle, the blacksmith, the orphaned child's mother, the empty measure, the famous sentence - came more from a theatrical tradition than from historical sources.

The event could still remain an event. The story was the house built around it.

He went again to Belwaghat, this time to Kamala Paswan's house.

Kamala was drying paddy. Manikant opened a facsimile of the play and showed it to her. He read aloud Phulo's dialogue.

Kamala's face tightened.

"Are you trying to say that Phulkali Devi never existed?"

"No. I am saying that the scenes we think we know for certain about her bear the influence of the play."

"My grandmother used to tell stories about her grandmother."

"What did she tell you?"

Kamala was silent for a while.

"She used to say that during the famine the women went to the granary. Phulkali went too."

"The lock?"

"I don't remember."

"The sickle?"

"No."

“That sentence?”

Kamala lowered her eyes. “I first heard that sentence in the school play. But later everyone began to say it was Phulkali’s.”

Manikant said nothing.

Kamala kept turning the paddy. Then she said, “Does that make Phulkali smaller? If she truly went in the crowd, but did not speak a famous line, did not give a speech - then what?”

“No.”

“Then her name ought to be on the memorial.”

Manikant did not answer. It was not his task to make a name larger or smaller.

He went to Aditya Narayan Singh’s haveli. The moment Aditya saw the play he said, “There, you see? Phulo was fictional.”

Manikant opened page five - Raghuvvar Babu, the mother of the orphaned child, the empty measure.

Aditya’s smile disappeared.

“Raghunath Babu’s relief register?”

“Some pages are destroyed.”

“Any order saying that he opened the gate?”

“No.”

“Any old oral memory in the family?”

Aditya thought for a moment. “My grandfather used to say that Raghunath Babu was in the village that night.”

“That much?”

“That much is certain.”

“Did he distribute the grain?”

“He used to say - he prevented disorder.”

“Those were your grandfather’s words?”

“Perhaps my father’s.”

Aditya’s voice grew quieter.

Manikant understood: history is not made only by people who tell lies. Often people cannot bear an empty space around a beloved ancestor. They place a story in that space, and the next generation forgets the join between story and memory.

Back at the office, he tried to write the four lines.

First draft: “During the famine of 1927, villagers gathered here and 134 maunds of paddy came out of the granary. Later sources conflict regarding leadership and the nature of the grain distribution. Many invented scenes from a 1948 school play entered both major later histories. Available contemporary records do not confirm a single leader.”

He read it.

Close to the truth. Bad for stone.

It was read at the committee meeting.

Kamala said, “Phulkali’s name has disappeared.”

Aditya said, “So has Raghunath’s.”

The District Magistrate’s representative said, “If we carve this much dispute on the plaque, the memorial will become a museum.”

Manikant thought: why should a memorial be less than history?

But he remained silent.

At last it was decided that a short text would go on the main stone, while the detailed sources would be kept in an adjoining collection room.

A new proposal for the main stone was requested.

Manikant wrote a second draft: "During the famine of 1927, villagers gathered here and grain came out of the granary. Memories differ concerning the hero, sequence, and nature of the event."

The representative said, "This says almost nothing."

Manikant replied, "It says what is certain."

The meeting broke up again.

Meanwhile, Rekha Kumari telephoned from the school. "Come. We have found something."

Manikant went. While an old school wall was being demolished, a small cloth bundle had been found between the bricks. Inside were three pages of a letter, the ink badly faded. At the top: "Dear Shyam Babu, 21 Bhadra 1948."

The writer: Chandrakishor Lal.

The letter described the preparation of the play: "The village elders do not tell the event in one form. According to some, the people forced open the granary; according to others, the Babu opened it himself. That women had gone there - this much I heard from many mouths. I heard the name of a widow, Phulkali, but how large her role was, no one is certain. For the play I made 'Phulo.' I also heard the name Raghunath, but all the dialogue is mine."

Manikant's heart began to beat hard.

Inside the third text was a fourth piece of evidence.

The letter continued: "The blacksmith, the mother of the orphaned child, the empty measure - all these I took from the play *The Threshold of Grain*, because the stage requires a story. People remember an event; the stage demands a sequence."

And the final line: "My fear is that the children will remember the play, not the event."

Manikant sat down in a chair.

Rekha Kumari said, "His fear came true."

Manikant read the final line of the letter again.

"True - and not entirely true."

"Why?"

"The children remembered the play. But because of the play, the event also survived. Only the two became mixed together."

The letter was extremely valuable, but Manikant did not make the mistake of treating it as "final truth." Chandrakishor too had been hearing the event twenty years later. The "many mouths" he mentioned were unnamed. The letter proved that the scenes in the play were invented; it did not prove that Phulkali's role had been nil or that Raghunath's had been central.

Manikant now had before him three kinds of history: dry contemporary records - gathering, grain, calm. The play of 1948 - scenes, dialogue, characters. Memories of the 1960s and 1970s - family truths coloured by the play.

And a fourth thing: the politics of the present, searching through all of them for its own hero.

Manikant himself designed the collection room. On one wall, the red booklet; on another, the green. In the middle, behind glass, the 1948 Night of Grain. Beneath it, Chandrakishor's letter. To one side, copies of the 1927 police register and tahsil accounts.

He gave the display the title: "The Event and Its Story."

Two days before the opening, Kamala Paswan came to see the collection room. She saw the red booklet on its wall, read the play, read the letter. After a long while she said, "I will give you a photograph of Phulkali."

"You have one?"

"Not certainly. There is an old photograph of a woman in the family. Everyone says it is her."

Manikant smiled. "Then the caption will say: 'Photograph believed by the family to be Phulkali Devi.'"

Kamala frowned at first, then laughed. "Your four lines spoil everything."

"Not the four lines. The word 'believed.'"

The next day Aditya Narayan came too. He brought an account book of Raghunath Babu's. It contained accounts from Asadh and Sawan of 1927. On the page for the Belwaghat granary was an entry: "Balance after night distribution - ..." The quantity was half erased.

"This proves the distribution was administrative," Aditya said.

Manikant looked at the page. "It proves that someone later wrote down the event using the word 'distribution.' Whose hand?"

Aditya did not answer.

"The date?"

"The day after the event."

"Then it is valuable. We will display it."

"Raghunath's name?"

"No."

Aditya was disappointed, but left the account book behind.

On the day of the opening, the main stone was finally installed. After much debate, agreement had been reached on this text: "During the famine of 1927, villagers gathered here and grain came out of the granary. Memories of the event are many; available contemporary records do not confirm a single leader."

No Phulkali. No Raghunath. Manikant knew that both sides were half dissatisfied. Perhaps that was not a bad sign.

There were speeches at the opening. The minister spoke of "people's power." The legislator spoke of "social cooperation." Kamala named Phulkali in her speech. Aditya named Raghunath in his. No stone can stop people's mouths.

Schoolchildren gathered in the collection room. Behind the glass, on a page of the play, stood the famous sentence: "The grain born of the earth shall not be kept from a hungry mouth."

A boy asked Manikant, "Who actually said this?"

Manikant opened his mouth to answer, then saw Chandrakishor's handwriting inside the glass: "All the dialogue is mine."

He said, "According to the evidence we have now, the playwright wrote that sentence."

"Then not Phulkali?"

"She may have said something else."

"Raghunath?"

"He too may have said something else."

The boy looked disappointed. "Then is there less real truth in history?"

Manikant did not laugh. He took him to the 1927 register. "Read this."

The boy read slowly: "Village gathering... granary opened... one hundred and thirty-four maunds of paddy... calm by morning."

"Only that much is real?"

"That much is what the paper says."

"And the rest?"

Manikant looked toward the red booklet, the green booklet, and the play between them. "The rest is what people say."

The boy did not seem entirely satisfied, but he moved on to the next glass case.

By evening the crowd had thinned. Two garlands lay on the main stone - one red, one green. When the wind blew, the ends of the garlands fell across one another and then separated again.

Before closing the collection room, Manikant looked once more at the page of The Night of Grain. He suddenly noticed that beneath the title Chandrakishor had written "history" in pencil and then crossed it out. The cancelled word was still visible.

He did not touch the glass.

The final four-line copy lay on the table. On its back he wrote one sentence for himself: "The third text proved both histories to be stories; but what remained after the stories were removed was not the end of history, but its beginning."

That line did not go on the memorial.

Manikant folded the paper and placed it in his own file.

Outside, only the letters of those two certain facts shone on the stone - people had gathered; grain had come out.

Whose hand had first gone to the gate, which words had come from whose mouth, whom people later made into a hero - all those questions remained outside the stone.

And for the first time Manikant understood that some blank spaces in history are not failures.

Sometimes those blank spaces themselves are evidence that story has not yet completely occupied the place of history.

The Translator

On a winter afternoon in 1983, in the back room of the Darbhanga archives, Naseem Ara saw that sentence for the first time. The room's window was half closed; the smells of dust, old cloth, and parchment mingled in the air. Naseem was twenty-eight then, a research assistant. Her work was to read Persian files and prepare brief descriptions: date, writer, recipient, subject, place.

That day she came upon a slender bundle whose outer slip said only: "Tirhut, private letters, late eighteenth century." There were five letters inside. Four concerned revenue and trade accounts. The fifth was different: a travelling munshi had written to his sister. In Persian he described the family, his journey, illness, rain, and his hope of returning. In the final section stood one sentence that Naseem could read, but when she tried to put it into Maithili her hand stopped.

Its broad meaning was this: a house does not become a foreign land so long as its doorway remains familiar with the voice of the person who returns.

Writing something on paper was easy. Catching the meaning was difficult.

Naseem wrote a first version:

"So long as the doorway recognises the returning voice, the house does not become a foreign land."

She read it. "Voice" sounded artificial to her. Was "returning" right when applied to a person? "The doorway recognises" was beautiful, but the original Persian verb suggested not merely recognition, but acceptance as one's own. And the source word for "house" carried four shadows at once: building, household, dwelling, one's own people.

Naseem put a question mark in the margin.

In the evening the experienced archivist Majid Sahib came into the room. He had a white beard, thin spectacles, and the habit of pulling up a chair and sitting down before a question had even been fully asked. Naseem showed him the sentence.

"Is this translation correct?"

Majid Sahib read it slowly. "Correct?"

"Yes."

"A correct translation and a final translation are not the same thing."

"I want the final one."

Majid Sahib smiled. "Then you will need a great deal of time."

Naseem thought he was joking. She laughed too.

But from that day onward the sentence began to follow her.

The following week she had to submit descriptions for the catalogue. Naseem changed the translation and wrote:

"So long as the threshold recognises the speech of the one who returns, the house does not become alien."

In this version "speech" replaced "voice," "threshold" replaced "doorway," and "alien" replaced "foreign land." But Majid Sahib drew a pencil line beneath "alien."

"Does a house become alien, or does a person?"

Naseem said, "The original carries the sense of 'unfamiliar.'"

"Then saying the house becomes alien may be natural enough. But think about what a Maithili reader will hear."

"Is the translator answerable to the original or to the reader?"

"To both. And, again and again, the two stand in opposition to each other."

That day, for the first time, Naseem wrote at the top of a small notebook: "Sentence 17: Possible Versions." Beneath it she copied the two translations. She put the notebook in her bag.

Three years later her research paper was published. Its subject was the language of correspondence, but on one page the sentence was quoted. The editor suggested replacing "threshold" with "doorway," because "threshold" seemed too poetic to him. Naseem disagreed. In the end the printed form was: "So long as the doorway recognises the speech of the one who returns, the house does not become a foreign land."

The moment Naseem saw it in print, the translation seemed impure to her.

Meanwhile, at home, her mother, Shamima Khatoon, delivered a different judgment on the sentence. Her mother knew no Persian, but possessed a treasury of Maithili songs and sayings. Naseem showed her the notebook.

Her mother said, "A doorway recognising speech - that sounds stiff. A doorway recognises people's feet, not their voices."

"The original has voice."

"Then say house, not doorway."

"The original has doorway."

Her mother laughed. "Will you become a slave to the original, or will you understand what it is saying?"

That sentence reminded Naseem of Majid Sahib. A translator has two masters, perhaps three: the original, the reader, and one's own ear.

By 1990 Naseem was teaching at the university. The sentence became an example in her classes. She would give the students the word-for-word meaning of the original, then write five Maithili versions on the board. The class would split into two camps. Some said: preserve "foreign land," because distance exists in the original. Others said: "alien" is better, because the feeling is one of belonging. Some opposed "speech" and wanted "voice." Others argued that "voice" is merely bodily sound, while "speech" carries both language and recognition.

Naseem wrote down every argument. The notebook grew thick.

In 1994 Majid Sahib died. When his library was auctioned, Naseem bought an old Persian dictionary that had belonged to him. In many places there were pencil notes in his hand. Beside the entry for the verb in the original sentence - the very verb that had troubled Naseem - Majid had written: "Not merely to be familiar; also to be accepted as one's own."

Naseem stared at that line for a long time.

Then she remembered her first translation: "recognises."

Was recognition enough?

That night she wrote a new version in her notebook:

"So long as the threshold of the house accepts the returning voice as its own, the house does not become a foreign land."

“Accepts as its own” seemed closer to the original, but now the threshold began to behave like a human being. The sentence was beautiful, perhaps too beautiful. Naseem was wary of excessive beauty in translation. Sometimes a translation places flowers over the original’s complexity and hides its face.

Above the sentence she wrote: “Too beautiful?” and added a question mark.

By this time her daughter Sahar had turned twenty. Sahar left Darbhanga to study in Delhi. When she returned home for the first time, more Hindi words had entered her Maithili. Shamima teased her: “Did you go to Delhi, or did you come back with a new tongue?”

Sahar laughed. “Nani, if my words have changed, have I changed too?”

“No, but Delhi has entered your speech.”

Naseem involuntarily connected that exchange with the sentence. The doorway recognises the “speech” of the one who returns – but what if the speech has changed?

That night Sahar sat in her old room with a book open before her. Naseem asked, “How do you understand this sentence?”

Sahar read: “So long as the threshold of the house accepts the returning voice as its own, the house does not become a foreign land.”

“It’s beautiful,” she said.

“Meaning?”

“So long as the people at home accept you.”

Naseem was startled. “The people at home?”

“Yes – the threshold is a symbol. The people of the house.”

“I was taking the threshold as a threshold.”

“Then it becomes like a ghost story – the threshold recognises a voice.”

They both laughed. But something lodged inside Naseem. Her 1994 version was metaphor for her daughter; for Naseem it had been almost literal personification. The same Maithili, yet a different language of reading.

In 1998 Naseem was invited to read a paper at a conference in London. The subject was the translation of South Asian private correspondence. For the conference, the organisers asked for an English translation of the original sentence. Naseem spent three weeks on that single line.

The first English version seemed harsh to her. The second was excessively poetic. The third had “home,” but lost the source word’s sense of household. The fourth had “threshold,” but the social meaning of a threshold was weaker for an English reader. The fifth used “speech,” which she feared would be heard as an address or formal utterance. “Voice” felt intimate, but language disappeared.

In the end she chose one form for the conference paper and added a footnote explaining that the source words for “home,” “doorway,” and “recognise” each carried several shades of meaning.

During the question-and-answer session an elderly translator asked, “If three words are so unstable, why did you choose a single translation?”

Naseem said, “One has to give the reader something.”

The man smiled. “Sometimes a translator also gives the reader an inaccurate certainty.”

That night Naseem returned to her lodging and opened the notebook. The 1983 version was on the first page. The paper had begun to yellow. She wrote: "The translator's offence: making an unstable thing appear stable."

Time passed. Shamima Khatoon died. Her low wooden seat on the osara of the old house stood empty. Sahar began working in Delhi. Naseem became head of her university department and later retired. The notebooks were now three - red, green, blue. All contained versions of the same sentence, comments, students' opinions, dictionary quotations, and her own dissatisfaction.

In 2007 the archives were renovated. Facsimiles were made of the old bundles. Naseem was called in as an adviser. Twenty-four years later she saw the original letter again, not in her hand but beneath glass. The ink had faded, the paper's edge was broken, yet the sentence remained exactly as it had been.

She was astonished: the original had not changed. She herself had.

The new project had a young research assistant, Deepti Jha. Deepti had read Naseem's old article. With enthusiasm she said, "Acharyaji, your famous sentence!"

Naseem laughed. "Famous not because of me; because of my failure."

Deepti read the old printed form: "So long as the doorway recognises the speech of the one who returns, the house does not become a foreign land."

She said, "It sounds rather old-fashioned now."

Naseem felt a slight sting. "Which word?"

"The whole movement of the sentence. 'Does not become a foreign land' - my generation might perhaps say 'does not become alien.' And 'the one who returns' is fine, but people raised in cities might understand 'the one who comes back' more immediately."

At "comes back," Naseem's face tightened. "The meaning is clear, but my ear still looks for the older cadence."

Deepti immediately fell silent. "Yes. I was only speaking from the reader's side."

Naseem regretted her reaction. As a student, she herself had argued for the reader before Majid Sahib; now she was becoming a guard posted over words.

That evening Deepti stopped her in the archive courtyard for tea. The employees came from different districts - some from Madhubani, some Supaul, some Sitamarhi, some Janakpur. Each had a different rhythm in Maithili. One employee, saying "my home," meant a house in Nepal. Another, saying "home," meant a rented room in Darbhanga. A third meant the village where his parents lived.

Naseem listened.

The word "home" had not changed. The lives around it had.

In 2011 Sahar came to Darbhanga with her daughter Anaya. Anaya was twelve. She understood Maithili, but again and again replied in a mixture of Hindi and English. Had Shamima been alive, she might have said: "Your tongue has changed." Naseem said nothing of the sort. She listened to the child's speech.

One day Anaya saw her grandmother's notebooks.

"Are all of these the same sentence?"

Naseem smiled. "Yes. The same sentence."

"So many times?"

"I never found the right form."

Anaya tried to read the first Maithili version. “So long as the doorway... re... the speech of the returner... recognises...”

She stopped. “Does ‘recognises’ mean to know someone?”

“Yes, but not only to know.”

“Then ‘accepts as one’s own’?”

“That too is one version.”

Anaya thought for a while. “When I come here from Delhi, does the doorway recognise me?”

“What do you think?”

“Not the doorway. You recognise me.”

Naseem laughed. “Then your translation?”

Anaya tried to answer in Maithili: “Where, when you come back... people, even if your speech has changed... still take you as their own... that is home?”

The sentence was grammatically uneven, but Naseem suddenly heard in it the shade of the original verb that Majid Sahib had glossed as “to be accepted as one’s own.”

She copied the child’s sentence into her notebook exactly as it was.

“It’s wrong,” Anaya said.

“How wrong?”

“The Maithili.”

“The meaning?”

Anaya shrugged. “That is probably right.”

Naseem remembered that answer for many years.

In 2016 a publisher asked her to prepare an edited edition of the letters. Naseem agreed on one condition: there would be an extended note on that sentence. At first the publisher agreed. When the manuscript was ready, the editor telephoned.

“Seven pages of commentary on one sentence is too much.”

“It took forty years.”

“Readers will not read seven pages.”

“Then four pages.”

“One footnote.”

Naseem fell silent.

The editor said, “We need one authoritative translation. We can put the alternative versions in an appendix.”

Naseem’s attention caught on the word “authoritative.” For four decades she had searched for authority; now the publisher was giving it to her because of her name.

“I am not authoritative,” she said.

Silence on the other end.

“You are the most senior scholar in this field.”

“Being senior does not mean being right.”

In the end, the book was postponed. Naseem felt sorrow, but also relief.

After 2020 university classes began to take place at a distance. Though retired, Naseem occasionally gave guest lectures. On the screen appeared students’ names from different cities and countries - Patna, Delhi, Kathmandu, Doha, Toronto. One day she gave them the sentence again.

“Translate it into Maithili.”

The students laughed. “Acharyaji, the source is Persian; we do not know Persian.”
“I will give you the word meanings. You do the translation.”

She explained the semantic range of the source's main words: house/household/dwelling; doorway/threshold; familiar/one's own; the returning person's voice/speech.

Fifteen minutes later eight versions appeared on the screen.

One student had written: “Where your speech, on returning, is no longer strange, that home is not a foreign land.”

A student wrote: “Home is the place where even a changed voice is accepted as one's own.”

Another: “So long as the door is not closed to your speech even after you return, the home survives.”

Naseem stopped at the third version. Nowhere in the original was there a word meaning “closed.” But for a migrant student, the most intense meaning of a doorway was entry.

She asked, “Where did you bring this ‘closed’ from?”

The student replied, “It may not be in the original. But when I hear ‘the doorway knows you,’ this is what I understand.”

Earlier, Naseem would have answered: “Then this is interpretation, not translation.” Now she merely wrote down: “2020: the reader hears the doorway as a right of entry.”

Four years later, in 2024, the archives asked again for all of her notes. This time the aim was a digital critical edition in which many versions could be placed together. Deepti was now in charge of the project. She came to Naseem's home.

“Acharyaji, now we can keep not seven pages, but seventy.”

Naseem laughed. “Then shall we frighten the reader?”

Deepti looked through all three notebooks - red, green, blue. “These are invaluable.”

“Not invaluable. They are an account of dissatisfaction.”

“That is precisely why they are valuable.”

The project began to take shape. Naseem had every version from 1983 to 2024 typed out with its date. On some pages she felt embarrassed the moment she saw her old rendering. Some filled her with affection. Some she could not even remember having written.

The strangest experience was that the Maithili of 1983 now sounded “old” to her ear. A form that had seemed completely ordinary then had, four decades later, become a marker of style. The words remained in the dictionary, but their weight in people's mouths had changed.

In her youth, “foreign land” had chiefly been a weighty word for a region or country far from home. Now, in migrant families, Delhi, Doha, Dubai, Patna, and Kathmandu repeatedly occupied points along the same line of life. “Speech” had once comfortably meant the sound of the household; now it also carried political and educational weight as a marker of linguistic identity. “Home” had expanded from the ancestral family house to a rented dwelling, a hostel, a residence abroad, and the domestic voices heard every day over the telephone.

The original Persian sentence remained exactly as it was.

The target language kept moving around it.

By the beginning of 2026 the critical edition was almost ready. Deepti proposed: "On the main page we'll give your latest translation, followed by 'Earlier Versions.'"

Naseem agreed, but the word "latest" made her uneasy. She thought: what should I write?

She spent three days on it. One version on the first day. Crossed out on the second. Five versions on the third. That night Sahar telephoned. Anaya was now studying linguistics. Three generations spoke together.

Sahar said, "Ammi, now I like your first version best."

Naseem laughed. "The one that sounded like a ghost story to you when you were twenty?"

"Yes. Now I understand the personification of the threshold."

Anaya said, "I like the idea in 'even a changed voice is accepted as one's own.'"

Naseem asked, "The original has no 'changed.'"

"When the original was written, the question of the returner's voice changing may have stood differently before the writer. It stands before me now."

Naseem was silent. At one time that sentence would have sounded to her like a violation of discipline. Now it sounded like a difficult truth.

"Then will translation keep going outside the original?"

Anaya said, "No. The reader exists inside time. The original does not exist outside time either."

Naseem gave no answer. The call ended.

That night she took out Majid Sahib's old dictionary. The pencil note was still clear: "Not merely to be familiar; also to be accepted as one's own."

She remembered Majid Sahib's face. In 1983 he had said, "You will need a great deal of time."

Naseem smiled softly.

She had been given a great deal of time.

Not a complete translation.

The next morning she wrote the principal version:

"So long as the threshold of the house continues to accept the voice that has returned as its own, the house will not become a foreign land."

She read it. "The voice that has returned" - as though the voice itself, rather than the human being, had come back. "Accept as its own" - holding both recognition and belonging from the source. "Will not become a foreign land" - preserving the possibility of distance.

Beneath it she wrote the date: 2026.

Then she added one line: "Version for this time."

When Deepti saw the manuscript, she asked, "Not 'Final Translation'?"

Naseem opened the red notebook. On the first page was the handwriting from 1983: "Sentence 17: Possible Versions."

"For forty years I searched for 'final,'" she said. "Language kept moving faster than I did."

"Then which form will we treat as the principal one in the edition?"

"The 2026 one. Because the reader will read it in 2026. But do not print it as though it cancels all the others."

“How?”

Naseem sketched a layout. On the main page would be a facsimile of the source sentence. Alongside it, the Maithili versions of 1983, 1994, 2007, 2011, 2020, and 2026. Beneath each, a brief note: why the translator chose a particular word at that time, and why she later became dissatisfied with it.

Deepti smiled. “This is no longer a translation. It has become the translator’s life.”

Naseem said, “Perhaps that is what translation is – an accounting of one’s life between languages.”

“Shall we print that line too?”

“No. It is too beautiful.”

They both laughed.

When the edition was published, more readers than expected stopped at that one page. Researchers argued over word meanings. Migrant readers preferred the 2020 version. Elderly readers preferred the 1983 form. Someone wrote: preserve “foreign land.” Someone else: “alien” is deeper. Someone asked whether the source writer had meant “doorway” literally or metaphorically. Naseem read every question and answered few.

One day a small letter arrived by post. Its writer was a schoolteacher in Janakpur. He wrote that the students had been given the six versions and asked to write a seventh. At the end of the letter were twenty translations.

Naseem read them one by one. Some were grammatically uneven, some highly ornamented, some astonishingly plain. One student had written:

“Where people hear your changed speech and say, ‘You have come back,’ that is home.”

The original had no “people.” Nor did it have “you have come back.” The structure of the Persian sentence had almost disappeared.

Yet Naseem’s eyes remained on that line for a long time.

She heard her mother Shamima’s voice: “A doorway recognises people’s feet.” She remembered Sahar’s face at twenty. Anaya’s uneven Maithili. Majid Sahib’s pencil. Deepti’s remark that the sentence sounded “old-fashioned.”

Naseem had spent four decades searching for the translation of a single sentence. In that time the paper of the original grew old, Majid Sahib died, her mother died, her daughter went away, her granddaughter’s speech changed, university classrooms moved onto screens, and Maithili itself took a thousand small directions in a thousand mouths.

In what moment’s language, then, could a complete translation exist?

On the back of the letter she wrote by hand: “Not the seventh version; the next version.”

Then she stopped. “Next” too demanded time.

She crossed it out and wrote: “Another version.”

That afternoon Deepti telephoned. The web page of the new edition needed a title. “Acharyaji, what shall we call the section – the Maithili for ‘Final Translation?’”

Naseem looked out of the window. The sky after rain was clear. Two children were playing in the lane and speaking Maithili, but their words carried many influences of the city. An elderly woman in the house opposite called to them from

inside; the children answered. All three voices belonged to the same language, and yet not quite the same.

Naseem said, "Write: 'This Time's Translation.'"

Deepti laughed. "And in the next edition?"

"Next Time's."

After ending the call, Naseem opened her red notebook again. Years earlier she had written "Possible Versions" at the top of the first page. Beneath it the two sentences were still there - one with "voice," one with "speech."

She crossed out nothing.

In the blank space on the page she wrote only the date: 2026. Beside it, in small letters: "Language has reached this point."

As she closed the notebook, Naseem understood that the translation of the original sentence might never be complete. But this incompleteness was not defeat. Completion would be possible only if both source and target language stood still. Language does not stand still. It walks with people, leaves home, returns, changes pronunciation, lightens or deepens the weight of old words, and new readers leave the marks of their feet upon old thresholds.

Before Naseem lay a facsimile of the original Persian sentence. It had not changed. But the paths leading to that sentence had changed continually.

She read her 2026 version once more:

"So long as the threshold of the house continues to accept the voice that has returned as its own, the house will not become a foreign land."

This time she did not write "Final" beneath it.

Only the date.

And she left a blank space - for the language that would come next.

The Nameless Deity

While collecting folktales, Vibha Jha had quickly learned one thing: a village tale is never merely a tale. Bound to it are paths, trees, ponds, lineages, seasons, fears, honour, quarrels, and often silence as well. But when she reached Kachnariya, she understood for the first time that sometimes the most essential part of a story is precisely what people deliberately refuse to say.

Kachnariya stood two kos east of an old channel of the Kamala. The river no longer flowed through that channel, yet the village elders still identified the old direction by saying "toward the Kamala." Vibha arrived in the last week of Bhadon. The paddy leaves were deep green, the first white flowers of kans were opening along the pond, and in the evenings the sound of pounding grain came from house after house.

She had been invited by Arvind Paswan, a teacher at the village school. Vibha was making audio recordings of disappearing oral traditions for a folk-culture centre in Darbhanga. Arvind had written in a letter: "Our village has the story of 'the deity whose name must not be spoken.' The elders still tell it. Ten years from now, perhaps no one will."

When Vibha first read the letter she had laughed. "The deity whose name must not be spoken" sounded like a title. But once she reached the village, Arvind gave her his first warning: "You may give it whatever title you like, but do not be too quick to ask the name in front of people."

"There is a name?"

"There is."

"You know it?"

Arvind smiled faintly. "I have heard it."

"Then why not write it down?"

"The difficulty here is not writing. It is saying."

Taking out her notebook, Vibha asked, "What do you mean?"

Instead of answering, Arvind looked toward the peepal tree in front of them. Beneath it stood a small earthen platform. There was no idol, no flag. Only a slender brass bell and an engraved sign resembling seven leaves.

"Devanath Kaka will sit there this evening," Arvind said. "Begin the story with him."

Devanath Mandal was around seventy-five, thin-bodied, sharp-eyed, with a tobacco leaf almost always tucked behind one ear. When Vibha introduced herself, he first examined the audio recorder.

"Will this keep everything we say?"

"Yes. Whatever you say will remain, together with your voice."

"And if I close my mouth, will it keep that too?"

Vibha laughed. "Silence is not a sound."

Devanath said, "In this story, it is."

Vibha stopped laughing.

Evening air moved beneath the peepal. Arvind sat a little distance away with two schoolchildren. Without touching the bell, Devanath traced a circle in the earth beneath it with his finger.

"The deity does not live here," he said. "This is only the place where the story comes to rest."

Vibha switched on the recorder.

Devanath began. Long ago, when the Kamala still flowed through its old channel, Kachnariya was uprooted three times. The first time, the water swallowed the fields. The second, fever emptied half the village. The third, a land dispute between two lineages grew so bitter that people began keeping watch at night.

During that third crisis, an unknown child came to the village. No one knew the child's parents, caste, or place of origin. For three days the child ate in different houses; on the fourth, the child sat beneath the peepal and listened to the quarrelling villagers.

"Did the child decide the dispute?" Vibha asked.

"No. There were plenty of people to make decisions. The child only asked: 'Do you remember the land, or only the boundary?'"

"Meaning?"

"People remembered the fields - where the mahua tree stood, where a plough had first cut the earth, where their mothers sang during transplanting. But the quarrel was about the boundary. The child told everyone to speak the memory of their own field. For three nights people told stories. On the fourth morning the boundary posts were set again. The quarrel stopped."

Vibha kept writing. The tale seemed to be opening like an ordinary folktale of local justice.

"And then the child became a deity?"

Devanath narrowed his eyes. "People were the ones who needed to call the child a deity. The child left on the fifth day."

"The name?"

Devanath fell silent. The leaves of the peepal rustled.

Vibha did not repeat the question.

He continued. After the child left, people in the village began using different forms of address: "the one of memory," "the child beyond the boundary," "the guest beneath the peepal," "the one who listens." Years passed. Whenever a new dispute arose, people sat beneath the peepal and spoke the memories of their fields. Gradually the platform was built, and the bell was hung.

"Why the bell?"

"Once before the story begins. Twice when the story is complete."

"When was the name spoken?"

Devanath looked at the ground. "Long ago, only when teaching a new storyteller."

"Who taught it?"

"The old storyteller."

"What happened when the name was spoken?"

Devanath's finger erased the circle in the earth. "A price had to be paid."

"What kind of price?"

"A memory."

Vibha thought this must be a rule within the tale. "In exchange for remembering the deity's name, one memory has to be given up?"

Devanath did not laugh. "As soon as the name leaves the mouth, one thing disappears from the storyteller. You do not know beforehand what it will be. You discover it later."

Vibha looked at the red light on the recorder. It was still recording.

"Do you know the name?"

Devanath did not answer.

"How many times have you spoken it?"

"Twice."

"What did you forget?"

Devanath remained silent for a long time. Then he said, "The first time, my teacher taught me the name. I repeated it. That evening when I went home, my mother asked, 'What story did your father tell you today?' I could no longer remember my father's voice. I remembered his face, remembered what he said, but not the sound of his voice."

"And the second time?"

"A researcher came, many years ago. He said his article would be incomplete without the name. I whispered it to him. After that..."

Devanath's voice stopped.

"What did you forget?"

"The place where I first met my wife. I remember the event. I remember that she was there. But the place has been erased."

Without thinking, Vibha stopped the recorder.

"Why did you stop it?" Devanath asked.

"That's enough."

"Keep the voice. A story does not survive because of fear."

Vibha switched the recorder on again, but did not ask for the name.

That night she stayed at Arvind's house. After dinner she sat on the veranda listening to the recording. Devanath's narration was clear. Between passages came the peepal leaves, a distant dog, a child's cough. At the point where the name was discussed, there was an unusual pause in the sound.

Setting down tea, Arvind asked, "Do you believe it now?"

"Believe what?"

"That speaking the name erases a memory."

"I do not believe anything yet. I am only documenting."

"Documenting is also a kind of believing."

Vibha fell silent.

"Have you heard the name?"

Arvind shook his head. "When I was a child. My grandmother said it by mistake."

"Then what did she forget?"

"That day she said: nothing. But a week later she could no longer remember the name of her mother's natal village. I do not know whether she had remembered it before. People join things together."

"So you do not believe this?"

“Belief and caution are different things. Whether fire is a deity or a chemical reaction, you still do not put your hand into it.”

The next day Vibha met another storyteller in the village - Phulkumari Devi. She was over eighty, but her voice was full. Wedding songs, flood stories, Chhath melodies - she could recite them all without pause. The moment she heard mention of the nameless deity, she said, “The men have made that story their own. The real story belongs to the women.”

Vibha's eyes brightened. “Tell me.”

In Phulkumari's telling, the story changed. According to her, it was not an unknown boy but a young girl who had come, a girl who had lost her home in a flood. She had not settled a land dispute, but a quarrel over sharing water from a well. She did not ask people about boundaries, but about the memory of thirst: “From whose hand did you first drink water in your home?”

Vibha asked, “Then the deity beneath the peepal was female?”

Phulkumari laughed. “Does a deity ask about gender?”

“The name?”

Phulkumari raised her hand at once. “Not that question.”

“You know it?”

“My mother taught me.”

“Have you spoken it?”

“Once.”

“What did you forget?”

Phulkumari's face changed. She looked toward the red chillies drying in the distant courtyard.

“My first child died at six months. For many years I could hear the child's crying. After I spoke the name, the sound disappeared.”

Vibha's hand stopped over her notebook.

“Did the grief lessen?”

“No. The grief remained. The voice went.”

That answer followed Vibha throughout the day.

Until then the story had been, for her, a folk belief whose social meaning, workings of memory, and prohibitions had to be understood. But Phulkumari's sentence - “The grief remained. The voice went.” - brought the belief closer to the human body.

On the third day Vibha asked permission to examine the brass bell. It was taken down. On its inner rim there were four faint marks that looked like letters, obscured by corrosion, soot, and rain stains. Vibha examined them with a magnifying glass. The first was perhaps “sa.” The second might be “ma” or “bha.” The third was a curve. The fourth was almost erased.

“Could this be the name?” she asked Arvind.

“People say so.”

“How old is the bell?”

“No one knows for certain. Perhaps seventy or eighty years.”

“But the story is said to be older than that.”

“Yes.”

Vibha photographed the bell, but did not try to decipher the letters. She felt a small pride in this restraint - a pride that broke the very next morning.

Four children came to the school to see her audio recorder. The youngest, ten-year-old Neel, wanted to press its buttons. Vibha stopped him. "This is not a toy."

Neel saw the photograph of the bell. "That's the name."

Vibha was startled. "You can read it?"

"My grandfather told me."

"Don't say it." Arvind's voice sharpened.

Neel laughed. "I won't. Grandfather says that if you speak it, the story runs away."

When the children had gone, Vibha looked at Arvind.

"A ten-year-old knows it?"

"Some children hear it. The prohibition is not absolute."

"Then why has the tradition not broken?"

"Perhaps the rule is not meant to hide the name, but to teach the weight of the name."

Vibha wrote that answer down.

That evening Devanath returned to tell the story again. This time Vibha told him Phulkumari's version. Devanath listened attentively.

"A girl?"

"Yes."

"A well?"

"Yes."

Devanath smiled. "That may be right."

"Yesterday you said it was a boy."

"My father used to say it was a boy."

"Phulkumari's mother said it was a girl."

"Both stories live."

"Then who is the deity?"

"The one who listens to the story."

Vibha grew impatient. "That answer makes my work difficult. To make an archival entry I need a name, local forms, tale type, storyteller, place - everything."

Devanath said, "The archive does not need a deity. It needs boxes."

"Without boxes, how will anyone else find it?"

"We found it without a name."

Vibha was silent. She remembered the ethics of her profession. Whenever she asked someone for a story, she always said: "If there is something you do not wish to tell, do not tell it." Yet somewhere inside, she loved completeness. An incomplete record troubled her. Here the whole story stopped behind one word.

That day Devanath himself said, "You want the name?"

Vibha wanted at once to say no, but her voice did not come.

Devanath read her face. "For your work."

"No. If there is a price..."

"The price is mine."

"But the request is mine."

Devanath looked at the bell. "If the name remains only a source of fear, the story will die. Sometimes someone must hear it."

“Why?”

“So that they know the silence is not an empty space.”

Vibha switched off the recorder. “If you tell me, it will not be recorded.”

Devanath nodded.

Evening was deepening beneath the peepal. Arvind moved away. Only Vibha and Devanath remained. The bell was still.

Devanath whispered four syllables.

Vibha could not write that word here; she did not write it in her notebook either. Hearing it, she was surprised by how ordinary it sounded. It was neither mysterious nor difficult to pronounce. It was a word that sat easily in a Maithili mouth. Its meaning too seemed connected with something ordinary.

After speaking the name, Devanath closed his eyes. For a few moments nothing happened.

Vibha exhaled.

“Are you all right?”

“Yes.”

“What do you remember?”

Devanath opened his eyes. “What?”

“Who am I?”

He laughed. “Vibha. From Darbhanga. You catch voices.”

“Your wife?”

“Savitri.”

“Your mother?”

“Janaki.”

“The story?”

“Which story?”

A shiver passed through Vibha’s body.

“The nameless deity.”

Devanath furrowed his brow. “The one beneath the peepal?”

“Yes.”

“What happened in it?”

Vibha gripped her notebook. “Yesterday you told me - the Kamala’s old channel, three uprootings, a child...”

Devanath listened, but his face was blank.

“Three uprootings?”

“You told me.”

“I did?”

“Yes.”

Devanath looked toward the peepal. “Strange. I remember the rule of the bell. I remember the name. But the story...”

He could not finish the sentence.

For the first time, Vibha felt fear. Not of the deity. Of her own question.

“I am sorry.”

Devanath stopped her. “Will an apology bring the story back?”

Vibha’s eyes filled.

“It is in the recorder,” she said. “Everything is there.”

Devanath smiled slowly. "Then my memory has gone into your little box?"

Vibha looked at the small black recorder. Suddenly it felt heavy.

"Would you like to listen?"

Devanath thought for a long time. "No. Not now."

Vibha did not sleep that night. She could write the name down. The word she had heard remained perfectly clear. Four syllables. If she wished, she could fill it into the Centre's catalogue record and the archive would become "complete."

But Devanath's story was no longer inside Devanath.

She opened her notebook. After "Local name of deity:" there was a blank line. Vibha put down her pen, lifted it again, and finally wrote: "Unpublished because of a community prohibition."

Beneath that: "The name is not present in the audio recording either."

This was not a lie. The recorder had been off when the name was spoken.

But it was recorded in her memory.

The next morning Phulkumari came to see Vibha. News travelled quickly through the village.

"He told you the name?"

Vibha lowered her head.

"What did he lose?"

"The whole story."

There was neither surprise nor anger on Phulkumari's face, only weariness.

"Didn't I tell you?"

"You warned me."

"You asked him?"

"Yes."

"Then half the price is yours as well."

"What have I lost?"

Phulkumari replied, "You do not know yet."

The sentence lodged inside Vibha like a thorn.

All day she tested her own memory. Her parents' faces? Remembered. Her first school? Remembered. Her first meeting with her husband? Remembered. The day her daughter was born? Remembered. The roof of her Darbhanga house? Remembered.

Nothing was gone.

In the evening she went to Devanath's house. He was sorting maize kernels in the courtyard. Vibha did not take out her notebook.

"Kaka, would you like to hear the story again?"

"In your voice?"

"I can read it."

"Read."

Using her notes, Vibha began telling the story: the old channel of the Kamala; three uprootings; the child; memories of the land; three nights of storytelling; the peepal; the bell.

From time to time Devanath interrupted: "Did I say that line like this?"

"Almost."

"What does 'almost' mean?"

"The words may have been different."

Halfway through the story Devanath suddenly said, "There was no child there. There was an old blind man."

Vibha stopped. "Yesterday you said a child."

"Now I remember an old blind man."

"Is the memory returning?"

"Or is a new story being made?"

For the first time, Vibha smiled.

She finished reading. Devanath listened, but at the end said, "It sounds like my story, but it is not mine."

"Why?"

"Because now I am the listener."

Over the next week Vibha recorded the story from different people in Kachnariya. Thirty-four-year-old Meena Devi said the deity was not a boy, but a girl who carried water. Fifty-five-year-old Suresh Mandal said it was only a voice heard at the boundaries of fields. Seventeen-year-old Pramod said the deity was "the man who never asked anyone's name."

Neel, the ten-year-old, began: "Once a person came to the village whose name everyone knew, but no one said aloud."

Vibha asked in surprise, "Everyone knew?"

Neel said proudly, "I know it too."

"Don't say it."

"Do you think I'm a fool?"

All the children laughed.

Vibha understood: the prohibition was not stopping the story; it was leaving room for the story to take many forms. If the name became a fixed public sign, perhaps people would tighten the tale around it. The vacancy of the name left space for the figure to become a child, a girl, a voice, an old man - all of them.

But this literary explanation did not return Devanath's lost memory. For that reason Vibha did not feel wholly satisfied with her understanding.

On her final working day, a message arrived from the Centre: "Complete the entry and send it. Deity's name, local spelling, alternative names, worship date, list of principal storytellers required."

Vibha opened the form.

"Name of deity:"

She wrote: "Pronunciation restricted; not to be published without the consent of storyteller/community."

"Local spelling:"

"Not recorded."

"Alternative names:"

"The One Who Listens; Guest Beneath the Peepal; Child Beyond the Boundary; Listener to Thirst; other forms."

"Worship date:"

"No fixed worship; bell used on occasions of dispute or collective memory-telling."

"Principal storytellers:"

Devanath Mandal, Phulkumari Devi, and others.

Then she added a note: "In this tradition, silence, the prohibition on the name, and variations in the story are themselves elements of the tradition; the blank space should not be treated as an archival deficiency and filled."

Vibha read the note three times. She was afraid she might be trying to turn her own wrongdoing into a theory in order to protect herself.

She went to Devanath and read the form aloud.

Devanath said, "It is right."

"I know the name."

"Know it."

"If I die?"

"Then one fewer person will know."

"If the name is lost completely?"

Devanath looked at the bell. "If the story survives, why is the name necessary?"

"Perhaps there is meaning in the name."

"Perhaps."

"And what if the name itself opens the story?"

"Then one day someone will search for it again. But your work does not require you to open every door."

Vibha did not write that sentence down. She merely remembered it.

On the day Vibha left Kachnariya, a small gathering formed beneath the peepal. There was no worship, no formal farewell. Phulkumari rang the bell once. Neel and his friends began telling the story. The children corrected one another: "No, it wasn't a boy." "My grandmother says it was a girl." "My grandfather says it was an old blind man."

Devanath sat to one side and listened. Sometimes recognition crossed his face; sometimes surprise.

The story reached the point where the guest was to be given a name. Neel fell silent. The other children did too. The peepal leaves rustled. A silence the length of a breath remained.

Then Neel carried the story forward - without the name.

Vibha's recorder was running. The red light shone. This time she understood: the recorder kept silence too. Not sound, but the time between two sentences.

The pause lasted about four beats.

Vibha did not cut it out.

Back in Darbhanga, the Centre's editor examined the entry.

"No name?"

"We will not publish it."

"Then it will be difficult to find."

"There are alternative names."

"You know it?"

Vibha paused for a moment. "Yes."

"Then at least in a closed register?"

Vibha remembered Devanath's blank eyes when he had failed to recognise his own story. She remembered Phulkumari's sentence: "The grief remained. The voice went."

“No.”

The editor kept looking at her. “This is unusual by the rules of research.”

“The rules of the tradition are part of the source too.”

There was an argument. In the end the entry was accepted without the name, on the condition that the field notes clearly explained why.

Months passed. The recordings from Kachnariya entered the Centre's collection. The title “The Nameless Deity” was not Vibha's; an archive employee supplied it. Vibha did not object. The title was not wholly true – there was a name – but public namelessness was closer to the truth.

Six months later Vibha returned to Kachnariya. This time mustard was flowering on the old bed of the Kamala. The peepal had new leaves. A new cord had been tied to the bell.

Devanath was well. The moment he saw her he said, “The catcher of voices has returned.”

“My name?”

“Vibha.”

“The story?”

Devanath smiled. “Some of it.”

He began of his own accord: “Long ago a village was uprooted three times...”

Vibha's heart began to beat faster.

“Then?”

“A person came. A child or an old man – that is not clear to me.”

“And then?”

“He told everyone: speak the memory of your land.”

Vibha listened without interruption. Half the tale resembled Devanath's older telling; the other half resembled the children's newer versions. In places, Phulkumari's well had entered it too.

“Where did you remember all this from?” Vibha finally asked.

Devanath said, “People kept telling it. I kept listening.”

“Then your own story returned?”

“No. The village's story is settling inside me again. What was there before may have been different.”

The answer made Vibha both sad and relieved.

“Do you remember the name?”

Devanath glared playfully. “That road again?”

They both laughed.

In the evening the bell rang. Phulkumari did not come this time; the pain in her knees had worsened. Neel sat down to tell the story. Devanath sat before him as a listener. Vibha sat behind them.

At the place of the name, silence came again.

Four beats.

Perhaps five.

This time Vibha heard the name automatically inside her mind – four syllables, clear. She could have opened her mouth. No one was there to stop her. Perhaps she would lose nothing by speaking it; the rule concerned the storyteller, not the listener.

But she did not open her mouth.

Neel crossed the silence and continued the story.

When the tale was complete, the bell rang twice.

The first note went into the leaves of the peepal. The second travelled toward the distant mustard fields.

Vibha switched off the recorder. Then she opened a new page in the catalogue register.

The box marked "Name" was still blank.

Instead of filling it, she drew a fine line around the box so that the next researcher would understand: this place had not been omitted; it had been deliberately left empty.

The children ran laughing toward their homes. Devanath took down the bell, wiped it with a cloth, and hung it back up.

Vibha wanted to repeat the name once in her mind, only to test whether she still remembered it. But she stopped herself.

Some memories do not need to be called again and again in order to survive.

Some names, perhaps, are safest in memory when the story keeps moving around them - and the mouth falls silent at exactly the place where a word could have been.

The Path of Time

On the map, the old footpath of Sirsiya village was a straight line, but on the ground it had never been straight. In one place it curved to spare the roots of a mango tree; elsewhere the monsoon water cut through it and people filled earth to make a new way along the side; where a field embankment thickened, the path simply took its edge. Since childhood Neelima had felt that this path was like the people of the village: one thing on paper, another in use.

This time it was because of that very footpath that she had to return to Sirsiya.

Seven years had passed since her father's death. Her mother lived with Neelima in the city. The division of the ancestral land remained incomplete on paper. Neelima wanted to have her share demarcated separately and give it out on sharecropping; her elder brother Shekhar said that the narrow western path could not be separated because it was an old village thoroughfare and ran along the edge of his field.

"The path runs along the edge of your field," Neelima had said, "so on paper it will fall within your share."

Shekhar had replied, "Let it fall wherever it does on paper. Baba said the footpath was not to be closed. People would continue to use it."

"Baba also told me that the western strip would be my share."

"It will be. But the path is a different thing."

"How can the same piece of land be two different things?"

Shekhar had fallen silent. After that, each sat clinging to a sentence of their own: Baba told me this.

The surveyor was due the next morning. Before he came, Neelima wanted to see the footpath herself. Shekhar had gone to the fields. Her mother had gone to a neighbour's house for a puja. Neelima picked up her father's old bamboo walking stick - the same stick that had leaned in the veranda for seven years, its grip worn smooth.

"Why are you taking that?" her mother had asked.

"There are bushes and undergrowth."

Her mother laughed. "You will need more stubbornness than a stick."

Neelima did not answer.

The afternoon was declining when she reached the western footpath. On one side lay an empty paddy field, on the other scrub, and between them a strip of earth two feet wide. In the distance she could see the new paved road, from which the sound of motorcycles came now and then. Most people in the village used that road now. The old path remained mainly a short way for fields, herdsman, and two or three houses.

Neelima walked slowly. In her mind she measured as she went - a foot and a half here, two feet there, the embankment intruding here. With her father's stick she tapped the earth along the edge.

In the middle of the footpath stood the stump of an old peepal tree. In her childhood the tree had been large; after lightning struck, half of it dried, and later it was cut down. Only the stump remained, scarcely a foot and a half above the ground.

Neelima passed beside the stump.

And the sound from the paved road stopped completely.

At first she thought the wind had stopped. Then she realised that the electricity pole in the distance was gone.

She stood still.

The paddy fields were full and green. The footpath was wider now, with the wheel marks of two bullock carts along its sides. The mango tree that in the present was only a stump stood here young and vigorous. From far away came not the school bell, but the beat of a drum.

Neelima turned back.

There was no peepal stump - there was an entire tree, thick-trunked, dense with leaves.

Her mouth went dry.

"What...?"

A boy came toward her carrying firewood on his head. His dhoti was hitched to his knees, a thin gamchha over his shoulder. Neelima stared at him. The boy looked at her too, but showed no surprise.

"Whose house are you going to?" he asked.

Neelima could not answer immediately.

"Is this Sirsiya?"

The boy laughed. "What else would it be?"

"What year is this...?"

He gave her a strange look. "Why are you asking about the year?"

Neelima tightened her grip on her father's stick. She suddenly did not want to ask the boy anything more. She simply walked on.

A little farther ahead, four women sat on the field ridge singing a transplanting song. The laughter of one young woman among them made Neelima stop.

She knew that laugh.

Her mother - Chandrakala.

But here Chandrakala could hardly have been twenty.

Something struck hard in Neelima's chest. She moved behind a bush beside the path.

Young Chandrakala, her veil half fallen from her head and her hands wet with transplanting water, was laughing as though quarrelling with someone.

"If bullock carts use this path, the embankment will break again," one woman said.

Chandrakala replied, "Will you close the road to save the embankment? How will people go?"

"There is a path on the eastern side too."

"Half of it goes under water in the rains."

An elderly woman said, "Yesterday the landowner said the footpath had moved into the field. He will shift it to the side."

Washing the mud from her hands, Chandrakala said, "A footpath does not move into a field. The field grows over people's footsteps."

They all laughed.

Neelima's eyes filled, because even now her mother could say exactly such a sentence, in exactly that manner.

She did not have the courage to go farther. She wanted to return. She walked quickly toward the peepal tree. Reaching it, she crossed beside it as fast as she could, expecting the present to return.

She crossed the tree.

But the present did not return.

The sky was grey. Half the fields were under water. Fresh earth had been packed onto the footpath, and bamboo stakes had been driven beside it like a small embankment. In the village in the distance there were a few tin roofs, more tiled ones. Two electricity poles now stood there, but no wires.

Neelima held her breath and looked around.

Two children came running along the path - a boy in front, a girl behind.

Neelima recognised the boy's gait.

Shekhar.

About twelve years old.

The girl running behind him - Neelima herself, seven or eight.

Her whole body trembled. Little Neelima had a blue cloth bag swinging from her hand. Her foot slipped in the mud and she fell down hard.

"Shekhar!" the girl cried.

Little Shekhar turned back, laughed first, then saw his sister's knee and ran to her. He put her bag on his own shoulder and took her hand to pull her up.

"Don't tell Ma," he whispered. "She'll say I made you run."

Wiping her nose, little Neelima said, "You did make me run."

"Still, don't tell her."

"I will."

"I'm carrying your bag."

"I'll still tell."

The two went on, quarrelling.

The adult Neelima remained standing beside the path. She did not remember this incident. The small scar on her knee was still there, but in her memory she had fallen on the veranda.

"What year?" she asked herself.

From far away came her father's voice.

"Shekhar! Neelu!"

She hid behind the tree.

Her father was young, perhaps around forty, a hoe over his shoulder. He reached the two children and first looked at the injured knee.

"What happened?"

"Nothing," Shekhar said at once.

"If it is nothing, why is there blood?"

Neelu was about to speak, but Shekhar showed her the bag he was carrying. The girl fell silent.

Their father seated both of them beside the footpath and wiped the mud away with his gamchha. Then he glared at Shekhar.

"You make your sister run?"

Shekhar was silent.

"This path is narrow. Learn to walk together. If one races ahead, the other will fall."

Neelima felt something strange hearing the sentence. Here there was no division of land, only two children.

Just then two farmers came by. One of them said, "Mishraji, this path has moved too far inward. It is eating our embankment."

Leaning on his hoe, her father said, "The old path was washed away in the flood. People walk here now, so this is the path now."

"Whose land is it?"

"We will see the record. But the path made by people's feet cannot be removed immediately by paper."

The other farmer laughed. "Your daughter goes to school, so of course you love the path."

Her father became serious. "If the daughter cannot go, the son will not go either. A path is not made for one person."

Something seemed to drop inside Neelima.

She remembered the present dispute: "The western strip is my share." She remembered one part of her father's voice, but not this scene.

She thought this must have been 1988 or 1989. Her age fitted.

She ran back toward the peepal. This time she circled the tree twice, then, trying to judge the direction of the present, turned west.

Ten steps later the water vanished.

The heat was fierce.

Brick dust had been spread on the footpath. In the distance something like a mobile tower was rising, unfinished. Some houses in the village had become concrete.

Neelima stopped.

"Another time again."

This time she felt more tired than frightened.

Ahead stood her father - older now, though still walking briskly. Shekhar was with him, about thirty. The two had spread papers over the ridge of a field.

Neelima was moving behind the bushes when she stopped. It seemed necessary to hear this scene.

Shekhar was saying, "Neelu has settled in the city. If we leave her share unused, farming becomes difficult."

Her father said, "If she has settled elsewhere, has she lost her right?"

"That isn't what I'm saying."

"It is what you want to say."

Shekhar was silent.

Her father put a finger on the paper. "The eastern strip is yours, the western hers. The house in the middle remains joint."

"And this footpath?"

"The footpath will fall along the edge of your field, because that is where the line on the map lies."

Neelima's ears grew hot. Exactly the sentence Shekhar kept repeating.

Her father continued, "But do not close the path. It may be part of the field, but not part of private passage."

Shekhar said, "People use the road now."

"Now. Who knows ten years from now? A flood may come, the road may break, someone's house may need this as its shorter way. Land left for a path is not wasted land."

"Neelu will say her share has become smaller."

Her father laughed a little. "She will. Then we will explain it to her."

"You will explain?"

Her father's laughter softened. "Wherever I am, I will explain."

Neelima stood holding the leaves of the bush. She understood the year now - 2012, three years before her father's death.

Suddenly she felt anger too. Why had Baba not told both of them the whole thing clearly? Why one sentence to Shekhar and another to Neelima? Why had he not settled the land papers plainly?

Then she understood: perhaps her father had thought there was time.

People often assume they will explain later.

Later does not always come.

Neelima moved on. Shekhar and her father did not look toward her. Perhaps she was too far away; perhaps to people inside that time she was only a shadow at the edge.

Here the footpath was almost as it was in the present, but the peepal was larger. Neelima passed it.

And again time changed.

This time there was floodwater everywhere. Not as in the memory from childhood - deeper. The footpath had disappeared under water. Only the raised ridges could be seen. People were moving with bamboo poles in their hands.

Neelima turned toward a voice. It was her mother - Chandrakala - middle-aged now, wet end of her sari over her head, a bamboo pole in her hand.

"Come this way!" Chandrakala shouted again.

Without thinking, Neelima went toward her. Her mother did not recognise her.

"Whose house are you from?" her mother asked.

Neelima opened her mouth, but did not give her name. "I need to go ahead."

"Everything ahead is water. Walk beside this bamboo."

Chandrakala took her hand and pulled her up onto the higher ridge. The touch was real - warm, strong.

Neelima's eyes filled.

"Was the path here before?" she asked.

Breathing hard, Chandrakala said, "It used to be over there." She pointed toward the submerged field. "It was cut away last night. People are climbing onto this ridge now."

"Then the old footpath?"

"The water took it."

"What happens then?"

Chandrakala looked at her strangely. "Then wherever people walk, a path will be made."

Another form of the same sentence.

Neelima kept looking at her mother. Her mother mistook the tears in her eyes for splashes of floodwater.

"Don't be afraid," Chandrakala said. "Just watch your next step."

Behind her two women were carrying baskets of earth, raising the ridge. Someone asked, "Shall we fill here or toward the east?"

Chandrakala said, "Here. Children and the elderly will come out this way."

Neelima understood that today's footpath might have been born on this temporary flood embankment. The line on the map that had seemed fixed since her father's childhood had shifted many times on the ground.

She asked, "What year is this?"

Before Chandrakala could answer, someone shouted her name from far away. "Chandrakala! Where is Neelu?"

Neelima's breath caught.

Her father's voice.

Chandrakala shouted back, "At school! Classes haven't ended yet!"

Neelima calculated. She must have been very young then - perhaps already born, but not present in this scene.

Time had made her a stranger inside her own family.

She left her mother and went forward along the footpath - or rather, the new embankment. This time she did not turn back. She had understood that turning backward did not return her to an earlier time.

After a short distance, water at her knees became water at her ankles, and then earth.

She was in another time again.

Evening light. Fine dust on the footpath. The school building in the distance was small. The peepal was younger. There was not a single electricity pole.

A man in the field beside the path was driving bamboo stakes into the ground. Neelima did not recognise him at first. Coming nearer, she saw that it was her father, but so young that this was before Neelima's birth.

With him was an elderly man - Neelima's grandfather.

Her grandfather said, "The boundary is up to this mango tree."

Her father said, "On the paper."

"On the ground too."

"But the footpath cuts across here."

"People cut through wherever it suits them. Boundaries do not change for people's convenience."

Her father said nothing.

Her grandfather drove in a bamboo stake. "The surveyor will come tomorrow. This stake will not be moved."

Neelima shivered. It was like an old echo of the present conversation.

Her father asked, "If the path crosses the boundary, will we close it?"

Her grandfather snapped, "Do you understand every matter only as a road for other people?"

"Ma has to go to the western hamlet. The eastern path is bad in the rains."

"Then our field should be cut?"

Her father said nothing.

After a while her grandfather walked toward the house. Her father remained alone beside the stake. Then, after looking around, he shifted one of the stakes two feet to the west.

Neelima laughed involuntarily.

Her father heard the sound and turned.

For the first time, someone from an earlier time looked directly at her.

"Who is there?" her father asked.

Neelima panicked.

"I've come to ask the way," she said.

Her father kept looking at her. "Where to?"

Neelima could not find an answer. "Home."

Her father smiled. "Whose home?"

At the question, something seemed to break inside Neelima. After crossing so many periods of time, she truly did not know which year's home she meant. The city home with her mother? The ancestral house in Sirsiya? The veranda of childhood? The present courtyard divided by inheritance?

"In Sirsiya," she said only that much.

Her father laughed. "Then go by this path. The peepal is ahead, then turn right."

"And to return?"

"For returning too the path is the same, but the feet are never the same."

Neelima looked at her father's face. Whether this was an ordinary sentence or something else, she could not decide.

Her father put the hoe on his shoulder and walked away.

Neelima moved toward the peepal and turned right.

Not the present - another time again.

This time she recognised the year of her own wedding.

The village house was freshly painted. Dry straw had been spread on the footpath because the earth was slippery after rain. She could hear the shehnai in the distance, and women's songs.

Neelima stood still.

Her wedding day.

She did not see herself on the footpath; the wedding procession had come by the main road. But Shekhar was spreading straw there. He must have been about twenty-seven. A friend was saying:

"Who will walk here? Everyone will come by vehicle on the main road."

Shekhar replied, "Tomorrow, after Neelu's farewell, when she remembers the way back to Ma's house, she will remember this little path."

His friend laughed. "She will go live in the city. You think she'll remember this mud?"

Shekhar went on spreading the straw. "People do not easily forget the place where they have fallen."

Neelima touched the scar on her knee.

Then the small incident from years ago came back to her - she and Shekhar running, her fall, Shekhar lifting her bag. The memory returned slowly, like writing pressed beneath water.

Her mother came out from the wedding house and said to Shekhar, "Don't spread straw so far. People will use the main road."

Shekhar replied, "This is for me."

"For you?"

"Neelu used to say that after marriage everything would change. Let one thing remain as it was."

Her mother said nothing. She merely stroked his head and went back inside.

Neelima's eyes filled with tears.

For the previous three days in the present, every conversation with Shekhar had become an argument. She had thought he was using the footpath as an excuse to hold back land. Perhaps some part of that was true as well. Human feelings are not made from a single cause.

She did not want to turn this scene into proof that he should be forgiven. Shekhar was stubborn now. He often kept the land accounts unclear. Neelima too had left the village's responsibilities to Shekhar for years and now wanted only her own share made clear.

The footpath could become evidence for both sides.

Perhaps that was why it was not evidence at all.

Neelima walked forward.

Time changed again.

Night.

She panicked at once. Stars were overhead; a few bulbs shone in the village. The footpath was dark. A vehicle passed on the paved road in the distance, leaving a streak of light.

This looked like the present - but she could not be certain.

She looked at her father's walking stick. It was still in her hand. She looked at her watch. The second hand was moving, but the time seemed stuck at 5:20 - the seconds circled, the minute hand did not advance.

She walked quickly along the footpath.

The peepal stump came. She crossed it.

Daylight appeared.

Exhausted, she sat down on the earth.

"Enough."

For the first time she said aloud on the path, "Let me go back."

No answer came.

The village before her was unfamiliar. There were fewer houses, more fields. Beside a hut, two men were looking at what seemed to be old palm-leaf papers. Perhaps this was a very old time. Neelima did not want to go there.

She turned back.

Then stopped.

She had already learned that turning back did not turn time back.

Then a voice came from far away.

"Neelu!"

She froze.

Shekhar's voice.

The present Shekhar - his voice at this age, with this roughness.

“Neelu! Where are you?”

Neelima looked toward the sound. Beyond the field there was nothing, only sunlight.

Again the voice: “Neelima!”

She walked toward it.

The footpath did not go in that direction. A field embankment lay ahead. Neelima stopped for a moment. Through every period she had always remained on the footpath. Now her brother’s voice was coming from outside it.

She put one foot onto the ridge.

Nothing happened.

A second step.

The air changed.

At the third step she heard the sound of a motorcycle in the distance again.

At the fourth, the electricity pole appeared.

Neelima ran.

The next moment she was standing in the empty field of the present. The sun was setting. The peepal stump was behind her. A tractor was moving along the paved road.

Shekhar came running along the footpath.

“Where had you gone?” His face was frightened. “I’ve been looking for you for two hours!”

Neelima tried to speak, but her throat was dry.

Shekhar caught her hand. “Did you fall? Are you hurt?”

“No.”

“Why didn’t you answer the phone?”

Neelima looked at the phone in her bag. It was not switched off. There were no missed calls. Her watch said 5:20.

“Two hours?” she asked.

“You left at half past two. It’s twenty past five now.”

Neelima looked again at her watch. The minute hand was moving forward now.

“I... was on the path.”

Shekhar said irritably, “I walked this path three times. You were nowhere.”

Neelima looked at his face. She could have told him the story - their mother, their father, the flood, the straw on her wedding day. But the words were so impossible that she did not speak them.

The two walked silently toward home.

After a while Neelima asked, “What exactly did Baba say to you about the footpath?”

Shekhar opened his mouth to answer at once, then stopped.

“He said it would fall along the edge of my field.”

“And?”

“And... that it was not to be closed.”

“Both?”

“Yes.”

“He told me the western strip would be my share.”

“That is true too.”

"Then why did each of us remember only half a sentence?"

Shekhar did not laugh. "Because each half was useful to one of us."

For the first time all day, Neelima breathed easily.

When they reached home, their mother was standing in the veranda. "Where were you?"

"On the footpath," Neelima said.

Her mother wrinkled her nose. "For so long?"

Neelima kept looking at her. Before her eyes stood the young Chandrakala pulling her up onto the embankment through floodwater.

"Ma," she asked, "when there was that flood in the 1980s, did the footpath shift?"

Her mother answered at once, "Not once - three times. What is now the path used to be Budhan Sahu's field embankment."

Shekhar was startled. "Three times?"

"You were a child. What would you remember?"

Neelima and Shekhar looked at one another.

Their mother started inside, then turned and said, "When the surveyor brings the old map tomorrow, its line will not match the ground. I'm telling you now."

The surveyor arrived at seven the next morning, a chain over his shoulder and papers in his hand, accompanied by two assistants.

He opened the old plot map. The footpath cut across the fields like a straight line.

The surveyor looked at the winding path on the ground. "This doesn't match at all."

Their mother laughed from the veranda. "Didn't I tell you?"

The surveyor was a practical man. "There are two ways. Accept the old line on the map as the boundary; then the present path will cut across two or three plots. Or record the path in current use as a common right of passage and measure the ownership boundaries separately."

Shekhar looked at Neelima.

Until yesterday, this was where the quarrel would have begun.

Neelima asked, "If it is recorded as common passage, what happens to the area of my land?"

The surveyor said, "Your ownership area will not decrease. But you will not be able to place a permanent obstruction on the path."

Shekhar said, "I agree."

Neelima did not answer immediately. She remembered the value of the field, future sharecropping, boundaries, all of it. She did not want to decide in a rush of emotion.

"How wide?"

"As wide as it is in use - about two feet on average."

"In some places it's three."

"Then we will measure it with the bends."

Neelima said, "Fine. But write it clearly on the map: common right of passage. Not the private path of any one share."

Shekhar nodded. "Fine."

The surveyor began work.

The chain was stretched. Stakes were driven. An assistant called out the distances. At one point the old map line ran almost ten feet away from the present path. Shekhar said in surprise, "That far?"

From a distance their mother called, "A flood measures more than people do."

The surveyor burst out laughing.

By noon the boundary was settled. The western strip belonged to Neelima, the eastern to Shekhar. Between them the footpath crossed the ownership boundary in several places, but on the papers it was marked separately as "the path in current use for common passage."

When the work was finished, Neelima went alone to the peepal stump.

Deliberately, she passed beside it.

Nothing changed.

The electricity pole remained where it was.

The sound of the paved road remained.

In the distance Shekhar was talking to the surveyor.

Neelima crossed beside the stump again.

Nothing.

She put her hand on it. The wood was warm.

"Only that much?" she said softly.

No answer.

She turned toward home along the footpath. A little farther ahead, Shekhar was carrying two boundary stones. He was about to set one where the path narrowed.

Neelima said, "Half a foot farther out."

"Then it will go into my field."

"Your recorded area won't shrink."

Shekhar looked at her. "You've become the surveyor now?"

"Since yesterday."

Shekhar laughed and shifted the stone half a foot outward.

The second stone fell on Neelima's side. She lifted it herself and set it half a foot inside her own field.

Between the two stones the footpath remained wide enough for two people.

Pressing the soil around the stone, Shekhar said, "Do you remember falling here when we were children?"

Neelima looked at him.

"You remember?"

"A little. I carried your bag. I don't remember whether you told Ma or not."

Smiling, Neelima said, "Maybe I didn't."

"I think you did."

"Then our memories are different."

"So?"

Neelima did not answer.

They walked toward the house. At the narrow place Shekhar started to go first, then stopped and moved to the side.

"Let's walk together," he said.

Neelima placed her foot beside his.

That day the footpath did not go into any other time. Earth remained earth, grass remained grass, evening remained evening.

But with two pairs of feet falling together, its width seemed exactly as much as was needed.

The Lineage of Mirrors

After the rains, the assembly ground at Saurath usually stood empty, but no month of the year was ever entirely empty at the house of the panjikar Madhavi Jha. Someone came asking about an old ancestral line; someone came before a marriage to compare branches; someone came merely to see how far back the names of his forebears had been recorded. Madhavi's grandfather used to say, "A register does not create a lineage; people create their relationships, and the register merely catches their shadow."

Madhavi had always taken this sentence as professional caution. Twelve years had passed since her grandfather's death, yet whenever she opened the thin pages of an old register, it seemed as though his voice rose from somewhere inside.

One afternoon in Bhadon, three people from Kamalpur arrived on her osara: an elderly man, Ramlochan Jha; his niece Kaushiki; and Kaushiki's maternal uncle, Madhukant. Each wore a different kind of tension on the face.

After greeting her, Ramlochan said, "A branch has to be checked."

Madhavi indicated the seats. "Tell me the names."

Ramlochan named two families. Kaushiki belonged to the "southern house" of Kamalpur, and a young man named Abhiram was from nearby Rajpur. The two wished to marry. Someone in the family had said that both descended from the same old branch.

Madhukant interrupted. "Not merely 'someone.' My elder uncle himself had seen the register. He said both fall in image seven of the 'Mirror Branch.' Such a marriage is improper."

Kaushiki looked up. "Uncle could not read the register."

"Everything seems modern to you," Madhukant snapped.

Madhavi raised a hand and silenced them both. "First we will see the register. I will not decide the marriage. I will only see what is written and what it may mean."

Madhukant did not like the sentence, but he remained silent.

From his bag Ramlochan took out an old ledger wrapped in cloth. "This is our family's private supplementary register. It is not a copy of the principal panji. It has remained in the family."

Madhavi unwrapped it. The ledger differed from ordinary genealogical register-sheets: thick handmade paper, red thread at the edges, water stains here and there. On the first page the title was clear: "Memory Register of the Southern House of Kamalpur." Beneath it stood a date resembling 1889, followed by the names of five generations.

At the sixth generation, names suddenly stopped.

From there a strange notation began:

"First image of the central mirror."

"Second image of the right mirror."

"Two sequences from the third image of the left mirror."

"Central image vacant; first image on the right held the household."

Madhavi turned the page. Human names appeared only here and there in the margins. The main sequence ran through numbers and the word “image.”

“Who wrote this?”

Ramlochan said, “There is disagreement about that. The family says a panjikar named Jagdish Mishra wrote it in my great-grandfather’s time. But I do not know his handwriting.”

Madhavi took out a specimen book left by her grandfather. It preserved two pages written by a panjikar named Jagdish Mishra. The hands matched, especially the open belly of the letter da and the tilted head of sha.

“The beginning may be in his hand,” Madhavi said. “But two or three different hands appear on the later pages.”

Kaushiki leaned forward. “What is image seven?”

Instead of answering, Madhavi examined the ledger again. Nowhere did it say “seventh image.” It said: “seventh sequence from the first image on the right.” Madhukant’s uncle had perhaps shortened this to “image seven.”

“They are not the same thing,” Madhavi said.

Madhukant frowned. “Seventh sequence means seventh generation.”

“Not necessarily. First we must understand what ‘image’ means.”

Ramlochan said very softly, “There is an old mirror in our house.”

Madhavi looked at him.

“Three-panelled. Very old. The middle panel is large, the two side panels narrow. Baba used to say this register was connected with that mirror.”

Kaushiki stared in surprise at her uncle. “Why was I never told this?”

Ramlochan said awkwardly, “Only the old people in the house spoke of such things. I never understood it myself.”

Madhavi closed the ledger. “We will have to see the mirror.”

Madhukant laughed. “Now genealogy will be decided by looking into a mirror?”

Madhavi replied calmly, “Not genealogy. We are trying to determine what this ledger records.”

The next morning all four went to Kamalpur. Ramlochan’s old house stood at the southern edge of the village, half concrete and half old brick and earth. The main courtyard had been repaired recently, but the “southern room” at the back usually remained locked. When the heavy wooden door opened, the smell of dampness came out.

Inside were old trunks, brass plates, a broken spinning wheel, and, leaning against the wall beneath a cloth covering, one large object.

Ramlochan removed the cloth.

A three-panelled mirror.

The central glass was as tall as a person. The left and right panels were half as wide and could turn on hinges. The frame was of dark wood, carved above with vines and leaves. The glass had clouded in many places, with black stains along the edges.

Madhavi first saw her own reflection: full in the centre, bent in the side panels. She immediately stepped aside. The frame interested her more than the image.

“Look here.”

On the inside edge of the right frame were thin scratches - not ordinary numerals like 1, 2, 3, but small circles, pairs of lines, diagonal cuts. The left frame had them too. On the lower strip of the central frame were seven small compartments.

Kaushiki reached out a finger. Madhavi stopped her. "Photograph first. Then we will examine it closely."

Ramlochan said, "My mother used to say that on the second day after Deepavali the family sat near this mirror. The custom had ended by the time I was a child."

"What did they do?"

"She used to say: 'They looked at the image of the house.' That is all."

Madhukant laughed again. "The image of the house - it simply means everyone saw themselves together in the mirror."

Kaushiki gently turned the right panel. For a moment Ramlochan's face appeared in the central mirror, Kaushiki in the right panel, and Madhukant's shoulder at the edge of the left. When the angle shifted again, Kaushiki vanished, Ramlochan appeared twice, and Madhavi only halfway.

Madhavi said, "In this mirror, 'where the image appears' may matter more than 'how many people appear.'"

Madhukant said, "A mirror is not a toy."

"Quite so. And the ledger is not merely a puzzle either."

On the western wall of the room were traces of three low seats. The earthen floor had been changed, but the old wooden supports remained in the wall. Madhavi stood two arm-lengths before the mirror and set the three panels at different angles. At one point the person before the central glass appeared in the middle, the seat on the right appeared in the left panel, and the seat on the left in the right panel.

Kaushiki said excitedly, "So people sat on those seats?"

"Possibly."

Something suddenly returned to Ramlochan's memory. "My mother used to say, 'Do not leave the middle seat empty.' Not at weddings, but on the night of the lamps."

Madhavi asked, "The night of the lamps?"

"After the final Kartik worship. The names of dead members of the household were also spoken."

Madhukant grew restless. "We came to examine lineage, not to hear a tale about rites for the dead."

Madhavi read one line from the ledger: "Central image vacant; first image on the right held the household."

"This may refer to the order of the seats," she said. "If the person in the middle seat was no longer alive, did the person in the right seat take responsibility for the household?"

Ramlochan's expression changed. "My great-grandmother Godavari Devi."

"What about her?"

"Great-grandfather Harinarayan died very young. Great-grandmother did not return to her natal home. She managed the household, the fields, and three children. The family says she was called 'the one who held the house.'"

Madhavi looked at the date in the ledger. "This entry is from about the same period."

Kaushiki quietly kept looking at her own face in the right-hand mirror.

That day they found only a hypothesis, not proof. Madhavi asked permission to inspect the old trunks in the house. Ramlochan readily agreed; Madhukant remained dissatisfied.

The first trunk held clothes and old wedding materials. The second contained receipts for utensils, land papers, and accounts from the family shrine. At the bottom of the third trunk they found a cloth pouch containing seven small wooden slips. Each bore the same circle-and-line marks found on the mirror frame.

Kaushiki turned one over. On the back was written: "Godavari."

The second: "Jagannath."

The third: "Lalita."

The fourth: "Shobha."

The fifth: "Batesar."

The sixth: "Nirmala."

On the back of the seventh there was no name, only: "The Child Who Came."

Madhukant said, "The Child Who Came? What does that mean?"

Ramlochan was silent for a long time. "The son of Great-grandmother's sister." "Whose?" Kaushiki asked.

"I do not remember his name. His parents died during an epidemic. Godavari Devi brought him into her own house. The family used to call him 'Batuk.'"

Madhavi's attention immediately returned to one entry in the ledger: "Third image on the right, born outside, taken into the household sequence."

She placed the page before Kaushiki.

"This is not the ordinary language of genealogy," Madhavi said. "It is the language of membership in the household."

Madhukant said loudly, "Does living in a house change one's lineage?"

Madhavi looked at him. "The person who wrote this ledger may have been asking exactly that question."

Inside the pouch there was also a thin piece of cloth. When they opened it, seven small square mirror-plates came out - not glass, but polished metal. Each bore the same sign on its back. Perhaps they had been placed on the seats, or used to mark positions in the sequence.

Madhavi could now begin to see the shape of the story. But she did not hurry. A story is easy to construct; evidence is difficult.

Three days later, among the old materials in her own house, she searched for Jagdish Mishra's panji notes. In a bundle from her grandfather's time she found a small sheet marked "Kamalpur Southern House - Special Supplement." Only one page. The handwriting was Jagdish Mishra's.

It contained no names, only rules:

"In this house the lineage of names remains, in its proper place, in the separate panji. For household memory, a mirror-order is maintained. Central image - the one who bears responsibility for the household. Right image - the one who bears the house with that person. Left image - the one who is under the shelter of this house. Children according to sequence. Blood and household-order are not to be treated as the same."

Madhavi read the page and let out a long breath.

The sentence changed the whole matter.

She called Ramlochan. Kaushiki came too. Madhukant arrived late this time, but he came.

Madhavi placed the sheet on the table. "This ledger was not an alternative blood-lineage. It was a supplementary order of household responsibility and shelter."

Kaushiki asked softly, "Then the 'Mirror Branch' is not the family's lineage?"

"It is a kind of family lineage, but not a biological or blood relationship. The word 'lineage' may have been added by later people. The writer calls it 'household memory.'"

Madhukant read the page. "Is this genuine?"

"Paper, ink, handwriting - all fit Jagdish Mishra's period. But I am not granting permission for a marriage on this basis. I am only saying that the mirror-order by itself does not establish blood relationship."

"Then where is the blood-lineage?"

"We will look for it in the separate principal panji."

For three days Madhavi examined the human name-sequences of the two families. Abhiram's branch from Rajpur did connect at one point with the Kamalpur household - but through the child called "Batuk." Batuk was the son of Godavari Devi's sister, not part of Harinarayan's blood-line. A later copyist had treated the "left image" of the mirror-order as a son of the house and joined it to the main lineage as though it were a branch.

The social closeness between Kaushiki's and Abhiram's families was real; at that point, however, there was no evidence of a shared male ancestor by blood.

Madhukant asked again, "But Batuk was raised in the family. Then is he not of the family line?"

This time Madhavi smiled. "The question you have just asked may be the very reason the mirror-register was created. From the point of view of the household, he belonged to the family. From the point of view of blood, he belonged to another branch. The problem began when later people treated the two as the same thing."

Ramlochan said softly, "A mirror does not ask a person's name."

Madhavi looked at him. It was a beautiful sentence, but she did not want to turn it into a law of history. "A mirror does not ask names, but human beings decide who sits where before it."

Kaushiki smiled faintly for the first time.

The matter might have ended there. But Madhukant was not satisfied. His objection concerned not only the marriage, but land as well. Batuk's descendants were claiming a share in an old orchard belonging to the southern house. If Batuk belonged to the "lineage of the house," that claim gained moral force; if he was merely a dependent, it weakened.

"Can this mirror-register serve as evidence of property rights?" he asked.

Madhavi replied firmly, "No. A document made for one purpose should not be pushed into a different dispute. Land records are separate."

Madhukant's face tightened. "Then what use is all this discovery?"

"To prevent the same mistake from being repeated."

"I think you are becoming sentimental."

"I think you treat every piece of paper as a measurement of land."

That day's meeting ended in bitterness.

As she was leaving, Kaushiki stopped Madhavi. "What about my marriage?"

Madhavi said, "I will record the two families' name-sequences and the traditional matching inquiry separately. But the decision will follow the process of the families and the relevant acharya/panjkar community. I will only state clearly that it is wrong to treat the 'mirror-order' as a blood lineage."

Kaushiki nodded. "I only want not to be stopped for a false reason. That is all."

The sentence remained with Madhavi.

A week later Ramlochan came again. This time he was accompanied by a very old woman - Manikamini Kaki, about ninety-two. Leaning on a stick, she sat on the osara and, while drinking water, said, "So all of you are trying to discover what the mirror means?"

Madhavi was startled. "You saw the custom?"

"Saw it? I have sat on that seat."

Ramlochan became excited. "Kaki, why did you never tell us before?"

"Did anyone ask?"

Everyone fell silent.

Manikamini Kaki began to explain. In her childhood, on one night in Kartik, the people living in the household - blood descendants, a widowed daughter, a fatherless nephew, the orphaned daughter of a long-serving worker - took turns sitting around the three seats. In the middle sat the person who would take chief responsibility for the household in the coming year. In the right-hand mirror sat that person's companion or supporting household member. In the left sat those considered "dependants." The children sat in front. Small marks were made on the mirror frame, and names were written on the wooden slips.

"Why?" Madhavi asked.

Kaki said, "The name-register was separate. This was for seeing whom the house stood upon."

"Why was the mirror necessary?"

Kaki laughed. "Because a man sitting in the middle can tell himself: this house is mine. When the mirror opens, he sees everyone beside him. Old Godavari used to say, 'Without them your face is not complete.'"

A slight shiver ran through Madhavi, not from mystery but from meaning. The mirror was not meant to multiply souls. It was meant to make responsibility visible.

"Kaki, who was 'the Child Who Came'?"

Without thinking, Manikamini said, "Batak. His real name was Basant."

Ramlochan was astonished. "Basant?"

"Yes. His mother was Godavari's younger sister. Both his parents died in the epidemic. Godavari brought him here. Batak ploughed the fields of this house, raised its children, and cared for Godavari in her old age. But at marriages his ancestral line was stated through the house of his own parents. Everyone knew that."

Madhavi kept writing. "So in the mirror-register Batak belonged to this household sequence, but in the name-register to his own ancestral line?"

"Exactly."

"Later people forgot?"

Kaki sighed deeply. "When people stop doing something, first they forget its meaning. Later they keep hold of the words."

After this sentence she fell silent.

Madhavi took her to the mirror in Kamalpur. The moment Manikamini Kaki saw the panels, she corrected the right-hand hinge. "Not like this - like this." She turned the panel inward to roughly forty-five degrees, and the left a little less.

Suddenly the images of all three seats appeared clearly within a single central view.

Kaki slowly sat on the middle seat. In the mirror behind her, Ramlochan, Kaushiki, and Madhavi appeared across three different panels.

"The lamp used to be here," Kaki said, pointing to a stain below. "In the lamp-light, the wooden marks shone."

Kaushiki asked, "Which image were you?"

Kaki smiled. "First the third on the left. Later the first on the right. Once, the middle as well."

"Meaning?"

"As a child I was a dependent - my mother had died. After marriage I became a right-hand image in this house; I helped my elder sister-in-law run the household. After her death, I was the middle for two years."

Kaushiki said in surprise, "The same person in three different images?"

"Does a human being remain only one thing?" Kaki replied.

For the first time, Madhavi understood the language of the ledger from within. "Lineage" here was not a fixed blood-line but a sequence of roles in the household. One person could occupy different positions in different periods of life. That was why the numbers did not correspond to generations.

Kaushiki stood before the mirror. "Then which image am I?"

Kaki laughed. "The custom no longer runs. Decide for yourself."

Madhukant, who had reluctantly accompanied them, stood at the door listening to everything. Suddenly he asked, "All this is Kaki's memory. There were rules on paper, yes, but isn't the system merely a family story?"

Madhavi said, "Yes, it is a family story. That is precisely why it was wrong to turn it into a blood panji."

The resistance in Madhukant's voice gave way to tiredness. "My father used to call it the 'Mirror Branch.'"

Manikamini Kaki replied at once, "Your father was small when the practice ended. He understood half."

"Then what I have believed all these years...?"

Kaki looked at him. "Everyone lives by taking half a thing as whole."

That evening Madhavi remained alone in the southern room for a while. Standing before the three-panelled mirror, she set the panels at the angles Kaki had shown. Her own face appeared in the centre; the right-hand seat was empty; part of the doorway appeared in the left panel.

She moved one step to the right. Her face vanished from the central mirror and appeared only halfway in the left panel.

Two steps back - different fragments of her appeared in all three panels.

She understood that the greatest danger in the “lineage of reflections” was that later readers might mistake a reflection for a person. The older writer, however, may have treated the reflection as a “position” - a place occupied by a role in life.

Madhavi decided not to correct the old ledger. Correcting it would repeat the same error: forcing an old thing into the clarity of a modern meaning. She would prepare a separate explanatory sheet.

Back home, she wrote a detailed note:

“The ‘mirror-order’ of the Southern House of Kamalpur is not a list of human blood lineage. It was an auxiliary system of household memory in which persons living in the family or under its shelter were recorded according to the positions in which they appeared across the mirror’s three panels. The same person could occupy different ‘images’ at different periods of life. Therefore blood relationship, marriage prohibition, or inheritance cannot be inferred from the mirror-order alone.”

She stopped. The language sounded too legal. She remembered her grandfather’s old sentence: the panji merely catches a shadow.

Madhavi added another line:

“The purpose of this register was to remember upon whose labour, shelter, and responsibility the household stood.”

The next day Ramlochan, Madhukant, and Kaushiki came. Madhavi read the note aloud.

Ramlochan’s eyes grew moist. “Will this be added to the ledger?”

“Not inside the old ledger. As a separate conservation note, with a date. People in the future should know that this interpretation was made now.”

Madhukant asked, “And the marriage?”

Madhavi showed the lineage-lines of the two families from the name-panji on a separate sheet. “According to the evidence found here, the shared point in the mirror-order does not establish a shared male ancestor by blood. The remaining traditional or family inquiries may follow their own process. This much alone I will certify.”

Kaushiki let out a long breath.

Ramlochan said, “What should we do with the mirror now?”

“Leave it where it is. But preserve photographs and notes of the frame, the wooden slips, and the ledger. And if possible, write down Manikamini Kaki’s complete oral account.”

Madhukant said slowly, “In the land dispute?”

Madhavi looked directly at him.

He laughed at himself. “All right. Separate documents.”

A few months later Kaushiki’s marriage was settled. Madhavi did not attend the wedding; it was not her task to decide. But in Kartik, a letter came from Ramlochan: “The mirror room has been cleaned. Kaki says we should see the ‘image of the house’ once again.”

Madhavi could not restrain her curiosity. One Kartik evening she reached Kamalpur. A lamp burned in the southern room. The mirror had been cleaned, though its old cloudy stains remained.

Manikamini Kaki did not sit in the middle seat. She said, “Now the middle image should be occupied by the one who will bear responsibility for the house this year.”

Everyone looked at everyone else. Ramlochan was tired with age. Madhukant lived away. At last Ramlochan's daughter-in-law Veena stepped forward - the woman who for years had managed the field accounts, Kaki's medicines, and the upkeep of the house, though her name had never been prominent on any old genealogical page.

Veena sat hesitantly in the middle seat. Her husband sat to the right. Manikamini Kaki sat on the left, because she herself said, "Now I am a dependent - write it."

Everyone laughed.

Kaushiki and Abhiram had come too, but Kaki did not seat them on any of the three positions. "You two are guests for now. Establish your own house, then think about your mirror."

The light of the lamp fell differently across the three panels. Veena's face was clear in the central mirror; her husband and Kaki appeared in the side panels. The children standing behind made crooked, shifting images. No one could remain still.

Ramlochan asked Madhavi, "Should we make a record?"

Madhavi thought for a moment.

"If the family wishes, do it on a new sheet. If we simply continue the old panji, people may again think a blood lineage is being extended."

Manikamini Kaki said, "Then call it 'Image of the House.'"

Madhavi took a fresh sheet. She wrote the date. She wrote all the names plainly, without mystery. Then in separate columns she wrote: "middle," "right," "left," "children."

Kaushiki asked, "No mirror signs?"

Madhavi smiled. "If the meanings of signs are not written down, the next people will make another story out of them."

Manikamini Kaki nodded. "A story will be made anyway."

"Then?"

"Then at least write that it is a story."

At the top of the sheet Madhavi wrote the title: "Image of the House - Not a Blood Panji."

She kept writing.

Inside the mirror the children's reflections changed as they ran behind one another. At one moment Veena vanished from the middle panel and her granddaughter appeared; then a shift in angle brought half of Ramlochan's face; then only the lamp.

Madhavi looked up. What had seemed in the old ledger to be a "lineage" of images was not a fixed lineage at all, but a sequence of the household's changing burdens.

Then she remembered her grandfather's sentence again: a panji merely catches a shadow.

This time Madhavi revised it silently in her mind.

A panji can catch a shadow; but if the next reader mistakes the shadow for the body, the meaning of relationship changes.

She wrote no conclusion at the end of the sheet. She only drew a small sketch of the three mirror panels and beneath each, where a name might have gone, wrote one word:

"Responsibility."

“Companionship.”

“Shelter.”

Then she stopped her pen.

Inside the mirror, people kept moving again and again, but on the paper, this time, no reflection had been written in place of a human being.

There were the names of people - and, separately, the meaning of the images.

The Invisible Book

On the third floor of the State Library in Darbhanga, a glass display case had stood empty for three months. Red velvet had been spread inside it, with a thin brass strip around the edges, and above it, in small letters, was written:

“Shared Lamp — estimated eighteenth century? Original copy not yet located.”

The first time Renuka Karn read the label, she felt both amused and irritated.

“Original copy not yet located” made it sound as though the manuscript were merely stuck behind someone’s cupboard and someone would find it tomorrow and put it on display.

But no one had ever seen an original copy of Shared Lamp.

Some said it had been written around 1780. Some placed it at the beginning of the nineteenth century. Some said its author was an unknown Maithil scholar. Some said it had been written by a widowed woman teacher. Some said there had never been a single author at all.

And yet quotations from the book were everywhere.

In old essays. In household-education pamphlets. In agricultural registers. In booklets of speeches from women’s associations. In twentieth-century dissertations. Even in an old decision of a village council.

And the quotations were so famous that some people used them in everyday conversation without mentioning any source:

“A lamp that lights only its own threshold sends its smoke into the neighbour’s eyes.”

Another group’s favourite line was:

“Only when the wick is first trained within the house can it endure the wind outside.”

A third line was often quoted by scholars of women’s studies:

“Whose threshold is it? Whoever’s foot crosses it, the threshold must hear that person’s question.”

All three lines were said to come from Shared Lamp.

The problem was that each line had become the basis of a different interpretation.

Those who quoted the first said the work supported the sharing of knowledge. Those who quoted the second said no: the work favoured discipline, order, and limited instruction. The third group said both readings were male-centred; the real subject of the work was women’s voice within the household and the right to cross the threshold.

Renuka’s job was not to decide this dispute.

At least that was what her appointment letter said: “Prepare a critical catalogue of all available quotations, references, and sources relating to Shared Lamp.”

But in her first meeting with the Vice-Chancellor, the meaning of the task changed.

"I do not want merely a catalogue," the Vice-Chancellor said. "There is a national seminar in three months. If we can produce a reconstructed text of Shared Lamp, it will be a major achievement for the library."

Renuka asked, "A reconstructed text — without the original?"

"The quotations exist."

"And the text between the quotations?"

"Scholars can infer it."

"And call inference the original text?"

There was silence in the room for two moments.

The Vice-Chancellor smiled. "You are a cataloguer, not a judge. Arrange what is available. The editorial committee will decide the rest."

Renuka did not say "Very well." She simply picked up the file.

As soon as she came out, Dr Mahendranath Jha approached her. He was the university's senior historian of texts and had been writing about Shared Lamp for forty years.

"Too many questions in the first meeting are not wise," he said quietly.

"If I do not ask questions, how will I make the catalogue?"

"The catalogue will be made from sources. The sources already exist."

"Not the original source."

Mahendranath laughed. "Give up your obsession with originals. Half the history of ancient literature runs on quotations."

"Then I will write a history of quotations."

"And the book?"

Renuka looked toward the empty glass case. "If the book is found, then the history of the book."

Mahendranath studied her, as if deciding whether the young woman was stubborn or merely newly appointed.

"You are Shashibhushan Karn's granddaughter, are you not?"

Renuka's face hardened slightly.

"Yes."

"Then Shared Lamp is not an external subject for you. Your grandfather laid the foundation of its modern study."

Renuka knew that.

Her grandfather, Professor Shashibhushan Karn, had written a famous article in 1978: "Shared Lamp: An Unknown Work of Mithila's Folk-Knowledge Tradition." In that article, forty-two quotations had been gathered together for the first time. He had concluded that Shared Lamp was probably an organised work by a single author, dealing with knowledge, household society, and moral discipline.

After that article, the name Shared Lamp entered the university curriculum.

As a child Renuka had often seen a yellow file in her grandfather's study. On it was written: "S.D."

Grandfather never allowed her to touch it.

"Not yet," he would say. "There are unfinished things in this."

After his death, many of his papers had been donated to the university. Some remained at home. Renuka did not know where the yellow "S.D." file had gone.

During the first week she did nothing but count quotations.

There were sixty-three.

The earliest printed reference she found was in an 1889 handbook of household conduct. Its author, Pandit Rameshwar Dutt, wrote: "As it is said in Shared Lamp..." followed by two lines.

No author of the original book. No publisher. No date.

A 1904 agricultural instruction leaflet cited "Shared Lamp, page 21." A 1911 report from a girls' school cited "Shared Lamp, p. 7." A 1919 polemical pamphlet said "Shared Lamp, third section." A 1926 moral-education booklet gave "Shared Lamp 2:4." A 1933 Maithili essay simply said, "The author of the Lamp says..." An old village-council decision from 1948 said, "According to the old saying of Shared Lamp..."

So many different systems of reference for the same book.

Renuka made a slip for every quotation. At the top she wrote the quotation; beneath it, the earliest available source, date, and later repetitions.

After three days she noticed something strange.

The line found in the 1889 handbook appeared word for word in the 1904 leaflet — but the 1904 author cited "Shared Lamp, page 21," not the 1889 handbook.

A line in the 1919 polemical pamphlet matched the 1911 report exactly, down to the punctuation.

This meant that later writers were probably copying not Shared Lamp itself but earlier sources that quoted it — while continuing to cite the original book.

Renuka began stretching red thread between the slips.

The sixty-three quotations gradually contracted into seventeen "earliest available attestations."

All the rest were quotations of quotations.

She called Mahendranath.

He examined the slips.

"This is ordinary," he said. "When people do not have the original at hand, they quote from another writer."

"But where is the evidence that anyone ever had the original in hand?"

"The earliest authors must have had it."

"They give no description of the original either."

"Older writers did not cite sources so systematically."

Renuka opened the 1904 leaflet. "This writer gives full details for three other books — author, year, chapter. Only for Shared Lamp does he write 'page 21.'"

"Coincidence."

"The 1911 report says 'p. 7.' In 1926 it becomes '2:4.' No one uses the same pagination."

"Different copies."

"Copies so different that one has pages, one sections, one chapter-and-line?"

Mahendranath leaned back in his chair. "What are you trying to prove?"

"Nothing yet. Only that the genealogy of the quotations matters more than an imagined completeness of the book."

"Genealogy of quotations?"

"Which line travelled from where to where."

Mahendranath picked up one of the slips. It held the famous line: "A lamp that lights only its own threshold..."

"This line is in Shashibhushanji's article."

"Yes."

"So?"

"Grandfather cites the 1904 agricultural leaflet."

"That is proper."

"But the 1904 leaflet does not say 'the neighbour's eyes.' It says 'the eyes of another house.' 'Neighbour' appears for the first time in Grandfather's article."

Mahendranath frowned.

"He may have polished the language."

"Then it is not the original quotation; it is Grandfather's edited form."

"A small linguistic correction."

Renuka put the slip down. "A small correction that later became the most famous version."

Mahendranath said nothing.

That night Renuka went home and asked her mother about Grandfather's papers.

Her mother was roasting makhana in the kitchen.

"A yellow file?" her mother asked. "There were many."

"Marked 'S.D.'"

Her mother stopped the tongs. "Your grandfather and your maternal grandfather once quarrelled over that file."

"Nana?"

"Yes. Nana used to say, 'If there is no original, do not make it into a book.' Your grandfather used to say, 'If there are quotations, something original must have existed.'"

Renuka was hearing this for the first time.

"Where is the file?"

"When Grandfather died, the university vehicle took away many papers. But some boxes are still in the upstairs room."

Until nine that night Renuka opened dust-filled boxes. Old examination papers, students' letters, conference invitations, her grandfather's spectacle case, a red pencil, unfinished articles.

At the bottom of the third box she saw yellow cardboard.

"S.D."

Renuka's hand stopped.

Inside the file was the draft of her grandfather's published article. Red and blue notes in the margins. Some letters. Some photocopies. And at the very bottom, a small black-covered notebook, labelled in her grandfather's hand:

"Search for the Sources of the Quotations — Private Notes."

First page: "Problem: no one makes a direct claim to have seen the original copy."

Second: "Rameshwar Dutt's phrase 'as it is said in Shared Lamp' — could the title refer not to a book, but to a teaching register?"

Renuka sat upright.

Third page: "Pagination inconsistent. 21, 7, 3/4, Section 3. Different copies possible, but no evidence."

Fourth: “Women’s night school, Pariharpur, 1907–1913. Oral mention of a collective writing-register called ‘Shared Lamp’? Requires investigation.”

Renuka’s breathing quickened.

On the next page Grandfather had written: “If Shared Lamp was not a single work but a collective notebook, then the modern search for an ‘author’ would be mistaken.”

Beneath it, in red pencil: “Not in the article — evidence insufficient.”

Grandfather had known the possibility.

Yet in his published article he had strongly argued for a single unknown author.

Why?

There was a letter in the file, dated 1977, from the university’s publications division:

“Respected Prof. Karn, for inclusion in the forthcoming Mithila Ancient Texts Series, a definite introduction to Shared Lamp is expected. An uncertain proposition such as ‘possibly a collective tradition of quotations’ will be difficult within the structure of the series. Kindly provide, on the basis of the available evidence, a clear view regarding probable author, period, and subject.”

There was no copy of Grandfather’s reply.

Her mother came and stood in the doorway.

“Found it?”

Renuka showed her the notebook.

Her mother did not read the page. She only said, “Your grandfather liked definite things.”

“Even when they were not definite?”

Her mother placed a bowl of makhana on the table. “Then he stayed awake all night.”

“And what did he publish?”

Her mother met Renuka’s eyes. “What his time asked of him.”

Renuka did not like the answer. But she could not immediately make her grandfather guilty either.

The next morning she searched for Pariharpur.

In the district records she found an education report from 1909: “Pariharpur Women’s Night School — private initiative. Teachers: Bhagwati Devi, Janki Sahu, Rahmatun Nisha (assistant). Subjects: literacy, accounts, letter-writing, household health.”

No mention of Shared Lamp.

In the 1912 report there was one line: “The students write weekly sayings/experiences in a ‘shared register.’”

Renuka almost rose from her chair.

“Shared register.”

Not “Lamp.”

But Grandfather’s note referred to an oral mention of a collective writing-register called Shared Lamp.

She decided to go to Pariharpur.

Mahendranath said when he heard, “Oral memory from a village will not prove an 1889 book.”

"I am not going to prove it."

"Then why?"

"To investigate what Grandfather could not."

"The seminar is two months away."

"Exactly why I must go now."

Pariharpur was not far from an old channel of the Kamala. From the passenger vehicle Renuka had to travel half a kos in a small local vehicle and then continue on foot. The night-school building no longer existed. A new primary-school room stood on its site. But villagers still knew the place as the "old reading osara."

The headmaster sent her to the house of an elderly woman, Farida Khatoon, aged eighty-six.

"My grandmother Rahmatun Nisha was an assistant at that school," Farida said.

Renuka asked carefully, "Have you heard about a shared register?"

Farida did not answer at once. "There were many registers. Accounts, names, songs."

"Shared Lamp?"

The old woman's eyes brightened slightly.

"My grandmother used that name."

Renuka's heart began to beat faster. "Was it a book?"

"A book... yes, she called it the lamp-book."

"Who wrote it?"

Farida laughed. "If I had asked Grandmother a question like that, she would have scolded me. She used to say, 'Whichever person's thought seems good that day, she writes it down.'"

"Not one author?"

"Not from what I heard."

"Where did the original book go?"

Farida fell silent.

"Grandmother said that in the flood of 1916 the osara collapsed. Many papers were soaked. Some were dried, some were lost."

"The lamp-book?"

"She used to say, 'Half the pages of the lamp went into the water, half into people's mouths.'"

Renuka wanted to write the sentence down at once, then stopped.

"Those were your grandmother's exact words?"

Farida shook her head. "I was a child. How can I say exactly? That was the sense."

Renuka wrote: "Paraphrase; not verbatim."

Farida looked pleased. "Do scholars write that difference down?"

"They should."

"Then write it."

Another family in the village was said to descend from Bhagwati Devi. There lived Urmila Devi, about seventy years old. An old trunk in the house still held some papers from the school — a register of names, contribution accounts, and two letters.

One letter, from 1910, was probably in Bhagwati Devi's hand. It said:

"In the night class the register has now grown. Janki says we should call it 'Lamp,' because one person's words are read by another. Rahmatun says, what does the name matter? The register belongs to everyone."

Renuka looked from the line to Urmila.

"This is extremely important."

Urmila said matter-of-factly, "To me it is only Grandmother's old paper."

"It shows the origin of the name 'Lamp.'"

"Perhaps."

"Would you give this paper to the library?"

Urmila's face hardened immediately.

"No."

Renuka was silent.

"People have come before," Urmila said. "They took papers away, then put their own names on them. What belongs to our house will remain in our house."

"May I take a copy?"

"The paper will not go outside."

"May I photograph it here?"

Urmila thought. "In your report, will you write my grandmother's full name?"

"If I use it as evidence, yes."

"Rahmatun's name too?"

"Yes."

"Janki's?"

"Yes."

"Then take the photograph."

The brief exchange reminded Renuka of a line in Grandfather's notebook: "Searching for one author is a convenience of my own."

A collective book made it difficult to give one author. Three women's names took more space. And what about twenty-five students?

By evening, seven documents from Urmila's trunk had been photographed. One small list contained weekly topics: "salt accounts," "care after childbirth," "letter-writing," "drying paddy," "a daughter's education," "neighbourhood quarrels," "lending money," "reading the lamp-register."

Renuka lingered over "reading the lamp-register."

Was it a book? A register? A collective exercise? A collection of sayings? A living dialogue?

As soon as she returned to the city, she reread Grandfather's notebook.

On one page was a name: "Pariharpur — Farida? granddaughter of Rahmatun — incomplete address."

Grandfather had evidently tried to search.

Below it he had written: "Time short. Article must be sent."

Renuka's anger toward him did not disappear, but it changed shape. How often were mistakes in history born not of malice, but of deadlines?

The following week Mahendranath, the Vice-Chancellor, and the editorial committee met.

Renuka fixed all sixty-three slips to the wall.

"These are all the available quotations."

Then, with red thread, she showed the seventeen earliest sources.

"Of the sixty-three, forty-six are later repetitions. Not one gives evidence of direct access to the original book."

Mahendranath said, "That I can accept."

Renuka showed the photograph of the Pariharpur letter.

"This 1910 letter discusses giving the name 'Lamp' to a shared register. The 1912 government report mentions a 'shared register.' Oral memory points toward a collective women's night-school book."

A committee member, Dr Charulata Mishra, asked immediately, "Then are you saying Shared Lamp was originally a collective book written by women?"

"That possibility is strong, but it is not proved."

"The 1889 quotation predates this."

"Yes. Which is why I cannot say that the Pariharpur lamp-register was the same source. Perhaps the name Shared Lamp belonged to an older tradition and was adopted for the school register. Perhaps the writer in 1889 had seen some other text. Perhaps different things were later merged under one name."

The Vice-Chancellor grew impatient. "But what are we supposed to say at the seminar? Did the book exist or not?"

Renuka said, "We should say that the evidence does not at present establish a single, stable book."

"No one will come to a seminar with that title."

Charulata Mishra smiled. "I would come for exactly that title."

Mahendranath kept looking at the slips. "And the reconstructed edition?"

"It should not be made."

The Vice-Chancellor sat upright. "That is not your decision."

"Then let the committee decide. But if forty-six quotations travelled through secondary quotation-sources and the originals behind the remaining seventeen are absent, creating the text between them would not be editing. It would be creation."

"We can mark it clearly."

"Then the book would not be Shared Lamp; it would be 'a modern reconstruction based on Shared Lamp.'"

The room fell silent again.

Mahendranath said slowly, "Shashibhushanji's article?"

Renuka placed a copy of Grandfather's private notebook before him.

"He himself recorded the possibility of a collective text. He did not publish it because he considered the evidence insufficient."

Mahendranath read the page. His face looked as though someone had opened a new page in an old debate with a teacher.

"This is a private note," he said.

"Yes."

"Scholars write doubts privately. Published conclusions are different."

"The problem is not the published conclusion. The problem is that later readers removed his caution and turned the conclusion into fact."

Charulata said, "On that point I agree."

The Vice-Chancellor tapped the table with a finger. "I have had an empty glass case prepared for three months."

Renuka said without thinking, "Let it remain empty."

Everyone looked at her.

"Why?"

"Because the original is absent."

The Vice-Chancellor did not laugh.

But Charulata slowly smiled.

In the end they reached a compromise. No complete reconstructed text would be published. Instead, a volume titled *Shared Lamp: Corpus of Quotations and Genealogy of Sources* would contain all sixty-three quotations, their earliest available sources, textual variants, later repetitions, and an explicit statement of the level of evidence.

Renuka's work had now doubled.

The hardest part was tracing the changing forms of each quotation.

"A lamp that lights only its own threshold sends its smoke into the neighbour's eyes."

A form from around 1890: "The lamp kept only on one's own threshold sends its smoke to another house."

1904: "The smoke of the lamp at one's own threshold hurts the eyes of another house."

1933: "The lamp that lights only its own threshold smokes the neighbour's eyes."

1978, Shashibhushan Karn: "A lamp that lights only its own threshold sends its smoke into the neighbour's eyes."

After 1990, Grandfather's version was the one most often quoted.

Beside his line Renuka wrote: "Edited modern form; not established as original."

Writing those four words was difficult.

At home that night her mother saw the manuscript.

"You will write 'not established as original' beside Grandfather's name?"

"Yes."

"People will say the granddaughter is cutting down her grandfather's work."

"I am also publishing his notes. He recorded his own doubts."

Her mother was silent.

"Does it hurt you?"

"Of course it does."

Renuka stopped over the paper.

Her mother continued, "But if your grandfather were alive, first he would scold you for three hours, and then at night he would quietly reread his article."

Renuka laughed.

"And the next day?"

"Hard to say."

They both laughed.

The week of the seminar approached. The empty glass case in the library now became the centre of the exhibition. Quotation cards were arranged around it. The middle, reserved for the original, remained empty.

The exhibition committee wanted to place an "imagined cover" inside the empty case so that visitors would not be disappointed.

Renuka objected.

“Why make a cover for which there is no evidence?”

“Visual appeal.”

“The exhibition is about the absence of the book.”

“An empty glass case is not visually attractive.”

“Then truth is not visually attractive.”

In the end the case remained empty.

Mahendranath was not entirely pleased by the decision, but his position had softened.

One day he brought an old notebook into Renuka's room.

“These are notes by my teacher, Dr Vamdev Chaudhary.”

“About Shared Lamp?”

“Yes.”

An entry from 1965 read: “Discussion with Prof. Shashibhushan. I believe the quotations do not derive from one source. Shashibhushan insists on the possibility of a single work.”

The next line: “Debate unresolved.”

Renuka looked at Mahendranath.

“Why did you not show this earlier?”

“I had seen it.”

“Then?”

Mahendranath pulled up a chair and sat down.

“Because I had been Shashibhushanji's student. His article was foundational for me. Papers that shook that foundation I dismissed as ‘insufficient evidence.’”

“Why bring it now?”

After a long pause Mahendranath said, “Looking at your slips, I realised that for forty years we argued about the meaning of the book, not about the nature of its existence.”

Renuka took the notebook.

Mahendranath laughed. “Now in my old age I have to become a student again.”

“Is that bad?”

“No. Only the knees hurt.”

On the first day of the seminar the hall was full.

The first session was “Shared Lamp: A Philosophy of Sharing Knowledge.” The second: “Discipline and Order: An Alternative Reading of Shared Lamp.” The third: “Threshold, Woman, and Household Writing.”

All three camps arrived carrying their favourite quotations.

In the opening lecture Renuka showed only the genealogy of sources.

She said, “So far, in no document have we found a direct statement such as ‘I saw the original copy of Shared Lamp.’ Of the sixty-three available quotations, forty-six appear to have travelled through earlier quotation-sources. The earliest available evidence for the remaining seventeen quotations is of different kinds. Whether Shared Lamp was one book, several versions, a tradition of collective registers, or whether separate texts later merged under one title — this question remains open.”

Hands rose immediately in the hall.

The first question: “Are you denying the existence of the book itself?”

“No. I am saying the form of its existence is uncertain.”

Second: "Then is study of the meanings of these quotations useless?"

"No. The quotations are real textual evidence, even if the original book is absent."

Third: "If there is no original, how can we know the author's intention?"

Renuka answered, "Perhaps we cannot. But we can know how later readers used the quotations."

Mahendranath sat in the back row. He nodded slightly.

The debate became sharper in the afternoon session.

One scholar said, "The theory of a collective women's register is attractive, but the 1889 source predates it. Do not make history from modern desire."

Charulata Mishra replied, "We are not calling the theory a fact. But the assumption of a single male author is not a fact either."

Another scholar said, "The texts show stable ideological consistency — a sign of one author."

Renuka displayed three mutually contradictory quotations on the screen.

"Or of many hands?"

There was laughter.

The debate did not end.

Renuka did not want it to end.

The exhibition opened in the evening.

Visitors stopped before the empty glass case.

Some asked, "Where is the book?" The staff replied, "That question is part of the exhibition."

Some were disappointed. Some read the quotations. Some stared at the empty velvet.

An elderly man looked at the case and said, "I thought there would be a book here."

With him was a girl of about fifteen. She kept reading the cards.

Suddenly she stopped at one line:

"Only when the wick is first trained within the house can it endure the wind outside."

The girl said to her grandfather, "Nani says this!"

Renuka was nearby. She turned.

"In exactly these words?"

The girl thought. "No. Nani says, 'Only when the wick is trained at home will it hold in a storm.'"

"When does she say it?"

"When I say I want to go away to study," the girl laughed. "She means I should learn household work first."

Her grandfather said, "My mother used to say it too."

Renuka asked, "Which village?"

"Basaith."

"Whose saying do you consider it?"

The old man shrugged. "An old proverb."

"Have you heard the name Shared Lamp?"

"No."

Renuka took out her notebook, then stopped.

“May I write this down? With your name, as a ‘living form’?”

The old man looked slightly surprised. “Is that useful too?”

“Very.”

The girl became excited. “I’ll ask Nani for more.”

Renuka smiled. “But write exactly the words Nani says. Do not add your own.”

“All right.”

After the exhibition closed that night, Renuka stood before the empty case.

All day people had wanted to see something inside it. There was nothing.

But the cards around it now seemed more alive to her than before.

The next day something unexpected happened.

A small parcel arrived in the library mail. Sender: “Shri Navalkishor Sah, Sitamarhi.”

Inside was an old printed pamphlet: “Household Lamp, 1876?” The year had been written by hand, not printed. On one of the middle pages stood a line:

“An old saying of Shared Lamp: dividing the threshold does not divide the light.”

Renuka went completely still.

This could be the earliest reference yet found — if 1876 was correct.

Mahendranath came immediately.

“The paper has to be examined.”

“Yes.”

“The ink.”

“Yes.”

“The year is handwritten. It may have been added later.”

“Yes.”

“The printer’s address?”

“Incomplete.”

“Then no announcement yet.”

Renuka smiled. “You have changed.”

Mahendranath smiled too. “My knees hurt, but the student learned something.”

The paper, type design, and printer’s mark were examined. The conclusion: the printing could belong to the last quarter of the nineteenth century, but 1876 could not be confirmed. The handwritten date might have been added later.

Even so, one thing was clear: the name Shared Lamp might have been in circulation before 1889.

The Pariharpur theory did not become weaker; it changed form.

Perhaps the women’s night school had adopted an older title. Perhaps Shared Lamp was not a book at all but the name of a circulating tradition of quotations. Perhaps an original book had existed and later collective registers took its name. Perhaps all of these were partly true.

Renuka changed the first sentence of her introduction.

She had first written: “Shared Lamp is a lost work of Mithila...”

She crossed it out and wrote: “The textual tradition circulated under the name Shared Lamp is presently available to us without an original copy...”

Mahendranath read it and said, “The word ‘book’ has disappeared from this.”

“Deliberately.”

“People will be angry.”

"Then they will write comments."

"And the next edition will be thicker."

They both laughed.

On the final day of the seminar, the editorial committee held a public discussion: "Is a reconstruction of Shared Lamp possible?"

A young researcher had used computational methods to combine the sixty-three quotations into "probable chapters." His presentation was attractive, grouping similar words, themes, and metaphors.

"Look," he said, "six thematic clusters are clear — lamp, threshold, water, grain, education, debt. From this we can infer the original structure."

Renuka asked, "Do these clusters belong to the original author, or to our classification?"

The young researcher paused. "The data reveal patterns."

"And the meaning of the patterns?"

"Requires interpretation."

"Then this is not reconstruction — it is modern classification."

The young researcher did not become angry. "Correct. Then we should call it that."

Renuka was pleased. This was a useful dispute.

Another scholar proposed printing an "inferred critical edition" with blank pages between quotations.

Charulata said, "Blank pages would look beautiful, but readers would again assume that this was the original chapter order."

For the first time Mahendranath said openly, "I oppose a reconstructed original."

There was movement in the hall.

A senior scholar asked, "You have spent forty years arguing for a single book."

Mahendranath replied calmly, "That is why the opposition is more necessary."

Renuka looked at him.

"I do not need to withdraw my old articles," Mahendranath continued. "I wrote what I understood from the evidence available at the time. But new evidence changes old conclusions. A scholar's lineage continues not through books, but through revision."

That sentence was not a quotation from Shared Lamp. It was Mahendranath's own.

The final decision was: 1. No complete reconstructed text of Shared Lamp. 2. A critical corpus of all sixty-three quotations. 3. All textual variants. 4. Clear genealogy of sources. 5. A separate chapter on the Pariharpur "lamp-register" documents. 6. An appendix of "living forms," explicitly identified as modern oral forms. 7. The search for an original copy would continue, but the fact of its absence would not be concealed.

It took six months for the volume to be completed.

Its final title was: Shared Lamp: Quotations, Sources, and the Absent Original.

The Vice-Chancellor did not like the phrase "Absent Original," but the committee kept it by majority vote.

On publication day the glass case was cleaned again.

Someone suggested placing a copy of the new volume inside it.

Renuka refused.

"This case is for the original Shared Lamp. My book is about it."

"Then it stays empty?"

"Yes."

The brass label was changed.

Before: "Shared Lamp — estimated eighteenth century? Original copy not yet located."

Now: "Original text/book circulated under the name Shared Lamp: not yet located. The displayed material consists of quotations and later evidence."

This time, reading the label did not irritate Renuka.

After the opening, people came. Some bought the new volume. Some argued. Some said, "The scholars have made the book disappear." Some said, "What used to be certain has now all become uncertain."

Renuka listened to them all.

In the afternoon Urmila Devi from Pariharpur arrived, along with Farida Khatoon's granddaughter and two teenage girls. Urmila looked at the glass case, then at the facsimile of her grandmother's letter on the wall.

Beneath it was written clearly: "From the family collection of Bhagwati Devi; reproduced with permission."

Urmila kept reading the name for a long time.

"Rahmatun's name is there too," she said.

"Yes."

"Janki's?"

"It is."

"And the students?"

Renuka pointed to a list. "Every name found in the register."

Urmila said softly, "Then it is right."

Farida's granddaughter read one card and smiled: "Half the pages of the lamp went into the water, half into people's mouths."

Beneath the card it said: "Farida Khatoon's remembered paraphrase of her grandmother's statement; not a verbatim quotation."

"Was it necessary to write that?" the granddaughter asked.

Renuka said, "Very."

"Why?"

"Because if we turn remembered meaning into exact words, a hundred years from now people will say those exact words were spoken."

Urmila laughed. "Then another new Shared Lamp would be born."

Renuka laughed too.

In the evening, the same girl who on the first day had mentioned her grandmother's "wick trained at home" saying returned, this time with her grandmother.

The grandmother's name was Sharda Devi.

Renuka said, "Would you say the line you use, once more?"

Without thinking, Sharda Devi said, "Only when the wick is trained at home will it hold in a storm."

"Whom did you hear it from?"

"My mother."

"And she?"

"From her mother."

"Have you heard the name Shared Lamp?"

Sharda shook her head. "No."

In the "Living Forms" register, Renuka wrote: "Sharda Devi, Basaith; family oral form; no direct connection with Shared Lamp established."

The girl asked, "Then could this be a line from the book or not?"

Renuka stopped her pen and looked at her.

"It could be. It could also not be."

"Then why write it down?"

"Because it is alive today. Evidence for an old original is one thing; life in the present is another."

The girl nodded as though satisfied.

When the exhibition was closing, Renuka stood alone beside the empty glass case. Library staff were switching off the lights one by one. Shadows lengthened over the quotation cards.

The case for the original remained empty.

A few months earlier, that emptiness had felt like failure. Not now.

Now around the empty place she could see lines, names, errors, revisions, families, the night school, the flood, scholars' stubbornness, women's registers, Grandfather's unfinished notes — all of it.

The book was absent. But the history of its absence was full.

Renuka took Grandfather's notebook from the yellow file. On its final blank page she wrote:

"To this day the original has not been found. No attempt should be made to fill the place of the original. When new evidence arrives, old conclusions should change."

She stopped.

Then she added one more line beneath it:

"A quotation may be the shadow of a book; but sometimes a shadow belongs to many bodies."

The moment she stopped writing, she became afraid that one day this sentence too might turn into a quotation and begin circulating under the name Shared Lamp.

She immediately added in brackets:

"—Renuka Karn, note written today."

Then she closed the notebook.

She did not put her own line into the empty glass case.

The case remained empty.

And perhaps for the first time, the emptiness looked not like the lack of a book, but like the discipline imposed by evidence.

The Seventh Direction

At Darbhanga's Centre for Folk Memory and Land Records, maps were usually of two kinds: those that showed land and those that asserted claims over it. Maps of a third kind rarely appeared. But on the day Anuja Jha found an old map called "The Seventh Direction," she understood that some maps do not keep account of land at all; they keep account of the places from which human beings are absent.

The map had been drawn on thick handmade paper. Around its edges were the ordinary directional marks: north, south, east, west. There were also two small signs for above and below. In the middle lay some villages of Mithila, ponds, old markets, river channels, schools, monasteries, mosques, crossroads, railway lines. But strangest of all were the fine red lines that obeyed no rule of geographical distance. One ran straight from a village in Madhubani to a veranda in Janakpur, then from there to a closed printing press in Darbhanga, then to a riverine tract beyond the Kosi. Some lines returned again and again to the same point.

In the upper right-hand corner was written:

"Six directions tell the body where a place is. The seventh direction tells memory in what order to move."

Below it was the signature: "Naresh Mishra, 1981–2004."

Anuja's task was to turn the Centre's entire collection into a digital archive. Its director, Vijaykant Thakur, wanted every map entered into a geographic information system. For land records this was simple: plot number, boundary, coordinates. But what coordinates could be assigned to the red lines of "The Seventh Direction?"

"Keep this one aside," Vijaykant said. "We will preserve it in the collection as a philosophical note. It is useless for the geographic information system."

Before folding the map, Anuja read the sentence again.

"The seventh direction tells memory in what order to move."

"Who was Naresh Mishra?" she asked.

Vijaykant pushed his spectacles upward. "He taught philosophy. Later he did independent research. For many years he wandered from village to village. People said he was an eccentric man. He wrote essays about direction."

"Why a map?"

"You probably will not find the answer to that question on the map itself."

"Other papers?"

"Three boxes. No one has catalogued them."

Vijaykant's tone was clear: if Anuja wanted, she could look, but the office's principal work was not to stop because of it.

Anuja did not fold the map. She could see a peculiar discipline in the red lines. They were not disorderly. At some points were small numbers: 1, 2, 3, 4. At some were words: "smell," "sound," "touch," "no name," "no place to return."

By evening that day, Anuja had opened the first box.

Naresh Mishra's notebooks contained fewer philosophical quotations than statements by ordinary people.

“Jamuna Devi of Sonbarsa — first place: yellow mustard. Second: the blacksmith’s hammer. Third: mother’s red anchal. Geography does not determine the sequence.”

“Abdul Sattar, Jainagar — the station whistle takes him directly to his grandmother’s courtyard; the forty kos in between are absent from memory.”

“Chandreshwar Paswan — the old pond was filled in. He says the pond is no longer in the village, but in his dreams the roads around it still curve around the same water.”

On one page of the notebook, in large letters, was written:

“The seventh direction is not an angle between north and west. To search for it on a compass would be an error. It is the sequence in which absent places join one another in memory.”

Anuja leaned back in her chair.

The idea was interesting, but was it something that could be mapped? The sequence of memory would differ from person to person. Ten people from one village would make ten directions.

The next page seemed to have heard her objection:

“One person = one seventh direction. A collective map emerges only where many memory-sequences repeatedly cross one another.”

Anuja smiled involuntarily.

“Very well, Naresh Babu,” she said in the empty room. “Let us see.”

The second box contained audio reels, small tapes, photographs, and hand-drawn village maps. Much of the equipment could no longer be used. Shivnarayan, the Centre’s old technician, still had one tape machine. While cleaning it, he said, “Are we going to wake all the ghosts in here?”

“We are going to wake voices.”

“There is not much difference between ghosts and voices.”

On the first tape was the voice of an elderly woman.

“Name?” Naresh Mishra asked.

“Jamuna Devi.”

“Your village?”

“Now? Or before?”

“Both.”

Laughter.

“Now Rahika. Before, Sonbarsa.”

“When you remember Sonbarsa, what comes first?”

“Mustard.”

“After mustard?”

“The clang of the blacksmith.”

“After the blacksmith?”

A long silence.

“Mother.”

“After Mother?”

“Back to mustard.”

Naresh’s voice: “The route?”

Jamuna Devi: “What route? I am sitting right here.”

The tape ended.

Anuja played it again. "What route? I am sitting right here."

Half the meaning of the "seventh direction" lay in that answer.

Two days later Anuja searched the Centre's register for Jamuna Devi's family. From an old address she learned that her grandson Manoj lived in Rahika. Anuja did not telephone; she sent a letter. A week later Manoj came to the Centre himself.

"You have Grandmother's voice?" he asked.

"Yes."

He listened to the tape. At the line about mustard, his eyes filled.

"Does Sonbarsa still exist?" Anuja asked.

"The village does. But the hamlet where Grandmother lived has changed greatly because of river erosion. The old house is gone."

"The blacksmith?"

Manoj laughed. "I know nothing about him. Grandmother used to say there was a Musahar blacksmith who worked his hammer at dawn. I never saw him."

"Her mother's red anchal?"

"Her mother. There is no photograph of her."

Anuja opened the map and showed Manoj Jamuna Devi's red line: mustard — blacksmith — mother — mustard.

Manoj looked at it for a long time.

"This is a map?"

"That is what Naresh Mishra called it."

"To me it looks like the beat of a song."

Anuja noted down: "the beat of a song."

The next testimony was Abdul Sattar's. His family had moved from Jainagar to Nepal. On the tape, the station whistle led to his grandmother's courtyard, the smell of raw mango, a Ramadan evening, then the sound of a bridge. Geographically those places lay far apart, but in memory they were a moment away.

The third was Chandreshwar Paswan's pond. The pond had been filled and a school built over it. Naresh had asked, "If there is no pond, then what happens to direction?"

Chandreshwar had replied, "When I go near the western wall of the school, my feet want to turn right by themselves. The old pond began there. The body sees today's wall; the feet remember the old water."

Reading that sentence, Anuja looked toward the window.

She remembered one place from her own childhood: the veranda of their old house in Darbhanga, where a harsingar tree had stood. The house had been sold. The tree had been cut down. A three-storey building stood there now. Anuja had passed along that road many times, but had never gone inside.

She began to search for the veranda in her memory. What came first?

The fragrance of harsingar.

Then her mother's voice: "Shoes outside."

Then her father's radio.

Then her sister Meera running and laughing.

Then?

An emptiness.

Anuja closed the notebook at once.

Meera had gone abroad eight years earlier. She was alive, healthy, with a family. But the sisters now spoke only on festivals and special occasions. No accident, no death. Only distance. And yet in Anuja's memory Meera remained a twelve-year-old child.

Anuja became annoyed with herself. This research was not a personal diary.

And yet in Naresh's notebook she found a sentence:

"A researcher who does not look at his own seventh direction will turn another person's memory into mere data."

"You gave a lot of orders," Anuja muttered.

The third box proved the most important. It contained papers from Naresh Mishra's final years. One proposal was titled: "Seventh Direction Map: An Archive of Memory for Displaced and Altered Places." It had been sent to an institution and rejected. Reason: "Method subjective; land-record use unclear."

Beneath it, in Naresh's hand: "Not for land records. For absent geography."

In one letter he had written:

"When land does not survive, history survives on paper. But the felt experience of place does not respect the boundary of paper. The question is not where the old house stood; the question is the order in which, on remembering it, people reach one place after another."

Anuja's professional mind kept objecting. If a map did not tell distance, did not tell direction, did not tell a route of travel, why call it a map?

One day she spread the map across Vijaykant's desk.

"I need one month."

"For what?"

"To understand the method of this map."

"Will you be able to put it into the geographic information system?"

"Not yet."

"Then?"

"Possibly in another form."

Vijaykant held his head. "The word 'possibly' frightens me."

"A large part of history rests on 'possibly.'"

"There is no budget."

"I will do it after my regular work."

"Then I have no right to stop you either."

Anuja laughed.

She began searching for people who had known Naresh. One name appeared repeatedly: "Prof. Shakuntala Chaudhary, Department of Philosophy." Now retired, she lived in Laheriasarai.

The moment Shakuntala Chaudhary heard Naresh's name, she said, "So at last someone has opened that mad map?"

Anuja was startled. "You have seen it?"

"I watched it being made."

"Why the seventh direction?"

Pouring tea, Shakuntala said, "At first he called it 'memory-direction.' Later, the seventh. He counted six directions: north, south, east, west, up, down. He was explicit that the seventh was neither anyone's religious direction nor an inner moral

direction. For him, the seventh meant sequential movement without spatial movement.”

Anuja wrote this down immediately.

Shakuntala laughed. “This matters. Once someone told him that in certain traditions the seventh direction is described as an inward direction. Naresh became very cautious. He said, ‘I will not steal another tradition’s term. My seventh direction is only a technical name for this map.’”

That caution settled inside Anuja like a check on her own method.

“How did he determine the technique?”

Shakuntala placed five spoons on the table.

“Suppose these are five places. Geography will ask the distances. Naresh would ask: when you remember the first place, which second place comes by itself? Then the third? Then does it return to the first? A sequence that repeatedly remains stable is a memory-route. When the same points appear among many people, that becomes a communal convergence.”

“Then this map is a network?”

“You may use that word if you wish, but he did not like ‘network.’ He said that in a network the centre is determined by an outside observer; in memory-direction the centre belongs to the person remembering.”

“What use did he think this had?”

Shakuntala grew serious. “He argued most fiercely about the question of use. He said that where roads, embankments, erosion, migration, or city expansion make a place disappear, how long people continue to keep it in their mental geography is itself a social record. For example, an old pond is filled in, but for five generations people continue to give directions by saying ‘near the pond.’ The government map says there is no pond. People’s language says there is.”

Anuja remembered the memory-system of Story 15, The Lineage of Mirrors, but this was different: that had been a register of household roles; here it was the social persistence of place.

“Naresh’s own seventh direction?” Anuja asked.

Shakuntala fell silent.

“He never said. Only once, in his final year, he said: ‘My direction begins with a voice.’”

“Whose?”

“He did not say.”

That night, when Anuja went home, she wrote out her own seventh direction for the first time.

She wrote: fragrance of harsingar; Mother’s “Shoes outside”; Father’s radio news; Meera running and laughing; the red wooden bench on the veranda; the brass bucket kept beneath the stairs; rainwater; Meera saying, “I’m going up to the roof”; and the ringing of the telephone in the present house.

She stopped. Why was the final point the present-day telephone?

Because after Meera went abroad eight years earlier, in the first few months she used to telephone at night. The instant the phone rang, Anuja’s mind went straight to the old roof. The telephone was modern; the memory was old.

She did not draw this line on the map. She kept only the list.

The following week a school group came to the Centre. Their teacher wanted to see Naresh Mishra's map. Anuja temporarily spread it across a table. The children looked at the red lines and began asking questions.

One boy asked, "Didi, where is the seventh direction?"

Anuja instinctively began to lift her hand, then stopped.

"On this map it is not shown by an arrow."

"Then how is it a direction?"

"Remember your kitchen at home. What comes first?"

The boy laughed. "The smell of fish."

"Then?"

"Mother scolds me: wash your hands."

Everyone laughed.

"Then?"

"Nani's house... because fish used to be cooked at Nani's house."

Anuja wrote three words on the board: kitchen → mother → Nani's house.

"How many kilometres are there in this?"

The boy said, "How would I know?"

"But there is still an order?"

"Yes."

"Naresh Mishra called such an order the seventh direction."

A girl asked, "Then everyone's direction is different?"

"Mostly."

"And there is one map?"

That question lay at the centre of Anuja's month's work.

She said, "Where many people's memories repeatedly meet at the same places, the map can become collective."

The girl did not seem satisfied. "Then what if people forget?"

Anuja paused before answering.

"Then the direction changes."

The school group left, but the question remained: what if people forget?

Naresh's papers contained a full note on this.

"A memory-map is not a permanent monument. It is a map of a particular moment in time. If people forget, that change itself is an archival fact."

Anuja was beginning to understand that Naresh did not want to create a fixed truth. He wanted to record changing states of memory.

Before the month was over, Anuja prepared a proposal. The red lines would not be uploaded directly into the geographic information system. Instead there would be two layers.

The first layer would contain physical places, with available coordinates. The second would contain the "memory-sequence," in which the links between points would record not distance but sequence number, storyteller, date, sensory cue, and level of certainty.

If a point no longer existed physically — such as a filled-in pond — its historical location could be entered with an estimate, while the memory-link remained separate.

Vijaykant read the proposal.

"This turns the map half into a data-register."

"Call it a register."

"Half register, half map."

"Possibly that is what is needed."

"Possibly again."

"This time, a useful possibly."

Vijaykant smiled. "Fine. Make a small sample. Twenty people."

Anuja began work.

Sonbarsa, Jainagar, Pariharpur, the old pond, the closed printing press, an erased market, a shifted river ghat — the memory-sequences of twenty people.

An elderly tailor, Naseem Ahmad, began his seventh direction with the "snip-snip" of scissors. From there it went to the old cloth market, then to his father's shop, then to the fire of 1987, then to his present small tailoring room.

A woman teacher, Padma Devi, began with "the school bell," then moved to her mother's literacy lessons, then to the end of her own education after marriage, and finally to sending her daughter to school. Four places; fifty years of time.

A migrant youth named Roshan began with the beep of a Delhi Metro door and reached the railway crossing in Darbhanga, then the bamboo gate of his grandmother's village.

Anuja understood: the seventh direction was not merely "the past." A present object could open an old place; a future decision could become tied to an old memory.

Time in this map was not linear, but neither did the person enter time itself as in Story 14. Here the journey was the sequence of the mind.

One day, while entering data, Anuja saw a familiar name on Naresh's map: "Jha Residence, Lakshmipur Chowk."

Her old house had been near Lakshmipur Chowk.

Her heart seemed to stop for a moment.

The line bore the number 47. Beside it, in small letters: "harsingar / shoes / radio / two sisters."

Anuja rose from her chair.

"Two sisters."

This could not be coincidence.

She searched all three boxes again. At last she found a thin envelope marked: "Lakshmipur, 1996, Mrs Sudha Jha."

Sudha Jha — Anuja's mother.

Anuja's hands trembled.

There was no tape, but there was a handwritten interview.

Naresh had asked: "When you remember the house, what comes first?" Sudha answered: "Harsingar." "Then?" — "Two daughters who never leave their shoes outside." "Names?" — "Anuja and Meera." "Then?" — "Radio. Their father listens to the news very loudly." "Then?" — "The roof. Meera runs upstairs. Anuja says she will fall." "Then?" — "One day this house will be sold. The children will go to their own homes. But perhaps the fragrance of harsingar will keep me there."

Anuja's eyes filled.

In 1996 the house had not yet been sold. Her mother may have said it as a joke or a guess. The house was sold in 2010. Her mother died in 2015.

At the end of the paper Naresh had written:

“Sudha Jha’s sequence is interesting: a possible future absence has already entered the memory-sequence.”

Anuja laid the paper on the table and stood at the window for a long time.

Her own list almost repeated her mother’s: harsingar, shoes, radio, Meera, roof.

Was memory inherited? No.

Had she heard her mother say such things? Possible.

Did the same objects in the same house naturally open a similar sequence? Also possible.

The central fact was not where the sequence came from. The central fact was that mother and daughter, in different years, had drawn almost the same direction around the same absent house.

Anuja telephoned Meera.

For the first time in eight years, not on a festival, not for some task, not after a message asking “what time can we talk?” She called directly.

Meera answered.

“What happened?”

“Nothing.”

“Then why are you calling at this time?”

“I have a question.”

“Ask.”

“When you remember the old house, what comes first?”

Meera was silent, then laughed. “Have you suddenly gone mad?”

“Answer.”

“Harsingar.”

Anuja closed her eyes.

“Then?”

“Ma shouting — shoes outside!”

They both laughed at the same time.

“Then?”

“Baba’s radio.”

Anuja’s throat tightened.

Meera asked, “What is wrong with you?”

Anuja told her about Naresh’s map and read out their mother’s interview.

There was a long silence at the other end.

Meera said softly, “Ma remembered me running?”

“Yes.”

“And you?”

“Being afraid you would fall.”

Meera laughed, then her voice changed. “She was right.”

They spoke for almost an hour: about the old house, their mother, their father, the roof, school, quarrels between sisters. At one point Meera said, “I used to think you did not like talking about old things.”

Anuja was surprised. “Why?”

"After the house was sold, you said: what is the use of keeping all this? Divide the photographs and donate the rest."

"I was trying to be practical."

"I thought it made no difference to you."

"It did."

"Then why didn't you say so?"

Anuja could not find an answer.

She remembered Naresh's line: "A researcher who does not look at his own seventh direction..."

She said, "Perhaps I did not have the language for it."

After the call ended, Anuja added a tenth point to her private list: "Meera — today's voice."

This time the seventh direction did not close upon the past. It returned toward a present relationship.

The sample project was completed. The Centre's small exhibition was titled: "The Seventh Direction: Places That Move in Memory."

Vijaykant wanted seven arrows at the entrance. Anuja refused.

"Why? It will look attractive."

"The seventh direction is not an arrow."

"Then what symbol?"

Anuja thought. In the end the entrance displayed only the six ordinary directional signs: north, south, east, west, up, down. The centre remained blank. Beneath it was a small line:

"Seventh direction: memory-sequence; no arrow."

In the first room was Naresh's original map. In the second, the memory-sequences of four people with audio. In the third, a digital screen: points appeared on a physical map, but the memory-lines carried no measure of distance. Touching a point opened the narrator's sequence.

Anuja deliberately did not include her family's map in the exhibition. Her mother's permission could no longer be obtained. Meera could give permission, but Anuja decided that this time it would remain private. Not every memory needed to become a public archive.

Shakuntala Chaudhary came on the opening day and stood for a long time before the map.

"He would have been happy," she said.

"Naresh Mishra?"

"Yes. But on seeing your 'no arrow' he would first make five objections."

"And then?"

"After the sixth objection he would agree."

Anuja laughed.

A university student asked, "Madam, this is not a scientific map, is it?"

Anuja said, "If by scientific you mean a spatial map in which things can be measured, no. If keeping method, source, date, repetition, and uncertainty explicit is part of scientific discipline, then this is an archival method."

"Does the seventh direction really exist?"

Anuja asked, "Does your childhood home still exist?"

“No.”

“Do you remember it?”

“Yes.”

“How do you go there now?”

The student laughed. “By remembering.”

Anuja only nodded.

In the final week of the exhibition, an elderly woman stood before the map under glass. Her hand trembled. She pointed at one location and said, “This Barahi Tola is in the wrong place.”

Anuja came closer. “On the official map it is here.”

“The official map is wrong.”

“The old location?”

“Before my marriage Barahi Tola was beside the river. Later it shifted.”

“When?”

“After the flood.”

“The official map may show the new settlement.”

The woman was dissatisfied. “Then where is the old one?”

Anuja did not immediately take out her notebook. First she said, “If you wish, tell me. I will make a separate record of both the old and present locations.”

The woman sat down.

“First memory?” Anuja asked.

“Not mustard,” the woman laughed. “Everyone asks about mustard. For me, the bell on the buffalo.”

Anuja laughed too.

A new seventh direction began.

On the day the exhibition closed, Centre staff began putting Naresh’s original map back into its case. Anuja spread it out one last time. The red lines now seemed less mysterious than before, but more alive.

She looked at the line for Lakshmipur Chowk — harsingar / shoes / radio / two sisters.

Beside it was a small sign by Naresh that Anuja had not noticed earlier: an open circle whose two ends did not touch. In his notebook she found its meaning: “A memory-sequence is not a closed circle; leave room for the present to enter.”

Anuja remembered her private list. Tenth point: Meera, today’s voice.

The sequence had changed now.

Harsingar → Mother → radio → Meera as a child → roof → telephone → Meera today.

In memory she still reached the old house, but she did not remain trapped there. The seventh direction brought her back to the living voice of her sister in the present.

She folded the map.

Outside it was evening. To go home from the Centre, Anuja usually took the road south. That day too she turned south. The compass direction had not changed. The road was the same. The distance was the same.

But a faint fragrance of harsingar came from somewhere — perhaps from someone’s courtyard nearby.

Anuja stopped for a moment.

Her memory walked toward the old veranda, left its shoes outside, passed the radio, climbed the stairs — and this time, on the roof, there was not the twelve-year-old Meera, but today's Meera standing at the other end of the telephone.

Anuja kept her feet on the road.

At that moment the seventh direction cut across no one's north, south, east, or west.

It became only the sequence by which one absent place could lead to one living relationship.

The Last Reader

When the doors of Sonbarsa's "People's Reading Room" opened for the first time after the fire, there were no books inside - only wet ash, twisted iron shelves, and a black layer of paper on the floor that crumbled to powder beneath a footstep.

The fire had broken out three nights earlier. Rainwater had leaked from the roof down to the old wiring, or perhaps a rat had gnawed through a cable - the electricity department offered two different explanations. The fire itself had not been very large; the building survived. The books did not. Paper took the smoke first, then the flame, then the water from the fire engine.

A collection one hundred and thirteen years old turned into wet black pulp in three hours.

No one was injured.

For that reason the incident remained in the newspapers for no more than two days.

But Raghupati Mishra was still sitting on the veranda of the reading room on the third day.

He was seventy-two years old, a retired postal worker. All his life he had delivered letters, and in his spare time he had read books. His membership card in the People's Reading Room was number 047. It had been issued in 1968, when he was fourteen.

The librarian, Madhavi Kumari, almost forty years younger than Raghupati, said to him on the third day:

"Go home, Kaka. There is nothing left here now."

Raghupati kept looking at the heaps of ash.

"Something remains."

"What?"

He tapped his forehead with a finger.

Madhavi did not answer.

Raghupati said again, "I have read them."

"All of them?"

"Almost every book that stood on those shelves."

Madhavi did not laugh. She knew this was not an empty boast. Old members of the reading room said that if Raghupati did not take a book home, he sat there and read it. Children's books, poetry, novels, agricultural pamphlets, travelogues, old magazines, plays - whatever came to hand.

Madhavi asked softly, "Do you remember them?"

Raghupati could not answer at once.

"Some."

Everything began with that "some."

The principal accession registers had not been completely destroyed. Two survived inside a small iron safe in the office - one covering 1951 to 1988, the other 1996 to 2014. The register for the eight years in between was missing. A digital list of newer books

survived as a copy on Madhavi's phone, because a week earlier she had taken the list home to revise it.

From these sources, much of the information about titles, authors, and publication years could be rebuilt.

But the text inside the books?

No.

At first Madhavi thought they could search for replacement copies. Some books would be found in the market, some in other libraries, some with authors' families. But when she examined the accession registers she realised that nearly three hundred books had been printed fifty or sixty years earlier by small presses, without anything like a standard book number and without reprints.

Some titles appeared nowhere except in this reading room's catalogue.

One Day's Rain - Shashikala Chaudhary, 1962.

Three Windows - Neelambar Jha, 1957.

Letters of Earth - Jagdish Kamat, 1971.

Wooden Wings - Rameshwar Mandal, year unclear.

Half a Heron - author's name blurred in the register.

Two Bamboo Leaves - a children's story?

The River's Door - a play or a novel?

Seven Kathas of Sky - poetry?

The register preserved the title, not the genre.

And not a single sentence from inside.

On the fifth day after the fire, the district library officer came. He inspected the damage to the building, took photographs, and promised reconstruction. As he was leaving he said:

"Prepare a list of the old collection. Send a proposal for whatever can be bought again."

Madhavi said, "Some books will not be found at all."

"Then mark them 'unavailable.'"

Raghupati had been listening from the veranda.

He suddenly said, "Why unavailable? I remember them."

The officer looked at him.

"What do you remember?"

Raghupati said, "In One Day's Rain, a woman places an earthen pitcher on the roof. The whole story takes place during one day's rain. At the end the pitcher fills, but her husband does not return home."

Madhavi looked startled.

Raghupati continued, "In Three Windows there is a house where three generations look at the same pond through three different windows."

"You remember books that old?" the officer asked.

"Not all of them. Fragments."

The officer became enthusiastic. "Excellent! Prepare memory-based descriptions. At least we will have some idea of the contents."

Madhavi said at once, "We will not call an estimate the contents of the book."

The officer laughed. "Call it whatever you like. But do the work."

He left.

Raghupati looked at Madhavi.

"Shall I write?"

Drying the damp edge of the register, Madhavi said, "Write. But make it clear from the very first line: 'According to Raghupati Mishra's memory.'"

"What if I remember wrongly?"

"Then we will write that the memory may be wrong."

Raghupati did not like that sentence.

"I am the one who read them."

"Which is why you will be the one to write. But what was read and what is remembered are not the same thing."

Raghupati fell silent.

From the next day he began working in the reading room's temporary quarters. The room was behind the panchayat building. One table, two chairs, a thin strip of sunlight through the window.

Madhavi read titles from the accession register; Raghupati closed his eyes and tried to remember.

"One Day's Rain."

Raghupati answered at once:

"Shashikala Chaudhary. Blue cover. A drop of water on it."

Madhavi said, "The colour of the cover is not in the register."

"I remember it."

"All right. The story?"

Raghupati wrote:

"A newly married woman in a town in Mithila, perhaps Malati, places an earthen pitcher on the roof during the first rain..."

Madhavi asked, "Are you certain the name was Malati?"

Raghupati stopped.

"Possibly."

"Then write 'possibly Malati.'"

"If I write 'possibly' this many times, the story will become lame."

"We are not writing the story. We are writing memory."

Raghupati wrinkled his nose.

Five titles on the first day.

Seven on the second.

Only two on the third.

Some books seemed to open the moment he closed his eyes.

"Wooden Wings."

Raghupati began:

"A boy makes a wooden bird. His father is a carpenter. The child wants the bird to fly. The father says wood does not fly; it becomes boats. At the end the child ties paper to the bird's wings and lets it go from the roof."

Madhavi asked, "Does it fall?"

"No. It catches the wind."

"How far?"

"As far as the mango tree."

"The boy's name?"

"Manoj."

"Certain?"

Raghupati smiled. "This time, certain."

Four days later they came to Letters of Earth.

Raghupati dictated:

"A postman reaches a village with letters during a flood. The bridge is broken. He carries the letters above his head and crosses the water. One letter belongs to a house where the recipient has already died. He buries the letter in the earth..."

Madhavi suddenly stopped him.

"Kaka."

"Yes?"

"This sounds like your own life."

"So what if I was a postman?"

"You told me that in the flood of 1987 you crossed water carrying letters above your head."

Raghupati stopped his pen.

"That was a different incident."

"And the letter to a dead recipient?"

Raghupati thought for a long time.

He remembered a scene: rain, a mud house, an elderly woman saying, "He died three days ago." The letter in his hand. But had he buried that letter?

No.

Probably not.

"I gave the letter to the people of the house," he said slowly.

"Then was it buried in the book?"

"It may have been."

Madhavi wrote a note: "Memory may be influenced by personal experience."

Raghupati disliked it.

"Will you doubt everything?"

"Where the two do not match."

"You do not trust me?"

"I do. But a claim about a book requires more than trust."

That night at home, Raghupati tried again to remember Letters of Earth. Lying in bed, he closed his eyes.

The story began:

The postman.

The flood.

The letter.

The dead man.

But the postman's face was Raghupati's own younger face.

He opened his eyes.

The next day, on the page for Letters of Earth, he himself wrote in red:

"My own life as a postman may have entered this recollection."

Madhavi said nothing.

By the end of a week they had made memory-notes for twenty-seven books.

News spread.

People in the village began saying, "Raghupati Kaka is writing the books again."

The remark gave Raghupati both pride and fear.

He kept saying, "I am not writing them again. I am writing what I remember."

But for people's convenience the two were the same thing.

A local newspaper ran the headline:

"Three Hundred Books Alive in the Memory of a Seventy-Two-Year-Old Reader."

Madhavi slapped the newspaper down on the table.

"Three hundred?"

Raghupati said, "I didn't say that."

"Alive?"

"I didn't say that either."

"Now people will think you can recite entire books from memory."

Raghupati folded the newspaper. "People will think whatever they want."

"No. This will spoil the work."

It did.

The next day the district office telephoned. The officer was delighted.

"There is so much interest! I am thinking we should publish selected books under the title *Reborn from Memory*."

Madhavi said, "The descriptions have not even been verified yet."

"This is literature, not a court of law."

"But a new text under an old author's name?"

"We will clearly say it is memory-based."

Raghupati listened in silence.

After the call ended, Madhavi asked, "What do you want?"

Raghupati took time to answer.

"If the books could be read again..."

"They would not be the books."

"What about what I remember?"

"That would be the book inside you."

The sentence kept Raghupati awake all night.

He kept thinking: the book inside.

Does a reader create a second copy of a book within himself?

Or, in the act of reading, does the book mix with the reader's life and become something else?

The next day an event made the question more difficult.

Madhavi's friend Suchitra, who was doing research at the university, came from Patna. After hearing about the fire, she had brought an old book with her.

"Look."

On the cover was written:

Wooden Wings

Rameshwar Mandal

Second Edition, 1982.

Raghupati almost rose from his chair.

"It survived?"

"In the Patna University collection."

Madhavi immediately took out Raghupati's memory-note.
 Raghupati was excited.
 "Let's see! Is Manoj in it or not?"
 Suchitra opened the book.
 The central character was not Manoj but "Chandan."
 His father was not a carpenter; his maternal uncle made toys.
 A wooden bird? Yes.
 The child wanted it to fly? Yes.
 Paper wings? No. He tied thin strips of cloth.
 Did he release it from the roof? No. From the high embankment of a pond.
 And at the end?
 The bird did not catch the wind and reach the mango tree.
 It fell straight into the water.
 Chandan did not cry. His uncle took the bird out of the water and said, "The
 wood did not fly, but your eyes saw the sky."
 Raghupati remained silent for a long time.
 Madhavi placed his memory-page before him.
 "You wrote that the bird flew as far as the mango tree."
 Raghupati kept turning the pages of the book.
 "I remembered it clearly."
 "Yes."
 "Manoj too."
 "Here it is Chandan."
 Raghupati lowered his face.
 Suchitra said gently, "Memory is like this."
 "No," Raghupati said. "I made an error."
 Madhavi said at once:
 "An error. But not a lie."
 "What is the difference?"
 "With a lie, you know what you are saying is false. Memory showed you a scene
 that felt true."
 Raghupati closed the book.
 "And the mango tree?"
 Madhavi asked, "Did you ever try to make a wooden bird fly when you were a
 child?"
 Raghupati did not smile.
 "Once. With a neighbour named Manoj. Near a mango tree."
 Madhavi and Suchitra looked at one another.
 Raghupati leaned back in his chair.
 Manoj.
 The mango tree.
 Paper wings.
 All of it had entered the book from his own childhood.
 They stopped work for the day.

That evening Raghupati went to the burned reading-room building. The shattered glass had already been removed. The shelves had been taken out. Only black smoke marks remained on the walls.

He thought: if the real copy of Wooden Wings had never been found, his Manoj, mango tree, and paper wings would have become "Rameshwar Mandal's story."

Twenty years later someone might quote it.

What the author had never written would circulate under the author's name.

Raghupati felt afraid - not of Story 16, but of his own life: afraid of certainty.

The next morning he told Madhavi:

"At the top of every note, write in red: 'This is not a reconstruction of the original book.'"

Madhavi laughed. "I have been saying that since the first day."

"And underneath: 'memory-text.'"

"That is a good name."

"Do not remove the book's title. But below the author's name write: 'in Raghupati Mishra's memory.'"

Madhavi nodded.

The nature of the work changed.

Earlier Raghupati had tried to remember the "correct story." Now he also wrote down the structure of his remembering.

Three Windows:

"I remember three women - grandmother, daughter-in-law, granddaughter. The relationships in the book may have been different. The pond feels certain. I remember the western window as red, but the window in my maternal grandparents' house was red too."

One Day's Rain:

"The pitcher on the roof - certain? A very strong image. The husband does not return - possibly. Low confidence in the name Malati. My mother had an acquaintance called Malati Mausi."

Two Bamboo Leaves:

"Two child brothers? Or two sisters? In memory, one leaf speaks to the other. Perhaps it was not a story but a poem."

Half a Heron:

"Title certain. Nothing remembered from inside. Only a white cover with half a bird."

Earlier Raghupati had wanted to fill the blank places.

Now he marked them as blank.

But memory did not stop playing its games.

One day, for The River's Door, he wrote five pages. The story centred on a woman boatman named Jyoti, who altered the height of her doorway according to the rising and falling river. At the end the river changed course and the doorway was left in the wall.

Madhavi read it, enthralled.

"This is very good."

Raghupati smiled with pride.

Three weeks later a copy of *The River's Door* was found in a private collection in Kolkata.

It was a play.

The principal character was an elderly scholar.

There was no woman boatman.

No Jyoti.

"Door" was only a metaphor: "Rivers open every door."

Raghupati's five pages were entirely wrong.

He began tearing them up.

Madhavi caught his hand.

"Why?"

"This is not the book."

"That is true."

"Then why keep it?"

"It is your story."

"Where did I write it? I remembered it."

"But what you remembered is not in the original. Then it is a new story born from Raghupati's memory."

Raghupati became angry.

"It is theft."

"If you print it under the old author's name, that would be wrong. But what if you say: I remembered it incorrectly, and from that mistaken memory this story was born?"

Raghupati kept holding the pages.

"You want to make me an author?"

"Not I. Memory is doing that."

Raghupati did not tear the pages.

On the file he wrote:

"The *River's Door* - a separate story born from false memory. Does not correspond to the original play."

From that day there were two files.

One: "Memory-text: verification pending/partial."

The other: "New writing born from memory: not representative of the original."

Raghupati felt embarrassed by the second file, but slowly it grew thicker.

In remembering a book called *Yellow Bus* he wrote of a ten-year-old child inside a bus - later the recovered book turned out to be a travelogue.

In remembering *Little Bell* he wrote a school story - the original was a veterinary pamphlet.

In remembering *The Salt Tree* he imagined a widow growing a plant in the saline soil of her courtyard - the original book was a scientific agricultural leaflet.

Madhavi laughed. "You turn every genre into literature."

Raghupati replied, "In old age the mind turns even a farming booklet into a story."

But behind the laughter lay a serious question.

Why does memory fill empty places with story?

Suchitra sent some articles on psychology. Madhavi read aloud from them: memory is often reconstruction, not exact storage; present experience can alter an old recollection.

Raghupati listened and said, "Scholars took a long time to understand. My mother used to say: 'The mind is not an empty room, it is a kitchen; whatever you put in, something will get cooked.'"

Madhavi immediately began writing it down.

"Which book is that from?"

Raghupati burst out laughing. "This time, from my mother. Write that clearly."

Two months later the reconstruction committee met.

The district officer, a panchayat representative, Madhavi, Suchitra, two teachers, and Raghupati.

The officer's primary objective was still to buy the books again.

Madhavi presented the report:

Total listed titles: 2,748.

Copies found elsewhere: 1,936.

Repurchase possible: 1,422.

Only photocopy/digital copy possible: 418.

Still unavailable: 392.

Raghupati's memory-notes:

238 titles.

Partially verified: 87.

Clearly mixed/incorrect: 41.

Impossible to verify: 110.

The officer asked, "Can we publish these 110?"

Madhavi said, "As memory testimony."

"Not as reconstruction of the books?"

"No."

"People will be disappointed."

For the first time Raghupati himself said:

"Let them be."

Everyone looked at him.

"At first I too thought that if I remembered something, the book had survived. Now I understand: what survived in me was not the book but the experience of reading it. To call that the book would be unjust to the author."

The officer looked disappointed.

"Then what use is this work?"

Raghupati answered:

"Which books people read, which images stayed with them, how time altered them - is that of little use?"

Suchitra added, "And wherever the original has been found, the comparison is valuable in itself."

Madhavi showed the second file. "And some mistaken memories have become new stories."

The officer laughed. "Then the project has turned from a library project into a literary conference."

"Perhaps," Raghupati said.

The committee finally agreed that the project would not be called "Reconstructing Books from Memory."

Its new title was:

"Behind the Books Once Read: One Reader's Register of Memory."

Raghupati found the title somewhat heavy, but approved it.

Meanwhile repairs to the reading-room building had begun. The burned shelves were removed. New plaster went up on the walls. The panchayat decided that one room would preserve the history of the old collection.

Madhavi wanted Raghupati's memory-pages displayed there.

Raghupati said, "Not all of them."

"Why?"

"The mistakes too?"

"Especially those."

"People will laugh."

"Then they will read."

Raghupati agreed.

The first display panel placed two versions of Wooden Wings side by side.

Left:

Raghupati's memory:

Manoj, father a carpenter, paper wings, flight as far as the mango tree.

Right:

Available 1982 edition:

Chandan, maternal uncle a toy-maker, cloth wings, bird falling into the pond.

Between them a small line:

"Memory is not a copy of the original; the reader's life may alter it."

Schoolchildren came to see the exhibition.

One child asked, "Kaka, why did you write a lie?"

Raghupati's face reddened, but Madhavi did not intervene.

Raghupati bent toward the child and said, "Do you remember yesterday afternoon exactly?"

"Yes."

"What did you eat?"

"Rice and lentils."

A friend standing behind him laughed. "You ate khichdi at school."

The child fell silent.

Everyone laughed.

Raghupati said, "See? The mind sometimes fills an empty place. The difference is that when you find out, you admit it."

The child asked again, "Then is your story bad?"

Raghupati was about to say "No," then stopped.

"As the story of the old book, it is bad. If you look at it as my story, that is another matter."

Satisfied, the child moved on to the next panel.

That same day a Class Twelve student named Neha stopped at Raghupati's mistaken memory of The River's Door. She read all five pages.

"This isn't in the original?" she asked.

"No," Raghupati said.

"Then who wrote it?"

"I remembered it wrongly."

"How can a wrong memory be this complete?"

Raghupati laughed. "That is my question too."

Neha said, "May I write a play based on this?"

Raghupati answered at once, "The original play *The River's Door* is something else. Change the title."

"I want to use the story of the woman boatman."

"Then make it your own story. You do not need to give my name."

Madhavi was listening from a distance.

Three weeks later Neha brought a short four-page play:

"*The Door Left in the Wall.*"

Its principal character was not the woman boatman but her daughter. After the river changed course, the daughter painted the old doorway inside the new house so that her mother would not forget direction in the new place.

Raghupati read it and remained silent for a long time.

"This is not my story," he said.

Neha became nervous. "Is it bad?"

"No. That is why it is good."

"What do you mean?"

"You changed even my mistaken memory again."

Neha laughed.

Raghupati suddenly felt that once a book is read, change cannot be prevented. The only question is whether the change will be hidden under the original's name, or accepted under its own.

That night at home he opened the second file.

The Salt Tree - mistaken memory.

He began completing the story.

The first five pages had come from memory. Now he wrote deliberately.

He gave the widow a name: Champa.

The saline soil was no longer a scientific error; it was the dried bed of the village's old pond.

The tree did not literally grow salt; the white mineral crust spreading on its leaves was what Champa called "salt flowers" when she spoke to the children.

At the end she did not cut the tree down. She changed the soil.

Raghupati completed the story in three days.

On the file he wrote:

"An original story born from confusion over the old title. Not a reconstruction of the lost unknown book."

He stared for a long time at the word "original."

For the first time in his life, he wrote his own name as an author:

"Raghupati Mishra."

His hand trembled.

The next day Madhavi read it.

"This should be published."

"Let the library be rebuilt first."

"Both can happen together."

Raghupati laughed. "You people are always in a hurry."

"You waited seventy-two years."

"Not to become a writer."

"Memory waited."

The People's Reading Room reopened seven months after the fire.

It kept its old name.

The new shelves held repurchased books, photocopies, donations, and rare works printed from digital copies. The total collection had not yet reached its former size, but the room again smelled of paper.

On one wall were written three words:

"Original." "Memory." "New Writing."

Madhavi's insistence.

"So that people do not mix them up," she said.

In the room devoted to the old collection's history, a selection of Raghupati's notes was displayed. "Certain," "doubtful," "mixed with personal memory," "inconsistent after original located" - every label was clearly marked.

At the opening, the district officer gave a speech.

"Fire may destroy books, but not ideas."

Raghupati did not applaud that sentence. It seemed too beautiful to him, too easy.

Some ideas truly had been destroyed.

Of some books, not a single sentence remained in anyone's memory.

Some authors' names were blurred in the register.

Some things would not return.

It was necessary to admit that.

After the speech, the officer called Raghupati to the stage.

"Our last reader!"

Everyone laughed and applauded.

Raghupati stood at the microphone.

"I am not the last reader," he said.

The officer kept smiling, assuming it was a modest phrase.

Raghupati continued:

"I am only a reader who had read many books from the old collection. I remember some correctly, some wrongly, and much not at all. What I do not remember, I will not invent and place under the name of an old author."

The hall became quiet.

"And when a wrong memory gives birth to a new story, we will call it a new story."

Neha, sitting in the front row, smiled.

"Saving books is necessary," Raghupati said, "but so is preserving the limits of one's own memory."

He stepped away from the microphone.

The speech was short.

Later Madhavi said, "It was good."

Raghupati replied, "In a long speech, memory adds things again."

In the evening, after the opening crowd had thinned, Madhavi brought a small bundle.

"This is for you."

On top was a newly printed booklet:

The Salt Tree

Raghupati Mishra

People's Reading Room Publication Series, 1.

Raghupati did not reach for it.

"Without asking me?"

"On the manuscript you wrote, 'if it is worth publishing.'"

"Was that consent?"

"I read it as consent."

"See? Not only memory - reading changes things too."

They both laughed.

Raghupati opened the booklet.

On the first page was an editorial note:

"This story was born from the author's mistaken memory of an unavailable title from the destroyed collection. It is not a reconstruction of the old book."

Raghupati let out a long breath.

"Good."

"Will you read it now?"

"Something I wrote myself?"

"Become its first reader."

Raghupati sat in a chair on the veranda. Outside, evening was descending. Light fell on the glass doors of the new shelves.

He began reading The Salt Tree.

After two pages he stopped.

"Did I write this sentence?"

Madhavi called from a distance, "Three months ago."

"I don't remember it."

"Then be careful. Tomorrow you may say some old writer wrote it."

Raghupati burst out laughing.

He went back to reading.

The story was both familiar and unfamiliar. Some sentences he remembered writing at the time and now had forgotten. Some scenes acquired new meanings when he read them now.

Suddenly he understood: even an author eventually becomes a reader of his own writing, and the reader's memory goes on rewriting.

Neha came in through the doorway, carrying a copy of her own play.

"Kaka, have you read it?"

"Half."

"Read mine too."

"First let me finish this one."

Neha sat opposite him.

For a while both read in silence - an old reader reading his new story, a teenage girl reading her new play.

The ashes of the old books had by then been mixed into the earth behind the building. Raghupati could have turned them into a symbol if he had wished - words from ashes, seeds from ashes, rebirth from ashes. But he thought nothing of the sort.

Ash was ash.

What was gone was gone.

What lay on the table was something else.

Some of it from memory.

Some of it from error.

Some of it deliberately written.

Some of it waiting to change again because of the next reader.

Raghupati turned the final page of *The Salt Tree*.

Neha asked, "How is it?"

He closed the book.

"Different from what I remembered."

Neha laughed. "You wrote it yourself."

"Exactly."

Madhavi heard them as she was closing the shelves. "So?"

Raghupati ran his hand over the cover of the new book.

"Then this is not a book that survived."

He looked at Neha.

"This is the first book after the fire."

Neha placed her play on the table.

"The second as well."

Raghupati opened her manuscript.

Outside, a new light came on over the reading room's signboard.

There was no last reader anymore.

The Incident at the Pond

It had not been even two days since the new stone steps were built at the western ghat of Baraela Pond when Gunja fell into the water.

The incident took place at about 5:12 in the evening - on this time almost everyone agreed. The stopped clock at the medicine shop beside the pond showed 5:10, but the shopkeeper said it ran two minutes slow. The school bell had already rung at five. The water tanker arrived at 5:20 - there was a register entry for that. So 5:12 was entered on the panchayat's inquiry sheet.

Gunja was fifteen years old. The bone in her right leg was not broken, but her knee was badly sprained; there were abrasions from the stone on her arm, and she had fever for three days. Munna Paswan, who worked with the masonry team constructing the ghat, had pulled her out of the water.

Within two hours, five versions of the incident were circulating through the village.

First: Gunja had forced her way into a closed ghat.

Second: the ghat was unfinished, but the contractor had declared it complete in order to claim payment.

Third: a red cord had been tied across the entrance, but children had untied it.

Fourth: panchayat workers themselves had removed the cord in order to take photographs.

Fifth: the real problem was not the steps at all, but the public handpump that had been broken for three days; had the handpump been working, Gunja would never have gone to the pond.

Three days later an inquiry meeting was held in the panchayat building.

The mukhia, Sarojini Devi, said, "Before searching for someone to blame, we need to understand what happened."

The contractor, Prem Lal Singh, immediately said, "The incident is clear. The worksite was closed. The girl crossed the cord."

Gunja's mother, Mira Devi, leaned forward in her chair. "Where was the cord?"

"It was tied."

"If it was, why didn't my daughter see it?"

"Ask her."

The atmosphere might have heated up, but Sarojini raised her hand.

"Today we will hear the statements of five people separately. No one will interrupt. Afterwards, we will write down separately the facts that agree and the matters that remain disputed."

On the table at the back of the room lay a thick school register. The secretary, Arun Kumar, had written a heading across the top:

"Baraela Pond, Western Ghat Incident - Register of Facts."

Gunja asked to testify first.

Her father wanted her mother to speak, but Gunja said, "I am the one who fell."

Sarojini nodded.

Gunja sat in the chair. A cloth bandage was wrapped around her knee.

"Tell us exactly as it happened," Sarojini said.

Gunja began.

That day, when she returned from school, her grandmother had said, "The handpump is not working again. Bring two buckets of water."

There was no private tap in the house. The public handpump stood at the turn of the lane, but its handle had been spinning uselessly for three days. People were temporarily bringing washing water from the pond. Drinking water came by tanker.

Gunja took two brass buckets and went to the pond. The western ghat was the closest to her house. The new stone shone. Above it was a plaque reading "Water Conservation Scheme." Two bamboo poles stood at the edge, but there was no cord between them.

"Did you see a red cord?" the secretary asked.

"No."

"The bamboo poles?"

"Yes."

"Did anyone stop you?"

"No."

"Anyone else at the ghat?"

"Two children were sitting above. A goat was drinking water. Munna Kaka was below, gathering some tools."

Gunja stepped onto the first stair. The stone was wet because there had been light rain in the afternoon. The second stair was fine. The moment she placed her right foot on the third, the stone suddenly tilted forward.

"Did the stone break?"

"No. The whole stone tilted."

"Did your foot slip?"

Gunja thought.

"I am not certain whether the stone moved first or my foot slipped first. But it felt as though the ground beneath my foot changed."

She dropped the buckets and tried to regain her balance. Her left hand struck the wall, but the wall was wet. She fell sideways into the water.

The pond was not very deep, but there was a hollow close to the ghat. Gunja knew how to swim, but she was not in a sari - her school salwar-kurta grew heavy when soaked. Munna ran down into the water and caught her.

"Did anyone push you?" Sarojini asked.

"No."

"Did anyone tell you it was closed?"

"No."

"The red cord?"

"I did not see it."

Prem Lal shifted in his chair, but said nothing.

Gunja continued, "That is all I remember."

"And whose fault was it?" someone called from the back.

Sarojini said at once, "Not that question yet."

Gunja answered anyway: "I do not know."

Everyone fell silent.

Her father said softly, "The fault is with whoever built the steps."

Gunja looked at him, but said nothing.

The first statement ended.

The second statement was Prem Lal Singh's.

He was the contractor, though he rarely supervised the actual labour himself. Papers, material, wages, payments - those were his domain. On the day of the incident he had come to the ghat at three in the afternoon. According to him, the work was "almost complete," but instructions had been given that the steps were to remain closed for two days to dry.

"Instructions to whom?" the secretary asked.

"I told Munna and Harikishor: put up bamboo and a red cord."

"Was it put up?"

"When I left, I saw it tied."

"What time?"

"Three fifteen."

"From where to where?"

"Between the two bamboo poles."

"Do you have a photograph?"

Prem Lal took out his phone. A photograph timestamped 3:17. In it, the new ghat, two bamboo poles, and a red cord between them were clearly visible.

The room stirred.

Mira Devi looked at Gunja. Gunja remained silent.

Prem Lal said, "There. It was closed."

Sarojini handed the photograph to the secretary. "Enter this in the register of facts: cord present at 3:17."

Prem Lal's voice grew firmer.

"My workers had also put up a warning: 'Wet construction. Do not descend.'"

"Where?" the secretary asked.

"On a cardboard sign."

The photograph was enlarged. A small sign hung from the bamboo, but the words were unreadable.

"Was the sign there at the time of the incident?" Sarojini asked.

"I was not there at five."

"Then you do not know."

Prem Lal did not like the formulation, but accepted it.

"Why did the third stone move?" Sarojini asked.

"Whether it moved is for the technical inspection to determine. The girl may have put her weight down suddenly; the mortar underneath may not have fully set."

"Was that why the ghat was supposed to stay closed?"

"All new construction is kept closed."

"The iron anchor-pin for the third stone?"

Prem Lal's expression changed slightly.

On the plan for the western ghat, each stone had two iron retaining pins at the back to stop it sliding on the slope.

During the inspection after the incident, the right-hand retaining pin behind the third stone was found to be missing.

"Why was there no pin?" the secretary asked.

Prem Lal said, "Munna will answer that. I supplied all the materials."

"Do you consider the work complete?"

"Almost."

"Payment bill?"

"Not the final bill. Partial."

"Then why does the measurement book say 'ghat steps complete'?"

Prem Lal was silent for a moment.

"The measurement was taken the day before. Minor finishing work can remain."

Mira Devi laughed. "Is the anchor-pin a minor decoration?"

Sarojini stopped her.

Prem Lal said, "I am not running away from responsibility. If the pin was not fitted, investigate it. But entry into a closed worksite is also a question."

"Fine," Sarojini said. "You say the cord was there at 3:17. Whether it was there at 5:12, you do not know."

"Yes."

"Could the third stone have been unfinished?"

"Possibly."

"And did you know that at three o'clock?"

"No."

The second statement ended.

The third was Munna Paswan's.

Munna was a thirty-six-year-old mason who had been working at the ghat for the previous twenty days. Half of two weeks' wages were still unpaid. Because of this, Prem Lal had already been saying, "This man will speak against me."

Munna did not sit in the chair. Standing, he said, "I will say what I saw."

He had not set the third stone himself. That day he had been assigned to fill the wall on the eastern slope. Harikishor and Ramesh had laid the third stone. The right-hand retaining pins had run short.

"Run short?" the secretary asked.

"Yes. Four pins short."

"Whom did you tell?"

"Prem Lal Babu's clerk, Rakesh."

"When?"

"The day before."

"In writing?"

"I sent a message by phone."

The message was shown. Munna's basic phone still contained the old text:

"4 retainers pending, bring tomorrow. Stones held."

Rakesh had replied:

"Morning."

Did the pins arrive in the morning?

Munna said, "Two came. We needed four."

"The third stone?"

"No right-hand pin."

"Then why didn't you stop the work?"

Munna was silent.

"Did you say anything?"

"Harikishor said the clerk had told us to lay the stone and hammer in the pin later."

"The mortar?"

"There was mortar underneath."

"Could the pin be hammered in later?"

"By lifting the stone."

"Was it lifted?"

"No."

"You knew this?"

"Yes."

Voices rose in the room.

Prem Lal tried to speak: "This is a lie—"

Sarojini raised her hand.

Munna continued, "I went to tell Babu at three o'clock. He was getting into his vehicle. I said, 'Look at the third stone on the western side.' He said, 'We'll see tomorrow. Tie the cord now.'"

Prem Lal's face reddened.

"Those exact words?"

"That is what I remember."

"Did anyone hear?"

"Rakesh was nearby."

Rakesh was not at the meeting.

"Who tied the cord?"

"Harikishor and I."

"After three?"

"After three."

"At the time of the incident?"

Munna drew a long breath.

"It was not there."

"Why?"

"I did not open it."

"Who did?"

"I did not see."

"Where were you at the time of the incident?"

"Below the ghat, washing tools."

"Washing tools at a closed ghat?"

"I was a worker. I was allowed inside."

"Did you see Gunja coming down?"

"From behind. I called out, 'Slowly.'"

Gunja lifted her head at once.

"You said 'slowly'?"

"Yes."

"Not 'stop?'"

Munna's face fell.

"At that moment I had forgotten that the pin was missing from that stone. Twenty days, twenty stones, fifty sacks, so much work..."

He stopped.

"When the stone moved, I remembered."

The room was silent.

Munna said, "I jumped into the water. The girl came out. That's all."

"Whose fault do you consider it?" someone at the back asked again.

This time Munna answered.

"I have a share in it too."

Prem Lal snapped, "Don't turn yourself into a hero now."

Munna did not look at him.

"I knew the stone was incomplete. I saw the girl descending. I could have said 'stop.' I said 'slowly.' That is my share."

Sarojini dictated, "The decision on fault will come later. This sentence remains in the statement."

The third statement ended.

The fourth statement was Sunita Devi's.

Sunita was the ward member. The ghat scheme was in her ward, and preparations for its inauguration were also her responsibility. The opposition had already been accusing her of rushing the scheme merely to show it as complete for election photographs.

The moment she came into the meeting, Sunita said, "There is a game going on to defame me."

Sarojini said, "Only the incident."

Sunita said that an engineer from the block office was supposed to arrive at four in the afternoon, but had not come. A panchayat assistant took photographs and sent a progress report. For the photographs, plastic sacks, sand, and tools were removed from in front of the ghat.

"The red cord?" the secretary asked.

"It remained."

"Show the photographs."

A photograph timestamped 4:08.

The two bamboo poles were clear.

The cord?

In one photograph a red line could be seen.

In another photograph, it could not.

Sunita said, "It is not visible in the second because the angle changed."

There was no photographic specialist in the room, but the secretary enlarged the image. The cord might be there, or might not.

"How long were you there?" Sarojini asked.

"From four to four twenty."

"Did anyone untie the cord?"

"I did not see anyone."

"The route for the water tanker?"

Sunita's face hardened.

A small tanker vehicle entered from the western side of the pond. Because construction material lay before the ghat, the vehicle had difficulty turning. On the day of the incident, the tanker arrived at 5:20, but there was disagreement over whether an empty tanker had come around five for a trial run.

Sunita said, "No tanker came before 4:20."

Kanhaiya, the tea seller, laughed from the back.

Sarojini looked at him. "Your turn will come."

Sunita continued, "The real issue is that people should not enter a worksite. In the village, people have little habit of following rules."

Gunja asked quietly, "The handpump?"

Sunita looked at her.

"A repair complaint was sent."

"It had been broken for three days."

"It was repaired on the fifth day."

"The incident was on the third."

"I am not the mechanic who repairs the handpump."

Gunja fell silent.

Sunita turned toward the secretary. "Write this: the western ghat was not the regular place for filling water. The northern ghat was open."

Mira Devi said, "The northern ghat is half a kos from my house."

"So?"

"My daughter should carry two buckets half a kos?"

"For safety, yes."

Mira Devi's face flushed, but Gunja caught her mother's hand.

Sarojini asked, "Can you say that the cord was present at the time of the incident?"

Sunita paused.

"No. I was not there after 4:20."

"Who removed the cord?"

"I do not know."

"Had the ghat been officially declared open?"

"No."

"The measurement book says complete?"

"That concerns the engineer and the contractor."

"Was an inauguration date fixed?"

"Next Sunday."

"Then why take photographs five days earlier?"

Sunita answered with mild irritation, "A progress report is not sent without photographs."

The fourth statement ended.

The fifth was Kanhaiya Sah's.

Kanhaiya's tea stall had stood at the bend by the pond for twenty years. The panchayat said the shop projected two cubits too far onto road land; Kanhaiya said it was ancestral space. He had an old dispute with Sunita Devi. Because of this, Prem Lal whispered, "Whatever he says will be revenge."

Sitting down in the chair, Kanhaiya said, "I have no time for revenge. I sell tea."
 Everyone laughed lightly.

Kanhaiya had been at his stall from four o'clock on the day of the incident. From his position he could see the upper portion of the ghat, though not the third step.

"Did you see the red cord?" the secretary asked.

"Around three or half past three."

"At four?"

"I didn't notice."

"At four twenty?"

"Then a small goods vehicle came."

Sunita spoke at once. "Lie."

Sarojini struck the table. "No interruptions."

Kanhaiya said, "It was not a tanker. A small vehicle carrying empty drums. Possibly from the water department."

"Not 'possibly,'" the secretary stopped him. "Say what you saw."

"A small blue vehicle. Two empty drums in the back. The driver got down and asked for the sand blocking the front of the ghat to be moved."

"Who moved it?"

"Two young men - Sunita's assistant Deepak and the contractor's Rakesh."

"The cord?"

Kanhaiya said, "One bamboo pole was removed so the vehicle could turn."

The room erupted.

Sunita half rose from her chair. "This is completely—"

"Sit down," Sarojini said sharply.

"Kanhaiya ji, what time?"

"Around 4:45."

"Did you look at a clock?"

"Five schoolteachers came for tea. One said, 'It is almost five.' It was before that."

"Was the bamboo pole put back?"

"I did not see."

"Why not?"

"A customer came. I went inside to make tea."

"Then you did not see the cord left untied."

"No."

"You saw only one bamboo pole being removed."

"Yes."

"Deepak and Rakesh?"

"Yes."

"Where are they now?"

Deepak was in the village; Rakesh had gone to town.

"Did you see Gunja?"

"Yes. Going with two buckets."

"Did you stop her?"

Kanhaiya was silent.

"No."

"Why?"

"I thought the ghat was in use. People were going there."

"Which people?"

"Two children, a goat-herder, Munna."

"You did not see the cord at that time?"

"Not then."

"So you too assumed it was open."

"Yes."

Kanhaiya looked slightly embarrassed.

"The handpump?"

"Broken for three days. Everyone was coming to my shop asking for water."

"Complaint?"

"I had told the ward member."

Sunita said, "Did you make a phone complaint or submit an application?"

Kanhaiya laughed. "Water does not come after reading an application."

Everyone laughed again, except Sarojini.

The fifth statement ended.

After the meeting, all five statements lay before them.

Sarojini said to the secretary, "Now write only what agrees across the accounts."

Arun wrote:

1. The incident occurred at about 5:12 p.m.

2. Gunja fell into the water after placing her foot on the third step of the western ghat.

3. There is no evidence that anyone pushed her.

4. The third stone did not break; it tilted/slid.

5. During inspection after the incident, the right-hand retaining pin was absent.

6. The mortar beneath the stone had not fully hardened.

7. The red cord is visible in the photograph taken at 3:17 p.m.

8. Whether the cord was present at 5:12 remains disputed; Gunja, Munna, and Kanhaiya did not see it at the time of the incident.

9. The public handpump had been broken for at least two days before the incident.

10. The western ghat had not been formally declared open.

11. The measurement book records the ghat steps as "complete."

12. Final payment had not yet been made.

"These are facts?" Sarojini asked.

Prem Lal said, "Number nine is not directly connected to the incident."

Mira Devi answered immediately, "My daughter went to fetch water!"

Sunita said, "The northern ghat existed."

Gunja was silent.

Sarojini said, "Number nine stays. We will not call it a cause; we will call it a circumstance."

Munna kept looking at number five.

Prem Lal said, "The pin was found missing after the incident. We may assume it was also absent when she fell, but someone could have removed it later."

Munna snapped, "Someone would remove a retaining pin and run away?"

Sarojini stopped them again.

The next day an engineer conducted a technical inspection. The report said:
“The right-hand retaining pin of the third stone was not installed. The left pin is present. Mortar is of insufficient age. The stone can tilt under edge loading. Use should remain prohibited until a proper barrier is in place.”

The report answered one question: the stone was not safe for use.

But it raised the rest:

Why was an unsafe stone recorded as “complete”?

Where was the cord closing the ghat at the time of the incident?

If it had been removed, who removed it?

If it had not remained in place, why did no one tie it again?

If the handpump was broken, why was an alternative water arrangement not made immediately?

Why did Gunja not treat the bamboo poles as a warning?

Why did Munna, knowing the stone was unfinished, say only “slowly” rather than “stop”?

Why was the panchayat preparing photographs and an inauguration while construction remained incomplete?

Fault did not sit inside one name.

The next day Deepak was called. He admitted that at around 4:45 a “small material vehicle” had entered and one bamboo pole had been removed.

“The cord?” the secretary asked.

“It went slack with the bamboo.”

“Did you tie it again?”

Deepak scratched his head.

“I think Rakesh tied it.”

“Did you see him?”

“No.”

“Rakesh?”

Rakesh gave a statement by phone: “I stood the bamboo pole back up. Tying the knot was Deepak’s job.”

Each left half the task with the other.

The secretary wrote: “Removal of bamboo admitted. Whether the cord was securely retied is unproved.”

Prem Lal said, “See? A panchayat assistant removed it.”

Sunita said, “And the contractor’s clerk was there too.”

Gunja’s father said, “I want the cost of treatment, not this argument.”

At that point the direction of the meeting changed.

Gunja had been treated at a private clinic. The total expense was fifteen thousand four hundred rupees. For the family, this was not a small sum.

Prem Lal said, “On humanitarian grounds I will give five thousand.”

Mira Devi flared up. “Not humanitarian grounds. Responsibility.”

Sunita said, “The panchayat can pay something from the emergency fund.”

Gunja’s father said, “Not something. All of it.”

Sarojini asked, “If responsibility is not assigned to a single person?”

“There is one daughter. Why divide responsibility into five parts?”

The room fell silent.

That question lay outside the register of facts.

Madhavi - the schoolteacher who supervised Gunja's studies - was present at the meeting as an observer. She spoke for the first time.

"May I ask one thing?"

Sarojini gave permission.

"We are trying to divide blame. Why should treatment expenses wait until blame is decided? The child's treatment is itself a fact."

Prem Lal said, "Then why should someone who is not at fault pay?"

Madhavi replied, "Because the scheme, the panchayat, the construction - all of them are parts of a public work. Settle the accounting among yourselves later."

Sarojini looked toward the secretary.

"This can be an administrative measure."

In the end it was decided that Gunja's full treatment expense would be paid immediately from the panchayat's emergency fund. Afterwards, according to the inquiry findings, the amount would be adjusted against the contractor's bill, the panchayat maintenance head, or other responsible shares.

Prem Lal submitted a written objection.

Sunita did too: "This shall not be treated as a prior determination against the panchayat."

But Gunja's father received the money.

Gunja returned to school.

After the incident, people began teasing her by calling her "Pond-Gunja." One day, annoyed with a classmate, she said, "The pond isn't mine. It belongs to everyone."

The moment she said it, she stopped herself.

Everyone's.

If the pond belonged to everyone, then whose was the ghat?

The contractor's work?

The panchayat's scheme?

The labourers' effort?

The need of women who came to fetch water?

Children's play?

The fishermen's livelihood?

An achievement to be photographed?

At one place, many rights and responsibilities overlapped.

Fifteen days later the final inquiry meeting was held.

Rakesh was present.

Deepak was present.

The engineer was present.

All five principal statements were read again.

Rakesh admitted that the retaining pins had run short. "I thought we would fit them in the morning."

"And the measurement book says complete?" Sarojini asked.

The engineer said, "The measurement inspection was visual. Every pin was not checked individually."

"Then 'complete'?"

"It should have been recorded as ninety-five per cent progress."

The secretary wrote: "Administrative error."

The engineer immediately said, "Write procedural lapse."

There was light laughter in the room.

Sarojini said, "The word 'error' stays."

It was agreed that the cost of repairing the steps and ensuring safety would be deducted from Prem Lal's bill. The contractor's side accepted responsibility for the missing pin, but did not accept that the incident had occurred "solely because of the pin."

On the question of the cord not being retied, Deepak and Rakesh each described the other's unfinished task. No single person could be conclusively identified.

The ward office had failed to record the handpump complaint on the day it was received. Sunita said the information had been given orally; the secretary's register contained a written complaint on the fifth day.

"Then what about the three days in between?" Mira Devi asked.

No one answered.

Gunja said, "If I had gone to the northern ghat, I would not have fallen."

Everyone looked at her.

She continued, "That is also true. But I went to the western ghat because it is close to home. I did not see the cord. I saw the bamboo. I thought the work was complete."

Prem Lal immediately said, "You should have stopped when you saw bamboo."

Gunja nodded.

"Possibly."

Mira Devi was dissatisfied. "Why are you taking blame?"

Gunja turned toward her mother. "I am not saying blame. I am saying what I saw."

The room fell silent again.

On the final page Sarojini made two headings:

"Established Facts"

and

"Conclusions Regarding Responsibility."

The first part contained twelve points.

The second said:

"The incident has not been established as arising from a single cause. An unsafe/incomplete step, the absence of an effective barrier at the time of the incident, the practical reality of public access to the construction site, the breakdown of the public handpump, and the absence of a clear preventive warning by persons present all appear to have contributed. Individual criminal liability is not determined on the basis of this panchayat inquiry."

Prem Lal objected to the word "incomplete."

The engineer objected to "unsafe."

Sunita objected to "handpump."

Munna objected to "persons present."

Mira Devi objected to "individual liability not determined."

Gunja read the whole thing and said, "This is right."

Everyone looked at her.

“Why?” her father asked.

“Because it does not say anyone is innocent. It only says that writing one name will not finish the whole matter.”

Sarojini smiled faintly.

Not everyone signed the report.

Prem Lal wrote, “Signed with objection.”

Sunita wrote, “Disagreement regarding handpump point.”

Munna simply signed.

Gunja’s father did not sign.

Gunja signed as a witness.

One month later the western ghat was rebuilt.

The third stone was lifted. Two new retaining pins were installed. A metal barrier remained until the mortar set. Above it, a permanent sign was fixed:

“Do not enter a wet or construction-stage ghat.”

The handpump was repaired too.

A small programme was arranged for the reopening. Sunita wanted Gunja to cut the ribbon - as a symbol of “safety awareness.”

Gunja refused.

“Why?” Sunita asked.

“I will not become a photograph for the programme.”

The remark stung Sunita, but she did not insist.

On the day of the programme, returning from school, Gunja saw the ghat from a distance. Red ribbon, microphone, chairs. Prem Lal was there too. Munna was at the edge examining the new stones. Kanhaiya was sending tea from his shop. Her mother was at home.

Gunja did not go until the programme was over.

In the evening, after everyone had left, she arrived alone.

Holding the permanent iron railing, she slowly descended.

First step.

Second.

Third.

She stopped.

The stone no longer moved.

Her reflection broke into fragments in the water. Evening wind moved across the pond.

Munna called from behind, “Are you afraid?”

Gunja turned.

“A little.”

“Stay above.”

Gunja said, “No. This time I’ll go down slowly.”

Munna paused.

“That day too I said ‘slowly.’”

“Yes.”

“I should have said ‘stop.’”

Gunja looked at him.

“And I should have asked when I saw the bamboo.”

Munna said at once, "No, that—"
Gunja raised her hand. "I am not dividing blame."
Munna fell silent.
The two sat beside the water.
After a while Kanhaiya came with tea.
"Now the report says I saw the bamboo being removed. People say I am Sunita's opponent, so I lied."
Munna laughed. "You are her opponent."
Kanhaiya laughed too. "So what I saw becomes false?"
Gunja said, "No."
"And what I did not see?"
Kanhaiya set the cup down. "That is not written in the report."
Munna said quietly, "That is the hardest part."
Gunja asked, "What?"
"Not saying what you did not see."
All three kept looking at the pond.
The last light of the sun spread across the water. A cut piece of the red ribbon still lay on the new stone steps. When the wind rose, the strip moved once toward the stairs, then caught against the railing.
Gunja picked it up and put it into the rubbish bin.
That evening there were still five versions of the incident at the pond.
But some things had become the same in all five:
The stone had moved.
The cord had not been effective at the time of the incident.
Gunja had fallen.
Munna had gone into the water.
And in a public place, many people's small decisions had met at one moment.
The rest - whose error was heavy and whose was light - was like five reflections cast upon the surface of water.
The pond was one.
The viewpoints were five.

Night at the Court

The old royal palace of Ratanpur had become a museum. At the outer gate stood a ticket counter; inside, the great hall of the court had a high ceiling, broken jharokhas, and glass cases along the gallery. In the last room lay a blackened beam, beneath which a brass plaque read:

“Night at the Court, Samvat 1973. Fire in a conspiracy by external rioters. The royal family remained safe. The archive and the northern diwan-khana were partly destroyed.”

Archana Jha was the museum’s new archival officer. During her first week in the post, what irritated her most were the words “external rioters.”

“External to whom?” she asked the senior attendant, Ramvilas.

Ramvilas shrugged. “The plaque is very old.”

“Who were the rioters?”

“It is written in the history.”

“Which history?”

Ramvilas pointed toward the wall. Behind glass stood a thick volume: Ratanpur State Chronicle, Volume 4. Author: court historian Pandit Madhavaraj Mishra. Published in Samvat 1984, eleven years after the fire.

Archana read its chapter, “Night at the Court.”

The story was orderly.

Unbroken composure in the king.

Religious steadfastness in the priest.

Valour in the soldiers.

A conspiracy by a “greedy grain merchant.”

Betrayal by two “wicked guards.”

The women’s quarters kept safe.

Almost no names of court servants.

And in the end, the fire brought under control through royal grace.

The history was so clean that Archana distrusted it.

Fire rarely produces a clean story.

The palace was due for renovation. The museum department wanted a new gallery devoted to “Night at the Court.” Archana’s responsibility was to examine the old plaque, gather the sources, and prepare a new account.

The director said, “We do not want too much controversy. Tourists want a clear story.”

Archana asked, “What do you mean by clear?”

“Something they can understand.”

“What if the sources are confused?”

“Then put that in small print.”

Archana did not smile.

She looked at the source list at the end of the State Chronicle. There were five entries:

1. Court security register.
2. Statement of the royal priest.
3. Report of the diwan's office.
4. "Statements of trustworthy citizens."
5. Royal proclamation.

Who were the "trustworthy citizens"? No names.

Archana went to the archive room in search of the first source.

The security register had burned in the fire. In the surviving portion, entries remained only up to the morning of the day of the incident. The evening pages were blackened, their edges eaten away. One name appeared repeatedly: Devnarayan Rai, soldier at the northern gate.

The State Chronicle described Devnarayan as "a treacherous guard who, out of greed, colluded with the merchant Madan Sah and opened the northern service gate at an improper hour."

Archana checked the staff list. Devnarayan had been dismissed three days after the fire.

Nothing more.

Then, in an old bundle, she found a petition headed "Prayer for Justice." The paper was crumbling, the ink faded. Sender: Devnarayan Rai. Dated seven months after the fire.

Wearing gloves, Archana began to read.

"I did not open the gate out of greed. The water reservoir inside the palace had become empty by evening..."

Archana stopped.

The State Chronicle did not mention the reservoir even once.

The petition continued:

"In the third quarter of the evening, Harihar Babu of the diwan's office ordered that the northern service gate be opened so that water-pots could be brought from the well outside. I did not open the gate without an order. At the time the gate was opened, smoke was already rising from the archive room."

The words caught Archana's eye.

"Smoke was already rising."

Devnarayan wrote that he had not opened the gate to bring outsiders in; he had opened it for water-carriers bringing water. A crowd gathered afterwards, when people saw the smoke and ran toward the palace. The merchant Madan Sah reached the main gate after the fire had begun.

One witness was named in the petition: "Kunwaria Dasi."

Archana turned back to the chapter in the State Chronicle.

Kunwaria? No.

Among the women servants: only "the maids."

She set the petition aside.

The next day the archive index was searched for "Kunwaria." No salary register contained the name. Most lists of attendants in the women's quarters had been destroyed in the fire. But a folklore-collection register from the 1950s contained an entry:

"Old palace songs from Dhanesari Devi, daughter of Kunwaria Naain."

Collector: Surendra Thakur, student at Vidyapati College, 1956.

The register contained seven pages of songs.

The first two were wedding songs.

The third, a birth song.

The fourth was titled:

“The Night of the Fire.”

Archana began reading.

The song did not feel like a narrative so much as memory:

*“After the northern threshold opened,
the smoke did not rise;
the smoke had darkened the evening first,
only then did the threshold open...”*

Then:

*“The queen’s chest was carried out first,
the account books were not;
the golden plates went outside,
the pages of debt remained within...”*

Archana stopped.

Pages of debt?

The song continued:

*“Kunwaria cried, bring water,
the munshi cried, leave the papers,
the maid saw a red glow
through the slit of the account room...”*

What was the “red glow” from?

The song did not say.

In the final section:

*“Did the lamp fall from my hand?
Sometimes yes, sometimes no;
the smoke had burned my eyes before,
the lamp then counted the earth.”*

Archana lingered over those lines.

Kunwaria’s descendants might still be in the village.

The folklore register gave an address: “Bhatpura, Naai Tola.”

Archana went to Bhatpura the following week.

Dhanesari Devi was no longer alive. Her granddaughter, Sarita Kumari, about sixty-five, was drying thread on the veranda.

Archana showed her a photocopy of the register.

Sarita put on her spectacles, read it, and laughed.

“My mother still used to sing this song.”

“Was Kunwaria your great-grandmother?”

“Yes. She worked as a naain in the palace – childbirth, hair, service inside the women’s quarters.”

“And the night of the fire?”

Sarita nodded. “There was a story in the family.”

“What story?”

Sarita did not begin at once.

"Stories keep changing. Shall I tell you what my mother used to say?"

"That is exactly what I want. If you do not remember the exact words, say so."

Sarita looked pleased.

"Great-grandmother used to say that the smell of smoke came first in the women's quarters. In the men's court there was no dancing or music that night; an accounts meeting was in progress. The people of the court were discussing grain advances, land revenue, and stores."

"The State Chronicle says the king was in the prayer chamber."

Sarita laughed. "Our family story does not say where the king was. How could Great-grandmother see every place outside the women's quarters?"

Archana wrote the sentence down.

"What did she see?"

"Smoke. Running about. The queen's chest, jewellery, children. The maids were first ordered to carry out the chests. Water came later."

"The lamp?"

Sarita thought.

"My mother said Great-grandmother knocked over a lamp by mistake. But the fire had already begun."

"Where did it fall?"

"Near the doorway of the women's quarters, onto a curtain."

"Then did the fire spread?"

"Possibly. Great-grandmother admitted her own mistake. But she used to say - it may be right to say 'I made the fire grow,' not 'I started the fire.'"

Archana stopped her pen.

"Those exact words?"

"No. The meaning."

"I am writing: remembered meaning."

Sarita nodded.

"The pages of debt?"

Sarita's face changed.

"That was spoken of in whispers in the family."

"What?"

"Before the fire, a munshi had taken several account books from a wooden chest and placed them on the floor. Great-grandmother saw a red light through the slit - smoke was already coming from there."

"Was the munshi setting fire to them?"

Sarita raised her hand at once.

"No. I am not saying that. Great-grandmother did not say it either. Whether it was a lamp or an ember, whether paper was burning or it was merely light - she did not go inside."

Archana wrote:

"Limit of vision: slit/corridor."

The meaning of that limit suddenly became clear to her: no one sees everything.

Back at the palace, Archana searched for an old plan of the building. The account room was not directly visible from the women's quarters. Between them ran a narrow

service corridor with a latticed slit. Kunwaria could have seen only light or smoke, not the action inside.

That limit mattered.

The third source was the royal priest.

The State Chronicle said:

“At the first moment of the fire, the royal priest Haridev Shastri was present with the royal family in the shrine; through his prayer and composure fear was calmed.”

Haridev Shastri's private papers were not in the museum. They would have to be sought at the temple.

The old Shiva temple east of the palace was still functioning. Its chief priest, Naresh Shastri, was a fourth-generation descendant of Haridev.

Archana asked, “Old worship registers?”

At first Naresh hesitated. “The temple register is not an object of the royal museum.”

“I will not take it. I only want to see it.”

After considerable discussion, a wooden chest was opened.

Inside were many registers wrapped in cloth. The one from the year of the fire had survived.

In Haridev's hand, under the date, was written:

“Second day after the new moon. Evening arati as usual. Royal family not present.”

Archana held her breath.

State Chronicle: the king in the shrine.

Temple register: royal family not present.

The next line read:

“After arati, smoke observed in the northern building. Reached there with disciple Shivnath. Fire had already taken the account house and wooden eaves. A separate lamp-fire seen toward the women's quarters.”

A separate lamp-fire.

So Kunwaria's fallen lamp may indeed have created a second point of fire, while the principal smoke had already begun in the account house.

Then:

“Maharaj in the southern courtyard, in dispute with the diwan and the grain merchant.”

Archana read those words twice.

The grain merchant.

Madan Sah?

The State Chronicle said Madan Sah was an external conspirator, caught after the fire began.

The priest's register said he was already present in the southern courtyard, disputing with the king.

Archana looked at Naresh Shastri.

“Has this register ever been published?”

“No.”

“Why not?”

“It is a household worship register. Who would be interested?”

"When the State Chronicle was being written?"

Naresh shook his head. "I do not know whether anyone asked."

"Then the source behind the source?"

Archana smiled too. "That is why I am here."

The fourth source was the merchant Madan Sah.

In the State Chronicle, Madan Sah was the principal villain: "one who withheld grain in a famine year to raise prices, evaded royal tax, and aided outside agitators."

After the fire, his shop was sealed, part of his property confiscated, and he was imprisoned for three months.

After that his name disappeared from the history.

There was no longer a "Madan Sah & Sons" in town, but the Sah family still had descendants in the old grain market. Searching through them, Archana reached Chiranjeevlal Sah.

Chiranjeevlal said, "Madan Sah was my great-grandfather's uncle."

"Any papers survive?"

"There are very old ledgers in the accounts room. But will you again write some disgrace about the royal court?"

"I will read the papers."

"All scholars say that."

"Then the papers themselves can be seen."

At that answer Chiranjeevlal laughed.

Three days later the upper room of the old warehouse was opened. Dust, sacks gnawed by rats, an iron safe. Inside the safe were trade ledgers - oil, grain, ghee, spices, debts of the royal court.

The palace appeared repeatedly in the ledger for the year of the fire.

"Mustard oil for the royal store - 12 jars. Payment pending."

"Sesame oil for palace lamps - 6 jars."

"Paddy for famine relief - 32 maunds, on royal account credit."

Madan Sah was not merely an opponent of the court. He was also a supplier.

The entry for the day of the incident read:

"Evening summons to court. Credit due: 487 rupees 6 annas. Request payment."

Below it, in a trembling hand written that night:

"Not the warehouse, the palace burned. Two jars of my oil were already inside the palace. People will say: my oil, my fire."

Archana's hand stopped.

On the next page was a draft letter:

"Honoured Diwanji, the charge of conspiracy against me is false. I came to the southern courtyard on an evening summons. I demanded the outstanding payment before Maharaj. Munshi Harihar said payment would follow scrutiny of the famine accounts. There was a dispute. Meanwhile smoke was seen to the north. The gate was closed. I wished to leave, but the guards stopped me."

Madan had been in the palace before the fire, not after it.

The letter continued:

"My oil jars had reached the service courtyard three days earlier. Whether one jar broke when the fire spread, I did not see. If the oil fed the fire, responsibility also lies with the keeping of the stores."

Chiranjeevral said, "See? He was innocent."

Archana replied at once, "This is the draft of his own letter."

"So?"

"His own case."

"The State Chronicle is also someone's case."

"Correct."

Chiranjeevral was not pleased, but fell silent.

Archana asked, "What is the family's oral account of Madan Sah?"

"They used to say the royal court did not want to pay the money, so they put the blame for the fire on him."

"Did Madan himself say that?"

"It is the family story."

"Does anyone say that an oil jar broke?"

Chiranjeevral thought.

"My grandmother used to say one jar burned. But she also said, 'A lamp cannot burn without oil, and oil can make a fire spread; that does not make the oil-seller a criminal.'"

Archana noted: "Family moral statement; not direct evidence."

Four sources now lay before her.

Devnarayan - the gate.

Kunwaria - the women's quarters/service corridor.

Haridev - the temple and southern courtyard.

Madan - trade, debt, royal dispute.

Four different places.

Four different interests.

Four different languages.

With four coloured pencils, Archana marked four fields of view on the palace plan.

From the northern gate Devnarayan could see smoke from the account room, but not the southern courtyard.

Through the slit Kunwaria could see light, but not the inside of the account room.

By the time Haridev reached the northern building, the fire had spread; he did not see its beginning.

Madan saw the dispute in the southern courtyard, not the northern account room.

No one saw the whole night.

Only the State Chronicle claimed the whole night.

That interested Archana most of all.

The story with the least direct access was the most complete.

Why?

Where had Madhavaraj, author of the State Chronicle, been on the night of the fire?

The staff register was searched. In the year of the incident, Madhavaraj was a junior Sanskrit teacher at the court, aged twenty-three. Residence: five kos from the palace.

There was no evidence that he had been present that night.
Then how did he write a “complete” account eleven years later?

Archana read the preface.

“Prepared, by order of His Majesty, from available royal records, trustworthy elders, the office of the diwan, and the statement of the religious authority.”

Religious authority - presumably Haridev.

But Haridev’s register contradicted the State Chronicle.

“Trustworthy elders” - unnamed.

The diwan’s office - many records destroyed in the fire.

Royal proclamation - a document of power issued after the event.

Archana began to suspect that the State Chronicle was less an attempt to discover the cause of the fire than to stabilise an official memory.

But suspicion was not enough.

She searched for Madhavraj’s private papers. His family had moved to Patna. The university archive held two collections of his letters. One letter, written to his friend Jagannath Jha while the State Chronicle was being prepared, said:

“The chapter on the Night at the Court is difficult. Maharaj wishes the outside conspiracy to be made clear. The old men of the diwan’s office say the merchant was responsible. The priest is silent. The soldier has been dismissed. It has been considered improper to write the account from the women’s quarters.”

Archana stopped breathing for a moment.

“It has been considered improper to write the account from the women’s quarters.”

The letter continued:

“The incident appears greatly entangled; uncertainty in history gives the reader distrust. One purpose of the State Chronicle is also to restore confidence.”

Archana read the sentence three times.

The purpose of history: to restore confidence.

And facts?

The next part of the letter said:

“Madan Sah does not admit guilt, though his oil may have fed the fire. Devnarayan claims an order; there is no written order. Munshi Harihar was injured in the fire, and afterwards his memory was weak. In such a condition a clear sequence will have to be made.”

“A clear sequence will have to be made.”

Archana lowered the page.

Did this letter prove the State Chronicle false?

Partly.

It proved that the author knew the complexity and made a “clear sequence” in accordance with royal preference.

But who started the fire remained unknown.

Archana gave the director an interim report.

He read it and held his head.

“You went to change one museum plaque and have opened up the entire dynasty?”

“The plaque is not correct.”

“There is not enough evidence for ‘conspiracy by external rioters.’”

"Correct."

"Madan Sah was innocent?"

"That is not established either."

"The soldier?"

"He claims an order. No written order."

"The maid?"

"She saw smoke before the fire near her; her lamp may have caused a second spread."

"The priest?"

"The register says the king was not in the prayer chamber."

The director leaned back in his chair.

"Then what do we put on the plaque?"

Archana said, "What is certain."

"Tourists will not read twelve paragraphs."

"Four lines."

"Read them."

Archana read her draft:

"On one evening in Samvat 1973, fire broke out in the northern part of the Ratanpur palace. Available sources do not agree on how the fire began. Contemporary and later sources describe the roles of a soldier, a palace attendant, a priest, and a merchant in different ways. A later royal history concluded that the fire resulted from an external conspiracy, a conclusion not fully supported by the surviving evidence."

The director said, "This sounds less like a museum plaque than a court judgment."

"Then give me your draft."

"I would write only: 'The cause of the fire is disputed.'"

"And the external rioters?"

"Remove that."

Archana was partly satisfied and partly not.

"Where will the four voices go?"

"Into the gallery."

So the plan for the new gallery was made: "Night at the Court: Four Places, Four Voices."

First section - Northern Gate.

Devnarayan's petition.

Two maps.

The outside well.

A small heading: "The gate was opened - but on whose order?"

Second - Women's Quarters.

Kunwaria's song.

The service corridor.

A list of what the women saved: jewellery, clothing, children's boxes.

Heading: "Smoke first, or the lamp?"

Third - Temple.

Haridev's register.

The entry: "Royal family not present."

Heading: "Difference between royal memory and the worship register."

Fourth - Trade.

Madan Sah's ledger.

Debts owed by the court.

Oil jars.

Heading: "Supplier, creditor, or conspirator?"

In the centre: the palace map.

Four fields of view.

No single line saw the entire building.

The designer asked, "Do we need one box with the main answer: 'What actually happened?'"

Archana said, "No."

"People will look for it."

"Then leave an empty space."

"Empty?"

"One question: 'Did anyone see the whole night?'"

The designer laughed. "You are turning the museum into an examination."

"History is not an examination. It is a question."

The designer scratched his head, but agreed.

While the gallery was being built, a new problem arose.

During repairs, the floor of the northern account room was lifted. Beneath it lay a layer of ash and burned wood. Archaeology department staff examined samples. The greatest fire intensity appeared to have been near a wooden cupboard in the north-west corner.

An old metal lock, two coins, and metal clips from a burned account book were also found there.

Some newspapers immediately ran the headline:

"Century-old mystery solved - fire began in the archive."

Archana held her head the moment she saw it.

The fire may have begun in the room.

Who started it was still unknown.

The archaeological report itself was cautious:

"Available burn marks indicate an early zone of high heat in the north-west area; however, later alterations to the building make it difficult to determine a definite point of origin."

The newspaper turned "high heat" into "birthplace of the fire."

The director said, "At least one thing is clear now."

Archana replied, "A little."

How did the new evidence fit the four accounts?

Devnarayan - smoke already to the north. Compatible.

Kunwaria - red glow from the account room through the slit. Compatible.

Haridev - by the time he arrived, the account house was burning. Compatible.

Madan - he was in the southern courtyard. No contradiction.

But the cause?

Archana began studying the surviving list of the account books destroyed in the fire. Among them was the "Famine Credit Register." She remembered the "pages of debt" in Kunwaria's song.

Had someone deliberately burned the famine accounts?

It was a very attractive story.

So attractive that Archana became afraid of it.

An attractive story can also be an historian's enemy.

She searched for Munshi Harihar - an accounts officer in the diwan's office, injured in the fire. He remained in service for two years after the incident and then retired. Did his descendants have papers?

Harihar's great-grandson, Jayakant Jha, had a small diary, but the page for the night of the fire had been torn out.

Why was it torn?

Jyakant said, "It was already like that."

"Did anyone in the family say anything?"

"Grandfather used to say Hariharji's hand was burned in the fire and writing became difficult."

The diary entry for the day before the fire said:

"Ordered to resubmit famine-credit accounts. Many names disputed. Madan Sah demanding payment. Diwan displeased."

The next surviving page was from five days after the fire:

"Hand painful. Everyone questions me. It would not be proper to say everything I remember."

Archana shivered.

"It would not be proper to say everything I remember."

A confession of guilt?

Fear of authority?

Private shame?

Simply an exhausted man?

The meaning did not open.

Jyakant asked, "Did you understand it?"

"No."

"People used to say Munshi Harihar was dishonest."

"The paper does not say that."

"Then?"

"The paper says the accounts were disputed, he was injured, and he wrote that some things should not be said."

Jyakant was disappointed.

People often want a verdict from paper.

Paper often gives only a sentence.

Archana considered adding Harihar's diary to the new gallery, then stopped. The plan of four voices would become five. Yet Harihar stood inside the central question.

The director said, "Then change the title - 'Five Voices.'"

"No," Archana said. "Harihar's voice is incomplete. He belongs in the torn place."

"Then?"

"In the centre: 'The Missing Voice.'"

The director laughed wearily. "You like empty spaces very much."

Archana replied, "History gives them itself."

A week before the gallery opened, a letter came from the present royal family.

"The new presentation should not become one-sided against the dignity of the royal family. Due respect should remain for the accepted history of the court."

The director was anxious.

"We are not removing the accepted history," Archana said.

"But you want to call it a 'royal construction'?"

"The letter is evidence that the author created a clear sequence."

"Soften the phrase."

"Later royal interpretation?"

"Good."

Chiranjeev Sah also sent a letter:

"The plaque calling Madan Sah a conspirator should be removed entirely."

Sarita Kumari telephoned:

"Write Kunwaria's name correctly. Do not write only 'maid.'"

Naresh Shastri said:

"The conditions of permission must be written beside the facsimile of the temple register."

Devnarayan's descendants were difficult to locate. At last a family was found in Samastipur. His grandchildren had no documents of his, but the family story said:

"Grandfather used to say the blame for opening the gate remained on his head all his life."

An elderly granddaughter, Savitri Devi, said:

"When I was a child, he used to say, 'I opened the gate, not the fire.'"

Archana asked, "Those exact words?"

Savitri laughed. "Who remembers 'exactly' after seventy years?"

"Then I will write it as remembered meaning."

"Only let his name remain."

Four families, four different demands.

The royal family - reputation.

The Sah family - innocence.

The naain family - a name.

The soldier's family - correction of dishonour.

The temple - context.

The museum - visitors.

The department - peace.

While the historical gallery was being made, the interests of the present were also climbing onto its walls.

On the morning of the opening, Archana read all the plaques one final time.

The principal plaque:

"During the 'Night at the Court' in Samvat 1973, fire broke out in the northern part of the royal palace. The initial cause of the fire is uncertain. A later royal history established a story of external conspiracy; other surviving sources do not fully support that conclusion."

At the last moment the director again reconsidered the word "established."

Archana did not change it.

In the Northern Gate section, Devnarayan's petition.

Beneath it:

"Interest: preserving employment and reputation. Access: northern gate. Limit: not inside the account room."

Women's Quarters:

"Source: later oral song/family memory concerning Kunwaria. Access: women's quarters and service corridor. Limit: view through a slit; action not fully visible."

Temple:

"Source: Haridev Shastri's contemporary worship register. Access: northern building after the fire had spread, and southern courtyard. Limit: beginning of the fire not directly observed."

Trade:

"Source: Madan Sah's trade ledger and draft letter. Access: southern courtyard. Interest: defending himself against accusation and recovering outstanding payment."

At the centre, the four-coloured map.

And one empty frame:

"Did anyone see the whole night?"

Below, in small letters:

"No."

The opening drew a larger crowd than expected.

Schoolchildren liked the map.

A journalist wrote: "Conspiracy narrative questioned."

The representative of the royal family kept a stiff face.

Chiranjeevlal stood for five minutes before Madan Sah's ledger.

Sarita smiled and touched Kunwaria's name.

In the afternoon an elderly man came to Archana.

"I used to teach history," he said. "One thing is not right."

Archana became alert.

"What?"

"You have written the interests of all four sources. What about the interest of the State Chronicle?"

Archana looked toward the central glass case.

On the label for the State Chronicle there was only:

"Later royal history; compiled eleven years after the fire."

No line on interest.

The old man smiled. "Does power have no interest?"

Archana did not answer immediately.

"It does."

"Then?"

That evening, after the exhibition closed, Archana wrote a new small label:

"State Chronicle

Access: later royal records and selected statements.

Purpose: preparation of the state's official history; according to the author's private letter, also to 'restore confidence.'

Limit: author not an eyewitness; full process of source selection unknown."

When the director saw it the next morning, he asked, "Why was this not there before?"

Archana told the truth. "It did not occur to me either."

"The historian's interest?"

"A clear story."

The director laughed.

Two weeks after the gallery opened, a group of university students came. One student asked:

"Then who set the fire?"

Archana said, "At present, I do not know."

"The munshi?"

"No evidence."

"The maid?"

"Her lamp may have made the fire spread, but the principal smoke came earlier."

"The merchant's oil?"

"It may have fed the fire. There is no proof that it started it."

"The soldier opened the gate?"

"Yes, probably under orders. But opening the gate and starting the fire are different events."

"The king?"

Archana looked at the student's face.

"There is no evidence that he set the fire."

The student looked disappointed.

"Then where is the fun?"

His friend laughed.

Archana smiled faintly too.

"Did you come looking for fun?"

"If history has a mystery, there should be a solution."

Archana pointed to the four-coloured map.

"Look at the limits instead of the solution. What the soldier saw, the maid did not. What the maid heard, the merchant did not. By the time the priest arrived, much had already happened. And the State Chronicle made one story from above all of them."

"Then the truth?"

"Some facts agree. Some do not."

"That is very unsatisfying."

"Yes."

The students moved on.

Archana liked that answer. Dissatisfaction, too, could be part of historical experience.

A month later the museum held a public discussion: "Night at the Court: Whose Story?"

Five people sat on the stage:

Archana.

Abhay Pratap, representative of the royal family.

Sarita Kumari.

Chiranjeevlal Sah.

Professor Shailendra from the history department.

The soldier's family could not attend.

Abhay Pratap said, "It is improper to call the State Chronicle false. At that time the state was under political pressure. The administration had to maintain order."

Archana said, "The word 'false' does not appear in the gallery."

"But that is what visitors will understand."

Sarita interrupted, "My great-grandmother's name is on the wall for the first time after all these years. Earlier the State Chronicle had only 'the maids.' I have come for that much."

Chiranjeevlal said, "I want the accusation against Madan Sah removed."

Professor Shailendra asked, "Why? The ledger does not prove his innocence."

Chiranjeevlal answered at once:

"Nor does it prove his guilt."

"Correct."

Abhay Pratap said, "Why put the king in the dock?"

Sarita laughed. "There are more lines about my great-grandmother's limits on the wall than about the king."

The hall laughed.

Archana noticed that today every family wanted justice for its ancestor. But the third account was not automatically true either. A descendant was not automatically authoritative.

During the discussion, a woman at the back stood up. Her name was Zarina Khatoon. She said:

"My grandmother used to say that on the night of the fire poor people outside the palace ran in carrying water-pots, but no one is named in the later history. What source are those people?"

Archana was startled.

"Do you have a family account?"

"Yes. My grandmother's maternal grandfather was a kahar."

Devnarayan's petition had said, "water-pots to be brought from the outside well."

The water-carriers - absent from the history.

After the discussion, Archana spoke separately with Zarina.

Zarina said:

"The family story was that when the gate opened, four kahars, two water-carriers, and several people from the market went inside with water-pots. When the fire grew larger, the royal men told them to get out. Later they heard, 'outsiders entered and set the fire.' Grandfather remained angry about that all his life."

"Names?"

"Two are remembered - Rahmat and Bhola. The rest are not."

"Whose direct account was it?"

"Grandmother heard it from her maternal grandfather. I heard it from Grandmother."

"Two generations later."

"Yes."

Archana wrote it down.

"Will you add it to the gallery?" Zarina asked.

Archana said, "First I will look for more evidence."

Zarina looked a little disappointed, but nodded.

Five days later, in an old municipal register, Archana found an entry for payment on the day after the fire:

"Labourers carrying water for extinguishing fire - 8 persons - total wages 2 rupees."

No names.

The number: eight.

Devnarayan's petition - water-carriers.

Zarina's family story - six or seven outside water-bearers.

Municipality - eight labourers.

Archana added a small new plaque to the gallery:

"Outsiders: 'Rioters' or Fire-Fighters?"

A contemporary payment register records eight labourers carrying water. Devnarayan's petition also mentions bringing water from the outside well. Most names are absent."

The plaque reversed the central royal narrative: the word "outsider" itself became uncertain.

But Archana did not write that all outsiders had been innocent. Whether anyone in the crowd stole something, whether anyone worsened the fire - there was no source.

It was easy to make an inverted story too:

First, "wicked outsiders."

Then, "outsider rescuers."

Both were simple.

Archana had become wary of simplicity.

On the day the renovation was completed, the old blackened beam was placed back at the centre.

The conservator said, "This came from the northern account room."

"Certain?"

"That is what the old inventory says."

"When was the inventory made?"

"In the 1960s."

Archana immediately had the label changed to: "Probably from the northern account room."

Ramvilas laughed. "You are going to put 'probably' on everything."

Archana said, "Where necessary."

"People will say the museum knows nothing."

"What we do not know, we should not claim."

Wiping the beam, Ramvilas said, "I found the old plaque easier."

"So did I."

"Then why change it?"

Archana looked at the black line in the beam.

"Because it was easy."

In the evening the museum emptied.

Archana walked alone through the gallery.

Northern Gate.

Women's Quarters.

Temple.

Trade.

Central map.

Missing Harihar.

Outside water-carriers.

State Chronicle.

One night, so many doorways.

She watched the four coloured lights fall over the map. Each colour illuminated only its own region. Some parts lay beneath two colours. Some beneath three. And the small portion inside the account room - where the fire may have begun - lay within no one's direct field of vision.

That part of the map had been left grey.

Someone had suggested placing a red dot there: "probable origin."

Archana had refused.

Grey was more accurate.

She went to the open page of the State Chronicle. In beautiful lettering it said:

"In the first watch of the night, conspiratorial outsiders broke through the northern gate and entered..."

Archana read the new plaque beneath it:

"A contemporary payment register records outside labourers carrying water; sources dispute why the northern gate was opened."

Two histories inside the same word: "outsider."

Then Kunwaria's song:

"The smoke had darkened the evening first..."

Then Haridev:

"Royal family not present."

Then Madan:

"People will say: my oil, my fire."

Then Devnarayan:

"I opened the gate, not the fire."

Archana realised that all four were also defending themselves.

The soldier: his job.

The maid: her mistake.

The priest: his silence.

The merchant: the accusation.

None was an impartial god.

But the State Chronicle was not an impartial sky either.

It was only the fifth side - the most powerful one.

The bell sounded outside. Time to close the museum.

Ramvilas called from a distance, "Archana ji, shall I switch everything off?"

Archana was about to say yes, then looked toward the central map.

Even when all four colours went dark, the grey part would remain the same.

"One minute."

She took out her notebook and wrote a sentence for the final gallery text:
“The truth of the Night at the Court is not a fifth complete story made by adding together four accounts; it lies among the limits within which each source possessed a different right, opportunity, and reason to see.”
She read it.
Too heavy.
She crossed it out.
Then she wrote something shorter:
“Everyone could see one fire; no one could see the whole fire.”
She smiled.
Whether it would go on the plaque or not would be decided tomorrow.
For today it would remain on paper.
Ramvilas called again.
Archana switched off the lights.
In the darkness, the four colours of the map disappeared.
The grey place disappeared too.
But the Night at the Court did not become one story again.

The Stolen Idol

The main doors of the Bhuvaneshwari shrine at Amarahi opened at 4:55 every morning. For thirty-five years, Ishwarnath Jha had begun the day in almost the same order: first the outer bell, then the tulsi leaves, then the small lamp inside, and finally the brass key in the grille of the sanctum.

That morning, the instant the grille opened, his hand stopped in the air.

The red cloth lay upon the throne.

Two dried leaves from a garland remained.

The small silver crown had overturned.

The idol was gone.

At first Ishwarnath thought Baldev must have removed it during some special cleaning in the night. Then he immediately realised: Baldev never touched the idol. Tradition, fear, and employment - all three prevented him.

He shouted "Baldev!" so loudly that the guard sleeping on the outer veranda started awake.

Baldev Paswan came running.

"What happened?"

Ishwarnath merely pointed toward the empty throne.

Baldev's face turned yellow.

"The idol..."

"Where is it?"

"I... I was here in the night..."

He could not finish the sentence.

Within five minutes the temple bell was ringing in alarm. Within seven, Malti Devi, who sold flowers in front of the shrine, arrived. Within ten, two local youths. Within twenty, the temple committee president, Devkinandan Chaudhary.

By sunrise the news had spread through the whole of Amarahi:

"Bhuvaneshwari Mata has been stolen."

People kept using exactly those words:

"Mata has been stolen."

Each time, Ishwarnath shivered inwardly.

An image had been stolen.

The Mother?

That did not seem an appropriate question to bring to one's lips at such a moment.

The police arrived. The lock on the main door had not been broken. The latch on the rear service door was intact from outside. A small window in the northern wall was closed with iron bars.

"An inside man," Sub-Inspector Ajit Yadav said at first glance.

"Not me," Baldev said immediately.

No one had yet accused him.

The sentence sounded suspicious precisely because it had come on its own.

Ajit Yadav asked, "Who was on night duty?"

"I was."

"Alone?"

"Yes."

"From when?"

"Eight at night until five in the morning."

"Did anyone come in between?"

"No."

"Did you go anywhere?"

Baldev's throat went dry.

"No."

Ishwarnath looked at him.

Baldev turned his eyes away.

The police examined the sanctum, veranda, locks, doors, and keys. Ishwarnath had the main key. A duplicate key was kept in a safe at the committee president's house. There was no sign of force on the lock.

"Is the idol heavy?" Ajit Yadav asked.

Ishwarnath said, "About nine kilos."

"Ashtadhatu?"

The committee president immediately said, "Very old ashtadhatu. At least three hundred years."

Ishwarnath looked at the president.

Three hundred?

The plaque said "ancient."

No one had ever established three hundred.

Ajit Yadav kept writing.

"Value?"

The president said, "Priceless."

Police paperwork does not accept "priceless."

"An estimate?"

The president said, "It could be worth crores."

Ishwarnath looked at him again.

Ajit Yadav raised an eyebrow.

"Registered with the archaeology department?"

The president fell silent.

Ishwarnath said softly, "No."

"Photographs?"

There were many. From devotees, festivals, weddings, New Year.

"Any old close-up photographs?"

Ishwarnath showed one on his phone. A small raised patch was visible near the idol's left foot.

Ajit Yadav enlarged the image.

"Is this broken?"

"A repair joint."

The president immediately said, "An old repair."

Ishwarnath said nothing.

The sub-inspector looked at him.

"When?"

Ishwarnath opened his mouth, but the president spoke first.

"Long ago. Before my time."

Ishwarnath remained silent.

That silence became the first knot in the story.

Baldev Paswan worked for the temple committee on contract. His pay was eight thousand five hundred rupees. Night duty. No second man to relieve him. Six months earlier his wife had said:

"For this salary you stay awake all night, sleep at home all day - when will the children know you?"

Baldev had said:

"It is a job. If I leave it, where will I find another?"

On the night the idol was stolen, he had been on the veranda from nine. The last devotee left at ten. At half past ten, Ishwarnath closed the doors. Baldev fastened the outer gate.

Everything was fine until eleven.

After midnight the mosquitoes increased. At one he made tea. At half past two his stomach began to hurt. There was no toilet in the temple compound; for three years the committee had been saying one "would be built." The night guard usually went beyond the bamboo grove behind the temple into the empty field.

That night Baldev left at 2:28.

He remembered looking at his watch because he had left his phone charging on the veranda.

He returned at 2:40.

Twelve minutes.

He had not told the police about those twelve minutes.

Why?

Because the idol had been stolen.

Because the lock was not broken.

Because his job was contractual.

Because the committee president had long been saying, "The guard sleeps at night."

The twelve minutes were true.

The truth stood against him.

He lied:

"I didn't go anywhere."

On the second day Ajit Yadav asked again:

"CCTV?"

The president said, "There are two cameras."

One at the main gate.

One in the corridor of the sanctum.

Both had been dead for three days.

“Why?”

“A power surge burned the equipment.”

“Repair?”

“I had given instructions.”

“To whom?”

The president named a young man - Rakesh Electronics.

Rakesh said, “No advance payment came.”

The president said, “A bill was required first.”

Meanwhile, the idol disappeared.

Baldev listened silently.

Those broken cameras could not prove his twelve minutes.

Nor could they prove that he had been there.

The failed equipment both saved him and drowned him.

On the third day the police checked the private cameras of shops outside the temple. The flower shop's camera had been switched off at night. The sweet shop's camera faced the road. A chemist's camera, from a distance, showed the rear bend behind the temple.

At 2:32, a shadow.

No bicycle.

No motorcycle.

A man, a thin sack over his shoulder.

At 2:36 the shadow disappeared.

At 2:52 it appeared again - this time the sack was heavy.

The timing matched Baldev's twelve minutes.

After watching the video, Ajit Yadav asked:

“Where were you at this time?”

Baldev's knees trembled inside.

“On the veranda.”

“The camera shows a man going around the rear bend.”

“Not me.”

“I asked where you were.”

“On the veranda.”

He lied a second time.

His reputation had now become more important to him than his job. If he admitted today that he had vanished for twelve minutes, tomorrow people would say: then he was the thief.

The later truth arrives, the more suspicious it becomes.

For Jitan Sada, the idol was not a goddess.

At first it was “nine kilos of metal.”

Jitan collected scrap behind a market eight kos from Amarahi - old wire, motor coils, brass taps, iron tools - and sold it on. He had a small history of theft: copper wire from the back of shops, iron rods from construction sites, once an old fan from a school.

A temple?

Never before.

Three weeks earlier he had met “Mahesh Babu.” No one knew his real name. He bought and sold old things: watches, coins, brass vessels, old door fittings.

Mahesh had said:

“The idol at Amarahi is genuine ashtadhatu. Old. Outside the district it could fetch five lakhs.”

Jitan laughed.

“How would I get it?”

“You won’t need to open the door. One bar in the service grille is loose.”

“You go.”

“Everyone knows my face.”

“And me?”

“Five thousand in advance. Twenty more afterwards.”

Twenty-five thousand was a great deal for Jitan.

His daughter’s school fees were unpaid.

He owed eight thousand to a moneylender.

His wife kept saying, “This scrap work won’t run the house.”

He was not a religious man, but the moment he heard the idea of stealing an idol, he felt fear.

Not of the goddess - of people.

The temple crowd.

A beating.

The police.

Mahesh said:

“At night an idol is metal. Worship begins in the morning.”

Jitan did not laugh at that sentence.

For three days he went around the temple and watched. Not pretending to be a devotee. He offered no flowers. He merely drank tea, watched the shops, measured the back wall with his eyes.

One bar in the service grille really was loose. A brick beneath it had shifted. Someone had left an old repair incomplete.

Reaching the idol was not difficult.

Getting it out was difficult - it was heavy.

On the night of the theft Jitan arrived at 2:30. He saw that the guard was not at the rear. He did not know Baldev had gone to relieve himself; Mahesh had told him that between half past two and three the guard usually drank tea or slept.

Jitan shifted the loose bar.

Went inside.

Spread a cloth.

Lifted the idol.

It was heavier than he expected.

The repair on the left foot felt rough in his hand.

He took no flowers, no crown, no silver.

Not the donation box.

Only the idol.

Because that was the deal.
He got out.
The sack went over his shoulder.
It felt as if his shoulder would break.
Mahesh was not at the agreed place.
Jitan waited until three.
He could not take the idol home. His wife would see it. He hid the sack inside an empty kiln at an old brickworks by the river.
Mahesh came at dawn.
Opened the sack.
Saw the idol.
The moment he saw the repair on the left foot, his face changed.
“What is this?”
“The idol.”
“This is not old.”
“What?”
Mahesh scratched at the joint with a fingernail.
“New casting.”
“You said three hundred years.”
“The photo I was sent was from a distance.”
He looked underneath the idol. Small letters had been scraped away, but one mark remained like a number: “88.”
Mahesh swore.
“This could be from 1988.”
Jitan’s stomach sank.
“Then?”
“Then I won’t even be able to sell it as scrap. The metal may be worth fifteen or twenty thousand, but melting it will be difficult. The whole district will be looking for it.”
“My money?”
Mahesh laughed.
“You brought it. That’s your problem.”
“The five thousand advance?”
“Keep it.”
“The rest?”
“For what?”
Jitan grabbed his collar.
Mahesh called out to two men.
Jitan released him.
The whole crime was his.
The bargain was half a bargain.
For the first time, Jitan looked at the idol not as a goddess, but as trouble.
Nine kilos of metal.
Five thousand rupees.
A dream of twenty-five thousand.
And now the possibility of prison.

He was a thief.
Not a devotee.
That would not change the story.

Phulkumari Devi was eighty-seven. Her knees hurt, her eyes were clear after cataract surgery, and her memory was sharp in some places and full of holes in others.

For her, Bhuvaneshwari Sthan was not merely a place of worship.

Her husband, Hemkant Thakur, had been a metalworker.

The flood of 1987 had cut away half the platform of the old shrine at Amarahi. Where the old small idol went in that flood, no one knew for certain. Some said the water carried it off. Some said it was taken into a safe house and later disappeared. Some said even that idol had never been the “original.”

One thing Phulkumari remembered clearly.

For a month after the flood the temple continued worship before an empty throne.

Then the committee called Hemkant.

“Make it exactly like the old one,” the president’s father had said.

Hemkant replied:

“It cannot be made exactly the same. It will be made from what we have seen.”

Two photographs of the old idol, one priest’s memory, descriptions by three elderly women.

From those, a new casting.

Phulkumari watched her husband making the wax model night after night. The left foot broke once. He joined it again. That was why the final metal had the small raised patch.

The idol was installed in the spring of 1988.

On the first day Hemkant returned home and said:

“Today people bowed their heads to metal I made.”

Phulkumari had asked:

“Were you proud?”

Hemkant said:

“Afraid.”

“Why?”

“Tomorrow people will say this idol has been here for centuries. No one will say it came out of Hemkant’s furnace.”

Phulkumari laughed.

“You want your name?”

“No. Only the truth.”

Hemkant died three years later.

Phulkumari continued to visit the shrine. Whenever she saw the idol, she saw the repair on the left foot. Devotees called it an ancient miraculous image. She never publicly corrected them.

Why?

The first year she thought: I will say it.

The second year: to whom?

The third year: what difference does it make now?
 For her the idol was recent metal, but the worship was old.
 Did people's faith depend upon the age of the idol, or upon the name of the goddess? She could never decide.
 When she heard of the theft, her first sentence was:
 "Hemkant's repair has gone too."
 Her granddaughter Neelu said:
 "Dadi, Mata has been stolen."
 Phulkumari replied at once:
 "Who can steal the Mother?"
 Neelu fell silent.
 "The image has gone," Phulkumari said.
 No one in the house paid attention to the distinction.
 The next day Phulkumari went to the temple. People were crying before the empty throne. Ishwarnath was temporarily worshipping a silver kalash draped in red cloth.
 Phulkumari worshipped.
 Bowed her head.
 Then she rose and asked Ishwarnath:
 "Did you tell the police about 1988?"
 Ishwarnath's face changed.
 "Kaki..."
 "Did you tell them?"
 "No."
 "Why?"
 "The committee president says first let the idol be found."
 "Will saying the wrong age make it be found sooner?"
 "If we call it ancient, higher officials will pay attention."
 Phulkumari's eyes sharpened.
 "If a lie brings attention, will the lie continue?"
 Ishwarnath was silent.
 "You were there at the installation," Phulkumari said.
 "I was a new priest."
 "Hemkant made it."
 "I know."
 "Then?"
 Ishwarnath said very softly:
 "The temple's prestige."
 Phulkumari laughed, but the laughter was hard.
 "The goddess's prestige or the committee's?"
 Ishwarnath did not answer.
 Phulkumari looked at the empty throne.
 "If we say the image is new, does that make the worship less old?"
 Inside, Ishwarnath knew: no.
 But the crowd?
 Donations?

The shrine's image as a pilgrimage place?

The committee?

The word "ancient"?

The livelihood of the temple was the livelihood of many people.

Malti sold flowers.

The prasad shop.

The drummer.

Women who made garlands.

Rickshaws on pilgrimage days.

The eating houses.

The pandas.

The priest's family.

The guards.

For three days after the theft, the crowds increased, but worship offerings declined. People came to look, and gave less.

"No idol, I'll make the vow-offering later," one devotee said.

The words stuck in Ishwarnath's ear.

Phulkumari heard them too.

She said:

"Then was your vow to the idol?"

The devotee looked embarrassed.

Phulkumari's question was not merely philosophical. By noon Malti Devi still had flowers unsold. The prasad sweets remained. Five families' daily earnings were cut in half.

Faith had become livelihood.

Livelihood was being shown as proof of faith.

On the fifth day Baldev was not arrested, but he was suspended.

Reason: "security lapse during night duty."

When he reached home, his wife Phulo said:

"Tell me the truth. Where had you gone?"

Baldev froze.

"How do you know?"

"Your face says it."

For the first time he told her about the twelve minutes.

Phulo sat down holding her head.

"Why did you lie to the police?"

"My job."

"And now?"

"Now the lie will eat the job too."

"The theft?"

"Not me."

Phulo took a long breath.

"Then tell the truth."

Baldev was afraid.

"Will people believe it?"

"They will believe less once they discover the lie anyway."

The next morning he went to the police station.

"I want to change my statement."

Ajit Yadav's face hardened.

"Why?"

Baldev told everything - no toilet, the field behind the bamboo, from 2:28 to 2:40.

"Why lie before?"

"Fear."

"Of whom?"

"Of losing the job. Of being accused."

"Did anyone know you went out at that time?"

Baldev thought.

"On many nights it was regular."

"Regular?"

That word was dangerous.

"What do you mean?"

"Usually between half past two and three... stomach, toilet..."

Ajit Yadav kept writing.

"Then a thief could know your routine."

Baldev's face dried up.

He had opened the door to his own security failure.

"Who could know?"

"The tea seller. The cleaner. Temple people. Anyone who watched."

"Mahesh, the old-goods dealer?"

Baldev started.

"Which Mahesh?"

By then the police had reached Mahesh.

From the chemist's camera they had Jitan's build, from two market photographs, and from a scrap dealer the information: "For two weeks Jitan had been asking the price of ashtadhatu idols."

Jitan had not fled his home.

By day he did his usual work.

At night he went to check the idol at the kiln.

He could not decide where to take it.

Mahesh's phone was switched off.

On the sixth day the police reached Jitan's house.

At first Jitan denied everything.

Then the camera.

Then the scrap dealer.

Then Mahesh's name.

He did not collapse.

He calculated.

How long could the lie last?

Would Mahesh escape?

Was the five thousand still left?

If the idol was recovered, would the punishment be less?

If not?

He said:

“I took the idol.”

At the police station the first question was:

“Did you believe in the goddess?”

Jitan laughed bitterly.

“No.”

“Then why choose a temple?”

“Money.”

“Did someone tell you?”

“Mahesh.”

“Where is the idol?”

Jitan showed them the kiln.

The idol was still there inside the sack.

With the repair on the left foot.

The news spread instantly:

“Mata recovered.”

Temple bells.

Flowers.

Drums.

Jitan in the police lock-up.

No one was eager to hear his story.

“Theft for money” was simple.

But Mahesh mattered to the police.

Mahesh was arrested two days later. Old coins, two stolen brass bells, and several other small objects were found in his house. He did not admit planning the theft and treating the idol as antique merchandise, but the messages said a great deal.

When the police sent the idol for metal testing, the fact that it was not genuinely ancient became public.

A local newspaper ran the headline:

“Idol Said to Be Worth Crores Turns Out to Be Only 37 Years Old?”

The committee president was furious.

“Why ‘only’? The worship is ancient!”

Ishwarnath read the paper and laughed dryly.

Now the truth had become prestige.

Ajit Yadav went to Phulkumari’s house.

“You said your husband made it?”

“Yes.”

“Proof?”

Phulkumari opened an old iron trunk.

Hemkant’s account book.

Wax.

Metal expenditure.

“Bhuvaneshwari image - total weight 9 seer 10 chhatank” - in the old measure.

Below it:

"Left foot joint remade."

Date - 1988.

One blurred photograph: Hemkant beside the furnace, the unfinished idol behind him.

The police history became clear.

The idol was new.

The worship tradition was old.

The theft was real.

Its value was not "crores."

Case closed?

No.

Because the community's story was only beginning.

The day the idol was brought back, the committee wanted a special procession.

"So much humiliation has occurred," President Devkinandan said. "There should be a grand reinstallation."

Ishwarnath asked:

"Why a fresh consecration? Worship has continued before the kalash in the meantime."

"The idol passed through impure hands."

Ishwarnath's face changed.

"Are the hands of a criminal impure, or are they human hands?"

The president was silent.

"We will do whatever ritual the shastra requires. But no spectacle."

The president was dissatisfied.

The second problem was the plaque.

The old brass plaque read:

"Ancient ashtadhatu image of Shri Bhuvaneshwari."

Now everyone knew: 1988.

"Change the plaque," Phulkumari said.

The president replied:

"People's faith will be hurt."

Phulkumari said:

"If faith rests on a lie, it will be hurt sooner or later."

Malti the flower seller listened silently. She said:

"Kaki, people come from far away to see the 'ancient idol.'"

Phulkumari looked at her.

"Your flowers sell?"

"That too."

"Then if the truth is written, your income may fall?"

Malti lowered her eyes.

"Possibly."

Phulkumari did not become harsh.

"That is difficult."

Malti looked at her in surprise.

Phulkumari continued:

“It is easy to say ‘remove the lie’ when one’s own daily bread will not be affected.”

Ishwarnath kept the sentence in his mind.

The committee meeting lasted five hours.

One side: “1988 must be written.”

Another: write “image representing an ancient tradition.”

A third: “Why mention the date at all?”

A fourth: “Everyone knows after the theft; hiding it would be foolish.”

At last the new plaque was drafted:

“Worshipped metal image of Shri Bhuvaneshwari, made in 1988 by local craftsman Hemkant Thakur from memory of the preceding form and available photographs. The worship tradition of this place predates the present image.”

The president became stuck on the words “local craftsman.”

“Will the idol become smaller if we name the artist?”

Ishwarnath asked:

“Does the goddess become smaller?”

The president fell silent.

Phulkumari’s eyes filled.

Hemkant’s name, after thirty-four years, on stone.

He had not wanted prestige.

Only truth.

Baldev’s suspension continued.

The idol had been recovered, the thief had confessed; his case should have become simple.

But the committee said: security lapse.

The police said: false statement.

Baldev said: no toilet.

The committee said: an excuse.

One day his wife Phulo arrived at the committee meeting.

“Nine hours of night duty. Not one relief guard. No toilet. The tea seller is far away. Then what kind of security is this?”

The president was angry.

“Discipline?”

Phulo replied:

“Does discipline stop the stomach?”

Some people laughed. The president did not.

Ishwarnath was not entirely on Baldev’s side.

“He lied.”

“From fear,” Phulo said.

“Fear does not turn a lie into truth.”

Baldev himself said:

“Maharaj, the lapse was mine. I lied to save my job. But I did not steal.”

Ishwarnath looked at him.

“This time you are speaking correctly.”

The committee decided: deduction of one month's wages and a warning, followed by reinstatement. Along with that, two guards would rotate at night and a toilet would be built behind the temple.

To Baldev this felt like half justice.

But his job survived.

Did his reputation return in full?

No.

Some people still whispered:

"How could the idol go without the guard's collusion?"

There was no evidence.

Baldev slowly learned that being proved innocent and becoming innocent again in people's eyes are two different things.

One day Jitan's wife Sita stopped Ishwarnath outside the police station.

"Panditji."

Ishwarnath stopped.

Sita folded her hands.

"I have not come to ask forgiveness. I did not commit the theft."

Ishwarnath nodded.

"I have come to ask - the idol has returned. Will his punishment be less?"

"I do not know."

"People say the goddess will curse him."

Ishwarnath took a long breath.

"The law will do its work. Do not sell fear in the name of the goddess."

Sita's eyes filled.

"He is not a devotee. He did it for money."

"I know."

"Then people are making a story: that the thief dreamed at night, the goddess told him to return the idol."

It was the first time Ishwarnath had heard this.

"Who says that?"

"The whole market."

In reality Jitan had not returned the idol.

The police had recovered it.

But the other story was more satisfying:

thief → fear of the goddess → repentance → return.

Ishwarnath became angry.

The next day, in his discourse, he said:

"Do not turn into a miracle something that did not happen. The police recovered the image. The thief stole it for money. Whether he repented is a matter in his own mind; I do not know."

Some devotees were disappointed.

An elderly man said:

"Panditji, calling it a miracle increases faith."

Ishwarnath replied:

“If a lie increases faith, then what use is truth?”

Phulkumari, sitting behind, smiled.

The idol returned to the temple.

This time Phulkumari was called to the very front.

“Hemkantji’s family.”

She wanted to refuse, but her granddaughter Neelu said:

“Dadi, go.”

Phulkumari reached the threshold of the sanctum.

The idol was on the throne.

New garments.

Flowers.

The repair on the left foot unchanged.

She looked at the foot.

She remembered her husband - smoke from the furnace, wax, heated metal, the ringing of the hammer.

Her eyes filled.

But she did not touch the idol’s foot. She touched the earth beneath the throne.

Neelu asked:

“Dadi, has Mata come back?”

Phulkumari said:

“The image has come back.”

“Mata?”

“Where had she gone?”

Neelu thought for a while.

Then smiled.

Outside, Malti was selling flowers. Business was heavy that day.

“The idol has returned” - people were crowding in.

Seeing Phulkumari, Malti said:

“Kaki, people came even after the truth was written.”

Phulkumari laughed.

“People come for a story and stay for flowers.”

Malti laughed too.

The new plaque had been installed.

Some people read it.

Some did not.

Some were startled by “1988.”

Some said, “Oh, so it is new?”

Others answered, “The worship is old.”

While the debate continued, the flowers kept selling.

Three months later Jitan’s case was proceeding in court. Mahesh faced charges of planning the theft and attempting to receive stolen property. Jitan faced the theft charge.

A social worker asked Jitan in jail:

"Did you undergo a religious change after the crime?"

Jitan laughed.

"No."

"Repentance?"

"No one wants to be in jail."

"About stealing the idol?"

Jitan thought.

"I took it for money. I got five thousand. I owed eight thousand in interest. Now ten thousand has gone to the lawyer."

"Fear of the goddess?"

"I was more afraid of being beaten by people."

The social worker looked disappointed.

Jitan continued:

"But I did understand one thing."

"What?"

"Mahesh said that at night an idol becomes metal. He was wrong."

The social worker became eager.

"So faith?"

Jitan shook his head.

"No. At night too it was not only metal."

"Then?"

"For nine kilos of metal the whole village woke up. The guard lost his job, the flower seller lost income, the old woman remembered her husband, the priest's prestige, the police, leaders - everyone."

He laughed.

"How can metal be so many things?"

The social worker began writing in a notebook.

Jitan said at once:

"Do not write that I became a devotee."

"All right."

"Truly."

"All right."

Jitan leaned back.

His repentance was not a religious story.

He had simply understood that what was price to him was something else to someone else.

That understanding did not make the crime smaller.

But it made the object larger.

Six months later came the temple's annual fair.

New security.

Two guards in rotation.

The cameras repaired.

A toilet built.

A new plaque.

Baldev now had evening duty instead of the night shift. Some people still watched his face closely, but the old suspicion was slowly becoming lighter.

After worship Ishwarnath sat outside.

Phulkumari came.

Malti with a basket of flowers.

Neelu with her.

Phulkumari asked:

“Panditji, how old do people say the idol is now?”

Ishwarnath laughed.

“Those who read the plaque say 1988. Those who do not read it say ‘very old.’”

“Then the work is half done.”

“Truth’s work is often half done.”

Malti interrupted:

“I tell customers: the image is from 1988, but the shrine is old.”

Phulkumari was surprised.

“Did your income fall?”

“For the first month. Not now. A new story has formed: ‘the idol that returned after being stolen.’”

Ishwarnath held his head.

“Another story!”

Malti laughed.

“Do people worship without a story?”

Phulkumari said:

“Let there be a story. Just do not add what did not happen.”

At that moment a new family entered the temple. A small child read the plaque and asked his father:

“Who is this maker, Hemkant Thakur?”

Phulkumari turned her ear toward them.

The father read the plaque and said:

“A local craftsman.”

The child asked again:

“He made the goddess?”

The father hesitated.

“The image.”

Phulkumari smiled softly.

That difference of one word seemed immense to her.

When the fair ended, Baldev stood guard before the sanctum at night.

The idol was inside.

There was no extra glass enclosure - Ishwarnath had said not to turn worship into a museum.

Baldev held the new key.

He took a small paper from his pocket - the rotation schedule.

At two o’clock the second guard would arrive.

He could go to the toilet without leaving the gate unattended.

A small facility.

Built after the theft of the idol.

He thought: before the theft the committee had talked about cameras, locks, and keys; no one had talked about the toilet. Theft was one crime, but security had not been completed merely by finding a criminal.

Far away, Malti was packing her shop.

Ishwarnath was extinguishing lamps inside.

Phulkumari had already gone home.

A faint oily light fell on the idol.

The repair on the left foot made a shadow.

Baldev had never paid so much attention to it before.

Suddenly he understood that the idol's real history was written in that repair - a history the brass plaque had failed to write for years.

Whether he folded his hands or not, no one saw.

That was not necessary for the story either.

What mattered was that when the guard looked toward the throne now, he no longer saw only "an ancient idol worth crores."

He saw:

Hemkant's furnace.

Phulkumari's memory.

Ishwarnath's silence.

His own twelve minutes.

Jitan's five thousand.

Malti's flowers.

The committee's prestige.

And the village's faith.

The idol was one.

The theft happened once.

But the things different people had lost were all different.

Someone's faith.

Someone's livelihood.

Someone's name.

Someone's honour.

Someone's lie.

Someone's old memory.

Even after the image returned, not everything returned on the same day.

The Shot at the Border

Half a kos south of the Rekhapur post ran a narrow drainage channel. In the rains it swelled; in winter the water came up to the knees; in summer only patches of mud remained. On the map, that channel was not the border. The actual border ran like a straight line between old white boundary stones - in some places ten cubits north of the channel, in others twenty cubits south.

The villagers trusted the stones more than the map.

That was why, after the incident, when the survey team arrived and said, "Boundary stone number 47 has shifted seven cubits east-south-east from its original position," half the village spoke at once:

"Who shifted it?"

No one had an answer.

Rain? A plough? Bullocks? Border guards? A farmer? Children at play? Or had the stone itself tilted over the years as soil washed away and gathered again?

But when the shot was fired, no one was thinking about that question.

That evening, only the worlds of four people, coming from four different directions, stopped at one point.

A soldier. A farmer. An officer. A child.

And one bullet.

Constable Arun Tamang's shift ran from four in the afternoon until ten at night. He and Constable Imran Ali took turns guarding the western tower of the post. For the previous two weeks the border strip had been declared "sensitive," because illegal consignments of fertiliser, diesel, and tobacco had been intercepted three times at night.

Arun's orders were clear: "If you see activity in the restricted strip after sunset, first call out, then give a light signal, then stop the person according to the situation. The weapon is the last resort."

The sequence had been repeated so often in training that Arun could recite it without thinking:

First warning. Second warning. Third warning. Stop. Safety. Fire only in the face of an immediate threat.

At 5:58 that day the sun was sinking. A strong wind blew from the north-west. Dry reeds swayed. From the distant village came the continuous grinding sound of a paddy-threshing machine.

At 6:05 Arun saw a figure through the binoculars.

Between boundary stones 46 and 47. A bent body. Something long over the shoulder. Behind it, a dark shape like an animal.

He spoke into the radio: "Activity in the western strip."

The post replied: "Distance?"

"About one hundred and fifty yards."

“Keep watch.”

The figure did not cross the drainage channel. It stopped near the stone. Then bent down and began pulling something.

Arun's first thought: a sack. Second: a pipe. Third: a rifle?

In the wind, among the reeds, the shape of the long black object kept changing.

He came down from the tower and moved along the lower earthen line of the post. Imran followed five or seven yards behind.

6:07.

Arun shouted: “Stop where you are!”

The wind was strong. The paddy machine roared. A tractor sounded in the distance.

Whether the figure turned or not was unclear.

He shouted again: “Border security! Stop!”

The figure kept pulling.

Arun's hand went to the torch. He flashed the red signal.

The figure stood upright once. The long object at its shoulder rose for a moment.

Arun says that in that instant it looked like the barrel of a gun.

He shouted a third time: “Hands up!”

Then the figure turned back and began walking quickly.

Arun raised his rifle.

He says that he aimed not at the body but at the ground ahead.

One shot.

The figure fell.

The animal behind it leapt away.

Arun ran.

When he came close he saw the farmer Sadanand Mahato on the ground, clutching his right arm.

The “long object” on his shoulder was a length of iron irrigation pipe. The animal behind him was his calf.

At first it was unclear whether the bullet had struck the ground and then grazed the arm, or had directly skimmed past the arm.

Sadanand's kurta was torn; his arm was injured. There was not much blood, but the wound was serious.

Arun felt his stomach turn empty.

“Where is the weapon?” Imran asked.

There was nothing.

Only the pipe. A rope. A small hammer. The broken tether from the calf's neck.

Arun spoke into the radio: “One civilian injured. Medical assistance required.”

The post's first question was: “Cross-border activity?”

Arun looked at Sadanand's feet.

White boundary stone 47 was almost beside his knee.

Which side?

At that moment Arun thought: south.

That meant inside the restricted strip.

Later the survey would say that the stone itself had shifted.

But at that moment, the stone was the border.

Sadanand Mahato had three kathas of land beside the border strip. It had belonged to the family since his father's time. Half the field was irrigated; the other half depended on rain.

On the morning of the incident his pump had failed. A thin iron pipe had come loose from the tube-well joint. Sadanand meant to repair it during the day, but there were guests at home, then the market, then the calf got loose.

At 5:45 in the evening his son said, "The calf has run toward the western field."

Sadanand took a rope and went out.

He knew one should not go into the border strip after sunset.

But to him, "sunset" meant after it had become dark. Villagers measured time less by the clock than by the remaining light.

He found the calf near the drainage channel. Its neck rope was tangled in a bush. While freeing it, his eyes fell upon the pipe - the iron length lay beside the field ridge.

"Better take it now than come again tomorrow."

He put the pipe over his shoulder and caught the calf's rope.

Then came a voice.

The first call did not reach him clearly. The paddy machine was loud.

He turned and saw someone waving from the direction of the post.

He thought perhaps the soldier was saying, "Not that way."

Sadanand himself says that he stopped.

The soldier says that he did not.

At that one moment their two accounts separate.

According to Sadanand, he put the pipe down and cupped a hand to his ear: "What?"

Then the red light flashed.

He became afraid.

Why?

Because there were two small containers of diesel in his pocket.

For the pump.

Half a litre in each. Bought from the village shop. Not for illegal trade.

But he knew that walking around with diesel in the border strip could look suspicious.

He thought: "The guards will catch me, question me, confiscate the containers."

He began moving back toward home.

Quickly? He says no. Arun says yes.

Sadanand says the calf pulled, making his steps quicker.

Then came the voice: "Stop!"

This time he heard clearly.

Instead of stopping, he tried to take the pipe off his shoulder.

Because he thought it unwise to turn toward a soldier with an iron pipe still on his shoulder.

His hand went upward.

From a distance Arun saw it as "raising the long object."

Then the shot.

According to Sadanand there was not even one breath between the clear warning and the bullet.

According to Arun, even after the third warning he was still turning away.

The moment the bullet hit, Sadanand first felt no pain, only a hard blow. He fell. The calf pulled free and ran.

When the soldiers reached him, Sadanand's first sentence was: "I am in my own field."

Arun's first sentence: "Show me your hands."

Both agree on those words.

On the rest, they do not.

Sadanand stayed in hospital for three days. The bullet grazed the flesh of his arm and passed on; the bone was spared. The doctor said he was fortunate.

In the village people said: "A farmer has been shot at the border."

Some said: "Brutality by the soldier." Others: "He broke the rules."

At first Sadanand told no one about the two containers of diesel.

His wife Shanti knew. She said, "Don't tell them. People will turn it into smuggling."

Sadanand agreed.

His first statement said: "I had gone to catch my calf. I was picking up the pipe. I had nothing else with me."

"Nothing else" was a lie.

A small lie born of fear.

But in an inquiry, a small lie can become heavy.

Deputy Commandant Devvrat Sen received the official notice of the incident from the radio log at 6:14.

"Suspicious person in border strip. Warning ignored. One controlled shot. One civilian injured. No weapon recovered."

Devvrat was in his office. He reached the site at 7:10.

By then it was dark. The injured man was in hospital. The soldier had been separated. Thirty or forty villagers had gathered near the border. There were no slogans, but there was anger.

Devvrat's first act was not to disperse the crowd, but to arrange lights. He wanted to see the ground.

Stone 47. Pipe. Rope. Hammer. A container of diesel?

No.

No diesel was found there.

Later Shanti Devi would say that the containers had been in Sadanand's pocket and that a boy from the family had removed them when he was taken to hospital.

Devvrat did not yet know this.

He took Arun's statement.

"How many warnings?"

Without hesitation Arun said: "Three oral warnings, one light signal."

Devvrat wrote it down.

"The prescribed sequence?"

“Yes.”

Devvrat paused for a moment.

Trained personnel often speak in trained sentences. That does not necessarily make them lies. But sometimes the standard sequence and the remembered sequence merge into one another.

“The words?”

Arun said: “Stop. Border security. Hands up.”

“In that exact order?”

Arun fell silent.

“Are those the training phrases, or the exact words you used that night?”

Arun’s face changed.

“Approximately.”

Devvrat wrote in his notes: “Verbatim memory uncertain.”

Imran’s statement: he heard the first call. Heard the second. The third?

“Possibly.”

“Before the shot, did Arun say ‘hands up?’” Devvrat asked.

Imran thought. “He said something. The wind was strong.”

“So three warnings?”

“I heard two clearly.”

Devvrat nodded.

At nine that night headquarters telephoned: “Preliminary report immediately.”

Devvrat sat down to write.

There was little time. Questions from above: “Were rules followed?” “Was there infiltration?” “Was there smuggling?” “Any local tension?”

Devvrat drafted:

“At approximately 18:07 a person was observed engaged in suspicious activity within the restricted border strip. The sentry issued prescribed oral warnings and a light signal. Instead of stopping, the person changed direction and raised a long metal object in his hand. Perceiving an immediate potential threat, the soldier fired one controlled shot, injuring the person in the right arm. Subsequent examination identified the object as an irrigation pipe.”

He had written the word “prescribed.”

Did that word mean that the prescribed procedure had been followed in full?

Arun himself did not clearly remember the exact order of three warnings. Imran had clearly heard only two.

But “prescribed oral warnings” was a phrase in the office’s standard template.

Devvrat stopped his pen for a moment.

Then headquarters telephoned again: “Has the report been sent?”

He sent it.

The next morning the official statement in the news said: “After suspicious activity continued despite warnings, one shot was fired in accordance with procedure.”

“In accordance with procedure.”

Devvrat had not written those exact words in his preliminary report, but they had appeared in the departmental statement.

The phrase spread through the village like fire.

Reading it in hospital, Sadanand said: "In accordance with procedure? I wasn't even allowed to hear them!"

Reading it at the post, Arun thought: "Did I break procedure or not?"

Reading it in his office, Devvrat held his head.

The official sentence had become cleaner than the facts.

The fourth viewpoint belonged to twelve-year-old Rani.

Rani was the daughter of Sadanand's neighbour Ramsevak. At the time of the incident she had been grazing goats east of the drainage channel.

No one took her statement on the first day.

Why? A child. "What would she understand?"

On the second day she told everyone at school: "I saw the whole thing."

Children gathered around.

"The soldier fired without saying anything."

By evening the sentence had reached the village.

Sadanand's supporters said: "An eyewitness child says there was no warning."

The inquiry team went to her house.

Rani was excited, frightened, proud - all three.

Devvrat asked, "Where were you standing?"

Rani showed the place beside the channel.

"How far?"

About one hundred and twenty yards.

"What did you see?"

"Sadanand Kaka was taking the pipe. The soldier came running. Red light. Kaka turned. Shot."

"Sound?"

"I heard the shot."

"The soldier calling out?"

"No."

"Was the paddy machine running?"

"Yes."

"Could you see the soldier's mouth?"

"Small, from far away."

"Could you see whether he was shouting?"

Rani paused.

"His mouth... looked open."

"Then how can you say 'without saying anything'?"

Rani's face reddened.

"I did not hear him."

"You did not hear = he did not speak?"

Rani fell silent.

Devvrat said gently, "Tell only what you heard. Do not fill in what you did not hear."

Tears came to Rani's eyes. "I am not lying."

"I am not saying you are."

Rani's mother interrupted: "Don't frighten the child."

Devvrat moved back. "All right. You tell us yourself."

Rani began again.

She saw the red light. Sadanand lowering the pipe? "Possibly."

The soldier raising the rifle. Yes. One shot. Yes.

"Was Kaka running away?"

Rani answered immediately: "No."

Then stopped. "The calf was pulling him."

"Were his steps quick?"

"Yes, a little."

"Was there a container in his hand?"

"I saw something shiny."

Sadanand's mother, who was present, immediately asked: "What container?"

Rani became frightened. "I don't know."

Devvrat wrote: "Object identification uncertain because of distance."

Rani went inside the house.

That night her father asked: "Did you really see something shiny?"

"Yes."

"Did Kaka take diesel?"

"I don't know."

"Don't say that to anyone."

"Why?"

"People will turn it around."

Rani's mind became tangled.

The next day at school the teacher asked: "Was there a warning before the shot?"

Rani said: "I did not hear one."

The teacher said: "Good. Say only that much."

But her friends said: "You said before that he shot without warning."

Rani became irritated. "If I couldn't hear anything, then for me it was without warning."

That was a child's logic. Not a complete lie. Not a complete fact.

Five days later the inquiry became formal.

The team consisted of Devvrat, a representative of the district magistrate, local police, the survey department, and a medical officer.

The first surprise was boundary stone 47.

The survey officer used old coordinates, new instruments, and a 1989 map.

"The stone was in the wrong place."

Devvrat asked: "By how much?"

"About seven cubits east-south-east."

"Since when?"

"I do not know."

"Then where was the farmer at the time of the incident?"

The survey line was drawn.

The place where Sadanand had fallen lay about three cubits inside his own country according to the original border line. But according to the shifted stone, it lay inside the restricted strip.

There was an uproar in the village.

"See! He was shot in his own field!"

The security side said: "Is a soldier supposed to look at the stone or carry old coordinates?"

The question was difficult.

Devvrat asked: "How often are the boundary stones verified by the post?"

The survey officer replied: "Annual joint inspection."

"The last one?"

The file was searched.

Eighteen months earlier. The stone had then been recorded as correct.

But the document said only: "Stones 40-50 in normal condition." There had been no individual measurement.

"Normal" - another government word.

The second surprise concerned the direction of the bullet.

The doctor said the bullet had grazed the outer part of the arm. Its angle might have been downward toward the ground. A metal fragment was found in the soil, possibly from the same bullet. If that match were established, Arun's claim of aiming "at the ground ahead" would be plausible.

But not certain.

Third: the diesel.

After Rani's statement about something "shiny," the police questioned the family. Shanti Devi eventually produced two containers.

"For the pump," she said.

No receipt.

The village shopkeeper said: "I gave it to him. Half a litre each."

"When?"

"That same evening."

"Receipt?"

"Who gives receipts for that amount?"

Sadanand had to give another statement.

"Why did you hide it before?"

He was silent.

"Smuggling?"

"No."

"Fear?"

"Yes."

"Of whom?"

"Of all of you."

Devvrat wrote: "Small quantity of diesel; claim of local motor use partially corroborated independently. Concealed in first statement."

Sadanand's lawyer said: "The diesel did not cause the injury."

Devvrat replied: "Correct. But it is relevant to understanding why the farmer moved away when confronted."

The lawyer was dissatisfied.

Fourth: the radio log.

Time: 18:05 activity. 18:07 constable on patrol. No entry such as “person unresponsive” at 18:08. At 18:09:38 the radio log said: “One shot, civilian injured.”

How much time had there been for warnings? Arun said about a minute. Imran said thirty to forty seconds. The farmer said one clear warning and then immediately the shot. Rani did not hear the calls.

Were all clocks set to the same time? No.

The post’s digital clock was about twenty-two seconds fast. The chemist’s camera was thirty-seven seconds slow. Rani had no watch.

Exact seconds collapsed.

But one point remained stable: at least about two minutes separated the first radio report from the shot.

So it had not been wholly “sudden.”

The phrase “immediate potential threat” in the officer’s preliminary report now seemed too compressed.

Devvrat wrote that himself.

Arun’s second statement was the most difficult.

Devvrat asked: “The stone was in the wrong place. You did not know that.”

“No.”

“Sadanand did not cross the original border.”

Arun’s face tightened. “But the stone was in front of me.”

“Correct.”

“I don’t patrol with a map in my hand.”

“Correct.”

“He raised a long object.”

“A pipe.”

“I know now that it was a pipe.”

“At that moment?”

“No.”

“Are you certain about the third warning?”

Arun fell silent.

“This is important.”

“I remember the training sequence.”

“The event?”

Arun lowered his head.

“I remember the first ‘stop.’ I remember the second ‘border security.’ I remember the red light. The third... I think I said it.”

“You think?”

“Yes.”

“Then why did your first statement say ‘three oral warnings’?”

After a long time Arun said: “Because that is what I was supposed to do.”

The room fell silent.

That sentence became the centre of the inquiry.

"What you were supposed to do became what you remembered doing?" Devvrat asked.

Arun's eyes were red. "Possibly."

"The decision to fire?"

"I have no doubt about that. The pipe rose, the man turned, the distance was decreasing..."

"The distance was more than a hundred yards."

"Darkness, wind. It felt like a threat."

"Possibility of escape?"

"Yes."

"Threat and escape are different."

Arun was silent.

"Did he advance toward you?"

"No."

"Throw anything?"

"No."

"Point the pipe toward you?"

Arun took a long breath. "For a moment it appeared so to me."

"Now?"

"Now, looking at the photographs, it is a pipe."

Devvrat made a note.

Arun suddenly said: "Sir, what if it really had been a gun?"

"That question is not the inquiry's answer."

"But that is the question inside a guard's mind at that moment."

Devvrat nodded. "So I will record the circumstance. But not turn a possibility into a fact."

Arun pushed his chair back. "Will the report make me a criminal?"

"I do not know yet."

"Sadanand lied about the diesel."

"That will be written too."

"The stone was in the wrong place."

"That too."

"Then?"

Devvrat said: "Then every inconvenient fact will be written together."

Arun did not laugh.

Sadanand's second statement.

"Did you hear the first warning?"

"Unclear."

"The second?"

"Something like 'border security.'"

"Then did you stop?"

"For a moment."

"Then moved again?"

"Yes."

"Why?"

"Because of the diesel. Fear."

"You say the diesel was lawful."

"Yes."

"Then why fear?"

Sadanand snapped: "At the border they ask for papers. The shop gives no receipt. They can keep you all day. Farmers know this."

"So you wanted to get away from what looked like the restricted strip?"

"Yes."

"Did you raise the pipe?"

"To take it down."

"Toward the soldier?"

"No."

"Rani says the pipe went up."

"What could she see from that distance?"

Devvrat remained calm. "That is why I am asking."

"I was in my own field."

"According to the original border, yes."

"That's all."

"But could you see stone 47?"

Sadanand was silent.

"You knew people treated that stone as the border?"

"Yes."

"Then, in your own understanding?"

Sadanand's face changed.

He told the truth: "I thought this side of the stone was my field. The pipe was there."

"Which side of the stone?"

They looked at the map.

Sadanand placed his finger according to memory.

Possibly, by the shifted stone, he himself had taken one or two steps into what appeared to be the restricted strip while chasing the calf or picking up the pipe.

"Then your statement, 'I was in my own field'?"

"The land is mine."

"The border line?"

"I do not know."

That was the difference.

Ownership of a field and a national border do not share the same geometry.

Sadanand's land papers did not cross the border, but the ridge was irregular; the border line cut near the edge of the field.

He owned the field. But not every footstep within it fell under the same administrative permission.

The original stone was displaced. Memory was old. The rule was new. The border was hard.

Sadanand sat holding his head.

"Am I a farmer or a cartographer?"

Devvrat did not answer.

Rani's second statement was taken differently.

This time only a female teacher, Rani's mother, and the survey officer's large map were in the room.

"You were here," the teacher said. Rani put down a red dot.

"Sadanand here?" A green one.

"The soldier?" Blue.

Seeing the distances, Rani herself said: "Was it that far?"

"You saw it."

"It did not feel far."

"After the shot?"

Rani drew a line on the paper.

"Did the soldier call out three times?" the teacher asked.

"I did not hear."

"His mouth?"

"It looked as if it opened twice."

"Twice?"

"Possibly."

"Then why did you first say 'without saying anything'?"

Rani lowered her eyes. "Everyone kept asking whether the soldier spoke or not. I didn't hear him. So I said no."

"And now?"

"Now I will say: I did not hear."

"Did Sadanand Kaka run?"

Rani thought. "The calf was pulling. He walked quickly."

"The pipe toward the soldier?"

Rani acted it out with her hands - first on the shoulder, then down, then perhaps to one side.

"I am not certain."

"Good."

Rani breathed with relief.

Then the child herself asked the next question: "Didi, if I said it wrongly before, am I a liar?"

The teacher said: "No. You quickly made a meaning out of what you saw. Now you are separating what you are not certain about."

Rani thought. "Sadanand Kaka too?"

"Ask him."

"The soldier?"

"Ask him too."

A faint smile came to Rani's face. A child was not an angel of truth, only a human being learning how to tell it.

The final report took eighteen days.

Pressure came from two directions above.

Headquarters: “Will the use of force be declared compliant with procedure or not?”

District administration: “Compensation to the civilian?”

The village: “A case against the soldier.”

The soldiers’ association: “Do not make the jawan a scapegoat.”

Political parties? Devvrat did not want to admit them into the report. Their meetings continued outside.

He divided the document into four sections:

1. Established facts. 2. Uncertain/disputed elements. 3. Procedural lapses. 4.

Conclusions regarding responsibility.

Established facts:

- One shot was fired.
- Sadanand was injured; his life was not in danger.
- No weapon was found; the object was an iron irrigation pipe.
- Boundary stone 47 at the site had shifted about seven cubits from the original survey position.

- According to the original border line, the place where Sadanand fell was within his own country.

- The soldier made the first radio report at least about two minutes before the shot.

- A red light signal was used.

- At least two oral calls are supported by both Arun’s and Imran’s statements.

- The third call is not certain.

- Sadanand had a small quantity of diesel with him and concealed it in his first statement.

- There is no evidence that the diesel was intended for illegal trade.

- Because of the distance, Rani’s position for hearing the calls was limited.

- The object in Sadanand’s hand was a pipe, not a gun.

Disputed:

- The soldier’s third warning.

- Whether Sadanand’s movement was “running away” or “moving quickly because of the calf/toward home.”

- The direction of the pipe.

- Whether the shot was aimed directly at him or downward toward the ground as a stopping shot.

- How far, at the moment of the incident, Sadanand had gone inside the restricted strip as indicated by the shifted stone.

Procedural lapses:

- Boundary-stone verification had not been performed on time.

- Local marking of the restricted area was unclear.

- The first departmental statement used the expression “in accordance with procedure” before the inquiry was complete.

- Arun’s first statement presented the standard training sequence as though it were exact memory.

- Sadanand concealed the diesel.

- Child witness Rani's first sentence, "without saying anything," circulated through the village with greater certainty than her actual experience, which was "I did not hear."

When he came to the final conclusion, Devvrat's pen stopped.

"Soldier guilty"? "Soldier innocent"? Both sentences were smaller than the document's complexity.

He wrote:

"The available evidence does not establish that the injured person was about to mount an immediate armed attack on the soldier. The soldier's perception of the pipe as a possible weapon may have been situationally understandable; however, because of the distance, direction of movement, uncertainty regarding warnings, and confusion created by the displaced boundary marker, it cannot be said with certainty that the decision to fire met the expected standard of restraint. The incident cannot be explained solely as the civilian's disregard of rules or solely as deliberate aggression by the soldier."

Then:

"The civilian is eligible for compensation for treatment and loss of income because the injury occurred within an official border-security operation; such compensation does not constitute an admission of criminal liability."

Departmental discipline for Arun? "Review of use-of-force training, temporary removal from armed duty, final administrative decision by higher committee."

For Sadanand? "Warning regarding instructions for the restricted strip; no case relating to diesel trade."

The stone? "Immediate reinstatement, reflective markers, signs in the local language."

The report went upward.

For three days there was no reply.

Then headquarters said: "The language is excessively uncertain."

Devvrat asked: "Which part?"

"The conclusion."

"The evidence is uncertain too."

"The public wants a clear answer."

Devvrat was silent.

"Was the jawan compliant with procedure?"

"I have written that it cannot be established with complete certainty."

"That is the problem."

For the first time, Devvrat laughed in his office chair. "Is the problem the event, or the language?"

There was silence at the other end of the phone.

In the end, the report was not accepted in full exactly as written, but was retained as a "factual annexure." The public summary was milder:

"A civilian was injured in the incident. The inquiry identified displacement of a boundary marker, communication/visual confusion, and questions concerning the use-of-force process. Compensation approved; departmental review continuing."

The words "in accordance with procedure" had disappeared.

Sadanand read it and said: "What about the soldier?"

Shanti said: "Nothing is clear."
Arun read it and said: "What about me?"
Imran said: "Nothing is clear."
Both sides were dissatisfied.
Perhaps, this time, the document was closer to the truth.

Compensation arrived - medical expenses, five weeks' loss of income, damage to the field.

Sadanand took the money. Some people said: "The government has admitted its mistake."

Devvrat said: "Compensation is not a legal admission of error."

No one in the village paid much attention to that distinction.

Arun was removed from armed duty for one month. Then came retraining. During firing practice the instructor asked:

"Long object = weapon?"

The jawans answered: "Not necessarily."

"Person in a strip that looks like the border = infiltrator?"

"Not necessarily."

"Remember the standard sequence?"

Arun's face tightened.

The instructor continued: "Remembering the sequence and remembering the event are two different things."

Arun recognised Devvrat's sentence.

He could not say that he completely regretted the decision to fire. At that moment, the danger had felt real to him.

But neither could he now say: "The protocol was completed, therefore the decision was right."

There was a gap between the paper and the instant.

Boundary stone 47 was reset in its proper position.

The old hole was filled. A new reflective sign read: "Border Line - Entry Prohibited After Sunset."

In the local language too.

The ridge of Sadanand's field now visibly divided into two clear areas. He laughed: "My field is in my own country, but if I go three cubits nearer the strip, I need permission."

The survey officer said: "A border does not see fields."

Sadanand replied: "A field does not see borders."

Both were right.

On her way to school, Rani would stop to look at the stone.

One day Arun was patrolling there. Rani saw him. Arun recognised her too.

Both were uncomfortable.

Rani spoke first: "Now I say: I did not hear the warning. Not that there was no warning."

Arun was startled. "Good."
"Did you call out three times?"
Arun could not laugh. "Twice for certain."
"The third?"
"Not certain."
Rani nodded as though she had solved a difficult sum.
"And the pipe looked like a gun?"
"At that moment."
"Now?"
"Now it is a pipe."
Rani smiled.
"At that moment it looked to me as though the soldier fired without saying anything."
"Now?"
"Now I know only that I did not hear."
For the first time Arun gave a faint laugh. "We both changed."
Rani said: "The incident did not."
The sentence stayed inside Arun.

Sadanand and Arun met face to face three months later.
The place was the panchayat building, for the final signatures on the compensation papers.
Sadanand's arm was almost healed, though lifting heavy things still caused pain.
Arun was not in civilian clothes; he wore his uniform.
They nodded their heads to one another, something like a greeting.
The papers were completed. People went outside.
Sadanand suddenly said: "I hid the diesel."
Arun said: "I know."
"You read the report?"
"Yes."
"Do you think I am a smuggler?"
After a long pause Arun said: "No."
"That night?"
"I was suspicious."
"I thought you had wanted to shoot from the start."
Arun's face tightened. "No."
Sadanand kept looking at him. "Now... I don't fully believe that, but I believe it more than before."
Arun said: "I thought you were running."
"I was moving away because of the diesel."
"I did not know that."
"I didn't tell you either."
Both were silent.
Sadanand asked: "If that same moment came again?"
Arun did not answer immediately.

"Possibly no shot. I would take cover, keep more distance, call the other jawan."

"Possibly?"

"Yes."

Sadanand laughed. "You have caught the report's disease."

Arun laughed too.

But this was not reconciliation. Not friendship. Not a ceremony of forgiveness.

Only two men seeing the edges of their own sentences.

A year later, the incident became a small exercise in the school's social-studies class.

The teacher gave the students four documents: Arun's first statement. Sadanand's first statement. Rani's first account. The final register of facts.

The students read them separately.

One student said: "The soldier was lying; he invented three warnings."

Another: "The farmer lied too; he hid the diesel."

A third: "The child was the most truthful."

Rani, now thirteen and in the same class, immediately said: "No."

Everyone looked at her.

"My first statement was not completely right either."

The teacher smiled. "Then who was most truthful?"

Rani said: "The document?"

The teacher held up the register of facts. "A human being made this too."

Rani thought. "Then... the things that agree everywhere?"

"The beginning."

"And the rest?"

"Questions."

One student was troubled. "Then the conclusion?"

Rani looked through the window toward the boundary stone.

"One shot was fired. Kaka was injured. The pipe was not a gun. The stone was in the wrong place. I could not hear all the calls. The soldier felt threatened. Kaka hid the diesel."

"Then the fault?"

Rani shrugged. "I am a child, not a judge."

Everyone laughed.

Rani did too.

This time she did not mind being called a child.

A new iron post was installed beside boundary stone 47. At night a solar lamp glowed on it. The red line was clear.

One evening Sadanand went to inspect his field. Arun was patrolling in the distance. Rani was returning home with the goats.

All three saw one another, but no one stopped.

The stone stood firm in its new position.

Yet when villagers told the story of the incident, they still pointed by turns toward the old place: "The shot was fired there."

The survey officer would say: "No, the actual border is here."

Sadanand would say: "The incident happened near the stone's old position."

Arun would say: "What I saw was according to the old stone."

Rani would say: "I was east of the drainage channel."

All four statements made the place different, though the earth was one.

A shifted stone can be reset. A shifted memory?

There is no single instrument with which to measure it.

Even so, some things were reset:

"I did not hear" should not be turned into "he did not speak."

"Standard procedure" should not be taken as "what actually happened."

"My field" should not be mistaken for "the border line."

"It felt like a threat" should not automatically become "there was a threat."

The sound of the shot lasted only a moment.

Its meaning went on for a very long time.

The Marriage Dispute

By nine o'clock at night, five different stories were already circulating outside the wedding hall in Bariyahi.

Some said the groom's side had demanded five lakh rupees.

Some said the bride herself had refused the marriage.

Some said the groom had yielded to his mother's wishes.

Some said the bride's friend had poisoned her mind.

And some said the matchmaker had ruined everything.

Inside, behind strings of flowers, Madhavi and Saurabh sat in two different rooms.

The wedding pavilion stood decorated.

The priest had opened his book of mantras.

Food was being served.

The groom's party was eating.

People from the bride's side were running about trying to stop the rumours outside.

People from the groom's side were saying, "Humiliation in front of so many people."

The marriage had not yet broken.

But neither had it begun.

There were two suspended hours in between, during which five different people were seeing five different causes.

Saurabh Jha did not think of the beginning of this marriage as an "arranged marriage."

He would say:

"I chose Madhavi."

Their first meeting had been at a small restaurant beside a bookshop in Darbhanga.

The matchmaker, Kaushalya Devi, had allowed the two families to leave them alone for an hour.

Saurabh was not a government engineer; he worked as a structural consultant for a private construction company.

Madhavi taught economics at Patna University.

In the first conversation Madhavi asked him directly:

"What does your family think about a wife continuing to work after marriage?"

Saurabh laughed.

"Why 'wife'? You already work. You should continue."

"Where?"

"Wherever it is possible."

"I do not want to leave Patna."

"My work takes me between Darbhanga and Patna."

Madhavi asked a second question:
 “Joint family?”
 Saurabh paused slightly.
 “My mother lives with me. My younger brother is away. Father died five years ago. I do not like the thought of Mother living alone.”
 Madhavi nodded.
 “I am not opposed to your mother. But I do not want marriage to mean that after my job, the entire responsibility of the house automatically becomes mine.”
 Saurabh had said:
 “That is fair.”
 The meeting went well that day.
 At the second meeting Saurabh said:
 “I don’t like very large weddings.”
 Madhavi laughed.
 “Neither do I.”
 “But Mother...”
 “In my house too.”
 They both laughed.
 Saurabh remembered that laughter.
 Then how had the wedding night acquired so many guests, three kinds of flowers, a horse, a band, a stage, and four hundred meal plates?
 “Family,” Saurabh had said to his friend Amit.
 Amit asked:
 “And you?”
 “Am I not part of the family?”
 “Part of it, yes. Part of the decisions?”
 Saurabh did not answer.
 That was his first silence.
 From the beginning of the marriage negotiations, Saurabh’s mother, Vidya Devi, kept saying:
 “We want nothing.”
 The sentence travelled from house to house.
 “We want nothing.”
 But on the day of the tilak, Vidya Devi said to Madhavi’s mother, Shailaja:
 “Please don’t give a car. The children will live in the city; keeping a car becomes a nuisance. If you wish to do something for your daughter of your own accord, put it toward arranging their home in Patna.”
 Shailaja laughed.
 “That would be for my daughter.”
 Vidya said:
 “Yes, for the daughter.”
 Saurabh was not in the room during that conversation.
 Later Kaushalya Devi told him:
 “They have refused all talk of a car and such things. The bride’s side only says they want to furnish the children’s home.”
 Saurabh asked:

“How much?”

“Does one ask for an account of such things?”

Saurabh let the matter go.

His second silence.

Three weeks later, two lakh fifty thousand rupees appeared in his bank account.

Sender: Shailaja Karn.

Message:

“Madhavi-Saurabh home furnishing.”

Saurabh immediately telephoned Kaushalya.

“Why this money?”

Kaushalya laughed.

“Oh, for the daughter. You did not ask for it.”

“But why in my account?”

“Perhaps they did not have Madhavi’s account details.”

“Should I return it?”

“If you do that now, it will look insulting. After the wedding, buy things in Madhavi’s name.”

Saurabh asked his mother.

Vidya said:

“I had refused the car. They want to do something for their own daughter. What insult is there in a gift given from one’s own heart?”

Saurabh said:

“Does Madhavi know?”

Vidya was silent.

“Mother?”

“Do parents ask a daughter about every gift they give her?”

Something tightened inside Saurabh.

He did not touch the money.

He did not return it either.

“I will talk to Madhavi after the wedding,” he thought.

His third silence.

Madhavi learned about the bank transfer on the day of the wedding.

And not from Saurabh.

From Rupa.

Rupa was her colleague and friend. They had taught together for five years, travelled to conferences together, and moved freely in and out of one another’s homes. During the wedding preparations Rupa had kept saying:

“Anything that is not clear now will turn into smoke later.”

Madhavi would say:

“Saurabh is a good man.”

Rupa would reply:

“A good man and a good marriage arrangement are two different things.”

Madhavi would become irritated:

“You see problems in everything.”

“A friend’s job is not only to count flowers.”

On the wedding evening, while looking for a phone cable in the dressing room, Rupa saw a payment slip fall out of Shailaja’s bag. She picked it up.

“Two lakh fifty thousand - Saurabh Jha?”

The kajal box stopped in Madhavi’s hand.

“What?”

Rupa handed her the slip.

Madhavi read it.

“Ma!”

Shailaja came inside.

“What happened?”

Madhavi held up the slip.

“What is this?”

For a moment Shailaja’s face changed, then returned to normal.

“For furnishing the house.”

“Whose house?”

“Yours.”

“Why was the money sent to Saurabh’s account?”

“He will buy the things.”

“Did anyone ask for it?”

Shailaja stopped.

“‘Asked’ is not the right word here.”

Rupa remained silent, but her face spoke.

Madhavi asked again:

“Did anyone say anything?”

“Vidya didi said no car, the children will live in Patna, whatever you do should be for their home.”

“Saurabh?”

“He did not ask for anything.”

“Then why send money to his account?”

Shailaja lowered her voice.

“Daughter, this is the time for the wedding. Over something like this—”

“When, then?”

“Later.”

A sound like laughter came from Madhavi’s mouth.

“Everything later.”

Rupa said softly:

“Ask Saurabh now.”

Shailaja immediately said:

“Not now.”

“Why?” Madhavi asked.

“The groom’s party is in the courtyard.”

“Then?”

“Let the wedding take place. The money is for you.”

Madhavi stood holding the receipt.

The problem was not merely the two lakh fifty thousand rupees.

Many small things from the previous two months came back to her at once.

Saurabh had said: "Living in Patna is possible."

Vidya Devi had said: "If the children stay in Darbhanga the first year, I will have support."

Kaushalya had said: "There is flexibility in these matters."

Madhavi's mother had said: "Let the wedding take place first; where you live can be decided afterwards."

Once Saurabh had said: "Mother would like me to be home at least four days a week."

Madhavi had asked: "Then Patna?"

Saurabh had laughed. "We'll see."

For the first time, that "we'll see" sounded frightening.

She said to Rupa:

"Call Saurabh."

Shailaja almost whispered:

"Madhavi, no drama."

Madhavi replied calmly:

"I want to stop the drama."

Vidya Devi's version was entirely different.

To her, the root of the wedding dispute was not Rupa, not money, not even Madhavi's job.

It was "the new generation's idea of marriage."

"Marriage builds a home; it is not a contract," she told her elder sister-in-law.

Vidya was fifty-six. After her husband died she had managed the house, the land, her younger son's education, and the beginning of Saurabh's career by herself. Saurabh spent half the month away. The younger son lived in Bengaluru.

She wanted her elder son's marriage to make the house feel like a house again.

She did not say that aloud.

She said:

"We want nothing."

Because if she said, "I want my daughter-in-law to live at home," people would call her old-fashioned.

"I want my son near me" sounded more acceptable.

But the two wishes were not separate.

After the first meeting, Saurabh had told her:

"Madhavi will not leave her job."

Vidya said:

"Who asked her to leave it?"

Saurabh was pleased.

Then Vidya added:

"But the house must run too."

"We will both run it."

Vidya laughed.

"You will come home from the office at eight and run the kitchen?"

"If needed."

Vidya thought: he will understand after the marriage.

That "after the marriage" was her silence.

One day Kaushalya said:

"Madhavi does not want to leave Patna."

Vidya replied:

"Let her stay in Darbhanga for the first year. There are daily vehicles for the job."

"Two hours."

"People do it."

Kaushalya said:

"I will explain it gently."

Later she told Vidya:

"Madhavi says two days a week in Darbhanga may be possible."

Vidya did not hear "two days." She heard "may be possible."

She made her own meaning: gradually, the whole household.

On the day of the tilak, Shailaja raised the question of a car.

Vidya truly did not want a car.

There was already one vehicle in the house.

And on some days Saurabh had a company vehicle.

She said:

"No car. The children will furnish their home."

Shailaja asked:

"Household things?"

"As they wish."

"In Patna?"

Vidya paused for a moment.

"Wherever they live."

That one sentence later acquired two meanings.

Shailaja understood: the Patna home was settled.

Vidya understood: Darbhanga or Patna would be decided later by the family.

When Saurabh asked about the money transfer, Vidya called it a gift.

To her it honestly did not feel like a "demand."

She remembered her own wedding. Her mother had given a wooden chest, bedding, brass utensils. No one had asked for a list, yet everything had been given.

"A daughter does not go empty-handed" was an ordinary sentence of her generation.

When she heard that Madhavi had stopped the wedding after seeing the payment slip, Vidya felt humiliated.

"Did I ask for money?" she asked Saurabh.

"Mother, right now this—"

"Did I refuse the car or not?"

"Yes."

"Did I say give cash?"

Saurabh was silent.

"Did I?"

"Not in those words."

“Then?”

“But you did say it should go toward the house.”

“For the daughter!”

“Madhavi does not know.”

“Parents give their daughter a gift - must the future daughter-in-law grant permission?”

Saurabh sat holding his head.

Vidya's hurt was not about the money.

She felt that before the wedding Madhavi had already put her in the dock as a “greedy mother-in-law.”

And outside, relatives were turning it into rumour:

“They demanded five lakhs.”

“Five?” Vidya said angrily. “I didn't even ask for the two and a half!”

The amount doubled in the rumour.

Prestige had now become part of the event.

Vidya said:

“If the girl distrusts us this much already, why marry at all?”

That sentence went outside as:

“The groom's mother has refused the marriage.”

The direction of the original statement changed again.

Rupa did not consider herself the person who had ruined the wedding.

But she admitted that she had told Madhavi to “open the matter up.”

Rupa's own experience was not neutral either.

Her elder sister had married five years earlier. Before the wedding everyone had said:

“She will continue her job.”

After the wedding the city changed.

Then a child.

Then the mother-in-law's illness.

Then “six months' leave.”

The job never returned.

Her sister would say:

“No one forced me. It was only that every decision came one by one in such a way that in the end there was no option left.”

Rupa was frightened by that sentence.

When Madhavi's marriage was fixed, her first question was:

“Is Saurabh's ‘yes’ the same as his family's ‘yes’?”

Madhavi laughed.

“Are you a pre-marriage auditor?”

“Yes.”

Rupa did not trust Kaushalya.

Kaushalya rounded every matter into “it will work out.”

One day Rupa herself met Saurabh at a small dinner for Madhavi's birthday.

She asked:

“Will Madhavi live in Patna?”

Saurabh said:

“We will arrange it.”

“What does that mean?”

“According to work.”

“Joint family?”

Saurabh became slightly uncomfortable.

“Mother is alone.”

Rupa drew a conclusion from that much: Saurabh was not clear.

Later she told Madhavi:

“Your question does not have a straight answer.”

Madhavi said:

“Not every question in life has a straight answer.”

Rupa fell silent.

She admitted that perhaps, in trying to protect her friend, she read every ambiguity as danger.

When she saw the payment slip on the wedding day, her first thought was:

“I was right.”

Later, that thought embarrassed her.

Because in a friend's crisis, “I was right” can be the ugliest satisfaction.

When Madhavi said she wanted Saurabh called, Rupa went at once.

On the way she met Amit, Saurabh's friend.

“What happened?”

Rupa said:

“Madhavi wants to speak to Saurabh.”

“Now?”

“Yes.”

“The groom's party?”

“Let them eat.”

Amit snapped:

“Did you say something?”

Rupa stopped.

“I saw the receipt.”

“What receipt?”

“The money.”

Amit's face changed.

“Oh.”

“You knew?”

Amit was silent.

“You knew?”

“Saurabh told me the money had come.”

Rupa's anger rose.

“Then why didn't Madhavi know?”

“He said after the wedding—”

Rupa laughed.

“Every man's favourite time: after the wedding.”

Amit was stung.
“Not everything is about men.”
“Whose account was it in here?”
“Saurabh never touched the money.”
“But he did not tell her either.”

Amit fell silent.

Rupa called Saurabh.

What happened afterwards she did not hear from outside. Madhavi and Saurabh spoke alone inside.

Yet another story formed outside:

“The bride’s friend scolded the groom.”

In truth, Rupa did not say a single word to Saurabh inside.

Rumour needs a character.

She became one.

Kaushalya Devi was fifty-five. For twenty years she had arranged marriages.

In her own language she said:

“I do not make relationships. I translate the language of families.”

The problem was that in translation, she changed meanings.

She considered that her art.

Vidya said:

“Let the daughter-in-law work, but the household comes first.”

Kaushalya told Madhavi’s family:

“They have no objection to her job.”

The two sentences were not entirely contradictory.

But neither were they the same.

Madhavi said:

“I want to live in Patna after marriage.”

Kaushalya told Vidya:

“Because of her job she will stay in Patna a few days a week.”

“I want to live” became “will stay a few days.”

Saurabh said:

“A separate home is possible, once Mother becomes comfortable.”

Kaushalya told Shailaja:

“They are looking at a house in Patna.”

Possibility became action.

Shailaja said:

“I will furnish my daughter’s home.”

Kaushalya told Vidya:

“The bride’s side wants to arrange the household themselves.”

Vidya said:

“No car. Put it toward the house.”

Kaushalya told Shailaja:

“No car at all; whatever you wish, do it for the children’s home.”

Wish became permission, permission became expectation.

Was there deception in all these changes?

Kaushalya said no.

"If every raw sentence were repeated exactly, would any marriage take place?" she would tell her sister. "Families speak harshly at the beginning and soften later."

In her experience there had been many marriages in which families that first said "no job" later educated the daughter-in-law.

Sons who first said "no separate home" later settled in the city.

Families that whispered "we want a car" finally took nothing.

Kaushalya did not think of herself as a liar. She thought of herself as the guardian of possibility.

But in this marriage all her softening accumulated in one place.

When the dispute arose on the wedding day, Shailaja caught hold of her and said:

"You told me the money was for my daughter."

Vidya said:

"You told me the bride's family wanted to do it of their own accord."

Madhavi said:

"You told me living in Patna was settled."

Saurabh said:

"You told me Madhavi might stay in Darbhanga two days a week."

Kaushalya looked around at all four.

Every sentence was hers.

Every sentence incomplete.

For the first time she understood that language can postpone conflict, but it cannot erase it.

It only changes the date.

Madhavi and Saurabh sat facing each other in the small office room upstairs in the wedding hall.

The music below had been stopped.

Not completely - the drummer was somewhere away drinking tea.

Madhavi placed the payment receipt on the table.

"Did you know?"

Saurabh could have lied.

"No."

He did not.

"Yes."

Madhavi's face stayed still.

"Since when?"

"Three weeks."

"Why didn't you tell me?"

"I thought we would talk after the wedding."

"Why?"

"Because I haven't spent the money. I was thinking of returning it."

"Then why didn't you?"

Saurabh took a long breath.

"Mother said it would be insulting."

"So you protected yourself from Mother's discomfort and kept me in the dark."

"Not like that."

"Then how?"

Saurabh was silent.

Madhavi said:

"More than the money, this silence is the problem for me."

"I didn't ask for it."

"I am not saying you asked for it."

"Outside everyone is saying that."

"I am not outside."

That sentence calmed Saurabh slightly.

Madhavi continued:

"What is the truth about the Patna house?"

"I looked at houses."

"Where?"

"Two places."

"Does your mother know?"

"Yes... partly."

"Partly?"

"She thinks it will only be for a few days a week."

Madhavi laughed.

"Will my life also be partial?"

"Don't be sarcastic."

"I want an answer."

"Mother is alone."

"I have known that from the first day."

"Then?"

"Then we will make a plan. Clearly."

"Life is not a timetable."

"I am not asking for a timetable. I want to know: after marriage, will we live in Patna or Darbhanga?"

Saurabh held his head.

"Both."

"How?"

"Monday-Tuesday Patna, Wednesday evening Darbhanga..."

Even as he spoke, he heard how temporary it sounded.

Madhavi asked:

"And if we have a child?"

Saurabh was startled.

"Not now—"

"Exactly. Everything is 'not now.' The job later. The house later. The money later. Children later. And the wedding now."

Saurabh's voice sharpened.

"What do you want? Should we stop the wedding right now?"

Madhavi took time to answer.

"I want to enter the marriage knowing these things, not assuming they will somehow become all right afterwards."

"Who can give you certainty about life?"

"Not certainty. Honest uncertainty."

Saurabh was silent.

Madhavi placed a finger on the receipt.

"This money will be returned."

"Yes."

"Today."

"There is a digital transfer limit for the full amount at once."

"Digitally?"

Saurabh took out his phone.

The daily return limit was too low. The whole amount could not go back.

He said:

"There is a per-day limit."

Madhavi looked at him in disbelief.

"Look at this - the money here, the wedding there, the transaction stuck in between."

Both of them burst out laughing.

The first laughter in the tension.

But the laughter did not solve the problem.

Saurabh said:

"I will return it in two transfers."

"Fine."

"Then the wedding?"

Madhavi was silent.

"Madhavi?"

"One more thing."

"What?"

"Can you tell your mother that I will not leave my job, and that living in Patna is necessary?"

Saurabh wanted to say yes immediately.

His mouth opened.

Then stopped.

Madhavi saw the stopping.

"That's it."

"What is?"

"That pause."

Anger rose inside Saurabh.

"Mother is my responsibility."

"Have I told you to abandon her?"

"That is what it means."

"No."

"Separate house, Patna, job - where is Mother?"

"You are asking what responsibility I am prepared to take after marriage. Have you yourself decided how you will divide your responsibility?"

Saurabh lowered his voice.

“You want me to live away from Mother.”

“I want you to make that decision in your own words - not through Kaushalya Kaki, your mother, my mother, all of them in between.”

Saurabh rose from the chair and went to the window.

Below, wedding guests were eating sweets from leaf plates.

A child was pulling flowers off the stage.

He said:

“I cannot leave Mother and live full-time in Patna.”

Madhavi's face changed.

“Fine.”

“Fine?”

“That is the answer I needed.”

“Then?”

“I cannot live full-time in Darbhanga.”

Saurabh turned.

For the first time they could see the incompatibility clearly.

Not blame.

Difference.

For three months that difference had been covered in soft words.

Below, Vidya, Shailaja, Kaushalya, Rupa, and Amit were all waiting.

Half an hour later Saurabh came out.

“I need to speak to Mother.”

Vidya said:

“Now?”

“Yes.”

Madhavi went separately to speak to Shailaja.

Saurabh took his mother to one side.

“Mother, I cannot live full-time in Patna.”

Vidya released a breath of relief.

“I've been saying that.”

“But Madhavi cannot live full-time in Darbhanga.”

“After marriage—”

“No. That is exactly the mistake.”

Vidya fell silent.

“I should have made it clear before.”

“Then will you abandon the marriage?”

Saurabh looked exhausted.

“I don't know.”

Vidya's eyes filled.

“So many people, society...”

For the first time Saurabh spoke harshly:

“Will ‘people’ live the marriage, or will we?”

Vidya stepped back as if hurt.

"Am I not your people?"

Saurabh regretted it at once.

"Mother, not that."

"Then?"

That was the difficulty.

The word "family" contains everyone, but it does not say how much weight each person's wish will carry.

Vidya said:

"Madhavi does not want to live with me?"

"She does not want to leave her work in order to do so."

"Who asked her to leave it?"

"Daily travel between Darbhanga and Patna is not practical."

"People do it."

"For how many days?"

"For as long as necessary."

"Mother."

Vidya fell silent.

Saurabh said:

"You want your daughter-in-law to live in this house."

For the first time Vidya said it directly:

"Yes."

The moment the words came out, they felt to her like an admission of guilt.

Saurabh remained calm.

"Fine. It should have been said."

"Is that a crime?"

"No. But Madhavi should have known."

"You could have told her."

Saurabh had no answer.

In the other room Madhavi told her mother Shailaja:

"The money will be returned."

Shailaja said:

"Fine."

Her voice was hurt.

"Ma, I am not blaming you."

"Not blaming me? This entire wedding hall is paid for by us - relatives, honour - and now the wedding is stopped."

"Should I marry because of that?"

"Am I saying that?"

"You are saying so much has been spent."

Shailaja began to cry.

"Is it a crime for parents to spend on their daughter?"

Madhavi immediately took her hand.

"No."

"I gave the money for my daughter."

"But without telling me."

"If I had told you, you would have refused."

Madhavi stopped.

"Then you knew I did not want it."

Shailaja was silent.

That was her silence.

"I thought there are many things in a marriage that parents do not ask the child about," Shailaja said.

"Am I a child?"

Shailaja wiped her eyes.

"For a mother."

"Old enough to marry, but a child when money is sent?"

The sentence hurt Shailaja.

She said:

"You have become too educated."

For the first time Madhavi became angry.

"Do not say that."

Both were silent.

Rupa stood outside the door. She did not enter.

After a while Shailaja said quietly:

"I was afraid the groom's side would say nothing was given."

"Did anyone say that?"

"Kaushalya said Vidya didi is very simple, but society watches."

"Society?"

"Relatives."

"So the money in Saurabh's account was for society?"

Shailaja was tired.

"Daughter, there was not one cause. Some of it was for your home. Some for honour. Some from fear."

Madhavi became calm.

That was probably the most accurate sentence of the whole night.

At half past ten, the two families held a small meeting.

People outside were told:

"The bride is not feeling well."

Rupa heard this lie and said:

"Somehow it is always the woman's health that fails."

Amit said:

"Should we announce the truth right now?"

"No. Just a comment."

At the meeting were Madhavi, Saurabh, Vidya, Shailaja, Madhavi's father Subhash, Saurabh's maternal uncle, and Kaushalya.

Rupa and Amit remained outside.

For the first time Subhash heard the full story of the money transfer.

He looked at Shailaja.

"Why didn't you tell me?"

Shailaja said:

"You get tense about every expense. It was my savings."

Madhavi was startled.

"Your own savings?"

"Yes."

"Babuji didn't know?"

"No."

Now the money was no longer simply the story of "a demand from the groom's side."

Shailaja's private savings.

Her daughter's home.

Prestige.

Fear.

Vidya's suggestion.

Kaushalya's softened translation.

Saurabh's silence.

Subhash sat holding his head.

"This wedding has travelled a long distance without me."

Kaushalya began:

"If you want to blame me—"

Madhavi stopped her.

"Do not make a list of blame."

Vidya said:

"But the decision?"

Saurabh looked at Madhavi.

"I think the wedding should not happen today."

The room seemed to stop breathing.

Shailaja:

"What?"

Vidya's face hardened.

Subhash:

"Postpone it?"

Madhavi said:

"Yes. Not today."

Saurabh looked at her.

"Postponed - or ended?"

Madhavi had not expected the question.

"I don't know yet."

Vidya stood up.

"My son is supposed to wait around here?"

Saurabh said:

"Mother."

"No. Is marriage a game?"

Madhavi said directly:

"Exactly for that reason, there should be no final decision tonight. All of us are under pressure."

Saurabh's maternal uncle said:

"After a wedding is postponed like this in society, it is difficult for it to happen later."

Rupa, outside, heard him and clenched her mouth.

Madhavi replied:

"Then let it be difficult."

Subhash looked at his daughter.

Fear and pride were mixed on his face.

For the first time Kaushalya spoke very softly:

"Shall we take one month?"

Vidya laughed bitterly.

"You are still trying to fix another date."

Kaushalya fell silent.

At eleven o'clock the announcement was made:

"Due to unavoidable family circumstances, the marriage will not be solemnised today."

That was all.

"Unavoidable family circumstances."

Five words.

Five months of ambiguity inside them.

The groom's party left.

Relatives from the bride's side were half sympathetic, half curious.

Food remained.

The flowers were fresh.

The wedding pavilion stood empty.

Rupa helped Madhavi remove her jewellery.

"Did you do the right thing?" Rupa asked, then immediately said:

"No. Not that question now."

Madhavi gave a tired laugh.

"I don't know either."

"Are you afraid?"

"Very."

"Saurabh?"

"He is not a bad man."

"I know."

"His mother is not bad."

"I know."

"Then?"

Rupa said:

"Perhaps the problem is simply that even good people can build the wrong arrangement for one another."

Madhavi looked at her.

“Perhaps.”

Rupa added:

“But if I had not shown you the receipt?”

Madhavi was silent.

There was no answer to that question.

Perhaps the wedding would have taken place.

Perhaps the dispute would have come later.

Perhaps everything would have worked.

Perhaps it would have become worse.

One receipt can alter an event. That does not prove the whole event happened because of the receipt.

When Saurabh returned home, Vidya did not speak to him for two days.

On the third day she asked:

“Was the money returned?”

“Half on the first night. The rest yesterday.”

“Fine.”

“Mother...”

“What?”

“Why do you think the wedding stopped?”

Vidya answered immediately:

“The girl’s mistrust.”

Saurabh gave a sad smile.

“Only that?”

Vidya became annoyed.

“What do you think?”

“Our collective lack of clarity.”

“Big words.”

“Fine. We did not make things clear.”

Vidya was silent.

Saurabh said:

“You want your daughter-in-law to live in the house.”

“Yes.”

“I wanted Madhavi to agree to that.”

“Is that desire wrong?”

“No. But I did not tell her.”

Vidya looked out the window.

“I was afraid too,” she suddenly said.

“Of what?”

“That you would move away.”

Saurabh’s throat tightened.

“Mother.”

“Your father died. Your younger brother is far away. You are here. After marriage, if your wife lives in Patna, you will go to Patna. Then?”

Saurabh sat beside her.

“Why didn’t you say this before?”

Vidya laughed.

“A mother tells her son: don’t leave me alone? Shall I become a burden?”

Saurabh took her hand.

“I thought this silence was dignity.”

Vidya wiped her eyes.

“Perhaps.”

Both were silent.

Some silences preserve dignity.

Some silences break relationships.

The difference becomes clear only with time.

One week later Kaushalya came to Madhavi’s house.

Shailaja did not want to meet her.

Madhavi made her sit.

Kaushalya looked tired.

“I have come to apologise.”

Madhavi was surprised.

“For what?”

“I changed the words.”

“Deliberately?”

“Yes and no.”

“What kind of answer is that?”

“Vidya said: the daughter-in-law should put the home first. I said: there is no objection to the job. Both are true. But I did not state the tension between them.”

“Why?”

“The marriage might have broken.”

“So did you save a marriage, or merely postpone a dispute?”

Kaushalya lowered her head.

“Now it seems the second.”

Madhavi said nothing.

Kaushalya continued:

“But let me say one thing. Not every marriage can be so clear beforehand.”

“I agree.”

“People change.”

“I agree.”

“Then?”

“Hiding uncertainty and acknowledging uncertainty are different.”

Kaushalya listened carefully.

“May I write that sentence down?”

Madhavi laughed.

“To use again in matchmaking?”

“Possibly.”

Both laughed.

Kaushalya took a small red register out of her pocket. She kept her marriage notes in it.

Beside Madhavi's name was written:

"Lecturer, Patna; job to continue."

Saurabh:

"Consultant; lives with mother."

Below that:

"Both agree."

Kaushalya crossed out the word "agree."

She wrote:

"Agreement on some points; residence/family role still to be clarified."

Madhavi said:

"If you had written this before?"

Kaushalya closed the register.

"Perhaps that night would not have happened."

"Perhaps the marriage would never have been fixed."

"That too."

There was both regret and relief inside that "too."

For one month Madhavi and Saurabh did not speak.

Rumour lived a life of its own.

"Dowry demand."

"The bride is too modern."

"The mother-in-law is rigid."

"The friend is a women's-rights activist."

"The groom is weak."

"The matchmaker is a liar."

Each sentence was convenient to someone.

Saurabh buried himself in work.

Madhavi in college.

One day Rupa asked:

"Do you miss Saurabh?"

Madhavi became irritated.

"Why this adolescent question?"

"Answer?"

Madhavi was silent.

"Yes."

"Then?"

"Missing someone is not enough reason to marry."

Elsewhere Amit asked Saurabh:

"Will you call Madhavi?"

"I want to."

"Call her."

"What will I say?"

"The truth."

“Which truth?”

Amit laughed.

“That is the problem.”

In the sixth week a letter came to Madhavi.

From Saurabh.

Across the top he had written: “Not an explanation.”

The letter was short:

“I am not writing to prove myself innocent. I now understand that I made very few decisions; I only kept postponing them. I cannot abandon my mother - that is still true. I do not expect you to leave your job - that too is true. I still do not know the arrangement that can hold those two truths together. If you wish to speak knowing only this much, I will speak. If not, no reply to this letter is necessary.”

Madhavi read the letter three times.

She did not reply that night.

Three days later she wrote:

“I too can see my own side more clearly now. I was not angry only because I saw money; I was afraid that decisions were being made without me. I too had left some uncomfortable questions for ‘later’ because the relationship felt good. We can talk. Not in order to fix the marriage, but in order to understand.”

Two weeks later they met in Patna.

No Kaushalya.

No mothers.

No Rupa.

No Amit.

An ordinary restaurant.

Saurabh said:

“Mother will not leave Darbhanga.”

Madhavi said:

“I will not leave my job in Patna.”

“Divide the week?”

“For some time, perhaps. For life?”

“I don’t know.”

“Fine.”

“Separate home?”

“Live in Patna, go regularly to Darbhanga.”

“Mother?”

“Try to bring her to Patna?”

“She will not agree.”

Both laughed.

Earlier, these were obstacles.

Now, they were facts.

Saurabh said:

“Shall we marry?”

Madhavi drank some water.

"I do not know yet."

Saurabh nodded.

"Neither do I."

Earlier, that answer would have sounded like failure.

Now, it sounded honest.

They parted.

Three months later the decision was made: there would be no marriage.

No quarrel.

No new demand.

No hero.

Madhavi received a two-year research opportunity from the university and would go to Delhi.

Saurabh's company took on a new project around Darbhanga; leaving Vidya and relocating became even harder.

After talking, they understood that there was affection in the relationship, but the life-structure each wanted was different.

Saurabh said:

"If the wedding had happened that night?"

Madhavi took a long breath.

"Perhaps we would have managed."

"Is managing a good thing?"

"Sometimes. Sometimes not."

"I feel guilty."

"So do I."

"For what?"

"For the questions I should have asked earlier and did not."

Saurabh laughed.

"You asked plenty."

"Asking the right question once is not enough. If the answer is vague, one has to ask again."

"I should have answered."

This time they both laughed without bitterness.

Kaushalya made the final entry in her red register.

"Madhavi Karn - Saurabh Jha.

Marriage not solemnised.

Reason—"

Her pen stopped.

At first she wanted to write:

"Dispute over money."

Then crossed it out.

"Disagreement over residence."

Crossed that out too.

"Family pressure."
Crossed that out.
"Mutual decision."
That too was only half.
At last she wrote:
"No single cause."
Below it, five small words:
"money / place / family / silence / desire."
She closed the register.
Rupa's name did not appear in that entry.
Nor Vidya's fear.
Nor Shailaja's savings.
Nor Saurabh's postponement.
Nor Madhavi's suspicion.
No register can contain an entire marriage.

One year later Rupa herself was going to marry.
She invited Madhavi.
Madhavi laughed:
"Asked all the questions?"
Rupa said:
"Fifteen pages."
"Poor groom."
"He asked twelve pages too."
"Then it is equal."
Suddenly Rupa became serious.
"About your wedding night... sometimes I think I should not have shown you the receipt."
Madhavi was silent for a few moments.
"Why?"
"Perhaps everything would have worked out."
"Perhaps."
"Do you regret it?"
Madhavi looked out the window.
"Saurabh was a good man. He still is. That is why sometimes it hurts."
"Then?"
"Pain is not proof that a decision was wrong."
Rupa nodded slowly.
"And the receipt?"
Madhavi smiled.
"The receipt only opened the door. The room inside was already full."
Rupa remembered that sentence.

Two years later Saurabh married.

This time Kaushalya was not the matchmaker.

Saurabh himself spoke to Neelima, a woman from a family he knew.

At the first meeting he said:

“Mother lives with me. I cannot leave Darbhanga and live elsewhere full-time.”

Vidya was listening from outside.

Neelima said:

“My work is in Madhubani. Daily travel is possible.”

Saurabh said:

“We will divide the household responsibilities. Mother will have expectations - I am saying that beforehand too.”

From inside Vidya bristled: “Why announce me?”

But she remained silent.

Later Saurabh said:

“Mother, if you wish, say it yourself.”

Vidya told Neelima:

“I want people to live in the house. But how much, in what way - I am still learning.”

Neelima laughed.

“So am I.”

That marriage took place.

Did the dispute over Madhavi's marriage become a “lesson” for this marriage?

In some part.

But that did not turn the earlier relationship into merely a failed story.

Saurabh never called Madhavi “the wrong girl.”

Gradually Vidya too came to say only:

“She was very different.”

Shailaja kept the payment receipt separately with her papers - she neither tore it up nor displayed it.

At her own wedding Rupa sent the gift list to both bride and groom beforehand.

Kaushalya created a new rule for her matchmaking:

“Where ‘we’ll see later’ appears three times, hold another meeting.”

People laughed.

But she counted.

For the owner of the Bariyahi wedding hall, that night was an entirely different memory.

He would say:

“Four hundred plates were prepared, two hundred and eighty were eaten, the rest of the food was distributed. The flower man took full payment. The band returned half.”

History can sometimes be that practical.

The night that left years of meaning inside five families appeared in the hall owner's register only as:

“Wedding postponed. Food distributed.”

Once Kaushalya saw the register and laughed.

“That is also one truth.”

The owner asked:

“And the others?”

Kaushalya said:

“There are many.”

She went outside.

Preparations were under way for a new wedding on the veranda.

Flowers were being tied again.

Chairs arranged again.

A pavilion built again.

Someone asked:

“Kaki, that wedding that broke here last time - what was the real reason?”

Earlier, Kaushalya would have made one clean answer:

“A money dispute.”

“The girl's job.”

“The mother-in-law.”

“A misunderstanding.”

This time she said:

“There was no single reason.”

The questioner looked disappointed.

“Then what is the story?”

Straightening a string of flowers, Kaushalya said:

“That is the story - everyone wanted there to be one reason.”

She moved on.

The Flood Boat

When the Kamala Balan broke through the eastern embankment at Belahi and entered the village, people first climbed onto the high platforms inside their houses, then onto the roofs, and by the third day began waiting for boats. Flood was nothing new to this village, but this time the water rose so quickly that people who at dawn had been thinking of untying the cattle from the cowshed and sending them to safer ground could not get beyond their own verandas by afternoon. The school building, the panchayat house, and the raised mound of an old brick kiln were declared relief points. The block administration assigned the evacuation of the lower hamlet to a private boat-contractor group.

On paper, the contract provided for two motorboats. At the landing, only one was operating. Its name had been painted on the side: "Mukti." No one would have paid attention to the name if, on the evening of the fourth day, the boat had not capsized. The place where it overturned lay about half a kos east of the village's old mango grove, in land that was ordinarily fields. This time it was a broad expanse of yellow-brown water. Beneath the water, field ridges, bamboo fences, the masonry rim of a well, small culverts - all had vanished. Only treetops, electricity poles, and, here and there, corners of thatched roofs still gave a sense of direction.

When the boat overturned, an elderly woman, Saraswati Devi, did not survive. The others were pulled out by nearby dinghies and relief workers. Ten-year-old Tara Paswan was the youngest passenger to survive fully conscious. From the next day there was only one question: why had the boat overturned?

Answers came from four directions. The boatman, Jaglal Sahni, said too many people had been put aboard for the boat's safe capacity, and that the contractor had pressured him to take everyone across in a single trip. Passenger Nirmala Jha said Jaglal had suddenly cut the boat around in the middle of a strong current, and that was when it lost balance. Contractor Ramanand Yadav said the boat was sound; the passengers had shifted to one side and the boatman had left the prescribed route. Tara said, "I stood up, and because of me everyone stood up." There was some truth in all four accounts, something incomplete, something born of fear, something in self-defence. And when the boat was pulled from the mud five days later after the water receded, it took no one's side.

Jaglal Sahni had been reading water for forty years. His father rowed dinghies; his grandfather rescued people during floods. In Jaglal's childhood there had been no map to guide him: trees, current, wind, and colour gave direction. From a slight swelling on the surface he could tell that a field ridge lay below. From the drift of foam he could judge which way to steer if the boat was to stay safe. But "Mukti" was not his own boat. It belonged to contractor Ramanand Yadav - an old diesel motor, a broad belly, planks along both sides. Its registered capacity in calm water was eighteen people, but the district instruction for swift flood currents was no more than twelve passengers.

On the first day Ramanand had said, "That is government caution. The boat is registered for eighteen." Jaglal had replied, "That registration is for still water." Ramanand laughed. "If we take only twelve at a time in a flood, it will take seven days. Calls keep coming from above." During the first three days Jaglal had taken fourteen or fifteen people several times, and everyone had reached safely. Reaching safely can make a bad decision look right - until the next bad decision.

On the day of the accident there had been six trips since morning. Jaglal's eyes were red, his palms blistered, his stomach holding only flattened rice and jaggery. The second boat existed on paper, not on the water. He had asked Ramanand, "Where is the other boat?" Ramanand said, "At the upper landing." Jaglal had heard its motor was broken. Ramanand replied, "You run your own boat." Before evening a block employee arrived with a list: "Twenty-seven people are still left in this hamlet. The water will rise further tonight." Jaglal said, "Twelve per trip." The employee looked at his watch. "Two trips." Jaglal said, "It will be dark." Ramanand called from the bank, "Take as many as can sit. Children don't take separate space."

Before the final trip began, sixteen passengers boarded "Mukti" - eight adults, three elderly people, four children, and one adolescent. The boatman made seventeen. There were also two sacks of dry grain, a small medicine chest, and four bundles of clothes. Jaglal wanted the grain sacks taken off. Nirmala Jha said, "On the next trip will the people go, or the sacks? There is little food at the relief camp." Ramanand said, "Two sacks won't sink the boat." Jaglal answered angrily, "A boat does not sink by counting sacks. It sinks from everything added together."

Saraswati Devi wanted to get down. "Let me off. Let the children go." Tara caught her arm. "No." Nirmala said, "Kaki, we will all go. No one knows when the boat will come again." Later Nirmala would hear that sentence inside herself many times. At that moment it had been only compassion.

Jaglal arranged where everyone should sit. Heavier people in the middle, children low, bundles on the floor. "Do not stand up under any circumstances. Whatever falls into the water, let it fall." Tara sat beside her grandmother. In her shoulder bag were two books, a notebook, her mother's photograph, and a red tin containing her grandmother's medicine. Nirmala sat toward the front on the left, holding the orange medicine chest from the primary health centre.

The boat moved off. The first ten minutes were ordinary. Far away, blue tents were visible on the relief mound. Then a thin gleam of water appeared across the bottom of the boat. A teenage boy said, "Water." Jaglal pointed to a cut-off plastic container. "Bail it out." Nirmala asked, "Is this much water normal?" Jaglal said, "It happens in old boats." He was not lying, but neither was he telling the whole truth. Three days earlier, the joint along the right side of the bottom had been temporarily patched with bitumen and cloth; Jaglal had asked for the plank to be replaced, and Ramanand had said, "It will last four days." Ten minutes later water had collected again. Nirmala said, "Keep near the bank." Jaglal answered, "Which bank? Everything is water." Then the submerged crowns of the mango grove appeared ahead. Jaglal steered slightly south, because going straight would have meant cutting across the main current from the breached embankment. Ramanand had told him to take the shorter route, but Jaglal saw that the colour of the water had changed. The water had risen since the previous trip. Behind the mango grove, the broken

raised edge of an old paved road was creating a lateral current beneath the surface. From the sound of the motor Jaglal realised that the stern was being pulled sideways.

"Everyone sit low!" he shouted. More water had collected along the right side of the bottom. Nirmala thought the weight should be shifted to the left. "Children, move closer to the left," she said. At the same instant Jaglal shouted, "Nobody move!" Two instructions collided. Some children shifted, some froze, adults reached to hold them. The boat leaned slightly to the left.

Then, ahead in the water, a thick mass of bamboo uprooted by the flood came spinning toward them. Jaglal had two choices - strike it head-on or cut sharply to avoid it. He pulled the right oar hard. The bow swung, the lateral current struck the left side of the hull, the water pooled in the bottom rushed at once from right to left, and people reached whichever way they could to steady themselves. Later everyone would remember that instant differently. Nirmala remembered Jaglal turning the boat without warning. Jaglal remembered Nirmala making the children move. Ramanand later heard that the passengers had stood up. Tara remembered that she had stood to save her bag. In fact, all four things happened within half-seconds of one another.

In Tara's memory, the clearest thing just before the boat overturned was the orange medicine chest. It had been beside Nirmala Didi. When the boat leaned, it slid across the floor. For one instant Tara thought her grandmother's medicine was falling away. She let go of her bag and reached out. Her grandmother caught her arm. "Sit." Tara rose halfway. At that same moment the boat turned sharply. Tara slipped and fell against her grandmother, and two people in front reached out to save them. The orange chest tipped over. Tara remembered that "everyone looked toward me." That was why she later said, "Because of me everyone stood up." But not everyone had stood. One person rose halfway, another reached out, another caught a child. A child's memory can turn a scene into a cause.

The boat first leaned left, then seemed to right itself, and then rolled over to one side. Water filled Tara's ears. When she surfaced, she saw the boat's black overturned belly. Nirmala was pushing a child toward the boat's rope. Jaglal was diving into the water. Tara searched for her grandmother. Someone shouted, "Hold the boat!" Tara caught the rope, then let go and tried to swim toward her grandmother. Nirmala seized the back of her shirt. Two dinghies were approaching from a distance. In Tara's memory, her grandmother's red anchal appeared once on the water - whether it was really hers or someone else's cloth, Tara never knew.

At dawn Saraswati Devi was found near the roots of the mango grove. Tara kept saying only one thing: "I stood up." Her mother said, "It was not because of you." Tara repeated, "I stood up." Sometimes a child takes blame into her own hands because her own blame feels smaller and more understandable than the blame of the whole world.

Ramanand Yadav did not like the word "contractor." He said, "I provide transport services." His organisation, "Mithila Disaster Boat Service Group," had three boats - one owned and two hired. For five days, the block had contracted two motorboats, two boatmen, twenty-four life jackets, rope, lighting, and fuel. The second boat, "Jaymala," developed engine trouble on the evening of the first day.

Ramanand had two choices: immediately hire another boat, which would be expensive, or carry on with “Mukti.” He chose the second.

No written notice was sent to the block. In the daily certificates, both boats were marked “operational” on all five days. Ramanand later said, “The second boat was kept in the Bhatni area.” People in Bhatni said it was not. A repair slip showed that “Jaymala” had been with a motor mechanic from the evening of Day 2 until the morning of Day 5. Then how were two boats operational on Days 3 and 4? Ramanand said, “A hired boat was brought in for some time.” The owner’s name was unclear, payment was said to have been in cash, and there was no witness. The inquiry team wrote: “Continuous availability of the second boat is not established.”

On paper there were twenty-four life jackets. Six were on “Mukti.” Twelve were on the disabled “Jaymala.” Six were locked in the block warehouse. “Why in the warehouse?” an officer asked. An employee said, “No distribution order.” Waiting for an order in the middle of a flood - no one had an answer. Tara and Saraswati Devi had no life jackets. If Saraswati had been wearing one, would she have survived? No one could say with certainty. After a death, the word “possibly” becomes very heavy.

In his first statement Ramanand said, “The boat’s registered capacity was eighteen; there were sixteen passengers. It was not overloaded.” During the inquiry, a line was found below the registration entry: “Calm-water transport; for flood/strong current, according to local instructions.” The local instruction was twelve. Ramanand said, “I never received it in writing.” His signature appeared on the receipt register at the block warehouse. He said, “I sign many papers.” Truth and negligence can sometimes live in the same sentence. Nirmala Jha’s statement was taken two days later. She began: “The boatman suddenly turned the boat.” She was asked, “Why?” She said, “There was a clump of bamboo ahead, probably to avoid it.” She was asked, “Did the passengers move?” Nirmala was silent. “Did you say anything?” She heard her own voice clearly in memory: “Children, move to the left.” She admitted it. “And the boatman?” - “Nobody move.” “Who spoke first?” - “Almost at the same time.”

Nirmala said, “I thought water was collecting on the right side of the bottom, so shifting weight left would restore balance.” The officer asked, “Do you know how to operate a boat?” “No.” The answer was difficult. During the flood people had kept looking to her as someone who made decisions - who should go on the boat first, who should receive medicine, who was missing. A boat was not her sphere of decision, but in a crisis a person does not instantly abandon the language of an old role and become an expert in a new one. The teacher gave an instruction; the boatman gave an instruction; the two instructions collided.

On the subject of the two grain sacks, Nirmala admitted, “Jaglal wanted them taken off; I objected.” “Then were the sacks the cause?” Irritated, she said, “One sack does not overturn a boat. Everything together...” She stopped. That was the problem. Sacks, too many passengers, a leaking joint, strong current, a mass of bamboo, a sudden turn, passengers shifting, too few life jackets, the absence of the second boat, pressure from the approaching evening. Finding one cause was easy; seeing ten causes together was difficult. She added to her statement: “I do not want to say that the boatman alone was at fault.”

The first time anyone tried to take Tara's statement, her mother stopped it. The second time she spoke with a woman from a child-support service. Tara's first sentence was: "I stood up." "Why?" - "The box." "Which one?" Tara said, "Grandmother's medicine." Her mother said gently, "Grandmother's medicine was in your bag; the orange box belonged to Nirmala Didi." Tara stared. The first knot in memory loosened.

The woman asked, "Before you stood up, was the boat straight?" Tara said, "A little tilted." "Water inside?" - "Yes." "The boatman?" - "Sit." "Nirmala Didi?" - "Move left." "When did the boat tilt badly?" Tara shaped the boat with her hands. "First like this, then it turned, then like this." "Why did it turn?" - "The bamboo." "Did the bamboo hit?" - "No, it passed close by." Tara said again, "But I stood up." The woman stopped the conversation. Tara's mother asked, "Why?" She replied, "Because the child is not speaking facts now. She is speaking blame."

Five days later, after the water fell, "Mukti" was hauled into the raised courtyard of the school. The district engineer, a local carpenter, police, Jaglal, and Ramanand were all present. The bitumen patch along the right side of the bottom had peeled away. Cloth had been stuffed inside. The repairman was called. He said, "I said it was a temporary repair." "For a strong current?" The repairman fell silent. "I do not know how to run a boat." The engineer's note said: "The leak alone is not a sufficient cause of capsizing, but moving water inside the hull may destabilise load distribution."

Then came the load assessment. Registered capacity: eighteen in calm water; disaster instruction: twelve. At the time of the accident: sixteen passengers, the boatman, and baggage. The engineer said, "By the flood instruction, this was an overload. The baggage would have reduced the boat's freeboard above the waterline." There was no fresh mark on the bow from striking bamboo. This strengthened Jaglal's claim that he had turned to avoid collision. But the site inspection showed a strong lateral current south of the mango grove; turning an overloaded boat sharply at that angle was risky.

Ramanand immediately said, "The prescribed route was north. Why did Jaglal go south?" Jaglal answered, "The north was in the pull of the breached embankment." "On the earlier trip?" - "The water was lower." Ramanand said, "And the instruction?" Jaglal answered quietly, "Water does not obey instructions."

The irregularity involving the second boat became clear in the block file. Daily certificates had been signed on the basis of telephone information. There had been no site verification. Six extra life jackets sat in the warehouse. One sentence from officials kept returning: "It was an emergency." Emergencies loosen rules, but emergencies also make rules more necessary - the engineer drafting the report wrote that in a handwritten note, but it did not enter the final official language.

Tara, now staying at her aunt's house, dreamed at night of the orange box floating on water, her grandmother saying "sit," herself standing, the boat overturning. One day Nirmala brought her a new blue shoulder bag. Tara asked, "Grandmother's photograph?" Nirmala lowered her head. "It wasn't found." Instead of taking the bag, Tara said, "I stood up." Nirmala replied, "Yes, but the boat was already leaning. There was water inside. The boat turned. People moved." Tara asked,

"Then how many things overturn a boat?" Nirmala said, "There is no exact count." For the first time Tara did not say, "Because of me."

Jaglal stopped operating boats after the accident. He went to the house of Mahendra, Saraswati Devi's son. Mahendra asked, "Will my mother come back?" Jaglal said, "No." "Then what will an apology do?" Jaglal was silent. Mahendra asked again, "Could you have refused to go?" - "Yes." "Why didn't you?" Jaglal had many answers: the contractor, the evening, people's pleas. But he said, "I thought I could get them across." Mahendra did not laugh. "You thought." Jaglal said, "It was a bad decision that day. My share is in it. But saying it was mine alone does not make the other shares disappear."

Tara came out from inside the doorway. "Kaka, I stood up." Jaglal said, "I saw." "Then?" - "The boat was already in danger." "Why did you take it out?" After a long time Jaglal said, "I thought I could handle it." Tara said, "You couldn't." Jaglal nodded. "Yes." The child's question struck him more deeply than the official interrogation. One month later, the preliminary inquiry findings were made public. Six facts were recorded: at the time of the accident there were sixteen passengers against a limit of twelve; there was a temporary repair and leakage at the right-side bottom joint; there were not enough life jackets; availability of the second boat required by contract was not established; immediately before the capsize, a lateral current, a sharp turn to avoid the bamboo, and movement of the load occurred together; no single cause could be scientifically determined.

Under responsibility, the contractor's side was cited for incomplete service capacity, shortage of safety equipment, operating with a temporary repair, and failure to ensure compliance with the passenger limit. The boatman was cited for accepting more passengers than the limit and for a risky turn, though the floating obstruction and the immediate current were noted. The administration was cited for inadequate site verification, daily certification based only on telephone information, extra life jackets remaining in the warehouse, and failure to arrange an alternative boat. Passenger movement was described as an "emergency reaction," not deliberate negligence. Tara and the other children were not named in the responsibility section.

Tara asked, "Why isn't my name there?" Her mother said, "Because it was not your fault." Tara asked Nirmala, "Did they write that I stood up?" Nirmala said, "It may be in the account of what happened, but not under blame." "What's the difference?" Nirmala explained, "What happened can be a fact. Deciding that it makes someone blameworthy is a different thing." Tara repeated slowly, "I stood up - true. The boat overturned because of me - not necessarily?" Nirmala said, "Yes." For the first time, the knot of blame loosened a little.

The village did not agree unanimously with the report. Some said, "The government will give everyone a little blame so no one gets trapped." Some said, "The boatman is poor; the contractor will escape." Some said, "The real fault is the administration's." Some asked, "Why did so many passengers get on?" And the answer came: "When your house is going under in a flood, do you stop to count?" Every question sounded reasonable; every one, by itself, was incomplete.

Proceedings began against Ramanand for false daily certification, safety deficiencies, and breach of contract. His lawyer's draft said: "The accident resulted immediately from passenger imbalance and the boatman's sudden turn; contractual

deficiencies were remote causes.” At night Ramanand kept returning to the words “remote causes.” The absence of the second boat was remote? The life jackets? The bitumen repair? The twelve-passenger limit? He did not withdraw his appeal - the business had to continue. But the following year, when submitting a bid in another district, for the first time he added the cost of a “third reserve boat.” His accountant said, “Profit will fall.” Ramanand said, “Write it in.” Whether that was remorse, fear, or business education, no one could say.

Nirmala gave a flood-safety class at the school. At first she had thought she would tell the children: do not stand in a boat, obey the boatman, wear life jackets. Then she understood that teaching rules only to children could not cover an institution's failures. On the board she wrote three headings: “What should passengers do?” “What should the boatman/operator do?” “What should the administration ensure?” One child asked, “What if the boatman says something wrong?” Nirmala stopped. From the back row Tara said, “The boat should be safe first, so that we do not have to make such decisions.” Nirmala looked at her. “Right.”

Three months later “Mukti” lay overturned behind the school. One day Tara went there. Jaglal had come looking for his old rope. Tara looked at the black patch on the right side of the bottom. “Did water come in from here?” - “Yes, some.” “Was that the whole reason?” - “Not by itself.” “Because I stood up?” - “Not by itself.” “You turned the boat?” - “Yes.” “The contractor pressured you to take more people?” - “Yes, but I took them aboard.” “Nirmala Didi said move left?” - “Yes.” Counting on her fingers, Tara said, “Then all of it?” Jaglal replied, “All of it happened. The weight of blame is different for each part.” “How much?” - “I do not know how to measure that.”

Tara said, “I am afraid of boats.” Jaglal replied, “All right.” “Then when will I get into one again?” - “When you feel ready.” “If the flood comes?” Jaglal said, “Then get in with the fear. Fear is not bad; fear teaches you to check.” Tara placed one foot on the overturned boat, then took it down again. “Will you run boats again?” Jaglal looked inside the hull. “Possibly.” “This boat?” - “No.” “Why?” - “This one has taught too many things.” Tara said, “Then repair it and run it.” Jaglal smiled faintly for the first time. “Will you become the contractor?” Tara laughed too.

A year later the rains came again. This time the block stationed three boats in advance. Capacity boards were clear, life jackets counted, night lighting provided, boatmen rotated, site inspections made daily. On paper everything was right. They had all learned that paper was not enough, so the count was made at the landing too.

Jaglal was on a new boat operated by a cooperative. Before every trip he counted the passengers one by one. “Twelve. That's all.” A thirteenth person said, “I'm a child, there is room.” Jaglal shook his head. “Next trip.” People became annoyed. “The water is rising.” Jaglal said, “That is why there is a limit.” Beside them, a second boat stood ready.

Tara was at the landing with her mother. The old fear rose inside her body. She looked at the bottom of the boat - dry. She put on a life jacket. She read the capacity board. She heard the motor of the second boat. Only then did she climb aboard. After she sat down, Jaglal said, “Nobody stand up.” Tara put her bag down low.

The boat moved slowly across the water. At one place, seeing a line of foam, Jaglal turned it gently. Tara's fingers tightened around the rope, but the boat remained

steady. When they reached the safe mound, Tara stepped out and looked back. A year earlier she had believed that one child rising halfway had overturned the boat. Now she understood that a boat is not made only of wood; it is made of rules, repairs, numbers, decisions, money, fatigue, weather, training, fear, and trust in one another.

If one thing among these comes loose, the boat may still continue. If two or three come loose, perhaps it may still continue. But how far - no one can measure in advance with certainty. That is why safety must not be left to one person.

Jaglal turned the boat for the second trip. This time no one, in haste, said, "Take as many as can sit." The water was the same. Human preparation had changed a little. And this time the story of the flood boat went forward without overturning.

The Painter's Death

Twelve years after Nachiketa Mishra's death, his daughter Ira unlocked for the first time the upstairs room where her father had been painting on his final night.

The house was about to be sold.

Her mother, Shashiprabha, said, "Keep whatever is worth keeping. The museum will take the rest."

Ira asked, "The scaffold?"

Shashiprabha's face hardened. "If they want that too, let them take it."

Twelve years of dust lay on the scaffold. One wooden leg bore a black stain; rust had spread over the iron joint above. On the wall was an unfinished painting: three female figures, with a blue-grey sky behind them. The right side of the picture was blank. Nachiketa had been working on this painting when, at about two in the morning, he fell from the upper scaffold.

At dawn Shashiprabha had found him on the floor.

The police had written at the time: "Probable accidental fall from an elevated work scaffold."

The hospital doctor had recorded the cause: "Internal cerebral trauma following a fall."

The family accepted the death as an accident and performed the last rites.

Three months later an art magazine published an article titled: "Did Nachiketa Mishra Step Out of His Final Painting?"

The writer cited the dark colours and solitary figures in Nachiketa's later paintings, along with one line from his diary: "Now, climbing up means not coming down."

The article never directly used the word suicide.

But everyone understood what it was suggesting.

Five years later, a documentary included an old statement by Nachiketa's assistant, Subodh: "The right joint of the scaffold was not sound."

The accident returned.

And now, twelve years after the death, the private papers of the celebrated art critic Devyani Sen had been released after her own death. In her diary entry for the night Nachiketa died, one sentence appeared:

"I let go of his hand. I wish I had not let go in such anger."

A new headline was born: "Mystery of Nachiketa Mishra's Death Deepens Again."

Some headlines were more direct:

"Murder?"

That was why Ira had opened the upstairs room.

She did not want to defend her father.

Nor her mother's version.

Nor Subodh's.

Nor Devyani's.

She only did not want somebody, twelve years later, to put four lines together and buy and sell one human being's final night.

Nachiketa Mishra had emerged from the tradition of Mithila painting, but he had never remained confined within the traditional style. During the last twenty years of his life, his paintings had been exhibited from Delhi and Kolkata to Patna and Kathmandu. Critics gave him names such as “breaker of boundaries,” “Mithila modernist,” and “the unstable painter of folk memory.”

At home Shashiprabha would say, “People manufacture names. The man keeps grinding colours.”

Nachiketa would laugh.

As a child, Ira had thought her father wanted nothing beyond colour.

As she grew older, she understood that he wanted fame too.

And he was frightened of fame as well.

Selling the house had not been an easy decision. Shashiprabha now lived with Ira in Patna. The old Darbhanga house stood empty. Maintenance had become difficult. The museum had offered to take the contents of Nachiketa's studio.

Ira began making an inventory.

Canvases: 27.

Unfinished canvases: 11.

Paint boxes: 4.

Brushes: 83.

Wooden moulds.

Old letters.

Exhibition invitations.

The scaffold.

And four diaries.

The first diary had been found in the studio that very night - Nachiketa's.

The second was in Shashiprabha's cupboard.

Subodh had kept the third with himself for twelve years; after the documentary, he gave it to Ira.

The fourth had arrived one month earlier as a copy from Devyani's private papers.

For the first time, all four lay together on one table.

A strange thought came to Ira:

as though four people were holding a dead man from four different directions.

No one was ready to let go.

Nachiketa's diary was unlike other people's diaries.

Dates were often missing.

Pages bore stains of colour.

Sometimes there was only a colour combination:

“Blue + ochre = not dusk, injury.”

Sometimes an account of purchases:

“Canvas six by eight - expensive.”

Sometimes only one sentence:

"People search for the village in my pictures; I want to paint an empty sky."

Two months before his death:

"Devyani says again that bodies are disappearing from the new paintings. Perhaps she is right. As long as the body remains, people demand a story."

A week later:

"Shashi says I sleep too little. Ira said on the telephone: see a doctor. I am not ill. I am tired."

That line became a favourite quotation of the suicide theory:

"I am tired."

Ira stopped reading.

She remembered that telephone conversation.

Her father had said, "Your mother will turn me into a patient."

Ira had laughed. "If you paint until three in the morning, of course you'll be tired."

Her father had said, "I am tired."

Ira: "Sleep."

Her father: "Sleep and rest are not the same thing."

At the time Ira had taken the line as a philosophical flourish and left it there.

After his death, people made it into a sign.

Further on in the diary:

"Should I go to Kathmandu next month or not? Three canvases unfinished."

"When Ira comes, give her the old red painting."

"Tell them to replace the upper plank of the scaffold."

Ira stopped.

"Tell them to replace the upper plank of the scaffold."

The line appeared on a page from four days before his death.

She immediately set Subodh's diary aside.

But first she read Nachiketa's final page.

The date of the day he died was clearly written:

"17 July."

Below it:

"Devyani comes today. Read her article. She will finish me off, then say a new Nachiketa has been born."

The next line:

"Shashi angry. Money."

Then:

"Remove the third face in the painting of three women?"

Then, as if written in the evening:

"Light above is right. From below the colour looks dead."

Then the most quoted line:

"Now, climbing up means not coming down."

Beneath it was a small arrow and a note about colour:

"A little yellow in the blue - transparent layer."

Writers had quoted only the first sentence.

Not the note about colour.

Ira wondered: did the sentence mean death?
Or was a painter saying that once he had climbed the scaffold, repeatedly climbing down to judge the colour was no longer practical?
She did not decide.
The diary itself did not say.

Shashiprabha's diary was more orderly.
Dates.
Expenses.
Medicines.
Household work.
Who telephoned.
When the electricity went out.
Ira had never read her mother's diary before. She asked permission.
Shashiprabha said, "Read it. But this is not history."
"Then what?"
"My day."
Ira opened the first page.
Three months before the death:
"Nachiketa awake all night again. Made tea at dawn, left half of it."
"Subodh asked for five thousand in advance. Nachiketa said he would give it.
Electricity bill for the house still unpaid."
"Devyani's article came. Nachiketa laughed outwardly, angry inside."
"Ira said Baba needs rest. Nachiketa agreed in front of Ira, not in front of me."
One month before the death:
"Doctor changed the blood-pressure medicine. Nachiketa says colours look dull when he takes the medicine. Nonsense."
The next entry:
"Today he said: one day I will leave everything. I asked: painting? He said, 'Understand it as you wish.'"
Ira read the line and looked toward her mother.
"Ma."
Shashiprabha was looking out of the window.
"What did he mean?"
"At the time I thought he meant he would give up exhibitions."
"After his death?"
"People said he meant life."
"And you?"
Shashiprabha took a long breath.
"For twelve years, both meanings have lived together."
Ira's throat tightened, but she kept asking questions.
"The day he died?"
Shashiprabha opened the diary herself.
17 July:

"Nachiketa irritable from morning. Did not drink milk.
 Subodh came at ten.
 Telephone call from Devyani at two.
 Argument about money at four.
 Devyani arrived at six-thirty.
 No dinner at eight.
 Devyani left at nine-twenty.
 I went upstairs at ten. Both brushes thrown. Nachiketa said, 'Leave me alone.'
 Left milk at ten-forty-five.
 Around one at night, a sound? Not certain. Strong wind.
 Went upstairs at four-forty-five in the morning. Nachiketa on the floor."

Ira's hand trembled.

"A sound?"

"The scaffold falling?"

"Then why didn't you go upstairs?"

Shashiprabha's face suddenly looked very old.

"I thought it was the window shutter."

Ira was silent.

"For twelve years this question has woken me every day," Shashiprabha said. "It would be better if you did not wake it too."

"I am not blaming—"

"I did not say blame. I said question."

Ira put down the diary.

Shashiprabha continued, "Read the argument about money at four as well."

"What was it?"

"An advance for an exhibition had arrived. He wanted to pay Subodh and two workmen. Household debts were still due. I said: the house first."

"And he?"

"He said, 'The house eats my work.'"

"And you?"

"I said, 'Your work eats the house.'"

Shashiprabha laughed faintly. "A beautiful marriage."

Ira could not laugh.

"I loved him," Shashiprabha said. "That does not mean he was easy to live with."

Ira realised that her mother's diary was less about Nachiketa's death than about the exhaustion of a marriage.

Was "Leave me alone" a sign of suicide?

Or an ordinary sentence in a quarrel between husband and wife?

The diary did not answer.

It made Shashiprabha's loneliness clearer instead.

Subodh Paswan had been Nachiketa's assistant for eleven years.

Grinding colours.

Stretching canvases.

Frames.

Carrying paintings.

Nachiketa would say publicly, "My large paintings would not be possible without bodh."

Very rarely.

Subodh's diary was full of this.

He did not call it a diary.

He called it a “work register.”

Date.

Task.

Hours.

Payment.

Materials.

Who said what to whom.

Ten days before the death:

"Right joint of upper scaffold loose. Iron nail worn. Told Babu. He said: tomorrow."

Nine days before:

"Nail did not come."

Seven days before:

“Devyani ji came. Babu on scaffold. From below she said, ‘Nachiketa, this figure is far too safe.’ Babu came down and wiped away half the face.”

Six days before:

“Shashi Didi said repair the scaffold first. Babu angry - ‘Everyone stops my work.’”

Four days before:

“Spoke of replacing the upper plank. Wood ordered.”

Three days before:

“Wood did not arrive. Contractor’s vehicle out of service.”

Two days before:

"Tied temporary wire around right joint. I did not like it."

One day before:

“Babu said new nail tomorrow.”

Day of death:

“Reached at ten in the morning. Nail not brought. Babu said, ‘Devyani is coming today, do not dismantle the scaffold.’ I said: climb less on the right side.

Paint in the afternoon.

Heard quarrel in the house at four.

Left at six.

Before leaving, tightened the wire again."

Ira held her breath and turned the page.

The next entry was two days after the death:

"I told the police the scaffold was sound."

Ira looked up from the diary.

Subodh sat opposite her. Ira had called him to the house for this reading.

“Why?”
 Subodh’s face tightened.
 “Fear.”
 “Of whom?”
 “If I said it was loose, they would ask: why did the work continue? Why wasn’t the scaffold dismantled? Why did you tie it with wire? I would be responsible.”
 “Were you?”
 Subodh was silent for a long time.
 “In part.”
 “Accident?”
 “Could be.”
 “Certain?”
 “No.”
 “Did the scaffold fall?”
 “Not completely. The right plank was found tilted.”
 “Did the joint break?”
 “The wire came loose.”
 “You tied that wire?”
 “Yes.”
 Ira turned the page.
 “In the documentary you said, ‘I knew beforehand.’”
 “Yes.”
 “Then people said: accident.”
 “People seize one sentence.”
 “And you?”
 Subodh lowered his eyes.
 “At first I thought he died because of me.”
 “And now?”
 “Now I think I may only have been one cause. Possibly not even a cause.”
 Ira noticed the word “possibly.” It sounded light in Subodh’s mouth, but it carried twelve years of weight.
 “If the right joint was loose, did Nachiketa know?”
 “Yes.”
 “Then why did he climb?”
 Pain crossed Subodh’s face.
 “He thought experience was safety.”
 “What do you mean?”
 “A man who has climbed scaffolds for twenty-five years says one day: nothing will happen to me.”
 “Did you stop him?”
 “I told him.”
 “Forcefully?”
 “As forcefully as a labourer can speak to the owner.”
 The sentence lodged inside Ira.
 “Owner?”
 “Babu used my name. He cared for me too. But in work, the owner is the owner.”

Subodh's diary did not record only Nachiketa's death. It recorded the division of labour in the art world.

One name on the painting.

Many hands on the scaffold.

"Why did you keep this register for twelve years?"

"First fear. Then anger. Then because it was proof that I had warned him."

"Proof for whom?"

Subodh gave a faint laugh.

"For myself."

Ira understood.

The four diaries were also four acts of self-defence.

Devyani Sen had been Nachiketa's contemporary, friend, critic, sometimes rival, sometimes very close.

People kept inventing stories about their relationship.

Love?

No?

No one knew.

Shashiprabha used to say, "Devyani knew Nachiketa differently from the way I did. That's all."

"Didn't that hurt you?" Ira had once asked.

"It did."

"And now?"

"Now people are dead."

Devyani's diary was literary. Few short sentences. Much self-analysis. At times it seemed she wrote with some future reader in mind.

One month before Nachiketa's death:

"Nachiketa is cutting himself out of his later paintings. People will call this courage. I think he is fleeing the expectations of the viewer."

Two weeks before:

"Shashiprabha does not like me. Fair enough. I demand Nachiketa's art in the way she may demand the husband - whole."

One week before:

"Nachiketa said, 'You like me only when I oppose the old Nachiketa.' The accusation may be correct."

Day of death:

"Six-thirty at his house.
Saw the new painting. Three women. Third face unfinished.
I said: this painting is cowardly.
He did not laugh."

The next line:

"I gave him a copy of my latest article. He threw it on the table."

It was the article later published as "Nachiketa's Disappearing Bodies."

"He said, 'You do not look at my paintings. You look at your theory.'"

Devyani wrote:

“Correct.”

Ira was startled.

The critic was admitting her own failure.

Further on:

“I too became angry. Said: ‘In your new paintings there is a performance of risk, not risk.’”

Then:

“He climbed the scaffold. From above said, ‘You want risk?’”

Ira bent closer to the page.

“I said, ‘Come down.’”

Then:

“He began wiping away the face of the third figure.”

Then:

“I started to climb. He stopped me. Said the scaffold was unsafe.”

Ira stopped at once.

Nachiketa told Devyani the scaffold was unsafe.

So he himself knew.

Devyani continued:

“I below. He above. It was an image of the whole relationship.”

Ira involuntarily exclaimed, “Devyani!”

From the other room Shashiprabha called, “What?”

“Nothing.”

The diary continued:

“He came down. Argument again.
I said, ‘Destroying yourself will not make the art great.’
He said, ‘You turn everything into art.’”

Then came the famous line:

“I let go of his hand. I wish I had not let go in such anger.”

Ira read the next sentence.

The newspapers had not quoted it.

“On the first step of the stairs he had caught my wrist - whether to stop me or persuade me, I do not know. I jerked my hand free and walked out.”

So “I let go of his hand” was not a push from the scaffold.

She had left the house.

Next:

“After sitting in the car, I regretted it. Go back? I did not.”

Time:

“9:25 p.m.”

Shashiprabha’s diary:

Devyani left at about 9:20.

The times matched.

Estimated time of death: between one and three in the morning.

Did that weaken the murder theory?

Ira stopped herself immediately.

The diary was Devyani’s account.

The time was her own.

Was there any external evidence?

The old gatekeeper was dead.

The shop in the lane had been closed.

But further on Devyani's diary held another line:

"If news comes tomorrow that he has done something to himself, people will blame me. I will too."

Was this fear that he might kill himself?

Or ordinary fear after a bitter quarrel?

On the next page, written the day after the death:

"Nachiketa is dead.

Everyone says, 'He fell.'

Shashi did not look at me.

Ira is far away.

Yesterday's sentence in my diary says: 'Destroying yourself will not make the art great.' Now it will look like prophecy.

It was not prophecy.

It was my anger."

Devyani had herself written down her fear of how future readers would alter the meaning.

Then:

"I did not tell the police the whole of the quarrel. Cowardice."

Ira leaned back in her chair.

In each of the four diaries, someone had told the police less than the whole thing.

Shashiprabha - less about her uncertainty over the sound in the night.

Subodh - concealed the defect in the scaffold.

Devyani - reduced the quarrel.

Nachiketa - dead, unable to speak.

Truth was not simply hidden behind one person's lie.

It was trapped among four different fears.

Ira drew up a timeline from the four diaries.

Morning - Nachiketa irritable.

10:00 - Subodh.

4:00 - argument about money.

6:30 - Devyani.

9:20-9:25 - Devyani leaves.

10:00 - Shashiprabha goes upstairs.

10:45 - milk left there.

Around 1:00 - Shashiprabha may have heard a sound.

1:00-3:00 - estimated time of death.

4:45 - Shashiprabha finds him.

The right joint of the scaffold was loose.

Nachiketa knew.

He prevented Devyani from climbing it.

Even so, he himself probably climbed it later.

Why?

Fresh night-time paint had been found on the right side of the picture - a shine visible in the police photographs.

A brush lay on the upper plank.

A bowl of paint had overturned near the third rung of the scaffold.

This strengthened the accident theory: he had been painting.

But then there was Nachiketa's diary.

"One day I will leave everything."

"I am tired."

"Now, climbing up means not coming down."

And Devyani's quarrel?

"Destroying yourself..."

And his mother's "Leave me alone."

And Subodh's unsafe scaffold.

Put them together and almost any story could be made.

That was the problem.

Ira could prove suicide if she wanted.

Or accident.

Or suspicion against Devyani.

Or Subodh's negligence.

Or Shashiprabha's guilt.

There was material for every one of them.

The art magazine telephoned.

"Ira ji, will you respond to Devyani Sen's diary?"

"No."

"Will you clarify the meaning of 'I let go of his hand'?"

"Read the next sentence in the diary."

"I have. But people are asking whether there was a physical struggle between them."

"It says he held her wrist near the stairs."

"Then the murder theory is false?"

Ira paused.

"The diary does not prove murder."

"And suicide?"

"It does not prove that either."

"Accident?"

"Not certain either."

The journalist laughed. "Then where is the news?"

Ira ended the call.

A week later Arvind Kumar, curator of a proposed retrospective exhibition, came to see her.

He wanted to display all four diaries in the exhibition.

"People will see multiple perspectives on Nachiketa's final night."

Ira asked, "Will they see the art or the death?"

"Both."

"Which pages?"

Arvind read out a list:

Nachiketa: "Now, climbing up means not coming down."

Shashiprabha: "Leave me alone."

Subodh: "Right joint loose."

Devyani: "I let go of his hand."

Ira burst out laughing.

"A beautiful murder mystery."

Arvind became uncomfortable. "I do not want to sensationalise it."

"With these four lines?"

"Then give the full context."

"The full diaries?"

"A selection."

"Who will select?"

Arvind was silent.

Ira placed all four diaries on the table.

"These diaries are less portraits of Nachiketa than self-portraits of the people who wrote them."

"What do you mean?"

"Mother's diary records her marriage. Subodh records his labour and his guilt. Devyani records her criticism and her claim over him. Baba records his art and his exhaustion. All of them look at Baba, but they look at themselves as well."

Arvind said slowly, "That could become the centre of the exhibition."

Ira answered at once, "Then Baba becomes the centre again."

Arvind did not laugh.

"Then?"

Ira could not answer.

That night Shashiprabha looked at all four diaries.

"Did you read Devyani's whole diary?" Ira asked.

"No."

"Do you want to?"

"No."

"Why?"

"It is private."

"It became public after her death."

"Does becoming public give me a moral right to read it?"

Ira was silent.

Shashiprabha looked toward her own diary.

"Will you put mine in the exhibition in full?"

"No."

"Why?"

"Private."

"Then Devyani's?"

Ira understood.

The moment a dead person becomes famous, the private lives of those close to that person become public property.

As the story of Nachiketa's death kept being made and remade, Shashiprabha, Subodh, and Devyani all became characters.

"I would use only the relevant portions—"

Shashiprabha laughed.

"Relevant to what? Death? Marriage? Art?"

Ira closed her mouth.

Shashiprabha softened again.

"I am not stopping you. Just understand this: a diary is a window, not the whole house."

Ira wrote down the sentence.

One day Subodh came to see the studio again.

The scaffold was still there.

He crouched by the right joint.

"This is not the wire."

"Which wire?"

"The one I tied."

"Did the police remove it?"

"Possible."

"How thick was it?"

Subodh showed her with his fingers. "This thick."

"If the wire came loose?"

"The plank could tilt."

"Break?"

"No. Drop suddenly on one side."

"And the person?"

"Loses balance."

"Where was Nachiketa's body found?"

Subodh indicated a place on the floor.

"Here."

"What if he jumped?"

Subodh lifted his face.

"If he wanted to jump, why the scaffold? The window is here."

Ira looked at the window.

A two-storey drop.

The scaffold was twelve or thirteen feet high.

Did that favour accident?

Possibly.

But does suicide always choose the most logical means?

Ira did not want a verdict from that either.

Subodh continued:

"One thing the police never asked."

“What?”

“Babu was afraid of heights.”

Ira stared.

“What?”

“Very.”

“Then the scaffold?”

“He climbed for work. But once he was standing above, he would not look down.”

A childhood image returned to Ira: her father going onto the roof to bring down a kite, always keeping away from the edge.

“In the diary he wrote: ‘Now, climbing up means not coming down.’”

Subodh laughed.

“Once Babu climbed up, he would say, ‘Now send all the colours up. I am not coming down; climbing up again is difficult.’”

Ira went still.

“He used to say that?”

“Many times.”

“Why didn’t you say this before?”

“Did anyone ask?”

Again the same thing.

The answer that is born depends on the question someone asks.

Ira began looking for old recordings.

Nachiketa’s interviews.

Workshops.

Television appearances.

Question-and-answer sessions with students.

In a workshop from 2008, Nachiketa could be heard laughing:

“I don’t like high scaffolds. Once I climb up, send all the colours up; I am not going up and down again and again.”

The students laughed.

Then:

“For me, climbing up means not looking down.”

Ira held her breath.

The famous diary line now sounded like a very ordinary sentence of labour.

“Now, climbing up means not coming down.”

The suicide article grew weaker.

But did that make suicide impossible?

No.

The meaning of one sentence had changed.

Not the conclusion about a life.

Ira wanted to send the old recording to the writer of the magazine article.

Then she stopped herself.

His article twelve years earlier may have been sensational, but it had offered one possible reading of Nachiketa's diary. If Ira now simply declared it "wrong," would that not become another absolute certainty?

She added the recording only to the exhibition file.

"Context: Nachiketa had previously used this expression in conversations about working on scaffolds."

That was all.

There was another thing in Devyani's private diary that had not entered the news. Three days before the death:

"Arvind wants a retrospective of Nachiketa. Nachiketa is unwilling. Says, 'A retrospective for a living man is rehearsal for death.'"

Ira asked Arvind:

"Is this true?"

Arvind was startled.

"I was a young curator then. Yes, there was a proposal."

"Baba refused?"

"At first."

"Then?"

"One day before his death, he sent a message: 'We will talk.'"

"Do you still have the message?"

Arvind showed her a copy from an old collection of letters.

"Sit tomorrow or the day after. Not all the old pictures. If it can be done with the new work as well, I may consider it."

One day before the death.

A plan for the future.

Did that weaken the suicide theory again?

Ira stopped herself again.

The diaries contained despair.

They also contained future plans.

Both can exist within the same human being.

While clearing the house, Ira found an envelope with her own name on it.

Her heart seemed to stop for a moment.

"For Ira."

Her father's handwriting.

Why had no one found it for twelve years?

The envelope had been wedged behind an old frame.

Ira opened it with trembling hands.

There was no letter inside.

Only a small photograph: Ira at eight years old, paint on her hands, standing with her father.

On the back he had written:

"The red painting to Ira. She says it is bad, so it belongs to her."

Below it was a date from six days before his death.
 That was all.
 Ira began to cry.
 If someone read this paper in order to build a story of death, they might say:
 “The father was distributing his possessions to his daughter - a sign of farewell.”
 Another reader might say:
 “A future gift - a plan to keep living.”
 The same paper could serve both theories.
 Ira showed it to her mother.
 Shashiprabha laughed and cried together.
 “You did not like that red painting.”
 “And now?”
 “Now that your father is dead, everything becomes lovable.”
 Ira laughed through her tears at her mother’s sarcasm.
 Perhaps this was one form of the family’s self-preservation - refusing to make
 memory sacred.

The date of the exhibition drew near.

Proposed title:

“Nachiketa: Final Colours.”

Ira refused.

“The Final Night.”

Refused.

“The Unfinished Painting.”

Refused.

At last:

“Nachiketa Mishra: Four Perspectives, Many Pictures.”

Arvind asked, “No word ‘death’?”

“No.”

“People will ask by themselves.”

“Let them.”

The exhibition did not create four separate rooms for the four diaries.

Ira did not want visitors to become detectives, moving from clue to clue.

Instead she organised four themes:

“Work.”

“Home.”

“Gaze.”

“Risk.”

Each room contained excerpts from all four diaries.

Under “Work”:

Nachiketa - colour.

Shashiprabha - electricity bill.

Subodh - scaffold/labour.

Devyani - criticism.

Under “Home”:

Nachiketa - "The house eats my work."
Shashiprabha - "Your work eats the house."
Subodh - advance wages.
Devyani - "Shashiprabha quite reasonably does not like me."
Under "Risk":
The scaffold.
The loose joint.
Nachiketa's fear of heights.
Devyani's phrase "performance of risk."
Shashiprabha's sound in the night.
There was no "Death Room."
On the final wall there were only facts:

"Nachiketa Mishra was found unconscious beneath the scaffold in his studio on the morning of 18 July; he died before reaching hospital. Medical records note severe injuries caused by a fall. The immediate police conclusion considered accidental fall probable. The available private diaries give different emotional meanings to the event; no single diary establishes the cause of death conclusively."

Arvind read it and said, "Very cautious."

"Yes."

"An art exhibition or an inquiry report?"

Ira said, "At least the next generation will not be told that four lines amounted to four verdicts."

There was a large crowd on opening day.

People looked at the paintings.

They read the diaries.

The scaffold was displayed too, but not under the name "death scaffold."

Its label read:

"Nachiketa's work scaffold; Subodh's work register contains several entries concerning repair of the right joint."

Some visitors photographed the right joint.

A young man asked Ira:

"So it was an accident, wasn't it?"

"I am not certain."

"The scaffold was bad."

"Yes."

"Then?"

"A bad scaffold increases the possibility of an accident. It does not by itself tell the whole event."

A woman asked:

"Devyani did not push him?"

"There is no such evidence in the diary."

"But 'let go of his hand'?"

"Read the next sentence."

The woman read.

“Oh.”

A student asked:

“Suicide?”

Ira indicated the audio recording.

Nachiketa’s old laughter came through the loudspeaker:

“Once I climb up, send all the colours up...”

The student listened and said:

“Then the article was wrong.”

Ira replied:

“One interpretation of one quotation became weaker. Not the entire question.”

The student remained dissatisfied.

Ira was no longer afraid of that dissatisfaction.

Shashiprabha sat quietly in one corner of the exhibition.

An elderly woman recognised her and asked:

“You are Nachiketa ji’s wife?”

“Yes.”

“He was a very great artist.”

“Yes.”

“Was he this quiet at home too?”

Shashiprabha burst out laughing.

“No.”

The woman was startled, then laughed too.

Ira watched from a distance.

If Nachiketa’s greatness could not bear the fact that he had also been irritable at home, then greatness was very fragile.

Subodh came too. He stood before a page from his work register.

Below it, for the first time, was written clearly:

“Assistant and construction worker: Subodh Paswan.”

He came to Ira and said:

“You wrote the name.”

“Late.”

“Even so.”

Devyani was not there.

A page from her diary was.

On one page she had written:

“The more I write Nachiketa, the more I end up writing myself.”

Ira had chosen that line deliberately.

Perhaps it was the most accurate line for all four diaries.

Three days later a review appeared in a national magazine.

Its title:

“One Artist’s Death, Four Failed Truths.”

Ira read it and became irritated.

Then she read the article to the end.
 The writer said:
 "The exhibition refuses to solve the murder mystery."
 Ira felt relieved.
 But the next paragraph said:
 "Perhaps this refusal also reflects the family's wish to protect its reputation."
 Ira burst out laughing.
 No act of selection is neutral.
 Could she say the critic was wrong?
 No.
 Family reputation might be influencing her.
 Love for her father.
 The impulse to protect her mother.
 A sense of justice toward Subodh.
 Respect for Devyani's privacy.
 Ira too was a fifth perspective.
 She opened her notebook and wrote:
 "The four diaries I arranged are also my self-portrait."
 She did not immediately close the page.
 She continued:
 "For that reason, my role should also be declared in the catalogue."
 In the next edition of the catalogue, a line was added:
 "Selection and presentation: Ira Mishra, daughter of the artist."
 Earlier they had intended to write only "curatorial assistance."
 Now the relationship was explicit.

One night after the exhibition had closed, Ira stood alone before the unfinished painting of the "three women."
 There were three figures.
 The first face was clear.
 The second half formed.
 The third nearly erased.
 Devyani had written that the painting was cowardly.
 Nachiketa had been wiping away the third face.
 Subodh had said that colour was needed on the upper portion that day.
 Shashiprabha had written nothing about the painting in her diary.
 Ira wondered: who were the three women?
 Mother?
 Devyani?
 Ira?
 None of them?
 People would certainly invent a story.
 She checked the painting's title.
 On the reverse, in Nachiketa's hand:
 "Three Figures. Title later."

The exhibition committee had wanted to give it a temporary name:

“Three Women.”

Ira had that removed as well.

The label read:

“Untitled, unfinished.”

Because a name too can make a story.

One day before the exhibition ended, an elderly painter, Nachiketa's old friend Ashok Verma, came.

He stood silently before the scaffold for a long time.

“Was this right joint always bad?” he asked.

Subodh was not there.

Ira said:

“There are notes that it was loose before the death.”

Ashok shook his head.

“Nachiketa was a fool.”

Ira stared.

“What?”

“We were all fools. From youth onward we climbed scaffolds like this. Safety belt? We laughed at it. As if, because we were artists and not labourers, our bodies were different.”

Subodh's sentence came back to Ira:

“The owner is the owner.”

Ashok continued:

“Once, in 1999, Nachiketa almost fell. In front of me.”

“What?”

“That time too the right plank shifted. It was another scaffold.”

“Did anyone write it down?”

“Why would we?”

“Why did you not say it after his death?”

Ashok thought.

“No one asked.”

Ira gave a tired laugh.

No one asked.

A great deal of truth dies for lack of a question.

“Does this prove accident?” Ira asked.

Ashok looked at her.

“You still want to prove something?”

Ira was silent.

Ashok moved toward the paintings.

The house was sold.

The museum took the paint boxes, brushes, scaffold, and some tools.

Ira kept the red painting.

Shashiprabha kept one small wooden box.
 And the four diaries?
 Nachiketa's - joint preservation by family and museum.
 Shashiprabha's - with Shashiprabha herself.
 Subodh's - with Subodh, with a digital copy made by permission.
 Devyani's - limited access under the rules of her archive.
 Ira did not put all four together permanently as a "collection of truth."
 Because they belonged to four different lives.
 On the night the exhibition closed, Ira took one last photograph of the scaffold.
 The right joint.
 Rust.
 Perhaps the old friction marks left by the wire.
 The wooden plank.
 She thought:
 how many stories can one object bear?
 If you say:
 "This bad scaffold killed Nachiketa" - simple.
 If:
 "Nachiketa killed himself" - simple.
 If:
 "He quarrelled with Devyani" - simple.
 If:
 "Subodh was negligent" - simple.
 If:
 "Shashiprabha heard a sound and did not go upstairs" - cruel simplicity.
 Life had been more disorderly than all of these.
 Ira opened her own diary.
 Twelve years earlier, on the day of the death, she had written:
 "Baba is gone."
 Only that much.
 Today, underneath it, she wrote:
 "I still do not know whether he fell, jumped, or whether a moment of carelessness
 and exhaustion came together. I know only this: four diaries do not write four deaths.
 Four people write their own Nachiketa."
 She stopped.
 Then added:
 "And I am the fifth."
 She closed the pen.
 Far away, museum workers were turning off the lights.
 The unfinished painting went into darkness.
 So did the scaffold.
 The diaries were not behind one sheet of glass - they remained in their own
 homes, archives, and memories.
 Nachiketa's death remained a question.
 But Ira no longer felt that an unanswered question was a failure.
 Before answering some questions, it is necessary to see:

whom the answer saves,
whom it blames,
and whose face rises within it.
All four diaries had set out to paint Nachiketa.
In the end, all four became mirrors.

The Old Lawsuit

Anamika Mishra taught history, but she had always kept away from the old lawsuit in her own village.

When, in childhood, two elderly men sitting on the veranda would fall silent the moment they saw one another, her mother would say:

“It is about Bariyar Patti.”

Anamika would ask:

“What?”

“An old land dispute.”

“How old?”

Her mother would wave the question away.

“Long before you were born.”

That answer had been enough for a child.

Later, at university, Anamika researched land records, colonial surveys, rent registers, and the social history of villages. She read hundreds of old lawsuits.

Lines on maps, rent receipts, witness statements, tiny notes scribbled at the edge of survey registers - all became part of her work.

But Bariyar Patti?

She never touched that file.

Because Bariyar Patti was regarded as land belonging to her family.

And the opposing family - the Mandal household - still said that the land had been cultivated by their ancestors.

A historian, Anamika could remain detached in other people's disputes.

In a dispute in her own courtyard?

She kept avoiding that question.

Then one day her uncle telephoned.

“Anamika, now your learning will be of some use.”

Anamika laughed.

“Kaka, is learning something stored in a warehouse?”

“Stop joking. We need you to look at the Bariyar Patti papers.”

“Why?”

“The highway is being widened. Four kathas will go into the road. The compensation is a large amount. Our name is in the circle-office register, but the Mandal family has objected again.”

Anamika stopped laughing.

“Which Mandal?”

“Dinbandhu - Rameshwar Mandal's grandson. He says the 1926 lawsuit was decided on a faulty foundation.”

“Now?”

“Wisdom has awakened after a hundred years.”

Anamika was silent.

Her uncle continued:

"Your great-grandfather Shivlochan Babu gave evidence in that case. The court decision was in our favour. Just prepare a historical note - the land is ancestral to the family, the case was won, continuous possession."

Something tightened inside Anamika.

"Kaka, 'just' is not so simple."

"There are documents, aren't there?"

"I will look at the documents."

"That is what I am asking you to do."

After ending the call, Anamika sat at her desk for a long time.

Her husband, Aditya, asked:

"Will you go?"

"I will have to."

"As a historian or as a member of the family?"

Anamika tried to smile and could not.

"That is exactly the problem."

Bariyar Patti was a long plot of seventeen kathas at the western edge of the Kachanama mauza. Old people said a seasonal channel once flowed there. The channel was gone now. Wheat grew through the middle, mustard along the side, two shisham trees stood to the south, and a new paved road ran along the north.

The red stakes for the highway project had been driven four kathas into the plot.

Her uncle, Devkant Mishra, pointed them out.

"The highway will cut through from here. Less land, higher value."

Dinbandhu Mandal happened to be standing at the edge of his own field. He was about sixty. The moment he saw Anamika, he folded his hands.

"Professor Didi, will you decide now?"

Anamika answered at once:

"I am not the person who decides."

Dinbandhu laughed.

"That was my fear too."

Devkant Kaka glared at him.

"What does that mean?"

"Nothing. Only that the person reading the history belongs to the other house."

Anamika looked down at the soil.

Four red stakes.

An old mango stump.

A pond in the distance.

And through the middle of the land, a narrow footpath leading not toward the highway but toward the settlement to the south.

"This footpath?" Anamika asked.

Dinbandhu said:

"People from our tola have used it for generations."

Her uncle said immediately:

"The path was allowed out of kindness. It gives no ownership."

"Kindness?" Dinbandhu laughed, though his eyes did not. "My grandmother used to say this path was made through the middle of the land our people cultivated."

Her uncle said:

"Land does not run on a grandmother's story."

Dinbandhu did not reply.

Anamika understood: from the very first day, words were being selected.

"Kindness."

"Cultivation."

"Ownership."

"Old."

Each word drew its own boundary.

She bent down and touched the dry earth beside one of the red stakes.

No one could tell from the soil whether a channel had ever flowed there.

The first rule of history:

what is no longer visible must not therefore be assumed never to have existed.

The old court file was in the district archives.

"Raghunath Mishra versus Bhola Mandal, Civil Suit No. 42 of 1925."

The file was not thick.

One hundred and thirty-eight pages in all.

The first page:

Claim - Khesra 327, total area 17 kathas 6 dhurs.

Plaintiff - Raghunath Mishra.

Defendant - Bhola Mandal.

Dispute - possession and right of cultivation.

Decision, 1926:

"Plaintiff's ownership established. Defendant's possession permissive; no permanent right."

Anamika stopped at the sentence.

This was the sentence her uncle wanted.

"Ownership established."

Was that all?

She read the next page.

Raghunath Mishra's claim:

The land had belonged to the family since his great-grandfather's time.

Bhola Mandal was only a sharecropper.

The family paid the rent.

The survey map showed a clear boundary.

Bhola's father, Harkhu Mandal, had been permitted to cultivate it.

Bhola Mandal's reply:

His family had cultivated the land "for three generations."

The Mishra family only retained its "revenue name."

The western part of the old channel was actually cultivated by the Mandal family.

At the time of survey, the channel had dried, and the boundary was drawn incorrectly.

They had never accepted the relationship as sharecropping.

Anamika made notes.

The first difference:

The court's language was "ownership versus permissive possession."

Bhola's language was "cultivation versus name."

The same land, two different systems.

She read the witness statements.

The first witness for Raghunath's side - Shivlochan Mishra.

Anamika's great-grandfather.

Age then: thirty-two.

Occupation - schoolteacher, temporary local assistant during the survey.

Her heart began to beat faster.

Statement:

"During the survey of 1911, I accompanied the amin for local identification. The old channel was the eastern boundary of Khesra 327. Harkhu Mandal cultivated with the permission of the plaintiff's family."

Anamika turned the page.

Cross-examination:

"Question: Does the channel change its course according to the rains?"

"Answer: The watercourse changes somewhat, but the old boundary is fixed according to local memory."

"Question: Whose local memory?"

"Answer: Elders of the village."

"Question: Names?"

"Answer: I do not now remember."

Anamika stopped her pen.

I do not now remember.

Her uncle had said over the telephone: "Great-grandfather gave evidence."

Yes.

But what kind of evidence?

"Local memory" - unnamed.

She read the next witness.

Damodar Sahu, age fifty-eight:

"I have seen Harkhu Mandal cultivating the field since my childhood. I do not know to whom he gave a share of the produce."

Raghunath's side used the statement in its own favour - cultivation admitted, ownership not.

Bhola's side used it too - long cultivation admitted.

The same sentence was useful to both sides.

The third witness - Chandrika Devi, widow, approximate age sixty-five.

Anamika was startled.

A woman witness in a 1925 lawsuit.

The statement was short:

"My marital home is in Mandal Tola. When I came there after marriage, Harkhu cultivated paddy on this land. I heard that Raghunath's grandfather paid the rent. I

saw the harvested paddy brought to Harkhu's house. I do not know how much of it went elsewhere."

Cross-examination:

"Have you seen any document?"

"No."

"Do you know the boundary of the land?"

"In the rains, cultivation shifts on both sides according to where the channel flows."

That sentence caught Anamika.

"In the rains, cultivation shifts on both sides according to where the channel flows."

The map was fixed.

The cultivation shifted.

She did not close the file.

The next day she examined the map.

The revenue survey map of 1911 lay rolled in cloth in the district map room. The paper was yellow, its edges crumbling.

The employee said:

"Touch it as little as possible."

Anamika put on gloves.

Khesra 327 was long.

On the eastern side ran a crooked blue line - "old channel."

The western boundary was straight.

But on looking closely, she saw that the blue line had been drawn twice.

The first pencil line was faint.

The final ink line was different.

"Is this a correction?" the employee asked.

"Possibly."

Anamika looked at the edge of the map.

In tiny letters:

"Channel unstable. Boundary by local identification."

Signature:

"S. L. Mishra, local assistant."

S. L.

Shivlochan Mishra.

Anamika's great-grandfather.

She applied for a copy.

"Will the original pencil line show in the digital image?" she asked.

"It is faint. You need high resolution."

"Do it."

"Extra fee."

"Fine."

Before leaving the map she looked once more.

What if the first pencil line had been the boundary?

What if the final ink line was an administrative simplification?
 Why had it changed?
 She needed the survey field-book.
 It was found three days later.
 Measurement entry:
 "Khesra 327 - paddy, low land, eastern channel."
 In the margin:
 "Watercourse shifting; to keep khesra line fixed, boundary joined by old peepal -
 earth mound - southern bamboo clump."
 Anamika sat still.
 Not the channel.
 Three fixed markers joined into a line.
 Peepal.
 Earth mound.
 Bamboo clump.
 None of the three now existed.
 Who had made that decision?
 Below it were initials:
 "S. L. M."
 Shivlochan.
 She closed her notebook.
 The historian's hand suddenly became the family's hand.

The moment she returned home, her uncle asked:
 "What did you find?"
 "The decision is in our family's favour."
 Her uncle smiled.
 "That's all."
 "Not all."
 "Then?"
 "Great-grandfather helped fix the survey boundary through local identification."
 "So? He was educated."
 "The channel shifted."
 "Rivers and streams shift. A boundary is still needed."
 "On what basis?"
 Her uncle became irritated.
 "What is the use of digging through documents this old? The court saw the
 matter and decided."
 Anamika said calmly:
 "The court relied on that very map."
 "And rightly so."
 "I am not yet saying right or wrong."
 "That is your problem. Everything becomes 'not certain.'"
 Anamika tried to smile.
 "That is the job in history."

Her uncle stood up.
 “Do not prepare documents against the family.”
 Something flared inside Anamika.
 “I will not prepare lies for the family either.”
 “Who said anything about lying?”
 “You asked me to write ‘continuous ancestral possession.’”
 “There is a judgment.”
 “The judgment is a legal conclusion from 1926. The cultivation before that is complicated.”
 “History above law?”
 Anamika said nothing.
 Her uncle left with one final sentence:
 “The history department will not pay the compensation.”
 That was true.
 And precisely for that reason, the conflict was difficult.

For the first time, Anamika went to Dinbandhu Mandal’s house as a researcher. Dinbandhu sat with his wife Kamla Devi, his sister Saroj, and his son Neeraj. Anamika said directly:
 “I belong to the family on the other side. So keep that in mind when listening to me.”
 Dinbandhu laughed.
 “No one from the Mishra household has ever said that before.”
 “I work with history.”
 Kamla asked:
 “Will history give us our land?”
 “No.”
 “Then?”
 “We will separate what the papers say from what memory says.”
 Dinbandhu opened an old chest.
 Receipts.
 Marriage letters.
 A red cloth bundle containing a family register like a genealogy.
 And two old papers stained with earth.
 “Look at this.”
 A paddy transaction note from 1934:
 “From Bhola Mandal, Bariyar Patti paddy 11 maunds. Toward revenue payment, 2 maunds 5 seers to Raghunath Babu.”
 Anamika examined the page carefully.
 “Sharecropping?”
 Dinbandhu answered at once:
 “No. Rent.”
 “The paper says ‘toward revenue payment.’”
 “My grandfather used to say: the state was the owner; the Mishra people merely held the name.”

Anamika wrote:

“Family interpretation.”

Dinbandhu did not become angry.

“Write the Mishra family’s interpretation too.”

“I will.”

The second paper, from 1942:

“Paddy received from Rameshwar Mandal.”

Recipient’s signature – Devkinandan Mishra.

A smaller quantity.

“What does this paper establish?” Anamika asked.

Dinbandhu was silent.

Neeraj intervened:

“We were cultivating it.”

“That establishes use. Not necessarily ownership.”

Neeraj frowned.

“Are documents made only by owners?”

The question stung Anamika.

“Often the power to create documents is not equally distributed.”

Kamla Devi said:

“That is why you should listen to what our grandmother said.”

She began recounting the memory of her late mother-in-law, Shanti Devi.

“Shanti Dadi used to say that Harkhu Baba cultivated west of the channel, the Mishra people east. After the floods the channel shifted. One year Harkhu’s paddy was on one side, the next year on the other. At that time no one counted kathas and dhurs. When the survey people came, the land became a line.”

Anamika asked:

“From whom did Dadi hear this?”

“From her father-in-law Rameshwar.”

“Rameshwar?”

“Bhola’s son.”

So one generation removed from the event.

“What did he say about why the lawsuit was lost?”

Dinbandhu answered:

“No papers.”

Kamla said:

“And caste.”

The room fell silent.

Anamika asked softly:

“Were those Dadi’s words?”

“Yes. She used to say: ‘Our people knew the field; their people knew the paper.’”

Anamika wrote the sentence down, adding:

“Oral family memory; three generations later.”

Neeraj said:

“You write something like that after every statement, as if it is a lie.”

“No,” Anamika said. “It tells the reader where the sentence comes from.”

“Will you also write after the Mishra court judgment: ‘family paper?’”

"I will write: court record, based on the plaintiff's documents and witnesses."
Neeraj grew quiet.

Anamika opened the genealogy-like register wrapped in red cloth.
It was not a formal genealogical register maintained by a panjika, but a household family record.

Names:

Harkhu.

Wife Dhanmuniya.

Son Bhola.

Daughter Phoolmati - "married in Jhanjharpur."

Second daughter - "died in childhood."

Bhola's son Rameshwar.

In the margin, a small line:

"Phoolmati returned after being widowed and lived in the house at the western field."

Anamika looked up.

"House at the western field?"

Dinbandhu said:

"There was a hut beside Bariyar Patti."

"For how long?"

"Dadi used to say: all her life."

"Phoolmati's name is not in the court file."

"In which lawsuits do women's names appear?"

Anamika thought.

If Phoolmati had lived there, the social history of land use was different.

But was a family genealogy proof of ownership?

No.

She wrote:

"Family record suggests relationship and residence; not an explicit record of land rights."

Kamla said:

"You give limits to every document."

"Every document has its own limits."

"And people?"

Anamika paused.

"People too."

That night Anamika opened an old chest in her own house.

Her mother had said that her great-grandfather's notebooks were with her uncle.

Reluctantly, her uncle handed them over.

"There are private things in these."

"I will not make them public without the family's permission."

"But you will read them?"

"I will."

Her uncle gave her the key.

Shivlochan Mishra's notebooks had three sections.

The first - school.

The second - survey.

The third - household accounts.

In the survey section, day by day:

"Amin sahib late."

"Rain."

"Survey chain broke."

"Villagers quarrelled over boundary."

Anamika read patiently.

One page:

"Difficulty over the line of the western channel in Kachanama. Water went east last year, west this year. Cultivators recognise a moving boundary."

"Moving boundary."

Next:

"A government map cannot remain moving. Fixed markers required."

Anamika's heart quickened.

Then:

"Suggested line joining peepal, mound, bamboo. Amin sahib accepted."

That was all.

No conspiracy.

No money.

No "benefit to the Mishra family."

Only administrative convenience.

And that line later became the foundation of the lawsuit.

Next page:

"Harkhu Mandal angry. Says fields move with water. Raghunath's father says: without a line, how can revenue be assessed?"

Then:

"I understand both arguments. In survey, one must write one."

Anamika leaned back in her chair.

"One must write one."

The historian's familiar offence.

Complicated life.

One line.

One boundary.

One register.

She turned the page.

"People at home say the western strip has always been ours. I did not enter the family's claim in the survey. But I did think that the line would benefit the family."

Anamika's hand stopped.

Her great-grandfather had known.

He had not taken a bribe.

He had not knowingly forged a false map.

But he had understood the consequence.
Then the final line:
“Perhaps neutrality is only this much: know your own advantage and keep its name in your mind.”
Anamika stared at the note for a long time.
Her great-grandfather had used the word neutrality.
Why, a hundred years later, did the sentence seem to have been written for her?

Anamika found one of her own old research articles.
Year: 2012.
Title:
“Fixed Lines and Modern Land Records: Early Surveys of North Mithila.”
One paragraph used Kachanama as an example.
She had written:
“The Kachanama litigation of 1925-26 shows how, with the arrival of formal mapping, the claim of a long-term unauthorised cultivator weakened in court.”
Anamika lowered her face as she read the words.
“Unauthorised cultivator.”
Where had that term come from?
The court judgment.
That was all.
At the time she had not read Bhola Mandal's full statement.
Not the field-book.
Not Shivlochan's note.
Not the Mandal family papers.
For the sake of one footnote, she had used the lawsuit.
She had adopted the judgment's language as her own.
This was not only a question of family attachment.
It was professional as well.
She showed the article to Aditya.
“I made an error.”
Aditya read it.
“The sources were limited.”
“But the language was certain.”
“Then write a correction.”
“Twelve years later?”
“History lives longer than your article.”
Anamika laughed.
“Do not say things like that. You sound too much like a professor.”
Aditya laughed too.
But Anamika did not sleep that night.

The next stage was the revenue register.
Jamabandi, 1908:

Khesra 327, name - Badrinarayan Mishra, Raghunath's father.

Cultivation column blank.

1916:

Same name.

Crop column - something indistinct like "paddy, partial share."

1921:

Name - Raghunath Mishra.

Possession note - "Bhola."

Anamika stared.

"Possession: Bhola."

1923:

Name - Raghunath.

Possession - blank.

1927:

Name - Raghunath.

Possession - "self/labourers."

So after the lawsuit, the record changed.

Her uncle would say:

"Look, the name is ours."

Dinbandhu would say:

"Look, Bhola had possession."

Both would be partly right.

The revenue register told the state the name of the person paying revenue.

The possession note sometimes showed actual cultivation.

But ownership, social arrangement, seasonal boundary - none of those fitted wholly into one column.

Anamika obtained copies.

Along with them she found an old receipt book.

1919:

"Rent deposited by Raghunath Mishra, including Khesra 327."

Strong evidence for her uncle.

But in a village-expense register from 1919:

"Bhola Mandal - one rupee toward cleaning the drain in Bariyar field."

Strong evidence for Dinbandhu?

Cleaning the drain implied use.

Not ownership.

History kept becoming "yes, but."

Anamika grew tired.

There was a ninety-five-year-old woman in Kachanama named Jasoda Devi.

Dinbandhu said:

"She is the last person who heard it directly from Shanti Dadi."

Anamika went to see her.

Jasoda's hearing was poor; her memory was sometimes sharp, sometimes distant.

"Bariyar Patti?" Jasoda asked.

"There used to be water there."

"How much?"

"Up to the knees."

"When?"

"When I was a child."

If she was ninety-five, her childhood meant the 1930s.

After the lawsuit.

"The Mishra-Mandal dispute?"

Jasoda laughed.

"At my wedding, people from both houses ate together."

Anamika was startled.

"So there was no quarrel?"

"The land quarrel was separate, the feast separate."

With one sentence, the simple story of a feud passed down through generations broke apart.

Jasoda continued:

"Raghunath Babu used to call Bhola 'brother.'"

"And the lawsuit?"

"The lawsuit was in court. Did cultivation in the village stop?"

"Did it?"

Jasoda thought.

"For some years Bhola cultivated. Later his son."

"Even after the judgment?"

"Yes or no... I remember childhood. People at home used to say so."

Anamika wrote:

"Chronology uncertain."

Jasoda became angry.

"Am I lying?"

"No. I do not know the exact time."

"Who knows time exactly?"

Anamika smiled.

"That is why I am asking."

Jasoda closed her eyes and said:

"The rains know the right time."

Anamika did not write that down.

It was beautiful poetry, not evidence.

But she kept it in her mind.

By then the matter had spread inside the family.

Her uncle's son, Pranav, said:

"Didi, why so much research? The land is going to be sold."

Anamika replied:

"That is why."

"The Mandal people have woken up only because they see money now."

Dinbandhu's side was suspicious of Anamika too.

Neeraj said:

“In the end you will submit a report in your family's favour.”

Anamika asked:

“Then why did you show me the papers?”

Neeraj was silent.

Kamla said:

“Because at least you will read them.”

Not complete trust.

Only temporary usefulness.

Anamika understood: both sides set their own condition for what counted as the historian's neutrality.

If the report supported us - neutral.

If it went against us - partisan.

She reread her great-grandfather's line:

“Know your own advantage and keep its name in your mind.”

But only in the mind?

Or in the report too?

Anamika designed a structure.

Title:

“Bariyar Patti: A Comparative Account of the Available Historical Sources.”

First column:

Source.

Second:

What it says.

Third:

What it establishes.

Fourth:

What it does not establish.

I. Court decision, 1926.

Says - Raghunath's ownership accepted; Bhola's possession permissive.

Establishes - the legal conclusion of the court at that time.

Does not establish - the entirety of social and seasonal land arrangements before 1911.

2. Survey map, 1911.

Says - fixed khesra boundary.

Establishes - the line accepted by the survey administration.

Does not establish - the full history of the channel's earlier and changing course.

3. Field-book / Shivlochan's notes.

Says - channel shifting; boundary created by joining fixed markers.

Establishes - boundary administratively fixed.

Does not establish - a final answer about ownership before the boundary was created.

4. Revenue registers.

Say - revenue name in Mishra family; in one year possession noted as Bhola.

Establish - revenue relationship and some recorded possession at particular moments.

Do not establish - the full nature of the social agreement.

5. Mandal family's paddy record.

Says - paddy to Mishra family "toward revenue payment."

Establishes - exchange of produce or payment.

Does not establish - with certainty whether this was sharecropping, rent, or another arrangement.

6. Household genealogy.

Says - Phoolmati lived in the house at the western field.

Establishes - written family memory of relationship/residence.

Does not establish - ownership of land.

7. Oral testimony.

Says - cultivation shifted with the channel; Mandal family remembered as long-term cultivators.

Establishes - living social memory and remembered use.

Does not establish - exact date, area, or legal right by itself.

8. Anamika's 2012 article.

Says - "unauthorised cultivator."

Establishes - an interpretation by an earlier researcher based on limited sources.

Does not establish - historical fact.

As she wrote the last line, Anamika's hand trembled.

Should she include her own article among the sources?

Why not?

It had become part of history too.

Someone could quote it.

If she concealed the error, the same problem would repeat itself.

Her uncle read the draft.

After two pages, he closed the file.

"This is no use to us."

"It is for verification."

"We need proof of our land."

"The judgment is there."

"Then write clearly: the land belongs to the Mishra family."

"As a historian I will not make a present-day legal declaration of ownership."

"The court already did."

"In 1926."

"So?"

"The current record and the legal authorities will decide the present position. I can only explain the meaning of the historical sources."

Her uncle became angry.

"Aren't you a daughter of this family?"

Anamika said very softly:

"I am. That is why I have to be more careful."

"Are the Mandal people this careful?"

"They can write their own report."

"You collected documents for their side."

"I collected all the documents."

Her uncle rose from his chair.

"Did your great-grandfather leave land so you could study against the family?"

Anamika raised her face.

"Great-grandfather himself wrote in his notes that the line would benefit the family."

Her uncle went still.

"What?"

Anamika put the notebook in front of him.

He read.

His face changed, but he immediately said:

"So what? Knowing that there would be a benefit means he committed an error?"

"No."

"Then?"

"Then I cannot say that the boundary was a perfectly impartial natural truth."

"A record was made. The court accepted it."

"Yes."

"That's all."

Anamika said wearily:

"For you, that is all. Not for history."

Her uncle walked out.

He did not eat dinner with them that night.

The next day Dinbandhu read the draft.

At first he was pleased.

Then on the sixth page his face fell.

"You have written: ownership not established."

"Yes."

"Why do you give oral testimony less weight?"

"Not less. A different kind."

"My grandmother lied?"

"The same question again."

"I want our land."

Anamika remained calm.

"I can give you history. Not land."

Dinbandhu became angry.

"Then what is the use of this research?"

"At least it reduces false claims."

"Does it not strengthen our side?"

"Some points do. Some do not."

"You have written that the Mishra court judgment is strong."

"As a legal judgment."

"Because of that the officer will accept their side."

"Possibly."

"Then history once again belongs to the side with papers."

Anamika was silent.

The accusation was not a light one.

She said:

"A historian cannot change the power of documents. But she can write the limits of documents."

Dinbandhu laughed.

"Will writing the limits return the land?"

"No."

"Then?"

Anamika had no answer.

Kamla Devi intervened.

"Dinu, this woman cannot fight every battle for us."

Dinbandhu fell silent.

Kamla turned to Anamika.

"Give the whole thing you have written. Do not cut anything."

"I will not."

"Your great-grandfather's words too?"

"Yes."

"Your old article?"

Anamika smiled.

"Yes."

For the first time Kamla looked at her with trust.

Not complete trust.

But some.

The hearing at the circle office drew only a small crowd.

It was for verification of names for highway compensation.

Before the officer lay the current jamabandi.

A copy of the court judgment.

Dinbandhu's objection.

Anamika's historical account had not been submitted with the consent of both families; she submitted it herself as an "independent research note."

The officer asked:

"Are you a party?"

"I am a member of one of the families, but this document declares the conflict of interest."

"What?"

Anamika showed the first page:

"The author is a descendant of the party currently recorded in the revenue register; this relationship should be kept in mind while reading the conclusions."

The officer raised his eyebrows.

"Few people write that about themselves."

Her uncle sat behind her, displeased.

Dinbandhu too.

The officer turned the pages.

"What are you ultimately saying? Whose land is it?"

Anamika took a deep breath.

"The 1926 judgment accepts ownership of the Mishra family. The present revenue entry is also in the name of the Mishra family. From a historical perspective, use before the judgment and the making of the boundary were more complex; there is evidence of long cultivation by the Mandal family and of a shifting channel. I am not deciding present legal ownership."

The officer said:

"Very academic."

"That is why I am a historian."

There was a little laughter in the room.

Her uncle did not laugh.

The officer turned to Dinbandhu.

"Submit your legal claim through the separate process. To stop compensation I need a competent order."

Dinbandhu looked toward his lawyer.

The hearing moved on.

Anamika understood: history was one part of the decision, not the decision itself.

Her report gave neither her uncle an immediate victory nor Dinbandhu one.

Both were dissatisfied.

Perhaps that was a strange proof of its usefulness.

But the story did not end there.

Four days after the hearing, Dinbandhu telephoned Anamika.

"We found something."

"What?"

"A small brick platform while cutting the old field ridge."

"Where?"

"Inside the red stakes."

Anamika went.

Under the earth was an old brick foundation about two feet wide.

Her uncle said:

"Some labourer's hut."

Dinbandhu said:

"Phoolmati's house."

"Proof?"

"The genealogy."

Anamika bent over the bricks.

Age of the bricks?

Impossible to know without examination.

Whose house?

Unknown.

Phoolmati?

Unknown.

But the household genealogy's phrase "house at the western field" had suddenly acquired a physical possibility.

She recorded only the location, measurements, and photographs.

Her uncle snapped:

"So now this has become a house?"

Anamika said:

"It is a brick foundation."

Dinbandhu said:

"Phoolmati's."

"I cannot write that yet."

Dinbandhu became annoyed.

"You stop everything."

"Because the moment I give it a name, the story is decided."

Her uncle said sarcastically:

"No names in history?"

"When there is evidence."

For one moment both men were irritated with Anamika for the same reason.

Inside, she laughed.

A local specialist examined a sample of the brick.

Estimated date: early to mid twentieth century.

That was all.

It did not prove Phoolmati.

But Neeraj posted a photograph online:

"Hundred-year-old house of Phoolmati Dadi found - proof of our right."

Her uncle's son Pranav immediately replied:

"False propaganda. Old labourer's shed."

Within two hours, history had become a war.

Anamika telephoned Neeraj.

"Correct the note."

"Why?"

"There is no proof."

"When your family says something false, then?"

"I will tell them too."

"It is not a house?"

"It could be a house foundation."

"Phoolmati?"

"Not certain."

Neeraj became irritated.

"Can life run on all this 'not certain'?"

Anamika said:

"Life runs. History stops and asks."

Neeraj did not remove the post.

But he added a correction underneath:
“According to family belief.”
It was a small victory.

Anamika wrote a corrective note to her 2012 article.

“In the earlier article, the term ‘unauthorised cultivator’ relied too heavily upon the court decision. Newly available or newly reread sources – the field-book, the local assistant’s notes, possession entries, the family genealogy, and oral history – show a more complex pattern of land use. The earlier terminology should be considered revised.”

The journal editor replied:

“A correction to a twelve-year-old article is unusual.”

Anamika wrote:

“Still necessary.”

The editor replied again:

“This is not a correction of a printing error. It could be published as a historiographical note.”

Anamika agreed.

She did not want to turn her error into a small typographical mistake.

The present Bariyar Patti dispute continued for three months.

Legal advice.

Record examination.

A fresh survey.

The highway project did not want delay.

In the fresh survey, the current khesra boundary, according to the court and revenue map, came out in the name of the Mishra family. Dinbandhu’s objection did not provide enough immediate documentation to change the ownership record.

Her uncle was pleased.

“See?”

Anamika said:

“That is the present administrative outcome.”

“Another ‘but’?”

“But the history is complicated.”

Her uncle burst out laughing.

“You have a disease of ‘but’.”

For the first time in three months, both laughed.

It now appeared likely that compensation would be approved in the Mishra family’s name.

Dinbandhu was disappointed.

But the fresh survey revealed something else.

The southern footpath did not appear on the government map as “customary public access,” yet on the ground it had clearly existed for more than forty years.

Dinbandhu asked:

“After the highway is built, will they close this path?”
 Her uncle said:
 “Why should I care?”
 “A buyer will come tomorrow.”
 Because there was a plan to sell the remaining part of Bariyar Patti.
 Anamika said:
 “At least make a written arrangement to keep the footpath open.”
 Her uncle was startled.
 “Then the land will be reduced.”
 “Not the area. A right of use.”
 “So now you are a lawyer?”
 “No. I am reading history.”
 “This path was given out of kindness—”
 Anamika stopped him.
 “You used that word three months ago.”
 Her uncle fell silent.
 Dinbandhu stood at a distance.
 Anamika continued:
 “Whatever the documents say, the footpath is a living use. Why leave the next
 dispute behind us?”
 Her uncle thought.
 The reason for the decision was not history alone.
 Practicality.
 Village relations.
 A future buyer.
 The panchayat.
 Everything.
 At last the family agreed: if the land were sold or transferred, the deed would
 include a condition that the southern footpath remain open.
 Dinbandhu said:
 “This will not return the land.”
 Anamika said:
 “No.”
 “Then what did we get?”
 Anamika said nothing.
 Kamla Devi, standing nearby, answered:
 “The path.”
 Dinbandhu looked at her.
 “I asked for the land.”
 Kamla said:
 “Fight the lawsuit. Save the path now.”
 It was not a complete solution.
 Justice? According to whose definition?
 Anamika did not decide.

Highway construction began.
The red stakes disappeared.
Heaps of earth.
Machines.
Four kathas of Bariyar Patti were swallowed into the new width of the road.
One day Anamika went to look.
Gravel had been laid where the possible old line of the channel had run.
No peepal.
No earth mound.
No bamboo clump.
The section of brick foundation was documented with photographs and measurements, then covered again with earth; there was no basis to stop the project.
Dinbandhu said:
“History has gone beneath the highway.”
Anamika said:
“Some of it.”
Her uncle said:
“Another ‘but?’”
All three laughed.
For the first time, together.
The laughter did not end the dispute.
It was only one moment.

Back at the university, Anamika began preparing a lecture on “the old lawsuit.”
On the first slide she did not place a photograph of the land.
Nor the court judgment.
Nor her great-grandfather’s notes.
She put five sentences:
“A court judgment speaks a legal conclusion.
A map speaks an administrative line from a particular time.
A revenue register speaks the state’s relationship.
A family genealogy speaks memory of relationship and residence.
Oral testimony speaks lived use and meaning.”
Below that:
“One source does not speak the language of another.”
A student asked:
“Madam, then where is the truth?”
Earlier, Anamika would have given a long answer to such a question.
This time she said:
“Between the sources.”
The student asked again:
“And the historian?”
Anamika paused.
She remembered her great-grandfather’s line:
“Know your own advantage and keep its name in your mind.”

She said:

"The historian too is not a god standing outside the sources. Her family, training, older writings, questions - all shape meaning. That is why one's own position must be declared."

A student asked:

"Is neutrality possible?"

Anamika said:

"Complete detachment, perhaps not. Discipline is possible: say only as much as a document says; do not add what it does not say; do not hide your own interest; and do not cut out inconvenient evidence."

She heard her own answer.

She had known the theory before.

After Bariyar Patti, the words had become heavier.

Six months later, there was a small ceremony at Dinbandhu's house - the birth of Neeraj's daughter.

Anamika was invited.

So was her uncle.

The two families, who at one time had rarely attended one another's weddings or funerals, were now completely normal with each other?

No.

But at the birth of a child, her uncle was eating sweets.

Jasoda Devi's sentence returned to Anamika:

"The land quarrel is separate, the feast separate."

Anamika smiled.

Dinbandhu asked:

"What?"

"Nothing."

"History again?"

"Yes."

On the veranda, Neeraj's daughter was asleep.

Kamla said:

"Shall we name her Phoolmati?"

Everyone laughed.

Neeraj said:

"No, we do not need that much history."

In the end she was named "Ira."

Anamika felt an inward sense of relief.

A year later, talk of selling the remaining land of Bariyar Patti began again.

The buyer was a businessman from the city.

He wanted to close the footpath and fence the whole property.

Her uncle showed him the deed.

"There is a condition. A three-hand-wide path on the south remains open."

The businessman said:
 “Why, on privately owned land?”
 Her uncle was silent for a moment, then said:
 “It is customary use.”
 Anamika heard him and smiled.
 Earlier her uncle had said: “Kindness.”
 Now: “Customary use.”
 A word had changed.
 Was that all history could do?
 Sometimes, change a word and make room for a practice.
 The businessman wanted to lower the price.
 Her uncle refused.
 The sale fell through.
 Pranav was angry.
 “A deal worth lakhs, because of a three-hand path?”
 Her uncle said:
 “The next man will fight another lawsuit.”
 Anamika said nothing.
 History had become an economic argument.

The district archives asked Anamika to deposit digital copies of the Bariyar Patti documents.

She made three groups:
 “Court file.”
 “Survey/Revenue.”
 “Private family papers.”
 The Mandal family was hesitant at first about depositing its papers.
 Dinbandhu asked:
 “If we deposit them, could someone use them against us?”
 “Possible.”
 “And if we do not?”
 “The papers could be destroyed at home.”
 Kamla said:
 “Give copies. Keep the originals at home.”

Anamika said:
 “And add a clear condition: source belongs to the family; interpretation remains open.”

What about her own family’s great-grandfather’s notebook?
 Her uncle refused at first.
 Then he gave permission for a copy.
 “That line too?” Anamika asked.
 “Which one?”
 “The family’s benefit.”
 Her uncle glared at her.
 “You will never leave it.”

“No.”

Her uncle sighed.

“Give it.”

At that moment Anamika saw her uncle connected to her great-grandfather for the first time - both knew the document could make the family's position more difficult, yet in the end both allowed it to remain.

Neutrality?

No.

Honest discomfort?

Possibly.

A new file was opened in the archives:

“Kachanama Bariyar Patti: Multi-Source Collection.”

On the first page, Anamika's note:

“This collection does not decide the present ownership dispute; it is for preservation of the available historical sources.”

Second:

“The sources are mutually conflicting and/or operate at different levels.”

Third:

“Collector Anamika Mishra is related by descent to one party in the dispute; this interest is declared.”

The archivist read it and said:

“You will write a dispute next to your own name like this?”

“Yes.”

“The next researcher may think you were biased.”

“Let them.”

“Then?”

“At least it will not be hidden.”

The archivist stamped the page.

Thump.

A new piece of paper entered history.

The sound made Anamika shiver.

A hundred years later, how seriously would someone read that stamp?

Would someone lift one sentence from her note and make it serve their own side?

Would someone say, “Anamika Mishra herself admitted...”?

She could not control the future reader.

She could only leave context behind.

That evening she went to Bariyar Patti.

Vehicles moved along the highway.

Four kathas had become road.

Wheat grew in the remaining field.

The three-hand-wide southern footpath remained open.

A small boy came pushing a bicycle along the path.

Seeing the new red boundary stake, he asked:

“What is this?”

Dinbandhu, who was in the field, said:

“Boundary.”

The boy asked:

“Where was it before?”

Dinbandhu laughed.

“Ask Professor Didi.”

Anamika went over to the boy.

“At different times, there were different things before.”

“What do you mean?”

She thought: a child does not need a hundred-year lawsuit.

“When water flowed here, people watched the water. When the survey came, a line was made. When the court decided, the paper became stronger. Now there is this stake.”

The boy touched the stake.

“Is this the real one?”

Anamika paused before answering.

“For the present survey - yes.”

“Forever?”

“No one knows that.”

The boy pushed his bicycle away.

Dinbandhu laughed.

“Even to a child: ‘not certain.’”

Anamika said:

“Why give him false certainty?”

Her uncle was approaching from a distance with a walking stick.

The three stood together.

Her uncle looked at the land.

“If Great-grandfather saw all this, what would he say?”

Anamika remembered the sentence in the notebook.

“Perhaps he would say: one line must be written.”

Dinbandhu said:

“And I would say: water will not obey the line.”

Her uncle smiled.

“And the court?”

Anamika said:

“It will read the line available to it.”

All three fell silent.

The sun was low.

A light wind moved over the heads of the wheat.

Two women carrying bundles of grass walked along the footpath - neither Mandal nor Mishra, simply people of the village.

No one stopped them.

Anamika wondered: had the old lawsuit ended?

The legal document would say: in 1926.

Family memory would say: still not.
The highway department would say: after compensation.
The archives would say: the file remains open.
History might say only this:
many kinds of right, use, memory, and document can exist at once upon a single
piece of land.
Sometimes a court chooses one line.
Sometimes a family chooses one story.
Sometimes a historian chooses one word.
The error begins when the chosen thing is mistaken for the whole world.
Anamika took out her phone and photographed the boundary stake.
Then the footpath.
Then the old mango stump.
She placed all three photographs in one file.
None of them was titled "The Real Boundary."
The first:
"Current survey stake, date."
The second:
"Southern footpath, customary use, date."
The third:
"Old stump, local directional memory, date."
That was all.
This time she knew:
to give something a name is itself a decision.
She closed the file.
The old lawsuit was not closed.
But now its papers were a little less alone.

The Night of the Fair

The Basaha Fair ran for three nights once a year. By day there were cattle markets, agricultural tools, cloth, sweets, toys. As evening fell came the swings, folk songs, plays, flutes, music, the smell of hot oil, dust, and the feet of thousands of people.

Manjari Karn disappeared at that fair.

“Disappeared” was not the word anyone used until half past ten on the first night.

Seven o'clock - “She got separated in the crowd.”

Eight - “She must have gone toward some shop with someone.”

Nine - “Why is her phone switched off?”

Ten - “She hasn't reached home?”

Half past ten - “Missing.”

By dawn:

“Kidnapping?”

“She ran away?”

“Love affair?”

“Fear of marriage?”

“A gang at the fair?”

“Caught a bus to the city?”

“Someone lured her away?”

That night Manjari existed inside all those stories.

She alone was absent to tell her own.

Manjari was twenty-four. After graduating, she had completed a one-year course in library science, but had no permanent job. Sometimes she prepared temporary catalogues for schools, sometimes organised a panchayat reading room, sometimes stayed at home.

At home were her mother Sunaina, her father Harinarayan, and her younger brother Neeraj.

Three months earlier, a marriage arrangement had been almost settled. The groom: Amit, employed at a bank in Muzaffarpur. Good family. Good income. Good house. The young man looked fine in his photograph.

Manjari's answer?

“Let us talk for now.”

Her family treated that sentence as the first step toward “yes.”

For Manjari, it actually meant: let us talk for now.

Her mother said:

“Daughter, you won't find such a good family again.”

Manjari said:

“I am not saying no.”

Her father:

“Then?”

"I want six months."

"Why?"

"There is a job opportunity."

"Where?"

"A six-month contract for a girls' hostel reading room in Darbhanga. Along with catalogue training."

Her father did not laugh.

"You will postpone marriage for a six-month job?"

Manjari was silent.

Neeraj said:

"You can work after marriage too."

Manjari asked:

"Has anyone asked Amit?"

No one had.

The next day Amit's family was consulted. The reply came:

"We have no objection to her working after marriage, but first we will see the circumstances at home."

Manjari disliked the word "see."

But was that reason enough to end the marriage arrangement?

Possibly not.

She remained inside that "possibly."

On the day of the fair, Manjari went with her childhood friend Sushma.

Sushma was married and had a two-year-old daughter. Her parental home was five kos from Basaha. She had come especially to walk through the fair with Manjari.

"This is the first time since marriage I've got to roam this fair alone," Sushma said, laughing.

"Alone?" Manjari pointed toward the child.

"She does not count."

They looked at bangles.

Ate papad.

Saw wooden toys.

Stopped at a small bookstall where old competitive-exam guides, religious booklets, and children's stories lay side by side.

Manjari bought a cheap cloth shoulder bag.

Sushma asked:

"Why? You have ten at home."

"This one is light."

"For walking around the fair?"

"Yes."

Sushma paid no attention.

Two hours later, that same bag would become the police's first question:

"Did she buy it for travelling?"

Sushma would say:

"I didn't understand that then."

Memory often acquires meaning after the event.

By six in the evening, the crowd around the swings had become dense. Sushma's daughter began to cry. Sushma took her in her arms and went to look for water.

"Stay near this red flag," Sushma said.

Manjari laughed.

"Am I five years old?"

"Look at the crowd."

"Fine."

Sushma returned in five or seven minutes.

Manjari was not there.

At first she thought nothing of it.

The glass-bangle stall.

The sweet shop.

The books.

The swings.

She telephoned.

The phone rang.

No one answered.

Then it was switched off.

A slight unease entered Sushma.

She waited beside the red flag for fifteen minutes.

Then began asking the shopkeepers.

One woman said:

"Blue kurta?"

"Yes."

"She went that way."

That way opened into five different paths.

Sushma tightened her hold on the child.

Razia Khatoon, who ran the bangle stall at the fair, remembered Manjari clearly.

Why?

Because Manjari did not buy bangles.

She came to the stall, looked at red and green bangles, tried a pair on her wrist, then took them off.

Razia said:

"For the wedding? This colour will look good."

Manjari laughed.

"There isn't a wedding yet."

"There will be."

"Everyone is in such a hurry."

Razia laughed.

"I sell bangles. I don't hurry people."

Manjari stood there for another two minutes. Then she asked:

“Maasi, which way is the main bus stand from the fair?”

Razia pointed.

“Straight through the eastern gate. But it is crowded at night.”

“A safe place for a woman to stay if she misses the bus?”

Razia looked at her carefully.

“Where are you going?”

Manjari did not answer at once.

“If the bus is missed.”

Razia said:

“There is a Mithila Women’s Rest House near the bus stand, but I don’t know whether there will be a vacancy. My niece stays in a hostel near the railway station.”

Manjari nodded.

“Name?”

“Kusum Hostel.”

“Thank you.”

Razia considered the conversation ordinary.

People at a fair asked directions.

A woman asking about a safe place to stay at night was not extraordinary.

But when the police came the next day, every question made that scene mysterious.

“Did she look frightened?”

“Was she avoiding someone?”

“Any man following her?”

“Did she change clothes?”

“Count money?”

“Say anyone’s name?”

The more Razia thought, the cloudier memory became.

At last she said:

“Write only what I saw. She was alone. She asked the way. She asked for a safe place for a woman to stay. I did not see any man with her.”

“Her face?”

“Normal.”

“What does normal mean?”

Razia became irritated.

“I sell bangles. I do not do psychology on faces.”

The constable laughed.

Razia did not.

At seven that night Sushma telephoned Manjari’s mother.

“Maasi, I haven’t been able to find Manjari for a while.”

At first Sunaina said:

“She must be at some shop.”

“Her phone is off.”

“Battery dead?”

“Possible.”

“Don’t leave the fair.”

“I won’t.”

At eight Harinarayan and Neeraj arrived on a motorcycle.

The first thing Neeraj asked was:

“Who did she go with?”

Sushma stared.

“What do you mean?”

“Some boy?”

“I don’t know.”

“You are her friend. You don’t know?”

Sushma snapped:

“Does being a friend mean I can read every page of her mind?”

Harinarayan stopped them.

“Not now.”

All four searched the fair.

At the announcement booth her name was called:

“Manjari Karn, age twenty-four, blue kurta, white dupatta...”

The announcement went out three times.

No one came.

At half past nine they went to the police outpost.

Sub-Inspector Premrata Yadav was on duty.

She looked at the photograph.

Name, age, clothing, phone number.

Then asked:

“She is an adult?”

Harinarayan’s face changed.

“Yes. But my daughter is missing.”

“I am recording that. Do you suspect anyone?”

Neeraj answered immediately:

“There are many outsiders at the fair.”

Premrata stopped writing.

“Any particular person?”

“No.”

“Marriage fixed?”

A slight silence filled the room.

Sunaina said:

“Talks are going on.”

Neeraj said:

“Almost fixed.”

Sushma remembered Manjari’s “six months.”

Premrata asked:

“Does Manjari ji agree?”

Sunaina answered at once:

“Yes.”

Sushma looked at her.

"Completely?" Premlata asked.
Sunaina paused.
"Girls are naturally hesitant about marriage."
Something snapped inside Sushma.
Manjari had not said "hesitation."
She had asked for time.
But this was a police outpost.
Night.
The family was frightened.
Sushma said nothing then.
That was her first silence.

Premalata Yadav's experience told her: an adult young woman disappears, the family immediately says "kidnapping," people around them immediately say "love affair," and some police personnel immediately say "she must have gone willingly."

All three easy conclusions were dangerous.

She told Woman Constable Seema:

"Send the photograph to the fair gates, bus stand, road to the railway station, and hospitals."

Neeraj asked:

"Trace her phone location."

"We are starting the procedure."

"Quickly."

Premalata looked at him.

"For me too, she is a missing person. But let one thing be clear: if she has gone of her own free will, that is not a crime."

Neeraj said at once:

"She would never do that."

Sunaina said softly:

"Never."

Sushma stayed silent again.

Premalata looked at her.

"You are her friend?"

"Yes."

"We will speak separately."

Neeraj interrupted:

"She can speak in front of us."

Premalata said calmly:

"In an inquiry, separate conversations are normal."

Neeraj was displeased.

Sushma sat with Premalata on a chair outside.

"Anything the family does not know?"

Sushma remained silent for a long time.

"She was not happy about the marriage."

"Refused?"

"Not clearly. She wanted six months."

"Why?"

"A job in Darbhanga."

"The family knows?"

"Yes."

"Any plan to meet someone today?"

"She didn't tell me."

"Money?"

Sushma suddenly remembered that before coming to the fair Manjari had asked:

"How much cash do you have?"

Sushma had said:

"Two thousand."

Manjari:

"Can you give me five hundred?"

Sushma had given it to her.

"I'll return it when we reach home."

Sushma told the police.

"I gave her five hundred."

"Why?"

"I didn't ask."

"The bag?"

"She bought it at the fair."

"Did she put anything into it?"

"Not in front of me."

Premlata wrote.

Then Sushma suddenly said:

"I think she may have gone of her own choice."

The moment the sentence left her mouth, guilt came.

Her friend was missing.

And she was saying "willingly."

Premlata only asked:

"Why?"

"Because she wanted some space. To make a decision."

"Running from whom?"

Sushma answered immediately:

"I did not use the word running."

Premlata nodded.

"Fine."

The difference mattered.

At eleven that night, Manjari's room was searched.

At first, only a phone charging cable.

Her clothes looked normal.

The original file of certificates was missing.

Sunaina was startled.

"The certificates?"

Neeraj searched the cupboard.

"Not here."

"When did she take them?"

No one knew.

Sushma knew that three days earlier Manjari had said:

"I should put the original certificates in plastic."

Sushma had joked:

"To show at the wedding?"

Manjari had laughed.

"For work."

That night the missing certificates suddenly seemed to have a clear meaning.

But then -

had the plan existed from before?

Sunaina looked beneath the bed and pulled out an old clothes trunk.

Inside lay a book: Introduction to Library Classification. A folded paper was tucked into it.

Neeraj opened it.

At the top:

"For Ma and Babu."

Sunaina took the paper from his hand.

The letter was short.

"I am leaving home of my own will in an attempt to keep myself safe. I do not wish to make a decision about my marriage yet. I do not want to lose the six-month work opportunity. Do not try to search for me, catch me, and bring me back. I will speak myself when I have had time. Do not accuse anyone because of me. Sushma is not responsible for this decision."

Below:

"Manjari."

Date?

Five days before the fair.

The room went silent.

Neeraj read the first sentence and said:

"See! She ran away."

Sunaina shouted:

"Do not use the word ran again."

"Then what?"

"She wrote: work."

"Where?"

"Not written."

Harinarayan sat down.

One line of the letter struck him like a hammer:

"Do not try to search for me, catch me, and bring me back."

He asked:

"Did I frighten her this much?"

No one answered.

Sushma read the paper, stunned.
She had not known about Manjari's plan.
Why was her name in the letter?
"Sushma is not responsible."
That meant Manjari had expected blame to fall on her friend.
Sushma's eyes filled.
Neeraj said:
"Give this to the police."
Sunaina crushed the letter in her fist.
"No."
Everyone looked at her.
"Why?" Harinarayan asked.
After a few moments Sunaina said:
"Find her first."
Neeraj understood.
"Ma, if the police get the letter, they'll say she left willingly."
"And if someone forced her to write it?"
"It is dated five days earlier."
"Does a paper prove everything?"
Sushma kept looking at Sunaina.
Was this motherhood?
Prestige?
Fear?
All three?
Sunaina herself possibly did not know.

At one in the morning Premlata's phone rang.
Sushma.
"A letter has been found."
"Send a photograph."
Sushma paused.
"The family at present—"
"Sushma ji, in a missing-person inquiry the letter is important."
Sushma said:
"I am sending the photograph."
She sent it against the family's wishes.
The second silence broke.
When Neeraj found out, he exploded.
"Who gave you the right?"
Sushma shouted back:
"Manjari named me in the letter - I am not responsible! The police are going to question me anyway. Am I supposed to hide the paper?"
Sunaina said nothing.
Harinarayan said:
"She did the right thing."

Neeraj went outside.

Inside a single incident, the family was dividing into different sides.

Once the police read the letter, their language changed.

One constable said:

“Madam, she has gone voluntarily. The matter is clear.”

Premalata said:

“No.”

“There is a letter.”

“It is five days old. Whether she is safe now is not established.”

“She is an adult.”

“Which means she may stay where she wishes. But first, independent verification that she is alive and safe.”

“The family?”

“We will tell them the letter has been found and the inquiry continues.”

She separated the lines in the letter:

1. A plan to leave home by choice.
2. A wish to postpone the marriage decision.
3. Six months' work.
4. An attempt to protect Sushma from blame.
5. No location.
6. No mode of travel.
7. No mention of going with anyone.

The letter said a great deal.

It also did not.

Premalata kept the difference in view.

At four in the morning, information came from the bus-stand outpost:

Around seven on the fair night, a young woman in a blue kurta had asked about a bus to Darbhanga.

“Did she board?”

“The first bus was full and left. The second was at nine, but it was cancelled because of a breakdown.”

“Nine?”

“Yes.”

“The young woman?”

“I remember seeing someone until around eight. Not certain.”

The bus employee's memory was weak in the crowd.

A tea seller said:

“A young woman was sitting alone.”

“Photograph?”

“Could be.”

“With anyone?”

“I didn't see.”

“Where did she go?”
“I was selling tea.”
The same limit again.

By morning the police had heard Razia the bangle seller's account.
“Kusum Hostel.”

Premlata immediately informed the local outpost.

Kusum Hostel, near the railway station, gave rooms to working women and students. Entry after eight was restricted, though the gates had remained open late on fair night.

There was no “Manjari Karn” in the register.

“Fake name?” a constable asked.

The manager said:

“We do not rent rooms without identification.”

“Did a young woman come late asking?”

The guard did not remember.

Fair crowds.

The first lead ended.

Premlata asked Razia again:

“You gave her the hostel's name, but she did not reach it.”

Razia snapped:

“I gave directions. I did not escort her there.”

The police fell silent too.

It was easy to turn a witness into a guide to the whole story.

She had witnessed only one conversation.

The next morning, posters bearing Manjari's photograph appeared at Amarahi Chowk.

Neeraj had written:

“MISSING YOUNG WOMAN. POSSIBLE ABDUCTION.”

The moment Premlata saw them she said:

“Remove ‘possible abduction.’”

“Why?”

“There is no evidence.”

“She is missing.”

“Write that.”

“People won't pay attention.”

“Why attract attention with a false claim?”

Neeraj said angrily:

“If the police's own daughter or sister vanished, you would understand.”

Premlata did not harden her face.

“I understand fear. I also understand the effect of words.”

“Effect on whom?”

"On Sushma, whom people have begun to suspect. On any innocent person. On Manjari ji herself."

"Where is she?"

"We are looking."

Neeraj was not prepared to change the poster.

Then Harinarayan said:

"Remove 'abduction.'"

Neeraj looked at his father.

"Babu?"

"You read the letter."

"Is the letter the final truth?"

Harinarayan said:

"No. But abduction is not either."

This was the first change in the family's language.

At home, while folding Manjari's clothes, Sunaina remembered a conversation from ten days earlier.

In the kitchen Manjari had said:

"Ma, what if I do not marry now?"

Sunaina, cutting vegetables, had answered:

"What will people say?"

Manjari fell silent.

Sunaina had immediately corrected herself:

"I mean - there will be pressure on Babu."

Manjari said:

"Why is 'people' the first answer?"

Sunaina became irritated.

"You turn everything into an examination."

Manjari did not laugh.

Now that conversation came back to Sunaina like a knife.

Had the mother placed reputation above her daughter?

No - she would say at once.

But the first sentence?

"What will people say?"

The first sentence of the mind often reveals the real rule of a household.

Sunaina did not keep a diary.

So the incident existed only in memory.

She decided to tell the police.

When Premlata came to the house, Sunaina herself said:

"There is something I did not tell you earlier."

Neeraj was displeased.

Sunaina recounted the whole conversation.

"Manjari did not want the marriage?" Premlata asked.

"Not now."

"There is a difference."

“Yes.”

“Family pressure?”

Sunaina lowered her eyes.

“I thought it was normal persuasion. To her it may have felt like pressure.”

The sentence was difficult for her to say.

Premlata only wrote it down.

Sushma did not return to her own home. She stayed at her parental home near the fair and helped in the search.

Again and again she remembered her five hundred rupees.

If Manjari had planned this in advance, why had she not said anything?

How close was their friendship?

Did Manjari not trust her?

Pain brought humiliation with it.

Then the name in the letter:

“Sushma is not responsible.”

Perhaps the trust had been enough for Manjari to want to protect her.

Perhaps she knew Sushma would stop her.

Sushma kept questioning herself.

A year earlier, Manjari had said:

“You were very quiet on your wedding day.”

Sushma had laughed:

“There was a war inside.”

“Did you want to run away?”

“No.”

“To refuse?”

Sushma had joked:

“After the wedding party had reached the courtyard?”

Now she wondered: Manjari had kept talking to her about marriage, but Sushma had answered by measuring everything against her own experience.

“Everyone is afraid.”

“It becomes fine after marriage.”

“Leaving home is difficult at first.”

Was this advice, or another language of pressure?

Sushma was the police’s witness as a friend.

But she was also examining her own story.

By the afternoon of the second day there was a new piece of information.

A bookstall owner at the fair said:

“A young woman in a blue kurta bought an envelope.”

When?

Around five.

The letter at home was dated five days earlier.

An envelope?

The letter had been found inside a book, without an envelope.
 Then a second letter?
 Police interest increased.
 Questioned again, the bookseller said:
 "I sell ten white envelopes a day. I don't remember the face clearly."
 "The photograph?"
 "Looks like her."
 Looks like.
 The constable became excited.
 "A letter to whom?"
 Premrata stopped him.
 "First establish whether it was the same young woman."
 Within another five minutes the bookseller began saying, "Yes, it was her."
 Premrata grew more cautious.
 Memory takes the shape of the question.
 She recorded:
 "Possible; not confirmed."
 The envelope did not become a lead.

By the second night, Manjari's phone remained switched off.
 Telecom data showed the last signal near the eastern gate of the fair at half past
 six. After that the device went dark.
 The family's fear grew again.
 The letter said she had gone willingly.
 But why switch off the phone?
 If safe, why not send one message?
 Premrata too was uncomfortable with the question.
 An adult's privacy.
 A family's anxiety.
 Independent verification of safety.
 All three had to be balanced.
 She telephoned the library training centre in Darbhanga.
 "Manjari Karn?"
 "Her name is on the selected list. Reporting date is five days from now."
 "Has she come early?"
 "No."
 So she had not yet reached the place of the job she intended to take.
 The letter's "six-month work" was true.
 But where had the journey gone?

On the second night, while packing up her stall, Razia Khatoon telephoned her
 niece Nusrat.
 "No young woman named Manjari reached Kusum Hostel?"
 "No."

“Anyone come asking on fair night?”

Nusrat said:

“Maasi, one young woman came as far as the gate that night. No room was available. Her name sounded like ‘Manju’.”

Razia’s heart quickened.

“Clothes?”

“Blue? I don’t remember. It was dark.”

“Where did she go?”

“The manager told her to try the women’s rest house.”

Razia immediately told the police.

The Mithila Women’s Rest House was behind the bus stand.

Its register was checked.

One entry from that night:

“Manju Kumari, District Madhubani, one night.”

Identification?

“Last four digits - 4721.”

The last four digits of Manjari’s identification card?

The family was asked.

4721.

The first solid match.

Premlata breathed out.

The register recorded departure:

5:40 in the morning.

Destination?

Not written.

The manager remembered:

“A quiet young woman. Came late at night. Said she had missed a bus. One small bag, one plastic document file.”

“Alone?”

“Yes.”

“Frightened?”

“Tired.”

“Did she telephone anyone?”

“Not in front of me.”

“In the morning?”

“Drank tea and left. Asked where the bus for Samastipur departed from.”

Samastipur?

The family was stunned.

The job was in Darbhanga.

Travel apparently toward Samastipur.

The letter was incomplete again.

Neeraj said:

“See? Some other place.”

Sushma said:

“Does she have a college friend in Samastipur?”

One of Manjari's former classmates, Vandana, worked at a women's education centre near Samastipur.

Sunaina said:

"I have heard that name."

The police telephoned.

Vandana:

"Manjari? We haven't spoken in six months."

"Did she come?"

"No."

Another lead ended.

In fact, Manjari did not go to Samastipur.

She left the rest house and reached the bus stand.

The Samastipur bus stood in front of her.

The Darbhanga bus was two hours later.

She sat on a bench.

In the letter she had written:

"I do not want to lose the six-month work opportunity."

But reporting at the training centre was five days away.

She had no permanent place to stay yet.

Cash: three thousand seven hundred rupees.

Sushma's five hundred kept separate.

Certificates.

Phone switched off.

In the rest house at night she saw her plan for the first time outside the paper.

On paper the plan was straight:

Leave home.

Darbhangha.

Work.

Six months.

Talk later.

In life:

First bus full.

Second cancelled.

Hostel full.

Rest house for only one night.

What would she do in Darbhanga five days early?

The family would search.

If she went to Darbhanga, they might find her at once.

She had asked about the Samastipur bus because Vandana lived there - at least a woman she knew.

But when it was time to board, she did not telephone Vandana.

Why?

Six months without contact.

What would she suddenly say: "I have left home"?

With one foot on the bus step, she came back down.

The conductor snapped:

“Are you boarding or not?”

Manjari stepped away.

Ten minutes later she was drinking tea.

Then an elderly woman asked:

“Daughter, where are you going?”

From Manjari’s mouth came:

“I don’t know.”

It was the first wholly true sentence she had spoken since the previous night.

The elderly woman laughed.

“Then a bus stand is not a good place.”

Her name was Urmila Devi. Retired from a government school. Waiting for a bus to her sister’s house.

During the conversation Manjari learned that Urmila had once been associated with an organisation in Darbhanga city called “Sakhi Women’s Residence” – temporary accommodation for women coming for work or examinations.

Manjari stared.

“Would I get a place for two or four days?”

Urmila looked at her carefully.

“Do you have documents?”

“Yes.”

“Are you running from someone?”

Manjari answered at once:

“No.”

“Does your family know?”

Manjari was silent.

Urmila sighed.

“Then first telephone home.”

“Not now.”

“Why?”

“If I telephone, they will come and take me back.”

“You are an adult?”

“Twenty-four.”

“Does anyone beat you?”

“No.”

“Marriage?”

Manjari lowered her eyes.

Urmila understood.

“I will not hide you. The institution will house you according to rules. Identification, local verification.”

“Fine.”

“If police are searching for you?”

Manjari’s stomach tightened.

“Have I committed a crime?”

“No. But if a missing-person report has been made, it is good to inform them that you are safe.”

Manjari was not ready yet.

She wrote down the address from Urmila.

Then boarded the Darbhanga bus.

But after getting off at the main bus stand, she did not go directly to the training centre.

She went to Sakhi Women’s Residence.

A room was available.

Identification.

Five days’ advance payment.

Emergency contact?

On the form she began to write Sushma’s number.

Stopped.

Mother?

Stopped.

At last, Urmila Devi’s institutional contact.

The manager said:

“A home number is necessary.”

Manjari’s hand trembled.

She wrote her mother’s number.

But requested:

“Please do not telephone now. I will call myself.”

The manager said:

“Not unless there is an emergency.”

Manjari got the room.

She was safe.

But she had not told her family.

The moral weight of that fact did not let her sleep that night.

On the third morning Manjari switched on her phone.

One hundred and thirteen missed calls.

Messages.

Sushma.

Ma.

Babu.

Neeraj.

Amit.

Unknown numbers.

Police.

She switched it off again at once.

Five minutes later, switched it on once more.

A message from Sushma:

“If you are safe, just write that much. I will not ask where you are.”

Another:

"The police are searching. The letter was found."

A third:

"They are no longer blaming me. Please just let us know you are safe."

For the first time Manjari began to cry.

She had wanted the letter to protect Sushma.

By not saying where she was, she had left her friend in hell for two nights.

She typed:

"I am safe."

Before sending, she stopped.

If Sushma told the family immediately?

Of course she would.

Then what?

She did not send the message.

Writing a letter on paper had been easy.

Typing "safe" on a phone was difficult.

She looked at the unknown police number.

Call the police directly?

Urmila Devi had spoken of procedure.

Manjari telephoned the local women's helpline.

Gave her name.

Age.

District.

Said:

"A missing-person report may have been made for me. I am away from home of my own choice. I am safe. My family may be told that I am safe, but not my location for now."

The woman officer asked:

"Anyone forcing you?"

"No."

"Anyone with you?"

"No."

"Injury?"

"No."

"May a local woman police officer meet you to verify the location and your safety?"

Manjari paused.

"Yes."

An hour later a local woman constable came to Sakhi Residence.

Identification matched.

A separate statement from Manjari.

"Adult, safe, staying by choice."

Then information was sent to Basaha police station.

Premalata's phone rang.

"Manjari Karn has been found safe. Adult. Staying voluntarily."

The local officer paused.

"She requests that her location not be shared with the family yet."

Premlata said:

"I need the verification details officially. We will tell the family she is safe. Her location will not be made public without her consent."

Three days of searching changed into one sentence:

"Safe."

Premlata leaned back in her chair.

Relief.

And the next difficulty - the family.

When Sunaina was told:

"Manjari is safe,"

she cried first.

Then asked:

"Where?"

Premlata said:

"The place has been verified. She does not want it shared yet."

"I am her mother."

"I know."

"The police will hide my daughter from her mother?"

"She is an adult."

"Will I snatch her away?"

Premlata was silent.

Sunaina heard her own sentence.

"Do not try to search for me, catch me, and bring me back."

The letter.

She sat down.

Harinarayan asked:

"Can you connect us by phone?"

"When she is ready."

Neeraj said angrily:

"This law is mad."

Premlata remained calm.

"She is safe. At this moment that is the main thing."

"And the family's rights?"

"She has rights too."

"Are we criminals?"

"That is not the question in this inquiry."

Sushma was listening outside.

She drew a long breath.

For the first time in three days, her body loosened.

After the police verification, Manjari sent Sushma one sentence:

"I am safe. Forgive me."

Sushma answered at once:

"Forgiveness later. Stay alive."

Then:

"Why didn't you tell me?"

Manjari wrote and erased for a long time.

At last:

"If I had told you, you would have stopped me."

Sushma:

"Possibly."

"That is why."

"But I spent three nights on the road with my child during the search."

Manjari's eyes filled.

She wrote:

"I had not thought of that."

Sushma:

"In the letter you wrote as though you had thought of everything."

Manjari stared at the screen.

That was true.

In the letter, Manjari was firm, orderly, planned.

The real Manjari had changed her decision three times at the bus stand.

Had said "I don't know" to a stranger.

Switched her phone on and off.

Been afraid even to send Sushma a message.

The letter was not a copy of her mind.

The letter was a tool for making a boundary.

She replied:

"On paper a sentence has to be written whole. My mind was only half complete then."

After a long time Sushma wrote:

"Keep that sentence."

"Where?"

"For yourself."

The first family telephone call came four days later.

Manjari spoke first with her mother.

When Sunaina answered, she could not say anything.

Manjari said:

"Ma."

That was all.

Both began to cry.

After some time Sunaina asked:

"Are you eating?"

Manjari laughed and cried at the same time.

"Yes."

"Is the place all right?"

"Yes."

"Any person—"
 "Ma, I am not with any man."
 Sunaina was embarrassed.
 "I didn't mean—"
 "Everyone asks that."
 Silence.
 Then Sunaina said:
 "Why did you write the letter five days earlier?"
 "Because five days earlier I had more courage."
 "And on the day of the fair?"
 "Less."
 "Then why did you go?"
 Manjari was silent for a long time.
 "Because if I had not gone that day, perhaps I would not have been able to go at all."
 "Would I have stopped you?"
 "Yes."
 Sunaina's voice was hurt.
 "Me?"
 Manjari softened.
 "Ma, you would have stopped me with love. But you would still have stopped me."
 Sunaina had no words.
 Then:
 "The marriage?"
 "Not now."
 "Amit?"
 "I will speak to him myself."
 "People?"
 Manjari was silent.
 Sunaina recognised her own word.
 "All right," she said. "People later."
 For Manjari, that small sentence was the first new door in the house.

The conversation with Harinarayan was harder.
 "Daughter, you should at least have told me."
 "Yes."
 "Would I have hit you?"
 "No."
 "Locked you in?"
 Manjari remained silent.
 Harinarayan understood.
 "I would probably have said: wait five days, let the relatives come, talk, then we will see."
 "And in five days?"
 "I don't know."

"That is why."
Harinarayan sighed.
"Was I wrong?"
Manjari did not answer immediately.
"We were all in the same house, each living inside a different fear."
"That sounds like a book."
Manjari smiled faintly.
"I work in libraries."
The first laughter.
Then her father asked:
"When does the job begin?"
"In five days."
"Accommodation?"
"Arranged."
"Money?"
"I have enough for now."
"If you run short, ask."
Manjari's throat tightened.
"All right."
"When will you come home?"
"Let the work begin. Later."
Harinarayan did not press.
That was a difficult decision on his side.

She spoke to Neeraj a week later.
"Why didn't you tell me?"
"You kept advising me in Amit's favour."
"I was thinking practically—"
"Fine."
"I thought it was a good match."
"Are you going to correct many words today?"
"Yes."
Neeraj laughed, then became serious.
"I had put up posters saying kidnapping."
"I saw."
"How?"
"Sushma sent a photograph."
"I was frightened."
"I know."
"The police made me remove it."
"They were right."
"Do you think I was wrong?"
Manjari said:
"At that time you misunderstood me."
Neeraj was silent.

"I kept telling everyone: you ran away."

"I left home."

"Difference?"

"A lot."

Neeraj thought.

"Explain."

Manjari said:

"'Ran away' makes it sound as though I fled from someone in fear, without a plan. 'Left home' says I made a decision, even if it was incomplete."

"But you changed your plan three times at the bus stand."

Manjari laughed.

"Sushma told you everything?"

"Some."

"An incomplete decision is still a decision."

Neeraj said slowly:

"Fine."

Complete reconciliation?

No.

But the word changed.

Manjari spoke to Amit herself.

"I will not marry now."

Amit was silent for a long time.

"My family has been humiliated."

"I know."

"Disappearing on the night of the fair?"

"Yes."

"You could have told me something."

"I did not have the courage to tell my own family. How could I tell you?"

Amit's voice hardened.

"Then marriage was not the right decision."

"Possibly not."

"Still possibly?"

Manjari laughed.

"Now I am certain - not at this time."

Amit said:

"Fine."

He did not abuse her.

Did not threaten.

Did not become a saint.

He was simply disappointed.

Manjari felt relief and guilt together.

For a relationship to end, the person on the other side does not have to be a villain.

Later, Razia the fair stallholder heard that Manjari was safe.

She said:

“Good.”

A police constable joked:

“You gave her the name of a hostel, but the young woman ended up at another residence.”

Razia snapped:

“I gave a direction, not destiny.”

Premlata overheard and smiled.

Razia added:

“Will my statement remain in the file?”

“Yes.”

“Then write clearly - I saw no man with her.”

“It is written.”

“And this too - her face looked normal.”

The constable laughed.

“You argued about the word normal earlier.”

Razia said:

“Now I understand. If someone writes ‘frightened,’ the whole story becomes different.”

Premlata nodded.

A single word can turn a witness into a story.

When closing the police file, Premlata wrote the final note:

“The missing person was independently verified as safe by local police. The adult woman left home voluntarily in order to arrange residence/work. No evidence of abduction or force was found. The initial letter indicates voluntary departure; however, it was not treated as the sole decisive source, and safety was verified independently.”

The constable asked:

“Do we need to write this much?”

Premlata said:

“Tomorrow someone may read only the letter and say the police did not search. Someone else will say kidnapping. That is why.”

“Madam, will anyone ever read this file?”

Premlata laughed.

“If a historian comes along.”

Five days later Manjari reached the training centre.

Her name was on the selected list.

Certificates correct.

Six-month contract.

The officer in charge asked:

“Permission from home?”

Manjari paused.
“I am an adult.”
The officer looked at her.
“I am not asking permission. I am asking for an emergency contact.”
Manjari gave an embarrassed laugh.
“Mother.”
She wrote her mother’s number.
This time without telling her first.

Two months later Sunaina came to Darbhanga.
Manjari went to meet her at the railway station.
At first they only looked at each other.
Sunaina said:
“You have become very thin.”
Manjari:
“Two kilos.”
“Why did you cut your hair?”
“The heat.”
“At home—”
Sunaina stopped herself.
“Fine.”
Both laughed.
Sunaina saw the residence.
The reading room.
Manjari’s desk.
Coloured slips.
The girl students.
That night Sunaina asked:
“Do you still have the letter?”
“The original is at home.”
“I kept it.”
“You didn’t tear it?”
“I wanted to very much.”
“Why?”
“That paper makes me guilty.”
Manjari was silent.
“Then later I understood - it was your shield.”
Manjari looked at her mother’s face.
“Not the whole truth.”
“What is wrong in it?”
“Nothing. But I was not as certain as I wrote.”
“Not leaving the job - true?”
“Yes.”
“Not marrying—”
“Not then.”

“Don’t search—”

Manjari sighed.

“At the time I felt that if I wrote ‘do not worry,’ it would mean nothing. ‘Do not search’ felt necessary.”

“But we searched.”

“I knew you would.”

“Then?”

“Perhaps part of me wanted you to search too - only not to catch me.”

Sunaina stared.

“Both at once?”

“Yes.”

Her mother laughed.

“Human beings are very difficult.”

“A letter is simple.”

They laughed for a long time.

After six months, Manjari’s contract ended. The centre offered her a one-year extension.

Before accepting, she went home.

This time without disappearing.

She sat with Ma and Babu.

Money.

Place to stay.

Safety.

Future.

Marriage - “Not now.”

Harinarayan said:

“One year later?”

Manjari:

“We will talk one year later.”

Her mother smiled.

“This time I understand what ‘we will talk’ means.”

Neeraj asked:

“Amit?”

“He is engaged.”

The house went quiet.

Then Sunaina said:

“Good.”

No grand tragedy.

Life moved forward.

The following year, the Basaha Fair returned.

Sushma insisted:

“Come.”

Manjari laughed.
 "People will say I disappeared again."
 "This time the child will hold on to you."
 All three went - Manjari, Sushma, and Sushma's daughter.
 The red flag was still there.
 The bangle stall.
 Razia still seated behind it.
 Manjari stood before her.
 At first Razia did not recognise her.
 Then her eyes widened.
 "Oh!"
 "Maasi."
 Razia stood up and caught her hand.
 "Because of you, the police turned me into a psychologist."
 Manjari burst out laughing.
 "Will you buy bangles this time?"
 Manjari looked at a red-and-green pair.
 "No."
 "Marriage?"
 "No."
 "Fine. Bangles are not compulsory for marriage."
 Manjari bought a blue glass pair.
 Sushma teased:
 "See, the story changed."
 Razia said:
 "The story will keep changing. Pay me."

On the way back from the fair, Sushma asked again the question she had carried for a year.

"Tell me the truth - that night had you planned everything before, or did it happen suddenly in the crowd?"

Manjari kept walking slowly along the path.

"Both."

"That is not an answer."

"It is."

"The letter was five days earlier."

"There was a plan."

"Then you changed your decision three times at the bus stand."

"I was afraid."

"You asked about Kusum Hostel."

"I needed somewhere to stay."

"You almost boarded the Samastipur bus."

"I remembered Vandana."

"Then you got off."

"Yes."

"In the end, Darbhanga."

"Yes."

Sushma said:

"Then what was the event?"

Manjari stopped.

The fair glowed behind them.

The road ahead was dark.

The child held Sushma's hand.

Manjari said:

"The event was not that I disappeared. The event was that for the first time I had to make a place outside home in order to make a decision."

Sushma was silent.

"That is a very book-like answer," she said at last.

Manjari laughed.

"Fine. Ordinary answer: I was frightened, but I went."

"That I believe."

They walked on.

After reaching home, Manjari asked her mother for the old letter from the cupboard.

Sunaina gave it to her.

The folds in the paper were worn.

Manjari read:

"I am leaving home of my own will in an attempt to keep myself safe..."

She stopped.

The first sentence now seemed almost amusing:

"in an attempt to keep myself safe."

As if safety were not certain, only the attempt.

Perhaps the letter had not been as firm as people later read it.

"I do not wish to decide about my marriage yet..."

True.

"I do not want to lose the six-month work opportunity..."

True.

"Do not try to search for me, catch me, and bring me back..."

True - though some hidden half of her had also wanted someone to worry.

"I will speak myself when I have had time..."

She spoke within four days.

"Sushma is not responsible..."

Completely true.

Manjari considered writing a new date beneath the letter.

Then did not.

Let the paper remain of that time.

Sunaina asked:

"What will you do with it?"

"Keep it."

“Why?”

“It is not proof. But it is my language from that night.”

“History?”

Manjari laughed.

“Ma, not everything is history.”

Sunaina said:

“Your professor friend will be hurt if she hears that.”

Both laughed.

Manjari folded the letter again.

This time she did not put it inside a book, but into an ordinary envelope.

Across the front she wrote:

“Letter from the Night of the Fair - not the whole story.”

Sunaina read it and asked:

“Do you need to write that much?”

Manjari replied:

“So that if someone finds only this paper later, they do not make me too certain.”

Outside it was night.

Very faintly, on the air, came music from the fair's final evening.

A year earlier, on such a night, Manjari's name had been repeated over and over from the announcement booth.

Now no one was calling her name.

She was at home -

but this time the house was not deciding, by its own measure, what her presence meant.

At least not yet.

The Hero's Tale

Aditi Kumari first heard the heroic ballad of Kajraghat on the stage of her school. She was twelve years old then.

Only the meaning of two lines remained with her: one hero was on horseback, one flag fell into the river, and at the end the whole field sang, "Veernath lives forever."

Twenty years later, the District Cultural Council told her:

"One hundred and ten years have passed since the Kajraghat conflict. This time, prepare a joint folk performance."

Aditi was a theatre director. Not a historian. Not a folk singer either. Her task was to bring scattered songs, dances, storytelling, and the rhythm of the stage into one programme.

"What does 'joint' mean?" she asked.

The president, Mahendra Narayan, said:

"The traditions of both villages together. Leave the old dispute behind now. Honour both Veernath and Harikesh."

It was the first time Aditi had heard the two names together.

"Harikesh?"

The president looked surprised.

"You have never heard the Nadiyari song?"

"No."

"They do not consider Veernath the hero."

"Then?"

"That is exactly why we need a joint programme."

Aditi smiled.

"Do you want a programme, or reconciliation?"

Mahendra Babu laughed.

"Both."

The problem was already present inside that answer.

Kajraghat was an old river crossing between two villages: Veerpur to the north, Nadiyari to the south. There was now a concrete bridge, but half a kos east of it the old ghat could still be seen - steps, broken bamboo posts, a few stones, and a river that widened in the rains.

At Veerpur's main square stood a stone statue of Veernath on horseback, sword raised. The plaque below read:

"Veernath Rai, Defender of Kajraghat. In 1916, protected the district from grain looters."

There was no statue on the Nadiyari side. Only a small earthen platform by the river. Every year, during the dark fortnight of Bhadra, boatmen's families placed lamps there. Behind the platform, written in lime:

“Harikesh - who left the boat to save people.”

Two memorials.

Two actions.

Two heroes.

One night.

Aditi went first to Veerpur.

Raghunandan Rai, seventy-seven, was the principal singer of the heroic ballad. White moustache, sharp voice, throat still strong. His family traced itself to Kedar, Veernath's younger brother.

“Will you sing the whole song?” Aditi asked.

Raghunandan said:

“The whole song would take all night.”

“As much as you think necessary.”

“I decide what is necessary?”

“Yes.”

Raghunandan was pleased.

“Then stop all the recording first. Tea.”

Aditi laughed.

After tea came a dholak, manjira, and a local stringed instrument something like a sarangi. Three young men joined them.

Raghunandan began the opening alap.

In the song there was the terrible famine of 1916. At night, “boatmen-looters” from the southern village attacked the northern village's grain store. Sacks were loaded onto boats. Veernath, a state watchman, blocked the ghat with only seventeen men. Harikesh was the leader of the boatmen - clever, cruel, greedy. He wanted to steal the village's grain and sell it at a high price in the market across the river.

The main battle scene showed three boats under Harikesh. Veernath cut the thick rope of the ghat and released the first boat into the current, leapt onto the second, and crossed swords with Harikesh. At the end Harikesh's flag fell into the river. Veernath did not kill him; he said:

“Grain belongs to hungry people, not traders.”

Harikesh fled. Veernath saved the granary.

The song ended:

“The ghat survived, the grain survived, Veernath's name survived.”

Aditi asked:

“Harikesh does not die?”

“No.”

“At the platform it says, ‘the one who saved people.’”

Raghunandan's face changed.

“That is Nadiyari's story.”

“Have you heard it?”

“Many times.”

“What do they say?”

“That we were oppressors. It is a song, not history.”

Aditi did not laugh.

“And your song?”

Raghunandan was silent.

Then he said:

“Our song is tradition.”

“Is tradition different from history?”

“History is on paper. Tradition is in people’s mouths. They are different, but not false.”

Aditi wrote that sentence down.

In Nadiyari, the principal singer was not a man but seventy-year-old Basanti Devi.

Aditi was surprised.

“Women sing the heroic ballad?”

Basanti Devi said:

“Our song is less about the hero, more about the widow.”

That day five women sat by the river. No dhol. One small drum like a mridang, but the first part without rhythm.

Basanti began.

Here too, the night in 1916 was a time of famine, but there were no “looters.” Nadiyari’s fields had failed for three years because of flooding. Grain collected as royal tax lay in a northern store. The trader Manohar Sah had bought it and was preparing to send it across the river to market. Harikesh was a boatman paid to carry the consignment.

He was not initially a leader in this song, but a boatman. The dispute began at the ghat. Veernath was a royal watchman; the order was that the sacks should cross the river. Hungry people from Nadiyari blocked the way. There was pushing and shoving.

Veernath’s men used lathis. Someone dropped a torch. The thatch over the sack-boat caught fire. The thick rope at the ghat was cut.

Here too Veernath cut the rope - not to stop the boat, but to release the burning boat into the current.

But three children and two women were on the boat.

Harikesh jumped into the river. He saved two children. Searching for the third, he was taken by the current.

At the end of the song, Harikesh’s body was never found.

Basanti sang softly:

*“The grain came ashore, the boat went with the river,
No name on a plaque, only in a mother’s mouth.”*

Aditi listened without breathing.

The song ended.

“Veernath?” she asked.

Basanti said:

“A villain in our song.”

“He does not help save the children?”

“No.”

“In any version?”

Basanti answered at once:

“Not in this song.”

"Have you heard Raghunandan's song?"

"Yes."

"There Harikesh is greedy."

Basanti laughed.

"In the song of the man who has the statue, he is the hero."

"And in the song of the man who has the platform?"

Basanti looked straight at Aditi.

"He is the hero there. Write that down."

Aditi did.

Two days later Aditi returned to the Council office.

Mahendra Babu was eager.

"What did you understand?"

"Two different battles."

"That is why we need the programme."

"How do we put them into one programme?"

"Join the best parts of both songs. Veernath's courage, Harikesh's sacrifice."

Aditi frowned.

"And the parts where one song says Harikesh was stealing grain, while the other says Veernath beat hungry people with lathis?"

Mahendra Babu waved his hand.

"Leave out the disputed parts. Focus on shared heritage."

"Will the story survive?"

"Reconciliation will."

Aditi was silent.

She understood that the word "shared" could sometimes be a polite way of cutting away inconvenient memory.

She went to the archives, not to prove history but because she needed at least a chronology for the stage.

One page of the district administrative report from 1916 read:

"Crowd conflict at Kajraghat concerning transport of grain. Total dead: 11; missing: 3. Twenty-three sacks of grain destroyed/wet. One boat burned. Royal watchman Veernath Rai injured. Boatman Harikesh Mahato missing. Commercial goods belonging to trader Manohar Sah; proof of purchase from the royal-tax granary available."

Aditi stopped.

Raghunandan's song: village grain saved.

Basanti's song: royal/trader grain being taken away from a hungry village.

The report: commercial goods of Manohar Sah purchased from the royal-tax store.

So the grain was not simply "the village's," and not simply "the king's" - on paper it was merchandise that had been sold.

The next page said:

"Crowd consisted of farmers/boatmen from the southern bank and employees of the northern post. Who initiated the first violence is unclear."

Then:

"Because the rope was cut, the burning boat entered the main current. Source of the order disputed."

Aditi leaned back in her chair.

The cutting of the rope seemed almost like a fixed fact.

Why it was cut - disputed.

Whose order - disputed.

Children in the report?

There was a list:

Among the eleven dead, two children.

Among the three missing: Harikesh Mahato, an adolescent called "Chhotkan," and a woman "name unknown."

Three children in the song.

The document was not complete either.

Would the archive produce a third, clear story?

No.

Aditi felt relieved.

She did not want to make a third song claiming to be "the correct history."

Raghunandan was shown the report.

He put on his glasses and read it.

"Manohar Sah's goods? Could be false."

"Why?"

"A royal report will read a trader's papers. It will not read people's stomachs."

"And a song?"

"A song reads people's stomachs."

"Harikesh was greedy - is that people's stomachs?"

Raghunandan's face tightened.

"He took money from the trader."

"Proof?"

Raghunandan went inside the house and brought a copy of an account book from an old tin chest.

Manohar Sah's accounts for 1916.

"Harikesh, boatman - advance 3 rupees, for grain consignment."

"Look."

Aditi read it.

"Yes. Payment."

"Then?"

"Wages for a boatman."

"Would the leader of looters take wages?"

"The question works in reverse too - does a man who takes wages become a looter?"

Raghunandan was silent.

"Is Manohar Sah in your song?"

"No."

"Why?"

"I do not know whether he was in the older song."

"In the version you sing?"

"I learned it from my father."

"He?"

"From his father."

"A written copy?"

"There is a booklet from 1958."

The booklet was brought.

Aditi read it.

She was startled.

In the 1958 text Harikesh was described as "leader of the boats." The word "greedy" was not there. Manohar Sah's name appeared in one line:

"Sah's sacks, the royal seal."

"Why is this line no longer sung?"

Raghunandan scratched his head.

"It does not fit the rhythm."

Aditi laughed.

"History fell out of rhythm?"

Raghunandan was not offended.

"Songs change. Every singer changes them."

"When was 'greedy' added?"

"My father used to sing it."

"Why?"

"At that time another dispute over ghat tax had arisen with Nadiyari. Possibly."

Raghunandan stopped after saying "possibly."

Aditi wrote:

"A present dispute can alter the character of an old hero during performance."

It was harder to find an older version of Basanti Devi's song. There was no written text. But Geeta Devi, the daughter of Basanti's elder sister, had a recording from 1974, digitised from an old cassette. The singer was Basanti's mother, Jamuna Devi.

Aditi listened.

Jamuna Devi's voice was thin, but the words were clear.

The startling difference was that Veernath was not merely "the king's lathi" in that version. One stanza said:

*"Veernath shouted: leave the fire,
Turn two pitchers of water toward the ghat."*

Aditi called Basanti at once.

"This line is not in your song."

Basanti was silent for a while.

"My mother used to sing it."

"Why did you leave it out?"

"The song is long. One cannot sing everything."

"Who decides which lines are left out?"

Basanti looked directly at her.

"The singer."

"This line makes Veernath look a little different."

"He may have told people to put out the fire. Even so, the lathis were used."

"Does your present song say Veernath ordered the lathis?"

"Yes."

"And the older recording?"

They listened together.

Jamuna Devi sang:

*"The king's soldiers raised their lathis,
Whose order it was, the dust covered."*

Basanti's present song said:

"Veernath said: raise the lathis."

Aditi switched off the recording.

Basanti remained silent for a long time.

"Did that line change?"

"It came into my mouth like that."

"When?"

"After eighty-four or eighty-five."

"Why?"

Basanti said slowly:

"Around that time the Veerpur panchayat fenced off land at the ghat. Our tola protested. The police used lathis. I was singing the song. The old lathi and the new lathi became one."

Aditi had no reply.

Basanti herself smiled - a sad smile.

"Does a song sing only old things? The present enters the throat."

Aditi now understood clearly that the present forms of both songs did not contain only 1916.

The land dispute of the 1950s, the panchayat of the 1980s, recent memorials, schools, elections, sponsorship - all were inside them.

She raised this in the fair committee meeting.

Mahendra Babu said:

"Do not make it too complicated. The audience wants entertainment."

Raghunandan was present. So was Basanti.

Basanti said:

"I do not sing entertainment."

Mahendra Babu became uncomfortable.

"I mean - the pleasure of folk song."

Raghunandan said:

"There should be heroic rasa."

Basanti replied at once:

"In our song, pathos comes first."

"Then how can it be joint?" Mahendra Babu asked irritably.

Aditi said:

"Joint does not mean one song. It means one stage."

Everyone fell silent.

"First Veerpur will sing its song. Then Nadiyari will sing its own. In between, no one will explain which is 'correct.' Only a few stable facts will appear on the screen - date, number of dead, the burned boat, the cut rope, Harikesh missing, Veernath injured."

Mahendra Babu asked:

"How will the audience decide?"

"Why must they decide?"

"A programme needs a message at the end."

Aditi laughed.

"Not everything in life is a school play."

Raghunandan laughed at that.

Basanti too.

Mahendra Babu did not.

Rehearsals began.

Veerpur's young singers danced with pieces of wood like swords. There was no such dance in Nadiyari's women's song. Aditi kept the two presentations distinct.

The first problem was time.

Veerpur's song lasted one hour and ten minutes. Nadiyari's, fifty-five minutes. The whole programme had ninety minutes.

"Cut," Mahendra Babu said.

Which part?

One of the Veerpur youths said:

"Shorten the famine introduction. The battle is the main thing."

Raghunandan thundered:

"Without famine, why is there a battle?"

A young man from Nadiyari said:

"Add the part about Manohar Sah's consignment."

Basanti said:

"The trader is not central in our song. Hunger is."

Aditi understood: abridgement itself was politics.

She made a rule: each tradition would decide what to cut from its own song, but the programme booklet would list omitted sections as "present in the full tradition."

Mahendra Babu said:

"Will the audience read the list?"

"Those who do will know that the stage is not the whole song."

It was Aditi's small compromise.

On the third day of rehearsal, a young performer named Vishal, playing Veernath, asked:

“Madam, I defeat Harikesh but do not kill him. Then why do I stop the sword?”

Raghunandan instructed him:

“Here lies Veernath’s generosity.”

Basanti said from behind:

“This scene does not exist in our song at all.”

Vishal stopped mid-laugh.

“Then whom am I playing?”

Aditi said:

“The Veernath of Veerpur’s song.”

“The real one?”

“The real human being may have been larger than this.”

Vishal was dissatisfied.

“An actor needs a character.”

Aditi said:

“You need the character of this version.”

Then Pawan, playing Harikesh in Nadiyari’s song, asked:

“Is my Harikesh real?”

Aditi laughed.

“The answer is the same for you.”

The young men were disappointed.

Theatre wanted certainty. Folk memory carried uncertainty.

One day Aditi went alone to the old ghat.

An elderly fisherman named Ramcharit was drying his nets there.

“The woman doing the programme?” he recognised her.

“Yes.”

“Making the two songs fight?”

“No. One stage.”

Ramcharit laughed.

“A fight looks better on one stage.”

Aditi laughed too.

“Which song do you believe?”

Untangling a knot in his net, Ramcharit said:

“I used to row boats. My father sang the Nadiyari song. My mother was from Veerpur.”

“Then?”

“Both.”

“Whom do you call the hero?”

Still working the knot, Ramcharit said:

“Whichever house is feeding me that day, that house’s song.”

Aditi laughed, but he was serious.

“Really?”

“Truth is one thing. When you sing, hospitality is also true.”

Then he hummed one line:

“Two horses returned riderless, two boats without oars.”

Aditi was startled.

“Which song is that?”

“An old lament.”

“Veerpur or Nadiyari?”

“Both.”

“Two horses?”

“I don’t know.”

“Veernath survived.”

“Yes.”

“Then?”

Ramcharit laughed.

“A song is not mathematics.”

Aditi wrote down the line.

Two horses returned riderless, two boats without oars.

She began searching whether different forms of it existed in both traditions.

In the Veerpur booklet of 1958:

“Two horses empty, the enemy fled across.”

In the Nadiyari recording of 1974:

“Two boats empty, the son taken by the current.”

Ramcharit had probably joined the two into a line of his own.

A third oral form - belonging to someone’s household.

Aditi was delighted.

Then immediately cautious.

This was not “the original.”

It was a mixture.

But mixture too was tradition.

The programme’s sponsor, a local rice-mill owner named Ajay Sah, saw the publicity poster and suggested to the Council:

“Make the photograph of Veernath’s statue bigger. That is the recognisable image.”

The Nadiyari side objected.

Basanti said:

“Where will you get a picture of our Harikesh?”

No image of Harikesh existed.

Ajay Sah said:

“Then put a symbolic boat.”

Raghunandan snapped:

“Veernath is a man and Harikesh is a boat?”

Basanti laughed.

“Now you understand.”

The publicity poster was changed: only the river, the empty ghat, and the titles of two songs approaching from opposite directions. No hero’s face.

Ajay Sah was dissatisfied.

“Weak publicity.”

Aditi said:

“Fine.”

During rehearsals the performers gradually began listening to one another's songs.

Vishal of Veerpur said:

“The fire scene in Nadiyari's song is good.”

Pawan replied:

“The horse rhythm in yours is good.”

Basanti scolded:

“Take the rhythm, not the story.”

Raghunandan said:

“If they take the story, is it theft?”

Basanti laughed.

“You'll turn our Harikesh greedy again.”

The laughter lightened the atmosphere.

But one day a serious dispute broke out.

One passage in the Veerpur song said:

“The crowd from Nadiyari came to loot grain.”

The Nadiyari performers refused:

“We will not stand silent on stage hearing that word.”

Raghunandan said:

“The song will not be changed.”

Basanti said:

“Our song has the words ‘the king's dog’ for Veernath. Will you listen to that?”

Raghunandan grew angry.

“That is an insult.”

“And ‘looter?’”

Mahendra Babu became alarmed.

“Remove both words.”

Aditi said:

“No.”

Everyone looked at her.

“If those words are in the tradition, they will remain while the songs are sung. But the programme booklet will explain the context: these are the partisan words of the songs, not the organisers' statement of fact.”

Mahendra Babu held his head.

“Who will read footnotes during a programme?”

Aditi said:

“A footnote does not silence a singer's throat. It gives the audience another option.”

Raghunandan thought.

“We keep ‘looter.’”

Basanti:
“We keep ‘the king’s dog.’”
Aditi:
“Fine.”
Mahendra Babu:
“This is reconciliation?”
Aditi:
“This is an honest stage.”

A week before the programme, the headmaster of Veerpur school called Aditi. The school held “Veernath Jayanti” every year. Students wrote essays titled “My Ideal Veernath.”

The headmaster said:
“After the joint programme, the children will be confused.”
“About what?”
“Whether Veernath was a hero.”
“Why must a person in history fit into one word?”
“School education needs ideals.”
Aditi said:
“It also needs critical thought.”
The headmaster was dissatisfied.
“They are small children.”
Then a teacher named Neelam intervened:
“Children can hear both songs. They hear them at home anyway.”
The headmaster said:
“Children from Nadiyari hear something different.”
Neelam replied:
“Then why should school teach only one?”
Silence.

Aditi understood: the song was not merely a cultural programme. Heroes were made in school lessons, memorials, caste and village identities, election speeches - everywhere.

She asked the young people of Nadiyari too:
“Is Harikesh’s story taught in school?”
“No.”
“Then where?”
“At home.”
“In memorial songs.”
“On river-worship day.”
“At migrant gatherings.”
Migrant gathering?
People from Nadiyari living in Delhi sang the “Harikesh Song” every year at their community gathering.

Aditi watched a recording.

The startling change was that “grain” had become the metaphor “earnings from labour.” Harikesh did not merely cross the river; the song sounded as though he crossed “the city.”

Basanti said:

“People who have gone away to the city or abroad add their own sorrow.”

“Is that improper?”

“The song is alive.”

Aditi asked:

“Then Veerpur’s addition of ‘greedy’ is also a living tradition?”

Basanti was silent.

Then she laughed.

“Your question is difficult.”

“Why?”

“Because I have to answer against my own side.”

“Then?”

“Yes. That too is tradition. I do not like it, even so.”

The centre of the tale was slowly becoming clear to Aditi: a tradition cannot call only its own changes “living” and the opponent’s changes “distortion.”

On the night before the programme, Aditi could not sleep.

She looked over the stage sequence again:

1. Sound of the river, without words.

2. Available stable facts from 1916 - only on the screen.

3. Veerpur song.

4. Five-minute interval - so the audience could breathe on its own.

5. Nadiyari song.

6. Open conversation with senior singers of both traditions - Aditi asking questions, not giving a verdict.

7. A shared song at the end? That was the problem.

The Council wanted a shared ending.

Raghunandan had suggested: “Blessed Kajraghat.”

Basanti refused: “People died at the ghat. Why call it blessed?”

Basanti suggested: “Let there be no hunger again.”

Raghunandan: “Where is heroism?”

Aditi thought of Ramcharit’s mixed line:

“Two horses returned riderless, two boats without oars.”

But whose tradition was it? Probably Ramcharit’s personal mixture. Calling it “an old shared line” would be false.

She decided: no shared song.

At the end, only the sound of the river.

Mahendra Babu would probably be annoyed.

Fine.

On the day of the programme, the field was full.
 People from Veerpur came in procession from beside the statue. People from Nadiyari came after placing lamps on the river platform.
 On stage, the screen showed a grey image of the river.
 The first fact appeared:
 “1916. Famine/food crisis.”
 Second:
 “Crowd conflict at Kajraghat during transport of grain.”
 Third:
 “11 dead, 3 missing; one boat burned.”
 Fourth:
 “Veernath Rai injured; Harikesh Mahato missing.”
 Fifth:
 “The boat rope was cut; sources do not agree on the reason/order.”
 That was all.
 No “hero.”
 Raghunandan’s troupe entered. Dhol. Horse rhythm. Veernath as hero. The word “looter” came. Murmurs rose among the Nadiyari audience. One young man was about to heckle, but Basanti raised her hand and stopped him.
 The song went on. Veernath defeated Harikesh and spared his life. “Grain belongs to hungry people.” Cheers. Applause from the Veerpur side.
 Interval.
 The Nadiyari troupe. A slow, sorrowful melody. Hunger. Grain. Lathis. The words “the king’s dog” appeared. Voices rose on the Veerpur side. Raghunandan restrained one of his young men.
 Harikesh in the river. Children. Current. Body missing. Women’s voices.
 The song ended.
 The field was strangely silent.
 The same audience had now heard both stories.

The open conversation began. Aditi sat in the middle, Raghunandan on one side, Basanti on the other.
 Aditi’s first question:
 “Do your songs contain only 1916?”
 Raghunandan said:
 “No. My father, my grandfather, I - all of us.”
 Basanti:
 “My mother, the panchayat lathi-charge, migration - all of it.”
 The audience stirred.
 Aditi read the 1958 booklet line: “Sah’s sacks, the royal seal.”
 Raghunandan acknowledged that it was absent from the current performance version.
 From the 1974 recording came Basanti’s mother’s line: “Whose order it was, the dust covered.”

Basanti acknowledged that in her current song Veernath was named directly as the one who ordered the lathi-charge.

Mahendra Babu's face tightened.

An elderly man from Veerpur stood and shouted:

"Then is everything false?"

Aditi leaned toward the microphone.

"No. A song is memory. But memory is not a fixed archive."

The old man:

"Was Veernath a hero or not?"

Aditi looked at Raghunandan.

Raghunandan himself answered:

"In our song, he was."

The old man was angry.

"In our history?"

Raghunandan sighed.

"I am not a historian. My grandfather gave me this song. I sing it."

It was perhaps the first public sentence of Raghunandan's life in which he acknowledged the limits of the song.

A young man from Nadiyari asked Basanti:

"Wasn't Veernath an oppressor?"

Basanti said:

"Our song says so. But in my mother's older song he also tells people to put out the fire. I left that line out."

The young man fell silent.

The air in the field changed.

Had the heroes become weaker?

Possibly not.

They had become human.

Then something unexpected happened.

Ramcharit, the old fisherman who dried his nets by the river, stood up in the audience.

"May I sing one line?"

Aditi gave permission.

Without accompaniment, Ramcharit sang:

"Two horses returned riderless,

Two boats without oars,

In one house a hero's lamp burned,

In one house grief without end."

Raghunandan immediately said:

"That is not an old song."

Basanti said too:

"Not ours either."

Everyone laughed.

Ramcharit laughed.

"I made it."

Aditi was surprised.

"When?"

"Many years ago. My mother had one song, my father another. There used to be arguments in my house. I joined them."

Mahendra Babu brightened.

"There! A shared ending!"

Aditi said at once:

"No."

Mahendra Babu stared.

"Why? It brings both traditions together."

Aditi said:

"It is Ramcharit ji's personal song. Calling it an old shared tradition would again be false."

Ramcharit nodded.

"If you sing it with my name, sing it."

Laughter in the audience.

Raghunandan said:

"The line is good."

Basanti:

"Good, yes. But whose house has the 'hero's lamp'?"

Ramcharit:

"Whoever sings it can decide."

Basanti laughed.

"Then another quarrel."

Ramcharit:

"The song is alive."

This time both Raghunandan and Basanti laughed.

There was no shared song at the end of the programme.

Aditi dimmed the stage lights. The sound of the river played.

One line appeared on the screen:

"Different memories of this night remain alive in different homes, songs, and occasions."

Below it:

"No single performance is the whole event."

That was all.

Some in the audience were disappointed.

Some pleased.

Some said: "No decision was reached."

Some: "For the first time, I heard the other song."

Aditi sat down backstage, exhausted.

Mahendra Babu came over.

"The programme was successful, but the ending was weak."

"Why?"

“No message.”

Aditi drank some water.

“Both songs were heard. Is that so little?”

Mahendra Babu said nothing.

The next day the newspapers carried different headlines.

The Veerpur paper:

“People Proud of Veernath’s Valour; Historic Song at Joint Celebration.”

The Nadiyari weekly:

“Harikesh’s Sacrifice on District Stage for the First Time.”

A city newspaper:

“One Battle, Two Heroes: Message of Reconciliation.”

Aditi read the headline and laughed.

She had never said “reconciliation” on stage.

The stage was one thing. News made its own story.

A week later Veerpur school invited Aditi to speak with the students.

One child asked:

“Madam, was Veernath a bad man?”

“Why?”

“In Nadiyari’s song.”

Another child said:

“In our book he is a hero.”

Aditi wrote two words on the board:

“Action”

“Meaning”

“One person’s single action may acquire different meanings for different people. For example: the rope was cut. Veerpur’s song says it was to save the grain/stop the enemy. Nadiyari’s song says people were trapped/the fire grew. The report says: rope cut, reason disputed.”

A child asked:

“Then was cutting the rope bad or good?”

“We have to look at both what happened and what the intention was.”

“Does anyone know?”

“Not completely.”

A girl asked:

“Did Harikesh take money from the trader?”

“The account book records an advance for carrying the consignment by boat.”

“Then greedy?”

“Taking wages does not prove greed.”

“Veernath worked for the king?”

“Yes.”

“Then an oppressor?”

“Having a job by itself does not prove oppression.”

The children were frustrated and curious at the same time.
The headmaster sat at the back, perhaps wondering where the ideal had gone.
Aditi said:
"Heroism does not mean never asking questions."
At that sentence the headmaster lifted his head.

There was a conversation in Nadiyari too.
A young man asked:
"Why isn't our song taught in school?"
Aditi said:
"That is a question for the school and curriculum."
"You tell us."
"When local history is taught, both traditions should be included - clearly identified as oral traditions."
Basanti said:
"And the older version sung by my mother too."
"Yes."
A woman asked:
"Will you restore the line where Veernath tells people to put out the fire?"
Basanti was silent.
Then she said:
"Next Bhadra, I will try singing it."
Everyone was surprised.
Tradition was changing - because of Aditi? Possibly in part. Because the old recording had been heard again. Because of a public acknowledgement.
But what that change would mean would be decided by the next generation.

Raghuhandan too made one change to his song.
At the next Veernath Jayanti, he restored the old 1958 line:
"Sah's sacks, the royal seal."
Vishal later asked:
"Baba, that line breaks the rhythm."
Raghuhandan said:
"Fix the rhythm. Do not cut the line."
"Why?"
"I cut it before. Now let it stay."
"Then what of Veernath saving the grain?"
Raghuhandan said:
"Grain is grain. On paper, Sah's; in people's stomachs, their own. Sing both."
Vishal scratched his head.
"Very complicated."
Raghuhandan laughed.
"Old age."

While filing the complete documentation of the programme, Aditi became stuck on one problem:

The title.

The Council wanted: "Two Heroes of Kajraghat."

Basanti said:

"If you write that, Veernath becomes a hero for us too."

Raghunandan said:

"If you write 'two stories,' our right to call Harikesh a hero becomes weaker."

Aditi proposed:

"Kajraghat: Two Hero Traditions."

Both thought.

Basanti:

"Fine."

Raghunandan:

"Yes."

In other words, "hero" referred not to the person as an established fact, but to the claim of each tradition.

A small grammatical device.

But the politics changed.

In the documentation, Aditi recorded the "performance context" of each song.

Veerpur:

- Statue anniversary.
- School.
- Public fair.
- Heroic rasa/horse rhythm.
- Male-dominated performance, though women were listeners and auxiliary

singers.

Nadiyari:

- River platform/memorial day.
- Family remembrance.
- Migrant gatherings.
- Pathos first, later heroic passages.
- Strong tradition of women as principal singers.

Then:

"Performance context may alter words, character, and emphasis."

Mahendra Babu said:

"This will make people think folk tradition is unstable."

Aditi replied:

"They will understand that it is alive."

Aditi was now using Basanti's word.

Two months later, a university research student came to meet Aditi.

"I want to research Kajraghat. What really happened?"

Aditi laughed.

“Change the first question.”

“Why?”

“Ask ‘what really happened,’ certainly, but not in the hope that one document will give you everything.”

“Then the thesis?”

“You do it. I am a director.”

“Your conclusion?”

Aditi thought.

“My conclusion concerns performance. A singer does not merely repeat an old story; the singer brings the present audience, present disputes, lineage, rhythm - everything along. That is why the ‘hero’ is not a fixed statue.”

The research student took notes.

“Was either Veernath or Harikesh really a hero?”

Aditi said:

“Ask history that question. Ask the songs, and each is a hero in his own place.”

A year later another Kajraghat programme was held - this time Aditi was not the organiser. She went as a spectator.

The new director was the young Vishal, the same one who had played Veernath.

The publicity poster read:

“Kajraghat: Two Hero Traditions.”

Aditi smiled.

The Veerpur song kept the line “Sah’s sacks, the royal seal.”

In the Nadiyari song Basanti restored her mother’s older line:

“Veernath shouted: leave the fire.”

But the harsher “king’s lathi” passage remained as well.

So in the same song Veernath was no longer only a villain.

Harikesh remained an opponent in the Veerpur song, but “greedy” had disappeared and “leader of the boats” had returned.

Raghunandan said:

“That is how it was in the booklet.”

Basanti laughed.

“Did we win?”

Raghunandan said:

“No. My booklet won.”

Both laughed.

Aditi thought: do not call this laughter historical reconciliation. It was simply mutual respect between two elderly performers. Giving it a larger political meaning would be making another story.

She only listened.

At the end of the programme the young director tried something new.

Ramcharit’s personal verse was sung - but the screen clearly said:

“Composition: Ramcharit Sah. Mixed family tradition. Estimated composition: 1990s.”

Ramcharit sat in the front row, smiling proudly.

The verse:

“Two horses returned riderless,

Two boats without oars,

In one house a hero's lamp burned,

In one house grief without end.”

This time Basanti herself changed the third line as she sang:

“In two houses, heroes' lamps burned...”

Raghunandan immediately looked at her.

Basanti smiled.

“That is how I felt today.”

Ramcharit laughed and shouted:

“Permission from the author?”

Everyone laughed.

Basanti replied:

“Who grants permission in an oral song?”

Raghunandan struck the dhol with his hand.

“Then next time it will change again.”

“Let it.”

Aditi found the moment beautiful, but inside herself remained cautious.

“Heroes' lamps in two houses” - did this new form prove that the two heroes were equally great?

Not necessarily.

It was Basanti's choice that night.

Tomorrow she might sing “one house” again.

Tradition was not a verdict.

It was a process.

After the programme a journalist asked Aditi:

“Should we say the dispute is over now?”

Aditi laughed.

“The song changed. Where does the history of a dispute end?”

“Have both communities accepted each other's hero?”

“Some people have. Some have not.”

“Then what was achieved?”

Aditi looked toward the field. Young men from Veerpur were helping pack Nadiyari's instruments. Basanti was arguing about something with Raghunandan. Ramcharit was joking about who had changed which line of his verse.

“Earlier, many people had heard only their own song,” Aditi said. “Now at least the existence of the other song is no longer hidden.”

The journalist wrote it down.

“That's all?”

“Is that so little?”

The journalist smiled.

At night Aditi went to the old ghat. The noise of the programme was far away. A faint line of moonlight lay across the river.

The thick rope of the ghat no longer existed. The concrete bridge had changed everything.

She thought: on that night in 1916, someone cut the rope.

From that small action one tradition made heroism, another crime. The archive only said: the rope was cut.

One action.

Intention disputed.

Consequences multiple.

Memory edited from generation to generation.

Then where was heroism?

Possibly not only in the outcome.

Possibly not only in the intention.

Possibly not fixed at all in the later songs.

Aditi caught herself thinking “possibly” and laughed.

Then corrected herself:

“Possibly.”

At the water’s edge, a boy was listening to the day’s programme on his phone. Basanti’s line played again:

“In two houses, heroes’ lamps burned...”

The friend beside him said:

“Next time I’ll make this line into a fast-rhythm spoken piece—”

Aditi turned.

Both boys recognised her and fell silent.

She laughed.

“Make it. But write that it is your version.”

The boy asked:

“Won’t that spoil the old one?”

“No.”

“Then?”

“Do not hide what you changed.”

Both nodded.

Aditi walked on.

Behind her, the river.

Voices.

An attempt at a new rhythm.

Veernath remained fixed in the statue.

Harikesh remained a name on the platform.

But in the songs both kept moving - now hero, now guilty, now human, now only a symbol.

The battle of Kajraghat had happened once.

The hero’s tale was still happening, again and again.

The Last Meal

Dinner at Devaki Devi's house was usually at seven-thirty, but that night no one sat down at the table before eight.

The reason was the will.

The lawyer had come in the afternoon. For three weeks Devaki Devi had been saying, "The papers must be put in order." The family understood that she meant the division of property. But who would receive what - no one knew clearly.

Devaki Devi was seventy-seven. Her husband had died thirty years earlier. She had one son, Aniruddh, in Delhi, and one daughter, Madhavi, a widow who lived in Darbhanga city. Aniruddh's son Ishan had been living with Devaki for the past four years; he ran a small business of his own and also looked after his grandmother.

People in the family would say, "Ishan is the heir."

Devaki would laugh and say, "Why are you searching for an heir to a living person?"

But that afternoon, after the lawyer left, Devaki said, "I am thinking of giving half the mango orchard to the trust for the girls' school."

At first Ishan thought she was joking.

"Half?"

"Yes."

"Does Babu know?"

"He will now."

"The orchard belongs to the family—"

Devaki stopped him at once.

"What does 'the family' mean?"

Ishan fell silent.

Madhavi was there too. She said, "Ma, take this decision slowly."

Devaki laughed. "I have been taking it slowly for three years."

Ishan's face fell. The orchard brought income - the mango contract, litchis, fish from two ponds, rent from the warehouse on the south. Ishan had been keeping all those accounts for four years.

He said, "I have been managing everything for four years."

"Your labour will be recorded separately."

"Labour on paper?"

Devaki did not answer.

Ishan got up and went outside.

Forty-five minutes after that quarrel, Devaki Devi fell ill at dinner.

That was why, from the next day onward, people began to treat the will and the meal as one story.

The cook, Phulwati Devi, was fifty-five. She had been cooking in the house for eighteen years. She called Devaki “Malikin,” but they were close enough for her to scold her sometimes.

“Eat less salt.”

“Where is the taste in food without the salt from your hand?”

“The doctor will blame me.”

“Doctors blame the kitchen for everything.”

Dinner that night was ordinary: rice, masoor dal, sponge-gourd with chickpeas, cumin potatoes, coriander-mint chutney, curd, and, at Devaki’s insistence, makhana kheer.

Phulwati had been preparing since the afternoon. Bhola had brought the coriander from the market. Bhola was an old household servant - orchard, market, small repairs, guests, everything. He was sixty-two and had been in the house since Devaki’s husband was alive.

While washing the coriander, Phulwati said, “There is so much soil on it.”

Bhola said, “I got it cheap.”

“Cheap means feeding us mud?”

“Wash it three times.”

Phulwati washed it four times.

Mint from a pot at home, green chilli, ginger, salt, lemon. The chutney was ground on stone; Devaki always said machine-ground chutney smelled different.

That day Phulwati noticed, in a corner of the kitchen, an old soft-drink bottle containing a yellow-green liquid.

“What is this?”

“Medicine for the orchard,” Bhola said.

“Why in the kitchen?”

“It began raining. The warehouse roof leaks. If I left it outside it would wash away.”

“Do not keep it here.”

“I’ll move it now.”

Phulwati went back to peeling potatoes. She did not notice whether Bhola actually removed the bottle.

That bottle would become the centre of the investigation that night.

Ishan had gone out half an hour before dinner. Madhavi followed him to the veranda.

“Where are you going?”

“To the shop.”

“Now?”

“To cool my head.”

“About Dadi’s decision—”

“Maasi, not you.”

Madhavi fell silent.

Ishan started his motorcycle, then switched it off again.

“Does it seem right to you? Giving away half the orchard?”

"It is her property."

"Yes, on paper."

"Ishan."

"For four years I have looked after the doctor, bank, labourers, orchard, tax, night-time hospital visits - all of it. Babu is in Delhi. Then?"

Madhavi said, "Caregiving wages are not inheritance."

The sentence came out harsh.

Ishan's face tightened.

"And Babu in Delhi? He is the heir?"

"I did not say that."

"Everyone does."

He started the motorcycle and left.

He came back at seven-thirty, carrying a paper packet from the chemist's - Devaki's heart medicine, which was due to run out the next morning.

Phulwati said, "Now the food is cold."

Ishan said, "Heat it."

"Your grandmother has asked three times."

"I won't eat."

Phulwati snapped, "Why quarrel with your stomach?"

At last Devaki called from the dining room, "Ishan! Sit at the table."

He sat.

There were five people at the meal: Devaki, Madhavi, Ishan, Phulwati, and Bhola. Normally Phulwati and Bhola ate later, but Devaki said, "Today everyone eats together."

Phulwati laughed. "I am fine in the kitchen."

"Does the table ask caste?"

Bhola became uncomfortable. "Malikin, I—"

"Sit."

Devaki said, "See? Even after the will, everyone at one table."

Ishan stopped with food halfway to his mouth.

"Dadi, don't start again."

"I started?"

"Eat."

Devaki laughed. "Fine."

The first ten minutes were quiet. Phulwati served dal, Bhola water. Devaki liked the chutney very much.

"Good today."

Phulwati said, "The coriander was full of soil."

Bhola said at once, "I got it cheap."

Devaki laughed. "You have an illness of saving money."

At about eight-twenty Devaki said, "The chutney is a little bitter."

Phulwati tasted it at once.

"The chilli?"

"No. Something else."

Madhavi tasted it too. "It seems fine to me."
 Ishan said, "Dadi's tongue has changed because of the medicines."
 Devaki glared at him. "Are you the doctor?"
 Bhola gave her water. Devaki took two sips.
 Five minutes later she began sweating.
 Then came abdominal cramping.
 Phulwati ran to bring ajwain.
 Ishan asked, "Did you take the night medicine?"
 "Not yet."
 At eight-forty Devaki vomited. First food, then water, then a bitter fluid.
 Bhola brought a bucket.
 Phulwati cloths.
 Madhavi rubbed her back.
 Ishan telephoned the doctor.
 Later, the four of them would remember this scene in four different ways.
 Phulwati would say: "She mentioned the chutney."
 Ishan: "First she sweated, then vomited."
 Madhavi: "She had been tired all day."
 Bhola: "She became worse after drinking water."
 The investigation would try to turn each word into a sequence.
 Life, in that moment, had been more chaos than sequence.

Dr Naval Kishor was the family's old physician. He was sixty-eight. Ishan called him at eight-fifty that night.

"Dadi is vomiting, sweating, stomach cramp."

"Chest pain?"

"She isn't saying so."

"Breathing?"

"Fast."

"Bring her to the hospital immediately. I am coming."

Ishan asked, "Food poisoning?"

Naval Kishor said, "No diagnosis over the telephone."

When Devaki reached the hospital she was still able to speak, but weak. Blood pressure unstable, heartbeat irregular, heavy sweating, severe abdominal symptoms.

Several possibilities came into the doctor's mind at once - food poisoning, exposure to agricultural poison, a serious cardiac arrhythmia, a drug reaction.

Devaki had old heart disease. She took three medicines regularly. The dose of one had been changed the previous month. Sometimes she also drank an herbal decoction despite the doctor's objections.

"Decoction today?"

Madhavi said, "In the morning."

"Who made it?"

"Bhola brought the leaves. Phulwati boiled it."

Phulwati grew frightened. "Doctor Babu, the same old one."

"I am only asking."

To Phulwati's ear, even the question "Who made it?" sounded like an accusation. By half past nine Madhavi too felt mildly nauseous. Ishan said his stomach felt heavy. Bhola was normal. Phulwati was normal.

The doctor immediately ordered the remaining food to be preserved as samples. Ishan telephoned the house and told a neighbour, "Do not throw away anything on the table."

At ten-ten Devaki's condition suddenly worsened. Her heart rate became very slow and then irregular. Breathing problems. Intensive care.

The district hospital toxicology physician asked by telephone, "Any agricultural chemicals in the house?"

Ishan said, "There was a bottle in the kitchen."

Naval Kishor's face changed.

"Secure the bottle. Inform the health officer and the police."

The family stared.

Madhavi said, "Police?"

"If exposure to a toxic substance is possible, reporting is necessary."

Ishan's face turned pale.

For one instant he remembered the will.

That fear would make him behave like a guilty person for many days afterwards.

Devaki Devi died at three-twenty in the morning.

The hospital corridor was quiet.

Ishan sat against the wall.

Madhavi closed her eyes.

Naval Kishor wrote on the papers.

The cause of death was not immediately written as "poison."

"Acute cardiorespiratory failure; possible toxic/pharmacological cause; tests pending."

Madhavi asked, "Doctor, poison?"

"Possible."

"Food?"

"Possible."

"Could someone deliberately—"

Naval stopped her at once.

"I cannot say anything about that."

A post-mortem became mandatory.

Aniruddh objected from Delhi.

"Mother was seventy-seven. Heart disease."

Naval said, "Correct. But there were sudden symptoms after food, an agricultural chemical in the house, and possible exposure. Investigation is necessary."

"What does that mean?"

"It means I am not certain."

To the family, that uncertainty sounded like weakness in a doctor.

To the doctor, it was honesty.

Phulwati's statement was taken at the house.

"Who cooked the meal?"

"I did."

"The chutney?"

"I did."

"The coriander?"

"Bhola brought it from the market."

"Was it washed?"

"Four times."

"The pesticide bottle?"

"I saw it in the kitchen."

"The cap?"

Phulwati thought.

"Closed."

"Certain?"

"I remember it closed."

"Did Bhola move it?"

"He said he would."

"Did you see him?"

"No."

"Did you touch the bottle?"

"No."

"Any quarrel with Devaki Devi?"

Phulwati's eyes filled.

"In a house of eighteen years, there will be no quarrel?"

"About what?"

"Salt. Leave. Wages. My granddaughter's schooling. Her medicines."

"Any wages unpaid?"

"Two months."

The investigator wrote it down.

Phulwati became irritated.

"Now will you write that I poisoned her for money?"

"I am writing the circumstances."

"Two months were unpaid, but Malikin paid my granddaughter's school fees separately."

"Paper?"

"No."

Phulwati understood that care that had been lived as affection turned, in an investigation, into a transaction.

She said, "Write that I ate the food too."

"How much chutney?"

"A little."

"Devaki?"

"She took it twice."

"She said it was bitter?"

"Yes."

"Did you taste it?"

"Yes."

"Bitter?"

"Not to me."

That night Phulwati kept remembering her own tongue again and again.

Was it really not bitter?

Or had memory changed after the event?

In Bhola's statement, the bottle became the centre.

"Why was it in the kitchen?"

"Rain."

"There was a veranda."

Bhola fell silent.

The real reason was simple: he was tired. The bottle was in his hand, the rain was heavy, the kitchen was near. He had put it there for two minutes and forgotten.

"Did you remove it?"

"I think I did."

"Where?"

"On top of the grain room."

The bottle had been recovered from the corner of the kitchen.

"Then you did not remove it."

Bhola lowered his face.

"Possibly not."

"Did you spray the orchard in the morning?"

"Yes."

"Washed your hands?"

"Yes."

"How many times?"

Bhola snapped, "Now a history of my hands?"

"It is necessary."

Bhola fell silent.

Then came the land question.

While Devaki's husband was alive, he had said that Bhola could build a house on the land at the back.

There was no paper.

For years Devaki had kept saying, "We'll see."

"Angry?"

"Yes."

"Did you ever say: a lifetime of service, and nothing at the end?"

"Yes."

"Ever speak of her death?"

Bhola held his head.

"At the tea shop I said something like, 'Will she give me the papers after she dies?'"

"We will write the context."

Bhola said, "Will people read the context?"

The investigator was silent for a moment.

"Not everyone."

Bhola said, "Then paper too is a story."

Ishan's statement began with the will.

"Quarrel?"

"Conversation."

"Raised voices?"

"Yes."

"About what?"

"The mango orchard."

"You opposed the decision?"

"Yes."

"Expected to be an heir?"

Ishan was irritated.

"Everyone does."

"You?"

"I thought Dadi would give me some share."

"Where did you go after the quarrel?"

"To the chemist's."

Receipt: 7:18.

"What did you buy?"

"Heart medicine."

"Did you give the night dose?"

"No. It was to be after dinner. Dadi became ill first."

"Who handled the medicine box?"

"I did."

"Ever make a dosage mistake?"

Ishan paused.

"Once."

"When?"

"Three months ago. I gave the morning pill at night."

"Did you tell the doctor?"

"No."

Ishan's face reddened.

"Did that kill her?"

"I am not saying that."

"But you wrote it."

"A fact."

Then the investigator asked, "Were you tired after four years of caregiving?"

Ishan laughed bitterly.

"Is that a criminal question?"

"No."

"Yes, I got tired. Dadi rang the bell at three in the morning. Doctor, bank, labourers, orchard, taxes. Sometimes I thought Babu was resting in Delhi, Maasi had

her own house, I was the one serving. Then Dadi paid off my shop debt, and I felt ashamed. Then we quarrelled. That is life.”

“Did you ever wish Dadi would die?”

Ishan looked up.

“Is it a crime if, in irritation, one thinks, ‘How long will all this go on?’”

“A case is not built on thoughts.”

“But people will build one.”

Ishan was right.

Dr Naval Kishor's view was different.

The investigator asked, “Why did you not first assume poisoning?”

“I considered it as a possibility.”

“Specific treatment?”

“The substance was not clear.”

“The symptoms?”

“Some resembled agricultural poisoning, some cardiac disturbance, some a medicine reaction.”

“Meaning?”

“One body is not one book.”

“The decoction?”

“A possible drug interaction.”

“Could the death have been prevented?”

Naval paused.

“I don't know.”

“The family wants a definite answer.”

“Medicine does not provide certainty according to desire.”

The doctor's notes from the previous month contained Devaki's symptoms - reduced appetite, sometimes a slow pulse, mildly impaired kidney function, unstable blood pressure. The dose of one heart medicine had been reduced.

Naval Kishor was not free of questions either.

Had the dose been reduced enough?

Should the next examination have taken place sooner?

Should he have insisted more strongly that she stop the morning decoction?

After death, a doctor becomes the judge of his own earlier decisions.

The laboratory results came four days later.

Traces of one group of agricultural pesticide were found in Devaki's blood and stomach samples.

Also in the remaining chutney.

Also on the remaining bunch of coriander, recovered near the rubbish bin.

The pesticide bottle contained the expected high concentration.

None in the water jug.

None in the dal.

None in the rice.

None in the kheer.

The news spread:

“Poison in the chutney.”

Phulwati did not leave her house for three days.

But the laboratory note was cautious.

Original contamination of the food, secondary contamination in the kitchen, and contamination after sample collection could not all be completely distinguished.

The market was investigated.

The coriander seller bought from a wholesale market.

The wholesaler bought from many farmers.

Among other buyers from the same consignment, two families reported stomach upset; one hotel owner reported nothing.

No produce remained for testing.

Thus “poison” grew stronger.

“From where” did not.

Meanwhile the will came out.

The lawyer, Shivkant Jha, said the latest draft had not been signed.

In that draft, half the mango orchard was to go to the girls' school trust. The income from the remainder was to support a family elder-care fund. The main house was jointly for Madhavi and Aniruddh. The southern warehouse was to be available for Ishan's business for ten years. Bhola was to receive a written lifetime right of residence on five dhurs at the back. A fixed amount was for the education of Phulwati's granddaughter. Ishan was to receive separate cash.

The family was stunned.

Bhola began to cry.

“She kept saying ‘we'll see’...”

Phulwati realised that the school fees for her granddaughter had not merely been occasional charity; Devaki had been making a plan.

Ishan's supposed motive was no longer simple.

Not the whole orchard, but cash and the right to use the warehouse.

“Did he know about the draft?”

Ishan said, “No.”

The lawyer said, “Only Devaki Devi and I.”

But “he did not know” too was limited by what the lawyer knew.

Devaki might have told someone.

No one knew.

Dr Naval Kishor's professional trouble also grew.

A local media outlet asked:

“Did the family doctor delay recognising poisoning?”

Naval said, “I told them by telephone to bring her to hospital. The substance was not clear.”

“Specific treatment in time?”

"For which substance?"
 "Agricultural poison—"
 "Not all agricultural poisons are the same."
 The journalist kept repeating the question.
 Naval ended the call.
 That night he reread Devaki's file.
 One month earlier: "Advised stopping herbal decoction; patient reluctant."
 Two weeks earlier: "Appetite reduced."
 Three days earlier Ishan had telephoned: "Sometimes pulse slow."
 Naval had said: "Check next week."
 Next week never came.

Phulwati returned to prepare for the shraddha.
 Madhavi said, "Rest."
 "Sit at home and listen to people talk?"
 She went into the kitchen.
 The old grinding stone had been taken for testing; a new one had arrived.
 Phulwati did not touch it.
 Bhola asked, "Shall I bring coriander?"
 Phulwati shouted:
 "No!"
 Both fell silent.
 After a while Phulwati began to cry.
 "Malikin took chutney twice."
 Bhola said, "Your fault has not been proved."
 "Proved? Every day I taste it on my tongue."
 "I kept the bottle in the kitchen."
 "Did you give poison?"
 "No."
 "Then?"
 They looked at one another.
 Blame wants a single human name.
 In this house there were too many names.

While clearing Devaki's room, Ishan found a small page.
 "Ishan -
 Keep the orchard accounts transparent.
 Keep the shop debt separate.
 Night medicines on time.
 Do not make your whole life into service to me."
 Ishan sat down staring at the fourth line.
 "Do not make your whole life into service to me."
 Madhavi came in. Ishan showed her the page.
 "Maasi, am I a bad person?"

"Why?"

"I used to get tired."

"Fatigue is not murder."

"People say motive."

"People make stories."

"I wanted Dadi's orchard."

"Yes."

"I quarrelled."

"Yes."

"Then?"

"Then you wanted the orchard and you quarrelled. That much. If there is more evidence, then more."

Ishan stared at the page for a long time.

Suspicion against Bhola also increased.

He brought the bottle.

He had complained about the land.

He had served the water.

A neighbour said:

"Bhola used to say, a whole life of service and nothing in the end."

The investigator questioned him again.

Bhola admitted the anger.

"Anger is not murder," the investigator said.

"People?"

"I have no control over people."

In the third week of the investigation, another result arrived.

The level of agricultural pesticide in Devaki's blood was below the range usually considered lethal, but interpretation was difficult because of the timing of the sample, metabolism, and age.

The level of one heart medicine was above the expected range - but the meaning of a post-mortem level was not straightforward either.

Now the number of questions increased.

Pesticide?

Medicine?

Both?

Old heart disease?

Decoction?

Dehydration?

Ishan immediately found a new direction for guilt.

"I handled the medicine."

Naval Kishor said:

"An elevated level does not prove that you gave her extra medicine."

"Then?"

"In an elderly body, a drug may leave the system more slowly. Her kidneys were weak."

“Why didn't you reduce the dose?”

Naval was silent for a moment.

“I did reduce it. Perhaps not enough. Perhaps it was not the cause at all.”

Ishan held his head.

“Why is nothing straight?”

“Because the body isn't.”

Aniruddh came from Delhi and called a meeting about the property.

Madhavi was irritated.

“Now?”

“Legal work doesn't stop.”

The lawyer brought the older signed will from five years earlier.

Main property: equal shares to Aniruddh and Madhavi.

A small cash amount to Ishan.

No mention of Bhola or Phulwati.

No trust.

The new draft was legally incomplete.

Morally, it said a great deal.

Aniruddh said:

“Mother did not sign it.”

Madhavi said:

“But her wishes had changed.”

“She might have changed the draft again.”

Ishan said:

“Dadi had been thinking about it for three years.”

“How do you know?”

Ishan fell silent.

Bhola listened from the veranda.

Phulwati from the kitchen.

The investigation into the dead woman's body was not yet complete.

The investigation into her property had begun.

That night Madhavi went into her mother's room.

Cupboard.

Saris.

Medicines.

Spectacles.

A tin of ghee.

She thought of the way people were saying:

“The last meal.”

“She ate this at the last meal.”

“The chutney from the last meal.”

“The quarrel at the last meal.”

Devaki herself had not known it was the last.

If she had woken the next morning, she would have quarrelled again with Ishan about the orchard, scolded Phulwati about salt, told Bhola to remove the bottle, complained to the doctor about medicines, told Madhavi to go home.

The meal would have remained just a meal.

Madhavi found the word “last” cruel.

In the end, the police found no clear evidence of deliberate poisoning.

No single point of highly concentrated poison in the chutney.

No separate purchase of poison.

No threat.

No clear plan.

But the source of accidental contamination could not be determined either.

Coriander from the field?

The bottle in the kitchen?

Hands or surfaces?

The old herbal decoction?

Several factors?

The final investigation report said:

“Death may be related to the combined effect of toxic exposure and pre-existing cardiac disease/pharmacological factors. There is insufficient evidence of deliberate poisoning. Storage of agricultural chemicals in the kitchen was a serious safety lapse. Original contamination of food material cannot be excluded.”

The family was dissatisfied.

Ishan asked:

“Meaning no one is guilty?”

The investigator said:

“Not that. Some lapses are clear. Proving a crime is a different matter.”

Phulwati asked:

“Is my name cleared?”

“There is no criminal evidence.”

“People?”

No answer.

Bhola said:

“The bottle was my mistake.”

“Yes.”

“Did Malikin die because of me?”

“The report does not say that with certainty.”

Uncertainty is sometimes not relief.

Sometimes it is a lifelong burden.

At the hospital, Devaki’s case was reviewed.

Some doctors said: pesticide treatment should have come earlier.

Some: heart disease.

Some: medicine level.

Some: could the death have been prevented?
Naval Kishor said:
“Do not make the first decision easy using knowledge that came afterwards. Next time, do not choose one cause too quickly.”

One month later Phulwati made chutney again.

Madhavi asked:

“Is there coriander?”

Phulwati became frightened.

“Why?”

“To eat.”

“No.”

“Phulwati.”

“I won't make it.”

Madhavi sat down beside the grinding stone.

“I will make it. Teach me.”

Together they washed the coriander.

Once.

Twice.

Three times.

Four times.

Phulwati said:

“Five times.”

Madhavi smiled.

“Fine.”

Mint, chilli, ginger, salt, lemon.

No agricultural chemical was now kept anywhere near the kitchen.

The chutney was ground.

Madhavi tasted it first.

“Good.”

Phulwati's eyes filled.

“Malikin said it was bitter.”

“Yes.”

Both were silent.

Phulwati tasted it too.

The return of food from crime scene to food was a slow process.

The property dispute continued for six months.

In the end the family used the old legal will as the basis, then made a separate family settlement.

One-third of the mango orchard to the girls' school trust.

One portion to the family.

The southern warehouse for Ishan's use for ten years.

A written lifetime right of residence for Bhola on five dhurs of land.

An education fund for Phulwati's granddaughter.
The main house jointly to Madhavi and Aniruddh.
This did not fully match Devaki's new draft.
Nor did it fully match the old will.
Aniruddh said:
"Mother might have changed it again."
Madhavi said:
"Possibly."
At first Ishan was irritated. Then he took out Devaki's page and looked at it:
"Do not make your whole life into service to me."
Aniruddh read it for a long time.
"I was away."
Ishan first wanted to say something bitter.
Instead he only said:
"Yes."
Two syllables.
No verdict.
An entire history inside them.
Bhola took the paper for his five dhurs and went before Devaki's photograph.
"See?"
Phulwati said:
"What will a photograph see?"
Bhola said:
"I have something to say."
"Say it."
"She delayed."
"Who?"
"Malikin. With the papers."
Then he stopped himself.
"I too delayed in moving the bottle."
Phulwati said:
"Not every delay is the same."
Bhola looked at her.
"What does that mean?"
"Do not use the same scale."

A year later, on Devaki's death anniversary, the family again sat at one table.
Ishan.
Madhavi.
Aniruddh.
Bhola.
Phulwati.
Devaki's chair empty.
Rice.
Dal.

Sponge gourd.
Potatoes.
Curd.
Makhana kheer.
Madhavi deliberately had chutney made too.
Aniruddh paused when he saw it on the plate.
Ishan too.
Phulwati said:
“If you are afraid, don’t eat it.”
Aniruddh took some.
“I’ll eat.”
Ishan half a spoon.
Madhavi a full serving.
Bhola very little.
Phulwati last.
No one used the words “last meal.”
During the meal Aniruddh asked:
“Did Ma finish the kheer that night?”
Phulwati said:
“Yes.”
Ishan said:
“I didn’t.”
Madhavi said:
“Half.”
Bhola laughed.
“Another investigation now?”
Everyone laughed softly.
For the first time, that night could enter laughter.

After the anniversary Ishan went to the hospital.
He asked Naval Kishor:
“If there had been no agricultural pesticide, would Dadi have survived?”
“I don’t know.”
“If the heart-medicine level had been lower?”
“I don’t know.”
“If I had brought her to hospital five minutes earlier?”
“I don’t know.”
In one year Ishan had learned how to listen to “I don’t know.”
Naval asked:
“What do you want to hear?”
Ishan thought:
That I was not the reason.
Naval said:
“There is no evidence of any deliberate act by you causing her death.”
“That much?”

“That much is a lot.”

The portion of orchard given to the girls' school trust was marked out.

One student asked Ishan:

“Did Devaki Devi give this orchard in her will?”

Ishan could have told the simple story:

“Yes.”

Instead he said:

“Not in the older signed will. In the later unsigned draft, she wanted to give half.

The family agreed to one-third.”

The girl perhaps did not understand all of it.

But Ishan liked that Devaki did not become a flat statue of a “generous grandmother.”

Devaki had been complicated - wanting to donate, quarrelling with family, paying Phulwati's granddaughter's school fees, telling Bhola for years “we'll see,” grateful for Ishan's care, disagreeing with his claim on the orchard.

A human being.

That year the mango crop was heavy.

The first consignment went to the school, the second to the family, the third to market.

Bhola sorted fruit.

Ishan kept accounts.

Phulwati picked raw mangoes.

Phulwati asked:

“Chutney?”

Ishan paused.

Then laughed.

“Make mango chutney. Not coriander.”

Bhola said:

“Still afraid.”

“Yes.”

Phulwati said:

“Fear too can become a taste.”

At dinner that night Madhavi looked again at the empty chair.

A year earlier everyone had placed a different cause around that chair.

Phulwati - the chutney.

Bhola - the bottle.

Ishan - the quarrel and the medicines.

The doctor - poison, heart, medication.

Aniruddh - age.

Police - insufficient evidence of crime.

The lawyer - unsigned draft.

People - inheritance.

No one entirely false.

No one the whole truth.

Madhavi understood that the difficulty of the “last meal” was not only poison.

The difficulty was this: once the dead person has finished eating, she cannot give her own explanation.

Everyone else who remains alive looks toward the empty chair and fills the blank space with a cause of their own.

She lifted the bowl of chutney.

Took a little onto her plate.

The taste was ordinary - coriander, mint, lemon, a mild chilli.

She ate.

Nothing happened.

But that “nothing happened” did not prove what had happened a year earlier.

She held the bowl toward Ishan.

“Will you take some?”

Ishan said:

“A little.”

That was all.

No mystery opened.

No criminal stepped forward.

Devaki did not return.

But slowly the family learned to live with the fact that some deaths leave questions, and in the empty space left by a question, the thing that runs fastest is not truth.

It is story.

Everyone at the table kept eating.

The empty chair remained empty.

The Poet and the King

In the old archives of the Sonvarsha kingdom, Ira Jha first encountered the name of the poet Harinath on a torn order-sheet. Mice had eaten away the right corner of the paper, half the royal seal remained on the left, and only this much could still be read clearly in the middle:

“Because of a breach of courtly decorum, the poet Harinath Mishra is ordered to remain outside the capital...”

The order did not name the offence.

Ira's interest awakened in that absent word.

She was researching “The Poetic Culture of the Sonvarsha Court” for the university. Her subject was poetry, not crime. But after three months of examining court manuscripts, expense ledgers, grant registers, and handwritten poetry collections, she had begun to feel that it was difficult to understand the court's poetry without understanding Harinath's exile.

The strangest thing was that different files gave different reasons for his banishment.

The official history said:

“The poet was sent to the provinces because of indecorous speech.”

A nineteenth-century literary commentary said:

“The king could not tolerate truth.”

A family genealogy said:

“An improper affair of love.”

And a town folk song said:

“The jealousy of another poet reached the king.”

Four causes.

One exile.

Ira decided to place all four beside one another and see what happened.

The head of the archives, Ramlochan Babu, said:

“Be careful with this subject. People want a story, not files.”

Ira laughed.

“I want the files.”

Ramlochan Babu shook his head.

“Files are stories too, daughter. Only their storyteller carries an official seal.”

The Sonvarsha kingdom had been a small principality about two hundred years earlier. In the last decade of King Shivanarayandev's rule, drought, rising grain prices, and disputes over canal tax had increased. To preserve its prestige, the court had expanded festivals, donations, and poetry assemblies.

Harinath Mishra had been the principal court poet of that period.

His complete works did not survive. What remained existed in varying forms across different copies.

The first manuscript Ira found was titled Spring Description and Royal Praise.
 On page forty-seven appeared Harinath's name.
 The poem began with flowers, mango blossoms, the palace garden, and hope for rain. In the middle appeared one line:
 "The denser the shadow of the crown, the greyer the ridges of the fields."
 Ira read the line twice.
 Inside an ordinary praise poem, it lodged like a thorn.
 In a later copy, the same place read:
 "The denser the shadow of the crown, the fairer the ridges of the fields."
 One word had changed.
 Grey to fair.
 Ramlochan Babu bent over the page.
 "Because of this one word, people call Harinath a rebel."
 "Which reading is older?"
 "People have been quarrelling over that for thirty years."
 Judging by paper, ink, and handwriting, the first manuscript appeared older, but it had no certain date.
 The second belonged to the royal library, was later, and bore a stamp saying "authenticated."

Ira searched for a fuller copy of the exile order.
 One survived in the palace administrative files.
 It said that the poet had violated courtly decorum through "an improper verse uttered in assembly and private correspondence." He was ordered to leave the capital within fifteen days and reside at Chandraghat in the eastern district.
 His property was not confiscated.
 Half his salary continued.
 His family was allowed to remain in the capital.
 Ira paused over those arrangements.
 If Harinath had been a political rebel, why continue half his salary?
 If the love offence had been so grave, why protect his family and property?
 If it was only jealousy, why had the matter reached the level of a royal order?
 She searched the next pages of the file.
 A small note said:
 "The meaning taken from the poetic recitation moved public opinion in an adverse direction."
 The subject of that sentence was unclear.
 Who gave the meaning - the poet, the listeners, or the court?

The third source was a letter.
 It was not Harinath's.
 It was written by Madhavi Devi, a music instructor in the palace, to her sister. The original was lost; only a copy preserved in a family genealogy survived.
 The date was four days before Harinath's exile.

Madhavi wrote that during rehearsal of a new song at court, Harinath handed her a page and said:

“Keep the thorn of the words alive in the raga.”

Madhavi wrote:

“I asked which thorn. He laughed and said: the line where everyone’s ear will stop.”

There was no explicit reference to love in the letter.

But later writers repeatedly quoted the next sentence:

“He looked at me as though the answer were written inside me.”

Upon that one sentence, an entire love story had been built.

Ira read the rest of the letter.

The next two lines seemed more important.

Madhavi wrote that the pay of the court musicians had been reduced. Harinath had urged her to sing a satirical verse about the farmers’ grain tax at the musical assembly. Madhavi was afraid that the musicians would be punished.

Popular books almost always omitted this part.

Ira made a note:

“Sign of love? Or artistic collaboration? Later selective quotation?”

The fourth source was oral.

Some of Harinath’s descendants still lived in his ancestral village, Bharauli, thirty kos from the capital.

Ira went there.

Eighty-one-year-old Shailkumari Devi seated her on the veranda and said:

“In our family it is said that the royal poet Raghav Jha, out of jealousy, poisoned the king’s ears against Harinath.”

“Raghav Jha was another poet?”

“Yes. The king listened to him less.”

“Who told you this story?”

“My grandmother. She heard it from her grandmother.”

“Any letters? Manuscripts?”

Shailkumari Devi brought out a wooden chest.

Inside were copperplates, marriage registers, land papers, and a small cloth pouch.

The pouch contained the old silver nib of a pen.

“They say this was Harinath’s pen.”

Ira did not take the pen into her hand.

She only looked at it.

An object can shine like proof, she already knew, but the history of an object too is made from stories.

Shailkumari Devi also sang a folk song.

In it, Raghav went to the king and said:

“Harinath writes in the queen’s courtyard, not in the king’s fields.”

The king became angry.

Harinath replied:

“A poem belongs to whoever hears it.”

Then he was sent to Chandraghat.
The song was beautiful, but Ira doubted its age.
It contained an image of a railway train, though no railway had yet reached the region in Harinath's time.
"Is this line old?" Ira asked.
Shailkumari Devi laughed.
"The song is old. Lines keep becoming new. Whoever sings adds his own time."
Ira wrote that answer in heavy letters in her notes.

Back in the capital, she found another file: the salary ledger of Royal Poet Raghav Jha.

From the very month of Harinath's exile, Raghav's stipend had increased.
It could have been beautiful evidence for the jealousy theory.
But in the same year the salaries of three other officials also rose because the drought had increased administrative work.
Raghav had been given additional responsibility for composing royal proclamations in verse.
Ira stopped herself.
The desire for proof is not proof.
She began comparing the surviving copies of Harinath's poem.
Five copies were found.
The disputed line appeared in five forms:
"The denser the shadow of the crown, the greyer the ridges of the fields."
"The denser the shadow of the crown, the fairer the ridges of the fields."
"The denser the shadow of the crown, the ridges remained grey."
"The denser the shadow of the crown, the greyer the body of the earth."
And in one copy the entire line was absent.
The rest of the poem varied too.
In one version the king was generous like a cloud.
In another he was simply "cloud."
In one the people were content.
In another they were "waiting."
Ira thought: perhaps Harinath's offence was not only what he wrote.
Perhaps the offence was also that the text did not remain fixed.
One line was spoken in an assembly.
Listeners took its meaning according to their circumstances.
A copyist changed a word.
The court authenticated another reading.
A later historian called the change political.

Then a second letter by Madhavi Devi appeared.
Why it had survived in the royal files was unclear. Perhaps a copy had been made during some seizure.
Madhavi wrote to her sister:

“What happened in the assembly changed the moment its story went outside. I am not certain whether Harinath said ‘grey’ or ‘lean.’ There was an uproar. The king said nothing at once. Raghav stood and asked what the line meant. Harinath replied: ‘The meaning of a word depends upon the stomach of the person who hears it.’ Some in the assembly laughed. Some remained silent.”

Ira’s breathing quickened.

The politics seemed clear in that sentence.

But the next part of the letter again changed direction.

Madhavi wrote that after the assembly Harinath spoke with her for a long time in the rear garden of the palace, and Raghav saw them there.

“I fear he will give this meeting another meaning.”

So the seed of the love accusation too may have been planted on the same night.

At this point Ira wrote to her research supervisor, Professor Leela Mishra.

The reply came:

“Do not hurry to find one cause. Court punishments were often written in deliberately multi-meaning language, so that the king could later change the reason if he wished.”

That sentence became central to Ira’s research.

She began examining other administrative orders.

In penalties against other officials, the offences were explicit:

bribery,

absence,

tax evasion.

Harinath’s order was unusually vague.

“Improper verse.”

“Private correspondence.”

“Decorum.”

All three were phrases that could later take whatever meaning was useful.

King Shivnarayandev’s private diary was not available.

But the royal physician’s register described the king on the day of the exile as:

“Sleepless, angry, but unwilling to reverse the decision.”

No cause.

The royal priest’s note did not name Harinath at all.

Only:

“Restraint upon speech was understood as protection of the kingdom.”

In the merchants’ association ledger from the same week there was one entry:

“Because of the poet’s case, discussion of the canal tax has increased in the bazaar.”

Ira stayed with that line for a long time.

If the poem had already become linked to agrarian anger about taxation, then love or jealousy might have been secondary in the king’s mind.

But if the private meeting in the garden had become court gossip, then the political meaning of the poem might itself have become a useful cover for punishment.

What should be called the cause?

Ira went to Chandraghat, where Harinath had lived for five years in exile.
 In a monastery library there were three songs attributed to him.
 Surprisingly, none said anything against the king.
 One remembered the capital.
 One the river.
 The third used the metaphor of “the word that left its house.”
 Its final line was:
 “Once it leaves the mouth, the speaker is no longer its owner.”
 Ira smiled.
 That line was very convenient for her research.
 So convenient that she immediately became suspicious.
 The manuscript dated from forty years after Harinath’s death.
 The scribe was unknown.
 It might contain Harinath’s original line.
 Or an addition by a later copyist.
 The mahant of the monastery said:
 “People here regard Harinath almost as a saint of resistance to the king.”
 “Was he a saint?”
 “Who can say? But stories give people direction.”
 “And history?”
 The mahant laughed.
 “History gives direction too. Its shoes are only better polished.”
 Ira did not write that sentence down.
 Very beautiful sentences, she felt, were dangerous in a research paper.
 They occupied the place of facts.

The site identified as Harinath’s residence in Chandraghat was now a primary school.
 On a wall was a plaque:
 “Poet Harinath Mishra, Pioneer of Free Speech, lived here in exile.”
 The plaque had been installed in 1975.
 The headmaster said proudly:
 “He told the king about the suffering of the farmers, and therefore he was banished.”
 “What is the source for that information?”
 “It is in the book.”
 The book had been published by the District Cultural Council.
 Its source list cited the same nineteenth-century commentary Ira had already seen:
 “The king could not tolerate truth.”
 The commentator had named no source.
 Ira returned from Chandraghat with an uncomfortable realisation.
 A sentence supported by weak evidence had become the strongest public truth in memory.
 The reason was obvious.

The story was simple, moral, and useful:
 the poet spoke truth;
 the king punished him.
 The love story was equally simple:
 the poet loved a forbidden woman;
 a jealous rival informed;
 the king banished him.
 The jealousy story too:
 a talented poet against a lesser court rival.
 But the files were not simple.
 The king did not stop Harinath's salary completely.
 Madhavi was not punished.
 Raghav's salary rose, but his responsibilities also increased.
 The poem survived in five forms.
 The order was deliberately vague.
 Discussion of the tax dispute increased in the market.
 Later songs added love.
 A modern plaque made the poet a symbol of resistance.
 Ira began to think that perhaps the question "What was the real reason?" was the wrong question.
 Perhaps the court itself did not want one reason.
 She needed evidence for that idea.

Three weeks later, in a file from the royal seal department, she found a small draft.

It was not the final order, but a minister's note prepared before the order was issued.

Three reasons were written as bullet points:

"1. Improper reception of a verse in assembly.

2. Discussion arising from private communication with a woman of the music house.

3. Complaint by poet Raghav that the hierarchy of seniority was being disrupted."

Against all three, in red ink, was written:

"Specific cause not to be stated in the order. If the king wishes, return should remain easy."

Ira sat upright.

The page clarified a great deal.

But not everything.

All three accusations had indeed been before the court.

It did not say which one the king believed.

Perhaps none.

Perhaps all three were used together.

Perhaps the chief concern was not the poem itself, but the public discussion around it - the "improper reception."

Not the word.

The social life of the word.

Below, the minister had written another note:

“A harsh punishment during famine may turn public opinion against the court.”

So even the form of punishment had been shaped by politics.

Ira requested a copy of the page.

Ramlochan Babu looked at the document for a long time.

“This should end the dispute.”

Ira said:

“No. It will change the form of the dispute.”

“Three reasons are clear.”

“What is clear is that three reasons were listed. It is not clear exactly what happened, how true each accusation was, which reading of the poem was recited, or which cause the king himself inwardly believed.”

Ramlochan Babu smiled.

“You have become a researcher.”

Ira did not laugh.

She felt that perhaps becoming a researcher meant fewer answers, but clearer boundaries around questions.

She began searching for a letter by Raghav Jha.

The folk tradition had made him the villain, but his own voice was nowhere.

After a long search, a copy appeared among the papers of Raghav's grandson.

Raghav had written it to a friend two months after Harinath's exile.

He wrote:

“People blame me. It is true that I made a complaint. But my complaint was not about love. Harinath would leave the assembly and have his poems sung first in the music house; before the king heard them, the bazaar would already be singing his lines. If a court poet reaches the street before he reaches the court, what is his position?”

Ira stopped at that line.

Raghav's jealousy was not merely jealousy of talent.

It was jealousy of institutional authority.

Who should hear first?

Who owns a poem?

Does a court poet write for the king, or for the public?

In the letter Raghav also praised Harinath's talent:

“He understands the movement of words better than I do, but he thinks himself the owner of words. That illusion will become his difficulty.”

The truth of that judgment could not be tested.

But Raghav no longer resembled the simple villain of the folk song.

Madhavi's third letter reached Ira last of all.

It had been written in the final years of Madhavi's life, about thirty-five years after the exile.

She wrote:

“People now ask whether Harinath loved me. I have grown old, but people’s curiosity remains young. I say: he respected me, and I understood his music. If people wish to place the word ‘love’ there, let them. But remember: because of my name, do not remove the dust of the fields from his poetry.”

Ira remained silent for a long time after reading it.

Madhavi herself had disagreed with the later story made from her.

But her disagreement too was not final truth.

Love is a private experience.

Its definition may have been different in letters of that period.

Even so, one thing was clear:

later storytellers had made the woman into the cause, and in doing so had shrunk the political and artistic questions.

Ira’s dissertation chapter took shape:

“Four Meanings of Exile.”

She made four sections.

First:

the poem and the tax dispute.

Second:

Madhavi’s letters and the later construction of the love story.

Third:

Raghav’s complaint and institutional rivalry at court.

Fourth:

the deliberately ambiguous language of the royal order.

But when she came to write the conclusion, her hand stopped.

“Why was Harinath really exiled?”

The question seemed to demand one sentence.

The university form too required a “principal conclusion.”

She wrote:

“The available evidence does not establish a single cause.”

Then erased it.

She wrote:

“The exile was a convergence of four interrelated disputes.”

The sentence sounded good.

Too good.

Too clean.

At last she wrote:

“The royal record shows that the court preserved a set of multi-meaning accusations rather than declaring one exclusive cause. This allowed later generations, according to their own needs, to make poetry, love, jealousy, or politics the principal explanation. The history of the exile is therefore not only a history of an event, but also a history of the struggle over the right to meaning.”

Ira stopped there.

Before the dissertation was submitted, the university held a seminar.

The hall was full.

Teachers.

Students.

Local historians.

Descendants of Harinath.

Representatives of the cultural council.

Ira gave her presentation.

She displayed the five versions of the disputed line.

The draft order.

The letters of Madhavi and Raghav.

The questions began.

The first came from a local poet.

"Why do you not say clearly that Harinath was a people's poet and that the king punished him for speaking truth?"

Ira said:

"There is material supporting that interpretation, but not only that material."

"So you are taking the king's side?"

"No. I am describing the limits of the evidence."

The second question came from one of Harinath's descendants:

"Why discuss a relationship with Madhavi Devi? This affects the honour of the family."

Ira replied:

"Because private correspondence appears among the accusations in the contemporary order. But the love story has not been presented as an established fact."

The third question came from a representative of the cultural council:

"If the plaque at Chandraghat says 'Pioneer of Free Speech,' are you saying it is wrong?"

Ira said:

"That is a twentieth-century construction of memory. Harinath's poetry became a symbol of resistance - that is itself a historical fact. But the plaque is not a direct record of the eighteenth-century royal decision."

There was movement in the hall.

The final question came from Professor Leela Mishra.

"Ira, suppose the king himself were present, and you asked why he exiled Harinath, and he gave you one reason. Would the problem then be solved?"

Ira was silent for a moment.

"No," she said.

"The king would be giving his own interpretation of his decision. It would be important evidence, but it would not erase the experiences of the others. And even the king might later change the reason he gave."

"Then there is no truth?"

"The event occurred. The exile happened. The order was issued. Harinath went to Chandraghat. Those are facts. But 'cause' is formed in social language. In the same decision, king, minister, poet, rival, musician, bazaar, and later historians can see different causes."

The hall went quiet.
Ira remembered Ramlochan Babu's first sentence:
Files too are stories, only their storyteller carries a seal.

One year after the dissertation was published, the Sonvarsha Palace Museum opened a new exhibition:

“Harinath: The Rebel Poet.”

Ira was invited to the opening.

On one wall, the disputed line was written in large letters:

“The denser the shadow of the crown, the greyer the ridges of the fields.”

Under it, a plaque:

“For this fearless line, the poet was exiled.”

Ira stopped.

Nearby, her research book was displayed under glass.

She asked the museum officer:

“Did you read my book?”

“Yes. It was very useful.”

“Then why one cause?”

The officer smiled.

“Visitors need a clear story. If we write four causes, the plaque becomes too long.”

Ira had nothing to say.

At that moment she understood that Harinath's story was being changed yet again.

This time not by the king.

By the museum.

Power does not live only in a crown.

Wherever there is the right to select, there is power over meaning.

In the second room, an excerpt from Madhavi's letter was displayed.

But not the line about “the dust of the fields.”

Only:

“He looked at me as though...”

The heading below:

“Forbidden Love?”

Ira closed her eyes.

One sentence from Raghav's letter was displayed too:

“He thinks himself the owner of words.”

But the preceding sentence -

“It is true that I made a complaint” -

had been omitted.

The visitors were delighted.

The story had become beautiful.

A rebel poet.

A jealous rival.

A mysterious love.

A severe king.

History had become theatre again.

After the opening Ira went to Chandraghat.

Schoolchildren were playing near the plaque.

A teacher recognised her.

"You wrote a book about Harinath, didn't you?"

"Yes."

"Tell the children something."

Ira stood before them.

She wanted to say:

Harinath was a fearless poet.

Or:

We do not know.

Both were incomplete.

She asked:

"How do you know Harinath's story?"

One boy said:

"He called the king bad, so the king expelled him."

A girl said:

"No, he loved the queen."

Another boy said:

"My grandfather says another poet trapped him."

Ira laughed.

"See? There are already three stories among you."

"Which one is right?" the children asked together.

Ira drew four circles on the ground.

In the first she wrote:

Poem.

Second:

Letter.

Third:

Complaint.

Fourth:

Royal order.

In the middle she wrote:

Exile.

"The event in the middle is certain. The evidence around the four sides is different. Some of it is strong, some weak. The work of history is not only to choose one circle. It is also to ask who held which paper, who spread which story, and why."

A girl asked:

"Then was the king bad or not?"

Ira paused before answering.

"The king sent a poet out of the capital under vague accusations. Documents establish that. The decision affected the poet and his family. But I do not have complete evidence for the one reason the king held in his mind."

"Was the poet right?"
"That too is not fully known."
The boy looked disappointed.
"Then the story isn't fun anymore."
Ira laughed.
"Sometimes difficult stories last longer."

That evening Ira looked through books kept in an old room at the school.
There she found a local handwritten song booklet.
The paper was recent, but the song was written in an old tune.
Its final line about Harinath's exile read:
"The king called it crime, the poet called it meaning;
The village called it love, and time called it a question."
Ira read it and smiled.
The line certainly was not Harinath's.
Perhaps a teacher had added it twenty or twenty-five years earlier.
But it contained, in miniature, the problem she had spent months searching
through files.
She copied the line into her notes.
Not as evidence for her dissertation.
Only as later memory.

On the train back to the capital, Ira sat by the window.
The fields moved backwards.
Some green.
Some grey.
She remembered the disputed line:
"The shadow of the crown..."
Perhaps Harinath had said "grey."
Perhaps "fair."
Perhaps someone had misheard in the noise.
Perhaps Raghav deliberately gave it the harsher meaning.
Perhaps the king feared agrarian resentment.
Perhaps gossip about the private meeting made punishment easier.
Perhaps all three worked together on the same night.
The difficulty of history was not that truth existed nowhere.
The difficulty was that fragments of truth fell into different hands, and the most
powerful hand hung its fragment up as though it were the whole picture.
Harinath was exiled.
That was the event.
Poetry was the cause.
One interpretation.
Love was the cause.
Another.

Jealousy.

A third.

Politics.

A fourth.

And perhaps the real power of the court lay precisely in the fact that it did not need to choose one cause.

It could write the order so that every cause remained possible.

The poet went to Chandraghat.

The king remained in the capital.

Raghav became the principal court poet.

Madhavi continued teaching music.

Farmers continued quarrelling over the canal tax.

The poem kept changing from copy to copy.

Two hundred years later Ira sat among those changing words.

She understood that the king could drive the poet out of the capital.

But he could not lock the poem forever inside one meaning.

Yet even that was only half the truth.

Because even if poetry remained free, the struggle over its meaning was not free.

Every institution that printed a text, mounted a plaque, wrote a textbook, arranged an exhibition - in every generation it built for itself a small throne.

Ira opened her notebook.

On the last page she wrote:

“Power influences meaning; it does not create truth according to whim. Documents impose limits. Contradictory evidence resists. Material circumstances resist. Yet among the available facts, which story will be heard in the loudest voice cannot be separated from power.”

She closed the notebook.

Evening was falling beyond the train window.

Whether the fields looked grey or beautiful depended on light, distance, and the viewer.

But the fields existed.

And who paid tax on those fields, whose grain diminished, whose poem was sung, whose name entered the order - those questions were not merely metaphors.

Ira understood that perhaps historical honesty meant holding two things together:

meaning changes,

but not everything is arbitrary.

The train went on.

She had not found one single cause for Harinath's exile.

But she had seen the system in which a king preserved ambiguity around causes to protect his decision, a poet left behind a line, a woman's letter became a love story, a rival's complaint became jealousy, and later generations kept choosing one of the four stories according to the needs of their own time.

In the end, “The Poet and the King” was no longer the story of any one person.

It had become a long dispute over the ownership of meaning.

The Accident at the Turn

At seven fifty-four in the morning, Navalakha Turn was not yet fully awake.

The milk van had gone. There was still time before the first school bell, and half the market shutters were only partly open.

At 7:54:24, the surveillance camera outside the chemist's shop showed a small blue vehicle entering from the right. Two streaks of night dew had not yet dried on its windscreen. Its driver, Suresh Yadav, would later say that he had not been travelling faster than thirty.

At 7:54:27, the camera at the cloth shop on the other corner showed the front wheel of a bicycle. Anil Mishra, riding it, had a cloth bag on his back containing three measured kurtas and two half-stitched pyjamas. He was on his way to open his small tailoring shop.

At 7:54:30, the chemist's camera froze.

The next moving image began at 7:54:41.

The accident happened during those eleven seconds.

Before the missing interval the camera showed the vehicle, the bicycle, the turn.

After it: the bicycle on the road, the vehicle tilted to one side, people running, dust.

Nothing in between.

On the first day everyone assumed this was a small technical defect. If four people had seen the accident, why should eleven seconds of video matter?

By the third day everyone understood:

into those eleven seconds, each person had placed a different story.

Suresh Yadav was thirty.

He drove a small vehicle for a private school, but at the time of the accident it was empty. Before reaching the school to collect the children, he had been going to fill it with petrol. His driving licence was valid, and the previous month's inspection sticker was still on the vehicle.

Immediately after the accident, he climbed out, folded his gamchha beneath Anil's head, and telephoned the ambulance himself.

He did not flee after the police arrived.

Even so, by evening his photograph was circulating on social media with the caption:

"Speeding school vehicle crushes cyclist."

"Crushes?" Suresh asked at the police station. "He is alive. I myself sent him to hospital. The vehicle stopped there too."

The constable recording his statement did not look up.

"People write headlines. You give your statement."

Suresh said that just before he reached the turn, a white goods vehicle had been occupying half the road.

The bicycle suddenly emerged from behind it.
He braked.
Swerved left.
But the rear of the bicycle was struck.
“Suddenly?” the constable asked.
“Yes.”
“Where was the bicycle coming from?”
“The lane on the right.”
“Into your path?”
“I couldn’t see it before. The goods vehicle was between us.”
“So the goods vehicle was at fault?”
Suresh fell silent.
He did not want to give the name of the guilty party.
He wanted to describe a scene.
But the question was being asked in the language of blame.

Two days later Anil regained consciousness in hospital.
His right shoulder and wrist were injured, and there were seven stitches in his head. The doctor said he would need several weeks of rest.
As soon as the police heard that his memory was clear, they went to take his statement.
Anil said that after coming out of the lane onto the main road, he first stopped.
The goods vehicle was not parked at the edge of the road but very close to the turn. Because of it, the right side of the main road was not visible.
He slowly pushed the front wheel of the bicycle outward.
Then someone sounded a horn.
He stopped again.
He thought the vehicle was still far away.
When he began to cross, the blue vehicle suddenly appeared in front of him.
“You had stopped?” Sub-Inspector Meera Thakur asked.
“Yes.”
“Completely?”
Anil closed his eyes, trying to remember.
“Whether my foot was on the ground or I was moving very slowly - I cannot now say with certainty. But I did not simply ride straight out.”
“You heard the horn?”
“Once. But everyone sounds the horn at a turn.”
“Was the vehicle going fast?”
Again Anil paused.
“It seemed fast to me. How could I measure its speed at the moment of the accident?”
Meera wrote that sentence down carefully.
She was used to people presenting estimates as facts.
Anil did the opposite.
Where he did not know, he said that he did not know.

Even so, the local evening news carried the headline:
“Injured Cyclist Alleges: School Vehicle Came at High Speed.”
His full sentence did not appear.

The third eyewitness at the turn was Kamli Sahu.
She sold tea and was boiling milk when the accident happened. Her cart stood about twenty-five cubits from the site.

On the first day Kamli had said:

“I saw it. The cyclist came out without looking.”

Suresh's supporters seized upon that sentence.

But when Meera questioned her again in detail, Kamli said:

“I did not see the whole thing. The milk was rising and I was lifting the ladle. When I looked up, the bicycle was already in the middle of the road. So I thought he must have come out without looking.”

“So you did not actually see him emerge from the lane?”

“No.”

“How fast was the vehicle?”

“Very fast.”

“How fast?”

Kamli laughed.

“I sell tea. I don't measure speed.”

“Then why did it seem very fast?”

“The brake squealed loudly. Dust flew.”

Meera wrote:

A loud brake sound and speed are not the same thing.

A regular customer at Kamli's cart, Rambabu, gave a different account.

His back had been toward the road, so he had not seen the accident.

He had only heard it.

First a horn.

Then something scraping.

Then impact.

“Was it two horns or one?” Meera asked.

“Two,” Rambabu said.

Kamli interrupted:

“One.”

“You were watching the milk,” Rambabu laughed.

“And your back was turned,” Kamli said.

Both trusted their own incomplete senses completely.

The fourth source was the preliminary police report.

It said:

“The cyclist may have failed to exercise due caution while entering the main road, and the motor-vehicle driver may have failed to reduce speed appropriately near the turn.”

"Both?" Suresh's employer said after reading it. "What kind of language is this? Who is guilty?"

Meera replied:

"A preliminary report is not a final order deciding guilt."

"The insurance company wants one name."

"Sometimes a road contains more than one cause."

The employer left dissatisfied.

On the fourth day, Bablu Jha, owner of the chemist's shop, gave the police the complete surveillance file.

Everyone's hopes settled on it.

"Now we will see the truth," Suresh's employer said.

"Now it will become clear," Anil's younger brother said.

"Now we won't need anyone's statement," said a reporter.

Meera said nothing.

At the station the video was played.

7:54:24 - blue vehicle.

7:54:27 - bicycle wheel.

7:54:30 - image freezes.

7:54:41 - dust, people, vehicle stopped.

Silence.

"The middle?" Meera asked.

Bablu Jha said:

"The camera is old. Sometimes it freezes while recording."

A technician was called.

After examining the file he said the camera did not record continuously. It recorded when it detected movement, but when storage ran low it sometimes skipped short intervals. The voltage had also dipped at that time.

"So eleven seconds are missing?"

"Missing is not quite the right word. They may never have been written."

"Can they be recovered?"

"How do you recover something that was never written?"

The answer disappointed everyone.

People assumed a digital object either existed or had been deliberately erased.

"Never existed" was the most difficult answer.

The chemist's camera was not the only one.

The cloth shop across the turn had a small camera. It pointed mainly at the shop entrance, but a corner of the road appeared in the frame. The bicycle wheel could be seen. Then a customer's body blocked the view. The collision itself was not visible.

A bank camera saw the turn from a distance between two trees. Its timestamp was four minutes and eighteen seconds ahead of the chemist's. The bank employee said the clock had not been corrected for months.

The municipality had a junction camera too, but it had been out of service for a week because a cable had been cut during road excavation.

For the first time, instead of looking only at the vehicle and the bicycle, Meera looked at the directions in which all the cameras faced.

One camera low.

One behind a tree.

One dead.

One incomplete.

Many images.

No complete viewpoint anywhere.

Meera had white chalk marks made on the road:

where the vehicle first appeared,

where the bicycle appeared,

where the bicycle wheel lay after the collision,

where the tyre marks began.

Arun Paswan, a technical assistant from the traffic department, took measurements.

The braking mark was short.

“Can we estimate speed from this?” Meera asked.

“An estimate, yes. But we need road surface, tyre condition, brakes, load. The mark alone cannot give an exact number.”

“Thirty?”

“Possible.”

“Forty?”

“Possible.”

“Fifty?”

Arun shook his head.

“Less likely, but scientifically I would not say yet.”

Meera thought:

People want numbers.

Evidence gives limits.

While measuring the road, Arun suddenly said:

“This turn wasn’t always this narrow.”

“What?”

“Look at this drain excavation. There is a two-cubit heap of earth on the right. Then the goods vehicle is parked beside it. The actual width for movement has been cut almost in half.”

The drain work had been under way for three weeks.

The contractor had dug out part of the road to lay pipes, but half the safety barrier had collapsed. Two strips of red cloth hung torn in the wind. There was no lighting visible at night. By day the heap of earth blocked the view around the turn.

The goods vehicle had been parked beside that heap.

Its owner was a trader with a grocery warehouse nearby.

Parking within a prescribed distance of the turn was prohibited, but the old yellow line on the road had disappeared beneath excavation dust.

"We park here every day," the driver said. "No one has stopped us."

"Does doing it every day make it the rule?" Meera asked.

"If it was wrong, why didn't the police say so earlier?"

Meera wrote that question down.

A round traffic mirror had been installed at the turn by the municipality five years earlier so that vehicles coming out of the lane could see the main road.

Now its glass was grey and half broken.

An advertisement had been pasted over part of it.

The first time Anil came back to the turn after leaving hospital, he stopped as soon as he saw the mirror.

"This used to be clean," he said.

"Did you look at it?" Meera asked.

"Yes. When coming out of the lane I used to look here. On the day of the accident... I don't remember whether I looked or not. Perhaps out of habit I did look, but nothing was clear."

"Why didn't you mention it in your statement?"

"Because I didn't remember that this thing could matter."

Every object at the turn was becoming a witness after the accident:

dust,

mirror,

yellow line,

drain,

parked vehicle,

camera,

horn.

Before the accident they had merely been background.

Suresh too was brought back to the site.

He was asked to drive along exactly the same route again.

He drove the empty vehicle slowly.

The goods vehicle had already been removed. From a distance the turn was clearly visible.

"Now everything can be seen," one constable said.

Suresh stopped the vehicle.

"That day it was not clear. Put that vehicle back, rebuild the earth pile exactly as it was, then look."

Meera stopped the reconstruction at once.

"He is right," Arun said. "Change the obstruction and you change the view."

That evening the goods vehicle was placed back in the same position, according to measurements.

White sacks were stacked to the height of the former earth pile.

A bicycle of Anil's height was placed in the lane.

Sitting in the driver's seat, Meera looked.

The mouth of the lane had almost vanished.

Then she stood where the bicycle had been and looked toward the main road.

The blue vehicle would not become fully visible until it was already close.

From both directions, the two road users saw one another late.

"Then the accident was inevitable?" a reporter asked.

Arun stopped him immediately.

"No. The risk was higher. Nothing was inevitable. If the vehicle had been slower, if the bicycle had stopped fully, if the goods vehicle had not been there, if the mirror had been clean - there were many points at which the event could have been avoided."

The reporter wrote:

"Official Admits Accident Could Have Been Avoided."

Later Arun told Meera:

"Half of what I said has disappeared."

"Half-truth travels fastest," Meera replied.

One week after the accident, four clocks were placed side by side at the station:

the chemist's camera,

the bank camera,

the cloth shop camera,

Suresh's vehicle-location system.

All four showed different times.

The vehicle's location system recorded speeds between twenty-eight and thirty-four kilometres per hour five minutes before the accident, but its final logged point was about seventy metres before the turn.

The next point came after the collision.

"That proves thirty," Suresh said.

Arun replied:

"Seventy metres before the turn. Not at impact."

"But it doesn't prove fifty either."

"That is also true."

Anil's brother grew angry.

"Then what are all these machines for?"

Meera said:

"They tell us limits. A limit is also information."

The brother did not feel that answer was justice.

Meanwhile, the incomplete chemist's video reached social media.

Someone had copied it on a phone from the police file.

At thirty seconds the vehicle could be seen moving.

At forty-one seconds, the aftermath.

Some people called the freeze in between a "cut."

Others called it a "conspiracy."

An edited version was made in which the frozen eleven seconds were removed completely.

Now the blue vehicle appeared to move and then suddenly reach the bicycle.

It looked extremely fast because eleven seconds of elapsed time had been compressed away.

That clip was shared thousands of times.

"See?" Anil's brother said. "How fast it is!"

Meera showed him the original.

"In this edited version, eleven seconds have been removed. The distance the vehicle travelled during eleven seconds now appears in a single jump. That gives a false impression of speed."

"So the video is a lie?"

"The frames shown in the video are real. The way they were joined creates the deception."

"Why is there so much trouble between truth and falsehood?"

Meera answered wearily:

"Because the event itself is not that simple."

The effect on Suresh's family was different.

The school suspended him temporarily.

Parents were asking questions.

His wife Rekha said:

"Nothing has been proved, yet punishment has begun."

Suresh remained quiet.

At night he seemed to hear the brake sound again and again.

He reread his statement:

"The bicycle suddenly emerged."

One night he told Rekha:

"Perhaps 'suddenly' is the wrong word."

"Why?"

"It was sudden for me. For him, perhaps he had been coming out slowly."

"So you will take the blame onto yourself?"

"I am talking about a word."

Rekha became irritated.

"Now words will decide whether you keep your job."

Suresh understood:

testimony does not contain memory alone.

Livelihood has weight inside it too.

At his house Anil kept the broken bicycle bell on a table.

His wife Mala wanted him to make a harsh complaint against Suresh.

Hospital expenses.

Closed shop.

Unfinished tailoring work.

Everything was accumulating.

"You said the vehicle was going fast," Mala said.

"It seemed fast to me."

"Same thing."

"No."

"What will you gain by twisting words in law?"

Anil looked toward his plaster.

"If I say I saw what I did not see, will my injury become smaller?"

Mala fell silent.

The accident had created tension in their house too between fact and need.

For Kamli Sahu, the incident became a different kind of trouble.

Reporters came to her tea cart asking:

"What did you see that day?"

Customers increased, but they came to buy the accident more than the tea.

At first she would say:

"The bicycle was in the middle."

By the second week the sentence had become:

"The bicycle suddenly appeared in the middle."

In the third week, a reporter wrote:

"Eyewitness: Cyclist Suddenly Entered the Road."

Kamli read the newspaper and panicked.

"I did not say 'entered,'" she told Meera. "I said 'appeared.' Those are different, aren't they?"

Meera did not laugh.

"Very different."

She recorded a supplementary statement.

Rambabu still insisted there had been two horns.

But the bank's external audio unit, part of a separate security system, recorded one sharp horn, followed immediately by a bus horn from farther away.

"See, two!" Rambabu said triumphantly.

The technician said:

"The second horn may not be from the accident site. It could be the bus at the main junction."

Rambabu looked disappointed.

"So we cannot trust our ears either?"

Meera said:

"Trust them. Just separate the sources."

As the investigation continued, a new question arose:

Where was the speed-limit sign at the turn?

Old municipal records showed that one had been installed.

At the site there was a post.
 No signboard.
 Some said a storm had broken it.
 Others said it had been stolen.
 The municipal file said:
 "Repair completed."
 Meera asked for photographs.
 There was no post-repair photograph in the file.
 There was, however, a payment entry.
 "What does the sign have to do with this accident?" the municipal engineer asked.
 "Was there a system to warn drivers to slow down at the turn?"
 "Do people reduce speed because of a sign? Everyone knows there is a turn."
 "Suresh comes from another neighbourhood."
 The engineer fell silent.
 The permit for the drain excavation was checked too.
 The contractor had been instructed not to deposit debris within ten metres of the turn, to place reflective barriers at night, and to clean the site daily.
 All three rules were only partly followed.
 The contractor said:
 "The accident was between a vehicle and a bicycle. Why are you dragging my work into it?"
 Arun replied:
 "Because a road is not only asphalt. Anything that reduces sight distance becomes part of the circumstances of an accident."
 "So the municipality is guilty in every accident?"
 "Not every one. In this one, whatever the evidence shows will be written."
 Meera noticed:
 fear of blame prevented people even from acknowledging circumstances.
 If someone admitted one contributing factor, they feared the whole crime would be placed on their head.
 So everyone tried to make their own share zero.

Two weeks later the District Road Safety Committee inspected the site.
 The white goods vehicle had been removed.
 The debris cleared.
 The broken mirror replaced.
 A new speed sign installed.
 The yellow no-parking line repainted.
 The committee chair said:
 "Now the turn is safe."
 Meera asked:
 "Have you seen the photographs recording the condition on the day of the accident?"
 "They will be in the file."

“Will the inspection report mention the earlier condition?”

“The main thing is that it has now been improved.”

Meera was uneasy with the answer.

Improvement was necessary.

But improvement can sometimes erase evidence.

The mirror that now shone did not show how grey it had been on the day of the accident.

She preserved all the first-day photographs in a separate file.

The insurance company sent its own surveyor.

His conclusion was simple:

“A motor vehicle moving on the main road has primary right of passage; a cyclist entering from a side lane is expected to exercise greater caution.”

Anil's brother was furious.

Suresh's employer was pleased.

But Meera read the next line in the report:

“The motor-vehicle driver bears an equal duty to reduce speed at a sight-obstructed turn.”

Each side read its own sentence.

No one shared the sentence in between.

A few days later the traffic tribunal held a preliminary hearing.

Four video feeds were played together before the judge.

Arun synchronised their mismatched timestamps.

For the first time, the distant bank camera showed that two seconds before the accident, a small part of the cyclist's head could be seen behind the white goods vehicle.

At that moment the blue vehicle was outside the frame.

“So the bicycle did not stop?” Suresh's lawyer asked.

Arun said:

“This video shows very little movement. Whether it was stationary or moving extremely slowly cannot be determined.”

Anil's lawyer asked:

“Where was the blue vehicle?”

“Outside the frame.”

“So the cyclist could not have seen it?”

“We cannot conclude that because this camera did not see it, a human being could not see it either.”

The judge smiled.

“Today everyone needs more patience than the machines.”

The next feed came from the cloth shop.

The bicycle disappeared behind the body of a customer.

For only an instant, the bonnet of the blue vehicle flashed into view.

Then the customer moved aside.

The accident had already happened.

The lawyer asked:

“In this frame, isn't the vehicle in the middle of the road?”

Arun froze the image.

“It appears so because of perspective. The edge of the road is not visible as a reference.”

“But the video is clear.”

“The image is clear. The geometry is not.”

The sentence remained in the courtroom for a moment.

Meera wrote it down:

“Image clear, meaning not.”

After the hearing reporters waited outside.

One asked:

“According to the police, who is at fault?”

Meera said:

“The investigation is examining the driver's caution, the cyclist's entry into the road, illegal parking, blocked sightlines, construction debris, the damaged mirror, and the missing sign. Each factor is supported by different evidence.”

“One name?”

“Not yet.”

The next day's headline read:

“Police Still Fail to Identify Culprit.”

Meera cut out the report and placed it in her file.

The word failure hurt.

After a while, though, she thought:

perhaps choosing one name too quickly was not success.

Anil gradually began to walk again.

The first day he reached his shop, he did not take the bicycle.

He went on foot.

At Navalakha Turn he stopped before the new mirror.

He could see his own face in it.

The road was clear.

The yellow line bright.

The speed sign new.

He stood there for a long time.

Kamli brought him tea.

“The turn is good now,” she said.

Anil replied:

“Why did none of this look bad to me before the accident?”

Kamli said:

“When you live with something every day, its defect becomes habit.”

From a distance Suresh approached on foot.

The school had not yet taken him back as a driver.

He was returning from the police station after signing papers.

When Anil saw him, for a moment his body tightened.

Suresh stopped too.

For the first time after the accident they were facing one another without police, lawyers, or family.

Suresh said quietly:

“Are you better now?”

“I can walk.”

“The shop?”

“Open half a day.”

Silence.

Kamli set tea down in front of both of them as if they were ordinary customers.

Suresh said:

“There is one thing from that day that keeps coming back to me. I sounded the horn, but perhaps I braked half a second later. I thought the bicycle would stop.”

Looking into his cup, Anil said:

“I thought the vehicle was far away. Perhaps I saw nothing in the mirror, but out of old habit assumed the road would be clear.”

Each was sharing his own “I thought.”

The accident had formed in the instant of assumptions before the facts.

“Do you consider me guilty?” Suresh suddenly asked.

Anil took time before answering.

“My injury came from your vehicle. That is a fact. But the turn that had been made there was not made by you alone.”

Suresh looked up.

“And whether I myself was completely stopped - I cannot honestly say for certain now.”

This was not forgiveness.

It was not friendship.

Only two people loosening the edges of their own certain stories.

A little way off, a reporter's raised phone became visible.

Suresh fell silent at once.

So did Anil.

A public image could change words again.

Two months later the tribunal issued an interim order.

It did not finally determine criminal guilt, but it accepted shared responsibility for compensation.

It recorded four elements:

insufficient speed caution by the motor driver,

the cyclist's entry under uncertain visibility,

illegal parking,

and safety failures by the construction manager.

A separate recommendation concerned municipal maintenance and the missing signs.

Suresh's employer was angry.

"They gave a little blame to everyone. Is that justice?"

Anil's brother was angry too.

"My brother went to hospital and the municipality gets away with writing papers!"

Reading the order, Meera understood:

to write multiple contributing causes does not mean dissolving responsibility.

Each share can be distinguished according to evidence.

But the human mind wants a story:

one victim,

one culprit,

one moment.

A system is made of many hands.

That is why it is difficult for a system to admit its own errors.

Three months later, the Road Safety Committee installed a new sign at Navalakha Turn:

"Obstructed-View Turn: Reduce Speed."

Cleaning of the mirror was added to a monthly checklist.

Metal posts were installed to prevent parking within twenty metres of the turn.

New excavation rules required debris to be removed immediately.

A small news item appeared:

"Navalakha Turn Made Safe After Accident."

No one's name.

Meera liked this better than the earlier sensational headlines.

But this too contained a weakness.

"After the accident" made the accident sound merely like the cause of improvement.

She wondered:

why does a system so often notice after an injury what it could have noticed before?

Six months later Anil began cycling again.

On the first day, at Navalakha Turn, he stopped fully.

Put his foot on the ground.

Looked into the mirror.

Looked right.

Looked left.

Then crossed.

A young man behind him sounded the horn.

Anil did not move.

Suresh too returned to work, but on another route.

He developed the habit of slowing down long before every turn.

One day the helper laughed.

“There isn't even a turn here.”

Suresh said:

“I slow down for what I cannot see.”

He heard his own sentence and fell silent.

At Kamli's tea cart a new notice had been pasted:

“Video of the accident will not be shown here.”

Someone asked:

“Why?”

Kamli said:

“Because the part everyone wants to see is not in the video. People watch the rest and add eleven seconds from their own minds.”

Rambabu laughed.

“You have become a philosopher.”

Straining tea, Kamli said:

“No. I have only heard the same incident too many times.”

At the end of the year, Meera used the Navalakha Turn file as an example in district training for new constables.

On the screen she played the first footage:

blue vehicle,

bicycle wheel,

frozen frame,

dust.

She stopped it at thirty seconds.

“What happened here?” she asked.

One constable said:

“The camera stopped.”

Another:

“Someone cut the video.”

A third:

“The accident.”

Meera said:

“All three are assumptions. The evidence says only this: moving video for these eleven seconds is not available from this camera. Everything else must be examined through separate evidence.”

Then she showed the site plan:

goods vehicle,

debris,

broken mirror,

missing sign,

mouth of the lane,

brake marks.

“What is the most dangerous gap in an accident investigation?” Meera asked.

Someone said:

“Missing video.”

Meera shook her head.

“Missing video is dangerous. More dangerous is the belief that the first story we think of when we see the gap must therefore be the truth.”

She paused on her own wording, then smiled.

“Must therefore be the truth.”

The class laughed.

Meera opened the next page.

It showed a photograph of the turn after improvements:

clean mirror,

open sightline,

yellow line,

speed sign.

“What does this photograph prove?”

A constable said:

“That improvements were made.”

“And it does not prove that the site looked like this on the day of the accident. Always record the time difference.”

Meera remembered her first week, when the committee had seen the new mirror and said, “Now it is safe.”

One part of investigation is understanding an event.

Another is preventing post-event changes from covering the earlier event.

After the training, a new constable asked:

“Madam, in the end who was guilty?”

Meera closed the file.

The question had followed her since that day.

“The legal part will be answered by the court. The investigative answer is this: the driver’s decision was one cause, the cyclist’s decision one cause, blocked visibility one cause, parking one cause, construction management one cause, maintenance one cause. Their weights are not equal, but no one is zero without evidence.”

“Then how do we write the story?”

“As much as was seen, write that much. What is an estimate, call an estimate. What is a gap, do not fill it.”

The constable wrote it down.

That evening Meera rode home through Navalakha Turn.

Traffic was ordinary.

For a moment her motorcycle flashed in the new mirror.

Ahead, Anil was on his bicycle.

Farther away, a school vehicle took the turn slowly.

Suresh was not its driver.

Steam rose from Kamli’s tea cart.

Nothing happened.

The ordinariness was so ordinary that no one would share its video.

As she crossed the turn, Meera thought:

perhaps safety is the name for thousands of such unreported moments, when people see one another in time, signs work, mirrors are clean, debris has been removed, vehicles are parked away from the corner, and no one trusts an assumption completely.

The old camera still hung above the chemist's shop, but Bablu Jha had installed a new one.

The new system recorded continuously, synchronised its own time, and gave an alert when storage was filling.

Bablu proudly told everyone:

"Now not even one second will be lost."

Meera smiled when she heard him.

Better technology was good.

But she knew that even if some future recording were complete, meaning would not become complete automatically.

A camera chooses a direction.

A frame creates a boundary.

Sound may remain outside.

Perspective may alter the sense of speed.

And human beings will still ask questions.

A complete image is not a complete story.

An incomplete image is not a lie.

The lie begins when we fill a gap for our own convenience without evidence, and then forget that the filling was ours.

At Navalakha Turn, those eleven seconds were still unavailable.

But slowly those eleven seconds made something else clear:

the accident was not only the collision of two moving objects.

It was a single moment in which road design, maintenance, habit, assumption, decision, timing, and institutional neglect met.

And that was why its truth could not fit inside one name.

The Prize for a Lie

When the result of the “Mithila New Writing Award” was announced, the first congratulations did not go to Arunesh Mishra.

They went to his editor, Ratan Jha.

Ratan grew tired of answering the telephone.

Literary magazines.

Local television.

University departments.

Booksellers.

Everywhere, the same phrase:

“The bravest story of the year.”

The winning story was titled “The Voice of the Soil.”

Arunesh was a fiction writer in his forties. Five collections had already been published, but this was his first major award.

The story centred on an elderly singer in a flood-ravaged village who, before leaving her village, recounted fragments of remembered folk songs to a young teacher.

The songs never appeared whole.

There was only the narrator’s description, a few lines, and the old woman’s words.

The award committee’s statement said:

“The story creates a unique bridge between oral tradition and modern displacement.”

Arunesh read that sentence three times.

Then an unfamiliar message arrived on his phone.

“Unique? Open my research file.”

The sender was Deepa Karn, a former student of the university.

Arunesh did not recognise the name.

The second message contained a photograph.

A page from an old notebook.

At the top:

“Field Note: Belahi Tola. Singer - Surati Devi, approximate age 72.”

Below it was a sentence that had entered Arunesh’s story in almost the same order:

“When a house goes under water, people first save not their belongings, but their voices.”

Arunesh’s hand stopped.

He remembered that line as one of the central sentences of his own story.

He did not attend the award dinner that night.

Ratan said on the telephone:

“What can one similar sentence prove? Such phrases circulate in people’s speech. First look at the whole file.”

"I don't know Deepa Karn."

"Then how could you have knowingly copied her?"

For a moment the question relieved Arunesh.

Then another question rose immediately:

if he did not know her, how had the sentence reached him?

The next morning the corridor of the university's Maithili Department was unusually crowded.

Deepa had posted five photographs on social media.

Each compared her field notes with passages from "The Voice of the Soil."

In one case, a whole sentence was similar.

In another, the sequence of a scene.

Elsewhere, the idea behind an elderly singer's words.

Deepa's accusation was simple:

"My unpublished research was turned into fiction, and my name appears nowhere."

By then the headline had already been written:

"Award-Winning Writer Accused of Literary Theft."

When Arunesh reached the department, the chair, Professor Vaidehi Thakur, had already seated three people in her office:

Deepa.

Ratan Jha.

And a research assistant named Nilambar.

The moment Nilambar saw Arunesh, he lowered his eyes.

Arunesh understood at once that somewhere near this young man lay the missing link.

Vaidehi Thakur said:

"This is not a meeting to decide guilt. First we will understand the journey of the papers."

Deepa placed a thick file on the table.

"This was my M.A. research project. Two years ago. I did fieldwork on folk songs in Belahi, Khajuri, and Piprahi. Four sessions with Surati Devi. Audio recordings, transcription, commentary."

"Was it public?" Arunesh asked.

"No. One copy in the department collection. My private copy. And a digital copy with my supervisor."

Ratan interrupted:

"Then how did it reach Arunesh?"

Deepa looked at Nilambar.

Nilambar spoke slowly.

"I was digitising the collection."

"And?" Vaidehi asked.

"Ratan Sir once asked for material for a special issue on folklore. I prepared summaries from five or six old research projects and sent them."

Ratan said at once:

"Summaries. Not full files."

"Yes, but..." Nilambar stopped.

"But?"

"I had also extracted some quotations from Deepa Didi's file. I had written the sources, but perhaps in a separate attachment."

Ratan's face changed.

"Perhaps?"

Nilambar opened his phone and searched old email.

There were two attachments:

"Folk Material."

"Source List."

Ratan had opened the first.

There was no sign that he had opened the second.

Arunesh leaned back in his chair.

Ratan said:

"I sent the first file to Arunesh as background reading for a story."

"The source list?"

"I never saw it."

Deepa did not laugh, but her voice hardened.

"So the names were in one file, the material in another. And the writer received only the material. Then the names disappeared by themselves?"

Before Ratan could answer, Arunesh spoke.

"I read the file."

Everyone looked at him.

"Yes. About a year and a half ago. Ratan said it contained raw material on folk singing, displacement, and floods. I read it. I did not write the story then. Six months later I began. I no longer remembered which sentence had come from that file and which from my own notes."

Deepa asked:

"But five similarities?"

Arunesh remained silent.

Vaidehi Thakur said:

"Before counting similarities, we must distinguish their nature."

They read all five examples separately.

The first -

"When a house goes under water..."

was nearly word for word.

The second concerned an episode from Surati Devi's life:

on the night of a flood, she had not carried away a sack of paddy but her granddaughter's notebook and a sheet containing song lyrics.

In Arunesh's story, the character leaves behind a sack of grain and saves her granddaughter's notebook.

The relationship and object had changed.

The structure of the scene remained close.

The third was the meaning of a song.

Deepa's note said:

"The river is mother, sister, and creditor."

The story said:

"The river is mother, sister, and moneylender all at once."

The fourth concerned group singing at night in a rehabilitation camp in Belahi.

That was a real event mentioned in several interviews.

The fifth was an old woman's saying:

"A song is a house without a fixed place."

In the story:

"A song is a moving house."

Vaidehi Thakur separated the five sheets.

"These are not five pieces of evidence of the same kind. One is close verbal borrowing. Two may be transformations. One is a shared event. One is a general idea. It is easy to give all five one name. That is not enough for an inquiry."

Deepa said:

"My problem is not only five lines. My field labour disappeared."

For the first time Arunesh looked at her fully.

She did not merely look angry.

She looked tired.

"I travelled by boat for two months," she said. "Three times Surati Devi refused to speak to me. On the fourth, her daughter-in-law first sat beside us. I asked for meanings of songs, then corrected errors. Now the story wins an award and everyone says - the writer's imagination."

Arunesh said quietly:

"You are right that the credit disappeared."

Ratan looked at him immediately, as though the sentence were a legal confession.

Arunesh added:

"But I still do not know how much of the story came from memory of that file, how much from my own notes, and how much arose independently."

Deepa said:

"That is all I am asking - show the journey."

After the meeting, the award organisation formed an inquiry committee.

Three members:

a literary writer,

an archival specialist,

and a publishing-ethics specialist.

Its first request was simple:

all drafts.

That was where Arunesh's problem became serious.

He wrote first on paper, then typed on a computer.
He had not preserved all his paper drafts.
Seven digital drafts survived.
The earliest was dated six months before publication.
But Ratan's "Folk Material" file was nine months older than that.
Arunesh turned over an old trunk at home.
His wife Mrinal asked:
"Where is that small black notebook you used?"
It was found behind the bookcase.
Inside was the first seed of "The Voice of the Soil":
an old man, not a woman;
drought, not flood;
proverbs, not songs.
A page later appeared three words:
"people saving voices."
Arunesh stared at them for a long time.
Had he written those words before reading Deepa's material or after?
The notebook could not prove it.
The date only said "Phagun."
No year.
Mrinal asked:
"You truly don't remember?"
"No."
"Then that is the hardest thing."
"What?"
"You cannot save yourself by lying, and when you tell the truth, the truth is still unclear."

The committee began reconstructing the chain of sources.
Nilambar's email showed that the "Folk Material" file contained thirty-seven fragments.
They did not all come from Deepa.
They came from eight research projects, two published articles, three folklore collections, and Nilambar's own notes.
The source list contained all the names.
But there were also mistakes in matching excerpt numbers to source numbers.
Because of those mistakes, two quotations taken from Deepa's work had slipped under the name of another researcher.
Nilambar said:
"I prepared it in a hurry. The special issue had a deadline."
Committee member Sudhanshu Pathak asked:
"Did you put verbatim quotations inside quotation marks?"
"Some."
"And the others?"
"Not all."

“Why?”

“I thought this was an internal research document, not publication.”

“Does being internal reduce the need for sources?”

Nilambar fell silent.

Then came Ratan's turn.

“What instructions did you give the writer when you sent the material?”

Ratan read his email:

“These are raw voices. Do not use them directly; use them to understand the atmosphere.”

The committee asked:

“Why didn't you send the source list?”

“I did not know there was a separate file.”

“Did you ask?”

“No.”

“Did you notice lines in the writer's draft that were close to the field notes?”

Ratan was silent for a minute.

“I marked two.”

“What did you write?”

He opened his computer.

An old tracked-changes copy remained saved.

One comment read:

“This line feels too archival. Make it more narrative.”

Deepa spoke immediately:

“So you sensed that it was close to a source.”

Ratan said:

“But I did not know what the source was.”

A committee member said:

“Then the issue is not only literary borrowing. It is also editorial source provenance.”

Arunesh's drafts were opened.

In the first draft, the disputed key sentence was incomplete:

“When a house sinks, what do people save?”

In the second:

“When a house sinks, people save memory first.”

In the third:

“When a house sinks, people first save not their belongings, but their voices.”

That was Deepa's sentence.

The committee asked:

“What did you read between the second and third draft?”

Arunesh checked browsing history, email, notebooks - everything.

During that week, Ratan's old file had been opened again.

The computer's recent-files list showed that much.

No one in the room spoke.

Arunesh himself said:

"Then the probability becomes very high that the sentence came from there."

Deepa's face remained hard, but for the first time relief appeared alongside anger.

At least one point was no longer vague.

"I will remove the sentence," Arunesh said.

Deepa answered at once:

"Removing it alone is not the solution. Cite the source."

"A footnote in a short story?" Ratan asked.

"Why not?"

Ratan did not laugh.

"It is a story collection, not a research paper."

"Then a preface, acknowledgements, an author's note - something."

The committee recorded the dispute.

The next three similarities were harder.

Surati Devi herself was still alive, but over eighty.

The committee did not want to trouble her.

With Deepa's permission, they listened to the old recording.

Surati Devi said:

"The river is my mother too, my sister too, and the moneylender who charges interest."

In Deepa's notes that became:

"mother, sister, creditor."

In Arunesh's story:

"mother, sister, moneylender."

All three forms had emerged from the same original voice.

Now the question turned around:

who was the original author?

Deepa said:

"The words are Surati Devi's. I only made the record."

Arunesh said:

"Then the credit belongs to her first."

Ratan said quietly:

"And what if the metaphor is an old folk-song line?"

Nilambar immediately searched two folk-song collections.

Similar sentiment was found.

Not the exact three-part phrase.

The committee wrote:

"In oral tradition, ownership cannot be resolved solely through individual authorship. Even so, the collecting labour of the field researcher and the contribution of the speaker should both be acknowledged."

After that sentence, the controversy grew even louder online.

One side wrote:

"The committee is turning theft into philosophy."

Another:

“Folklore belongs to no private owner.”

A third:

“Return the prize.”

A fourth:

“The young researcher wants publicity.”

Deepa's inbox filled with abuse.

She told Vaidehi Thakur:

“I made an accusation about a text. Now people are writing about my character.”

Vaidehi said:

“Public controversy moves from facts to persons very quickly.”

Deepa asked:

“If I had stayed silent, would that have been better?”

“No.”

“Then this?”

“This consequence is not your fault. But you still have to pass through it.”

Arunesh did not escape attack either.

Readers began combing through his older stories.

Someone found a similar rain scene in a story from ten years earlier and a Bengali translation.

Someone else called a common proverb theft.

Someone identified a real similarity too:

two sentences in an essay Arunesh had written years earlier had been reproduced without quotation marks.

Arunesh reread the essay.

“That was a mistake,” he told Mrinal.

“Then why didn't you see it before?”

“Because no one showed it to me.”

“So ethics depends on being caught?”

Arunesh fell silent.

The award organisation asked him for a public statement.

Ratan prepared a draft:

“The similarities were unintended. The author remains committed to independent creation. The allegation is under investigation.”

Arunesh read it.

“This sounds like a lawyer.”

“Right now a lawyer's language is necessary.”

“But it does not say that the material actually reached me.”

“If you say that, the headline will be: ‘Writer Admits It.’”

“And if that is the truth?”

Ratan was silent for a while.

“Truth and headline are not the same thing.”

Arunesh rewrote the statement.

The new version said:

"I acknowledge that an internal research compilation was given to me for reading, without its source list. The present inquiry indicates a strong possibility that at least one sentence in my story came into my memory through that compilation from Deepa Karn's field notes. I accept responsibility for my part in the failure of attribution. The nature of the remaining similarities is still under review."

Ratan held his head.

Deepa read the statement and wrote only:

"Late, but in the right direction."

The inquiry lasted four weeks.

Meanwhile, the prize money was not deposited in Arunesh's account.

The organisation had frozen it.

Before issuing its final report, the committee showed draft findings to all parties.

The conclusions were not one-dimensional.

First:

The major disputed sentence was highly likely to have originated in Deepa's field note. The sequence of Arunesh's drafts and the use of the file supported this conclusion.

Second:

Two scenes were inspired by real oral interviews but sufficiently transformed in the story; nevertheless, source acknowledgement was appropriate.

Third:

One community event was documented by several independent sources, so individual ownership over it was weak.

Fourth:

The "river as mother/sister/moneylender" metaphor originated in Surati Devi's oral expression; Deepa was collector/transcriber. Use by the writer required acknowledgement at both levels.

Fifth:

The editorial process broke the chain of attribution by separating the source list from the material.

Sixth:

Nilambar's method of compilation failed to distinguish clearly between quotation and paraphrase.

Seventh:

Arunesh's own note-taking system was inadequate for source marking; he kept external material and his own imaginative notes in the same notebook without distinction.

Eighth:

The available evidence did not establish a knowingly planned "theft of a story," but the failure of attribution was real and multi-layered.

Deepa stopped at the word "knowingly."

"I never claimed I could prove what was in his mind," she said. "I said my material travelled without my name."

A committee member replied:

"The report agrees with that."

Arunesh felt relief on reading "planned theft not established."

Then immediate shame.

Because the next line clearly said that the attribution failure was real.

Ratan objected to the fifth finding.

"I never received the source list. Calling this an editorial failure is harsh."

The committee asked:

"Before sending raw research material to a writer, whose responsibility is it to verify the source chain?"

"Ideally, the editor's."

"Then?"

Ratan lowered the paper.

"I accept my part of the failure."

Nilambar's voice was the quietest.

"I had the source list. Now, when I think of why I made it a separate attachment, it seems foolish."

Deepa said:

"Not only foolish. A methodological error in research work."

"Yes."

"And next time?"

"A source marker attached to every excerpt itself."

For the first time there was a little ordinary human laughter in the room.

But the question of the award remained.

The organisation's rules said a story proved to contain plagiarism would be disqualified.

But plagiarism itself was defined in only two lines:

"Presenting another person's original work or a significant portion of it as one's own without adequate acknowledgement."

How much was "significant"?

One sentence?

Two scenes?

The structure of the whole story?

The inquiry committee had been formed to examine process, not literary value.

Whether to cancel the award was for the jury.

The jury sat for five hours.

Reporters waited outside.

At last the chair announced:

"The award will not be immediately revoked. However, payment of the prize money will remain suspended until a revised edition is published with explicit source acknowledgement and a note on contributions. The organisation will also revise its rules."

No one was fully satisfied.

Those who wanted the award cancelled said:

“A famous writer has been protected.”

Those who believed the accusation baseless said:

“The writer has been humiliated under mob pressure.”

Deepa said:

“At least the fieldwork is no longer invisible.”

Arunesh said:

“I am more concerned now with repairing the story than with the award.”

Ratan remained silent.

Work on the revised edition began.

The first question:

remove the disputed sentence or quote it?

At first Arunesh wanted to remove it.

Deepa said:

“If you remove it, the history becomes clean - but the error disappears too.”

“Then?”

“Keep it. Put it in quotation marks. Add a source note at the end. Let the reader see where the voice came from.”

Arunesh agreed.

The second disputed scene was changed.

Not merely to “avoid similarity.”

Arunesh wanted to clarify the boundary between a real incident and fictional transformation.

At the third point, Surati Devi’s name was given with permission.

Her family was contacted.

Her grandson asked by telephone:

“If Grandmother’s words remain in the book, what does she receive?”

Everyone stopped.

Ratan said:

“Acknowledgement.”

Deepa said:

“Only acknowledgement?”

Using the frozen prize money as a reference point, Arunesh proposed a separate honorarium.

The organisation examined the legal details.

In the end the publisher established contributor payments for both Surati Devi and Deepa’s research project.

Deepa said:

“This is not the complete answer to rights, but at least it is not merely symbolic.”

The revised edition added two pages titled:

“Sources and Collaboration.”

They stated that the story was fictional, but its background on folk singing, post-flood displacement, and memory had been shaped by several field sources.

Special acknowledgement was given to Deepa Karn's Belahi field study and to the oral interviews with Surati Devi.

The disputed sentence's original speaker was also clearly credited.

Arunesh changed his note-taking system.

From then on, he drew a red square before material from an external source, and a round dot before his own imaginative notes.

Mrinal laughed.

"If you had been this disciplined earlier?"

"Perhaps this story would have taken another form."

"The award?"

"Who knows."

Six months later the university held a seminar:

"Originality, Oral Tradition, and Attribution."

Five people were on the stage:

Deepa.

Arunesh.

Ratan.

Nilambar.

Vaidehi Thakur.

The most interesting question came from a student:

"If the writer did not knowingly copy, is it fair to call it plagiarism?"

Deepa answered:

"Intention matters, but effect matters too. If my labour is used without my name, saying 'I didn't remember' does not restore the credit."

Arunesh said:

"From my own experience I can say this much: memory is not as dependable as a writer's private property. What we read and hear leaves traces. That is why preserving sources is an ethical practice, not merely a legal defence."

Ratan added:

"Editors have a role too. If we give a writer raw material, its source chain must accompany it."

Nilambar said:

"And even a research assistant's spreadsheet can be part of literary ethics. I learned that the difficult way."

The room laughed.

Another student asked:

"Then what does original writing mean? Everything comes from somewhere."

Vaidehi Thakur replied:

"Not every influence is theft. Not every similarity destroys originality. The question is: what have you taken from another person's distinctive wording, structure, labour, discovery, voice, or expression? How much? How did you transform it? Where did you give credit?"

“So there is no clear boundary?”

“Some boundaries are clear. If you take exact words, quotation is required. Some areas are grey. Grey areas do not reduce responsibility. They increase the need for care.”

After the seminar an elderly man approached Arunesh.

He was from Belahi.

“Surati Devi is my aunt,” he said.

Arunesh grew slightly uneasy.

“How is her health?”

“So-so. She didn’t understand the award controversy. I told her that something she had said went into a book.”

“What did she say?”

The old man laughed.

“She said: if my words belonged only to me, why do I keep forgetting them? The one who remembered them has a share too.”

Deepa, standing nearby, smiled when she heard it.

“Write that down,” she told Arunesh. “But this time with the name.”

Arunesh took a notebook from his pocket.

He drew a red square.

Then wrote:

“Surati Devi, oral statement, conveyed through family.”

Everyone laughed.

One year later the revised edition of “The Voice of the Soil” was placed on a literature syllabus.

Not only because of the story.

Because of the dispute over its sources.

Students were assigned to compare the first and revised editions.

Deepa was now conducting further research on:

“Co-rights of Collector, Speaker, and Editor in Oral Archives.”

Nilambar created a new system for the university’s digital archive.

Every quotation automatically carried its source number.

Ratan printed a new rule in his magazine:

“Raw research material will not be sent to writers without source metadata.”

Arunesh began writing a new story.

Before the first page of each new work, he now wrote one small question:

“Where did this idea come from?”

Sometimes the answer:

“Own experience.”

Sometimes:

“Such-and-such book.”

Sometimes:

“Conversation with so-and-so.”

Sometimes:

“Do not remember - check.”

That last category became the most useful of all.

The prize money was eventually released.

There was no second ceremony.

The organisation sent the certificate by post.

Arunesh opened the envelope.

Across the top, in shining letters:

“Mithila New Writing Award.”

Mrinal asked:

“Will you hang it on the wall?”

Arunesh looked at the certificate for a long time.

“Yes,” he said. “But not alone.”

He had it framed.

Beneath the certificate he placed two smaller sheets.

The first:

a copy of the “Sources and Collaboration” page from the revised edition.

The second:

the line from the inquiry committee’s finding:

“The failure of attribution was real and multi-layered.”

When Ratan saw the frame, he said:

“Will people who come to your house read all this?”

“Those who only want to see the award can look at the top. Those who ask how the award survived can read below.”

One day Deepa came to the house.

She stood before the frame for a long time.

“You didn’t change the title?”

“Of the story?”

“No. People online still call this affair ‘The Prize for a Lie.’”

Arunesh smiled.

“Perhaps the award itself was not a lie. The simple stories that formed around it - ‘great writer completely innocent’ or ‘thief writer caught’ - both were incomplete.”

Deepa said:

“An incomplete statement is not always a lie.”

Arunesh replied:

“No. But when an incomplete statement is presented as the whole truth, it does the work of a lie.”

Their reflections appeared together in the glass.

Above them, the name of the award shone.

Below, the source list and the acknowledgement of failure.

Arunesh understood then:

perhaps originality is not a mirror in which the writer appears alone.

Behind the writer stand many voices, labours, readings, memories, mistakes, influences, and choices.

Erasing them all in order to see only one's own face is not originality.
And naming those voices does not make the work any less one's own.
The award remained on the wall.
But the sources remained beneath it.
And this time, no one's name was left behind in a separate attachment.

The Village Fire

The fire in Simaria's southern hamlet broke out one evening in Vaishakh, when the wind was not strong enough for anyone to call it a storm, but strong enough to carry smoke from one house to the thatch of another.

The first smoke was seen at the rear corner of Sugiya Devi's house.

On that point almost everyone agreed.

Agreement ended there.

Some said an electric wire had sparked.

Some said live embers had remained in the cooking-hearth ash.

Some said rubbish had been burned on the vacant ground behind the houses.

A few people, in lowered voices, mentioned a land dispute.

For two days five different stories circulated through the village, and all five spread among their own groups as though they were the truth.

Sugiya Devi's house had burned down.

Her younger son Ranjit, daughter-in-law Muniya, granddaughter Rupa, and elderly sister-in-law Basanti had all survived.

The paddy stored inside, clothes, school notebooks, a wooden chest, wedding utensils, and some documents had not.

But on the third day after the fire, Sugiya Devi said:

"Those who are in such a hurry to know who started the fire should first ask how the fire travelled from one house to eight."

The question was first heard on the veranda of the panchayat building.

An inquiry team had come from the district.

Its chair was not the Sub-Divisional Officer but Neelima Chaudhary, the block disaster officer. With her were a junior engineer from the electricity department, an officer from the fire service, an assistant inspector from the police station, and the panchayat secretary.

Village head Mahendra Yadav had arranged chairs at the front.

People from the affected hamlet sat on mats on the ground.

The headman had said:

"Everyone will get a full opportunity to speak."

Sugiya Devi said quietly:

"An opportunity and trust are two different things."

Neelima looked toward her.

"You speak."

"I will. But I will also see what kind of paper my words are written on."

A faint murmur ran across the veranda.

The panchayat secretary said:

"There are rules for recording statements."

"Let there be rules," Sugiya said. "Let the words remain mine."

Neelima signalled to the secretary.

"Write them as she says them."

The first statement was Sugiya Devi's.

She said that at around half past six in the evening she and Muniya were sorting greens in the courtyard. Ranjit had gone toward the fields. Rupa was writing in a school notebook. Basanti was lying inside on a cot.

"Who saw the smoke first?" Neelima asked.

"Rupa."

Twelve-year-old Rupa was sitting at the edge of the mat. Everyone looked toward her.

"You tell them," Sugiya said.

Rupa did not stand. From where she sat, she said:

"I smelled something first. Like burning plastic."

The electrical engineer stopped his pen at once.

"Plastic?"

"Yes. Then there was a dripping, popping sound. At the corner where the wire came close to the house, I saw a small light."

"Where was the hearth?" the assistant inspector asked.

"At the front of the house, toward the inner courtyard."

"And the ash?"

Muniya answered:

"The hearth had been extinguished after midday. Water had also been poured over the ash."

An elderly panchayat member spoke from behind:

"Many times ash looks dead on top but keeps smouldering inside."

Muniya turned toward him.

"Did you see my hearth that day?"

The old man fell silent.

Neelima said:

"Say what you saw. If something is an assumption, it will be written as an assumption."

The secretary wrote two headings at the top of the page in red ink:

"Observed fact."

"Assumption."

Sugiya Devi continued:

"Rupa screamed. I went to the back corner. The wall near the wire was blackening. The dry bamboo of the roof caught. I brought a bucket."

"How long before the next house caught?" the fire officer asked.

Sugiya thought.

"I didn't look at a clock. By the time I had filled the bucket twice - perhaps before the third - the fire had reached Ramwati's roof."

Ramwati was Sugiya's neighbour in the hamlet.

She immediately said:

"My roof did not catch directly. The bamboo fence between the houses burned first."

"Whose fence?"

"Between mine and Sugiya's."

"Was dry grass stored on it?"

"Yes, but I had removed half of it."

Someone from the back said:

"Not half. There was a whole heap."

Ramwati turned sharply.

"Say what you saw. Don't throw words into the air."

The first hour of the inquiry passed like that:

one fact,

two assumptions beside it,

and behind every assumption, someone's social position.

When Sugiya Devi's statement ended, Neelima asked:

"Do you suspect anyone?"

The veranda suddenly became quiet.

Two months earlier, land had been measured for road widening in the fields north of the panchayat. An old footpath beside the southern hamlet had also been entered on the map. Two families who had encroached upon that path had been mentioned again and again in village whispers after the fire.

Sugiya knew everyone was waiting for this answer.

She said:

"Suspicion is not the answer to a question."

"Even so?"

"There has been a land quarrel. There has been abuse too. But I did not see anyone setting fire to anything."

"So you are not accusing anyone of arson?"

"I will not say I saw what I did not see. But I will not say there was no dispute either."

The assistant inspector wrote the answer down.

The second group to come to the panchayat building that day was from the village's northern hamlet.

They were mainly landowners, shopkeepers, and older panchayat members. The fire had not reached their homes, but many had run to help put it out.

Ramlochan Singh, whose field adjoined the rear of the burned settlement, said:

"In my view this was a hearth fire. In poor households the wiring is tangled, yes, but it is not right to put everything on electricity."

The electrical engineer asked:

"Did you see fire from the hearth?"

"Not directly."

"Then what is the basis?"

"Village experience."

Neelima asked:

"Should village experience be written in place of fact?"

Ramlochan's voice hardened.

"I have lived in this village for forty years. My experience has value."

Sugiya Devi spoke from the back:

"I have lived here for fifty-five years. Who will decide the value of my experience?"

Neelima stopped them both.

"Everyone's experience will be recorded. But what was directly seen will be marked separately."

Ramlochan continued:

"One reason the fire spread is that the houses in that hamlet are packed together. It is a settlement that gradually came up on government land. How could a fire engine enter through those lanes?"

There was a factual element in that statement.

The lane leading inward from the main road toward the southern hamlet began about eight cubits wide, but at three places narrowed to less than five. In one place a veranda had been extended, elsewhere bricks had been piled up, elsewhere a bamboo platform had been built over the drain.

But Muniya immediately objected to the phrase "settlement on government land."

"We have land papers for our house."

Ramlochan said:

"I am not talking about every house."

"But you are talking about the houses that burned."

The panchayat secretary called for the files.

The land record in Sugiya Devi's family's name was available.

So was Ramwati's.

Documents for two houses were disputed.

The rest were entered in the old habitation list.

Neelima dictated:

"The description of the settlement as collectively illegal is not supported by the records."

The moment that line was read out, another murmur ran across the veranda.

Then shopkeeper Shambhu Sah said:

"I passed that side five minutes before the fire began. I saw rubbish burning."

"Where?"

"Near the ridge of Ramlochan Babu's field."

Ramlochan stood up.

"In my field?"

"Near the ridge. Not inside the field."

"Who was burning it?"

"I didn't see."

"Then why take my name?"

Shambhu did not smile.

"You asked the place."

That created a second possibility:
burning rubbish.

The inquiry team went to the scene and remained there until evening.

The ruins of Sugiya Devi's house had not been cleared.

She herself had stopped anyone from doing so.

"If there is to be an inquiry, let it remain as it is until then," she said.

The electrical engineer examined the point where the service wire entered.

The meter box had melted.

Part of the main service wire was blackened and twisted.

Almost all the bamboo in the roof had burned to ash.

Engineer Anshuman Jha put on gloves and lifted the wire.

"There are marks here resembling electrical arcing," he said.

The assistant inspector asked:

"Meaning the fire started from electricity?"

"Meaning an electrical arc may have occurred here."

"Did the fire come first, or the arc?"

Anshuman fell silent.

"That is precisely what has to be determined," he said later.

There was melted plastic beneath the meter.

But if fire had reached from outside, the plastic could have melted afterwards as well.

The wire joint had not been made with a standard clamp, but with an old twisted connection.

Anshuman wrote:

"Not an unauthorised connection; but an old, unsafe joint."

Sugiya asked:

"What is the difference between unauthorised and unsafe?"

"Unauthorised means without departmental approval. Unsafe means technically defective."

"Who made this joint?"

Anshuman checked the records.

The meter had been replaced three years earlier, but the service wire had been left unchanged.

"Perhaps the old technician."

"From the department?"

"A contract worker."

"Then whose name is on the paper?"

Before answering, Anshuman checked the file again.

That question was not answered that day.

Fire officer Ravindra Paswan began measuring the lane.

The distance from the main road to Sugiya's house was about one hundred and eighteen metres.

At the first narrowing: a pile of bricks.

At the second: a temporary tin shelter over the drain.

At the third: the habitual parking place of a motorcycle.

On the day of the fire, the small fire vehicle had stopped at the first narrowing.

The hose had been pulled inward by hand.

“How long before water reached the house?” Neelima asked.
 Ravindra checked his unit register.
 “Call recorded at 6:47. Departure at 6:50. Main village turn at 7:08. Hose reached inside at 7:16.”
 Ranjit, who had spoken little until then, said:
 “The first call from my phone was at 6:41.”
 “To whom?”
 “The local fire number.”
 Ravindra checked the register again.
 “Our control room records it at 6:47.”
 “Where did six minutes go?”
 Ravindra said:
 “That requires a separate inquiry.”
 Neelima dictated:
 “Six-minute discrepancy in notification time.”
 Ranjit said:
 “And the vehicle could not enter.”
 Ramlochan called from a distance:
 “People themselves narrowed the lane.”
 Ranjit turned on him.
 “Whose bricks were piled there?”
 The bricks belonged to a panchayat drainage project.
 They had been there for a month.
 The panchayat secretary’s face changed.
 “The work had stopped.”
 “Why?”
 “The payment file was pending.”
 “Then why weren’t the bricks removed?”
 There was no immediate answer.
 At that point a third direction opened in the story of the fire:
 not who had started it,
 but why it had spread so far.

On the second day the electricity department issued its preliminary note.
 On the village’s southern feeder, two voltage fluctuations had been recorded between 6:33 and 6:39 that evening.
 A consumer complaint had also been recorded saying that a fan had sped up and slowed down.
 Anshuman said:
 “This does not prove electricity caused the fire. But it increases the probability of an electrical fault.”
 Headman Mahendra Yadav asked:
 “Then write that the fire started from electricity.”
 “Not yet.”
 “Why?”

“Because if the fire reached the wire first, the voltage fluctuation may itself have been a consequence of the fire.”

“Then what use is this paper?”

Anshuman said calmly:

“The purpose of a record is to increase or decrease probabilities, not to end the story.”

That evening a separate meeting was held in the southern hamlet.

The inquiry team was not there.

Sugiya Devi, Ramwati, Muniya, Basanti, Ranjit, Rupa, and members of the other affected families sat together.

Of the eight houses, five had burned completely and three partly.

One family's goat had died.

Two people had suffered burns to hands and feet, but their lives were not in danger.

The greatest loss was not only of belongings.

It was of papers.

Caste certificates.

School certificates.

Bank slips.

Copies of land documents.

Labour cards.

Old-age pension papers.

So many things had gone in the fire.

Ramwati said:

“The relief people gave blankets. How will the papers be remade?”

Muniya said:

“We are not here only to give statements to the inquiry. Write down our demands.”

Ranjit brought a notebook.

They wrote five points:

First: an independent technical inquiry into the cause of the fire.

Second: no public allegation of arson or hearth negligence before the inquiry was complete.

Third: a single-window camp for reissuing burned documents.

Fourth: permanent obstacles to be removed from the lane.

Fifth: a fire-safety water point and safe electrical connections for the southern hamlet.

Basanti asked:

“Write my name too?”

Muniya said:

“Your part of the house burned too.”

Basanti said:

“I am part of the household, but on paper my name is often not there.”

So beneath the memorandum they wrote the names of all affected adults, women and men alike.

Rupa began drawing the lane on a separate sheet.

She was drawing:

houses,

lane,

well,

tap,

pile of bricks,

electricity pole.

Sugiya asked:

“What are you making?”

“How the fire travelled.”

“You saw it?”

“As much as I saw, I’ll draw. What I didn’t see, I’ll leave blank.”

Sugiya laughed.

“Good.”

No one yet knew that Rupa’s map would later become the most useful document in the inquiry.

On the third day the police came to take their own statements.

Assistant Inspector Jagdish Mandal first took Ramlochan Singh’s, because discussion of the land dispute had spread widely.

Ramlochan said:

“Suspicion against me is politics.”

“Who is doing the politics?”

“Some people.”

“Names?”

“No need to take names.”

“Where were you at the time of the fire?”

“At the shop.”

Shopkeeper Shambhu said Ramlochan had been at the shop until 6:20.

After that, he had not seen where Ramlochan went.

Ramlochan’s son said:

“Father reached home at 6:30.”

The house was in the northern hamlet, about a seven-minute walk from the site.

The timeline neither proved nor fully eliminated the allegation.

But half the village formed its own conclusion from that alone.

One local news page ran the headline:

“Mysterious Fire in Dalit Settlement After Land Dispute.”

Another wrote:

“Eight Houses Destroyed by Spark from Cooking Hearth.”

A third:

“Negligence by Electricity Department?”

All three headlines spread the same day.

Sugiya Devi's granddaughter Rupa saw them through a school friend.

She came home and asked:

"Dadi, can all three things be true at the same time?"

Sugiya said:

"Some things can be possible at the same time. But headlines turn possibility into truth."

"Then where is truth?"

"Where people are not in a hurry."

Rupa wrote that sentence at the top of her map.

On the fourth day the fifth group gave statements:

young volunteers who had come to distribute relief,

local teachers,

and health workers.

Their perspective concerned less the instant in which the fire began than what happened afterward.

Teacher Kavita Kumari said:

"I arrived at seven. People from the affected hamlet were fighting the fire, but many outsiders were standing and watching."

One young man objected:

"That is wrong. I was pulling the hose."

Kavita said:

"I did not say everyone. I said many people."

Health worker Pramila Devi said:

"Two people with burns had to be carried to the main road on a charpoy because no vehicle could enter the lane."

Neelima asked:

"Did you see discrimination in relief distribution?"

Pramila thought.

"On the first night, while making lists, women's names were less often being written as heads of families. It was corrected later."

"Why?"

"Old habit."

Muniya called from the back:

"Old habit is also part of the incident."

Neelima wrote that sentence in her private notes.

Something else had happened at the relief camp.

Some people had brought used clothes in a separate heap and wanted affected women to hold them while photographs were taken.

Sugiya refused.

"If someone needs something, give it. Do not put it in my hands and turn your donation into a photograph."

Some volunteers became annoyed.

Some were embarrassed.

Rupa had seen that too.

On her map she began drawing not only the path of the fire but the paths of people:

who came from where,

where water was delayed,

where the vehicle stopped.

On the fifth day the technical inspection was repeated.

This time senior engineer Sudhakar Mishra came with Anshuman.

He examined the point where the wire entered, the load on the pole, and the connections of five nearby houses.

"This line is carrying more than its rated capacity," he said.

Anshuman showed him the register.

"After three new connections were added, the service wire was not upgraded to match the load."

"A proposal in the file?"

"Six months ago."

"Approval?"

"Pending."

Sugiya asked:

"What does pending mean?"

Sudhakar looked at her.

"The work remains to be done."

"And the wire?"

"Old."

"Then shall I write that the fire started from the old wire?"

Sudhakar paused.

"The cause is not yet certain."

Sugiya smiled.

"I am learning the way you all speak - what is not certain, say it is not certain."

For a moment an awkward smile appeared on Sudhakar's face.

That day a small melted bead of copper was found in the ash.

The possibility of an electrical fault increased again.

But the fire officer said:

"A bead like this can also form later from the heat of a fire."

Again the conclusion receded.

The possibility of burning rubbish was examined too.

Ash was found where Shambhu Sah had indicated.

It contained recently burned plastic, leaves, and pieces of cloth.

The site was about fourteen cubits from the main point of burning.

That day the wind had been moving from west-southwest toward east-northeast.

The rubbish site lay west of the first house.

“Then a spark could have travelled,” the police officer said.

The fire officer replied:

“It could have. But the earliest burn pattern on the roof is heavier near the corner with the electrical wire.”

“Meaning?”

“Both possibilities exist. One stronger, one weaker.”

The assistant inspector disliked this language.

His file wanted a single line naming the cause.

On the seventh day of the inquiry, summaries of the five groups of statements were read out at the panchayat building.

The affected families' account:

first smell of plastic,

light near the wire,

fire quickly catching the roof,

blocked lane,

late arrival of water.

The account of the northern hamlet and locally influential people:

dense housing,

possible domestic negligence,

rubbish burning,

unplanned lane;

some dismissed rumours of the land dispute as politics.

The panchayat administration's account:

relief arrived quickly,

lane obstructions were temporary,

drainage work incomplete,

difference in notification time under inquiry.

The electricity department's account:

old joint,

excess load,

voltage fluctuation,

melted copper mark;

cause possible but not decisive.

The relief, health, and teacher group's account:

post-fire access,

vehicle obstruction,

difficulty reconstructing documents,

old social habits in relief work,

self-determination of the affected families.

When the summary was read, Ramlochan said:

“Why have you separated my statement under ‘influential people’? I am a villager.”

Neelima replied:

“Because social position affects the weight a statement is given.”

"That is prejudice."

"It would be prejudice if your statement were discounted without basis. Here we are only recording whose statement was heard first, whose statement newspapers printed, whose statement officials immediately wrote down."

Sugiya said quietly:

"Until the first day, my words were being heard as 'emotion.'"

The panchayat secretary lowered his eyes.

Rupa came forward carrying her map.

"What is this?" Neelima asked.

"I made it."

On the paper, the lane was red.

Water routes were blue.

Smoke direction was grey pencil.

Obstacles were marked in black.

Rupa had drawn question marks at three places.

The first:

"Where did the fire begin?"

Second:

"Why did the water stop here?"

Third:

"Why couldn't the vehicle enter here?"

Neelima looked at the map for a long time.

"Who taught you this?"

"No one."

"How did you write the times?"

"I asked everyone what they remembered. Where the time wasn't certain, I drew a circle."

The fire officer took the map.

"The brick pile is in the right place."

The health worker said:

"The charpoy turned from here."

Ranjit said:

"The first bucket was filled from this tap."

Ramwati said:

"No, the first bucket came from the water pot at my house."

Rupa immediately lifted her pencil.

"Then should I change this?"

Neelima said:

"Write both. The first bucket is not certain."

Everyone laughed.

For the first time in the middle of the tension, there was collective laughter.

Rupa's map became an official annexure to the inquiry.

It did not establish the cause of ignition.

But it made the causes of spread much clearer:

dry roofs close to one another;

dry grass on bamboo fencing;

three lane obstructions;
a six-minute discrepancy in notification;
low water pressure;
an old overloaded electrical service line;
no firefighting equipment in the hamlet.
None of these things by itself accused one person.
Together they increased the scale of the disaster.

The question of the land dispute remained.
The police investigated for two weeks.
No direct evidence of arson was found against Ramlochan or his family.
It could not be established who had burned the rubbish.

One adolescent said that at about five in the evening two children had burned dry leaves there, but he could not remember whether water had later been poured on them.

The main fire was seen about an hour and a half later.
Scientific testing of samples found no clear trace of accelerant.
When this information reached the village, two reactions followed.
Some people said:
“See? The arson story was false.”
Ramwati answered from the southern hamlet:
“When did we ever accuse anyone?”
Others said:
“The police saved the wealthy people.”
There was no direct basis for that allegation either.
Sugiya Devi kept her distance from both claims.
“Do not turn what lacks proof into proof.”

Meanwhile relief work continued.
Temporary roofing came from the district.
A camp was organised to reconstruct documents.
The electricity department replaced seven service lines, and the inspection was not limited to the southern hamlet - the whole feeder was checked.
The panchayat removed the brick piles.
Drain work began again, this time with a minimum lane width marked out.
Ramlochan objected that the width rule should apply to every hamlet.
Sugiya said:
“Correct. The rule that applies to us should apply to you too.”
For the first time, the two stood on the same side of an issue.

A month later the final technical report arrived.
Its title was:
“Simaria Southern Hamlet Fire Incident: Analysis of Cause and Spread.”

The headman was disappointed by the first line of the conclusion:

“A single definite source of ignition could not be established.”

The second line:

“Available physical evidence makes a fault in the electrical service connection more probable, but an external heat source cannot be completely excluded.”

The third:

“Rapid spread of the fire was jointly facilitated by residential proximity, combustible materials, lane obstructions, delayed water access, and weaknesses in electrical infrastructure.”

Neelima read the report before the affected families.

Sugiya Devi asked:

“What about the land dispute?”

“No evidence was found.”

“The hearth?”

“Not a leading possibility.”

“The rubbish?”

“Not fully excluded, but less probable.”

“Then what will people believe?”

Neelima said:

“People may believe what they choose. The report will say only how far the evidence goes.”

Rupa asked:

“Is my map in it?”

Neelima opened the annexures.

“Yes. Under the title ‘Community-Based Incident-Path Map.’”

Rupa laughed at the phrase.

“I only drew the route.”

“Sometimes the route is the most important thing,” Neelima said.

Two months later the rains began.

New walls rose where the burned houses had stood.

When Sugiya Devi rebuilt, she made several decisions:

a tin roof,

no exposed wiring,

the meter in a separate frame,

and a strip of two and a half cubits left open beside the house.

Ranjit said:

“If we leave that much space, the house will be smaller.”

Sugiya replied:

“Let the house be smaller. Let the fire’s road be smaller.”

Ramwati no longer stored dry grass on her fence.

The panchayat created a water point.

In large letters it read:

“FIRE-SAFETY WATER.”

A few days later half the lettering washed away in the rain.

Rupa painted it again.

At school, teacher Kavita Kumari asked the children to write an essay on disaster.

Rupa wrote the title:

“The Village Fire.”

Her first sentence:

“The fire in our village was not one person’s story.”

The second:

“We did not get the full answer to the question of where the fire began.”

The third:

“But we found many answers to the question of why it spread so far.”

She brought the essay home.

Sugiya could not read, so Rupa read it aloud to her.

At the final sentence Sugiya stopped her.

Rupa had written:

“When blame searches only for one name, the road, the wire, the water, the papers, power, and delay can all disappear from sight.”

Sugiya said:

“That line is difficult.”

Rupa asked:

“Should I change it?”

“No. Explain it to me.”

Rupa explained slowly.

Sugiya listened, then said:

“Add one more line.”

“What?”

“People’s voices are like fire too - some voices travel far immediately, while some take time even to cross the wall of their own house.”

Rupa added it to her notebook.

Outside, the rain had grown heavy.

Water drummed against the new tin roof.

Sugiya stood at the corner of the courtyard looking at the wire that now ran from the pole to the house with a new clamp.

She still did not know exactly where the first spark had been born on that evening in Vaishakh.

But one thing was clearer in the village than before:

to prevent the next fire, it may be necessary to know the name of the first spark.

But knowing only the name is not enough.

Across the River

When work began on a bridge over this stretch of the Kamala, no one imagined that the first dispute would arise not over the bridge, but over the ghat.

One night in Bhadra, the water suddenly fell. Two days earlier the current had still been muddy and broad. On the third morning, a long row of stones appeared in the middle of the river.

Boatman Jagarnath Sahni first thought it was an old embankment caught in the sand.

When the sun rose higher, square edges resembling steps emerged at intervals along the row.

Jagarnath did not take his boat there. He watched from a distance.

By afternoon, village children had taken photographs on their phones and posted them on social media:

“Old temple emerges from river.”

By evening another message began circulating:

“Buddhist-period ghat discovered.”

By night a third claim had joined them:

“Evidence of a Jain pilgrimage site.”

The next morning fisherwoman Basanti Devi, sitting in her courtyard, said:

“Now everyone has found their own thing. Did anyone ask the river?”

Anamika Jha, assistant archivist at the district museum, received official notice of the discovery two days later.

The letter was brief:

about seven hundred metres north of the eastern pier of the bridge under construction, “possible archaeological remains” had been observed after the water level fell; preliminary inspection was required.

Anamika was not an archaeologist.

Her work concerned records, old files, local grant deeds, copies of copperplates, and the museum catalogue. But because the district had no permanent archaeological officer, notices like this first came to her.

By the time she reached the site, the river had begun to rise again.

Half the row of stones was under water.

Four groups stood separately on the bank.

Haridev Mishra, priest of the temple, with two assistants.

Bhikshu Anand from the newly built meditation centre, with three students.

Cloth merchant Saurabh Jain and his uncle, Vimalchand, from the town's Jain community.

And families of local boatmen and fishers - Jagarnath, Basanti Devi, their daughter Chameli, and several others.

Everyone was looking at the same steps.

Everyone had a different name for them.

Haridev Mishra said:

“This is Dharmaghat. Our temple register clearly states that seven steps descended to Devshila for ritual bathing.”

Bhikshu Anand said calmly:

“Old monastery bricks have been found on this side. A colonial survey also mentions a ‘monastery mound.’ It is possible that this was a travellers’ ghat.”

Vimalchand, Saurabh Jain’s uncle, took a plastic-wrapped copy from his bag.

“Our community manuscript says ‘Uttarsar bank.’ On the eighth day of the bright fortnight of Chaitra, the ascetic community crossed the river here.”

Basanti Devi did not laugh.

She only said:

“My grandmother called it Parghat. For her, all the boats used to leave from here.”

Anamika recorded all four statements.

“What is the official name of this place?” she asked.

The revenue clerk said:

“There is only a plot number on the revenue map. No ghat name is recorded.”

“Old map?”

“We will have to check the tehsil.”

“For now, do not declare the site by anyone’s name,” Anamika said. “First we will write only what is visible.”

Haridev Mishra looked slightly dissatisfied.

“What is visible is a staircase.”

“Yes.”

“Steps of a ghat.”

“Yes.”

“Dharmaghat.”

Anamika looked at him.

“For now I will write ‘stone step-like structure’ in the record.”

Haridev Mishra fell silent.

Nine stones were visible in the first inspection.

Three showed clear wear.

One had a round socket, as though a post or bamboo pole had once been fixed there.

Another carried a small carving that looked like a wheel from a distance, but up close could just as easily have been a half-eroded flower.

Two kinds of brick were found on the bank:

one broad and flat,

another relatively recent.

No one was allowed to pick anything up.

Anamika photographed the site, recorded measurements and orientation.

Basanti Devi said from behind:

“If the river rises again tonight, everything will disappear.”

“Then we will look again next time.”

“The river does not show the same thing every time,” Basanti said.

That sentence did not enter Anamika’s file.

But it stayed in her mind.

Back at the museum, she called for old tehsil maps.

The oldest available map was one hundred and fourteen years old.

It showed the river channel about two hundred metres west of the present one.

A small symbol marked one place:

“Ferry.”

No ghat name.

On the next map, “ferry” disappeared and became “boat crossing.”

On the third, the bend of the river had changed and the same general area was labelled “old ghat.”

Anamika traced maps from different years onto transparent paper.

One thing was never stable in all three:

the river.

Yet there was a roughly semicircular zone where, despite the changing channel, people kept making ways to cross.

She opened the museum register.

About fifty-five years earlier, a schoolteacher had deposited two terracotta figurines, some red pottery fragments, and one worn coin from the “Uttarsar area.”

The location note was vague:

“Across the Kamala, near old ghat.”

Farther back, a district gazetteer mentioned a “monastery mound,” but it was unclear whether the mound lay west or east of the river.

The temple register was not in the museum.

Nor was the Jain community ledger.

Written history of the local boatmen’s families was almost nonexistent.

Anamika did not have four sources before her.

She had four different kinds of memory.

Three days later the water fell again.

This time Dr Sanjeev Ranjan arrived from the state archaeology department.

With him came a pottery specialist, a photographer, and two workers.

Dr Sanjeev’s first statement was:

“Assume nothing is proved.”

His second:

“Everything we find need not belong to the same period.”

His third:

“Religious use and date of construction are separate questions.”

All three sentences gave Anamika relief.

Cleaning was confined to a very limited area.

Fresh silt around the exposed steps was removed.

An older stone edging appeared beneath.

Traces of lime were visible at one joint.

A little farther away, in a layer of soil, they found a pottery fragment, an iron nail, two kinds of brick, and a small bead.

There was no clear inscription proving “temple,” “monastery,” or “Jain pilgrimage site.”

But on the back of one stone something resembling three characters appeared.

Dr Sanjeev did not take a rubbing because the surface was too soft.

High-resolution photographs were taken.

When enlarged, the characters seemed something like “ti...r...”

Haridev Mishra said:

“Tirtha.”

Bhikshu Anand said:

“‘Tir...’ can be many things.”

Vimalchand said:

“It could also be ‘tir’ - bank.”

Basanti Devi said:

“It is the bank of a river after all.”

Dr Sanjeev did not smile.

“History cannot be completed from three letters.”

The next day permission was granted to examine the temple register.

Haridev Mishra brought it wrapped in cloth.

The oldest page was not an original but a later copy.

Across the top was written:

“Ancient Sequence of Shri Uttardharma Sthan.”

It contained a tale of an ascetic who, during the rains, was unable to cross the river.

Villagers joined bamboo and wood into a temporary path.

After reaching the other side, the ascetic placed a lamp on a stone.

Later, ritual bathing and lamp-offering began near that stone.

There was no deity, king, or battle in the story.

Haridev Mishra said:

“This is that very Dharmashila.”

Anamika asked:

“How old is this copy?”

“About eighty years.”

“The original?”

“The original register was destroyed in a flood.”

“Did the copyist use older material, or write from oral tradition?”

Haridev Mishra remained silent for a while.

“The page does not say.”

Later portions of the register contained clear rules for pilgrimage, donations, fairs, and bathing dates.

Continuous references could be traced for about seventy years.

Anamika wrote:

“Tradition demonstrably living; date of ancient origin uncertain.”

Haridev Mishra looked at the page.

“You write ‘uncertain’ a lot.”

“If something is uncertain and I write it as certain, then I will be creating the register myself.”

For the first time, Haridev Mishra smiled faintly.

Bhikshu Anand’s centre lay about three kilometres from the river.

The building itself was new, but its library contained a copy of an old survey report.

A note from the late nineteenth century mentioned an “old brick mound near the ferry route.”

A later Buddhist scholar had treated the area as a possible “travellers’ resting place,” because an ancient north-south route may have crossed the river there.

There was no firm evidence of a monastery.

But Bhikshu Anand showed Anamika something else:

a small clay seal found decades earlier by a local farmer, bearing a wheel-like figure.

“Why is this not in the museum?” Anamika asked.

“It was in private hands earlier. Now it is in a glass case at the centre.”

“Has it been scientifically tested?”

“No.”

“Then it is difficult to call it evidence.”

“I am not calling it evidence,” Anand said. “I am calling it a question.”

He then opened a Maithili translation of an old Pali verse in which crossing a river was used as a metaphor.

Anamika immediately said:

“This is not evidence connecting the text to this site.”

“No. But people have long given spiritual meanings to the language of crossing rivers. People at our centre see this ghat through that lens.”

“So the tradition may even be new?”

“A new tradition is not false if its age is stated honestly.”

Anamika copied that sentence almost word for word into her notes.

On the day she went to examine the Jain community ledger, Vimalchand opened the upper room of his house.

Several cloth-wrapped account books lay in a wooden cupboard.

The book he had mentioned at the site was itself a copy made about one hundred and thirty years earlier.

The date of its supposed original was given inside as “Samvat...,” but several digits were worn away.

One line read:

“Descending at Uttarsar bank, the sangh rested; after the morning fasting observance, continued by the southern route.”

Anamika asked:

“The word ‘tirtha’ does not appear here.”

Vimalchand removed his spectacles and wiped the page.

“No.”

“Only riverbank?”

“Yes.”

“Then why do you call the place a Jain pilgrimage site?”

Vimalchand’s uncle answered first:

“Our grandfather said the community of monks crossed here before the rains.”

Saurabh Jain interrupted:

“And it matters to us because it preserves the memory of an old route. The word ‘tirtha’ may have been added later.”

Vimalchand said quietly:

“Traders remember roads. Ascetics remember places to rest. Families turn them into stories.”

Other pages in the ledger mentioned fees paid to boatmen, food donations, and rest.

One entry was especially striking:

because of a flood, the travelling community remained stranded on the far bank for three days.

Anamika saw in these details less a religious claim than an old record of the river’s behaviour.

She took copies.

The final source was Basanti Devi.

“I have no papers,” Basanti said first.

“Do you have stories?”

“Many. Which one do you want?”

“About this ghat.”

Basanti Devi was drying fish in the courtyard. Chameli sat near the hearth.

“My grandmother said the river’s channel was not straight in the old days. Sand islands formed in the middle. Travellers would get down on this side, walk across the island, then take another boat.”

“What was the ghat called?”

“Parghat.”

“Any story about a god or goddess?”

Basanti thought.

“There was the story of the Boat-Woman Mother.”

Anamika stopped her pen.

“Who was she?”

“No one knows her name. Grandmother said that once, during a flood, a boat overturned. A woman lifted three children one by one onto a high sandbank, then

she herself was swept away. After that, before the first trip of the day, some boatmen would pour two drops of milk into the water.”

“What caste or religion was she?”

Basanti raised her eyes.

“Grandmother used to say—”

“What?”

“The water did not ask her caste, so why should I?”

Anamika fell silent.

Basanti continued:

“But this story is not told in every household. Mostly in our boatmen’s hamlet. The temple people may not accept it.”

“How old is the story?”

“I don’t know.”

“Do people still offer milk?”

Jagarnath called from outside:

“I do.”

“All boatmen?”

“No. Some.”

“Why?”

Jagarnath shrugged.

“My father did.”

Anamika wrote:

“Local boatmen’s tradition; date uncertain; current within a limited community.”

Basanti laughed.

“I got ‘uncertain’ too.”

Anamika laughed with her.

As the investigation continued, the dispute grew as well.

The bridge-construction company wanted to make a temporary access road near the ghat.

The archaeology department said no heavy machinery until the inquiry was complete.

The district administration wanted an information board installed quickly to control the growing crowds.

Everything came down to one sentence:

what should the site be called on the board?

“Ancient Hindu pilgrimage ghat”?

“Ancient Buddhist travellers’ ghat”?

“Historic Jain route site”?

“Local Parghat”?

Each name had supporters.

Anamika suggested:

“Uttarsar Old River-Crossing Site.”

Haridev Mishra said:

“Religion disappears from that.”

Bhikshu Anand said:

“Time disappears from it.”

Vimalchand said:

“The name from our ledger disappears too.”

Basanti Devi said:

“Let ‘ghat’ remain. Enough.”

The meeting went on for a long time.

At last the District Magistrate said:

“The first board will be temporary. It can be changed when scientific examination is complete.”

Anamika thought:

a board can be changed.

A story, once printed, is harder to change.

For that reason she prepared a detailed note.

It had four sections:

“Material Evidence.”

“Written Sources.”

“Living Religious Traditions.”

“Local Oral Memory.”

She deliberately did not use the heading “Truth.”

Under material evidence she wrote:

multiple phases of construction possible;

step-stones may have been reused;

bricks from different periods;

no definitive religious symbol identified.

Under written sources:

the temple’s copied register,

the Jain travel ledger,

the colonial survey,

the revenue maps.

Under living traditions:

bathing and lamp-offering,

meditation visits,

community memorial journeys.

Under oral memory:

the Boat-Woman Mother’s story,

the old ferry,

routes used during floods.

After reading the note, Dr Sanjeev said:

“You have made one difficult point clear.”

“What?”

“The same site can serve different purposes for different people at different times.”

“And even at the same time?”

“Yes.”

Scientific tests answered some questions and increased others.

The lime sample from the upper joint of the steps proved relatively recent.

There was no evidence that it was more than about two to two and a quarter centuries old.

Some pottery from a lower soil layer was much older.

The dimensions of one brick resembled medieval structures, but when that brick had been brought there remained uncertain.

The clay seal with the wheel-like figure was sent for examination, but its provenance was weak:

which field,

what depth,

what date -

nothing was secure.

Specialists examined the image of the three marks on the stone.

The first could be "ti."

It could also be "di."

The second was worn.

The third could be "r," or merely a tool mark.

Haridev Mishra was disappointed.

"So nothing is proved?"

Dr Sanjeev said:

"This is proved: the site is old, it has been built and rebuilt repeatedly, and it has long been associated with crossing the river."

"Religion?"

"Religious traditions exist in written and living sources. The stone itself does not presently name one particular tradition."

Haridev Mishra looked toward the river.

"People speak more than stones."

"Yes," Anamika said, "but we have to state from which period those people's words come."

Meanwhile the bridge piers rose.

Passengers on Jagarnath's boat declined.

Earlier, market-goers, schoolchildren, cyclists, milk sellers - everyone used the ferry.

When the construction company put up a temporary pedestrian crossing, half the passengers moved there.

One day Jagarnath asked Anamika:

"Will the old ghat be saved?"

"As far as the identified structure goes, there are instructions to protect it from construction."

"And the boat?"

Anamika did not answer.

"The ghat will survive, the boat will not," Jagarnath said himself.

For the first time Anamika understood that heritage was not only a question of old stones.

Sometimes a living occupation became the past before one's eyes.

She added a new paragraph to the District Magistrate's note:

"Documentation of the living ferry tradition."

Jagarnath did not like the phrase.

"What does documentation mean?"

"Recording your boat, route, songs, way of reading the water, flood signs - everything."

"I am still alive."

"That is why now."

"Do it after I die."

Basanti scolded him.

"Shall everyone leave their work unfinished waiting for you to die?"

Jagarnath fell silent.

On the day of documentation, Chameli went out in the boat.

She was in Class Twelve and was thinking of enrolling at the college across the river.

Anamika asked:

"Do you know how to handle a boat?"

"Yes."

"Will you continue doing it?"

Chameli looked at the water.

"Who will sit in the boat after the bridge is built?"

Jagarnath interrupted:

"When a flood closes the bridge, everyone will come looking for boats."

Chameli smiled.

"Then I'll charge double."

The boat left the bank.

Watching the current, Jagarnath said:

"This place is deep. See how the colour changes there?"

Anamika could barely see the difference.

"Where the water looks a darker blue, that is the old channel."

"On the maps the river keeps shifting," Anamika said.

"A map looks from above. A boat looks from below."

Chameli said:

"Babu says that to everyone."

Jagarnath laughed.

"A true thing does not become bad by being said again and again."

When the boat reached midstream, Basanti Devi poured two drops of milk into the water.

Anamika asked nothing.

She recorded only the time, place, and action.

On the far bank stood a small earthen platform with a red cloth, a lamp, and some dried flowers.

"The Boat-Woman Mother?" Anamika asked.

"Some people call it that," Basanti said.

"Some?"

"Some call it River Mother. Some simply leave a lamp. A name is not always necessary."

Anamika did not take a photograph until Basanti gave permission.

"Take it," Basanti said, "but write that this is not a temple."

"What should I write?"

"That people leave lamps here."

The sentence seemed exactly right to Anamika.

A few weeks later the district administration held a public hearing.

This time the disagreement was sharper than before because the tourism department had submitted a proposal:

"Integrated Heritage Circuit."

The proposal included a colourful drawing:

a grand gateway,

decorated ghats,

symbols of four religions,

rows of shops,

lighting.

Basanti Devi looked at the picture and asked:

"Where is the boat?"

The officer said:

"We can keep a decorative boat."

Jagarnath immediately replied:

"A decorative boat does not carry anyone across the water."

Haridev Mishra had another objection.

"Do not turn the ritual practice of Dharmaghat into a tourist spectacle."

Bhikshu Anand said:

"Loudspeakers and coloured lights are not appropriate for a meditation place."

Vimalchand said:

"Our old travel route has been reduced to four symbols. There is no history here."

For the first time, all four groups were opposing the same proposal, though for different reasons.

Anamika found the scene revealing.

People who disagreed over the site's name now disagreed together with the government's attempt to "integrate" them.

In her note she wrote:

"Do not turn plurality into decorative sameness."

The District Magistrate underlined the sentence in red.

"Put this in simpler language."

Anamika rewrote it:

“All traditions are different; let their differences remain.”

That was accepted.

The archaeology department authorised limited excavation.

Two small test trenches were opened on the upper part of the ghat.

The first trench contained recent debris, beneath that a layer of brick, and beneath that ash-mixed soil.

The second showed impressions of decayed wood, iron nails, and river sand.

The wood itself had not survived, but its former position was visible in the soil.

Dr Sanjeev offered a possibility:

at some point there may have been a wooden ghat-path or temporary causeway here.

Haridev Mishra immediately remembered the bamboo-and-wood path in the temple register.

Bhikshu Anand pointed to the possibility of a travellers' ghat.

Vimalchand showed the mention of boatmen's fees in the ledger.

Jagarnath said:

“My grandfather used to drive wooden posts here too.”

The absence of a single piece of wood touched all four memories at once.

Anamika wrote:

“Material sign open to multiple interpretations.”

Dr Sanjeev looked at her note.

“People won't like that phrase.”

“Why?”

“People want conclusions.”

“Does history always provide conclusions?”

“No. But administration wants a signboard.”

Eventually the signboard was made.

Across the top:

“UTTARSAR OLD PARGHAT”

Below:

“Evidence and traditions indicate that this site was used in different periods for river crossing, bathing, travel, rest, and religious practice. The site is associated with distinct memories among Hindu, Buddhist, Jain, and local boatmen communities. Available archaeological material does not at present conclusively establish any single story of origin.”

The final sentence was debated at length.

The word “conclusively” remained.

So did “single.”

Haridev Mishra wanted his register mentioned separately too.

For that purpose four smaller boards were made beside the main one, each clearly stating the date, nature, and limitations of its source.

The temple board:

"Present copy approximately eighty years old; date of earlier source unknown."

The Buddhist board:

"Colonial survey mentions an old brick mound; no definitive identification as a monastery."

The Jain board:

"Travel ledger mentions Uttarsar bank and rest by the sangh; the word 'tirtha' appears in later oral tradition."

The boatmen's board:

"Parghat, ferry, Boat-Woman Mother's story, and water rites; primarily oral tradition."

Basanti Devi could not read her own board.

Chameli read it aloud.

"Is it all right?" Anamika asked.

Basanti said:

"It says 'primarily oral.' Does that make it a small thing?"

"No."

"Then it is all right."

The bridge was completed.

On inauguration day the stage stood at the western end.

Leaders, officials, journalists, and schoolchildren came.

The old ferry was kept closed that day.

Jagarnath tied up his boat at the bank and watched from a distance.

Chameli walked across the new bridge for the first time.

Halfway across she looked down.

Some steps of the old Parghat were under water.

Some remained exposed.

On one side she could see the flag of the temple.

Far off, the roof of the meditation centre.

Toward town, the white building of the Jain dharmashala.

And at the bank, her father's boat.

She did not continue toward the college after crossing.

She turned back halfway.

"Why?" Jagarnath asked.

"Too much crowd today."

"From tomorrow?"

"College from tomorrow."

Basanti Devi asked:

"By boat?"

Chameli looked toward the bridge.

"By bridge. It will be faster."

For an instant something seemed to fall across Jagarnath's face, but he said:

"Fine."

That evening, after the inauguration crowd had thinned, Anamika came to inspect the site.

The main signboard was intact.

The temporary bamboo barrier was secure.

A child was reading the board with his grandfather.

“Dada, which one is the real story?” the child asked.

“All four are written there,” the grandfather said, adjusting his spectacles.

“But which is the real one?”

The old man could not find an answer.

Anamika did not interrupt.

Haridev Mishra had come to place a lamp.

He heard the child’s question.

“Which story did you like?” he asked.

“The Boat-Woman Mother.”

Haridev Mishra smiled.

“Then listen to that one first.”

Bhikshu Anand arrived at the same time with two students.

Vimalchand’s family was due the following week for a commemorative journey.

The four traditions were not present at the same hour, but each kept its own time at the same place.

Anamika looked toward the river.

The water had fallen.

The seventh stone of the staircase could be seen clearly.

Fresh flowers lay on it.

She did not know which group had placed them there.

She did not draw a conclusion from the flowers.

While preparing the museum’s final report, Anamika found the heading “Origin of the Site” too empty.

She changed it to:

“Layers of Use.”

First layer:

river crossing.

Second:

trade and travel.

Third:

bathing and worship.

Fourth:

memory of resting by religious communities.

Fifth:

modern religious rereading.

Sixth:

heritage site after bridge construction.

Dr Sanjeev read the report and wrote a note:

“Sequence should not be assumed chronological; layers overlap.”

Anamika accepted the comment.

She added:

“These uses may have begun at different times, but in later periods they coexisted.”

The report was submitted.

The work seemed finished.

Then, the following year, a flood came.

The bridge survived, but the eastern approach road was closed for two days.

People looked for boats again.

Jagarnath's old boat was not enough.

The administration called for emergency motorboats, but for the first three hours local boatmen ferried people across.

Chameli too handled a boat.

She had become a college student.

By chance Anamika was in the area that day for an inspection.

She saw:

the bridge empty above,

the boats full below.

Basanti Devi was organising people into a queue on the bank.

Haridev Mishra was distributing flattened rice and curd to stranded travellers on the temple veranda.

Bottled water came from Bhikshu Anand's centre.

The Jain dharmashala opened its rooms for the night.

No meeting had been held.

No “integrated heritage” plan existed.

Need was arranging its own system.

By evening the current grew stronger.

Jagarnath said:

“Stop the boats now.”

Some people still wanted to cross urgently.

One young man said:

“I have necessary work.”

Chameli answered clearly:

“The current has changed. Not now.”

“You people travel here every day.”

“That is why I am saying - not now.”

Anamika stood at a distance listening.

Separate from old stories, archaeology, and religious claims, the ghat at that moment was simply a place of decision:

when to cross,

when not to.

At night Basanti Devi released two drops of milk into the river.

Chameli asked:

“What do two drops mean in so much water?”

"Not for the water."

"Then?"

"For me."

Chameli said nothing.

The next morning the water fell a little.

Emergency boats began running.

The bridge approach reopened by the evening of the second day.

The ghat steps disappeared under water again.

Three weeks later, when the river returned to normal, Anamika came back.

Flood silt had collected on the signboards.

Chameli was wiping them clean with a cloth.

"Have you taken responsibility for this work now?" Anamika asked.

"No one gave it to me. I was passing, saw it dirty."

"Which board did you clean first?"

Chameli laughed.

"All of them."

She removed the silt beneath the main board.

"Didi," Chameli asked, "it says 'river-crossing site.' Now there is a bridge. Has the name become old?"

Anamika looked toward the river before answering.

"Does crossing happen only by boat?"

"No."

"By bridge?"

"Yes."

"Then?"

Chameli shook her head.

"But on a bridge the crossing is fixed. From this side to that side."

Anamika said:

"In memory, the far side is not always fixed."

"That is difficult again."

"Then let me make it simple. For the person standing on this bank, the other bank is across the river. For the person standing there, this bank is across the river."

Chameli thought for a moment.

"So the far side keeps changing?"

"When the person changes."

Chameli finished wiping the board.

At that moment an elderly pilgrim came asking Haridev Mishra:

"Where is Dharmaghat?"

Haridev pointed toward the old steps.

Behind them two young men were asking the way to Bhikshu Anand's centre.

A family was going toward the Jain dharmashala.

Jagarnath was untying his boat - not for tourism, but to inspect his field on the other bank.

Basanti Devi placed a lamp on the platform.

No one's activity was erasing anyone else's story.

No one's story was becoming proof of another's.

As evening fell, the bridge lights came on one by one.

A long line of light appeared across the river below.

Anamika remembered the old maps:

ferry,

boat crossing,

old ghat.

Then the temple register:

bamboo-and-wood path.

The Jain ledger:

Uttarsar bank.

The colonial note:

old brick mound.

The Boat-Woman Mother's story:

a nameless woman and three children.

And the present bridge:

cement,

steel,

electric light.

In all of them, one thing returned again and again:
the desire to cross.

But for different reasons.

For some, worship.

For some, pilgrimage.

For some, trade.

For some, education.

For some, livelihood.

For some, rescue.

For some, memory.

Anamika opened the final page of the report again.

She felt like adding one sentence.

Then she stopped.

A historical file does not need a beautiful final line.

She closed the file.

From the ghat Basanti Devi called:

"Will you come to this side?"

Anamika smiled.

"I am already on this side."

Basanti pointed to the opposite bank.

"From where I am, you are on that side."

Anamika went down.

Jagarnath's boat pushed away from the bank.

Vehicles continued passing over the bridge above.

Below, the boat slowly cut through the current.

When they reached midstream, Anamika looked at both banks.

For a few moments it was difficult to decide which one was “this side” and which one was “across the river.”

Perhaps the river had never needed the distinction.

People did.

They needed it to mark a route,

to tell a story,

to return,

and to cross again.

The Mason's Fall

The new five-storey commercial building rising at the western edge of town had already been named "Samriddhi Sadan," though half its walls had not yet been plastered.

A blue board hung at the main gate:

"SAFETY FIRST."

Directly beneath it, workers entered along a narrow path between cement, sand, and iron rods.

Mason Budhan Sada usually arrived before seven in the morning. He did so that day as well, but stopped as soon as he looked at a bamboo in the fourth tier of the scaffold.

One of its nodes had split.

The rope was wet from the night's rain too.

Budhan told the guard:

"It is not safe to climb on this tier today."

The guard, Kanhaiya, replied:

"How would I know? Tell Munshi ji."

Site clerk Rakesh Ojha was on his phone trying to locate a delivery truck.

Budhan repeated:

"The upper bamboo needs to be replaced."

Without looking up, Rakesh said:

"The engineer will inspect at nine. Work below until then."

Budhan began work at ground level.

But at eight o'clock the contractor's representative, Anil Sah, arrived and said that the outer wall of the second floor had to be completed by afternoon.

"A client is coming to inspect tomorrow," Anil said. "We are behind schedule."

Rakesh said quietly:

"One bamboo on the scaffold is damaged."

Anil looked upward.

"Will we stop the whole day for one bamboo? Replace it, but keep the work going too."

No clear order followed about who would replace the bamboo.

The separate subcontractor responsible for erecting the scaffold had had no workers on site for three days.

Budhan and his fellow worker Chhotelal continued arranging their tools.

Chhotelal asked:

"Are we going up?"

Budhan said:

"I don't want to."

"Will they cut the day's wage?"

Both fell silent.

They were daily-wage workers.

Even after attendance had been marked, half a day's wages could be cut if "no work available" was entered.

At home Budhan had his wife Manju, two children, and his elderly mother. The previous week, medicines for his younger son had cost extra.

A little after nine, site engineer Praveen Kumar arrived.

He carried a file in one hand and was looking toward an interior beam.

Rakesh told him about the scaffold.

Praveen came outside, looked up from the ground, then opened the inspection register.

"Who does the daily scaffold inspection?"

Rakesh said:

"The subcontractor's supervisor."

"Is he here today?"

"No."

Praveen frowned.

"Then exterior work should remain stopped without a written inspection."

Anil Sah immediately intervened.

"Sir, it is only one bamboo. The rest is strong. We can do the work carefully."

Praveen said:

"'Carefully' is not a certificate."

He wrote something in the inspection register.

Later, that one line became the most disputed sentence in the case.

It read:

"Defective member of upper scaffold section to be replaced; reinspection required."

The words "work stopped" were not there.

Nor were the words "work may continue."

Praveen went inside to inspect the concrete work.

Anil said to Rakesh:

"Where will we find people to change the bamboo?"

Rakesh replied:

"The scaffold crew's phone is switched off."

"Then brace it from below."

An extra bamboo was fitted diagonally as support.

The guard and two workers tightened the rope.

Budhan looked at the arrangement.

"This is not an inspection," he said.

Rakesh did not snap at him.

In a tired voice he said:

"I know. But this is all we have today."

Budhan asked again:

"What if I don't climb?"

Rakesh was silent for a moment.

"I won't mark you absent. But who will do the outer wall?"

There was no direct command in the sentence.
 Budhan understood its weight all the same.
 At 10:20 he climbed onto the scaffold.
 Chhotelal went up behind him.
 They began lifting bricks, spreading mortar, and extending the outer wall along the edge of the second floor.
 At about eleven the wind strengthened.
 A sheet of plastic blew away from the sand pile below.
 Budhan touched one of the scaffold ropes and said to Chhotelal:
 "It is loosening."
 Chhotelal said:
 "Shall we go down?"
 At that moment Rakesh called from below:
 "Finish five bricks on this course and come down in ten minutes."
 Rakesh would later say that he had meant only to "secure the unfinished section."
 Chhotelal would say that he had clearly heard:
 "Finish five bricks."
 The mixer was making a great deal of noise below.
 How clearly anyone heard which words could not be established.
 At 11:27, one joint of the outer scaffold shifted.
 The mortar pan fell first.
 Chhotelal grabbed the wall.
 The plank beneath Budhan's foot tilted to one side.
 Budhan fell.
 There is no need to describe the accident further than that.
 Work on the site stopped immediately.
 Praveen Kumar ran out from inside.
 Anil Sah called an ambulance.
 Rakesh telephoned Manju.
 Budhan did not regain consciousness before reaching the hospital.
 At 1:45 in the afternoon, the doctor declared him dead.
 That evening the blue "SAFETY FIRST" board still hung exactly where it had been.

Four kinds of story began to form immediately after the accident.
 The contractor's office issued its first written notice:
 "Unexpected scaffold failure; preliminary investigation under way."
 Among the workers the story was:
 "They made him climb without replacing the damaged bamboo."
 The engineer's note said:
 "Instructions had been given to replace the defective member and reinspect."
 At Budhan's home, Manju had only one question:
 "If instructions had been given, why did the work continue?"

The next day labour-department inspector Seema Jha arrived.
The first thing she asked for was not photographs of the site.
It was the attendance register.
Budhan's name was marked for a full day.
"He died at 11:27. Then why a full day's attendance?" Seema asked.
The site clerk said:
"The decision to pay the whole day's wage was made afterwards."
"A decision or an entry in the record?"
Rakesh fell silent.
Seema asked for the scaffold subcontract.
The main contract belonged to Shubhnirman Private Limited.
Scaffolding was the responsibility of Aaradhya Support Service.
The subcontract clearly required daily supervision.
The supervisor's signature was absent for the previous two days.
Anil Sah said:
"I was not aware of this absence."
Seema asked:
"You are the site representative?"
"Yes."
"Then who was supposed to know?"
Before answering, Anil began drinking water.
Praveen Kumar produced his inspection register.
Seema read the disputed line again and again:
"Defective member to be replaced; reinspection required."
"Why did you not issue a written stop-work order?" she asked.
Praveen said:
"I understood that exterior work would automatically remain stopped until reinspection."
"Understood by whom?"
"Site management."
"The workers?"
Praveen was silent.
He said:
"I had told both Rakesh and Anil in front of them."
Anil's account was different.
According to him, the engineer had merely said:
"Check the upper section."
He denied any complete work stoppage.
Rakesh's position lay somewhere in between.
He said:
"I understood it as a stop. But the interior work was not stopped. I told them to complete five bricks on the outside for safety."
Seema asked:
"For safety, you kept workers on a defective scaffold?"
Rakesh lowered his head.
"At that moment I thought five minutes posed less risk."

“Does risk check the clock before arriving?”

Rakesh did not answer.

Chhotelal's statement was the hardest.

He was not merely a co-worker.

He had been on the scaffold during the accident.

Again and again he said:

“If I say we were forced, why did I climb too? If I say it was voluntary, why did Budhan keep raising the bamboo problem?”

Seema asked him to state only facts.

Chhotelal said:

Budhan pointed out the defect in the morning.

Rakesh heard him.

The engineer wrote it down.

The bamboo was not replaced.

A diagonal support was fitted.

The two workers discussed their fear that wages might be cut.

Then they climbed.

“Did anyone explicitly threaten you?” Seema asked.

“No.”

“Did anyone explicitly say, ‘If you do not climb, you will be dismissed?’”

“No.”

“Then where did the fear come from?”

Chhotelal looked directly at Seema.

“Madam, fear is not always spoken in a sentence.”

Seema copied those words exactly into her file.

On the third day Manju came to the site.

The company had called her to complete compensation forms.

She wore a blue sari.

Her brother-in-law Raju and her twelve-year-old daughter Rani came with her.

Anil Sah expressed his sympathy.

“The company will provide full cooperation,” he said.

Manju asked:

“How much is ‘full?’”

Anil paused.

“According to the law: insurance, outstanding wages, additional assistance - everything.”

Manju said:

“I am not asking about money. I am asking whether ‘full cooperation’ includes the truth.”

The room went silent.

Manju asked for Budhan's bag.

Inside were:

a hammer,
a trowel,
a measuring tape,
a gamchha,
a half-eaten box of flattened rice and jaggery,
and a small notebook.

The notebook was mainly for wage accounts.

On some pages Budhan had added brief notes about the day's work:

"three window frames,"

"north wall,"

"half plaster,"

"scaffold loose."

The day before the accident he had written:

"Told them upper rope needs changing."

Manju handed the page to Seema.

The company's lawyer said a private notebook was not a "formal safety record."

Seema replied:

"Correct. But where formal records are incomplete, it is supporting evidence for the sequence of events."

To Manju, the important word was not "evidence."

It was "told."

Budhan had told them.

Between who heard, who wrote, and who postponed, his life had become trapped.

On the fifth day of the inquiry, a scaffolding expert was called.

He examined the broken bamboo, ropes, joints, and planks.

His preliminary opinion was that the accident was not caused by a single bamboo alone.

Vertical support was insufficient.

The rope at two joints was old.

One end of the plank was inadequately tied.

And the temporary diagonal bamboo had altered the direction of the load.

In other words, the defect lay not in one object but in the whole assembly.

Anil Sah treated this finding as helpful to his side.

"See? It was not only that bamboo."

Seema said:

"Multiple defects do not reduce responsibility. Sometimes they increase it."

Praveen Kumar also stated his position.

"I had identified the defect."

Seema asked:

"After identifying it, did you ensure an effective stop-work measure?"

Praveen answered:

"No."

It was the first clear "no" that any senior person had spoken about his own role in the inquiry.

Rakesh's position was different.

He was not a permanent company employee.

He was a site clerk on a monthly honorarium.

He said:

"The deadline was not mine.

The scaffold subcontract was not mine.

The engineer's instruction was above me.

The attendance register was in my hand.

Half of every responsibility came to me, but complete authority over nothing."

Seema asked:

"Then why did you call out for them to finish five bricks?"

After a long silence Rakesh said:

"Because at that moment I used the small authority I did have, and I used it wrongly."

Manju was present when he gave this statement.

She did not abuse him.

She asked only:

"What would have happened if Budhan had climbed down?"

Rakesh said:

"The wall would have been five bricks short."

"That's all?"

"Perhaps the day's work would have remained incomplete."

"And now?"

Rakesh lowered his eyes.

Manju asked nothing further.

Gradually the inquiry moved beyond the accident and into the structure of employment itself.

The workers had no appointment letters.

Safety training was certified by a single collective signature sheet.

But five workers, including Chhotelal, said they had merely been handed helmets, not trained.

There were enough helmets.

There were too few safety harnesses.

In several places the permanent lifeline to which harnesses should have been attached was broken.

The daily inspection register was supposed to be completed by the subcontractor's supervisor.

But site management had no clear procedure for stopping work when that supervisor was absent.

The schedule showed that the exterior wall was three days behind.

The client-inspection date had already been fixed.

An email from the contractor company said:

"Ensure visible progress."

That sentence was not an order to cause an accident.

But Seema noted that administrative pressure does not always say:

“Take the risk.”

It may only set targets for time, payment, and reputation.

And as that pressure travels downward, the risk can eventually reach the worker's body.

The company's lawyer objected to this interpretation.

“That is inference.”

Seema replied:

“That is why I am recording it as work context, not as the immediate cause.”

Manju listened carefully to the distinction:

cause,

context.

She felt that inquiry language placed every fact into a separate box.

Grief had no such boxes.

At home Budhan's mother kept asking at night:

“Why did he fall?”

At first Manju would say:

“The scaffold broke.”

After a few days:

“The scaffold had not been inspected.”

Then one day:

“There were many things.”

The old mother said:

“Will many things bring back one son?”

Manju had no answer.

Rani wrote her father's occupation in her school notebook:

“Mason.”

Her teacher had read the news about the accident.

She advised Rani to take leave.

Rani said:

“At home I hear everyone saying the same thing again and again. At school I can at least read about something else.”

Manju did not stop her.

Ten days later the workers were called back to the site.

A new scaffold had been erected.

The blue board at the gate had not changed.

But below it a new notice was pasted:

“Before climbing the scaffold, check today's inspection mark.”

Chhotelal read it and stopped.

“What if there is no inspection mark?”

The new supervisor said:

“Stop work.”

“Wages?”

The supervisor did not answer.

Chhotelal did not laugh.

“Without an answer to that question, the rule is only half a rule.”

The remark reached the labour department.

In her interim order Seema wrote:

“When work is stopped for safety reasons, the period shall not be treated as worker absence for the purpose of wage deduction.”

The company argued that this would increase costs.

For the workers, it was the first time that the sentence “I will not climb” had become valid inside the rule itself.

Manju went to the bank to receive the first instalment of compensation.

On the way she felt guilty that seeing the money brought her a sense of relief.

Then she stopped herself.

Budhan’s death and the household’s expenses were not contradictory truths.

The payment was not the value of a life.

But when one life stopped, the expenses of those who remained did not stop.

At the final hearing, four principal sides were present:

the contractor,

the engineer,

the workers’ representative,

and the family.

Seema read the sequence of events.

The defect was noticed in the morning.

The subcontractor’s supervisor was absent.

The engineer wrote that the defective member should be replaced and reinspection carried out.

The defective member was not formally replaced.

A temporary support was fitted.

Exterior work continued.

The workers climbed.

The scaffold failed.

There was no single moment in that sequence at which all responsibility settled entirely on one person.

But that did not make anyone’s responsibility zero.

The main contractor was held responsible for failing to ensure a safe system of work.

The scaffold subcontractor was cited for the absence of daily inspection and a qualified supervisor.

The engineer was recorded as professionally at fault for failing to verify an effective stop-work measure after identifying the defect.

The site clerk's oral instruction to finish five bricks was treated as an immediate factor increasing risk, while the deadline pressure and authority structure were recorded as context.

A proposal to describe Budhan and Chhotelal's decision to climb as an "equal share of safety responsibility" was rejected by Seema.

The report said:

"Within economic dependence and workplace hierarchy, workers' consent cannot be treated as a completely free choice."

Manju read that line three times.

She asked Seema:

"Where in this does it say Budhan made a mistake?"

Seema said:

"He saw the risk and still climbed - that is a fact. But fact and blame are not the same thing."

"Then does his decision mean nothing?"

"It means something. But the circumstances in which that decision was made mean something too."

Manju nodded slowly.

She remembered Chhotelal's sentence:

fear is not always spoken in a sentence.

Two months later, the exterior wall of Samriddhi Sadan was complete.

The client-inspection date had already been changed.

Invitations for the building's inauguration were printed.

Budhan's name appeared nowhere.

One day Rani asked her mother:

"How many bricks did Babu lay in this building?"

Manju said:

"There is no count."

"Then no one will know he worked here?"

Manju took out Budhan's little notebook.

"This knows."

Rani turned the pages:

north wall,

window frames,

plaster,

told them the rope needed changing.

She asked:

"Will we put this notebook in a museum?"

For the first time Manju smiled faintly.

"No. First we will build the roof of our own house. Then we will see."

She decided to use part of the compensation to complete their unfinished roof.

Raju called a mason he knew.

On the day work began, Manju climbed the steps and inspected the bamboo scaffold.

The mason said:

“Sister, don't worry. It is strong.”

Manju replied:

“Worry is my job. Inspection is yours.”

She began looking at the bamboo, rope, and planks one by one.

At first the mason was uncomfortable.

Then he said:

“All right. Let's look together.”

Rani called from below:

“Ma, have you become an engineer?”

Manju answered:

“No. I have learned to ask questions.”

One day while the roof was being built, rain began.

The workers came down.

The mason said:

“Half the day is gone.”

Manju asked:

“Will you pay the full wage?”

“Only half the work was done.”

Manju looked toward Budhan's notebook.

“The day may be half. A body is not.”

After some argument, full wages were paid.

It was no great reform.

In the next lane, work might still be going on in the old way.

At Samriddhi Sadan too, who knew how long the new rules would survive on paper?

But later Chhotelal said that once, when there was no inspection mark, he refused to climb the scaffold.

His day's wage was not cut.

Rakesh found a job at another site.

He began carrying a red pen in his pocket.

When he saw a defect, he no longer wrote merely:

“Replace.”

He wrote:

“WORK STOPPED - UNTIL REINSPECTION.”

Praveen Kumar changed the language of his inspection register too.

Anil Sah's company appointed a permanent safety supervisor.

The reasons included legal pressure, insurance conditions, and reputation.

Whatever the reasons, the result was recorded.

None of this brought Manju peace.

Peace is not something that arrives with a signature on the final page of a report.

But she understood one distinction.

Responsibility can be divided.

The shares of fault can be different.

But saying “everyone was at fault” cannot be used to erase anyone's fault.

And saying “he climbed himself” cannot be used to make invisible the circumstances within which his choice was formed.

The final line in Budhan's notebook had been written the day before the accident:

“Told them upper rope needs changing.”

Manju wrote nothing beneath it.

She left the page exactly as it was.

Because sometimes an unfinished sentence asks the clearest question of an entire system.

The Old Photograph

The back room of Neelam Jha's house in an old neighbourhood of Madhubani had remained closed for a long time.

When the family decided to sell the house, the day came when old trunks, brass utensils, and bundles of papers were being sorted. That was when Neelam found a black-and-white photograph pressed inside a wooden frame.

Five people stood in it - two women, two men, and a young man of perhaps twenty or twenty-two in the middle.

Behind them were a mud wall, a sloping thatched roof, and a bamboo fence.

The corners of the photograph were worn, but the face of the young man at the centre was clear.

Neelam said to her husband Shailesh:

"He looks like Babuji."

Shailesh cleaned his spectacles and looked.

"The nose is similar. But if there had been such an old photograph of Babuji, Ma would have recognised it."

Neelam's mother, Vimala Devi, was gathering clothes from the courtyard at the time.

The moment she saw the photograph, she stopped.

"This is not Babuji," she said at once.

"Then who?"

Vimala Devi placed a finger on the young man's face.

"This is Gopal Mama."

"Which Gopal Mama?"

"Your Nana's maternal cousin. He went to Burma and never came back."

Neelam was startled.

She remembered no story in the family of anyone who had gone to Burma.

Vimala Devi pointed to the woman standing at the left of the photograph.

"This is his mother. And this other one... perhaps Saraswati Mausi."

"Perhaps?"

"It was a very long time ago. I was a child."

Neelam turned the photograph over.

On the back, in faint blue pencil, someone had written:

"Raghunath, Jaynagar, 1952?"

"Raghunath?" Neelam asked.

Vimala Devi frowned.

"I don't know who wrote that. Gopal's name was not Raghunath."

With that single word, the first crack appeared inside the photograph.

The next day Neelam took the photograph to her uncle Prabhakar Jha.

Prabhakar Jha was eighty, and he took pride in remembering the old names, marriages, and village relationships of the family.

The moment he saw the photograph, he laughed.

"This is not Gopal. This is Ramanand."

"Who was Ramanand?"

"My father's younger paternal cousin. He worked in a railway workshop in Calcutta."

"Ma says this is Gopal Mama, the one who went to Burma."

Prabhakar Jha shook his head.

"Your mother has mixed up things from childhood. Gopal was very dark. Look here - the small mark on the right side of the chin. Ramanand had a mark there."

Neelam examined the young man's chin.

Between the grain of the paper and the specks of the old print, there really was a dark dot.

"And 'Raghunath' on the back?"

"Raghunath may have been his household name. In those days one person could have two or three names."

Prabhakar Jha took an old copy of a genealogy register from his cupboard.

There was a Ramanand in it.

But the birth year was such that in 1952 he would have been about forty-two.

The young man in the photograph did not look forty-two.

Prabhakar Jha fell silent for a while.

"The date may have been written wrongly."

"Or the person?" Neelam asked.

Prabhakar Jha did not answer.

Neelam's curiosity was no longer merely about identifying a face.

She was astonished that one young man could stand among so many names:

Babuji,

Gopal,

Ramanand,

and the Raghunath written on the back.

She photographed the picture with her phone and sent it to the family group.

She regretted it almost immediately.

Within half an hour replies began arriving.

A cousin in Delhi wrote:

"That is my Nana."

A distant relative in Patna wrote:

"I have a copy of this very photograph. This is Shivnath Chaudhary."

A voice message came from Siraha in Nepal:

"This is a photograph of my father when he was young. His name was Mahendra Thakur."

Neelam sat holding the phone.

Shailesh did not laugh.

He said:

"If everyone is recognising someone from their own family, perhaps there is something in the face that resembles many old family faces."

"Or perhaps all the families were connected at some point."

"That too is possible."

Neelam decided to begin with the physical facts of the photograph.

In Madhubani market, an old photographer named Ramesh Sah still knew how to recognise black-and-white negatives and old photographic paper.

He opened the frame and carefully removed the photograph.

"This is an original printed copy," he said. "On the back there is a faded stamp: 'Prakash Photo Studio, Jaynagar.'"

Neelam looked closely.

Indeed, half of a circular stamp survived near the bottom.

"How old?"

"Judging from the paper and the way the edges are cut, around the 1950s, perhaps. But I cannot say with certainty."

"How could the same photograph reach many different families?"

"In old studios, many prints were made from one negative. Wedding pictures, farewell groups, group portraits - people gave copies to relatives. But if different families have the same image under different names, technique alone will not answer the question."

He examined the photograph through a magnifying glass.

"One more thing. The young man in the centre is sharp. The other four are slightly blurred. That may be because of the camera's focal point, or perhaps he happened to stand at exactly the right distance."

"What does that tell us?"

"Only this: the camera does not declare him to be the truth."

Ramesh Sah's sentence stayed with Neelam.

In the family group she wrote:

"If you recognise the person, please do not send only a name. Tell me what your identification is based on."

The answers changed.

For one person, the basis was the nose.

For another, the shape of the ears.

Someone said:

"My grandmother used to call this my father's photograph."

Someone had a name written on the back.

Someone had only a family story.

Neelam made a notebook.

On the first page she wrote:

"Photograph facts."

On the second:

"Identification claims."

On the third:

"Basis of claim."

She was not a historian by profession.

She taught mathematics at a town school.

Even so, she understood that different kinds of evidence were not of equal weight.

Vimala Devi found the entire effort unnecessary.

"I am telling you, it is Gopal Mama."

"How are you certain?"

"Ma used to say so."

"When?"

Vimala Devi fell silent for a moment.

"Not while showing this photograph. She used to tell Gopal's story."

"Then when did the photograph and the story become connected?"

"In my mind they are connected."

That answer mattered to Neelam.

Memory does not always preserve a name.

Sometimes it places a suitable name into an empty space.

A few days later the relative in Patna who had named Shivnath Chaudhary sent his copy of the photograph by post.

The two prints were almost identical.

But there was one important difference.

In the Patna print, half of a sixth person was visible at the right edge.

That portion had been cropped from Neelam's copy.

On the back was written:

"With Shivnath Babu, Jaynagar."

The sentence did not make clear whether "Shivnath" was the young man in the middle or someone else in the group.

The Patna relative, Ajay Chaudhary, said:

"My grandmother used to say that Shivnath is in the middle."

"Did your grandmother personally recognise anyone in this photograph?"

"Yes... I think so."

"Do you think so, or did she say so?"

Ajay laughed.

"Are you running a court?"

Neelam laughed too.

"No. I just want to understand how many things we inherit as evidence when perhaps what we have inherited is interpretation."

From Nepal, Mahendra Thakur's son Dinesh sent a copy from an old marriage register.

It recorded Mahendra Thakur's marriage in 1951 and a residence in a village near Jaynagar.

Dinesh said:

"In our house it was said that Babu had a photograph taken at a studio after his marriage."

"Which woman in the photograph is the bride?"

"That I don't know. It may not be a wedding photograph at all. Perhaps he was with friends."

"Do you have the original print?"

"No. There was a small copy in an old album. It was damaged in a flood. I saw it when I was a child."

In this claim, the photograph itself was absent.

Only memory remained.

In Neelam's notebook, beside "Mahendra Thakur," she wrote:

"Second-generation memory; original print unavailable."

A week later Neelam went to Jaynagar.

Prakash Photo Studio no longer existed.

A mobile-phone repair shop stood in its place.

An elderly shopkeeper next door said the old studio had closed in the 1970s.

The owner's son might be living in Darbhanga.

Neelam traced the address and went there.

Prakash Lal's son, Sudhanshu, was about seventy-five.

He did not have the studio's complete archive, but two iron trunks contained some surviving registers and envelopes that had once held negatives.

"Father worked more by serial number than by date," Sudhanshu said. "Writing the customer's name depended on the customer."

Neelam showed him the photograph.

Sudhanshu looked at it for a long time.

"I don't recognise the face. But the painted backdrop is not from our studio."

"Then the stamp?"

"The print could have been made here. People brought outside negatives."

That opened a new possibility.

Even the assumption that the photograph had been taken in Jaynagar was no longer certain.

Sudhanshu opened one register.

The pages listed serial numbers, numbers of copies, sometimes names, sometimes only notes such as:

"railway employee,"

"Nepal party,"

"farewell group."

Neelam spent hours reading pages from the 1950s.

At one entry she stopped.

"Serial 317 - old plate, five copies - Raghu Babu."

The date was 1956.

Neelam's pulse quickened.

"Could this 'Raghu Babu' be Raghunath?"

"It could."

"Can you locate the negative?"

Sudhanshu searched both trunks.

The envelope for serial 317 was empty.

On it were pencil marks:

"outside plate."

Again, no final proof.

But now the faint “Raghunath” written on the back of Neelam’s photograph had acquired an independent echo.

Neelam next showed the photograph to Sujata Mishra, a friend who worked with family archives.

Sujata looked first not at the central face, but at everyone around him.

“Why are you looking at them?”

“Because everyone else is trying to identify only the middle person.”

She enlarged the scan.

The woman at the left had a broad border on her sari and a small nose ring.

The other woman’s wrist had two thick bangles.

The man at the right was not holding a walking stick but a folded paper.

The young woman at the edge wore a black thread around her neck with a small square pendant.

Neelam asked every family:

“Who are the others?”

Here the answers became even weaker.

Vimala Devi called one woman Gopal’s mother, but could identify no one else.

Prabhakar Jha was certain only about the central youth.

Ajay Chaudhary’s grandmother’s note said “with Shivrath Babu,” but named no one else.

In Dinesh’s memory the picture was of “Babu and railway friends.”

Sujata said:

“When four people in a group disappear and only one face becomes a family member, the photograph may have become a memory-token rather than an identity document.”

The phrase struck Neelam as harsh.

“A photograph isn’t a document?”

“It is. But what it proves is that these people once stood together in front of a camera. It does not automatically prove their names.”

Meanwhile, the sale of the house was moving ahead.

The buyer wanted the back room emptied quickly.

Vimala Devi became irritated.

“Will you hold up the whole house over one photograph?”

“The house isn’t being held up. I’m only saying we shouldn’t throw the photograph away.”

“Who said to throw it away? It is Gopal Mama’s. Keep it.”

“What if he isn’t Gopal?”

Vimala Devi grew angry.

“You educated people want doubt in everything. The name by which I have known him all my life – is that wrong too?”

Neelam fell silent.

For the first time she understood that identification was not only a fact.

It was also a relationship.

If Vimala Devi had for decades treated this face as Gopal Mama and attached her mother's story to it, the word "wrong" struck at an entire emotional world.

But emotional truth did not become evidence of a name.

Holding both things at once was difficult.

A few days later an unexpected clue appeared.

Neelam's younger brother Alok found an envelope at the bottom of an old trunk.

On it was written:

"Raghunath's photograph - received from Malati Didi."

There was no photograph inside.

There were only two letters.

One, dated 1978, had been written by Vimala Devi's mother.

It contained the line:

"I am sending Raghunath's photograph. He looks like Gopal, and you had wanted to keep it."

Neelam read the sentence several times.

Vimala Devi read it too.

Her face changed.

"Ma wrote this?"

"Yes."

"Then this isn't Gopal?"

"The letter says it is Raghunath's photograph, and that he looks like Gopal."

Vimala Devi said nothing for a long time.

Then, very quietly:

"I forgot 'looks like Gopal.' 'Gopal' remained."

That one sentence revealed the whole transformation of memory.

For the first time in Neelam's notebook, a claim had not merely weakened.

The process by which it had been created had become visible.

But who was Raghunath?

The second letter was from a woman named Malati Didi.

She had written:

"I gave everyone copies of Raghunath Bhai's photograph, because before going abroad he had a picture taken with all of us."

Which foreign country?

The letter did not say.

At the bottom was an address in Saharsa.

Sujata Mishra traced the archive and located Malati Devi's family.

Malati Devi was no longer alive.

But an old album had survived in the home of her daughter, Kamla Singh.

Neelam went to Saharsa.

The moment Kamla Singh opened the album and saw the young man at the centre, she said:

"This is Raghunath Mama."

A tingling ran through Neelam's body.

“How do you recognise him?”

Kamla Singh laughed.

“My mother used to say so. But now you’ll ask how my mother recognised him, won’t you?”

Neelam smiled too.

“Yes.”

Kamla turned the next page of the album.

There was another photograph:

an older man, about fifty, with a woman and two children.

Beneath it, in clear ink:

“Raghunath, Moulmein, 1968.”

The face resembled the young man’s:

the nose,

the spacing of the eyes,

the mark at the right of the chin.

But resemblance alone was still not enough.

The album also contained a small passport-style photograph.

On the back was a signature:

“Raghunath Prasad Mishra.”

Kamla Singh said that Raghunath had worked first in Assam and later in Burma on railway-contract work.

Neelam was astonished.

Burma.

Burma had survived in Vimala Devi’s story of Gopal.

Perhaps the person had changed while the journey remained.

“How is Raghunath connected to my family?” Neelam asked.

Kamla Singh’s answer was not simple.

Raghunath was not Malati Devi’s own brother, but a maternal cousin.

Malati had married into a family distantly related to Neelam’s grandmother.

During the 1950s Raghunath had spent some months in Jaynagar, working in cross-border trade and railway-related business.

“Where was the group photograph taken?”

“Ma used to say: before they crossed the border. But which border, which year - I don’t know.”

Kamla Singh’s album contained yet another copy of the group portrait.

This one was wider than Neelam’s.

The sixth person was fully visible.

And on one corner of the mud wall behind them, half of a board could be seen:

“...pur”

Most importantly, five names were written on the back:

“Malati, Sharda, Raghunath, Devkinandan, Harish.”

The names appeared to run from left to right.

Neelam held her breath as she read.

According to this copy, Raghunath was the young man in the middle.

“Whose handwriting is this?”

“Ma’s.”

"How long after the photograph was taken did she write it?"

"I don't know."

Again the same problem.

There was now a name.

But not the date of writing, and not the basis on which it had been written.

Neelam was not discouraged.

This time the evidence was strong, even if not complete.

Photographs of Raghunath at different ages.

Family letters.

The travel story.

The signature.

The names on the group print.

All pointed in one direction.

Sujata said:

"In history we do not write certainty as a percentage, but we do weigh evidence. The Raghunath identification is now the strongest."

"Then the other three families were wrong?"

"Not necessarily that their entire stories were wrong. The question is how the photograph reached each house and how the name changed."

Neelam returned to that question.

Ajay Chaudhary's family copy may have reached them through Shivnath.

The phrase "with Shivnath Babu" could have meant that Shivnath was some other person in the group.

In Dinesh's family, Mahendra Thakur may have been one of Raghunath's railway-related acquaintances.

Over time, "the people with Babu" could have become "Babu's photograph."

Prabhakar Jha's Ramanand may have been a relative with a similar face, whose work history had settled onto Raghunath.

Vimala Devi's Gopal identification had already been explained by the letter itself: from "looks like Gopal"

to "Gopal."

None of the four families had been lying.

All four families had been doing the work of memory.

Some names attached themselves through relationships.

Some stories attached themselves to faces.

Some journeys moved from one person to another.

The photograph remained silent.

On the final day before the house changed hands, Vimala Devi was putting the photograph back into its frame.

Neelam said:

"Ma, shall we write a new name on the back?"

"What will you write?"

"Raghunath Prasad Mishra - probable."

"Why 'probable'? Haven't we found him now?"

Neelam thought for a moment.

"The evidence for Raghunath is strong. But the other names in the photograph are written in the same hand, and we don't know when they were written. We do not know the exact date. We do not know the place. And we still don't fully understand every family's connection."

Vimala Devi turned the frame over.

The old blue-pencil line was still there:

"Raghunath, Jaynagar, 1952"

"The question mark was already there," she said.

"Yes."

"Then leave it."

Neelam made a small new label.

On it she wrote:

"Central figure: strong probability of being Raghunath Prasad Mishra. Sources for identification: 1978 letter, Malati Devi's album, other photographs, family connections. Previously identified by different families as Gopal, Ramanand, Shivnath, and Mahendra. Earlier identifications should also be preserved."

Shailesh read the label and said:

"Such a long description?"

Neelam smiled.

"The short name is what caused the problem."

Vimala Devi looked at the photograph again.

"For me, this face still opens the story of Gopal Mama," she said.

Neelam took her hand.

"The story will remain. The name will be written separately."

The house was emptied.

The new owner took the keys.

Neelam did not place the photograph in the bookshelf of the new house.

She put it in the family's document box:

with the letters,

genealogy copies,

album reproductions,

and her notebook.

A few months later, while teaching a lesson on "evidence" at school, Neelam wrote on the board:

"What is seen = the whole truth?"

A student said:

"A photograph is evidence."

Neelam asked:

"What does a photograph prove?"

"That the person was there."

"The name?"

The student fell silent.

"The relationship?"

Another student said:

“Not that either.”

“The date?”

“If it is written.”

“And if it is written - when was it written, and by whom?”

The class laughed.

Neelam laughed too.

She did not show her family's photograph to the class.

The story was private.

The lesson was general.

At the end of the day she returned home and opened the document box.

The young man in the centre of the photograph was still looking toward the camera in exactly the same way.

The face had not changed.

The name had changed four times.

In one family's memory he was an uncle.

In another, a grandfather.

In a third, a railway worker.

In a fourth, a young man who went abroad.

Neelam understood:

a photograph does not lie.

But a photograph does not speak its own name either.

People write names.

And along with a name, people also write their relationships, absences, journeys, and resemblances into a face.

Neelam ran her finger over the question mark in the old blue writing on the back.

She did not erase it.

Because in the end, that small mark was the most honest part of the photograph.

The Voice in the Night

That rainy night was the last night the Jha family would spend in the old haveli.

From the next day the house was to stand empty. On the third day the buyers' men would begin measuring, and within a month the rear section would be demolished and the foundations of a new house dug.

The haveli stood in an old neighbourhood of Darbhanga - inside from the main road, beyond two narrow lanes where no car could enter, only motorcycles, bicycles, and people on foot.

At the front was a small osara. Inside lay a square courtyard, rooms on all four sides, an old kitchen to the north, a wooden staircase to the west, a closed hall to the south, and at the back a section that had not been fully used for thirty years.

Selling the house had not been an easy decision.

But the roof leaked.

Cracks in the walls were widening.

Drain water stood near the foundations.

And repairing such a large house in the middle of the city was beyond the family's means.

Sabita Jha, the present owner, had spent the evening packing boxes.

Her son Nachiket had come from Delhi.

Her younger sister Meera had arrived from Madhubani with her daughter Aditi.

Ramvilas, the old caretaker, was staying that night too because the truck for moving the belongings was due very early in the morning.

The fifth person was Sabita's elder sister-in-law, Urmila Devi, who had entered this house as a new bride fifty-five years earlier and now lived in a nearby flat.

Urmila Devi had insisted on staying the night.

"It is the house's last night," she had said. "Once the door closes, I want to see morning one last time from my old room."

Nachiket had joked:

"Do houses have last nights too?"

Urmila Devi had replied:

"Not like people. But sometimes the day one leaves a place becomes a date."

By nine o'clock the electricity had gone and returned twice.

Rain hammered on the roof.

The three buckets set in the courtyard were already full.

Sabita made khichdi not on the old hearth but on a small electric cooker.

Everyone ate in the same room because the others were crowded with boxes, old chairs, and open cupboards.

After dinner Meera found the old brass lamp and lit it.

"Ma used to light this every evening," she said.

Sabita did not reply.

Their mother had died in this house, but that was not why the house was being sold.

The reasons were more ordinary:

money,
repairs,
convenience,
distance,
the heirs living in different cities.

Within those ordinary reasons, memory kept searching for an extraordinary place of its own.

At about half past ten everyone prepared bedding.

Urmila Devi went to the old southern room.

Sabita and Meera took the eastern room.

Nachiket slept on the veranda because he found the air inside too humid.

Aditi insisted that she wanted to sleep with Urmila, her grandmother's sister, instead of with her mother.

In the end Meera took her into her own room.

Ramvilas laid a cot beside the small store at the back.

Water continued dripping into the middle of the courtyard.

The first sound came at about 11:27.

Nachiket remembered the time later from his phone.

It was not very loud.

First came a long scrape - as if some heavy piece of wood were slowly shifting.

Then a thin, breaking sound.

Nachiket distinctly felt that a woman had said:

"Open."

He sat up at once.

In the darkness of the veranda, his first glance went toward the closed southern hall.

One door of that hall had remained shut for almost three decades.

Inside were old trunks, a broken wooden cot, utensils, and bamboo stools from weddings long ago.

"Maasi?" Nachiket called.

Urmila Devi answered immediately from her room:

"I am here."

Sabita and Meera came out too.

"What happened?"

"Someone spoke."

"Who?"

Before Nachiket could answer, Ramvilas came from the back carrying a stick.

"I heard it too," he said.

"What did you hear?" Meera asked.

Ramvilas did not look toward the southern hall.

He looked toward the old well at the back.

"It sounded like a child crying."

Nachiket said:

"Not crying. Someone said 'open.'"

Urmila Devi stood holding the doorframe.

Her face had suddenly gone rigid.

"To me it sounded like 'Urmi,'" she said very softly.

Sabita looked at her.

"Who would call you Urmi?"

Urmila Devi did not answer.

Meera sent Aditi inside.

The child protested, but her mother shut the door from within.

The four adults and Ramvilas remained standing in the courtyard.

The rain had weakened.

Between the regular drip of water from the roof, the house was so quiet that everyone's breathing could be heard separately.

Nachiket tried to open the latch of the southern hall.

It had jammed.

Ramvilas brought oil.

Two minutes later the door opened with a groan.

Inside was the smell of damp.

Against the wall stood three trunks, an iron bedframe, an old mirror, an empty clothes chest, and a broken rope hanging from the roof.

No person.

The window was bolted from inside.

Dust covered the floor.

There were no fresh footprints.

"A cat?" Meera said.

Ramvilas shook his head.

"A cat could get in here, but the sound I heard came from behind the house."

Sabita grew irritated.

"It is a rainy night. Wood swells. Tin shifts. Drains make noise. The house is old."

It was the simplest explanation, so everyone tried to accept it.

But Urmila Devi did not return to her room.

She sat down on the bench on the veranda.

"Whose voice did you think it was?" Sabita asked again.

Urmila Devi kept looking at the flame of the lamp.

"It is a very old name," she said.

"How does a name become old?" Nachiket asked.

"When no one has called it for a very long time."

Meera understood that the questions should stop for now.

Everyone tried to sleep again.

The second sound came at 12:49.

This time Aditi heard it too.

First came a tin-tin sound - as though some round iron object were striking stone.

Then a brief breath-like voice.

Meera heard:

“Ma.”

Aditi said:

“Someone said ‘aa...’”

Sabita heard no word at all.

To her it sounded only as though a gust of air had blown once from the rear.

Ramvilas ran straight toward the well.

Beyond the rear courtyard stood an old well, no longer used.

Its mouth was covered with a heavy iron grille.

At one corner of the grille, an iron ring from the old pulley was moving in the wind and striking the stone.

Ramvilas caught the ring and held it still.

“This is the tin-tin,” he said.

Nachiket shone a torch into the well.

The water was far below.

Moss covered the inner wall.

“And the rest of the sound?”

Ramvilas did not answer.

Nachiket released the ring and waited for the wind.

After a while it struck the stone again.

Tin.

Tin.

Then, indeed, a hollow sound travelled around inside the well and rose upward.

But it was not “Ma.”

Not “open.”

Not “Urmi.”

It was only air.

“See?” Sabita said.

Meera replied:

“I see. But we still haven’t seen whether the first sound came from here.”

Sabita fell silent.

Nachiket suddenly became interested in the architecture of the house.

As a child he had known this game of sound.

Words spoken on the eastern veranda sometimes seemed to come from beneath the western staircase.

The bell of a rickshaw in the back lane sometimes sounded as though it were ringing inside the courtyard.

He took out a sheet of paper and began making a rough map of the house.

“A map now?” Meera laughed.

“If the sound travels, it must have a route.”

Ramvilas explained that above the old northern kitchen there was a hollow flue built to carry smoke out.

Its upper opening was now half-covered by a broken sheet of tin.

There was also a square ventilation hole in the roof of the southern hall, later half-bricked over.

"Air could enter in one place and emerge from another," Nachiket said.

Urmila Devi listened, but her attention was not on the map.

At about half past one the electricity failed completely.

The brass lamp was lit again.

This time Urmila Devi herself began to speak.

"My younger sister's name was Uma," she said.

"Before my marriage everyone called me Urmi. Only Uma used to say 'Urmi Di.'"

Sabita asked quietly:

"Uma Mausi?"

Urmila Devi nodded.

Uma had lived in this house for only two months, many years earlier.

Her marriage had broken down, and instead of going to her parental home she had come here to stay with her sister.

At that time the family did not speak openly about such matters.

"She used to cry a lot at night," Urmila Devi said. "I would tell her - be quiet, there are people in the house. One night she knocked on my door. I did not open it."

Meera held her breath.

"Why?"

"I was angry. We had quarrelled during the day. I thought she would calm down after a while. In the morning she packed her things and went to her parental home. After that she never really spoke properly with me again."

Uma died many years later after an illness.

She did not die in this house.

"Do you think the first voice was hers?" Nachiket asked directly.

Urmila Devi looked at him.

"I think that in what I heard, I heard Uma. Those are not the same thing."

Nachiket stopped asking.

It was the clearest statement of the night.

After two o'clock everyone stayed awake.

They stopped pretending to sleep.

Aditi came out again.

Her curiosity was greater than her fear.

She said that when she pressed her ear to the wall of the eastern room, sounds from the lane were very clear.

Everyone began experimenting.

Ramvilas went into the back lane and clapped from different places.

Nachiket listened from the courtyard.

A clap from one point seemed to come from the southern hall.

Another seemed to come from beneath the staircase.

Meera stood by the kitchen smoke-flue and softly said:

“Aa...”

Aditi stood in the hall and said it sounded almost like:

“Ma.”

Everyone laughed.

But the laughter held more unease than relief.

Nachiket wrote another line on the map:

“Sound is not a word. Does the mind add the word?”

Sabita read it.

“Do not leave everything to the mind. The house really is damaged.”

“Yes, Didi,” Meera said, “but the mind lives inside the house too.”

The third sound came at about a quarter to three.

This time there was no rain.

The wind too was very light.

The sound was brief:

one sharp scrape,

then something like a distant call of a name.

Sabita stood up suddenly.

“Babuji,” she said.

Everyone looked at her.

“What did you hear?”

“He did not call my name,” Sabita corrected herself at once. “It was just... the voice sounded like his.”

Her father had spent his life postponing repairs to this house.

A few months before his death, Sabita had had a serious quarrel with him.

She wanted to sell the house and move into a smaller one.

Her father had said:

“As long as I am alive, this house will not be sold.”

Sabita rarely spoke of that argument.

Nachiket remembered only that after his grandfather’s death, his mother had not raised the question of selling the house for a long time.

“Do you feel guilty?” Meera asked.

Sabita answered sharply:

“No.”

Then, after a while, she added:

“Perhaps I did. I don’t know now.”

Inside the southern hall, Ramvilas noticed something.

Behind the old mirror, a wooden panel had come half loose.

Even without wind, changes in the house’s temperature made the panel shift slowly and rub against the frame.

Ramvilas moved it by hand.

It produced the same long scraping sound that had begun the first noise.

Nachiket immediately called everyone.

He released the panel again.

It shifted slowly.

Scrape.

Then air entered through the ventilation opening above and circled in the hollow back of the mirror, producing a thin sound.

The combination came very close to the first sound.

Ramvilas said triumphantly:

“There. The ghost is caught.”

Aditi burst out laughing.

But Nachiket said:

“The ghost is not caught. We have found two causes that can make the sound.”

Urmila Devi smiled too.

“Exactly.”

“Then why did you hear Uma Mausi’s voice?” Aditi asked with childlike directness.

Urmila Devi did not avoid the question.

“Because I had kept her voice inside me.”

“For so many years?”

“Some voices do not count years.”

The rest of the night was spent examining the house.

Nachiket and Ramvilas identified three possible sources of sound:

the iron ring at the well,

the mirror panel in the southern hall,

and the northern smoke-flue.

A fourth source was the tin gate in the back lane, which groaned in strong wind.

But they could not reproduce the full sequence of every sound.

Sometimes they could reproduce the scraping but not the thin voice.

Sometimes the tin-tin came, but the direction of the sound changed.

The house was like a musical instrument whose strings had gone slack, and the wind played it without practice.

By four o’clock everyone was exhausted.

Urmila Devi sat on the veranda with her eyes closed.

Sabita leaned silently against the wall.

Meera held a sleeping Aditi in her lap.

Nachiket drew arrows on his map.

Ramvilas made tea.

Before sunrise the rain began again.

But now the sounds were ordinary:

water,

drain,

dripping,

wood shifting.

No “open.”

No "Urmi."

No "Ma."

At half past five the movers arrived.

Suddenly the house filled with human voices:

"Where does this trunk go?"

"Chair outside."

"Careful."

"Slowly on the stairs."

The mystery of the night became small inside the noise of labour.

By afternoon the southern hall was empty.

The mirror was taken down.

The trunks were loaded onto the truck.

Urmila Devi ran her hand once along the frame of her old room.

Nachiket folded the night's map and put it in his pocket.

"Will you keep that?" Sabita asked.

"Yes."

"Why? We found the cause."

Nachiket smiled.

"We found causes. Not the whole voice."

This time Sabita did not object.

Once the house was empty, the acoustics changed.

With the furniture gone, the echo grew stronger.

Words spoken in one room could be heard three rooms away.

Part of what the family had for years called "the sound from the southern hall" had perhaps been absorbed and redirected by clothes, trunks, cupboards, and curtains.

The next day an engineer came to inspect the building.

Nachiket did not tell him the story of the night.

He only showed him the map of the sound routes.

The engineer examined the hollow parts of the wall, the old ventilation ducts, and the shared roof.

"In a house like this, the direction of sound can change," he said. "Especially at night, when background noise is low."

Nachiket asked again in Maithili:

"You mean a sound from one place may seem to come from somewhere else?"

"Yes. And the human mind wants to recognise words. In an ambiguous sound, familiar words can seem to appear."

Nachiket wrote this explanation on the back of his map.

But not as final truth.

Because it could explain why sound changed direction.

It could not explain why five people heard five different words.

The answer to that question lay less in the bricks of the house than inside the people.

A week later demolition began.

Urmila Devi did not come that day.

Sabita stayed away too.

Nachiket was present only on the first day because his signature was required on the papers.

When the roof of the southern hall was opened, the old ventilation duct could indeed be seen running from one room toward another.

The pulley ring at the well was removed.

Instead of throwing away the mirror panel, Nachiket kept it.

No secret room was found.

No bones.

No written message.

Nothing that could turn the night's voices into a miracle.

A month later the rear section of the house no longer existed.

Nachiket returned to Delhi.

The map remained in his papers.

A few months later, at a family gathering, the story of that night came up again.

Aditi said eagerly:

"I heard 'aa...'"

Meera immediately said:

"No, you heard 'Ma.'"

Aditi laughed.

"I never said 'Ma.' You heard that."

Meera stopped.

Ramvilas, who had come to the gathering, said:

"I thought I heard a child crying."

Sabita said:

"At first I didn't hear anything at all."

Urmila Devi remained silent.

Nachiket took out the map.

That night he had written everything down immediately:

First sound:

Nachiket - "open."

Ramvilas - child crying.

Urmila - "Urmi."

Sabita - indistinct.

Meera - indistinct.

Second sound:

Meera - "Ma."

Aditi - "aa."

Sabita - wind.

Third sound:

Sabita - like Babuji.

Because the record existed, memory could see its own corrections.

Meera laughed.

"See? My mind wrote its own word into the child's voice."

Urmila Devi took the map.

"It says 'Urmi' for me," she read.

"What do you remember now?" Nachiket asked.

"The sound?"

"Yes."

Urmila Devi thought for a long time.

"Not clearly anymore. I remember Uma. Not the sound."

She handed the map back.

"That is good," she said.

"What is?"

"That the voice has blurred, but I said the thing I had never been able to say."

Nachiket understood:

one effect of the night sounds was that the house had made everyone listen to their old silences.

After the new house was built, the family went there once.

The old courtyard was gone.

The well was gone.

The southern hall was gone.

There was a straight roof, smooth walls, level floors.

Aditi clapped.

The sound came straight back.

"The sound doesn't wander here," she said.

Nachiket smiled.

Urmila Devi kept looking at the new wall.

"When the house changes, the sound changes too," she said.

Sabita added:

"And people?"

Urmila Devi replied:

"People carry old houses longer than sounds do."

Outside in the lane someone closed an iron gate.

There was a brief scrape.

Everyone fell silent for a moment.

This time no one heard a word.

It was only the sound of iron.

But Nachiket knew:

if the same sound had come in darkness, in rain, among old guilt and half-open memory, perhaps it might once again have become someone's name.

Whose Fault?

The school's main gate opened at the usual time that Monday, but the sound inside was not usual.

The bell rang.

Students stood in lines.

Teachers moved toward their classrooms.

But there was no morning assembly.

A brief notice came from the principal's office:

Aditya Mishra, a student of Class Ten, was no longer alive.

The notice said only that, at the family's request, the rest of the day's programme would be kept simple.

The cause was not discussed.

But the question had already reached beyond the school walls.

Local news pages.

Parents' phone groups.

Private messages among students.

Everywhere the same question circulated:

Whose fault?

Aditya was fifteen.

The police preliminary report treated his death as suicide.

No graphic details were released, and the family had expressly requested that such details not be circulated.

Details could be withheld.

Meaning could not.

On the first day outside the school, three explanations were heard most often.

Some said the mathematics teacher was excessively strict.

Some said there was pressure at home over marks.

Some said his friends had begun excluding him.

A fourth point was spoken more quietly:

for several months Aditya had become increasingly silent.

A fifth point was hardly said aloud at all:

people see silence, then fill its meaning according to their own convenience.

Aditya's father, Shailendra Mishra, worked at the district cooperative bank.

His mother, Reena Devi, did accounts work at a private clinic.

His younger sister Aarohi was in Class Seven.

On the second day after his death, two teachers and one administrative employee from the school went to the family's house.

There were too few chairs in the sitting room.

There were too many words.

Shailendra Mishra had placed five objects on the table before him:

Aditya's identity card,
his mathematics answer booklet,
a school discipline notice,
his diary,
and a small slip of paper on which several names were written.
The names were not accusations.
They were only names:
"Amit Sir."
"Ma."
"Babuji."
"Raghav."
"Megha."
"Principal."
Shailendra Mishra asked:
"Which of these can explain my son's death?"
No one answered.

The mathematics teacher, Amit Jha, had not gone to the family's house that day.
The school said the atmosphere was tense and it would be better to keep him apart.

Two days later written statements were taken from the teachers.
Amit Jha's was the longest.
He wrote that Aditya was talented but inconsistent.
Sometimes he gave excellent answers.
Sometimes he left pages blank.
His marks had fallen in the most recent examination.
Amit Jha acknowledged that he had said in front of the class:
"You have ability, but you do not work hard enough."
He also acknowledged that, while returning an answer booklet on one occasion, he had said:
"If you continue this carelessly, the board examination will be difficult."
According to the teacher, these were not insults.
They were ordinary academic warnings.
The word "ordinary" appeared five times in his statement:
"ordinary comment,"
"ordinary discipline,"
"ordinary expectation,"
"ordinary retest,"
"ordinary parent notification."
The inquiry committee later paid special attention to that word.
Amit Jha had been teaching for fifteen years.
His own language did not seem harsh to him.
His argument was:
a classroom needs limits;
without limits students become lax.

"I never singled him out as a target," he said. "What I say in a class of thirty, I say for everyone."

Committee member Suchitra Karn asked:

"Does something said to everyone have the same effect on everyone?"

Amit Jha fell silent.

Then he said:

"How is a teacher supposed to know that?"

No one had a complete answer.

Aditya's friend Raghav gave a very different account.

Raghav said Aditya was not afraid of the mathematics teacher.

Sometimes he even imitated him and laughed.

Raghav did not say:

"Sir was the main reason."

He said:

"That week Aditya was more worried about the group project than mathematics."

There were five students in the project group.

Aditya was supposed to prepare the presentation.

For two days he sent nothing.

Raghav became irritated.

In the group's message history was one line from Raghav:

"Because of you everyone's marks will be cut."

A line from Megha:

"If you cannot do it, say so beforehand."

A third message:

"This time you deal with it yourself."

When Raghav read these lines before the committee, he began to cry.

"At the time it felt like ordinary irritation," he said.

The word "ordinary" had appeared again.

Megha separately said that for the previous two months Aditya had been reading group messages less often.

Sometimes he replied.

Sometimes he disappeared for two days.

Once she had asked:

"Everything all right?"

Aditya replied:

"Fine."

Megha said:

"I took that 'fine' to mean fine."

The committee wrote that sentence down too.

In Reena Devi's statement, neither the teacher nor the friends came first.

She described the routine at home.

Everyone left around seven in the morning.

Reena usually returned after six in the evening.
Shailendra's work sometimes kept him out until seven.
Aditya and Aarohi reached home first.

Dinner was usually at eight.

At dinner, the father would ask about studies:

"What happened today?"

Aditya usually said:

"Nothing."

His mother would ask:

"How did the test go?"

He would say:

"Fine."

In their house, "fine" had gradually become a way of ending conversation.

Reena Devi acknowledged that she worried about marks.

The family was of modest means.

To her, education seemed like security.

"I used to tell him to work hard because opportunities do not keep returning," she said.

"Did you ever compare him with anyone?" the committee asked.

Reena Devi opened her mouth to say no.

Then stopped.

"Sometimes the neighbour's son's name would come up," she said. "But in which house does that not happen?"

No committee member answered.

Reena Devi added:

"Now I understand that saying 'it happens in every house' does not make it lighter."

Shailendra Mishra was harsher in his statement.

Harshest toward himself.

After seeing Aditya's most recent results, he had stopped his cricket coaching for a month.

"I thought it would save time," he said.

Aditya had not protested.

"If he had insisted strongly, perhaps I would have agreed," Shailendra said.

Suchitra Karn asked:

"Because he did not insist, did you assume it had not hurt him?"

Shailendra's eyes remained fixed on the table.

"Yes," he said quietly.

The committee did not formally take Aarohi's statement.

At the family's request, a child psychologist was present and there was only a general conversation.

Aarohi said that lately her brother had stayed awake very late at night.

“Studying?”

“Sometimes. Sometimes looking out of the window.”

“Did he say anything?”

“He would tell me: go to sleep.”

Aarohi repeated one thing that did not appear in any adult statement.

Aditya often changed the papers on his desk.

One day one had said:

“Things to do.”

Another day:

“Things not done.”

A third:

“Did anyone see the things I did do?”

Aarohi had not understood what they meant.

The papers were later thrown into the rubbish bin.

The diary survived.

Once the diary was found, both family and school placed great weight on it.

Some pages mentioned the teacher.

Some mentioned the parents.

Some mentioned friends.

At first glance the diary looked almost like a map of blame.

But when it was read, the matter was not so simple.

On one page:

“Amit Sir said again, ‘Where is your attention?’ I got angry. Not with him. With myself.”

On another:

“Babuji stopped cricket. He thinks that will make me study. I don’t understand what I want.”

On a third:

“Raghav is right. The group is stuck because of me. But as soon as I open the messages my heart starts racing.”

On a fourth:

“Ma comes home tired. If I tell her, she will worry. If I don’t, I am alone.”

The fifth page contained only one sentence:

“I tell everyone half the story, then complain that no one understands the whole thing.”

That sentence was repeated most often within the family.

Shailendra said:

“See? He himself says he didn’t tell us.”

Reena Devi immediately replied:

“That does not reduce our responsibility.”

For the first time before the inquiry committee, they contradicted each other.

Some pages of the diary were completely ordinary.

Cricket scores.

Two lines from a song.

Examination dates.

A list of birthday gifts for his sister.

A friend's joke.

The committee considered those ordinary pages important too.

Because after a death, readers begin searching only for sorrow.

Suchitra Karn said:

“A diary is not a prophecy. It is made of fragments of day-to-day feeling.”

Principal Vimal Chaudhary agreed.

But the school's institutional report was written differently.

It stated:

“According to school records, Aditya had received no formal disciplinary punishment.”

That was true.

But those records did not contain informal scolding.

Comments made in front of the class.

Verbal messages to parents.

Removal from sports time.

The principal said:

“If something is not recorded, how can we verify it later?”

Suchitra asked:

“If there is no system for recording it, how does its absence from the record become proof of the school's innocence?”

The room went quiet again.

The school had a counsellor.

But only two days a week.

One counsellor for 126 students in Class Ten.

In the previous six months, Aditya had not gone to her.

The administration had initially written that fact as:

“Counselling service was available.”

The committee suggested a revision:

“Counselling service was available, but was not used by the student; no evidence is available establishing why it was not used.”

Changing that small sentence was not easy.

The administration said:

“This creates an unnecessary implication against the school.”

Suchitra replied:

“The first sentence created the opposite implication - as though mere existence of the service proved access.”

In the end, the revised sentence remained.

Aditya's class teacher, Vibha Thakur, gave the least discussed statement.

She said Aditya was not habitually absent.
He submitted homework most of the time.
He did not disrupt class.
“So the usual warning signs were few?” the committee asked.
Vibha Thakur nodded.
“We look for a problem when a student breaks rules,” she said. “We have much less of a system for seeing the disorder inside a student who quietly follows them.”
She remembered one incident.
Two weeks earlier, during recess, Aditya had been sitting alone in the classroom.
Vibha had asked:
“Not going to the field?”
Aditya said:
“Not today.”
“Feeling ill?”
“No.”
“Then?”
“Just.”
Vibha had been in a hurry to check notebooks.
She moved on.
“Now I give meaning to that ‘just,’” she said. “That day I did not give it time to have a meaning.”
The committee members continued writing.

On the fifth day of the inquiry, a local news page ran the headline:
“Diary Reveals Secret: Teacher Responsible?”
The headline was based on one diary line containing Amit Sir’s name.
The full page was not published.
The next day another outlet wrote:
“Student Distressed by Family Pressure?”
That report was based on Shailendra’s decision to stop cricket.
A third outlet picked up the friends’ group messages.
In three days, three guilty parties had been created:
teacher,
father,
friends.
Reena Devi stopped reading the news.
Raghav became afraid to come to school.
Someone wrote slogans outside Amit Jha’s house.
The principal requested police protection.
In the name of finding the cause of one death, the lives of the living had become separate courtrooms.

Amid all this, one small fact received almost no attention.

Aditya's attendance record showed that in the previous month he had gone to the school health room three times.

The reason column said:

"headache,"

"dizziness,"

"stomach discomfort."

The health-room attendant, Kamla Sah, said that on all three occasions he had sat quietly for a while.

"Did he say anything?"

"Nothing in particular."

"Did you ask?"

"Yes - had he eaten? Had he slept? Did he have a fever?"

"About how he was feeling emotionally?"

Kamla Sah lowered her head.

The health-room form had no field for mood or emotional state.

This fact proved no one's guilt.

But it showed what the system knew how to ask about, and what it did not.

The committee built a timeline for Aditya's final three months.

Dates.

Tests.

Sports.

Group project.

Absences.

Health-room visits.

Teacher comments.

Events at home.

Diary lines.

Each in a different colour.

The timeline filled a wall.

Yet no single day shone like one red line.

Some days were difficult.

Some ordinary.

Some good.

One Sunday Aditya had gone to a fair with his family.

He wrote in the diary:

"Laughed a lot today."

Two days later:

"Feels heavy again."

The committee marked this reversal carefully.

Distress does not always look the same continuously.

One senior teacher said:

"If he laughed at the fair, how serious could the problem have been?"

Counsellor Mrinalini Das replied:

"Laughter is not proof that there is no inner crisis."

For the first time in the meeting, the language of mental health sounded different from the language of accusation.

Mrinalini said:

“Our aim is neither to reduce the death to one cause nor to erase questions of responsibility. Those are different levels.”

She drew five overlapping circles:

personal emotional state,

family relationships,

peer group,

school environment,

support system.

“These circles enter into one another,” she said. “Sometimes one event carries great weight. Sometimes many small things accumulate. Where there is evidence, say so. Where there is not, do not write an assumption as fact.”

Shailendra Mishra was dissatisfied.

“Then where is the answer to my question?”

“Whose fault?”

“Yes.”

Mrinalini did not answer immediately.

“An inquiry can identify concrete areas of responsibility,” she said. “But reconstructing the complete inner pathway that led one child to a death may not always be possible from documents.”

Shailendra’s face hardened.

“I do not want philosophy,” he said. “I want change.”

That sentence changed the direction of the inquiry.

The family said:

if there could be no agreement on one guilty name, then whatever broken parts of the system were visible should still be repaired.

Five concrete questions were formed.

First:

Was there a clear policy against humiliating comments made publicly in class?

Second:

How were teachers supposed to recognise signs of emotional difficulty in a student, and where were they supposed to refer the student?

Third:

Was counselling genuinely accessible, or merely available on paper?

Fourth:

Were parents informed only about marks and discipline, or also about concerns relating to well-being?

Fifth:

Could a student ask for help anonymously?

The school’s old handbook contained only half an answer to the first question.

The rest of the system ran on custom.

The principal had initially been defensive.

Later he began examining old records himself.

In the previous two years, only a very small proportion of students had gone to the counsellor.

That could have been evidence of success.

It could also have reflected fear or lack of awareness.

There had been no survey.

For the first time, the school conducted an anonymous student survey.

The question was:

“If you were deeply distressed, whom in the school would you go to?”

Many students wrote the names of friends.

Some wrote their class teacher.

On many sheets appeared:

“Don’t know.”

That answer entered the inquiry committee’s final report.

Amit Jha came before the committee again.

This time his language had changed.

“I could not measure the effect of every comment I made,” he said. “But I understand now that public comments can be reduced. A student can be spoken to separately.”

Suchitra asked:

“Do you consider yourself responsible?”

Amit Jha thought for a long time.

“I cannot declare myself the cause of one event,” he said. “But I cannot escape responsibility for my own conduct either.”

That sentence was retained verbatim in the report.

Raghav and Megha also wanted to meet Aditya’s family.

At first Reena Devi was not ready.

Then one evening a small meeting was held with school mediation.

Raghav said:

“I keep rereading those messages.”

Shailendra asked:

“What did you see then?”

“A friend who wasn’t doing his work.”

“And now?”

“A friend who was struggling.”

Shailendra was silent for a moment.

“And Aditya himself?”

Raghav’s eyes filled.

“Perhaps both.”

For the first time, Shailendra nodded.

The final available page of the diary was the hardest for the inquiry.

It contained no one's name.

Only three unfinished sentences:

"I am tired."

"I need to talk to someone."

"Tomorrow..."

That was all.

The next page was blank.

Some people wanted that page treated as the final proof.

Mrinalini Das said:

"It is a sign that help was needed. But it is still incomplete. We cannot make it the complete explanation of the death."

Reena Devi allowed the school to keep a copy of that page, but on one condition.

"Do not turn it into a display," she said. "The point should not be only that students read it and become frightened or emotional. Write beside it that asking for help is not weakness, and that teachers and families have a duty to listen."

The school did not make the diary public.

Instead, teacher training included an anonymised example under the heading:

"Incomplete Signals."

Three months later the final report was issued.

Nowhere did it say:

"Such-and-such person caused the death."

But it did not say:

"No one was at fault."

The report treated public shaming by a teacher as inappropriate educational conduct.

It found counselling access inadequate.

It recommended that communication with parents move beyond marks alone.

The friends' group messages were not declared the cause of the death, but peer-support training was recommended.

Academic pressure within the family was recorded as part of the broader family context, without turning the parents into criminals.

Most importantly, the report accepted that the available evidence did not establish a single cause.

At first Shailendra Mishra was dissatisfied with that sentence.

Then he read the line immediately after it:

"Failure to establish a single cause does not remove the need for institutional reform."

He did not fold the page away.

From the next session the school began several changes.

The counsellor became available five days a week.

Once a month each class held a well-being conversation, but it was not turned into a sermon.

Training became compulsory for teachers on public humiliation, emotional warning signs, confidentiality, and pathways to support.

Students were given an anonymous help box along with a clear list of safe phone and in-person contacts.

Parent meetings no longer discussed only report cards.

A short discussion was added on sleep, routine, social withdrawal, excessive pressure, and the availability of support.

None of these reforms brought Aditya back.

For that reason, the family never called them a “solution.”

Six months later the school proposed creating a small memorial corner in the library.

Reena Devi refused.

“Do not turn him only into a symbol of sorrow,” she said. “He played cricket, sang out of tune, stole his sister’s chocolates, and was delighted when he solved a difficult mathematics problem.”

The school did not build the memorial.

Instead it replaced the old netting around the sports field, because Aditya had played wicketkeeper there.

No nameplate was installed.

One day Aarohi saw the new net and asked her mother:

“Was this changed because of Bhaiya?”

Reena Devi said:

“It was changed for many students.”

“But after Bhaiya?”

“Yes.”

Aarohi thought for a while.

“Then why no name?”

Reena Devi held her hand.

“Every change does not need the dead person’s name written on it. Sometimes making the system better is itself a form of memory.”

At the end of the year Shailendra Mishra again placed the five objects on the table: the identity card, the answer booklet, the discipline notice, the diary, and the small paper with the names.

The paper still carried six names.

At one time Shailendra had wanted to place a tick beside one of them.

He had thought that choosing one name might quiet the noise inside him.

Over the year he understood:

fault and responsibility are not the same thing.

Fault asks:

“Who did it?”

Responsibility asks:

“What will each of us change now?”

In some places the answer to both questions may be the same person.

In some places they are different.

In some places the evidence remains incomplete.

He did not tear the paper.

He did not cross out the names.

He wrote only one line beneath them:

“No single name can explain Aditya’s whole life.”

Reena Devi read it.

“Then is the question over?”

Shailendra shook his head.

“No. The question has changed.”

“To what?”

He looked out of the window, where the evening light was slowly fading.

“When the next student says ‘fine,’ how long will we pause before asking again?”

Reena Devi did not answer.

Some questions are not answered in reports.

Their answers are written in behaviour:

the next day,

the next classroom,

the next dinner table,

the next message from a friend,

the next silence we encounter.

And perhaps that is why the question more difficult than “Whose fault?” is:

“Whose responsibility?”

Its answer is not one name.

It is work divided among many hands.

The Scent of Makhana

The first time makhana was roasted in the kitchen of the new house, Madhavi realised that scent too has its own path.

There was no smoke, no flame, nothing visible.

Yet the smell went straight in through her nose and opened an afternoon from years ago.

That afternoon was in the courtyard of her parental home. The rain had hidden itself away. The earth was damp, and her mother was roasting makhana in an iron kadai. The makhana did not pop; it merely rustled softly as it changed colour. With one hand her mother kept stirring it, and with the other she braided the hair of Madhavi's younger sister.

In the smoke of the present kitchen, for one instant Madhavi heard the damp smell of that old courtyard clearly - heard it, because sometimes memory wakes not through the nose but through the ears.

"Less ghee or more?" her mother-in-law asked.

Madhavi started.

A brass container of ghee stood in front of her, rock salt beside it, and washed makhana in a strainer.

"As much as all of you usually eat," she said.

"We use little ghee," her mother-in-law said. "Avinash wants something light in the evening."

Madhavi nodded.

She had been married for only three months.

In those three months she had learned many things about the household:

who took less sugar in tea,

who did not drink milk at night,

which bowl was brought out for guests,

which towel belonged only to Babuji,

and that garlic was not added to dal on Saturdays.

Amid all this knowledge, one question had never been asked:

what did Madhavi herself like to eat?

She had never asked anyone that question either.

For the first few weeks after marriage, she had folded her hunger into the household timetable.

What was cooked, she ate.

What remained, she kept.

What she did not like, she did not discuss.

A household needs small conveniences in order to run - that was all she had understood.

As soon as the makhana touched the hot pan, a faint brown fragrance rose.

Madhavi's hand stopped for a moment.
 Her mother used to heat the kadai first, then lower the flame almost completely.
 "If you hurry, it will brown outside and stay soft inside," she used to say.
 When Madhavi was twelve, she had laughed at that.
 "Does makhana have an inside and an outside too?"
 Her mother had answered:
 "Everything does."
 At the time the sentence had been ordinary.
 Now it suddenly became heavy.
 "What happened?" her mother-in-law asked again.
 "Nothing. The smell... that's all."
 "The new makhana is good. It came from Darbhanga."
 Madhavi wanted to say:
 the same smell used to rise in my house too.
 But the sentence never fully formed.
 "Yes," was all that came out.
 Her mother-in-law left the kitchen.
 Madhavi kept stirring the makhana.
 Its colour kept changing.
 Inside her, the distance between two houses began to be measured - not in railway kilometres, not in hours by road, but by a single smell.
 It had been two days since she had telephoned home.
 Her mother had asked:
 "Everything all right at your in-laws' house?"
 Madhavi had said:
 "Fine."
 Her mother asked again:
 "Avinash is good?"
 "Yes."
 "Your health?"
 "Good."
 The conversation had ended within five minutes.
 Earlier, Madhavi used to talk to her mother for so long that Babuji would interrupt:
 "Put the phone down, the battery will die."
 Now there were more subjects to talk about, but fewer words.
 Madhavi emptied the makhana onto a plate.
 She picked one up and put it in her mouth.
 Crisp outside.
 A little soft within.
 She laughed.
 There was no one to witness the laughter.
 Still, she felt as though her mother had heard it.

When Avinash returned from the office in the evening, tea was served in the sitting room.

The bowl of makhana went around.

Babuji said:

“It has been roasted well today.”

Her mother-in-law said naturally:

“Madhavi made it.”

Avinash ate two pieces.

“Tastes like Ma’s.”

It was a compliment.

Everyone smiled.

Madhavi smiled too.

But something inside her shifted slightly.

“Whose mother?” her mind asked.

It was a foolish question.

Avinash was speaking of his own mother.

Yet the comparison of tastes seemed suddenly to push Madhavi’s mother out of the kitchen.

It felt as if two memories were asking for the same place in one kadai.

She said nothing.

She refilled the bowl.

That night Avinash was reading a book.

While putting clothes away in the cupboard, Madhavi asked:

“Do you like makhana very much?”

“Yes. Since childhood. Ma used to make it.”

Madhavi opened her mouth to say:

“My mother too.”

Then she continued folding the clothes.

Avinash looked up from the book.

“What?”

“Nothing.”

“You are quiet today.”

“I am tired.”

Avinash returned to his book.

Madhavi did not mind.

In fact, she felt relieved.

Some things become too small if they are spoken immediately.

What was happening inside her did not yet have a name.

The next day, when she saw the box of makhana in the kitchen, no fragrance rose.

There was only makhana.

Memory does not always come when summoned.

Madhavi remained busy with household work all day:
her mother-in-law’s medicine,

Babuji's clothes,
the milkman's account,
the midday meal.
In this house the work was clear.
There was little need for anyone to tell her what to do.
She noticed and did it herself.
At her parental home too she had worked.
But there, her name remained in the middle of the work.
"Madhavi, do this."
"Madhavi, sit here."
"Madhavi, don't do it today, I'll do it."
In this house she was becoming less "Madhavi" and more an arrangement that worked.
She felt ashamed even for thinking this.
Her mother-in-law was not harsh.
Babuji spoke affectionately.
Avinash listened late into the night if she wanted to talk.
There was no cruelty.
No humiliation.
Then where did this faint emptiness come from?
She grew irritated with herself.
It seemed improper to live in comfort and still search for sorrow.

On the third day her mother telephoned.
"Your Mausi came yesterday. She was remembering you."
"I miss her too."
"Makhana is being dried near the pond here. They say the crop is good this year."
Madhavi's hand stopped.
"Makhana?"
"Yes. I roasted some yesterday. Your Babuji ate half the tin again."
Madhavi laughed.
Her mother laughed too.
In two seconds of laughter, three months of distance became a little smaller.
"Shall I send you some?" her mother asked.
Madhavi could have said yes immediately.
But she stopped.
There was already makhana in this house.
Excellent makhana brought from Darbhanga.
Why send makhana from her parental home?
"No, there is some here," she said.
Her mother became quiet.
Then, in a normal voice:
"All right."
After the call, Madhavi regretted it.
The question had not really been about the object.

Perhaps her mother had wanted to send not makhana, but a small part of her own hands.

Madhavi had preserved convenience and closed that path.

She thought of calling again.

She did not.

“If I say it now, Ma will understand that I regret saying no,” she told herself.

In the evening her mother-in-law said:

“Navaratri is next week. People will come to the house. We will make makhana kheer. Will you make it?”

“Yes.”

“Have you made it before?”

“With Ma.”

It was the first time Madhavi had mentioned her mother naturally in this kitchen.

Her mother-in-law asked:

“How does she make it?”

Instead of answering immediately, Madhavi looked at her.

The question was very small.

But it made room inside her.

“First she roasts the makhana in a little ghee. She reduces the milk for a long time. Cardamom at the end.”

“I put it straight into the milk,” her mother-in-law said. “This time make it your mother’s way.”

Madhavi smelled the fragrance again.

The kadai was still empty.

On the day of Navaratri there were voices everywhere in the house.

Aunts.

Older relatives.

Women from the neighbourhood.

Children.

People crossed the kitchen threshold continuously.

Madhavi stood reducing milk.

When she began roasting the makhana, her mother-in-law came and stood beside her.

“Such a low flame?”

“Ma says if you hurry it will brown outside and stay soft inside.”

Her mother-in-law smiled.

“She is right.”

The instant she heard the sentence, Madhavi’s eyes filled.

She bent quickly toward the kadai as though smoke had entered them.

There was no smoke.

There was fragrance.

Makhana.

Ghee.

And her mother's sentence.

The kheer was made.

Everyone ate.

Some found it too sweet.

Some found it just right.

Avinash ate two bowls.

Babuji said:

"The taste is different this time."

Her mother-in-law immediately said:

"It is the way they make it in Madhavi's parental home."

"The way they make it in Madhavi's parental home."

Two words of belonging.

Madhavi understood that sometimes making a place for oneself in a house begins with a sentence as small as that.

While clearing the utensils that night, her mother-in-law said:

"Tell your mother her method is very good."

Madhavi wanted to say:

it would be better if you told her yourself.

But she only said:

"Yes."

The following Sunday Avinash said:

"Let's go out somewhere."

"Where?"

"Wherever you say."

Madhavi suddenly said:

"Shall we go to my parental home?"

Avinash looked at the clock.

"Now? It is four hours away."

Madhavi felt her question had been childish.

"No, leave it."

Avinash was silent for a few moments.

"If you want to go, I can take leave tomorrow. We can reach tonight and come back tomorrow evening."

Madhavi quickly said:

"No, it isn't that necessary."

"What counts as necessary?" Avinash asked.

The question was simple.

The answer was difficult.

Illness is necessary?

A wedding is necessary?

A festival is necessary?

Or can simply missing someone sometimes be reason enough?

"I just miss home," Madhavi said.

"Then let's go."

That evening, as she got into the car, Madhavi felt guilty.

She told her mother-in-law:

"We are going suddenly."

Her mother-in-law replied:

"When missing someone comes suddenly, how can you give notice beforehand?"

Madhavi looked at her.

The woman of this house suddenly did not seem so unfamiliar.

All along the road, fields, markets, bridges, petrol pumps, and bus stands slipped behind them.

Now and then Madhavi told Avinash things from her childhood:

where her school had been,

where the fair used to be held,

which bridge had once been made of wood.

Avinash listened.

There was no solution in that listening.

Only space.

When they reached her parental home at night, her mother was standing at the door.

Her first words were not:

"Why suddenly?"

They were:

"Are you hungry?"

Madhavi laughed and laughed as she embraced her mother.

In the kitchen was the same old kadai.

Its rim had grown blacker.

The osara seemed smaller.

Perhaps Madhavi had changed.

Her mother opened a tin.

"This is the makhana I had said I would send you. You told me not to."

Madhavi took the tin in her hands.

"Give it to me now."

Her mother looked at her face.

"Don't they have makhana there?"

"They do."

"Then?"

Madhavi searched for an answer and then laughed.

"This is different."

Her mother laughed too.

"Makhana is makhana everywhere."

"No."

"What is different?"

Madhavi had no words.

It is difficult to explain a fragrance.
“It is just different.”

After everyone had gone to sleep, Madhavi went into the kitchen for water.
The tin stood on the table.
She opened it.
Dry makhana has no strong scent of its own.
The fragrance rises only when heat, ghee, time, and someone's hand come together.
She thought:
perhaps a house is like that too.
Things alone do not make a home.
Walls.
Bed.
Tin.
Utensils.
All of these are like dry makhana.
The fragrance rises only when someone's hands move among them day after day.
Her mother came from behind.
“Can't sleep?”
“I came for water.”
Her mother sat down on a chair.
“Everything good there?”
This time Madhavi did not answer “fine” immediately.
“It is good,” she said slowly. “But sometimes I feel I learned everything too quickly.”
Her mother did not understand.
“Is learning bad?”
“No. But... who needs what, when tea is served, when medicines are taken, when meals are made - everything. Sometimes I feel I never asked myself anything.”
Her mother remained silent.
Madhavi became afraid that she sounded as though she were complaining.
“They are all very good to me. I am not blaming anyone.”
“Why do you need to find blame?” her mother said. “If you are tired, you are tired. If you miss home, you miss home. Where does blame come into that?”
Madhavi ran a finger over the table.
“Did you feel like this after your marriage?”
After a long time her mother laughed.
“When I first went from your Nani's house to my in-laws' house, I put too much salt in the food for three days. Everyone kept saying, ‘The new bride has a heavy hand.’ The truth was that at Nani's house the salt tin was small; the pinch fell differently.”
“That's all?”
“Not all. Many things. But not everything stays in memory. Some smells remain.”
Madhavi looked at her mother.

Her mother took one makhana from the tin and broke it.
“See. Dry inside. This one will keep well.”

At the time of departure the next day, her mother put the tin of makhana, homemade pickle, and an old cloth bag into the car.

Madhavi did not protest.

When she returned to her marital home, her mother-in-law opened the tin.

“So much makhana!”

Madhavi laughed.

“Ma said to share it.”

“Then first we will eat it ourselves, and whatever remains can be shared,” her mother-in-law said.

It was not greed.

It was the laughter of belonging.

Madhavi understood.

A few days later women from the neighbourhood came to visit.

Her mother-in-law asked Madhavi to roast makhana.

Madhavi opened the tin from her parental home.

The kadai heated.

The ghee melted.

The makhana went in.

The fragrance rose.

This time it did not take her straight back to her parental home.

First came her mother’s courtyard.

Then this kitchen.

Her mother-in-law saying “low flame.”

Avinash’s two bowls of kheer.

Babuji’s praise.

The night drive.

Her mother’s table.

And then the present.

Madhavi was startled.

Memory no longer travelled in only one direction.

Inside the fragrance, the two houses were no longer opposed to each other.

They had become separate knots on the same thread.

A neighbour asked:

“What are you thinking about?”

“Nothing. Watching the flame.”

From a distance her mother-in-law called:

“Don’t hurry. It will brown outside and stay soft inside.”

Madhavi’s hand stopped again.

The sentence had once belonged to her mother.

Now her mother-in-law was saying it too.

For an instant it did not feel like theft.

It felt like expansion.

A sentence can change houses without losing its meaning.
Sometimes the meaning grows.

That night Madhavi telephoned her mother.

“Today we roasted your makhana.”

Her mother asked:

“Good?”

“Very good.”

“Everyone ate?”

“Yes.”

There was silence for a while.

Earlier such silences had made Madhavi uncomfortable.

Now they did not.

“Ma,” she said, “that thing you used to say - ‘brown outside, soft inside’ - Maaaji says it now too.”

Her mother laughed.

“So my knowledge has travelled.”

Madhavi laughed too.

“Yes.”

After the call she stood by the window.

The night was quiet.

A faint fragrance of makhana still drifted from the kitchen.

She understood that in order to preserve the memory of her parental home, she did not need to keep her marital home at a distance.

And in order to make a place for herself in her marital home, she did not need to erase the scent of where she had come from.

Her life between the two houses was not a bridge that required her to leave one end behind in order to reach the other.

It was like that fragrance:

rising from one place,

settling in another,

then becoming a third meaning inside someone's breath.

The next morning Madhavi went to the kitchen to make tea.

The makhana tin was half-empty.

Her mother-in-law had taken some out during the night.

The lid had not been closed properly.

Madhavi pressed it shut.

Suddenly she remembered her mother's words:

“If you leave the tin open, the makhana will go soft.”

Smiling, she ran her hand over the lid.

There was no fragrance in the kitchen now.

Yet she knew:

give it a little ghee,

a little heat,
a little time,
and the fragrance would rise again.
And now that fragrance was teaching her not only how to return.
It was teaching her how to stay.

Yellow Flowers

When Anamika first saw the garden of that house, she remembered not the names of the flowers but their colours.

Just inside the main gate, on the right, ran a long strip of grass. In the middle stood a round fountain, and all around it were rows of flowers. Red roses could be seen from everywhere. White jasmine had been planted for its evening fragrance. But Anamika's eyes kept returning to one low shrub - small yellow flowers which, among all the larger blooms, seemed to be saying something softly.

That day she had come with her mother, Sushila, to ask for work.

For many years Sushila had done domestic work in different houses in the city. Now pain in her knees had grown worse. She wanted Anamika to work not at sweeping and mopping floors but in a garden; there would be open air, sunlight, and her hands were already familiar with soil.

The mistress of the house, Revati Chaudhary, was looking out over the garden from the veranda. A cup of tea was in her hand.

"Age?" she asked.

"Eighteen completed," Sushila replied.

Revati looked at Anamika.

"Do you know plants?"

"Not all of them," Anamika answered truthfully.

"Roses?"

"Yes."

"Marigolds?"

"Yes."

"Petunias?"

Anamika was silent.

Revati smiled faintly.

"You'll learn."

The old gardener, Raghunath Das, was watering the garden with a hose at the time. He was told to show the girl the work.

On the first day Raghunath taught her only one thing:

watering did not mean giving every plant the same amount of water.

"Some need it at the root. Some become diseased if their leaves are wetted. Some want water in the morning, some in the evening. A garden does not run on equality. It runs on understanding need."

Anamika remembered the sentence.

When they reached the yellow-flowered shrub, she asked:

"What is this?"

"This?" Raghunath bent toward it. "People here call it yellow daisy. The proper name may be something else. Owners notice colour more than names."

"Does it flower for long?"

"If you keep removing the dried flowers in time, it blooms again and again."

Anamika held a withered flower between her fingers.
It seemed cruel to cut a flower away.
Raghunath handed her the shears.
“If you leave what is finished, the new flowers lose strength.”
She cut off her first dried flower.

Within two months Anamika began to understand the garden's rhythms.
Which corner received sunlight first.
Which hose joint leaked.
Which rose thorn should be pruned not with a trembling hand but a firm one.
Which pot had to be moved under the veranda when rain came.
All of it settled into the memory of her body.
People in the house rarely called her by name.
Mostly she was “the garden girl” or “the girl who works with the gardener.”
Revati sometimes said “Anamika,” because she had written the name down on the first day.
At first Anamika did not feel hurt by this.
She too did not know the names of everyone in the house.
To her, Revati was “Malikin,” her husband “Babu,” the college-going daughter “Didi,” and the younger son “Chhota Babu.”
But she gradually learned the names of the plants.
The yellow-flowered shrub became her particular responsibility.
The reason was simple.
Raghunath paid more attention to the roses.
So did the mistress.
The yellow flowers were small and grew at the edge, so Anamika kept watching them.
She removed dried blooms, loosened the soil, picked tiny insects from beneath the leaves by hand, and mixed in cow-dung manure from time to time.
One morning Revati was walking in the garden with guests.
The house was hosting an afternoon tea organised by some association.
A table was being laid on the veranda:
white cloth,
glass tumblers,
small silver-coloured spoons,
flower vases.
Revati stopped beside the yellow flowers.
“How have these become so full?”
Raghunath was at a distance.
Anamika was digging the soil nearby.
She raised her head.
Revati said to a guest:
“I love yellow. Last year this plant almost dried up. This year it is doing very well.”
The guest bent to look at the flowers.
“Beautiful.”

Anamika lowered her eyes to the soil again.

For the first time she understood that the eyes saying “beautiful” were on the flowers, not on her hands.

Her nails were packed with soil.

There were small cuts on two fingers.

The previous week she had had to prepare a neem solution to remove pests.

None of those things was a colour a guest would see.

Even so, she did not become angry.

Only slightly surprised.

Beauty hides the marks of its labour so easily.

After the afternoon tea was over, much remained on the veranda.

Kamli, the kitchen helper, gave Anamika two samosas and a sweet on a plate.

“Your flowers got a lot of praise today,” Kamli said, laughing.

“My flowers?” Anamika asked.

“If not yours, then Malikin’s.”

They both laughed.

The laughter was light, not bitter.

But the phrase “Malikin’s flowers” lodged somewhere inside Anamika.

That night, after returning home, she looked at the small courtyard of their rented house.

In front of the house was a strip of soil barely a hand wide.

There were a tulsi plant, two chilli plants, and coriander her mother had planted.

No ornamental flowers.

“Shall I plant yellow flowers here too?” Anamika asked.

Sushila was taking dal off the stove.

“Where is the space?”

“In that corner.”

“The chilli plant will spread there.”

“One pot?”

“Will you spend money meant for a pot on flowers?”

Anamika fell silent.

The argument was not wrong.

The following week, while cleaning in the garden, she noticed a small new shoot near the yellow shrub.

It had come up a little way from the main plant.

Raghunath said:

“This has grown by itself. If you leave it here, it will become crowded. Pull it out.”

Anamika lifted the tiny shoot with some soil still around it.

Its roots were extremely delicate.

“Throw it away?”

“Plant it wherever you want. There is no space here.”

Anamika did not throw it away.

She found an old broken plastic container.

She made two holes in the bottom, filled it with soil, and planted the shoot.

She placed the container behind the gardener's room, where it received half a day's sun.

A few days later the little plant stood upright.

Anamika wanted to take it home.

But she was afraid that carrying away a plant without asking might be called theft.

Even if Raghunath had said, "Plant it wherever you want," did a thing from the house still belong to the house?

She was not sure.

So she decided to ask Revati.

One evening Revati was sitting on the veranda.

Anamika approached carrying the container.

"Malikin, this young plant had grown outside the main shrub. Raghunath Kaka told me to remove it. I planted it in this container. If you permit me, may I take it home?"

Revati looked at the container, then at the plant.

"This?"

"Yellow flower."

"Take it. There are plenty here."

Anamika thanked her.

Revati added:

"If it survives, show me a picture."

Anamika nodded.

She liked the fact that whether the plant lived mattered, even slightly, to Revati too.

That night Sushila looked at the plastic container at home.

"This is the flowerpot?"

"It was free."

"Then all right."

Anamika laughed.

She placed the plant near the steps of the osara.

Every morning before leaving she watered it.

Every evening she returned and checked the leaves.

Now, among the chilli plants, there was one ornamental plant.

Sushila was indifferent at first.

But one day, when a small bud appeared, she herself called Anamika.

"Look, your yellow flower is coming."

"Mine?" Anamika smiled.

Sushila did not understand what she meant.

"You planted it. So it is yours."

On the day the bud opened, Anamika stood looking at it for a long time.

It was as bright as the flowers at the large house.

Only the background was different.

Behind it stood a wall with peeling cement, a towel hanging from a hook, chilli leaves, and a water bucket.

The yellow was no less beautiful here.

She took a photograph on her phone.

Then she remembered that she had promised to show it to Revati.

The next day she did.

Revati was genuinely pleased.

“Ah, it survived! Very good.”

At that moment her daughter Ira came onto the veranda.

Seeing the photograph, she asked:

“Whose house is this?”

“Anamika’s,” Revati said.

Ira looked at Anamika.

Perhaps it was the first time she had heard her name.

“It’s lovely. The colour stands out beautifully against the wall.”

Anamika felt a strange happiness.

Sushila was always embarrassed by that wall because the paint had peeled.

The very same wall was making the yellow flower appear brighter.

A few days later Ira began taking photographs in the garden for a college photography project.

She photographed dew on leaves, rose thorns, fountain water, shadows, soil - everything.

One morning Anamika was cutting the dried heads from the yellow flowers when Ira approached with her camera.

“May I photograph your hand?”

Anamika was startled.

“Mine?”

“Yes. While you’re cutting the flowers.”

Anamika immediately drew her hand back.

There was soil under her nails.

“My hand is dirty.”

“That is why.”

Anamika could not decide whether she liked the answer.

Why should a “dirty hand” look beautiful in a photograph?

Something a person wants to clean every day can become an interesting image for someone else.

Even so, she gave permission.

Ira took several photographs.

In one, a dried flower lay between the blades of the shears.

In another, Anamika’s fingers loosened the soil.

In a third, the yellow flowers were behind her palm.

“No face?” Anamika asked.

“If you want.”

Anamika thought for a moment.

“The hands are enough.”

That evening her own decision surprised her.

Why not the face?

Had she too begun to treat her presence in the garden as limited to her hands?

Two weeks later there was a small exhibition-like gathering at the house.

Ira had hung her college-project photographs on the veranda wall.

The theme was:

“Labour Inside the House.”

Kamli’s hands holding a rolling pin.

Driver Ramvilas’s keys.

The guard’s register.

Raghunath’s shears.

Anamika’s soil-filled fingers.

Guests came again.

One woman stopped in front of Anamika’s photograph.

“A beautiful composition,” she said.

Anamika was moving a flowerpot a little distance away.

Again she heard “beautiful.”

This time the beautiful thing was not only the flower.

It was her hand too.

But another question rose inside her:

if a photograph of a hand is beautiful, what is the value of the work the hand performs?

That night she spoke about it with Kamli.

Kamli laughed.

“My rolling pin looks very dignified in a photograph too. Try making rotis from five in the morning and then you’ll understand.”

They both laughed.

Anamika said:

“Still, didn’t you like it?”

“I liked it. But a photograph does not raise wages.”

The sentence was simple.

Anamika thought about it for a long time.

A few days later Raghunath fell ill.

Most of the garden’s responsibility came to Anamika.

The heat was increasing.

A hose joint broke.

Disease appeared on two rose plants.

The fountain motor stopped.

A large celebration for Revati and her husband’s wedding anniversary was due the following week.

The garden had to look immaculate.

Extra labourers were brought on contract.
But they did not know the flowerbeds.
All day Anamika gave instructions:
Do not dig here.
Do not cut this root.
This leaf is diseased.
Keep this pot in the shade.
Twice Revati came outside and said:
“The yellow flowers must remain in good condition. The stage will be on that side.”

Anamika said:

“Yes.”

Two days before the celebration, the decorators arrived.

They were to put up a strip of artificial flowers behind the stage.

One worker placed a heavy iron base on the edge of the yellow-flower bed.

Anamika stopped him immediately.

“Not here. The roots will be crushed.”

The worker said:

“I was told to keep the line straight.”

“Move the line a little forward.”

“Ask the owner.”

Anamika went to Revati.

Revati was busy on the phone.

She gestured with one hand.

“Let the decorators do what they think is right. Just don’t let the flowers break.”

Anamika returned.

The iron base had already been placed.

Two small branches were trapped beneath it.

She told the worker again:

“Move this.”

“I don’t have time.”

Anamika tried to lift the base herself.

It was heavy.

Ramvilas the driver saw her and came to help.

Together they shifted it half a hand’s breadth outward.

The decorator became annoyed.

“The line is ruined.”

For the first time Anamika answered without hesitation:

“Make the line again. Once the root breaks, it will not join again.”

When she returned home that night, her own yellow plant had five flowers.

Sushila had plucked one and placed it in the household shrine.

Seeing the empty stem, Anamika asked:

“Why did you pluck it?”

“I put it in the puja.”

Anamika was about to say:
“Without asking?”
But she stopped.
Whose plant was it?
Hers?
The household’s?
Her mother’s?
Who decided how the flower could be used?
Sushila saw her face.
“Did you mind?”
“No,” Anamika said, then added truthfully, “A little.”
“Then next time I will ask.”
Anamika had not expected the answer to be so simple.

On the evening of the celebration, the garden glittered with lights.
The stage stood behind the yellow flowers.
Guests took photographs, laughed, and talked.
Some stood in front of the flowers for pictures.
Anamika watched from a distance.
Then Ira came looking for her.
“Why are you standing here? Mummy is calling you.”
Revati stood near the stage.
When Anamika arrived, she said:
“Raghunath wasn’t here, but you kept the garden very well. Thank you.”
Several guests were nearby.
Suddenly Anamika felt everyone’s eyes on her.
She liked it.
She felt uncomfortable too.
Revati added:
“You especially saved these yellow flowers.”
Anamika looked at them.
She remembered:
the pressed roots,
the broken hose,
the neem solution,
morning watering,
dried flowers,
the shears,
the plastic container.
She only said:
“The plants were fine. They simply needed the work done at the right time.”
Revati probably did not think about the depth of the answer.
She smiled and turned toward the next guest.

After the programme ended, paper cups, tissues, and broken pieces of decoration lay scattered across the grounds.

Two plastic spikes were caught in the yellow-flower bed.

Anamika and the temporary workers who had come in Raghunath's place began cleaning.

Ira came out holding her camera.

Then she put the camera inside and picked up a bag.

Anamika asked:

"Why are you doing this?"

"I took enough photographs today. Now I'll work."

Anamika laughed.

"The work won't look as beautiful as the photographs."

Ira laughed too.

"Then I'll learn."

For a while the two of them picked up litter together.

The following month Raghunath returned.

But because of his age and illness he decided to work only half-days.

The house manager asked Anamika whether she would take on more responsibility.

Her wages would increase a little.

Anamika was ready to say yes.

Then she remembered Kamli's sentence:

a photograph does not raise wages.

She asked:

"How much will they increase?"

The manager told her the amount.

"And the work?"

"Half of Raghunathji's responsibility."

"Then will the wage increase according to half the responsibility?"

The manager looked at her.

Perhaps he had not expected the question.

"This is the budget limit."

Anamika did not fall silent.

"I will do the work. But write down what my responsibilities in the garden are. And if extra workers come, I should also have the authority to give them instructions."

The demand surprised even her.

A few months earlier, the people in the house had rarely spoken even her name.

Now she wanted the name of her responsibility written down.

The discussion continued for two days.

In the end, the wage increase was less than she had wanted but more than the first offer.

Her responsibilities were put in writing.

Raghunath smiled.

"You saved the papers more than the flowers."

Anamika replied:

"If there is no paper, later everyone will say the flowers bloomed by themselves."

Raghunath laughed loudly.

The rains came.

For a while the yellow flowers in the garden almost disappeared.

Too much water collected.

Mud filled the roots.

Anamika opened the drainage, changed the soil, cut back some branches.

For a week the shrub looked almost ugly.

Revati asked:

"Has it gone bad?"

"I have pruned it. It will come back."

"There is no function at the moment," Revati said with a light laugh. "Take your time and make it healthy."

Anamika smiled too.

It gave her a strange relief to hear that for a few days the plant was excused from the constant examination of looking beautiful.

Her own plant at home grew rapidly in the rains.

The plastic container became too small.

This time Sushila herself bought a clay pot from the market.

"Money on flowers?" Anamika teased.

Sushila replied:

"Now this isn't a flower. It has become a member of the house."

They both laughed.

While changing the pot, the roots emerged:

fine,

white,

spread through the soil.

Anamika placed them in the new pot with great care.

She remembered the yellow shrub at the large house, whose roots had almost been crushed under the iron base of the stage.

Flowers can be seen above the ground.

Roots never appear in anyone's photograph.

She thought:

labour is like roots.

People see flowers.

They see colour.

They see fragrance.

Roots remain beneath the soil.

But being invisible does not mean being unimportant.

The following week Ira wanted another photograph for her project.

This time she asked Anamika:
“With your face?”
Anamika said:
“Yes. But not with flowers behind me. While I’m working.”
“Doing what?”
“Changing roots.”
Ira was surprised.
Then she smiled.
Anamika knelt, loosening the soil.
The camera was in front of her.
This time she did not want to hide her dirty hands.
Her face was in the frame too.
After taking the photograph, Ira showed her the screen.
Anamika looked at it.
The yellow flowers in the background were blurred.
In the foreground her face, hands, and the soil were clear.
“The flowers have gone out of focus,” Ira said.
“Let them,” Anamika replied.

That evening, when she returned home, two new yellow flowers had opened in her own pot.

This time Sushila had not plucked one for puja.
“I was waiting to ask,” her mother said.
Anamika looked at the flowers.
For a moment she felt like saying:
“Take one.”
Then she cut one herself and placed it in her mother’s hand.
“Keep this.”
Sushila put the flower in the household shrine.
The second flower remained on the plant.
In the morning the first ray of sunlight fell on it.
The wall was still peeling.
The bucket was still there.
The chilli plant leaned to one side.
Nothing had been arranged like an exhibition.
Even so, the yellow shone.

As Anamika stepped out through the door, she looked at the flower and then at her own hands.

Yesterday’s soil was still caught in the corners of her nails.
She did not turn back inside to wash them.
That day she went to work with the soil still on her hands.

The Afternoon Table

It was a Jeth afternoon. Sunlight lay so white on the courtyard tiles that the eye could not rest on it directly. Inside the dining room, the heavy curtain had been drawn halfway, the fan turned fast overhead, and in the middle of the table a glass bowl of water held two floating green leaves.

Prabha Jha walked around the table for the third time, checking whether all the bowls faced the same direction, whether there was an oil stain on the pickle jar, whether the lemon wedges had been cut evenly.

This was not a formal luncheon.

Four old friends - Prabha, Meera, Jyoti, and Savita - met once a month for lunch, taking turns at one another's homes. The arrangement had begun in their old college group, but over five years it had become a small tradition among four women living four different lives.

There were only two rules:

do not prepare too much;

eat whatever is normally cooked in the house;

and for two hours, do not talk about work.

The rules were broken almost every time.

The smell of mustard tempering drifted from the kitchen.

Prabha called out:

"Rama, take the dal off now. Don't let it boil over."

"Yes, Didi," came the answer from inside.

There was tiredness in the voice - or perhaps only the heat. Prabha could not tell.

Rama had worked in this house for nine years. At first she had only swept and washed utensils; later she began cooking too.

Prabha often said:

"My house would not run without Rama."

Rama would smile when she heard it.

But every discussion of increasing her wages was somehow postponed to the next month.

Meera arrived first.

She wore a pale blue cotton sari, carried a cloth bag under one arm, and had fine beads of sweat across her forehead.

"They've dug up your lane again," she said as soon as she came in. "The rickshaw man made me get down halfway."

Prabha immediately turned the fan toward her.

"Will this city's roads ever be finished, or will our lives end first?"

They both laughed.

Meera taught science at a government school. Among the four, she was the only one with a regular salaried job.

Sometimes Prabha envied Meera's leave, pension, and fixed salary.

Sometimes Meera listened to Prabha speak of her airy house, beautiful curtains, and son studying abroad, and thought of her own small government quarters.

Neither had ever said these things directly.

Jyoti came in saying:

"I can stay only five minutes."

Then she put her phone - which Prabha, in her mind, still wanted to correct into the word "telephone" - into her bag.

Jyoti ran a small beauty parlour. Her face was always carefully made up, but today the kajal beneath one eye had spread slightly.

The moment she came in, she looked at the table and said:

"Prabha, you've changed the meaning of 'don't prepare too much' again."

On the table were rice, moong dal, parwal curry, pumpkin bhujia, curd, mango pickle, papad, and makhana raita.

Prabha defended herself immediately.

"Everything is ordinary. Rama made it."

The moment the sentence left her mouth, something about it felt wrong.

As though the proof that the meal was ordinary was that the labour had not been hers.

Savita arrived last.

Her car stopped outside the gate, and the driver opened an umbrella for her.

Savita held an administrative post at a private hospital. A bright watch shone on her wrist.

The moment she sat down she said:

"Sorry, the meeting ran long. People think only doctors work in a hospital."

Then, without pausing:

"Does anyone have cold water?"

Rama placed four glasses on the table.

Savita lifted one.

"This is filtered, isn't it?"

"Yes," Prabha said. "From the RO."

For one moment Meera looked at Rama as she turned to go back.

There were small red blister-like marks on her palm.

Meera thought of asking about them.

But just then Jyoti began telling them about a new client.

"Yesterday a woman came and said, 'Make my face look ten years younger.' I told her, 'Looking ten years younger is not the responsibility of cream. That's the photographer's responsibility.'"

Laughter spread around the table.

Savita said:

"Then make a twenty-year plan for me."

Prabha, spooning out raita, said:

"You are still the Savita from college."

It was a compliment.

But Meera noticed that after saying it, Prabha looked for a moment at Savita's watch.

She did not know what it cost.

Once, Savita had casually said in the group that she had bought it at Delhi airport on the way back from a hospital conference.

That day Prabha had changed the subject.

They began eating.

For the first five minutes they talked only about taste.

Was there too little ghee in the dal or just enough?

How had the parwal been cut?

How much fenugreek was in the mango pickle?

Was the curd bought from the market or made at home?

These small questions were like a safe place for the four women.

Here no one had to answer about salary, children's results, husbands' behaviour, an ageing mother's illness, or bank loans.

Jyoti tasted the pumpkin bhujia.

"I want this recipe."

Prabha said immediately:

"Ask Rama. All I know is how to eat."

They laughed again.

Rama was standing near the door.

Jyoti turned toward her.

"How do you make it?"

Rama explained in two sentences.

Jyoti stopped her midway.

"Good - so you don't boil it first?"

"No, Didi. Then the taste changes."

Savita put down her spoon.

"No one in my house likes pumpkin. If the cook makes it, it gets thrown away."

It was an ordinary sentence.

But Rama went still for a moment.

Perhaps she remembered the value of food that is thrown away.

Perhaps she remembered nothing at all.

She picked up a plate as an excuse and went inside.

Meera said softly:

"The children in our school's midday meal eat pumpkin very well. If the spices are good."

Savita laughed.

"If you're hungry, everything tastes good."

Meera smiled too.

But the smile did not reach her eyes.

Prabha changed the subject at once.

"And how are everyone's children?"

That question always came in the middle of lunch.

Jyoti's daughter was in Class Twelve.
Meera's son was in Patna preparing for a competitive examination.
Savita's daughter worked in Bengaluru.
Prabha's son was abroad.
Four children in four directions.
Four mothers presenting their worries as achievements.

"Tanvi says it is difficult to work here," Savita said. "The salary is not good. At least there they value merit."

The word "merit" lay on the table for a few moments.

Meera kept mixing dal into her rice.

She remembered Rinki, a girl at her school who was excellent at mathematics but had missed an examination because she had to work in the field with her mother that day.

She could have argued with Savita.

But the rule for the afternoon was:

no work talk.

Jyoti, speaking of her daughter Pakhi, said:

"She wants to study fashion design. Her father says she should first do a general degree. I think a child should do what she wants."

Meera smiled and asked:

"The fees?"

Jyoti was silent for a second.

"We'll see. If we have to take a loan, we will."

Savita said easily:

"If the institute is good, tell me. I know people. Scholarships can be checked too."

Jyoti's face brightened, then immediately became neutral again.

"No, no, I'll look into it. If I need anything, I'll tell you."

Prabha noticed that tiny change.

Accepting help and preserving equality at the same time were difficult things to do together.

Rama came in again.

This time a girl of about seventeen or eighteen was with her.

Thin, face darkened by sun, a steel bowl in her hand.

"This is Kajal," Rama said. "My daughter. She came to town to submit her college papers, so she stopped here."

For a moment Prabha was uncertain.

Where should Kajal sit?

There were four chairs around the table.

A fifth stood against the wall.

Prabha immediately began pulling it forward.

Kajal said:

"No, Didi, I've already eaten."

Rama said too:
“She’ll just go back with me.”

Meera asked:
“Which college?”

Kajal named it.
“I am enrolling in B.A.”

“Which subject?”
“History.”

Her answers were brief, but her eyes were eager.

Meera began asking questions at once:

how many marks in Class Twelve?

Had she filled the scholarship form?

Were her caste and income certificates ready?

Between the questions, Rama kept looking at her daughter with such pride that the dining room suddenly seemed to have become a corner of her own home too.

Savita said:

“What will you do after studying history? These days you should choose a practical subject.”

She had never asked that question of Tanvi.

Kajal was silent for a moment.

“I like reading old papers and records. Later I will sit for examinations.”

Savita nodded.

“Fine, if the goal is clear.”

Prabha saw Kajal looking at the two green leaves floating in the bowl at the centre of the table.

“Sit, have a little raita,” she said.

Kajal refused again.

Rama handed her the steel bowl.

“Take this curd home.”

Prabha almost stopped her.

“Oh, the curd...”

Then she fell silent.

Rama regularly took a little of the leftover food home.

But today, in front of the four friends, the sight of that small right made Prabha uncomfortable.

Jyoti looked at Kajal’s fingernails.

“Such clean nails! Do you ever put colour on them?”

Kajal laughed.

“Maybe when I start college.”

“Come to my parlour,” Jyoti said. “The first time, I’ll put it on for you.”

Was the offer genuine affection, or simply Jyoti’s habit of sharing the world of her business?

Jyoti herself did not know.

After Kajal and Rama went inside, silence stayed at the table for two or three moments.

The fan suddenly sounded very loud.

Savita drank water.

"Rama's daughter is good."

"Very bright," Prabha said. "Always first or second in school."

Meera asked at once:

"Then the college fees?"

Prabha gathered curd from the edge of her bowl with her spoon.

"Rama said something will be arranged. It is a government college."

Meera asked again:

"Do you help with anything?"

The question was not harsh.

But to Prabha it felt as though a small stain had suddenly appeared on the white cloth covering the afternoon table.

"I... help when there is a need," she said. "She has her self-respect too. If one does too much, she may not like it."

That was half true.

Rama never directly asked for help.

But it was also true that Prabha had never asked in detail:

how much was the fee?

How much did books cost?

What was the bus fare?

Sometimes "self-respect" becomes a convenient reason not to ask.

Savita spoke in Prabha's defence.

"Everyone has limits. The employer cannot take responsibility for the entire family of a domestic worker."

Meera nodded.

"No. But the employer is responsible for wages."

For the first time, the air at the table changed.

Jyoti kept breaking her papad.

Prabha smiled.

"There goes my 'no work talk' rule."

Meera laughed too.

"I am a teacher. Breaking rules comes naturally to me."

The tension loosened a little.

But the subject remained on the table.

Savita said:

"At the hospital I see this all the time - people compare wages without understanding the whole arrangement. Food, leave, bonus, medical expenses - add everything."

Meera asked:

"And time?"

"Time?"

"What time does Rama come?"

Before answering, Prabha had to think.

"Seven-thirty... around that."

"And leave?"

"Four. Sometimes five."

Jyoti said quietly:

"Two girls work at my parlour. They call me Didi. But at the end of the month, rent is not paid with 'Didi.' It is paid with wages. I understood that late."

She fell silent after saying it.

The smudged edge of kajal around her eye now looked to Prabha like a mark of exhaustion.

Savita did not argue.

She only took a small piece of mango pickle.

After a few moments she said:

"I raised Shanti's wages at home last month. She asked. At first I felt bad - so suddenly! Later I calculated and realised that in five years I had never increased them on my own."

No one commented on the confession.

The four women looked at their plates.

At that table, envy and affection did not seem like opposites.

Meera could envy Savita's watch and at the same moment admire the honesty of her admission.

Prabha could appreciate Jyoti's independent business and still compare herself inwardly with the number of Jyoti's clients.

Savita could want the security of Meera's fixed government job while joking about her government salary.

Utensils clattered in the kitchen.

Prabha suddenly stood up.

"Rama, leave it. Do it later. Eat first."

Rama came out wiping her hands.

"I'll eat, Didi."

"Now."

Prabha's voice had become unnecessarily firm.

She herself could hear that the insistence sounded like pity.

Rama smiled.

"All right. I'll eat with Kajal."

She took out two plates and began setting them on a small low platform inside.

Meera said:

"Why not sit here and eat?"

Rama waved a hand at once.

"No, Didi. I'll eat comfortably there."

The fifth chair at the table was still empty.

Prabha looked at it.

She felt that equality is not created merely by saying:

"Come, sit here today."

Nine years of habit,

the boundaries of a house,
working hours,
wages,
language,
forms of address -
all of them determine the height of a chair.
One afternoon's invitation could not change all that.
But once a question becomes visible, it cannot become invisible again.

After the meal came kheer.
It had not been planned.
Rama had made it that morning from leftover milk.
After her first spoonful Savita said:
"This is the best thing of all!"
Prabha said naturally:
"Rama's hand."
This time the phrase did not sound wrong to her, because she immediately added:
"And I need to recalculate what that hand is worth."
Meera laughed.
"I am recording this declaration as a witness."
Jyoti said:
"We'll ask next month."
Savita smiled too.
Rama was listening from the doorway.
Whether she laughed or only moved her lips, Prabha could not tell from that distance.
After that, the conversation became light again.
College days.
An old professor.
The four friends travelling by bicycle.
Tasteless hostel vegetables.
Foolish quarrels from the first year of marriage.
They laughed, interrupted one another, corrected old memories.
At such moments the four could almost become girls again - the same age, with the same amount of money in their pockets and the same future before them.
Almost.

Savita rose at three.
"I have to get back to the hospital."
While telephoning the driver, she said to Kajal:
"If your scholarship papers get stuck, leave your number with Prabha. There is someone in my department who can explain the process."
Kajal thanked her.
Savita made it clear:

“Not a recommendation - the process. The rest is your marks.”

Kajal smiled.

As Jyoti was leaving, she gave Kajal the address of her parlour.

But this time she added:

“You don’t have to get colour put on. If you’re ever tired while you’re in town, just come in for a glass of water.”

Meera took an old competitive-examination book from her bag and handed it over.

“Our school library has two copies. This one is extra. It isn’t history - general studies. It may be useful.”

After everyone left, the house suddenly became very quiet.

On the table remained four half-empty glasses, a small circle of oil from the pickle jar, crumbs of papad, and spoon-marks in the kheer bowls.

Prabha reached out to lift the tablecloth.

Then stopped.

Rama was eating inside with Kajal.

They were speaking softly:

fees,

bus fare,

forms,

photographs,

signatures.

Prabha went to her room and brought out a small account book.

For the first time she began writing down:

how many hours Rama worked,

when her last wage increase had been,

what had been given at festivals,

how much sick leave she had taken.

As she worked out the numbers, Prabha felt ashamed that something so ordinary had taken her nine years to examine.

But it was easy to leave shame as only a feeling.

Numbers were harder.

Numbers demanded the next decision.

When Rama came out, Prabha did not close the account book.

“Rama, sit for five minutes this evening. We need to work out the wages and hours again.”

Rama looked at her.

“Did I do something wrong?”

“No. Perhaps something has been wrong from before.”

Prabha smiled.

But this time she did not use the smile to make the matter lighter.

Rama said nothing.

She began wiping the table.

The green leaves floating in the glass bowl had drifted to the edge.

As she lifted the bowl, Rama asked:

“Shall I throw these leaves away?”

“Yes,” Prabha said.

From inside, Kajal called:

“Ma, give me one. I’ll press it in a book.”

Rama took out one leaf and gave it to Kajal.

She carried the other toward the waste bin.

Then, after thinking for a moment, placed it in the pot by the window.

Prabha watched the small act.

The two leaves were identical.

One would become a memory in a book.

The other would decay into soil.

Value does not exist only in an object.

It is also made by the place and the gaze of the person who keeps it.

As the afternoon sun softened, it fell obliquely across the dining table.

The cloth had been removed.

Small scratches from the day’s use were visible on the white glass, scratches that could not be seen while the table was dressed.

Prabha ran her palm over them.

She understood that the afternoon’s conversation had ended, but the table had not become as clean as before.

Some marks had become visible.

And perhaps the next time the four friends sat at this table, plates would be placed over those marks, there would be laughter, envy too, affection too -
but the marks would not disappear completely.

Kohl

The morning light had not yet fully spread.

A thin strip of yellow sunlight was climbing the eastern wall of the courtyard, and in Sharda Devi's room, before the old wooden mirror, Ira had already drawn kohl twice along her eyes and wiped it away with cotton both times.

When she raised her hand for a third attempt, Sharda Devi spoke from the cot.

"Give it to me. I'll put it on."

Ira laughed.

"You? What if the line goes crooked? My first-day photographs will be ruined."

"My hand does not tremble that much yet," Sharda Devi said, sitting up with the help of a pillow. "And on a first day, the eyes should look straight, not the photograph."

Ira had been appointed as a history teacher in the district school.

Today was her first day.

Since the previous evening, the house had been full of small preparations:

a file of papers,

copies of certificates,

a steel water bottle,

two pens,

the bus timetable,

and Neelima asking again and again whether she would forget her lunchbox.

In the middle of all those preparations Ira kept looking at herself in the mirror.

Was the sari right?

Was the braid too tight?

Should she wear the small bindi on her forehead or not?

Should she put on kohl or leave it off?

Neelima, Ira's mother, appeared in the doorway.

"Ma, don't start the old rule again. No thick kohl to ward off the evil eye."

Without looking toward her, Sharda Devi said:

"I don't put it on for the evil eye."

"Then for what?"

"For the eyes."

Neelima smiled and walked away.

Ira placed the small brass kohl box in Sharda Devi's palm.

Blackness had gathered around the lid.

Sharda Devi stroked it with her thumb.

"Is this bought from the market?"

"Yes. The one you make spreads too much."

"The one I made stayed with the eye. The market one stays with the photograph," Sharda Devi said, and laughed softly at her own sentence.

With her left hand she gently lifted Ira's chin.
In the mirror Ira could see her grandmother's face above her shoulder.
The eyes looked smaller among the wrinkles, but the gaze was steady.
Holding her breath, Sharda Devi drew a line from the inner corner of the right eye outward.

The touch was very light.
Suddenly Ira remembered childhood:
school plays,
wedding ceremonies,
the first time she stepped outside after a fever.
Each time Sharda Devi would place a dot of kohl at the corner of her eye.
Back then Ira believed that her grandmother knew the reason for everything.
Now she knew that her grandmother too had done many things by instinct and guesswork.

"Don't close your eye," Sharda Devi said. "As far as the line travels, keep your gaze steady."

Ira asked:

"Who taught you?"

It was an ordinary question.

Sharda Devi's hand stopped for half a moment.

"My mother. But the first time I put it on properly, I did it on myself."

"When?"

"When I was supposed to leave home for teacher training."

Ira immediately took her eyes away from the mirror.

"You had been selected for teacher training?"

Sharda Devi finished the line on the other eye, closed the box, and said:

"I had been selected. I did not go."

For a moment, the sound of birds outside became very clear in the room.

Ira wanted to ask many questions at once.

Why didn't you go?

Who stopped you?

When was this?

Why didn't you tell Ma?

But her grandmother's face was not one on which answers should be demanded immediately.

Sharda Devi wiped a line of dust from the mirror with her finger.

"I was nineteen then. Six months of training in Madhubani. There was even a small monthly stipend. The headmistress at school had helped me fill in the application. I had thought that after six months I would teach in the village school, I would have my own earnings, and most of all, there would be a few hours in the day for which I would have to account only to myself."

Ira kept listening.

What surprised her was not that her grandmother had once wanted to become a teacher.

What surprised her was that her grandmother remembered the desire in the language of “my own time.”

“Then why didn’t you go?”

“There was no single reason.” Sharda Devi’s voice remained very ordinary. “Nani fell ill. Your younger uncles were both in school. There was little money in the house. Babuji did not like the idea of my staying away. And I...”

She stopped.

“You?”

“I learned to say ‘all right’ too quickly.”

Ira said nothing.

There was no single face to blame in that answer.

There was her father’s fear.

Her mother’s illness.

The lack of money.

The needs of the household.

And among all of that there was a nineteen-year-old girl who had learned to read the faces around her before she learned to object.

“The day you were supposed to leave for training?” Ira asked.

“Not the day I was supposed to leave. The day I first thought I would go.” Sharda Devi smiled. “After submitting the papers, I came home and put kohl on myself properly for the first time. The line was so thick that my mother looked at me and said, ‘Are you going to become a teacher or perform in a dance?’ I became angry. Then she herself wet a little cotton and wiped half of it off. She said, ‘Let the line remain, but don’t let it cover the eye.’”

Ira looked at her eyes in the mirror.

The line Sharda Devi had drawn was very thin.

So thin that from a distance perhaps no one would notice it.

Yet to Ira, her own face seemed a little clearer.

“What happened to the training letter?”

“It stayed in a trunk for a few days. Then under some clothes. Then there was marriage. Then children. Then the trunks changed. I don’t know where the paper went.”

Something like pity rose suddenly in Ira, and she immediately felt embarrassed by the emotion.

Sharda Devi read her face.

“Don’t look at me like that. Life is not only the name of the one road I did not take.”

“I wasn’t looking at you with pity...”

“I know. But when the new generation hears an old desire, it immediately wants to write a judgment on our behalf.” Sharda Devi laughed. “Many things in my life were good too. Saying that does not make the old desire false.”

Neelima appeared again at the door.

“Twenty minutes until the bus.”

Then she saw Ira’s eyes and said:

“Ma, you really have done it beautifully.”

Sharda Devi looked at her daughter with a questioning expression.

“So my hand has finally received recognition?”

“It was recognised long ago. Only you never showed me your certificate,” Neelima said.

The moment she saw Ira’s face, she understood that the old story had been opened.

“You knew?” Ira asked her mother.

Neelima nodded.

“A little. Ma had told me she had given up some training. I always thought it was because of the household. Not all this detail.”

Sharda Devi said:

“Details are not always necessary. Sometimes one generation gives the next only the conclusion:

‘Study.’

‘Keep your own earnings.’

‘Do not be afraid to go away.’

The reason stays inside.”

Neelima sat on the corner of the bed.

“So when Ira was little and you refused to let me leave my job, was this why?”

Sharda Devi did not answer immediately.

“Half the reason. The other half was that I knew your nature. If you had left the job, five years later you would have blamed me.”

All three laughed.

There was no glorification of old sacrifice in the laughter.

Only the knowledge of one another’s nature.

Ira lifted her bag.

When she bent to touch her grandmother’s feet, Sharda Devi stopped her.

“Don’t become so serious on the first day. Go to school. Learn the children’s names. And don’t try to change the world in the first week.”

Ira said:

“Keep my eyes straight?”

“When necessary.”

“And when it isn’t necessary?”

“Then let your eyes rest.”

Ira went outside.

While crossing the courtyard, she turned once and looked toward her grandmother’s window.

Sharda Devi waved.

Neelima was hurrying after Ira with the lunchbox she had forgotten.

The morning of the house suddenly became ordinary again:

the smell of milk coming to a boil,

water falling from the tap,

a low song from the neighbour’s radio,

the first cart on the road.

After Ira had left, Sharda Devi returned to her room.
The brass kohl box lay before the mirror.
She picked it up and opened the lid.
On the black surface was a fresh circular mark from Ira's use.
For many years Sharda Devi had not applied kohl to her own eyes.
At first there had been no time.
Then spectacles.
Then the easy sentence:
"What need is there now?"
At festivals she might still wear a bindi.
But the kohl box was opened mostly for children and grandchildren.
She went very close to the mirror.
Without her spectacles, her face blurred.
Fine lines around her eyes seemed to merge into one another.
She laughed.
There was no point in searching for the face of nineteen.
Even so, she took the thin kohl stick between her fingers.
The first line went crooked.
She reached for cotton.
Then stopped.
She let the crooked line remain.
The line on the other eye came out a little better.
She put her spectacles back on.
The mirror became clear.
Her face had not changed into some earlier version of itself.
No lost young woman had returned.
No unfinished training had been completed.
Only Sharda Devi's present eyes had become a little clearer along their dark edges.
Neelima entered and stopped.
"Ma?"
"What?"
"Nothing." Neelima smiled. "It looks good."
Without taking her eyes from the mirror, Sharda Devi said:
"If it looked good on Ira, why shouldn't it look good on me?"
Instead of answering, Neelima opened the curtain at the window.
The morning sunlight filled the room.
The line of kohl was straight on one eye and slightly crooked on the other.
Sharda Devi made no attempt to even them.
For the first time she felt that every line did not need to be equal.
What mattered was that the line did not cover the eye.

The New Curtain

The idea of changing the curtains in the house began with colour.

Aarti Jha said that the old light-brown curtains in the sitting room no longer went with the newly painted walls.

Her husband, Naveen, said:

“If they are perfectly fine, why change them?”

But two weeks later, when Aarti brought home printouts of designs she had seen online, the decision was made.

The new curtains would not be heavy.

They would be sheer.

Outside light could enter, but the shapes inside would not be clearly visible.

Aarti liked that very much.

“The house should feel open, and still remain private,” she said.

Savita was sweeping at the time.

She did not stop.

Only when she reached the window did she look outside once.

From the lane, the balcony of the house opposite was clearly visible.

Then she lifted the lower edge of the old curtain and swept beneath it.

Savita had worked in this house for five years.

Two houses in the morning, Aarti's house before noon, then the house of an elderly couple.

Her own home was in a newly settled colony beyond the railway line:

one room,

a tin roof,

and, instead of a gate, an old sari hung across a bamboo frame.

When the new curtain arrived, its box was placed in the middle of the sitting room.

Aarti was excited.

The fabric was grey-blue, with a fine yellow line along the edge.

“Look,” she said to Savita, “during the day no one outside will be able to see in.”

Savita took the cloth in her hands.

“It is light.”

“Yes, and it won't hold much dust.”

Savita smiled.

At the word “dust,” she remembered the sari hanging at her own doorway.

It got soaked in the rain.

It became stiff in the sun.

And when the wind blew hard, half the doorway opened by itself.

A carpenter was called to hang the curtain.

The old rod was removed.

A thin metal rail was installed.
Savita kept gathering the fallen plaster from below.
When the carpenter left, Aarti drew the curtain open, then closed it.
The light really did change.
The face of the room softened.
“Now it looks right,” Aarti said.
Savita replied:
“The light has stayed inside.”
Aarti laughed.
“I am going to send that line to my sister.”
By afternoon Aarti had taken several photographs of the curtain.
One with the vase in front.
One with half the sofa.
One of the folds of the cloth alone.
Savita was cleaning the glass at the time.
In one photograph her arm appeared.
Aarti immediately took another.
“Was the first one bad?” Savita asked.
“No, only... your hand came into it.”
Savita said, “Yes,” and continued working.
She did not feel hurt.
But the sentence remained in her ear:
your hand came into it.

Aarti's friends came that evening.
They looked at the new curtains.
They discussed the texture of the cloth.
They praised the light.
After serving tea, Savita returned to the kitchen.
Voices drifted in from the sitting room:
“How much the room has changed!”
“So light!”
“The house can breathe now.”
As Savita washed dishes, she thought:
the house can breathe.
A great deal of air came into her own house because the doorway did not close properly.
Yet whether that was called breathing or failing to keep the wind out had never occurred to her before.
The next day, when sunlight fell from behind the curtain, the cloth looked not blue but almost white.
Savita moved it aside to clean the window.
Aarti immediately said:
“Oh, people outside will be able to see everything inside. Draw it across a little.”
Savita spread the curtain again.

Outside, the milkman was passing along the road.
Inside, on the table, lay Aarti's half-open book, spectacles, mobile phone, and fruit.

That day Savita's daughter Pooja came straight from school to where her mother was working.

Her school timing had changed, and Savita had to leave for the next house.

Aarti said:

"Let her sit here for half an hour."

Pooja sat in a corner of the sitting room and began her homework.

Her eyes kept going to the curtain.

"Do you like it?" Aarti asked.

"Yes," Pooja said. "You can see outside, but people outside cannot see in?"

Aarti was pleased.

"Exactly."

Pooja went closer to the window.

"It would be nice if we had one like this at home."

Savita heard from the kitchen.

"Get on with your work. We do not need everything in our own house."

Pooja fell silent.

Aarti asked casually:

"Don't you have a curtain at home?"

"We do," Savita said. "An old sari."

"Oh, I have the old curtains put away. If you want them, take them."

The offer was generous.

Savita knew Aarti genuinely meant to give them.

Even so, a small hesitation rose inside her.

The old curtain:

what was no longer useful enough for this house was good enough for hers.

She did not refuse immediately.

"I'll see."

Three days later, Aarti had the old brown curtains washed and placed in a plastic bag.

"Savita, take these. What's the point of throwing them away?"

Savita took the bag.

It was heavy.

When she reached home, Pooja was delighted.

Together they measured the doorway.

The cloth was much too wide.

It was also too long.

They were not sure whether the bamboo pole beneath the tin roof would bear its weight.

Savita's husband Raju said:

"Cut it in half."

Pooja immediately said:

“No! It will be ruined.”

Savita laughed.

“It wasn’t made to the measurements of our house. So what exactly would ‘ruined’ mean?”

The curtain remained in the bag for two days.

On the third, Savita cut one section for the doorway and another for the window.

She folded the edges and stitched them by hand.

Pooja held the thread for her.

When the new-old curtain was hung, the room really did change.

But not like Aarti’s sitting room.

The brown fabric looked heavy in the small room.

Less air came in.

The interior became darker in the afternoon.

Raju said:

“Keep it open during the day.”

Pooja said:

“No, people outside will see in.”

Savita tied a knot in the middle.

Half open.

Half closed.

Air too.

Privacy too.

The following week Aarti asked:

“Did you put up the curtain?”

“Yes.”

“Send me a picture.”

Savita was silent for a moment.

Her simple phone did not take clear photographs.

Pooja borrowed a neighbour’s phone and sent one.

Aarti saw:

the tin wall,

the bamboo rod,

the knotted brown cloth in the middle,

a plastic bucket below,

a schoolbag in one corner.

Aarti wrote:

“It looks very nice.”

Savita read the message and smiled.

She knew Aarti had written it kindly.

Even so, in that “very nice,” Savita could not see the heat in her house,
the smoke,

the leaking roof,

or the crooked doorway.

The photograph showed only the curtain.

A few days later there was a small puja at Aarti's house.

There were many guests.

The sitting-room curtains were kept fully closed because the lane outside was crowded.

Savita moved back and forth between the kitchen and the sitting room.

Once, as she came out carrying a tray, she heard Aarti's aunt say:

"The most important thing is to have a trustworthy domestic worker. What happens inside the house should remain inside the house."

Aarti said naturally:

"Savita has been with us for five years. She is like one of our own."

Savita's steps slowed for a moment.

"Like one of our own."

It was praise.

But she heard the word "like" clearly.

She set down the tea and returned to the kitchen.

That evening, after everyone had left, Aarti was tired.

Savita was clearing the table.

At one corner of the new curtain was a small greasy fingerprint.

Aarti said:

"Oh! The new curtain!"

Savita took a damp cloth and began rubbing the stain gently.

Aarti came and sat nearby.

"How did you put the curtain up at your house?"

"I cut it in half."

"You cut it?" Aarti was surprised.

"Our doorway is small."

Aarti remained silent for a moment, then laughed.

"I had imagined the whole thing hanging there."

"If I had hung it whole, the doorway would have disappeared."

They both laughed.

Then, without having planned to say it, Savita said:

"A curtain isn't only for looking beautiful."

Aarti looked at her.

Savita kept moving the cloth over the stain.

"How much to open, how much to cover, where the air should come from - all that is different in every house."

Aarti did not reply.

She only looked at the folds of the curtain.

The next day Aarti again began taking photographs of the new curtain.

This time Savita was cleaning the window.

Again her hand entered the edge of the picture.

Aarti lowered the phone.

"Wait," Savita said. "I'll move."

Aarti said:

“No. Stay.”

In the photograph there was the curtain,
sunlight,

Savita's hand on the glass,
and half her face, blurred behind the sheer fabric.

Aarti looked at the picture.

This time she did not take another.

Savita finished her work and left.

When she reached home, Pooja was loosening the knot in the brown curtain.

A strong wind was coming in from outside.

“Shall I open it all the way?” Pooja asked.

Savita said:

“As much as the air needs.”

Pooja pulled the curtain halfway aside.

Sunlight fell across the floor in a rectangle.

The sounds of the lane came in.

From outside, the room was still not fully visible.

Savita sat down beside the doorway.

For the first time she felt:

to give privacy and to make someone invisible are not the same thing.

A home's privacy is not made by cloth alone.

It is also made by deciding:

who will be seen,

who will do the seeing,

and whose presence will not be removed from the picture.

The wind rose.

The brown curtain billowed inward, then moved out again.

Savita reached out no hand to stop it.

Fragrance

Neelima Jha did not like fragrance.

At least, that was what she believed.

Living in a small flat in Delhi, she chose soap, oil, incense, laundry liquid - everything - without any strong scent.

Sometimes, before leaving for the office, she would open the cupboard and look at the bottles there, then withdraw her hand without touching any of them.

One day, on her birthday, her colleague Tanushree gave her a small bottle.

The bottle was transparent, with a pale golden liquid inside.

"It isn't very strong," Tanushree said. "It isn't exactly floral either. Something green, something like wet earth, something woody."

Neelima laughed.

"Does describing a smell always sound like poetry?"

"Put it on. Then you'll understand."

That evening Neelima opened the bottle.

She put one drop on her wrist.

At first there was something sharp.

Then something faintly sweet.

And then, suddenly, something rose from within the fragrance and carried her out of the room.

She was no longer in her flat.

She was in the rear courtyard of the old house in Pipra, where at three in the afternoon the sunlight crossed the tulsi platform and climbed the left-hand wall, while her mother spread paddy out to dry.

The memory did not arrive first as a picture.

The smell came first:

a damp sari,

wood heated by the sun,

raw mango leaves,

and, somewhere in the distance, the smoke of burning cow-dung cakes.

Neelima lifted her wrist to her nose and smelled it again.

"How can this smell like the village?" she asked herself.

The name written on the bottle told her nothing.

She thought of searching online for its ingredients.

Then she placed the phone back on the table.

She was afraid that a scientific list might shut the secret door of memory.

The next day at the office, Tanushree asked:

"How was it?"

Neelima thought for a few moments.

"Like something that cannot be named."

Tanushree laughed.
 "Then it was the right gift."
 For several days Neelima did not touch the bottle.
 Then, one Sunday afternoon, when she was alone at home, she put on another drop.
 This time the memory changed.
 She saw not her mother, but her Mausi.
 A summer-holiday afternoon.
 All the children asleep inside.
 Mausi washing her hair at the courtyard tap.
 Soapnut water, mustard oil, sunlight, and the dampness of the raw wall mixed into a strange smell.
 Neelima was nine years old then.
 She sat in the shade of the tiled roof drawing a house on paper.
 Mausi had asked:
 "When you grow up, where will you live?"
 Neelima had answered:
 "In this house."
 Mausi had laughed.
 "All children say that."
 Now, thirty years later, Neelima did not remember the sound of that laugh.
 She remembered only the smell of that afternoon.
 She looked at her wrist.
 Nothing on the skin had changed.
 Yet inside her, an old sentence had opened:
 "In this house."
 It had been many years since Neelima had been to Pipra.
 She had never married.
 Changing jobs had eventually brought her to Delhi.
 Her mother now lived in Darbhanga with Neelima's younger brother.
 The house in Pipra remained closed.
 Sometimes an uncle opened it with the key and checked on it.
 That night Neelima telephoned her mother.
 "Ma, did Mausi ever wash her hair with soapnut at the Pipra house?"
 Her mother was silent.
 "Why have you suddenly remembered that?"
 "I smelled something."
 "What smell?"
 Neelima began to describe it.
 After two sentences she realised she was not succeeding.
 Her mother said:
 "Your Mausi didn't use soapnut. She kept shikakai. And she put fenugreek in mustard oil."
 "I remember soapnut."
 "Memory does not keep everything exactly right."
 The remark seemed ordinary.

Yet it stung a little.
Could a smell that felt so clear still be wrong?

The following week Neelima did not wear the fragrance to the office.
It had begun to feel private.
One evening, while returning by Metro, she caught a similar scent from the shawl of the woman sitting beside her.
Neelima became immediately alert.
She waited for herself to be transported again to Pipra.
Nothing happened.
She remained only in the Metro carriage:
the metal pole,
the glow of mobile screens,
tired faces.
That night Neelima understood:
scent alone does not unlock memory.
Perhaps time, mood, bodily fatigue, and expectation are also part of the latch.
After that she began making small experiments with the fragrance.
One drop in the morning:
nothing.
On a rainy day:
the veranda of her old school.
Late at night:
a wedding pavilion she had previously forgotten.
One day:
only the office lift.
Another day:
her mother's wardrobe.
She thought of writing notes.
Then stopped.
She was afraid that once the memory was written down, it would separate from the smell.

A few months later her mother fell ill.
Neelima went to Darbhanga.
The hospital room smelled of medicine, phenyl, boiled milk, and old sheets.
Her mother was recovering.
One afternoon Neelima sat by the window.
Her mother noticed the bottle in her bag.
"What is that?"
"Fragrance."
"You wear it?"
"Sometimes."
Her mother held out her hand.

Neelima placed a drop on her wrist.
Her mother closed her eyes.
Neelima waited.
“What did you remember?”
Her mother opened her eyes.
“Nothing in particular.”
Neelima felt disappointed.
Her mother smelled her wrist again.
“Wait... something like wood.”
“The Pipra house?”
“No.” Her mother laughed. “Your Nana’s old trunk. He kept woollen clothes in it.”
Neelima fell silent.
The same fragrance was opening a different house inside her mother.
“You didn’t remember Mausi’s shikakai?”
Her mother looked at her.
“You are in a great hurry to find your own memory inside me.”
The sentence was not harsh.
Even so, Neelima understood the impatience in her question.

After her mother was discharged from hospital, they decided to go together to Pipra.
When the house was opened, there was dust inside, closed rooms, papers gnawed by mice, and the smell of old wood.
Neelima first went to the rear courtyard.
The tulsi platform was half broken.
The tap was gone.
Tin had replaced the old tiled roof.
The wall that used to receive the afternoon sun now lay in the shadow of a neighbour’s new house.
Neelima took the bottle from her bag.
Her mother called from a distance:
“You’ll put that on here too?”
“Let’s see.”
One drop.
Neelima closed her eyes.
First came the scent from the bottle.
Then dust.
Then the dampness of the closed house.
Then smoke from cow-dung cakes drifting in from outside.
But the old afternoon did not come.
Neelima opened her eyes.
She felt more relief than surprise.
Her mother was squatting near the tulsi platform, scratching at the soil.
“Your Mausi didn’t plant tulsi here,” she said suddenly. “I planted this later.”

Neelima laughed.

"I always remembered it as Mausī's."

"See?"

"Yes."

For a while both remained silent.

By evening they had opened the windows.

Dust rose.

Old boxes were brought outside.

When one trunk was opened, her mother really did pull out a woollen shawl.

"Does this smell like Nana's trunk?" Neelima asked.

Her mother lifted the shawl to her nose.

"No. Now it smells only like old cloth."

Neelima closed the lid of the fragrance bottle.

That night she slept in the Pipra house.

The electricity came and went.

The sound of crickets entered through the window.

At dawn, without applying the fragrance, she went into the courtyard.

The earth was damp with the night's dew.

Leaves had fallen from the neighbour's neem.

In the distance someone was lighting a stove.

At that moment a smell rose:

not from the bottle,

not exactly from the old memory either.

It was the smell of the village as it was now.

Neelima took a deep breath.

She understood that for a long time she had been using fragrance to demand that the past return exactly as it had been.

But memory is not a house whose key can be kept in a bottle.

Each time, it is made anew with the body of the present and the time of the present.

After she returned to Delhi, the bottle remained in the cupboard.

Neelima did not throw it away.

But she did not wear it every day either.

Sometimes, on a rainy day, she opened the cap.

Sometimes she only looked at it.

One afternoon Tanushree asked again:

"Do you still have that gift?"

"I do."

"Does it still remind you of the village?"

Neelima thought for a few moments.

"Sometimes the village. Sometimes the hospital. Sometimes nothing at all."

"So the fragrance changed?"

“Perhaps I changed.”

That evening, when she reached home, she opened the window.

It had rained outside.

The smell of wet concrete, neem leaves, and ginger from a distant tea stall entered together.

Neelima looked toward the bottle.

She did not reach for it.

That day, the fragrance of the present was enough.

The Silver Bowl

The silver bowls always stayed in the upper kitchen cupboard - the place where the plates, glasses, and bowls used every day never reached.

Manjari Devi took them out only when guests were coming.

A delicate vine-and-leaf pattern was engraved around each rim, with a small flower in the centre. Years of use had dimmed the shine inside a little, but from the outside they still looked bright.

This time Manjari's elder sister-in-law's daughter, Neelakshi, was coming with her husband and two children.

As soon as the news came over the phone, Manjari first checked the bedding, then the kitchen.

"Take down the silver set from the top shelf," she told her daughter-in-law, Sumedha.

Sumedha pulled over a chair and climbed up.

There were five bowls.

One had a faint tarnish.

"Why has this one gone dark?"

"It hasn't been used for a long time," Manjari said. "Leave it. I'll polish it."

Sumedha was surprised.

"You?"

"Things like these are not given into the maid's hands."

It was an ordinary sentence, one that had been said many times in the house.

But this time a question rose in Sumedha:

Why not?

Manjari sat down with lemon, ash, and a fine cloth.

As she polished the bowl, her fingers kept moving over the engraving.

"Where did these come from?" Sumedha asked.

"From my wedding."

"From your parental home?"

Manjari was silent for a moment.

"Yes... they were among the things sent from there."

Sumedha accepted the answer and turned away.

But Manjari's fingers stopped.

The bowl was not only part of her wedding things.

The first memory attached to it was not of her wedding at all.

It was of her mother's kitchen.

Manjari had been twelve.

Special guests were expected at the house.

Her mother, Sarla Devi, sat polishing four silver bowls with ash.

Manjari sat beside her and watched.

"Why don't we use these every day?" she had asked.
Her mother laughed.
"If we use them every day, what will remain special?"
"Special for whom?"
Her mother had not answered.
In memory, her mother's hands were perfectly clear:
ash along the edges of her nails,
lemon juice in the lines of her palms,
old red bangles at her wrist.
At the time of Manjari's wedding, when the trunks were opened, two of those four bowls were among the things sent with her.
Later, her mother bought two more and sent them.
The fifth bowl appeared much later, after Sarla Devi's death, when the old house was being emptied.
The bowl Manjari was polishing now was that fifth one.
The flower on it was slightly crooked.
Her mother used to say:
"The artisan's hand must have slipped."
Manjari had always thought that crooked flower made the fifth bowl the most beautiful of them all.

The guests arrived.
Neelakshi sat in the drawing room with the children.
Sumedha made tea.
Manjari brought in makhana, cashews, and raisins in the silver bowls.
Neelakshi recognised them at once.
"There were bowls like these at Nani's house!"
Manjari smiled.
"They are from that very house."
"Really?"
Neelakshi took one in her hand.
"I remember Nani saying half her life had gone in making these things shine."
Everyone laughed.
Manjari laughed too.
But one phrase remained caught inside the laughter:
half her life.

After lunch, Sumedha began gathering the bowls.
The household helper, Parvati, was washing dishes by the sink.
"Give these to me," Manjari said.
Parvati wiped her hands and stepped back.
She knew that she did not wash the silver things.
Manjari set the five bowls apart.
"Maaji," Sumedha asked, "why can't Parvati Didi wash them?"

Manjari answered at once:

“What if something like this gets lost?”

The moment the sentence left her mouth, her own voice sounded hard to her.

Parvati's back was turned.

Sumedha said nothing.

Manjari lifted one of the bowls.

It was not heavy.

Then why did the responsibility feel so heavy?

That night, after the guests had gone to sleep, Manjari was alone in the kitchen.

The silver bowls stood upside down on the table.

She dried them one by one with a cloth.

Five bowls.

Five slightly different kinds of shine.

Suddenly she remembered that her mother too had never trusted the maid to polish them.

But had that distrust been only fear of theft?

Or because of the value of the things?

Or because caring for them had simply been assigned as one of the special responsibilities of the woman of the house?

Manjari remembered many afternoons of childhood:

her mother opening a trunk,

taking out cloth,

polishing silver,

wrapping everything again,

putting it all back.

The men of the house probably did not even know where the bowls were kept.

By looking after the “valuable things of the house,” a woman herself became their guard.

The next morning, while drinking tea, Neelakshi said:

“Mausi, I loved these bowls when I was little.”

“Take one with you,” Manjari said.

Neelakshi laughed.

“No, no. Your set will be broken.”

“So what if the set breaks?”

Neelakshi looked at her.

“You are saying that?”

Manjari laughed herself.

“I am surprised too.”

She placed the fifth bowl - the one with the crooked flower - in Neelakshi's hand.

“This was Nani's?”

“Yes.”

“Then you should keep it.”

Manjari said:

“Keeping something does not only mean locking it in a cupboard.”

Neelakshi turned the bowl in her hand.

“Then I’ll use it.”

“Do.”

After Neelakshi left, four bowls remained in the cupboard.

The empty space was clearly visible.

Sumedha looked up and said:

“The set is broken.”

Manjari replied:

“Perhaps now the things will begin to live.”

They both laughed.

A few days later Sumedha’s friend came to the house.

Sumedha was taking out ordinary glass bowls.

Manjari said:

“Bring down the silver ones.”

“On such an ordinary day?”

“On an ordinary day.”

All four bowls came down.

This time Manjari said to Parvati:

“Will you wash them?”

Parvati looked at her face for a moment.

“Me?”

“Yes. Just don’t use a harsh scrubber.”

Parvati laughed.

“I’ve been watching these rules for so many years. They changed today?”

A faint embarrassment rose in Manjari.

“Some rules change late.”

Parvati took the bowl.

Silver gleamed beneath the running water.

Manjari watched from a distance.

It did not feel as though she was doing someone a favour.

She was only putting down the weight of an old distrust whose reason, perhaps, had never been properly examined.

That week Neelakshi sent a photograph of the bowl.

Her two-year-old daughter was eating curd from it.

Curd smeared the rim.

A spoon lay inside.

The crooked flower was half-covered.

Neelakshi had written:

“Nani’s bowl is now part of breakfast every day.”

Manjari looked at the photograph for a long time.

Her first thought was:
Such a valuable thing in a child's hands?
Immediately another thought followed:
Then whom had it been made for?
She opened the cupboard.
The four remaining bowls sat at slightly different heights.
Now they looked less like a "set" and more like four independent objects.
Manjari took one out and served herself curd in it.
When Sumedha entered the kitchen, she stopped.
"Maaji, you in a silver bowl?"
"I'm eating curd."
"I can see that."
Manjari smiled.
In the bowl's shine she saw her mother's hands again:
ash,
lemon,
red bangles.
But this time her mother did not seem only to be polishing.
It was as though she had placed the bowl on the table and was saying:
Now use it.
Manjari ate the curd slowly.
The bowl was on the table.
The cupboard was closed.

Drying Her Hair

After the rain stopped, the air on the rooftop suddenly cleared. The last drops of water were still falling from the tin awning, and to the east sunlight emerged through a break in the clouds.

Kiran and Mrinalini, two sisters, came up to the roof after washing their hair and sat down with it loose and wet.

Kiran, the younger, was twenty-six. Mrinalini was five years older.

They had grown up in the same house, yet even the way they dried their hair was different.

Mrinalini rubbed her hair vigorously with a towel, divided it into two sections, and let them fall down her back. Kiran first worked the tangles loose with her fingers, then spread her hair in the sun, as though separating it leaf by leaf.

"Why do you still keep your hair so long?" Mrinalini asked.

Kiran said, "Why should I cut it?"

"It takes time."

"Does the hair take time, or do I give it time?"

Mrinalini laughed. "Still the same old thing."

"The same old thing" was an old shorthand between them. Whenever Kiran heard anyone offer advice, she would ask questions at once—why? Who said so? What is necessary? At first Mrinalini would exhaust herself answering; later she had learnt simply to smile and say, the same old thing.

Down in the courtyard, their mother was talking about Kiran's marriage. A proposal had come from a bank employee in Darbhanga. Everyone at home was pleased.

Kiran had still said neither yes nor no.

Mrinalini had come to her mother's house two days earlier. She had been married for six years.

"Mother says the man is good," Mrinalini said softly.

"Good in what way?"

"He has a job. The family owns its house. It is a small family."

Kiran ran her fingers over the ends of her hair. "Those are details about the household. Where are the details about the person?"

Mrinalini did not answer. The wind strengthened. Her wet hair stuck to her cheek.

"Did you say yes on the very first day?" Kiran asked.

Mrinalini said, "My time was different."

"How different could it have been six years ago?"

"Very."

They both fell silent.

An old clothesline was stretched across the roof. Their mother's dhoti, two towels and a blue salwar were drying on it. Each time the wind rose, the clothes billowed out, then sagged again.

Mrinalini looked towards a neighbour's roof in the distance. "It is true, I said yes quickly. But at the time I thought—the house will change, life will open up."

Kiran looked at her.

"Did it open?"

Mrinalini smiled, but the smile did not reach her eyes. "Some things opened. Some closed. Not every marriage is the same."

Kiran asked, "Yours?"

"Mine does not have a single answer either."

The sentence was unexpected. At home, Mrinalini always spoke easily about her marriage—her husband Vineet's job, her daughter Aarohi's school, her mother-in-law's knees, the new refrigerator, the old car.

For the first time Kiran understood that the daily news of a life and the meaning of that life were not the same thing.

Parting her hair down the middle, Mrinalini said, "Do you think freedom lies only in not marrying?"

"No."

"Then?"

Kiran thought for a while. "Perhaps in accepting the consequences of your own decision as your own."

"That sentence sounds like a book."

"Perhaps."

"Life is not a book."

"Which is why it is harder to read."

They both laughed again.

Their mother called from below, "The sun is out. Put the jars of mango pickle upstairs."

Kiran got up. So did Mrinalini. Together they set four jars on the roof. Their hair clung wetly to their backs.

Their mother came upstairs. Seeing both daughters with their hair loose, she said, "The sun will grow strong. Come inside. You will get headaches."

Kiran said, "Let it dry a little."

Their mother looked at Mrinalini. "You make her understand. The boy's family want to come on Sunday."

In an even voice Mrinalini said, "Let Kiran first understand what she wants. What am I supposed to make her understand before that?"

Their mother stopped short. For a moment displeasure crossed her face, followed by weariness.

"Do we want something bad for you?"

Kiran said at once, "No one said that, Mother."

Their mother checked the lids of the jars and went downstairs.

Mrinalini said softly, "You see? This is called a conversation, but in a family a question turns into an accusation very quickly."

Kiran said, "But just now you took my side."

"I did not take a side. I only made room for time."

"Is there a difference?"

"A great deal."

Kiran looked closely at Mrinalini. Parts of her hair had already dried; the lower ends were still wet.

"Did you ask for time before your marriage?"

Tracing a small line in the water on the rooftop floor with one finger, Mrinalini said, "No. Perhaps I did not know the language in which to ask."

The wind rose again. From far away came the sound of a temple bell and a rickshaw horn together.

Kiran asked quietly, "If you had known that language, would you not have said yes?"

Mrinalini was silent for a long time.

"If that question were easy to answer, life would be easy."

"Then Vineet-ji?"

"He is not a bad man."

"That was not what I asked."

Mrinalini did not laugh. "I understood."

She drew her hair forward and studied its ends. "I love Vineet. But sometimes I think the order of love and choice was reversed. The choice came first; I learnt love afterwards."

Kiran said nothing.

"Is that wrong?" Mrinalini asked.

"How would I know?"

"The right answer."

In the courtyard below, Aarohi, Mrinalini's five-year-old daughter, was sailing a plastic boat in a puddle. Looking up, she shouted, "Mummy! Is your hair dry?"

Bending over the parapet, Mrinalini called back, "Half!"

Aarohi laughed and ran away.

Kiran said, "What do you want for Aarohi?"

Without thinking, Mrinalini said, "That she should stand on her own feet."

"That is all?"

"No. I want her to recognise her 'no' early. And her 'yes' as well."

"Did you not recognise your own 'yes'?"

"I mistook my family's 'yes' for my own. Later I searched for my own voice inside it."

Kiran's expression softened.

"You have never said anything like this before."

"When did you ever ask before?"

Kiran was about to protest, then stopped. Perhaps it was true.

The sisters had shared so much—clothes, books, memories of school, their mother's habits, their father's anger, stories about the neighbours—yet they had never spoken of the loneliness inside marriage.

Kiran felt that sisterhood, too, could sometimes be very close on the surface and still remain unfamiliar within.

Mrinalini said, "Do you want to meet the man?"

"I am not against meeting him."

"Then meet him."

"Everyone will take that to mean I am ready to decide."

"Meeting is not a decision."

"In this house?"

Mrinalini burst out laughing. "In this house even drinking tea can be taken as a decision."

They both laughed again.

Kiran said, "I want to meet him alone."

"Say so."

"Will Mother agree?"

"Perhaps not."

"Then?"

"Talk to her."

"Will you stay with me?"

Mrinalini looked at her. "If you need support, I will. If all you need is courage, perhaps it would be better for me to stay away."

Kiran raised her eyebrows.

"That is a very difficult answer."

"Making speeches about freedom is easy; giving it space is difficult."

The roof was beginning to grow hot. They shifted into the shade.

Suddenly Mrinalini caught hold of a thick lock of her hair. "You know, after I married I cut my hair."

"I remember. Everyone said—you have become very modern."

"The real reason was time. Aarohi had not even been born then, but there was still the house, work, travel—half an hour spent drying my hair began to feel like a burden."

"Did you regret it?"

"No. Later I grew it again, because one day I understood that cutting it was not freedom, and growing it was not bondage either. The question was: whose decision was it?"

Kiran looked at her own wet hair.

"So if I keep my hair long, I am free?"

"If that is what you want, yes."

"And if I cut it?"

"Then too."

"That is a very convenient philosophy."

"Any philosophy useful for living ought to be a little convenient."

The sky was almost clear now.

Mrinalini tossed her hair back again. The ends of Kiran's hair were still damp.

"The boy's family will come on Sunday," Kiran said.

"What will you do?"

"First I will tell Mother—I will meet him, but I want to speak to him alone."

"Good."

"And if she does not agree?"

"Then decide where your boundary lies."

"You cannot tell me?"

"No. If I tell you that, then I too will be doing what everyone else does—deciding in your place."

Kiran was silent for a while, then said, "You have changed a great deal."

Looking into the distance, Mrinalini said, "Perhaps I was always like this. I just never found the time to say it."

Aarohi called again from below, "Mummy! Now?"

Mrinalini touched her hair. "Almost!"

Kiran laughed.

That evening the conversation with their mother was difficult. Voices rose and fell. Their mother said, "In our time such things did not happen." Kiran replied, "My time is now."

Mrinalini stayed there, but intervened only once: "Let her finish what she is saying."

In the end their mother agreed that Kiran could speak to the man alone in a separate room for twenty minutes, with the door left open.

It did not feel like complete freedom to Kiran, but it felt like more than zero.

They met on Sunday. Abhishek, the prospective groom, turned out to be less formal than she had expected.

Kiran's first question was, "Do you want your wife to give up her job after marriage?"

Abhishek laughed. "No."

Kiran asked her second question. "What if I ever accept a job in another city?"

Abhishek's smile faded a little. "Then we will talk."

Kiran did not entirely like the answer, but it seemed better than false clarity.

After the meeting everyone asked, "What did you understand?"

Kiran said, "Nothing yet."

Disappointment spread through the house, but Mrinalini smiled.

It rained again the next day.

Mrinalini was preparing to leave. Kiran was braiding her hair.

"Will you say yes or no?" Mrinalini asked.

"I do not know yet."

"Good."

"Good?"

"Yes. Not knowing is a state too. There is no need to hurry it into an answer."

Kiran tied the braid and fastened it with an elastic band.

Mrinalini looked at herself in the mirror. "Too tight."

Kiran deliberately loosened it a little.

"Now?"

"Now it is right."

Mrinalini moved towards the stairs.

Kiran remained on the roof. The wind was blowing again. Her hair was half dry, half wet.

She picked up the towel, then put it down again.

The sun went on doing its work.

For the first time, this half-dry state did not seem incomplete to Kiran. It seemed like a whole interval in itself—a place where a decision was still taking shape, but did not need to be wrung out quickly and forced into form.

White Flowers

On the way back from the cremation ground, the first thing Ragini found beautiful was a white flower fallen by the roadside.

She felt ashamed of it at once.

Everyone was walking in silence. Her maternal uncle was in front, two cousins behind him, then her mother, and then Ragini. The sun was sharp, but the sky was clear. A light breeze came from the direction of the river.

Ragini walked with her face lowered, yet the flower's white petals remained caught in her eyes.

She thought: this is not a time to notice beauty.

Aunt Sushma Devi's cremation had ended half an hour earlier.

Ragini had not been very close to her aunt, but neither had she been distant. In childhood, she would spend two weeks of the summer holidays at Sushma Aunt's house. Her aunt would oil her hair, save pages from school notebooks to make little drawings, and arrange earthen flowerpots in the veranda of the house.

The family's stock sentence about Sushma Aunt was: "She was a very quiet woman."

Ragini now found that sentence unbearable.

Why, once someone died, did people compress an entire life into two or three adjectives?

By the time they reached home, the courtyard was full. The women were on one side, the men on the other. Glasses of water, tea, whispers, phone calls, clothes, weeping - everything was going on at once.

Ragini went inside with her mother. Her mother was tired.

"Bring me a little water," her mother said.

Ragini went into the kitchen.

Outside the kitchen window stood a flowerpot. Two white flowers were blooming in it.

Ragini stopped.

Again the same sensation - the flowers were very beautiful.

And again the same guilt.

She looked away.

She brought the water to her mother. After taking a sip, her mother asked, "Does your head hurt?"

"No."

"Then why does your face look like this?"

Ragini did not answer.

People kept arriving throughout the afternoon. Some remembered Sushma Aunt's cooking, some her illness, some the care her husband Kailash Babu had given her, and some the sorrow of her daughter arriving late from abroad.

In each person's memory, Sushma was different.

An elderly neighbour said, "She loved flowers very much."

Ragini looked involuntarily towards the window.

The old woman went on, "She was especially fond of white. She used to say: white is not empty; it is a place for all colours."

The sentence did not sound like her aunt to Ragini. It was too poetic. Perhaps the neighbour was putting it in her own way.

Even so, the sentence stayed inside her.

By evening the crowd had thinned. The house suddenly seemed much emptier.

Ragini was sitting in the veranda. Her aunt's daughter, Nupur, sat in the chair opposite with her eyes closed.

Nupur had arrived by plane the previous night. By now her crying had almost stopped.

Ragini asked softly, "Do you need anything?"

Nupur opened her eyes. "No."

After a while she herself said, "Mummy had stopped looking at flowers in her last month."

Ragini was startled.

"Why?"

"Her body had grown very weak. She no longer went outside. She kept the window curtains closed too. The light hurt her."

Nupur's voice was plain and direct.

"Did Mummy plant the flowers in that pot?" Ragini asked.

"No. The gardener changed them last week. Mummy never even saw them."

Ragini felt an odd relief.

The flowers were not her aunt's final sign. There was no secret message. They were only flowers.

That night the women of the family were preparing to sleep in one room.

Ragini could not sleep.

Her mother lay beside her. In the dark, her voice came: "Ragini?"

"Yes."

"Why aren't you crying?"

At the question, Ragini shrank inwardly.

"I don't know."

"Doesn't your heart feel heavy?"

"It does."

"Then?"

Ragini said quietly, "Ma, I found the flowers beautiful."

Her mother was silent.

"On the way back from the cremation ground. Then again outside the kitchen. I felt as though it was wrong."

Her mother turned onto her side. In the darkness, her face could not be seen clearly.

"If you found them beautiful, why was it wrong?"

"Today?"

"Why not today?"

Ragini searched for an answer.

Her mother said, "Has anyone ever written down the rules of mourning exactly?"

Ragini was surprised. Her mother was counted among the strict observers of rules in the family.

"But you observe every rite."

"Ritual and the mind are not the same thing."

There was silence for a while.

Her mother spoke again. "When your grandfather died, on the way home after the cremation I smelled hot jalebis. I felt hungry. I was so ashamed that I told no one for three days."

For the first time Ragini came close to laughing, but stopped herself.

"Then?"

"Then what? The body does its work. The mind does its own. The two do not always move in the same rhythm."

Ragini lay awake for a long time.

The next morning, preparations for the rites began in the house. The courtyard was washed. White sheets were spread out.

Ragini went to the kitchen window. The two white flowers were still there. Small drops from the night's dew clung to their petals.

This time she did not look away.

She looked carefully at the flowers.

The edges of the petals were not perfectly even. One had a brown spot. The yellow pollen at the centre protruded slightly.

Beauty was not perfection.

Nupur came and stood behind her.

"Did Mummy like flowers like these?" Ragini asked.

Nupur said, "Mummy liked flowers, but not white in particular. She liked orange marigolds more."

Ragini smiled. "The neighbour said white."

"She tells everyone Mummy liked white. Perhaps, to her, white is the colour of mourning, so she has associated it with Aunt."

The two were silent for a while.

Ragini understood again: the living keep choosing colours for the dead.

Some call them quiet. Some self-sacrificing. Some religious. Some flower-loving.

The dead person cannot step in and correct any of it.

"What did Aunt really like?" Ragini asked.

Nupur's face changed.

"Many things. Hot tea. Songs from old films. Marigolds. Drying clothes in the sun after rain. And... laughing at the wrong time."

Ragini liked the last one.

"At the wrong time?"

"Yes. When Baba was scolding me, Mummy would wink at me. I would burst out laughing."

Nupur herself gave a faint laugh.

As soon as the laugh escaped her, guilt crossed her face.

Ragini recognised it at once - the very feeling that had risen in her when she looked at the flowers.

She said, "Laugh."

Nupur looked at her.

"If Mummy were here, she would probably say the same," Ragini added.

Nupur laughed again. This time a little more freely.

Then tears came into both their eyes.

For the first time Ragini understood that laughter and tears were not opposites.

Later in the day Ragini was sent to the market. People were buying garlands for worship from the flower seller.

In front of the shop, white tuberose, marigolds, roses, and jasmine lay in separate heaps.

The flower seller asked, "What would you like?"

Ragini looked at the white flowers for a few moments.

Then she said, "Give me marigolds."

"Yellow or orange?"

"Orange."

She took her aunt's favourite colour home.

At home, her maternal uncle asked, "Weren't there any white ones?"

Ragini said, "There were. But Aunt liked orange."

Her uncle looked at her in surprise for a moment, then said, "All right."

The orange flowers looked very bright against the white sheet.

Perhaps some people found them unusual. No one said anything.

While arranging the flowers, Ragini felt her hands trembling for the first time.

She began to cry.

The tears came suddenly, without prelude.

Her mother came close and placed a hand on her back.

Ragini sat among the flowers and wept.

She no longer felt guilty about the white flowers.

The orange flowers were beautiful.

The weeping was true as well.

Both at the same time.

Thirteen days later, Ragini returned to her own city.

There was a park on the way to her office. Earlier she had passed it every day without looking.

One morning she saw white flowers blooming there.

She did not stop.

But this time she did not look away either.

The flowers were not her aunt.

The flowers were not death.

The flowers were not guilt.

They were simply living things - blooming now, to wither later.

Ragini kept walking.

A few steps later, she remembered an old laugh of her aunt's - no particular incident, only the sound of the laughter.

She smiled.

Then her eyes filled with tears.
This time she pushed neither feeling away.

A Small Party

The house in the city did not look small from the outside, but the party had been called a “small” one.

Madam Riddhima had said, “Only family, two or four friends, that is all.”

By noon, thirty chairs had been arranged in the drawing room.

Fifteen-year-old Sonali had to come to work with her mother that day.

Her mother, Sushila, had been doing the cooking and cleaning in this house for five years.

Sonali normally went to school, but that day the school was closed and Sushila needed an extra pair of hands.

“You will only pick up plates, serve water, and keep an eye on the children,” her mother had said. “Do not go near anything hot in the kitchen.”

Sonali did not like parties, but she was curious to see the house.

The moment the main door opened, the first thing she noticed was the smell - the sweetness of cake, floor cleaner, flowers, and perfume.

Pink and white balloons were tied around the middle of the drawing room. On the wall, in golden letters, were the words: “Seven Years.”

The birthday was that of Madam Riddhima’s daughter, Anvi.

Anvi was eight years younger than Sonali, but her room seemed larger than Sonali’s entire house.

There was a bookcase, toys, boxes of colours, a small table, stars on the wall, and a piano beside the window.

As Sonali set down a jug of water, her gaze became fixed on the piano.

Anvi said at once, “You can touch it.”

Sonali started. “Me?”

“Yes.”

Sonali pressed one white key with a finger. A clear note sounded.

She burst out laughing.

Just then Riddhima came in. “Anvi, get ready. The guests will start arriving.”

Sonali immediately took her hand away.

Riddhima looked at her. “You are Sonali, aren’t you? Sushila’s daughter?”

“Yes.”

“Do you go to school?”

“Ninth class.”

“Very good. Do not give up your studies.”

It was meant as praise, yet to Sonali it sounded as though someone had already assumed that the possibility of her leaving school was greater.

She said, “Yes,” and went out.

The guests began to arrive. The children wore bright clothes. Some brought large gift boxes, some envelopes, some flowers.

Sonali's work increased. Shoes to one side, water to another, empty glasses to collect, snacks to carry out from the kitchen.

One woman asked, "Child, where are the tissues?"

Sonali told her.

Another woman placed an empty plate in her hand and said, "Put this away."

Sonali took the plate.

After a while one child called her "Didi." Another merely pointed a finger towards a glass.

Little by little, Sonali understood that not everyone at the party saw her in the same way.

To some she was Sushila's daughter. To some, the maid. To some, Didi. To some, simply a pair of hands.

In the kitchen, Sushila was wiping away her sweat.

"Tired?" her mother asked.

"No."

"Do not lie."

"A little."

Sushila put two samosas on a small plate. "Eat."

Sonali stood in a corner and began to eat.

Music came from the drawing room.

Anvi and her friends were dancing.

Sonali watched from behind the doorway.

She liked watching them dance. Just then a boy, turning round and round, saw her and said, "You come too."

Riddhima's niece laughed. "She is working."

The boy turned away at once.

It was a small sentence.

Sonali could not decide immediately whether it had hurt her or not.

"She is working" was not untrue.

But the sentence seemed also to decide that dancing did not belong to her share of the afternoon.

When the cake was cut, all the children crowded forward.

The candles went out. There was applause. Photographs were taken.

Riddhima said, "Sushila, give Sonali some cake too."

A beautiful slice came into Sonali's hand, with a pink flower on top.

She began eating it in the kitchen.

Anvi came running in. "Why are you here?"

"I am fine here."

"Eat in the drawing room."

Sonali smiled. "You go to your guests."

Anvi said, "Aren't you a guest?"

Sonali did not answer.

Perhaps Anvi did not fully understand the meaning of her own question either. She ran away again.

Later in the afternoon, when the games began, the children were divided into two teams.

One game required them to be blindfolded and stick a star in the correct place on a picture.

Sonali was moving chairs. Anvi said, "Didi, you play once too."

Riddhima heard from a distance.

For a moment there was hesitation on her face. Then she said, "Yes, go on. Five minutes."

Something tightened inside Sonali. "Five minutes."

She joined the game. A cloth was tied over her eyes.

All the children kept shouting, "Left! Right! Up!"

Laughing, Sonali stuck the star in the wrong place.

Everyone clapped.

For those five minutes she forgot her clothes, the smell of plates on her hands, her mother in the kitchen - everything.

Then, the moment the blindfold came off, Sushila called, "Sonali, fill the water bottles."

She went straight to the kitchen.

The laughter remained behind.

Towards evening the gifts began to be opened.

One box contained expensive coloured pencils. Anvi was delighted.

Sonali watched from a distance. She loved drawing. The art teacher at school had told her the previous month, "You have a good hand. Keep practising."

At home she drew with three short pencils and a half-used box of colours.

Anvi opened the box and took out one pencil. "Didi, look."

Sonali examined its point.

"Very nice."

"Do you draw?"

"A little."

"Draw me."

"Now?"

"Yes."

Sonali laughed. "Let the work finish first."

Anvi put the pencil in her hand. "Keep this."

Sonali returned it at once. "No, it is your present."

"Only one."

Sonali refused again.

Riddhima had been watching the exchange.

After a while she came over to Sonali. "Do you like colours?"

"Yes."

"Anvi gives away a lot of things. Do not feel awkward about taking it."

Sonali said, "It is her present. I will not take it without a reason."

Riddhima was silent for a moment.

"You are right."

The answer brought Sonali relief.

The party began to end. The guests left. Paper, burst balloons, ribbons, pieces of cake, and drops of water lay scattered over the floor.

The house that had been glittering two hours earlier now looked tired.

Sonali picked up a broom. Sushila was gathering the dishes.
 For a while Riddhima too was lifting chairs.
 "There turned out to be a lot of work today," she said.
 Sushila laughed. "It was a small party, after all."
 The two of them laughed.
 Riddhima laughed too.
 For the first time, Sonali understood the joke in the party's name.
 In one corner of the courtyard, the string of a balloon had become caught around a table leg. Sonali bent to free it.
 Just then she found a sheet of paper from one of the children's drawing games.
 Half the page was blank.
 She picked up a pencil and quickly drew a picture - a broom in the middle of the drawing room, two feet moving towards the kitchen, and three balloons floating in the air.
 Anvi looked over her shoulder.
 "What is this?"
 "The party."
 "Where are the people?"
 "They are there."
 Sonali pointed to two small lines beside the broom handle. "That is me."
 Then to another figure near the kitchen door. "That is Mother."
 Anvi studied the picture carefully.
 "Where am I?"
 Sonali drew a little girl beneath one of the balloons.
 Anvi was delighted.
 Riddhima came over as well. She looked at the picture.
 For a few moments no one said anything.
 There was no cake in the picture, no presents, almost no decoration.
 The people who had kept moving behind the glitter of the party were at the centre of the picture.
 Riddhima asked softly, "Will you keep this sheet?"
 Sonali said, "If Anvi does not want it."
 Anvi said at once, "Didi, you keep it. But make me a copy."
 Sonali laughed. "A copy later."
 When it was time to leave, Riddhima paid Sushila extra wages.
 Sushila counted the notes and put them in her bag.
 Then Riddhima turned to Sonali.
 "You worked the whole day too. This is yours."
 She held out a separate envelope.
 Sonali looked at her mother for a moment.
 Sushila said, "Take it."
 Sonali took the envelope.
 There was not enough money in it to change a life. But it was not a "gift."
 It was payment for work.
 Sonali understood the importance of that difference at once.
 On the way home her mother asked, "What will you buy?"

Sonali said, "Colours."

"With all the money?"

"No. I will save half."

When she reached home she looked at the party picture again.

It seemed incomplete.

The next day she opened her old coloured pencils from school and sat down to work.

The balloons became red, yellow, blue.

The kitchen door brown.

The broom a pale black.

Her mother's sari green.

Her own kurta blue.

She had not drawn the cake.

After a while she thought the party would seem wrong without it.

So she drew a tiny cake in one corner - so small that one had to look carefully to see it.

When the picture was finished, she understood that the glitter had not disappeared.

Only its place had changed.

The balloons were still bright, but so were her mother's hands.

The lamp was still luminous, but so was the water spilled on the floor.

Anvi's clothes were colourful, but the figure of Sonali holding the broom had not been left outside the picture either.

Beneath the picture she wrote the title: "A Small Party."

Then, after thinking for a moment, she drew a fine line beneath the word "Small."

She understood that the size of a thing is not measured only by the room, the number of guests, or the expense.

Sometimes the people who look small in the picture are the very ones who make the whole scene possible.

The Silken Scarf

The scarf was a pale violet, and whenever sunlight fell upon it, its colour seemed blue one moment and pink the next.

Sudha had not gone to the market intending to buy it.

She was merely looking at fabrics when the shopkeeper opened the scarf and spread it across the counter.

Tiny silver dots lay over the silk, like stars very far away in the night.

"It will look good on you," the shopkeeper said.

Sudha laughed. "Do you say that to every customer?"

"This colour does not suit everyone."

Sudha took the scarf in her hands. The fabric slipped through her fingers.

She bought it.

When she reached home, she hung the scarf inside the wardrobe. For three days she did not wear it.

On the fourth day there was the school's annual seminar. Sudha taught history at a higher secondary school. She normally wore cotton saris, plain sandals, and her hair tied back.

That day, after putting on her sari, she draped the scarf over her shoulder - merely to see how it looked.

Standing before the mirror, she was silent for a while.

The face was the same.

The same fine fatigue around the eyes.

The grey at the edges of her hair was the same too.

Yet the silken scarf seemed to change the whole figure.

Sudha took the scarf off, then put it on again.

Its sheen did not make her look younger; on the contrary, it seemed to show her present age more clearly.

She thought - perhaps I will wear it today.

As soon as she reached school, her colleague Meena said, "Oh! You are very dressed up today."

Sudha smiled.

"Does it look good?"

"Very."

Another teacher, Renu, said, "For a moment I thought some new madam had joined us."

Everyone laughed.

Sudha laughed too.

Until the seminar began, the scarf continued to give her pleasure.

The hall was filled with students, teachers, and parents. There was a lamp on the stage, flowers, posters.

Sudha was to conduct one of the sessions.

As she walked towards the microphone, the end of the scarf caught on a chair.

She laughed and freed it.

The session went well. During the questions and answers she was at ease.

A student asked a difficult question about the history syllabus. As Sudha answered, she grew animated. Her voice strengthened, her hands opened in gesture, her face came alive.

When the session ended, the principal said, "Very well conducted."

Sudha thanked him.

At that moment she had forgotten the scarf altogether.

At afternoon tea the teachers were sitting together.

Meena's husband had also come as a guest.

Looking at Sudha, he said, "Doesn't this colour look a little too young on you?"

The sentence was spoken as a joke.

Two people nearby laughed.

Sudha gave a small laugh too.

"Too young?"

"Oh, I mean... it is a bright colour, isn't it? You are usually so simple and restrained."

He used that English word so casually, as though he were correcting the compliment.

Sudha looked down at her cup of tea.

The silken scarf suddenly felt heavy on her shoulder.

She drew one end of it forward.

Then she thought - is it too bright?

Tea ended.

Sudha went to the mirror in the washroom.

Now the same scarf looked different in that mirror.

The colour that, a few moments earlier, had seemed to open her face now looked like an effort laid over it.

"Too young."

The words sounded again inside her.

Sudha thought of taking the scarf off.

Then of putting it in her bag.

Then she grew irritated with herself.

Why should one person's comment have so much power?

But asking the question did not make its effect disappear at once.

She adjusted the scarf and went back into the hall.

For the rest of the programme she spoke less.

On the bus home, the scarf lay in her lap.

Sunlight entered through the window. Its colour kept changing between blue and pink.

Sudha watched it.

When she reached home, she opened the wardrobe.

She hung the scarf inside.

She did not wear it the next day.

Or the day after that.

A week later her mother asked on the phone, "Did the seminar go well?"

Sudha told her about the programme.

Not about the scarf.

That night, while putting away clothes, she saw it again.

She reached out and touched it.

The fabric was still just as light.

Only the memory was heavy.

The following Sunday, Sudha's daughter Ishani came home. She worked in Bengaluru.

While opening the wardrobe, her eyes fell on the scarf.

"Ma, is this new?"

"Yes."

"Why don't you wear it?"

"No reason."

Ishani took out the scarf and put it around her own shoulders.

"It is beautiful."

Sudha said, "Shall I give it to you?"

Ishani asked at once, "Don't you like it?"

Sudha fell silent.

"I do."

"Then?"

"Nothing."

Ishani turned before the mirror, then put the scarf back on her mother's shoulder.

"It is yours."

Sudha laughed. "How can you be so sure?"

"Because you bought it."

"Are buying something and making it your own the same thing?"

Ishani looked at her mother's face.

"Did someone say something?"

Sudha was surprised.

"Why?"

"You become this philosophical about clothes only when someone has made a comment."

Sudha burst out laughing.

Then she told her the whole story.

When she had heard it, Ishani did not speak at once.

Sudha liked that.

After a little while her daughter asked, "Before that comment, did you like the scarf?"

"Yes."

"And after the comment?"

"No... I mean, I still do, but..."

"But you stopped looking with your own eyes and began looking through his?"

Sudha looked at her daughter.

"Isn't that too simple a conclusion?"

"Perhaps."

Sudha held the scarf up before the mirror again.

Ishani stood behind her.

"Do you truly like it?"

"Ma, you are asking for my eyes again."

Sudha was silent.

Ishani smiled. "Give your own answer first."

She left the room.

Sudha remained alone before the mirror.

For a long time she looked at her face.

The lines.

The greying hair.

The slight looseness of the skin below her chin.

The gleam of the scarf.

Suddenly she understood - the problem was not whether the scarf made her look young or not.

The problem was that "looking young" could be turned by someone into praise, and by someone else into an accusation.

She asked herself - what do I see?

The answer did not come at once.

That evening she was to go to the market with Ishani.

Sudha put on the scarf.

As they stepped out, her daughter said nothing.

Even that silence felt like a form of respect.

At a shop, a woman saw Sudha's scarf and asked, "Where did you get it?"

Sudha told her the name of the shop.

The woman said, "The colour is beautiful."

Sudha thanked her.

The compliment did not greatly increase her confidence.

She liked that too.

On the way home her daughter asked, "How did it feel today?"

Sudha said, "Like a piece of cloth."

"That is all?"

"And a little like my own."

A few days later she wore the scarf to school again.

Meena said, "The beautiful one again!"

Sudha laughed.

That male colleague who had made the comment was there too.

He glanced at it once but said nothing.

Sudha did not try to examine whether she felt relieved.

While she was teaching, one end of the scarf brushed against the chalkboard and turned white.

The students laughed.

Sudha laughed too.

She brushed it off.

The pale chalk mark did not disappear entirely.

In the evening, while washing the scarf at home, she noticed the mark.

Her first thought was - the silk is ruined.

Then she ran a finger over the place where the stain remained.

The history of this scarf was no longer only the shine of the shop or somebody's comment.

Now it also contained the school stage, the sunlight on the bus, her daughter's silence, the chalk in the classroom - all of it.

The scarf had become a little less pristine, and a little more her own.

Sudha spread it in the shade to dry.

When the breeze touched it, the fabric stirred.

The colour changed again.

Sudha kept watching.

This time she did not need to decide whether she looked young, old, dressed up, or ordinary.

The scarf was beautiful.

And she was present in her own body.

That was enough.

Rain at the Window

The rain began after noon. Scattered drops at first, then a downpour.

Rama stood by the window. Streams of water crossed one another on the glass and ran down. The guava tree opposite bent to one side in the wind, then rose again.

The dal was simmering in the kitchen. There was still time before the stove needed to be turned off.

From behind her came Arvind's voice. "Will there be tea?"

The question was ordinary.

So ordinary that on any other day Rama would have said yes and gone into the kitchen.

That day she did not turn at once.

Arvind asked again, "Did you hear me?"

"Yes."

"Then?"

Looking out of the window, Rama said, "You make it."

The room fell silent.

Arvind folded the newspaper. "Me?"

"Yes, you."

There was no anger in the sentence. Perhaps that made it more uncomfortable.

Arvind got up. "All right."

As he went towards the kitchen, he asked, "Two cups?"

Rama smiled faintly. "Half the sugar in mine."

Arvind stopped. "You take half the sugar?"

This time Rama turned and looked at him.

"For many years."

For a moment embarrassment crossed Arvind's face.

"I thought you took it without sugar."

"I used to. Now I take half."

"Since when?"

Rama turned back to the window. "Perhaps three years."

The soft sounds of utensils began in the kitchen.

Rama was surprised - three years. Why could she herself not give the exact date?

Perhaps the change had been so small that no one had been told.

Perhaps it had been said, but not heard.

In her mind she began counting all the small things that had changed in the house without anyone keeping an account of them.

Monu had gone to a hostel.

The younger daughter, Diya, had gone to Pune for work.

Her mother's knees had worsened.

Arvind had retired.

Rama's temporary teaching job had ended.
 The house was quieter than before now, yet Rama felt busier inside.
 Arvind came in carrying the tea.
 Two cups.
 One with more sugar, one with less.
 "This is the one with less," he said.
 Rama took the cup.
 The first sip was right.
 She said, "It is good."
 Arvind smiled. "It is not so difficult."
 Rama watched the steam rising from the cup.
 "A lot of things are not difficult. It is just that no one does them."
 Arvind's smile stopped.
 "What do you mean?"
 Rama felt she ought now to give the usual answer - nothing.
 "Nothing" was a very useful sentence in this house.
 But outside, the rain was hard.
 She said, "I mean only that you can make tea."
 "I just did."
 "And I have been making it for thirty years."
 Arvind was silent.
 Rama regretted it at once.
 The sentence had come out like an account being settled, when she did not want to settle accounts.
 "I am not saying that you have done nothing," Rama added.
 "Then what are you saying?"
 The question was so direct that the answer became difficult.
 Rama looked again at the streams of water on the glass.
 "I do not know."
 Arvind too came and stood by the window.
 For a while they watched the rain together.
 Then he asked, "Why do you like rain so much?"
 Rama was surprised.
 "You do not know?"
 Arvind smiled. "Is there a correct answer to a question like that?"
 Rama thought.
 "When I was a child, if it rained, Father would not send me to school. I would sit by the window and read."
 "I see."
 "And Mother would make hot muri."
 "I remember that. You told me once."
 Rama looked at him.
 "When?"
 "A long time ago."
 Rama felt a small happiness.
 Some things had been heard.

Then Arvind asked, "And now?"

"Now what?"

"Why do you like rain now?"

Rama thought for a long time before answering.

"Because when it rains, work outside stops. People stay at home. Time slows a little."

Arvind said, "But you have to stay at home anyway."

The moment the sentence left his mouth, he stopped himself.

Rama's face changed.

"Have to?"

Arvind said quickly, "I meant - now that you do not have a job..."

"I understood."

Rama set down her tea.

Lightning flashed outside.

Rain struck hard against the glass.

Arvind asked softly, "Are you unhappy that you left your job?"

Rama laughed. "Left it? The temporary post ended."

"Yes, but..."

"But I did not try again."

Arvind was silent.

"Why not?"

The question shook Rama inwardly.

Such an ordinary question.

Three words.

Yet behind those three words stood years.

Her son's Class Twelve examinations.

Her daughter's illness.

Her mother-in-law's surgery.

Caring for her mother.

Arvind's transfer.

Moving house.

Then age.

Then the erosion of confidence.

Then: "What is the need now?"

Rama said, "There was no single reason."

"Then?"

"All the little reasons."

"Was I stopping you?"

Rama did not answer at once.

"Not directly."

Arvind looked more uncomfortable.

"Indirectly?"

Rama said, "You used to say: 'How will the house run?' 'What about the children?' 'Mother?' 'You will exhaust yourself.' You never said, 'Do not go.'"

Arvind said quietly, "I was worried."

"I know."

"Then?"

"Sometimes worry becomes a barrier too."

Arvind put a hand on the window frame.

"Are you blaming me?"

Rama said wearily, "I am not talking about blame."

"Then?"

"I am saying that perhaps there were things neither of us understood."

For the first time, Arvind put his cup down.

"What did you need?"

Rama closed her eyes when she heard the question.

Perhaps this was the sentence she had wanted to hear many years earlier.

But the answer was no longer the same now.

"Back then?"

"Yes."

"Back then I needed someone to say: Go, try. We will all manage the house together."

Arvind lowered his eyes.

Rama added, "And I should also have said clearly that I wanted to try. I did not."

"Why not?"

"Perhaps I wanted you to understand without my saying it."

Arvind gave a small laugh, but there was pain in it.

"I failed that examination."

Rama laughed too.

"So did I."

The rain eased a little.

The room began to darken.

Arvind switched on the light.

"And now?"

Rama asked, "What?"

"What do you need now?"

Rama looked out of the window.

Water had collected on the road. A child was running with his slippers in his hands.

For the first time in a long while, Rama thought about her desire in the present tense.

Not what she had wanted.

Not what she had failed to receive.

What did she want now?

"I want to teach again," she said softly.

Arvind was surprised.

"At a school?"

"Not necessarily. Perhaps children at home. Perhaps online. Perhaps a small group for studying history."

She laughed at herself. "I do not know exactly."

Arvind said, "That could be done."

Rama said at once, "See? The same thing again."

“What?”
“You immediately started deciding what was possible.”
Arvind stopped.
“Then what should I say?”
Rama smiled. “First ask what I have been thinking.”
Arvind nodded.
“All right. What have you been thinking?”
Rama burst out laughing.
“You learnt that quickly.”
“I learnt to make tea quickly too.”
They both laughed.
The laughter did not put everything right.
Thirty years of unheard things could not be completely heard in one afternoon.
But at least the direction of the conversation had changed.
The next day it did not rain.
Rama took out an old file: certificates, appointment letters, training papers.
Some had yellowed.
Arvind came into the room, saw them, but did not offer advice at once.
After a few moments he merely asked, “How old are they?”
Rama said, “Very.”
“Still useful?”
“We will see.”
That evening Rama taught history to two children from the neighbourhood.
The first day, without a fee.
By the second week there were four children.
After a month, eight.
Rama began to recover the rhythm of running a class.
Sometimes Arvind set down water; sometimes he arranged the chairs.
One day he asked, “Shall I make tea?”
Checking the children’s notebooks, Rama said, “Yes.”
“Half the sugar?”
Rama looked up.
“You remember?”
“Now I do.”
Rama smiled.
A few weeks later, it rained again.
Rama stood by the window.
The same streams on the glass, the same bending of the tree.
From behind her Arvind called, “Tea?”
Rama turned.
“Will you make it?”
“If you want.”
Rama thought.
“Not today.”
Arvind said, “All right.”
No disappointment.

No “why?”

Rama turned back to the window.

Watching the rain was no longer only a memory of an old longing.

Within it, a small place had opened in the present - a place where someone asked a question, but also left room for the answer.

With her eyes, Rama followed a drop sliding down the glass.

It travelled downward and joined another stream.

Rama thought perhaps marriage was like this - two streams met, but that did not mean one had to forget how far each had flowed separately before they joined.

Outside the window, the rain continued.

Inside, Rama stood quietly.

This time, the silence had been heard.

The Taste of Lemon

The doctor had said that a little lemon could be given to reduce the bitterness in her mouth.

Sandhya cut half a lemon and placed it on a plate. Her mother, Devaki Devi, sat propped against pillows on the bed. The illness was not very serious, but two weeks of fever had left her weak.

“Have a little,” Sandhya said.

Her mother made a face. “It tastes sour.”

“That is why it is a lemon.”

“I don’t want it.”

Sandhya laughed. “The doctor said so.”

At that, her mother fell silent. With a small spoon, Sandhya mixed a little salt into the lemon juice.

“Only this much.”

Devaki Devi opened her mouth.

The moment the juice touched her tongue, her eyes narrowed.

“Very sour.”

Without thinking, Sandhya said, “Don’t turn your face away. Swallow it.”

The words stopped her as soon as they left her mouth.

Her mother used to say the very same thing to her in childhood.

Sandhya had been seven then. After a fever she did not feel like eating anything. Her mother would mix lemon juice, salt, and a little sugar and feed it to her by the spoonful. Sandhya would turn her face away. Her mother would say, “Don’t turn your face away. Swallow it.”

Still holding the spoon, Sandhya looked at her mother’s face for a long time.

Her mother asked, “What happened?”

“Nothing.”

“Why are you staring at me like that?”

“I remembered something.”

“What?”

Sandhya said, “You used to give me lemon just like this.”

Devaki Devi laughed. “I used to give you many things.”

It was an ordinary sentence, but something softened inside Sandhya.

She prepared another spoonful.

Her mother said, “No more.”

“Just one.”

“Have you become a doctor?”

“No. I’m a daughter.”

“A daughter is more difficult than a doctor.”

They both laughed.

Afternoon sunlight came in through the window. Medicines, water, a thermometer, cloths, and lemon lay neatly arranged on the table.

Sandhya had been staying at her mother's house for the past five days. Her husband and son phoned. She would say, "Two more days."

Every day her mother asked, "What about the work at home?"

Sandhya would say, "It's going on."

Then her mother would ask, "What is your son eating?"

"He is twenty-five, Ma."

"Do twenty-five-year-olds not eat?"

Sandhya would laugh in exasperation.

Illness had weakened her mother's body, but not her habits.

In the afternoon her mother slept. Sandhya saw the remaining half of the lemon in the kitchen. Childhood returned to her again.

It had been summer. After an upset stomach, she had stopped eating. Her mother had mixed water, lemon, salt, and sugar in an earthen tumbler and given it to her.

Sandhya had wrinkled her nose at the first sip.

Her mother had said, "If the taste is bad, close your eyes."

"Will closing my eyes change the taste?"

"No, but you'll complain less."

Now Sandhya smiled.

She wondered how often her mother had used laughter like that while caring for her.

To make the fear of a child's illness lighter.

To hide her own exhaustion.

Or perhaps simply so that life could keep moving.

In the evening her mother woke.

Sandhya asked, "Does your mouth still taste bad?"

"A little."

"Lemon?"

Her mother glared at her.

Sandhya laughed.

"All right, no."

A few moments later her mother herself said, "Give me a little."

Sandhya looked at her in surprise.

"What?"

"Lemon. But less salt."

She made the mixture.

Her mother tasted it slowly.

"This time it's all right."

Sandhya felt as happy as if she had passed an examination.

At night her mother said, "You are very tired."

"No."

"Liar."

"A little."

"Go back. I'm fine now."

Sandhya sat down beside the bed.

"Two more days."
 "You have your own home."
 "Then what is this house?"
 Her mother fell silent.
 Then she said, "This too."
 That "too" went deep into Sandhya.
 How many times after marriage had she heard: "Go to your own home," "Take care of your own house," "How many days will you stay here?"
 Her maternal home had slowly become "here."
 Perhaps without thinking, her mother had now said, "This too."
 Sandhya touched her mother's hand. The skin was no longer hot; it felt normal.
 "The fever is down," she said.
 "A doctor by touch?"
 "A daughter."
 "That difficult breed again."
 They both laughed once more.
 The next morning her mother started towards the kitchen herself.
 Sandhya stopped her. "Where are you going?"
 "To make tea."
 "I'll make it."
 "You've been making it for five days."
 "So?"
 "Today I will."
 Sandhya said, "You're weak."
 Her mother stopped.
 "When you were a child, I could go into the kitchen the day after your fever came down, and now I can't?"
 Sandhya had no answer.
 Her mother walked slowly into the kitchen.
 Sandhya followed close behind.
 Her mother lit the gas.
 "Don't guard me so much."
 "What if you fall?"
 "Then catch me."
 Sandhya fell quiet.
 Suddenly she understood that care can sometimes build a wall around the body.
 Her mother needed help, but she also needed the right to do small things for herself.
 Sandhya moved aside.
 Her mother made tea.
 Two cups.
 Handing one to Sandhya, she said, "Less sugar."
 Sandhya laughed. "You remember?"
 "Have I forgotten everything?"
 As she drank her tea, Sandhya remembered the taste of lemon again.

In childhood her mother had known her taste precisely—how much sugar, how much salt, how much lemon.

Now Sandhya was learning her mother's taste.

The reversal was not simple.

Her mother had not become a child.

Sandhya had not become her mother.

Only the direction of care had changed for a while.

In the afternoon Sandhya spoke to her son Aarav on the phone.

He asked, "Is Nani all right?"

"Yes."

"And you?"

Sandhya said, "I am too."

Aarav said, "Don't worry about home."

Sandhya fell silent.

The sentence brought her an unexpected sense of relief.

Perhaps care keeps travelling from one direction to another—from mother to daughter, daughter to mother, son to mother.

No one remains permanently above or below.

In the evening Devaki Devi sat in the veranda. Sandhya was cutting a lemon.

Her mother asked, "Again?"

"You said it tasted all right, remember?"

"I don't feel like it today."

Sandhya stopped the knife.

"All right."

That was all.

Her mother looked at her.

"No forcing today?"

Sandhya smiled. "Today the patient decides."

"Not the patient. Mother."

"All right, Mother."

Both were silent.

The lemon remained half-cut on the table.

In that small decision Sandhya found a strange peace.

Care is not only giving; sometimes it is also stopping.

The next day Sandhya prepared to leave.

Her mother wanted to help fold the clothes.

"You sit."

"Starting again?"

Sandhya laughed. "All right, fold this chunari."

Her mother folded it.

The bag was closed.

At the door her mother said, "Take the lemons. There are too many left."

Sandhya laughed. "You keep them."

"What will I do with so many?"

"Make pickle."

"Will you eat the pickle?"

“Yes.”

Her mother went to the kitchen, brought three lemons, and put them in the bag.

“This is an order,” she said.

Sandhya did not protest.

On the bus home, a faint scent of lemon rose from the bag.

Sandhya closed her eyes.

She remembered the fever of childhood.

Then her mother’s weak hands now.

Then her mother making tea.

Then the half-cut lemon left on the table.

The taste was never one thing.

Sometimes sour.

Sometimes mixed with salt.

Sometimes refused.

Sometimes asked for.

Sandhya understood that memory, too, is like taste. Its proportions change with time.

When she reached home, Aarav opened the bag and saw the lemons.

“What are these?”

“Nani’s orders.”

“What will they become?”

Sandhya said, “We’ll see.”

The next morning she cut one lemon.

A drop of juice touched her finger.

She tasted it.

It was very sour.

Sandhya puckered her mouth and laughed.

This time there was no one to tell her, “Don’t turn your face away. Swallow it.”

By her own choice, she tasted another drop.

The Pink Cup

There were twelve cups in the office kitchen altogether—six white, three blue, two cream-coloured, and one pink.

The pink cup had tiny white dots on it. Its handle was slender, but comfortable to hold.

Madhavi drank her tea from that cup.

No rule said it belonged to her. Her name was not written on it. In the office inventory it was listed simply as “cups—twelve.”

Even so, everyone knew the pink cup was Madhavi’s.

That knowledge was not formal ownership; it was habit.

Every day at ten fifteen Madhavi went to the kitchen, heated water, made herself a light tea, picked up the pink cup, and stood by the window for five minutes.

Those five minutes were the private corner of her day.

She was a project coordinator at the office. All day there were phone calls, meetings, files, emails, deadlines.

During the cup’s five minutes, no one asked anything of her.

One Monday the pink cup was not in its place.

Madhavi first checked the cupboard. Then the sink. Then the dish rack.

No.

She took a white cup.

She made tea.

The taste was the same, but the experience was not.

She laughed at herself.

Could a cup matter this much?

She went back to the meeting.

At eleven, her colleague Nisha came to her desk. The same pink cup was in her hand.

“Madhavi Didi, will you look at this report?”

Madhavi’s eyes caught on the cup rather than the report.

Nisha went on drinking her tea.

“Yes, leave it,” Madhavi said.

Nisha left the file and went away.

Madhavi said nothing.

By afternoon the cup had been washed and returned to the cupboard.

The next day, when Madhavi arrived at ten fifteen, the pink cup was in its place.

She picked it up.

A small relief passed through her.

Then she felt embarrassed by that relief.

Did she have the right to make anything this private in a shared office kitchen?

She filled the cup with tea and stood by the window.

The following week, one day, the cup was missing again.

This time she saw it with Rakesh, the administrative assistant.

Rakesh was drinking coffee from it.

"This is a good cup," he said casually. "The handle is comfortable."

Madhavi smiled. "Yes."

That was all.

A small irritation remained inside her all day.

She knew Rakesh had done nothing wrong. The cup was communal.

Then whom was she irritated with?

Rakesh?

Herself?

The invisible rule that existed only in everyone's habits?

On her way home that evening, Madhavi thought of buying a new cup from the market.

Then she did not.

She realised the issue was not the cup.

Perhaps the issue was that small private space she had silently come to regard as her own.

Even her desk at the office was not entirely private.

The files belonged to everyone.

The computer belonged to the organisation.

The chair could be replaced.

Other people fixed the meeting times.

Emails arrived without warning.

Among all this, perhaps the pink cup was one small thing she had chosen for herself.

On Friday afternoon Nisha took the cup again.

When Madhavi reached the kitchen, Nisha was making tea.

"Nisha," Madhavi said.

"Yes?"

"This cup... I rather like it."

The sentence trailed off.

Nisha immediately looked at the cup.

"Oh! You drink from this every day, don't you?"

"Yes."

"I knew, but I thought perhaps you weren't going to use it today."

Madhavi was surprised.

"You knew?"

"Everyone knows."

"Then why did you take it?"

Nisha laughed. "The cup was empty. I thought—what difference would one day make?"

Madhavi laughed too.

The sentence was simple, but the question lay precisely there.

What difference would one day make?

In truth, not much.

But what if it happened again and again?

She said, "Nothing will happen. But if possible, leave this one for me."

Nisha immediately emptied the cup. "I'll take another today."

Madhavi said, "No, no. Finish it now. Next time."

Nisha laughed. "All right."

The matter ended there.

Madhavi was astonished that it had taken her so many days to say something so small.

The following week the cup began to remain regularly in its place.

One day Rakesh picked up a cream-coloured cup and said, "The pink one is reserved."

Everyone laughed.

Madhavi did too.

But the word "reserved" made her a little uncomfortable.

She did not want a small preference in a shared space to turn into an official entitlement.

She only wanted people to remember.

The distinction was subtle.

One day a new trainee arrived at the office—Sameera.

During her first week she was very quiet.

She took notes in meetings, asked few questions, and ate lunch alone.

On Friday Madhavi went to the kitchen and found Sameera holding the pink cup.

Madhavi stopped.

Sameera immediately said, "Oh, is this yours?"

"There's no name written on it," Madhavi said.

"Nisha Didi said you use this one."

Sameera began to put the cup back.

Madhavi said, "Keep it. Drink from it."

Sameera asked hesitantly, "Are you sure?"

"Yes."

Madhavi made tea in a white cup.

The two of them stood by the window.

After a while Sameera said, "At my old office I had a blue mug. I forgot it on the day I left the job."

"And then?"

"What then? I phoned the next day to ask. Someone said it had been washed and put on the communal rack."

"Did you go and get it?"

"No. It felt strange. Asking for a cup after I had already left the job..."

Madhavi laughed. "Why should asking for a cup feel strange?"

Sameera shrugged. "Perhaps because it was such a small thing."

Madhavi looked at the pink cup.

"Small things are not always small."

Sameera smiled.

That day five minutes became ten.

The following Monday Madhavi brought a new cup in her bag.

It was pale green.
She placed it on the kitchen rack.
Nisha asked, "Whose is this?"
Madhavi said, "Anyone can use it."
"And the pink one?"
Madhavi thought for a moment.
"I like that one."
Everyone laughed.
The matter rested there.
A few weeks later repair work began in the office building.
The kitchen was closed for three days.
Everyone was given paper cups.
On the first day Madhavi took her tea in a paper cup.
The window was closed.
She spent her five minutes sitting at her desk.
The paper cup was hot.
It had to be held differently.
Madhavi remembered the pink cup.
But more than the pink cup, she remembered the five minutes by the window.
Then she understood clearly: the cup was not the private space; it merely marked that space.
The object was a sign. The space was real.
The kitchen reopened.
The pink cup was back on the rack.
Madhavi made tea.
She went to the window.
Outside the window that day, workers were dismantling the scaffolding.
Sameera came in.
She took tea in the green cup.
"This one is nice," she said.
Madhavi smiled. "Keep it."
"Really?"
"Yes. If you like it."
Sameera turned the cup in her hand.
"Should I write my name on it?"
Madhavi said, "If you want."
Sameera took a marker and wrote her name in small letters on the bottom of the cup.
Madhavi watched.
For some reason, she liked the sight.
Someone was marking a boundary clearly.
Not by snatching a right.
Not by yielding through hesitation.
That evening Madhavi looked at the bottom of the pink cup too.
It was blank.
She took the marker in her hand.

She thought for a few moments.
Then she did not write her name.
She put the cup back.
The next day Nisha asked, "You're not writing your name?"
Madhavi said, "There's no need."
"Why?"
"Because now I know how to say what I like."
Nisha laughed. "A great achievement."
Madhavi laughed too.
A few days later the cup appeared in Rakesh's hand again.
Rakesh said at once, "Oh, sorry. I picked it up out of habit."
Madhavi said, "Drink from it."
"Sure?"
"Yes. Give me the green one today."
From a distance Sameera called, "That one is mine!"
Everyone burst out laughing.
Madhavi did too.
She picked up a white cup.
She made tea.
She stood by the window for five minutes.
The cup was white, not pink.
But the space was still hers—not because anyone had kept it safe for her, but because she had learned to claim those five minutes herself.
The next day the pink cup was back in its place.
Madhavi picked it up.
She filled it with tea.
The handle felt comfortable against her fingers.
She smiled.
The cup was still dear to her.
But now, in order to be dear, it no longer needed to stand rigidly as a boundary.

The Scent of Sunlight

Kamala Devi chose a separate day for airing old clothes in the sun.

The sky had to be clear that day, the breeze gentle, and no shadow should fall across the terrace before afternoon.

The family laughed at this rule.

“So much calculation just to dry clothes?” her daughter-in-law would say.

Kamala Devi would smile. “Old clothes do not dry quickly. They carry time inside them.”

That Sunday she opened an old iron trunk.

Inside were folded saris, an odhni, a dupatta, two blouses, and an old shawl.

Some smelled of camphor, others of the dampness of the trunk.

She began spreading the clothes out on the terrace one by one.

The moment a pale purple sari came into her hands, she stopped.

It was Manjari Didi’s sari.

Manjari Didi—her sister, four years older than she was.

It had been twelve years since her death.

Kamala Devi brought the sari to her nose and breathed in.

First, dampness.

Then camphor.

Then something she could not say was truly still present in the cloth—a mingled scent of sunlight, oil, and old soap.

That smell opened an afternoon.

The two sisters were drying clothes in the back courtyard of the large family house.

As she lifted a sari onto the clothesline, Manjari Didi had said, “You want everything quickly.”

Kamala was young then. She had replied, “And you need rules for everything.”

Manjari had laughed.

“Not rules. A method.”

Kamala had answered, “You give rules the name of method.”

A small quarrel had followed.

The quarrel had been minor.

Yet it had remained in memory.

Kamala Devi spread the sari on the terrace.

The sunlight grew stronger.

The purple of the cloth slowly began to look brighter.

Her daughter-in-law came upstairs.

“Maaji, you still keep such an old sari?”

“Yes.”

“But you don’t wear it.”

Kamala Devi said, "Not everything is kept in order to be worn."
 Her daughter-in-law said nothing.
 From downstairs, her granddaughter Aaroahi called, "Dadi! Where's my science notebook?"
 Kamala Devi called back, "On the table."
 Then she looked at the sari again.
 It seemed as though the sunlight were entering the cloth.
 Manjari Didi came back to her mind.
 How long before the end had they last spoken properly?
 Kamala Devi could not remember clearly.
 Didi had been ill. Their phone calls had become fewer.
 Once Didi had said, "You never have time."
 Kamala had replied, "It isn't like that. There is simply too much work at home."
 Didi had laughed. "When has housework ever become less?"
 That day the conversation had ended quickly.
 Now Kamala Devi wondered—had it been a complaint or a joke?
 She could not decide.
 Memory returns again and again to places where meaning was left half-finished.
 By afternoon the wind grew stronger.
 The sari fluttered on the line.
 Kamala Devi hurried over and fixed it with clips.
 One edge flew up and brushed her face.
 She laughed.
 Something like Manjari Didi's voice rose within her: "See? Use clips."
 Kamala Devi said aloud, "Yes, I have."
 Then she fell silent herself.
 There was no one else on the terrace.
 She did not feel embarrassed.
 Later in the afternoon, when the clothes were being turned over, her daughter-in-law came upstairs again.
 "Maaji, is this Didi's sari?"
 "Yes."
 "Your sister's?"
 "Yes."
 "You had never shown it to me."
 Kamala Devi said, "It was in the trunk for many years."
 Her daughter-in-law touched the sari.
 "The cloth is still good."
 Kamala Devi said, "Very good."
 "Then wear it."
 Kamala was startled.
 "Me?"
 "Yes. Why not?"
 Kamala Devi did not answer at once.
 Wearing her sister's sari felt as though it would mean crossing some boundary.
 But who had made that boundary?

Manjari Didi?
The family?
Or Kamala herself?
She brought the sari to her nose again.
Now the smell of sunlight was stronger.
The dampness had faded.
The camphor had almost disappeared.
Suddenly she understood—cloth changes too.
Like memory.
In the evening the sari was brought downstairs.
Before folding it, Kamala Devi placed it over her shoulder and stood before the mirror.

The purple looked strangely beautiful beside her white hair.

Her daughter-in-law stood in the doorway watching.

“Wear it.”

Kamala Devi smiled.

“Not today.”

“Someday?”

“Perhaps.”

She folded the sari again.

This time she did not place it at the bottom of the trunk, but on top.

The following week there was a programme at her granddaughter’s school.

Her daughter-in-law took out the sari and said, “Maaji, today?”

Kamala Devi thought for a few moments.

Then she said yes.

As she put on the sari, she remembered the shape of Manjari Didi’s body.

Didi had been taller than she was.

The pallu fell a little longer.

Kamala Devi fixed it with a pin.

She stood before the mirror.

She did not feel that she had become her sister.

Nor that her sister had returned inside her.

Only that an old piece of cloth was receiving the warmth of a body again.

At the school, no one knew the history of the sari.

Two women said, “What a beautiful colour.”

Kamala Devi thanked them.

That was all.

After returning home, she took off the sari and placed it on a chair.

It no longer smelled of sunlight, but faintly of the body’s perspiration and soap.

Kamala Devi smelled it in surprise.

Manjari Didi’s garment was now carrying the scent of Kamala’s day.

At first she could not tell whether this brought grief or peace.

Then, slowly, peace became stronger.

She spread the sari in the sun again.

Her daughter-in-law asked, “Again now?”

Kamala Devi said, “It was worn today. Let it have some air.”

The sari lay spread on the terrace.
Sunlight fell upon it.
Kamala Devi placed a chair beside the clothesline and sat down.
She remembered the quarrel with Manjari Didi.
“You want everything quickly.”
“And you need rules for everything.”
Kamala Devi smiled.
She no longer felt the need to answer.
Not everything needs to be resolved.
Some incompleteness remains part of a relationship.
The affection between sisters does not diminish merely because the meaning of
one small quarrel was never settled.
The sunlight moved slowly.
A shadow began to fall across the sari.
Kamala Devi rose.
She removed the clips.
She folded the cloth.
Once more she brought it to her nose and breathed in.
The smell could no longer be identified clearly.
Sunlight, soap, the body, the old trunk—all had mingled.
Kamala Devi felt that this was right.
Perhaps memory is like that too—not a single scent, but a mingling of many
times.
She carried the sari inside.
She opened the trunk.
Then she stopped.
She did not put the sari back in the trunk.
She hung it on an empty hanger in the wardrobe.
Her daughter-in-law watched from a distance, but said nothing.
Kamala Devi smiled as she closed the wardrobe.
After some things have seen sunlight, it does not seem right to shut them back
into darkness.

The Earring

Sudha Devi noticed not the earring first, but its glint.

It was afternoon. The sitting-room window stood half open. A strip of sunlight lay across the floor.

As Gauri bent while sweeping, the small golden earring in her ear flashed in the sun.

Sudha Devi looked up from her book.

“Is it new?”

Gauri straightened. “What?”

“The earring.”

Gauri raised a hand to her ear. “Yes. I bought it the day before yesterday.”

Sudha smiled. “It’s nice.”

Gauri smiled too. “I like it too.”

The conversation could have ended there.

But Sudha’s eyes went back to the earring.

A small round hoop, with a red glass dot in the middle. It was not very expensive. Yet, glinting beside her face, it made Gauri look slightly different from the familiar figure Sudha saw every day.

Sudha suddenly wondered—how often had she ever really looked closely at Gauri’s face?

Gauri had worked in the house for seven years.

Sudha remembered her days off, knew which school her daughter attended, and knew that her husband pulled a rickshaw.

But she did not know which colour Gauri liked, whom she went to the market with, or whether she ever bought anything simply for herself.

Sudha closed the book.

“Where did you buy it?”

Gauri stopped sweeping and laughed. “From the market near the railway station.”

“By yourself?”

“Yes.”

“No one gave it to you?”

Gauri’s smile altered slightly. “If I buy something for myself, does someone else have to have given it to me?”

Sudha said quickly, “No, no, that isn’t what I meant...”

Gauri began sweeping again.

Sudha felt her question had been rather foolish.

She thought—perhaps she had formed a habit of looking for some practical reason behind everything Gauri owned.

A sari—for a festival.

Shoes—for the rains.

A mobile phone—for her daughter's schoolwork.
 An earring—perhaps someone had given it to her.
 Why had the possibility that Gauri might simply like something and buy it for herself not occurred to her first?
 Gauri went into the kitchen.
 Sudha opened her book again, but could not read.
 She remembered her own first pair of earrings.
 A few months after her marriage, she had bought a small pair set with pearls out of the first money she managed to save from her salary.
 Her mother-in-law had said the moment she saw them, "So much money for your ears?"
 Her husband, Arun, had laughed and said, "If you like them, it's all right."
 The sentence had sounded like support, but also a little like permission.
 Sudha had not noticed that at the time.
 Today the memory suddenly opened in a different way.
 There came the sound of cups from the kitchen.
 Gauri brought tea.
 "Less sugar in yours."
 Sudha took the cup.
 "Do you like red?"
 Gauri laughed. "You're asking because of the earring?"
 "Yes."
 "I like red. But in clothes, green."
 "Green?"
 "Yes. My daughter says I look dark in green."
 Sudha smiled. "Dark?"
 "She doesn't mean fair or dark. She says my face looks clearer in it."
 They both laughed.
 Sudha felt a small, unexpected pleasure in this brief conversation.
 Most of what she knew about Gauri had to do with trouble, leave, wages, illness, and working hours.
 Almost nothing had to do with what she liked.
 A few days later, while clearing her wardrobe, Sudha found an old jewellery box.
 Inside was a small pair of silver earrings. She had not worn them for years.
 She thought of giving them to Gauri.
 Then she stopped.
 Why?
 Because Gauri wore earrings?
 Because it seemed natural to give an old thing to the woman who worked in the house?
 She put the box back.
 That evening Arun asked, "What were you looking for?"
 "Nothing."
 "Old jewellery?"
 "Yes."
 Arun said, "If you don't wear it, give it to someone."

Sudha laughed. "Someone?"
 "You could give it to Gauri."
 Sudha looked at Arun.
 "You thought the same thing too?"
 "What?"
 "Nothing."
 The next day Gauri came wearing the earrings with the red dots again.
 Sudha said, "Do you wear them every day?"
 "No. I felt like wearing them today."
 'I felt like it today.'
 Sudha liked that sentence.
 That afternoon the electricity went off.
 The fan stopped.
 Gauri paused in her work and sat by the window.
 Sudha sat there too.
 It was hot.
 Fanning herself, Sudha asked, "When you bought the earrings, did anyone at home say anything?"
 Gauri shrugged. "My husband asked, 'How much?' I said, 'What's it to you?'"
 Sudha burst out laughing.
 Gauri laughed too.
 "And then?"
 "Then he said, 'All right. But don't let us run short of ration next week.'"
 The laughter stopped for a moment.
 Sudha asked, "Did you?"
 "No. I had saved separately."
 There was pride in Gauri's voice.
 "For how long?"
 "Three months. Ten rupees here, twenty there."
 Sudha looked at the earring.
 Its shine seemed different now.
 Not an expensive object—three months of small savings.
 But Sudha stopped herself.
 She was turning it into a story.
 Perhaps to Gauri it was not a symbol of sacrifice at all, only a beautiful thing.
 She asked, "Why did you save especially for this?"
 Gauri said, "Because I liked it."
 That was all.
 Sudha felt the answer was complete.
 A few days later Sudha's sister Meera came to the house.
 When Gauri came in with the tea, Meera noticed the earrings too.
 "Oh, how pretty!"
 Gauri thanked her.
 After Gauri left, Meera said softly, "These days even domestic workers dress up so much."
 Something tightened inside Sudha.

“Why shouldn’t they?”
 Meera looked surprised. “I was only saying.”
 “Yes, but why ‘even?’”
 Meera laughed. “There goes your sociology again.”
 Sudha fell silent.
 She remembered her own first question—“No one gave it to you?”
 How different was she from Meera?
 The language was different.
 Perhaps the way of seeing was not entirely so.
 The following week Gauri arrived without the earrings.
 Sudha asked, “Not wearing them today?”
 Gauri said, “One hook has come loose. It may fall off.”
 “Get it repaired.”
 “I will.”
 Sudha remembered the old silver earrings again.
 This time she took out the box, held it in her hand, and thought once more.
 Giving was not wrong.
 But the manner of giving mattered.
 She called Gauri.
 “Look at these.”
 Gauri looked at the earrings.
 “They’re nice.”
 “I haven’t worn them in a very long time. If you like them, would you take them?”
 Gauri took the earrings in her hand and examined them carefully.
 Then she said, “No, Didi.”
 Sudha was startled.
 “Why?”
 “My red ones will be repaired. You keep these.”
 “But I don’t wear them.”
 “Then sell them, exchange them, or give them to someone else.”
 Sudha smiled. “You don’t like them?”
 Gauri said plainly, “Not that much.”
 They both burst out laughing.
 Sudha felt relieved.
 Hearing Gauri say ‘no’ pleased her more than she had expected.
 The right to refuse a gift—this too was a small form of equality.
 The next day Gauri came wearing her repaired red earrings.
 The hook was new.
 “How much did it cost?” Sudha asked.
 “Twenty rupees.”
 “Good.”
 Gauri said, “And you should wear your old earrings.”
 Sudha laughed. “An order?”
 “Advice.”
 That evening Sudha stood before the mirror and put on the old silver earrings.

Her face did not change.

But the memory returned—the first salary, her mother-in-law's remark, Arun's 'If you like them, it's all right.'

It seemed to her that for years those earrings had lain in the wardrobe not merely as an object, but as an unfinished decision.

The next day she sat in the sitting room wearing the silver earrings.

Gauri came in and smiled as soon as she saw them.

"See?"

Sudha said, "Yes, I took your advice."

Gauri picked up the broom.

For a moment the two women looked at each other's ears.

In one, a cheap golden hoop with a red dot.

In the other, an old silver earring.

In that single moment, perhaps each imagined something of the other's life.

To Gauri, Sudha's earring may no longer have been merely jewellery—perhaps it held an old job, an old house, someone's remark, someone's permission.

To Sudha, Gauri's earring held three months of savings, a favourite colour, and the gleam of 'I felt like it today.'

But those imaginings were not the whole truth.

Sudha understood that.

She could not turn Gauri's poverty into a beautiful story merely to ease her own guilt.

Nor could Gauri's memory of one pair of earrings make Sudha's privilege equal to her own life.

On payday, Sudha still paid the wages.

Gauri still did the work.

The house was still Sudha's.

The economic line within the relationship had not disappeared.

But for once, a gaze had paused across that line.

Sudha said, "Will you have some tea?"

Gauri said, "Let me finish sweeping first."

"All right."

A little later they sat in the kitchen.

Sudha picked up her cup.

Gauri picked up a steel tumbler.

Sudha looked at the tumbler for a moment.

Then she rose, took another cup from the cupboard, and placed it in front of Gauri.

Gauri said, "What's wrong with the tumbler?"

Sudha stopped.

Then she laughed. "Nothing."

She put the cup back.

They both laughed at this small misstep.

Sudha understood—performing equality was not equality either.

One had to ask what the other person actually wanted.

When the tea was finished, Gauri got up.

Sunlight came through the window again.
The earring flashed once more.
Sudha looked up, but this time she did not see only the glint.
She saw Gauri's face too.
Gauri asked, "What?"
Sudha said, "Nothing. The earring is nice."
Gauri smiled.
"I like it too."

Red Nail Polish

The first time Ruchika painted her nails red, she felt as though her hands had changed.

The hands were the same—slender fingers, a small cut beside the right forefinger, an old school-ink stain on the middle nail.

But the moment the red colour went on, her fingers suddenly seemed to demand attention.

She held her hand away and looked at it.

Then close up.

Then she applied a second coat to the nails of her left hand.

Her friend Pakhi had given her the bottle of nail polish.

“Keep it,” Pakhi had said. “I have three at home.”

Ruchika had asked, “What if Ma sees?”

Pakhi had laughed. “So what? They’re nails, not a wall.”

Ruchika had liked that sentence.

That evening her mother had gone to the market. Her father was at the shop. Her younger brother was at extra tuition.

The house was empty.

Ruchika opened the window, spread paper over the table, uncapped the bottle, and very carefully painted the first nail.

The smell was sharp.

The first coat was uneven.

The second was better.

Painting the right hand with the left was difficult.

A red line strayed onto the skin beside one nail.

Ruchika wiped it away with cotton.

She kept smiling as she looked at her hands.

She did not feel that she had become prettier.

Rather, she felt that her hands looked the way she herself had chosen.

That small difference felt enormous inside her.

At the sound of her mother’s key, Ruchika started.

She quickly pushed the bottle behind a book.

But where could she hide her nails?

Her mother, Vibha Devi, put down the shopping bag and went towards the kitchen.

“Ruchi, put away the onions.”

Ruchika picked up the bag.

Her mother saw her hands at once.

“What is this?”

Her voice was not loud.

That made Ruchika more nervous.
 "Nail polish."
 "I can see that. Why?"
 The question struck Ruchika as strange.
 "I liked it."
 Her mother pulled Ruchika's hand towards herself and looked.
 "So red?"
 "It's red, so it looks red."
 Her mother frowned.
 "You'll go to school wearing this?"
 "Tomorrow is a holiday."
 "And the day after?"
 "I'll remove it the day after."
 Her mother let go of her hand.
 "All right. When your father sees it, he'll have something to say."
 Something dropped inside Ruchika.
 "Why Father?"
 "You know."
 "What have I done wrong?"
 Her mother said wearily, "It isn't a matter of right or wrong. Not everyone in a house likes everything."
 Ruchika fell silent.
 Instead of explaining anything, the answer confused her further.
 If it was not wrong, why the fear of having to remove it?
 If it was only a matter of liking, whose liking carried more weight?
 At dinner that night, her father, Ravindra Jha, did indeed notice her nails.
 "Since when is this?"
 Mixing her rice, Ruchika said, "Today."
 "Do schoolgirls do this sort of thing now?"
 "Not all of them."
 "Why did you need to?"
 That word again—need.
 Ruchika had not prepared an answer, yet she said, "I didn't need to. I wanted to."
 The dining table fell silent for a moment.
 Her younger brother Neel stared at her hands, trying not to laugh.
 Her father said, "Wanting something is not a reason for everything."
 Ruchika asked, "Then what kind of reason is needed?"
 Her mother immediately said, "Enough. Eat your dinner."
 Her father said nothing more.
 Ruchika too fell silent.
 That night she did not remove the nail polish.
 Before sleeping, she kept looking at her hands in a tiny mirror no bigger than a matchbox.
 The red no longer gave her the same excitement as before.
 Her parents' words had settled over it.
 Even so, she did not feel like removing the colour.

Her grandmother noticed it in the morning.
 Her grandmother, Shakuntala Devi, was sitting in the veranda taking the sun.
 "Such red nails!"

Ruchika thought: now for the third hearing.
 But Dadi took her hand and brought it close to her eyes.
 "The colour is fine. The edges aren't neat."
 Ruchika burst out laughing.
 "You like it?"

Dadi said, "What is there to like or dislike? In our time there was *alta*."
 "On the nails?"

"Mostly on the feet. Sometimes on the hands too."
 For the first time Ruchika looked carefully at her grandmother's hands.
 Wrinkled skin, thick nails, one finger slightly crooked.
 She began to imagine those hands once painted red.
 "Did you use it?"

Dadi laughed. "A lot after I was married. Before that it was forbidden at home."
 "Why?"

"So that a girl would not look grown-up too soon."
 Ruchika fell silent.
 "Painting nails makes you grown-up?"

Dadi shrugged. "Fear has its own logic."
 Ruchika liked that sentence very much.
 Pakhi came in the afternoon.
 Ruchika showed her hands.
 Pakhi said, "Wow! Very nice."
 Ruchika said, "There was an argument at home."
 "Didn't I tell you?"

"What did you tell me?"

"That nail polish is a revolution."
 Ruchika laughed.
 "I don't want to start a revolution."
 "Then?"

Ruchika could not answer.
 She only looked at her hands.
 "I just like the way they look to me."
 Pakhi said, "Then that's enough."
 Her friend's answer seemed simple to Ruchika.
 But home was not that simple.
 The next day her mother was cutting vegetables in the kitchen.
 Ruchika sat beside her shelling peas.
 Her mother suddenly asked, "Will you remove the colour?"

"Before school."
 "Did I say something so terrible?"

Ruchika looked up in surprise.
 "No."
 "Then why have you been talking less since yesterday?"

Ruchika kept dropping peas into the bowl.
 "I couldn't tell whether you wanted to protect me or stop me."
 Her mother stopped the knife.
 "Perhaps a little of both."
 Ruchika looked at her mother's face.
 Vibha Devi said softly, "Your father is not a bad man. But many things seem to change too quickly for him."
 "What changed for him because of my nails?"
 Her mother laughed.
 "Nothing. But in his eyes perhaps you became grown-up from a child in a single day."
 Ruchika asked, "And in your eyes?"
 Her mother did not answer at once.
 "In my eyes... you have been changing for a long time. But I see you every day, so it happens slowly."
 Ruchika went on shelling peas.
 "Is growing up bad?"
 "No."
 "Then why be afraid?"
 Her mother began moving the knife again.
 "Perhaps because once a child grows up, she will make her own decisions, and her parents will no longer have a place in every decision."
 The answer felt clearer than Ruchika had expected.
 She said, "I won't make every decision on my own."
 Her mother smiled. "That's what you say now."
 They both laughed.
 On the night before school reopened, Ruchika took out the nail-polish remover.
 She wiped each nail one by one.
 The red came away onto the cotton.
 Her nails looked ordinary again.
 She felt a small sadness.
 But it did not feel like defeat.
 The school rule against nail polish was explicit.
 She did not want to pick a fight simply by breaking the rule.
 She had made this decision herself.
 That difference gave her peace.
 On Tuesday, after returning from school, she sat beside Dadi.
 Dadi asked, "Where have the red nails gone?"
 "Not allowed at school."
 "All right."
 "You're not disappointed?"
 "They weren't my nails."
 Ruchika laughed.
 Dadi said, "Put it on again next holiday."
 "You too?"
 Dadi laughed loudly.

“Me?”
 “Why not?”
 Dadi looked at her own hands.
 “At this age?”
 Ruchika said at once, “Do nails change with age?”
 Dadi was silent for a moment.
 Then she said, “The way you talk is dangerous.”
 Ruchika smiled.
 On Saturday Pakhi brought the bottle again.
 Ruchika cleaned Dadi’s nails.
 Dadi kept pulling her hands away.
 “It feels cold.”
 “Keep still.”
 “Giving orders, are you?”
 “Today I’m the craftswoman.”
 Her mother stood at the doorway watching.
 The first nail turned red.
 Dadi looked at it herself and smiled.
 “It’s very bright.”
 “Shall I remove it?”
 Dadi said immediately, “No.”
 The other hand was painted too.
 Her mother came inside.
 Ruchika asked, “You too?”
 Her mother laughed. “No.”
 Dadi said, “Let her put some on you.”
 Her mother said, “I don’t like red.”
 Ruchika stopped.
 “Then what colour?”
 Her mother thought for a moment.
 “Perhaps pale pink.”
 Pakhi said, “I have that.”
 Everyone laughed.
 Ruchika suddenly understood—womanhood was not one colour.
 For Dadi, red could carry the memory of old alta.
 For her mother, pale pink might simply be what she herself liked.
 For Ruchika, red nails were a new way of seeing her own hands.
 For Pakhi, it was mischief and play.
 The same object did not carry the same meaning for everyone.
 Her father came home that evening.
 In the veranda, Dadi was turning the beads of her rosary with red nails.
 Ravindra Babu stopped short.
 “Ma!”
 Dadi said fearlessly, “What?”
 “What have you done?”
 “Painted my nails.”

Ruchika fought down her laughter.
 Her father looked at Dadi, then at Ruchika.
 "Is this your doing?"
 Ruchika said, "With Dadi's permission."
 Dadi immediately said, "By my own wish."
 Her father laughed.
 Some of the tension broke.
 Taking the opportunity, Ruchika asked, "Can I wear it on holidays?"
 Her father made his face serious.
 "Not at school."
 "Not at school."
 "And not too... bright..."
 Dadi interrupted, "Does someone measure brightness now?"
 Her mother laughed from the kitchen.
 Defeated, her father said, "All right, whatever you like."
 Ruchika was not immediately delighted.
 Was 'whatever you like' permission, or irritation?
 Then she thought—perhaps for now, this much was enough.
 On Sunday morning she painted her nails again.
 This time the edges were neater.
 Dadi inspected them.
 "Yes, you've had practice."
 Her mother was wearing Pakhi's pink polish.
 Ruchika looked at her hands.
 "It looks nice on you."
 Her mother said, "I like it too."
 Ruchika smiled at that answer.
 A family photograph was taken that day.
 Dadi's red nails, her mother's pink ones, Ruchika's red ones.
 Her father, his unpainted hand resting on the back of Dadi's chair.
 Neel making a face in the background.
 It was an ordinary family photograph.
 No declaration.
 No revolution.
 A few weeks later Ruchika grew tired of red.
 During one holiday she left her nails completely unpainted.
 Her mother asked, "Nothing today?"
 "Don't feel like it."
 Her mother said, "All right."
 To Ruchika, this 'all right' sounded different from the 'all right' of the first day.
 Before, it had been caution.
 Now it was acceptance.
 Ruchika looked at her unpainted hands.
 She liked them.
 Then she looked at the red bottle in the cupboard.
 She liked that too.

She understood—freedom was not only the freedom to apply colour; it was also the freedom not to.

She did not have to prove the meaning of her body in the same way every day.

Sometimes red.

Sometimes bare.

Sometimes some other colour.

The hands remained the same, but the decision could change.

She set the bottle upright.

She tightened the cap.

Then she held her hands out into the sunlight at the window.

Sunlight shone on the unpainted nails.

Ruchika smiled.

She no longer needed red in order to recognise her own hands.

But her first encounter with red would remain hers too.

The Sheer Curtain

The curtain hanging between the hospital beds was so sheer that light showed through it.

The first time Anamika saw it, she thought—this is not privacy; it is the performance of privacy.

Her bed was by the window. There was a woman in the other bed, but the curtain was drawn all the way across.

Her face could not be seen.

Only, now and then, the tip of a slipper, the shadow of a hand, the bent figure of a nurse.

Anamika had to spend one night in hospital after a minor operation. The doctor had said—nothing to worry about, only observation.

Even after hearing ‘nothing to worry about’, the worry had not ended.

If something inside the body has been cut and stitched, the mind takes time to accept it as small, whatever language may call it.

At six in the evening a nurse came and took her blood pressure.

On the phone Anamika told her daughter Trisha, “Everything is fine. You study.”

Trisha asked, “Pain?”

“Very little.”

That was only half true.

The pain was bearable, but fear had a different measure.

The moment she ended the call, a faint sound of weeping came from behind the curtain.

At first it was so soft that Anamika thought perhaps someone was coughing.

Then came the sound of a breath breaking.

Then a clear sob.

Anamika closed her eyes.

She did not want to listen.

But the curtain did not stop sound.

After a while a man’s voice said, “Don’t cry. The doctor hasn’t said anything definite yet.”

The woman’s answer was very soft. The words were indistinct.

Against her will, Anamika began to listen.

She was annoyed with herself.

This was none of her business.

She adjusted her pillow, drank some water, and looked out of the window.

Even so, her ears remained turned towards the curtain.

The man said again, “We won’t tell the children yet.”

A whole story formed inside Anamika at once.

A serious illness.

Small children at home.
A bad report.
Long treatment.
She stopped herself.
How easy it was to make an entire life from four unfinished sentences.
And how unfair.
There was silence behind the curtain again.
Anamika looked at the sheet spread across her stomach.
She remembered the day before her operation.
Trisha had asked, "Mummy, are you afraid?"
Anamika had answered immediately, "No."
Why?
To protect her daughter?
Or so that she herself would not have to hear the sound of her own fear?
Dinner arrived.
Anamika ate half the khichdi.
The woman behind the curtain seemed not to eat anything. Anamika heard the nurse say, "Have a little."
The answer came: "I don't feel like it."
Again Anamika's imagination began to work.
Again she scolded herself.
She opened a book.
She read one page.
On the next page she read the same line three times.
Her attention would not hold.
At about nine the curtain slid halfway aside.
The nurse went in.
For one moment Anamika saw the shoulder of the woman sitting on the other bed.
A pale yellow hospital gown.
Loose hair.
That was all.
The curtain closed again.
Anamika felt relieved that she had not seen the woman's face.
Had she seen the face, perhaps the story in her mind would have become even more solid.
At half past ten the lights were dimmed.
The corridor outside the ward was still bright.
Shadows kept moving across the curtain—the nurse, an attendant, perhaps a relative.
Anamika tried to sleep.
After a while the crying began again.
This time the woman was alone.
The sobs were being suppressed, as though even the sound of grief might violate hospital discipline.
Anamika turned onto her side.

She remembered her mother.

Her mother had never cried loudly in a hospital. Not even during her father's illness.

Once, after returning home, she had broken down in the kitchen.

Anamika had been twenty then.

She had asked, "Why didn't you cry at the hospital?"

Her mother had said, "Everyone can hear you there."

Anamika had not understood then.

Now, looking at the curtain, the meaning of that sentence became clear.

In a hospital, bodies lie on separate beds, but voices belong to everyone.

At about eleven Anamika became thirsty.

Her water bottle was empty.

She reached towards the call button for the nurse, then stopped.

The woman behind the curtain was saying again, "I want to go home."

Someone answered—probably the same man—"We'll speak to the doctor tomorrow."

"I don't want to stay here."

There was fear in the voice.

Suddenly Anamika's own fear did not seem smaller.

Only different.

Why compare fear?

Another person's fear becoming larger does not make one's own fear false.

She pressed the button.

The nurse brought her water.

"Can't sleep?"

"A little."

"Pain?"

"Bearable."

The nurse smiled. "Nights are long in hospitals."

Anamika wanted to ask—is the woman behind the curtain all right?

The question came as far as her tongue.

Then she stopped herself.

That information was not hers to claim.

The nurse left.

Anamika drank the water.

At that moment a voice came from behind the curtain. "Sister?"

Anamika started.

"Yes?"

"Do you have water in your bottle?"

"Yes."

"Has the nurse gone?"

"Yes. Do you need some?"

"No, I have some. I was only asking."

Silence.

Anamika smiled in the dark.

Their first direct exchange.

Still no face.

A little later the same voice asked, "Are you getting any sleep?"

"No."

"Neither am I."

Anamika said, "Nights are long in hospitals."

She repeated the nurse's sentence.

The woman behind the curtain gave a small laugh.

After the crying, the laugh sounded very different.

"She was right."

Then silence again.

Anamika felt that perhaps this much was enough.

She wanted to ask the woman's name.

She wanted to ask about the illness too.

She asked nothing.

After a little while the woman herself said, "I'm Sarita."

"I'm Anamika."

"Are you being discharged tomorrow?"

"Perhaps. You?"

The moment the question left her mouth, Anamika regretted it.

Sarita was silent for a few seconds.

"I don't know."

Anamika said quickly, "I didn't need to ask."

"No, it's all right."

Then Sarita said, "A few tests are still left."

That was all.

Anamika did not ask, "What tests?"

Sarita did not ask what operation Anamika had undergone either.

The curtain remained hanging between them.

For the first time, its presence did not feel to Anamika like only an obstruction.

The curtain stopped nothing—not sound, not shadows.

But it could at least remind them to stop their questions.

The night moved slowly forward.

Now and then came the sound of wheels in the corridor.

Now and then someone coughed in the distance.

Now and then the nurses spoke softly among themselves.

Sarita did not cry again.

At about two, Anamika woke and heard a faint snore from behind the curtain.

She felt relieved.

Then she wondered at herself—why did the sleep of an unknown woman bring her relief?

Perhaps because, after hearing her breathing, her crying, her laughter through the night, the woman was no longer entirely a stranger.

Yet she was not familiar either.

Something in between.

The first grey light of dawn came through the window.

The curtain began to brighten.

Anamika sat up.
 The pain was less.
 Sarita's voice came from behind the curtain. "Is it morning?"
 "Yes."
 "What does the sky look like from the window?"
 Anamika looked outside.
 "Pale grey. There are clouds, but no rain."
 "Will the sun come out?"
 "I can't say."
 Sarita said, "All right."
 The question seemed ordinary to Anamika, but there was such expectation in the voice that she began to speculate.
 Then she stopped herself again.
 Sunlight could be only sunlight too.
 At seven the cleaner came in.
 The curtain was drawn aside.
 For the first time Anamika saw Sarita fully.
 About her own age.
 A dusky face.
 Swelling beneath the eyes.
 Hair loosely tied.
 Not a face from any story.
 Just a tired human being.
 The two women looked at one another.
 A faint smile.
 "The night is over," Sarita said.
 "Yes."
 Because of the cleaning, the curtain remained open for five minutes.
 Anamika felt a strange kind of nakedness.
 Seeing a face was an ordinary thing, but after sharing only voices through the night, a face suddenly felt very private.
 The cleaning ended.
 The curtain was drawn again.
 Anamika felt relieved.
 Privacy was not only concealment.
 Sometimes it was a chosen distance.
 At nine, the doctors began their rounds.
 Anamika's doctor came and examined the wound.
 "Everything is fine. Discharge this afternoon."
 A lightness spread through Anamika.
 She sent Trisha a message: "Home today."
 The reply came immediately: "Yay!"
 Anamika smiled.
 A doctor came behind the curtain.
 Even if she wished to, Anamika could not close her ears.
 She heard a few words—"report... another test... no hasty conclusion... two days..."

Not Sarita's voice.

Anamika straightened her pillow and turned her face towards the window.

Deliberately, she stopped catching the words.

She began counting the sounds in the corridor.

One trolley.

Two pairs of footsteps.

A bell far away.

A small bird-shadow at the window.

The doctor left.

There was silence behind the curtain for a long time.

Anamika asked nothing.

About half an hour later Sarita herself said, "Sister?"

"Yes."

"You're going home?"

"Yes, this afternoon."

"Good."

Anamika said, "You... take care."

That was what she managed to say instead of 'What did the doctor say?'

Sarita said softly, "You too."

Trisha arrived in the afternoon.

She packed her mother's bag, helped her into her slippers, and gathered the papers.

Sarita's relative had perhaps gone outside.

Anamika stood up.

There was a slight pull of pain.

Trisha said, "Slowly."

Anamika looked towards the curtain.

She wanted to say goodbye.

One could not knock on a curtain.

She said softly, "Sarita ji, I'm leaving."

The answer came from behind the curtain. "All right. Rest when you get home."

Anamika laughed.

"You too."

A moment later Sarita said, "Last night... thank you."

Anamika was surprised.

"What did I do?"

"Nothing."

Then Sarita laughed.

"Perhaps that's why."

Anamika held that sentence in her mind for a long time.

Thanks for doing nothing.

No questions.

No advice.

No grand words of consolation.

Only being there.

Trisha asked, "What happened?"

“Nothing.”

This time ‘nothing’ was not a sentence meant to hide something.

She truly had not done very much.

And perhaps that had been right.

At home, Trisha placed water beside her mother’s bed.

“How was the night in hospital?”

Anamika said, “Long.”

“What was the woman sharing the room like?”

Anamika paused.

At the words ‘the woman sharing the room’, Sarita’s crying, her laughter, the grey dawn, and the curtain all returned together.

“There was a woman,” she said.

Trisha waited.

Anamika said nothing more.

She did not tell her daughter the unfinished things she had heard from Sarita.

Because something overheard does not become one’s own.

That evening, as Anamika drew the curtain at the window at home, she remembered the sheer fabric in the hospital.

The curtain at home was thick. It blocked the light from outside.

She left it half open.

Trisha asked, “Won’t you close it all the way?”

Anamika said, “This much is fine.”

She sat by the window.

She understood—privacy was not complete silence, nor was it a complete wall.

Sometimes one needed only enough space for someone to be able to hear, without deciding to enter.

The hospital curtain had been very sheer.

Even so, through the night it had sustained a small boundary between the two women.

And that boundary had been made less by cloth than by the decision not to ask questions.

Cardamom

Harinarayan Jha did not like cardamom tea. At least, he had held firmly to that position for forty years.

Every morning his wife, Sudha, crushed one cardamom pod into the tea, and every morning Harinarayan would say, "Why so much fragrance?"

Sudha would reply, "Because tea is not merely hot water."

The exchange was so old that both of them spoke it without thinking.

One day Sudha went to Jaipur to stay with their daughter Meera. She had to have her knee examined and planned to remain there for ten days.

Harinarayan had said, "Go. Stay comfortably. I'll manage everything here."

Sudha had laughed. "Your own tea too?"

"What sort of art is making tea?"

"All right. We shall see."

On the first morning Harinarayan woke at five. The house was unusually quiet.

He went into the kitchen. He put the water on to boil. Added tea leaves. Milk. Sugar.

He poured it into a cup and sat down to drink.

Something seemed missing in the first sip.

He refused at once to admit that what was missing was cardamom.

He checked the sugar.

The milk was right.

The tea leaves were right.

Even so, the taste was flat.

He finished the cup, but after opening the newspaper his eyes kept straying towards the kitchen.

On the second morning he took out one cardamom pod.

He placed it on his palm and looked at it.

Such a small thing.

How did Sudha crush it?

He put it in the mortar and struck it hard with the pestle.

The cardamom was smashed to pieces.

He put it into the tea.

At the first sip the aroma was so fierce that it seemed to fill his nose.

"This isn't tea. I've made a perfume," he muttered.

On the phone Sudha asked, "Did the tea get made?"

"Yes."

"Cardamom?"

Harinarayan was startled. "How do you know?"

Sudha laughed. "From your voice."

"I crushed it too much."

"I don't crush it completely. I only press it a little."
 Harinarayan found the distinction utterly unnecessary.
 "Crushing is crushing."
 "No. There is oil inside cardamom. If you grind it completely, the fragrance becomes different."
 "Are you a chemist?"
 "I have been making tea for forty years."
 They both laughed.
 After the call ended, Harinarayan kept looking at the mortar.
 'I only press it a little.'
 The sentence brought back an old scene.
 The fifth year of their marriage.
 A rented house in Darbhanga.
 Early morning.
 Sudha was making tea and Harinarayan, irritated, was searching for office papers.
 He had said, "Why do you have this habit of doing everything so slowly?"
 Sudha had answered, "I am not slow. I do things in my own way."
 Harinarayan had snapped, "Even a way of doing things has to look at the time."
 Sudha had said nothing.
 He could not remember whether the tea that morning had more cardamom or less.
 But the phrase 'my own way' returned now with complete clarity.
 On the third morning Harinarayan merely pressed the pod lightly beneath the flat of a knife.
 The tea was better.
 But still not like Sudha's tea.
 He did not telephone her.
 Today he would understand it himself.
 Two cardamom pods?
 No, too many.
 Half of one?
 Difficult.
 Milk first or afterwards?
 He laughed at himself over that question.
 What he had called 'ordinary tea' for forty years contained so many decisions?
 All day he attended to small household tasks.
 He washed two cups.
 Swept the veranda.
 Cut vegetables.
 At lunch he put too much salt in the dal.
 In the evening Meera called.
 "Babu, Ma says you must eat on time."
 "Am I a child?"
 Meera laughed. "She said you would give exactly that answer."
 Harinarayan smiled.
 "How is her knee?"

"Fine. The examination is tomorrow."

At bedtime the other side of the bed seemed unusually empty.

Harinarayan opened a book.

Two pages later he realized that he was not reading.

He remembered one of Sudha's habits.

Before sleeping she would put a hand under the pillow and straighten the pillowcase.

Harinarayan would ask, "Why does it need to be so exact?"

Sudha would say, "Why should the thing on which I rest my head be crooked?"

He used to laugh then.

Now he straightened his own pillow.

On the fourth morning, while making tea, it struck him that cardamom measured not only flavour but time.

While the water came to the boil, Sudha would press the cardamom.

After adding the tea leaves, she did not pour in the milk at once.

There was the interval of a few breaths.

Harinarayan had never noticed it before.

He repeated that interval by guesswork.

The tea came out right.

Very close.

He took the cup to the veranda and sat down.

The first sip gave him a sudden sense of pride.

The second brought a question: was this truly the same taste?

For how many years had he been drinking Sudha's tea, and why could he not remember its exact taste?

Perhaps because, more than the taste, he had remembered the conversation — "Too little cardamom." "Too much sugar." "The milk boiled over."

Did complaints remain in memory more stubbornly than details?

The thought made him uncomfortable.

That afternoon, while looking for papers in an old cupboard, he found a small file.

It contained deposit and withdrawal slips, the children's old school-fee receipts, medical papers, and between them a yellowing sheet in Sudha's handwriting.

'Household expenses—1994.'

Rice.

Dal.

Milk.

School fees.

Rent.

At the bottom, in very small letters: 'Cardamom—50 grams.'

Harinarayan laughed.

He remembered that there had been a time when cardamom seemed expensive.

He would say, "Why put it in the tea every day?"

Sudha would reply, "One pod a day will not bankrupt the household."

That year his salary had arrived late.

Sudha had added the small amount she earned from sewing to the household expenses.

Harinarayan knew this.

But seeing 'Cardamom—50 grams' on the old sheet made that kitchen suddenly vivid again.

Ordinary things had been economic decisions.

Even a single cardamom pod.

On the fifth day Sudha's examination results were fine.

On the phone she said, "I'll stay another three days. Meera says I should go out a little."

Harinarayan said, "Stay."

Then, for no particular reason, he added, "The tea is getting made."

Sudha laughed. "Have you learned?"

"Not like yours."

"Who told you to make it like mine?"

Harinarayan paused.

No one, in fact.

He had entered the competition by himself.

"Then I am making it in my own way," he said.

"There. Now it is right."

After the call ended, the phrase 'in my own way' again carried Harinarayan back to the early years of their marriage.

Sudha did everything in her own way.

He did everything quickly.

At first the difference was a collision.

Later it became an arrangement.

No one ever announced who would do what.

Sudha made tea.

Harinarayan did the marketing.

Sudha folded the clothes.

Harinarayan paid the electricity bill.

Sudha made the guest list.

Harinarayan handled the train tickets.

Then time changed.

The children grew up.

Bills could be paid from home.

Goods began arriving at the door.

The division of work changed, but the old sentence remained.

'Why cardamom in the tea?'

On the sixth day Harinarayan deliberately made tea without cardamom.

He tasted it.

It was not bad.

Only different.

He wondered—perhaps this had once been what he preferred.

Or had he simply gone on saying 'I don't like it' out of the habit of objecting?

There was no way to answer the question without asking Sudha.

That evening, on the phone, he said, "Tell me one thing."
 "Tell me."
 "Did I truly dislike cardamom in the beginning?"
 There was silence at the other end.
 Then Sudha laughed.
 "You are asking after forty years?"
 "Answer me."
 "In the beginning you liked it very much."
 Harinarayan stared.
 "What?"
 "In the first year of our marriage you used to say the tea at my mother's house had too little cardamom."
 "Me?"
 "Yes."
 "Then afterwards?"
 "Once your stomach was upset. The doctor told you to cut down on spices. We stopped cardamom for two months. When I began putting in a little again, you developed the habit of complaining."
 Harinarayan was speechless.
 "I don't remember."
 "I do."
 "Are you sure?"
 "No. What court of law has jurisdiction over memory?"
 They both laughed.
 After putting down the phone, Harinarayan felt a small sting.
 For forty years he had believed a little story about himself—"I don't like cardamom."
 Perhaps the story was not entirely true.
 Does a person turn even a taste into a part of his character?
 On the seventh day he pressed one cardamom pod into the tea.
 This time he did not try to reproduce Sudha's recipe.
 A little more water.
 Less milk.
 Half the sugar.
 One cardamom pod.
 The tea came out differently.
 He liked it.
 He thought of writing down the proportions on a piece of paper.
 Then he laughed.
 Why write them down?
 Tomorrow he might feel differently.
 Sudha's word 'way' came back to him once more.
 A way was not a rule.
 A way was a living thing.
 On the eighth day Meera said, "Ma will return tomorrow."
 Harinarayan found himself putting the house in order.

He changed the bedsheet.
Cleaned the kitchen.
Refilled the cardamom tin.
Watered Sudha's plants.
He laughed at himself.
Sudha had not left the house shining like this when she went away.
Whom was he welcoming—his wife, or his own orderly memory of her?
The next afternoon Sudha returned.
The bandage on her knee was small.
Meera carried the bags inside and left.
The moment Sudha entered the house she asked, "Did the plants survive?"
"They survived."
"Milk?"
"There is milk."
"The stove?"
"Still here."
"And you?"
Harinarayan said, "I survived too."
They both laughed.
After Sudha sat down, Harinarayan asked, "Tea?"
Sudha raised her eyebrows. "You'll make it?"
"Yes."
"Then make it."
In the kitchen Harinarayan took out one cardamom pod.
He pressed it.
Then, after thinking, he picked up half of another pod.
He stopped.
The anxiety about the 'right' taste had returned.
He put the half pod back.
The tea was ready.
Two cups.
Sudha took the first sip.
Harinarayan began reading her face.
Sudha said, "It's good."
"That's all?"
"What do you want? A certificate?"
"Is it like yours?"
Sudha took another sip.
"No."
Harinarayan could not decide whether he was disappointed or relieved.
"It's different," Sudha said. "Less milk."
"You don't like it?"
"I didn't say that."
Then she looked at Harinarayan's cup.
"You've reduced the sugar?"
"Yes."

"You used to like it sweet."

"Now I like less."

Sudha smiled.

"See? Taste changes."

Harinarayan said, "And memory too."

Sudha looked at him.

"Has the philosophy begun now?"

"A man alone for eight days gets a great deal of time."

They sat on the veranda drinking tea.

After a while Sudha asked, "Tell me the truth. How many times did you order food while I was away?"

"Twice."

"Twice?"

"Three times."

"I knew it."

"How?"

"If all the kitchen tins are this tidy, there cannot have been much cooking."

Harinarayan laughed.

The laughter held eight days of solitude, forty years of argument, and a single cardamom pod all at once.

That evening Sudha went into the kitchen.

Not to make tea—to look after dinner.

She opened the cardamom tin.

"How did it get used up so quickly?"

From behind the newspaper Harinarayan said, "I was practising."

Sudha laughed.

"Tomorrow morning you make the tea."

"Why?"

"So the practice continues."

Harinarayan instinctively wanted to say, 'That is your job.'

The sentence formed halfway and stopped.

He said, "All right."

At five the next morning they rose together.

Harinarayan put water on in the kitchen.

Sudha stood by the doorframe.

"Don't watch," Harinarayan said.

"I'm not saying anything."

"Your face is."

"Why blame my face?"

Harinarayan pressed the cardamom.

Sudha said, "A little less."

"You said you wouldn't say anything."

"That was a suggestion."

"I don't need it."

Sudha laughed and went out.

The tea was made.

Two cups on the table.
 Sudha drank.
 She said nothing.
 Harinarayan asked, "Well?"
 "Well what?"
 "Is the cardamom right?"
 Sudha put down the cup.
 "Are you truly worried about the taste now, or about my approval?"
 Harinarayan was silent.
 The question had struck the exact place.
 He thought.
 "A little of both."
 Sudha smiled.
 "Then the tea is good."
 "That answer is an evasion."
 "In a forty-year marriage, some answers are evasions too."
 They both laughed again.
 That afternoon Harinarayan showed Sudha the old expense sheet.
 'Cardamom—50 grams.'
 Sudha looked at it for a long time.
 "That is my handwriting."
 "Yes."
 "How much we used to economize."
 "Do you remember?"
 "Some things."
 "Do you remember that I liked cardamom?"
 Sudha laughed. "Again?"
 "I want proof."
 "You won't find proof on a household-expense sheet."
 "Then where?"
 Sudha folded the paper.
 "Accept that sometimes you liked it and sometimes you didn't. What will be ruined by that?"
 Harinarayan took back the paper.
 He understood that he had a habit of seeing his past as one unbroken thing.
 'I was like this.'
 'Sudha was like that.'
 'I didn't like this.'
 'She always did that.'
 Perhaps a marriage is made less of 'always' and more of small decisions that keep changing, turn by turn.
 That evening Sudha made tea for herself.
 And for Harinarayan too.
 He smelled his cup.
 "Too much cardamom today."
 Sudha said, "Deliberately."

“Why?”

“Because that is what I felt like today.”

Harinarayan took a sip.

At first he wanted to say, far too much.

Then he tasted it again.

“It’s all right.”

Sudha narrowed her eyes. “Truly?”

Harinarayan laughed.

“No. A little too much.”

“Then say so.”

“I am saying it.”

They exchanged cups.

Sudha’s cup happened to have less cardamom.

Harinarayan’s had more.

After the exchange each found the taste he wanted.

It was so ordinary a thing that no one would have noticed it.

No memorable event.

No anniversary.

No vow.

Only two cups of tea crossing the table into each other’s places.

Harinarayan suddenly felt that perhaps something very deep about married life hid inside just such ordinary exchanges.

Not the same taste every day.

Not the same role every day.

Sometimes one makes it, sometimes the other.

Sometimes one person’s cup suits the other.

Sometimes it is better simply to exchange them.

He looked at Sudha.

“What?” she asked.

“Nothing.”

“Then why are you looking at me like that?”

Harinarayan lifted his cup.

“The cardamom is right.”

Sudha laughed.

“So at last you have learned?”

Harinarayan said, “No. Now I understand that it need not be learned once and for all.”

Sudha shook her head.

“Philosophy again.”

“Free with the tea.”

Evening was descending over the veranda.

The steam from the two cups slowly thinned.

The scent of cardamom was in the air—not too much, not too little.

As much as was wanted today.

The Flower Vase

The sound of the flower vase breaking was so sharp that everyone sitting in the drawing room fell silent at once.

The thick glass vase lay divided into five large pieces on the floor. Smaller shards had scattered farther away.

Water was spreading across the rug.

Three white tuberose, two roses, and green leaves lay overturned among the glass.

Eight-year-old Era stopped on the first step of the staircase.

At that moment no one looked at her.

Everyone was looking at the vase.

"Who knocked it?" Shailaja Devi's voice rose first.

Her daughter-in-law Aparna appeared in the kitchen doorway.

"I'm here."

Shailaja's son Nachiket rose from beside the sofa.

"Was the table wobbling again?"

Aparna said at once, "I told you yesterday to get the leg fixed."

Nachiket's younger brother Alok said, "Don't put it on me. I didn't even touch it."

The glass of the vase was still trembling faintly.

Era came down the stairs.

She kept looking at the flowers and leaves.

One side of a tuberose stalk had already browned. The outer petals of the roses had shrivelled.

Era knew this from before.

The previous evening she had carried one rose to her mother.

"Ma, this is drying up."

Aparna had said, "It is still all right. The guests are coming tomorrow. We'll change them then."

They had not been changed.

Today, an hour before the guests were due, the vase had broken.

"Era!" Aparna called.

Era startled.

"What were you doing here?"

"I was on the stairs."

"Did you go near the table?"

"No."

Shailaja Devi said, "Children are always running about. Someone's foot must have struck it."

Era said, "I wasn't running."

No one answered.

That evening the family was holding a small celebration for Shailaja Devi's seventieth birthday.

The word 'small' had been used because there were only twelve guests from outside the family.

But the house had been under cleaning for three days.

The old curtains had been washed.

The cushion covers changed.

The pictures on the walls straightened.

The flower vase taken out of the cupboard.

The moment it was brought out, everyone always said that the vase dated from Shailaja Devi's wedding.

"Fifty years old," Shailaja would say.

After it broke today, 'fifty years' suddenly became very heavy.

Aparna went to fetch the broom.

Shailaja stopped her.

"Don't touch it with your hands. Pick up the large pieces first."

Nachiket said, "Ma, it's glass. You'll cut yourself."

"I know what glass is."

Her voice was hard.

Alok silently brought an old sheet of newspaper.

The pieces were placed on it one by one.

Eera stood in a corner watching.

The flowers seemed sadder to her than the vase.

The glass was broken—that was clear.

The flowers had been wilting since yesterday—no one was saying that.

"The table leg was loose again," Aparna said.

Nachiket bent down to check the table.

The right leg really did wobble a little.

"It must have fallen with a knock," he said.

Shailaja said, "Then who put the vase on a table like this?"

Aparna fell silent.

The question had moved in the direction where everyone knew the answer was Aparna.

She was the one who had arranged the flowers in the vase as well.

"Mummyji, you yourself said it would look good on this table."

"If I said so, did that mean you couldn't see the table leg?"

Aparna's face changed.

"For three days I have been looking after everything alone."

"Alone?" Alok broke in. "Didn't I go to the market?"

"You went to the market, but who had the list for everything inside the house?"

Nachiket said, "Is accounting necessary now?"

Aparna looked at him.

"If not now, then when?"

Shailaja kept her eyes fixed on the pieces of the vase.

"Enough."

But saying 'enough' did not make the matter end.

The broken vase seemed to have lifted the lid from every old grievance.
 Alok said, "I think this table should have been changed long ago."
 Nachiket said at once, "Three months ago you said you would call a carpenter. Did you?"
 "I was in Delhi."
 "Then you could have told me."
 "Must I tell you everything?"
 Aparna laughed, but the laughter was hard.
 "Yes. In a house, someone or the other has to keep saying everything before anything gets done."
 Shailaja raised her voice. "Is this my birthday or a village council?"
 Everyone fell silent again.
 Era liked the word 'council', but not just then.
 She quietly picked up one of the tuberose flowers lying on the floor.
 Aparna said at once, "Era, there is glass. Stay away."
 Era stepped back with the flower in her hand.
 The lowest blossom on the tuberose was brown.
 She touched it with a finger and a petal came away.
 "Ma," she said.
 No one heard her.
 The doorbell rang outside.
 The first guest had arrived.
 The house changed in a single moment.
 Shailaja straightened herself.
 Aparna adjusted the end of her sari.
 Nachiket wrapped the glass pieces in newspaper and put them behind the kitchen.
 Alok began pressing a cloth into the wet patch on the rug.
 "Quickly," Aparna said.
 Era, still holding the flower, went to the window.
 The door opened.
 "Many happy returns!"
 Laughter entered the house.
 Shailaja Devi smiled and brought the guest inside.
 The table where the vase had stood was empty.
 Aparna quickly stood the surviving flowers in a small brass vessel.
 Era saw the wilting rose propped upright from behind with green leaves so that it would look straight again.
 The celebration began.
 The cake arrived.
 Photographs were taken.
 Someone asked, "Oh, where is that old flower vase?"
 Shailaja paused for half a second.
 Then she laughed and said, "It is resting today."
 Everyone laughed.
 Era did not.
 She looked at her mother's face.

Aparna was laughing too, but her eyes were tired.
After the cake was cut, Eera went out to the balcony with her cousin Neel, who was her own age.

Neel asked, "Did you break the vase?"

"No."

"Dadi was saying children keep running around."

"I wasn't running."

"Then who did it?"

Eera said, "I don't know."

Neel was disappointed.

He wanted an answer to the mystery.

"Did the table fall by itself?"

"The table didn't fall. The vase did."

"Then someone must have hit it."

Eera showed him the tuberose.

"This was already going bad yesterday."

Neel smelled it.

"It still has fragrance."

"Does fragrance mean a flower is fresh?"

Neel shrugged.

"How would I know?"

They went back inside.

In the middle of the gathering, Shailaja Devi's old friend Vimla arrived.

As she handed over her gift she said, "Do you remember that glass flower vase of yours? I saw it the first time I came to this house after your wedding."

Shailaja smiled.

"It broke."

This time she did not hide the fact.

Vimla said simply, "Oh, it is an object. Objects break."

Shailaja's face tightened slightly.

"It survived fifty years."

Vimla said, "Then it was used for fifty years too."

Eera heard this from a distance.

Shailaja did not answer.

A little later Vimla pressed her hand and moved on to another subject.

After the guests left at night, the house became quiet again.

Half the cake, empty cups, paper napkins, and gift boxes remained on the table.

The flowers in the small brass vessel had drooped.

Aparna sank into a chair.

Nachiket said, "The rest tomorrow."

Shailaja began walking slowly towards her room.

Then she stopped.

"Where are the glass pieces?"

"Behind the kitchen," Nachiket said.

"Don't throw them away."

Alok asked, "Can it be joined?"

"I don't know."

Aparna said wearily, "Even if it is joined, the marks will remain."

Shailaja said, "Let the marks remain."

Everyone looked at her when she said it.

Shailaja went to her room.

Eera was still holding the tuberose stalk.

Her mother noticed.

"Why are you still carrying that?"

Eera said, "It was already wilting."

Aparna stopped.

"What?"

"Yesterday I showed it to you. You said we would change the flowers after the guests came."

Aparna took the flower.

The brown petal fell away at her touch.

Nachiket came closer.

Eera said, "When the vase broke, everyone looked at the flowers. But the flowers had already started going bad."

The room fell silent.

Eera suddenly feared that she had said something wrong.

She added, "I'm not saying why the vase fell. I don't know."

Nachiket said softly, "Yes."

Eera looked at her mother's face.

Aparna turned the flower stalk in her fingers.

"I wanted to change them," she said. "Then there was the cake, the ice, the phone calls, the tablecloth..."

The sentence remained unfinished.

Alok said, "I could have gone to bring flowers."

Aparna looked at him but said nothing.

Nachiket shook the table leg with his hand.

"This too had been loose for some time."

Alok said, "We all knew."

This time no one blamed anyone.

Eera thought perhaps what she had said had ended the quarrel.

But almost at once she understood—no.

Her mother's face was still tired.

Dadi's grief was still there.

The table still wobbled.

The vase was still broken.

One fact did not answer every question.

Aparna stroked Eera's head.

"Go wash your hands."

Eera went away.

Behind her the adults began talking in low voices.

What they decided, Eera did not hear completely.

She woke early the next morning.

When she came into the drawing room, the table was gone.
The space where it had stood was empty.
Nachiket had turned the table upside down on the veranda and was tightening its legs.

Alok was holding a screwdriver.

They were arguing now and then, but not as they had the previous day.

"Hold it here."

"I am holding it."

"Straight."

"It is straight."

Eera laughed.

In the kitchen Aparna was putting a fresh bunch of marigolds into water.

Not tuberose.

"These today?" Eera asked.

"Yes. They were fresh in the market."

"Does Dadi like them?"

Aparna stopped.

"I didn't ask."

Eera said, "Ask her."

Aparna smiled. "Yes."

A little later Shailaja Devi came out.

Aparna showed her the flowers.

"Mummyji, shall I keep these or bring others?"

Shailaja looked at the marigolds.

"These are fine. I like marigolds better."

Aparna stared.

"You do? I thought it was tuberose."

Shailaja said, "Your father-in-law liked tuberose."

The room became silent again.

Then Shailaja herself laughed.

"See? How many things we run on assumption."

Aparna laughed too.

Eera touched one petal of a marigold.

It was fresh.

That afternoon Nachiket took the pieces of the vase to a glass repairer.

The repairer said, "I can join it, but the lines will remain. It would not be wise to keep water in it."

Nachiket telephoned Shailaja.

Shailaja said, "Have it joined. We won't put water in it."

"Then what will we do with it?"

"We'll see."

Three days later the vase came back.

The lines were plainly visible.

One piece had not fitted exactly, so one edge was slightly crooked.

Shailaja looked at it for a long time.

Aparna asked, "Shall I put it in the cupboard?"

Shailaja said, "No."
 Nor did she ask for it to be placed on the table.
 The newly tightened table now stood steady.
 Shailaja had the vase placed on a small shelf beside the window.
 There was no water inside.
 Era asked, "No flowers?"
 Shailaja said, "Not now."
 For several days the vase remained empty.
 Its broken lines shone in the sunlight.
 Era kept looking at it.
 One day, coming home from school, she picked up five dry seed pods from the roadside and brought them with her.
 "Shall I put these in it?"
 Shailaja looked at the pods.
 "These aren't flowers."
 "That is why they don't need water."
 Shailaja smiled.
 "Put them in."
 Era stood the five pods in the vase.
 Dry seed forms inside the broken glass looked strangely beautiful.
 Aparna saw them from a distance.
 "Who made this arrangement?"
 Era raised her hand.
 Aparna said, "It's good."
 Era asked at once, "Truly?"
 "Yes."
 "Not for guests?"
 Aparna was silent for a moment, then laughed.
 "No. For the house."
 Era liked that answer very much.
 Nachiket came home that evening.
 He saw the vase.
 "Where are the flowers?"
 Era said, "Now it has seeds."
 "Why?"
 "Because it cannot hold water."
 Nachiket looked at the repaired cracks.
 "All right."
 From the veranda Shailaja said, "Everything cannot be used in exactly the same way as before."
 Alok, who was drinking tea just then, added, "The table is all right now too."
 Aparna said, "Three months late."
 Nachiket said, "Yes, yes. It has been entered in the record."
 Everyone laughed.
 Era too.
 That laughter did not erase the previous day's quarrel.

But it had blunted its edge.
A few weeks later the marigolds began to wilt.
This time Aparna changed them without waiting for a celebration.
Era noticed.
“There are no guests today.”
Aparna said, “Flowers are not only for guests.”
Era said nothing.
She went to the window.
On the small shelf, the repaired vase still held the dry seed pods.
There was not a single flower in it.
Even so, it did not look empty.
Era remembered what she had said that day—the flowers were already wilting.
Now she understood that she had been right only about the flowers.
The adults knew more about the table.
Dadi knew more about the history of the vase.
Her mother knew more about the exhaustion of the house.
No single person saw the whole scene.
That day she had simply noticed the wilted petals.
Perhaps that much had been her part.
Era straightened one of the five dry pods.
Sunlight fell on the broken lines of glass.
The lines did not disappear.
But light passed through them.

The Dry Kamala

Gopi, if you were here, I would not have to stop so many times to ask directions.

You remembered everything.

Which field came after which ridge, where the footpath turned behind which clump of bamboo, how far the ghat was from which mango tree - everything.

I remember names, not directions.

Now I am standing beside this dry channel and wondering - is this the same Kamala or not?

There is no water.

There is sand.

Grass has sprung up here and there.

At two places children are playing bat and ball.

A goat is licking the wood of an old boat buried in the sand.

You would have laughed if you had seen it.

You would have said, 'Do people play in a river's belly?'

I would have said, 'When the river has left its water behind, people are hardly going to leave the space empty.'

Then you would have said, 'A river does not abandon a place. It only closes its eyes for a few days.'

I remember that sentence of yours.

Much else is blurred.

I have turned seventy-eight, Gopi.

You stopped at fifty-six.

That is why I still feel you are my younger brother.

Time stopped adding years to you; it did not stop adding them to me.

From the railway station to the village, one once had to take a bullock cart.

Now there is a road.

Concrete.

Shops on both sides.

Where we used to say there were paddy fields, there are now three motorcycle-repair shops.

A chemist's shop.

A marriage hall.

A tea-and-milk stall.

The village has the same name, but the face of its entrance has changed.

The first thing I looked for after getting down was the peepal tree.

It was not there.

You used to say, 'When you see the peepal, you will know you are home.'

The peepal has been cut down.

An electric pole stands in its place.

A blue board on the pole says: 'Pipra Panchayat.'
 I had to read the name to know that I really had returned.
 Otherwise the road recognised nothing for me.
 Gopi, I have come this time to see the land.
 Yes, the same old five kathas.
 On paper, the names of our descendants are still entered against yours and mine.
 My son said, 'Babu, go and see it once. Then we will decide whether to sell it or keep it.'
 I asked, 'What am I to see?'
 He said, 'The boundaries.'
 Boundaries!
 If you were alive, you would laugh until your stomach hurt.
 Look for the boundary of land beside the Kamala from a piece of paper?
 Even so, I have come.
 The file is in my bag.
 There is also a photocopy of the old map.
 The paper says: Kamala to the north, Ramcharitra Yadav's field to the south, a mango orchard to the east, and a public footpath to the west.
 Three of those four things have disappeared.
 I cannot tell whether 'Kamala' means this dry channel or the new channel in the distance.
 Ramcharitra Yadav is dead. His son divided the field and built five houses on it.
 The mango orchard has been cut down.
 The footpath has been absorbed into the road.
 The paper is still straight.
 The earth has gone crooked.
 First I went toward the old ghat.
 It is hardly right to call it a ghat now.
 Where the ghat stood, there are two brick houses.
 Clothes were drying in the courtyard of one of them.
 I asked, 'Was there a river here before?'
 The woman of the house looked at me in surprise.
 She said, 'A very long time ago.'
 I laughed when I heard 'a very long time ago.'
 What seems like yesterday to me is, for her, a very long time ago.
 She must be thirty-five or forty.
 The river must have moved away from here before she was born.
 I said, 'There was a ghat here. One stone step.'
 She said, 'I have heard about it.'
 Heard about it.
 Gopi, something I saw with my own eyes has now become something another person has only heard about.
 What is old age, if not this?
 The woman offered me water.
 I did not sit down.
 I went on.

The sand in the dry channel is hard.
 In some places the feet do not sink at all.
 Do you remember how, even in Jeth, the middle of the channel used to be soft
 underfoot?
 We would take off our shoes and carry them in our hands while crossing.
 You would stop halfway and splash water.
 I would scold you - the books will get wet.
 You would say - the books can be dried; where will we find Jeth's water again?
 It is not Jeth now, but Ashwin.
 Even so, there ought to be at least a thin ribbon of water.
 There is none.
 Far to the east the new channel is glinting.
 People say the river has shifted over there.
 'Shifted' - as though an old woman had moved her cot and sat in another corner.
 I saw how a river shifts.
 In the first monsoon the bank was cut.
 The next year the current split into two.
 In the third year sand filled the old bend.
 After that, in no year did the water return.
 By then I was no longer in the village.
 I was in Darbhanga for my job.
 You were here.
 You had written in a letter: 'This year the Kamala has turned its face away from
 our house.'
 I did not understand the sentence then.
 I thought perhaps the flood had been smaller.
 Now I understand.
 For a river to turn its face away means the entire geography is written anew.
 I do not know where your letter is now.
 It was in the large trunk.
 When the boys moved house, they may have thrown the trunk away or given it to
 someone - I have not been able to ask.
 I learned the value of papers late.
 You were a map without paper.
 Look, there is a shami tree here.
 I think the old deep pool used to be somewhere near this spot.
 The place where we used to catch fish.
 You would say, 'This is not a deep pool. It is the Kamala's eye.'
 Why did you say that?
 You were very fond of inventing names for things.
 The people of the village laughed.
 So did I.
 You never took offence.
 You would say, 'Give a thing a name and you remember it.'
 You were right.
 The pool is gone now, but 'the Kamala's eye' remains in my memory.

The name has survived; the thing has not.
 A little farther on I met a boy.
 He was pushing a bicycle.
 He asked, 'Baba, where are you going?'
 I said, 'I am looking for the old Mishra Tola.'
 He asked, 'Whose house?'
 I told him my name.
 He did not recognise it.
 I told him your name.
 He still did not recognise it.
 I felt nothing.
 Why should a sixteen-year-old boy recognise the name of someone who died
 thirty-three years ago?
 Then he asked, 'Whose grandson are you?'
 I told him Babuji's name.
 His face lit up.
 'Oh! The old pond-house?'
 I was startled.
 Pond?
 When had our house become the pond-house?
 The boy said, 'Where the pond is now, your family's orchard used to be, didn't it?'
 Gopi, just understand this.
 Where there was an orchard, there is a pond.
 Where there was a river, there are houses.
 Where there were fields, there is a road.
 Which map am I to believe?
 The boy began walking with me.
 His name was Vishal.
 He said his grandfather had known you.
 'Gopi Kaka?' he asked.
 I stopped.
 'You have heard the name?'
 'Dada used to say he was a very fast swimmer.'
 I laughed.
 You really were a fast swimmer.
 But I was less pleased by the story of your swimming than by the fact that your
 name had not vanished entirely.
 It had survived in somebody's grandfather's story.
 Vishal said, 'He helped many people across during the flood too, didn't he?'
 I nodded.
 Yes, that year.
 Was it eighty-seven or eighty-eight?
 I do not trust myself with years any more.
 The water had crossed the threshold of the house.
 You had tied bamboo together into a raft.
 You ferried across three children, two old women, and a calf.

I reached from the city two days later.
 By then you had become a hero.
 You had said, 'Not a hero. There simply was no boat.'
 I remember that too.
 How many sentences remain, while the face itself is growing blurred.
 Is that an injustice or not?
 Vishal took me toward the new embankment.
 He said, 'Climb up here. You can see the old channel from above.'
 I climbed slowly.
 My knees hurt.
 Vishal pushed the bicycle with one hand and tried to support me with the other.
 I said, 'No. I can walk by myself.'
 If you were here, you would say, 'Even old age has not cured you of pride.'
 I would say, 'It would not cure you either.'
 You would laugh.
 The wind was strong on the embankment.
 From above I saw the dry old Kamala on one side and the glinting new channel
 far away on the other.
 Between them lay fields, houses, a brick kiln, scrub, a pond, a road.
 Gopi, a river is not only water.
 The old path of a river is also part of the river's history.
 I understand that now.
 Vishal said, 'Baba, look over there. Behind that tin roof - your family's old land
 should be there.'
 'Should be?'
 'Dada used to say so.'
 Again - a geography heard from someone else.
 I opened the map.
 The wind nearly carried the paper away.
 Vishal somehow held it down.
 On the map, the Kamala was a blue line.
 Not straight, but fixed.
 On the earth, the Kamala was not fixed.
 A river does not grow old on paper.
 Its course does not change.
 Beside it, my five kathas lie equally fixed.
 I said to Vishal, 'According to this paper, I am beside the river.'
 He looked down at the dry channel.
 'It must have been so when the paper was made.'
 'Yes.'
 'It is not so now.'
 'Yes.'
 That ought to have ended the matter.
 But the mind would not accept it.
 I began telling you - see, Gopi, the land stayed and the river went away.
 Then I thought to myself - where is the land the same either?

Sand was deposited.
 Soil was cut away.
 Someone shifted a ridge.
 Someone filled a hollow.
 Someone built a house.
 The name stayed the same; the substance changed.
 If you were alive, perhaps you would say, 'The world runs on names.'
 Or something else?
 I do not want to invent your answer.
 It is easy to put one's own wisdom into the mouth of the dead.
 I will not say in your name what you never said.
 I take care about that now.
 I did not before.
 How many times after your death did I tell people, 'Gopi used to think this way.'
 Did you really think that, or was I speaking on your behalf?
 How much was mine?
 How much yours?
 The dead slowly dissolve into the language of the living.
 It is not right, but it happens.
 Vishal asked, 'Who are you talking to?'
 I was startled.
 'My brother.'
 'Where is he?'
 I looked down toward the old channel.
 'He is no longer here.'
 Vishal was silent for a moment.
 Then he said, 'My Dada is gone too. Sometimes I talk to him.'
 That was all.
 He said it so simply that I felt no need to explain myself.
 The two of us walked farther along the embankment.
 Below us, kans grass had grown in one place.
 There Vishal said, 'The old cremation ground was on this side.'
 I stopped.
 'The old one?'
 'The new ghat is over there now.'
 He pointed east.
 Gopi, you were cremated here.
 I understood all at once.
 The river flowed here then.
 I was here, Babuji, your two sons, the whole village.
 Smoke above.
 Water below.
 The cold of Magh.
 Your body in the fire.
 Even now I remember that I could not cry.
 Everyone kept saying - he is the elder brother, he must hold himself together.

I kept looking at the wood.
 You were fifty-six.
 A fever worsened.
 Three days in hospital.
 Then it was over.
 No river accident.
 No heroic death.
 An ordinary death.
 The man who had saved people in a flood died of a fever.
 Life does not choose its ending according to the story.
 That day I had released your ashes into the Kamala.
 Now that place is dry.
 Gopi, the thought struck me in a strange way.
 I had always thought - the river carried your ashes away.
 Now the river itself is no longer here.
 Then did the river carry you too toward its new channel?
 A meaningless question.
 I know.
 Who can know how far ashes travel?
 Even so, the mind makes questions.
 Vishal asked, 'Shall we sit?'
 I said, 'Yes.'
 We sat on the grass of the embankment.
 There was less smell of earth in the air than of dust.
 Someone was burning paddy stubble in the distance.
 The smoke slanted away.
 It reminded me of the smoke from your pyre.
 Then I stopped myself.
 Not every smoke is death.
 Stubble is stubble.
 Does one need old age to learn even this?
 Vishal gave me his bottle of water.
 I drank.
 He asked, 'Will you sell the land?'
 'I don't know.'
 'Prices are rising here.'
 I laughed.
 'You know the prices?'
 'Everyone does.'
 True.
 A village boy knows the market price of land; I do not know where my land is.
 Time apportions its tasks well.
 I opened the file and read out the khata number.
 Vishal said I could get a copy of the records at the panchayat office.
 My son had told me the same thing.
 But before seeing the papers, I had wanted to see the earth.

Without the earth, the papers make no sense.
 And the earth does not obey what the papers say.
 It was nearing noon.
 Vishal had to go home.
 He said, 'Shall I drop you at Mishra Tola?'
 I said, 'You go. I will come slowly.'
 'Do you know the way?'
 I laughed.
 'No. But today it is necessary for me to lose my way.'
 He looked at me, perhaps not understanding the sentence.
 'All right, Baba.'
 He mounted his bicycle and rode away.
 I went down into the old channel again.
 I looked at my footprints in the sand.
 The wind had already erased half of them.
 Gopi, I thought - I will not be foolish enough to look for your footprints.
 The earth does not preserve anyone's feet for so many years.
 The earth is not a memorial.
 It is used - by water, sand, grass, houses, paths.
 I began looking for the place where my five kathas might now lie.
 I kept the paper's north and south in my head.
 An old farmer was in a field.
 His name was Jagdish Mahto.
 The moment he saw my face he asked, 'Are you Dharnidhar Babu?'
 I stared in surprise.
 'You recognised me?'
 He laughed.
 'Not by your face. By the way you walk.'
 'By the way I walk?'
 'Your Babuji too used to walk with his neck slightly thrust forward like that.'
 Babuji came back to me all at once.
 His neck forward?
 I had never noticed.
 Jagdish must be seven or eight years younger than I am.
 He knew you well.
 'Gopi Babu used to talk a great deal,' he said.
 I laughed.
 'That is true.'
 Jagdish led me to the edge of the field.
 'Your family's land used to begin from here.'
 'Used to?'
 'The boundary has changed now. After the new survey, it was fixed again.'
 He pointed out three houses, a pond, and a small mustard field.
 'All this?'
 'Some of it was sold. Some divided. Some is still under an old dispute.'
 I opened the file.

Jagdish raised a hand to stop me.
 'Look at the papers in the panchayat office. You will not find the old boundary here with your eyes.'
 I closed the file.
 He was right.
 Then I asked, 'When did the Kamala move away from here?'
 Jagdish thought for a long time.
 'It is hard to name one year. Slowly.'
 That was the answer I needed.
 Slowly.
 The river did not disappear in one night.
 Just as a family does not split in a single day.
 Just as a village does not become the edge of a town in one year.
 Just as a brother's voice does not end on the day he dies.
 Slowly, things leave their places.
 And one day, when you look back, the geography has changed.
 Jagdish asked, 'Why have you come after so many years?'
 'The land.'
 He laughed.
 'Land brings people back.'
 I said, 'Or memory?'
 He said, 'Is there a difference?'
 I did not answer.
 Gopi, Jagdish still asks questions like that.
 Did he ask them before too?
 You would remember.
 I do not.
 He took me home for a meal.
 Rice, dal, potato curry, curd.
 His daughter-in-law asked, 'Do you live in the city?'
 I said, 'In Patna, with my son.'
 'You do not come to the village?'
 'Rarely.'
 'Rarely' was easy to say.
 The truth was that I had not come for ten years.
 For the first two or three years after you died, I kept coming.
 Then Babuji went.
 Ma went.
 Half the house collapsed in a flood.
 My son got a job.
 I retired.
 One reason after another.
 No single reason was enough; together they made a distance.
 After the meal Jagdish said, 'Will you see the old pond?'
 I went.
 Where our orchard used to be, there truly was a pond.

Green water.
 Ducks along the bank.
 A little girl playing beside her mother, who was washing clothes.
 I asked, 'How did this pond come to be?'
 Jagdish said, 'They dug out the soil. Bricks were made from it. Water collected in the pit. Later the panchayat had it deepened.'
 I kept looking for the orchard.
 There had been four mango trees in it.
 One guava.
 Once you fell while plucking mangoes.
 Your right hand split open.
 Ma did not let you climb a tree for seven days.
 On the eighth day you climbed again.
 Now ducks swim in that place.
 Gopi, I felt sorrow.
 Then, after a while, I felt something good too.
 The land became a pit, the pit a pond, the pond filled with water, and ducks came into the water.
 Not every change is a loss.
 That is difficult to accept, especially when the loss is one's own.
 Jagdish said, 'This pond is used for irrigation now.'
 I nodded.
 Our orchard has become water for other people.
 That sentence came to my mind.
 I will not put it into your mouth.
 It is my sentence.
 Evening began to fall.
 I went to the place where our old house had stood.
 There is no house.
 Half a wall remains.
 Moss on the bricks.
 The doorframe is gone.
 The tulsi altar in the courtyard is gone.
 Ma used to tend it.
 I touched the wall.
 Nothing on it was recognisable.
 At one place the limewash was blue.
 I remembered - one year you had said we should paint the outer wall blue.
 Babuji had refused: 'A house is not a temple.'
 You had secretly painted one corner blue.
 Was this the same blue?
 I do not know.
 How many layers of colour can lie beneath moss?
 I took my hand away.
 Not every mark needs to be turned into evidence.
 In the last light of evening, the new Kamala glinted in the distance.

I decided to go there.
 My feet were tired, but I went.
 To reach the new channel, one must cross the old Kamala.
 Across the sand between them, the fields, the road.
 A culvert.
 An embankment.
 Then water.
 Here the Kamala was not narrow.
 It flowed slowly, dark in colour.
 A new ghat stood on the bank.
 Two women were washing clothes.
 A man was casting a net.
 Some children were bathing.
 Life had moved with the river.
 The old channel dried, but the river did not go alone.
 The ghat, the nets, bathing, stories - all of them changed place.
 I sat down on the bank.
 Gopi, your ashes were not released into this water.
 This is new water.
 Or is it the same river?
 The name is the same.
 The water is different.
 The path is different.
 The question is old.
 I put my hand into the water.
 Cold.
 You would say, 'You recognise a river not with your hand, but with your feet.'
 Or am I inventing that sentence?
 See, I have started again.
 Dead brother, it is not difficult for you to remain silent; what is difficult is for me
 to let you remain silent.
 I took my hand out of the water.
 For a while I sat without speaking.
 For the first time all day, I said nothing to you.
 I watched the water.
 That was all.
 The sun sank lower.
 The sky went from yellow to red, then grey.
 A boat crossed the river.
 The sound of its small motor travelled a long way.
 I remembered the old dinghy, but I did not compare them.
 It is not always right to measure a new thing by the measure of the old.
 That night I stayed at a relative's house in Mishra Tola.
 After I lay down on the cot, sleep took a long time to come.
 Dogs barked outside.
 Someone was singing far away.

I said to you again, 'Gopi, should I sell the land?'
 Naturally, no answer came.
 Earlier I would have invented the answer you might have given.
 Today I did not.
 I thought for myself.
 The five kathas have a market value.
 My son needs the money.
 I am not going to farm.
 I have no intention of returning to the village permanently.
 Then selling it would not be wrong.
 But the boundaries must be clear.
 I will not claim as mine and sell what is not mine.
 Whatever the river took, whatever changed in the new survey, whatever went in
 the partition - all of it must be understood.
 The decision will not be yours; it will be mine.
 Saying that brought a lightness inside me.
 It is all right to speak to a dead brother.
 It is not all right to make him take decisions for you.
 At dawn I went again toward the dry channel.
 There was a light mist.
 The sand was damp with the night's dew.
 Some of yesterday's footprints remained; some had vanished.
 I reached the place where Vishal had said the old cremation ground used to be.
 The kans grass moved in the breeze.
 I had brought no flowers.
 No incense.
 No water.
 I only stood there.
 I said to you, 'I will have the land measured. I will act according to whatever turns
 out to be true.'
 That sentence had nothing to do with your death.
 Even so, it felt necessary to say it to you.
 Perhaps because we had thought through so many decisions together.
 That too was one meaning of being brothers.
 Then I looked around.
 At the place where you were given to the fire, there is grass now.
 A house a little distance away.
 A child untying a cow.
 Two women gathering cow-dung cakes on the dry channel.
 The sky clear.
 No sacred silence.
 Life moving in its ordinary sounds.
 I liked that.
 Memory does not need a temple every day.
 Sometimes grass is enough.
 I turned back toward the road.

The dry Kamala receded behind me.
 The new channel was not visible ahead, but I knew it was there.
 Gopi, until yesterday I thought the Kamala had dried up.
 Today I understand - the channel I kept looking at has dried up.
 Not the river.
 The whole village can fit inside that difference.
 The old peepal is gone.
 But the village remains.
 The house is gone.
 But people remain.
 The orchard is gone.
 But there is a pond.
 You are gone.
 But your name is in the story told by Vishal's grandfather, in my sentences, in Jagdish's memory.
 I stopped as soon as I had said that.
 Then I added silently - and in some places, it is not there at all.
 It would be wrong to call something preserved where it has not been preserved.
 Some things truly do end.
 I am forgetting the exact sound of your voice.
 It hurts to admit that.
 But it would be more wrong to put my own voice in your place.
 When I reached the road, I took the file from my bag.
 I looked once more at the map.
 The blue line of the Kamala still flowed in its old place.
 I took out a pencil and changed nothing on the map.
 Why should I draw my memory onto a government document?
 I wrote only a small note in the margin: 'Land seen: Ashwin.'
 I wrote the date.
 That was all.
 When it was time to catch the passenger train, the sand of the old channel was shining in the distance.
 I said to you one last time, 'Come, Gopi.'
 Then I laughed at myself.
 Where would you come from?
 I walked on by myself.
 I learned this late, brother.
 The dead begin some roads with us.
 But in the end, it is the living who must lift their feet and walk.

The House of Sand

Subhadra Devi stopped the moment she set foot on the sand.

“Not here,” she said.

Prabhakar asked, “What?”

“Our house was not here.”

Kaveri looked across the white sand stretching into the distance.

“Then where?”

Subhadra raised a hand, but could not settle on a direction.

To the east the new Kosi glimmered.

Behind them was the embankment.

Between the two lay a broad expanse of sand.

No tree.

No field ridge.

No threshold.

No well.

That a house had stood there thirty years earlier survived only in the memories of four people, not upon the earth.

With Subhadra Devi had come her son Prabhakar, her daughter Kaveri, and Prabhakar’s fifteen-year-old daughter, Meeta.

This was Meeta’s first visit to the village.

She had been born after the family was already living in the new settlement west of the embankment.

The old village was a story to her.

A story in which there was a house, a courtyard, a neem tree, a cowshed, and one day the river came very close to the house.

Then the house was no more.

Subhadra Devi never said, “It was washed away.”

She said, “It was eroded away.”

Meeta had never quite understood the difference between those two expressions.

Now, standing on the sand, she tried to.

Prabhakar said, “Ma, the old settlement was right here. Naresh Kaka said so.”

Subhadra Devi shook her head.

“The settlement may have been here. Our house was not.”

Kaveri laughed.

“Ma, if the settlement was here, where could the house have gone?”

Subhadra looked at her daughter.

“You were sixteen then. Do you remember everything?”

“If I do not remember, do you remember everything?”

Prabhakar wanted to smile at the remark, but saw Subhadra’s face and remained silent.

The wind lifted the sand.
 It drew fine lines beside their feet, then erased them.
 Meeta bent down and picked up a fistful of sand.
 Subhadra immediately said, "Your hands will get dirty."
 Meeta laughed.
 "Dadi, it is only sand."
 "Sand makes things dirty too."
 Prabhakar said, "After thirty years, that is still the first thing you say?"
 Subhadra looked at him.
 "First thing about what?"
 "That Meeta should not touch the sand."
 Subhadra smiled.
 The tension eased a little.
 They began walking slowly forward.
 Naresh Kaka, who now lived in the new settlement, had said that morning,
 "When the river shifted east, the sand over the old village lay exposed again. If you
 want to see it, see it now. After the rains, its shape will change again."
 "Lay exposed."
 Subhadra had remained silent for a long time over those words.
 As though the entire house had survived intact beneath the sand and was now
 emerging into the open.
 But nothing had emerged here.
 Only level sand.
 Two herdsman in the distance.
 A few goats.
 A clump of kans grass in one place.
 Meeta asked, "How big was the house?"
 Prabhakar said, "Very big."
 Kaveri immediately said, "Not very big."
 "It seemed small to you?"
 "You were a child. Everything seems big to a child."
 Prabhakar laughed.
 "You are two years younger than I am."
 "Then why should I accept your childhood measurements?"
 Meeta kept looking from one face to the other.
 Subhadra said, "The house was neither big nor small. It was as large as it needed to
 be."
 Meeta asked, "How many rooms?"
 "Three," Prabhakar said.
 "Four," Kaveri said.
 They looked at each other.
 Subhadra said slowly, "Three at first. Later, a small storeroom was built beside the
 veranda."
 Kaveri smiled as though she had won.
 Prabhakar said, "That storeroom does not count."
 "Why?"

"Grain was kept in it."
 Subhadra said, "Grain lives in a house too."
 Meeta burst out laughing.
 With a finger, she drew a small square in the sand.
 "Like this?"
 Prabhakar said, "Far too small."
 Meeta enlarged the square.
 Kaveri said, "The courtyard was in the middle."
 Meeta left an empty space in the centre.
 Subhadra watched.
 "Which way was the door?" Meeta asked.
 Prabhakar pointed east.
 "This way."
 Kaveri said, "No, south."
 Prabhakar laughed.
 "You remember nothing."
 "I remember clearly. When you came out through the door, the tulsi altar was on the left."
 "The tulsi altar was in the courtyard."
 "Yes, but the main door faced south."
 Both looked at Subhadra.
 Subhadra kept her gaze fixed on the sand.
 "It faced east at first," she said.
 Prabhakar smiled.
 "See?"
 Subhadra added, "Later, your Babuji had a new gate made on the south side."
 Kaveri smiled.
 "See?"
 Meeta giggled.
 "Both are right."
 Subhadra said, "Memory does not always lie. Sometimes it remembers different times."
 Everyone fell silent at that sentence.
 The wind rose again.
 One edge of Meeta's square disappeared.
 She drew it again.
 Prabhakar scanned the sand and said, "The neem tree must have been somewhere around here."
 Subhadra immediately said, "The neem was behind the house."
 "Yes, so this would have been behind it."
 "When you do not know where the house stood, how do you know where behind is?" Kaveri said.
 Prabhakar fell silent.
 He was irritated, but said nothing.
 Thirty years earlier, the erosion had not taken the house in a single day.
 First the fields went.

Then the bamboo grove.
 Then the earth behind the cowshed cracked.
 The villagers began removing things from the house.
 The door leaves.
 Charpoys.
 Sacks of grain.
 Utensils.
 Trunks.
 The bamboos from the roof.
 Some things were saved.
 Some were left behind.
 At last, half the house collapsed into the river.
 The family themselves dismantled the remaining half to salvage the materials.
 That was why Subhadra never said, "It was washed away."
 Being washed away seemed to happen in a single moment.
 Erosion had waiting in it.
 Time to watch the loss come a little at a time, day after day.
 Meeta had heard this from her grandmother many times.
 Today she asked, "You all kept watching it happen?"
 Subhadra said, "What else could we have done?"
 Meeta was silent.
 Prabhakar said, "I was sent to town."
 Kaveri said, "Ma and I stayed."
 "I stayed for two days too."
 "Then you went to Mama's."
 Prabhakar's voice hardened slightly.
 "I was a child."
 Kaveri softened at once.
 "Yes. So was I."
 Subhadra looked at both of them.
 "Why are you keeping accounts now of who was a child?"
 No one answered.
 Meeta kept enlarging the outline of the house in the sand.
 "Where was the kitchen?"
 Subhadra pointed to one corner.
 Kaveri said, "No, Ma, the kitchen was here."
 Subhadra glared at her.
 "Will you teach me where my kitchen was?"
 Kaveri laughed.
 "All right, you are right."
 Prabhakar said quietly, "Ma, perhaps the directions have become reversed."
 Subhadra said, "The directions have not turned around. The earth has."
 Meeta's finger stopped at the words.
 "The earth has turned around."
 She liked the sentence.
 But she said nothing.

They reached the clump of kans grass.
 There the sand lay a little lower.
 It was damp.
 Subhadra stopped abruptly.
 "The well was here."
 Prabhakar was startled.
 "The well?"
 "Yes."
 Kaveri said, "I remember the well as being very close to the house."
 "Then the house must have been close to here."
 Subhadra bent down and touched the dampness.
 Her fingers trembled.
 Meeta thought her grandmother would cry.
 But Subhadra merely dusted off her hand and straightened up.
 "The dampness may not be because of the well either," Prabhakar said carefully.
 "Did I say this was water from that very well?"
 Subhadra's voice had gone sharp.
 Prabhakar stepped back.
 Kaveri tried to change the subject.
 "Ma, the trunk of the neem tree was very thick, wasn't it?"
 "Thick."
 "Then perhaps some roots have survived?"
 Subhadra said, "You want to search for roots beneath thirty years of sand?"
 Kaveri said nothing.
 Meeta used the damp sand to make a small mound with her hands.
 "This is the well," she said.
 Prabhakar smiled.
 Subhadra did not.
 She kept looking into the distance.
 Noon was advancing.
 The sand dazzled the eyes.
 Prabhakar took out a bottle of water.
 Everyone sat down.
 There was no shade anywhere to sit in.
 Kaveri put a gamchha over her head.
 Meeta asked, "Where did you all live after the erosion?"
 Prabhakar said, "First, in the camp set up at the school."
 Kaveri said, "Three weeks."
 Subhadra said, "Six weeks."
 Both looked at their mother again.
 Subhadra shook her head.
 "First the school. Then your Mama's house. Then a hut west of the embankment.
 Altogether, more than six weeks."
 Kaveri said, "I was asking only about the school."
 "Then three."
 Meeta laughed.

"Again, both are right."
 Prabhakar said, "This girl has become the judge now."
 Meeta said, "I am only separating the times."
 For the first time, Subhadra looked at her closely.
 "Your father has the habit of mixing things together. You separate them."
 Prabhakar made a theatrically wounded face.
 "Now the complaints against me begin."
 Everyone laughed.
 The laughter sounded strangely open on the sand.
 No one was near.
 Only the wind.
 Subhadra suddenly said, "That night your Babuji was taking down the bamboos of the roof."
 Prabhakar and Kaveri fell silent.
 Meeta had never seen her great-grandfather.
 There was a photograph of Raghunath Mishra at home - dhoti, shirt, thick moustache.
 Subhadra said, "People told him to leave them, the water was already close. He kept saying, 'These bamboos will be used in the new house.'"
 Kaveri asked softly, "Were they?"
 Subhadra laughed.
 "Some of them. Many had warped."
 Prabhakar asked, "Did Babuji cry that night?"
 Subhadra looked at him.
 "Why do you ask?"
 "No reason."
 Subhadra remained silent for a long time.
 "No."
 Then she said, "I did not see him cry."
 That answer changed the first "no."
 Prabhakar lowered his head.
 Subhadra said, "A person's weeping is not always visible."
 Meeta kept stirring the sand with her fingers.
 Kaveri drank from the bottle.
 The wind had stopped.
 The heat intensified.
 After a while they saw an old man approaching from a distance.
 A walking stick rested on his shoulder.
 As he came closer, Kaveri recognised him.
 "Madhu Kaka?"
 The old man stopped.
 Kaveri told him her name.
 Madhu Mahato studied her face for a long time.
 "Ah, Raghunath Babu's daughter?"
 Kaveri laughed.
 "Yes."

Subhadra began to rise.
 Madhu Kaka immediately said, "Stay seated, Bhabhi."
 He too sat down on the sand.
 Prabhakar asked, "Kaka, where was our house?"
 Madhu Mahato looked all around.
 "The house?"
 "The old house."
 "Somewhere along this stretch."
 "Exactly where?"
 Madhu Kaka laughed.
 "Who can say exactly where?"
 Prabhakar looked disappointed.
 Subhadra said, "I keep saying it was not here."
 Madhu Kaka asked, "Where do you remember it?"
 Subhadra pointed east.
 "There."
 Madhu Kaka scratched his head.
 "Could be."
 Prabhakar asked, "The neem tree?"
 "Many houses had neem trees."
 Kaveri asked, "The well?"
 "There were three wells in this tola."
 Meeta looked at her grandmother.
 Subhadra was silent.
 Madhu Kaka said, "After the erosion, the river filled the place again, then sand piled over it. Layer upon layer of earth. Who knows whether the old threshold is still below or was carried away."
 Subhadra said quietly, "I did not come looking for the threshold."
 Madhu Kaka laughed.
 "All right."
 No one said anything for a while.
 Then Madhu Kaka noticed the lines Meeta had drawn.
 "What is this?"
 Meeta said, "The house."
 "Whose?"
 "Theirs."
 Madhu Kaka looked at the lines and laughed.
 "You have made the courtyard too small."
 Prabhakar immediately said, "See?"
 Kaveri asked, "Kaka, how much do you remember?"
 Madhu Kaka said, "My cow once got into their courtyard. It was large."
 Subhadra burst out laughing.
 "Your cow ate all my gourds."
 "You still remember that?"
 "Loss of gourds is not easily forgotten."
 Everyone laughed.

Meeta enlarged the courtyard.
 Kaveri said, "Not that much."
 Meeta stopped.
 "How am I supposed to draw it? Everyone says something different."
 Madhu Kaka said, "Draw it as you like."
 Subhadra immediately said, "No. This is not a game."
 Meeta fell silent.
 Subhadra saw her face.
 Then she softened her voice.
 "I mean, if you are drawing the house, ask before you draw."
 Meeta nodded.
 Madhu Kaka said, "Can a house be measured out of memory too?"
 Subhadra looked at him.
 "If I remember something wrongly, I will say it is wrong."
 "All right."
 Madhu Kaka got to his feet.
 "I am going to see to the cattle. Start back before evening. On sand, you lose your sense of direction quickly."
 He walked away.
 Meeta stared for a long time at the lines she had drawn.
 Then she asked, "Dadi, what is the clearest thing you remember about the house?"
 Without thinking, Subhadra said, "The smoke from the kitchen."
 Prabhakar was surprised.
 "Smoke?"
 "When the stove was lit in the morning, the smoke came out through the veranda. On rainy days it hung low."
 Kaveri said, "I remember the earth of the courtyard. Ma plastered it every day."
 Prabhakar said, "I remember the branch of the neem tree. I used to tie a rope to it and swing."
 Meeta asked, "Not the shape of the house?"
 Everyone was silent.
 Subhadra said, "Perhaps the shape is what I remember least."
 Meeta looked at the square she had drawn.
 She had been drawing the shape of the house, while each of them remembered something different.
 She erased the outline.
 Prabhakar asked, "Why?"
 "It was coming out wrong."
 Subhadra said, "Not wrong. It was one possible shape."
 Meeta smiled.
 "You were the one who said I should ask before drawing."
 Subhadra laughed.
 "All right."
 This time Meeta did not draw a house. She began making separate signs in the sand.

A circle - the well.
 A small square - the kitchen.
 A line - the veranda.
 A long stick-like mark - the neem tree.
 A large empty space in the middle - the courtyard.
 "The gate?" Prabhakar asked.
 Meeta left two small openings in two directions.
 Kaveri laughed.
 "Both gates."
 "Before and after," Meeta said.
 Subhadra studied it carefully.
 "Yes. Something like that."
 For the first time, she did not say "no."
 The afternoon light began to decline.
 The wind rose again.
 The edges of Meeta's signs began to break apart.
 Prabhakar took out his phone.
 "Let us take a photograph."
 Subhadra asked, "Of what?"
 "Of this house."
 Subhadra said, "This is not the house."
 Prabhakar paused.
 Meeta said, "A map of memory?"
 Subhadra smiled.
 "Call it only that."
 They stood around the lines.
 Prabhakar propped the phone against a stone, set the timer, and took the photograph.
 The picture showed four people, sand, a few lines, distant kans grass, and sky.
 The old house was not there.
 Meeta looked at the photograph.
 "Dadi, is it good?"
 Subhadra studied it for a long time.
 "I look old here."
 Everyone burst out laughing.
 Kaveri said, "You are old."
 "Quiet."
 The laughter opened out again.
 Prabhakar saved the photograph.
 Then he walked a little distance away by himself.
 As though searching for something in the sand.
 Kaveri followed him.
 "What?"
 "Nothing."
 "What kind of 'nothing' is this?"
 Prabhakar bent and picked up a fragment of an old baked brick.

Reddish brown.

"Look."

Kaveri took the fragment in her hand.

"Could this be from the house?"

"Could be."

"And it could belong to someone else's house too."

"Yes."

Prabhakar kept looking at the brick.

Kaveri said, "Will you take it?"

After a long moment Prabhakar said, "No."

He put the brick back on the sand.

"Why?"

"What use is there in calling something ours when we cannot prove it is ours?"

Kaveri looked at her brother's face.

"You have changed."

Prabhakar laughed.

"I am getting old."

They went back.

Subhadra was telling Meeta about the day of the erosion.

"First a crack opened behind the cowshed. Your great-grandfather filled it with earth. The next day, the crack came back."

Meeta asked, "Did you know then that the house would go?"

Subhadra said, "Knowing and accepting are different things."

"When did you accept it?"

Subhadra took time to answer.

"When we emptied the grain bin."

"Not when the house collapsed?"

"No. By the time the house collapsed, we were already living somewhere else."

Meeta was silent.

Subhadra said, "A house becomes empty from within first. The walls go later."

Prabhakar and Kaveri were listening from a distance.

Kaveri's eyes filled with tears.

She immediately turned her face away.

Prabhakar said nothing.

Subhadra may have seen, but she did not mention it.

The evening wind began to cool.

They prepared to leave.

By then Meeta's map was half erased.

Subhadra looked at it.

"Will you draw it again?" Meeta asked.

"Why?"

"The wind is erasing it."

Subhadra said, "Let it."

Meeta looked at her grandmother.

"Then the photograph will remain."

"Let the photograph remain."

Prabhakar said, "We can come again tomorrow."

Subhadra immediately said, "No."

"Why?"

"I have seen what I came to see."

Kaveri asked, "Did you find the place?"

Subhadra smiled.

"No."

"Then?"

"I did not find the place. I found some things about the house."

They walked toward the embankment.

Meeta kept looking back again and again.

The lines grew smaller.

Then vanished from sight.

By the time they reached Naresh Kaka's house in the new settlement, evening had fallen.

Dal was simmering on the stove.

Naresh Kaka asked, "Did you find the old house?"

Prabhakar laughed.

"No."

Naresh Kaka said, "I told you from the start - who can recognise a place on sand?"

Subhadra said, "You were right."

Naresh Kaka had perhaps not expected that admission.

He fell silent.

After dinner everyone sat in the courtyard.

The night was clear.

Meeta was looking through the day's photographs on the phone.

One showed Dadi touching the damp sand.

One showed Madhu Kaka.

One showed the house made of lines.

One showed all four of them.

Meeta asked, "May I show these photographs at school?"

Prabhakar said, "As you wish."

Subhadra asked, "What will you say?"

Meeta thought.

"I will not say, 'This was our old house.'"

"Then?"

"I will say: somewhere around this stretch of sand stood our family's house. I do not know the exact place."

Subhadra nodded.

"Good."

Kaveri said, "And say that the house had two gates."

Prabhakar laughed.

"Here we go again."

Everyone laughed.

That night Meeta slept in the same room as her grandmother.

After the light was switched off, Meeta asked, "Dadi, did you like the old house more, or the one you live in now?"

Subhadra was silent for a long time.

"Do not ask questions like that."

"Why?"

"The two houses belong to different times."

"Even so."

Subhadra turned over.

"In the old house there was your father's childhood. Kaveri's childhood. Your great-grandfather. The fields. The earth."

"In the new house your father was married. You were born. Your grandfather died there. That is where I now wake and sit each day."

Meeta asked quietly, "Then which one is home?"

Subhadra said, "Both."

"Even the one the river eroded away?"

"Yes."

"The one whose exact place you do not know?"

Subhadra laughed.

"Not knowing the place does not end a home."

Meeta asked again, "And if no one remembers it?"

This time Subhadra did not answer at once.

After a long while she said, "Then perhaps it ends. But that is natural."

Meeta was startled.

"Wouldn't that hurt you?"

"How long can everything remain remembered?"

"I will remember."

Subhadra placed a hand on her head.

"For as long as it remains in your mind of its own accord. Do not turn it into a duty."

Meeta closed her eyes.

The wind moved outside.

Someone put away utensils in the night.

A dog barked once.

Then silence.

Meeta woke early at dawn.

Subhadra was still asleep.

Prabhakar was drinking tea in the courtyard.

Meeta said, "Papa, will yesterday's house still be there?"

Prabhakar understood.

"The lines?"

"Yes."

"Depends on the wind."

Meeta said, "Shall we go and look once?"

Prabhakar glanced toward Dadi's room.

"Dadi will not go."

"Just the two of us?"

Prabhakar thought for a few moments.
 Then nodded.
 The two of them set out toward the embankment in the pale light of dawn.
 The sand was cool.
 None of yesterday's footprints remained.
 They guessed their way to the place where Meeta had drawn the house.
 A few lines survived.
 Most had disappeared.
 The circular sign for the well was gone.
 Half the line for the neem remained.
 One edge of the courtyard was visible.
 Of the two gates, only one survived.
 Meeta looked at it silently.
 Prabhakar asked, "Shall we draw it again?"
 Meeta shook her head.
 "No."
 They stood there for a while.
 In the distance, morning light lay on the water of the new Kosi.
 Prabhakar said, "I found a brick yesterday."
 Meeta asked, "From our house?"
 "I do not know."
 "Did you bring it?"
 "No."
 Meeta said, "You did right."
 Prabhakar laughed.
 "How do you know?"
 "If you do not know, it could belong to anyone."
 Prabhakar looked at his daughter.
 "You are beginning to talk like Dadi."
 Meeta said, "Dadi said yesterday: if I remember something wrongly, I will say it is wrong."
 The two started back.
 Behind them remained the half-erased house.
 For a moment Meeta thought of taking a photograph.
 Then she did not take out her phone.
 Yesterday's photograph was enough.
 Today's erasure needed to be seen too.
 When they returned to Naresh Kaka's house, Subhadra was awake.
 She asked, "Where had you gone?"
 Prabhakar said, "To the sand."
 Subhadra frowned.
 "I told you not to go."
 Meeta said, "We did not take you."
 Subhadra burst out laughing.
 "Very clever."
 Then she asked, "The lines?"

Meeta said, "Half of them are gone."

Subhadra was silent for a moment.

"Good."

That was all.

At noon the family set out for home.

As the vehicle climbed the embankment, the expanse of sand came into view once more.

Meeta kept looking out of the window.

Subhadra sat with her eyes closed.

Kaveri asked, "Ma, are you tired?"

"A little."

Prabhakar said, "Shall we come again next year?"

Subhadra opened her eyes.

"Why?"

Prabhakar had no answer.

Kaveri said, "Just like that."

Subhadra looked outside.

"The river will change again. The sand will change again. What we saw today will not remain next year either."

Meeta asked, "Then it is not necessary to come again?"

Subhadra said, "Nothing is necessary. If we feel like coming, we will come."

The vehicle moved on.

The sand fell behind.

The new Kosi remained alongside them for a while.

Then the road turned.

Meeta opened yesterday's photograph on her phone.

Four people standing on the sand.

Lines beneath their feet.

Sky in the distance.

She changed the name of the photograph to "The House of Sand."

Then, after thinking for a moment, she wanted to put a question mark after the word "House."

She did not.

Because the house did not depend upon the truth of the lines.

The lines could be wrong.

Directions could change.

The door could face two different ways at two different times.

The courtyard could be large in one person's memory, small in another's.

Yet the house could remain - in a different shape within each of them.

Meeta switched off the phone.

Subhadra was looking out of the window.

Her hands lay empty in her lap.

She had brought nothing back from the sand.

No brick.

No earth.

No dry grass.

Neither had Prabhakar.

Nor Kaveri.

The weight of what they were carrying away could not be measured.

Nor could the boundaries of what they had left behind.

The Sound of Bamboo

In the first watch of the night, the bamboo sounded.

Kharr... thak.

Then silence.

Shivnath opened his eyes.

Wind was moving over the roof of the old house.

The bamboo grove on the western side of the courtyard still survived.

Three bamboos leaned above the roof, two toward the wall.

When the wind grew strong, the bamboos rubbed against one another.

Sometimes a dry joint struck another.

Sometimes the leaves whispered.

Shivnath knew: it was the sound of bamboo.

Even so, at the first thak he remembered his father's walking stick.

When Jagdish Babu walked along the veranda at night, the stick made just such a thak.

Once.

Then twice.

Then, clearing his throat, he would say, "Shiva, are you asleep?"

Shivnath turned over.

There was no one in the house now except him.

His father had died three years ago.

His mother had gone before him.

His sister Jamuna was at her marital home.

His wife Neelam was in the city.

His son was abroad.

The sale of this house was being discussed.

A prospective buyer was coming tomorrow to inspect the land.

Shivnath had therefore come to the village one night in advance.

He had thought: it is only one night.

I will bolt the door and sleep.

In the morning I will look over the measurements.

By afternoon I will return.

But a night in the house was not as straight as measurements on paper.

Kharr... thak.

Shivnath sat up.

"Yes, Babu," slipped out of his mouth.

He laughed at himself.

"It is bamboo."

Whom was he explaining it to?

Himself.

He drank water from the lota.
A dog barked in the distance.
After a while, the wind rose again.
The bamboo leaves moved together.
Shivnath looked toward the roof.
“I know, Babu. You are not here.”
This time he said the sentence deliberately.
The room did not throw his voice back to him.
The earthen walls absorbed it.
Shivnath lay down again.
Sleep did not come.
He took out his phone.
The time was 10:54 p.m.
A message from Neelam: “Did you take your medicine? Bolt the door properly.”
He wrote back, “Yes.”
Then he felt like opening the old contact list.
Why?
He did not know himself.
His father’s number had never been deleted after three years.
The name still read “Babu—Village.”
The number was disconnected.
Many times Shivnath had thought of deleting the name.
He had not deleted it.
The sight of “Babu—Village” on the screen brought back an old tightening in his stomach.
His father’s final call had come from that number.
That night Shivnath had not answered it.
No one in the family knew this.
No one had even asked.
Shivnath had said, “I received the news in the morning.”
That was true.
But it was not the whole truth.
Kharr... thak.
“Is that why you are sounding?”
He asked the question of the wind.
The bamboo did not answer.
The sound stopped.
Before Shivnath’s eyes opened the night from three years earlier.
The house in Patna.
Rain.
Neelam asleep.
About half past ten at night.
The phone trembled on the table.
On the screen: “Babu—Village.”
Shivnath looked at it.
He did not answer.

Why?

He had been tired from work that night.

That was one reason.

His father had already spoken to him twice during the day.

That was another.

The first time he had said, "The bamboo is leaning over the roof. Get someone to cut it."

Shivnath had said, "Tell Ramsevak."

His father had said, "He lives in the city now."

"Then tell Bhola."

"Bhola will ask for money."

"Pay him."

His father had gone silent.

Annoyed, Shivnath had said, "Babu, why do you call me for every little job?"

There had been silence on the other end for a while.

Then his father had said, "If I do not tell you, whom should I tell?"

Shivnath's work meeting was about to begin.

He had said, "We will talk in the evening."

In the evening his father had called again.

That time they spoke for five minutes.

Less about the bamboo.

More about his eye.

His father's right eye had gone blurry.

The village doctor had told him to get it examined in the city.

His father had asked, "Can you come this week?"

Shivnath had said, "Next week, definitely."

He had said the word "definitely" very easily.

For three weeks he had been saying the same thing.

Next week.

Then next week again.

His father had said, "All right."

Whether that "all right" held resentment or weariness, Shivnath had not examined it then.

At half past ten the phone trembled again.

Shivnath looked at the screen.

His first thought: the bamboo again?

Then the eye?

Then money?

Then "When will you come?"

He turned the phone face down.

The ringing stopped.

A minute later it came again.

He did not answer that time either.

Neelam had asked, "Who is it?"

Shivnath had said, "From the village."

"Answer it."

"I will speak tomorrow."

That was all.

At around two in the morning, his father had fallen in the courtyard.

A neighbour saw him in the morning.

Where he had fallen, the walking stick lay some distance away.

Was Babu still alive when he fell, or not?

How long had he remained there needing help?

Why had he called?

No one had a certain answer to any of those questions.

The doctor had said his heart had stopped.

Whether before the fall or afterward, he could not say.

Shivnath knew that to say his father would certainly have survived if he had answered the phone would be a lie.

But he also knew he should have answered it.

For three years his life had moved between those two truths.

Kharr... kharr... thak.

Shivnath got out of bed.

He opened the door.

The veranda was dark.

A half-moon lay among clouds in the sky.

The bamboo grove bent in the wind.

He stood beside a veranda pillar.

"I did not answer your call, Babu."

For the first time in three years, the sentence was spoken aloud in full.

His throat went dry.

"I saw it. I read your name. I knew it was you."

The wind died.

The bamboo fell still.

Shivnath laughed, a bitter laugh.

"Why are you silent now? I am telling you, aren't I?"

At such moments in the night, the mind searches for meaning in sound.

If the wind blows, it is the father.

If the wind stops, the father is angry.

Shivnath shook his head.

"No. This is not a game."

He stepped down into the courtyard.

The earth was cold.

Weeds had grown in one corner.

His father used to sweep this courtyard every morning.

Shivnath would say, "Why so much? Earth is earth."

His father would say, "If we abandon the courtyard, the house will abandon us."

In the city Shivnath used to laugh at that sentence.

Now the house truly was preparing to leave him.

The buyer wanted to build a concrete house on this courtyard.

The bamboo would be cut.

The earthen walls would be broken.

The old well would be filled in.
 All of that was reasonable.
 Leaving the house empty to decay was not.
 Shivnath was not opposed to the decision.
 Even so, through the night he kept wondering: if Babu were alive now, what would he say?
 Then he stopped himself.
 It was very easy to put one's own answer into the mouth of the dead—he understood that now.
 No.
 The thought was not someone else's story he had heard.
 He only understood this much: it was very easy to manufacture answers for the dead.
 Babu would have said, "Sell it."
 Babu would have said, "Do not sell it."
 Shivnath could make either sentence suit his convenience.
 He decided he would not make the decision in his father's name.
 Crossing the courtyard, he went to the bamboo.
 The grove was old.
 Some culms were thick, some newly leafed.
 One bamboo really did lean over the roof.
 Had Babu been talking about this bend three years ago?
 Was it the same bamboo?
 Impossible.
 Bamboo changes in three years.
 New shoots rise.
 Old ones dry out.
 Someone cuts one.
 Another falls.
 Then why had Shivnath's guilt fastened itself to this one bamboo?
 Because there was the sound of bamboo.
 And sound opens a path.
 He raised his hand and touched the bamboo.
 Cold, smooth.
 The wind came.
 Above him two bamboos rubbed together.
 Eeee... kharr... thak.
 A shiver went through Shivnath's body.
 This time he remembered not his father's stick, but his father clearing his throat.
 "Shiva."
 Had he actually heard the word, or only in his mind?
 Shivnath's ears knew: bamboo.
 His mind said: voice.
 He closed his eyes.
 "You know why I went to the city, Babu."
 No one had asked him a question.

Yet the answer came.

“For a job.”

“To run the household.”

“To educate the children.”

“None of that was wrong.”

He kept speaking, sentence by sentence.

“What was wrong was that I kept believing there would be time next week.”

“What was wrong was that I turned everything you said into a list of tasks.”

“Cut the bamboo.”

“Get the eye examined.”

“Send the medicines.”

“Repair the roof.”

“Pension papers.”

“All lists.”

“You were not a list.”

He fell silent.

Leaves trembled on the bamboo.

Shivnath tried to remember his father’s face from his final year.

Not clearly.

The face existed in photographs.

In memory there were separate fragments.

White hairs between the eyebrows.

The arm of his spectacles behind his ear.

The dimple in his left cheek when he laughed.

The way he pressed his lips together when angry.

Shivnath found it difficult to assemble the whole face.

That hurt him in a different way from not answering the phone.

Sometimes, by holding on to guilt, a person begins to forget the person.

For three years, the night of Babu’s death had been Shivnath’s clearest memory.

But Babu’s living afternoons?

His laughter?

The way he walked in the fields?

The way he cut areca nut after meals?

All of that had blurred.

“I locked you inside the last phone call, Babu.”

As he said it, his eyes filled.

“That too is a wrong.”

He sat on the earth beside the bamboo.

His knees bent.

The night wind entered his clothes.

From the fields came a whistle-like sound in the distance.

Perhaps a train.

The village was no longer as quiet as before.

A highway had been built some distance away.

Even at night one could hear vehicles.

Babu used to be irritated by this change.

He would say, "Night should remain night."
Shivnath would say, "If there is a road, there is convenience."
Babu would say, "Convenience is not always peace."
They would argue.
At the memory of that argument, a faint smile came to Shivnath.
It was the first memory in which there was no death.
As though replying to Babu, he said, "The road is not bad."
Then he laughed at himself.
"See? I am still arguing with you."
The wind grew stronger again.
The bamboo leaves all sounded together.
The sound seemed less frightening to Shivnath now.
Rustling from every side.
A thak in between.
Not the music of a forest.
Only bamboo.
He got up and went inside the house.
There was an old lantern in the kitchen.
No oil.
Using the light from his phone, he heated water.
While making tea, Babu came to mind again.
Babu took little milk in his tea.
Half a spoon of sugar.
No cardamom.
Shivnath smiled.
He paused for a moment.
No.
Shivnath knew no one else's story.
He knew only his own father's tea.
That night he put less sugar in his own cup.
At the first sip he made a face.
"I still like it sweet."
He laughed.
Why impose his father's preference upon himself?
He sat on the veranda with the cup.
The phone was in his hand again.
"Babu—Village."
He opened the contact.
The old call history had vanished; the phone had been changed.
Only the name and number remained.
Shivnath kept his finger on the number.
There was no point in calling.
The number was disconnected.
Perhaps it had even been issued in someone else's name by now.
He withdrew his finger.
Then came the thought of changing Babu's name.

"Jagdish Babu."

"Babu."

"Old number."

He changed nothing.

He left the name as it was.

Memory did not require administrative tidying.

11:35 p.m.

Neelam called.

"Not asleep?"

"No."

"Everything all right?"

Shivnath wanted to say yes.

Habit.

Then he stopped.

"I cannot sleep."

"Why?"

"The bamboo is sounding."

Neelam laughed.

"The bamboo at the village house?"

"Yes."

"Have it cut tomorrow?"

Shivnath was silent.

Neelam asked, "What happened?"

"I am remembering some things."

"Babuji?"

Shivnath's throat tightened again.

"Yes."

Neelam said nothing for a long time.

Three years earlier, even she had not known that Shivnath had seen Babu's final call and deliberately not answered it.

She knew only this much: a call had come from the village at night, and Shivnath had said he would speak the next day.

Should he tell her now?

At night?

Over the phone?

Shivnath said, "Neelam."

"Yes?"

"That night Babu called twice."

"Yes, I remember."

"I saw the calls."

Silence on the other end.

"Meaning?"

"I deliberately did not answer."

The silence lengthened.

Shivnath began speaking hurriedly.

"We had already spoken during the day. I was tired. I thought it would be the same things again. I thought in the morning..."

Neelam said softly, "Stop."

Shivnath fell silent.

"You have kept this alone for all these years?"

The question was not what he had expected.

Shivnath said, "Yes."

"Why did you not tell me?"

"What would I have said?"

"What you are saying now."

Tears came from Shivnath's eyes.

Keeping his voice low, he said, "If I had answered..."

Neelam interrupted, "Who has the answer to that?"

"No one."

"Then say what is known."

Shivnath looked toward the bamboo.

"What is known is that I could have answered. I did not."

"Yes."

Neelam's "yes" was not forgiveness.

Nor blame.

Only acceptance of the fact.

Shivnath needed that "yes."

He said, "I have kept blaming myself for Babu's death."

Neelam said, "And you also know what the doctor said."

"Yes."

"Keep the two things separate."

Shivnath was silent.

Neelam said again, "The regret over not answering the phone will remain. But to make Babuji's death into something done by your own hand... perhaps that makes Babuji's life smaller too."

Shivnath asked quietly, "How?"

"For three years, in your mind, he has become only that night."

Shivnath trembled.

Neelam had touched exactly the place he himself had reached a short while earlier.

"Did you remember anything good about him today?"

Shivnath laughed through his tears.

"Our argument about the road."

"And?"

"Less sugar in his tea."

"And?"

"Sweeping the courtyard every morning."

"That is Babu too. Not only that night."

Shivnath looked at the earth of the veranda.

"Yes."

Neelam said, "Now try to sleep."

"I am not sleepy."

"Then sit for a while. But you will get cold."

"I am."

"Take a shawl."

Hearing this ordinary instruction, Shivnath suddenly felt trust in life.

He went and fetched a shawl.

Before ending the call Neelam asked, "Will you discuss the sale of the house tomorrow?"

"Yes."

"The bamboo?"

Shivnath looked toward the bamboo.

"We will see."

"All right."

The call ended.

Half the night had passed.

The wind weakened.

Shivnath sat on the veranda wrapped in the shawl.

The bamboo sounded from time to time.

Now he did not try to turn every sound into Babu's words.

One thak.

Only a thak.

One long kharr.

Only the rubbing of leaves and culms.

Amid these sounds, which had become ordinary again, memories of Babu would sometimes rise.

He let them come.

Then let them go.

After a while an old incident returned to him.

He had been ten years old.

He had entered this very bamboo grove and tried to cut a thin bamboo.

Babu saw him.

He did not scold.

He said, "First look at which way the bamboo is leaning. If you cut in the wrong direction, it will fall on you."

Babu had taken him by the hand and brought him out.

Then, with his own sickle, he had shown him how to cut it.

"Cutting is not only a matter of the edge; it is a matter of understanding direction."

Shivnath remembered that sentence clearly now.

He smiled.

"Babu, did you really say those exact words, or am I making them now?"

No answer.

He thought about it himself.

The sickle, the bamboo, Babu's hand—the scene was clear.

The words had perhaps changed.

Memory was not a verbatim file.

He accepted that he remembered the meaning of the sentence, not its exact wording.

That acceptance too brought relief.

Not every memory had to be made into an affidavit.

At around one in the morning he went inside.

He lay down on the bed.

This time sleep came.

Babu did not come in his dream.

Nor the bamboo.

There was only an open field.

At dawn, a dog's bark woke him.

The wind had stopped.

The bamboo was quiet.

Shivnath came outside.

The sky was grey.

He went to the grove.

In daylight the source of the night's sound looked ordinary.

A dry branch of a thick bamboo was touching the tin edge of the roof.

In the wind, that must have made the thak.

Shivnath moved it with his hand.

Thak.

Exactly the same.

He moved it again.

Thak.

"So it is you," he said to the bamboo.

Then he laughed.

"And not Babu."

There was less disappointment than clarity in the sentence.

Before sunrise, the neighbour Mahendra came over.

"Did you sleep last night?"

"A little."

Mahendra looked at the bamboo.

"This branch will pierce the roof. Cut it."

Shivnath asked, "How much?"

"These two dry ones, and half of the one that is leaning."

Mahendra brought a sickle and saw from his house.

They began cutting.

When the first dry branch fell, dust rose.

Shivnath looked at its joint.

The sound that had seemed like Babu at night was, in the morning, a bamboo hollow within.

He felt neither sorrow nor shame at this.

Knowing the cause of a sound did not make the memory false.

The second branch was cut.

The leaning bamboo was shortened by half.

The grove was not cut down entirely.

Mahendra asked, "The buyer will cut all of it anyway, won't he?"
"Perhaps."
"Then why labour over it now?"
Shivnath looked at the edge of the roof.
"Until today the house is mine. Why let the roof be damaged today?"
Mahendra laughed.
"Fair enough."
They sat down to drink tea.
Mahendra spoke of Babu.
"Jagdish Kaka slept very little at night."
Shivnath said, "Yes."
"At four in the morning he would call out to me—Mahendra, are you awake?"
"Why?"
"Nothing. He would simply be awake."
Shivnath laughed.
"He used to call me."
Mahendra said casually, "If he would not call his son, whom would he call?"
The same sentence.
Shivnath's chest tightened.
But this time he did not run from it.
He said, "I could not always answer."
Blowing on his tea, Mahendra said, "People in the city have their own work."
Shivnath thought: should I tell him?
Tell Mahendra the whole thing?
Then he decided: no.
Confession did not have to be made before everyone.
Neelam now knew some of it.
He himself knew some of it.
Some of it he had already said to Babu, even if Babu was not there to hear.
For now, that was enough.
At nine o'clock the buyer arrived.
His name was Satish Sah.
A surveyor came with him.
The land was measured.
They walked around the courtyard, the house, the bamboo, the well.
Satish said, "The house will have to be demolished."
Shivnath said, "Yes."
"All the bamboo will go."
"Yes."
"The well will be filled in."
Shivnath looked toward the well.
He was silent for a few moments.
Then he said, "First have the cover repaired. Until the sale is completed."
Satish said, "All right."
They began discussing the price.
Shivnath bargained hard.

Because of Babu's memory there was no question of giving away the land for nothing.

Nor, because of memory, of demanding twice the market price.

Each side had its own calculation.

By noon they reached a preliminary agreement.

The papers would be done the following week.

Satish left.

Mahendra asked, "Heavy heart?"

Shivnath thought.

"Yes. But not only because of the sale."

Mahendra did not ask further.

Shivnath liked that.

In the afternoon he began sorting out the house.

Babu's old walking stick was found in a corner.

The same one for three years?

Perhaps.

Dust lay over it.

Shivnath picked it up.

He set it on the ground.

Thak.

Once.

His body shivered again.

But this time he knew: this was the stick.

Not the bamboo.

And not Babu either.

He brought the stick outside.

What should he do with it?

Take it to the city?

Give it to his sister?

Leave it with the house?

He called Jamuna.

"Didi, I found Babu's walking stick."

Jamuna fell silent.

"Keep it."

"Do you want it?"

"What would I do with it?"

"I was thinking the same."

Jamuna laughed, a faint laugh of sorrow.

"If we take every object home in order to keep memory, the new house will become a warehouse."

Shivnath smiled.

"Then?"

"If you feel like it, take it. Otherwise give it to Mahendra. A walking stick is something to be used."

Shivnath looked at the stick.

"All right."

Then Jamuna asked, "You stayed alone last night? Were you not afraid?"
 "A little."
 "Of what?"
 Shivrath said, "Myself."
 Jamuna laughed.
 "What kind of answer is that?"
 "A long one."
 "Tell me sometime."
 Shivrath said, "I will."
 He ended the call.
 He took the stick to Mahendra's house.
 Mahendra said, "Why me?"
 "Your father's stick broke, didn't it?"
 "Yes."
 "Use this."
 Mahendra hesitated.
 "Jagdish Kaka's..."
 Shivrath interrupted, "A walking stick is something to be used."
 Mahendra looked at his face.
 Then took the stick.
 "All right."
 Before leaving for the city that evening, Shivrath went once more to the bamboo.
 The fresh cuts on the branches showed pale.
 The grove had been lightened.
 There was very little wind.
 Only the leaves rustled.
 Shivrath said, "I will not take back what I said last night."
 No answer.
 "I did not answer the phone."
 He repeated the sentence.
 "That fact will not change."
 "And I will not say you died because of it. I do not know that."
 "I will keep those two things separate."
 He fell silent.
 Then a new sentence came.
 "And you are not only that night."
 As he said it, his throat filled.
 He did not touch the bamboo.
 Did not bow his head to it.
 Did not light incense.
 He only stood there.
 Another memory of Babu came.
 A Makar Sankranti morning.
 Babu breaking tilkut.
 His teeth were no longer strong, yet he insisted on eating the hard pieces.
 Ma scolding him.

Babu laughing.
 Shivnath a child.
 In that scene there was no phone.
 No death.
 Only the fragrance of tilkut and laughter.
 Shivnath closed his eyes and remained in that scene for a few moments.
 Then opened them.
 Evening light on the bamboo leaves.
 He closed the house door.
 Slid the bolt into place.
 The key was to be left with Mahendra to watch the house until the papers were completed.
 He met Mahendra on the way.
 Shivnath handed him the key.
 Mahendra asked, "Should I cut the remaining bamboo in the grove?"
 Shivnath looked at it from a distance.
 "No. Not yet."
 Mahendra smiled.
 "Memory?"
 Shivnath shook his head.
 "No. There is no need yet."
 He was satisfied with his own answer.
 The bamboo did not need the shield of Babu's name in order to remain.
 Nor did it need Babu's name in order to be cut.
 When there was a need, a decision would be made.
 The vehicle set out toward the railway station.
 On the way Neelam called.
 "Have you left?"
 "Yes."
 "After last night's talk, are you all right?"
 Shivnath looked out of the window.
 Paddy fields were slipping behind.
 "Not completely."
 "All right."
 Neelam's voice was calm.
 "But clearer than before."
 "That may be enough."
 Shivnath said, "The matter of the house is settled."
 "Will you sell?"
 "Yes, probably. After checking the papers."
 "The bamboo?"
 Shivnath laughed.
 "We cut two dry branches. The rest is there."
 Neelam said, "All right."
 For a while both were silent.
 The vehicle was crossing a bridge.

Wind came through the window.
For a moment Shivnath again heard a kharr sound.
Not bamboo.
A loose tarpaulin fixed to the side of the vehicle was flapping.
If he wished, his mind could make the sound into Babu.
He did not.
He only listened.
Kharr.
Then silence.
In that silence Babu had not disappeared.
For the first time, instead, he was finding some space outside the night of his death.
Shivnath closed his eyes.
He remembered the fragrance of tilkut.
The earthen courtyard.
Tea with little sugar.
The old argument about the road.
Babu's hand while cutting bamboo.
Then the final phone call.
That too would remain.
He would not remove it.
But it would not remain the only memory.
The vehicle kept moving forward.
That night the wind would blow again in the village.
The bamboo would sound again.
Someone would hear it, someone would not.
The sound would have its own cause.
Shivnath's regret, its own.
There was no longer any need to make the two into one.

The Dusty Footpath

Divakar did not remember the village footpath.

He remembered only that on the way to school the dust used to climb as high as his toes.

In the rains, the same path became mud.

In winter, hard.

In Jeth, white with dust.

When he returned after thirty-five years, his first question was not about the path but the house.

“Kaka, where is Mishra Tola?”

The old man sitting at the tea stall in the square looked him up and down.

“Which Mishra?”

Divakar gave his father’s name.

“Shashibhushan Mishra.”

The old man narrowed his eyes.

“Shashi Babu’s son?”

Divakar nodded.

“Divakar?”

He started.

“You recognise me?”

The old man laughed.

“Not you. I recognise the name.”

That was the first sentence that opened the footpath for him that day.

The old man’s name was Ramanand Jha.

Divakar did not remember his face.

Ramanand said, “Not by this paved road. Take the dusty footpath on the left. It is shorter.”

Divakar settled the bag on his shoulder.

“Straight?”

Ramanand laughed.

“Since when is a village footpath straight?”

Then he pointed out the way with his hand.

“First pass Budhni’s cattle enclosure. After that comes Rahman’s Cut. Turn right there. Then left at Lachhminiya’s jujube tree. Ahead you’ll come to Shashi Babu’s Slope. After that, Mishra Tola.”

Divakar was silent for a few moments.

“Budhni’s cattle enclosure?”

“Yes.”

“Rahman’s Cut?”

“Yes.”

“Lachhminiya’s jujube tree?”

“Yes.”

"Shashi Babu's Slope?"

Ramanand looked at him.

"Your father."

Divakar's hand tightened around the strap of his bag.

"What happened to Babu there?"

Ramanand said, "Walk on and you'll understand. If you don't, ask someone."

The answer irritated Divakar.

In the city, when you asked for an address, you were given a house number, a street, a landmark.

Here people gave directions through the names of the dead, the living, and the vanished alike.

He stepped onto the footpath.

The dust was dry.

Two feet wide.

On one side, a harvested paddy field.

On the other, fallow land.

Bamboo in the distance.

With each step fine dust rose.

His shoes at once turned dull brown.

As a child had he walked barefoot, or in slippers?

He did not remember.

At the first bend he stopped.

There was something like an old cowshed.

Two buffaloes beside it.

A teenage girl was gathering dung.

Divakar asked, "Is this Budhni's cattle enclosure?"

The girl looked at him in surprise.

"Yes."

"Who was Budhni?"

"I don't know."

She laughed.

"Grandmother might know."

Divakar went on.

Budhni was no longer at the cattle enclosure.

The name was.

A little farther on, an old woman was cutting grass.

Divakar asked, "Mother, where is Rahman's Cut?"

Without lifting her head, the woman said, "Straight ahead. Where the path dips down."

"Who was Rahman?"

This time the woman raised her head.

"Do you want the name, or the way?"

Divakar smiled.

"Both."

The woman laughed.

"You've come from the city?"

"Yes."
 "That is why you want both."
 She put her sickle down on the grass.
 "It was Rahman Mian's field. One year the water cut the footpath away. He himself filled it with earth and remade the path. So it became Rahman's Cut."
 "The field now?"
 "No. His son sold it."
 "Rahman Mian?"
 "Dead."
 "How many years ago?"
 The woman shrugged.
 "The name remains. Who counts the years?"
 Divakar moved on.
 The footpath did indeed descend.
 On the other side lay an old cut in the earth.
 Grass had filled it now.
 He stopped and looked.
 There was no sign of Rahman.
 But the name had survived in the shape of the path.
 When the footpath climbed again, two boys were playing marbles.
 Divakar asked, "Lachhminiya's jujube tree?"
 Without looking up, one boy pointed ahead.
 "There."
 Divakar asked, "Who was Lachhminiya?"
 The boy said, "The one with the jujube tree."
 The other burst out laughing.
 "He's mad. Lachhminiya was an old woman."
 "Now?"
 "Dead."
 "The tree?"
 "Still there."
 Divakar walked on.
 A jujube tree leaned over the edge of the path.
 Its trunk was hollow.
 Few branches remained.
 A few small fruits still clung to it.
 Beside the tree, a mud platform had broken away.
 A man sat there on a spread-out gamchha.
 Divakar asked, "Is this Lachhminiya's jujube tree?"
 "Yes."
 "Did Lachhminiya live here?"
 The man said, "No. She lived at the other end of the village."
 "Then?"
 "She sold jujubes. Schoolchildren used to stop here. One paisa, two paisa."
 The man laughed.
 "Later she stopped taking money. She would say, eat as many as you can."

Suddenly a taste from very far away returned to Divakar.
 Sweet-and-sour jujube.
 Had he eaten fruit from this very tree?
 Impossible to say.
 There had been many jujube trees in the village.
 Yet the taste had risen on his tongue.
 He reached out to pluck one.
 The man said, "Have it."
 Divakar plucked one.
 Hard.
 Sour.
 He laughed.
 "It isn't ripe yet."
 The man said, "The name has ripened."
 Divakar looked at him.
 The man laughed at his own sentence.
 "I was only joking."
 Divakar walked on with the jujube in his hand.
 Now he knew the next name.
 Shashi Babu's Slope.
 His father.
 Shashibhushan Mishra.
 His father had died eight months earlier.
 In Patna.
 Not very far from the village, and yet in the last twenty-five years he too had returned to the village only rarely.
 Divakar had returned even less.
 After his father's death, while sorting papers, deposit and withdrawal slips, medicines, books, clothes, he had found an old key.
 Divakar had asked, "What is this for?"
 His mother had said, "It must be from the village house."
 The village house had fallen apart long ago.
 What could the key open?
 No one knew.
 The key was in Divakar's bag now.
 He himself was not quite sure why he had brought it.
 Perhaps he had hoped that on reaching the village he would find something he recognised.
 The footpath gradually rose.
 Divakar thought: is this the slope?
 A woman was approaching with a bundle of grass on her head.
 He asked, "Where is Shashi Babu's Slope?"
 The woman stopped.
 "You're standing on it."
 Divakar looked around.
 An ordinary incline.

Hard earth.
 A drain on one side.
 A field on the other.
 "Why is it called that?"
 The woman adjusted the bundle slightly.
 "How would I know? Ask the elders."
 She moved on.
 Divakar remained alone on the slope.
 His father's name.
 No plaque.
 No inscription.
 Only people saying: Shashi Babu's Slope.
 He walked down and then back up.
 Nothing remarkable.
 Perhaps his father had owned a field here?
 No.
 Divakar vaguely remembered that his fields had been west of Mishra Tola.
 Perhaps his father had fallen here?
 Perhaps he had saved someone?
 Perhaps there had been some quarrel?
 His mind immediately began to manufacture a story.
 Divakar stopped himself.
 There were stories behind the village names, but it was not right to invent them without asking.
 Above the slope stood a small hut.
 An old man lay on a cot outside, taking the sun.
 Divakar greeted him.
 "Baba, why is this called Shashi Babu's Slope?"
 The old man looked at his face for a long while.
 "Who are you?"
 "Shashibhushan Mishra's son."
 The old man sat up.
 "Divakar?"
 Again the same thing.
 Divakar laughed.
 "Everyone recognises me through my name."
 The old man said, "Your face is your mother's. Your name is your father's."
 His name was Devkinandan Chaudhary.
 He made room on the cot.
 "Sit."
 Divakar sat down.
 "Tell me the story of the slope."
 Devkinandan laughed.
 "What story is there in it?"
 "Then why the name?"
 "Your father used to push his bicycle here."

Divakar waited.

"That's all?"

"That's all."

"That was enough for the place to acquire his name?"

The old man laughed again.

"You're looking for a grand event?"

Divakar felt embarrassed.

"No... but..."

Devkinandan said, "Shashi Babu taught at the school. Every day he went this way on his bicycle. The bicycle would not climb the slope. He got off and pushed. Children followed behind. Someone would say, Shashi Babu's Slope has come. The name stuck."

Divakar fell silent.

That was all.

No heroism.

No accident.

A teacher pushed his bicycle every day.

The name survived.

Before Divakar's eyes, his father suddenly became young.

Dhoti hitched up?

Or trousers?

A black bicycle?

A bag over his shoulder?

He asked, "Did you see him?"

Devkinandan said, "I was two classes below him. Later I also worked with him at the school."

"What did he wear?"

"What?"

"How old was he when he used to push the bicycle?"

The old man laughed.

"You want me to calculate your father's age now?"

Then he thought.

"Twenty, twenty-two. His first job."

Divakar had never imagined his father's face at twenty.

In the family photographs his father had always been a father.

Rarely a young man.

Devkinandan said, "Very thin. The bicycle was heavy."

Divakar burst out laughing.

In old age his father's stomach had protruded and his gait had slowed.

"Did he get irritated while pushing it?"

"A lot."

"What did he say?"

Devkinandan closed his eyes and thought.

"I don't remember the exact words. But he certainly cursed the slope."

Both laughed.

Something inside Divakar grew lighter.

His father's name was not a memorial.

It belonged to a small everyday inconvenience.

In that ordinariness, his father seemed more alive.

Devkinandan asked, "When did your father last come?"

Divakar said, "Perhaps seven years ago."

"He didn't meet me."

"His knees were bad."

"Yes, I had heard."

Divakar took water from his bag.

Devkinandan asked, "Why have you come to the village?"

"Just like that."

As soon as he answered, Divakar felt the reply was incomplete.

Then he said, "I wanted to see a few things connected with my father."

"The house?"

"The house is no longer there."

"The place of the house is."

Divakar did not feel an urge to turn the absence of the old house into some sentimental story.

This sentence did not come from any story, nor could it have been some caution he had already formed in his own mind.

He merely said, "I'll see the place."

Devkinandan looked towards the footpath.

"First listen to the path."

"The path?"

"You've been asking the names, haven't you?"

Divakar laughed.

"Yes."

"Half the village lives on this footpath."

Devkinandan began pointing with his finger.

"There, Budhni's cattle enclosure. Budhni was the first woman of her time here to buy a buffalo on her own. Her husband died, her son was small. People laughed. She sold milk and educated her son."

Divakar thought of the girl who did not know who Budhni was.

The name remained; the story only halfway.

"You heard about Rahman's Cut?"

"Yes."

"Rahman Mian did not merely fill it with earth. For three days he gathered people and made the path. In those days the panchayat existed on paper; the work rested on people."

"Lachhminiya?"

Devkinandan smiled.

"Sold jujubes. Gave them to children on credit. Never collected the debt."

"And Babu?"

"Pushed his bicycle."

Both laughed again.

Divakar asked, "And ahead?"

Devkinandan's face brightened.
 "Many names ahead."
 He began to count them.
 "Phulkumari's Bend."
 "Jhagaru's Dust."
 "Bisesar's Rest."
 "Julekha's Shade."
 "Madan's Pit."
 "Saryu Dai's Stone."
 Divakar said, "All of them were people."
 "Yes. Some are alive, some are not. Some left the village."
 "How do the names remain?"
 Devkinandan said, "People give directions. That is how they remain."
 Divakar was silent at that sentence.
 The memorial of a name was not stone.
 One person simply said to another: turn right at Phulkumari's Bend.
 That was enough.
 And the name kept moving.
 Devkinandan got up.
 "Come, I'll walk you as far as Mishra Tola."
 Divakar said, "Your knee?"
 "Less bad than your father's."
 They both walked along the footpath.
 Devkinandan slowly.
 Divakar matching his pace.
 At the next place the footpath took a sharp turn.
 The old man said, "This is Phulkumari's Bend."
 "The story?"
 "If I tell every story, night will fall."
 "One line."
 Devkinandan laughed.
 "Phulkumari ran away from her mother's home by this way."
 Divakar started.
 "Why?"
 "I said one line."
 "You know?"
 "Everyone knows, but everyone will tell it differently."
 Divakar held back the question.
 There was no house at the bend.
 Only the footpath turning between two fields.
 The memory of a woman running away had become a direction on the road.
 A little farther on lay a thick layer of dust.
 Devkinandan said, "Jhagaru's Dust."
 "Why?"
 "Jhagaru drove a bullock cart. His cart used to get stuck here and he would curse.
 People would hear him from a distance and know - Jhagaru has arrived."

Divakar laughed.
 "Are all the names so ordinary?"
 "The names of ordinary people come from ordinary happenings."
 "No heroism?"
 "The names of heroes are written on government plaques. A footpath needs the people who walk it every day."
 The sentence settled in Divakar's mind.
 He asked, "Julekha's Shade?"
 "Up ahead."
 They came to an old shisham tree.
 Half its branches were dry.
 A mud platform beneath it.
 Devkinandan sat down.
 "Julekha Bibi used to keep a pitcher of water here. Whoever passed could drink."
 "Where was her house?"
 "Two kos away."
 "Then she came here every day?"
 "Yes. Her maternal home was on this road. After she was widowed, she lived with her brother. She would say, I cannot bear to see a thirsty person on the road."
 Divakar looked at the tree's shade.
 No pitcher.
 One corner of the platform broken.
 "Do children still know the name?"
 Devkinandan said, "They know the shade. Some know who Julekha was, some don't."
 "Then hasn't the name become only an empty shell?"
 The old man looked at him.
 "A name does not carry the whole person every time."
 Divakar was silent.
 "Your name is Divakar. Will someone who doesn't know you understand your whole life from it?"
 "No."
 "Then?"
 Divakar gave no answer.
 The leaves stirred.
 Less dust rose in the shade.
 After resting a little, they walked on.
 Ahead the footpath split in two.
 Devkinandan took the left path.
 "Where does the right one go?"
 "The new school."
 "The footpath has changed?"
 "It changes every day. A field boundary shifts, a house is built, a drain is dug, people find a shorter way."
 Divakar asked, "Then do the names change too?"
 "Some."

"Some disappear?"

"Many."

Devkinandan gave an old name: "Kalika's Hollow."

"Where is it?"

"Not there now."

"What happened?"

"The hollow was filled and a house built there. New people say 'near Sanjay's house'. Kalika disappeared."

Divakar felt a strange sadness although he did not know who Kalika had been.

Could one mourn the death of a name?

Perhaps not the name - a layer of a road.

Devkinandan said, "Not everything survives."

Divakar nodded.

There was no artificial consolation in the answer.

The footpath narrowed between fields.

At one place two women had put down bundles of grass and were talking.

Devkinandan called to one of them, "Saryu Dai!"

Divakar started.

"Saryu Dai's Stone?"

The woman laughed.

"Not me. My mother-in-law."

Devkinandan said, "The name is still moving."

Saryu Dai asked, "Who is this?"

"Shashi Babu's son."

The woman's face changed.

"Oh! The one who lives in the city?"

Divakar laughed.

"Yes, perhaps."

She said, "Your father taught me to read."

Divakar stopped.

"At school?"

"No. I never went to school. In the evenings, on the osara."

A new form of his father.

"For how long?"

"Not very long. Writing my name, numbers, reading a letter."

Saryu Dai laughed.

"My mother-in-law would say, what will a daughter-in-law do with reading? Your father would say, she will write her own name."

A slight fullness rose in Divakar's throat.

He had always seen his father at home with books.

A strict teacher.

A young father teaching a village woman her letters in the evening - he had not known that scene.

"Your mother-in-law's stone?"

Saryu Dai said, "She would sit there and take thorns out of her feet. Every time. The stone is still there."

A little farther on, a flat stone lay beside the footpath.
 Divakar felt like laughing.
 How small an action could bind a person's name.
 Removing a thorn from the foot.
 Pushing a bicycle.
 Leaving water out.
 Cursing.
 Selling jujubes.
 Making a path.
 The history of names was not a dynasty.
 It was the everyday body.
 Divakar took a small notebook from his bag.
 It was not the papers for the old village house.
 It was an empty notebook he had brought for the journey.
 He thought of writing: Budhni, Rahman, Lachhminiya, Phulkumari...
 Then he stopped.
 Devkinandan asked, "What happened?"
 "Shall I write the names down?"
 "Why?"
 "So that I don't forget."
 The old man said, "Write. But what you do not know, don't turn into a complete story."
 Divakar looked at him.
 "You think me that unreliable?"
 "Educated city people are quick to fill blank spaces."
 Saryu Dai laughed.
 So did Divakar.
 He opened the notebook.
 On the first page he wrote:
 "Budhni's cattle enclosure - Budhni kept buffaloes; ask the rest."
 "Rahman's Cut - he filled the road; ask the rest."
 "Lachhminiya's jujube tree - jujubes for the children; the rest."
 "Shashi Babu's Slope - pushed a bicycle; first job."
 He did not write "father".
 The name itself was enough.
 They walked on.
 At one place new bricks were being laid over the footpath.
 Two labourers.
 Devkinandan said, "The panchayat will pave it this year."
 Divakar stopped.
 "The whole footpath?"
 "From the square to the school. Later, farther on."
 "Then the names?"
 The old man shrugged.
 "A road becoming paved does not make the tongue paved."
 Divakar laughed.

"But the bends will change. The pits will be filled."

"Then some names will go."

"Doesn't that make you sad?"

Devkinandan thought for a few moments.

"Is the path for people, or for names?"

Divakar did not answer.

"In the rains, when we carry a sick person on a cot, our feet sink. Children fall off their bicycles. A paved road will be good."

Divakar felt ashamed of his sentimental attachment.

The dusty footpath was beautiful to his memory, but an inconvenience to the villagers as well.

Why should people be forced to walk in dust just to preserve names?

He closed the notebook.

The labourers continued levelling the bricks.

One labourer said to the other, "Will we finish up to Shashi Babu's Slope today?"

Divakar froze.

On the path being paved, his father's name was still in use.

Devkinandan saw his face and smiled.

"See?"

"Yes."

"The name isn't in the dust. It is in the mouth."

Divakar wanted to write that sentence in his notebook.

Then he did not.

Some sentences were better left as heard.

Mishra Tola was near.

The footpath widened.

New houses.

Fewer old mud houses.

At one place, a neem trunk had been cut down to a stump.

Devkinandan said, "Bisesar's Rest used to be here."

"Rest?"

"He would lean on his stick here and catch his breath."

"Does the name remain?"

"I say it. New people perhaps don't."

Divakar wrote in the notebook: "Bisesar's Rest - perhaps a disappearing name."

Devkinandan read it and laughed.

"You've made it very scholarly."

Divakar felt embarrassed.

"What should I write?"

"Write: Bisesar used to stop and sit here when he was tired."

Divakar wrote exactly that.

A simple sentence.

More alive.

At last Devkinandan stopped in an open place.

"Your house."

Divakar looked ahead.

No house.

A new concrete house.

An empty strip beside it.

Bamboo behind.

“Mine?”

“The old house stood on this empty part. Half the plot was sold later. That new house belongs to the buyer’s son.”

Divakar went onto the empty strip.

Grass over the earth.

An old brick in one corner.

He took the key out of his bag.

A small black key.

Devkinandan asked, “What is that?”

“Ma said it might be from the house.”

The old man took the key in his hand.

“Could be from a grain box.”

“Not the house?”

“Where would a house have such a small lock?”

Divakar laughed.

For three months he had treated the key as a symbol of the house; perhaps it was only a box key.

“Where is the box?”

“Who knows.”

Divakar put the key back in his bag.

He did not throw it away.

Devkinandan said, “You’ll keep it as a symbol?”

Divakar started.

“You know too much.”

“Your face says it.”

Both laughed.

Divakar sat on the grass.

Here had been his father’s childhood.

His grandfather’s house.

Perhaps his own first five years.

Yet nothing was recognisable.

He closed his eyes.

A smell?

A sound?

Nothing.

Someone was hammering in the distance.

A child crying.

A chicken calling.

The present.

Devkinandan said he would return to the house with the cot.

Divakar stopped him.

“Kaka, sit a little.”

“You sit. I’m there.”

He walked away.

Divakar was alone.

He thought of the slope bearing his father’s name.

In that name, his father was clearer than he was on the ground where the house had stood.

On the slope, a young teacher pushing a bicycle.

In Saryu Dai’s story, teaching letters.

In Ramanand’s mouth, a name.

In a labourer’s sentence, a direction.

Perhaps a person survives less in a house than in other people’s sentences.

Then Divakar stopped himself.

It could be a beautiful conclusion, but it was not the whole truth.

How many people’s names had not survived?

How many Budhnis, Rahmans, Lachhminiyas had done the same work without their names ever attaching to a footpath?

The road did not choose.

Language happened to lift some names by chance.

This was not immortality.

Only memory in motion.

That limited meaning seemed truer to Divakar.

At noon he ate at Devkinandan’s house.

Rice, dal, pumpkin curry.

After the meal the old man went to sleep.

Divakar decided to walk the footpath alone once more.

This time in the opposite direction.

From Mishra Tola to the square.

He kept the notebook in his bag, not in his hand.

The first place was Bisesar’s Rest.

He repeated the name in his mind.

Then Shashi Babu’s Slope.

Coming down the slope, a schoolgirl was pushing a bicycle.

Divakar laughed without meaning to.

The girl asked, “What happened?”

“Nothing.”

He thought of helping her push the bicycle uphill.

Then she managed it herself.

Divakar stepped aside.

The slope still made bicycles be pushed.

The reason for the name had not changed.

A little farther on came Julekha’s Shade.

This time an old man was asleep on the platform.

No pitcher.

Divakar took water from his bag and drank.

He thought: Julekha Bibi used to leave water here.

Then he held the bottle out towards the old man.

“Water?”

The old man opened his eyes and said, “I have some.”

Divakar put the bottle back.

There was no need to imitate Julekha.

Ahead, Jhagaru’s Dust.

A motorbike went past, raising a cloud of dust.

Divakar coughed.

Once again he understood the need for a paved road.

At Phulkumari’s Bend, the foundation of a new house was being dug.

Divakar thought: in a few years perhaps the bend will be straightened.

Phulkumari’s name?

He did not know.

He resisted the urge to take out the notebook and write.

Writing a name down would not keep it on the village tongue.

At Lachhminiya’s jujube tree he stopped.

The man from the morning was gone.

Two girls were plucking jujubes.

One said to the other, “Lachhminiya’s jujubes are still sour.”

Divakar smiled.

The name was moving.

At Rahman’s Cut, work had begun to level the ground.

A labourer was using a spade.

Divakar asked, “Do you know the name of this place?”

The labourer said, “Rahman’s Cut.”

“Who was Rahman?”

The labourer shook his head.

“Don’t know.”

Divakar could have told him.

Rahman Mian had filled the road with earth and remade the path.

He said nothing.

Why?

Perhaps because he himself had only heard the story that very day.

To repeat a borrowed story at once, as though it belonged to him, seemed wrong.

Then he thought: if no one repeats it, how will the story continue?

He said to the labourer, “I heard that a Rahman Mian once filled this path with earth.”

The labourer stopped his spade.

“Really?”

Divakar corrected himself at once.

“I don’t know for certain. An old man in the village told me.”

The labourer said, “Could be.”

Then he returned to work.

That was all.

Whether the story had been passed on or not, who could know?

At Budhni’s cattle enclosure, the girl from the morning was now filling water.

Divakar stopped.

"Is your grandmother here?"

"Yes, inside."

An old woman came out.

Divakar asked, "Who was Budhni?"

The old woman smiled.

"My grandmother."

Divakar started.

"Really?"

"Yes. I never saw her. I heard about her from my mother."

The girl said, "You never told me."

The old woman looked at her.

"When did you ever ask?"

The girl was silent.

Divakar felt like laughing.

The name stood in front of the house, the story lived inside the house, and yet the great-granddaughter did not know it.

Was that contradiction sad, or simply ordinary?

The old woman said, "Grandmother Budhni kept buffaloes. She educated her son.

Later the son took a job outside."

Divakar compared it with Ramanand's version.

Some things matched.

Some were new.

He asked, "Was the cattle enclosure here?"

"No. The old enclosure was two fields behind. The name shifted here."

Divakar was astonished.

"The name changed place?"

The old woman laughed.

"The buffaloes began to be tied here, so people started using the same name here."

Divakar's understanding of the whole day shifted once again.

He had assumed names were nails driven into the land.

Names too moved.

With people.

With use.

With memory.

"Then this isn't the real Budhni's cattle enclosure?" the girl asked.

The old woman said, "Why real or false? The name is used here now."

Divakar wanted to write that answer in his notebook.

Then he kept it only in his mind.

The square was near now.

Ramanand was still at the tea stall.

The moment he saw Divakar, he asked, "Found the house?"

"Found the place. Not the house."

Ramanand laughed.

"Good."

"I found the story of Shashi Babu's Slope too."

"What story?"

Now Divakar laughed.
 "He used to push his bicycle."
 Ramanand laughed loudly.
 "Yes, and curse a great deal."
 "Devkinandan Kaka said the same."
 Ramanand gave him tea.
 "Drink."
 Divakar sat down.
 Local people came and went.
 One man asked, "Who is this?"
 Ramanand said easily, "Shashi Babu's son, Divakar."
 Divakar listened.
 The order of names had changed.
 First the father, then the son.
 Someone said, "He lives in the city?"
 "Yes."
 Divakar thought: now he too had acquired a small identity – Shashi Babu's son.
 Would his name remain on this footpath?
 Probably not.
 What daily act had he performed here?
 Nothing.
 He had only walked.
 Asked names.
 Written a few things in a notebook.
 A road does not take a name for that.
 He felt no sadness about it.
 Perhaps once he would have.
 Before catching the evening passenger train, he went once more to the mouth of
 the footpath.
 Countless footprints from the day lay in the dust.
 Whose could he recognise?
 No one's.
 The footpath kept names, not footprints.
 Or was that too beautiful a conclusion?
 Divakar smiled.
 By now he had become wary of conclusions.
 The footpath was also simply a way.
 People went to work.
 Children to school.
 Buffaloes to the enclosure.
 The sick to the square.
 People going to weddings.
 People going to mourn.
 The names were useful markers in that movement.
 The stories came later.
 A boy came running from the square towards the footpath.

He asked someone, "Where is Sanjay Kaka's house?"
From a distance Ramanand called out, "Past Lachhminiya's jujube tree, turn right at Shashi Babu's Slope!"

The boy ran on.
Divakar stood still.
His father's name had been used again.
Not as tribute.
Not at a memorial meeting.
Not within the family.
Only as a direction.
In that form, the name seemed astonishingly true to him.
Ramanand asked, "What happened?"
Divakar said, "Nothing."
Then he added, "Babu is still showing the way."
Ramanand looked at him.
He might have offered some sentimental sentence.
He did not.
He simply went on drinking his tea.
Divakar liked that silence.
The passenger train arrived.
Before boarding, he checked his bag.
The key was inside.
The notebook was inside.
One unripe sour jujube was still in the small pocket.
He took it out and looked at it.
He thought of throwing it away.
Then put it back.
A symbol?
Perhaps.
Or merely a jujube?
There was no need to decide.
The train moved.
Through the window the square slipped behind.
The footpath remained visible for a few moments.
Then vanished behind the fields.
Divakar opened the notebook.
He read the names.
Budhni.
Rahman.
Lachhminiya.
Shashibhushan.
Phulkumari.
Jhagaru.
Julekha.
Bisesar.
Saryu Dai.

He thought of writing a title at the top of the page - "Village Memory".
He did not.
"The Names of the Footpath".
Not that either.
He left the page without a title.
Because the list was not complete.
It never would be.
Some names he had not heard.
Some had vanished before he came.
Some would change tomorrow.
Some new ones would be attached.
Paper would stop the list, while the footpath would keep moving.
He closed the notebook.
A fine film of dust had settled on the train window.
Divakar drew a line through it with his finger.
Then he felt like writing his own name.
He did not.
Evening was falling outside.
The village road was receding behind him.
And his father's name, he now knew, was not travelling back to the city with him.
It would remain there - where people pushing bicycles up the slope used it to tell one another when to turn right.

The Empty Pond

The pond had dried up.

Completely.

Cracked earth lay in the middle.

Weeds along the banks.

Two goats grazed on one side.

On the other, children played ball.

And five elderly people sat on the pond's northern ghat.

Naresh had not returned to the village after thirty-five years.

He had returned after only seven.

Even so, the pond seemed unfamiliar to him.

In his childhood it used to be full.

After the rains, right up to the banks.

In winter, half-full.

In Jeth, low.

But 'low' and 'empty' were not the same thing.

Now the bottom itself was visible.

Naresh wanted to go down the old bamboo ghat and have a look, but the first step was covered with dust.

Bushes reached as far as the second step.

The third step had disappeared.

Ramautar Kaka called out, "Don't go there."

Naresh turned around.

"Why?"

Ramautar laughed.

"If there is no water, how will you drown? Go on."

The other elders laughed.

Naresh did too.

He sat down on the stone of the ghat.

Of the five elders, he recognised three.

Ramautar Kaka.

Jaibun Dadi.

Parvati Kaki.

The other two—Salamat Mian and Janardan Babu—were names he had heard, though their faces were new to him.

Jaibun Dadi said, "Do you remember this pond?"

"Yes."

"How much?"

Naresh laughed.

"How much can one remember a pond?"

Jaibun Dadi said, "Then you remember nothing."
 Naresh looked around.
 "I used to bathe here."
 Ramautar said, "Everyone did."
 "Ma used to beat me."
 Parvati Kaki said, "Did your mother beat you every day?"
 "No, when I came to the pond."
 "Then you remember it properly."
 The wind lifted dust from the dry earth.
 Naresh asked, "Since when has there been no water?"
 Salamat Mian said, "Three years."
 Janardan Babu immediately said, "Not three, two."
 Jaibun Dadi said, "The year before last it was half-full."
 Ramautar said, "It kept shrinking year after year."
 Parvati Kaki said, "The tube-wells drew the water away."
 Janardan Babu said, "Not only that. The drain was blocked."
 Salamat Mian said, "It silted up."
 Five causes.
 One pond.
 Naresh smiled.
 "Then which one is right?"
 Ramautar said, "That the pond is dry—that is right. The rest is a mixture of causes."
 Meanwhile the ball rolled down onto the bed.
 A boy ran down after it.
 Naresh rose instinctively.
 "Careful!"
 The boy laughed and picked up the ball.
 "Kaka, where is the water?"
 The elders laughed again.
 Naresh sat down.
 Looking toward the boy, Jaibun Dadi said, "What would these children know?"
 "Know what?" Naresh asked.
 "The pond."
 Naresh said, "They can see the pond."
 Jaibun Dadi shook her head.
 "They see only an empty hollow."
 Ramautar Kaka said, "Patraha drowns in this hollow."
 Naresh immediately said, "He drowned."
 Everyone fell silent.
 Ramautar looked at him.
 "What?"
 "You said, 'drowns.' Patraha died a long time ago..."
 Ramautar said evenly, "Yes, a long time ago."
 Then he began the story.

"The monsoon has filled the pond up to a man's chest. At dawn Patraha untethers the buffalo. His mother says, 'Don't go to the pond.' But he follows the buffalo here."

Naresh watched him as he spoke.

Ramautar was telling it in the present tense.

"The buffalo goes into the water. Patraha stays on the bank. Then a calf comes out on the far side. He runs to catch it. His foot slips. First the water reaches his knees. Then his waist. Then suddenly it is deep."

Jaibun Dadi interrupted, "Not here. On the southern side."

Ramautar said irritably, "I am telling the story."

"If you put it in the wrong place, I'll correct you."

Salamat Mian laughed.

Ramautar pointed south.

"Fine, there. Patraha thrashes his arms. The buffalo turns and looks. His mother hears the shouting from home and runs here..."

Naresh interrupted again. "Kaka, 'ran here'?"

Ramautar stopped.

"Do you want to study grammar?"

Everyone laughed.

Naresh felt embarrassed.

"No. I just..."

Ramautar said, "Listen to the story."

He went on.

Who was Patraha?

Naresh remembered the name only vaguely.

Parvati Kaki said, "Patraha's real name was Patiram."

Salamat Mian said, "Not Patiram, Patikram."

Jaibun Dadi said, "At home they called him Patraha."

Janardan Babu said, "Whatever his name, he was thirteen."

Ramautar said, "Twelve."

Parvati Kaki said, "He had completed thirteen."

Naresh laughed.

"You cannot agree on a single thing?"

Jaibun Dadi said, "We agree that he drowned."

Then she corrected herself. "That he drowns."

Naresh looked at her.

There was no mystery on Jaibun Dadi's face.

No fear of ghosts.

She had only changed the way she told the story.

Naresh asked, "Why do all of you tell it in the present tense?"

Janardan Babu said, "What?"

"'He drowns,' 'he runs,' 'he shouts.'"

Salamat Mian said, "Then how should we say it?"

"He drowned. He ran."

Ramautar Kaka smiled.

"That would be history."

"And this?"

“A story.”

Having said only that, he fell silent.

The answer seemed incomplete to Naresh.

But he did not press the point.

Jaibun Dadi said, “Patraha was not the only one in this pond.”

Parvati Kaki immediately said, “Sukhni.”

Salamat Mian said, “Not Sukhni first. Bhola the boatman came first.”

Janardan Babu said, “Bhola did not drown. His boat overturned; he survived.”

Salamat Mian shook his head.

“I don’t mean Bhola. I mean Bhola’s father.”

Ramautar grew annoyed.

“Are you all going to start tracing the genealogy now?”

More laughter.

Naresh was surprised.

The old people were laughing while telling stories of those who had drowned.

There was no disrespect in the laughter.

The stories were old.

The edges of grief had been worn smooth, though the grief itself had not vanished.

Parvati Kaki said, “Tell Sukhni’s.”

Jaibun Dadi’s face changed.

“Sukhni plants paddy with me.”

Naresh began listening quietly again.

“It is hot at midday. Five of us women are coming back from the fields. We wash our feet at the pond. Sukhni says, ‘It is too hot; I’ll take a dip.’ I say, ‘Come home.’ She ties her sari tightly and goes into the water.”

Jaibun Dadi’s voice remained steady.

“Does she know how to swim?” Naresh asked.

“A little.”

“Then?”

“There is a pit in the middle of the pond. People had dug out earth there. From above the water looks level; underneath it suddenly becomes deep. Sukhni searches for the bottom with her feet and cannot find it. She moves her arms. We are standing on the bank...”

Jaibun Dadi fell silent.

Parvati Kaki said softly, “Rajjo takes off her sari and throws it.”

Jaibun Dadi nodded.

“Yes. Rajjo throws her sari. Sukhni cannot catch it.”

Naresh heard the present tense again.

This time he did not correct her.

Jaibun Dadi said, “I run to call the village. I turn back and look—the water is flat.”

The wind rose.

Dust lifted from the dry bed of the pond.

Naresh instinctively looked at the empty bottom.

Children were still playing ball there.

One boy was placing two bricks to mark the goal.
The water in Jaibun Dadi's story and the dust before Naresh's eyes did not lie on top of each other.

They were two different truths.

"How old was Sukhni?"

"My age."

"Then?"

Jaibun Dadi laughed.

"Then ask how old I was."

Everyone laughed.

Naresh too.

Then Dadi said, "Nineteen or twenty."

Parvati Kaki asked, "Was she married?"

"No."

Salamat Mian said, "I had heard she was engaged."

Jaibun Dadi said, "You have heard everything."

More laughter.

It occurred to Naresh that no single person told the story.

They all told it together.

One corrected the place.

Another the age.

Another the name.

Another the relationship.

And even then the story never became entirely fixed.

The midday sun grew fierce.

The elders shifted into the shade of the ghat.

Naresh asked, "After the pond dried up, did these stories become less frequent?"

Ramautar said, "Do stories depend on water?"

"But the place has changed."

"Where has the place changed?"

Naresh pointed to the empty bed.

"There is no water."

Ramautar said, "Is a pond only water?"

Naresh did not answer.

Janardan Babu said, "In government records it is still a water body."

Salamat Mian laughed.

"Is there water in the paper?"

Janardan Babu said, "I am not talking about the paper. I am talking about the name."

Parvati Kaki said, "For me this is a pond. For the children, a playground."

A boy shouted from a distance, "Ball!"

The ball came rolling to the steps of the ghat.

Naresh picked it up and threw it back.

The boy said, "Thank you, Kaka."

Jaibun Dadi said, "See? A playground."

Naresh smiled.

A little later a woman came along the footpath with a bundle of grass on her head.

She took the short route through the middle of the pond and crossed the bed.

Ramautar said, "Once boats used to stop here."

Janardan Babu said, "Not boats, dinghies."

Salamat Mian asked, "Whose?"

"Majid's."

"Majid's boat was large."

"You are starting again."

Naresh laughed.

The elders' argument seemed older than the stories themselves.

He asked, "Who else drowned?"

All five faces turned serious at once.

Ramautar said, "Many."

"How many?"

"Did anyone keep count?"

Janardan Babu said, "I remember four names."

Jaibun Dadi said, "Six."

Salamat Mian asked, "Do we count those who died on the bank too?"

Parvati Kaki said, "That is not drowning."

Then the names began to come.

Patraha.

Sukhni.

Nandu the washerman's son.

A wedding guest—no one remembered his name.

Chhotan Sah.

Malati's first child—no, the child survived; did Malati drown? They disagreed about that.

An unknown traveller—perhaps that story was wrong.

Jaibun Dadi said, "Not unknown. Barun."

Salamat Mian said, "Barun drowned in the river."

Ramautar said, "Fine, remove him."

Naresh burst out laughing.

"Are you making a list?"

Ramautar said, "You are the one who asked."

Naresh fell silent.

He realised that the question had been his, yet turning the answer into a count made him uneasy.

The dead were not a list of names.

Behind every name was a different house.

A different time.

A different mistake.

A different accident.

Janardan Babu suddenly said, "You may remember Chhotan Sah's story."

Naresh was startled.

"Me?"

"You were in the village then."

"How old was I?"

"Ten or eleven."

Naresh ran a hand over his head.

The name Chhotan Sah raised a blurred scene in his mind.

A red gamchha?

A crowd?

The bank of the pond?

His mother covering his eyes?

He was not sure.

"Tell it."

Janardan Babu began.

"It is evening. Chhotan is returning from the market. A little drunk."

Ramautar interrupted, "Very."

Janardan Babu grew irritated.

"Do you want to tell it?"

"Go on."

"Chhotan says, 'I will cross this pond.' People tell him to take the path. He takes off his clothes and ties on his gamchha..."

A red gamchha.

The colour in Naresh's memory sharpened.

"Red?" he asked.

Janardan Babu stopped.

"What?"

"Was the gamchha red?"

The five elders looked at one another.

Ramautar said, "Could have been."

Jaibun Dadi said, "Red-and-yellow checks."

Salamat Mian said, "I remember blue."

Parvati Kaki said, "What does the colour of the gamchha matter?"

Naresh said softly, "I remember it as red."

This time no one laughed.

Janardan Babu continued the story.

"Chhotan goes into the water. At first he swims. In the middle, his arms slow down. People shout from the bank. He laughs—says, 'I'm going across.' Then suddenly..."

Janardan Babu's hand stopped in mid-air.

"Disappears?"

"His head appears once. Then no more."

Inside Naresh, the blurred scene began to assemble itself.

His mother taking him by the hand and leading him home.

Someone saying, take the child away.

Someone calling for bamboo.

Someone for a net.

Lanterns until night.

Had he actually seen it?

Or had a story heard later become memory?
 He asked, "When was the body found?"
 Ramautar said, "At dawn."
 Salamat Mian said, "That very night."
 Jaibun Dadi said, "They searched at night and brought him out at dawn."
 Janardan Babu said, "That is right."
 Naresh's red gamchha had now entered the story.
 Would everyone say 'red gamchha' the next time?
 The thought made him uneasy.
 "I am not certain whether the gamchha was red," he said.
 Ramautar laughed.
 "You were the one who said it."
 "It came back to me that way, but I'm not certain."
 Jaibun Dadi said, "Then we won't say it is certain."
 That was all.
 The detail was left loose inside the story.
 Naresh felt relieved.
 At midday the elders began getting up one by one to go home for their meal.
 Jaibun Dadi said, "Come home and eat rice."
 Naresh said, "I'll stay here a little longer."
 Ramautar said, "What will you do staring at an empty pond?"
 Naresh said, "Nothing."
 Salamat Mian laughed.
 "The right answer."
 They all left.
 Naresh remained alone on the ghat.
 The children too had gone home.
 The pond bed was empty.
 Far away, the bell of a grazing goat.
 The wind.
 A torn plastic bag caught in the weeds.
 Naresh climbed down.
 The first step.
 The second.
 Where the third had vanished, there was only earth.
 He stepped onto the dry bed.
 The ground was hard and cracked in places.
 He walked toward the middle.
 Was this where Sukhni had been?
 He stopped himself.
 Who knew where 'this' was?
 Jaibun Dadi had said the south.
 Patraha too, in the south?
 Chhotan in the middle?
 Without water, depth could not be read.
 A place that looked level now might be deep in the rains.

He saw a wide fissure in the cracked earth.
A finger could fit inside it.
Green grass grew in a few places.
He found an empty old snail shell.
He picked it up.
Then put it back.
The urge to carry objects away as tokens of memory had grown weaker in him.
For a moment he wondered—would it be right to pick up this object and turn it into a memory?

No.

Naresh knew no other story about it.

He simply looked at the empty shell and left it there.

A boy came down into the middle of the bed with a bicycle.

“Kaka, give way.”

Naresh stepped aside.

The boy crossed straight through the pond and climbed up the other side.

The pond had become a shortcut.

Naresh smiled.

Then the phrase caught him—shortcut.

Why had that Hindi-English word come into his mind?

He laughed at himself.

The empty pond had become the village's new path.

He walked slowly toward the northern bank.

There, in the bed, was a round depression.

Perhaps people had dug earth from it.

Perhaps it was part of the old depth.

He did not decide.

It is easy to make a story.

Truth is harder without asking.

In the evening Naresh went to Jaibun Dadi's house.

He ate rice, dal and vegetables.

After the meal, Dadi sat in the courtyard cutting betel nut.

Naresh asked, “Dadi, do you always tell Sukhni's story in the present tense?”

Dadi went on cutting the betel nut.

“Grammar again?”

“No. I am really asking.”

Jaibun Dadi was silent for a while.

“I don't know.”

“It happens by itself while you tell it?”

“Perhaps.”

“Do you feel as though Sukhni is happening now?”

Dadi glared at him.

“Am I mad?”

Naresh laughed.

“No.”

“She died. Many years ago.”

“Then why ‘she goes in’, ‘she drowns?’”
 Jaibun Dadi put a piece of betel nut in her mouth.
 “When I tell it, I see it.”
 “In your mind?”
 “Where else would I see it?”
 “So that makes it present?”
 Dadi said irritably, “Give it whatever name you like.”
 Naresh fell silent.
 After a while Dadi herself said—
 “When we tell old things, there are two kinds. Some we say, ‘In those days it was like this.’ That is far away. Some we say, ‘She comes, she does this.’ That is before the eyes. That’s all.”
 Naresh said, “Does it make the grief less?”
 “No.”
 “More?”
 “Not that either.”
 “Then?”
 Jaibun Dadi laughed.
 “Must everything have a use?”
 Naresh gave up.
 Dadi said, “Don’t you hear stories in the city?”
 “Not much.”
 “That is why you have so many questions.”
 That night Naresh slept in his old house.
 The roof had long since been made concrete.
 The tiled roof of his childhood was gone.
 He kept thinking about Chhotan Sah’s red gamchha.
 Was it true?
 Or had his mother been wearing a red sari?
 Or had there been red lanterns by the pond?
 Memory mixes colours.
 He decided that the next day he would not repeat the colour as a fact.
 At dawn he went to the pond again.
 The elders had not yet arrived.
 Two women were crossing the bed.
 A child was driving chickens.
 The eastern sky was pink.
 The dry pond looked less ugly in the morning.
 Dew lay on the cracked earth along the bank.
 Naresh sat on the ghat.
 After a while Ramautar Kaka arrived.
 A stick in his hand.
 “Again?”
 “Yes.”
 Ramautar sat down.
 Naresh asked, “Kaka, will the pond ever fill again?”

Ramautar said, "If the drain is cleared, if the silt is removed, if the rains are good —then yes."

"Why doesn't the village do it?"

"It will."

"When?"

"When the quarrel ends."

"What quarrel?"

"Half the people say deepen it. Half say make it a field. Some say fish farming. Some say a playground for the children."

Naresh laughed.

"And the elders?"

"We say the pond should remain a pond."

"Because of those who drowned?"

Ramautar looked at him.

"No. Because of the water."

The answer was plain.

Naresh felt his own question had been sentimental.

Ramautar said, "The pond does not need to be filled for the dead. The living need water."

Naresh nodded.

He kept that sentence in his mind.

The sun rose higher.

One by one the other elders arrived.

Today Janardan Babu had brought his grandson Anmol with him.

He was about twelve.

Anmol sat watching a game on his phone.

Janardan Babu said, "Tell him the stories of the pond."

Without looking up, Anmol said, "I know all that."

"What do you know?"

"People drowned."

"Who?"

"Don't know."

The elders laughed.

Naresh remembered what Jaibun Dadi had said the day before—what would these children know?

Ramautar said, "Patraha drowns..."

Anmol looked up at once.

"Now?"

Everyone burst out laughing.

Ramautar too.

"No, boy, long ago."

Anmol said, "Then say 'drowned.'"

Naresh looked at Ramautar's face.

Kaka looked back at Naresh.

They both smiled.

"You've found your companion," Kaka said.

Naresh said, "I was saying the same thing yesterday."

Anmol switched off his phone and sat up.

"Tell the story."

Ramautar began again.

"The monsoon has filled the pond up to a man's chest. Patraha untethers the buffalo..."

Anmol laughed in the middle, but did not stop him.

The story went on.

Today Naresh noticed that the present tense was not only in the verbs.

The elders pointed to places with their hands as if there were water there.

"The bank is here."

"It is deep over there."

"His mother is under this tree."

There was no tree.

No water.

Yet the geography rose again inside the story.

Anmol asked questions from time to time.

"Did the buffalo survive?"

"Yes."

"Why didn't Patraha know how to swim?"

"Does everyone know?"

"Didn't anyone save him?"

"They tried."

Naresh could not remember what questions he himself had asked as a child.

Perhaps he too had asked things like these.

When the story ended, Anmol looked down at the bed.

"The water here couldn't have been very deep."

Janardan Babu said, "It has filled with silt now."

"Then is there a photograph?"

No one answered.

Ramautar said, "Who would have an old photograph?"

Naresh said, "I'll look at home."

Anmol said, "Send it if you find one."

The story was immediately seeking a new medium.

Naresh smiled.

At noon his mother opened an old trunk.

Naresh searched for photographs.

Weddings.

Shraddha ceremonies.

School.

Paddy fields.

One group photograph—with water behind them.

"Is this the pond?"

His mother put on her spectacles and looked.

"Yes."

The photograph was blurred.

Only half the water was visible.
 Ten or fifteen people stood on the bank.
 "When was this?"
 "Hard to say."
 "Around the time of Chhotan Sah?"
 His mother's face tightened.
 "Why?"
 "I heard the story yesterday."
 His mother handed the photograph back.
 "Listen to stories, but don't dig into everything."
 Naresh fell silent.
 "Did you see Chhotan?"
 "Yes."
 "Was his gamchha red?"
 His mother looked at him in surprise.
 "How would I remember?"
 Naresh laughed.
 "Right."
 His mother asked, "Do you remember?"
 "It seems red to me."
 "Then it isn't certain."
 The same answer as Jaibun Dadi's.
 His mother took the photograph again.
 "This may be from before Chhotan."
 "How can you tell?"
 "Your father is thin in this one."
 Naresh searched the photograph for his father.
 A young man.
 He did not look unmistakably like his father to Naresh.
 His mother placed a finger on him.
 "This one."
 "Certain?"
 His mother laughed.
 "Have you taught me to doubt too?"
 They both laughed.
 The photograph was sent to Anmol.
 With the message Naresh wrote, "This may be an old photograph of the pond; the year is not certain."
 He did not write, 'This is the pond from Patraha's time.'
 What he did not know, he did not claim.
 That evening Anmol replied, "Wow, there was so much water."
 That was all.
 On the third day, people from the panchayat came to inspect the pond.
 Measurements.
 Poles.
 Paper.

Some of the young people said, make it a field.
 Some of the elders—deepen it and bring the water back.
 Naresh watched.
 Anmol too.
 An official asked, “What was the old depth?”
 Five elders gave five answers.
 Six cubits.
 Eight cubits.
 Ten in the middle.
 Four at the edge.
 The official became irritated.
 “Give me one measurement.”
 Ramautar said, “How can a pond have one measurement?”
 The official spoke of testing the soil.
 Naresh thought—right.
 A story cannot measure depth.
 Measuring earth is one thing.
 Memory another.
 To accept the difference was not an insult.
 When the work was finished, the official left.
 Ramautar said, “These people will turn the pond into numbers.”
 Naresh said, “To deepen it, they need numbers.”
 Kaka looked at him.
 Then nodded.
 “Right.”
 That small agreement seemed important to Naresh.
 The elders’ stories were not all facts.
 Nor was the paper the whole pond.
 Each had its own work.
 That evening the elders were telling Sukhni’s story again.
 This time Anmol was listening.
 Jaibun Dadi said, “Sukhni ties her sari tightly...”
 Anmol asked, “What colour was the sari?”
 Dadi stopped.
 Parvati Kaki said, “Green.”
 Jaibun Dadi said, “I don’t remember.”
 Salamat Mian said, “Blue.”
 Ramautar said, “Were you there?”
 Salamat Mian laughed.
 “No.”
 Anmol burst out laughing.
 Jaibun Dadi said, “Forget the colour. Look at the water.”
 Then the story continued.
 Naresh suddenly understood—the story was in the present tense, but not all its details were fixed.
 It kept memory alive, not set in stone.

Living things change.
Things made permanent become records.
These stories were not records.
That was why they required caution.
And that was why they also carried warmth.
On the fourth day Naresh was to return to the city.
At dawn he went to the pond one last time.
A light mist hung in the air.
Anmol stood alone on the bed.
“So early?” Naresh asked.
“Dadi sent me for milk.”
“Through here?”
“Shortcut.”
They both laughed.
Anmol began crossing the bed.
Halfway across he stopped and said, “Kaka, does Patraha drown here?”
Naresh answered naturally, “No, a little farther south.”
The moment the sentence left his mouth, he stopped.
‘Drowns.’
The same present tense.
Anmol burst out laughing.
“You too!”
Naresh laughed as well.
“Yes.”
He could have corrected himself—‘drowned.’
He did not.
Because he knew Patraha was not drowning now.
Anmol knew it too.
The sentence had not become a lie.
It was time inside the story.
Anmol asked, “And Sukhni?”
Naresh said, “Ask Dadi about her. I am not certain where.”
“All right.”
Anmol ran up the far bank.
Naresh sat on the ghat.
The sun rose slowly.
Light spread across the dry bed.
After a while a woman crossed the pond.
Then two boys.
Then a goat.
Empty, the pond had become a path.
And in the mouths of the elders, it was still full of water.
The two forms did not cancel each other out.
Naresh stood.
As he turned to leave, he looked back.
No spirit.

No voice.
Only an empty pond.
But now the word 'empty' seemed less accurate to him.
There was no water.
There were people.
There was a path.
There were names.
There were stories.
And the verbs—drowns, runs, shouts—went on moving through their old water
on the tongues of the elders.

Erosion

The river had come three hand-lengths closer again that year.

Ramlochan measured such things by hand.

A bamboo stake was kept driven into the ground.

The distance from the bamboo to the stump of the old peepal tree.

From the stump to the first samadhi.

From the samadhi to the riverbank.

A new measurement every year.

Less every year.

Ramlochan's grandson Avinash would say, "Dada, use a tape measure."

Ramlochan would say, "A hand is enough."

"Hands change."

"So does the river."

After that answer Avinash would fall silent.

The family's old samadhi ground lay to the east of the village.

Once the river had been far away.

There had been a mustard field in between.

A mango tree.

Two field ridges.

Then a strip of barren land.

Only after that came the samadhis.

Now there was no mustard field.

The mango tree had fallen into the eroding bank the previous year.

The two ridges had disappeared long ago.

Half the barren strip was gone.

And only a few yards of earth remained behind the samadhis.

Four samadhis.

The oldest was Harinath Babu's.

Above it stood a small square brick platform, now half sunken.

The second was that of Ramlochan's grandfather, Devakinath.

The third, his father Shivpujan.

The fourth, Ramlochan's younger uncle Nripen, who had left the family to become an ascetic and returned to the village at the end of his life.

Not graves, samadhis—the family always used that word.

Avinash had taken leave from the city and come home.

This time he had brought a tape measure.

"Dada, today we'll measure it properly."

Ramlochan said, "Go ahead."

Sunaina, Ramlochan's daughter, came behind them carrying two lotas of water and a cloth.

Every year they cleaned the samadhis.

They cleared away loose earth.

Cut the grass.
 Straightened broken bricks.
 But this time the work had a different tone.
 It was not merely a matter of cleaning.
 A decision had to be made.
 The river had come so close that no one could say whether the first two samadhis
 would survive until the next monsoon.
 Avinash opened the tape measure.
 From the fresh edge of the eroded bank to Harinath Babu's samadhi was about
 seven and a half yards.
 Nine to Devakinath's.
 Twelve to Shivpujan's.
 Nripen's samadhi lay a little farther west, fifteen yards away.
 Avinash wrote the figures in his notebook.
 Ramlochan watched.
 "Last year?" Avinash asked.
 "About ten hand-lengths to Harinath."
 "Not hand-lengths. Yards?"
 "I don't know."
 Avinash let out a breath.
 "Then comparison is difficult."
 Ramlochan said, "We have eyes for comparison."
 Sunaina intervened. "Don't quarrel. Clean first."
 All three set to work.
 Grass had taken root on Harinath's samadhi.
 Sunaina eased it out slowly with a small hand-hoe.
 Avinash separated the loose bricks.
 Ramlochan pressed the soil firm with his hands.
 Behind them the exposed earth of the eroded bank stood like a wall.
 Dry above.
 Wet below.
 Roots protruding here and there.
 The river flowed far beneath them, while the bank itself was high.
 From a distance it looked safe.
 Ramlochan knew that erosion looked calm from a distance.
 One moment the earth stood firm.
 The next, an entire strip gave way.
 He had heard that sound before.
 Thud.
 Then the heavy splash of earth hitting water.
 The first crack that year had appeared in Chaitra.
 A strip fell in Jeth.
 The first rains of Asadh had yet to come.
 Sunaina asked, "Did anyone from the panchayat come?"
 Ramlochan said, "They came and looked."
 "What did they say?"

"They'll fill sacks with sand and try to hold the bank."

Avinash laughed.

"Here?"

Ramlochan glared at him.

"What is there to laugh at?"

"Dada, the river is cutting away this whole bend. What will ten sacks do?"

"Then you stop it."

"I should stop the river?"

"No. Stop laughing."

Avinash fell silent.

He regretted it at once.

Ramlochan was under no illusion that he could stop the river.

He simply wanted to do something.

Doing nothing was the hardest thing.

Sunaina sat down on the earth.

"Should we move the samadhis?"

For the first time that year the question had been spoken openly.

Ramlochan's hands stopped.

Avinash said at once, "That's why I've come."

Ramlochan said, "A samadhi isn't a trunk in the house that you can pick up and put somewhere else."

"Then the river will take it."

"I can see that."

Sunaina said softly, "Babu, we will have to do something."

Ramlochan placed his hand on Harinath's samadhi.

"Which one do we begin with?"

No one answered.

Four samadhis.

Little time.

Harinath was the nearest.

Logic said: him first.

Yet very few people in the family knew much about Harinath Babu.

There were more stories about Devakinath.

Shivpujan was Ramlochan's own father.

And every year ascetics came to Nripen's samadhi to offer incense.

If the labour available to save them was limited, whom should they save first?

Avinash said, "According to distance."

Ramlochan said, "All right."

Sunaina looked at her father's face.

"Will your heart accept that?"

Ramlochan said, "The heart has a different measure."

He rose and walked to the river's edge.

Avinash followed.

There was a fresh crack at the bank.

Avinash said, "Don't stand there."

Ramlochan laughed.

"Now you'll show me where to walk?"
 "Yes. Erosion doesn't look at age."
 Ramlochan stepped back.
 That small yielding pleased Avinash.
 The river below flowed muddy.
 The water did not look swift.
 But the roots in the bank trembled.
 Ramlochan said, "Your great-grandfather Shivpujan used to plough this bank."
 "The one whose samadhi is here?" Avinash asked.
 "Yes."
 "Then why is the samadhi here?"
 "The river wasn't here then."
 Avinash looked around again.
 It was difficult to imagine the old shape of the land.
 Sunaina called from a distance, "Babu, it's time to eat."
 Ramlochan said, "You go. I'll stay a little."
 Avinash did not leave.
 Two generations stood looking at the river.
 After a while Ramlochan asked, "What do you know about Harinath?"
 Avinash thought.
 "My great-great-grandfather?"
 "And?"
 "That's all."
 Ramlochan smiled.
 "That's about all I know too."
 "You never saw him?"
 "He died before I was born."
 "Then why should we save the samadhi?"
 The moment the question left him, Avinash realised his voice had turned harsh.
 Ramlochan remained silent.
 Avinash quickly added, "I mean, if we cannot save everything..."
 Ramlochan said, "Your question is not improper."
 Then he looked at the earth.
 "I have no answer."
 At midday the family held a meeting.
 On the veranda of the house.
 Ramlochan.
 Sunaina.
 Avinash.
 Ramlochan's younger son Ramesh, who lived in the village.
 Ramesh's wife Kamala.
 And their neighbour Kailash Kaka, who had seen the old samadhi ground being made.
 There was one subject: what should they do?
 Ramesh said, "We can take earth from them and build a new platform in a safe place."

Kailash Kaka asked, "Earth from which part?"

"From the samadhis."

"How much?"

Ramesh hesitated.

"As much as we can."

Ramlochan said, "Disturb what is inside?"

Ramesh fell silent.

Sunaina said, "Only the earth on top."

Kamala said, "We can remove the name plaques and put them up in the new place."

Avinash said at once, "That seems right."

Ramlochan looked at him.

"Is a samadhi a plaque?"

Avinash said, "No. But at least the plaque will survive."

Kailash Kaka said quietly, "First understand what lies inside each of the four samadhis."

Everyone looked at him.

Kailash said, "Harinath Babu was not an ascetic. In accordance with his last wish, the urn containing his ashes was buried here. The same with Devakinath. A portion of Shivpujan Babu's ashes was buried here. Nripen Babu's body itself was laid in samadhi because he had returned as a sadhu."

The veranda fell silent.

Avinash had not known these details.

He asked, "Is there any document for this?"

Kailash Kaka laughed.

"Document?"

"I mean, anything written?"

"I saw it."

Ramlochan said, "I was there too when Shivpujan's was made."

"Harinath?"

"Kaka saw that one."

Kailash Kaka nodded.

Avinash said, "Then all four are not the same."

Sunaina said, "So the decisions need not be the same either."

Ramlochan's face grew heavy.

The family was not facing one object to be saved, but four different kinds of memory and remains.

Ramesh said, "Nripen Kaka's samadhi is farthest back. It is safe for now."

Kailash Kaka said, "For now."

Those two words weighed heavily on the veranda.

Avinash opened his notebook.

"Let's make a plan."

Ramlochan laughed.

"Everything by plan?"

"At least we'll make fewer mistakes."

He began to write.

Harinath—surface earth, plaque, name.

Devakinath—the same.

Shivpujan—the family to decide.

Nripen—ask the religious elders or the sadhu community.

Ramlochan interrupted. “If you write ‘surface earth’, does it become the same earth?”

Avinash stopped his pencil.

“No. It’s only a description of the task.”

“All right.”

Kamala said, “First choose a safe place.”

Ramesh said, “The orchard behind the house.”

Ramlochan refused at once.

“Who knows whether this house too will be eaten away or sold?”

Avinash said, “Behind the village’s public temple?”

Sunaina said, “Would it be proper to put all our ancestors’ private samadhis there?”

Kailash Kaka said, “The high ground of the village cremation ground?”

Ramlochan thought.

“Far from the river?”

“Very far.”

Ramesh said, “For now.”

Everyone looked at him.

Ramesh became embarrassed.

“I said it the way Dada does.”

Ramlochan smiled.

“You said it correctly.”

The decision was postponed.

The next morning the river had eaten away another hand-length.

There had been no rain in the night.

Even so, another strip of bank had collapsed.

Ramlochan reached the samadhi ground before sunrise.

Avinash came a little later.

The moment he saw the fresh collapse, he took out the tape measure.

Ramlochan said, “Don’t measure today.”

“Why?”

“You can see it with your eyes.”

Avinash put the tape away.

Very little earth now lay between Harinath’s samadhi and the river.

A new crack had reached the ground behind the samadhi.

Avinash’s throat tightened.

“We begin today.”

Ramlochan said nothing.

“Dada.”

“Yes.”

“Today.”

Ramlochan nodded.

Ramesh, Sunaina, and Kamala were called.
 Kailash Kaka came too.
 Two young men from the village arrived with spades.
 There was no priest to recite mantras.
 No large religious ceremony.
 First everyone wanted to decide what would be touched and what would not.
 Ramlochan said, "Do not open the inside."
 Kailash Kaka nodded.
 "Remove the upper platform of Harinath's samadhi. Take a layer of the surface
 earth into a vessel. Do not put a spade where the urn might be."
 Avinash asked, "Exactly where is the urn?"
 Kailash Kaka said, "I don't know."
 "Then there is a risk."
 "That is why we use our hands."
 The work began slowly.
 One brick at a time.
 Earth by hand.
 Grass set aside.
 Avinash's city-bred efficiency was useless here.
 He wanted to work faster.
 Ramlochan kept saying, "Slowly."
 The river sounded behind them.
 The slower the work, the faster time seemed to move.
 Sunaina wrote each ancestor's name on a piece of cloth and tied it to the
 corresponding vessel.
 Harinath.
 Devakinath.
 Shivpujan.
 Nripen.
 Avinash asked, "The dates too?"
 Sunaina said, "Write only as much as we know."
 Kailash Kaka said, "Where we don't know, don't guess."
 Avinash liked that rule.
 No one knew Harinath's year of birth for certain.
 His year of death might be found in Babu's old diary.
 For now it was left unwritten.
 When the bricks of the first platform were removed, the soil inside appeared
 slightly sunken.
 Ramlochan stood with his palms joined.
 Avinash did the same.
 No one spoke.
 Then a little of the surface earth was taken into a small brass vessel.
 Avinash asked, "Only this much?"
 Ramlochan said, "Only this much."
 "Has the samadhi been saved?"
 Ramlochan did not answer.

Who could answer that question?
 The bricks would survive.
 The earth would survive.
 The name would survive.
 The place would not.
 The urn within had not been touched.
 If the river took the earth, it would take that too.
 Resistance rose within Avinash.
 "Dada, if the urn is here, why don't we try to take it out?"
 Ramlochan's face hardened.
 "Where will you dig?"
 "We can search carefully."
 Kailash Kaka said, "If we dig in the wrong place, we ourselves will damage what is still intact."
 "But the river..."
 Ramlochan cut him off. "If the river does it, that is nature. If we do it in ignorance, it is by our own hands."
 Avinash fell silent.
 He did not fully agree with the reasoning.
 But he stopped arguing.
 The work continued.
 The plaque from the first samadhi was lifted.
 It was heavy.
 Four men carried it.
 It was placed in a safe spot.
 Devakinath's samadhi came next.
 Its bricks were less damaged.
 Sunaina said, "Babu, may I take this plaque home?"
 Ramlochan said, "For now, keep everything together."
 "The new samadhi?"
 "Don't call it that yet."
 By midday the upper structures of two samadhis had been removed.
 Where square platforms had stood, there was now level earth.
 Avinash found the sight more painful.
 In dismantling the structures, the family itself seemed like the destroyer.
 Sunaina must have read his face.
 "Are we breaking them?" she asked.
 Avinash said, "I don't know."
 Ramlochan heard them from a distance and said, "To save some things, one must break some things."
 Kailash Kaka added, "And leave some things behind."
 The river dropped another mass of earth.
 Every head turned at once.
 The erosion was still some distance from the samadhis, but the sound was close.
 Thud.
 Water leapt up.

No one said anything.
In the afternoon two men from the panchayat arrived with sand-filled sacks.
They tried to place them along the edge.
Avinash helped.
So did Ramlochan.
The sacks were heavy.
Five, ten, fifteen.
A small wall of them formed.
Avinash knew it would not last.
Even so, he did not laugh.
When one is working, the line between futile and useful is not always clear.
At evening everyone returned home.
The plaques and bricks were temporarily kept on the veranda.
The vessels were taken inside.
Ramlochan stared for a long time at the four names.
Avinash said, "Tomorrow we'll choose the new place."
Ramlochan said, "Yes."
It rained that night.
Not heavily.
But steadily.
Avinash could not sleep.
Again and again he thought of the river.
The sacks.
The crack.
The flattened samadhi sites.
Ramlochan coughed in the next room.
As soon as the rain stopped at dawn, everyone ran towards the river.
Half the sandbags had collapsed.
The bank had retreated by two hand-lengths.
Part of the ground where Harinath's samadhi had stood was gone.
Devakinath's site still remained.
Sunaina covered her mouth with her hand.
Avinash stood still for a few moments.
Ramlochan only watched.
No one said, "I told you so."
No one pretended to hold back tears.
No one fell to their knees.
The river flowed below.
Ramlochan said quietly, "Now do you understand?"
Avinash asked, "What?"
"Why measuring by hand was enough."
Avinash's eyes filled.
"Dada, joking now?"
Ramlochan said, "I'm not joking."
Then he looked at the earth.
"You can keep the numbers. You cannot keep the earth."

Avinash said nothing.
 He did not immediately accept the old man's sentence.
 Later that day they decided to inspect a new place.
 The high ground west of the village cremation ground.
 Far from the river.
 An old peepal tree.
 The land was public, but the panchayat could grant permission.
 The family asked for a small place for the four plaques.
 The panchayat head asked, "Relocating the samadhis?"
 Ramlochan said, "No. A memorial."
 Avinash looked at him.
 For the first time the word had been said clearly.
 A memorial.
 Not a samadhi.
 The head said, "Then you can build a small platform."
 Ramlochan said, "Not four separate ones. One. Four names."
 Sunaina started.
 "Babu?"
 "Keep the place small. Keep the names clear."
 Ramesh asked, "The old bricks?"
 "Use whatever is sound."
 Avinash asked, "The earth in the vessels?"
 Ramlochan said, "Under the platform."
 "Then isn't it a samadhi?"
 "No."
 "Then why the earth?"
 Ramlochan looked at him.
 "Your question is right. Perhaps I need it."
 That admission silenced Avinash.
 Not every decision came from logic.
 But one could at least be clear about what the decision was being called.
 Over the next three days a new small platform was built.
 The sound old bricks were used.
 The rest were new.
 A stone slab was placed on top.
 Four names.
 Years of birth only where they were known for certain.
 Years of death where they had been established.
 Where they were not known, no blank date was left—only the name.
 Avinash said, "People will ask."
 Ramlochan said, "Let them ask."
 Two elderly men from Nripen's sadhu community came.
 They said, "Nripen's original samadhi is safe for now. Do not touch it. His name may be written here."
 The family agreed.
 Four names on one stone.

Harinath.
 Devakinath.
 Shivpujan.
 Nripen.
 Sunaina washed the stone.
 Kamala placed flowers on it.
 Ramlochan placed nothing.
 He merely sat there.
 Avinash took out his phone to photograph it.
 Then stopped.
 Ramlochan said, "Take it."
 "You don't object?"
 "Why should I?"
 Avinash took the photograph.
 One platform.
 Four names.
 The shade of a peepal tree.
 The river was not visible in the distance.
 He sent the photograph to the family group in the city.
 Many replies came.
 'Pranam.'
 'Sad.'
 'You did well.'
 'Was the old samadhi saved?'
 At that question Avinash hesitated over his reply.
 What should he write?
 'No.'
 'Some of it.'
 'Relocated.'
 'Memorial.'
 He wrote, "The old site is in the eroding zone. We removed the structures we could save. A memorial has been made at a new place."
 That was all.
 At dusk Ramlochan sat alone beside the new platform.
 Avinash came to him.
 "Dada, come home."
 "In a while."
 Avinash sat beside him.
 The peepal leaves stirred.
 Sounds from the village came from a distance.
 Ramlochan said, "Do you think I did the right thing?"
 Avinash started.
 "You're asking me?"
 "Yes."
 "How can I say it was wholly right or wrong?"
 Ramlochan smiled.

"This year you've learned how to give the right answer."

Avinash laughed.

Then, turning serious, he said, "I think we saved what we could. And what we could not save, we did not falsely claim to have saved."

Ramlochan nodded.

"That is good."

"Do you grieve for leaving the old place?"

"I cannot tell whether the grief is for the place or for the people."

"The people were gone long ago."

"That is why the place comes to stand in their stead."

Avinash fell silent.

The sentence struck him deeply, but he did not take out his notebook.

Not everything needed to be written down.

In the second week the erosion advanced further.

The old sites of Harinath and Devakinath's samadhis were almost swallowed by the river.

The family had already removed Shivpujan's platform.

Nripen's samadhi still remained, but the crack had drawn close.

People from the sadhu community came again.

This time the decision was not difficult.

The marker above it was removed.

Nothing inside was disturbed.

His name was already on the new platform.

Ramlochan was present while the work was done, but spoke very little.

Now and then came the sound of the eroding bank.

Thud.

Then a splash.

Avinash noticed that earlier everyone had run to look at the river whenever they heard that sound.

Now some merely raised their heads.

Human beings can turn even disaster into routine.

Whether that was terrible or useful was hard to decide.

The monsoon rose in full.

The river widened.

The old samadhi ground disappeared from sight.

Water flowed directly over that strip.

One day Ramlochan took Avinash to the farther bank.

"There," he said, pointing.

Avinash saw only water.

"Exactly there?"

Ramlochan said, "Approximately."

"You're certain?"

"No."

Both laughed.

There was grief in the laughter, but no false certainty.

Avinash said, "Dada, shall I bring the tape measure next year?"

Ramlochan looked at the river and said, "What will you measure?"
 Avinash had no answer.
 The tape measure seemed meaningless now.
 Then Ramlochan said, "You can measure the new platform."
 "Why?"
 "To see how many days pass before you say, 'Dada, hands change.'"
 Avinash burst out laughing.
 Ramlochan laughed too.
 After the monsoon the river receded.
 The old strip of land did not return.
 Where the samadhis had stood there was now a new sloping bank.
 Some roots protruded from it.
 A few pieces of brick were found far away in the sand.
 Ramesh picked up one brick and brought it home.
 Ramlochan asked, "Whose is it?"
 "It may be from the old platform."
 "Are you certain?"
 "No."
 Ramlochan said, "Then leave it where it was."
 Ramesh thought for a few moments.
 Then he took the brick back and put it down.
 Sunaina asked, "Won't we bring anything home for memory?"
 Ramlochan looked towards the new platform.
 "We already have."
 "What?"
 "The names."
 Avinash interrupted, "And a few bricks."
 Everyone laughed.
 Ramlochan said, "Yes, a few bricks."
 Sunaina said, "And earth."
 "Yes."
 Ramesh added, "And quarrels."
 Kamala said, "More of those than anything else."
 Everyone laughed again.
 There was no disrespect for the ancestors in that laughter.
 The living family was releasing its exhaustion.
 In autumn a small gathering was held beside the new platform.
 No large ritual.
 Members of the family.
 A few neighbours.
 Kailash Kaka.
 The four names were read aloud.
 Each person's story was told only as far as it was known.
 Very little about Harinath.
 About Devakinath, something of his fields.
 Ramlochan spoke about Shivpujan.

An elderly sadhu spoke about Nripen.

Avinash noticed that where there was no information, no one tried to fill the gap with a story.

After Harinath's name, the silence lasted a little longer.

Then Kailash Kaka said, "This much is known; say only this much."

Avinash thought that was right.

After the gathering a child asked, "Is this a samadhi?"

Ramlochan said, "No."

"Then what is it?"

"A place for the names of our ancestors."

The child asked again, "Where are the ancestors?"

Ramlochan did not point towards the river.

He said, "Someone who has passed does not have only one place."

Avinash looked at the old man's face.

The sentence sounded philosophical, yet Ramlochan said it in the same tone in which he spoke about the weather.

Whether the child was satisfied, no one knew.

He ran off to play with another child.

Time passed.

Moss began to grow on the new platform.

Peepal leaves fell on it.

Sunaina cleaned it twice a year.

Whenever Avinash came from the city he took a photograph, and then gradually the photographs became fewer.

Ramlochan grew older.

The tape measure remained tucked inside the notebook.

One day Avinash asked, "Dada, the old measurements are in the notebook. Should I keep them?"

Ramlochan said, "Keep them. Let paper do the work of paper."

"What work?"

"It will remind you where the river once was."

"And the samadhis?"

Ramlochan thought for a while.

"Those too."

"Then paper is necessary?"

"Leave the word necessary. Useful."

Avinash smiled.

That answer became one of Ramlochan's last lessons, though no one wrote it down as a lesson.

Two years later Ramlochan was gone.

A new question faced the family.

After his last rites Sunaina asked, "Should we add Babu's name to the new platform?"

Ramesh said, "That is the place for the ancestors."

Avinash remained silent.

Kamala said, "Isn't Babu an ancestor now?"

Everyone looked at one another.
 Life changes categories; words follow behind.
 Avinash said, "Let's ask Ma first."
 Ramlochan's wife was still alive, very old.
 When she heard, she said, "If you keep adding everyone to that platform, one day there will be no room left."
 Everyone laughed through their tears.
 "Then what?" Sunaina asked.
 The old woman said, "Does Ramlochan need a place of his own, or his name?"
 No one answered.
 Then she herself said, "His name will remain in the house too."
 Ramlochan's name was not immediately added to the new platform.
 Some agreed with the decision; some did not.
 At first Avinash felt uneasy.
 Then he remembered his grandfather's sentence: someone who has passed does not have only one place.
 He did not want to turn the platform into a fixed rule.
 The erosion had taught the family that placing too much trust in permanence was risky.
 The following year Avinash went alone to the old bend of the river.
 The river had shifted a little farther away again.
 Where the old samadhi ground had been swallowed by water, a small tongue of sand had emerged.
 Whether the river had returned its own earth or brought new earth, who could know?
 Avinash did not go down.
 He looked from a distance.
 If he wished, he could have said: Harinath was there. Devakinath there. Shivpujan there.
 But now the exact places were uncertain.
 He did not want to turn conjecture into reverence.
 He merely joined his palms.
 Then lowered his hands.
 The river kept flowing.
 Behind him, on the higher ground of the village, stood a small platform beneath the peepal tree.
 Four names.
 A few old bricks.
 A little earth.
 And the family's disagreements, decisions, labour, and helplessness—all of them more alive within the living people than in the platform itself.
 Avinash turned back.
 This time there was no tape measure in his bag.
 The work of measuring the river had not ended.
 Only its purpose had changed.
 How much land had been lost could be measured.

How much of a place survived in memory could not.
And what had not survived did not need to be declared as though it had.
Erosion does not eat only earth.
It eats certainty.
In the end the family could not stop the land from giving way.
But they could at least decide this much: where knowledge ended, they would not
invent a story.
In the empty space left behind by the river, that boundary became for them a new
kind of restraint.

The Scent of Earth

The first rain came to the city at five in the evening.

First the wind.

Then the dust.

Then large, heavy drops.

Sudhanshu was returning from the office.

Traffic stopped.

People ran beneath awnings.

The hot dust of the road released its smell the moment the first water touched it.

With that smell came his mother.

Not all of her.

At first, only her hands.

Hands lifting sacks of wheat spread out in the wet courtyard.

Two glass bangles at her wrist.

One bangle broken.

Was it really broken?

Sudhanshu was not certain.

He stood beneath the awning.

People were sheltering from the rain.

He could not shelter from the smell of wet earth.

His mother had been dead nine years.

He knew this by counting.

Not by memory.

Memory does not keep time in a straight line.

The first fragment was of her hands.

The second was of her voice.

“Bring that sack inside!”

Whom had she been calling?

Sudhanshu?

His sister Shobha?

Babuji?

Perhaps all of them.

At the first rain, his mother would set the whole house running.

Clothes.

Grain.

Cow-dung cakes.

Wood stacked beneath the eaves.

The charpoy in the courtyard.

The lamp beside the tulsi platform.

Bring something in.

Cover something.

Lift something.

Leave something.
 For her, rain was a list before it was a fragrance.
 Sudhanshu remembered that now.
 As a child, he had thought of the first rain only as play.
 His mother had not.
 A young man beneath the awning said, "Ah, the smell of wet earth!"
 Sudhanshu looked at him.
 He was smiling.
 Perhaps Sudhanshu too had once smiled like that.
 His mother would say, "First bring in the sack. Smell the earth afterwards."
 Did he remember that sentence exactly?
 Perhaps.
 Or was Sudhanshu making it now?
 He asked himself.
 There was no answer.
 The rain grew heavier.
 Water ran along the road.
 The first smell of earth began to thin.
 With it came another fragment.
 His mother stood at the threshold.
 Watching the rain.
 All the work had been brought inside.
 Her hands rested on her hips.
 Her face was calm.
 She drew a deep breath.
 Sudhanshu, still a child, asked, "Do you like the smell?"
 His mother said, "What is there to like or dislike about a smell? The earth is getting wet."
 That answer had annoyed Sudhanshu.
 He had wanted her to say: Very much.
 Why did his mother never turn everything into poetry?
 Now he thought: when had she had time to make poetry?
 Then another fragment.
 His mother entered the kitchen with mud between her toes.
 She said, "Will no one sweep? Will everyone just stand and watch the rain?"
 Shobha laughed.
 Sudhanshu ran away.
 Babuji folded his newspaper.
 His mother mopped the floor alone.
 That scene was clear.
 But had the floor of the house been red earth, or cemented?
 Sudhanshu stopped.
 Half of the old house had once had an earthen floor; later it had been cemented.
 Which year was this?
 Memory was joining two different times.
 He shifted beneath the awning.

The rain was slanting in.
His clothes were beginning to get wet.
He felt no hurry to reach home.
For a moment he wanted only to wait for the fragments.
His mother was arriving without order.
Once very young.
Once with white hair.
Once irritated.
Once laughing.
Once silent.
Once as she had been the year Sudhanshu left for the city to study.
Was it raining then?
No, that fragment was not of rain.
Yet it came.
The railway station.
His mother putting sattu into his bag.
Saying, "Eat less of the food outside."
Sudhanshu, irritated: "I'm not a child."
His mother: "Did I call you a child?"
Then the smile.
Why had the smell of earth opened this scene?
There was no logic to it.
Memory does not obey fragrance.
The first smell only opens a door.
Which room will open beyond it, no one knows.
The rain eased a little.
Sudhanshu began walking.
Water had collected in the unpaved strip beside the road.
A child, sandals in hand, splashed through it.
From a distance his mother scolded, "Don't run in the first rain!"
Sudhanshu stopped.
With that sentence came a third clear fragment.
His mother too used to say, "Don't go barefoot in the first rain."
"Why?"
"The earth is hot. Worms and insects come out."
"All the children are going."
"Did all their mothers ask me?"
That sentence was certain.
Sudhanshu laughed.
Here he trusted his memory.
His mother spoke exactly like that.
She did not like comparing her rules with other people's children.
He reached home.
The staircase of the apartment building was wet.
Inside the lift there was no smell of rain.
Only perfume, metal, and wet shoes.

Sudhanshu got off on the seventh floor.
 His wife, Mrinalini, opened the door.
 "Completely drenched?"
 "A little."
 "Umbrella?"
 "At the office."
 "Every year the same thing."
 Sudhanshu laughed.
 Mrinalini handed him a towel.
 "Shall I make tea?"
 He was about to say yes.
 Then he remembered his mother.
 Not because of tea.
 Because of the kitchen window.
 Did his mother make tea on the first rainy day or not?
 Probably.
 Tea was made every day.
 Memory fastens ordinary things onto special days.
 He said, "Please do."
 He opened the balcony door.
 The city below was wet.
 Among the concrete stood a few flowerpots.
 From their damp soil rose a faint smell of earth.
 Not as strong as the first smell outside.
 Mrinalini asked from behind him, "What are you looking at?"
 "I'm remembering Ma."
 She paused.
 "Because of the rain?"
 "Because of the smell."
 "Did your mother like the rain?"
 Sudhanshu opened his mouth to answer.
 Then closed it.
 "I don't know."
 Mrinalini looked surprised.
 "You remember so much, but not that?"
 "Perhaps she liked it. Perhaps she didn't."
 "Both?"
 "Yes."
 Mrinalini set down the tea and left.
 She did not press the question.
 Sudhanshu was relieved.
 He sat in the balcony.
 The rain had become thin.
 The city lights stretched long in the water.
 His mother came again.
 This time on a hot afternoon.

No rain.
 She was sieving earth in the courtyard.
 Why?
 To plaster the hearth?
 To fill a crack in the wall?
 For the tulsi platform?
 He did not remember.
 His mother rubbed the soil between her palms to test it.
 She said, "This earth isn't right. Too much sand."
 Sudhanshu asked, "Can earth be good or bad too?"
 "Not every soil is right for every task."
 That sentence felt certain.
 Sudhanshu closed his eyes.
 Earth on his mother's palm.
 Dust under her nails.
 Bangles at her wrist.
 The hands from the first fragment again.
 Was one bangle really broken?
 He thought of telephoning his sister Shobha.
 It was half past six.
 He called.
 Shobha answered.
 "So late in the evening?"
 "The first rain came."
 "It came here yesterday."
 "I'm remembering Ma."
 There was a brief silence at the other end.
 "I remembered her yesterday too."
 "What did Ma do in the first rain?"
 Shobha laughed.
 "What sort of examination is this?"
 "I'm only asking."
 "First she ran to the roof. Wherever it leaked, she put a bucket underneath."
 Sudhanshu started.
 "Yes."
 "You'd forgotten?"
 "No... I remember now."
 The leaking roof.
 That fragment opened.
 The old tiled roof.
 Heavy rain.
 Four vessels set out inside the house.
 A brass bucket.
 A metal pot.
 A broken tub.
 And, in one place, a lota.

His mother saying, "Not the lota. Bring a bigger vessel."
 Babuji insisting on climbing onto the roof.
 His mother stopping him: "Not now. You'll slip."
 Babuji saying, "If not now, when?"
 His mother: "When the rain stops."
 The two arguing.
 Sudhanshu and Shobha laughing.
 "Shobha," Sudhanshu said, "did Ma like the first rain?"
 "Why wouldn't she?"
 "Are you sure?"
 "It seems so to me."
 "She was always annoyed."
 "With the work. Not with the rain."
 "Is there a difference?"
 "A great one."
 Sudhanshu fell silent.
 Shobha said, "Do you remember? After all the work was done she would sit at the doorway and breathe in the smell."
 "Yes!"
 "You used to ask, 'Do you like the smell?'"
 Sudhanshu sat up straight.
 "You remember that?"
 "A little."
 "What did she say?"
 Shobha thought.
 "Perhaps: 'The earth is wet.'"
 Sudhanshu laughed.
 "That's what I remember too."
 For a few moments they were silent.
 The same sentence in two separate memories.
 Did that prove the sentence true?
 Not necessarily.
 But it strengthened their trust in it.
 Shobha said, "Once Ma cried in the first rain."
 Sudhanshu was startled.
 "When?"
 "After you had gone to the city."
 "Why?"
 "Don't you remember?"
 "No."
 "A large branch of the mango tree broke."
 Sudhanshu went quiet.
 The mango tree.
 Behind the house.
 Had Babuji planted it?
 Or Grandfather?

Shobha said, "A storm at night. Rain in the morning. Half the branch came down. Ma cried when she saw it."

"For the tree?"

"Perhaps."

"Ma cried for a tree?"

"Why shouldn't people cry for trees?"

Sudhanshu felt foolish for asking.

Shobha continued, "She said your swing used to be tied to that branch."

"I don't remember."

"That's why I do."

The sentence did not hurt Sudhanshu.

It relieved him.

What he did not remember, someone else did.

Memory is distributed within a family.

No one person holds the whole house.

"And the bangle?" Sudhanshu asked suddenly.

"What bangle?"

"I remember one broken glass bangle on Ma's wrist. In the first rain, while she was lifting a sack."

Shobha laughed.

"You remember such tiny things!"

"Was it true?"

"I don't know."

"Did Ma wear broken bangles?"

"Who would wear a broken bangle? It would cut the hand."

Sudhanshu fell silent.

"Then I'm wrong?"

"Maybe the bangle wasn't broken. Old glass sometimes has a white line through it."

Sudhanshu saw the first fragment again.

Perhaps the bangle had not been broken.

Had his memory added a mark of damage?

His mother had died, and so the bangle in an old scene had broken too?

The thought made him uneasy.

Memory paints later sorrow onto earlier scenes.

"All right," he said.

Shobha asked, "Are you about to cry?"

"No."

"Your voice sounds like it."

"It's the smell."

"Does smell go into the eyes?"

They both laughed.

The call ended.

The rain had stopped.

Drops clung to the balcony railing.

The smell of earth had almost vanished.

The memory had not.
 At dinner that night, his son Aniruddh came in.
 He was seventeen.
 He asked, "Babu, why are you sitting here in the dark?"
 Sudhanshu switched on the light.
 "I was watching the rain."
 "It's stopped now."
 "Yes."
 Aniruddh looked at the soil in the flowerpots.
 "This plant is drying up again."
 From the kitchen Mrinalini said, "If either of you ever watered it, it wouldn't dry up."
 Sudhanshu laughed.
 His mother came to mind.
 Had she complained in exactly the same way?
 "Who will water the tulsi?"
 Perhaps.
 Mrinalini called, "What are you laughing at?"
 "Nothing."
 Aniruddh asked, "Are you remembering Dadi?"
 Sudhanshu was surprised.
 "Your mother told you?"
 "Yes."
 "Ma told him," Mrinalini corrected from the kitchen.
 Aniruddh smiled.
 "All right. Which thing about Dadi?"
 Sudhanshu began searching for an answer.
 There were many fragments.
 Which one should he choose?
 He said, "At the first rain she would run about saving the house."
 Aniruddh laughed.
 "Saving the house?"
 "Clothes, grain, wood, the roof leaking..."
 "Oh."
 Sudhanshu said, "And afterwards she would sit at the doorway."
 "Why?"
 "Perhaps for the smell."
 Aniruddh said, "Dadi liked the smell of wet earth?"
 Sudhanshu answered at once, "The smell of earth."
 "Yes, that."
 "I don't know."
 Aniruddh laughed.
 "So much story, and then 'I don't know'?"
 "That is the right answer."
 Aniruddh looked at him in surprise.
 Sudhanshu liked his own answer.

That night he took out the box of old photographs.
His mother in many forms.
At her wedding.
Young.
With the children.
In the courtyard.
In a city hospital during her final year.
He set aside the photograph from her last year.
Today he did not want his sick mother.
Then he felt uneasy with himself.
Why should he choose which version of his mother he wanted?
Illness too had been part of her life.
He put the photograph back among the others.
In one old photograph his mother stood in the courtyard.
Was the earth behind her wet?
The photograph was black and white.
There was no knowing whether it had been taken after rain or on an ordinary day.

Sudhanshu began imagining the smell.
Then he closed the photographs.
A picture cannot give off a smell.
And imagination is not evidence.
The next morning the city was clean.
A few leaves lay on the road.
There was no smell of earth.
Sudhanshu went to the office.
He worked all day.
His mother came now and then without the smell.
One fragment—
His school results were poor.
His mother silent.
Babuji scolding him.
At night his mother saying, “So you failed once. What of it?”
“Why don’t you say that to Babuji?”
“He will say what he has to. That is his way. I am saying mine.”
This was not a rain-memory.
Still, it came.
Another fragment—
His mother bargaining in the market.
Half an hour over one rupee.
Sudhanshu embarrassed.
Back home, his mother saying, “Do you think money grows by itself for you?”
This too had nothing to do with rain.
A third—
His mother on her sickbed.
She asked, “Is the earth behind the house still the same?”

Sudhanshu had said, "The house has been sold."
 His mother replied, "I know. I asked about the earth."
 Sudhanshu had not been able to answer.
 He had not gone to the village that last year.
 With this fragment came guilt.
 He wanted the smell of earth to open only tender memories.
 Memory did not obey his wish.
 At noon in the office he messaged Shobha: "Did Ma ask about the earth behind the house near the end?"
 The reply came late.
 "Yes. She asked me too."
 Sudhanshu kept looking at the screen.
 Then the question had not been meant only for him.
 The guilt shifted a little.
 It did not disappear.
 Perhaps his mother had not been asking about the house, but about the state of the soil.
 Why?
 What was special about that earth?
 He called Shobha.
 "Why do you think Ma asked?"
 Shobha said, "The smell of the first rain was always very strong in the earth behind the house."
 "All earth smells in rain."
 "Maybe."
 "And?"
 "Ma used to grow vegetables there."
 "I remember now."
 "You're remembering everything now."
 Shobha laughed.
 So did Sudhanshu.
 "And after the land was sold?"
 "The new owner paved it."
 Sudhanshu fell silent.
 "All of it?"
 "Almost. I saw it the last time I went."
 "You went?"
 "Yes, two years ago."
 "Why didn't you tell me?"
 "Tell you what? That the courtyard was paved?"
 Sudhanshu understood: what was heavy news to him now had been an old fact to Shobha for two years.
 Memory does not move at the same pace within a family.
 There was no rain on the third day.
 The heat returned.
 The smell of earth disappeared.

His mother did not.
 Sudhanshu now began deliberately noting the fragments.
 Then he stopped.
 Why?
 To make a story?
 To preserve his mother?
 To prevent his own forgetting?
 He opened a notebook.
 On the first page he wrote: "The Scent of Earth."
 Then for a long time, nothing.
 The title seemed too beautiful to him.
 That made him suspicious.
 Could his mother's life fit inside a beautiful title?
 He did not tear out the page.
 Below it he wrote: "Fragments. No sequence."
 Then, one thing at a time.
 "First rain—bring the sacks inside."
 "Leaking roof—buckets."
 "No bare feet in the first rain."
 "Different soil for different work."
 "Mango branch—Shobha's memory, not mine."
 "Broken bangle? Not certain."
 "Earth behind the house—final question."
 That was all.
 He closed the notebook.
 He understood that paper would not correct memory.
 It would only show the boundary—how much was known, how much was not.
 On the fourth day, while returning from the office, he saw a dry earthen flowerpot in the market.
 The shopkeeper said, "Plant in the rains; it will take root quickly."
 Sudhanshu bought one.
 When he brought it home, Mrinalini asked, "Another plant?"
 "Yes."
 "Who saved the last two?"
 "This time I'll water it."
 Aniruddh laughed.
 "Dadi's influence?"
 Sudhanshu said, "Perhaps."
 Then at once, "No. For the plant."
 He smiled at his own answer.
 It was not right to connect everything to his mother.
 A week later, the second rain came.
 The smell was not as sharp as the first.
 Sudhanshu looked at the dry soil in the balcony pot.
 The first drop fell.
 The soil darkened.

The smell rose.
 He deliberately did not close his eyes.
 He kept looking straight ahead.
 His mother came.
 This time not as one scene.
 Fragments.
 His mother drying wheat.
 His mother searching for her slippers.
 His mother sweeping.
 His mother on her sickbed, asking about the back of the house.
 His mother braiding Shobha's hair.
 His mother arguing with Babuji about climbing onto the roof.
 His mother bargaining over one rupee in the market.
 His mother putting sattu into his bag at the railway station.
 His mother sitting silently at the doorway, watching the wet courtyard.
 No order.
 No single meaning.
 This time Sudhanshu did not try to arrange the story.
 Whatever fragment the smell brought, he let it come.
 Whatever did not come, he did not go searching for it.
 The rain grew stronger.
 Aniruddh stood at the balcony door.
 "Babu, should we bring the plant inside? It'll get too much water."
 Sudhanshu started.
 "Yes."
 Together they moved the pot inside.
 Water dripped from the soil onto the floor.
 From a distance Mrinalini said, "Put a cloth down first!"
 Sudhanshu burst out laughing.
 Aniruddh asked, "What?"
 "Nothing."
 Mrinalini handed them a cloth.
 Sudhanshu bent to wipe the water.
 His hands were dark with wet soil.
 Suddenly the first fragment of his mother's hands again.
 The bangle.
 The sack.
 The mud.
 He kept looking at his hands.
 Aniruddh said, "Babu?"
 "Yes."
 "Are you all right?"
 "Yes."
 Then Sudhanshu said, "I remember a bangle. Perhaps it wasn't broken."
 Aniruddh did not understand.
 "What?"

“Something old.”

He stood up.

Washed his hands.

That night he sent Shobha a photograph of his hand smeared with earth.

Shobha replied: “Like Ma?”

Sudhanshu wrote: “Perhaps just a hand.”

Shobha wrote: “Right.”

Whether that “right” meant agreement or amusement, he could not tell.

A week later Sudhanshu decided to go to the village.

Mrinalini asked, “Only to see the soil?”

“No.”

“Then?”

“I’ll meet Shobha. Some of the old people.”

“And the soil?”

Sudhanshu laughed.

“I’ll see.”

The old family house in the village now belonged to another family.

Sudhanshu informed them in advance.

The new owner, Vinod Yadav, said easily, “Come.”

Sudhanshu arrived on Saturday morning.

The house stood between recognition and unfamiliarity.

The main wall was now brick and cement.

The old doorway had been widened.

The courtyard was paved.

The strip at the back was covered with stone slabs.

Only one corner of earth remained, where two banana plants and a lemon tree grew.

Sudhanshu stood still.

Vinod asked, “Vegetables used to grow here?”

“Yes.”

“When I came, half of it was still bare. Later I paved it.”

“You did right.”

Vinod looked at him, perhaps expecting the old owner to show pain.

Sudhanshu truly was saddened.

But he had no right to say, “You did wrong.”

The house was Vinod’s now.

Vinod said, “I left this corner unpaved because my wife wanted plants.”

Sudhanshu did not touch the lemon tree.

The soil was dry.

The sky was clear.

The first rain had already passed.

He did not bend down to smell the earth.

He laughed at himself.

Without the smell, earth was simply earth.

Vinod’s wife brought water.

“I saw your mother once,” she said.

Sudhanshu was startled.

"When?"

"I was a child. At the haat."

"What do you remember?"

She laughed.

"What could I remember from so long ago? She spoke very loudly."

Sudhanshu laughed aloud.

His mother did speak loudly.

This was not a memory brought by smell.

A small fragment belonging to someone else.

She said, "My mother used to say your mother saved a lot of vegetable seeds."

Sudhanshu remembered none of this.

"Which seeds?"

"Bottle gourd, ridge gourd... I don't know."

In his mind he wrote: "Seeds—someone else's memory."

He did not take out the notebook.

In the remaining patch of old earth behind the house, Vinod's grandson was playing.

He was running a toy car through the soil.

Sudhanshu felt the urge to look for his own childhood there.

He stopped himself.

The child's play belonged to the child.

There was no need to lay an old scene over it.

Shobha arrived in the afternoon.

The two sat outside the old house in the shade of a neem tree.

The neem was new.

The old neem had been cut down long ago.

Sudhanshu said, "Do you see Ma here?"

Shobha said, "Sometimes."

"Where?"

"Nowhere in particular. Suddenly."

"From a smell?"

"Not always."

"Yesterday I remembered her while heating oil."

"What oil?"

"Mustard. She used to put it in our hair, remember?"

For a moment Sudhanshu almost smelled it.

Can suggestion manufacture a smell inside memory?

He laughed.

Shobha asked, "What?"

"Nothing."

They kept talking about the old house.

On one point they agreed.

On another they did not.

Did their mother bring the stove inside on rainy days?

Shobha: yes.

Sudhanshu: the stove was fixed.
 Then they remembered there had been two stoves.
 One fixed, one portable.
 Did their mother make pua in the first rain?
 Shobha said, "Sometimes."
 Sudhanshu did not remember.
 Did their mother ever step outside to be drenched in the first rain?
 Sudhanshu said, "No."
 Shobha said, "Once she did."
 "When?"
 "Babuji had gone to town. It rained after a very hot spell. She stood in the courtyard for two minutes."
 "You saw her?"
 "Yes."
 "Where was I?"
 "Probably at college."
 Sudhanshu fell silent.
 There was a mother in Shobha's memory standing in the rain, and not in Sudhanshu's.
 Were they two different mothers?
 No.
 Different moments of one life.
 Clouds gathered over the village that evening.
 Shobha said, "It'll rain again."
 Sudhanshu laughed.
 "Another examination for the smell?"
 "You're still asking questions."
 The first drop struck the neem leaves.
 Then the earth.
 The small surviving corner behind Vinod's house grew wet.
 The smell rose.
 Different from the city balcony?
 Sudhanshu drew a deep breath.
 He wanted to compare them.
 Then stopped.
 Measuring fragrance could not prove the past.
 Shobha asked, "Remember anything?"
 "A lot."
 "What?"
 Sudhanshu thought.
 The first fragment?
 The sack?
 The bangle?
 The roof?
 The mango branch?
 The final question?

He said, "I didn't remember Ma only once."
 Shobha smiled.
 "What sort of answer is that?"
 "The right one."
 The rain grew heavier.
 Vinod's wife called from inside, "You'll get soaked!"
 Shobha got up.
 Sudhanshu remained standing for two more moments.
 The smell of earth was strong.
 His mother came—
 but this time Sudhanshu did not want to hold on to her.
 Not a complete story.
 Not a complete face.
 Not a complete voice.
 Fragments were enough.
 He went inside.
 That night, in the village guest room, he opened the notebook.
 The first page: "The Scent of Earth."
 Below it: "Fragments. No sequence."
 He added a few new things.
 "Seeds—Vinod's wife; not my memory."
 "Ma stood in the rain for two minutes—Shobha's memory."
 "Earth behind the house almost entirely paved; one corner remains."
 Then he wrote: "Did Ma like the rain?"
 After a long time, the answer: "Not in one word."
 He stopped there.
 Closed the notebook.
 In the morning, when he left for the city, the earth was still wet.
 The smell was faint.
 Sudhanshu looked back once from the doorway.
 The day before, he had thought of taking a handful of soil with him.
 Now he did not.
 Taking the earth away would not preserve its smell.
 And memory did not need to be turned into an object.
 He left empty-handed.
 On the way Shobha said, "Will you come again next year?"
 "If I feel like it."
 "For Ma?"
 Sudhanshu said, "For myself. Ma turns up everywhere."
 Shobha laughed.
 "Well said."
 When he reached the city, Aniruddh asked, "Did you bring any soil?"
 "No."
 "Why?"
 "Whose soil?"
 Aniruddh did not understand.

Sudhanshu laughed.
“Never mind.”
Mrinalini asked, “How was the village?”
“Changed.”
“The house?”
“Someone else’s house.”
“The smell of the earth?”
Sudhanshu thought for a moment.
“It was there.”
“Like your mother’s?”
He laughed.
“Ma wasn’t a smell.”
Mrinalini said nothing.
Sudhanshu went to the balcony.
The potted plant was doing well now.
The soil was faintly damp.
He touched it with a finger.
There was almost no smell.
His mother came to mind again.
Without rain.
This time she was laughing.
At what?
He did not remember.
Sudhanshu did not try to complete the memory.
Let the laughter remain.
Without its cause.
That was enough.
A few weeks later the rains became regular.
The sharpness of the first smell was gone.
The city earth was wet every day.
Sudhanshu did not remember his mother every day.
At first this had felt like guilt.
Now it did not.
Memory is not a duty.
The first rain had opened a door.
The door did not need to remain open every day.
Sometimes a hand.
Sometimes a voice.
Sometimes a broken bangle that might never have been broken.
Sometimes his sister’s different memory.
Sometimes only an empty space.
His mother was not complete within these fragments.
But neither was she absent.
One evening Sudhanshu opened the notebook again.
He wrote one last line:
“Do not write as remembered what is not remembered.”

Then he closed the notebook.
Outside, it was raining.
There was no smell of earth, because the ground was already wet.
Sudhanshu sat in the balcony.
He remembered his mother.
This time, for no reason at all.
He smiled.
Perhaps memory had finally become independent of fragrance.

The Roofless House

Ghareshwar Jha recognised his house from a distance not by its walls, but by the sky.

Where the tiled roof ought to have been, the blue evening sky was visible.

He stopped on the footpath.

A bag on his back.

A small file in his hand.

He had returned to the village after eighteen years.

In the meantime he had come twice for weddings and once for a shraddha, but had not gone as far as his old house.

His parents had earlier moved to Patna to live with his younger brother.

His father had died there.

His mother later continued to live with the younger brother.

The house remained locked.

Sometimes someone looked after the fields.

Sometimes no one did.

Ghareshwar had begun with work in a textile mill in Surat, Gujarat.

Later he had a small warehouse.

Then a business of his own.

The village remained in his conversation, not in his daily life.

Now the land papers had to be put in order.

His younger brother had said, "Go and see the condition of the house. If it is worth rebuilding, we shall rebuild it; otherwise clear it, tidy the place and keep the land."

Ghareshwar had replied easily, "I'll go and see."

He had imagined a broken tiled roof, moss on the walls, a locked door.

He had not imagined that the roof would be entirely gone.

The front gate of the house hung half loose.

He touched it.

The hinge creaked.

There was less grass than scrub in the courtyard.

The wall of the room on the left survived.

Two pillars of the veranda on the right.

In the middle there was no roof.

No tiles.

No bamboo.

No rafters.

Only the broken upper edges of the walls.

As though the head of the house had been cut off.

Ghareshwar crossed the threshold.

He went inside looking upwards.

Sky inside the house.

A kite circled very high above.

A small peepal sapling had grown in a corner of the wall.
 Dry leaves lay on the floor.
 Old stains from rainwater.
 His first question was—who had taken the roof away?
 The second—when?
 The third—why had no one told him?
 It was the third question that sounded loudest inside him.
 “Who didn’t tell you?”
 The voice came from behind.
 Ghareshwar turned.
 Raghunandan Kaka stood at the gate.
 He was over eighty.
 It took Ghareshwar a moment to recognise him.
 Raghunandan laughed.
 “Ghareshwar?”
 “Kaka!”
 They came closer.
 Ghareshwar touched his feet.
 Raghunandan placed a hand on his head.
 “So at last you remembered the way home?”
 The sentence was spoken with laughter, not as a taunt.
 Ghareshwar smiled.
 “This roof?”
 Raghunandan looked towards the house.
 “Half went in the storm. Ramsevak had the rest taken down.”
 “Ramsevak?”
 “He used to look after your fields, didn’t he?”
 “When was that?”
 “Four years?”
 Raghunandan thought.
 “No, five. The year Bauan was married.”
 Ghareshwar fell silent.
 “No one telephoned?”
 “Ramsevak must have.”
 “Not me.”
 “Then your younger brother.”
 Irritation rose inside Ghareshwar.
 He would ask his younger brother.
 Then Raghunandan said casually, “Ramsevak is not here any more either.”
 “Where did he go?”
 “Gone means gone. He died.”
 Ghareshwar’s mouth remained open.
 “When?”
 “Two years ago.”
 Raghunandan came inside and sat on a brick.
 “Chest pain. At night. Before they could reach the hospital.”

That was all.

Then, pointing to the peepal growing on the wall, he said, "Cut that. The roots will split the wall."

Ghareshwar felt the distance between the two sentences was too small.

Ramsevak is dead.

Cut the peepal.

He could not decide whether to be angry at such ease or astonished by it.

"Ramsevak Kaka died?"

"Yes."

"No one told me."

"Someone at your home must have heard."

"Not me."

"You live away. News travels around before it reaches people."

A sentence rose inside Ghareshwar: I live away, but that does not mean people stop dying.

It sounded harsh even to him.

He did not say it.

Raghunandan stood up.

"First clear the house. Where will you stay tonight?"

"I had thought of staying here."

Kaka looked up.

"Under the sky?"

Ghareshwar laughed.

"Could I put tin over one room?"

"Today?"

"No. Today perhaps at your house?"

"Come."

Raghunandan's house was in the adjoining lane.

On the way three people recognised Ghareshwar and stopped him.

"Ghareshwar Babu?"

"The one who lives in Surat?"

"After so many years."

An elderly woman said, "How is your mother?"

"She is well."

"May God keep her so."

Then the woman herself said, "My sister Manorama is no more."

Ghareshwar stopped.

Manorama Mausī?

As a child he used to go to her house to eat jaggery.

"When?"

"Three months."

The woman wiped her head with the end of her sari.

"Come on, it is hot."

She walked away.

Ghareshwar looked after her.

Raghunandan said, "How many people will you stop for? You will hear many names."

"Kaka, does everyone here speak like this?"

"Like what?"

"Manorama Mausi died, and the next sentence is about the sun."

Raghunandan laughed.

"Will the sun stop?"

Ghareshwar said nothing.

Tea came on the veranda of Raghunandan's house.

His daughter-in-law Malti touched Ghareshwar's feet.

"I saw you when I was little," she said.

Ghareshwar smiled.

Malti asked, "Did you see the house?"

"Yes."

"Very bad?"

"There is no roof."

"Some of the walls are sound."

"You all knew?"

Malti said naturally, "Everyone saw it after the storm."

"No one told me..."

He did not finish the sentence.

Repeating the same thing again and again had begun to feel like self-pity.

While they drank tea, Raghunandan began giving him village news.

"Both of Shivshankar's sons are away."

"Babita became a teacher."

"The old school building was demolished and a new one built."

"Half the pond has filled up."

"Hardev Yadav is no more."

"When?"

"Five years."

"Hardev Kaka too?"

"Yes."

"Sugni Dai?"

"She went long ago."

"How long?"

"Eight or ten years."

"Bachchan Master?"

"He is alive."

Ghareshwar felt relief.

"Where?"

"In Darbhanga with his daughter. His eyesight is poor."

Names came one by one.

Some alive.

Some dead.

Some away.

Some still in the village, but old.

At some names a face rose inside Ghareshwar.
 At others, only the name.
 Raghunandan never lowered his voice when mentioning a death.
 He spoke in the same tone in which he spoke of roads, weddings, jobs, trees, crops.
 Once Ghareshwar asked, "Kaka, how can you say it all so easily?"
 Raghunandan set down his tea.
 "What?"
 "So-and-so died, so-and-so died."
 Kaka looked at him carefully.
 "What do you want? Shall I weep every time I tell you?"
 Ghareshwar was embarrassed.
 "No."
 "The day someone dies, we weep. Years later, we give the news."
 Malti, listening from the kitchen, said, "Sometimes we weep years later too."
 Raghunandan said, "That is different."
 That 'different' contained the whole matter.
 That night Ghareshwar slept in their house.
 An old spare room of Raghunandan's.
 Sleep came late.
 The roof above him was intact.
 Yet he kept seeing his own roofless house.
 Sky inside.
 Peepal.
 Ramsevak.
 Manorama Mausli.
 Hardev Kaka.
 Sugni Dai.
 He felt that the house had not lost its roof in a single day.
 It had gradually been absent, and the house had gradually opened up.
 First people went away.
 Then belongings.
 Then care.
 Then tiles.
 Then bamboo.
 Then the roof.
 The walls remained.
 Was the village like that too?
 People leaving one by one, while paths, walls and names remained?
 He stopped himself at once.
 Every broken house did not have to become a metaphor for life.
 The house was truly a house.
 The roof truly needed repair.
 Ghareshwar woke early.
 Malti gave him tea.
 Raghunandan asked, "Work today?"
 "First clear the house."

"Shall I call Bhola the labourer?"
 "Which Bhola?"
 "Haricharan's son."
 Ghareshwar laughed.
 "In my mind Bhola is still five years old."
 Raghunandan said, "Now his son is five."
 Time became suddenly clear in that sentence.
 Ghareshwar reached the house.
 Bhola came with two young men.
 They cut the scrub.
 Removed the dry leaves.
 Carefully cut the peepal growing on the wall.
 Separated the broken bricks.
 A few pieces of old wood in one corner.
 An iron hook.
 A broken earthen pot.
 Ghareshwar looked at the objects.
 Whose?
 From when?
 At first the impulse came to save everything.
 Then he understood—not every object was memory.
 Some of it was rubbish.
 Bhola asked, "Keep this pot?"
 Ghareshwar said, "No."
 "The wood?"
 "Set aside whatever can be used."
 "And the rest?"
 "Burn it."
 The answer surprised him.
 He had thought that the moment he entered the old house he would become sentimental and keep everything.
 When work stands before you, decisions become smaller.
 By afternoon the walls were clearly visible.
 The old plan of the house could be understood.
 This was the kitchen.
 This the store-room.
 This his father's room.
 This the veranda.
 Without the roof, the rooms were only boundaries.
 Ghareshwar stood in the middle of one room.
 Clouds above.
 Bhola said, "It may rain today."
 "Then?"
 "The bricks will get wet. Cover whatever you want to save."
 Ghareshwar laughed.
 Like his mother's voice—cover whatever you want to save.

He remembered his mother's old domestic caution.
 That was all.
 He did not want to attach the memory to some other story.
 He simply remembered the way his own mother behaved.
 He and Bhola covered the old door panels.
 In the afternoon Narendra, Bachchan Master's son, came.
 "Babuji heard that you had come."
 "Is Bachchan Master in the village?"
 "He will come from Darbhanga tomorrow. When he heard your name he said he would meet you."
 Ghareshwar's face brightened.
 "I'll see him."
 Narendra looked at the house.
 "Will you build the roof again?"
 "I don't know."
 "Half the foundations beneath these walls are weak."
 "Has anyone looked?"
 "A mason should inspect it."
 Then Narendra said casually, "Do you remember Shambhu, who studied with you?"
 "Shambhu Sah?"
 "Yes."
 "Where is he?"
 "He is no more."
 The iron hook fell from Ghareshwar's hand.
 "Shambhu?"
 "Yes. During the pandemic year."
 Ghareshwar stood leaning against the wall.
 Shambhu was his age.
 The same bench at school.
 Once the two of them had skipped an examination and gone to the pond.
 Later Shambhu ran a grocery shop.
 Had Ghareshwar ever had his telephone number?
 Perhaps not.
 "Family?"
 "His wife is there. Two daughters. The elder one is married."
 Narendra touched the wall and said, "Demolish this section and build it again; otherwise the expense will double."
 Shambhu is dead.
 Demolish the wall.
 Again, the same closeness.
 This time Ghareshwar noticed it, but was not irritated.
 Perhaps the people of the village were not insensitive.
 Life put death and masons in the same line of sentences.
 In the afternoon he wanted to go to Shambhu's house.
 He asked Narendra the way.

"The same house behind the shop."
 Shambhu's wife Kamla now ran the shop.
 Ghareshwar went.
 Kamla did not recognise him at once.
 When he told her his name, her eyes widened.
 "Oh, you?"
 She seated him inside.
 Ghareshwar saw Shambhu's photograph on the wall.
 No garland.
 An ordinary frame.
 "I only learned just now," Ghareshwar said.
 Kamla nodded.
 "You live away."
 "I did not even have his number..."
 "His old number had stopped working."
 Kamla rose to make tea.
 Ghareshwar said, "Please don't trouble yourself."
 "What trouble?"
 She gave him tea.
 They began speaking of Shambhu.
 The pandemic year.
 Fever.
 Difficulty finding a place in hospital.
 A few days.
 Then the end.
 Kamla kept the details brief.
 Ghareshwar asked few questions.
 He said, "When we were in school..."
 Kamla laughed.
 "I have heard the story of the pond."
 Ghareshwar was startled.
 "He told you that?"
 "Many times. He used to say—both of us skipped the exam and went to watch the fish."
 "Not to watch fish. To swim."
 "See? He went away protecting his side of the story."
 They both laughed.
 For a moment the dead Shambhu became a boy.
 After laughing, Kamla asked naturally, "Will the roof of your house be rebuilt?"
 Ghareshwar said, "I don't know."
 "Shambhu used to say the rafters in that house were very strong."
 "There are no rafters now."
 "They were taken down and sold after the storm?"
 Ghareshwar looked at her in surprise.
 "Sold?"
 "Ramsevak said they would rot. The money was sent to your brother."

Now the matter became clear.
 The roof had not been stolen.
 The rafters and bamboo had been taken down and sold.
 His younger brother probably knew.
 Ghareshwar's irritation changed direction.
 If he himself had never asked about his own house, whom was he blaming?
 Kamla said, "Ramsevak looked after it a great deal."
 "Yes. I understand that now."
 "After he died, the house was left completely unattended."
 In that sentence Ramsevak's value became clear.
 He had not merely been the man who watched the fields.
 He had been the last watcher of the house.
 Ghareshwar thought he should meet Ramsevak's family.
 Kamla said, "His son Bhola is the one working with you, isn't he?"
 Ghareshwar was startled.
 "Bhola is Ramsevak's son?"
 "Yes."
 He felt ashamed.
 Since morning the young man had been working beside him, and Ghareshwar had kept asking about his father's death as if speaking of a stranger, without joining the relationship to the name.
 His memory of village lineages and kinship was stuck in old places.
 Ghareshwar returned to the house.
 Bhola was clearing dust from a crack in the wall.
 Ghareshwar watched him for a while.
 "Your father used to look after the house?"
 Bhola stopped his hand.
 "Yes."
 "I only learned properly today."
 "What?"
 "A lot of things."
 Bhola laughed.
 "I thought everyone knew."
 "I wasn't among everyone."
 The sentence felt heavy the moment it came out.
 Bhola said, "Babu used to say—the people of the house are away; we must not let the house fall."
 "He had the roof taken down?"
 "Yes. Half the tiles had fallen after the storm. The remaining bamboo was getting wet and rotting. He spoke to Chhote Babu and had it sold. The money was sent."
 "Do you remember how much?"
 "I was away doing labour then. I heard about it later."
 Ghareshwar telephoned his younger brother.
 "Do you remember the roof?"
 His younger brother was silent.
 Then he said, "Yes."

"Ramsevak told you?"

"Yes."

"Why didn't you tell me?"

"I thought I would tell you later. Then... perhaps I did tell you?"

"No."

"You were very busy with the business."

Ghareshwar could have become angry.

Then he remembered his own many unanswered calls, postponed journeys, his own 'later'.

"All right," he said.

His younger brother asked, "Is the house very bad?"

"There is no roof."

"The walls?"

"Some are sound."

"What will we do?"

"I don't know yet."

"Shall we sell the land?"

Ghareshwar looked towards the open sky of the house.

"Not deciding yet."

He ended the call.

Bhola returned to work.

Ghareshwar said, "Who is in your family?"

"Ma. Me. My sister is married."

"I'll meet your mother."

Bhola said naturally, "Come in the evening."

In the evening Ghareshwar went with Bhola to Ramsevak's house.

Ramsevak's wife Saraswati Devi had become very thin.

The moment she saw Ghareshwar she said, "Eyes like your father's."

Ghareshwar touched her feet.

"Kaki, I only learned properly now how Babuji used to look after the house."

Saraswati said, "He needed work. He used to look after fields and houses."

"We..."

Ghareshwar wanted to say 'thank you'.

The word sounded formal.

Saraswati said, "He was paid."

Ghareshwar fell silent.

He had been turning it into a story of favour; Saraswati turned it into a relationship of labour.

Ramsevak had served them, but there had also been wages and accounts.

Both truths together.

"In his last days..." Ghareshwar asked.

Saraswati said, "He went quickly."

Then she said to Bhola, "Did you tie the cow?"

Bhola said, "Yes."

A cow in the middle of news of death.

Ghareshwar was beginning to understand this manner now.

On the way home Bhola asked, "Shall I call the roofer tomorrow?"

"First have the foundation checked."

"All right."

The next day Bachchan Master came.

Two men supported him.

His sight was dim.

Ghareshwar touched his feet.

Master brought his face close.

"Ghareshwar?"

"Yes, Master Sahib."

"I recognised you by your voice."

"My voice is still the same?"

"Some things do not change."

Then Master looked at the house.

"No roof."

"Yes."

"One old room at my school was roofless for a long time too. There is a new building now."

Ghareshwar laughed.

Master sat down.

He began asking for news of old pupils one by one.

"Manoj?"

"Delhi."

"Ramakant?"

"No more."

Ghareshwar was startled.

"Ramakant too?"

"Heart."

"Seema?"

"Married on the Nepal side. A grandmother now."

"Phekan?"

"Alive. But paralysed."

Again the names.

Ghareshwar noticed that now he himself was the questioner, while the person before him gave easy answers.

When someone was said to be alive, he felt relief.

When someone was said to be dead, a small jolt inside.

At some names, nothing.

Master said, "By living away, you escaped a great deal."

Ghareshwar was startled.

"Escaped what?"

"The work of watching everyone grow old every day."

Then Master laughed.

"And you lost a great deal too."

"What?"

"The work of watching everyone grow old every day."

The same thing.
One gain, one loss.
The sentence stayed with Ghareshwar for a long time.
After Master left, a mason examined the walls.
Three walls could be saved.
One would have to be demolished and rebuilt.
New rafters would be needed for a roof.
The cost was written down.
Ghareshwar looked at the figure in the file.
In the city the amount was not enormous.
For an empty house in the village?
That was another question.
He asked Bhola, "What if I roof only one room?"
"It will be enough to stay in."
"The rest?"
"Leave it open. Later."
Ghareshwar stood in the middle of the house.
The sun was lowering into the roofless part.
Suddenly he felt not attachment to that openness, but insecurity.
If it rained, the walls would deteriorate further.
Why let the structure rot in the name of memory?
He did not decide immediately.
On the third day there was a death in the village.
Maheshwar Kaka, a distant cousin of Raghunandan.
Age eighty-two.
The news came in the morning.
Raghunandan said, "Come, we'll go to the ghat."
Ghareshwar went.
He did not know Maheshwar well.
Even so, there were some old faces in the crowd.
The grief was immediate.
Weeping.
Silence.
Running about.
Wood.
Vehicle.
Papers.
Water.
That day no one spoke of death like ordinary news.
Raghunandan's sentence came back to him—on the day someone dies, we weep;
years later, we give the news.
Now Ghareshwar was seeing the difference.
The heat of grief changes into the temperature of news with time.
Death does not become ordinary.
News of death settles into ordinary language.

When he returned to the house in the evening, the darkness inside the roofless walls was different.

Stars above.

For the first time he sat for a while at night in his own house.

Bhola had rigged up a temporary bulb, but Ghareshwar kept it switched off.

The stars were enough.

The smell of cooking from a neighbour's house.

Far away, a child studying aloud.

A radio.

A dog.

Life.

He placed his hand on the wall.

Had all the people who had died lived in this house?

No.

Ramsevak was a neighbour.

Manorama Mausi in another lane.

Shambhu in his own house.

Hardev Kaka by the fields.

Yet all their news seemed to be gathering in this roofless house.

Because Ghareshwar had returned here.

The house was not the vessel.

His mind was the vessel.

Again he became cautious of turning everything into metaphor.

He sat quietly for a while.

He thought—in eighteen years, how many deaths had he himself told other people about just as casually?

Yusuf, a colleague in Surat.

"Yusuf Bhai is no more."

Then the next sentence—"The warehouse will remain closed tomorrow."

The warehouse owner's mother.

"She has passed away."

Then—"Payment on Monday."

He was no different.

Only distance had made the village's language sound strange to him.

Over dinner at Raghunandan's house that night he said, "Kaka, tomorrow I'll begin putting a roof on one room."

Raghunandan asked, "One?"

"One first. Over the remaining walls, a temporary covering to keep the water off."

"Will you live here?"

"I don't know yet."

"Then the roof?"

Ghareshwar laughed.

"A roof is not a decision to live here. It is work to save the walls."

Raghunandan nodded.

"Good."

Malti said, "You won't sell the house?"

"Not yet."
 "Prices have gone up."
 "I know."
 "Then?"
 Ghareshwar had no beautiful answer.
 "I don't feel like it yet."
 That was all.
 The next day timber, bamboo and tin arrived.
 There was neither time nor a craftsman to make a roof like the old tiled one.
 A simple tin roof over one room.
 Over the tops of the remaining walls, a strip to keep out the water.
 Work began.
 The sound of hammers echoed through the house again.
 A childhood memory of craftsmen rose in Ghareshwar.
 His father having the roof repaired.
 His mother calling from below, "That tile is upside down!"
 The craftsmen laughing.
 Ghareshwar and his younger brother playing with broken tiles.
 It was a pleasant memory.
 He let it remain.
 Bhola said, "Babu, shall we close this old niche?"
 Ghareshwar looked at the small recess in the wall.
 "No. Let it stay."
 "What use is it?"
 "None."
 This time keeping something useless seemed right to him.
 Not everything had to be useful.
 While the work was going on, an elderly woman came.
 Her name was Phulo Dai.
 The moment she entered the house she said, "In this courtyard your mother used to dry pickle with me."
 Ghareshwar smiled.
 "You remember?"
 "I remember the pickle. Your mother too."
 Then she said casually, "That friend of your mother's from Janakpur is no more."
 Ghareshwar searched for the name.
 "Kamla Mausi?"
 "No, Shyama."
 "Oh..."
 "Yes. Last year."
 Phulo Dai touched the wall.
 "Don't close this niche. An oil lamp used to stand here."
 Ghareshwar looked at Bhola.
 "Did you hear?"
 Bhola laughed.
 "Now we have a reason too."

Phulo Dai went away.
 A question remained in Ghareshwar's mind—why could he not remember Shyama Mausi's face?
 He knew the name.
 Some of the story.
 Not the face.
 The moment one hears that someone has died, a face does not have to arrive.
 Absence too has different degrees.
 It took two days to make the roof.
 One room became shaded again.
 Ghareshwar stood inside.
 The sky had disappeared.
 For three days he had been seeing sky above this room.
 Now there was tin.
 Even after the roof was made, the house did not immediately feel like a house.
 Bare walls.
 Broken floor.
 No door.
 Still, there was shelter from rain.
 He put his bag inside.
 That night he decided to sleep in his own house for the first time.
 Raghunandan objected.
 "The electricity is not right."
 "There is a lamp."
 "Snakes?"
 "Bhola has cleared everything."
 "Fear at night?"
 Ghareshwar laughed.
 "Of what?"
 Raghunandan laughed too.
 "People will say there are ghosts in the old house."
 "I have heard news of so many dead people here; not one has come as a ghost."
 Raghunandan grew serious and said, "Let the dead rest. The living make enough noise."
 Ghareshwar liked the sentence.
 That night, one room beneath a roof.
 The rest of the house under open sky.
 No rain.
 Moonlight.
 Ghareshwar lay on a charpoy.
 Beyond the wall, moonlight fell in the open part.
 He remembered the names one by one.
 Ramsevak.
 Manorama.
 Hardev.
 Sugni.

Shambhu.
Ramakant.
Shyama.
Some close to him.
Some distant.
Some only news.
He did not try to make equal grief out of them all.
That would not have been honest.
More for Shambhu.
For Ramsevak, something like a sense of debt.
For Manorama, the taste of jaggery.
For some of the rest, only names.
Memory is not a democracy of equality.
He did not feel guilty about that.
At dawn the first light fell into the roofless courtyard.
The roofed room was still dark.
Ghareshwar came outside.
He understood—a roof gives shade; an open house gives light.
Both could become useful sentences, but he did not want to make poetry of them.
He picked up a broom.
Began sweeping the courtyard.
Raghunandan Kaka appeared at the gate.
“Babu himself?”
“Today.”
“Do you sweep in Surat too?”
“Sometimes.”
Kaka laughed.
Two cups of tea came.
Ghareshwar asked, “Kaka, who was the last person to live in this house?”
“No one after your father and mother left.”
“Ramsevak at night?”
“Sometimes, during the crop season.”
“The night the roof fell?”
“That year it was a storm at night. Half the tiles blew away. Ramsevak came in the morning. The back room was wet. There were some old books inside.”
Ghareshwar was startled.
“Books?”
“He saved them. Must have sent them to your younger brother.”
Ghareshwar telephoned.
His younger brother said, “Yes, three sacks of old books came. Some were rotten. Whatever survived is with Ma.”
“You didn’t tell me...”
Ghareshwar was about to ask the same question again.
He stopped.
“All right. I’ll see them next time.”
By now he was tired of counting blame.

A man who leaves the village still has a right to news, but some responsibility for seeking news also belongs to him.

He did not turn that thought into a rule.

Every circumstance is different.

But for himself it felt true.

At noon he opened the file.

Land papers.

Khata number.

Boundaries.

Tax.

Necessary matters of work.

Ghareshwar went to the panchayat office.

Signatures.

Copies.

Date for measurement.

This was the real reason for his return.

News of the dead had become the story, but the paperwork did not stop.

That gave him relief.

Memory had not swallowed life whole.

On the way back from the panchayat he stopped at Shambhu's shop.

Kamla asked, "Did the work get done?"

"Half."

"Government work in one day?"

They both laughed.

Ghareshwar bought sugar, salt and matches.

As he paid, he looked towards the photograph.

Shambhu.

Kamla said, "Shall I put it on credit?"

Ghareshwar laughed.

"Am I still a schoolboy who runs up credit?"

"Shambhu used to say Ghareshwar always paid late."

"Lie."

"Whom shall we ask now?"

They both laughed.

The dead man did not become the final judge in a dispute.

The story remained open.

On the eighth day Ghareshwar had to return to Surat.

One room of the house was roofed.

The rest open.

The gate temporarily repaired.

The peepal on the wall cut.

The drain cleared.

Bhola was given the work of monthly upkeep.

"Fix the wage," Ghareshwar said.

"Whatever is proper."

"No. Fix it clearly."

They agreed on an amount.
 Ghareshwar did not want to turn Ramsevak's relationship into a vague favour.
 The value of labour should be clear.
 He said to Bhola, "If something breaks, tell me directly."
 Bhola laughed.
 "If I call, will you answer?"
 Ghareshwar looked at him.
 Then both laughed.
 "If I don't answer, call again."
 "All right."
 Raghunandan came to see him off.
 "Next time when?"
 Out of old habit Ghareshwar wanted to say, "Soon."
 He stopped.
 "I won't give a date. But not after such a long gap."
 Raghunandan nodded.
 "That answer is good."
 Malti packed puris for the journey.
 Ghareshwar said, "No need."
 "You'll eat them on the way."
 He put them in his bag.
 Before closing the gate he looked once more inside the house.
 One roof.
 Three open sections.
 Walls.
 Sky.
 Now the house seemed unfinished to him, not dead.
 'Unfinished' was the necessary word.
 If he called it dead, the work of the house ended.
 There was still a great deal of work left.
 On the way he found Ramanand Jha again at the tea stall.
 "Going back?"
 "Yes."
 "The house?"
 "One room covered."
 "The rest?"
 "Later."
 Ramanand said, "Don't keep saying 'later' until another eighteen years pass."
 Ghareshwar laughed.
 "I'll try."
 As he drank tea, a man came.
 Ramanand introduced him. "This is Jagmohan's son."
 Ghareshwar asked, "How is Jagmohan Kaka?"
 Ramanand was silent for a moment.
 Then said, "He is no more. Last winter."
 The old jolt came inside Ghareshwar again.

But this time he took a breath.
 "Oh."
 The man said, "He kept going to the fields till the end."
 Ghareshwar said, "When I was a child he used to let me sit on the bullock cart."
 The man smiled.
 "He used to seat all the children too."
 Two small memories met.
 Then the man asked, "You work in the cloth trade in Surat, don't you?"
 "Yes."
 The conversation moved on.
 Death remained in the middle without ending the conversation.
 The passenger vehicle arrived.
 Ghareshwar got in.
 The village receded beyond the window.
 The old house was not directly visible.
 Only the new glint of tin in one place.
 He guessed—perhaps the roof of his own house.
 Not certain.
 He opened his phone and sent two photographs to his younger brother.
 First—the roofless house.
 Second—one room with the new tin roof.
 He wrote: "For now, this much."
 His younger brother replied: "Good. Next time I'll come too."
 Ghareshwar did not write 'soon'.
 Only: "Come."
 The vehicle moved on.
 House after house beside the road.
 Some new.
 Some old.
 Some with tin roofs.
 Some tiled.
 Some concrete.
 Ghareshwar did not begin making a list of the dead in his mind.
 A list would make them all equal names.
 He kept Shambhu's laughter separate.
 Ramsevak's work separate.
 The jaggery at Manorama Mausi's separate.
 Jagmohan's bullock cart separate.
 Some names without images.
 That too was all right.
 Not every dead person comes asking for memory.
 Some remain only news.
 And news too is not disrespect.
 Two days after he reached Surat, it rained.
 Ghareshwar was in the warehouse.
 Bhola telephoned.

He answered at once.
 "Yes, Bhola?"
 "It is raining. The new roof is fine. Water is collecting in the open part, but the drain is working."
 "The walls?"
 "Fine."
 "Anything fallen?"
 "No."
 "All right. Check again after the rain stops."
 After ending the call, Ghareshwar smiled.
 No news of anyone's death.
 Only roof and water.
 The ordinariness of that news made him happy.
 That night his younger brother telephoned.
 "I showed Ma the pictures of the house."
 "What did she say?"
 "She was silent when she saw the first. Seeing the second she said—at least one room has survived."
 Ghareshwar asked, "Did Ma know Ramsevak had died?"
 "Yes."
 "Shambhu?"
 "Yes."
 "Manorama Mausi?"
 "Yes."
 Ghareshwar laughed.
 "Everyone knew except me."
 His younger brother said, "You used to rush through business matters on the telephone. When did you ever ask for village news?"
 The sentence stung.
 But it was not wholly wrong.
 Ghareshwar said, "I'll ask now."
 "Don't hear all the news in one day."
 "Why?"
 "You'll stay awake all night again."
 They both laughed.
 The call ended.
 Ghareshwar looked up at the roof of the warehouse.
 Rain on tin.
 Loud.
 The new roof over the one room of the old house must be sounding like this too.
 He imagined—the open courtyard filling with water, the walls getting wet, the roofed room staying dry.
 The house was not whole.
 Still, something remained.
 Like a few faces among pieces of news.
 Again he stopped the comparison.

Today no comparison was necessary.
He merely sent Bhola a short message:
“If the rain becomes very heavy, check again tomorrow. Thank you.”
Bhola replied, “All right.”
Ghareshwar put down the phone.
Rain kept beating on the tin.
This time he heard the sound of having a roof.

The River Spoke

Jatan Sahni used to say that the river called out names.

People laughed.

He laughed too.

For that reason no one knew for certain whether he was joking or telling the truth.

Jatan had been ferrying boats on the Bagmati for forty years.

At first with a bamboo pole.

Then with a broad wooden boat.

Later, small motorboats came as well.

But for night crossings he still preferred the old boat worked with a pole.

"The engine eats the sound of the water," he would say.

People would ask, "And what if it eats the sound of the water?"

Jatan would say, "Then whose name will the river call?"

And there would be laughter again.

The story of it kept circulating at the ghat.

Some said Jatan heard the names of dead people.

Some said the river repeated the name of whichever passenger sat in the boat.

Some said the old boatman's ears were ringing.

Jatan laughed at all three versions.

"When did I ever say dead people?"

"Then whose?"

"Whoever's name I hear."

"How would the river know anyone's name?"

"How do you know the river does not know?"

That ended the argument.

Jatan's house was half a kos from the ghat.

His wife was Devaki.

Their two sons lived away.

The elder drove a passenger vehicle in Muzaffarpur.

The younger worked in a shop in Janakpur.

For years Devaki had been saying, "Give up the boat."

Jatan would ask, "For whom?"

"For yourself."

"What harm is the boat doing me?"

"Your age."

"Will my age become less if I sit at home?"

Devaki would not answer.

She knew that taking Jatan away from the river would not merely mean changing his work.

The direction of dawn.

The movement of the water.

The sounds of the ghat.
Whose field was being eaten away.
Whose cattle-shed might go under.
Whose boat was late.
Whose wedding party had to be ferried across.
These were the measures by which Jatan's day was marked.
A bridge had been built two years earlier.
The number of passengers at the ghat had fallen.
By day the boat stood empty half the time.
Yet some people still chose the boat.
Cyclists for whom going round to the bridge was too long a detour.
People with cattle.
People going to the fields.
And some elderly people who disliked the climb onto the bridge.
Jatan would say, "As long as people need it, the boat will run."
Devaki would say, "Not the people. You need it."
At that sentence Jatan would fall silent.
One evening in Ashadh, clouds rose from the north.
It had not rained all day.
The air was sticky.
The water had risen a little.
There were only three passengers at the ghat.
A vegetable seller.
A schoolteacher.
A boy with a bicycle.
Jatan ferried them all across.
As the teacher stepped out, he asked, "Kaka, will the boat run tonight?"
"If the water remains."
The teacher laughed.
"Where will the water go?"
Jatan said, "Water being there is one thing; water moving is another."
The teacher shook his head and walked away.
The boy asked, "Did the river call any names today?"
Jatan said, "It called yours."
The boy started.
"Really?"
"It said, 'Take the full fare from this boy.'"
Everyone laughed.
The boy gave up insisting on paying two rupees less.
When evening settled, the ghat emptied.
Jatan was about to tie the boat and go home.
Then a voice came from the eastern side.
"Hey, Jatan!"
He turned.
Lakshman Mahato was running towards the ghat.
"Take me across once."

Jatan loosened the rope.
 "So late?"
 "I had gone to fetch medicine for the buffalo."
 Lakshman sat in the boat.
 The sky was grey now.
 Lightning flashed far away, without thunder.
 Jatan set the pole in the water.
 The boat eased away.
 When they reached midstream, Lakshman said, "Kaka, may I ask you something?"
 "Ask."
 "Is that business about the river calling names true?"
 Jatan shifted the pole.
 "What do you think?"
 "I think you make up stories."
 "Then why did you ask?"
 Lakshman laughed.
 "To hear the story."
 Jatan said, "You have already made the story yourself."
 "You tell me."
 Jatan watched the water for a while.
 Then he said, "At first I did not hear names."
 Lakshman fell silent.
 Jatan continued, "At first I heard only sounds."
 "What sort?"
 "The sort water makes."
 "Then when did the names begin?"
 Jatan laughed.
 "Do you need a year for everything?"
 "Approximately."
 "About twenty-five years ago."
 "Whose name was the first?"
 Jatan stopped the pole and thought.
 "Perhaps Sitaram."
 "Sitaram Kaka?"
 "No. I do not know which Sitaram."
 Lakshman grew more interested.
 "At night?"
 "At dawn."
 "Was anyone in the boat?"
 "No."
 "Then?"
 "The water was turning near the reeds at the bank. It sounded quite clearly to me like 'Si-ta-ram'."
 "Then?"
 "Then nothing."

Lakshman was disappointed.
 "What happened to the man?"
 "What man?"
 "Sitaram."
 Jatan laughed.
 "I do not even know whether there was such a man."
 "Then why a name?"
 "My ear made a name out of it."
 "So the river did not call it."
 "That is for you to decide."
 The boat reached the other bank.
 As he stepped out, Lakshman said, "You trap people."
 Jatan said, "The river traps people. I ferry them across."
 More laughter.
 Lakshman went away.
 Jatan turned the boat around alone.
 He was heading back to the ghat near his house.
 The sky had darkened.
 The wind came from the south.
 Small ripples moved over the water.
 On this solitary crossing Jatan usually did not speak.
 The day's names, talk, fares, quarrels—all were left behind.
 Only the pole.
 The water.
 The faint creak of the boat's wood.
 He reached midstream.
 A leaf caught against the side of the boat and spun there.
 A heron called in the distance.
 The reeds on the bank stirred.
 Jatan's ears were on the water.
 Kharr... sarr... tan...
 He kept working the pole.
 Then the sound came again.
 "Jatan."
 The pole stopped in the air.
 The boat turned slightly with the current.
 Jatan looked all around.
 No other boat.
 The bank was far away.
 No one at the ghat.
 Then he touched his ear.
 "What?"
 He asked it himself.
 The water did not answer.
 The waves slapped softly against the belly of the boat.
 Jatan lowered the pole into the water again.

“Jatan.”

This time the sound was faint.

Or was it the memory of the first sound?

He could not decide.

His heart beat faster.

His palms grew damp.

Suddenly Jatan remembered all his own stories.

Sitaram.

Phulo.

Karim.

Bachanu.

So many names he had claimed to hear over the years.

Some had truly been sounds.

Some perhaps the mind.

Some jokes.

Had he himself added some afterwards?

And now his own name.

There was suddenly no room for humour.

Jatan began to straighten the boat.

Lightning flashed again in the distance.

This time thunder followed.

He pushed towards the ghat near his house.

Every sound of the water seemed distinct.

Chhap.

Sarr.

Thak.

Hoo-o-o.

Not one contained a name.

He reached the ghat and tied the rope.

Normally he checked for water inside the boat, set the pole straight, and tested the knot twice.

That night he tied one knot and started away.

After ten steps he turned back.

He checked the rope.

Then he went home.

Devaki stood at the doorway.

“So late?”

“I ferried Lakshman across.”

“Can you see those clouds?”

“Yes.”

“Did you tie the boat properly?”

“Yes.”

Devaki studied his face.

“What happened?”

“Nothing.”

“A face that says ‘nothing’ looks different.”

Jatan said nothing.
Devaki served the meal.
Rice.
Dal.
Potato and pointed gourd.
Jatan ate less than usual.
Devaki asked, "Your stomach?"
"Fine."
"Then?"
Jatan drank some water.
"Today the river called my name."
Devaki's hand stopped.
For a moment she looked at Jatan's face.
Then she said, "So?"
Jatan stared.
"So?"
"You are the one who says the river calls names."
"Other people's."
"Did you make a rule?"
Jatan grew irritated.
"I am not joking."
Devaki's voice softened.
"Neither am I."
After a while she asked, "Did you hear it clearly?"
"Twice."
"Anyone on the bank?"
"No."
"Lakshman?"
"He had already got off."
"Any distant voice?"
"I did not see anyone."
Devaki was silent.
Jatan wanted her to say: It is nothing.
Or: It is an ill omen.
Or: Do not take the boat out tomorrow.
Devaki said none of these things.
She began clearing the plates.
Irritated, Jatan asked, "Aren't you afraid?"
Devaki said, "Of what?"
"The river called my name..."
"First decide whether it was the river or your ear."
Jatan was silent.
Devaki added, "And if it was the river?"
Jatan looked at her.
"Then?"
"What happens merely because someone says your name?"

That question had never appeared in any of Jatan's stories.
People always asked: Whose name?
When?
What happened afterwards?
Devaki asked: What happens because a name is spoken?
Jatan had no answer.
Rain began in the night.
Light at first.
Then heavy.
Water on the tiled roof.
Jatan lay down, but sleep did not come.
Devaki fell asleep after a while.
Jatan began searching for his name in the sound of the rain.
Ja-tan.
Two streams falling from the roof.
Ja-tan.
Bamboo leaves.
Ja-tan.
Frogs in the distance.
He became annoyed with himself.
Once the ear catches hold of a name, every sound can turn into that name.
He turned over.
Half asleep, Devaki asked, "The boat?"
"It is tied."
"Then sleep."
Jatan closed his eyes.
By dawn the rain had stopped.
The river had risen.
Jatan reached the ghat earlier than usual.
The rope was secure.
The boat was half full of rainwater.
He began bailing it out with a tin.
No one was at the ghat.
The eastern sky was pale.
Jatan listened deliberately.
The current of the river.
The soft crumble of the bank being eaten away.
Birds.
A cowbell in the distance.
No name.
He cleared the water from the boat's belly.
The first passenger was a milkman.
"Kaka, early today."
"Sit."
Two women arrived.
A student.

The boat filled.
 Jatan ferried them across.
 Their talk was ordinary.
 Paddy.
 School.
 The price of milk.
 The road.
 From time to time Jatan listened to the water.
 Nothing.
 At noon Lakshman returned.
 The moment he sat in the boat, he said, "Kaka, yesterday you did not finish the story for me."
 Jatan's body tightened.
 "Which one?"
 "The river calling names."
 Jatan set the pole.
 "That is the whole of it."
 Lakshman laughed.
 "Did it call anyone's name again yesterday?"
 Jatan looked at him.
 He wanted to say: mine.
 He did not.
 "No."
 The lie was small, but heavy.
 Lakshman changed the subject.
 He got off on the other side.
 Alone, Jatan wondered why he had been unable to say it.
 When the story concerned other people's names, it had been entertainment.
 When his own name entered it, had it become private?
 Or frightening?
 At the ghat's tea stall that afternoon sat Rampukar.
 He was an old friend of Jatan's.
 He too had once worked a boat, but had stopped when his knees went bad.
 Jatan sat down for tea.
 Rampukar said, "Why is your face so fallen?"
 "Didn't sleep much."
 "Devaki telling you again to leave the boat?"
 "Every day."
 Rampukar laughed.
 After a while Jatan asked, "Have you ever heard your own name in the water?"
 Rampukar stopped laughing.
 "Why?"
 "A question."
 "Your answer first."
 Jatan looked down at his tea.
 "I heard it yesterday."

Rampukar said nothing for a long time.
 Jatan grew irritated.
 "Now you too will find a meaning in it."
 Rampukar said, "I am thinking."
 "What?"
 "For how many years have you been hearing other people's names?"
 "Don't know. Twenty-five or thirty."
 "And your own for the first time?"
 "Yes."
 Rampukar drank his tea.
 "That is curious."
 "That is all?"
 "What do you want me to say? That you will die tomorrow?"
 Jatan flared up.
 "That is not what I mean."
 "Then?"
 Jatan fell silent.
 Rampukar said, "I too heard my own name once."
 Jatan sat upright.
 "When?"
 "Long ago."
 "You never told me!"
 Rampukar laughed.
 "No one asked."
 "What happened?"
 "Nothing."
 "Clearly?"
 "It sounded clear to me."
 "Where?"
 "In the old eastern channel, when a tree stood half in the water."
 "At night?"
 "Evening."
 "Then?"
 "I went home. Ate. Slept."
 Jatan stared at him.
 "You weren't afraid?"
 "A little."
 "And then you gave up boating?"
 "Because of my knee. Not because the river said my name."
 Jatan felt both relief and disappointment.
 "Whose voice did it sound like?"
 Rampukar scratched his head.
 "How can I answer that now? Perhaps the water. Perhaps someone in a field.
 Perhaps the mind."
 "So do you say it was the river or not?"
 "When I tell the story, I say the river. When I think about it, I don't know."

Jatan was silent.
 The answer sounded like his own.
 Rampukar said, "The problem is that you have begun believing your own story."
 "The story is a lie?"
 "I did not say that."
 "Then?"
 "A story and evidence are different things."
 Jatan laughed.
 "You have become a guru?"
 "Bad knees leave a man too much time."
 Both laughed.
 Jatan's fear lightened a little.
 But it did not vanish.
 For three days the river was ordinary.
 Jatan worked the boat every day.
 He deliberately tried less and less to hear names.
 The less he tried, the more the water became water again.
 One night the moon was bright.
 Five people from a wedding arrived late at the ghat.
 Going round by the bridge would take too long.
 Jatan untied the boat.
 Song.
 Laughter.
 One young man sang again and again.
 The river's voice could scarcely be heard.
 Jatan ferried them across.
 He returned alone.
 He did not wait for his own name.
 Even so, in midstream came a faint sound.
 "Hari..."
 Jatan's ears sharpened.
 Then again—"Hari..."
 He laughed.
 "Which Hari?"
 Water.
 Perhaps someone on the bank was singing a bhajan.
 He came home.
 Devaki asked, "Today?"
 "Hari."
 Devaki laughed.
 "Did God call you?"
 "Don't know which Hari."
 They both laughed.
 After Jatan told her of his fear at hearing his own name, Devaki now asked every night, "Today?"
 Sometimes Jatan said, "Nothing."

Sometimes, "Ram."

Sometimes, "Something like Phulo."

Sometimes, "Only water."

Devaki never drew a meaning from it.

At first that irritated Jatan; later he began to like it.

A week later their younger son came from Janakpur.

His name was Kishor.

The moment he saw his father at the ghat, he said, "Still on the boat?"

Jatan said, "The boat is still on the river."

Kishor said, "And so are you."

The matter came up over the meal at home.

Kishor said, "Babu, the bridge is built. The boat hardly runs now. Give it up."

Jatan said, "Did your mother send you?"

From the kitchen Devaki said, "Keep my name out of this."

Kishor said, "Your knees are fine, your eyes are fine, but you do have an age."

"Don't you?"

"I am forty."

"I am seventy."

"That is exactly my point."

Jatan laughed.

Kishor remained serious.

"At least stop the boat at night."

The night on which the river had spoken his name rose inside Jatan.

He said at once, "No."

His voice was sharper than he intended.

Kishor fell silent.

Devaki came out.

"Why not?"

Jatan had no clear answer.

Would giving up night crossings mean that he had been frightened by his own name?

He did not want to admit that.

He said, "Where there is need, the boat will run."

Kishor said, "And if there is no need?"

"Then it will not."

"Most nights there is no need."

Jatan grew irritated.

Devaki said, "Kishor is right."

"You have all made the decision together?"

"The decision is yours. The question is ours."

Jatan left his meal unfinished and went outside.

The courtyard was dark.

Far away the river could neither be seen nor heard.

He thought: the river called my name, and the people at home tell me to leave the boat.

Was it right to join the two things?

His mind was joining them.
He stopped himself.
If the river had not called his name, would the question of giving up the night boat become wrong?

No.

Age, passengers, the bridge—these were separate facts.

For the first time he tried to keep them separate.

The next day he went to the ghat with Kishor.

Kishor had learned to handle a boat as a boy, but had not done so in years.

Jatan handed him the pole.

“Take her.”

Kishor laughed.

“An examination?”

“Let us see whether you have forgotten.”

The boat was empty.

Kishor planted the pole.

At first the boat skewed sideways.

Jatan said, “Read the current.”

“I am reading it.”

“No. Look at the water.”

Kishor tried again.

Slowly the boat straightened.

Jatan smiled.

“Now.”

In midstream Kishor asked, “Babu, Ma said the river spoke your name.”

Jatan grew annoyed with Devaki.

“Does everything have to be told?”

Kishor said, “I didn’t laugh.”

“What do you think?”

“I don’t know.”

“That is all?”

“You taught me yourself—look at the water first, the story afterwards.”

Jatan said nothing.

Had he really taught him that?

Perhaps.

Kishor said, “Were you frightened?”

After a long time Jatan said, “Yes.”

That yes was difficult to say.

Kishor kept working the pole.

“And now?”

“Less.”

“Why?”

“Rampukar heard his own name once too.”

Kishor laughed.

“So you saw Kaka survived?”

Jatan laughed as well.

“Perhaps.”

They reached the other side.

Jatan stepped out and looked at the mud of the bank.

The event of his name in the night was now an event, not an instruction.

He could not find words for the distinction.

But he could feel it.

Kishor stayed in the village for three days.

He looked over the night records of the boat.

In the previous month there had been passengers on only seven nights.

Four were emergencies.

Three ordinary journeys.

Kishor said, “Stay at home at night. If anyone needs you, they can come and call you.”

Jatan thought about it.

This was not giving up the boat.

It was only giving up waiting at the ghat when there were no passengers.

He agreed.

Devaki did not smile as though she had won.

She only said, “Good.”

Jatan asked, “Aren’t you happy?”

“I am.”

“It doesn’t show.”

“You made a decision. Should I dance?”

They both laughed.

The new arrangement began.

At dusk Jatan tied up the boat and came home.

If anyone needed him, they would call.

No one came the first night.

Jatan was restless.

At home at the hour when he would normally have been at the ghat.

He kept turning his ears towards the river.

The sound was distant.

No name could be heard.

On the second night Lakshman Mahato came to the door.

“Kaka, I need to cross. The cow is ill.”

Jatan rose at once.

Devaki said, “Take the lantern.”

The boat was untied.

The night was deep.

Lakshman was quiet.

Jatan worked the pole.

When they reached midstream, Lakshman suddenly said, “Kaka, do you remember the story from that day?”

“Which?”

“Sitaram.”

Jatan laughed.

"You still remember?"

"I was thinking—if the river calls names, why does it choose one name before another?"

"Ask the river."

"You are the one who listens."

Jatan said, "Hearing and understanding are different things."

Lakshman fell silent.

The boat moved on.

Suddenly a voice came from the far bank: "Lakshman!"

Both men started.

Then it came clearly: "Hey, Lakshman!"

Lakshman burst out laughing.

"My brother!"

A man stood on the bank with a lantern.

Jatan laughed too.

"See? Not the river."

Lakshman said, "Sometimes a man sounds like the river."

Both laughed.

Lakshman got off.

Jatan returned alone.

Midstream.

Night.

He listened deliberately.

A few sounds.

No name.

Was he disappointed?

A little.

He was surprised to admit it.

Did he want the thing that had frightened him to happen again?

Perhaps the mind wanted proof.

If he heard it once more, would the event become "true"?

No.

Even twice would not explain its cause.

He reached home.

Devaki asked, "The cow?"

"He went to see it."

"Name?"

"Lakshman."

Devaki started.

Laughing, Jatan said, "His brother called him."

Devaki laughed too.

"Was the river on leave today?"

"Perhaps."

Days passed.

The night in which Jatan had heard his own name slowly began to become a story.

First Devaki.
 Then Rampukar.
 Then Kishor.
 A few weeks later he told Lakshman as well.
 Lakshman's eyes widened.
 "That same night?"
 "Yes."
 "Why didn't you tell me?"
 "I was afraid."
 Lakshman looked as though he might laugh, then did not.
 "And now?"
 "Now it is a story."
 "A true story?"
 Jatan said, "It is true that I heard it. I do not know who called."
 Lakshman was not satisfied.
 "The river?"
 Jatan smiled.
 "You decide."
 The old answer had returned.
 But its meaning had changed inside Jatan.
 Earlier the answer had been meant to deepen the mystery.
 Now it acknowledged a limit.
 He truly did not know.
 Autumn came.
 The river fell.
 Sandbars emerged.
 The ghat shifted lower down.
 Jatan continued to run the boat by day.
 At night only when someone called him.
 One day an official from the district discussed closing the old ghat after the bridge had been built.
 The villagers objected.
 "A short way to the fields."
 "Cattle."
 "Emergencies."
 Jatan remained quiet.
 People said, "A ghat without Jatan Kaka?"
 He laughed.
 "Is the ghat my ancestral property?"
 After the meeting Rampukar asked, "Tell me the truth—if they close it?"
 Jatan looked at the river.
 "Then something else."
 Rampukar stared.
 "You are saying that?"
 "Why?"
 "You used to say that if you left the river, you would die."

Jatan laughed.

"I say many things."

"Wisdom after the river called your name?"

For a moment Jatan's face hardened.

Then he said, "Perhaps."

He did not entirely deny the connection.

Hearing his own name had given him a fear of death.

The fear of death had opened the question of age.

The question of age had opened the question of whether the night boat was needed.

In that sequence the event had had an effect.

That did not make the event a prophecy.

Jatan continued to understand this distinction more in his behaviour than in words.

One winter night no one called.

Jatan sat outside the house by a brazier.

Devaki was spinning yarn.

The river's sound came from far away, clear.

The air was cold.

Devaki asked, "Does the river still call names?"

Jatan listened.

"Many."

"Whose?"

"I cannot make them out."

"Now you hear names everywhere?"

"Old ears."

They both laughed.

After a while Jatan said, "Shall I tell you something?"

"Tell me."

"When I heard my own name, do you know what I thought first?"

"That you would die."

Jatan started.

"How did you know?"

Devaki said, "Was it so difficult?"

"Yes."

"Then?"

"I thought the river was calling me."

"Where?"

"I did not think that far."

Devaki went on winding the yarn.

"Just because someone says your name does not mean they are always calling you to come."

Jatan smiled.

"You have broken the rule again."

"You keep making rules."

The night deepened.

The river flowed at a distance.
 Jatan did not hear his name now.
 He did not try to.
 The following spring a new boatman came to the ghat to learn the work.
 His name was Mohan Sahni.
 He was twenty-five.
 Jatan taught him to read the current, tie the rope, and distribute the passengers' weight.
 On the first day Mohan asked, "Kaka, does the river truly call names?"
 Jatan laughed.
 "Who told you?"
 "Everyone says so."
 "Everyone is not wrong, and no one is entirely right either."
 Mohan looked puzzled.
 "What does that mean?"
 Jatan set the pole in the water.
 "Listen to the sound first."
 Mohan fell silent.
 The boat moved.
 The many voices of the water.
 Leaves on the bank.
 Cattle in the distance.
 A woman calling to a child.
 Mohan said, "That was the woman who called a name."
 "Yes."
 "The river?"
 "Not yet."
 Mohan laughed.
 So did Jatan.
 A few weeks later Jatan cut his boating hours in half.
 Two watches in the morning.
 Mohan in the afternoon.
 At night, by turns, only when needed.
 Devaki said, "Practising how to leave now?"
 Jatan said, "Practising how to share."
 "Is there a difference?"
 "There is."
 He meant it.
 Leaving the river still seemed nearly impossible to him.
 But accepting that the river did not belong to him alone was becoming easier.
 The rains returned.
 The same season.
 Almost a year had passed.
 One evening Jatan and Mohan were bringing the boat back together.
 The passengers had got off.
 The sky was dark.

Mohan worked the pole.
Jatan sat in the bow.
In midstream the water struck the boat's belly.
Sarr... tan...
For a moment Jatan's body tightened.
Just like that night?
Then the sound came—"Ja...tan..."
He held his breath.
Mohan kept working the pole.
"Did you hear anything?" Jatan asked.
Mohan said, "What?"
"Nothing."
Jatan looked all around.
Two people stood on the far bank.
Whether anyone had called out, he could not tell.
The reeds were moving.
A small eddy turned like a throat in the water.
Then—nothing.
Mohan asked, "Kaka?"
Jatan said, "Keep the boat straight."
Mohan straightened it.
Jatan laughed.
The first time he had heard his own name, the pole had stopped.
This time the boat kept moving.
At the ghat Mohan tied the rope.
Jatan checked the knot.
"Good."
Mohan said, "Didn't the river call any names today?"
Jatan looked at him.
"Perhaps it did."
"Whose?"
Jatan smiled.
"I could not hear clearly."
Mohan was disappointed.
"Why do you always answer like that?"
"Because it was not clear."
That was all.
Jatan set off towards home.
On the way he repeated his own name silently.
Jatan.
The name was the same.
He was alive.
The river flowed.
There was no proof that the river had spoken.
There was no proof that it had not.
But for Jatan one thing had changed.

Earlier he had told stories of the river's names as though the mystery belonged to him.

Now he could call the sound he had heard a sound, the fear a fear, and the story a story.

The three were not enemies of one another.

When he reached home, Devaki asked, "Today?"

Taking off his shoes, Jatan said, "Perhaps mine."

Devaki's hand stopped.

"Again?"

"Nothing happened."

"Afraid?"

Jatan thought.

"A little."

"The boat?"

"Kept moving."

Devaki smiled.

"Then eat your rice."

Jatan laughed.

"What happens merely because a name is spoken?"

Devaki laughed too.

"Only now you understand?"

That night they ate their meal.

Far away the river kept flowing.

When the wind shifted, its sound sometimes reached the house.

Jatan listened.

Sometimes a name took shape.

Sometimes not.

He no longer tried every time to decide.

Some sounds are meant to be heard.

Some stories are meant to be told.

And some things—Jatan now believed—remain truer when left unfinished.

The Cave-In

The cave-in happened at seventeen minutes past two in the night.

The time was learned later from Meera's phone.

At that moment no one in the house looked at a clock.

First came the sound.

Deep.

As though someone beneath the house had let out a heavy breath.

Then a small jolt.

Then the sound of earth splitting.

Kaushalya Devi woke.

She sat up.

Dust was coming in from the courtyard.

"Dinesh!"

Her voice was so loud that three rooms opened at once.

Dinesh ran out.

Raghav behind him.

Meera with the phone in her hand.

Saroj standing at the doorway.

The middle part of the courtyard was gone.

Not all of it.

But the portion where the tulsi altar, the old stone, and the drain that carried away rainwater had been had sunk below.

Not a circle.

An uneven mouth.

The edges cracked.

Darkness inside the earth.

The tulsi altar half hanging.

One pillar of the verandah tilted.

Kaushalya Devi tried to come outside.

Dinesh shouted, "Ma, no!"

There was a fear in his voice Kaushalya had rarely heard before.

"Everyone out through the back door!"

No belongings.

No slippers.

Meera's phone simply remained in her hand.

Raghav had only a torch in his hand.

Saroj held her mother's arm.

They all reached neighbour Lalit's courtyard through the small back gate.

Behind them the house stood.

But the courtyard at its centre did not.

Kaushalya Devi turned back again.

"The tulsi..."

Saroj said, "Ma, not now."

"The lamp..."

"Not now."

From inside the house came the sound of something small falling.

Lalit too was awake by then.

He came carrying a torch.

"No one go inside."

Dinesh said, "The courtyard has caved in."

Lalit looked from a distance.

"The wall is cracked too."

Kaushalya Devi said, "That wall was cracked already."

Even at such a time she wanted the distinction made clear.

Which crack was old, which new.

As though the honour of the house had to be defended.

Lalit said, "Stay outside until morning."

The rain had stopped two days earlier.

The night was clear now.

Stars in the sky.

The courtyard gone, the sky unbroken.

Everyone sat in Lalit's verandah.

Kaushalya Devi was barefoot.

Meera noticed.

She took off her own slippers and placed them before her grandmother.

Kaushalya said, "I won't wear them."

"The ground is cold."

"And you?"

"I'm sitting inside."

Grandmother put on the slippers.

No one slept properly for the rest of the night.

Dinesh kept going out from time to time to look at the house.

Raghav kept stopping him.

Saroj stayed beside her mother.

Meera sat with the phone's light switched off, resting it in her lap.

After three o'clock Kaushalya said, "Exactly where did the tulsi altar sink?"

Dinesh started.

"Ma, in the middle of the courtyard."

"Not the middle. Toward the west."

Raghav said, "Ma, leave it for now."

"You people don't remember the directions of the house."

Saroj said, "I do."

Kaushalya said, "No. After your marriage that altar was moved."

Saroj fell silent.

In the middle of the night the family began correcting the map of the house.

The courtyard was no longer on the ground, but in conversation.

Meera quietly opened her phone and checked the time.

3:28.

She thought: even now Grandmother is correcting where the altar stood.
 At first light the villagers gathered.
 There was no festival.
 But disaster draws people.
 Someone wanted to go close to the edge.
 Dinesh stopped them.
 Someone said, "There must be an old well underneath."
 Someone else, "There used to be a pond here."
 Another, "The rainwater hollowed it out from below."
 Another, "Rat and snake burrows."
 One event, five causes.
 Dinesh said, "We'll know when the engineer sees it."
 Shivkant, an elder of the village, said, "The engineer wasn't even born when earth
 was filled in here."
 Dinesh went quiet.
 "Earth was filled here?"
 Shivkant said, "That's what I heard."
 "From whom?"
 "From my father."
 Hearing from a distance, Kaushalya Devi said, "Not a pond. It was a pit."
 Shivkant said, "Why a pit?"
 "Earth had been dug out."
 "Then that too was filled land."
 Kaushalya said, "By that measure the whole village is filled land."
 An argument was about to begin, but Dinesh stopped it.
 "First we'll empty the house."
 People from the local administration arrived.
 A rope boundary was put up.
 Entry into the main part of the house was stopped.
 The engineer came in the afternoon.
 He looked at the cracks from a distance.
 He tested the soil with a rod.
 A few questions.
 "An old well?"
 "Don't know."
 "Drainage?"
 "That side."
 "Heavy rain recently?"
 "Yes."
 "The cause can't be certain without testing the soil below."
 Kaushalya liked this answer.
 "See?" she said to Shivkant.
 "Not certain."
 Shivkant laughed.
 "When did I say I was certain either?"
 Meera felt like writing all this down.

Then she did not.
 For now, whether the house would survive mattered more.
 The engineer said, "The area around the courtyard is unsafe. Do not live inside until the next inspection."
 Dinesh asked, "The rooms?"
 "Some walls have diagonal cracks."
 "Will they survive?"
 The engineer said, "I can't say yet."
 That day the family stayed in Lalit's house.
 The next day they were offered two rooms in the community building.
 Kaushalya refused.
 "I'm fine in Lalit's house."
 Lalit's wife said, "Stay as long as you need."
 Dinesh said, "It may be long."
 At the word 'long' everyone fell silent.
 For the first time Kaushalya looked not at the house but at the ground.
 During the night the tulsi altar had fallen completely below.
 Only one brick remained caught at the edge.
 Meera felt like taking a photograph.
 She looked at her grandmother's face.
 She did not take one.
 In the afternoon Kaushalya herself said, "Take it."
 "What?"
 "A photograph. Tomorrow you'll say, what did it look like?"
 Meera was surprised.
 "You won't mind?"
 "What is, is."
 She took the photograph.
 A sunken courtyard.
 A tilted pillar.
 A cracked wall.
 And open sky.
 On the third day the family was allowed to remove their belongings.
 One person at a time inside the rope, accompanied by two labourers.
 Only as far as it was safe.
 Documents first.
 Medicines.
 Clothes.
 Rice.
 Utensils.
 The box of photographs.
 Kaushalya said, "The brass grinding stone."
 Dinesh said, "It was in the corner of the courtyard."
 "East?"
 "South."
 "No, beside the kitchen door."

Raghav said, "That is south."
 Kaushalya fell silent.
 The grinding stone was found.
 Two cubits from the crack.
 A labourer carried it out.
 Kaushalya ran her hand over it.
 "It belonged to your grandmother."
 Meera asked, "My great-grandmother?"
 "Yes."
 "What did she grind on it?"
 "Everything."
 "What do you mean, everything?"
 Kaushalya snapped, "Spices, chutney. Saying everything doesn't mean she ground the house on it."
 Everyone laughed.
 For the first time since the cave-in the family laughed openly.
 After the laughter, the silence felt less heavy.
 As the belongings were removed, the inside of the house grew empty.
 The walls remained.
 Empty rooms.
 The cave-in at the centre.
 Meera watched from a safe distance.
 The house seemed to her to have grown old after giving up its belongings.
 Then she questioned that thought.
 Do houses grow old?
 There are bricks and earth.
 People add meaning.
 On the fourth day the engineer's team returned.
 Tests of the soil below.
 Signs of old fill.
 Seepage of rainwater.
 Some hollow sections.
 There was no single final cause.
 The report would come later.
 Dinesh asked, "Will the house survive?"
 The engineer walked around the house.
 "The foundations around the main courtyard are affected. Some walls may be saved, but living in the whole house would be risky."
 "Repair?"
 "Possible, but very expensive. A new structure may be safer."
 Kaushalya said, "New where?"
 There was a small strip of land at the back.
 Dinesh pointed to it.
 The engineer said, "Have it tested. I can't say yet."
 Kaushalya turned her face away.
 She did not like the word 'new'.

That evening the family held its first meeting in Lalit's verandah. Dinesh opened the papers.

"Three options."

Kaushalya said, "A house is not an option."

Dinesh fell silent.

Raghav said softly, "Ma, the options are for the repair."

"Save whatever of the house can be saved."

Saroj asked, "And if it isn't safe?"

Kaushalya did not answer.

Meera sat in a corner.

She listened.

Dinesh said, "One—strengthen the whole thing, very expensive."

"Two—demolish the unsafe part and make a smaller house."

"Three—build a new house at the back and leave the old part empty."

Raghav said, "The first isn't practical."

Kaushalya immediately said, "Leave out that word 'practical'."

Dinesh lowered his head.

Saroj said, "Ma, the courtyard isn't there now."

Kaushalya looked at her.

"Is a courtyard only earth?"

No one answered.

Meera remained caught on that sentence.

After dinner that night Kaushalya began telling an old story.

"Your father's mundan was performed in that courtyard."

Dinesh said, "I don't remember."

"How would you? You were two."

"Then how do you?"

"I was his mother."

Saroj said, "The turmeric ceremony for my wedding was there too."

Raghav laughed. "At your wedding there was a tent over the courtyard. Where was the sky?"

"The tent was over the courtyard; the courtyard did not disappear."

Kaushalya said, "Your father used to dry paddy there."

Dinesh said, "Father used to dry the paddy?"

"I dried it; he turned it over."

"Then why do you call it Father's work?"

Kaushalya laughed.

"While telling stories, work changes hands."

Meera laughed.

"Then shall I write it down?"

Kaushalya looked at her.

"What?"

"The things about the courtyard."

"What will you do by writing them?"

"So I don't forget."

Kaushalya was silent for a moment.

"Sometimes forgetting is necessary too."

Meera was taken aback.

"Why?"

"If you keep everything, where will there be room in your head?"

Raghav laughed.

"Ma, is the house in the head small too?"

Kaushalya said, "Yours is very small."

Laughter again.

From that night the house began to be built in memory.

No one made a formal decision.

All day there was talk of repair, papers, measurements, labourers.

After dinner at night, some part of the house would rise up.

The first night, the courtyard.

The second night, the kitchen.

Saroj said, "The old hearth was in the left corner."

Kaushalya: "No, it was moved after the wedding."

Dinesh: "The smoke used to get into my eyes."

Raghav: "You used to cry all the time."

Dinesh: "Because of the smoke."

Raghav: "And when Ma beat you too."

Everyone laughed.

In memory the kitchen filled with smoke.

Meera asked, "How many hearths were there?"

"One at first."

"Then two."

"Gas came later."

"Where was the gas stove?"

There were three answers to that.

Meera said, "Three kitchens in one house?"

Kaushalya said, "Three times."

Meera wrote that sentence down.

Kaushalya saw, but did not stop her.

The third night, the verandah.

Dinesh remembered four pillars in the verandah.

Raghav: five.

Saroj: four pillars and one half-pillar joined to a wall.

Kaushalya: "Your father added one later."

Dinesh: "Then five."

Kaushalya: "Four before that."

Meera drew two sketches on the paper.

'Before.'

'Later.'

The verandah refused to remain in a single shape.

The fourth night, the storeroom.

Where Grandmother's trunk had been.

Where old clothes had been kept.

Where the jar of mango pickle came out once a year.
 Raghav said, "I used to steal jaggery here."
 Kaushalya said, "I knew."
 "Then why didn't you beat me?"
 "I used to leave exactly as much as you ate."
 Raghav's face became that of a child.
 Meera asked, "Grandmother, you deliberately left jaggery for him?"
 "Yes."
 "So he thought he was stealing?"
 "Yes."
 Everyone laughed.
 Raghav said, "That was my whole childhood."
 Kaushalya: "You were made of jaggery?"
 The fifth night, the tulsi altar.
 This time Kaushalya spoke very little.
 Saroj said, "Grandmother used to pour water there every morning?"
 Kaushalya: "My mother-in-law. Later, me."
 "How many times was the altar rebuilt?"
 "Three times."
 Dinesh started. "Three?"
 "The first was of earth. Then brick. Then your father put in a white stone like marble."
 "It wasn't marble," Raghav said.
 "I said like marble."
 Meera asked, "Which one was lost in the cave-in?"
 Kaushalya: "The last one."
 "The first two?"
 "They had gone long before."
 Meera understood—the house had not changed for the first time on the night of the cave-in.
 The courtyard had been changing all through life.
 Only now the change was violent.
 The sixth night, Father's room.
 Kaushalya's husband Shivdhar had been dead five years.
 Which way did his cot stand?
 Dinesh: against the north wall.
 Raghav: east.
 Saroj: beneath the window.
 Kaushalya said they were all wrong.
 "The cot was moved according to the season."
 Meera laughed.
 "Then there is no correct answer?"
 "The correct answer asks for the time."
 Meera wrote that down too.
 Dinesh said, "Meera, if you write every sentence Grandmother says, it'll become a book."

Kaushalya said, "Let her write. Later she'll cut half of it."
On the seventh day one wall of the old house fell by itself.
No one was inside.
Everyone ran when they heard the sound.
Dust.
Bricks.
Kaushalya stood at a distance.
It was the wall of Shivdhar's room.
Dinesh went to his mother.
"Ma..."
Kaushalya raised a hand to stop him.
"Nothing."
Then, after a long time, she said, "Did the window survive?"
The window frame was caught among the bricks.
"We can take it out," Raghav said.
After the engineer permitted it, the frame was removed.
Kaushalya said, "Keep it."
Dinesh asked, "For the new house?"
"Keep it for now. We'll decide the place later."
Meanwhile, the land at the back was tested.
A safe section was marked out.
A small new house could be built.
Not an exact copy of the old house.
Dinesh had a plan drawn.
Two rooms.
One kitchen.
A small verandah.
An open courtyard in the middle.
Kaushalya looked at the paper.
"The courtyard this small?"
Dinesh said, "The land is limited."
"The tulsi?"
"In the corner."
"The kitchen door toward the courtyard?"
"Yes."
"The verandah?"
"Here."
Kaushalya studied the paper for a long time.
Then she said, "Don't build the old house."
Everyone was surprised.
Dinesh said, "But you..."
"I said save the old house. It can't be saved now. If you're building new, build new."
Saroj asked, "Then the courtyard?"
"There should be a courtyard because a house needs open space. Not in order to make it like the old one."

Meera kept looking at her grandmother's face.

It had taken seven nights to arrive at that sentence.

On the day the foundations of the new house were laid, Kaushalya did not go toward the old house.

She sat on the land at the back.

The mason stretched a string and checked the line.

Meera asked, "Grandmother, which room will be here?"

"Right now it is earth."

"On the plan it's the kitchen."

"The plan is in a hurry."

Kaushalya laughed.

So did the mason.

Sound bricks from the old house were sorted out.

Dinesh wanted some of them used in the new house.

The engineer said, "Anything sound can be reused, but material used structurally must be checked."

In the end, the old bricks were not used for the main load-bearing work, but in a low wall along the courtyard.

Was Kaushalya happy?

She did not say so clearly.

She merely ran her hand over them.

There was an argument over where the old doorframe should go.

Saroj wanted it at the main door.

Raghav said it was too small.

Dinesh: "As decoration in the verandah?"

Kaushalya: "A doorframe is not decoration."

Meera asked, "Then where?"

Kaushalya: "Where there is a door."

At last it fitted the small door of the storeroom.

Raghav laughed. "The frame from Father's room on the storeroom?"

Kaushalya said, "A doorframe's work is to let people pass. It will."

No one grew sentimental over the sentence.

The mason fixed the frame.

Throughout the month of construction the family went on building the old house in memory.

Sometimes because of the work.

"Which way did the old drain run?"

Sometimes for no reason at all.

"Where was the pot of curd kept at Saroj's wedding?"

"Who remembers?"

"I do."

Sometimes there was an argument.

"Father's bookcase was against this wall."

"No."

"How old were you then?"

"I remember better than you."

Sometimes silence.

One night Kaushalya said, "When was the last time your father sat in the courtyard?"

No one answered.

He had not died at home, but in hospital.

Weakness in the final month.

Perhaps winter sunlight.

Perhaps Magh.

Perhaps the verandah.

Meera asked, "If we aren't sure, shall we leave it?"

Kaushalya nodded.

"Leave it."

What was not remembered was not filled in by making a story.

On the day the roof of the new house was laid, Kaushalya watched for a long time.

The roof of the old house had not been lost in the cave-in.

Long before, it had been altered over the years, first to tin and then to concrete.

Even so, her eyes remained fixed on the new roof.

Meera asked, "What did you remember?"

"Nothing."

"Really?"

"Sometimes nothing happens too."

Meera smiled.

Rain came.

The first water on the new roof.

The family was still staying in Lalit's house.

Dinesh ran over to inspect it.

The drain was working.

The walls were dry.

No water stood in the courtyard.

He came back and said, "It's all right."

Kaushalya asked, "The courtyard?"

"All right."

"The earth?"

"Wet."

That was all.

Kaushalya watched the rain through the window.

The old cave-in pit was now fenced with rope.

Rainwater was filling it.

Dinesh said, "That whole section will have to be filled."

The engineer had said the same: stable material, layer by layer, with drainage.

Kaushalya asked, "Then the pit will disappear?"

"Yes."

"A marker?"

"Do you want one kept?"

Kaushalya was silent.

Meera thought Grandmother would say yes.

She said, "No. Make it safe."
 Dinesh breathed out in relief.
 The pit did not become a memorial.
 It was a danger.
 It was filled.
 Layer by layer.
 The earth compacted.
 The drainage changed.
 The place where the old courtyard had been became a level strip.
 Kaushalya watched from a distance.
 "Shall we plant tulsi here?" Saroj asked.
 Kaushalya immediately said, "No."
 "Why?"
 "It will be planted in the new house."
 "The old place..."
 "Let the old place remain the old place."
 The decision felt harsh to Saroj.
 Not to Meera.
 The new house was completed.
 Much smaller.
 No long verandah like the old one.
 The kitchen was brighter.
 The bathroom was inside.
 The tulsi altar stood in the eastern corner of the courtyard.
 Kaushalya poured water there the first morning.
 Saroj wanted to take a photograph.
 Kaushalya said, "Take it."
 This time no one hesitated.
 On the day of the first meal in the new house, the whole family gathered.
 Raghav brought jaggery.
 "Will you steal in the storeroom?" Meera asked.
 Raghav laughed.
 "Where is the storeroom now?"
 Kaushalya looked toward the old doorframe of the storage room.
 "There."
 Raghav went inside.
 Kaushalya had indeed placed a small piece of jaggery there beforehand.
 Everyone burst out laughing.
 "Ma!"
 "I saved your childhood for you."
 Raghav ate the jaggery.
 Meera said, "Shall I write this scene down?"
 Kaushalya said, "Write it. This one isn't made up; it just happened."
 For the first time old and new memory met in the same house.
 That night everyone sat in the courtyard.
 A new sky.

The sky was, of course, the same.
But the frame was different.
Dinesh said, "Was the old courtyard this big?"
Raghav: "Bigger."
Saroj: "A little smaller."
Kaushalya laughed.
"Starting again?"
Meera brought the notebook.
She showed them the earlier pages.
Two directions for the courtyard.
Three times for the hearth.
Four or five pillars in the verandah.
The jaggery in the storeroom.
Three forms of the tulsi altar.
Father's cot according to the season.
Reading it, Saroj said, "This isn't a map of the house."
Meera said, "No."
"Then what is it?"
Meera paused.
"It isn't any one person's house."
Kaushalya listened carefully.
Meera continued, "Everyone's house is in a different place."
Dinesh laughed. "Philosopher."
Kaushalya said, "The child is right."
The night wind blew.
The leaves of the new tulsi plant trembled.
The filled strip of the old cave-in could not be seen in the dark.
Meera's school was to reopen the following week.
She was returning to the city.
Before leaving, she went to the remaining wall of the old house.
Some parts had been demolished on the administration's advice.
One wall remained, outside the safe boundary.
There was a patch of old blue paint on it.
Meera did not touch it.
She took a photograph.
Her grandmother came behind her.
"Will we keep this wall?" Meera asked.
Kaushalya said, "As long as it is safe."
"And if it falls?"
"Then it will fall."
"Will it hurt?"
"Yes."
"Then?"
"Will sorrow keep a wall standing?"
Meera fell silent.
Kaushalya looked at the wall.

“At first I thought the house should be saved. Then I understood—not every part of a house can be saved together.”

“Memory?”

“Not that either.”

“Then what survives?”

Kaushalya laughed.

“You ask too many questions.”

Meera laughed too.

Grandmother did not answer.

After reaching the city, Meera opened the notebook.

She thought of drawing one clean plan.

Combining all the memories into the ‘correct’ house.

Then she understood—such a correct house had never existed.

The house had changed with time.

Four pillars.

Then five.

An earthen altar.

Then brick.

The cot here.

Then there.

One hearth.

Then two.

Many forms of one house.

The cave-in erased one form, not the whole history.

Meera did not draw the plan.

She kept separate small sketches.

Beneath them she wrote not dates but ‘before’, ‘later’, ‘perhaps’.

Where nothing was certain, she left it blank.

A few months later the engineer’s final report arrived.

A probable combined effect of old fill, rainwater seepage, and a weak underground layer.

Not one cause.

Dinesh read the report and explained it to Kaushalya in simple words.

Kaushalya said, “Then Shivrakant was half right, and so was I.”

Dinesh laughed.

“Perhaps.”

“Did you learn this ‘perhaps’ from Meera?”

“From the engineer.”

Everyone laughed.

Later grass grew over the filled strip where the old courtyard had been.

Dinesh did not build on it.

He left it open for safety.

Kaushalya sometimes went as far as that place.

She did not sit there.

She only looked.

One day Saroj asked, “Ma, do you see the courtyard here?”

Kaushalya said, "Sometimes."
"And now?"
"Now there is grass."
The answer hurt Saroj.
Kaushalya took her hand.
"Is grass bad?"
"No."
"Then?"
Saroj smiled.
"Nothing."
A year passed.
The first winter in the new house.
Sunlight stayed in the courtyard only briefly because the western wall was high.
Kaushalya complained.
Dinesh said, "I showed you that on the plan."
"Is sunlight on paper the same as real sunlight?"
Dinesh fell silent.
Raghav laughed.
"A new complaint for the new house."
Kaushalya said, "Then the house is alive."
Meera came during the holidays.
She brought the notebook.
She showed it to her grandmother.
Kaushalya could not read all the small writing, so Meera read it aloud.
"First night—was the tulsi altar in the west or the middle?"
Kaushalya laughed.
"Now I remember it as west of the middle."
Meera wrote, "Grandmother's new memory."
"Will you cross out the old one?"
"No."
"Why?"
"Because that is what you said then."
Kaushalya nodded.
"Good. Memory changes; don't steal from it."
Meera smiled.
She wrote that sentence separately.
That night everyone sat in the courtyard of the new house.
Dinesh suddenly asked, "Was the clock on the south wall of the old house?"
Raghav: "North."
Saroj: "In the verandah."
Kaushalya: "First in the verandah, later in the room."
Everyone laughed.
The same thing again.
The house was built again.
For one night.
In conversation.

No one raised a wall.
No one counted bricks.
Only one person's sentence kept touching another person's memory.
Sometimes correcting it.
Sometimes distorting it.
Sometimes opening a new room.
The cave-in pit had been filled.
But the family did not use memory to fill it.
Memory is not earth for a pit.
It is something else.
It can rebuild a house, but not on the ground.
And a house built in memory does not always need a roof.

The Field of Kans Grass

When the first white kans grass of autumn burst into bloom, Taramani remembered her age.

Sixty-two.

If Phulia were alive, she would have been fifty-eight.

She did not make this calculation every year.

Sometimes it came of its own accord.

At the sight of kans.

The white kans flowers bent one way in the wind.

Then straightened.

Then bent the other way.

The field lay to the west of the village.

Earlier, there had been more grazing land there.

Now the unfinished earthwork of a new road ran through the middle.

Far off on one side stood a brick kiln.

On the other, an old drain.

The kans grew thick in patches.

Taramani took that route on her morning walks.

The doctor had told her to walk.

Her knees would not stiffen.

So she walked.

Not for the kans.

Not for memory.

For her knees.

That morning the wind was not strong.

The kans rubbed softly against itself.

Chhar-chhar.

Sar-sar.

Taramani had stopped by the roadside to adjust the strap of her slipper.

Then came a voice.

“Tara Di!”

She straightened.

The voice seemed to come from inside the kans.

Not very near.

Not very far.

Then—

“Hurry!”

Taramani’s body went cold.

Phulia used to call her “Tara Di.”

No one in the village did now.

Small children called her “Tara Dadi.”

Those of her own generation called her “Tara.”

Her nephews and nieces called her “Barki Ma.”
No one had called her “Tara Di” for forty years.
She stood at the edge of the road.
She did not put a single foot inside the kans.
There could be snakes.
Pits.
Thorns.
And more than anything else—running after a voice seemed foolish to her.
She called out loudly—
“Who is it?”
No answer.
The kans moved.
The wind rose a little.
Sar-sar-sar.
Taramani called again—
“Which child are you?”
Far away, someone seemed to laugh.
Or had a heron taken flight?
She was not certain.
A few moments later the milkman came along the road on his bicycle.
“Dadi, here?”
“I am out walking.”
“There are snakes in the kans.”
“I know.”
He rode on.
Taramani returned home.
She told no one anything.
Not on the first day.
Not on the second either.
Taramani had been twelve when Phulia disappeared.
Phulia was eight.
It was autumn.
At that time the kans grew more thickly not in this field but across the old drain.
Taramani remembered that clearly.
Phulia had not disappeared in the kans field.
At least, not as far as anyone knew.
That afternoon she had gone out behind the goats.
She had not returned by evening.
The goats came back.
Phulia did not.
That much was fact.
The rest was story.
Someone said she must have gone towards the fair.
Someone said across the drain.
Someone said a little girl had been seen as far as the railway line.
Someone said a band of wanderers had left that day.

Someone said the river.
 Someone said she had run away with someone—people could use that phrase even
 for an eight-year-old child.
 Her mother did not sleep for three nights.
 Her father went from village to village.
 Taramani searched too.
 The first day with everyone.
 The second day with her sisters.
 On the third day her mother kept her at home.
 “Will you disappear too?”
 Taramani still remembered that sentence.
 Phulia’s body was never found.
 No clothes.
 No slippers.
 No ribbon.
 Nothing.
 No proof of death.
 No proof of life.
 For many years her name remained in the present tense inside the house.
 “Phulia likes this vegetable.”
 “Phulia sleeps under this blanket in winter.”
 “What if Phulia comes back?”
 Her mother would say these things.
 Her father slowly moved into the past tense.
 “Phulia liked this.”
 Her mother would become angry.
 “Why ‘liked’?”
 Her father would fall silent.
 The grammar of the house split in two.
 Which side was Taramani on?
 Even now she could not say.
 Sometimes “was.”
 Sometimes only the name.
 Phulia.
 The next morning Taramani did not take the kans route.
 She took the eastern road.
 It was too short a distance for her knees.
 So she walked back and forth in the courtyard at home.
 Her daughter-in-law Rekha asked—
 “Not going out today?”
 “I don’t feel like it.”
 “Your knee?”
 “It’s fine.”
 That was all.
 On the third day her niece Nilima arrived.
 She taught at a school.

She had said earlier on the phone—
 “Barki Ma, I’ll stay one day during the Dashami holidays.”
 Nilima was the daughter of Taramani’s younger sister Saroj.
 She had been born after Phulia disappeared.
 She knew Phulia through stories.
 Not through photographs.
 There was not a single clear photograph of Phulia.
 She might be in one group photograph.
 No one was certain.
 That evening, over tea, Nilima asked—
 “Has the kans come out thickly?”
 Taramani’s hand stopped.
 “Yes.”
 “Shall we go and see it tomorrow?”
 “What is there to see in kans?”
 “It looks beautiful.”
 “So do snakes.”
 Nilima laughed.
 “We’ll look from the road.”
 Taramani said—
 “From the road.”
 That night she lay awake for a long time.
 The voice returned in her mind.
 Tara Di.
 Hurry.
 Had Phulia spoken like that?
 Perhaps.
 Children said “hurry” often.
 It was not a phrase peculiar to her.
 “Tara Di” was peculiar.
 But memory too could attach a peculiar word to a voice.
 Taramani had spent her life as a birth attendant.
 Later she had worked at the health centre.
 She had heard a baby’s first cry a thousand times.
 A mother’s fear.
 A newborn’s breath.
 Fever.
 Bleeding.
 Pain.
 She did not readily believe stories of miracles.
 If someone said, such-and-such goddess appeared in my dream,
 she would say, take the medicine on time.
 If someone said, the child has been struck by the evil eye,
 she would say, measure the fever.
 People in the village called her practical.
 Sometimes harsh.

Now a single voice had lodged like a thorn inside that practicality.
At dawn she went to the kans field with Nilima.
The two kept to the roadside.
The kans was white in the sunlight.
Nilima took photographs.
“Barki Ma, stand over there.”
“Why should I pose with kans?”
“Just like that.”
Taramani did not pose.
Nilima took the picture by herself.
There was little wind.
Dew lay on the kans flowers.
A small bird perched on a kans stalk.
Nilima said—
“Very beautiful.”
Taramani said—
“Not everything in autumn is beautiful.”
“I didn’t say everything was.”
“Fine.”
They kept walking.
At the place where she had heard the voice, Taramani stopped.
Nilima walked two steps ahead, then looked back.
“What?”
Taramani said—
“Can you hear anything?”
Nilima listened.
“A bird.”
“And?”
“The wind.”
“And?”
Nilima laughed.
“Are you testing me?”
Taramani said—
“No.”
She moved on.
No voice came.
On the way home Nilima suddenly mentioned Phulia.
“Barki Ma, did Phulia Mausī disappear around here?”
Taramani answered at once—
“No.”
“Then where?”
“No one knows.”
“Ma says they searched towards the old drain.”
“Searching there does not mean she disappeared there.”
Nilima nodded.
“Right.”

Taramani looked at her.
 "People make stories."
 "Don't you?"
 "Me?"
 "You tell stories too."
 Taramani fell silent.
 Nilima smiled.
 "Making a story and telling a story are different."
 "And if we add what we don't know?"
 "Then we are making it."
 Taramani said—
 "Then don't add it."
 Nilima asked—
 "Do you remember the last thing Phulia Mausi said to you?"
 Taramani stopped.
 She had several answers to that question.
 Sometimes she remembered—
 "Tara Di, tie my ribbon."
 Sometimes—
 "I am taking the goats out."
 Sometimes—
 "Don't tell Ma."
 Were all three from the same day?
 No one could be sure.
 She said—
 "No."
 Nilima looked a little disappointed.
 "Nothing?"
 "Something. But I'm not sure."
 "Right."
 Taramani liked that "right."
 Nilima did not press her.
 In the afternoon Nilima phoned her mother, Saroj.
 Taramani sat beside her, shelling makhana.
 Phulia entered the conversation.
 Nilima said—
 "Ma, Barki Ma says Phulia Mausi did not disappear in the kans field."
 Saroj said something from the other end of the phone.
 Nilima looked at Taramani.
 "Ma says the area behind the kans was searched that day too."
 Taramani said—
 "It was searched."
 "Then?"
 "We do not know where she disappeared."
 Nilima relayed the message.
 Saroj said something else.

“Ma says you once heard a voice before too?”
 Taramani’s hand stopped.
 “When?”
 Nilima repeated the question.
 Saroj answered.
 “Two or three years after Phulia disappeared. At night.”
 Taramani said—
 “I don’t remember.”
 Nilima handed her the phone.
 Saroj’s voice came through—
 “Didi, you don’t remember?”
 “No.”
 “Ma used to say that Tara said at night that Phulia had called her.”
 “Ma said many things.”
 “Did you say it or not?”
 Taramani searched inside her head.
 A night.
 The courtyard.
 A dog.
 A distant voice?
 Something blurred.
 “I’m not sure.”
 Saroj said—
 “Right.”
 Then the subject changed.
 Nilima’s job.
 Dashami.
 Curd.
 The call ended.
 Taramani was not upset.
 Rather, she was unsettled.
 Someone else remembered one of her own old memories better than she did.
 Or perhaps remembered her mother’s story about it.
 There was a difference.
 That evening she went to the house of an old neighbour, Mahendra Dai.
 Mahendra Dai was five years older than Phulia.
 Now she was past seventy.
 She sat in the courtyard picking through paddy.
 Taramani sat down.
 A few ordinary matters.
 Knees.
 The price of paddy.
 Nilima’s job.
 Then Taramani asked—
 “What do you remember about the day Phulia disappeared?”
 Mahendra Dai’s hand stopped.

"Suddenly?"
 "Yes."
 "Did you see the kans?"
 Taramani was startled.
 "Why?"
 "It is autumn. Every year somebody remembers one thing or another."
 "What do you remember?"
 Still sorting the rice, Mahendra Dai said—
 "I was in the field with Ma. When we returned home at dusk, there was an uproar."
 "Did anyone say towards the kans?"
 "Every direction."
 "Did you ever hear Phulia's voice afterwards?"
 Mahendra Dai looked straight at Taramani.
 "Her voice?"
 "I'm only asking."
 Mahendra Dai laughed.
 "Have you started believing in ghosts?"
 "No."
 "Then?"
 After a long pause Taramani said—
 "The day before yesterday, near the kans, someone said 'Tara Di.'"
 Mahendra Dai stopped laughing.
 Her face became serious.
 "Did you go inside the kans?"
 "No."
 "Good."
 "Why?"
 "Snakes."
 They both laughed.
 Then Mahendra Dai asked—
 "Did the voice sound like Phulia?"
 Taramani said—
 "Do I remember Phulia's voice exactly?"
 Mahendra fell silent.
 "Do you?"
 "No."
 "Then how can we say 'like'?"
 Mahendra Dai continued sorting the paddy.
 "When one hears a name, the mind makes a face. When one hears a voice, it makes a name."
 "Have you started talking philosophy?"
 "I've grown old."
 They laughed again.
 Mahendra Dai said—
 "The brick-kiln workers' children play in the kans."

"At dawn?"

"Sometimes."

"Would they call me 'Tara Di'?"

"Perhaps they heard someone else say it."

"No one calls me Di now."

Mahendra Dai shrugged.

"Then the wind."

"The wind says names?"

"You asked. I answered."

Taramani smiled.

"Fine."

By the second week the autumn light had deepened.

The kans flowered more profusely.

The village boys and girls went there to take photographs.

Kans on their phones.

Songs.

Laughter.

Taramani used that road less often.

She did not want to run away from her fear.

But neither did she want to test it.

One day Sushila, an old colleague from the health centre, came to see her.

In the course of conversation Taramani told her about the voice.

Sushila said—

"Have your ears checked."

Taramani laughed.

"That is exactly the answer you ought to give."

"Sometimes the ear recreates old sounds."

"With names included?"

"The brain adds the name."

"Are you a doctor?"

"I've watched patients for thirty years."

They both laughed.

Then Sushila said—

"But if you hear it again, don't be afraid."

"Why?"

"Because no one dies from a voice."

Taramani replied at once—

"Not every voice is safe."

"True."

Sushila grew serious.

"But don't go inside the kans."

"Everyone remembers snakes."

"Snakes are real."

Taramani liked that sentence very much.

Snakes are real.

The voice?

She did not know.
 That night Taramani opened her mother's old trunk.
 Why, she did not know.
 Clothes.
 A copperplate document.
 Old letters.
 A torn page from a school ledger?
 No.
 Nothing marked by name as Phulia's possession.
 For many years her mother had kept one red ribbon that had belonged to Phulia.
 Taramani thought it might be in the trunk.
 She did not find it.
 Perhaps Saroj had it.
 Perhaps it had been thrown away.
 Perhaps the ribbon had never belonged to Phulia at all.
 Objects too do not escape memory.
 She closed the trunk.
 Searching for evidence with which to test the voice in the kans struck her as
 absurd.
 Phulia was not a court case.
 Phulia was a missing child.
 Missing.
 That word had lasted longer in the house than the word dead.
 Until the day their mother died.
 In her final year their mother had been bedridden.
 Sometimes her mind was clear.
 Sometimes clouded.
 One day Taramani was wiping her hands.
 Her mother asked—
 "Has Phulia come?"
 Taramani said—
 "No."
 Her mother closed her eyes again.
 Later Taramani often wondered—why had she said "no" then?
 She could have said, "Ma, she disappeared many years ago."
 She could have said, "She will not come now."
 She could have said, "Rest."
 But she had stated only the fact—she had not come today.
 Her mother died three days later.
 Taramani did not feel guilty about that answer.
 Sometimes she felt sorrow.
 Dashami drew near.
 There was a fair in the village.
 More voices of people travelled along the road beside the kans field.
 One evening Taramani and Nilima were returning from the fair.
 Children shouted from behind the kans.

"Here!"
"Hurry!"
Taramani stopped.
Nilima did too.
Three children came running out from the far side of the road.
Not from inside the kans.
From the footpath behind it.
One girl called to her brother—
"Hurry!"
The cadence of the voice was like the first day's.
Taramani's chest lightened.
Then the girl came near and greeted Nilima respectfully.
"Teacher-ji."
She was a student from the school.
Nilima asked—
"Were you playing here?"
"I was going home."
Taramani listened carefully to the girl's voice.
Phulia?
No.
Or could any child's voice become Phulia as soon as she heard it?
Nilima looked at Taramani's face.
When they reached home, she asked—
"This voice?"
Taramani said—
"The 'hurry' sounded similar."
"Tara Di?"
"No."
Nilima fell silent.
Then she said—
"Perhaps someone else said the first words."
"Perhaps."
"Are you disappointed?"
Taramani answered quickly—
"Why?"
Nilima smiled.
"Just asking."
That night Taramani thought about it.
Disappointed?
Did she want the voice to be Phulia's?
If yes, what would that mean?
That Phulia lived in the kans?
For forty years?
As a little girl?
The thought was unbearable.
If Phulia had survived, she would be an old woman now.

Why a child's voice?
 Memory did not allow a person to grow older.
 That was unjust.
 For the first time Taramani imagined Phulia as a fifty-eight-year-old woman.
 Grey in her hair.
 Perhaps spectacles.
 Perhaps grandchildren.
 Perhaps bad knees.
 Would she laugh, or had she become stern?
 Where would she live?
 In this imagining, Phulia stepped out of childhood.
 Taramani felt a strange peace.
 The next day she said to Nilima—
 "If Phulia were alive, she would be an old woman four years younger than your mother."
 Nilima said—
 "Yes."
 "We have kept her a child."
 "Because she disappeared at that age."
 "That isn't right."
 Nilima thought for a moment.
 "But if we give her another face, that too would be imagination."
 Taramani looked at her.
 "You're right."
 They both laughed.
 "Then?"
 "Then only as much as we know."
 The rule kept returning.
 A local young man named Navin had a hobby of watching birds in the kans field.
 He went there at dawn with binoculars.
 One day Taramani met him on the road.
 "Dadi, don't go that way. The lower ground is marshy."
 "I stay on the path."
 "Yesterday I saw a crane."
 "Good."
 "And the children run about shouting."
 Taramani stopped.
 "Which children?"
 "The brick-kiln settlement."
 "At dawn?"
 "Sometimes even before sunrise. Their people's work starts early."
 "Do you know their names?"
 "Whose?"
 "The children's."
 Navin named three.
 Rinki.

Chhotu.

Mannu.

“Does anyone call anyone ‘Tara Di?’”

Navin laughed.

“You?”

“Suppose so.”

“I haven’t heard it.”

Then Navin became serious.

“Dadi, did something happen?”

“No.”

Taramani walked on.

If she had wanted, she could have gone to the kiln and listened to the children’s voices.

She did not.

Why?

Perhaps she did not want a solution.

Or feared that she would not find one.

Or feared that she would.

She could not trust the intention of her own mind.

A few days later a woman from the kiln came to Taramani’s house for medicine from the health centre.

Because of old familiarity, people still came to her for advice.

The woman had a ten-year-old girl with her.

Her name was Rinki.

Taramani looked at her.

“Do you play behind the kans?”

Rinki looked at her mother’s face.

“Sometimes.”

“At dawn?”

“Sometimes.”

“Does anyone in your settlement say ‘Tara Di?’”

The girl burst out laughing.

“Tara Dadi?”

“Di.”

“No.”

The woman asked—

“What happened?”

Taramani said—

“Nothing.”

She heard Rinki speak two or three more times.

Her voice was sweet.

Like the first day’s?

She could not compare them.

The first voice had already changed inside memory.

The more often she thought of it, the clearer it became.

The clearer it became, the less trustworthy.

Rinki took the medicine and left.
 Taramani did not follow her.
 That evening Mahendra Dai came over.
 "Did you examine the girl from the kiln?"
 Taramani was startled.
 "Who told you?"
 "This is a village."
 "I didn't examine her."
 "You questioned her."
 "Yes."
 Mahendra Dai laughed.
 "The result?"
 "Nothing."
 "Then Phulia?"
 Taramani became irritated.
 "Why do you keep bringing Phulia into this?"
 Mahendra Dai fell silent.
 "You were the one who told me about the voice."
 Taramani let out a breath.
 "Hearing a voice means Phulia has returned?"
 "No."
 "Then?"
 Mahendra Dai said quietly—
 "Are you afraid people will make another story?"
 Taramani looked at her.
 That was the right question.
 "Yes."
 "Then don't tell anyone."
 "I told you."
 "I'll keep quiet."
 "Will the village keep quiet?"
 They both laughed.
 But the matter was serious.
 The story of Phulia's disappearance had already changed enough.
 If the voice in the kans were added, the next generation would say—
 Phulia disappeared in the kans.
 She calls out at night.
 Don't cut the kans.
 Tara heard her on such-and-such a day.
 Taramani was afraid of this new story.
 She did not want proof.
 Nor did she want a false story.
 Mahendra Dai said—
 "Then tell Nilima not to write it down."
 "She isn't writing."
 "And you?"

“Where do I write?”
Mahendra Dai glanced at Taramani’s old notebook.
Taramani laughed.
“That’s for keeping track of medicines.”
“Fine.”
Dashami passed.
Nilima went back.
The kans field grew quiet.
The fair was dismantled.
A few pieces of torn plastic lay beside the path.
The wind became drier.
One morning Taramani deliberately took the same road again.
Deliberately.
She decided in her mind—
If the voice came, she would stop.
She would not go into the kans.
She would answer once.
Then go home.
Why such a rule?
She laughed.
Human beings make rules for uncertain things.
She reached the edge of the field.
Sunrise.
The heads of the kans were golden.
A herdsman in the distance.
Two cows.
No children.
Wind.
Sar-sar.
Taramani walked slowly.
She did not stop where she had heard the first voice.
She went on.
Near the drain.
Then a voice came from far away—
“Di...”
Nothing clearer.
Taramani stopped.
Then—
“Tara...”
Or “chara”?
Was the herdsman calling for fodder for the cows?
She looked into the distance.
The herdsman’s face was turned the other way.
The kans moved.
Taramani called—
“Who is it?”

The answer came—
 “Here!”
 This time it was clearly a child’s voice.
 Taramani remembered her rule.
 Not inside the kans.
 She remained standing on the road.
 A few moments later two children appeared on the footpath beyond the far edge
 of the kans.
 A boy.
 A girl.
 The girl was calling to someone behind her—
 “Here!”
 They did not see Taramani.
 They walked on.
 “Tara”?
 Had anyone said it?
 Taramani was not certain.
 She kept shaping the possible word in her mind.
 Tara.
 Chara.
 Dada.
 Ara.
 The wind swallowed one syllable and added another.
 She laughed.
 Relief?
 A little.
 Disappointment?
 Perhaps not.
 She started back.
 Behind her the kans rustled.
 This time she did not turn the kans into Phulia’s home.
 The field was only a field.
 But when she reached home, she remembered her mother’s old sentence—
 “What if Phulia comes back?”
 She drank water in the kitchen.
 And said to herself—
 “Not today.”
 She smiled at the answer.
 In the afternoon Nilima phoned.
 “Barki Ma, did you go to the kans?”
 “Yes.”
 “The voice?”
 Taramani was silent.
 Then she said—
 “There were children.”
 “Then that day too?”

"I can't say."
 "Right."
 Nilima changed the subject.
 The school inspection.
 Salary.
 The Dashami crowds.
 Taramani noticed how quickly life moved on to the next thing.
 That was not disrespect.
 It was necessity.
 In the evening she met Mahendra Dai.
 "I found the children," Taramani said.
 "Not Phulia?"
 "Will you never stop joking?"
 "No."
 They both laughed.
 Taramani said—
 "The voice was probably the children's."
 "Probably?"
 "Yes."
 "You didn't like 'probably' before."
 "I have grown older."
 Mahendra Dai said—
 "Then Phulia's story is over?"
 Taramani replied at once—
 "When was the story ever over?"
 They both fell silent.
 Did Phulia's disappearance demand the ending of a mystery?
 The family had searched for many years.
 The administration.
 The police station.
 Fairs.
 Relatives.
 Nothing.
 At one point the searching became less.
 Then stopped.
 Life went on.
 Was that defeat?
 Perhaps.
 Was it inevitable?
 Perhaps.
 Taramani did not want to pass judgement now.
 She only did not want one autumn voice to give the old helplessness a new, false
 ending.
 A few weeks later the cutting of the kans began.
 Villagers cut it for fodder and thatching.
 Some of it would also be cleared for the widening of the road.

Nilima said on the phone—
 “They’ll cut the kans?”
 “Yes, some of it.”
 “Does that upset you?”
 Taramani looked towards the field.
 “The kans grows again every year.”
 “Phulia?”
 “She is not the kans.”
 Nilima fell silent.
 “I didn’t mean it that way.”
 “I know.”
 Taramani softened her voice and said—
 “Keeping the field will not preserve Phulia. Cutting it will not erase her either.”
 Nilima said—
 “May I write that sentence down?”
 Taramani laughed.
 “You write it.”
 “Sure?”
 “Yes. This is what I am saying now. I may change it later.”
 They both laughed.
 When the kans was cut, the ground of the field became visible.
 Small rises and hollows.
 A footpath.
 A torn plastic bag.
 Marks where cattle had grazed.
 Nothing mysterious.
 One day after the cutting, Taramani went there.
 She could see a long way.
 She thought—if Phulia had disappeared here, nothing would be found now
 anyway.
 Then she corrected herself—
 It was not certain that she had disappeared here.
 She applied the rule to herself too.
 She did not go into the middle of the field.
 She stayed on the path at the edge.
 She met an old herdsman.
 He said—
 “Dadi, now that the kans is cut, the path is clear.”
 “Yes.”
 “Before, children used to hide inside.”
 “And now?”
 “Where would they hide now?”
 He laughed.
 Taramani asked—
 “Do you remember a girl named Phulia?”
 The herdsman thought for a long time.

“Whose daughter?”
 Taramani gave her parents’ names.
 “Oh, the girl who disappeared?”
 “Yes.”
 “I was small then. I remember the commotion.”
 “The kans?”
 “What?”
 “Did anyone say she was in the kans?”
 The herdsman scratched his head.
 “There was kans everywhere then.”
 The answer relieved Taramani.
 The story of this particular field was not present in the old memory.
 A new story could be stopped before it formed.
 She took leave of the herdsman.
 Winter began.
 Bundles of cut kans dried in heaps beside the houses.
 The field turned brown.
 No voice.
 Taramani began walking on the eastern road again.
 The kans route was no longer necessary.
 Did she remember Phulia less?
 No.
 Sometimes for no reason.
 One day while rolling rotis.
 One day while taking out wool.
 One day on hearing Nilima laugh over the phone.
 One day on seeing a child’s braid.
 The incident of the voice slowly lost its sharpness.
 Taramani knew memory would alter it again.
 Two years later perhaps she would say—
 “Someone in the kans once said something like “Tara Di.””
 Five years later—
 “Once I heard something like Phulia’s voice.”
 Ten years later someone else would say—
 “Taramani had heard Phulia’s voice.”
 The difference was small; the meaning enormous.
 She warned Nilima about this.
 Nilima said—
 “Then how should I remember it?”
 “As it is now.”
 “Meaning?”
 “Say—once, beside the kans, Barki Ma heard something like ‘Tara Di’; the source was not certain.”
 Nilima laughed.
 “That is a very long story.”
 “Truth is under no obligation to be short.”

"Right."
 In spring the kans field became green grass.
 The whiteness of autumn was gone.
 Taramani went there less often.
 Dust in summer.
 Water in the rains.
 The next autumn, kans again.
 Nature did not move for stories, but for its own cycle.
 That following autumn Taramani deliberately invited Nilima.
 "Will you come to see the kans?"
 Nilima laughed.
 "Last time you said—what is there to see in kans?"
 "I changed my mind."
 Nilima came.
 They went at dawn.
 The kans was white again.
 New stalks.
 New flowers.
 Not the previous year's stalks.
 Taramani said—
 "Look, this is new kans."
 "Yes."
 "We call it 'the same field.'"
 "Yes."
 "But the stalks are new."
 Nilima said—
 "Philosophy again?"
 Taramani laughed.
 "I caught the disease from Mahendra Dai."
 They sat beside the road.
 No voice came from inside the kans.
 A school bell in the distance.
 A vehicle.
 A cow.
 Wind.
 Taramani closed her eyes.
 Nilima asked—
 "Phulia Maudi?"
 "Yes."
 "The voice?"
 "No."
 "Then what?"
 After a long pause Taramani said—
 "Today I am not thinking of her as a child."
 "Then?"
 "I don't know. Only as a name."

Nilima said—

“Is that sad?”

“Sometimes.”

“And sometimes?”

“A relief.”

Nilima was silent.

The kans kept moving.

Taramani said softly—

“The difficulty with missing people is that they have no final age. The living can stop them at whatever age they choose.”

Nilima said—

“Then shall I imagine Phulia at fifty-eight?”

“You may. But say—it is imagination.”

“And you?”

“Sometimes I see her at eight. Sometimes as an old woman. Sometimes nothing.”

Nilima took her hand.

Taramani did not pull it away.

Far behind the kans a girl called out—

“Didi!”

They both looked that way at once.

Two girls were running along the footpath.

One calling to the other.

Nilima smiled.

So did Taramani.

The voice was clear.

Did it sound like Phulia?

For a moment.

Then it did not.

She said nothing to Nilima.

They rose and started home.

Behind them the field of kans remained.

There was no proof there.

No answer.

Only wind, the distant voices of children, and a name to which Taramani did not want to give a false ending.

Phulia disappeared.

The sentence seemed incomplete.

But Taramani now understood—some sentences in a life remain true even without a full stop.

The Dust of Tirhut

Jagesar, the cart-driver, measured the road by names.

He had never formed the habit of looking at milestones.

The clock came later too.

First one name.

Then another.

Then a third.

“Up to here, Basanti Dai.”

“Ahead, Karim Mian.”

“At that bend, Bachchan Master.”

“Past the peepal tree, Bhola Sah.”

Anyone travelling with him for the first time would think these were addresses of houses.

After a while it became clear—they were not.

They were the names of dead passengers.

People who, at one time or another, had sat in Jagesar's bullock cart.

Someone had gone to the market.

Someone to a daughter's home.

Someone to the hospital.

Someone to a wedding.

Someone only two kos.

The people died.

Their names remained on the road.

Jagesar was now eighty-four.

He drove the cart very rarely.

The two bullocks belonged to his younger son, Umesh.

Their names were Moti and Dhawal.

Not the old pair.

The old pair had gone long ago.

The cart too was half new.

The wheels had been replaced.

The axle had been replaced.

The planks had been replaced.

Jagesar said, “It is the same cart.”

Umesh laughed. “What is left?”

Jagesar said, “The sound.”

Whether the dry creak-creak that rose when the wheels moved was truly like the old one, or whether Jagesar's ears made it old, no one knew.

That day the autumn sunlight was mild.

The air that comes before the paddy harvest.

Jagesar had to go as far as the old market.

The reason was ordinary.

Umesh's brother-in-law had asked for a pair of ploughshares and two sacks of bran.

He could have gone by passenger vehicle.

Half the goods could have gone on a motorbike.

Umesh said, "Babu, why the cart?"

Jagesar said, "How many days will Moti and Dhawal stand tied to the post?"

"For work?"

"This is work."

There was another reason as well.

A section of the old road was to be paved the following month.

People in the village were saying: the dust will end.

Jagesar wanted to take the cart over that road once.

He told no one this reason.

Because the moment they heard it, people would say—sentimentality.

Jagesar did not like the word "sentimental".

He would say, "What is, is."

The journey to the market was about twelve kos.

In the old days, half a day.

Now, by motor vehicle, not even an hour.

As Jagesar was preparing to leave at dawn, his granddaughter Munia said, "I'll go too."

She was sixteen.

It was a school holiday.

Umesh objected.

"There'll be dust in the cart."

Munia said, "Will dust kill me?"

Jagesar laughed.

"Will the names of dead people frighten you?"

Munia was startled.

"What?"

Umesh put a hand to his forehead.

"Babu has started again."

Munia insisted.

In the end, she was on the cart.

Two sacks.

The ploughshares.

A water pitcher.

Fodder.

A small box of jaggery.

Jagesar in front.

Munia on the rear plank.

The village was slowly waking at dawn.

The cart passed through the gate.

The wheels raised dust.

Jagesar spoke the first name—

"Basanti Dai."

Munia immediately asked, "Who?"
 Jagesar kept urging the bullocks onward.
 "A passenger."
 "Where?"
 "On this road."
 "Why did you say her name?"
 Jagesar did not answer.
 Munia edged forward from the back.
 "Grandfather?"
 "You heard the name, didn't you?"
 "But why?"
 "The road has begun."
 Munia did not understand.
 The cart reached the village's last pond.
 Jagesar said, "Basanti Dai got on the cart here."
 "When?"
 "Many years ago."
 "Where did she go?"
 "To Madhubani, to her daughter's home."
 "Then?"
 "Then what?"
 "Where is she now?"
 Jagesar said matter-of-factly, "She died."
 Munia fell silent.
 After a while she asked, "So you count the names of dead people?"
 "Not all."
 "Whose?"
 "Those who sat in the cart on this road."
 "All of them?"
 "How could I remember them all?"
 The first bend came.
 Jagesar said, "Karim Mian."
 Munia was ready now.
 "Story?"
 "No story."
 "Then?"
 "Karim Mian."
 "That's all?"
 "That's all."
 Munia made a face.
 Jagesar laughed.
 "You want a story for everything."
 "How can there be a name without a story?"
 Jagesar gave a soft call to the bullocks.
 "Karim Mian had a radio."
 "And?"

“He sat in the cart with the radio held to his ear the entire way.”
 “And?”
 “He paid the fare when he got down.”
 “And?”
 “What else do you want?”
 Munia burst out laughing.
 “That counts as a story?”
 “No. A journey.”
 After Karim Mian’s name, Jagesar fell silent.
 Munia took out her phone and began to type.
 “What are you writing?”
 “Names.”
 “Why?”
 “So I don’t forget.”
 Jagesar said at once, “Don’t write them.”
 “Why?”
 “What will you do writing what you don’t know?”
 “You’ll tell me.”
 “Not everything I say is certain.”
 Munia switched off the screen.
 “All right.”
 The cart crossed the canal.
 The canal bridge was new.
 Jagesar looked towards where the old bridge had been.
 Only the remains of two bricks were there.
 “Bachchan Master.”
 Munia said, “I want the story of this name.”
 Jagesar smiled.
 “As soon as Bachchan Master got into the cart, he would say, ‘Drive slowly.’”
 “A bullock cart even slower?”
 “Yes.”
 “Why?”
 “His back hurt.”
 “Oh.”
 “And whenever a pothole came, he would warn me in advance—‘Pothole.’”
 “Didn’t you see it?”
 “I did. But a master’s job is to say things.”
 Munia laughed.
 “Did he die?”
 “Yes.”
 “When?”
 “Seven or eight years ago.”
 “Certain?”
 “No.”
 Munia fell silent.
 A little farther on, new electric poles stood beside the road.

Wires overhead.

Jagesar said, "There used to be a jujube tree here."

"Name?"

"The tree's."

"A passenger?"

"Not yet."

Munia laughed.

Slowly she began to understand Jagesar's rhythm.

A name would come at a distance.

The road in between.

The dust of the old road was fine.

As the sun rose, it settled on shoes, sacks, and the cart's planks like a layer of ash.

Munia pulled her dupatta over her nose.

"Grandfather, did everyone travel through so much dust?"

"Back then, was dust even dust?"

"What?"

"When you see something every day, you complain less."

"Do you like it?"

Jagesar thought.

"Liking is another matter."

"Then?"

"It belongs to the road."

Munia said, "It'll be better once it's paved."

"Better."

There was no opposition in Jagesar's voice.

Munia was surprised.

"Haven't you come out to save the dust?"

Jagesar laughed.

"Who told you?"

"Everyone in the village says you want to see the old road."

"People need something to say."

"True?"

"Half."

"And the other half?"

"Bran."

They both laughed.

Ahead was the old shade of a peepal tree.

The tree was now half dry.

Jagesar said, "Bhola Sah."

"The grocer?"

"Yes, when your father was small, he had a shop."

"Where did he go in the cart?"

"To the hospital."

Munia's laughter stopped.

"Was he ill?"

"Very."

"Did he survive?"

Jagesar said, "He survived that day. He died five years later."

Munia looked at her grandfather's face.

"So the name is for the hospital journey?"

"No. The name is only the name."

"You don't count the reasons?"

"How could I remember every reason?"

Jagesar stopped the bullocks.

He gave them water beneath the peepal tree.

Munia got down too.

She dusted her feet.

The dust settled on them again.

An old man was sitting on the platform beneath the peepal tree.

He recognised Jagesar.

"Ah, cart-driver!"

Jagesar laughed.

"Still the same name?"

"Has the name changed?"

The old man was Zahid Mian.

Munia greeted him respectfully.

Zahid asked, "Whose daughter?"

"Umesh's."

"He has a daughter this grown now?"

Munia laughed.

Zahid said, "When did you ever have me ride in your cart?"

Jagesar said, "You're still alive."

Zahid burst out laughing.

"Whose rule is that?"

Munia immediately said, "Grandfather counts only dead passengers' names."

Zahid fell silent.

Then he looked at Jagesar.

"Really?"

"What all will you tell a child now?"

Zahid laughed.

"Add my name later too."

Jagesar said, "What's your hurry?"

All three laughed.

Zahid brought puffed rice from his house.

They ate a little.

Munia asked, "Zahid Grandfather, your journey?"

Zahid said, "Not one. Many."

"Any special one?"

"Your grandfather will make it special."

Jagesar said, "That's the trouble. People think I'm a storyteller."

Zahid smiled.

"You're a man of names."

Jagesar's face grew a little serious.
 He set the cart moving.
 The peepal tree fell behind.
 Munia asked, "Why not Zahid Grandfather's name?"
 "He's alive."
 "What if you die before he does?"
 Jagesar looked at her.
 "Then it will be your job to count?"
 "Mine?"
 "Yes. Whoever remains."
 Munia fell silent.
 The talk had begun as a joke and grown heavy.
 Jagesar changed his tone.
 "Look, the egrets in that field."
 The subject changed.
 Ahead lay an old crossroads.
 Now there were a tea stall, a phone-repair shop, and a fertiliser-and-seed shop.
 Jagesar said, "Phulkumari Dai."
 Munia asked, "Like Basanti Dai?"
 "No."
 "Where did she go?"
 "To her daughter's wedding."
 "Not her own wedding?"
 "Her daughter's."
 "With luggage?"
 "Two brass lotas, one trunk, four sacks of rice."
 "All that in the cart?"
 "Back then, the cart was for luggage."
 "Where did she sit?"
 "On the sacks."
 "The fare?"
 "At the end she gave me a lota of milk."
 "No money?"
 "Money too. The milk was separate."
 Munia laughed.
 "You remember that?"
 "The milk was warm."
 Along with the name, a temperature had survived.
 Munia wanted to write it down, but remembered her grandfather's prohibition.
 She did not write.
 The cart crossed the crossroads.
 From there the old road narrowed.
 Paddy on both sides.
 Fewer motor vehicles.
 More dust.
 Jagesar's stick rested against the side of the cart.

He did not beat the bullocks.
 Only his voice—"Ho, Moti... Dhawal..."
 Munia asked, "Did you ever beat a passenger?"
 "A passenger?"
 "In anger?"
 Jagesar laughed.
 "I hardly beat the bullocks either."
 "A passenger?"
 "I did make one get down once."
 "Who?"
 "I won't count the name."
 "Alive?"
 "Perhaps he's dead now."
 "Then?"
 "If he didn't complete the journey in the cart, why count his name?"
 Munia laughed.
 "You have so many rules."
 "None of them are written."
 After a while Jagesar himself said, "That man was drunk and abusing the bullocks. I put him off."
 "Name?"
 "No."
 "Don't you remember?"
 "I remember."
 "Then?"
 "Counting names does not mean giving everyone an equal place."
 Munia thought about that answer.
 A person did not become virtuous merely by dying.
 Jagesar's list was not a memorial tribute.
 Some journeys he liked.
 Some he did not.
 Some he remembered.
 Some he deliberately left out.
 Ahead stood a new school beside the road.
 Jagesar said, "Nathuni Paswan."
 Munia asked, "Story?"
 "Goat."
 "What?"
 "He would sit in the cart, but never without his goat."
 "Where was he going?"
 "To the livestock market."
 "The goat in the cart?"
 "Yes."
 "What did the bullocks say?"
 "Do bullocks speak?"
 "Don't bullocks sometimes answer too?"

Jagesar was startled.
 "Which river?"
 Munia laughed.
 "Nothing."
 Jagesar laughed and shook his head.
 He continued, "The goat bleated all the way. Nathuni kept saying, 'Be quiet, you'll see the town.'"
 Munia doubled over laughing.
 "To the goat?"
 "Yes."
 "Did he sell it?"
 "No."
 "Then why go to the market?"
 "The price was too low."
 "So he brought it back?"
 "Yes. Two journeys' fare."
 "Did he pay?"
 "Half."
 "And you accepted?"
 "I waived the fare for the goat's noise."
 Munia laughed again.
 So did Jagesar.
 Some names were lightened by laughter.
 Some were heavy.
 Ahead was an old brick culvert.
 Jagesar suddenly fell silent.
 Munia waited.
 No name came.
 They crossed the culvert.
 Then Jagesar said softly, "Saraswati."
 His tone had changed.
 Munia did not ask.
 Jagesar himself said, "My sister."
 "Yours?"
 "Yes."
 Munia knew her grandfather had had a sister who had died long ago, but perhaps this was the first time she had heard the name.
 "In the cart?"
 "To take her back to her in-laws' home."
 "The last time?"
 Jagesar was silent for a long while.
 "No."
 Munia let out a breath of relief.
 "Then?"
 "One time."
 "Special?"

“No.”

Jagesar said, “Not every journey is special. It isn’t necessary that an old journey become special later merely because the person dies.”

Munia nodded.

Nothing more was said about Saraswati.

The name remained behind the culvert.

Noon approached.

The sunlight grew sharp.

The cart stopped beside a mango grove.

Fodder for the bullocks.

The two of them ate puris and pickle.

Munia took a photograph with her phone.

Jagesar with the cart, bullocks, and dust.

“Grandfather, smile.”

“Why?”

“For the picture.”

“Is there no face without a smile?”

He remained sitting straight.

Munia took the picture.

“Is this the last journey through dust?”

Jagesar said, “Who knows.”

“The road will be paved.”

“There will be other dust.”

“Where?”

“Is there a shortage of dust in the village?”

Munia smiled.

After eating, Jagesar leaned his back against the earth and closed his eyes for a while.

Munia asked, “Asleep?”

“No.”

“Remembering names?”

“No.”

“Then?”

“Does closing one’s eyes require a purpose?”

Munia fell silent.

After a while Jagesar said, “When your father was small, the cart overturned once in this grove.”

“What?”

“An empty cart. The bullocks were safe. I fell.”

“Name?”

“I’m alive.”

They both laughed.

The journey began again.

Beyond the grove, a new highway cut across the road.

It was difficult for the bullock cart to cross.

Jagesar stopped.

Cars, trucks, motorbikes.
 Munia got down and signalled with her hand.
 One vehicle stopped.
 The cart crossed.
 Jagesar said, "There used to be peace here."
 Munia said, "Now there is convenience."
 "Yes."
 "Does it make you angry?"
 "Why?"
 "The old road changed."
 Jagesar said, "The road is for people. People are not for the road."
 Munia liked the sentence.
 She wanted to write it down.
 Then remembered her grandfather's prohibition.
 She kept it in her mind.
 Beyond the highway, the cart moved along the surviving stretch of the old road.
 Jagesar said, "Ramkali."
 "Who?"
 "A dai."
 "A midwife?"
 "Yes."
 "Where?"
 "One night, three kos from the village."
 "In the cart?"
 "She and her bag."
 "At night?"
 "Yes."
 "Were you afraid?"
 "I knew the road then."
 "And now?"
 "Now too."
 "Ramkali Dai died?"
 "Long ago."
 "Was a baby ever born in your cart?"
 Jagesar laughed.
 "You want a story, don't you?"
 "Yes."
 "No. We reached in time."
 Munia made a face.
 "Why are all the stories so ordinary?"
 "Most of people's lives are ordinary."
 "Death?"
 "That too, many times."
 Munia fell silent at Jagesar's answer.
 Far away was a temple spire.
 A faint bell.

Jagesar said no name.

Munia herself asked, "No one here?"

"Many."

"Then?"

"Not every name is tied to a place."

"When do you count them?"

"When they come to mind."

"Then how is this measuring the journey?"

Jagesar laughed.

"You ask too many questions."

"You said you measure the road by names."

"Sometimes."

"Then the rule is broken."

"You made the rule."

Munia fell silent and laughed.

She wanted to turn her grandfather into a system.

Jagesar's memory was not a system.

Four kos before the market lay a dried-up pond.

Jagesar said, "Maulvi Samad."

Munia asked, "Related to Karim Mian with the radio?"

"No."

"Story?"

"He sat in the cart humming poetry the whole way."

"Which one?"

"I don't remember."

"One line?"

"No."

"Then why do you remember the name?"

"I remember the voice."

"Not the poem?"

"No."

Munia thought: memory can abandon the words and retain the sound.

Jagesar's face was calm.

Munia asked, "Can you hear his voice even now?"

"No. I only know that he was humming."

The distinction seemed subtle to Munia.

Not hearing it now.

Remembering that one had heard it.

Ahead, two men were walking.

The cart slowed.

An old man raised a hand to stop it.

"To the market?"

Jagesar said, "Sit."

Munia was startled.

A new passenger.

His name was Harikishor Mahato.

Around seventy.
 He sat beside Munia on the plank.
 "The fare?"
 Jagesar said, "Whatever seems fair."
 Harikishor laughed.
 "Still the old cart-driver?"
 "Now I'm old; the cart is half new."
 The journey continued.
 A question came to Munia: when would Jagesar count Harikishor's name?
 She did not ask.
 Harikishor himself began speaking of old times.
 "On this road, you once carried my father."
 Jagesar thought.
 "Name?"
 "Kailu Mahato."
 Jagesar's face brightened.
 "Kailu!"
 Harikishor laughed.
 "You remember?"
 "He would not stay seated in the cart."
 "What?"
 "He would walk half the way and sit half the way."
 "Why?"
 "He'd say, 'The bullocks will get tired.'"
 Harikishor burst out laughing.
 "Father was like that."
 Munia asked, "Has Kailu Baba died?"
 Harikishor's laughter softened.
 "Ten years ago."
 Jagesar said, "Kailu Mahato."
 The name was added now, in the middle of the road, with a new witness.
 Munia felt that her grandfather's list was not fixed.
 Someone else could return a name to him.
 Harikishor said, "And do you count Gangaram?"
 Jagesar fell silent.
 "Which Gangaram?"
 "The timber trader from Sonbarsa."
 Jagesar shook his head.
 "He used to load goods on the cart and ride a horse himself."
 "He sat in it once."
 "When?"
 "In the rain, when his horse slipped. In your cart."
 Jagesar scratched his head.
 "I don't remember."
 Harikishor said, "I was with him."
 Jagesar laughed.

"Then it is your memory."

"Add the name."

"Why, if I don't remember?"

Harikishor said, "It happened."

Jagesar said calmly, "My counting belongs to my memory."

Harikishor nodded.

"Fair enough."

Munia remained caught on that answer.

Not remembering was not an injustice.

Memory was not a complete account-book.

Before Harikishor got down, he paid the fare.

Jagesar returned half.

"This much only."

Harikishor said, "Why?"

"Half the road."

"An old rule?"

"The fare rule is firm."

All three laughed.

Harikishor got down.

Munia asked, "You truly won't add Gangaram's name?"

"I don't remember."

"Harikishor Grandfather said it."

"If he counts, he can add it."

"Your list is incomplete."

"Yes."

Jagesar was matter-of-fact.

Munia felt there was something large in that "yes".

The market was near.

Less dust, more crowd.

Shops.

Passenger vehicles.

Farm vehicles.

Bicycles.

Only two or three bullock carts.

Some old people turned to look at Jagesar's cart.

One said, "Is that Jagesar?"

Jagesar raised a hand in greeting.

They reached the market.

The bran was unloaded.

The ploughshares were handed over.

His brother-in-law's son paid the money.

Jagesar checked the account.

Munia thought: the grandfather who counts the names of the dead is perfectly exact about fares and money.

Sentiment and accounting can live in the same body.

Two hours at the market.

Jagesar did not wander about looking for old acquaintances.
 Whoever he happened to meet, he met.
 A lassi.
 Some puffed rice.
 Fodder for the bullocks.
 Munia looked at bangles but bought none.
 On the return journey, the cart was almost empty.
 Jagesar left two empty sacks at the back.
 A woman with a child wanted to ride a little way.
 Jagesar said, "Sit."
 Her name was Renuka.
 The child was Navin.
 Living names.
 Munia smiled.
 Jagesar asked, "What?"
 "Nothing."
 Renuka got down after three kos.
 She tried to pay the fare.
 Jagesar would not take it.
 "Such a short way."
 "Why?"
 "The cart was empty."
 Renuka insisted.
 Jagesar finally took half.
 Munia noted to herself: the behaviour of living passengers too would become memory.
 On the way back, the sun was in the west.
 The dust was golden.
 Jagesar began counting names again.
 This time in reverse order.
 "Maulvi Samad."
 A little later—"Ramkali."
 Then—"Saraswati."
 Munia asked, "This time you left out Nathuni Paswan."
 Jagesar was startled.
 "Did I?"
 "Yes. The one with the goat."
 Jagesar laughed.
 "See? It isn't a list."
 "But the name?"
 "Now I've said it—Nathuni."
 Munia smiled.
 Had she saved the name by correcting her grandfather's lapse?
 Or was it only a game?
 Hard to say.
 In the slanting sunlight, the dust rose and made a long line behind them.

Munia wanted to take a photograph.
 The cart was moving.
 The image shook.
 She took one anyway.
 Jagesar asked, "What?"
 "The dust."
 "A photograph of dust?"
 "Yes."
 "In a few days the road will be paved."
 "That's why."
 Jagesar said, "Will people take photographs of the paved road later?"
 Munia said, "Probably not."
 "Why?"
 "New things seem ordinary first."
 Jagesar laughed.
 "Where did you learn that?"
 "Just now."
 When they crossed the highway, Munia got down again.
 The cart crossed safely.
 Jagesar said, "You'll make a good cart-driver."
 Munia said, "I won't drive bullocks."
 "Then?"
 "I'll show the road."
 "Half a cart-driver."
 They both laughed.
 They rested again near the mango grove.
 Evening.
 Jagesar ate jaggery.
 Munia drank water.
 She asked, "Grandfather, who was your very first passenger?"
 Jagesar thought for a long time.
 "I don't remember."
 "How old were you when you began driving the cart?"
 "Seventeen or eighteen."
 "No first name?"
 "No."
 "The most recently dead name?"
 "What do you mean?"
 "Someone who died recently and had once sat in your cart."
 Jagesar thought.
 "Shambhunath?"
 "Certain?"
 "No."
 Munia laughed.
 "Your system is terrible."
 "It isn't an attendance register like your school."

"Then why do you count names?"
 Jagesar put a piece of jaggery in his mouth.
 "Sometimes the road feels empty."
 Munia fell silent.
 This was the first direct answer.
 "And when you say the names?"
 "Less empty."
 "Do the people come back?"
 Jagesar said at once, "No."
 His voice was firm.
 "Dead people do not climb into the cart. Saying a name brings no one back."
 Munia nodded.
 Jagesar continued, "It only reminds me how many times I travelled from one place on this road to another with people."
 "Loneliness?"
 "Perhaps."
 "You admitted it?"
 "What?"
 "Loneliness."
 Jagesar laughed.
 "In old age must one accept every word?"
 Munia laughed too.
 The cart moved again.
 The sky was orange.
 The culvert lay ahead.
 This time Jagesar did not say Saraswati's name.
 Munia waited.
 They crossed the culvert.
 She herself said, "Saraswati."
 Jagesar looked at her.
 He neither grew annoyed.
 Nor smiled.
 He only nodded.
 The name was now between two people.
 A little farther on came Nathuni Paswan.
 Munia said, "Goat."
 Jagesar laughed.
 "Count the name, not the animal."
 "Without the goat, the story is incomplete."
 "Your story."
 When they reached the school, children were playing after classes.
 A ball rolled onto the road.
 Jagesar stopped the bullocks.
 A boy picked up the ball and ran away.
 Munia said, "Whose name now?"
 Jagesar said, "No one's."

"Why?"

"The living are all in front of us."

Munia fell silent at that sentence.

When they reached the peepal shade, Zahid Mian was not there now.

The platform was empty.

Jagesar did not stop the bullocks.

Munia asked, "Zahid Grandfather?"

"He must have gone home."

"No name?"

"Alive."

"What if, in a few years—"

Jagesar cut in, "Today's journey, today's matter."

Munia fell silent.

He did not want to place a future death into the list in advance.

There was less dust on the road now, not because of evening dew, but because the wind had died.

Karim Mian's bend.

Jagesar said, "Karim."

Munia said, "The radio."

"Yes."

"Which programme?"

"I don't remember."

"Which year?"

"No."

"Which season?"

"Perhaps winter."

"Perhaps?"

"Yes."

Munia said, "Then this is all I'll remember—Karim Mian sat with a radio held to his ear."

Jagesar said, "Why will you remember it?"

Munia paused.

A fair question.

Why should she?

"Because you told me."

Jagesar said, "You don't have to carry every story you hear."

Munia was taken aback.

"Then?"

"What stays in your mind will stay. What doesn't, let it go."

For the first time, Munia understood her grandfather's list not as an inheritance but as a personal habit.

She had no duty to imitate it.

The village was near.

Basanti Dai's pond.

Jagesar did not say the name.

Munia did not remind him.

Both were silent.
 By the gate, the sun had almost set.
 Umesh was waiting outside.
 "So late?"
 Jagesar said, "It's a cart."
 Munia jumped down.
 Umesh looked at her clothes.
 "Have you rolled in the dust?"
 "Yes."
 She laughed.
 "The bran?"
 "Delivered."
 "The ploughshares?"
 "Delivered."
 "The money?"
 Jagesar handed over the amount tied inside his gamchha.
 The account was complete.
 Umesh said, "Babu, work on the road starts the day after tomorrow."
 Jagesar nodded.
 "Let it."
 "And the cart then?"
 "Won't the cart run on a paved road?"
 "It will, but..."
 "But what?"
 Umesh laughed.
 "Nothing."
 After dinner, Munia kept looking through the day's photographs on her phone.
 Her grandfather's face.
 The bullocks.
 The line of dust.
 The old road.
 The peepal tree.
 The market.
 In one image Harikishor Mahato sat behind them.
 In another, Renuka and the child were blurred.
 The living passengers were in photographs.
 The dead passengers only in names.
 Munia liked the contradiction.
 She took out a notebook.
 She remembered her grandfather's prohibition.
 Should she write the names or not?
 After a long while she wrote only three things on one page—
 "Karim Mian—the radio."
 "Nathuni Paswan—the goat."
 "Saraswati—Grandfather's sister; an ordinary journey."
 Then she stopped.

Basanti Dai?
 Bachchan Master?
 Phulkumari?
 Ramkali?
 Maulvi Samad?
 Kailu Mahato?
 She did not write them.
 Why?
 Some names still belonged only to her grandfather.
 Why should her notebook immediately claim them?
 She closed the page.
 At dawn Jagesar rose at his usual time.
 Water for the bullocks.
 The cart beside the tethering post.
 Munia asked, "Grandfather, do you remember all the names you said yesterday?"
 Jagesar said, "Is this an examination?"
 "Just asking."
 "Some."
 "Have you forgotten some?"
 "Possibly."
 "Does that make you sad?"
 "Why?"
 "The dead people."
 Stroking the bullock, Jagesar said, "The dead are not the responsibility of my memory."
 Munia fell silent.
 "Then the names?"
 "The journeys."
 He stopped on that one word.
 Jagesar continued, "I drove the cart. People sat in it. They got down. Some sat again. Some did not. Saying the names reminds me of the journeys. That's all."
 Munia asked, "Will someone count your name?"
 Jagesar laughed.
 "I was less a passenger, more a cart-driver."
 "Have you ever sat as a passenger?"
 "When I was ill."
 "Whose cart?"
 "Lallan's."
 "Is he alive?"
 "No."
 Munia brightened. "Then did Lallan count your name?"
 Jagesar burst out laughing.
 "Who knows! Not everyone is mad like me."
 Munia laughed too.
 The paving of the road began.
 First the edges were cleared.

Then the earth was levelled.
 Stone chips.
 Roller.
 For a few days the dust grew even worse.
 Jagesar sat outside the house watching the vehicles.
 Returning from school, Munia said, "There's plenty of your dust now."
 Jagesar said, "This is construction dust, not the old road's dust."
 "The difference?"
 "You want a difference for everything."
 Munia laughed.
 A week later Jagesar took the cart out again for a short distance.
 Munia was not with him.
 She was at school.
 Jagesar was alone.
 The cart moved slowly over a section of road being paved.
 He said of his own accord, "Basanti Dai."
 Then silence.
 Karim Mian.
 Bachchan Master.
 The names came.
 There was no one there to hear them.
 He did not need a listener.
 Munia never came to know this afterwards.
 By winter the road was fully paved.
 There was less dust.
 The cart sounded different when it moved.
 The wheels made another kind of creak on the hard surface.
 The bullocks' hooves sounded a clear tak-tak.
 On the first day, Jagesar took the cart onto the paved road.
 Umesh was with him.
 Munia was at school.
 Umesh said, "How is it?"
 "Clean."
 "Good?"
 "Yes."
 "Do you miss the old dust?"
 Jagesar said, "It's still in my nose."
 They both laughed.
 Near the peepal tree they met Zahid Mian.
 "See? The road is done."
 "I see."
 "Will you count my name on the paved road now?"
 Jagesar said, "You're still alive."
 Zahid said, "A great injustice."
 They both laughed.
 Time passed.

One year.
Jagesar's cart went out less often.
His knees.
His eyes.
The bullocks had not been changed.
Munia was in Class Twelve.
One evening Zahid Mian died.
Umesh brought the news.
Jagesar fell silent.
Munia watched his face.
"Grandfather..."
Jagesar said, "Yes."
That was all.
The next day he went to the funeral.
Returned.
No one mentioned the rule about names.
A few weeks later Jagesar took the cart out for a short distance.
Munia went with him.
They reached the peepal tree.
The platform was empty.
Munia restrained herself and waited.
Jagesar said—
"Zahid."
One word.
Then the cart kept moving.
Munia did not ask—story?
She knew there were many stories.
The puffed rice.
The laughter.
"Add my name later too."
Which story should be chosen?
Jagesar chose none.
The name was enough.
Munia said softly, "Zahid."
Jagesar heard her.
He said nothing.
Now the name was shared between two people.
Ahead, the paved road shone.
Less dust.
The journey continued.
Munia suddenly asked, "Grandfather, when will you count my name?"
Jagesar loosened the reins slightly.
"Your name is not for counting."
"Why?"
"You are in front of me."
"Then?"

Without turning, Jagesar said, "The names of the living are not counted; they are called."

He turned halfway towards Munia between the bullocks.

"Munia, give me some water."

Munia laughed and held out the pitcher.

Her name came out of the count and returned to the present.

The cart moved slowly onward along the paved road of Tirhut.

Three Graves

No one in the family saw the moment when the third grave disappeared.
 That was what troubled Naseem most of all.
 The news of the first grave had come after the floodwaters receded.
 The same with the second.
 And the third as well.
 The river had never devoured a grave before their eyes.
 They would only arrive the next time and see that the bank had shifted, the earth
 was gone, the grave was gone.
 This time it was Majid Mian's grave that had disappeared.
 Naseem's father.
 He stood beside the river.
 His sister Rubina beside him.
 His mother, Zainab Bibi, a little behind.
 And Naseem's daughter Aaliya, who was seventeen.
 All four were silent.
 The water flowed below.
 The bank bore the raw face of fresh erosion.
 Crumbly earth.
 A few roots exposed.
 Kans grass in the distance.
 Where the grave had stood the year before, there was now air.
 Naseem said, "Was the exact place here?"
 Rubina looked at him.
 "This question now?"
 "The exact place."
 Zainab Bibi said, "To the right of that jamun tree."
 Aaliya looked around.
 "Where is the jamun tree?"
 No one answered.
 The river had swallowed the jamun tree too.
 Naseem scraped at the earth with his foot.
 Rubina said, "Stay away from the edge."
 He stepped back once.
 "Do we have last year's photograph?"
 Aaliya took out her phone.
 "I'll look."
 The pictures opened.
 A family photograph from the previous year.
 Zainab sitting beside the grave.
 Naseem standing.
 Rubina with her head bowed.

Aaliya was taking the photograph, so she was not in it.
 Behind them, half the trunk of the jamun tree.
 Naseem matched the direction in the photograph and looked at the river.
 "Yes, here."
 Rubina said, "Where is 'here'? There is nothing here now."
 Zainab said softly, "The place was there."
 Aaliya asked, "If the earth is gone, does the place remain?"
 Zainab did not look at her daughter or granddaughter.
 "Is a place separate from the earth?"
 Naseem said, "Let's go home first."
 They recited the dua.
 No one was certain over whose exact place it was being recited.
 Then they turned back.
 This family's burial ground was not the village's separate large cemetery.
 In the old days there had been a raised strip of the family's field.
 Between neem, ber and jamun trees.
 Eight or ten graves.
 Some very old, without names.
 Some with small stones.
 Some marked only by a mound of earth.
 The Bagmati had then been very far away.
 Zainab would say, "Far means truly far."
 Naseem would ask, "How far?"
 She would say, "Two paddy fields, a grazing strip, then sand, and only then the river."
 Now there were no paddy fields.
 No grazing strip.
 What the sand had been like, Aaliya knew only from stories.
 The graves of three generations of the family disappeared one after another.
 First, Karim Bakhsh.
 Naseem's great-grandfather.
 Naseem had never seen him.
 Neither had Zainab.
 The stories of Karim Bakhsh had come from Grandfather Nasiruddin.
 The second was Nasiruddin's grave.
 Naseem's grandfather.
 He remembered him vaguely.
 A white beard.
 A small tin of betel nut.
 Rising with a hand braced on his knee.
 The third was Majid Mian.
 Naseem's father.
 His face was still clear.
 His voice clear.
 His laughter clear.
 His irritation clear.

That was why the loss of the third grave felt different.

When the river first swallowed the great-grandfather's grave, the family had said, "It was old."

When the grandfather's grave went the second time, they had said, "We ought to do something."

Nothing was done.

When the father's grave went the third time, words fell short.

On reaching home, Zainab went straight to the kitchen.

Rubina stopped her. "Ma, sit down."

"I have to put the rice on."

"Now?"

"Are we not to eat all day?"

Zainab lit the stove.

Naseem sat on the veranda.

Aaliya sat beside him.

She asked, "Abba, when did Great-Grandfather's grave go?"

Naseem raised his head.

"You want to ask that now?"

"Yes."

"Why?"

"I want to understand all three."

Naseem thought.

"About eleven years ago."

"Certain?"

"Ten or eleven."

"Grandfather's?"

"Six years."

"Grandfather meaning your grandfather."

"Yes."

"And Nana..."

"Your grandfather Majid."

"This year."

Aaliya began writing something on her phone.

Naseem said, "What?"

"Dates."

"Why?"

"To remember."

Naseem felt like stopping her.

Then he paused.

"Where it isn't certain, write 'about'."

Aaliya nodded.

Rubina came onto the veranda.

"Is this turning into a record?"

Aaliya laughed.

"No, Phuphi. For myself."

Rubina said, "What is written for oneself can become a record later."

Naseem looked at his sister.
 "You and your schoolteacher language again."
 Rubina was a teacher.
 She said, "Is it wrong, then?"
 Naseem was silent.
 From inside, Zainab called, "Shall I serve the rice?"
 They all went in.
 The meal was dal, rice, and potato-parwal curry.
 No one spoke of the graves.
 Once Aaliya looked at Zainab, her father's mother.
 She was eating in an ordinary way.
 Was there less grief in that ordinariness?
 Aaliya kept the question to herself.
 After the meal, Zainab prepared paan.
 Naseem said, "Ma, will we go to the river next year?"
 Zainab's hand stopped.
 "Why not?"
 "The grave is..."
 He did not finish the sentence.
 Zainab said, "If there is no grave, is there no person?"
 Naseem said, "That's not what I mean."
 "Then?"
 "There is no place."
 Zainab put the paan into her mouth.
 "There is a place."
 Rubina asked, "Where?"
 Zainab did not point towards the river.
 Nor did she put a hand on her chest.
 She only said, "Where it was."
 Naseem grew irritated.
 "Ma, the earth is gone. The tree is gone. The marker is gone. I was using the photograph to find the exact place."
 Zainab remained calm.
 "Why do you need the exact place?"
 "For the grave."
 "There is no grave."
 Naseem fell silent.
 The sentence sounded harsh from his mother's mouth.
 But it was a fact.
 Rubina said softly, "Then where will we sit next year?"
 Zainab said, "On the bank."
 "Which bank? That will change too."
 "Then whichever bank remains."
 Rubina lowered her head.
 The family's first disagreement opened there.
 Naseem said that going to the river now had less meaning.

Rubina said that if they stopped going, the connection would break.
 Zainab said they would go.
 Aaliya asked why.
 No one had a complete answer.
 That evening, Habib Chacha stopped at the house while returning from the village mosque.
 He was seventy-five.
 An old acquaintance of the family.
 Naseem told him about the graves.
 Habib Chacha listened in silence.
 Then he said, "All three are gone?"
 "Yes."
 "Karim Bakhsh, Nasiruddin, Majid?"
 "Yes."
 Habib Chacha drew a long breath.
 "The river's work."
 Naseem did not like the phrase.
 "Work?"
 "I mean the river erodes."
 "I know that."
 Habib looked at him.
 "Will the river stop because you are angry?"
 Naseem was silent.
 Habib Chacha asked Zainab, "What does your heart say?"
 Zainab said, "We'll go next year too."
 Habib nodded.
 "Go."
 Naseem immediately asked, "Even if there is no place?"
 Habib said, "I am not the one to account for where a dua must be said. But if sitting by the river brings Majid to mind, sit there."
 Naseem said, "And if he comes to mind at home?"
 "Then at home."
 "So place isn't necessary?"
 Habib laughed.
 "You've made me a judge now?"
 Naseem was embarrassed.
 Habib went on, "To me, place matters, and it is not everything either."
 Aaliya was listening from a distance.
 She liked that answer.
 Fewer complete sentences, more half-truths.
 That night Aaliya slept beside her grandmother.
 She asked, "Dadi, did you see Karim Bakhsh?"
 "No."
 "Then why did you go to his grave?"
 "The elders of the house went. I went too."
 "What do you know about him?"

Zainab thought.
 "Little."
 "What?"
 "I heard he was very tall."
 "And?"
 "He knew carpentry."
 "And?"
 "That's all."
 Aaliya laughed.
 "Only that much?"
 "Only that much."
 "Then which is bigger, the grave or the memory?"
 Zainab turned on her side.
 "Did they give you this question at school?"
 "No."
 "Then sleep."
 Aaliya laughed and closed her eyes.
 After a while Zainab herself said, "One more thing about Karim Bakhsh."
 Aaliya opened her eyes.
 "What?"
 "Your grandfather used to say that he hummed while cutting wood."
 "Which song?"
 "I don't know."
 "Did you hear it?"
 "No. Something I heard from others."
 Aaliya added it in her mind: tall, carpentry, humming.
 Three fragments.
 The grave gone.
 Where is a whole person?
 The next day, after finishing her school work, Rubina came to Naseem.
 She had an old cloth bag in her hand.
 "Look at this."
 There were some photographs inside.
 One old black-and-white photograph.
 Four men.
 One child.
 Fields behind them.
 "Who?" Naseem asked.
 Rubina said, "Ma used to say one of them might be Karim Bakhsh."
 "Might be?"
 "Not certain."
 Naseem held the photograph close to his eyes.
 "Which one?"
 "The one on the right?"
 "Why?"
 "Tall."

Naseem laughed.
 "All four are tall."
 Rubina laughed too.
 The photograph yielded no identification.
 Aaliya said, "Anything written on the back?"
 They turned it over.
 Nothing.
 Rubina said, "Should we preserve this as Karim Bakhsh?"
 Naseem answered at once, "No."
 "Why?"
 "It isn't certain."
 Aaliya understood her father's rule.
 Zainab looked at the photograph.
 "This isn't Karim Bakhsh."
 All three were startled.
 "You never saw him."
 "No. But your grandfather used to say that two fingers of his right hand had been cut off. These men have complete hands."
 The hands in the photograph were tiny.
 Again, nothing was certain.
 Naseem laughed.
 "Ma, can you see fingers at this size?"
 Zainab laughed too.
 "Then leave it."
 The photograph went back into the bag.
 The ignorance remained.
 On the third day Naseem went to Salamat Mian, an old carpenter of the village.
 He had been of the same generation as Karim Bakhsh's grandson.
 "Have you heard about Karim Bakhsh's carpentry?"
 Salamat said, "I've heard."
 "What did he make?"
 "Ploughs, bullock carts, doors."
 "Has anything survived?"
 Salamat laughed.
 "Are you going to hunt for a hundred-year-old plough?"
 Naseem was silent.
 "I was only asking."
 "There may be an old doorframe in someone's house."
 "Certain?"
 "No."
 The same again.
 Naseem felt the urge to begin searching.
 Which door was Karim Bakhsh's?
 Which bullock cart?
 Then he stopped himself.
 Why hunt for objects after the grave had disappeared?

Where there was no certainty, desire could turn into proof.
 He went home.
 The river's erosion continued.
 Three weeks later news spread through the village that the two remaining graves in the old family burial ground were also at risk.
 They belonged to dead members of another family.
 The village began discussing it.
 "Something must be done."
 "Move the cemetery."
 "Reinforce the bank."
 "Write to the government."
 Naseem went to the meeting.
 He only listened.
 Someone proposed moving the stones.
 Someone said not to disturb them.
 Someone demanded a river embankment.
 Someone proposed a new cemetery on safer ground.
 Naseem said only one thing: "Let the families of those whose graves still remain decide first."
 The meeting ended.
 On the way home Aaliya asked, "Nothing for our three?"
 "What?"
 "A stone with their names somewhere?"
 Naseem stopped.
 No one in the house had suggested this before.
 "Just a stone?"
 "With the names written on it."
 Rubina, who was walking with them, said, "A memorial?"
 Naseem's mind resisted at once.
 "If there are no graves, why make something like a grave?"
 Aaliya said, "Not like a grave. Only the names."
 Rubina thought.
 "In the courtyard at home?"
 Naseem said, "Will the house become a museum?"
 Aaliya fell silent.
 Rubina said, "The child's question isn't bad."
 "Did I say it was bad?"
 "Your tone did."
 Naseem was silent.
 That night the discussion began again.
 Zainab laughed at the idea of a stone with names.
 "Write Majid's name in the house? Will I forget him?"
 Aaliya said, "What about me later?"
 Zainab looked at her.
 "You will remember as much as you remember."
 "And if I don't?"

"Then you'll read the stone?"
 Aaliya said, "At least the name."
 Zainab said slowly, "A name isn't a bad thing."
 Naseem asked, "Then shall we make one?"
 Zainab said, "I am not saying that."
 The decision was postponed again.
 A few days later Aaliya was making a family tree for a school project.
 She asked her father for the names.
 "Majid, son of Nasiruddin, son of Karim Bakhsh?"
 Naseem laughed.
 "Yes."
 "Karim Bakhsh's father?"
 Naseem was silent.
 Zainab was asked.
 She did not know.
 Neither did Rubina.
 Habib Chacha wanted to make a guess, then said, "Not certain."
 The family tree stopped at Karim Bakhsh.
 Aaliya said, "See, names really do disappear."
 Naseem said, "They do."
 "Then the stone?"
 "That again?"
 Aaliya laughed.
 On the paper she left a blank line above Karim Bakhsh.
 Naseem looked at it.
 The blank line felt strangely right to him.
 Where the name was not known, there should be no guess.
 That blankness too was part of the family history.
 Autumn came.
 The river fell.
 The raw edge of the erosion dried.
 Naseem went alone towards the old burial ground.
 He did not tell Zainab.
 He wanted to find the stump of the jamun tree.
 Nothing.
 The river's bend had changed.
 The water seemed farther away, but the old bank was gone.
 He stopped at a safe distance.
 In his mind he placed the three graves.
 Great-grandfather a little to the north.
 Grandfather in the middle.
 Father to the south.
 Was that true?
 He laughed at himself.
 Perhaps it was the other way round.
 Last year's photograph was on his phone.

He did not open it.
 The exact measure of the graves' direction now seemed less necessary.
 He remembered his father.
 Majid Mian was quiet while drinking tea in the morning.
 His tea was very hot.
 At the first sip he would burn his lips, yet he hardly blew on it.
 Naseem smiled.
 That memory had nothing to do with a grave.
 Then Grandfather Nasiruddin.
 The tin of betel nut.
 If a child asked, half a piece.
 Naseem had been six or seven.
 He had wanted betel nut; Grandfather had refused.
 "Grow up."
 Had Naseem taken some secretly?
 Perhaps.
 Not certain.
 Great-grandfather Karim Bakhsh.
 Three things heard from others: tall, carpentry, humming.
 Three generations.
 Three different densities of memory.
 A full face for his father.
 A few scenes for his grandfather.
 Only fragments heard from others for his great-grandfather.
 The river had taken all three equally, like earth.
 Memory was not equal.
 Here Naseem found a question: had the place itself once made them equal or not?
 Three graves on one strip of land.
 One great-grandfather, one grandfather, one father.
 A dua beside each when they visited.
 The places alike.
 The memories different.
 Now there was no place.
 The difference lay exposed.
 He went home.
 That night Naseem himself raised the proposal of the stone with names again.
 Aaliya was surprised.
 "You?"
 "Listen."
 "Yes."
 "Not like a grave. And not a stone in the house either."
 Rubina asked, "Then?"
 Naseem said, "If there is a need to write the names, write them on paper. But not the names alone."
 Zainab said, "Then what?"
 "One thing each person remembers with certainty."

Rubina smiled.

"A family book?"

Naseem answered at once, "No. Nothing grand."

Aaliya said, "Three pages?"

"Yes. That's all."

Zainab asked, "Why?"

Naseem searched for an answer.

"Because Karim Bakhsh's name may remain later, but almost nothing of the person."

Zainab said, "Can you write a whole person?"

"No."

"Then?"

Naseem laughed.

"As much as is certain."

Three pages were made.

The first: Karim Bakhsh.

They wrote:

"He was tall - something heard from others."

"He knew carpentry - something heard from others."

"He hummed while working - Nasiruddin used to say so; Majid had told Zainab."

Aaliya said, "Such a long path for the source?"

Rubina laughed.

"That's why records are difficult."

Zainab said, "Just write: 'He was said to hum.'"

That was all they wrote.

No photograph.

Because there was no photograph they could identify with certainty.

The second: Nasiruddin.

Naseem wrote, "The tin of betel nut."

Rubina: "Sitting in the sun in Magh."

Zainab: "After namaz he would sit silent for quite a while."

Naseem asked, "Lots of people do those things."

Zainab said, "This is how I remember him."

It was written.

The third: Majid.

Here the page began filling quickly.

Naseem had many things.

Rubina had many.

Zainab more.

Aaliya too.

"Dada grew irritated while teaching me mathematics."

"Dada peeled mangoes so thinly that the peel was almost transparent."

"Dada didn't like the fan running fast."

"Dada would run outside to check the clothes when it rained."

Zainab stopped them.

"Didn't you say three pages?"

Everyone laughed.
 It was hard to keep Majid's page limited.
 At last they made a rule: one thing from each person.
 Naseem: very hot tea.
 Rubina: the old clock kept five minutes fast.
 Zainab: a handkerchief under his pillow while he slept.
 Aaliya: irritation during mathematics, followed by sweets.
 Four things.
 Zainab said, "A dead man reduced to four things?"
 Naseem said, "The grave wasn't the whole man either."
 The room fell silent.
 Zainab nodded slowly.
 "That is true."
 The three pages were not locked away in a trunk.
 Aaliya photographed them on her phone, Rubina kept one copy, and the originals stayed in Naseem's notebook.
 Zainab said, "Why so many copies?"
 Rubina said, "What if one is lost?"
 Zainab laughed.
 "The river can eat paper too."
 Everyone laughed.
 The river's power did not diminish in that laughter.
 Only the family's fear became a little lighter.
 The day came the following year when they used to go to the river.
 Naseem had thought Zainab might forget.
 She was ready in the morning.
 "Let's go."
 Naseem said, "Ma, the bank has changed even farther now."
 "Let's go."
 Rubina came.
 Aaliya too.
 The four of them went again.
 Half of the old path had been cut away.
 The new route ran along the field.
 At one place Zainab stopped.
 "There used to be a ber tree here."
 Naseem said, "Possibly."
 Zainab glared at him.
 "Your 'possibly' is everywhere."
 Aaliya laughed.
 They reached the new riverbank and stood there.
 It was not even the place where they had stood the previous year.
 The bend of the water was different.
 Zainab had not brought a mat to sit on.
 She did not sit on the ground.
 She only stood.

They recited the dua.
 Then remained silent for a while.
 Aaliya asked, "Dadi, does this place feel right?"
 Zainab said, "For whom?"
 "For all three graves."
 Zainab looked at the river.
 "No."
 Aaliya was startled.
 "Then?"
 "There is a river here."
 "Then why did we come?"
 Zainab smiled.
 "So that you could understand."
 "What?"
 "I still feel like coming here."
 Aaliya said, "Even though the place is wrong?"
 Zainab said, "The place isn't wrong. The place has changed."
 Naseem kept listening.
 He asked, "Ma, what if next year you don't feel like coming?"
 "Then I won't come."
 Naseem had not expected that answer.
 "That's all?"
 "That's all."
 Had the journey ceased to be a duty for Zainab?
 Naseem asked, "Then memory?"
 Zainab grew irritated.
 "You people are very fond of the word memory."
 Rubina laughed.
 Zainab said, "Majid comes to mind at home too. Karim Bakhsh doesn't come to mind more just because I come here. Nasiruddin's betel nut comes to mind more in winter sunlight. So why must everything be at the river?"
 No one answered.
 Naseem felt his mother had solved the question.
 Then he realised she had not.
 She had only spoken of her own experience.
 Place still mattered to Rubina.
 Written fragments mattered to Aaliya.
 Certainty and uncertainty in memory mattered to Naseem.
 The family did not arrive at one answer.
 Perhaps arriving at one was not necessary.
 On the way home Zainab grew tired.
 Naseem took her arm.
 She said, "Let go, I can walk."
 A little farther on, she herself took his arm.
 Naseem said nothing.
 Back home, Aaliya took out the three pages again.

"Shall we add something from today?"

Naseem said, "What?"

"Dadi said the place has changed."

Zainab heard from inside.

"Will you write down every sentence I say?"

Aaliya laughed.

"No."

"Then leave it."

The three pages remained as they were.

For the first time Aaliya understood that a document did not have to keep growing.

Some things could remain in speech.

Some on paper.

Some nowhere.

The next year Zainab's knees hurt more.

There was no journey to the river.

No one insisted.

After Eid the family gathered at home.

Food.

Children.

Rubina brought up the old matter.

"Karim Bakhsh used to hum."

Aaliya said, "Which song?"

Everyone laughed. "We don't know."

Naseem said, "Don't invent a song."

Aaliya said, "I know."

Nasiruddin's tin of betel nut came to mind.

Majid's hot tea.

No one mentioned the river.

Yet the three generations were not exactly present in the room; they were present as fragments in memory.

Zainab listened silently.

After a while she said, "One thing about Karim Bakhsh may be wrong."

Everyone looked at her.

"What?"

"That he was tall - was it Majid who said that, or Nasiruddin?"

Naseem said, "You had told us."

"I don't remember whom I heard it from."

Aaliya took out the three pages and looked.

It said: 'He was tall - something heard from others.'

No source was named.

Rubina said, "That's fine. It says it was heard from others."

Zainab was satisfied.

"Then let it stay."

The memory was not made certain.

Its limit was made certain.

Time passed.
 Aaliya went to college.
 Naseem's work in the city grew.
 Rubina retired.
 Zainab's walk became slower.
 The river did its work.
 The remaining marks of the old burial ground disappeared one by one as well.
 The village began using a new cemetery on higher ground.
 The family's three pages remained in the notebook.
 Sometimes they were opened.
 Sometimes not for an entire year.
 One day Aaliya came home during a holiday.
 She said she wanted to go to the river alone.
 Naseem asked, "Why?"
 "I feel like it."
 "The graves?"
 Aaliya thought.
 "Perhaps the river."
 Naseem smiled.
 "Go. Don't go near the edge."
 Aaliya went by the new path.
 She made no attempt to find the exact places of the old graves.
 Although the old photograph was on her phone, she did not open it.
 She sat at a safe, high place beside the river.
 She watched the water.
 Kankar grass.
 A boat.
 Animals in the distance.
 Did Karim Bakhsh come to mind?
 A little.
 The humming whose tune no one knew.
 Nasiruddin?
 The tin of betel nut.
 Majid?
 Many things.
 Not all at once.
 Suddenly Aaliya remembered her grandfather's irritation while teaching her mathematics.
 She laughed.
 Laughter beside the river did not feel strange.
 She recited the dua.
 Not over the exact grave.
 Not even in a direction she could identify with certainty.
 Then she rose and left.
 When she reached home Naseem asked, "How was it?"
 "The river."

"Did you remember the graves?"

Aaliya said, "The people."

Naseem looked at her face.

"Is there a difference?"

"There is."

That was all.

A few years later Zainab was gone.

Her grave was made in the new cemetery.

Far from the river.

On high ground.

Aaliya, Naseem and Rubina were all present.

Earth was given.

The dua was recited.

On the way back Naseem looked towards the distant river.

Rubina said, "Ma wasn't placed near the three of them."

Naseem said, "Where is there a place near the three?"

Rubina wiped her eyes.

"Not a place, I mean..."

The sentence remained unfinished.

Aaliya said, "Dadi is here. They were each in their own place."

Naseem said, "And that place is the river now."

Rubina was silent.

A few months later, when they went to Zainab's grave, Aaliya took the three pages with her.

Naseem asked, "Why?"

"Should we add something about Dadi?"

"What?"

Aaliya said, "I don't know. Perhaps not."

She did not open the pages.

Sitting by the grave, she remembered many things her grandmother had said.

'Did they give you this question at school?'

'The place has changed.'

'You people are very fond of the word memory.'

Aaliya laughed, and she cried too.

Naseem sat silently beside her.

On the way back Aaliya said, "I won't add Dadi to the pages."

"Why?"

"Those three pages were made after the three graves disappeared. Dadi has her own grave."

Naseem said, "If this grave too, someday..."

He stopped the sentence.

Aaliya completed it. "Then we'll see."

They kept walking.

Some things need not be decided in advance.

The rains came again.

The river eroded the bank again.

The new cemetery remained safe.
The site of the old burial ground was now deep water or sand, changing with the year.

Naseem sometimes opened the three pages.
Once the note about his father Majid's 'hot tea' seemed too small to him.
He thought: Is this a memory?
Then he remembered his father's face in the morning.
Majid holding the cup.
Steam.

His lips tightening at the first sip.
Naseem smiled.

A small thing was enough.
A grave had been a large structure.
Memory could be small.
Small did not mean less.

One day Rubina said, "I still feel like going to the old riverbank."

Naseem said, "Go."

"You?"

"Not this time."

"Then place isn't necessary to you?"

Naseem laughed.

"Are you testing me now?"

Rubina laughed too.

"I was only asking."

Naseem said, "Sometimes it is necessary. Sometimes it isn't."

Rubina nodded.

That became the family's last answer.

No manifesto.

No stone.

No new symbolic grave.

The river took the three graves.

The three names remained in the family.

Unequal fragments remained with the names.

One generation almost entirely as things heard from others.

One blurred childhood.

One close memory that felt almost alive.

No one corrected that inequality.

The river had made the places equal.

Memory had not.

And perhaps memory was not greater than place because it saved everything.

It was greater only in this much: even after a place disappeared, something could remain.

Something.

Not everything.

In the end, the family accepted that 'something' as enough.

The Marks of the Flood

Aditi had seen that brown line on the wall since childhood.

She did not know what it meant.

On the north wall of the sitting room, about four and a half cubits above the floor, ran a thin, crooked line.

The limewash beneath it was white.

Above it too, white.

In the middle, a brownish-yellow strip.

As though the painter had forgotten one line.

When Aditi was little, she used to think it marked someone's height.

When she grew older, she understood that no child in the house could have been that tall.

Once she tried to make a mark with a pencil up to the level of her own head.

Grandmother Shanti Devi saw her from a distance.

"Not on that wall."

Aditi asked, "Why?"

"No, not here."

"Whose line is this?"

Grandmother remained silent for a few moments.

Then she said, "The water's."

Aditi did not understand the answer.

How could water make a line on a wall?

She was seven then.

Today she was eighteen.

The house was being repaired.

The roof was to be replaced.

There was damp in the western wall.

The old window-frame had rotted.

The sitting-room wall was to be painted again.

Ganesh the mason set up a ladder and looked at the line.

"Shall I scrape this stain off?"

Aditi's father, Shailendra, said casually, "Yes, clean it completely."

Grandmother heard from the veranda.

"No."

Ganesh stopped his hand.

Shailendra looked towards his mother.

"Ma, this is an old damp stain."

"Not damp."

"Whatever it is, it will look bad under the paint."

"Paint around the line."

Ganesh smiled.

"Leave a strip in the middle?"

Shanti Devi said, "As much as there is, that much."

Shailendra put a hand to his head.

"Ma, the whole house is being done up. Why this stain?"

Grandmother did not answer.

Aditi kept looking at the wall.

For the first time she understood that the line meant more than water.

Otherwise why would Grandmother stop the painting?

Ganesh went to paint another room.

The sitting-room wall was left alone.

In the afternoon Aditi sat beside her grandmother.

"Grandmother, what water?"

Shanti Devi kept untangling yarn.

"The flood's."

"Which flood?"

"Forty-two years ago."

Aditi counted.

"You were....?"

"Your father was eight."

"And you?"

Grandmother laughed.

"Was I younger than your father?"

Aditi laughed too.

"Tell me."

Shanti Devi wound the thread into a ball.

"What shall I tell you?"

"The water came this high?"

"Yes."

Aditi looked at the line.

The ceiling was not very high.

The line was above an adult's shoulder.

"Was everything submerged?"

Grandmother said, "Not everything."

"The house?"

"The house remained standing."

"Then?"

"The water stayed."

Aditi waited.

Grandmother stopped there.

"That's all?"

"What do you want?"

"A story."

Shanti Devi narrowed her eyes.

"It did not feel like a story then."

Aditi fell silent.

She liked the sentence, but did not write it down.

By then she was trying to give up the habit of putting every little thing into her phone.

Grandmother said, "First the water came into the courtyard."

Aditi began to listen.

"How high?"

"To the ankles."

"Then?"

"To the knees."

"Then?"

"The veranda."

"In one day?"

"Two days."

"Where were all of you?"

"Here."

"Here?"

"A platform was built above."

Aditi was startled.

The house had no second storey.

"A platform?"

"Of bamboo. Between the sitting room and the storeroom."

"That high?"

"Above the water."

Aditi looked at the line on the wall.

"The water came up to the line?"

"On the highest night."

Grandmother went back to untangling the yarn.

Aditi asked, "Who made the line?"

"The water."

"You mean someone marked it with a pencil afterwards?"

"No. When the water went down, the stain remained."

"And you never painted it?"

"We did."

"Then how is this still here?"

Grandmother smiled.

"We did not paint over that part."

"Deliberately?"

"Yes."

It seemed like a mystery to Aditi.

"Why?"

Grandmother said, "At the time I thought it would help us remember."

"Remember what?"

"How high the water came."

"And now?"

"Now that you are asking, something more."

Aditi sat upright.

"What?"

Grandmother said, "Ask your father first."

Shailendra was in the outer courtyard discussing the roof with the mason.

Aditi went to him.

"Baba, tell me the story of the flood mark."

Shailendra said irritably, "Now?"

"Yes."

"The mason is standing here."

"Two minutes."

Ganesh laughed.

"I'll listen too."

Shailendra said, "What do I remember? I was eight."

"Whatever you remember."

He thought for a while.

"A red bucket."

Aditi was startled.

"What?"

"A red bucket floating on the water."

"Where?"

"Inside the house."

"And?"

"Babu carried me across the veranda on his back."

"Grandfather?"

"Yes."

"And?"

"Ma was shouting: lift the rice higher, lift the stove higher."

From a distance Shanti Devi called out, "Not the stove, the coal brazier."

Shailendra laughed.

"See? I'm wrong."

Aditi said, "Grandmother is listening."

Shanti Devi said, "If you all speak wrongly, of course I will listen."

Ganesh laughed.

Shailendra continued, "A goat was tied inside."

Grandmother at once said, "The goat belonged to the neighbours."

"Did I say it was ours?"

"Your tone said so."

Aditi burst out laughing.

The story was not opening through one person alone.

Grandmother was correcting it from a distance.

Her father supplied fragments.

Ganesh the mason had stopped work to listen.

Aditi asked, "Do you remember the line?"

Shailendra said, "The line came later."

"During the flood?"

"I remember watching the water on the wall."

"Fear?"

He thought.
 "I don't know."
 "So much water and no fear?"
 "I was a child. Sometimes it felt like a game. Sometimes frightening."
 "When was it frightening?"
 "At night."
 "Why?"
 "The water made noise."
 Grandmother corrected him again: "Not the water. The current outside."
 Shailendra said, "Ma, will you take even my memory away from me?"
 Grandmother laughed.
 "Say what you remember."
 Aditi found that sentence important.
 Say what you remember.
 Correcting facts was one thing; the right to one's memory was another.
 Ganesh the mason said, "Our house too had a flood mark from 2004. We painted it over later."
 Shanti Devi asked, "Why?"
 "My wife said the stain looked bad."
 "Was it bad?"
 Ganesh laughed.
 "A stain is a stain."
 Shailendra said, "Did you hear that, Ma?"
 Grandmother said nothing.
 Aditi looked towards the wall again.
 That day the line had suddenly taken a seat in the middle of the family.
 In the evening Shailendra's younger sister, Madhavi, arrived.
 She lived in Darbhanga.
 She had come after hearing about the repairs.
 As soon as she entered the sitting room she said, "Leave this mark."
 Shailendra put a hand to his head.
 "You too?"
 Madhavi laughed.
 "You like paint that much?"
 "I want the house put right."
 "Will the mark make the house collapse?"
 Aditi asked, "Aunt, what do you remember?"
 Madhavi said, "I was five then."
 "And?"
 "I remember Ma giving me roti on a brass plate, with water underneath."
 From a distance Shanti Devi said, "Not a plate, a leaf-plate."
 Madhavi was startled.
 "A leaf-plate?"
 "Yes. All the plates had been put up high."
 Madhavi laughed.
 "See, my memory has changed."

"What else?"

"Fish through the window?"

Shailendra laughed.

"Fish inside the house?"

Madhavi said irritably, "I was a child."

Shanti Devi said, "Small fish did come into the courtyard."

Madhavi looked triumphant.

"See!"

"Not as far as the window."

"But there were fish."

Aditi laughed.

That night after dinner they placed four chairs in front of the wall and sat there.

As though the line itself were the subject of the sitting.

Shanti Devi said, "The flood stayed in the house for three nights."

Shailendra said, "Four."

Madhavi said, "It felt like five to me."

Grandmother laughed.

"Was the water at the same level in the house every day?"

"The first day, the courtyard."

"The second night, the sitting room."

"The third night, high."

"Then it receded."

Aditi asked, "Is this wall the highest mark?"

"Yes."

"The other walls?"

"Painted over."

"Why was this one left?"

Grandmother said, "This one was clear."

Shailendra said, "And this is the sitting room. People would see it."

Grandmother looked at him.

"Did we leave it so people would see?"

"Then why?"

Grandmother fell silent.

After a long while she said, "After the water went down, I could not believe it had risen this high."

"Seeing the mark made you believe it?" Aditi asked.

"Yes."

"Do you remember the fear?"

"The fear too. But not only the fear."

"What?"

Shanti Devi began counting on her fingers.

"Whose names shall I take?"

"Names?"

"Neighbours."

The story changed at that point.

From the height of the water to people's names.

"On the first night Jabbar Mian came with a boat."
 Aditi asked, "A boat all the way to our house?"
 "Up to the courtyard."
 "What did he bring?"
 "Two sacks of flattened rice, jaggery and medicine."
 Shailendra said, "Medicine for Grandfather?"
 "Yes. He was short of breath."
 "And Jabbar Mian now?"
 "He is no more."
 Madhavi said softly, "His son Salman?"
 "He is here. At the market."
 Shanti Devi continued, "On the second day Phoolkumari Dai threw a rope from her roof."
 Aditi laughed. "Why?"
 "To pull clothes and things up to our roof."
 "Water between the two houses?"
 "The whole lane."
 "And Phoolkumari Dai?"
 "No more."
 One name after another.
 Jabbar.
 Phoolkumari.
 Ramai Kaka, who strengthened the bamboo platform.
 Saraswati Dai, who took shelter in this house with her two children.
 Rashid, who brought a doctor by boat.
 Banwari, who untied the buffaloes and got them to the raised road.
 Madhavi interrupted, "The buffaloes were not ours."
 Grandmother said, "They belonged to three households."
 Shailendra said, "Then the mark is not only the flood of our house?"
 Shanti Devi's face softened.
 "There was one house. There were many people."
 Aditi looked at the line.
 How many people's movements lay beneath that one strip.
 But no one's name was written on the wall.
 No list.
 Only the water stain.
 Aditi asked, "Why didn't you write their names?"
 Grandmother laughed.
 "Is the wall a school notebook?"
 Everyone laughed.
 "Then if no one asks later?"
 "Then no one asks."
 "I am asking now."
 "That is why I am telling you."
 The answer seemed simple to Aditi.
 The mark did not tell the story by itself.

The story opened when someone asked.
 The repairs continued the next day.
 The sitting-room wall was still unpainted.
 Ganesh asked, "Master, what is the decision?"
 Shailendra said, "Ask Ma."
 Shanti Devi said, "Paint the rest, leave the line."
 Ganesh asked, "Shall I make a straight border around it?"
 Grandmother said, "No. Leave it as crooked as it is."
 Shailendra laughed.
 "Half new, old stain in the middle."
 Madhavi said, "Fine."
 Shailendra looked at his sister. "It isn't your house."
 "It is my childhood."
 "On paper?"
 "This isn't about paper."
 A light quarrel between brother and sister.
 Aditi listened.
 The wall was property too.
 It was memory too.
 It was also the cost of paint.
 At noon a new question arose.
 As the mason scraped the wall, a small part of the line flaked away.
 The moment Grandmother saw it, she said, "Stop!"
 Ganesh was alarmed.
 "Ma, I didn't do it deliberately."
 Shanti Devi got up and came closer.
 A white wound in the brown strip.
 She touched it.
 Some colour came away on her finger.
 Aditi thought Grandmother would cry.
 She did not.
 She said, "As much as survives, that much."
 Shailendra was startled.
 "Ma?"
 "It is a wall. It will flake."
 Aditi noticed that Grandmother wanted to preserve the mark, but did not believe it immortal.
 The difference mattered.
 Ganesh carefully painted the remaining surface.
 The line survived, crooked and uneven.
 The fresh white paint made it look darker.
 Now Aditi could see the line more strongly than before.
 In the evening their neighbour Salman came.
 Jabbar Mian's son.
 Shailendra said, "Ma has been telling the story of your father's boat."
 Salman smiled.

"I was little, but I remember the boat."
 Aditi immediately asked, "Did your father bring the flattened rice?"
 Salman thought.
 "I have heard that he brought medicine that night. Wasn't the flattened rice from the panchayat boat the next day?"
 Shanti Devi said, "He brought flattened rice too."
 Salman said, "Could be."
 Grandmother was silent.
 For the first time doubt entered her story from outside.
 Aditi watched Grandmother's face.
 She did not get angry.
 "You were little."
 Salman laughed.
 "That is why I am not saying it for certain."
 Shailendra said, "Ma, maybe the flattened rice came from the panchayat."
 Grandmother said slowly, "Could be."
 Aditi liked that small 'could be'.
 The line was certain.
 All the stories were not.
 Salman looked at the wall.
 "You have still kept it?"
 Shailendra said, "Ma won't let it go."
 Grandmother said, "What is there for me to let go of? It is on the wall."
 Salman laughed.
 "The mark in our house is gone now. Abba had it painted over."
 Aditi asked, "Did he remember?"
 "A lot. He used to say the water came up to the chest."
 "Whose chest?"
 Salman stopped.
 "I never asked that question."
 Everyone laughed.
 Aditi understood that measurements too changed with the story.
 Whose chest?
 An eight-year-old child's?
 An adult's?
 The wall's?
 The line was more reliable, but only for this house.
 That night Aditi began looking through her old photographs.
 Pictures from childhood.
 Some taken in the sitting room.
 The same line in the background.
 She had not noticed it then.
 In one photograph she was five, standing before a birthday cake.
 The line was far above her head.
 In another, Grandmother's seventieth birthday.
 The line behind them.

In another, her father fitting a new television.
 The line behind him.
 The family's ceremonies kept changing; the mark remained a fixed background.
 Aditi wondered: would the photographs be different without that line?
 Perhaps not.
 Would the story be different?
 Perhaps.
 By the third day the paint had dried.
 The sitting room shone white.
 The brown line ran through the middle.
 Shailendra came in and said, "Now it looks even worse."
 Madhavi laughed. "Your eyes will get used to it."
 Aditi asked, "Baba, do you want it removed?"
 "Yes."
 "Why?"
 "So the house looks clean and tidy."
 "Is the mark dirty?"
 "Not dirty. An old stain."
 "What is the difference?"
 Shailendra thought.
 "They are not the same thing."
 "Do you remember the flood?"
 "Some of it."
 "Then?"
 "Memory does not need a wall."
 This was the first time Aditi properly heard that side.
 Grandmother: keep the mark.
 Her father: memory does not depend on a wall.
 Neither was wrong.
 Madhavi said, "Not for memory, for the history of the house."
 Shailendra replied, "History is not greater than the people living in the house.
 What if the stain bothers them?"
 Grandmother was listening from the veranda.
 She said, "It does not bother me."
 Shailendra said, "You are not the only person living in the house now."
 The room fell silent.
 The sentence was harsh, but true.
 Aditi's mother, Kalpana, came into the sitting room too.
 She had been silent until then.
 She said, "The stain does not trouble me. But it is also true that the decision
 should not be Ma's alone."
 Grandmother nodded.
 "All right."
 Aditi was startled.
 She had thought Grandmother would dig in her heels.
 Shanti Devi said, "Then everyone speak."

It became almost a family vote.
 Shailendra: remove it.
 Madhavi: keep it.
 Kalpana: it can be kept, but its edges should be neat.
 Aditi: no decision yet.
 Grandmother: keep it.
 Raghav, Aditi's younger brother, who had until then been outside with a friend,
 entered and immediately asked, "What?"
 Everyone explained.
 He looked at the line.
 "This is from the flood?"
 Everyone said at once, "Yes!"
 Raghav laughed.
 "I thought it was the mark left by an old cupboard."
 The room burst into laughter.
 Aditi was startled.
 The ignorance of the new generation lay open in that one sentence.
 Raghav was sixteen.
 He had been born in the house, grown up there, seen the line every day, and never
 known what it meant.
 "Why did no one tell me?"
 Shailendra said, "When did you ask?"
 Raghav said, "Did Aditi ask?"
 Aditi laughed.
 "When I was seven."
 Raghav went to Grandmother.
 "Tell me."
 Grandmother said, "Again?"
 "I don't know it."
 Grandmother looked at him for a few moments.
 Then she said, "First raise your hand up to the line."
 Raghav raised his hand.
 The line was above his fingertips.
 "That much water."
 His face changed.
 "Really?"
 "Yes."
 "Inside the house?"
 "Yes."
 "And all of you?"
 "On a raised platform."
 "Where was the platform?"
 Grandmother pointed with her hand to the two sitting-room walls.
 "Bamboo here. Planks here."
 Raghav began to imagine it.
 "My bed?"

"You were not even born then."

Everyone laughed.

Raghav asked question after question.

The story began again.

This time Aditi was not only listening; she was correcting too.

"Grandmother, perhaps the flattened rice came on the panchayat boat?"

Shanti Devi stared at her.

"Salman says one thing and now you...?"

Then she laughed.

"Write: not certain."

Raghav asked, "What are you writing?"

Aditi said, "Nothing yet."

She realised that the story changed the moment one began taking notes.

Listen first.

That night Raghav stood before the wall.

He compared his height with the line.

"Above my shoulders."

Aditi said, "Then Grandfather carried my father on his back..."

Shailendra called from a distance, "You're calling me your father?"

"Your Baba."

Raghav laughed.

"I like the fish story."

Madhavi said, "That one is mine."

"Grandmother said there were fish in the courtyard."

"Then it belongs to the family."

A joke about ownership of stories.

By the second week the repairs were almost complete.

The line remained on the sitting-room wall.

Shailendra was still not satisfied.

He suggested a solution.

"Let us write in small letters beside it: 'Flood-water level, 1984'."

Aditi was startled by the date.

"1984?"

Grandmother said, "1987."

Shailendra said, "Oh yes."

Madhavi said, "1987 or 1988?"

The room went silent.

Everyone laughed.

Before making a historical plaque, even the year was uncertain.

Madhavi began searching through papers.

Old newspapers?

A government relief slip?

Shailendra said, "The 1987 flood was very severe."

Grandmother said, "That one."

Raghav wanted to search on his phone.

Aditi stopped him. "For a family event, ask the family first."

The old trunk was opened.
 Papers.
 Land receipts.
 Letters.
 A relief-distribution paper was found.
 The date was faint; the year, 1987.
 Name: Shivnath Jha?
 Shivnath, Shanti Devi's husband.
 The paper mentioned flattened rice, jaggery and kerosene.
 Aditi was startled.
 "Then the flattened rice came as relief?"
 Grandmother looked at the paper.
 "This must have been later."
 Salman's doubt returned.
 Shailendra laughed.
 "Ma, perhaps Jabbar Mian brought the medicine, and the flattened rice came as relief."
 Grandmother was silent for a while.
 "Could be."
 The story was slowly correcting itself.
 Without insult.
 Aditi liked the process.
 Grandmother's memory was not declared weak.
 The paper was not declared the whole truth.
 The two together allowed an inference.
 The year 1987 now seemed nearly certain.
 Shailendra returned to his plaque idea.
 "Now we can write it."
 Grandmother said, "No."
 "Why?"
 "Do not turn the wall into a museum."
 Shailendra laughed.
 "Now you say that?"
 "The line is enough."
 Aditi understood: Grandmother did not want the meaning of the mark fixed in writing.
 Why?
 She asked that night.
 "Would it be bad if we wrote it?"
 Shanti Devi said, "Not bad."
 "Then?"
 "People will read it and move on."
 "And now?"
 "They ask."
 "Will everyone ask?"
 "No."

"Then many people will never know what it means."

Grandmother said, "All right."

"You don't mind?"

"No."

Aditi fell silent.

In Grandmother's view, the value of the mark did not lie in everyone understanding it.

If someone asked, the story opened.

If someone did not, it was only a stain.

Both were fine.

Raghav did not agree with that idea.

He said, "At least put up a little square code so the story opens on the phone?"

The whole family roared with laughter.

Grandmother asked, "What?"

Raghav explained that one could scan it with a phone and read the story.

Grandmother said through laughter, "Will you turn my wall into a shop?"

Aditi laughed too.

But Raghav's suggestion was not completely foolish.

The new generation wanted to keep meaning in its own medium.

Aditi wondered whether to write the story.

The next day she proposed making short audio recordings separately with Grandmother, her father, her aunt, Salman and Raghav.

Shanti Devi refused at once.

"Why my voice?"

"We can listen to it later."

"You listen now."

Aditi lowered the phone.

"All right."

Her father said, "I'll record my voice."

Madhavi said, "So will I."

Grandmother said, "Let them."

After all, the story was not under any one person's control.

Aditi recorded her father and her aunt.

Her first question: "What comes to mind when you see the line?"

Shailendra: "The red bucket."

Madhavi: "The fish."

Second: "What was most frightening?"

Shailendra: "The sound of the water at night."

Madhavi: "When Ma went downstairs leaving me behind."

Shanti Devi, listening from a distance, said, "Leaving you where? You were with your father."

Madhavi laughed.

Grandmother's correction entered the recording as well.

"See? Your voice too."

Grandmother said irritably, "Turn it off."

Aditi turned it off.

A short recording of Salman.
 He said, "I remember Abba's boat, but I will say less about what I only heard."
 That caution had value.
 A short recording of Raghav.
 "I used to think the line was the mark left by a cupboard."
 The newest point of view.
 Aditi did not record her own voice.
 Her memory was not of the flood.
 Her memory was of the line.
 That was a different story.
 A month later there was a small meal, almost like a house-warming.
 In truth, it had always been the same home; only the repairs were complete.
 Family, neighbours, and a few older people came.
 The brown line stood out clearly on the white sitting-room wall.
 Some guests asked, "Was this patch left unpainted?"
 At first Shailendra gave an embarrassed laugh.
 Then he said, "The flood mark."
 The questions began.
 "Which year?"
 "1987."
 "The water came this high?"
 "Yes."
 "Inside the house?"
 "Yes."
 Shanti Devi listened silently from the veranda.
 An elderly neighbour, Mahendra Kaka, said, "Seven families spent the night in this house then."
 Grandmother immediately said, "Not seven, five."
 Mahendra said, "I remember seven."
 Shailendra asked, "Who all?"
 The counting began.
 The Jha family.
 Saraswati Dai's family.
 Two members of Banwari's household.
 Jabbar's children?
 Mahendra said, "Jabbar's family was on another roof."
 Grandmother said, "So five."
 No one reached a conclusion.
 The guests laughed.
 Aditi saw the mark making a story again.
 Exactly like this.
 Perhaps differently, year after year.
 An elderly woman said, "I remember a lamp floating against this wall."
 Grandmother laughed.
 "A lamp on the water? Your story has grown."
 The woman said, "Then I must have seen something shining."

"Maybe a bowl."
 "Maybe."
 Memory opened.
 Aditi wanted to record the voices.
 Then she remembered Grandmother's words: you listen now.
 She did not take out her phone.
 After the meal Raghav stood in front of the line.
 "Didi, this story could go viral."
 Aditi laughed.
 "No."
 "Why?"
 "Let the story stay in the house."
 The moment she said it, she stopped.
 Like Grandmother?
 She thought: there was nothing wrong if the story went outside.
 But just then she had no desire to make it public immediately.
 Let it belong to the family for some time.
 Raghav said, "You have become old-fashioned."
 "Maybe."
 Winter came.
 The line now lay steady on the dry wall.
 One day Aditi's friend Neha came.
 The moment she saw the line in the sitting room she asked, "What is this?"
 Aditi said easily, "A flood mark."
 "This high?"
 "Yes."
 "When?"
 "1987."
 "Did you see it?"
 "No. I wasn't even born."
 "Then how do you know?"
 Aditi smiled.
 "I've heard the story."
 "Certain?"
 "The water line is certain. Some parts of the story less so."
 Neha laughed.
 "What kind of answer is that?"
 "An accurate one."
 Aditi liked her own answer.
 A few weeks later Shanti Devi fell ill.
 An ordinary fever.
 Then she recovered.
 One night during the illness Aditi was beside her.
 Grandmother said, "Will you keep the line?"
 Aditi was startled.
 "You are fine."

"I am asking about the line, not death."
 Aditi felt embarrassed.
 "I don't know."
 Grandmother laughed.
 "That is the right answer."
 "Do you want us to keep it?"
 "For now, yes."
 "Later?"
 "If the house becomes yours, it will be your decision."
 "But this house is Baba's..."
 "Whoever it belongs to, theirs."
 "And the memory?"
 "Whoever it belongs to, theirs."
 Aditi was silent.
 Grandmother said next, "I am asking you to preserve the mark, not the wall."
 "What is the difference?"
 "What if the wall falls?"
 Aditi had no answer.
 Grandmother said, "Whether the story remains then will depend on all of you."
 For the first time Grandmother separated the story from the mark.
 Aditi stayed awake for a long time.
 A year passed.
 The repairs no longer looked new.
 Dust had settled on the white paint.
 Parts of the line had faded.
 Raghav left for college.
 So did Aditi.
 Grandmother and Aditi's parents remained in the house.
 When Aditi returned for the holidays, she found a new cupboard set against the lower part of the wall.
 The cupboard covered a small section of the line.
 She said at once, "Why is this here?"
 Shailendra said, "This is where there was space."
 "It covers the line."
 "Half a foot."
 Aditi became irritated.
 Then she stopped herself.
 Grandmother laughed from the veranda.
 "Now you want the stain?"
 Aditi smiled.
 "Maybe."
 Grandmother said, "Don't move the cupboard. A house is for use."
 Aditi was startled.
 "You?"
 "Let as much of the line show as shows."
 Grandmother's insistence had changed.

The mark was not a sacred object.
It had to adjust to the use of the house.
To Aditi this felt like a deeper lesson, though she did not want the word 'lesson' in her mind.

Two years later there was heavy rain.
The village flooded, but the water did not enter the house.
Everyone looked once at the line.
Raghav said on the phone, "Don't let a new mark be made."
Shailendra laughed.
"No."

Grandmother said, "Keep the drain by the door clear."
A story from the past became practical instruction for the present.
Shailendra cleared the drain.
The water drained away.
Aditi thought: the line was not only memory; it was also a warning about how water moved around the house.

But Grandmother had never used such words.
She only said, "Do not block the path of water."
That was all.

Three years later Shanti Devi was no more.
There was no long illness.

One winter night.
The family gathered.
After the funeral rites the house slowly returned to ordinary life.
The same line remained on the sitting-room wall.
One day Aditi stood alone before it.
Grandmother's voice came back to her.

"The water's."

"As much as there is, that much."

"You listen now."

"A house is for use."

Aditi did not want the line suddenly to become a memorial to Grandmother.

It was, first of all, a flood mark.

Grandmother had been one carrier of its meaning.

Aditi deliberately kept that distinction.

A year later Shailendra again raised the matter of repainting.

"This time?"

Aditi smiled.

"As you wish."

Shailendra was surprised.

"You don't object?"

"If you paint over it, the story will not disappear."

Madhavi, who was there, said, "I object."

Everyone laughed.

The family debate began again.

Shailendra: "The wall is flaking."

Madhavi: "Leave the line."
 Kalpana: "As far as technically possible."
 Aditi: "Ask the mason first."
 Deepak, Ganesh the mason's son, came.
 Ganesh now did less work.
 Deepak examined the wall.
 "The old plaster is loose. The paint will not hold unless it is all removed."
 Madhavi's face fell.
 "The line?"
 "It is on the plaster. If the plaster comes off, it will go."
 The room fell silent.
 This time the question was not beauty but structure.
 Leaving loose plaster merely to save the line would not be in the house's interest.
 Aditi remembered Grandmother's sentence: a house is for use.
 Shailendra said, "Then remove it."
 Madhavi said, "One minute."
 She took a photograph.
 So did Aditi.
 Raghav asked for a video on the phone.
 Deepak climbed the ladder.
 The scraper touched the line.
 Suddenly Aditi's throat tightened.
 She thought: it is only a stain being removed, why this much?
 Then Grandmother's voice: what if the wall falls?
 The first piece flaked off.
 Part of the brown line disappeared.
 Then another.
 Within a few minutes all the old plaster had come off.
 No line.
 The rough brick face of the wall.
 Madhavi wiped her eyes.
 Shailendra touched his sister's shoulder.
 No one said, 'It is nothing.'
 It was something.
 Aditi looked at the pieces of plaster that had fallen to the floor.
 One piece carried a strip of brown.
 She wanted to pick it up.
 She stretched out her hand.
 Then stopped.
 What would she preserve?
 Plaster?
 A stain?
 Memory?
 She did not pick up the piece.
 Madhavi picked up a small one.
 Aditi did not stop her.

Each person's decision was different.
Deepak applied new plaster.
The wall was white again.
The line was gone.
For the first week the room felt unfamiliar.
Raghav came home during the holidays.
The moment he saw the wall he said, "It feels empty."
Shailendra laughed.
"Shall we make a cupboard mark now?"
Everyone laughed.
Aditi told Raghav Grandmother's old story again.
Raghav interrupted, "The fish were in the courtyard, not up to the window."
Aditi laughed.
"You remember?"
"Yes."
"And Jabbar Mian and the flattened rice?"
"Perhaps the relief boat."
"Right."
The story was continuing without the line.
A few years later there was a new child in the house: Raghav's daughter Sana.
She was three.
Running through the sitting room, she drew a line on the wall with a pencil.
Raghav shouted, "Hey!"
Aditi laughed.
"Let it stay."
Shailendra said, "No, the paint is new."
Kalpana took a cloth and wiped it off.
The pencil line disappeared.
No one turned it into history.
Not every mark was worth preserving.
That seemed right to Aditi.
One evening at a family meal Sana asked, "What is a flood?"
She had seen a picture at school.
Raghav said, "A lot of water."
Sana asked, "Did it come into our house?"
Raghav looked at Aditi.
Aditi smiled.
"A long time ago."
"How high?"
Raghav raised his hand and indicated roughly the old height on the wall.
"This high."
Sana's eyes widened.
"The mark?"
Raghav stopped.
"It used to be there."
"Where?"

The white wall.
 No brown line.
 Aditi said, "About here."
 She traced a crooked line in the air with her finger.
 Sana looked up.
 "I can't see it."
 "It isn't there now."
 "Then is it true?"
 The room fell silent.
 Aditi laughed.
 "Yes. There are photographs of the mark. And many people remember the story."
 Sana asked, "Grandmother?"
 Raghav said, "Your great-grandmother remembered it very well."
 "Where is she?"
 Another door into a new story opened.
 Aditi understood: the new generation had once not known the meaning of the mark; now there was no mark at all.
 The meaning would have to reach them through the story.
 That was harder.
 But not impossible.
 She did not tell Sana about the platform, the red bucket, the fish, the boat, the flattened rice, the medicine and the rope all at once.
 Only the first thing:
 "Once, water rose above shoulder height inside your great-grandmother's house."
 Sana asked, "Was she afraid?"
 Aditi stopped.
 She did not remember Grandmother's answer.
 Her father had said that for a child it had been both a game and a fear.
 She did not want to invent anything.
 She said, "I am not certain. When your grandfather comes, we'll ask him."
 Raghav laughed.
 "My Baba?"
 "Yes. He was eight then."
 Sana was excited.
 "I'll ask him."
 The story was deferred to the next person.
 That felt right to Aditi.
 The wall was white now.
 The old water mark was gone.
 But the drain was kept clear.
 During the rains, rice was not kept low.
 Shailendra still spoke of the red bucket.
 Madhavi still insisted on the fish.
 Salman said Jabbar Mian had brought the medicine; the matter of the flattened rice was not certain.
 In Madhavi's trunk lay a small piece of plaster bearing the brown strip.

Aditi had photographs on her phone.
In Raghav's memory there was first 'the cupboard mark', and later the flood.
For Sana there was, for now, only a crooked line drawn in the air.
Year after year, the mark had become a story.
Then one day it disappeared from the wall.
For the first time, the story truly became the family's responsibility.
Aditi remembered Grandmother's old sentence:
"You listen now."
She understood that perhaps the whole meaning of this story was only this much.
Listen first.
Then say what is certain.
If something has changed, accept that it has changed.
And what no longer survives on the wall, do not force back onto the wall.

The Abandoned Well

The village's old well had been closed for fifteen years.

Closed did not mean filled in.

Two thick stone slabs lay over its mouth.

Between them was a narrow gap, like a place left for breathing.

Moss covered the slabs.

A peepal root ran along one side.

An old iron pulley stood there, half eaten by rust.

No rope.

No bucket.

No water visible.

At night sounds came from near that well.

Nitya first heard this from her grandmother, Kamala Devi.

Nitya studied at university and had come to the village for the holidays.

She was interested in old houses, wells, ponds, and shrines.

But her interest was more in their dimensions, construction, and use than in people's stories.

How wide.

How deep.

How old the bricks were.

From what period the parapet dated.

On seeing the well, the first thing she asked was -

"When was it closed?"

Grandmother said, "About fifteen years ago."

"Why?"

"Piped water came."

"That was all?"

"The water had gone bad too."

"Was it tested?"

"It must have been."

Nitya smiled.

Grandmother's 'must have been' seemed an incomplete answer to her.

She wrote in her notebook: 'Closed: about 15 years; reasons - piped water, bad water.'

She added a question mark.

Grandmother saw it.

"Have you caught a disease of writing everything down?"

"I'll forget."

"Forget some things too."

Nitya laughed.

That evening the electricity went out.

The courtyard was dark.

The sky was clear.
 A dog barked in the distance.
 Somewhere, a calf's bell sounded.
 Kamala Devi was sitting on a cot.
 With the fan stopped, Nitya came outside.
 Just then a 'tann' came from the direction of the old well.
 Once.
 Then a faint scraping rustle.
 Nitya raised her head.
 "What was that?"
 Grandmother said, "The well."
 "Did the stone move?"
 "The wind."
 Again, 'tann'.
 Nitya stood up.
 "Shall we go and see?"
 Grandmother said, "What will you see at night?"
 "What's making the sound?"
 Kamala Devi said calmly, "Not water."
 "Then?"
 "People's names."
 Nitya burst out laughing.
 "Nani!"
 Kamala Devi did not laugh.
 "What?"
 "How can a sound be a name?"
 "You won't understand."
 "Why?"
 "Your ears do not carry enough of the names of this place."
 Nitya thought of picking up her notebook.
 Then, seeing her grandmother's face, she did not.
 The sounds came again during the night.
 Sometimes the metallic tann.
 Sometimes the dry leaves rubbing, ghass-ghass.
 Sometimes a hollow resonance from within.
 Nitya kept listening.
 She heard no name.
 The next morning she went to the well.
 The stone slabs were still.
 At one corner, an old iron ring was loose.
 When the wind blew, the ring struck the slab.
 'Tann.'
 Nitya smiled.
 "A name?" she said softly.
 The ring struck again.
 Only metal.

She called her grandmother.

"Look, the sound comes from here."

Kamala Devi came over.

"Could be."

"Then what about people's names?"

"Did you ask what causes the sound, or what I hear in it?"

Nitya paused.

"They're different?"

"Very."

Kamala Devi sat beside the slab.

"Once this well was open."

"I know."

"No, you don't."

Nitya laughed.

"All right, tell me."

Kamala Devi began pointing around the well with her finger.

"There used to be a large stone platform here."

"A neem tree on this side."

"Ropes would be spread there to dry."

"At dawn Kamala Dai would be the first to come."

Nitya interrupted, "You're Kamala, and she was Kamala too?"

"Not me. Another one."

"Who?"

"Kamala Musaharni."

"And?"

"Razia."

"Phoolmati."

"Gulabo."

"Sakina."

"Saryu."

"Malati."

"Champa."

The names began to come out one by one.

Nitya began counting.

"So many people every day?"

"Not everyone every day. It depended on the day."

"To draw water?"

"Water, clothes, talk, quarrels, news."

Nitya smiled.

"A well or a meeting place?"

"Call it the women's meeting place."

Kamala Devi laughed.

"Men came too, but mornings and evenings this place was mainly for women."

Nitya asked, "How do names enter the sounds?"

Grandmother looked towards the ring.

"The moment I hear this tann, Kamala Musaharni comes to mind."

"Why?"

"The hook on her brass bucket would strike like that."

Nitya said at once, "Then it is sound-memory."

Kamala Devi was annoyed.

"Does everything need a name?"

"No."

"Now listen to the scraping."

The wind blew.

Dry peepal leaves rubbed against the slab.

"And this?"

Kamala Devi closed her eyes.

"Razia."

"Why?"

"She brought a broom made of dry date-palm fronds. First she swept around the well, then she drew water."

"Is she alive?"

"No."

"Kamala?"

"No."

Nitya stopped asking questions.

Grandmother continued drawing out names.

One sound did not always mean one name.

Sometimes that same tann brought Phoolmati.

Sometimes Gulabo.

Nitya asked, "Are you sure?"

"Who can be sure about memory?"

"Then saying people's names..."

Kamala Devi said, "I am telling you what I hear."

Nitya opened her notebook.

"May I write it?"

"Write, but write only as much as I said."

"Not my interpretation?"

"That is yours."

Nitya wrote -

"Grandmother: 'The sounds of the well at night are not water; they are people's names.'"

Then below it -

"Tann = sometimes Kamala Musaharni; scraping = Razia; not fixed."

Kamala Devi looked at the notebook.

"'Not fixed' - that you've written correctly."

That day Nitya began asking neighbours about the well.

First, Sakina Khatoon.

She was about seventy-two.

She said, "When I was married into this village, for the first month I spoke to no one at the well."

"Why?"

"Shyness."

"Then?"

"Kamala Dai asked, 'Do you have salt at home?'"

"That was all?"

"Friendship through salt."

Sakina laughed.

"Was that Kamala Musaharni?"

"Yes."

"Nani says she hears her name in the sounds at night."

Sakina was silent for a moment.

Then she said, "Kamala used to bang down her bucket very hard."

Nitya laughed.

"So Nani's account matches?"

"Does it match, or is your mind making it match?"

Nitya paused.

Sakina said, "Do not reach conclusions quickly in matters like these."

Nitya liked that sentence.

The next day she met Vimala, Phoolmati's daughter.

Phoolmati had died.

Vimala said, "Mother used to sing at the well."

"Which songs?"

"Many."

"Any lines?"

"I am not sure now."

"Nani sometimes remembers Phoolmati in the sounds."

Vimala laughed.

"Mother was rarely quiet."

That was all.

Nitya realised that she was turning her grandmother's names into a project of verification.

She stopped herself.

This was not a court.

Memory could be examined, but it did not have to be proved.

That night Nitya carried out an experiment.

She placed her phone near the well.

She started an audio recording.

Then she sat with her grandmother in the courtyard.

Half an hour.

Metallic sounds.

Leaves.

A distant train.

The cry of an owl.

A dog.

Then a hollow humming sound, like 'oonn'.

Grandmother said, "Did you hear?"

"Yes."

"Saryu."

"In that?"

"Yes."

"Why?"

"She used to hum while drawing water."

"That sounds like wind."

"Could be."

"Then Saryu?"

"Could be."

Nitya smiled.

The next day they listened to the recording.

Grandmother too.

Inside the phone's tiny acoustic space, the night sounded flat.

Tann.

Scrape.

Oonn.

Nitya asked, "Any name now?"

Kamala Devi listened for a long time.

"No."

Nitya was startled.

"Yesterday you said Saryu."

"Yesterday it was night."

"The recording has the same sound."

"How is it the same?"

"This is it."

Grandmother shook her head.

"The phone keeps the sound. It does not keep the night."

Nitya fell silent at that sentence.

She resisted the urge to write it down.

Grandmother said, "Now you hear only metal?"

"Yes."

"So do I."

"Then the name?"

"It may come again tomorrow."

For the first time Nitya understood: her grandmother was not claiming that a spirit's voice had been captured in the recording.

She was only describing her own experience of hearing.

That distinction changed the whole story.

There was talk in the village of filling in the well.

A panchayat meeting was called.

The reason was safety.

The stone slabs were old.

Some children climbed on them to play.

The peepal roots were breaking the parapet.

One man said, "Fill it completely with earth."

Another said, "It is historic; preserve it."

A third asked, "Whose history?"
 A fourth said, "Put a new iron grille over it."
 Nitya sat in the meeting.
 Grandmother did not go.
 She said, "Whatever you do, make it safe."
 Nitya asked, "You do not want to save the well?"
 "What do you mean by save?"
 "Do not fill it."
 "What if it is dangerous?"
 "Then?"
 "Should people stay alive, or should the well?"
 Nitya was silent.
 Grandmother had no romantic answer.
 At the meeting they discussed the well's old use.
 Which families had used it, and since when.
 Whose land it stood on.
 Whether the papers described it as public or private.
 There was argument.
 Finally it was decided that an engineer would inspect it first.
 The inspection took place the following week.
 The well's parapet was weak.
 The water was now very far below.
 It could not be declared fit for use without testing.
 It did not need to be filled in completely, but a strong grille and a low protective wall were necessary.
 The peepal roots needed to be controlled.
 Children's access had to be prevented.
 Nitya heard the report and told her grandmother.
 Kamala Devi said, "Good."
 "If a grille is put on it, the sound will change."
 "Let it change."
 "The names?"
 "Do names depend on a grille?"
 Nitya laughed.
 Meanwhile Nitya learned something else.
 The well had not only been a place for water; it had been a place for news.
 Sakina said, "When a child was born in someone's house, often the first news spread at the well."
 Vimala said, "When a letter came from someone's in-laws."
 Malati Dai said, "When someone's cow fell ill."
 Razia's daughter-in-law said, "When there was a quarrel in someone's field."
 Someone said, "When someone's husband returned from the city."
 Someone else, "When someone's daughter passed an examination."
 Nitya asked, "Where did the men get their news?"
 The answer was: the crossroads, shops, fields, mosque, temple, market.
 The women had their own network.

The well had been one of its centres.
 The meaning of 'people's names' began to become clearer to Nitya.
 The sounds at night did not open only dead people in her grandmother's ears.
 Living people too.
 One night, hearing a tann, Grandmother said, "Shakuntala."
 Nitya asked, "Has she died?"
 "No. She is in Delhi with her son."
 Nitya was startled.
 "Then the names are not only of the dead?"
 Grandmother stared at her.
 "When did I ever say the dead?"
 Nitya was silent.
 She herself had turned the story into a memory of the dead.
 "What did Shakuntala do?"
 "While pulling the bucket, she held the rope between her teeth. I scolded her a lot."
 "Why?"
 "Her teeth would break."
 They both laughed.
 Nitya wrote: 'Names = absent and living too.'
 Then she struck out the word 'absent'.
 Because to Grandmother, Shakuntala was not wholly absent.
 She could be called on the phone.
 Nitya asked, "Shall we speak to Shakuntala Dai?"
 Grandmother said, "Call her."
 The call connected.
 Shakuntala was in Delhi.
 Her voice was old, but sharp.
 Grandmother said, "Do you remember the well?"
 Laughter came from the other end.
 "Are you going to tell my teeth story again?"
 Kamala Devi burst out laughing.
 Nitya was surprised.
 Shakuntala already knew.
 "Did you really hold the rope in your teeth?"
 "Many times."
 "Why?"
 "Greed - I wanted to fill two buckets at once."
 "And Nani scolded you?"
 "Kamala scolded everyone."
 Kamala Devi said, "Lies."
 All three laughed.
 Nitya realised that a tann in the night had built a bridge all the way to Delhi.
 But she did not write that sentence in her notebook.
 It sounded too beautiful.
 That was why she did not.

She was wary of decorating the story.
 On the day the grille was to be installed, the old slabs were removed.
 The mouth of the well was fully opened for the first time in many years.
 A safety rope was put up, with people standing around.
 Nitya looked from a distance.
 Darkness inside.
 Far below, a faint gleam of water.
 The smell of dampness.
 Old brick and stone in the walls.
 Roots in one corner.
 Nitya felt a thrill.
 Kamala Devi did not come.
 "You will not look?"
 "I have seen it enough."
 "It has opened after fifteen years."
 "Has the well become new?"
 Nitya was silent.
 The worker said the old pulley should be removed.
 It was rusted through.
 Nitya was about to object.
 Then she remembered Grandmother's words: make it safe.
 The pulley was no longer fit for use.
 The panchayat decided to preserve one part of it, but disable it from turning.
 The ring was replaced.
 A strong iron grille was installed.
 A lock.
 A low protective wall was rebuilt all around.
 The stone slabs were removed.
 So was the source of the old night-time 'tann'.
 On the first night after the grille was installed, Nitya and her grandmother sat in the courtyard.
 The wind blew.
 Leaves.
 A distant vehicle.
 The grille made a faint 'jhann'.
 Nitya smiled.
 "A new sound."
 Kamala Devi listened.
 She said nothing.
 Again, jhann.
 Nitya asked, "A name?"
 "Not yet."
 "Why?"
 "A new sound needs a place."
 Nitya laughed.
 "Even a sound has to settle in the village?"

"You laugh too much."

On the second night, at a jhann, Grandmother said, "Renu."

"Who?"

"Your mother."

Nitya was startled.

"Mother is alive in Patna."

"So?"

"Did she draw water at this well?"

"When she was little. Very rarely."

"Then why Mother at this new sound?"

Kamala Devi's face changed slightly.

"The day the grille was installed she asked on the phone, 'Did you fill the well completely, or did you save it?'"

Nitya was silent.

The name was now connected not only with sound but also with what had happened that day.

Grandmother's system broke again.

Perhaps there had never been a system.

Nitya asked, "Then the sound is an excuse?"

Kamala Devi smiled.

"Could be."

"And the name is the real thing?"

"Could be."

They both laughed.

Gradually Nitya opened her notebook less often.

She listened more.

Sometimes Grandmother said a name.

Sometimes she did not.

Sometimes Nitya herself guessed, 'Sakina?'

Grandmother said, "No."

"Phoolmati?"

"No."

"Then?"

"Nothing."

Not every sound had a name.

That seemed important to Nitya.

One night there was a great deal of wind.

Peepal leaves, the grille, a distant tin roof, an animal's bell - all sounded together.

Kamala Devi said, "A market tonight."

Nitya laughed.

"Where are the people's names?"

"With this many sounds, whose name can one hear?"

They both went inside.

Winter came.

There were fewer nights of sitting by the well.

Nitya prepared to return to the city.

Before leaving, she went to look through old panchayat papers.
 The exact year in which the well had been built was not known.
 One repair was recorded in 1956.
 Another in 1978.
 Use had declined after the piped-water scheme.
 One water test showed a high bacterial count.
 Nitya wrote the facts in her notebook.
 The household accounts and her grandmother's stories went on separate pages.
 She did not want to combine the two into a single 'correct' history.
 Facts had their place.
 Memory had its own.
 On the day she was leaving the village, Nitya went to the well.
 Dawn.
 No night-time sounds.
 Dew on the grille.
 Darkness below.
 Kamala Devi came up behind her.
 "Taking leave?"
 "From the well?"
 "From me too."
 Grandmother laughed.
 Nitya asked, "Nani, what if someday this well is filled in?"
 "Then they will fill it."
 "The names?"
 Kamala Devi thought for a while.
 "Are people's names locked inside the well?"
 "You used to say the sounds held names."
 "The sound changed. Did the names disappear?"
 "No."
 "Then?"
 Nitya was silent.
 Kamala Devi said, "A place helps. But a place is not the only home of a name."
 Nitya wanted to write that sentence down.
 She did not.
 For several weeks after returning to the city, Nitya kept listening to the night recording.
 The old tann.
 The new grille's jhann.
 Leaves.
 The owl.
 The distant train.
 She heard no names.
 Sometimes Shakuntala Dai came to mind.
 Sometimes it was only metal.
 Once, her mother's name.
 Was it because Grandmother had said it, or because of the sound?

Hard to say.

She played the recording for a friend.

Her friend said, "These are just ordinary night sounds."

Nitya said, "Yes."

"Then?"

"Nothing."

She did not tell the story.

Because without the place, without Grandmother, without the history of the names, the recording truly was ordinary.

Two months later Grandmother phoned.

"Yesterday children were playing near the well."

"Was the grille safe?"

"Yes."

"Then?"

"One girl called her friend by name - 'Ruchi!'"

Nitya laughed.

"Is that another name from the well?"

Kamala Devi said, "This time I really heard it."

They both laughed.

A living name had been spoken again beside the old well.

No mystery.

No ghost.

One girl was calling another girl.

Nitya was happy about that.

A few months later she returned to the village.

The low wall around the well was clean.

There was no rust on the grille.

The peepal had been trimmed and kept under control.

The panchayat had installed a small stone marker: 'Old Public Well - Closed for Safety.'

Nitya read the plaque.

No year.

No names.

That seemed right to her.

Why should an entire history fit on a plaque?

Kamala Devi was sitting nearby.

Nitya asked, "Do names still come at night?"

"Sometimes."

"Whose?"

"Yesterday, Gulabo."

"Gulabo Dai?"

"Yes."

"Why?"

"Gulabo's grandson came with a wedding invitation."

Nitya burst out laughing.

"Nani! That is daytime news!"

"Names have many roads."

This time Nitya did not argue.

She had understood by then: Grandmother was not teaching acoustics.

She was describing the way her own memory worked.

That night the two of them sat there again.

Jhann.

Nitya was silent.

So was Grandmother.

Then, from a distance, a woman called out, "Sakina Chachi!"

Sakina was alive, sitting on the veranda of her own house.

Kamala Devi smiled.

"Did you hear?"

Nitya said, "This time it is definitely a name."

After a while the grille moved again.

Jhann.

No name came to Nitya.

She did not feel that anything was missing.

Not every sound needs a story.

Nor does every name need a sound.

At night, the well was simply a well.

And sometimes, in the ears of those sitting beside it, the whole village opened up.

Dried Maize Leaves

When the Kartik wind began to blow, the dry maize leaves rattled.
 Harinarayan Mahato stopped his hand.
 He was standing on the ridge of the field.
 His granddaughter Chanda was ahead, cutting the dry stalks.
 Behind them, his son Naresh was tying bundles.
 The crop had not been bad that year.
 The maize had been fair enough.
 The grain had already reached the house.
 Only dry stalks and leaves remained in the field.
 Some for fodder.
 The rest to be left to rot into the soil.
 Chanda laughed again and said, "Dada, listen to this sound."
 Deliberately, she ran her hand over a dry leaf.
 Kharr-kharr.
 Harinarayan's face changed.
 Chanda stopped laughing.
 "What happened?"
 Harinarayan did not answer.
 The wind blew again.
 Hundreds of dry leaves sounded together.
 Khad-khad.
 Kharr.
 Phuss.
 In that ordinary sound Harinarayan saw the empty tethering post in the cowshed.
 A yellow bullock.
 Its ribs visible enough to count.
 Its name - Hira.
 Then the sound again.
 A woman with the end of her sari drawn over her mouth.
 Her name - Saguni Kaki.
 Then the sound again.
 A teenage boy with a bundle of dry leaves on his back.
 Himself.
 Very young.
 Chanda touched her grandfather's arm.
 "Shall we sit?"
 Harinarayan sat down on the field ridge.
 Naresh left his work and came closer.
 "Babu, are you dizzy?"
 "No."
 "Then?"

Harinarayan looked across the field.
 "The leaves sounded."
 Naresh laughed.
 "Leaves will sound."
 Harinarayan looked at him.
 "Yes."
 That was all.
 Naresh returned to his work.
 Chanda did not.
 She remained sitting beside her grandfather.
 "Who was Hira?"
 Harinarayan was startled.
 "How do you know?"
 "You said the name softly."
 Harinarayan had not realised the name had come out of his mouth.
 With a finger he scratched at the earth.
 "A bullock."
 "Yours?"
 "My father's."
 "When?"
 "In the year of the famine."
 Chanda was silent.
 She had read the word famine in books.
 She had rarely heard it from her grandfather's mouth.
 "Which year?"
 Harinarayan shook his head.
 "Don't count it."
 "Why?"
 "I was thirteen or fourteen."
 "You aren't sure of the year?"
 "It will be in the records."
 "And for you?"
 "The sound is certain."
 The wind blew again.
 Harinarayan closed his eyes.
 That year the maize had stopped growing while it was still green.
 The leaves yellowed from the top.
 Then turned brown.
 The stalks grew thin.
 The cobs only half formed.
 The kernels shrivelled.
 The rains came late at first.
 Then barely came at all.
 The water in the well fell low.
 The pond became mud.
 Paddy was transplanted in only half the fields.

Even where it was planted, the soil cracked.
 Maize remained the last hope.
 Then that too dried up.
 Harinarayan said, "The leaves used to sound exactly like this."
 Chanda looked towards the field.
 "But this year's crop is already harvested."
 "Now the sound belongs only to the leaves."
 "And then?"
 Harinarayan said, "Then, the moment you heard it, your stomach came to mind."
 Chanda did not understand.
 "Your stomach?"
 "There was little grain in the house."
 There were five people in Harinarayan's household in that famine year.
 His father, Ramsevak.
 His mother, Devkala.
 His grandmother.
 Harinarayan.
 His younger sister, Phoolo.
 Two bullocks - Hira and Moti.
 A cow - Birni.
 And a heifer.
 Whose needs came first - the people's?
 Or the animals?
 The question was never once spoken aloud in the house.
 But every day it had to be answered.
 Who should get the fodder?
 How much straw was left?
 There was no paddy straw.
 The dry maize leaves had now become fodder.
 The leaves Naresh today intended to leave to rot into the soil were then counted one by one.
 Harinarayan said, "I used to cut the leaves and carry them home."
 Chanda asked, "Did the bullocks eat them?"
 "When hungry, they ate many things."
 "Nutrition?"
 Harinarayan laughed.
 "Your education has spoken."
 Chanda laughed too.
 "They must have been poor in nutrition."
 "They were. That was why Hira grew thin."
 Hira was a yellow bullock.
 Moti was white.
 Their names did not match their colours.
 His father would say, "Do you name someone only after looking at colour?"
 Hira was calm.
 Moti was stubborn.

As the months of famine lengthened, the ribs of both began to show.
 Ramsevak would place bundles of leaves before them.
 Moti ate quickly.
 Hira slowly.
 Harinarayan fed him small pieces by hand.
 "Did that save him?" Chanda asked.
 Harinarayan was silent.
 "No."
 Hira died before Paush.
 There was no exact date.
 Morning.
 Cold.
 He lay in the cowshed.
 Ramsevak had tried to raise him all night.
 By morning his breathing stopped.
 Harinarayan said, "What I remember first is the sound."
 "Which sound?"
 "The dry leaves."
 "Not Hira's?"
 Harinarayan looked at his granddaughter.
 "By the end Hira made very little sound."
 Chanda was silent.
 The wind stopped.
 The field fell completely still.
 Harinarayan could not decide whether this silence weighed more heavily on him
 than the sound had.
 He said, "People quickly make the memory of a dead animal small."
 "Why?"
 "They say - it was a bullock."
 "But?"
 "The household ran because of him."
 Ramsevak ploughed the fields with them.
 The cart.
 The market.
 Hauling paddy.
 Carrying goods for weddings.
 Hira and Moti were not merely animals; they were a working pair.
 When Hira was gone, Moti was alone.
 A plough could not be worked with one bullock.
 Ramsevak had to borrow a neighbour's bullock.
 Sometimes one was available.
 Sometimes not.
 Half the work remained undone.
 Naresh had been listening from a distance.
 He came closer.
 "Talking about Hira?"

Harinarayan said, "Do you remember him?"
 "You've told me about him."
 "What?"
 "That he died during the famine."
 "That's all?"
 Naresh was silent.
 Harinarayan laughed.
 "See?"
 Chanda asked, "What?"
 "A story shrinks and shrinks until it becomes one sentence."
 Naresh said, "I can only tell what I heard."
 Harinarayan nodded.
 "Right."
 He did not blame Naresh.
 How could someone remember what he had never heard?
 Harinarayan said again, "Moti survived."
 "How?"
 "He was sold."
 Chanda was startled.
 "Sold so that he could survive?"
 "So that the household could survive."
 Ramsevak took Moti to the market.
 During a famine, bullocks fetched little.
 There were few buyers.
 Whatever money they got was spent on grain.
 Harinarayan had been angry then.
 Angry with his father.
 "Hira died, and you sold Moti too."
 Ramsevak had said, "Should I feed your sister or the bullock?"
 It was a harsh sentence.
 But a year of famine brought harsh questions.
 For several days Harinarayan barely spoke to his father.
 Chanda asked, "Did you understand later?"
 "When I grew older."
 "Then?"
 "Then I would remember Moti's eyes."
 He had not wanted to go to the market.
 Ramsevak pulling the rope.
 Moti repeatedly turning towards the house.
 Did Harinarayan remember that scene for certain?
 He stopped himself.
 "Perhaps I added to it later."
 Chanda asked, "What?"
 "That Moti kept turning towards the house - I am not certain."
 "Then?"
 "I am certain that Father held the rope."

Chanda noticed this correction her grandfather made.
 It was easy to add an animal's eyes to a memory.
 Harinarayan did not want to add them.
 The wind again.
 The leaves rattled.
 Harinarayan's face changed once more.
 This time it was a person.
 "Saguni Kaki," he said.
 Chanda had heard the name before.
 From the old hamlet of the village.
 "Who was she?"
 "She worked as a farm labourer."
 "For our house?"
 "For everyone's."
 Saguni Kaki was a widow.
 One son had gone to Punjab.
 In those days, saying Punjab made it seem very far away.
 A letter now and then.
 Money now and then.
 During the famine year there would be no news of her son for months at a time.
 Saguni Kaki looked for labour.
 There was hardly any work in the fields.
 Whose field was there to plough?
 Whose crop was there to harvest?
 No work meant no wages.
 Sometimes Ramsevak gave her the task of cutting fodder for the household.
 Sometimes Devkala gave her grain.
 Saguni would say, "I will not take it without work."
 Devkala would say, "Does food ask about work before entering the stomach?"
 The two would quarrel.
 Chanda laughed.
 "A quarrel like that?"
 "In a famine, pride too fights with hunger."
 One day Saguni was tying dry maize leaves into bundles.
 The wind was strong.
 The leaves kept blowing away.
 Irritated, she said, "There is no work among the living, so now I must fight dead leaves."
 Harinarayan had heard her from a distance.
 He remembered that sentence even now.
 Certain?
 Yes.
 Because he had repeated it to his mother when he returned home.
 His mother had laughed.
 The following week Saguni fell ill.
 Fever.

Cough.
 Her appetite, already poor, declined further.
 Some said the famine killed her.
 Some said the fever.
 Some said an old illness.
 Harinarayan said, "I do not know what killed her."
 Chanda grew serious.
 "A death certificate?"
 "How would I have known about such things then?"
 "You can say, 'She died during the famine.'"
 "Yes. Not 'she died from the famine.'"
 Chanda nodded.
 The distinction was small, but necessary.
 On the day Saguni died, a cartload of grain came to the village.
 Government grain or a trader's?
 Harinarayan was not certain.
 A queue formed.
 On one side, people waited for grain.
 On the other, there was mourning at Saguni's house.
 In his memory, both scenes belonged to the same day.
 Perhaps they were on different days?
 Harinarayan stopped.
 "There may have been a difference of a day or two."
 Chanda said, "Then don't say it was the same day."
 Harinarayan laughed.
 "It is difficult to tell a story with you beside me."
 "We shouldn't write something wrong."
 "Who said we were writing anything?"
 They both laughed.
 Naresh began tying bundles again.
 He was not much in the habit of listening to stories.
 Stopping work made the day longer.
 But his ears were listening.
 Harinarayan said, "I do not know the number of people who died during the famine."
 "How many?" Chanda asked.
 "I don't know."
 "In the village?"
 "Some."
 "Who?"
 Harinarayan searched for names.
 Saguni.
 Lkhan Das's child?
 No - did that child survive?
 Harinarayan stopped.
 "Only as much as I know for certain."

Chanda said, "Saguni Kaki."
 "Yes."
 "And?"
 "Old Rambadan."
 "Who was he?"
 "He lived outside the hamlet."
 Did Rambadan die of hunger?
 Not known.
 He was very old.
 He died in the midst of the famine.
 Harinarayan did not want to put his name on a list of 'famine dead'.
 Because the cause would be an assumption.
 "Then is Saguni the only human memory?"
 Chanda asked.
 "No. There were those who did not die too."
 The memory of famine was not filled only with the dead.
 There were more living people in it.
 Devkala.
 Ramsevak.
 Phoolo.
 Harinarayan himself.
 Their neighbour Jabahir Mian.
 Nanki Dai.
 Basudev Kaka.
 Kishori Sahu.
 And the things all of them did.
 Sharing food.
 Hiding fodder.
 Raising prices.
 Extending credit.
 Refusing credit.
 Migration.
 Returning home.
 Each was a different story.
 Chanda asked, "Jabahir Mian?"
 "He had straw."
 "A lot?"
 "It seemed like a lot then."
 Jabahir Mian had sold his two cows as soon as the famine began.
 People had called him a coward.
 Later, his straw remained.
 He gave fodder on credit to three households in the village.
 To Ramsevak too.
 Hira was still alive then.
 Two bundles of straw.
 "Money?"

"Later."

"Was it paid?"

"Father paid him a year later."

"How much?"

"I don't know."

Why did Jabahir's name sometimes come with the sound of the leaves?

Because the dry straw in his storehouse sounded just like this in the wind.

Harinarayan had been a child.

Lifting the bundles.

Dust in his nose.

Stinging in his eyes.

But happiness in his mind - Hira would eat.

The sound of leaves was not only death.

Sometimes it was relief.

At this point Chanda said, "Then why does the sound frighten you?"

Harinarayan said, "It does not frighten me."

"Your face changed today."

"Memory is not a single colour."

"You remembered a dead animal."

"The living too."

Harinarayan stood up.

He straightened his knees.

"Come on, let's work."

Chanda said, "And the story?"

"Along with the work."

He began tying a bundle.

Chanda separated the dry leaves.

Harinarayan noticed that she was gathering even very small pieces.

"Why so much?"

"Fodder."

"They won't eat all of it."

"I'll chop it and mix it."

Harinarayan smiled.

"Education again."

"Useful education."

The day advanced.

The wind eased.

The rattling of the leaves diminished.

Harinarayan himself cut a dry stalk.

When he crushed a leaf in his hand, it made a sound.

This time, Phoolo.

His younger sister.

Phoolo had been eight years old in the famine year.

She did not die.

She lived for many years.

Marriage.

Children.
 Then death in old age.
 But in the memory of the famine she was always eight years old.
 One day Phoolo ate half a roti and hid the other half.
 Their mother caught her.
 "Why?"
 Phoolo said, "For tomorrow."
 Did Devkala cry?
 Harinarayan was not certain.
 He remembered his mother's face, not tears.
 Devkala said, "Tomorrow's roti will be dealt with tomorrow."
 She gave the half roti back to Phoolo.
 Did Phoolo eat it or not?
 Harinarayan's memory was blurred.
 Hearing this, Chanda asked, "Did Phoolo Dadi remember this?"
 "I never asked."
 "Ever?"
 "No."
 "Why?"
 Harinarayan was silent.
 Some questions are not asked while there is still time.
 Later, the person who could answer is no longer there.
 Chanda looked at her grandfather's face.
 "Do you regret it?"
 "Sometimes."
 "Did she talk about the famine?"
 "Very little."
 "Why?"
 "She would say - it is gone."
 Harinarayan would say, "I remember."
 Phoolo would say, "Let it remain remembered. Why open it every day?"
 Brother and sister used memory differently.
 One opened it.
 One kept it closed.
 Both were right.
 Chanda said, "You open it."
 Harinarayan laughed.
 "The leaves open it."
 "And if the leaves do not sound?"
 "Then something else will."
 Memory does not have only one key.
 The smell of earth.
 Dry leaves.
 The bell of a bullock.
 An old sack.
 Winter sunlight.

Sometimes nothing at all.
At noon Naresh opened the food container.
Roti.
Potato and chickpeas.
Onion.
Chanda gave her grandfather two rotis.
Harinarayan handed one back.
"One for now."
Chanda laughed. "There is no famine now."
Harinarayan looked at her.
Then he laughed too.
"All right. Give me two."
He ate both.
Chanda did not make a note of this small moment.
Harinarayan himself noticed it.
Habits from a famine sometimes survive even when the stomach is full.
Taking less roti.
Picking up grains of rice with the broom.
Not throwing away stale food.
Measuring out an animal's fodder.
Naresh sometimes became irritated by all this.
"Babu, there is no shortage now."
Harinarayan would say, "Shortage does not ask before it comes."
Chanda asked, "Is that a lesson from the famine?"
Harinarayan said, "Lesson is not the word."
"Then?"
"Habit."
After eating, they sat in the shade.
Chanda asked her grandfather about the sky in the famine year.
"How hot was it?"
"Hot."
"Clouds?"
"They would come, but not rain."
"Did people pray?"
"A lot."
"And work?"
"That too."
"The government?"
Harinarayan thought.
"Some grain."
"Relief?"
"I understand that word now. Then I understood sacks."
Chanda smiled.
"What grain?"
"Wheat, perhaps."
"Maize?"

"I don't remember."

"How much?"

"No."

Chanda stopped asking questions.

The complete economic history of the famine was not in her grandfather's memory.

She would have to search for that in papers, records, and old newspapers.

What she would get from her grandfather was the history of the body.

Thirst.

Hunger.

Dust.

Fodder.

The sound of leaves.

One day Ramsevak had sent Harinarayan to a distant hamlet to ask for dry pigeon-pea stalks.

Three kos on foot.

An empty sack.

On reaching there he learned that they had already been distributed.

He returned with the sack empty.

Dry maize fields along the road.

Wind.

Leaves sounding.

Harinarayan felt as if all the fields were laughing at his empty sack.

He said that sentence now.

Then stopped.

"Did it truly feel like that then, or am I making a story of it now?"

Chanda asked.

Harinarayan thought.

"While telling it now, it feels like laughter. Then it was probably anger."

"Then I won't write 'laughing'."

"So you are going to write it after all?"

"Perhaps."

Harinarayan laughed.

"Show it to me first."

"All right."

By afternoon, one part of the field was cleared.

Dry leaves in bundles.

Some stalks cut.

Some left in the soil.

Chanda said, "Shall we give this bundle to the cowshed?"

Naresh said, "For our cow first."

"And if there is some left?"

"Then."

Harinarayan was listening.

He remembered Jabahir from the famine year.

He said, "Our own animal first, and then we share whatever remains."

Chanda looked at her grandfather.
"A famine rule?"
"A household rule."
It was an ordinary thing.
It did not need to become a story.
When they returned home in the evening, Lali the cow sniffed the bundle.
She did not eat it.
Naresh said, "See? She will not eat these leaves on their own."
Chanda chopped them and mixed them with green Napier grass.
Lali began to eat.
Harinarayan watched.
He remembered Hira.
Where was green fodder then?
There was very little.
One day Ramsevak had brought grass from a distant marshy patch.
For Birni the cow.
Birni's milk had fallen.
The child Phoolo needed milk in the house.
So many decisions.
Whose stomach first?
The relationship between people and animals was not a simple story of love.
Use.
Dependence.
Affection.
Compulsion.
All at once.
At dinner Harinarayan said, "When Hira died, his hide..."
Then he fell silent.
Chanda did not ask.
Some details are not necessary.
A story of famine is not a competition to intensify sorrow.
Harinarayan changed the subject.
"Birni survived."
"The cow?"
"Yes."
"For how long?"
"Many years."
"After the famine too?"
"She calved."
There was more milk in the house again.
Phoolo grew older.
The rains were good the following year.
The fields grew green again.
People said - the famine was over.
But where did a famine ever end completely?
Debt.

A sold bullock.
 Dead animals.
 Young men who had left home for the city.
 Bodies made ill.
 Habits.
 Memory.
 All remained behind.
 Harinarayan said, "Rain arriving does not make an end-date for a famine."
 For the first time in the conversation, Naresh spoke seriously. "Father paid those debts for several years, didn't he?"
 "Yes."
 "To whom?"
 "Sahuji. Jabahir. Others."
 "Records?"
 "Someone may have them."
 Naresh said, "I had only heard that Grandfather did not mortgage the land."
 "He pledged half the field's produce in advance."
 "I didn't know that."
 New information passed between father and son.
 Chanda listened silently.
 The story was not travelling only from grandfather to granddaughter.
 The son too was hearing some things for the first time.
 Naresh asked, "Why did you never tell me?"
 Harinarayan laughed.
 "Did you ask?"
 All three laughed.
 The next day Chanda went alone to the field.
 There was no wind.
 The dry leaves were silent.
 Deliberately, she shook one leaf.
 Kharr.
 Hira came to mind.
 She had never seen Hira.
 The memory was not hers.
 Then what was it?
 A story heard from her grandfather.
 She said to herself, "This is not my memory."
 Saying the sentence brought a slight relief.
 A story may pass from generation to generation, but it does not become one's own experience.
 She did not photograph the leaf.
 She sat in the field for a while.
 The sounds of the village.
 A farm vehicle in the distance.
 A child.
 A cow.

The life of the present.
 In the evening she told her grandfather, "I remembered Hira."
 Harinarayan smiled.
 "See?"
 "But I didn't remember him - I remembered your story."
 Harinarayan was silent for a few moments.
 Then he said, "You put that correctly."
 "Is there a difference?"
 "There is."
 "How much?"
 "A great deal."
 He did not explain the distinction.
 There was no need.
 A few days later, the village held a meeting about animal fodder.
 There was no famine that year, but the rains had been scanty.
 People wanted to take precautions.
 Storing straw.
 A common fodder area.
 Cutting and preserving maize residue.
 Naresh wanted to mention Harinarayan's old famine story at the meeting.
 Harinarayan stopped him.
 "Make policy, not my story."
 Naresh was surprised.
 "Experience is useful."
 "Say what is useful - store fodder beforehand. Why use Hira's name?"
 Naresh nodded.
 Practical matters went before the meeting.
 Do not waste dry leaves.
 Keep stored fodder dry.
 Separate spoiled fodder.
 Advice from the veterinary doctor.
 Harinarayan's private memory did not become a public speech.
 That felt right to him.
 That night Chanda opened her notebook.
 She had been thinking of writing the story.
 She wrote the title - "Dried Maize Leaves."
 Then a line beneath it - "In the famine year, the rattling of leaves awakens
 memories of dead animals and people."
 She stopped.
 The line was too neat.
 Her grandfather's story was not so neat.
 The dead animal - Hira.
 The dead person - Saguni.
 But between them Moti had been sold.
 Birni survived.
 Phoolo hid half a roti.

Jabahir gave straw.
 Ramsevak took debts.
 Devkala divided food.
 An empty sack.
 Dry leaves.
 Chanda did not cross out her opening sentence.
 Beneath it she wrote, "The story is not only about the dead."
 Then she closed the notebook.
 She decided to show it to her grandfather.
 The next day Harinarayan read it.
 Slowly.
 "'The dead person - Saguni' - will you write that?"
 "You told me."
 "Write that she died during the famine. Not that she died from the famine."
 Chanda corrected it.
 "Hira?"
 "Died in the famine?"
 Harinarayan thought.
 "There was a shortage of fodder. But there may have been illness too."
 "Then?"
 "Write: Hira died in the famine year. I am not certain of the cause."
 Chanda corrected it again.
 Her grandfather's memory resisted simple causes.
 The famine was the background.
 The medical cause of every death was not certain.
 That honesty did not make the story less sad.
 Harinarayan read on.
 "You didn't write that Moti turned towards the house?"
 "You aren't certain of it."
 "Right."
 "Phoolo's roti?"
 Harinarayan was silent.
 "You may write it. But she lived. Her permission is no longer available."
 Chanda asked, "She has died."
 "Does that make permission automatic?"
 Chanda thought.
 "No."
 "Phoolo did not like public stories."
 "Then should I not write it?"
 "You may tell it within the family. If you are going to publish it, think."
 Chanda marked the passage in her notebook.
 The question of the right to write was separate from the memory of famine, but it was necessary.
 She left the decision for later.
 Harinarayan said, "Write about Jabahir's straw."
 "Why?"

"The moment people say famine, they will write only about the dead. Who will write about the one who shared?"

Chanda smiled.

"Is that the main point?"

"There is no single main point."

Again, the same resistance.

A resistance to binding one story to one meaning.

By Margashirsha the maize field had been completely cleared.

Bundles of dry leaves lay beneath the cowshed eaves.

Some were chopped for the animals.

Some went into the soil.

Some for fuel?

The house now used gas.

Not a hearth like Devkala's.

Harinarayan touched one bundle.

The leaves were quiet now.

The wind did not reach them.

He did not deliberately shake them.

He did not want to open memory.

Chanda noticed.

"Dada, no sound today?"

"I don't want one."

Chanda nodded.

Some days memory may remain closed.

One Paush night, Lali the cow chewed leaves in the cowshed.

Dry leaves went kharr-kharr between her teeth.

Harinarayan heard it while lying on his cot.

Hira came to mind.

But this time, alongside him, was the sound of Lali's stomach being filled.

Past and present in the same sound, but not the same thing.

He got up and went to the cowshed.

Lali was eating.

The water bucket was full.

There was enough straw.

Harinarayan ran a hand over her.

No return of a dead animal.

Only a living animal.

He smiled.

Naresh came behind him.

"What happened?"

"Nothing."

"Why are you outside in the cold?"

"Lali is eating."

Naresh laughed.

"She eats every day."

"Exactly."

They both went inside.
By spring, the dry leaves had diminished.
The fodder was used up.
The rest had rotted into the soil.
Preparations began for the new crop.
Chanda returned to university.
One day Harinarayan went to the field alone.
Almost none of the old maize leaves remained.
The field had been ploughed.
The soil had been turned.
He sat on the ridge.
No sound.
Hira?
He did not come to mind.
Saguni?
No.
Phoolo?
No.
Only sunlight.
Harinarayan felt relieved.
The dead had not disappeared merely because memory was not arriving.
Remembering all the time is not reverence.
Sometimes forgetting, sometimes rest.
He returned home.
The rains were good the following year.
The maize was green.
Chanda came home during the holidays.
She went to the field with her grandfather.
Green leaves rustled softly in the wind.
Chanda asked, "This sound?"
Harinarayan listened.
Not the dry rattle.
A soft susurration.
"Different."
"Do you remember the famine?"
Harinarayan said, "Not now."
"Why?"
"The leaves are green."
Chanda laughed.
"That's all?"
"That's all."
A few months later these same leaves would dry again.
Then the sound would change.
Perhaps memory would return.
Perhaps not.
Harinarayan was no longer uneasy with that uncertainty.

The famine year did not live inside him only as one rattling sound.
It survived in many small habits.
Do not throw away roti.
Think of the animals' fodder beforehand.
Repay credit on time.
Do not bind a death to a cause by guesswork.
When you tell someone's story, respect its limits.
And when the leaves sound, sometimes listen.
Sometimes keep working.

The Last Boat

On the day the bridge opened, Ramdhani the boatman sat alone in his boat for the first time.

There is a mistake in that sentence.

He had sat alone many times before.

At dawn.

At noon.

Late at night.

After tying up the boat.

In a gentle breeze.

Before a storm.

But on all those occasions the empty boat had been waiting.

That day, the waiting was over.

The bridge had opened.

A red ribbon.

Drums.

Schoolchildren.

People from the panchayat.

An officer from the district.

Garlands of flowers.

Motor vehicles on both sides.

People were saying, "Now crossing the river will be easy."

Ramdhani too said, "Good."

No one had asked him.

Still, he said, "Good."

The bridge truly was good.

Safe in the rains.

Lights at night.

Faster for the sick.

Easier for children going to school.

Goods from the market.

Wedding vehicles.

Everything easier.

Ramdhani's boat had been difficult.

Timing according to the water.

Fear in the rains.

Waiting in the sun.

Only a limited number of people at a time.

Loading an ox was a separate trouble.

Mind the bicycle.

Keep the sacks apart.

A child would cry.

Some old woman would insist on getting off in the middle of the river.
 Arguments over the fare.
 Ramdhani knew all these difficulties.
 So how could he oppose the bridge?
 He did not.
 On the first evening after the bridge opened, he went to the ghat.
 The boat was tied.
 He untied the rope.
 He lifted the oar.
 And crossed the river.
 No passenger.
 He did not get down on the other side.
 He turned the boat.
 Then came back.
 Two crossings.
 Then home.
 His wife, Gita, asked, "Was there anyone?"
 "No."
 "Then why did you go?"
 Ramdhani said, "I rowed the boat."
 Gita thought he was joking.
 She laughed.
 Ramdhani did not.
 The same thing happened the next day.
 One crossing at dawn.
 One in the evening.
 On the third day, two in the morning.
 None in the evening.
 On the fourth day, one.
 Passengers: zero.
 Fare: zero.
 The boat kept moving.
 Ramdhani's son Dinkar said, "Babu, it may not burn fuel, but it burns time."
 Ramdhani said, "The boat does not burn fuel, true."
 Dinkar laughed.
 "I am talking about time."
 "Who eats time?"
 "You do."
 Ramdhani's face hardened.
 Gita intervened. "Do not quarrel."
 Dinkar had trained in electrical work in the town.
 For a few days he had also worked as a labourer on the new lighting poles of the bridge.
 He was pleased with the bridge.
 "Babu, this bridge is good for all of us."
 Ramdhani replied at once, "It is good."

"Then leave the boat."
 "If the bridge is good, does that make the boat bad?"
 Dinkar fell silent.
 The question was not difficult, but with his father it was difficult.
 Ramdhani was sixty-two.
 Forty years on the river.
 First with his father.
 Then alone.
 His father, Nathuni, had been a boatman.
 Nathuni used to say, "Do not look at the river. Read it."
 As a boy Ramdhani would laugh.
 "Where are the letters?"
 Nathuni would point out the colour of the water.
 "These are letters."
 The direction of the foam.
 The circle of a whirlpool.
 The grass on the bank.
 Clouds.
 Wind.
 The slap-slap against the belly of the boat.
 "Read all this."
 Ramdhani learned to read it.
 School up to class five.
 The river for forty years.
 When the bridge opened, Nathuni was not there.
 He had died long before.
 Ramdhani wondered: if Babu had been alive, what would he have said?
 He did not invent an answer.
 It is easy to put one's own words into the mouths of the dead.
 He did not do it.
 During the first week after the bridge opened, people walked across it out of excitement.
 The ghat was empty.
 Some children looked down at the boat from the bridge.
 "Ramdhani Kaka!"
 He would raise his hand.
 "Any passengers?"
 "No."
 "Then?"
 The children laughed.
 So did he.
 Two weeks later the bridge had become ordinary.
 People crossed by the bridge and scarcely looked at the boat.
 Ramdhani kept rowing.
 Morning mist.
 Cold water.

The first push of the oar.
The boat leaving the bank.
At that moment his body worked by itself.
Right hand.
Left shoulder.
The distance between the feet.
The bend of the waist.
If the current was strong, change the angle.
In midstream, lighten the oar.
Watch the sand on the far bank.
To stop doing this was not merely to leave a livelihood.
It was to abandon a language of the body.
Ramdhani could not put that into words.
He simply rowed.
One day an old passenger, Bhola Sah, came to the ghat.
Ramdhani was delighted.
"Going across?"
Bhola laughed.
"No, I came to look at the field here."
"All right."
Bhola looked at the boat.
"Still rowing?"
"Yes."
"Does anyone get in?"
"Sometimes."
That was a lie.
Since the bridge opened, no one had boarded and paid a fare.
At once Ramdhani felt uneasy inside.
He added, "Not yet."
Bhola said, "Someday tourists will get in."
Ramdhani understood the word but not the thought.
"For a ride?"
"Yes."
"My boat is not a swing."
Bhola laughed.
Ramdhani did not.
The work of his boat was to take people across.
Not to give rides.
But the work of taking people across had ended.
That contradiction irritated him.
One evening Gita asked, "Shall we sell the boat?"
Ramdhani stopped with a morsel in his hand.
"To whom?"
"A fisherman might take it."
"This is not a fishing boat."
"A boat is a boat."

"No."

Gita fell silent.

She knew argument was useless at that moment.

The household income had fallen.

Dinkar earned.

They had a small field.

Two goats.

Gita went to work sorting makhana.

There was no hunger.

But Ramdhani's fares had stopped.

He had no money of his own.

Earlier there had been the day's coins, notes, credit, change.

Now he had to look towards Dinkar's hand.

One day, when he asked for five rupees for soap, he did not feel insulted, only hollow.

Dinkar gave it naturally.

The problem was not Dinkar.

It was inside Ramdhani.

He kept rowing.

Slowly people in the village began joking.

"Owner of an empty boat."

"A boat under the bridge."

"Ramdhani's exercise."

Sometimes Ramdhani laughed.

Sometimes he did not.

One boy said, "Kaka, do ghosts ride it?"

Ramdhani stared at him.

"You are alive. Will you ride?"

The boy stepped back in fright.

Then Ramdhani laughed.

"Double fare."

Everyone laughed.

There was no ghost in this joke.

Ramdhani did not row at night.

Earlier, if there had been a passenger, he would.

Now there was no reason.

Only mornings and evenings.

One day the schoolteacher Kusum brought the children to the ghat to see the river.

She was teaching them about the structure of the bridge.

The children ran towards the boat.

"Kaka, can we get in?"

Ramdhani said, "Permission from the school?"

Kusum smiled.

"If it is safe."

Ramdhani turned serious at once.

"Life jackets?"

Kusum said, "We do not have any."

"Then no."

The children were disappointed.

Kusum asked, "Do you still row it?"

"Yes."

"Why?"

Ramdhani looked for an ordinary answer.

"So the boat does not rot."

"By rowing it?"

"The wood stays aired, the joints show themselves, you see where water is coming in."

The answer was half true.

Kusum nodded.

"All right."

She asked the children the names of the parts of the boat.

No one knew.

Ramdhani began explaining without being asked.

"This is the oar."

"This is the bow."

"This is the stern."

"This is the middle plank."

"This is the ring for tying the rope."

A child asked, "How do you know the path in the middle of the river?"

Ramdhani looked at the water.

"The path does not stay fixed."

"Then?"

"Watch the current."

"How?"

Ramdhani moved his hands to explain.

Kusum listened carefully.

She said, "Next time, if we bring life jackets, will you give the children a short lesson?"

Ramdhani caught on the word.

"Lesson?"

"Not rowing the boat. Understanding the river."

Ramdhani did not answer at once.

"We'll see."

That night Gita asked, "What was the schoolwoman saying?"

"Children."

"What about them?"

"Seeing the river."

"Good."

Ramdhani fell silent.

Teaching the river seemed strange to him.

His father had taught him the river.

Whom would he teach?
 Then he thought: his father too must have learned from someone.
 No answer.
 A month later water began seeping through the bottom of the boat.
 Ramdhani immediately pulled the boat ashore.
 The crack was small.
 Earlier this work had been done by a local carpenter, Ghuran.
 Ghuran had died.
 His son made furniture, not boats.
 Ramdhani began the repair himself.
 Dinkar helped.
 "Babu, this boat hardly carries anyone, and still you spend on it?"
 "It moves."
 "Without passengers."
 "Does a boat become a boat because of passengers?"
 Dinkar was irritated.
 "What is its work?"
 Ramdhani did not answer.
 Cotton in the crack, tar, a thin strip of wood.
 Dinkar kept helping in silence.
 When the work was finished, Ramdhani said, "Thank you."
 Dinkar was startled.
 "Babu, what language is this?"
 They both laughed.
 The next morning the boat was back in the water.
 Ramdhani deliberately checked the crack.
 Dry.
 He was pleased.
 No passenger.
 Still, the work had succeeded.
 Meanwhile there was an accident on the bridge.
 A two-wheeler skidded.
 People said, "See? The boat was safer."
 Ramdhani objected at once.
 "Have there never been accidents in boats?"
 Everyone fell silent.
 Ramdhani did not like using the bridge's failure to glorify his boat.
 He knew boats had capsized.
 People had drowned.
 He himself had narrowly escaped twice.
 An old means is not sacred.
 A new means is not flawless.
 Both are means.
 The rains came.
 The river rose.
 The bridge remained open.

Traffic continued.
Ramdhani kept the boat tied for three days.
The current was too strong.
Dinkar joked, "No passengers, then whom are you afraid for?"
Ramdhani was serious.
"If the boat sinks, the boat will be lost."
On the fourth day the water fell.
He untied the boat.
One evening crossing.
In midstream he passed beneath the shadow of the bridge.
Above, the sound of motors.
Below, the oar.
Two worlds at once.
Ramdhani did not look up.
He watched the current.
The bridge piers had changed the flow.
He had to learn that anew.
Earlier the midstream current had run one way.
Now there was a whirlpool behind the pier.
Change the boat's angle.
Should Ramdhani resent the new bridge, or learn from it?
He learned.
For two weeks he watched the current behind the pier at different water levels.
One day teacher Kusum came again.
This time with four children and life jackets.
Permission from the panchayat.
Dinkar too.
Ramdhani was surprised.
"You?"
Dinkar said, "Maa said children should not go alone."
Gita laughed from a distance.
Ramdhani inspected the boat.
Rope.
Bottom.
Oar.
Life jackets.
Four children.
Kusum.
Dinkar.
Ramdhani.
Seven in all.
He calculated the load.
"All right."
The boat pushed off.
The children were excited.
Ramdhani said, "You need not stay silent, but do not all lean to one side."

The boat left the ghat.
 As they reached beneath the bridge, he did not stop the oar, only slowed it.
 "Look at the water."
 The children looked.
 "There's nothing."
 "Look closely."
 A girl said, "Here it is going round and round."
 "A whirlpool."
 "Why?"
 Ramdhani pointed at the bridge pier.
 "It obstructs the water's path. The water turns behind it."
 "Is it dangerous?"
 "Depends on its size."
 He turned the boat at a safe distance.
 "Has the river changed?"
 "When the bridge was built, the current changed a little."
 Kusum asked, "Your old route?"
 "The route is new."
 Ramdhani heard himself as he said the sentence.
 The route is new.
 It did not sound bad to him.
 He showed the children the colour of the banks, the wind, the clouds, the movement of the water.
 No one was allowed to row.
 The lesson lasted fifteen minutes.
 Then back to the ghat.
 Kusum wanted to pay.
 Ramdhani refused.
 "It is for the school."
 Kusum said, "For your labour."
 Ramdhani paused.
 Dinkar looked at his father.
 Ramdhani took half the amount.
 "This much."
 Back home he gave the money to Gita.
 Gita smiled.
 "Passengers?"
 Ramdhani said, "Students."
 "What's the difference?"
 "A lot."
 They both laughed.
 After that Kusum wanted to bring children once a month.
 Ramdhani made clear rules.
 No life jackets, no trip.
 If the rain was heavy, no.
 If the wind was bad, no.

Not too many children.
 One adult with them.
 No one would be allowed to row.
 Not beyond the ghat stretch.
 Kusum agreed.
 Did Ramdhani's boat begin carrying people again?
 No.
 Four or five children once a month.
 Teaching.
 Sometimes a small honorarium, not a fare.
 On the other days Ramdhani was alone again.
 He continued rowing the empty boat.
 Why?
 Now his answer was somewhat clearer.
 Exercise for the body.
 Maintenance of the boat.
 Reading the current.
 But only that?
 No.
 He had begun to enjoy the solitude.
 Earlier the boat was always full of people's voices.
 "Hurry."
 "Slowly."
 "How much is the fare?"
 "Hold the goat."
 "The bucket fell."
 "Stop on that side."
 Now there was silence in midstream.
 Ramdhani's own breath.
 The oar.
 The water.
 The bridge above.
 He began to understand that silence not as earnings but as time.
 One day Dinkar got into the boat alone with his father.
 "Where?" Ramdhani asked.
 "Across."
 "The bridge?"
 "Today by boat."
 Ramdhani laughed.
 The boat pushed off.
 In midstream Dinkar said, "Babu, teach me."
 "What?"
 "The oar."
 Ramdhani was surprised.
 "You are an electrician."
 "Will I stop being an electrician if I learn the oar?"

Ramdhani had no answer.
 Near the bank, in safe water, he put the oar in Dinkar's hands.
 The first push was wrong.
 The boat spun.
 Ramdhani laughed.
 Dinkar was annoyed.
 "Do not laugh."
 "My Babu used to laugh at me too."
 "So this is revenge?"
 They both laughed.
 Ramdhani corrected the grip of his hands.
 "Less force."
 "Less?"
 "Do not fight the water."
 "Then?"
 "Give it direction."
 Dinkar tried more gently.
 The boat straightened.
 His face lit up.
 Something rose inside Ramdhani, but he did not give it a word.
 "Enough for today."
 Dinkar said, "More."
 "Tomorrow."
 "Will you really, tomorrow?"
 "Are you no longer a passenger?"
 Dinkar laughed.
 The following week a new bus service began over the bridge.
 The village was excited.
 So was Ramdhani.
 "Faster to town."
 Gita asked, "Will you ride the bus?"
 Ramdhani said, "Why not?"
 On the first day he went to town by bus.
 Across the bridge.
 From the window he saw his own boat below.
 Tied by the rope.
 Small.
 From above, the river looked different.
 For the first time Ramdhani saw the current from the height of the bridge.
 The curve behind the pier was clear.
 He marked the route in his mind.
 He did his work in town and returned.
 In the evening he untied the boat.
 He checked from below the whirlpool he had seen from above.
 The old boatman became a passenger on the bridge, then a boatman again.
 There was no contradiction in that.

Time passed.
A year.
The bridge was no longer new.
Nor had the boat become the last in any absolute sense.
Yet in the village people began calling it 'the last boat'.
Because all the other boats that had carried passengers from that ghat had been sold.

One to a fisherman.
One became timber.
One rotted away.
Ramdhani's was the only one left.
A journalist came.
He took photographs.
"The last boatman."
Ramdhani said, "Why last?"
"Now only you are left."
"Dinkar is learning."
The journalist grew excited. "The tradition continues!"
Ramdhani corrected him at once. "He does electrical work."
The journalist's story weakened.
He asked, "Why do you row an empty boat every day?"
Ramdhani said, "To keep rowing."
The journalist laughed as if the answer were incomplete.
Ramdhani patted the boat.
"If a boat is tied up and left, it rots. If a body is tied up and left?"
The journalist wrote it down.
Ramdhani was afraid the sentence had become too beautiful.
He added, "But there are days when I do not row either."
The journalist laughed.
"Shall I write that too?"
"The truth."
The article was published.
Its title was: 'The Last Boatman in the Age of the Bridge.'
Ramdhani could not read all of it.
Dinkar read it aloud to him.
The article said, 'Ramdhani still converses with the river.'
Ramdhani stopped him.
"Did I say that?"
"No."
"Does the river talk?"
Dinkar laughed.
"That is how journalists write."
Ramdhani was annoyed.
"I look at the water. What conversation?"
Gita said, "Leave it."
Ramdhani folded the article and put it away.

He did not want the empty boat turned into a mystery.
 The work was enough.
 The following year Ramdhani's knee began to hurt.
 The doctor advised rest.
 "Boat every day?"
 "Less."
 "How much?"
 "Half."
 Ramdhani laughed.
 "Half a river?"
 The doctor did not laugh.
 "Your knee will be completely ruined."
 Ramdhani reduced his crossings.
 First every day.
 Then four days a week.
 Then three.
 The empty days were difficult.
 He sat at the ghat.
 The boat remained tied.
 The water moved.
 At first he felt: I should row.
 Gradually watching too became a practice.
 Sometimes Dinkar rowed.
 Not alone, but with his father.
 One day Ramdhani said, "Today you row. I will sit."
 Dinkar was surprised.
 All the way across?
 "Yes."
 Dinkar took the oar.
 Ramdhani became the passenger.
 Without meaning to he kept giving instructions: "Right. Less. Not behind the pier."
 Dinkar got annoyed. "Let me see for myself."
 Ramdhani fell silent.
 A few moments later the boat was straight.
 Was Ramdhani proud?
 Yes.
 Afraid?
 A little.
 Giving up control was difficult.
 On reaching the other side Dinkar said, "Fare."
 Ramdhani laughed and searched his pocket.
 He gave him a coin.
 Dinkar took it.
 At home he showed it to Gita.
 "First earnings."

Gita laughed until tears came to her eyes.
 Ramdhani said, "Drama."
 But he himself was smiling.
 The school's river lessons continued.
 After Kusum, a new teacher arrived.
 At first he took no interest.
 The programme stopped for two months.
 Did Ramdhani feel sad?
 A little.
 But he kept rowing the boat.
 That proved that teaching was not the only reason.
 Then one day the new teacher himself came to the ghat.
 "The children will learn to read the current."
 Ramdhani said, "Life jackets?"
 "We will bring them."
 The programme resumed.
 With time, Ramdhani's story grew shorter.
 People asked, "Why without passengers?"
 He said, "Practice."
 That was all.
 Sometimes, "Boat maintenance."
 Sometimes, "Because I feel like it."
 There was no single answer.
 He himself stopped wanting one.
 One winter morning there was dense fog.
 Ramdhani came to the ghat.
 He thought of untying the boat.
 Very little of the water was visible.
 Earlier, if a passenger had needed to cross in such fog, he would use sound,
 direction, and signs on the bank.
 Today there was no need.
 He did not untie the rope.
 He sat there.
 The fog lifted.
 Sunlight.
 Ramdhani returned home.
 Gita asked, "The boat?"
 "No."
 "Why?"
 "Could not see."
 "Before?"
 "Before, passengers needed to cross."
 Gita smiled.
 Ramdhani understood: rowing an empty boat did not mean taking risks.
 There is a difference between practice and stubbornness.
 He learned that difference late.

The following summer the wood of the boat needed repairs again.
 Dinkar said, "This time half of it will be new."
 Ramdhani said, "Then where is the old boat?"
 Dinkar laughed.
 "As much as remains."
 An old saying about the family boat came to Ramdhani's mind: if each plank is replaced one by one, is it still the same boat?
 He did not argue.
 Where it had rotted, they replaced it.
 The boat carried a faint new smell.
 On the first crossing Ramdhani, Dinkar, and Gita went together.
 Gita had not been in the boat for years.
 "I am afraid."
 Ramdhani said, "Go by the bridge."
 "Today, the boat."
 In midstream Gita was silent.
 A bus passed over the bridge.
 Gita said, "Faster up there."
 Ramdhani said, "Yes."
 "The breeze is good down here."
 "Yes."
 Dinkar said, "Keep both."
 All three laughed.
 There was something like a simple solution in that sentence.
 But for crossing the river, the two were not equal.
 The bridge was the main route.
 The boat was private, limited.
 That inequality was accepted.
 Ramdhani was no longer jealous of the bridge.
 Perhaps he had never been jealous in the first place.
 His sorrow was a mixture of livelihood, habit, identity, and body.
 The word jealousy was too small.
 One day the old passenger Bhola Sah came again.
 This time he said, "Will you take me across?"
 Ramdhani was startled.
 "The bridge?"
 "Today I feel like taking the boat."
 Ramdhani was silent for a few moments.
 "Fare?" Bhola laughed.
 Ramdhani said, "There will be a fare."
 "How much?"
 The old rate?
 A new one?
 Ramdhani thought.
 Then said, "As before."
 Bhola boarded.

The first voluntary passenger after the bridge opened?
 Perhaps.
 Ramdhani did not turn it into a historic moment.
 The boat pushed off.
 Bhola said, "After a long time."
 "Yes."
 "Brings things back."
 "What?"
 "Going to the market."
 "Today is not market day."
 They both laughed.
 On the far side Bhola got down.
 He paid the fare.
 Then returned by the bridge.
 Ramdhani came back alone in the boat.
 One way with a passenger.
 One way empty.
 His day was complete.
 At home he did not give the fare coin to Gita.
 He kept it in his pocket.
 At night he took it out and looked at it.
 An ordinary coin.
 No memorial.
 The next day he spent it in the market on salt.
 That pleased him.
 The fare had become money again, not a symbol.
 Ramdhani grew older.
 His knee worsened.
 The boat made fewer crossings.
 One day the doctor said plainly, "Now row less."
 Ramdhani came home and handed the boat's rope to Dinkar.
 "Keep it."
 Dinkar was startled.
 "Have you given it up?"
 "No."
 "Then?"
 "You untie it. I will go when I go."
 Shared control.
 For Ramdhani, this was a great thing.
 Dinkar did not row the boat regularly.
 Once or twice a week.
 Sometimes for a children's lesson.
 Sometimes with his father.
 Sometimes only for maintenance.
 Ramdhani sat at the ghat and gave fewer instructions.
 One day a child asked, "Kaka, is this the last boat?"

Ramdhani said, "Do not say 'last' too quickly."
 "Why?"
 "Tomorrow someone else may build one."
 The child laughed.
 "The last boatman?"
 Ramdhani looked at Dinkar.
 "Then what is he?"
 Dinkar said at once, "I am an electrician."
 Everyone laughed.
 Ramdhani said, "See?"
 A year later Ramdhani stopped rowing altogether.
 Knee, shoulder.
 He sat in the boat while Dinkar rowed.
 Sometimes, during school lessons, he only spoke.
 "The current is there."
 "Careful behind the pier."
 "Wind from the right."
 The language of his body slowly changed into words.
 What his hands had once done without thinking, his mouth now explained.
 The change felt strange to him.
 Words were often slow.
 Water was immediate.
 Dinkar said, "You tell me. I will look."
 Ramdhani would get irritated. "Look first, then listen to me."
 A new lesson.
 One evening the lights on the bridge came on.
 Below, the boat was tied.
 Ramdhani sat alone at the ghat.
 He remembered the first day of the bridge.
 The empty boat.
 The first crossing.
 Gita had asked: Was there anyone?
 He had said: No.
 Now too, there was no one.
 But it was not necessary to row.
 He sat quietly.
 The water moved.
 He felt no restlessness.
 Perhaps the true ending of the last boat was not that the boat stopped.
 The ending was that the boatman no longer needed to prove every day that the
 boat was still a boat, that he was still a boatman.
 He knew it even without lifting the oar.
 Dinkar came from behind.
 "Let's go home."
 Ramdhani stood.
 "Did you check the rope?"

"Yes."

"Not loose?"

"No."

"Children tomorrow?"

"Four."

"Life jackets?"

"There are six."

"Good."

They walked home beneath the lights of the bridge.

The boat remained tied behind them.

People kept crossing on the bridge.

Each continued doing its own work.

No one's defeat.

No one's victory.

Only the old way of crossing the river had changed.

And within Ramdhani, the way of rowing a boat had changed as well.

The Tree Stump

“Drop me at the Peepal.”

When the elderly woman seated in the bus said this, Naval paused in the middle of punching her ticket.

“Where is the peepal?”

The woman looked at his face.

“What?”

“The peepal.”

“At the peepal.”

“I’m asking, where is the tree?”

The two young men seated in the front laughed.

The woman did not.

She said, “The tree has been cut down. The place is still there.”

It was Naval’s third day as conductor on this route.

The names of all the stops were clearly printed on the sheet.

Bus Station.

College Turn.

South Market.

Eastern Square.

Canal.

Belahi.

“At the Peepal” was not on the list.

Yet from his very first day, passengers had been using that name.

“Two to the Peepal.”

“Three to the Peepal.”

“One child’s half-ticket to the Peepal.”

At first Naval had thought perhaps the name had been left off the list.

On the second day he understood that what the list called “Eastern Square” was the same place people called “At the Peepal.”

By the third day his curiosity had grown.

Taking her ticket, the old woman said again, “See that I don’t miss it.”

“All right.”

Naval moved on.

The bus was packed.

The hot wind of Jeth came in through the windows.

Dust, heat, and the smell of ripening mangoes.

From time to time the driver, Ramsevak, glanced at Naval through the mirror.

He had been driving on this route for seventeen years.

Before Eastern Square, Naval came forward and rang the bell.

Ramsevak slowed the bus.

Naval called loudly, “Eastern Square!”

No one got up.

He called again, "Eastern Square! Anyone getting off, get ready!"
 The old woman remained seated with her bag in her lap.
 The young men in front looked at each other.
 As he applied the brake, Ramsevak called out, "At the Peepal!"
 Four people stood up at once.
 The old woman too.
 Naval said nothing.
 The bus stopped.
 He watched the passengers getting down.
 Two tea-and-paan shops stood on the left side of the road.
 A chemist's shop on the right.
 In the middle was a round cement platform.
 At its centre stood a low, broad, black-brown stump.
 Old rain stains marked its edge.
 The top was cut flat.
 No branch.
 No leaf.
 Standing at the door, Naval watched the old woman step down.
 She passed behind the stump and turned east.
 The bus moved again.
 Naval came up to Ramsevak and asked, "The place is named after that stump?"
 Ramsevak said, "Not after the stump. After the peepal."
 "But there is no peepal."
 "There was."
 "How long ago was it cut?"
 "Six months."
 "Then why hasn't the name changed?"
 Ramsevak laughed.
 "Cutting a name and cutting a tree are not the same job."
 Naval did not like the answer.
 He was a man who liked rules.
 The name on the paper should be the name spoken aloud.
 The stop printed on the ticket should be the place where one got down.
 He believed that if road names were clear, there would be less confusion.
 Here people were getting down in the name of a vanished tree.
 It struck him as odd.
 On the last run that evening, the bus stopped there again.
 The shops were half closed.
 Three children sat on the stump.
 One child was kicking up dust with a slipper.
 Naval got down.
 He took tea.
 Phulo Devi, who sold the tea, asked, "You're new?"
 "Yes."
 "Where did the old conductor go?"
 "To another route."

"He used to call 'At the Peepal' very well."

Holding the cup in his hand, Naval said, "The officially registered name of this place is Eastern Square."

Stirring the milk on the stove, Phulo Devi said, "Maybe."

"Then why does everyone call it At the Peepal?"

"Because this is At the Peepal."

"Where is the peepal?"

Phulo Devi stopped the spoon and looked at him.

Then she pointed towards the stump.

"It was there."

"I understand that. But it isn't there now."

"So?"

Naval laughed.

"Nothing."

Phulo Devi asked whether the tea had too little sugar or too much.

Naval said, "It's fine."

It dawned on him that answers here were not as straightforward as measuring sugar in tea.

No one knew for certain when the peepal had been planted.

Phulo Devi said that when her mother-in-law came there after marriage, the tree was already large.

Ramsevak said there had been no platform when he was a child.

Vijay, the chemist, said the bus had begun stopping there only after the platform was built.

According to Nandkishore, the cloth seller, bullock carts had once stopped there for shade.

No one had measured the tree's age.

What was measured was the work the tree did.

Shade.

A halt.

Waiting.

A meeting place.

"We'll meet at the Peepal."

"Turn right from the Peepal."

"Leave the goods at the Peepal."

"Catch the bus at the Peepal."

People also gave different versions of why the tree had been cut.

There was no legend.

Only several versions of ordinary reasons.

A large branch had broken in a storm and fallen across the road.

It had been touching the electric wires.

The trunk had become hollow inside.

People from the road department came.

Everyone had a different account of whether permission from the forest department had come or not.

But one morning the saw began to run.

By noon half the tree was gone.
 By evening only the trunk remained.
 The next day, a stump.
 Phulo Devi said, "People did not weep."
 Naval was startled.
 "I didn't ask that."
 "It was written on your face."
 She laughed.
 "Everyone says that when an old tree is cut, the village weeps. No one wept here."
 "Then?"
 "Everyone carried on with their own work."
 "No one was sad?"
 "Sadness is one thing. Work is another."
 Phulo Devi handed a customer a packet of biscuits.
 "In the morning the milk van stopped there as usual."
 "The schoolchildren gathered there as usual."
 "At noon the bus stopped there as usual."
 "In the evening people met there as usual."
 "The tree was gone, but the place did not take a holiday."
 Naval finished his tea.
 The bus whistled.
 He climbed aboard.
 For the next few days Naval conducted an experiment.
 He would call, "Eastern Square."
 People remained seated.
 Then he would call, "At the Peepal."
 People stood up.
 One day he called only "Eastern Square."
 A young woman missed her stop.
 She got down at the next turn and said irritably, "Why didn't you call it earlier?"
 "I did."
 "What did you call?"
 "Eastern Square."
 "I don't know it as Eastern Square."
 "That's what is printed on the ticket."
 The young woman turned the ticket over and over in her hand.
 "Do I get down by reading the ticket, or by recognising the place?"
 Naval did not answer.
 Ramsevak drove on.
 Quietly he said, "A route is not a book."
 Naval heard him.
 He gave no reply.
 After that he began calling both names.
 "Eastern Square—At the Peepal!"
 That solution worked for a few days.
 But the question remained inside Naval.

Whose is a name?
 The paper's?
 The people's?
 The tree's?
 The place's?
 One Sunday the bus was not very crowded.
 Naval sat near the stump for five minutes.
 The round platform was being used in many ways.
 On one side stood Phulo Devi's tea glasses.
 On another, a bicycle leaned against it.
 An old man sat on a spread-out gamchha.
 Two children played marbles.
 A woman rested her basket of vegetables and caught her breath.
 The stump itself was useless.
 The space around it was active.
 Naval ran his fingers over the stump's surface.
 The saw marks were still visible.
 At the centre was a dark circle from rainwater.
 There were no fresh green shoots along the edge.
 From a distance Phulo Devi said, "It won't sprout."
 Naval asked, "Why?"
 "The roots were cut."
 "Then why did they leave the stump?"
 "The machine is supposed to come again."
 "Hasn't it?"
 "It will."
 The machine came three weeks later.
 Naval saw it when the bus reached there on its first run that day.
 Two labourers were breaking up part of the platform.
 A yellow machine was digging the earth around the stump's roots.
 There was a crowd at Phulo Devi's shop.
 No one protested.
 No one signed a consent form.
 Everyone watched.
 Naval stopped the bus and asked, "Will this go too now?"
 Vijay, the chemist, said, "A drain is going to be built."
 "Then what happens to At the Peepal?"
 Vijay laughed.
 "Where would it go?"
 "The stump won't be here either."
 "The place will."
 Naval remembered Ramsevak's first answer.
 By evening the stump was gone.
 Half the platform remained.
 There was a large pit in the earth.
 The next day the pit was filled.

Three days later the drain was cemented.
 A week later there was a flat edge there.
 Where the peepal had stood, there was now nothing that an outsider could point to and say: a tree once stood here.
 Naval thought the name would not survive now.
 He was wrong.
 That same week an elderly man boarded the bus.
 "One to the Peepal."
 A student said, "Two to the Peepal."
 Two women said, "Us too, there."
 Naval punched the tickets.
 "Eastern Square?"
 All three said together, "At the Peepal."
 He smiled.
 One day an outsider asked, "You keep saying 'At the Peepal'; where is the tree?"
 Without thinking Naval said, "It was cut down."
 "Then the name?"
 Naval paused.
 Then he said, "The place remains."
 He himself was surprised by his answer.
 He was beginning to sound like Ramsevak.
 A few months later notice came from the block office that new signboards would be installed at the main-road stops.
 Blue background.
 White letters.
 All the same size.
 Bus-route number.
 The authorised name of the stop.
 The list arrived.
 "Eastern Square."
 Vijay was pleased to hear about the signboard.
 "Now outsiders will find it easier."
 Phulo Devi asked, "Where will the board be put?"
 "Near the old platform."
 "The name?"
 "Eastern Square."
 Blowing on the stove, Phulo Devi said, "Let them put it up."
 Naval had thought she would object.
 He asked, "Won't you have 'At the Peepal' written?"
 "Am I the one writing the board?"
 "If all of you want, you could say so."
 "There are too many things in the world to keep asking for."
 Phulo Devi laughed.
 "If the board is coming, let it come."
 The signboard arrived.
 Four men planted it in the ground.

"Eastern Square"
 Below it, the bus-route number.
 On the first day, Naval deliberately called, "Eastern Square!"
 Two outsiders stood up.
 Five villagers did not.
 Then he added, "At the Peepal!"
 All five rose.
 The board stood there.
 Two names.
 One place.
 The problem was not over.
 A month later there was a plan to extend the roadside drain.
 The bus stop would have to be shifted seventy cubits east.
 Looking at the map, Ramsevak said, "Now watch the game."
 "What?"
 "Let's see whether At the Peepal moves."
 Naval's curiosity woke again.
 At the new stop, a metal shelter was built for shade.
 Two benches.
 The signboard was moved.
 "Eastern Square" was now seventy cubits east of the old peepal site.
 Phulo Devi's shop remained where it had been.
 So did Vijay's chemist's shop.
 On the first day Ramsevak stopped the bus by the new shelter.
 Naval called, "At the Peepal!"
 An old woman got down and looked back.
 "Why here?"
 "The stop is here now."
 "At the Peepal is over there."
 She pointed towards Phulo Devi's shop.
 Naval said, "The bus will stop here from now on."
 The old woman slowly walked back.
 Another passenger was annoyed.
 A third said, "All this for seventy cubits?"
 Naval understood that this time the place and the stop had separated.
 Before, the name had existed without the tree.
 Now the bus was stopping at a place without the name.
 For two weeks there was confusion.
 Some called the new shelter "New Peepal."
 Some called it "By the Signboard."
 Some called it "New Stop."
 Some insisted on getting down at the old place.
 Ramsevak pointed to the rule: buses had to stop only at designated points on the main road.
 Phulo Devi's customers decreased.
 For the first time she was openly angry about it.

“They cut the tree, removed the stump, and now they’ve removed the bus too.”
 Naval said, “It’s only seventy cubits.”
 “Seventy cubits for you.”
 “For you?”
 “For my tea, seventy cubits is a long way.”
 That sentence changed the direction of Naval’s thought.
 This was not only about memory.
 Livelihood.
 Movement.
 The direction of feet.
 The meaning of a short distance.
 A young man set up a tea cart by the new shelter.
 His name was Chhotu.
 He turned out to be Phulo Devi’s nephew.
 Phulo Devi did not stop him.
 “If people stand there, they’ll want tea there.”
 “What about your customers?”
 “Whoever wants it here will come here. Whoever wants it there will drink there.”
 Naval asked, “Competition?”
 Phulo Devi said, “He is family. The competition is family too.”
 Chhotu had a sign painted on his cart—
 “Peepal Tea House”
 Naval saw it and laughed.
 “Where is the peepal?”
 Chhotu answered at once, “In the name.”
 From a distance Phulo Devi shouted, “Don’t tease him!”
 Laughing, Naval climbed back onto the bus.
 Slowly the new stop came into common use.
 But the words “At the Peepal” were not ready to leave the old place.
 People said—
 “I’ll get down at the Peepal, at the new shelter.”
 Someone else said—
 “Take me to the old Peepal.”
 Someone called Chhotu’s cart “the new tea at the Peepal.”
 Children learned it differently.
 Raunak, a fifth-class student, caught the bus every day.
 He had never seen the tree.
 When the tree had been cut, he was away at his maternal grandparents’ home.
 One day Naval asked, “Do you remember the peepal?”
 Raunak said, “No.”
 “Then why do you say At the Peepal?”
 “Everyone says it.”
 “What is a peepal?”
 “A tree.”
 “Is there one here?”
 “No.”

"Then?"
 Raunak laughed.
 "You ask too many questions."
 The whole bus laughed.
 Naval did too.
 But he liked the answer.
 Sometimes language gives a child a place before it gives him the object.
 For Raunak, "At the Peepal" was first a bus stop.
 The tree came later as knowledge.
 One evening Naval got down at the old place and sat with Phulo Devi.
 He asked, "Would you like the tree to be planted again?"
 Phulo Devi said, "Why not?"
 "Exactly at the same place?"
 "There's a drain there."
 "Beside it?"
 "There's a shop beside it."
 "Then?"
 "Plant it along the edge of the school field."
 Naval was surprised.
 "Then how will the name At the Peepal stay here?"
 Phulo Devi looked at him again with that same old look.
 "You don't plant a tree to save a name."
 "Then?"
 "For the tree."
 Naval fell silent.
 That answer stayed inside him for a long time.
 A few weeks later the rains began.
 The schoolchildren really did plant three peepal saplings.
 Not at the old place.
 Behind the school.
 The teacher said, "Whichever of the three survives, we'll take care of it."
 No one named any of the saplings "the old peepal."
 Phulo Devi said, "Why burden a new tree with the old one?"
 Naval remembered that sentence too.
 Meanwhile, the panchayat discussed the name of the stop.
 The reason was not only the bus.
 Post.
 Medicine deliveries.
 Workers coming from outside.
 Wedding invitations.
 Giving directions over the phone.
 On paper: "Eastern Square."
 On people's lips: "At the Peepal."
 One member said, "Write both."
 Another said, "Why put an old name on a government signboard?"
 A third said, "Write what people say."

A fourth said, "If people say something else tomorrow, will you change the board again?"

The meeting's decision was simple.

On the new signboard, "Eastern Square" would remain at the top.

Below, in brackets: "Local name—At the Peepal."

Naval laughed when he heard about the decision.

He said to Ramsevak, "Now even the paper has accepted it."

Ramsevak said, "Paper learns slowly."

"And people quickly?"

"People learn differently."

The new signboard was installed.

Two names.

Some people were pleased.

Some said it was unnecessary.

Some did not read it at all.

Phulo Devi's tea tasted the same.

Chhotu's cart stayed by the new shelter.

The bus came at the same time.

Raunak still quarrelled for the same seat.

Life did not wait for the signboard's decision.

After a few months Naval understood the full rhythm of the route.

Where farmers would board.

Where students would.

Where the market crowd came from.

Where an old woman would get down slowly.

Where the driver had to veer left to avoid a pothole.

He no longer corrected a passenger's words while punching tickets.

If someone said "Eastern Square," he issued a ticket under that name.

If someone said "At the Peepal," he knew the place.

If someone said "by Phulo's tea," he understood the old site.

If someone said "new shelter," he understood the bus stop.

He had learned that one name for one place was convenient.

But life was not made according to convenience.

Sometimes a name was history.

Sometimes commerce.

Sometimes habit.

Sometimes only shared agreement.

One day an architecture student came from the city.

He was studying public spaces in the village.

After hearing about the stump, he asked Naval, "Was a memorial built here?"

"No."

"A photograph of the old tree?"

"I don't have one."

"Someone must?"

"Possibly."

"The platform?"

“Half of it was broken, and later it was removed.”
“Then how did the memory survive?”
Naval considered his answer.
Earlier, he had liked questions like this.
Now he did not answer quickly.
He said, “Get on the bus.”
The student was startled.
“What?”
“Take one round.”
The student boarded.
Naval moved forward.
The stop drew near.
In his ordinary voice he called out—
“At the Peepal!”
Five people stood up.
Two moved towards the door.
A woman took hold of her child’s hand.
A young man lifted a sack.
An old man adjusted his walking stick.
Naval looked at the student.
“This is it.”
The student began to write something.
Naval did not stop him.
He no longer felt irritated by the habit of writing.
But inwardly he knew that only words would go into the notebook.
Not the moment.
Five bodies rising together at the call.
Bags being gathered.
Moving towards the door.
The change of motion at one particular place on the road.
That was the work of the name.
A few days later there was an accident.
Not a serious one.
A bicycle slipped near the new stop.
The young man scraped his knee.
People gathered.
Someone phoned his home and said, “There’s been an accident at the Peepal.”
Naval heard it.
For a moment he thought—the accident had happened by the new shelter, not at the old peepal site.
Even so, the young man’s family came straight to the new stop.
The name had not fallen away.
It had shifted.
From the tree’s place to the bus stop.
No meeting had decided this change.
The signboard came later.

People first.
 The word had detached itself from the object and followed use.
 Naval found that exciting.
 Then he laughed at himself.
 He had begun as a conductor.
 Now he was becoming a philosopher of names.
 Hearing him, Ramsevak said, "Punch the tickets properly. Philosophy later."
 Both laughed.
 The rains grew heavier.
 Of the three saplings planted behind the school, two dried up.
 One survived.
 Raunak watered it every day after school.
 One day Naval asked, "Will this become At the Peepal?"
 Raunak shook his head.
 "No."
 "Why?"
 "This is the school peepal."
 "When it grows big?"
 "Even then."
 "The old At the Peepal?"
 "That is the bus place."
 Naval laughed.
 In the child's language the dispute was over.
 One object.
 One new place.
 One old name.
 All three separate.
 Autumn came.
 The white letters on the new signboard became a little dirty.
 Dust settled over the words in brackets: "Local name—At the Peepal."
 One day, as a joke, someone pasted a piece of paper over "Local name."
 Only "At the Peepal" remained visible.
 Two days later rain soaked the paper away.
 The signboard was whole again.
 No one made meaning out of the small event.
 Neither did Naval.
 He was learning that not every sight is a symbol.
 Sometimes paper simply gets wet.
 Sometimes a signboard simply gets dirty.
 Sometimes a stump is simply removed.
 And sometimes a word simply keeps going.
 Around Diwali, Phulo Devi replaced the roof of her shop.
 The old bamboo was removed.
 New corrugated sheeting went up.
 She had a name painted on the shop—
 "Phulo Tea House"

And below it, in smaller letters—
 “Old At the Peepal”
 Naval asked, “Now you’ve written it too?”
 Phulo Devi said, “For the customers’ convenience.”
 “Memory?”
 “Convenience first.”
 “Then?”
 “Whoever understands, understands.”
 That was her way.
 She did not sell memory by turning it into a burden.
 She sold tea.
 A year passed.
 No one on this route called Naval new anymore.
 He himself began explaining the route to a new conductor.
 A young man named Chandan.
 On the first day Naval showed him the list.
 “It says Eastern Square here.”
 Chandan said, “All right.”
 Naval added, “People will say At the Peepal.”
 Chandan asked, “Where is the peepal?”
 Naval could not help smiling.
 “There isn’t one.”
 Chandan’s face became exactly as Naval’s had been a year earlier.
 “Then?”
 Naval said, “You’ll understand in two days.”
 “What should I call out?”
 “Both.”
 “For how long?”
 Naval thought before answering.
 “Until one of them feels enough to you.”
 Chandan laughed.
 So did Naval.
 He did not give him a ready-made answer.
 Some things the route itself teaches.
 After that Naval’s job was linked to another run as well.
 Two days a week he was no longer on this route.
 When he returned a month later, he saw a new wooden bench in front of Phulo
 Devi’s shop.
 Chhotu’s cart was bigger.
 The signboard was still there.
 The school peepal sapling had grown to waist height.
 The drain at the old place was clean.
 Some things had changed.
 Some had not.
 Chandan called out, “Eastern Square—At the Peepal!”
 People rose.

Naval was sitting on a rear seat like a passenger.
 He remembered his first day.
 But this was not a story of his memory.
 He was watching a present unfolding before him.
 The bus stopped.
 An unfamiliar man got down and went towards the tea shop.
 With him was a child of about seven.
 The man asked Phulo Devi, "Where exactly is At the Peepal here?"
 Phulo Devi was straining tea.
 Before she could answer, the child spoke up—
 "Right here."
 The man looked around.
 "Where is the peepal?"
 The child said naturally—
 "There is no peepal."
 The man asked again, "Then At the Peepal?"
 The child pointed towards the new bus stop on the road.
 "The bus stops there."
 Then he turned towards Phulo Devi's shop.
 "And this is Old At the Peepal."
 The man burst out laughing.
 "Two of them?"
 The child laughed too.
 "Places change, don't they?"
 Naval was listening from inside the bus.
 He said nothing.
 There was nothing he needed to add.
 There was no tree.
 There was no stump.
 There was no old platform.
 A new peepal was growing somewhere else.
 But a word that had once become joined to people's walking, stopping, meeting,
 buying, waiting, and finding direction does not get cut down with the wood alone.
 It changes.
 It shifts.
 Sometimes it spreads.
 Sometimes it splits in two.
 Sometimes it enters a signboard.
 Sometimes it remains outside the signboard.
 The bus moved on.
 Chandan advanced through the aisle, punching tickets.
 Naval looked back through the window.
 Phulo Devi's shop grew smaller.
 So did the new shelter.
 The two names remained in the same view.
 Then came the bend.

The view disappeared.
Naval turned his face forward.
The next stop had a clear name.
He did not worry about it.

Smoke

When evening smoke rose from the distant fields, I did not at first understand why the smell of roasted chura came back to me.

The paddy had already been harvested.

Someone had gathered dry leaves and stubble in one place and set them alight.

The wind was moving from east to west.

A thin sheet of smoke sagged over the road.

I was sitting on the old bench outside my shop.

The shop is no longer mine; it belongs to my daughter now.

But in the evenings I still come and sit here.

My daughter makes tea, my grandson keeps the accounts, and I listen to the customers talk.

There were few customers that day.

There was more smoke.

My grandson held a gamchha over his nose and said, "Why do people burn the fields like this?"

I did not answer.

A morning from thirty or thirty-five years ago returned to me.

There had been smoke on the road that morning too.

But no field was burning.

Dry paddy straw was burning in my little stove, over which I was heating an iron pan.

I had to lightly roast chura in it.

Seven young men were to catch the bus for the railway station.

I had been given the responsibility of making bundles of chura, sattu, salt and chilli, and jaggery for them.

I was twenty-two then.

My husband had been dead for two years.

I had two small children.

I had opened this shop by the roadside to keep the household going.

Even calling it a shop was saying too much.

Four bamboo posts.

Thatch overhead.

A wooden plank in front.

A stove at the back.

Tea, jaggery, chura, sattu, savouries, bidis, soap, matches.

That was all.

That day, for the first time, seven young men were leaving the village together to earn money outside.

Earlier, people left singly, or two at a time.

Some went to Darbhanga.
 Some to Patna.
 Some as far as Kolkata.
 But seven going west together was something new.
 Farming in the village had been weak for three seasons.
 One year the rains were scant.
 The next, disease ate through the paddy.
 The third year the crop was decent, but wages fell.
 The landowners protected their accounts.
 The agricultural labourers looked to the account of their stomachs.
 The two accounts did not balance in the same place.
 Meanwhile Nandu, who had returned from outside, said there was work in the fields of Punjab.
 "Work all day, but the wages are higher than here."
 That was all he had said.
 People added the rest themselves.
 Someone said there was work there all year.
 Someone said the landowner provided food.
 Someone said the train fare was paid in advance.
 Nandu contradicted some things and laughed at others.
 But when hope spreads, the voice of caution grows faint.
 I still remember the names of those seven young men.
 Nandu.
 Tirpit.
 Shambhu.
 Mahesar.
 Lakhan.
 Ramji.
 And Chhotkan.
 Chhotkan was the youngest.
 His mother had told me, "Pack two extra days' food."
 I had asked, "Will they reach in two days?"
 She said, "How would I know? What harm if there is extra?"
 A mother's reasoning was larger than the journey.
 I made seven bundles.
 There was no need to write names on them.
 Each man knew his own bundle.
 More jaggery in one.
 Less chilli in another.
 In Chhotkan's bundle, his mother had made me put two sesame laddus.
 When they arrived at dawn, smoke from my stove was spreading across the road.
 Some rubbed their eyes.
 Some joked and laughed.
 Some checked their bags again and again.
 Some were silent.
 There were more people seeing them off than there were young men leaving.

In that crowd I kept handing out the food bundles.
 The bus arrived.
 There was pushing and jostling.
 The seven climbed aboard.
 Chhotkan stood by the window.
 His mother called from below, "Do not go hungry."
 The bus moved off.
 Dust and smoke rose together.
 I began putting the shop in order.
 At the time I did not realise that the work of my shop was about to change.
 Earlier, farmers came for tea in the morning.
 At midday, labourers returning from the fields ate sattv.
 In the evening, children bought jaggery or savouries.
 For a few days after those seven men left, the number of customers fell.
 I thought, "Seven men gone, seven fewer customers."
 But the arithmetic was not that simple.
 There was little cash in the homes of those seven men.
 So their families began asking for things on credit.
 Soap from one.
 Salt from another.
 Matches.
 Half a kilo of chura.
 I kept no ledger.
 I made small charcoal marks on the wall.
 Two lines for one household.
 Five for another.
 By the end of the month I myself would forget which lines belonged to which house.
 Credit then ran on memory.
 And memory, like a poor household's accounts, is fine when it is right; when it is wrong, there is a quarrel.
 Nandu sent the first money.
 His mother gave me twenty rupees and said, "Strike off the old account."
 I asked her, "How much was it?"
 She said, "You tell me."
 I looked towards the wall.
 For the first time, those charcoal lines seemed meaningless.
 I named an amount by guesswork.
 She paid without argument.
 Perhaps it was right.
 Perhaps not.
 Meanwhile another piece of news spread through Nandu's letter: there really was work.
 So the next group got ready.
 Nine this time.
 Then twelve.

Then the men from five families.
The mornings at my shop changed.
On days when a group was to leave by bus, I had to start preparing the night before.

Roast chura.

Sift sattu.

Break jaggery.

Save sheets of old newspaper.

Tie bundles in gamchhas.

Nimki for someone to eat on the road.

Sugar drops for someone's child.

Someone's mother saying, "Do not put in oil; it will spill."

Someone's wife saying, "Put in a little pickle."

As the village was emptying out, departure days became the busiest days at my shop.

I understood that contradiction much later.

Migration was taking customers away from me.

Migration was also giving me work.

I could not stop anyone from leaving.

Nor did I feel happy when anyone left.

But hands tying a food bundle do not ask what they feel.

They simply tighten the knot.

One day Shambhu's wife Kamli said to me, "Stop him."

I was startled.

"Me?"

"He listens to you."

Shambhu was drinking tea behind the shop at the time.

I called him over.

"Kamli says you should not go."

He did not laugh.

He said, "If I do not go, what will I do?"

I had no answer.

Kamli said, "We will do something or other here."

Shambhu asked, "What?"

That one word opened the whole difficulty of the village.

What?

The three of us were silent.

In the end Kamli herself said, "Go."

She did not cry.

That night I tied Shambhu's bundle better than all the others.

Two knots.

Cloth wrapped over it.

And inside, in a small box, Kamli's pickle.

My grandson interrupted, "Did you sell food to travellers?"

I returned to the present.

"Sold it, yes, and often gave it on credit too."

"Did you make a profit?"

I laughed.

"We did not keep accounts the way you do now."

"Then how did the shop run?"

"The way the village ran - some cash, some credit, some trust, some forgetting."

He shook his head.

He probably thought it was a terrible way to run a business.

He would be right.

But at the time, that was all that was possible.

Within three years the western hamlet and southern hamlet had changed.

More women were visible in the fields during the day.

More elderly people.

Adolescent children learned many kinds of work quickly.

Where a man had once ploughed, his wife now looked for labourers.

Where a father had gone to the market, his daughter began asking prices.

A household whose men were away did not merely become weaker.

In many homes, women's decisions increased.

In many places, their burden of work increased too.

The same change can do both things at once.

I watched all this from the shop.

If someone sent money, a tin roof appeared on the house.

If someone did not, quarrels began.

Someone returned in two months.

Someone after two years.

Someone because of illness.

Someone for a wedding.

Someone after his father died.

Someone simply because the work outside did not suit him.

I never liked calling those who returned successful or unsuccessful.

But people in the village did.

"So-and-so earned a great deal."

"So-and-so came back empty-handed."

"So-and-so's luck opened."

"So-and-so could not last."

As though a person's life were a single line in someone else's accounts.

A year later Chhotkan returned.

He was thinner than before.

Seeing him, his mother said, "You people said one gets good food there."

Chhotkan laughed.

"One gets food, Ma. One does not get time."

He stayed three weeks.

Then he left again.

This time his mother did not ask me to make his bundle.

She made it herself.

She said, "The first time I did not know what was needed. Now I know."

Migration was also creating knowledge within families.

Which train to take.
 How much sattu to carry.
 How much money to keep in a separate pocket.
 Whose address to write on paper.
 Whose place to reach on the first night.
 Whom not to trust.
 There was no school for any of this.
 People learned from one another.
 Some knowledge came through pain.
 Some through mistakes.
 Some through good fortune.
 One morning my younger brother Vinod came to the shop.
 He said, "Tie a bundle for me too."
 I thought he was joking.
 He was serious.
 I scolded him.
 "You have land."
 "Half a bigha."
 "You have a home."
 "Does a home fill the stomach?"
 I fell silent.
 The question Shambhu had asked had come into my own house in another form.
 What was there to do?
 For years I had tied food bundles for other people.
 That day my hands trembled as I tied one for my own brother.
 Vinod said, "Do not tie it so tight. How will I open it?"
 I snapped at him, "What if it opens on the road?"
 He laughed.
 I did not.
 For the first time, I disliked the smoke from the stove in my own shop.
 It stung my eyes.
 Again and again I stepped outside for air.
 Vinod left.
 After that day migration was no longer only the village's story for me.
 It became the story of my own house.
 Vinod kept sending money.
 I removed the thatch from the shop and put on a tin roof.
 The children's schooling continued.
 The shop carried more goods.
 There was gain.
 Inside that gain was Vinod's absence.
 I learned to accept that.
 Absent people do not leave only empty spaces.
 Sometimes they send money.
 Sometimes decisions.
 Sometimes worry.

Sometimes instructions.
 Sometimes nothing for an entire year.
 Then a family lives by guesswork.
 My children grew up.
 The shop expanded.
 The road widened.
 There were more buses.
 Getting to the railway station became easier.
 A journey that had once been an event for the whole village slowly became ordinary.
 At first twenty people would come to see someone off.
 Later, only a wife or a brother.
 Then sometimes no one.
 The traveller caught the bus alone.
 My work of tying bundles diminished too.
 Sealed packets, savouries and sweets became easily available in the market.
 People said, "We will buy it on the way."
 I felt relief too.
 And sadness.
 Not sadness because the work had decreased.
 Sadness because that old preparation had come to an end.
 Before someone left, his mother, wife, sister and children would gather once at my shop.
 Under the pretext of food, they managed to say a few things.
 Now travel became faster.
 Farewells became shorter.
 One generation's migration became the next generation's routine movement.
 My grandson said, "Where is Vinod Baba now?"
 "In Pune, with his son."
 "Does he come back to the village?"
 "Once a year."
 "His field?"
 "Given out on sharecropping."
 "Then did he migrate, or does he simply live outside?"
 I looked at him.
 I did not have a precise answer.
 "Some of what used to be called migration has now become a way of life."
 He asked, "What is the difference between the two?"
 I looked towards the smoke in the fields.
 "There is a difference between when a person chooses the reason for leaving and when the reason pushes him out. But very often both are mixed inside the same life."
 My grandson covered his nose again.
 The smoke had reached the shop.
 My daughter did not put out the stove, because there is very little smoke from the stove in this shop now.
 The tea kept boiling.

I remembered the old fire of paddy straw.
 Seven bundles.
 Seven young men.
 A mother's voice - "Do not go hungry."
 Then nine.
 Twelve.
 Then Vinod.
 In my memory, migration is made not of numbers but of food bundles.
 Someone's journey began with two days' sattū.
 Someone else's with his mother's pickle.
 Someone's with matches taken on credit.
 Someone's with tea he had not paid for.
 And someone's with the sentence, "What will I do?"
 The smell of smoke opens all of these at once.
 But I know that smell does not tell the story by itself.
 The story already lies within me.
 Smoke merely opens the door.
 Evening deepened.
 The fire in the field grew smaller.
 Two new customers came to the shop.
 Both were young.
 Bags on their backs.
 They asked for tea.
 One said, "What time is the morning bus?"
 My grandson told him.
 Without thinking, I asked, "Where are you going?"
 He said, "Surat."
 The other laughed and added, "Four months this time. Then we will come back for the festival."
 There was less fear in their voices.
 More practice in travelling.
 I was about to ask - have you packed food?
 But I stopped.
 They would have made their own arrangements.
 They no longer needed my old responsibility.
 My daughter gave them two cups of tea.
 One young man bought biscuits.
 The other, a small packet of chura.
 I looked at the packet.
 There was no knot.
 Its edge was sealed.
 Time had changed.
 Not hunger.
 Not travel.
 Nor, entirely, the reasons for going far from home.
 The young men drank their tea and left.

My grandson said, "Baba, you have gone off into thought again."

I said, "There is smoke, isn't there?"

He laughed.

"Smoke from the field."

"Yes, from the field."

This time I did not call it the smoke of home.

No omen.

No prophecy.

Only smoke from a field.

And yet it carried me back to that morning when seven young men climbed onto a bus.

Memory often does not ask permission from the true meaning of a thing.

It chooses its own road.

The fire in the field went out.

The wind still carried the smell.

The shop light came on.

My daughter balanced the accounts.

My grandson set aside two customers' chura for the morning bus.

I kept watching.

He did not tie it into a bundle.

He simply placed the packet to one side.

I thought to myself - good.

Every generation makes its own way of preparing for a journey.

Mine was the smoke of paddy straw and knots in cloth.

Theirs is something else.

The distant field had now disappeared into darkness.

The smoke could no longer be seen.

But its smell remained for a while.

The stories of those who left are like that too.

The people themselves are no longer before one's eyes.

Yet their labour, money, worry, absence, return - something or other remains in the air.

I rose from the bench outside the shop.

My grandson asked, "Will we count the smoke again tomorrow?"

I said, "No."

"Then?"

"Tomorrow we will watch the morning bus."

Whether he understood or not, I do not know.

I set off towards home.

The shop remained behind me.

The road lay ahead.

Tomorrow people would leave again along that road.

Some would return.

Some would not.

The smoke belonged only to this evening.

The story of migration was much larger than it.

The Silent Village

The afternoon bus dropped Devanath on the main road and moved on.

When the bus dust settled, the road was empty again.

It was still a kos and a half on foot to the village.

Once, three rickshaws used to stand at this bend.

Today only an overturned handcart lay in the shade of the peepal tree.

Devanath tucked his bag under his arm and took the footpath.

He had returned with the intention of spending a night in his village after twenty-four years.

He had come from time to time in between, but each time he had arrived well into the day and left before evening.

This time the reason was different.

The rear wall of the old house had cracked during the rains.

His younger brother had said on the phone, "Take out whatever timber can be saved. If the roof comes down, nothing will remain."

His sister had said, "Keep two of the old doorframes. They are from Babu's time."

Devanath had said, "We'll see."

It was easy to say, "We'll see."

As he reached the village path, he understood how large the meaning of seeing could become.

The first house belonged to Ghuran Mahato.

There was a rusted lock on the door.

In one corner of the verandah there was no straw now, only dust gathered there.

Without stopping, Devanath said, "Ghuran Kaka, where did your bamboo bench go?"

Hearing his own voice, he stopped short.

Ghuran Kaka had died ten years earlier.

His son lived in Surat with his family.

The house had not been sold.

The bench, however, was gone.

Looking at the lock, Devanath said again, "You did right. It would have rotted in the rains."

There was no one to answer.

He moved on.

The second house belonged to Ramsakhi Kaki.

All three of her daughters lived away.

For her last five years, Ramsakhi Kaki had lived with her eldest daughter and had died there.

The tulsi altar in front of the house was broken, but a wild plant had grown inside it.

Looking at the altar, Devanath said, "You wouldn't even drink water before tending the tulsi."

The wind blew.

Dry leaves rustled.

Devanath immediately shook his head.

"That is not an answer," he said softly.

Not for anyone to hear.

The village's main lane was as broad as before, yet its breadth now looked greater.

Once, at every doorway there had been a cot, utensils, children, goats, bicycles, sacks of grain, conversation—something or other.

Now the lane was clean.

So clean that it seemed unnatural.

Several houses had fresh paint.

Two houses had gleaming iron gates.

A large water tank stood on the roof of one house.

Devanath laughed.

"The houses got built and the people left," he said.

At once his own sentence seemed incomplete to him.

People had not left because they had built houses.

Someone had found a job in the city.

Someone's son had gone away to study and settled there.

Someone's family could no longer manage after the land was divided among five brothers.

Someone had to go away for treatment.

Someone married in the city.

Someone opened a shop.

Someone simply felt that the children's education would be better if they lived outside.

The village had not emptied in a single day.

One door after another slowly opened less often.

One hearth after another burned less often.

One night after another passed with a house without people in it.

And after a few years, emptiness became normal.

The house of Devanath's childhood friend Bisesar stood in the middle of the lane.

The gate was not locked.

He pushed it and it opened with a creak.

Grass had grown in the courtyard.

A blue line of paint was still visible on the wall.

Years ago, Bisesar's father had whitewashed the wall only up to that height.

Devanath and Bisesar used to throw a ball against that wall.

"Bisesar," Devanath called, "did you ever find your ball again?"

That day the ball had gone onto the roof and had never been found.

Bisesar now sold motor parts in Pune.

He was alive.

They had spoken on the phone only last month.

Devanath felt like laughing.

"Why am I speaking to a living man's house as though he were dead?"
 He asked himself.
 The courtyard gave no answer.
 He came back out.
 At the end of the lane there had once been a grocery shop.
 The shop's wooden shutters were closed.
 The old lettering above had half faded away.
 Of 'Janata Bhandar', only 'ta bha' remained clear.
 Devanath ran his hand over the shutter.
 "Ramcharittar Bhaiya, are you still keeping the credit accounts?"
 Ramcharittar was alive, but in Ahmedabad with his son.
 The shop had closed five years earlier.
 A page bearing Devanath's old credit account must once have been in this shop's ledger.
 No one knew whether that page still existed.
 He sat down on the platform in the middle of the village.
 Far away, a tractor could be seen working in a field.
 So the land was not empty.
 Cultivation continued.
 Only the owners of the fields no longer lived beside them.
 Lease, sharecropping, wage labour—whatever arrangement worked, the work went on.
 Devanath opened his bag and drank water.
 Then his phone rang.
 It was his younger brother.
 "Reached?"
 "Yes."
 "Seen the house?"
 "Not yet."
 "The mason will come tomorrow morning. He'll look at the timber and quote a price."
 "Yes."
 "Don't go near the roof. It's weak."
 "All right."
 "Who's there in the village?"
 Devanath looked around.
 The question was simple, the answer difficult.
 "At the moment, I can't see anyone."
 His brother was silent for a few moments.
 "Will you stay the night?"
 "I will."
 "Alone?"
 Devanath laughed.
 "The houses are here, aren't they?"
 Laughter came from the other end of the phone too.
 "Do the houses talk?"

Devanath wanted to say, ask me.

Instead he said, "I'll tell you tomorrow."

He got up.

His own house was at the rear of the village.

There were five more houses on the way.

A new lock gleamed on the door of one house.

The wall had fresh paint.

Devanath recognised it—Durganand's house.

The family lived in Delhi.

Every year they came for three or four days during Durga Puja.

The house stayed closed all year and then suddenly opened.

The courtyard was washed.

Smoke rose from the kitchen.

Clothes dried on the roof.

Children ran about.

Then the lock went back on.

"You live only four days a year," Devanath said to the house.

As soon as the sentence left his mouth, he stopped again.

Whether a house lives or dies is language made by human beings.

Brick and stone merely endure their condition.

He moved on.

On the outer wall of one house, the names of several cities had been scratched.

Some child must have carved them with a knife during a holiday—Delhi, Surat, Jaipur, Kathmandu.

Devanath read the words.

It seemed as though the village's four directions had been written on the wall.

Once, directions meant north, south, east, west.

Now directions also meant cities where one found work.

When he reached his own house, he fell silent.

The door was not as he had left it.

The wood at the bottom had swollen.

He had to turn the key three times to open the lock.

When he pushed the door inward, a fine smell of earth came out.

There was no single memory in that smell.

Many things were there at once.

Sacks of paddy.

Wet shoes.

Old clothes.

Termite-eaten wood.

Closed rooms.

And years of air that had not been able to enter.

Standing at the doorway, Devanath said, "I've come."

This time he knew clearly that he was addressing the house.

"It's been a long time, I know."

He took out the key and put it in his pocket.

"I'll have to take something from you."

The house was silent.
 "The roof timber."
 The house was silent.
 "My sister says to save two doorframes."
 The silence remained the same.
 Devanath understood the convenience of that silence.
 Talking to a living person is difficult.
 A person asks questions.
 A person objects.
 A person says—this is my share.
 A person says—I will not sell this.
 A person reminds you of old decisions.
 A house says nothing.
 So a human being can put whatever he likes into its mouth.
 Devanath went inside.
 In the first room stood Babu's old cot.
 The rope had rotted away.
 A clock hung on the wall, without hands.
 His mother had once said, "Don't throw this clock away; I received it at the time
 of the wedding."
 When his mother died, the clock stayed here.
 Devanath reached out to take it down, then stopped.
 "What am I to do with you?" he asked—not the clock, but the room.
 After a while he answered himself, "Stay here."
 The window of the second room was broken.
 Tiny footprints of some creature marked the dust.
 In one corner lay his sister's old brass-coloured trunk.
 Empty.
 After her marriage, his sister had taken her clothes and left the trunk behind.
 "You want a doorframe," Devanath murmured.
 He did not see his sister here.
 Neither as she had been in childhood nor as she was now.
 Only the sentence remained in memory.
 He felt relieved by that difference.
 Memory does not always make a human figure and stand it in front of us.
 Sometimes only something once said remains.
 Until evening, he went on opening the windows of the house.
 Where they opened, air came in.
 Where they were jammed, he left them alone.
 Outside, the sun was setting.
 The village's silence was now different from the silence of the afternoon.
 Metallic sounds came from far away.
 Someone was bringing a machine back from the fields.
 A bus horn sounded from the direction of the main road.
 A dog barked.
 Then silence again.

Devanath thought of sweeping the courtyard, then left it.
There was no point in cleaning everything for a single night.
He spread a mat on the verandah.
From his bag he took out rotis, fried vegetables, and pickle.
As he began to eat, Shyamlal's closed house came into view opposite.
Shyamlal used to quarrel with his father over the boundary ridge between their fields.

The two would argue all day, then sit on the same bench in the evening and chew tobacco.

Shyamlal had died.

His son was in Kolkata.

Breaking off a piece of roti, Devanath said, "Shyamlal Kaka, if Babu were alive now, would the two of you quarrel over the emptiness of this lane too?"

He smiled at his own question.

"You would say—your son ran away first."

"Babu would say—your son sold his house first."

He laughed.

The laughter stayed in the empty courtyard for a moment.

Then Devanath grew serious.

"We did not run away," he said.

He could not decide for whom he had said it.

"There was work."

"There were children."

"There were expenses."

"There was illness."

"There was too little land."

He kept eating his roti.

"And there was convenience too," he added at last.

That was the hardest sentence.

Life outside had not remained only a compulsion.

Many people found hospitals closer there.

They found better schools.

Markets, earnings, travel, work—everything became easier.

The wish to return to the village and the wish to live permanently in the village were not the same thing.

Devanath had known this before too.

Sitting today among the empty houses, it became clearer.

Night did not become completely dark.

The exterior electric lights of several houses came on by themselves at their set time.

Some families in distant cities had arranged for the lights to switch on every evening.

Five or seven yellow lights began to glow in the empty lane.

Devanath came outside and looked.

In the light, for a moment the village seemed inhabited.

But no door opened.

No one called a name.
 No one asked for water.
 Devanath said to one house, "Your light is certainly on time."
 To another he said, "Will your gate open again, or not until Puja this time too?"
 To a third—"Grass is growing on your roof; send word to your owner."
 Then he laughed at himself.
 "Who am I to send word?"
 Just then the sound of a motorcycle came from the lane behind.
 A young man stopped at his gate, taking off his helmet.
 At first Devanath did not recognise him.
 The young man said, "Dev Kaka?"
 He was Amresh, Ramcharittar's grandson.
 He lived in town but came once a week to look after the fields.
 "Baba said you had come," Amresh said.
 Devanath was surprised.
 "How did he know?"
 "Bisesar Kaka phoned him. You opened the gate to his courtyard, didn't you?"
 Devanath burst out laughing.
 "It wasn't locked."
 "He said some neighbour sent him a photograph."
 The empty village was not entirely without eyes.
 Sometimes labourers in the fields saw things.
 Sometimes people passing along the road saw them.
 Sometimes a photograph reached someone by phone.
 The houses were closed; the relationships were not.
 Amresh handed him a container of milk and two bananas.
 "If you need anything at night, phone me."
 "Where are you?"
 "I've built a new house near the main road."
 "Why not in the village?"
 Amresh laughed.
 "Who would I talk to here at night?"
 Devanath laughed too.
 Amresh left.
 The sound of the motorcycle slowly merged into the main road.
 Devanath put the container inside.
 Then he understood that the village had emptied not merely because people had left the village.
 The centre itself had shifted.
 The shops were on the road.
 The new houses were on the road.
 The clinic was on the road.
 The bus was on the road.
 The village's old centre had now become its edge.
 That night he slept on the verandah.
 Sleep did not come at once.

Sometimes there was the scratching of rats in the roof.
 Sometimes the wood creaked.
 Once the door of the rear room moved by itself.
 Devanath sat up.
 It was the wind.
 He went to the door and wedged it properly.
 "Enough," he said, "don't make a story out of it."
 He said this to himself.
 It was easy to turn the village's emptiness into fear.
 But reality was less dramatic than fear and lasted much longer.
 People had left one by one.
 Houses had closed one by one.
 There had been no miracle.
 No one had vanished in a single night.
 That ordinary process was precisely why the silence was deeper.
 At dawn, the sound of a dog woke him.
 The sun had not yet risen.
 A pale light, like mist, lay in the lane.
 Devanath stepped outside.
 The shapes of the closed houses looked grey.
 He looked from one side to another.
 Today he spoke to no one.
 For a while he simply listened.
 The sound of a pump in the distance.
 A bird's call.
 A vehicle on the main road.
 And wind between the houses.
 That was all.
 When the sun rose, the mason Nandu arrived with two labourers.
 He was from the neighbouring village.
 Looking at the house, he said, "The rear roof should be taken down. Two beams
 are sound; the rest are weak."
 Devanath said, "Take out whatever is safe."
 Nandu asked, "These doorframes too?"
 "Save two."
 "Why?"
 Devanath wanted to mention his sister's request.
 Then he simply said, "Someone wants them."
 The work began.
 At the first blow, dust fell inside the house.
 Devanath stood outside and watched.
 He had feared that as the timber came out, something would feel unbearable.
 Nothing like that happened.
 Wood came out as wood.
 The nails were rusted.
 One beam was hollow inside.

The other beam really was still usable.
 Nandu set it aside.
 "This will sell," he said.
 Devanath nodded.
 The things in a house had their own value.
 Separate from emotion.
 This did not hurt him.
 If anything, it brought some relief.
 By afternoon, the rear roof had been taken down.
 The sky became visible directly inside the room.
 Devanath went in and looked up.
 In childhood, lying in this room, he used to look at stars through a small gap between the tiles.
 Now the whole sky was open.
 He said to the house, "Half your roof is gone."
 At once he wanted to invent an answer himself—'Half your life went away too.'
 But he did not say the sentence aloud.
 Enough human meaning had already been loaded onto the house.
 He simply came out of the room.
 As Nandu separated the doorframes, he asked, "Kaka, weren't you afraid alone last night?"
 Devanath said, "No."
 "No one lives here."
 "I saw that."
 "People say old houses make sounds."
 Devanath looked at him.
 "Wood makes sounds."
 Nandu laughed.
 "And people?"
 Devanath smiled too.
 "People's voices come on the phone."
 In the afternoon his younger brother phoned again.
 Devanath told him the account of the timber.
 He also told him that two doorframes had been set aside for their sister.
 His brother asked, "Is the house very bad?"
 Devanath looked at the roofless room before him.
 "The house is old," he said.
 "Bad?"
 "Old."
 He deliberately chose no other word.
 After ending the call, he went for one more walk through the village.
 This time the lane did not seem quite so silent.
 Perhaps because he had begun to understand the routes inside the silence.
 The people of this house were in Delhi.
 The people of that house were in Surat.
 The people of the third house were in Janakpur.

The daughter of the fourth house was in Biratnagar after marriage.
The son of the fifth had opened a shop in Darbhanga.
No house was a complete story.
It was only a place whose story was now continuing elsewhere.
Devanath again reached Ghuran Kaka's house.
The rusted lock was as before.
Yesterday he had asked here where the bamboo bench had gone.
Today he asked nothing.
He also stopped beside Ramsakhi Kaki's tulsi altar.
The wild plant moved in the wind.
He did not take it for an answer.
This time he closed Bisesar's gate.
As he fastened it, he said, "I had opened your house."
That was all.
At the last bend of the lane he turned and looked back.
Not a single person was visible.
Even so, the village no longer looked to him like a row of dead people.
Dead people do not return to work in cities.
Dead people do not open their houses at Puja.
Dead people do not ask about the fields by phone.
Dead people do not install new gates.
The people of these houses were alive.
Life had simply spread beyond this lane.
The houses were silent.
The people were not.
Devanath returned to his own house.
Nandu was tying up the timber.
Two doorframes stood separately against the wall.
The sun was beginning to set.
Devanath locked the door.
Tomorrow he would return to the city again.
No one knew how many more days the house would remain standing.
He pulled the lock once to check it.
Then said softly, "I'm leaving."
This time he did not wait for an answer.
He crossed the lane and moved on.
No sound came from behind him.
And what did not come, Devanath did not try to turn into a voice and hear.

Between Three Years

When sixty-eight-year-old Anima Devi lifted the shutter of her shop halfway and stepped inside, the first thing she did was not dust the chair but open the cover of the old typewriter.

The machine no longer worked.

Two letter keys on the right had sunk inward, the ribbon had dried out, and a fine crack had appeared in the roller that fed the paper.

Even so, she opened it every morning and looked at it.

The shop's name was still written above: "Anima Writing Service."

Below the name, in smaller letters, a new strip had been added: online applications, document copies, printing, identity-card copies.

Her granddaughter Neha had made that strip.

Neha used to say, "Nani, the moment people hear 'Writing Service', they think only letters are written here."

Anima would say, "That is what people used to come for."

"And now?"

"Now people come to make what they have written count as something they can rely on."

Neha always laughed at that answer.

That day Neha was switching on the computer and connecting the wires. The old fan in the shop creaked as it turned. Outside, the Bhadon sun seemed pasted to the road.

For two months there had been talk of selling the shop.

The main road had widened. The chemist's shop next door had grown three times larger, two new printing centres had opened ahead, and Anima's son Manoj kept saying it made no sense for her to come and sit there every day for so little income.

Manoj's calculation was not wrong.

Anima's knees hurt when she climbed stairs. She had already had eye surgery. There was some pension income at home, and even without selling, the shop could be rented out.

And yet "it does not make sense" and "it is not necessary" are not the same thing - this was something Anima could never quite explain to anyone.

Neha was bent over the computer screen.

"Nani, shall we keep all these old file bundles?"

"Keep whatever is useful."

"Which of them is useful?"

Instead of answering, Anima pressed one key on the typewriter.

The key rose halfway and stopped.

At once she remembered her own right index finger at eighteen.

On that finger there had been not kajal but a stain of blue ink.

There was no shop that day.

There was not even the idea of a shop.

At eighteen, Anima stood on the veranda outside a typing-training centre in Darbhanga. In her hand was a college admission form, under her arm a cloth bag, and in her mind a faint irritation.

She had not come to learn typing.

Her maternal uncle had said, "For admission, it will look better if the application is neatly typed. Get it done in the market."

Anima had assumed it would be a matter of two minutes.

Inside, seven typewriters clattered together. At first the sound seemed to her like drops of different sizes striking a roof in a hard rain.

Avadhesh Babu, the instructor seated behind the desk, read the application.

"Name?"

"Anima Mishra."

"Subject?"

"History."

"Did you fill in this 'History' yourself?"

"Yes."

"Your handwriting is good."

That ordinary remark pleased Anima greatly. At home no one paid attention to her handwriting. Writing was a thing for use - lists, accounts, letters, copies.

Avadhesh Babu began typing the application.

Anima kept watching the letter keys.

At first glance, Devanagari typing seemed tangled to her. Letters that sat beside one another on paper lay far apart on the keys.

"Why is the order like this?" she asked.

Avadhesh Babu looked up over his spectacles.

"Are you going to type?"

"No."

"Then what does the order matter to you?"

Anima fell silent.

The answer did not insult her; it made her curious.

The application was finished.

Carbon paper had been placed beneath the sheet. One act of typing produced two copies.

Anima held both copies in her hands and looked at them for a long time.

The same words in two places, but the second copy lighter because the pressure differed.

At the time it seemed to her simply a small marvel of paper.

The moment she stepped outside, it began to rain.

Not the fierce rain of Bhadon; the sudden, dense, slanting rain of Asadh.

Anima stopped on the veranda.

The trainees left one by one. Someone opened an umbrella; someone ran across the road.

Avadhesh Babu said, "Sit until the rain stops."

Anima sat before an empty typewriter.

"Put your hands on it," Avadhesh Babu said.

"Me?"

"The paper is waste. Practise."

He turned over an old government circular and fed it into the roller.

Anima pressed the first key.

The letter landed crooked.

The second time, two letters jammed together.

The third time, the roller did not move forward.

She burst out laughing.

The rain had blurred the road beyond the veranda. Inside, Anima began searching for one letter at a time and typing her own name.

Anima.

Then Anima.

Then Anima.

In the third name, the letters for "ni" went down in reverse order.

Without saying anything, Avadhesh Babu freed the jammed keys.

When she returned home that evening, her mother looked at the application, asked the fee, and told her to change her clothes.

No one asked what she had done while waiting for the rain to stop.

Anima did not tell them either.

She was admitted to college.

She studied history.

Two years later she was married.

For many years after that season, the typewriter did not re-enter her life.

Sixty-eight-year-old Anima put the cover back over the typewriter.

Neha asked, "You are not going to throw this away?"

"No."

"It does not work."

"Not everything is kept in order to work."

"Then why?"

Anima laughed.

"I will answer that question when I become old."

Neha widened her eyes.

"You are not old yet?"

"I am still thinking about it."

A young woman came and stood outside the shop, carrying a stack of papers.

"Maiji, I need to fill out a hostel application."

Neha immediately turned a chair towards her.

"Sit."

The young woman sat down.

She gave her name as Aarti Paswan. She wanted to go to university for a postgraduate degree in history.

"History?" Anima repeated without meaning to.

Aarti said, "Yes, but everyone says, what work will I get with this subject?"

Neha kept entering the details on the computer.

Anima said nothing.

At thirty-seven, Anima had heard that kind of sentence often - "What will come of this work?"

That day, when she was thirty-seven, was in the month of Chait.

Dust was blowing in the afternoon.

Anima's husband, Mahesh, worked regularly in a cloth shop. The household ran; there was neither much comfort nor such scarcity that one day's income would change everything.

Two children were in school. Her mother-in-law was ill. The routine of the house ran largely according to Anima's time, but no separate value had ever been set on that time.

Anima taught the children at home. Sometimes she wrote a neighbour's application, sometimes prepared in neat handwriting a list of names for a wedding invitation. For most of this work people said thank you, not money.

Typing now came to her only in a formal, half-remembered way.

In her first year of college, her maternal uncle had insisted on enrolling her in that same training centre - "Learn a skill. It will not go to waste."

Anima had learned typing for six months. The certificate lay in a trunk.

On that day in Chait, her neighbour Shakuntala came running.

"Anima, come with me."

"Where?"

"Near the court. My brother's land application has to be submitted today, and the typist has not come."

At first Anima refused.

It was time to give her mother-in-law her medicine. It was nearly time for the children to return. Mahesh was not at home.

Shakuntala said, "Only half an hour."

By then Anima had learned that half an hour is never merely half an hour.

Even so, she went.

Near the court, an old typewriter stood in a half-built room. The owner, Ramlochan Das, had gone to eat. His son sat bored on a chair.

Shakuntala held out the papers.

"Didi knows typing."

The boy looked at Anima as though the information were not credible but amusing.

"You can do it?"

Anima sat down.

The moment her hands touched the keys, the old practice returned to her body from somewhere.

The first line slowly.

The second faster.

By the third, her fingers no longer had to search for the letters.

Shakuntala watched in silence.

The application was a page and a half.

In the middle, one name had been spelt incorrectly. Anima stopped over the source paper and asked again.

"Is this 'Ramvriksh' or 'Rambriksh'?"

Shakuntala said, "How would I know?"

Anima refused to type it without being certain.

Her brother's older papers were sent for. The name was "Ramvriksh."
 "What difference can that little thing make?" the boy said.
 Anima replied, "A small difference on paper can become a large one later."
 As she said it, she did not remember her own application at eighteen.
 Memory does not always understand when an occasion has arrived.
 The work was completed.
 Ramlochan returned and looked at the paper.
 "Who typed it?"
 Shakuntala pointed towards Anima.
 Ramlochan looked over the page from top to bottom.
 "It is clean."
 He tried to give Anima five rupees.
 Anima refused.
 Shakuntala caught her hand and said, "Take it. It is payment for the work."
 Anima refused again.
 Ramlochan said, "If you do not take payment, next time people will treat your work as a favour, not as work."
 Anima did not like that sentence.
 Even so, she took the five rupees.
 On the way home she kept the five rupees separately inside her bag.
 It was very little money.
 At the time milk sold for one and a half rupees a quarter-seer. A child's monthly school fee was more than five rupees. The house rent was several times that.
 Five rupees could not run a household.
 But that day, for the first time, Anima felt in her hand a separate price for her own time.
 When she reached home, her mother-in-law was annoyed. The medicine was half an hour late.
 Mahesh had also returned.
 "Where had you gone?"
 "With Shakuntala."
 "Why?"
 Anima showed him the five rupees.
 Mahesh laughed at first.
 "For this much?"
 The sentence stung Anima.
 But Mahesh immediately added, "I mean, why did they give you so little?"
 Anima was never certain what that first laugh had meant or what the second sentence meant.
 Many things in marriage are like that - once an interpretation is formed, it keeps changing for years.
 That night the two of them did the sums.
 One corner of Ramlochan's shop was empty. She could sit there for two hours in the morning and evening. Typing work might come.
 Mahesh said, "The children?"
 Anima said, "They will be at school in the afternoon."

"Ma?"

"I will give her medicine on time before I go."

"The house?"

Anima laughed in a tired voice.

"Where will the house run away?"

Mahesh laughed too.

Two weeks later Anima began sitting in that corner.

At first on Ramlochan's machine.

Six months later she bought an old machine on instalments.

Two years later she rented a small room of her own.

Ramlochan suggested the name, "Anima Typing Centre."

Anima looked at the paper on which it had been written in Hindi letters and said, "Write 'Writing Service'."

"You type, and you want to call it Writing Service?"

"People also come to have things written."

This time Ramlochan laughed.

Anima did not mind the laughter.

In the shop of sixty-eight-year-old Anima, Aarti's application was completed.

Neha said, "We need a copy of the income certificate."

Aarti turned out her bag.

"Here it is."

"Shall I select the scholarship option?"

Aarti immediately said, "Yes."

Anima kept looking at her face.

At eighteen, Anima had filled out her own scholarship application, but it had been mentioned so casually at home that later she did not even remember how much money it had been.

At thirty-seven, Anima counted her children's fee receipts month after month.

At sixty-eight, Anima had left the pension calculations to Manoj.

Money remains in life, but it does not have the same voice at every age.

Aarti rose after completing the application.

"How much?"

Neha named the amount.

Aarti paid, took the receipt, and went out.

At the doorway she turned back.

"Maiji, what did you do after studying history?"

The question was directed straight at Anima.

Anima smiled.

"I studied history."

Aarti waited.

"After that?"

"Many things that were not history."

"Work?"

Anima swept a hand towards the shop.

"This."

Aarti looked slightly disappointed. Perhaps she wanted a clean answer - study this, sit that examination, get that job.

Anima understood her disappointment.

"Before choosing a subject, do not think life will walk directly behind it. Very often life moves ahead and the subject is left behind. Then one day it comes and stands beside you again."

Aarti probably did not understand it completely.

"All right," she said, and left.

Neha said with a smile, "Nani, you give advice in such a roundabout way."

"Straight advice does not last very long."

Neha began sorting the file bundles again.

An old brown envelope came out.

Inside were three sheets of carbon paper, two receipts, and the first stamp of "Anima Writing Service."

Neha picked up the stamp and read it.

"Shall we keep this?"

Anima wanted to say, "Yes."

But she stopped.

"Put it separately."

"Will that be the keep pile or the throw-away pile?"

"Not decided yet."

Neha raised her eyebrows.

All at once Anima remembered those five rupees from when she was thirty-seven.

She did not remember the colour of the note.

Nor where it had been spent.

She remembered Mahesh's first laugh.

And the sentence that followed it.

But now, at sixty-eight, she was no longer certain that that day had changed her life.

Looking back, people draw lines around small events - the beginning was here, the turning point here, the decision here.

When an event is actually happening, there is no line around it.

That day her mother-in-law's medicine had been late. Her younger son had left his exercise book at school. Mahesh had cut potatoes that night. The neighbour's tap was broken.

Typing was only one part of that day.

That rainy afternoon when she was eighteen too was perhaps not as important as it seemed now.

Perhaps Anima would have found some other work even without a typewriter.

Perhaps she would have studied history and become a teacher.

Perhaps nothing would have changed.

At sixty-eight, Anima was no longer afraid of "perhaps."

Neha asked, "Shall we talk to Manoj Mama today about selling the shop?"

Anima looked out towards the road.

The afternoon was thinning. The shadow of the chemist's shop had reached her threshold.

"We will talk about selling later," she said.

"Then?"

"The shop will not open every day."

"Then?"

"Two days a week."

Neha was silent.

"Will you sit here?"

"Sometimes I will. Sometimes you, if you want."

"Me?"

"Is this computer of yours here or not?"

Neha laughed.

"I have other work."

"Let it be."

"Then why two days?"

Anima ran her hand over the typewriter cover.

"I do not know yet."

Neha was about to say something at that answer when an elderly man came inside carrying a folded paper.

"Daughter, will you write an application for me?"

Neha turned towards the computer.

Anima said, "First listen."

The man sat down. His pension payment had been stopped for two months. He needed to submit an application to the bank. He told the matter in fragments, forgetting dates and then correcting them. The account number was written in a corner of the paper.

Neha kept typing the details.

From time to time Anima asked, "When did you go the first time?" "Whom did you meet?" "Do you have a receipt?"

The application was ready.

Neha placed the printed copy before him.

The elderly man could not read it.

"Read it to me."

Anima read the entire application aloud.

At two places she stopped.

"Did you say this?"

"Yes."

"Is this date correct?"

"Yes."

Then the man put his thumbprint on it.

After he left, Neha said, "This work can be done from home too."

"It can."

"Then why the shop?"

Anima did not answer.

In the evening, before pulling down the shutter, she swept the floor. Neha gathered the wires. One bundle of old papers was set aside for scrap.

The envelope containing the carbon paper still lay in the middle.

Anima opened it.

At one corner of a carbon sheet, old letters pressed into it could be read in reverse.

It was impossible to tell whose typing they had been.

Neha said, "Keep it. Do not think so much."

Anima put the envelope in the drawer.

"All right."

"So it goes in the keep pile?"

"Yes."

"Why?"

This time Anima answered.

"I do not know the reason."

Neha burst out laughing.

Anima laughed too.

The shutter came halfway down. The sunlight outside had softened.

Anima looked inside the shop once.

She did not see the eighteen-year-old girl there.

Nor the thirty-seven-year-old woman.

She had not expected to see either of them.

Those years had passed; they were not characters hidden inside the present.

But even now, from time to time, her fingers could recognise the distance between letters without looking.

From outside Neha said, "Nani, lock it."

Anima put on the lock.

Whether the shop would open two days a week or whether the decision would change again was not certain.

Many decisions in her life had earlier been made within just such incomplete certainty.

At eighteen she had wanted to study history.

At thirty-seven she had learned to accept payment of five rupees.

At sixty-eight she was accepting that no single day can fully explain the meaning of another day.

Three days were not a life.

But the years between those three days had left their shadows in her walk, her fingers, her silences, and the way she wrote her own name.

As they crossed the road, Neha took her arm.

Anima did not pull her hand away.

The two of them walked slowly towards home.

The Reason to Return

When fifty-nine-year-old Madhavi Jha got off at Darbhanga's old bus stand, for the first time she did not feel that she had returned home.

She felt she had arrived at a place whose measurements her body already knew, but which her eyes were learning again.

Across from the bus stand, where there had once been two paan shops and a cobbler, there was now a glass-fronted chemist's shop.

The road had widened.

At the turn on the right, the old sweet shop still had the same name, but the tables inside had changed.

Madhavi tucked her small bag under her arm and, instead of taking a rickshaw, began to walk.

Her brother Vinod had said clearly, "Didi, you're carrying so much. I'll send a vehicle."

Madhavi had replied, "I can walk."

Vinod had laughed. "Living abroad has made you forget the heat here."

That was only half true.

She remembered the heat.

What she had forgotten was the sequence of smells that came along the road when one walked home through that heat.

First the hot dust.

Then kachri frying in mustard oil.

Then the drain.

Then the smell of soap from clothes drying in the sun in someone's courtyard.

And finally, as she neared the lane of her parents' house, the mingled smell of mango leaves and old brick.

That last smell was gone now.

Three old houses in the lane had been demolished and replaced by new multi-storeyed buildings.

Her parents' house still stood, but the blue paint on the gate was peeling.

The moment she opened the gate, Vinod came out.

"You walked?"

"Yes."

"I told you -"

"I know."

Vinod took her bag.

Madhavi stepped through the gate.

The courtyard seemed small.

She had this feeling in every old house - the measurements of childhood were always larger than the actual ones.

On the veranda, her sister-in-law Kiran was shaking out a sheet.
She hurried over, embraced Madhavi, and at once said, "I've cleaned your room."
Madhavi smiled.

"My room?"

Kiran smiled too. "The room that used to be yours."

The house was Vinod's now.

On paper, all three siblings still had a share, but Vinod was the one who lived there.

Their elder brother Arun had settled in Delhi.

Madhavi had been living abroad for twenty-four years.

Neither of their parents was alive now.

For the past year they had been discussing selling the house.

Vinod's son had gone away for work.

Arya, his daughter, was now at university.

Kiran's knees hurt.

Every year, repairing such a large old house became more expensive.

At last the three siblings had agreed: the house should be sold.

Madhavi's signature was required.

She could have sent it by post as well.

Vinod had said that twice.

The third time Madhavi had said, "I will come myself."

Vinod had not asked why.

He had assumed Didi wanted to see the house one last time.

Kiran had assumed perhaps Madhavi would feel better seeing the division of shares in person.

Arya thought her aunt might oppose the sale of the house.

Madhavi was in no hurry to correct any of those three assumptions.

First she bathed.

Then she sat on the veranda for tea.

Kiran asked, "Was the journey all right?"

"Fine."

"Straight from there?"

"Yes."

"You must be tired."

"Not yet."

Vinod placed a file of papers on the table.

"The lawyer will come at eleven tomorrow. Read these first."

Madhavi looked at the file, then at Arya.

Arya was sitting at the edge of the veranda, underlining something in a book.

She looked up.

"Bua, are you really going to let the house be sold?"

Kiran immediately interrupted. "Don't start again."

Arya closed the book.

"I only asked."

Madhavi said, "Vinod is not selling the house as one individual. We have all agreed."

Arya said nothing.
A little later she got up and went inside.
Madhavi kept looking at her back.
At seventeen, Madhavi too had gone inside from this very veranda.
The only difference was that she had not been carrying a book then, but an admission form.

It had been raining that day.
Her father had read the admission form and asked, "You want to go to Patna?"
Madhavi had said, "Yes."
"When did you apply for this?"
"Through school."
"Did you ask me?"
Madhavi had remained silent.
Her father had asked again, "Where will you stay?"
"In the hostel."
"No."

One word.
At that age, one word can become an entire wall.
Madhavi's mother, Sharda Devi, had been standing near the kitchen doorway.
Madhavi had wanted her to say something on her daughter's side.
She had said, "First listen to what Babu is saying."
Nothing had broken inside Madhavi.
She had simply hardened.
"The entrance examination is the day after tomorrow."
Her father folded the newspaper.
"Then you won't take it."
Madhavi had looked at her mother.
Sharda Devi had turned her eyes away.
Later, that scene was told many times in the family.
"Madhavi became stubborn from that very day."
"She wouldn't listen to anyone."
"She left home for her studies."

It was a short story, easy to remember, and it gave everyone a clear role.
The father was harsh.
The mother weak.
The daughter rebellious.
Even after Madhavi moved abroad, she kept hearing this story on the phone.
She never corrected it.
Because for seventeen years she herself did not know the second half of the story.
In the present, Arya called from inside, "Bua, may I open your old trunk?"
Madhavi was startled.
"Which trunk?"
"The green one in the upstairs room. Ma says it's yours."
Kiran said, "You left a lot of things when you went away. Books, notebooks, magazines."
Madhavi stood up.

The upstairs room had once been used for storing grain.
 Later it became a place for things no one needed.
 The trunk was the same one.
 The green paint had almost disappeared.
 There was no lock.
 Arya lifted the lid.
 Inside were old books, three notebooks, a woollen sweater, two boxes of glass bangles, and papers wrapped in cloth.
 Madhavi picked up the first book.
 A Maithili grammar.
 She laughed.
 "Was this your favourite book?" Arya asked.
 "No."
 "Then why are you laughing?"
 Madhavi opened the book.
 Nothing fell out from between the pages.
 She paused for a moment.
 She remembered that something should have fallen out.
 Memory can sometimes be more stubborn than objects.
 That night when she was seventeen, after her father had gone to sleep, Madhavi had not been crying in her room.
 She had been folding clothes.
 She had already decided that she would take the first bus in the morning and sit the examination.
 Where she would stay, what she would do after the examination - none of it was clear.
 The door had opened softly.
 Sharda Devi had entered.
 She had that same grammar book in her hand.
 She said, "Why have you spread your clothes out here?"
 Madhavi did not answer.
 Her mother put the book on the table.
 "Don't take so many clothes."
 Madhavi looked at her.
 "I am going."
 "I know."
 Those two words undid all of Madhavi's hardness.
 "Babu -"
 "Babu will go to the market in the morning. The first bus is at half past five."
 Madhavi could not understand what was happening.
 Sharda Devi opened the book at a page in the middle.
 Inside was enough money for the bus fare, the examination fee, and two days' expenses.
 "Take this."
 Madhavi did not take the money.
 "Why did you say in the daytime -"

"In the daytime I said what had to be said."

"You stopped me."

"If I had stood there openly on your side, your father would have torn up the admission form."

Madhavi was silent.

Sharda Devi said again, "Not every battle is fought by standing in front of someone."

For years that sentence remained word for word in Madhavi's memory.

Later the words changed.

Sometimes she remembered, "Not everything is said from the front."

Sometimes, "Not every road goes out through the door."

She was no longer certain what her mother had actually said.

But the money had been inside the book.

Her mother had known the bus time.

And in the morning, satt, chura and two lemons had been tied up in the kitchen.

Of those three things she had no doubt.

Turning the pages, Arya said, "There's nothing in this."

Madhavi returned to the present.

"There used to be."

"What?"

"Money."

Arya laughed. "Old treasure?"

"To some extent."

She handed the book to Arya.

"Keep it."

"Do I have to read the grammar?"

"Reading it isn't compulsory. There won't be any money in the book."

Arya looked at her face and understood that the remark was half a joke.

At lunch, the discussion about selling the house began again.

Vinod said, "The buyer will demolish the house. He's buying it for the land."

Kiran said softly, "It feels bad to hear that."

Madhavi asked, "If we preserve the house, who will live in it?"

Kiran was silent.

Vinod said, "I could stay, but the roof, the drains, the walls - the expense of everything."

"Then sell it."

Arya kept mixing rice on her plate.

"Doesn't it make you sad at all?" she suddenly asked.

Madhavi said, "It does."

"Then why sell it?"

"Sadness is not a practical plan."

Vinod almost laughed, but Arya did not.

That night Madhavi slept in her old room.

The tree outside the window had been cut down.

The ceiling fan was new.

The wall was painted in a pale colour Kiran had chosen.
 The room was not a museum.
 She liked that.
 Before going to sleep, she opened her phone.
 Her daughter Nilima, abroad, had sent a message: "Have you reached?"
 Madhavi wrote, "Yes."
 Nilima wrote again, "Did you cry when you saw the house?"
 Madhavi replied, "No."
 A little later she added, "Not yet."
 She put the phone down.
 That night she clearly remembered the journey she had made in middle age.
 She had been forty-two then.
 She had been living abroad for twelve years.
 Her two children were in school.
 Her work was stable.
 Her father had died.
 Her mother was living alone in this house, though Vinod lived nearby.
 Madhavi had come for five weeks.
 During that visit, one night the electricity went out.
 Mother and daughter sat on the veranda, fanning themselves with hand fans.
 Madhavi could not remember how the conversation had reached the day of the entrance examination.
 Perhaps her mother had said, "When you were Arya's age..."
 Arya had not even been born then; perhaps they had been talking about some other girl.
 Memory does not always preserve the edges of events accurately.
 Madhavi had suddenly asked, "Did you really want to send me that day?"
 Sharda Devi had stopped moving the fan.
 "You're asking this now?"
 "Yes."
 "There is a difference between wanting to send you and not wanting to stop you."
 Madhavi waited for the rest of the answer.
 Her mother said, "Your father was not a bad man. But the idea of a daughter living away from home frightened him."
 "Didn't it frighten you?"
 "It did."
 "Then why did you give me the money?"
 Sharda Devi began fanning herself again.
 "Does fear make it necessary to close the road?"
 Madhavi was silent.
 A little later her mother said, "Your stubbornness gave me an excuse."
 "An excuse?"
 "People said, 'The girl would not listen.' Fine. That suited me."
 For the first time Madhavi understood that the story the family had used for years as proof of her rebellion had also been a shield for her mother.
 Sharda Devi had never named her own decision as support.

Nor had she ever said, I sent my daughter.
 She had simply made sure that the door did not close completely.
 That night Madhavi had asked, "Then why did you never tell everyone later?"
 Her mother laughed.
 "What changes if everything is told to everyone?"
 Madhavi had said, "It would have changed things for me."
 This time Sharda Devi did not laugh.
 "Now you know."
 Madhavi had not been entirely satisfied with that answer.
 At forty-two she had felt that a truth discovered late was of less use.
 At fifty-nine she felt that a truth discovered late simply had a different use.
 The lawyer arrived before eleven the next day.
 The papers were read.
 The measurement of the land, the shares, the price, the method of payment.
 Madhavi listened patiently to everything.
 The lawyer said, "If you had wanted, you could have sent a power of attorney from abroad."
 Vinod laughed. "I told her that too."
 Madhavi signed and said, "I know."
 The lawyer asked, "Then you came all this way only for this?"
 Madhavi did not stop her pen.
 "No."
 The lawyer perhaps expected the rest of the answer.
 Madhavi added nothing.
 The paperwork was completed.
 In the afternoon Vinod went to the market.
 Kiran went to a ceremony in the neighbourhood.
 Arya was upstairs, sitting beside the trunk.
 Madhavi asked her, "Is there an argument at home about where you want to go?"
 Arya was startled.
 "Ma told you?"
 "No."
 "Then?"
 "Yesterday your questions were more about your own matter than about the price of the house."
 Arya was silent for a while.
 Then she said, "I want to go to Pune. To study conservation of old buildings."
 Madhavi repeated the words slowly. "Conservation of old buildings?"
 Arya laughed. "Studying how to preserve old buildings. Not for this house."
 "Good."
 "Babu says I should do my bachelor's degree here first. Go outside later."
 "Why?"
 "It's far. It costs money. I'll be living alone."
 Madhavi nodded.
 "All three can be genuine reasons."
 Arya asked, "And they might not be?"

"They might not be."
 "Are you on my side?"
 Madhavi did not answer at once.
 "I don't want to think of it as being on your side or against your father."
 Arya's face fell.
 Madhavi said, "But I do want to tell you one story correctly."
 She told her about that night when she was seventeen.
 The admission form.
 Her father's "No."
 Her mother's silence in the daytime.
 The book at night.
 The money for the bus fare.
 The sattu and chura in the morning.
 Arya did not interrupt with a single question.
 Madhavi also told her how the story had changed later in the family.
 She did not say that her mother had been great.
 Nor did she say that her father had been a tyrant.
 She said, "They were both afraid. The only difference was that Ma did not turn her fear into a lock on my road."
 Arya asked softly, "Then you didn't run away from home?"
 "I left home to sit an examination."
 "Without permission."
 "Yes."
 "But Nani helped you."
 "Yes."
 Arya took a long breath.
 "Babu always says, 'Bua went away out of sheer stubbornness, and later everything worked out.'"
 Madhavi smiled.
 "That's half the story."
 "Why didn't you tell us before?"
 At that question, the veranda from when Madhavi was forty-two opened again inside her.
 Her mother's hand fan.
 The darkness.
 "Now you know."
 Madhavi said, "Perhaps I kept feeling it was a matter between me and Nani."
 "And now?"
 "Now it is no longer only mine."
 Whether Arya understood or not, Madhavi was not sure.
 She only said, "The decision about your studies will be made after you talk with your parents. This story is not proof that you should be stubborn."
 "Then?"
 "It is not proof of anything. It is simply about completing an unfinished family story."
 Arya began gathering her books.

"Did you come for this?"

Madhavi had perhaps been waiting for that question from the first day.

She could have said: for the papers of the house.

She could have said: to see the old house one last time.

She could have said: to meet Vinod and Kiran.

None of those reasons was false.

But when she had booked the journey, the face before her had been Arya's.

Three weeks earlier, during a family call, Vinod had laughed and said, "My daughter is trying to become Madhavi Didi too. She says she wants to study outside."

Everyone had laughed.

Arya had not.

Madhavi had not either.

That very night, she had looked for the journey.

Madhavi said, "Yes. To a large extent."

Arya looked at her in surprise.

"For me?"

"So that you do not inherit an incorrect story."

Below, the gate opened.

Vinod had returned.

Arya stood up.

"Will you tell Babu?"

Madhavi said, "I will."

That evening over tea, Madhavi herself raised the matter.

At first Vinod laughed.

"Something this old?"

Madhavi said, "We still use that old story. To explain things to Arya."

Vinod became serious.

He listened to the story.

In the middle he asked, "Ma really gave you the money?"

"Yes."

"She never told me."

"I too understood its full meaning only much later."

Vinod kept looking at the veranda floor.

After a while he said, "Did Babu know?"

"I don't know."

That answer was necessary.

Madhavi did not want to invent a new role for her father out of her own memory.

Kiran asked, "Why didn't Maaji take your side in the daytime?"

Madhavi said, "Perhaps that was her way. Perhaps it was wrong. Perhaps that was all that was possible. I am not certain."

Arya listened silently.

Vinod said again, "So if I am stopping Arya, I have become like Babu?"

"I did not say that."

"But the story -"

"The story will not make the decision."

Madhavi set down her cup of tea.

"You will have to look at the expense. You will have to look at safety. You will have to look at the institution. Arya will also have to show that she is prepared. Just don't use my name as an example and tell only half the story."

Vinod laughed softly.

"That is fair."

Arya did not laugh this time either, but her shoulders relaxed.

The decision to sell the house did not change.

Nor was a decision about Arya's studies made that evening.

Madhavi wanted neither of those things to change at once.

On the third morning she walked around the courtyard.

She did not touch the veranda.

She did not scrape earth from the wall.

She did not take a brick as a keepsake.

She left the green trunk for Arya.

The grammar book too.

"Should I keep all this?" Arya asked.

"As much as you want."

"When the house is demolished?"

"Take out whatever you want before that."

"You won't take anything?"

Madhavi thought.

Then she took an empty notebook from the trunk.

On the first page was her signature from when she was seventeen.

The letters of her name were slightly crooked.

She put the notebook in her bag.

As she was leaving through the gate, Vinod said, "Come back soon this time."

Madhavi asked, "After the house is sold?"

"Can't you come back without the house?"

Madhavi smiled at Vinod's question.

At that moment she understood that signing the papers for the sale of the house had perhaps been the simplest decision of this journey.

The difficult decision had been to return and change an old story.

And harder still was changing it without declaring anyone guilty or innocent.

The rickshaw moved out of the lane.

Madhavi turned back to look at the house.

The gate was half open.

Arya was standing there.

Madhavi raised her hand.

Arya did too.

As the lane turned, the house disappeared from sight.

Madhavi touched the edge of the empty notebook in her bag.

At seventeen she had needed a road.

At forty-two, meaning.

At fifty-nine she understood that sometimes the reason to return is not a place, but a story.

A story whose other half has remained at home for a very long time.

The Sisters

Mridula and Neera met for the third time on the veranda of a school.

Both had grown old.

A mat was spread across the veranda. Eight or ten adolescent girls sat in a circle. In the middle lay cotton cloth, coloured thread, needles, scissors, and round wooden embroidery hoops.

The school was holding a three-day folk-craft workshop.

Neera had been invited as an old member of the village women's group. Mridula as a former art teacher.

The organiser perhaps did not know that the two were sisters.

Even after seeing each other's names on the list, neither had mentioned the fact.

"Make the border first," Neera told the girls. "The flower in the middle can come later."

Mridula immediately said, "It is not necessary to make the border first."

Neera looked at her.

"When did I say it was necessary? It is easier to learn that way."

Mridula picked up a piece of cloth.

"If you understand the central form first, the border will come into proportion by itself."

The girls began looking from one face to the other.

One girl laughed and asked, "Whose advice should we follow?"

Neera said, "Whichever one leaves you with less ruined cloth."

Mridula said, "If you are afraid of ruining something, you will never make anything new."

The two were silent for a moment.

Then Neera smiled.

"See? Even after forty years, she still jumps straight into the middle first."

Mridula laughed too.

"And she is still measuring the border."

To the girls, it sounded like an old joke.

In fact, it was the surviving tone of a very old quarrel.

Their first encounter of this kind had been when both had, for the first time, become women of separate households.

Mridula had been married for two years.

Neera was twenty then and still living in her parental home.

In the month of Sawan, Mridula had come to her parents' house for four days.

Their mother was drying mango leaves in the courtyard.

Neera was in the back room embroidering a vine pattern on cloth with needle and thread.

Mridula went inside and stopped the moment she saw the hoop.

Along the edge of the cloth was a small eye-like shape between two leaves. Then two leaves. Then an eye. Then two leaves.

Mridula took the cloth in her hand.

"Where did you get this from?"

Neera did not raise her head.

"What?"

"This vine."

"A vine is a vine."

"I made this."

Neera pushed the needle into the cloth.

"Yours?"

"Yes. It was in my notebook."

"There were many things in your notebook."

"This was exactly like this."

Only then did Neera raise her head.

"Not exactly like this."

"Two leaves, an eye in between."

"Nani's pillowcase also had two leaves."

"It did not have the eye."

"I made the eye."

Mridula laughed.

"You saw my notebook, then made it, and now you say the eye is yours."

Neera stood up.

"I saw your notebook, yes. But the vine is not yours."

"Then whose is it?"

"Whoever makes it, theirs."

That answer had stung Mridula.

Two years earlier, Mridula had spent hours sitting by the window of that very house making vines and floral motifs. On paper, on the empty margins of old newspapers, on the back pages of books.

Neera used to follow her around then.

"Teach me too."

"First learn to draw a straight line."

"I want flowers."

"Without the line, the flower will come out crooked."

"Let it be crooked."

Mridula used to get irritated.

Now, looking at Neera's cloth, she felt that her younger sister had taken something of hers.

Not only the vine.

Also that earlier time, when both had lived in the same house and no one needed to call anything separately their own.

Neera began gathering up the cloth.

Mridula asked, "Who are you making it for?"

"For the market."

"To sell?"

"Yes."

"My vine?"

"Do not start again."

Neera said that three women in the village were making cloth bags, pillowcases, and tablecloths together. A trader would take them at the market. If they got a good price the first time, they would make more.

The word price made it worse for Mridula.

Seeing a form she had made in someone else's hands was one thing.

Money being earned from that form was another.

"Did you tell them my name?"

Neera was startled.

"Whom?"

"The trader."

"Why would I tell him your name?"

"Because I made the vine."

Neera's face flushed.

"So because you married and left, everything in this house must still carry your name?"

Mridula let go of the cloth.

"How did the house come into this?"

"You brought it in."

"I am only talking about my vine."

"The vine was made in this house."

"I made it."

"And I changed it."

"A little."

"As much as it needed."

Their mother called from the courtyard, "What are you two fighting about again?"

Both answered together, "Nothing."

The four-day visit ended in three.

Mridula returned to her marital home a day early.

When she left, Neera was not on the veranda.

Mridula did not look for her either.

To Mridula, the meaning of that first encounter was clear: Neera had appropriated her design.

To Neera, the meaning was different: even after leaving the house, Mridula was unwilling to give up her claim over things that belonged to the house.

Their stories took different directions.

Neera's vine began selling at the market.

The group of three women became seven.

Seven became twelve.

The colours of the cloth changed.

The leaves became thick or thin.

The eye in the middle was sometimes round, sometimes long.

Someone began calling it "Neera's vine."

Neera did not stop the name.
 Mridula kept hearing the news in fragments.
 Sometimes their mother would say, "Neera's group's cloth now goes as far as Madhubani."
 Sometimes a relative would say, "Your sister's vine is doing very well."
 Mridula would reply, "That vine was in my notebook first."
 People would laugh.
 "These things happen between sisters."
 She did not like that laughter.
 She felt people did not understand what the matter meant.
 But as the years passed, she herself also became less certain of what its real meaning was.
 She became an art teacher.
 At school she taught children line, form, colour, proportion.
 Sometimes, if a small eye appeared between two leaves, her hand would stop.
 Then she would erase it.
 Neera continued working with her group.
 She married.
 She had two children.
 She moved back and forth between her marital home and her parental home.
 The vine kept moving too.
 The two sisters met at weddings and deaths.
 They exchanged news of each other's children.
 They spoke on the phone too.
 But not about the vine.
 Twenty years later, their second encounter took place at a district craft exhibition.
 Paintings by children from Mridula's school were displayed there.
 So were textiles made by Neera's group.
 Mridula went into one corner and stopped short.
 A large piece of cloth hung on the wall.
 Two leaves.
 An eye in between.
 Two leaves.
 An eye in between.
 On a small label below was written: "Neera-Leaf Vine: a recognised design of the local women's group."
 The heat of twenty years earlier returned inside Mridula.
 Neera was at the back speaking with a customer.
 Pointing to the label, Mridula asked, "So now it has acquired a name too?"
 Neera saw the customer off and came over to her.
 "I did not name it."
 "But you did not have it removed either."
 "How many people was I supposed to chase after to have it removed?"
 "You could have said something once, at the beginning."
 "To whom?"
 "Whoever wrote it first."

In a tired voice Neera said, "No one wrote it first. At the market people started saying, 'Give me the leaf one by Neera.' Then the trader wrote it on the bill. Then the women in the group began saying it. That is how the name travelled."

Mridula said, "Very convenient."

Neera looked at her face.

"You are still stuck on the same thing?"

"Where has the thing changed?"

"Twenty years have changed."

"That makes the matter old, not wrong."

Neera was silent for a while.

Then she said, "Come."

"Where?"

"I will show you something."

In a small room behind the exhibition, bundles of the group's materials were kept.

Neera opened one bundle.

Inside was an old, yellowed pillowcase.

The cloth had worn thin in several places.

Along the edge ran a vine of two leaves stitched in faded thread.

Between the two leaves was a round dot.

Not an eye.

But something like the beginning of an eye.

Mridula took the cloth in her hands.

"Was this Nani's?"

"Yes."

"Where did you get it?"

"Ma gave it to me."

For a long time Mridula kept looking at the vine.

Neera said, "What was in your notebook was different from this. The leaves were thinner. You lengthened the round dot in the middle and made it into an eye. You alternated the colours."

Mridula raised her head.

Neera continued, "I took your eye. The leaves were Nani's. I changed the border in my own way. The flowers from the group were added later."

Mridula asked, "Then why did you not tell me earlier?"

Neera laughed.

"I did tell you earlier. You wanted to hear that the entire vine was yours."

Mridula wanted to object.

But the old room came back to her.

"Two leaves, an eye in between."

"I made this."

"Nani's pillowcase also had two leaves."

Neera really had said that.

Mridula had heard her.

She had not accepted it.

"You also said, whoever makes it owns it," Mridula said.

"Yes."

"That is not entirely right either."

"I understand that now."

Neera folded the pillowcase again.

"There are twelve women in the group now. The same vine becomes twelve different things in twelve pairs of hands. Whose should we call it?"

Mridula said, "The one who made the first form?"

"Then Nani?"

"Nani too must have seen it somewhere."

Both fell silent.

For the first time, in that silence, the ground beneath the quarrel shifted a little.

But not entirely.

Mridula looked again towards the label.

"Even so, I do not like 'Neera-Leaf'."

Neera said, "Neither do I."

"Then change it."

"Next time I will tell the organiser."

"What will they write?"

Neera thought.

"'Two-Leaf Vine'?"

Mridula said, "Too ordinary."

"Is being ordinary bad?"

"A name should have identity."

Neera burst out laughing.

"See? You were the one asking to remove the name, and now you want identity in the name."

Mridula laughed too.

The second encounter did not end with that laughter.

They sat down to drink tea - Neera with little sugar, Mridula with none.

Twenty years of things did not open all at once.

Some came out.

Some remained.

Mridula acknowledged that the version with the eye had been in her notebook.

Neera acknowledged that she had learned a great deal from Mridula's alternating colours.

Mridula asked, "You earned money from it. Did it never occur to you to give me a share?"

Neera laughed.

"Are we getting stuck there again?"

"It is a question."

"For the first five years, half the money went into thread. The rest was divided among the group. How much should I have given you?"

Mridula laughed too.

"One rupee per leaf?"

"Extra for the eye."

After a very long time, the two laughed until their stomachs hurt.

Then Mridula grew serious.
 "I did not want the money."
 "I know."
 "The name?"
 "Perhaps."
 "Not perhaps."
 Neera nodded.
 "All right. The name."
 That one word became the centre of the second encounter for Mridula.
 For the first time she felt that Neera was not making her hurt seem small.
 At the same moment, her own first accusation also began to seem smaller: "The
 entire vine is mine."
 Time does not erase a quarrel.
 Sometimes it measures it correctly.
 After the exhibition, the sisters' relationship changed, but not like a miracle.
 They spoke on the phone more often.
 Sometimes about cloth.
 Sometimes about school.
 Sometimes about the children.
 Sometimes only, "Where are you?"
 Neera would sometimes send a photograph of a new design.
 Mridula would say, "The border is too heavy."
 Neera would reply, "Your old illness."
 Mridula would sometimes show a child's drawing.
 Neera would say, "Leave the middle empty."
 Mridula would reply, "Your old illness."
 It became a joke.
 But beneath the joke lay history.
 Then another twenty years passed.
 Today, at the school workshop, this was their third encounter.
 The girls kept practising.
 One girl, Aarushi, made two leaves.
 In place of the eye in the middle, she made a small triangle.
 The moment Neera saw it, she asked, "What is this?"
 Aarushi became nervous.
 "Did I do it wrong?"
 Mridula quickly said, "No."
 Neera pulled the cloth closer.
 "Not wrong. I asked, what is this?"
 "I made it from my own mind."
 "Why?"
 "Everyone was making the eye. I liked the triangle."
 Mridula looked at Neera.
 Neera smiled.
 "All right. Now you will have to make this triangle the same size everywhere."
 Mridula said, "Not necessary."

"Starting again?"

"If some are large and some small, it will look like movement."

Aarushi laughed.

"Whose advice should I follow now?"

This time both sisters answered together, "Your own."

The girls burst out laughing.

In the afternoon, a teacher came with a printed sheet.

There was to be a small exhibition on the final day of the workshop.

Every item had to be given a name.

The teacher asked, "What should we write as the name of this vine?"

Neera said casually, "Two-Leaf Vine."

Mridula said, "There is a triangle in the middle."

Aarushi said excitedly, "Then a new name!"

Neera looked at her.

"You name it."

Aarushi thought for a long time.

"Three-Corner Leaf?"

Mridula wrinkled her nose.

"Naming is difficult work."

Neera said, "That is why people fight over names."

Mridula looked at her.

It was hard to tell whether the sentence was a joke or a comment.

The teacher asked, "Shall I write both your names with the old vine?"

Both sisters were silent.

"Mridula-Neera Vine?"

Neera spoke first. "No."

Mridula too said, "No."

The teacher was surprised.

Mridula said, "I changed one part."

Neera said, "I changed another."

Mridula added, "The vine existed even before that."

Neera said, "And after that, twelve pairs of hands changed it."

Aarushi said from between them, "Now thirteen."

Neera patted her head.

"Yes, now thirteen."

The teacher asked, "Then the name?"

Mridula said, "Write: 'Two-Leaf Vine: the village's evolving form.'"

Neera thought for a moment.

"Evolving' is good."

Mridula asked, "Why?"

"Because it did not stop."

The two looked at each other.

Forty years earlier, Mridula had wanted the vine to stop inside a notebook with her name written beneath it.

Neera had wanted the vine to belong to whoever held the cloth in their hands.

Twenty years later, both had understood that each position was half right.

Today they could see that the vine had already gone beyond both of them.
That understanding did not make the old quarrel ridiculous.
Mridula still believed that Neera should first have acknowledged her name.
Neera still believed that Mridula had claimed more of the whole design than she should have.

Neither had entirely abandoned her own position.
The relationship changed; the positions did not disappear.
As the workshop ended, Aarushi showed them her cloth.
Two leaves.
A triangle in between.
Then two leaves.
Then a small circle.
Then two leaves.

"Why not the same symbol each time?" Neera asked.

Aarushi said, "I changed my mind."

Mridula laughed.

"This vine will last."

Neera asked, "Without rules?"

"By changing the rules as it goes."

Neera took the cloth in her hands.

"The border is still crooked."

Mridula said, "Let it be crooked."

Neera looked at her.

Forty years earlier, that sentence had been Neera's.

Mridula remembered.

So did Neera.

Both laughed.

Evening was falling as they came out of the school.

At the gate their roads separated.

Mridula would take a vehicle towards the town.

Neera would go towards the village.

After their first encounter, Mridula had left a day early.

After the second, they had taken separate buses.

Today too they were to go in separate directions.

Neera took a small piece of cloth from her bag.

An unfinished vine was stitched on it.

"This is for you."

Mridula took it.

Two leaves had been made.

The middle was empty.

"Where is the eye?"

"You make it."

Mridula laughed.

"Then you will say again that I took your vine."

"This time there are plenty of witnesses."

"Shall I make a triangle?"

"Your cloth."

Mridula put the piece into her bag.

"Not yours?"

Neera asked.

Mridula stopped.

Then she said, "It is in my hands. For now, it is mine."

Neera smiled.

"We will ask again after twenty years."

Mridula said, "Do not wait that long."

"Then we will meet sooner."

The two walked away in different directions.

After going some distance, Mridula turned back.

Neera had turned back at the same moment.

Neither raised a hand.

There was no need.

Each simply saw that the other was still on the road.

That night, when Mridula reached home, she took the piece of cloth out of her bag.

She placed the hoop on the table.

She threaded the needle with dark green thread.

Between the two leaves she did not make an eye.

Nor a triangle.

She made a small crooked line, half like a leaf and half something else.

Looking at that line, Mridula remembered Nani's pillowcase.

Neera's market cloth.

The label at the district exhibition.

Aarushi's triangle.

And her own old notebook.

No single person's memory contained the whole design.

Perhaps the relationship between sisters was like that too.

One sister kept saying: I made this line.

The other kept saying: it was already there.

After forty years, both understood that the line had existed before them and would remain after them, but in between, both their hands had changed its direction.

Mridula pushed the needle into the cloth.

She did not fill the empty middle completely.

She left some spaces empty.

This time she was in no hurry to give it a name.

The Old Doctor

Vasudha was sixty-eight when she saw that lane of the old market again.

The lane was the same, yet its width seemed to have shrunk.

The awnings of the shops had pushed forward, wires spread overhead like a net, and where a paan shop had once stood, the white signboard of a chemist now gleamed.

Vasudha walked slowly.

Her granddaughter Ira was with her.

Again and again Ira took out her phone and tried to photograph the old buildings, but Vasudha did not stop her hand.

She merely kept saying, "This doorway used to be green."

"Which doorway?"

"The one that is no longer there."

Ira laughed.

"How do you remember the colour of something that no longer exists so clearly?"

Vasudha did not answer.

Some colours survive not through the eyes but through an event.

Near the end of the lane stood a new concrete building.

On the ground floor was a photocopy shop; upstairs, a dentist's clinic.

Against one corner of the doorway leaned an old iron signboard.

Almost all its paint had flaked away.

Only a few letters remained: "...nath Jha ... Doctor."

Vasudha stopped.

Ira asked, "Do you recognise it?"

Vasudha said, "Not the name. Back then I simply called him the old doctor."

"How old?"

"He seemed very old to me then. Now I think he was probably not even fifty."

Ira laughed again.

To eighteen-year-old eyes, fifty is history.

Vasudha kept looking at the signboard.

She remembered that consulting room for the first time.

It was summer.

The neem leaves outside the window were still.

Inside, the fan sometimes made a faint growling sound as it turned.

Vasudha had been eighteen then.

She had passed Class Twelve and was preparing to enrol in college.

But another kind of preparation was going on at home too.

A family was due to come and see her for marriage.

Babuji said, "What is the harm in enrolling? If the marriage is fixed, we shall see later."

Ma remained silent.
 Vasudha understood what that "we shall see" meant.
 Usually, the seeing happened later; the decision came first.
 That day her head had hurt three times.
 Ma said, "Come, let us show you to the doctor."
 Babuji agreed at once.
 Vasudha was surprised.
 Babuji would not normally send her to a doctor for an ordinary headache.
 He would say, "Drink water and sleep."
 But this time he himself said, "Get it checked. Perhaps all that studying is straining your eyes."
 "Studying?" Vasudha had asked.
 Folding his newspaper, Babuji said, "If you keep your face buried in books day and night, the body is bound to say something."
 Vasudha then understood that the headache had become a witness in the argument at home.
 The consulting room was behind that green door.
 Inside were four wooden chairs.
 A chart of the human skeleton hung on the wall.
 In one corner stood a glass-fronted cabinet, with bottles arranged in straight rows.
 Dr Chandranath Jha wore thick spectacles.
 At first glance, his eyebrows made him look annoyed to Vasudha.
 He asked, "Where does your head hurt?"
 Vasudha pointed to the front of her head.
 "When?"
 "In the afternoon."
 "When do you eat?"
 "In the morning."
 "At midday?"
 Vasudha fell silent.
 Ma answered, "With all the preparation for college, the time..."
 The doctor did not look at Ma.
 "What do you eat in the afternoon?"
 Vasudha said, "Sometimes chura. Sometimes nothing."
 The doctor felt her pulse.
 He examined the insides of her eyelids.
 He asked a few ordinary questions.
 Then Babuji's concern entered the room.
 He had been waiting outside with Ma, but he came in and asked, "If studying is making her weak, will it not get worse?"
 Vasudha still remembered that moment.
 The doctor stopped his pen.
 "First understand the reason for the weakness."
 Babuji said, "She studies until late at night."
 "Does she eat at midday?"

Babuji was silent.

"Housework?"

Ma said, "She helps with a few things in the morning."

Vasudha wanted to laugh at that "a few things," but she did not.

Fetching water in the morning, cutting vegetables, getting her younger brother ready, and then studying - those were the few things.

The doctor wrote the names of two medicines on a sheet.

Then he wrote one line separately.

Babuji asked, "Should she stop books for a few days?"

The doctor said, "I see no medical reason for her to stop studying."

At the time Vasudha was not pleased by that sentence.

It seemed to her that the doctor was interfering unnecessarily in the affairs of her house.

She wanted him simply to say that the headache was ordinary.

Nothing more.

But Chandranath Jha added, "Meals on time, sleep, and rest for the eyes. Stopping studies will not make food arrive on time by itself."

Babuji's face tightened slightly.

For the first time Ma looked directly at the doctor.

The three of them spoke very little on the way home.

Vasudha was angry throughout the journey.

She felt that the doctor had exposed the arithmetic of her meagre daily routine in front of Babuji.

After they reached home, Ma set aside a plate for her midday meal - chura, jaggery, and roasted gram.

For two days Babuji did not raise the subject of her studies.

On the third day he said, "Fill in the papers for enrolment."

Vasudha filled them in.

The marriage was not fixed that year.

College began.

A few months later the headaches lessened.

That was all that happened.

But for eighteen-year-old Vasudha, it was not all.

In her mind she had decided that the doctor was a rude old man.

She kept remembering his question: what do you eat at midday?

It felt as though someone had announced before everyone that her plate was not filled properly.

When friends in college happened to mention doctors, Vasudha would say, "Chandranath Babu asks too many questions."

It was not praise.

Years passed.

Vasudha graduated.

She married.

She moved to Darbhanga.

Her husband Naresh worked in a bank.

The house was small, but there was a bookcase for books.

Sometimes Vasudha thought that life had not turned out exactly as she had imagined at eighteen, but neither had it turned out badly.

A few years later their daughter Rachna was born.

When Rachna turned fifteen, a familiar argument began in the house again.

This time the subject was not books but travel.

Rachna had been selected by her school for a state-level science camp.

She would have to stay away for seven days.

Naresh said at once, "So far away? Not now."

Rachna said, "The schoolteacher will be with us."

"Even then, no."

At first Vasudha remained quiet.

She remembered Babuji's "we shall see later."

Naresh was not a bad father.

He brought books for his daughter, taught her mathematics, and got up early on examination days to warm milk.

But at the word travel, his fear immediately became a decision.

The argument went on for three days.

On the third night Vasudha suddenly told the story of the old doctor.

But it was not the same story that eighteen-year-old Vasudha had kept in her mind.

She told Naresh, "My Babuji too wanted to stop my studies. An old doctor had said clearly that there was no reason to stop them. One sentence from him saved me."

"Saved you?" Naresh asked.

"Yes."

Vasudha herself was startled as she said the word.

The man who had seemed an intrusive old man to Vasudha at eighteen had become a protector in the story told by Vasudha at thirty-seven.

Rachna sat in front of them listening.

Naresh asked, "Did the doctor say anything about travel too?"

Vasudha laughed.

"No. But the point is that we cannot turn fear into a reason for closing off an opportunity."

Naresh argued.

Vasudha answered again.

In the end Rachna went to the camp.

Naresh himself took her to the railway station.

Rachna returned with many stories - the laboratory, the museum, new friends, bad food, laughter at night.

Vasudha felt that the old doctor's sentence had truly opened another door.

At that time Vasudha's mother was staying with her for a few weeks.

One afternoon Rachna was arranging photographs from the camp, Naresh had gone to the bank, and Ma was cleaning makhana on the veranda.

Laughing, Vasudha said, "See? That old doctor's words came in useful again."

Ma stopped her hands.

"What words?"

Vasudha told the whole story again.

This time the hero was clearly Chandranath Jha.

Ma listened.

Then she said quietly, "Who took you to that doctor?"

Vasudha said, "You did."

"Why?"

"My head hurt."

Ma smiled faintly.

"Your head had hurt before too."

Vasudha looked at her mother.

Picking black spots from the makhana, Ma said, "Your Babuji wanted to hear from a doctor's mouth that you should study less. I had heard that Chandranath Babu listened to the patient first and did not say whatever the family wanted to hear. That is why I took you there."

Vasudha was silent for a few moments.

"So you knew?"

"Knew what?"

"That he would not agree with Babuji."

Ma shook her head.

"I did not know that much. I only knew that he would not change the name of an illness to suit a household's convenience."

"So you saved my studies."

Ma said at once, "Do not make it so grand."

"Why not?"

"Because you filled in the papers. You sat the examination. In the end your Babuji gave the money. The doctor said what he thought. I took you there. One person does not do every part of a thing."

At the time Vasudha liked that answer only halfway.

A person likes a clear hero at the turning points of life.

The story becomes shorter.

Gratitude finds one direction.

So does responsibility.

Even then Vasudha continued telling friends the story of the old doctor.

But gradually she began adding her mother's role too.

At first she would say, "My mother took me to the right doctor."

A few years later she began saying, "Ma did not allow what Babuji wanted to hear to be declared a medical truth by the doctor."

The story was changing.

The event was not.

Meanwhile Chandranath Jha grew old.

Vasudha saw him only once again.

At a wedding.

He had grown very thin.

His hair was almost entirely white.

People surrounded him, telling him about their ailments.

Vasudha stood at a distance and thought: the man whom she had made into an important character in her life probably did not even remember her name.

She did not go up to him.
 At the time that caused her a faint sadness.
 Then embarrassment too - why did she want him to remember?
 A doctor's work was to see patients, not to collect the history of their lives.
 A few years later she heard that Chandranath Jha had died.
 At the news, Vasudha saw the green door for a moment.
 Then the day went on in its usual order.
 Time moved much further ahead.
 Rachna studied and found her work.
 She married.
 Ira was born.
 Naresh retired.
 Vasudha's mother died.
 A few years later Babuji too was gone.
 The arguments of the house became memories.
 In memory, people's voices are heard more clearly than they were in life, but their meanings are less clear.
 At sixty-eight, Vasudha understood that very well.
 Standing with Ira in the old lane, looking at the iron signboard, she felt for the first time something like pity for the doctor.
 No, not pity.
 A sense of proportion.
 In her own story Vasudha had sometimes made him a villain, sometimes a hero.
 But in the actual consulting room, the man had really been only a doctor asking why a thin girl's head hurt and refusing to give the family's wishes the name of an illness.
 He did not know Vasudha's future, nor the full tension within the family.
 Nor did he know that one sentence of his would appear thirty years later in an argument about a science camp.
 Ira tried to read the iron sign.
 "The whole name has not survived."
 Vasudha said, "Chandranath Jha."
 "Did you admire him very much?"
 The question was simple.
 Vasudha could have answered at once.
 The answer of her youth was: no.
 The answer from the years of her marriage was: very much.
 The answer in old age could not be short.
 She said, "He said one right thing in the right place."
 Ira waited.
 "That's all?"
 "To say 'that's all' would be too little; to say much more would be too much."
 Ira took a photograph of the signboard.
 Vasudha did not stop her.
 A small child came crying out of the dentist's clinic.
 His mother was soothing him: "Nothing happened, nothing happened."

Suddenly Vasudha remembered her anger at eighteen.

That anger had not been wrong.

She truly had felt ashamed in that room.

Whether Chandranath Jha understood her shame while asking his questions, Vasudha did not know.

His saying the right thing did not make him a complete and flawless person.

And Vasudha's shame did not make his words wrong.

At sixty-eight, those two truths could live together.

At eighteen, they could not.

At thirty-seven, it had been difficult too.

Ira asked, "Nani, did you know then that your mother had deliberately taken you to that doctor?"

"No."

"Then the real work was hers."

Vasudha smiled.

Ira was now trying to shorten the story again.

Trying to choose a new hero.

Vasudha did not stop her.

She only said, "Without Ma I would never have reached that room. Without the doctor, Babuji's excuse would not have broken. If Babuji had not given the money, I could not have enrolled. And if I had not filled in the papers, nothing would have happened."

Ira said, "So four people?"

"At least."

"And the headache?"

Vasudha laughed.

"That too."

The two of them began walking out of the lane.

On the way Ira stopped in front of a chemist's shop and bought water.

Vasudha drank two sips from the bottle.

She remembered the chura, jaggery, and roasted gram her mother had set aside for her.

For so many years she had remembered the doctor's sentence.

She had remembered less often that Ma had set aside her midday food every day.

In stories, sentences shine.

Care is usually hidden in small repeated acts.

In old age Vasudha's memory was not making the doctor smaller.

It was only beginning to see again the people around him.

At the turn of the lane Vasudha looked back once.

From that distance the iron sign could no longer be read.

The green door had disappeared long ago.

Yet Vasudha could still see the room clearly - the wooden chairs, the glass cabinet, the growling fan, Babuji's restlessness, Ma's silence, and her own eighteen-year-old face.

She did not now want to correct the anger on that face.

Cutting out an old version of memory does not make the truth.

It can only be kept beside the meanings that came later.
Ira had walked ahead.
"Nani, come."
Vasudha said, "I am coming."
She did not bow to the sign behind her.
Nor did she say any sentimental sentence.
In her mind, Ma's name came first.
Then Babuji's.
Then her own name at eighteen.
And last of all, the old doctor's.
This time the order seemed right to her.

House Number Five

In the monsoon of 1997, Sarita Sah looked closely for the first time at the north wall of House Number Five.

There was a strange window in the wall - its lower half filled in with brick, above it an old sakhua-wood frame, and inside that an iron grille.

When she had been shown the house, the broker had called it "a passage for air."

At the time Sarita had thought only that little afternoon sunlight came through it.

Three months after buying the house, she discovered another use for the window.

Sarita ground spices at home and packed them into small packets.

At first, orders came from five neighbouring houses.

Later, two small shops in the market also began taking packets of turmeric, coriander, and cumin.

When customers came through the main door, there was constant movement through the sitting room, courtyard, and kitchen.

Sarita's mother-in-law grew irritated.

The children's studies were disturbed.

Sarita herself wiped her hands and ran to the door twenty times a day.

One afternoon she stood beside the grille in the north wall.

From outside, the lane behind the market could be seen directly.

She put her palm on the bricks below the grille and measured the height.

Almost level with her waist.

Sarita called a mason.

A few of the upper bricks in the filled-in lower portion were removed, and stone slabs were fitted on both the inner and outer sides.

The grille remained above.

The window had now become a small counter for transactions.

Customers came from the lane and collected their packets.

Sarita wrote down the accounts from inside.

No one needed to enter the house.

Her younger daughter called it "Ma's shop-door."

Laughing, Sarita corrected her: "Not a door, a window."

Pointing to the old frame, the daughter would say, "It must once have been a door."

Sarita would reply, "Maybe. How would I know?"

At that time she truly did not know that it had once been a full doorway.

Nor did she know which woman had made that doorway, or why.

Go back twenty-nine years.

In 1968, this house had not yet been assigned a municipal number.

People called it the red-tiled house behind the pond.

On the deed, the owner's name was Devaki Devi.
 Devaki's mother had provided half the money for buying the house.
 Devaki had said plainly that if money from her parental home was being used, the house would remain in her name.
 A subdued argument over this continued for three days in her marital home.
 On the fourth day, the deed writer read the document aloud.
 Hearing her own name, Devaki said only, "All right."
 After that day she never discussed the deed.
 But her tone changed when decisions about repairing the house had to be made.
 Instead of saying, "Ask first," she began saying, "This is what will be done here."
 Three days a week, Devaki taught needlework to four adolescent girls.
 The girls entered through the front sitting room.
 If the men of the family were sitting there, the girls adjusted their veils, lowered their eyes, and hurried through to the courtyard.
 Devaki did not like this arrangement.
 One day she looked towards the narrow lane on the north side.
 On the other side of the wall was exactly the corner of the courtyard where the girls sat.
 Devaki said, "There will be a door here."
 Her husband asked, "There is already a main door, isn't there?"
 Devaki replied, "Not every door is the main door for everyone."
 The following week the wall was cut open.
 A sakhua-wood frame was fitted.
 A small threshold lay between the earth of the lane and the bricks of the courtyard.
 On the first day the girls entered through it, none of them had to cross the sitting room.
 Laughing, they came straight to Devaki.
 Devaki's classes did not continue for very many years.
 Two of the girls were married.
 One moved away with her family.
 The fourth enrolled in teacher training.
 Devaki's eyesight too began to weaken.
 But the northern door remained.
 The milkman came through it, the children went to school through it, the vegetable seller called from there.
 Sometimes in the evening Devaki sat on the threshold and enjoyed the air.
 She never imagined that the next woman who owned the house would have that door closed.
 2010.
 The stone ledge of the northern window was now free of the smell of spices.
 Sarita's work had ended long before.
 The house had been sold for the fourth time and was now in Neelima Karn's name.
 Neelima taught economics at a college.

Her mother came to live with her and, because of her knees, could not walk much.

In the very first week, her mother placed a chair beside the northern window.

The stone ledge stood at exactly the right height for her elbow.

She kept her cup of tea there.

In the evening, when neighbourhood women passed through the lane, they would stop for two minutes and talk.

The vegetable seller put her bag on the ledge while settling the account.

Children returning from school peered inside, called "Nani," and waved.

At first Neelima paid no attention to any of this.

To her, the window was merely an odd feature of an old house.

Once, while having the house painted, Neelima said, "Shall we fill in this window?"

Her mother objected at once.

"No."

"Why? Hardly any sunlight comes through here."

Her mother said, "Sunlight can come from another direction. People come from this one."

Neelima laughed.

"Are you keeping watch?"

"No. I listen to the news of the road."

Two years later, her mother's mobility decreased further.

The northern window became a small edge of the outside world for her.

She did not know anyone's whole life.

But by their voices she began to recognise the milkman, the vegetable seller, the postman, and the schoolchildren.

It was then that Neelima understood that all the uses of a house cannot be written into its plan.

What the mason called "the old window" was, for her mother, evening companionship.

After her mother's death, Neelima did not place a chair there for several months.

The stone ledge remained empty.

One day she put a stack of books there, then removed it.

It seemed to her that if she put objects there, they would cover her mother's place, and if she left it empty, the house itself would turn into a memorial.

In the end she decided nothing.

Life moved forward through use.

Sometimes keys lay there, sometimes a bag of vegetables, sometimes an umbrella wet from the rain.

Her mother's memory remained among these small uses, without a plaque, without a name.

Neelima did not know that spices had once been sold from that ledge.

Nor did she know about Devaki's doorway.

Now, 1984.

Devaki had already left the house.

When the new owner, Chandrakala Jha, came to see it, she opened the northern door and looked into the lane.

The lane that had been quiet in Devaki's time was now full of handcarts, bicycles, and traffic moving behind the market.

Chandrakala had two adolescent daughters.

At night, unfamiliar voices came from the lane.

The old wooden latch was loose.

Within a week of buying the house, Chandrakala said indoors, "I will have this door closed."

Her husband argued that a new lock could be fitted.

Chandrakala said, "Why keep the fear of something that has no use?"

A mason was called.

Removing the entire frame was difficult.

The sakhua wood above was still strong; taking it out would damage too much of the wall.

So the lower part of the doorway was bricked up.

A space about two cubits high was left above, and an iron grille was fitted there.

The doorway became a ventilator.

Afternoon air came through that grille.

Chandrakala's elder daughter, Meenu, placed her study table against that wall.

When the electricity failed in summer, she picked up her books and sat beneath the grille.

The younger daughter would laugh and say, "Ma closed the door, but opened half of it again for the air."

Chandrakala would say, "I have no quarrel with the air."

Both daughters later went away to study.

Chandrakala never learned why the old frame had originally been put there.

For her, the doorway was a question of security.

For Devaki, it had been a route of independent movement.

The two women never saw one another.

Their decisions were opposite.

Yet between those opposite decisions, the grille remained - and thirteen years later, beneath that same grille, Sarita made her little transaction counter.

Sarita did not know Chandrakala's name.

History did not move through this house carrying an identity card.

2026.

Anamika Mishra became the fifth owner of the house.

On the day of registration, her attention was not on the list of former owners but on the loan instalments and the handing over of the keys.

She was going to live in the house with her elderly father.

Her father needed a walking stick, but while seated he greatly enjoyed listening to sounds from outside.

On the first evening, Anamika noticed the old stone ledge beside the northern window.

The slab was chipped at one edge.

The grille carried three layers of paint.

She told the mason, "Replace the slab and repair the grille."

The mason asked, "Shall I make the whole window new?"

Anamika said, "Only as much as necessary."

She had no curiosity about the old form of the place.

She merely wanted her father to be able to sit there safely, with somewhere to rest his elbow.

A new stone slab was fitted, but the old sakhua-wood frame above was not removed.

The mason said, "This is still strong."

Anamika replied, "Then let it remain."

There was no feeling in this small decision of preserving a heritage.

The old wood was simply useful.

A few days later her father began placing a chair beside the window and sitting there.

When the vegetable seller called out, Anamika answered from the kitchen, but her father would first raise a hand in acknowledgement.

Schoolchildren passed through the lane.

Sometimes someone's ball came and struck the grille.

Her father pushed it back outside with his walking stick.

One day Anamika laughed and said, "This has become your guard post."

Her father said, "Not a guard post - a place for air and talk."

Anamika liked the phrase.

She did not know that about sixteen years earlier Neelima's mother had sat there listening to the news of the road.

Nor did she know that Sarita's customers had bought spices at that ledge.

Chandrakala's daughter had studied beside that grille.

And earliest of all, when it was still a full doorway, four adolescent girls had entered through it for Devaki's needlework lessons.

For Anamika, none of these was a story.

To her, the window was simply a useful part of the house that had already been there.

That year the municipality conducted a new survey.

The old blue number plate was removed.

On a white plate, in black numerals, it was written again - House Number 5.

The worker asked, "Is the plate all right here?"

Anamika said, "Yes."

That was all.

No former owner's name was written on the wall.

Not Devaki's, not Chandrakala's, not Sarita's, not Neelima's.

A few days later two adolescent girls came through the lane looking for someone's house.

One said to the other, "Turn left after House Number Five."

Anamika heard them from inside.

Her father was sitting beside the window.

Air was coming in through the grille.

The girls walked on without stopping.

The same house had been different things for different people at different times.

For Devaki, a doorway.

For Chandrakala, a boundary to be closed.

For Sarita, a work counter.

For Neelima's mother, companionship with the street.

For Anamika's father, a place for air and talk.

None of these five uses was the "real" one.

Nor was one decision a preparation for the next.

Each woman had acted according to the needs of her own time.

The connections were formed later - without acquaintance, without memorial, without any knowledge that one person's old decision might someday become useful in another woman's daily life.

Evening fell.

Anamika closed the main door.

She left the northern window open.

Her father said, "The air is good."

Anamika said, "Yes," and went inside.

Outside, the number five on the white plate slowly disappeared into the dark.

The house remained where it was - one number, changing uses, and a subtle connection among the unknown decisions of five women, a connection none of them ever fully knew.

The Photo Album

After the rain stopped, the evening light had still not cleared completely. The bricks of the courtyard were wet, drops kept falling from the mango leaves, and Chandrima sat on a bamboo stool on the veranda with an old photo album open before her. The album's cover must once have been deep red, but now its edges had worn grey. The golden line across the middle survived only where hands had touched it less.

Two days later, there was to be a small celebration at home for her mother's eightieth birthday. Nothing grand - the three children, their families, and a few close relatives. Chandrima's daughter Anvita had suggested choosing twelve old photographs and putting them on the wall. "In order," she had added, "the way life happened."

It was that word, "order," that made Chandrima open the album.

On the first page was her mother's wedding photograph. Right beside it was a scene from a completely different time - five children on the veranda with writing slates spread over the earthen floor, her mother Kamla Devi among them with chalk in her hand. On the next page was a photograph of Grandfather with his moustache, beneath it the courtyard filled with floodwater, and after that Chandrima receiving a school prize. No year, no month, no occasion was written anywhere.

"Someone has ruined this album," Anvita said.

Chandrima laughed. "No. It has always been like this."

"Then why didn't Nani put them in order?"

The question was simple. The answer was not.

Kamla Devi was sorting clothes in the inner room. At eighty, her body moved slowly now, but her eye was still sharp. Chandrima carried the album inside.

"Ma, why is this photograph of you teaching beside your wedding photograph?"

Without looking up, Kamla Devi said, "Because the same sari is in both."

Chandrima looked again. In the wedding photograph, her mother wore a red Banarasi sari. In the teaching photograph, she wore ordinary cotton. "Where is the same sari?"

"Not mine. Your Nani's. The black-bordered sari she wore on the wedding day - later she cut it up and made two bags for the children she taught. Look, one of the bags is hanging from the peg in the photograph."

Anvita brought the photograph close and looked. Indeed, a cloth bag hung in the background, with a black strip along its edge.

"So this isn't an order of time, but an order of objects?" she asked.

Kamla Devi smiled. "It was never easy to understand your Nani's order."

The album had originally belonged to Kamla Devi's mother. After her death, Kamla kept it with her. Whenever a new photograph turned up, she pasted it into whatever empty space she found. Chandrima had never paid attention to this disorder in childhood. Like everything else in the family, it had seemed natural.

Now Anvita sat down with a pencil and paper. "Come on, at least let us write down the years."

They began with the second page.

In one photograph, Chandrima's father, Suresh Babu, stood before a half-built brick wall. Everyone in the family called this photograph "the new house." Since childhood Chandrima had heard that Babuji had built the house by saving his first salaries after getting a government job.

Anvita asked the year.

Kamla Devi put on her spectacles. "This is not from when the house was built. This is from when the northern room was added."

Chandrima was startled. "But we always said this was a photograph from when Babuji was building the house."

"People kept saying it."

"The first house?"

"The first two rooms had been built five years before this."

"With whose money?"

Kamla Devi kept folding clothes. "Whose money is ever only one person's in a household?"

The answer felt incomplete to Chandrima. But instead of answering the question directly, her mother turned another page.

There were four women sitting beside a clay stove. On sheets of paper before them were fish, lotuses, creepers, and suns. In one corner, a much younger Kamla Devi, hair tied back, could be seen mixing colours.

"Is this the exhibition group?" Chandrima asked.

"The exhibition came much later. This is from when we were making colours for the first time."

Kamla Devi's mother used to paint on paper with women from the village. At first they painted walls and courtyards for weddings and festivals; later, paper. An organisation in the town bought some of the paintings. In the family, the matter was mentioned like an amusing anecdote - "Your Nani used to sell paintings." No one told it as part of the household's income.

Kamla Devi said quietly, "The first five hundred rupees for the northern room came from those paintings."

Anvita's pencil stopped.

Chandrima looked at her mother's face. "Why did you never tell us before?"

"Did anyone ask?"

The sentence was not harsh. It was spoken as though she were stating an ordinary account.

Anvita wrote on her paper: "The house was not built all at once."

Kamla Devi laughed. "You are not putting that as a caption under the photograph."

Then came a photograph Chandrima remembered well. Her elder sister Nirmala stood in front of the railway station, a small steel trunk in her hand, her braid slicked down with oil. Everyone in the family said, "Nirmala going to her in-laws' home for the first time after marriage."

Nirmala now lived in Madhubani. Chandrima called her.

"Didi, what year is that photograph with your steel trunk from?"

There was silence for a few moments at the other end. "Which trunk?"

Chandrima described it.

Nirmala began to laugh. "That wasn't after my marriage. It was two years after the wedding, when I was going to Muzaffarpur for teacher training."

Chandrima was startled again. "But we always..."

"For a long time I too thought everyone knew."

The established family story was that Nirmala had given up her studies after marriage. "That was how things were then," people would say, and the matter ended. But the trunk in one photograph cracked that story open. Two years later Nirmala had undergone training and had then taught at a school. The job did not last long because she was transferred to another town and her children were small. But "she gave up her studies" and "she studied again, worked, and then stopped" were not the same sentence.

Anvita wrote, "Nirmala Mausi's story was shortened."

Chandrima pulled the paper from her hand. "Don't write it like that. We are not preparing a charge sheet."

"Then what?"

"Just write the year."

Anvita took up the pencil again, but Chandrima herself understood that writing only the years was no longer possible.

In the middle of the album was a page on which five photographs had been pasted from different directions. In one, Chandrima was five years old, holding a paper fan. In another, her younger brother Neeraj wore his school uniform. In the third, Babuji held a bicycle. In the fourth, Kamla Devi stood beside a sewing machine. In the fifth was an empty veranda - only a clock hanging on the wall.

"Why is there a photograph of an empty veranda?" Anvita asked.

Kamla Devi kept looking at it. "It isn't empty."

Everyone leaned closer.

Below the wall were two tin boxes, in one corner a bamboo measuring stick, and folded cloth on the floor.

"That was the first day I was paid for my own work," Kamla Devi said.

Chandrima remembered her mother's sewing. Clothes for the family, blouses for neighbours, school uniforms for the children. But the word "income" had never formed in her mind around that work. Babuji brought home a salary; Ma "did sewing." Different verb, different meaning.

"How much did you get?" Anvita asked.

"I don't remember."

"Whose clothes were they?"

"I don't remember that either."

"Then why do you remember the day?"

Kamla Devi put a finger on the photograph with the clock. "Because that day I bought this clock with my own money."

Chandrima looked towards the wall. That same old clock was now running on another wall in the room. Over the years its glass had been replaced, its hands

replaced, perhaps its mechanism too. Yet the family still called it "the clock from Babuji's time."

"You bought this clock?" Chandrima asked.

"Yes."

"Then why did I remember that Babuji had brought it from Patna?"

Kamla Devi shrugged. "Perhaps he took it to Patna to have it repaired and brought it back. The story may have changed from there."

That word, "perhaps," interested Chandrima. Truth here was not a sealed box that would emerge intact the moment the album was opened. Memory itself kept wearing down edges, adding things, shortening things.

The afternoon faded. Neeraj arrived too. He found the work of arranging the photographs entertaining. In the first five minutes he fixed three dates with certainty, and all three times Kamla Devi corrected him.

One photograph led to a long argument. Neeraj was ten, with a new bicycle in his hands. Chandrima stood behind him, half her face cut out of the frame.

"This was my bicycle in Class Five," Neeraj said. "Babuji gave it to me as a prize."

That was all Chandrima remembered too.

Kamla Devi said, "Not as a prize. Your school was far away. You needed a bicycle."

"Babuji bought it, didn't he?"

Kamla Devi said nothing.

Neeraj laughed. "Now you'll say this too came from sewing money?"

"Half."

The laughter stopped there.

"The other half?" Anvita asked.

Kamla Devi looked at Chandrima.

Chandrima was startled. "Me?"

"From what remained of your scholarship money."

All at once Chandrima remembered a very old scene - the school office, the headmaster's table, an envelope, coming home and putting it in her mother's hand. The memory ended there. She had never asked where the money went.

Neeraj sat holding the bicycle photograph. "Then it wasn't my prize."

"The bicycle was yours," Chandrima said.

"The story was different."

"Stories are hardly ever complete."

As she said it, Chandrima realised she was repeating her mother's language.

By evening, they still had not finished choosing the twelve photographs. Instead, on Anvita's paper there were now arrows, question marks, names, and short notes where the years should have been.

One photograph showed Babuji's retirement ceremony. In the family this day was regarded as the peak of pride in his career. At the very edge in the background stood Kamla Devi. Anvita asked, "Nani, why are you standing so far back here?"

Kamla Devi said, "I arrived late. Your Mami was giving birth, and I had gone to the hospital."

"Which Mami?"

Then the photograph opened another family story - whose birth, whose absence, whose care. No secret; only the kinds of labour that had not come before the camera.

Chandrima slowly began to understand that families often take what a photograph shows and treat that as the story; what lies outside the photograph's frame is gradually reduced to cause, assistance, absence, coincidence.

After dinner the three siblings sat beside the album again. Nirmala was on the phone. They could not show her each page, so Chandrima described them one by one.

Near the end was a small black-and-white photograph. Four people in a boat. The faces were unclear. Neeraj said, "This is Nana and Nani on pilgrimage."

Kamla Devi shook her head. "No. This is from the days after the flood."

"Why are they laughing in the boat?"

"Because when the photograph was being taken, someone said, 'Why does everyone look so sad?'"

That was all.

There was laughter in the photograph; the day itself was one of sorrow. Both were true at the same time.

Anvita put down her pencil. "The order won't work."

"Why not?" Neeraj said. "Find the years."

"We can find the years. But putting things in order won't necessarily make the story right."

Kamla Devi looked at her granddaughter. "Then what will you do?"

Anvita thought for a while. "We'll put twelve photographs on the wall. But not in chronological order."

"Then?"

"Like they are in this album?"

Chandrima immediately wanted to object. It seemed to her that the disorder would simply be repeated. But at that moment she remembered the first page of the album - the bag made from the wedding sari, the children studying beside the bag. Far apart in time, close through an object.

"Not exactly like this," she said. "For our own reasons."

The next day they chose twelve photographs. The photograph of the women painting beside the half-built northern room. Nirmala's steel trunk beside the empty veranda with Ma's clock. Neeraj's bicycle beside Chandrima's scholarship ceremony. Babuji's retirement beside a photograph of Ma returning from the hospital the following day. The flood boat beside the dry courtyard of the new house.

No dates were written on the wall. Beneath them were only names and a single line each - "This room was not built all at once." "This journey was not a bride's departure." "The person who bought this clock is not in the photograph." "This bicycle came from three people's money." "This laughter belonged to a day of sorrow."

Kamla Devi read them all. She corrected two lines. She had one removed.

"Don't explain too much," she said. "Let the photographs remain silent about some things."

On the birthday, people stopped in front of the wall and looked. Some guessed the years, some recognised faces, some added their own memories. There were two arguments as well. Nirmala disputed Ma's date for one photograph. Neeraj read the

line beneath the bicycle, laughed, and then told his son, "I learned this only this week."

Chandrima stood at a distance and watched. She understood that a family's truth was not a final sentence. It lay in the spaces between many small sentences - one person's full memory, another's half memory, someone else's wrong one; something visible inside a photograph, something outside it.

At night, after everyone had left, Anvita began putting the album away again. "Ma, shall we arrange it by year now?"

Chandrima thought for a few moments.

Earlier she had felt that disorderly photographs were something to be corrected. Now it seemed to her that changing the order might make the album cleaner, but it would break certain connections - sari and bag, scholarship and bicycle, clock and sewing, flood and laughter.

"No," she said. "Let it remain as it is."

Anvita closed the album.

"Then Nani had arranged it correctly?"

Chandrima laughed. "I can't say that. Perhaps she simply pasted photographs wherever she found an empty space."

"Then did we invent all that meaning?"

"Finding meaning is part of living. But don't mistake meaning for the event."

Outside the veranda, a light drizzle had begun again. Chandrima went to put the album back in the cupboard. Earlier she used to keep it standing upright; this time she laid it flat so that there would be less strain on the old glue.

Before closing the cupboard, she looked once at the cover. Time in the album was not in order. Perhaps the family had never been in order either. Someone earned, someone cared, someone stopped midway, someone began again, someone kept hearing their own share told in another person's name.

The photographs did not prove those truths.

But they had certainly broken one convenience - the convenience of telling an entire family in a single sentence.

A Decision

Twenty years later, Seema recognised the jar first by its smell.

A row of glass jars stood arranged on the shop shelf. The lids were no longer tin as before but thick plastic; the paper labels were glossy; the lettering was large. Seema had come in to buy tilkut and chura for her daughter Arya. Arya picked up a jar and said, "Ma, shall we take this mango pickle? I ate it at Mausī's house. It was good."

Seema took the jar in her hand. She read the name - "Mithila Taste Store." Beneath it was written, "The old taste of home."

She did not laugh. The lid could not be opened there, but at the sight of the colour of the oil through the glass, the fenugreek seeds, the amount of fennel, and the thickness of the mango pieces, a summer afternoon came back to her.

"What happened?" Arya asked.

"Nothing."

"Then take it."

Seema put the jar back on the shelf.

Twenty years earlier she had been twenty-two. The last date for enrolling in the B.A. course was near, and money was short at home. Babuji's medicines, her younger brother Gaurav's school fees, the poor paddy harvest - everything had gathered in the same month. Her mother, Savitri Devi, made mango pickle every year in Jeth-Asadh. At first only for the household. Later the neighbours began asking for it. Then two or four jars at a time began going to the haat.

That year, for the first time, the owner of a town shop, Ramlochan Sah, had offered to take one hundred and twenty jars in a single lot.

"I'll pay cash," he had said. "But my shop's name will be on the label."

Savitri Devi had immediately asked, "And my name?"

"I have no objection to putting your name," Ramlochan had said, "but customers recognise my name. We sell all our goods under the same name. The person making them changes from time to time."

"Changes?" Savitri Devi's voice had hardened slightly. "If the person making the pickle changes, the taste will change."

Ramlochan had laughed. "If the taste remains good, the customer will buy again. What does the name matter?"

At the time Seema was sitting on the veranda filling in the pages of her college admission form. The figure for the fee kept catching her eye. She got up and went to the kitchen doorway.

"Ma, give them one batch," she had said. "We need the money now."

Savitri Devi had looked at her. "And the name?"

"What difference can the name make for one batch?"

Seema had said the sentence without thinking.

Twenty years later, standing before the shop shelf, Seema remembered that very sentence. Not word for word - memory preserves tone more strongly than words. She remembered her own impatience, the deadline for the admission fee, Babuji's cough, and her confidence as she explained to Ma that this was only a one-time arrangement.

Arya had gone to look at other things. Seema picked up the pickle jar again. This time she read the ingredients printed on the back - mango, mustard oil, salt, turmeric, fenugreek, fennel, nigella, red chilli.

All ordinary things.

Ma too used to say, "Pickle is made not by spices but by timing. In what sun the mango dried, how long it stayed in salt, when the oil went in - that is what matters."

That summer Seema and Savitri Devi had spent three days filling one hundred and twenty jars. Mango pieces were spread on bamboo mats in the courtyard. Seema measured the salt. Ma roasted the spices. Gaurav would wash jars for a while and then abandon half the work and run away. Babuji sat on a cot coughing and saying, "One hundred and twenty is a lot."

"The money will be a lot too," Seema had replied.

At the time, money seemed to her like a direct answer.

Ramlochan Sah sent his men to collect the jars. The paper labels were put on later at his shop. Savitri Devi's name appeared nowhere. The cash arrived by evening.

Seema paid the admission fee. She bought books. With the money left over, Babuji's medicines were bought. No one in the house called the decision wrong. Not even Savitri Devi.

But when the proposal for the next batch came, she refused.

"Why?" Seema had asked.

"It is too much work."

"He says he will raise the price."

"Even then."

Seema had thought Ma was tired. The skin of her palms had cracked from spices and salt. Babuji too had said, "It is not right to leave the household work and fill so many jars."

But Seema never asked again about the name.

A great deal happened in the twenty years between. Seema graduated. She first worked in a private school; later, after training, she joined a government school. Babuji died five years later. Gaurav went away for work. Seema married, settled in another town, and had Arya. Savitri Devi gradually made less pickle. First a hundred jars became twenty, twenty became five, and five became only two large household jars.

In the meantime, Ramlochan Sah's shop grew larger - Seema heard this from time to time but paid no attention. The town changed, the market changed, the jars changed. The name "Mithila Taste Store" remained somewhere at the edge of her life, never at its centre.

Now, twenty years later, that name stood before her on a glossy label.

"Ma, aren't you taking the pickle?" Arya asked again.

Seema said, "Let's go to Nani's house first."

"Now?"

"Yes."

Arya looked at her face, then picked up the shopping bag without asking another question.

Savitri Devi now spent most of her time in the front room of the old house. Her knees hurt; she went as far as the courtyard only two or three times a day. When Seema arrived, she was sitting by the window sorting mung beans.

"All of a sudden?" she asked.

"I was at the market."

"Then why does your face look like the market?"

Seema laughed. Her mother's habit had not changed - she read the face before asking the reason for a thing.

Arya went inside. Seema took the pickle jar out of her bag. On the way back she had bought it.

Savitri Devi put on her spectacles. She read the name.

"They still sell it?"

Seema was startled. "You recognise it?"

"Why wouldn't I recognise the name?"

"I thought... perhaps you had forgotten."

"Why would I forget something you picked up from the market after twenty years and brought here?"

There was irony in her voice, not anger.

Seema opened the lid. The smell of oil spread through the room. Savitri Devi took out a small piece into a bowl and tasted it. She chewed for a long time.

"It isn't mine," she said.

Something inside Seema loosened or tightened - she could not tell which. "The taste is different?"

"Very."

"But the same spices are listed."

"The spices are the same in every house."

Seema was silent.

After a while she asked, "Why did you never give them another batch after those one hundred and twenty jars?"

Savitri Devi went on sorting the mung beans. "You didn't understand then?"

"I thought your hands hurt."

"My hands hurt too."

"And?"

"The name."

The answer was so brief that Seema clearly heard her own twenty-two-year-old voice - what difference can the name make for one batch?

"Why didn't you say so then?"

"I did."

"When?"

"When I asked, 'And my name?' Wasn't that enough?"

Seema wanted to protest. She remembered that Ma really had asked the question when Ramlochan Sah made the offer. But at the time Seema had taken it as a small condition of the bargain, not as something from the heart.

"I needed the admission fee," Seema said softly.

"Yes."

"If that money hadn't come..."

"Who knows whether some other arrangement would have been made or not?"

"Do you regret it?"

Savitri Devi looked at Seema. "Do you?"

The question turned back on her.

Seema did not answer.

Twenty years earlier, she had walked down the college steps with the fee receipt in her hand. She had felt a light, almost intoxicating happiness - the happiness of having saved her studies in the middle of the household's shortage. That day she had seen books, not jars of pickle.

That same week Savitri Devi had filled a small household jar with the spices left over. Seema had tasted it and said, "Better than the shopkeeper's one."

Ma had said, "The shopkeeper's one was mine too."

Seema had laughed.

Remembering that laugh now, she felt ashamed. But memory brought another thing with it. The following year, when the time came to pay the college fee again, Savitri Devi had sold her two silver anklets. Seema learned of it much later.

"You stopped selling pickle because of the name," Seema said, "but you sold your anklets."

Savitri Devi smiled. "The anklets were mine."

In that answer Seema understood the difference of twenty years. For Ma, selling an object and surrendering the name attached to her labour were not the same thing. At the time Seema had seen both only as calculations of money.

Arya came in carrying an old pickle jar. "Nani, is there pickle in this?"

"Last year's. A little is left."

"May I taste it?"

"Eat."

Arya tasted the two flavours one after the other - the shop jar and Nani's jar.

"They're different," she said at once.

Seema asked, "Which is better?"

Arya shrugged. "They're both different. This one is more sour. Nani's has less fenugreek."

Savitri Devi laughed. "That is the right answer."

Seema realised that she was again looking for a contest in her own question - original and copy, right and wrong, victory and defeat. But what had happened twenty years earlier was not so simple. Ramlochan Sah had paid money; Savitri Devi had agreed; Seema had urged her; the household needed the money; the name had disappeared; her studies had survived; the commercial name of the pickle had taken hold; the taste had changed. So many people and so many causes had gathered inside a single decision that to call it simply a "mistake" or "right" would be another convenience.

Even so, some things were clear.

"Ma," Seema said, "if I had said then that your name must stay on it, otherwise we wouldn't give the pickle - would you have agreed?"

Savitri Devi answered after a long time. "Perhaps."

"Perhaps?"

"The house needed money. Your enrolment deadline was there. I myself could have said that I would not give it without my name. I did not. Why are you putting all the blame on your own head?"

Seema was taken aback. For twenty years she had almost forgotten the event; within an hour she had lifted its entire moral weight onto herself. Ma divided that weight too.

"Then why did you stop?"

"Because the next time the need was not as sharp as the first. The first time we needed the money immediately. The second time I could think."

"And after thinking?"

"I understood that if I was going to sell my pickle, it would be under my own name. Otherwise I would make it for home."

"Why didn't you start again under your own name?"

Savitri Devi looked at her palms. "After every decision, another decision needs time, money, and stubbornness. The first time, all three do not always come together."

For a while the room was silent. Outside, a vegetable seller passed calling out his wares.

Seema read the paper label again - "The old taste of home."

"I don't like this sentence," she said.

"Why?"

"Whose home? Whose old taste?"

Savitri Devi laughed. "In the market, everyone's home fits into the same sentence."

Arya said, "Then Nani, make it under your own name. I'll get the labels printed."

Seema immediately looked at her daughter. Twenty years earlier, giving instant solutions like this had been her own nature too.

Savitri Devi stroked Arya's head. "These knees of mine cannot manage so much pickle work now."

"A little?"

"For home."

Arya was not discouraged. "Then write down the recipe."

Savitri Devi said, "Writing the recipe does not make pickle."

"Then teach me."

This time Savitri Devi fell silent.

Seema looked at her mother's face. It seemed to her that this was not about restoring her mother's name to the pickle. The commercial name created twenty years earlier was still in use; there was neither proof nor even a clear wish to stop it or claim it. But another thing was possible - that within the family, the name attached to the labour should not become invisible again.

"Arya," Seema said, "if Nani teaches you, write her name first."

Arya laughed. "On the notebook?"

"Wherever you write it."

Savitri Devi looked at Seema. "Wisdom came after twenty years?"

"It cost a great deal."

"The admission fee was paid from that money."

"That is true too."

"Then both expensive and cheap."

All three laughed.

In the evening Seema rose to leave. She thought of leaving the shop-bought jar at her mother's house, then picked it up.

"Why are you taking that?" Savitri Devi asked.

Seema said, "Arya bought it."

Arya immediately said, "Ma bought it."

"All right - I bought it."

Savitri Devi smiled. "Eat it. You paid for it."

On the way, Arya asked, "Ma, if Nani's name had stayed on it then, what would have changed?"

Seema could not stop the two-wheeler, so she took some time to answer. Evening was settling on both sides of the road.

"Some things would have changed," she said. "Some would not. I don't know."

"Your studies?"

"Perhaps they would have gone the same way. Perhaps not."

"Then was the decision right or wrong?"

Seema laughed. "Why do you want an examination answer for everything?"

From behind her Arya said, "You're a teacher. You taught me the habit."

At home Seema put the jar in the kitchen. It was opened at dinner. Her husband asked, "New pickle?" Seema said, "Yes." She did not feel like telling the whole story. Not every story opens at once at the dinner table.

Two days later Arya went to Nani's house. She returned with a notebook. On the first page was written -

"Savitri Devi's Mango Pickle - learned by Arya."

Below it, there was no list of ingredients. The first sentence was: "The sun must be strong on the day the raw mangoes are cut."

Seema read the page and smiled.

"Nani said this isn't the recipe, it's the first condition," Arya said.

"She is right."

"And she said the taste will change. I won't be able to make it exactly like hers."

"That is right too."

Arya asked, "Then what is the point of writing the name?"

Seema did not close the notebook.

"The point is not that the taste will never change," she said. "The point is that before the changed taste, we do not forget whose hands were there."

That night Seema went back again twenty years - the heat of the kitchen, the sack of salt, her mother's cracked palms, the admission form, her own impatient sentence. But this time there was not only guilt in the memory. Her studies were in that decision too; her mother's consent too; the household's need too; and also a loss in giving up the name, a loss that had seemed small at the time.

Twenty years later, the outcome was not that Seema had become successful, or that some business had been taken away from her family. The outcome was not so simple.

The outcome was that one day, faced with her daughter's question, Seema could no longer say again that old sentence - "What difference does the name make?"

The first page of the notebook lay open.

Savitri Devi's name was at the very top.

A Friend's Daughter

Sarojini Jha recognised her first by the eyes. Not the face, not the name, not the clothes - the slight narrowing at the corners of the eyes when she listened to someone speak.

The veranda of the municipal library was crowded. Old members' names were being registered again, new identity cards were being distributed, and inside there was a book exhibition for children. Sarojini stood in the queue with her renewal slip in her hand. The young woman in front of her kept opening her bag to look for something, then closing it again.

When she reached the registration desk, the young woman turned around.

"Excuse me, do you have a pen?"

The moment Sarojini heard the voice, she found a second clue. A slight lift at the end of a sentence. Vinita used to ask questions in exactly that way.

Sarojini held out her pen. The young woman wrote her name - Deepa Mishra.

Mishra was an ordinary surname. Yet Sarojini asked without meaning to, "Where is your mother's family from?"

The young woman looked startled, then laughed. "Madhubani. Why?"

Sarojini immediately felt awkward about her question. "Nothing. Hearing the way you speak..."

Deepa submitted the slip and returned the pen. "My mother too starts guessing people's villages from the way they speak."

"Her name?"

"Vinita Mishra."

This time Sarojini forgot to answer. For a moment the sounds of the veranda seemed to recede - the rustle of papers sliding across the desk, children's laughter, the turning fan - though everything was still there.

Deepa looked at her face. "Do you know her?"

Putting the pen into her bag, Sarojini said, "From a very long time ago."

"Are you Sarojini Jha?"

Now it was her turn to be startled.

Deepa laughed. "That name appears many times in Mother's old stories."

Sarojini's first feeling was not pleasure. The first thing that rose in her mind was an old sentence - "She asked me. How could I have lied?"

A sentence forty years old. In all those years Vinita must have said so many things and forgotten so many. But inside Sarojini, that sentence had not aged. Even now it sounded in a twenty-four-year-old voice.

Deepa said, "If you're not in a hurry, shall we have tea? There are a few things about Mother I wanted to ask you."

Sarojini did not think before saying yes.

Behind the library was a small canteen. Tea came in steel tumblers with two savoury biscuits. Deepa returned carrying two teas.

"Mother says you used to teach very well."

"She saw me studying, not teaching."

"That's part of the story too. You used to correct her notes before examinations."

Sarojini smiled. "She didn't make notes. She rewrote the whole book."

"She still does."

At that "still," something inside Sarojini lightened. Vinita was alive, full of her habits, filling pages, perhaps pushing her spectacles up on her head and then searching for them. Four decades of distance did not suddenly become grief; it remained only distance.

Deepa asked, "How many years has it been since you two met?"

Sarojini did not calculate. "Many."

In fact, their last meeting had been twenty-three years earlier. At a wedding in Darbhanga. Amid a crowd, loud music, the smell of flowers, and the line for food.

Vinita had cut her hair short then. Sarojini recognised her at once. Vinita recognised her too. The two moved towards each other as if their bodies knew the path of an old friendship before their minds did.

"You teach now?" Vinita had asked.

"Yes."

"I had heard. I'm glad."

That was all.

Then some acquaintance came between them, a child dropped a plate, and the conversation broke. Either could have looked for the other again. Neither did.

For a long time afterwards Sarojini believed Vinita should have apologised. Perhaps Vinita believed Sarojini should first have listened. Silence had preserved each side's argument intact.

Deepa added no sugar to her tea. "Mother tells two kinds of stories about you."

Sarojini laughed. "I have two kinds of stories about her too."

"One is about college. The other..." Deepa paused. "About the marriage proposal."

Sarojini's hand became still around the tumbler.

"That story too?"

"Yes. But I learned your name much later."

Sarojini looked towards the window. Outside in the library courtyard, a boy was scraping a fallen neem leaf along with his shoe as he walked.

At twenty-four, Sarojini had liked the marriage proposal. This was something she admitted less readily to herself later. For years she told her own story this way - the family brought the proposal, I wasn't ready, Vinita said one thing, the proposal broke, and I went on with my studies and my job.

It was a convenient story. In it, Sarojini was independent, the others were conservative, and Vinita was the one who interfered unnecessarily.

But at the time Sarojini did like Abhay. He spoke little, read books, and at their first meeting had listened carefully when she spoke about teaching. Sarojini believed she would be able to continue teaching after marriage.

The trouble had begun with one sentence.

One day Abhay's elder sister met Vinita in the market. They knew each other by name. In the middle of ordinary conversation she asked, "Sarojini will leave her job after marriage, won't she?"

Vinita replied, "She says she isn't going to stop teaching."

Sarojini was not there.

The matter reached the household. First it became a question - "She won't leave her job?" Then a complaint - "Why weren't we told this beforehand?" Finally a decision - "Our views do not match."

To this day Sarojini did not know exactly what Abhay himself had said. The men of the families had conducted the conversation. The women had heard the outcome.

The day after the proposal was withdrawn, Sarojini went to see Vinita.

"Why did you have to say it?"

At first Vinita did not understand. Once she did, her face hardened.

"She asked me."

"Does every question have to be answered?"

"What was I supposed to say?"

"You could have said you didn't know."

"I did know."

"But it was my matter."

That was when Vinita said the sentence - "She asked me. How could I have lied?"

Sarojini was no longer certain whether she had heard the sentence that came after it. In memory, Vinita said only that much and fell silent. Perhaps she had said more. Perhaps Sarojini had walked away.

A few weeks later they both had examinations. They studied. They both passed. The friendship did not end in a single day; only its ease ended.

What had once been said without thinking was now selected before it was spoken. Once an evening passed over a single cup of tea; now, after half an hour, one of them remembered some work.

Sarojini received a teaching appointment. Vinita moved to another district. Two or three letters came; replies went too. Then marriage, household, work, children, transfers - life filled all the empty spaces.

Sarojini married five years later. Her husband never once raised the question of her giving up teaching after marriage. Sarojini often used that fact as proof in the story of her own life - see, it was good that the first proposal broke.

But "it was good" and "Vinita did the right thing" remained two separate sentences in her mind. She accepted the first. Not the second.

Running a finger along the rim of the tumbler, Deepa said, "Mother told me this story when, in my first job, I said something incorrect about a colleague."

Sarojini remained silent.

"Someone asked me whether that girl was going to leave the job. I guessed and said yes. Later her promotion was held up. Mother scolded me terribly."

"Vinita always knew how to scold properly."

Deepa laughed. "Then she told me her own story. She said, 'What you know, say; what you don't know, don't. But before saying someone else's thing, also ask yourself whether you have the right to say it.'"

For the first time Sarojini looked directly at Deepa.

"She didn't say that second sentence then," Sarojini heard herself say.

Deepa did not smile. "Mother says that at the time she did not understand that second sentence herself."

Sarojini had not expected this answer.

She had thought that if the subject ever came up, Vinita would defend herself. She would say she had spoken the truth. She would say that if the marriage depended on Sarojini giving up her job, it was good that it broke. She would say friendship demanded honesty.

Sarojini had kept all her counterarguments ready.

The sentence that came from Deepa was not an argument. It was the distance created by time.

"Does your mother regret it?" Sarojini asked.

Deepa thought for a moment. "I'd have to ask which part."

"Meaning?"

"She says she does not regret refusing to lie. But she regrets telling your matter without first telling you. Then she says, 'Why should Sarojini forgive me? I never even asked her.'"

Sarojini did not laugh. Inside her, the old wound seemed to shift from its place, not disappear.

For forty years the event had been arranged this way - Vinita said something, the proposal broke, the friendship cracked. The thread of cause was clear.

Now another fact had entered between those points - the proposal had been so fragile that it broke merely on hearing, "She isn't going to stop teaching."

If Vinita had remained silent, the marriage might have taken place. Then what? Would Sarojini have left her job? Fought? Would Abhay have taken her side? Would the marriage have broken later? Would nothing have happened? No one had answers to any of those questions.

For that reason, turning Vinita into a hero would also be wrong.

Without Sarojini's permission, she had placed Sarojini's wish before someone else. That had crossed a boundary.

But the wish itself had not been wrong.

For the first time Sarojini could accept both things together.

Deepa asked, "Are you angry?"

"Now?"

"With Mother."

Sarojini emptied her tumbler. "It is difficult to count the age of an old anger. Sometimes it grows old; sometimes it remains just as young."

Deepa said softly, "Mother says you always knew how to make a sentence well."

"It seems she still says a great many things about me."

"Not everything."

"Good."

They both laughed.

Deepa took a book from her bag. "I bought this for Mother. The print is large enough for her eyes."

Sarojini read the cover. The question of what kind of books Vinita read now suddenly felt simple and close.

"Is she in Madhubani now?"

"Yes. Not in the old house. In another part of town."

"Does she still read?"

"A great deal. She writes too, but doesn't show it to anyone."

Sarojini remembered the Vinita of college - the one who rewrote every lecture, wrote questions in the margins, and, the moment she handed someone a page of her own writing, said, "Don't laugh."

That memory belonged to a time before the marriage proposal. Sarojini was startled that after so many years Vinita had suddenly ceased to be merely a character in the story of one hurt.

Even as a teacher, she had not understood how many memories get pressed down behind a single event. Like an examination paper, the mind sometimes circles one answer in red and leaves the rest of the pages unseen.

Deepa asked, "Shall I give Mother your news?"

Sarojini did not answer at once.

From the veranda came an announcement that the library would close at five. People began to rise.

"Tell her," Sarojini said at last.

"What?"

"That we met today."

Deepa waited.

"And?"

Sarojini laughed. "Like your mother, you won't leave a question without the full answer."

"It's a hereditary defect."

"Tell her - I no longer see what happened that day the way I used to."

Deepa nodded. "That's all?"

"For now, that's all."

They went outside. The evening sun lay slantwise across the library steps. Deepa was going south; Sarojini north.

Before they parted, Deepa said, "Shall I give you Mother's phone number?"

Sarojini took out her phone and entered the number. In the name field she first typed "Vinita," then, after thinking, changed it to "Vinita Mishra."

Deepa noticed. "The full name?"

"There may be many Vinitas in the library."

"In your phone?"

Sarojini looked at her and laughed. "Too many questions."

Deepa went away.

Sarojini set off home on foot. Once on the way she opened the phone, looked at the name, then closed it. She could not decide whether she wanted to call Vinita.

She remembered her own face at twenty-four - anger at Vinita, the humiliation of Abhay's proposal breaking, the family's whispering, and the space in her future that had suddenly gone empty. That young woman had not been wrong to be angry with her friend.

Then she heard the sentence from the present - "Before saying someone else's thing, ask yourself whether you have the right to say it."

Vinita had not possessed that understanding then. Nor had Sarojini.

Both could measure the decisions of their youth with the wisdom of forty years later, but that did not change the old day. It changed only its meaning.

When Sarojini reached home, she put down her keys, changed her clothes, and set tea to boil. There was a new message on her phone. Deepa had written: "Mother said to ask Sarojini - does she still take half a spoon of sugar in her tea?"

Sarojini read the message twice.

In college she had taken half a spoon of sugar. After marriage she had given up sugar.

Vinita remembered that small thing.

Sarojini sat down to write a reply, then erased it. Writing "No" seemed too small. Writing the whole story seemed too large.

At last she wrote, "No sugar now. But I still want the tea hot."

She sent the message.

For a while no reply came from Vinita's side. Sarojini did not wait for one either.

She poured the tea into a cup and sat by the window.

It was clear to her now that there had not been only one cause behind the breaking of that old proposal. Vinita had said one sentence; a family had interpreted it in its own way; Sarojini had already known what she wanted from her life; and how much Abhay resisted, or did not, remained unknown.

For forty years she had turned that complicated matter into a simple story - the friend spoke, the marriage broke.

Meeting Deepa did not overturn that story. Vinita did not become innocent. Nor did Sarojini suddenly become wrong.

Only one new sentence had been added - even something true has a way in which it may be said, and a question of who has the right to say it.

And another - if a relationship breaks the moment it hears one truth, the person who spoke the truth is not the only reason it broke.

Sarojini took the first sip of tea. There was no sugar. The taste had changed.

But for the first time she felt that a changed taste does not make the old taste a lie.

The Bus Stop

Kiran Mishra remembered that bus stop first as a place of love.

That memory took shape much later. When the event itself happened, it was only a hot afternoon after her college examinations had ended, with dust along the roadside and three people standing beneath a tin awning waiting for the bus.

Kiran was eighteen. She held two books and a folded admission form. The first bus for home came and stopped before her eyes, people climbed aboard, the conductor blew his whistle, and the bus pulled away.

She could have boarded it if she had wanted.

But she did not.

Because on the other side of the road Naren Thakur had appeared, coming out of a bookshop with his old school bag slung over his shoulder.

After the bus had gone, Kiran looked at her watch as though she had missed it.

Naren crossed the road and came to the bus stop. "The bus has gone?"

"Just now."

"You didn't get on?"

Straightening the edge of her book, Kiran said, "It was too crowded."

The lie was so small that it scarcely felt like a lie to her.

Naren laughed. "How do you know the next bus will be less crowded?"

"Hope doesn't cost a fare."

They both laughed.

They had studied at the same school, but they had not been close friends. Naren was strong in mathematics, Kiran in history. During the last two years of school, their conversations had mostly been confined to books, examinations, and now and then imitations of their teachers.

That afternoon the bus was late. Because of the delay, for the first time they had enough time for their conversation to move beyond its usual limits - to home, studies, and the fear of going away.

Naren was thinking of going to Patna. Kiran wanted to stay in Darbhanga and study history, but at home there were two opinions - Babuji kept saying she should go away to study, while Ma wanted her to return home every evening.

"What do you want?" Naren asked.

Kiran took a little time before answering. "I don't understand whether saying what I want will make it happen."

"Whether it happens or not, the wanting should at least be your own first."

Kiran looked at him. At the time, that sentence seemed enormous to her. Later she understood that an eighteen-year-old boy can make even a simple thought sound like a principle.

When the bus came, it was not in fact any less crowded. Naren climbed first, then reached out from inside and took Kiran's books. Kiran got on. There were no seats. The two stood holding separate rails.

The bus kept jolting, people kept getting on and off, and nothing especially important was said between them again.

After reaching home, Kiran replayed that afternoon many times. More than Naren's sentence, she remembered the moment when he had held her books.

Three days later Kiran's admission was confirmed, and Babuji suddenly changed his decision - she would study in Darbhanga, not Patna. A month later Naren's family left Madhubani and moved to Samastipur.

Neither wrote a letter to the other.

Slowly, Kiran gave a meaning of her own to those unwritten letters. At first she thought - perhaps Naren was shy. Then - perhaps he became busy with his studies. Then - perhaps that afternoon had been ordinary for him. In the end the story became short - Kiran liked Naren; Naren did not like Kiran as much.

The story was simple, so it endured.

Twenty years later, Kiran saw Naren again at the same bus stop.

By then the bus stop had changed. The old tin awning had been replaced by a concrete roof. The road was wider. A paan shop, a chemist's shop, and a photocopy centre had opened nearby.

Kiran was thirty-eight. She had been married for fourteen years. Her husband Subhash worked in a bank. Their two children were in school. Kiran herself taught history at a college.

That day she was returning from her parental home. Her mother's eyes had been examined, and Kiran had stayed with her for two days before setting out for home.

She did not recognise Naren at first. He had less hair, thicker spectacles, and a fuller body. But the way he laughed had not changed.

"Kiran?"

The moment she heard her name, twenty years fell away for an instant.

"Naren?"

They both laughed, as though successfully recognising each other were an achievement in itself.

Naren was an engineer in Delhi. His wife Madhavi taught at a school. They had one son, then in Class Ten. He had come to Madhubani on some work connected with his sister's marital home.

At first their conversation stayed with safe subjects - work, children, parents, old teachers, the changed roads of the town.

Kiran noticed that Naren spoke of his wife with respect. She was glad to hear it, and inside that gladness was also a very old, very small sting that she did not immediately name.

A bus arrived. Naren looked at it but did not board.

Kiran asked, "Isn't that your bus?"

"It is. I'll take the next one."

"Why?"

"We've met after so many years."

Kiran laughed. "Letting buses go seems to be an old habit."

Naren looked at her in surprise. "Old?"

Kiran immediately wanted to change the subject, but it was too late.

Naren asked, "You remember that afternoon after the examination?"

"Some of it."

"I remembered it a great deal."

Inside Kiran, the eighteen-year-old girl woke at once. Outside, however, stood a thirty-eight-year-old woman whose bag contained her mother's medical prescription and two exercise books bought for her children.

Naren said, "That day I thought you had let the bus go because of me."

Kiran answered automatically, "You had a great deal of confidence in yourself."

"No. The opposite. I had so little confidence that I couldn't ask."

They laughed again, but this time the old years stood behind the laughter.

Naren said, "Later we moved to Samastipur. Twice I thought of writing to you. I didn't know your address. I could have asked a school friend and found it. But then I thought - if that afternoon had been only a coincidence, why should I place what was in my mind upon someone else?"

Kiran's first reaction was - so he too.

Her second reaction came immediately - what would this information change?

Subhash's face came to her. The shortages of the first year of marriage, the children's fevers, bank transfers, the quarrels between them, reconciliations, shared loans, shared laughter. Her whole life was not some wrong turn that could be corrected by one old sentence at a bus stop.

Kiran said, "I never wrote either."

"Then we're even."

"Not even. Our silences came from different reasons."

Naren was quiet for a moment. "I understand that now."

At that moment Kiran felt a strange regret inside herself. She did not regret not having married Naren. Nor did she wish to imagine the life she might have had with him. The regret was only that, at eighteen, each of them had taken an assumption for truth.

It had been such a small question - "Would you like to meet again?"

Neither of them had said it.

Meanwhile Kiran's bus arrived. This time she boarded it.

As she climbed in, Naren said, "Not another twenty years now."

Kiran laughed and waved.

But they did not exchange phone numbers.

Kiran realised this only five minutes later.

Sitting on the bus, she first laughed and then became annoyed with herself. After so many years, the same thing again - they had spoken, they had parted, and though the road to staying in contact was open, neither had asked.

But this time she did not turn it into a tragedy.

At home she told Subhash the whole story.

Making tea, Subhash said, "So both of you liked silence."

Kiran said, "No. We simply trusted our own assumptions too much."

"And now?"

"Now assumptions are expensive."

Subhash laughed.

Time moved again. The children grew up. Ma and Babuji died. Subhash retired. Kiran too stopped teaching, though she did not stop reading books. Sometimes she heard news of Naren from old classmates, sometimes she did not. She heard things like: he left Delhi for Pune, then came back and settled in Patna - but how much of it was true, she felt no need to check.

The memory of that bus stop too sank beneath the layers of everyday life.

That was why the third meeting really was a coincidence.

Kiran was then sixty-eight.

Subhash was at home doing exercises for his knees. Kiran had gone to see an exhibition of old magazines organised at a city library. On the way back, the shared vehicle suddenly turned onto another route, so she walked as far as the old bus stop.

The stop had changed again. A new signboard stood in front of the concrete roof. People waited with their phones in their hands. No one asked another person when the bus would come; everyone found the answer on a screen of their own.

Kiran stood in one corner.

"Is it too crowded this time as well?"

She turned the moment she heard the voice.

It was Naren.

His hair was almost white. The shape of his spectacles had changed. He carried a cloth bag. The laugh was still the same.

Kiran laughed so loudly that two young men standing nearby looked at her.

"You?"

"I was about to ask the same question."

Naren had come from Patna to his younger sister's house. Her grandson was ill; he was returning after buying medicines. Madhavi was at home. The two of them now spent half the year in Patna and half with their son in Bengaluru.

Kiran told him about Subhash's knees, her own reading habit, her granddaughter's drawings - everything.

This time giving an account of their lives did not feel formal. Age blunts the sharp edge of certain questions.

After a while Naren looked at the signboard and said, "Three times."

"What?"

"Meeting three times at the same place. That's evidence in favour of coincidence."

Kiran smiled. "No."

"Why?"

For the first time, Kiran said aloud the small fact she had kept safe inside herself for all these years - "The first time was not a coincidence."

Naren was silent.

"I deliberately let the first bus go."

First surprise, then laughter, then a tenderness came over Naren's face that Kiran could have called love, though by now the meaning of love was very different from what it had meant at eighteen.

"I thought so," Naren said softly.

"Then why didn't you ask?"

"You didn't say anything either."

"Yes. Now two old people are putting eighteen-year-old children on trial."

They both laughed.

After a moment Naren said, "The second time was not entirely a coincidence either."

Kiran looked at him.

"I had seen you from a distance. I let one bus go. Then you saw me."

"So you spent twenty years preparing to make us even?"

"Perhaps."

Kiran laughed again.

After this admission, the old story changed completely. At the first meeting, Kiran had chosen to wait. At the second, Naren had. At the third, neither had chosen anything.

Then what was coincidence?

Only the instant when two roads happened to meet at one place? Or the opportunity after which a person decided whether to stay or go on?

Kiran did not try to think the question through aloud. She understood only that for a long time she had decorated some events in her life by calling them "fate," and diminished others by calling them "mistakes." In truth, many events were half circumstance and half choice. The proportion was never clear.

Naren asked, "Did you ever regret it?"

The question was direct.

Kiran answered just as directly, "Yes. But not because I didn't marry you."

Naren nodded. "My answer would be the same."

"The regret is that we didn't ask."

"Mine too."

Kiran said, "But perhaps if we had asked then, we didn't yet have the wisdom to hear the answer."

"Possible."

"Now we have the wisdom, and the question has grown old."

Naren smiled. "That too is one of life's arrangements."

A bus appeared in the distance.

Naren asked, "Yours?"

Kiran looked at the route number. "Yes."

The bus came nearer. For a moment the old eighteen-year-old game stirred inside Kiran - let one bus go, stand here a little longer.

The thought made her laugh.

Naren too perhaps understood. "This time?"

Kiran said, "This time, if the bus is mine, I won't let it go."

The moment she said it, she feared the sentence might sound too carefully made. But Naren only nodded.

"All right."

Kiran boarded the bus. This time Naren did not take her books; she had no books in her hands. The conductor asked the fare. Kiran named her destination.

She found a place by the window. Before the bus moved, she looked outside. Naren was standing there waiting for a bus in the opposite direction.

He raised a hand. Kiran did too.

The bus moved away.

Kiran did not turn back to try to see the bus stop.

She kept looking ahead.

Now the first meeting seemed to her not the beginning of love but a small act of courage by an adolescent girl. The second was not proof of a lost life, but a moment in which two middle-aged people recognised their separate silences. The third was not a sign from fate, but truly a coincidence - a coincidence whose meaning they could create by adding their old choices to it.

Love too no longer seemed to her only the question, "With whom did one spend one's life?" Sometimes love is also this: that after many years, someone meets you and, without being asked, lets you see again a small version of your own past.

Regret too is not always a desire to change one's life. Sometimes it is only the admission that a question could have been asked then.

And coincidence - perhaps it is only a doorway. Whether one enters or takes the road onward is not always decided by the doorway itself.

The bus turned at the next bend.

Kiran put a hand into her bag. There was the list of old magazines she had taken from the library. She thought she would show it to Subhash when she reached home.

Suddenly she remembered that Subhash would ask, "Was the exhibition good?"

In her answer, she would tell him about Naren too.

This time there was no need to leave any story unfinished for forty years.

After the Marriage

Thirty Years Later

The morning tea had gone cold. Sudha skimmed the thin film of cream from the top of her cup with a spoon and kept looking towards the window. Half the guava tree in front was hidden behind the neighbour's new wall. Devesh sat at the table with two sheets of paper spread before him - one an estimate for repairs to the house, the other a printed copy of their daughter Archana's letter.

Archana had written, "You both come here. We can all live in the same city. The house is small, but a two-room place can be rented nearby."

Only yesterday Devesh had said, "What is there to think about? We'll be near our own people."

Sudha had not answered then. This morning the paper was on the table again.

"The contractor says that if we don't get the roof done this year, it will cost more after the next monsoon," Devesh said.

"Yes."

"And Archana's suggestion?"

Sudha set down her cup. "You announced the decision yesterday."

Devesh looked surprised. "Decision? I only said it seemed sensible."

"Even after thirty years, there is very little distance between your 'it seems sensible' and 'we have decided.'"

Devesh began to fold the paper, then stopped. The kind of weariness that used to appear on his face before an argument began came over him. But this time Sudha did not feel angry. Suddenly she remembered an evening from five years into their marriage.

Five Years Later

At that time they had been married for five years. They lived in a rented two-room house, with the kitchen opening off the veranda and a shared tap outside. Their son Anshu was three. Sudha was a temporary teacher at a local school; Devesh kept the accounts at a cooperative store.

One evening Devesh came home from work and said, "Manoj will stay here from next month."

Sudha went on stirring the dal on the stove. "For how long?"

"Until the examination. Six or seven months."

Manoj was Devesh's younger brother. He wanted to come from the village to the town to prepare for a competitive examination. Sudha was not against him. After her marriage, she had twice kept Manoj with them for a month at a time.

Even so, she asked, "Where will he stay?"

Devesh laughed. "In this house. Where else?"

"In which room?"

"We'll put a cot on the veranda."

Sudha put the lid on the dal. "Anshu wakes again and again at night. We have to pass through the veranda to get to the kitchen. I check my school notebooks there too."

"We'll manage for a while. He's my own brother."

"I'm not refusing."

"Then?"

That evening Sudha said the sentence clearly for the first time: "It would have been better if you had asked me first."

Devesh replied at once, "Do I have to take permission even for this?"

The word 'permission' stung Sudha. She had spoken of being asked; Devesh understood it as her trying to prevent him.

The argument did not grow very large. Anshu woke up. The milk boiled over. A neighbour called out for someone to place a bucket at the tap. The ordinary work of the house cut the argument into small pieces.

Manoj came. He stayed on the veranda. He studied late into the night. Sometimes he told Anshu stories. Sometimes he pushed Sudha's notebooks aside and spread out his own books. Six months later he sat the examination and returned to the village.

Seen from outside, the episode looked successful. No one had been harmed. Manoj later got an appointment. Sudha too never said that it had been wrong to let him stay.

But the real matter that evening in the fifth year of marriage was not Manoj. It was that Devesh understood 'home' as a place where his decision could naturally become the family's decision; while Sudha, despite living in that same home, had become the person to whom the decision was announced.

A few months later Devesh understood half of this. One day he had to go away for training with employees from the cooperative store. He came home and said, "It's work for three days. I'll have to go next week. Will that be all right?"

Sudha burst out laughing. "Now you're asking permission?"

Devesh laughed too. "No. I'm asking."

The thorn from their first argument had not come out completely in that laughter, but both of them were learning the name of the thorn.

Thirty Years Later

Sudha turned back from the window. "Living near Archana is not a bad idea."

Devesh said, "I didn't say it was bad either."

"What you said isn't wrong. The way you said it is old."

Devesh remained silent.

"You still reach the conclusion first and discuss it with me afterwards."

"And you?"

The question was direct. Sudha smiled faintly. "I have my own account too."

She remembered the time fifteen years into their marriage.

Fifteen Years Later

They had been married for fifteen years. Anshu was thirteen. Sudha had gone from being a temporary teacher to holding a permanent post. That year she received a two-year research fellowship at a state-level training institute. The institute was in another city. She would have to stay there five days a week and could come home at weekends.

The day the letter arrived, Sudha did not go straight home from school. She sat for half an hour on the library veranda. She had submitted the application three months earlier. She had told Devesh only this much: "There is an opportunity." Her thought had been that when the result came, she would discuss it in detail.

But when the result came and she reached home, her voice carried a decision.

"I'm going," she said.

Devesh read the letter. "Two years?"

"Yes."

"And Anshu's studies?"

"His school is here. You are here."

"I'm here - is that an answer?"

Sudha remembered the veranda from five years before. Perhaps that was why her voice hardened. "For Manoj's six months, 'we'll manage' was an answer."

Devesh put the paper down on the table. "So this is about settling the score?"

"No."

But Sudha immediately knew that the answer was not entirely true. She genuinely wanted the fellowship. Study, the library, training - all of it was her own desire. But inside that desire was also the shadow of an old sentence: 'Do I have to take permission even for this?'

For two days the ordinary work of the house went on. Anshu went to school. Devesh went to the office. Sudha cooked, checked notebooks, and called the institute to confirm dates.

On the third day Devesh said, "You should go."

Sudha had been preparing to argue; hearing the sentence, she fell silent.

"But one thing," Devesh continued. "This time I was not asked. I am going to say that."

Sudha could have said, "You did the same thing before." But she did not.

"All right," she said.

On paper, the two-year arrangement was simple. Sudha would take the bus early on Monday morning and return on Friday evening. Devesh would handle Anshu's meals, school, fees, doctor, and extra mathematics classes. The aunt next door would sometimes help. At weekends Sudha would try to finish all the unfinished household work at once and would end up exhausted.

For the first three months, each of them presented their own difficulty to the other as though it were evidence.

Devesh would say, "Yesterday Anshu was studying until two in the morning."

Sudha would reply, "Here I was preparing a report until three in the morning."

Sudha would say, "The bus was two hours late."

Devesh would say, "I have to get up at four every day to cook."

It was as though marriage contained a set of scales for hardship, and both wanted to prove that their own side weighed more.

By the sixth month, they had grown tired of the game. One Friday evening Sudha came home and found Devesh cutting aubergine in the kitchen while Anshu drew a science diagram at the table. Devesh asked, "Rice or roti?"

Sudha said, "Whatever is already made."

Devesh laughed. "It took me a long time to learn that answer."

That night, for the first time, they spoke about the fellowship without defending themselves. Devesh admitted that at the beginning he had been afraid of what people would say - that the wife lived away while the husband managed the house. Sudha admitted that she had deliberately told him only half the story about the application, because more than she feared rejection, she feared the argument that would come if she was accepted.

That admission did not end every problem. The next month they quarrelled again - Anshu's examination, Sudha's compulsory workshop, Devesh's office accounts, whose time was more necessary.

But by the end of the fifteenth year, they had learned something new: the word 'we' did not always have to mean being in the same place. Sometimes 'we' could also mean that one person stayed away to do their work, the other carried an extra burden at home, and both practised not turning the account of that burden into proof of love or a list of offences.

The fellowship ended. Sudha came home. A few years later Anshu would sometimes joke, "I learned to make roti from Babu." Sudha would laugh when she heard it. So would Devesh.

But behind that small achievement lay the exhaustion of those two years, which no photograph showed.

Thirty Years Later

"I have my own account too," Sudha said again.

Devesh pushed his chair back. "Tell me."

"During the fellowship, I made the decision first. I made you a partner afterwards."

"Yes."

"At the time I thought I was creating equality."

"And now?"

"Now I understand that equality is not revenge."

Devesh picked up his cup. The tea was completely cold. He took a sip and grimaced. Sudha laughed.

"Shall I warm it?"

"No. This crime I will suffer myself now."

They both laughed.

Archana's letter was still on the table. Devesh asked, "So what do we do now?"

Sudha said, "First we write down the questions."

"On paper?"

"Yes. Otherwise you'll give the answer first."

Devesh picked up a pen.

Sudha began to list them: "How much will the roof repairs cost if we stay here? How much will the rent be if we go near Archana? My doctor is here. Your old friends are here. Archana is there, our grandson is there. How many months of the year could we live here? Who will look after the house if it is closed? Do we need to sell it or not? And first of all - what do the two of us actually want?"

Devesh kept writing. At the last question he stopped. "Shall we write that separately?"

Sudha said, "Separately first. Then we'll see."

They did not take their separate sheets into separate rooms. They remained seated at opposite ends of the same table. Sudha wrote, "I do not want to leave this house, but I do not want to live far from Archana either."

Devesh covered his own paper.

"Are you copying?" Sudha asked.

"You don't look first."

After a while they exchanged papers.

Devesh had written, "I do not want to sell the house. But I do not want to stay here only because we have lived here for thirty years."

Sudha read the sentence twice.

"That's good," she said.

"It isn't an answer."

"Not every good thing is an answer."

No final decision was made that day. The roof estimate was folded and put into the file. Archana was called and told that a month later they would come for two weeks and see what living there felt like in practice. Selling the house was postponed. The necessary repairs would be done.

Archana laughed on the phone. "So much thought over such a small matter?"

Sudha laughed too. "Small matters are what make the history of a marriage."

After the call ended, Devesh asked, "Was that sentence a comment on me?"

"On both of us."

The contractor came in the evening. He climbed onto the roof and examined the cracks. Out of habit Devesh stepped forward and said, "The southern side first -" Then he stopped and looked at Sudha.

"What do you think?"

Sudha looked towards the roof. She remembered the veranda from five years into their marriage, where Manoj's cot had stood; the Monday morning fifteen years into their marriage when she used to take the bus for the fellowship; and today's table, where two wishes had been written on two separate sheets of paper.

"The southern side first," she said. "This time I think so too."

Devesh smiled.

In their wedding photograph, the two of them stood beside one another. Thirty years later Sudha understood that the history of a marriage is not made by the closeness of that one day. It is made by the times one person moved ahead without asking the other, the times the other repeated the same mistake in return, the times they kept adding up the burden on their own side, and the first time they placed the question on the table before the answer.

At night there was a light breeze on the roof. The repairs would begin the following week. Whether they would go and live near Archana was still undecided.

Sudha felt no unease about that indecision.

For the first time in thirty years, it seemed to her that sometimes the firmest thing in a marriage is not that both people have arrived at the same answer, but that now, before an answer is made, both are present in the question.

Mother's Friend

Two months after her mother's death, Aparna went to Leela Devi's house for the first time.

Leela Devi had not been able to attend the funeral. She had undergone knee surgery. On the thirteenth day, a short letter from her had arrived: "Saroj is gone, but an entire period of my life has gone with her." Aparna had read the letter three times. For the first time it became clear to her that there could be "an entire period" in her mother's life about which she knew almost nothing.

Her mother had mentioned Leela Devi's name now and then. "Leela's tea was always very weak," or, "Leela wrote everything down." Aparna had placed such sentences in the same category as references to an old school, a distant maternal uncle, or someone's wedding - there was a name, but no life.

Leela Devi lived in an old neighbourhood of Laheriasarai. The moment she opened the door, she said, "You are less Saroj's daughter than Saroj's eyebrows."

Aparna laughed. She did not like such comparisons. After her mother's death, people kept looking for her mother in her face. One saw the eyes, another the chin, another the way she walked. As though being a daughter meant slowly losing one's own face.

Leela Devi took her inside. The small sitting room had two chairs, an old divan, and a pot of tulsi by the window. There was no pile of photographs, no locked chest, nothing that immediately suggested the past was about to open here.

"Did you know me?" Leela Devi asked.

"By name."

"That's all?"

"Ma used to say she had worked with you on an adult education project."

Leela Devi was silent for a while. "Then you knew half of it."

Aparna thought to herself - another half-story. Since her mother's death, people had said many such things to her. "Your mother was very brave." "Your mother helped me greatly." "Your mother once said something to me." Everyone had a small piece of Saroj, but putting all the pieces together did not produce any definite picture.

Leela Devi rose to make tea. Aparna tried to stop her, but she said, "Your mother blackened the reputation of my weak tea for so many years; today I must provide the proof."

This time Aparna truly laughed.

The tea really was weak. Holding out the cup, Leela Devi said, "Saroj and I received our first appointment on the same day. Appointment is too grand a word. It was a six-month honorarium, with money sometimes after two months, sometimes after four."

"Ma was living at Nani's house then, wasn't she?"

"No. You don't know this?"

Aparna stopped with the cup in her hand.

"The two of us rented one room in Benata. For eight months."

Aparna heard the number first - eight months. Then "one room." Her mother had lived away from her parental home, before marriage, in a rented room with a friend for eight months. The information was spoken not like a secret but like an ordinary sentence. Perhaps that was why it had greater force.

"She lived alone?"

Leela Devi laughed. "With me. And we discovered what living independently meant when we quarrelled over the single key."

The story of the room opened slowly. The landlord's family lived downstairs; upstairs were two small rooms. Saroj and Leela occupied one, two young male trainers the other. The water tap in the courtyard was shared. For cooking they first used a clay stove, later a small kerosene stove. In the first week, the dal burned three times. Saroj could cook rice well; Leela made rotis.

"When your mother peeled potatoes, she cut the peel so thick that I used to say - less potato, more peel."

Aparna remembered her mother's kitchen. Saroj used to peel potatoes very thinly.

"Then?" Aparna asked.

"Not then. She learned. People are not born knowing every kind of work."

That ordinary sentence caught inside Aparna. Her mother had always come to her complete - knowing how to cook, how to keep accounts, what time the bus came, which doctor to visit after falling ill. To a daughter, a mother is often someone who "already knows." In that one rented room during those eight months had lived a Saroj who was still learning how to peel potatoes properly.

Leela Devi said that their work was to oversee evening literacy centres. Office work during the day, different villages in the evening. Sometimes by bicycle, sometimes by bus, sometimes on foot.

"Ma rode a bicycle?"

"You don't know this either?"

Aparna shook her head. She had never seen her mother on a bicycle. After the marriage there had been an old bicycle at home, but her father used it.

"Saroj learned from me. The first day she fell into a drain. Skinned her knee. The next day she tried again."

Aparna thought of her mother's knee - the one that hurt in old age, the one she used to rub with oil while telling her daughter, "Look after your joints." She had never said that the skin of that knee had once carried a wound from learning to ride a bicycle.

"Was she very fearless?" Aparna asked without thinking.

Leela Devi put down her cup. "No. Don't draw such a simple conclusion."

Aparna fell silent.

"I was the fiercer one. I would pick a fight over anything. Saroj looked first - what does the paper say, what is the rule, whose right is involved? At the time, that seemed like fear to me."

Leela Devi told her one incident. At a village centre, twelve women had learned to write their names. On the day of the project inspection, a panchayat employee

hurriedly pushed the register forward and said, "Put your thumbprints here; we're getting late."

Leela Devi objected. The employee said that if the signatures were wrong, the papers would have to be made again.

"I argued a great deal. Saroj kept trying to quieten me. I became angry. I told her - you always want peace."

Aparna saw a familiar version of her mother: "First understand the matter." She herself had heard that sentence a hundred times.

"Then?"

"Then Saroj gave each of the twelve women a separate sheet on which to write her name. She said - write here first. Whoever cannot do it, let her practise. Half an hour passed. The employee became impatient. In the end eleven of them signed. One woman's hand was trembling, so she used her thumbprint."

Leela Devi paused for a moment. "Then Saroj told the employee, 'If someone has learned, taking hold of her hand again and making her use a thumbprint is to take away half her education.'"

Aparna said nothing.

"I still remember that sentence. But don't imagine Saroj was a heroic woman every day. Two weeks later, the two of us had a quarrel."

The quarrel was over a protest about their honorarium. They had not been paid for four months. Leela Devi wanted all the trainers to sit in protest outside the office. Saroj was not ready.

"She said - first get a written account of who is owed how much. I told her - at this rate you will turn all of life into a file."

Leela Devi laughed, but an old irritation seemed still to survive within the laughter.

"I went to the sit-in. Saroj did not come. I called her a coward."

"What did Ma say?"

"Nothing. She barely spoke properly to me for three days."

On the fourth day Saroj returned from the block office with a list - each person's name, number of months, amount of honorarium, and which centre's payment was held up. The list bore no seal; it was simply an account. After the sit-in, the officials had said the arrears were not clear. Saroj had spent two days matching every trainer's attendance with the orders.

"Did the money come because of her list?" Aparna asked.

Leela Devi shrugged. "Who knows? Perhaps because of the sit-in too, perhaps because the budget came from above, perhaps because of the list. Memory likes giving the credit for everything to one person. Real life is not that neat."

As she said this, Leela Devi looked towards the window.

"That was when I understood that Saroj did not fight the way I did. That did not mean she did not fight."

Aparna remembered an old day. At university, her scholarship application had been stopped without explanation. In anger she wanted to go to the office. Ma had said, "First ask for the reason in writing. Keep a copy. Then go." Aparna had thought her afraid. Later the written reply revealed that one digit of her date of birth had been entered incorrectly. The error was corrected.

That day Aparna had followed her mother's advice, but she had not known the history behind the advice.

"After eight months Ma left the room?"

"Yes. Her mother fell ill. Saroj said she was going home for three months. I thought she would come back. She didn't."

"Did the family stop her?"

Leela Devi did not answer at once. "For many years I thought so. It was convenient for me - I remained independent, Saroj was stopped by her family. That made my own choice seem braver."

"And the truth?"

"The truth was probably mixed. She was needed at home. Saroj herself wanted to go. Then the question of marriage came up. Then the project shut down. Later she wrote to me, 'I could not return; it was not only because someone stopped me.'"

Aparna asked, "Do you have the letter?"

"No. It was lost long ago. I can't even say whether those were her exact words."

Aparna liked that answer. Leela Devi was not trying to turn herself into evidence. She spoke of the limits of her memory too.

"Did Ma continue meeting you later?"

"A great deal at first. Then less. Children, home, jobs, distance. Friendship does not always break; sometimes its use simply becomes less frequent."

Leela Devi told her: the first time Saroj came after marriage, she did not ask for the old key to the room, only whether the landlord still lived there. The second time, she spoke about her daughter Aparna's school. The third time, when Leela Devi's husband died, she stayed through the night.

"You were very small then. Saroj sat with me on the veranda at night. She did not try to console me. She simply sat there."

Aparna knew this quality in her mother. In grief, Ma spoke little. As a daughter, Aparna had sometimes taken that silence for helplessness, sometimes for compassion. After Leela Devi's story she understood - perhaps Ma did not choose the same meaning for every kind of sorrow.

"Had you planned to tell me all this about her?" Aparna asked.

Leela Devi shook her head. "No. I only wanted to tell you that the two of us lived in one room for eight months. The rest came because you kept asking and I kept answering."

That answer brought Aparna relief. Her mother's unknown life was not a complete story locked in a chest whose key Leela Devi possessed. It was a fragment of eight months - burnt dal, a shared key, a bicycle fallen into a drain, twelve women's signatures, an honorarium list, a quarrel between two friends.

Aparna began to rise. Leela Devi went inside and returned with an old blue mug. "This isn't Saroj's," she said before anything else. "It's mine. I simply felt like showing it to you. She used to say the colour was ugly."

Aparna looked at the mug and laughed. "Ma liked blue."

"Perhaps she came to like it later."

They both laughed again.

As Aparna was leaving the house, Leela Devi asked, "Did your mother ever talk to you about living separately?"

Aparna thought for a moment. "Once she asked me - did you ever have a room where the key was only in your own hand?"

"What did you say?"

"I said I had the key to my hostel room."

"What did Saroj say?"

"Nothing. She only smiled."

Outside, evening was falling. There were vegetable carts on the road, children returning from school, and the sound of a bus in the distance. Suddenly Aparna felt that her mother's life had not been "secret," only incompletely known to her.

She understood that a daughter often measures her mother's life from around the time of her own birth. The years before the daughter came into that life become a hazy preface. But they were not a preface. They too were a complete life - a life in which her mother sometimes learned, sometimes quarrelled, sometimes feared, sometimes made accounts, sometimes was misunderstood.

After returning home, Aparna did not sit down to search for any old object of her mother's. Nor did she need proof of Leela Devi's stories.

That night, while making tea, she remembered the potato peeling and laughed to herself. Her newest acquaintance with Saroj came not through any great event, but through the fact that once she had peeled potatoes too thickly.

And perhaps because of that small fact, her mother seemed for the first time to step out of memory and become a person again.

The Letter That Was Never Sent

Three days before retirement, Sudha was clearing out the old wooden desk at her school.

In the upper drawer were chalk, a stamp, a half-filled box of pins, two dried-up pens, and an examination list three years old. The moment she opened the lower drawer, the edge of a yellowed envelope was visible, peeping out.

There was no stamp on the envelope. No name either. Sudha recognised it as soon as she saw the way it had been folded.

The letter had been with her for thirty years, but it had never reached anyone.

The first time it had been written, Sudha was twenty-three. Then its meaning had been: do not send me here.

The second time it had been read, fifteen years later. Then its meaning had been: I will not do this to someone else.

And now, thirty years later, holding the letter in her hand, Sudha felt for the first time that perhaps neither meaning had been complete.

Before opening the envelope, she sat down before the desk. School had already let out. Two children were shaking dust from their shoes on the veranda, and from the direction of the kitchen came the smell of steaming dal and smoke.

Sudha opened the envelope. There were four pages inside. Along the folds, the whiteness of the paper had cracked like old cloth. The first line was still clear: 'To the Honourable District Superintendent of Education, I respectfully submit that I have been posted to Sonbarsa Tol Primary School, which is extremely difficult to reach.'

She smiled. The words 'extremely difficult' had been underlined three times. Perhaps at the time even those words had not seemed severe enough.

Thirty years earlier, there had been no paved road to Sonbarsa Tol. In the monsoon, one had to wade through knee-deep water at two places; in winter, push a bicycle through sand; and in summer, walk three kos before finding a passenger vehicle.

It was Sudha's first appointment. Everyone at home had said that getting a job was a very big thing. But the moment she read the last line of the appointment letter, half her happiness vanished.

'Sonbarsa Tol?' Babuji had looked for a map. The name was not on it.

Ma said, 'Go and see it first.'

Sudha said, 'What is there to see? Why build a school in a place a teacher cannot even reach?'

That night she sat down to write the letter.

The first page described the difficulty of the route. The second raised concerns about safety. The third said that sending a newly appointed woman teacher to such a place was not a sensible departmental policy. On the fourth page she had written one

sentence: 'A posting to a remote school is, in practical terms, equivalent to punishment.'

Ma stopped at that sentence.

'Punishment for whom?' Ma had asked, standing behind her.

'For me.'

'And the children?'

Sudha became irritated. 'Ma, not a lecture now.'

Ma said nothing. She left the open letter on the desk.

The next day Sudha put the letter in an envelope and went to the district office. There was a crowd at the window for submitting applications. A clerk said, 'Bring it after three.'

Sudha sat on the office veranda until three. In the meantime, an elderly man from Sonbarsa Tol, who had recognised her after seeing the school's name on her appointment letter, came and sat beside her.

'Are you the new teacher?'

Sudha said, 'Yes.'

'Then perhaps the school will open properly now. For two months there has been only one teacher. Even he comes only three days a week.'

Sudha pushed the envelope deeper into her bag.

The old man introduced himself as Bauku Yadav. He wanted his granddaughter to learn to write her name. The girl was seven years old.

Sudha did not submit the letter then. It was no grand decision. She simply could not work out how, in front of Bauku Yadav, she could walk up to the window and hand over a letter that said: do not send me here.

She thought: I will submit it tomorrow.

Tomorrow, she went to see the school.

The school had two rooms. Lime plaster fell from the ceiling of one; the other had a window without shutters. Twenty-eight children were listed in the attendance register; fourteen were present.

On the first day, Sudha stayed only an hour and a half. On the way back, her sandal got stuck in the water. She reached home and burst into tears before Ma.

'I will send the letter,' she said.

Ma only gave her tea.

The next day Sudha went again. The third day too. On the fourth day it rained and she did not go. When she arrived on the fifth day, two children were standing near the gate. One said, 'You did not come yesterday.'

It was not an accusation. It was only a sentence. But Sudha had no answer for it.

The letter was then put away in the upper drawer of her iron cupboard.

Six months later, the district office did not remember her transfer application, because no application had ever been submitted.

Two years later Sudha left Sonbarsa for another school. In the meantime she had not become accustomed to all the hardships of the journey; some days she still cursed it, some days she could not reach at all, and on some days the children went home before the half-day break.

But the letter was never sent.

The first leap in time did not come here. It came fifteen years later.

By then Sudha was the headmistress of a middle school in the block. Her son was in Class Eight. Babuji was no longer alive. Ma lived with her.

There was little space in the new house for the old iron cupboard. While sorting things, Ma found the letter again.

‘You still have this?’ Ma laughed.

Sudha opened the envelope and read it again.

This time, reading ‘A posting to a remote school is, in practical terms, equivalent to punishment,’ she felt ashamed.

She remembered the children of Sonbarsa: Sugna, who always drew an extra stroke in the middle when writing the letter ‘ksha’; Manoj, who left school after four months and went to Punjab with his maternal uncle; Renu, Bauku Yadav’s granddaughter, who after writing her whole name for the first time tore out the page and took it home.

Sudha was about to fold the letter when Ma said, ‘Read the whole thing.’

On the third page was a sentence Sudha had forgotten: ‘Where a place is difficult to reach, it is impossible to retain permanent teachers; the department should first make arrangements for transport.’

Sudha stopped.

In fifteen years the meaning of that sentence had changed. It had originally been written in self-defence. Now it sounded like a point about policy.

That year a new teacher, Neelam, had been posted to Sudha’s school. Neelam travelled thirty kilometres each day and, after two months, sought a deputation closer to her home.

At first Sudha had thought to herself: new people want convenience immediately. What did we have in our time?

After reading the letter, that sentence sounded harsh even to her.

Why should ‘It was difficult in our time’ become ‘Therefore it must be difficult for you too’?

But the problem was not simple. If Neelam were released, her class would be left without a teacher. If she were kept there, she would spend four hours on the road every day.

Sudha did not immediately approve Neelam’s application that day. She asked the block office for a list of vacancies and distances at two schools. Sitting with three teachers, she suggested an arrangement by which they would take turns going to the distant school. The arrangement was not perfect; two months later there were complaints again.

But for the first time Sudha understood that the old letter did not make her heroic. It could only turn an old inconvenience into a moral memory - if she chose to let it.

She put the letter in the lower drawer of the writing desk in the new house.

Ma asked, ‘Will you send it now?’

Sudha laughed. ‘To whom?’

‘To the person you wrote it to.’

‘The superintendent has changed. The office has changed. The matter has changed.’

Ma said, ‘Then the letter has changed too.’

Sudha did not pay much attention to that sentence at the time.

The third time the letter appeared was now, three days before retirement, in the drawer of the school desk.

Sudha had no clear memory of how the letter had reached this drawer. Perhaps she had brought it to school when the writing desk at home was changed. Perhaps it came with papers from some training programme. Paper travels more quietly than people do.

Sudha read all four pages again.

The surprising thing was that this time she felt neither the shame of the first rereading nor the pride of the second.

Inside the sentences she could see a twenty-three-year-old girl - who wanted a job, but not hardship; who wrote in the language of children's rights while thinking mainly of her own convenience; who was afraid, yet capable of calling her fear 'policy.'

Sudha wanted to blame her, then did not.

It is easy to judge a twenty-three-year-old person with the wisdom of fifty-eight.

A voice came from the veranda. Arun Jha, who was to become the new headmaster, entered the room.

'Didi, should we keep all these old files, or separate them out?'

Sudha looked at the pile in front of her.

'The school's files will remain at the school. I will take the personal papers with me.'

Arun Jha looked at the envelope. 'Is this personal?'

Sudha said, 'Yes.'

She folded the letter again.

Then Arun Jha handed her another paper. It was a new list from the block office. The merger of five schools with low enrolment had been proposed. Sonbarsa Tol Primary School was on the list too.

Sudha's finger stopped on the name.

'How many children are there now?'

'Twelve,' Arun said. 'Many families from the village have moved away. The road is good now, but there are fewer children.'

Sudha wanted to laugh, but the laugh did not come. Thirty years earlier there had been children and no road. Now there was a road and fewer children.

That afternoon Sudha went to Sonbarsa. There was no official work. Before retirement, she simply wanted to see the place once.

The journey now took half an hour. Where her sandal had once got stuck in water, there was a culvert. The sandy track had become a paved road. Of the school's two old rooms, one had a new roof and the other had become a storeroom.

A teacher met her at the doorway. Her name was Rashmi.

'How long have you been here?' Sudha asked.

'Three years.'

'The road is good now.'

Rashmi laughed. 'The road is good, Didi. But there is nowhere to rent a house here. I travel from town.'

Sudha remembered the first page of her letter. The difficulty had changed; it had not ended.

Nine children were playing in the courtyard. One girl was drawing a square house in the earth. Sudha asked her name.

‘Naina.’

‘Which class are you in?’

‘Class Four.’

‘If the school closes, where will you go?’

The girl looked towards the distant road. ‘The big school. They said a vehicle will come.’

‘Will you like that?’

Naina shrugged. ‘The playground there is bigger.’

Sudha fell silent. She had expected the child to say: I do not want to leave this school. But the child chose her own reason.

Rashmi said, ‘Some parents are writing a letter in protest.’

‘A letter?’

‘Yes. To stop the merger.’

Sudha touched the edge of the old envelope inside her bag. Thirty years ago, her letter had been about escaping the school; now the village’s letter was about saving it. The same form of paper, opposite wishes.

Sudha stayed there until evening. She wanted to see the old attendance register, but the register from thirty years earlier could not be found. Papers do not always survive.

As Sudha was leaving, Rashmi asked, ‘Did you work here?’

‘For two years.’

‘Then it must have been very difficult.’

Sudha said, ‘Yes. But when we tell the story of hardship, we often forget whose hardship we are talking about.’

Rashmi perhaps did not fully understand. She smiled.

When she reached home, Sudha opened the letter again.

First page - the route.

Second - safety.

Third - teachers would not stay.

Fourth - a remote posting was equivalent to punishment.

Sudha took up a pen. For the first time in thirty years, she wanted to add something to the letter.

Beneath the date, in small letters, she wrote: ‘This letter was never sent. That does not make everything in it right, nor does it make everything in it wrong.’

Then she stopped.

She added: ‘When I wrote it, I was looking at my own road. Later I looked at the children’s road. Now I understand: if those two roads are treated as opposites, a school will always become a punishment for someone.’

She did not again consider sending the letter to the district office. A complaint thirty years old did not need an answer now.

The next day, while clearing her desk at school, Sudha put the letter into her personal bag.

After retirement, no new desk was bought for her at home. The old writing desk was still there, but its lower drawer was filled with her granddaughter's colours, paper, and scissors.

Her granddaughter said, 'Dadi, this drawer is mine.'

Sudha laughed. 'All right.'

'Where will your papers stay?'

Sudha looked around. The middle drawer of the cupboard was empty.

She placed the letter there.

Her granddaughter asked, 'What letter is that?'

Sudha thought for a moment. Once she could have said: the one I never sent. Later she could have said: the one because of which I learned something. Now both answers seemed incomplete.

She said, 'It is a letter that has told me different things at different times.'

'A letter talks?'

'No. I change.'

Her granddaughter was not satisfied with the answer. She began opening her box of colours.

Sudha closed the drawer.

The letter was never sent after all.

But this time, its remaining unsent was not a regret.

The paper was no longer an unfinished task but a witness to an old way of seeing - one whose meaning had kept changing not because its drawer changed, but because life did.

Two Cities

Delhi, 2026.

Archana was filling out a small form in the housing complex office.

Name.

Building number.

Current address.

Permanent address.

Her pen came to a stop at "Permanent address."

Over the past twenty-eight years she had encountered this question many times, but today, for the first time, the two words felt awkward.

Current - Delhi.

Permanent - Darbhanga.

Her hand wanted to write only that much.

But in that house in Darbhanga, she no longer had a room of her own. Her nephew had converted the upstairs room into a place to study. Where the old cupboard had stood, bookshelves were now built into the wall. In the eastern corner of the courtyard, where she had once played beside the tulsi altar, there was now a water tank.

She had been living in this Delhi apartment for twenty-two years. She knew without thinking where the main electricity switch was, which kitchen tap dripped on rainy days, and what time the neighbour's child returned from school.

Then what was permanent?

The woman standing behind her said, "Didi, please hurry."

Archana started.

She left the "Permanent address" box blank and pushed the form forward.

The young man at the desk said, "This cannot be left blank."

"Why?"

"It is mandatory on the form."

Archana laughed. "All right. Let me think and write it."

Darbhanga, 1998.

At the time, Delhi seemed to her like a place for only six months.

She had received an opportunity for training at a university library. Everyone at home said - try it for six months; if you like it, extend your stay, otherwise come back.

While tying up a bundle of clothes, Ma had said, "Delhi gets very cold. Take this shawl."

Archana burst out laughing. "It is still Sawan."

"After Sawan comes winter."

For Ma, Delhi began with weather.

For Babuji, Delhi began with an address.

On a sheet of paper, in neat handwriting, he wrote the full address of the hostel in Karol Bagh, the nearest post office, and the phone number of an acquaintance.

"Keep this paper separately in your bag," he said.

Archana asked, "Won't I remember my own address?"

Babuji said, "The address of a new place lives on paper first. Later it settles in the head."

Ma did not go as far as the railway station. She disliked farewells. Babuji went. When the train started moving, Archana stood by the window and watched Darbhanga recede.

At that time she believed completely that the permanent address was the house where Ma folded and kept her shawl.

Delhi, 2001.

Six months had become three years.

After the training, she found temporary work in the library, then a regular post. From the hostel she moved to a rented single room, and then to a two-room flat.

One day, while she was filling out a bank form, the clerk asked, "Permanent address?"

Archana wrote the Darbhanga address.

"Current?"

Delhi.

The two lines appeared one beneath the other, as though life's two answers could be kept neatly separate.

That evening she called Ma.

Ma asked, "When will you come back?"

"At Dussehra."

"Certain this time?"

"Yes."

She returned at Dussehra, but only for four days.

On the fifth day she had a train for Delhi.

Darbhangha, 2005.

The lane to the house was the same, yet once, while giving directions to the rickshaw driver, she made a mistake.

"Turn right here," she said.

The rickshaw driver replied, "The road to the right is closed now."

Archana fell silent.

Where her memory held an empty field, five shops had been built. The old peepal had been cut down halfway. The milk shop now operated under another name.

When she reached home, Ma laughed and said, "Have you lived in Delhi so long that you have forgotten your own lane?"

Archana laughed too, but the remark caught somewhere inside her.

That night she went up to the roof. A train could be heard in the distance. In childhood, the sound used to make her long to sit in a train. Now it reminded her of her reservation for the next day.

It was the first clear moment when, while in Darbhanga, she found herself missing Delhi.

Delhi, 2009.

Her daughter Nupur was five. At the beginning of the new school session, the teacher had asked the children, "Where is your home?"

Nupur had answered, "Delhi."

At home Archana corrected her almost casually, "Our original home is in Darbhanga."

Nupur asked, "Mine too?"

Archana paused.

"Your home is here."

"Then why is your home there?"

"Because I grew up there."

Nupur thought for a while and asked again, "Is home wherever we grow up?"

Archana did not answer.

That night she opened the cupboard where the old papers brought from Darbhanga were kept. The hostel address Babuji had written was still inside an envelope. Along the fold of the paper, dark stains had appeared like soot.

She read it.

The hostel in Karol Bagh was no longer part of her life.

But the moment she saw the paper, the smell of the staircase, the iron cots in the corridor, and the sunlight of her first winter returned together.

That night she understood that Delhi too could become memory.

Darbhangha, 2013.

Babuji had grown old.

He seated Archana in the courtyard and showed her the estimate for repairs to the house.

"The eastern wall has to be rebuilt."

Archana looked at the estimated cost. "For this much, the entire roof could be repaired."

Babuji laughed. "Delhi calculations will not work here."

The sentence was a joke, but Archana objected.

"Arithmetic does not belong to a city."

Babuji looked at her. "You are right."

After a while he added, "But the way you think has changed."

Archana asked, "For the worse?"

"I did not say worse."

She liked that answer.

During that visit, one day Bhabhi introduced her to a neighbour by saying, "This is my sister-in-law from Delhi."

Archana smiled when she heard it.

In adolescence she had been introduced as "Ramnath Babu's daughter." At university, "Archana who studies history." For many years in Delhi, "the one from Darbhanga." Now, in Darbhanga, "the one from Delhi."

The name remained the same. The adjective kept changing.

Delhi, 2016.

Ma came to stay with Archana for three months.

In the first week Ma said, "Do people here never knock on a neighbour's door unless they have some work?"

Archana said, "People are busy."

By the second week, Ma had befriended Mrs Arora from the third floor in the stairwell.

A month later Ma herself began saying, "Do not go downstairs at six in the evening. It gets very crowded."

Archana laughed. "You have learned Delhi's rules?"

Ma said, "Learning the rules of a place does not make a person belong to that place."

Archana asked, "Then how does one belong?"

Ma went on cutting vegetables. "I don't know."

Archana was surprised. Ma usually had an answer. "I don't know" rarely came from her mouth.

After a while Ma said, "Perhaps when the concerns of that place become one's own concerns."

That year there was a water problem in the building. Archana sat in a residents' meeting until ten at night. When she returned, Ma was still awake.

"Was it resolved?"

"A water tanker will come tomorrow."

Ma smiled. "Then the concern has become yours."

Archana smiled too.

Darbhangha, 2019.

Ma's knee pain had worsened. Archana came for two weeks.

This time the city seemed neither old nor new to her. It simply seemed to be moving.

In the morning, when she went out to buy medicine, she did not need to ask for directions. But she stopped short at the building that had come up where the old pond used to be.

A girl asked her, "Kaki, where does that doctor live?"

Archana immediately began giving the old directions, then stopped herself.

"One minute. The route has changed now."

She asked a nearby shopkeeper, then gave the girl the correct directions.

She laughed.

Darbhangha had now become a city in which she needed both memory and new information.

Delhi was like that too.

Here too new flyovers were built, routes changed, neighbours changed, markets shifted. The only difference was that in Delhi she treated change as the present, whereas in Darbhanga she first said, "My old city has changed."

For the first time that day, the distinction seemed unfair to her.

Delhi, 2022.

Nupur was about to leave for another city for higher studies.

While packing, she asked, "Ma, which permanent address should I write?"

Without thinking, Archana said, "Delhi."

Nupur began writing.

Archana watched her hand.

After a while Nupur asked, "Did that hurt you?"

"Why?"

"Because I did not write Darbhanga."

Archana laughed. "Am I to decide your permanent address?"

"You are my mother."

"A mother gives an address, not permanence."

After saying it, Archana herself fell silent. The sentence sounded a little too beautiful to her. She was wary of beautiful sentences, because life often proved them false.

So she immediately added, "And write what the form asks for. Not poetry."

They both laughed.

Darbhangā, 2024.

Ma was no longer there.

The house was not empty. Bhaiya, Bhabhi, their son, his wife, two children - the courtyard remained full.

A small room upstairs had been prepared for Archana. A clean bedsheet, a jug of water, a chair.

Bhabhi said, "Your room."

Archana went inside.

The room was not hers.

And in that moment, the fact did not feel sad either.

If her old room had remained exactly as it was, perhaps the house would have become a museum. Living houses change - whether Delhi had taught her that or Darbhanga, she could not decide.

At night, her nephew's daughter came to sleep beside her.

She asked, "Badi Bua, are you from Delhi or from here?"

Archana said, "What do you think?"

The child thought. "You ask for directions when you come here, so you are from Delhi."

"And?"

"But you remember Dadi's old stories better than anyone, so you are from here."

Archana said, "Then both?"

The child became dissatisfied. "Choose one."

"Why?"

"That is the rule of the game."

Archana laughed. "Then in the game, I am from here."

"All right."

The child immediately moved on to the next question.

Archana stayed awake for a long time. In a child's game, one answer was necessary. Why in life?

Delhi, 2026.

The form was still before her in the housing office.

The woman behind her had moved to another desk. The young man was searching for something on his computer.

Archana read "Permanent address" again.

"What if there are two?" she asked.

The young man looked up. "Two permanent addresses?"

"Suppose there are."

He laughed. "The system accepts only one."

"Then I will write one for the system."

Archana wrote her Delhi address.

The pen lifted from the paper.

It did not feel like a betrayal. Darbhanga had not been abandoned, nor had Delhi won. One box on a form had simply been filled.

As she stepped outside, Nupur called.

"Ma, when are you going to Darbhanga?"

"Next month."

"For how many days?"

"Not decided yet."

"And your return date to Delhi?"

Archana stood outside the building. There was dust in the evening air. A fruit seller was calling out on the road. Above, clothes on her balcony moved in the breeze.

She said, "I will look at tickets in both directions."

Nupur laughed. "What kind of answer is that?"

"The right answer."

After ending the call, Archana took out the old sheet of paper Babuji had written. She did not carry it with her every day anymore; today she had happened to find it while looking for papers related to the building.

The address of the hostel in Karol Bagh had faded.

Below it, one line in Babuji's handwriting was still clear - "The address of a new place lives on paper first. Later it settles in the head."

Archana read the sentence again after a long time.

She realised that Babuji had said only half of it.

Some addresses, once they settle in the head, cannot be erased merely by erasing them from paper.

And some addresses, even after they change on paper, remain in the mind in their old form.

She put the paper back into her bag.

At the building gate, the guard said, "Archana ji, you are late today."

Archana replied without thinking, "Yes, there was some work at home."

After taking two steps, she noticed her own word.

Home.

She did not turn back to look at the building.

Nor towards Darbhanga.

She simply walked on - with a gait practised in both cities.

Twenty Years Later

The school gate had a new coat of paint, but the nameboard was still as high as it had been twenty years earlier.

The moment Mridula entered, she raised her head.

“Have the letters grown smaller, or have I grown bigger?”

Shweta laughed. “Both.”

It was a Sunday afternoon. The school had been opened for a twenty-year reunion of former students. Near the gate, two tables held name slips, bottles of water, and a small booklet. As each person gave their name, a volunteer pinned a slip to their chest.

Mridula’s slip read: “Class Ten ‘B’, 2006.”

The moment she saw the slip, it seemed to her like an object older than her own age.

Pinning on her own slip, Shweta said, “Twenty years. Can you believe it?”

“No.”

“Then how long does it feel?”

“Sometimes five. Sometimes fifty.”

The school veranda had changed. Part of the old tiled roof had been replaced by a concrete slab, the walls had fresh paint, and the library door was now glazed. But the third step of the staircase was still worn down in the middle.

The moment Mridula placed her foot there, she stopped.

“You fell here,” Shweta said.

“Not me. Neelima.”

“No, Neelima fell in the playground.”

The two looked at each other.

“See,” Shweta said, “it has begun.”

About fifty people had gathered in the assembly hall. Some had come from distant cities, some lived nearby. For the first half-hour, matching names with faces became a game in itself. Someone’s hair had turned white, someone’s spectacles had grown thick, someone’s laugh was exactly the same.

Neelima had come too.

The moment she saw Mridula, she opened her arms. “The one who fell on the stairs!”

All three burst out laughing.

“See?” Shweta said. “My memory was right.”

Neelima shook her head. “I fell in the playground. Mridula fell on the stairs.”

Mridula smacked her own forehead. “So it was me!”

She liked this small defeat. It was as though the rule of the reunion had become clear within the first five minutes - no one person owned memory alone.

There was a short programme in the hall. Two former teachers had come. The present headmaster spoke about the school's new building, student numbers, and the expansion of the library. Then it was announced that former students could go and see their old classrooms if they wished.

Seven or eight people from Class Ten 'B' went out together towards the veranda.

The room was now used by Class Nine. There were science charts on the wall, a water container in one corner, and a plant pot near the window. The old wooden desks and benches were gone; steel benches had been installed.

The moment Shweta entered, she looked at the third row on the right.

"Meenakshi used to sit here, didn't she?"

The room fell silent in an instant.

Mridula understood which incident was standing in the doorway.

Neelima said quietly, "Not on the right. The middle row."

"No," Shweta said, "by the window. That day she was by the window."

"The seats had been changed that day," said Arun, who until then had been standing silently near the door.

Mridula looked at him. The moment she heard Arun's voice, a smell from twenty years ago returned - wet shoes, paper, and chalk dust.

2006.

The second day of the half-yearly examinations.

It had rained all night. In the morning, the shoes of the students arriving at school left little marks of mud and water across the veranda. There was a science examination in the classroom.

Mridula was writing her name on her answer booklet when the invigilating teacher stopped beside Meenakshi's desk.

"What is this?"

Under the desk, near her feet, lay a sheet of paper folded four times.

Meenakshi looked first at the paper, then at the teacher.

"It isn't mine."

The paper was opened. Inside were formulae, definitions, and two diagrams - from the very chapter from which questions had been set.

The air in the classroom changed.

Mridula remembered that the rain had begun beating hard against the window just then.

Twenty years later, Shweta remembered that the rain had stopped before the examination even began.

Arun said it had not rained that day at all; in his memory, the sky had merely been grey.

Meenakshi had said, "It isn't mine."

On that sentence, everyone agreed.

What happened after that was something no two memories held in exactly the same way.

According to Shweta, the teacher had immediately taken away Meenakshi's answer booklet.

According to Neelima, she had been allowed to finish the examination and was called to the headmaster's room afterwards.

Arun remembered that the paper had first blown near his desk and he had pushed it aside with his foot - but in twenty years this memory had never before been so clear to him.

What Mridula remembered most clearly was not Meenakshi's face, but her left hand.

That hand was gripping the edge of the desk.

There was blue ink near the nail.

2026.

"I told the teacher that day that the cheat sheet wasn't hers," Shweta said in the classroom.

Neelima turned towards her at once. "You?"

"Yes. I told the teacher."

"You were silent."

The smile stayed on Shweta's face for a moment, then slowly disappeared.

"No. I did speak."

Mridula said nothing.

In her own memory, Shweta had said on the veranda after the examination, "Don't interfere. My name will get dragged into it too."

Mridula wanted to say the sentence now, but stopped.

Because she also remembered that three days later Shweta had gone to Meenakshi's house to deliver her notebook.

Neelima said, "I spoke in front of the teacher."

Arun could not quite laugh, though a faint smile appeared on his lips. "I remember Neelima crying."

"Why would I cry?"

"Out of fear."

"I did not cry."

"Someone was crying."

Everyone fell silent again.

Suddenly the old incident felt so close that the freshly painted walls seemed inappropriate.

Mridula ran her hand over the steel bench.

"Will Meenakshi come?" she asked.

Shweta said, "Her name was on the list."

Neelima checked her phone. "She messaged that she would be late."

They went out of the classroom.

Food had been arranged at the edge of the playground. There were steel plates instead of leaf plates. Someone was having a photograph taken with a teacher, someone was calling out an old nickname. Now and then a burst of laughter rose whose reason only the people in that particular group understood.

Mridula sat in the shade of a tree with her plate. Shweta came and sat nearby.

"You wanted to say something?" Shweta asked.

"About what?"

"That day."

Mridula mixed rice into the dal. "I remember it differently."

"What?"

"You said - don't interfere."

Shweta was silent for a long time.

"Did I say that?"

"That is how I remember it."

Shweta kept looking down at her plate. "It is possible."

Mridula had not expected that answer. She had assumed Shweta would deny it.

"In my own mind I have kept the story this way - that we all stood by her,"

Shweta said softly. "Perhaps because later I went to her house."

"You did."

"With her notebook."

"Yes."

"So I turned something I did later into something I had done at the beginning?"

Mridula did not smile. "Perhaps we all do that."

After eating a mouthful, Shweta asked, "What did you do?"

The question was simple.

Mridula did not answer.

2006.

After the examination, Meenakshi had been made to sit outside the headmaster's room.

Mridula passed through the veranda twice. The first time to drink water. The second time for no reason at all.

She could have sat beside Meenakshi.

She did not.

She was afraid the teachers would think the friends knew about the cheat sheet.

When she reached home, she told her mother the whole incident with great anger.

"It was unjust," she had said.

Ma had asked, "What did you say?"

Mridula had replied, "Everyone knew she would never do such a thing."

Ma asked again, "What did you say?"

Mridula had never properly answered that question in front of her mother.

2026.

"I did nothing," Mridula told Shweta.

Shweta looked at her.

"At least that is all I remember now."

"Later you used to come to school with her."

"Two days later."

"That is something too."

Mridula shook her head. "But the emptiness of the first day cannot be filled by what happened on the second."

Shweta was about to say something when Neelima waved from a distance.

"Meenakshi is here!"

Meenakshi stood at the entrance to the field. A plain cotton sari, a bag tucked under her arm, thin spectacles over her eyes. It took Mridula a moment to recognise her; not to recognise her laugh.

Meenakshi embraced each of them in turn.

"Have you started distributing old memories without me?" she asked, laughing.

Neelima said, "We can't decide where your seat was."

"My seat?"

"Class Ten 'B'."

Meenakshi threw back her head and laughed. "I changed seats for half the year. Sitting by the window made me sneeze."

Shweta immediately said, "See!"

"What?"

"On the day of that examination, were you sitting by the window?"

Meenakshi's laughter slowed a little.

"That incident?"

No one needed to answer.

Meenakshi took a plate. "Even after twenty years?"

"We saw the classroom today," Mridula said.

After the meal, they sat in the shade behind the library. It was no formal discussion. Five friends, five old wooden stools brought out from the school storeroom.

Shweta spoke first. "I remember telling the teacher that the cheat sheet was not yours."

Meenakshi looked at her carefully.

"I don't remember that."

Neelima said, "I remember saying it."

Meenakshi laughed. "I don't remember yours either."

Arun asked, "Then what do you remember?"

Meenakshi did not answer at once.

She looked towards the field in front, where two small children were kicking an empty bottle as though it were a ball.

"The first thing I remember is my mother's slippers," she said.

"Slippers?"

"Yes. She came outside the headmaster's room. It was raining. Her slippers were muddy. The first thing she looked at was not me but the floor - to make sure she did not dirty it. I was furious then. I thought - I am being accused of cheating and Ma is worried about the floor."

Mridula listened in silence.

"Later?" Neelima asked.

"Much later I understood - she was frightened. In her fear she did what she always did. Keep the house clean. Do not make a mess in someone else's place. I had mistaken her fear for indifference."

Arun said softly, "Did you later find out whose cheat sheet it was?"

"No."

"Never?"

"No."

"Did you want to know?"

Meenakshi thought. "Very much at first. Then less. Now, almost not at all."

Shweta asked, "What happened with the examination?"

"I submitted the answer booklet that day. The marks were withheld. A week later I had to take the examination again."

Neelima said, "I remembered that they did not let you take the examination at all."

"They did."

"You didn't come to school for three days?"

"One day."

"No, three."

Meenakshi laughed. "Will I know my own absence less well than you?"

"In memory, perhaps," Arun said.

Everyone laughed, but there was a slight discomfort inside the laughter.

Mridula asked, "Do you remember who stood by you?"

The moment the question came out, she felt perhaps she should not have asked it.

Meenakshi looked at her.

"Not exactly."

Shweta was bending and unbending the fingers of one hand.

Meenakshi continued, "I remember some other things."

"What?"

"The next day Shweta came to my house with my notebook."

Shweta raised her head.

"On the second day, Mridula waited for me near the gate."

Mridula's throat felt dry.

"Neelima did not speak to me about the matter for a week."

Neelima immediately said, "I was afraid."

"I understand that now."

"Then?"

"Not then."

"Arun?" Shweta asked.

Meenakshi looked at Arun. "After the examination was over, he gave me his science book."

Arun stared. "Me?"

"Your book had a red paper cover."

Arun laughed. "The red paper is true."

"I don't remember why you gave it to me."

Arun thought for a long time. "Perhaps the headmaster had kept your book?"

"No. My book was at home."

"Then I don't remember the reason either."

Meenakshi said, "All right."

Those two words granted no one absolution, and no one punishment either.

Suddenly Mridula understood that for twenty years she had kept a clean story of that day in her mind - Meenakshi innocent, the teacher harsh, the friends cowardly, and herself silent.

The story was not entirely wrong.

But it was not complete either.

Shweta had turned what she did later into courage shown on the first day.

Neelima did not want to call her fear crying.

Arun was now remembering a possible route by which the cheat sheet had travelled, something he had said nothing about at the time.

Meenakshi remembered her mother's mud-stained slippers more vividly than the words of the accusation.

And for all these years Mridula had treated her own silence as a fixed object, although some actions had followed even after that silence.

"Which one of these is the truth?" Shweta asked, half joking.

Meenakshi said, "Perhaps the question is wrong."

"Then what is the right question?"

"What does each person's memory preserve for them?"

Arun said, "That sounds like a teacher's question."

"I am not a teacher," Meenakshi laughed.

"What do you do?" Neelima asked.

"I work in an archive."

Everyone burst out laughing together.

Mridula said, "Then you should have the evidence."

Meenakshi shook her head. "Archives do not preserve everything. Sometimes they preserve only when a document was created, who signed it, and what decision was written down. Whose hand trembled, who stood outside, who took a notebook to someone the next day - those things usually do not remain in the file."

Hearing this, Mridula remembered her mother's old question - "What did you say?"

She had not answered it then.

Now the answer was - "Nothing."

But twenty years later, another question had become visible behind that answer - "And what did you do after that?"

By evening it was time for the group photograph.

The photographer said, "Everyone from Class Ten 'B', stand in one row."

Someone joked, "Stand according to your old seats."

An argument began at once.

"I was in the first row."

"You were in the second."

"I was by the window."

"How are we supposed to reproduce the window order here?"

Meenakshi laughed. "Stand wherever you find a place. This time no one has a fixed seat."

Everyone took their places.

Mridula stood to Meenakshi's right, Shweta to her left, Neelima behind them, Arun at the edge.

Everyone smiled at the camera.

After the first photograph, the photographer said, "One more. Someone had their eyes closed."

"Who?"

"I can't say yet."

Everyone laughed again.

The second photograph was taken.

As she came out of the school, Mridula removed the name slip from her chest.

“Class Ten ‘B’, 2006.”

She did not throw the slip away. She put it in her bag.

At the gate, Shweta asked, “If we meet again twenty years from today, how will we remember this day?”

Before answering, Mridula looked towards Meenakshi.

Meenakshi was waiting for the traffic to stop so she could cross the road. Neelima was holding her arm and saying something. Arun had begun looking at the group photograph on his phone.

Mridula said, “Differently.”

Shweta smiled. “So certain?”

“Yes.”

“Then what about the truth of what happened today?”

Mridula looked at the gate’s new paint, the worn third step, and the classroom inside where the old desks no longer existed.

“The truth will remain,” she said, “but perhaps not complete in any one person’s memory.”

The road cleared. The five of them crossed, one after another.

No one could say for certain who took the first step.

Aunt's House

2026.

When Sudha, at the age of sixty-eight, stood before Malati Mausi's house, the first thing that seemed wrong to her was not the house but the doorway.

Where the small southern door had once been, there was now a large iron gate. Above it, the house number was written neatly.

When she looked towards the old main gate, half that lane had disappeared behind a wall and two new shops.

"What are you looking at over there?" came a voice from behind.

Sudha turned. It was Manjari - Mausi's younger daughter, now around sixty.

Pointing towards the gate, Sudha said, "This used to be the back door."

Manjari laughed. "The road decides which side of a house is front and which is back. The main road is here now, so the main entrance is here too."

Sudha laughed as well, but the sentence lodged somewhere inside her.

The road decides which side of a house is front and which is back.

So many things throughout her life she had understood as human nature, courage, rebellion, love, and regret, which perhaps were only the result of time changing the road.

Manjari opened the gate.

"Come. You are coming here after thirty years."

"Thirty-two."

"You still count?"

"Some distances are measured in years."

"And some in doorways," Manjari said.

Sudha laughed again.

The moment she stepped inside, an old summer afternoon returned to her.

1969.

She was eleven.

As soon as the summer holidays began, her mother would send the three children to Malati Mausi's house. The house was not very far from Darbhanga, but to Sudha it seemed like another country.

In her own house, everything had a time - getting up, studying, bathing, eating. In Mausi's house, time moved less by the clock than by sounds.

If the creak of the pulley came in the morning, it meant someone was drawing water from the well.

If the thump-thump of the grinding stone came from the kitchen, breakfast was on its way.

If the courtyard fell silent in the afternoon, everyone had stretched out in their own rooms.

If the small southern door creaked in the evening, the children had returned from outside.

The main gate was at the front, but the children used it less.

The southern door made the path to the pond shorter. By that route lay the mango grove, an open patch of earth, and, two houses away, the home of Manjari's friend.

The door was so narrow that two children could not pass through side by side.

There was always an argument over who would go first.

Malati Mausi would say, "The doorway is narrow, not the road. Go out one at a time."

At the time, Sudha thought the sentence was only a way of stopping the children's quarrel.

Her favourite place in that house was not any furnished sitting room, but the western corner of the courtyard where a low wooden platform stood beside the old grain store.

Sitting there, she made round shapes from mango peel, drew plans of the house on paper, and argued with Manjari about which room belonged to whom.

"This one is Mausi's."

"No, this one belongs to everyone."

"The room where Mausi sleeps is hers."

Manjari would say, "Ma says no room in a house belongs to one person forever. When its use changes, its owner changes too."

Sudha did not like that.

She wanted the plan of the house to remain fixed.

The main gate here.

The kitchen here.

Mausi's room here.

The small southern door at the back.

At the end of the holidays, she showed Mausi the plan she had drawn.

Malati Mausi looked at it with great attention.

"You have drawn it well."

Sudha felt proud.

Mausi put a finger on the plan. "But this grain store may not be here by next year."

"Why?"

"Manjari and her brother need a study room."

Sudha was startled. "Then what about my platform?"

"The platform will move."

"Where?"

"Wherever there is space."

Sudha thought this was unjust.

Her eleven-year-old principle was that a favourite corner of a house ought to remain where it was.

When she came the next holiday, the grain store really was gone. In its place stood two desks, three chairs, and a shelf on the wall.

On the first day, Sudha sulked.

On the second, she sat at one of those desks and did her mathematics homework. On the third, she forgot that there had ever been a grain store there. Memory did not forget so quickly, but children make peace with convenience very quickly.

1982.

Thirteen years later, Sudha was again at Mausi's house. This time it was not the summer holidays.

She was twenty-three and had come away from home in anger.

The university geography department had selected her for three months of field training. The training involved mountains, old river channels, layers of soil, and mapping villages. The group would include both men and women. The college would arrange accommodation.

Babuji had said, "Your degree is finished. What need is there now to wander here and there for three months?"

Ma did not refuse outright, but her silence fell on Babuji's side.

It was decided at home that Sudha would write to the department saying that for personal reasons she would not take part in the training.

Instead of writing the letter, Sudha came to Mausi's house.

She was sure Malati Mausi would immediately say, "Go. Don't listen to anyone."

Mausi said nothing of the kind.

She looked at the application, read the selection letter, then asked, "Do you have the address of the place where you will stay?"

"Yes."

"Expenses?"

"The scholarship will cover most of them."

"Date of return?"

"Fixed."

"Who will you travel with?"

Sudha grew impatient. "Are you going to question me like Babuji too?"

Mausi folded the papers and placed them on the table.

"No. I want to understand whether you are rebelling or making a decision."

Sudha fell silent.

Mausi said, "There is a difference between the two. In rebellion, one hears someone else's 'no'. In a decision, one must also carry the weight of one's own 'yes'."

At the time, the sentence sounded like a lecture to Sudha.

She got up and went into the courtyard.

The house had changed too.

The western study room was now filled with Manjari's sewing machine and bundles of cloth. Before her marriage, Manjari taught sewing at home.

Half the old sitting room had been turned into a wooden cupboard.

A low masonry rim had been built around the well.

The southern door was still small, but its frame was new.

Sudha stood beside that door.

Where two children had once been unable to pass together, her own body now seemed large.

In the evening, instead of a phone call from Babuji, a message came from the post office – return the next day.

Mausi asked, “What will you do?”

Sudha said, “I will go for the training.”

“Then tell Babuji yourself.”

“He will not listen.”

“Tell him anyway. If the decision is yours, the sentence that carries it should be yours too.”

Sudha remained awake for a long time that night.

In the morning she did not open the main gate. She went out through the small southern door and walked towards the post office.

From there she telephoned Babuji.

The conversation lasted less than five minutes.

Babuji was furious.

In a trembling voice Sudha said, “I will go for the training. I will keep my own account of the expenses. I will return on the fixed date.”

Many things were said in reply, whose exact words Sudha could not remember later.

But the three sentences she herself had spoken remained with her all her life.

Returning from the post office, she came in again through the southern door.

Mausi was sweeping the courtyard.

“You told him?”

“Yes.”

“And now?”

“I am afraid.”

Mausi leaned the broom against the wall.

“Good. Fear does not make a decision smaller.”

Sudha understood then that Mausi was on her side.

For many years she told the incident in exactly that form – Malati Mausi had been the first supporter of her rebellion.

It was a convenient story.

Short.

Clear.

And not the whole truth.

1994.

There was a wedding at Mausi’s house. Sudha now had a job and was the mother of two children.

That night at the wedding, Manjari said casually, “The year you went for that training, Ma spoke to Babuji for three days.”

Sudha was startled. “She told me – the decision is yours.”

“She did. But after you left, Babuji was very angry. Ma kept trying to make him understand that it would be wrong to break with you over it.”

“Mausi had taken my side.”

Manjari thought for a moment. “Your side? Perhaps. But more than your training, she wanted the road between you and Babuji to remain open.”

Sudha did not like that answer then.

It seemed to weaken the old story she had kept.
Mausi became less of a heroine and more of a mediator.
For a long time Sudha did not accept this new meaning.
Then life moved on.
Babuji grew old.
Sudha's children grew up.

Once, when her daughter announced that she was leaving her job and moving to another city, Sudha herself began asking question after question - where would she stay? What would the salary be? How would she travel? What if she did not like the work?

Her daughter said irritably, "Are you trying to stop me?"
Sudha answered at once, "No."
And in that moment Malati Mausi's old face came back to her.
For the first time, she fully understood what the weight of a decision meant.
2026.

Manjari took Sudha further inside the house.
Half the courtyard was covered. Above it, instead of tin, there was a light translucent roof through which sunlight filtered.
The western room had changed again. There were now four desks and a bookcase.
"What is this?" Sudha asked.
"Children from the neighbourhood come to study here in the evenings. My granddaughter runs it."

Sudha stopped in the doorway.
"There used to be a grain store here."
"I don't remember that."
"Then it became a study room."
"That I remember."
"Then your sewing room."
Manjari laughed. "That lasted many years."
Sudha went inside.

The old shelf on the wall was gone. The window had been enlarged. The low platform was nowhere.

She remembered the plan she had drawn at eleven - a house in which every room ought to remain fixed.

"Are you selling the house?" Sudha asked.

"No. We will rent out half. We will live in this part. The study room will continue."

"The main sitting room?"

"It has become two small rooms."

"And the old main gate?"

"Vehicles can no longer come from that side. So we broke open the southern door and made it larger."

Sudha looked towards the gate.

Through that very doorway, one morning, she had walked out believing it to be the greatest rebellion of her life.

Now it was the main entrance.

Suddenly she laughed.

Manjari asked, "What happened?"

"Nothing. I was thinking that I had run away through the back door."

"Run away?"

"That is how it seemed to me then."

Manjari thought for a while.

"You went to the post office. You stayed here till evening. The next day Ma herself took you to catch the bus. How was that running away?"

Laughing, Sudha sank into a chair.

"Memory loves enlarging its own stories."

Manjari sat down too.

"Does a house do that as well?"

Sudha looked around.

"A house does the opposite. What we think is fixed, it makes smaller by changing its use."

For a while, both remained silent.

At four in the afternoon, three children came in through the gate.

A girl put her bag on a desk and asked, "Manjari Dadi, what used to be in this room?"

Manjari looked at Sudha.

Sudha opened her mouth to answer, then stopped.

"Many things," she said.

The girl laughed. "In the same room?"

"At different times."

"Now it is a study room."

"Yes. Now."

The girl opened her book. She had no interest in the old grain store, the sewing machine, or Sudha's wooden platform.

Sudha was surprised that this time she did not mind.

In childhood she had wanted a favourite corner to remain exactly as it was forever.

In youth she had wanted one decision of hers to remain a permanent definition of her life.

In middle age she had wanted Malati Mausi's role to remain clear - supporter or opponent.

In old age, the house gave her a third answer.

A room changes its use.

A doorway changes its direction.

The meaning of the same decision also changes with time.

That does not make the old thing false. It only reveals its limits.

Evening was falling.

Sudha rose.

Manjari asked, "Shall we go and see the old front lane?"

Sudha thought for a moment.

"No. I will leave from here."

The two walked towards the new main gate.

Before crossing it, Sudha touched the doorframe once. Perhaps some part of the old wood still remained inside; perhaps it was entirely new. She did not check.

Outside, the road was full of cars, bicycles, handcarts, and the voices of children returning from school.

Standing at the gate, Manjari asked, "Next time you won't take this many years?"

Sudha said, "No."

Then, after thinking, she added, "But next time, if the house has changed again, I won't complain."

Manjari laughed. "Will you give that promise in writing?"

"No. Not every promise needs to be written."

Sudha crossed the road.

Reaching the other side, she turned to look.

Children were entering through the gate she had spent half her life calling the 'back door'.

No one called it the back anymore.

The house had changed its direction.

Sudha understood - perhaps she had too.

The Red Trunk

It was an afternoon in Bhadon.

The sunlight in the courtyard had shifted to one side, but the humidity was still trapped inside the veranda. Malati was emptying the old room, carrying things out one by one.

A cot, two bamboo baskets, an old rug, and finally the red trunk.

The trunk's red paint had turned brown in patches. At the right-hand corner the metal had been crushed inward. The clasp for the lock had been replaced twice; the difference between the newer and older metal made that clear.

Looking at the trunk, Rashmi asked, "Is this still in the house?"

Wiping away sweat, Malati said, "This is exactly why the room never gets emptied. Your Nani says it must not be thrown away."

Janaki Devi, sitting on a low seat in the veranda, heard her.

"Who said it was something to be thrown away?"

Rashmi laughed. "Nani, this trunk is so heavy that even when empty it takes two people to lift it."

Janaki Devi said, "Empty things are not heavy. The people lifting them are weak."

Malati interrupted, "You have started again."

Rashmi ran a hand over the lid of the trunk. A thin layer of dust rose.

She had come to this house for three days. The following week she was to rent a small room behind a training centre near Jhanjharpur, where she would begin repairing solar-energy devices and small household electrical appliances.

Malati had said she would buy her a few utensils, a cot, and a light trunk for keeping clothes at the new place.

Looking at the red trunk, Janaki Devi asked, "Why buy a new trunk?"

Rashmi said, "Shall I take this one?"

"If it is useful."

Malati said at once, "You will give her this trunk? You never even let anyone touch it."

Janaki Devi laughed. "I never let anyone touch it?"

Malati stopped what she was doing.

All three women began looking at the same trunk.

In this house, the red trunk did not have only one story.

Janaki Devi had bought the trunk in 1984.

She was twenty-six then. There were two small children in the house, her mother-in-law held sway over the courtyard, and after evening fell Janaki Devi sewed beside an oil lamp.

Janaki Devi had known sewing even before marriage. In the beginning after marriage, she stitched only clothes for people in the household. Gradually women from the neighbourhood began bringing blouses, petticoats, and children's kurtas.

Some paid two rupees, some gave grain, some vegetables.

Many times the slip of paper with measurements written on it would be lost among the clothes.

Many times someone borrowed the scissors and returned them three days later.

Many times the money she had earned was kept in a kitchen tin and, without anyone asking her, was taken out for some necessary household expense.

Janaki Devi did not object to the money being used in the house.

Her only objection was that she came to know afterwards.

One Monday she bought a red iron trunk at the haat and brought it home.

The moment Mahendra Babu saw it, he asked, "What will you keep in such a large trunk?"

Janaki Devi said, "The things I have to keep searching for."

The first things placed in the trunk were not clothes.

A large pair of scissors, two measuring tapes, a box of tailor's chalk, needles and thread, slips bearing the measurements of four customers, and twenty-seven rupees tied in a piece of cloth.

Janaki Devi closed the lid and put a small lock on it for the first time.

Her mother-in-law said, "A lock even inside the house now?"

Janaki Devi answered, "The lock is less for the money than for the accounts."

For several days that sentence became a joke in the house.

Mahendra Babu would sometimes call it "Janaki's treasury."

Her brother-in-law called it "the Red Court."

Janaki Devi would laugh.

But she kept the key to the trunk tied into the knot of her sari end.

Two years later there were more measurement slips than rupees in the trunk.

Five years later a small account book had also found its way into it.

Janaki Devi began writing down whose clothes she had stitched and for how much, whether the customer had paid, and whose clothes were needed by the following Tuesday.

She wrote slowly, but her accounts were clear.

By then Malati had begun going to school.

Sometimes after coming home she sat on the trunk to do her homework.

Janaki Devi would scold her, "The lid will cave in."

Malati would say, "Will such a heavy trunk cave in under me?"

Time passed.

The sewing machine was replaced by a new one. The children grew up. A wooden cupboard came into the house.

The red trunk moved from the veranda into the inner room.

In Malati's memory, the trunk gradually became "Nani's sewing trunk."

In Janaki Devi's memory, it was not merely a sewing trunk.

It was the first clear boundary between her earnings and their account.

In 2003 Malati received an opportunity to stay in Darbhanga for six months for teacher training.

At the time, discussions of Malati's marriage were also under way.

Two or three elders in the family had said, "What will change if she lives away for six months now? If she gets a job after marriage, we will see then."

Malati herself was in two minds.

She wanted the training, but did not quite have the courage to go against what was being said at home.

Janaki Devi gave no speech.

She went into the room, unlocked the red trunk, and began taking everything out.

She tore up most of the old measurement slips.

She placed some account books in the cupboard.

The scissors went into the drawer of the sewing machine.

The needles and thread went into a box.

The trunk became empty.

Malati had asked, "What are you doing?"

Janaki Devi had said, "Put your clothes in it."

Malati did not understand.

"For where?"

"For Darbhanga."

Malati remembered that scene many times.

Every time, it seemed to her that on that day Ma had made the decision to send her for the training.

Fifteen years later, once, Janaki Devi corrected that memory.

"You had already made the decision. I only emptied the trunk."

Malati had laughed then.

But the sentence remained in her mind.

For six months in the Darbhanga hostel, the red trunk stayed beneath Malati's bed.

At that time it contained saris, two salwar-kurta sets, the training booklet, papers on school management, copies of certificates, a steel plate, and two jars of pickle given by Ma.

At night Malati spread books over its lid and studied.

Sometimes the other women staying there sat on it and drank tea.

Once the clasp broke.

Malati paid for a new clasp herself.

After she returned home, the trunk came back into the room.

Now the family story changed.

Someone would say, "This is the trunk Malati took with her when she went for training."

Someone else would say, "Janaki gave her trunk to her daughter."

Janaki Devi would listen.

She made no special effort to correct anyone.

She felt that if the story of an object changed, let it change.

If the object continued to be useful, what was the point of clinging to its old name?

After Rashmi was born, the trunk filled again.

First with small clothes.

Then quilts.

Then school notebooks, clothes worn for festivals, and important papers that had to be kept from getting wet during the rains.

For some years Malati kept the key.

For some years Janaki Devi did.

There also came a time when they stopped locking the trunk altogether.

By then there were enough cupboards in the house.

The red trunk ceased to be the place for necessary things and became the place for things for which no one knew, "Where shall we put this now?"

This was the version of the trunk Rashmi knew best.

Old blankets, a broken umbrella, extra curtains, leftover festooning from a wedding.

So when Janaki Devi said today that Rashmi should take the trunk, Rashmi laughed.

"My tools in this?"

Janaki Devi asked, "Do tools not belong in a trunk?"

"They do. But this is very old."

"Are the tools new?"

"Yes."

"Then the balance is even."

Malati said, "Do you keep answers ready for everything in advance?"

Janaki Devi said, "No. As one grows older, answers grow shorter."

Rashmi tried to open the lock.

The clasp was jammed.

She asked for mustard oil.

Malati said, "See? Buy a new one."

Rashmi applied oil, worked the clasp twice, and it opened.

The lid rose.

At that moment there was nothing valuable inside.

An old cotton quilt.

Two pairs of curtains.

An old attendance register from Malati's school, probably brought home when the service records were being checked.

Janaki Devi's empty box of tailor's chalk.

The paper pinwheel from Rashmi's Class Eight science exhibition.

And a bag of rusted nails and screws.

Rashmi began taking the objects out one by one.

"Shouldn't this register be at the school?" she asked.

Malati was startled.

"Oh! I had been looking for this."

Rashmi laughed. "So the trunk still makes things disappear."

Janaki Devi said, "Not the trunk. People put things away and forget them."

The moment she saw the paper pinwheel, Rashmi fell silent.

She remembered that in Class Eight she had made a model of a wind-driven wheel. A teacher at school had said girls were good at drawing, while boys were quicker with machines.

Rashmi had said nothing then.

After coming home she had asked for Nani's sewing scissors and cut the cardboard herself.

She had won second place at the science exhibition.

The paper pinwheel was now bent.

Janaki Devi asked, "Will you keep this?"

Rashmi looked at it for a long time.

"No."

Malati was surprised. "It is a memory."

"It is a memory. That does not mean the object has to be kept."

Rashmi separated the paper from the pinwheel because it could be reused. The broken bamboo stick went into the rubbish basket outside.

Janaki Devi watched closely.

"You are doing the right thing," she said.

Malati asked, "You don't feel bad?"

"Why?"

"She threw away an old thing."

Janaki Devi said, "I tore up my own measurement slips. Their work was finished."

The afternoon moved slowly towards evening.

The three women continued sorting what had been inside the trunk.

The quilt went to the roof to see the sun.

The curtains went into the washing pile.

The attendance register went into Malati's files.

Janaki Devi placed the empty chalk box beside her sewing box.

Half the nails and screws were rusted; the usable pieces were separated out.

The trunk was empty again.

Rashmi ran her hand along the inside.

At the bottom, most of the red colour remained.

She said, "Nani, your trunk is still red inside."

Janaki Devi replied, "Less sunlight reaches the inside."

Malati said, "And outside?"

"The colour outside does the work of being outside."

Rashmi laughed.

The next day she went to the market.

When she returned, she was carrying three bags of tools.

Malati asked, "Will all of this go in there?"

"Yes."

One bag contained a wire tester, pliers, a small cutter, and screwdrivers.

The second contained rubber gloves, insulating tape, extra wire, and small spare parts.

The third contained a receipt book, a register for customers' names, and an account book for expenses.

Janaki Devi smiled the moment she saw the account book.

"This is the most important one."

Rashmi asked, "More than the tools?"

"The tools will tell you what has gone wrong. The accounts will tell you where your work is going."

Malati said, "And the training certificate?"

Rashmi put a copy into a flat folder and stood it along one side of the trunk.

Malati said softly, "In my time, the certificate stayed in the middle."

Rashmi asked, "Why?"

"Because I thought it was the most important thing."

Janaki Devi looked at Malati.

"At that time, it was important."

Malati nodded.

The trunk filled up.

But this time it was being filled differently.

Rashmi placed the heavier tools at the bottom, the papers above them, cloth in one corner, and tied a small fabric pouch inside the lid for the key and loose change.

Watching her, Janaki Devi said, "I used to keep money there too."

Rashmi stopped.

"Really?"

"Yes. Later I learned that money and the key should not be kept in the same place."

Rashmi burst out laughing. "That lesson should have come earlier."

"Some lessons do not come free with a trunk."

Malati laughed too.

That evening two women from the neighbourhood came to see Janaki Devi.

The moment one of them saw the red trunk in the veranda, she said, "Oh, isn't this Janaki Didi's sewing trunk?"

Malati said, "Yes, the same one."

Rashmi was closing the lid.

Janaki Devi said, "It is not a sewing trunk now."

The woman asked, "Then what is it?"

Rashmi answered, "Now it is my work trunk."

There was less pride than information in her voice.

Janaki Devi liked that.

After dinner that night, Malati was about to hand Rashmi the key to the trunk.

Janaki Devi stopped her.

"That is the old key. Put on a new lock."

Rashmi asked, "Is the old lock bad?"

"No. Everyone knows where the key used to be kept."

Malati laughed. "See? The real story of the trunk is the lock."

Janaki Devi said, "No."

"Then what?"

Janaki Devi was silent for a while.

Then she said, "The story is that what is kept inside can change every time."

Rashmi looked at the trunk.

She thought - for Nani it had held measurements, earnings, and accounts.

For Ma, travel, study, and preparation for work.

For herself, tools, spare parts, and a customer register.

The same trunk.

Three different needs.

But she immediately understood that this summary too was not the whole truth.
 Nani's trunk had once held a quilt as well.
 Ma's trunk had contained jars of pickle.
 And perhaps tomorrow her own trunk would hold something she could not imagine today.
 Objects do not exist in order to become simple symbols of a life.
 Sometimes they are only objects.
 And perhaps that is precisely why their stories endure.
 The next morning Rashmi began cleaning the trunk.
 She did not try to scrub away all the rust from the outside.
 Where the metal had weakened, she applied oil.
 She placed two thin strips of wood underneath so that damp from the ground would not touch it directly.
 She fitted a new lock.
 Malati came out and said, "You won't repaint it?"
 Rashmi looked at the trunk's faded red colour.
 "Not now."
 "Why?"
 "The colour isn't bad. It is simply old."
 From inside Janaki Devi called out, "There is a difference between the two."
 In the afternoon a small vehicle came to carry the trunk.
 Rashmi and the driver lifted it together.
 When Malati came to help, Rashmi said, "I can lift it."
 Malati did not remove her hand.
 For a moment the trunk rose into the air, held from three sides.
 Janaki Devi sat on the low seat and watched.
 Rashmi laughed and said, "Nani, aren't empty things supposed not to be heavy?"
 Janaki Devi laughed too.
 "Where is it empty now?"
 The trunk was placed in the vehicle.
 Rashmi tugged the lock once to check it.
 At the gate Malati asked, "What will you tell people about whose trunk this was?"
 Before answering, Rashmi looked at the trunk.
 "If anyone asks, I will say - first it was used for Nani's work, then for yours, and now for mine."
 Malati said, "And the family's trunk?"
 Rashmi smiled.
 "Calling it the family's would make someone's work smaller."
 Janaki Devi was listening from a distance.
 She nodded.
 The vehicle drove away.
 The red trunk was leaving the courtyard for another place for the third time.
 The first time, it had held measurements and needles and thread.
 The second time, books and certificates.
 This time, wires, tools, and an account book.
 The trunk did not know which object was memory and which was the future.

It simply kept safe whatever was placed inside it.
And three generations, each in their own time, kept changing what it meant.

The Music Teacher

That day, on the third floor of the Women's Skills Centre, the final practical examination for the electrical-repair course was being held.

Nalini Jha had been in the building since half past eight that morning.

She was the head of the centre, but on examination days her work mostly consisted of checking papers, obtaining the inspectors' signatures, and finding solutions whenever some arrangement stalled.

By ten o'clock, the first two groups had entered the examination room.

The practice boards were fixed to the wall at the same height.

The wires, connectors, switches, test lamps, and tools had all been counted beforehand.

Outside in the corridor, the women trainees waited for their turns.

Nalini first noticed a problem when Shabnam Khatoon, in the third group, stood before her practice board.

Shabnam was short.

She could raise her hand above her head, but she could not comfortably reach the upper connection on the board.

She rose onto her toes and began the task.

Twice, a tool slipped from her hand.

The external examiner, Arun Babu, looked at the clock.

"The time is running," he said.

Shabnam nodded and rose onto her toes again.

Nalini stood near the door.

At first, it seemed to her merely an inconvenience.

Then the trainer, Rita, came up to her and said softly, "Nalini ji, shall we put a wooden platform underneath?"

Arun Babu heard her.

"The examination arrangement should be the same for everyone," he said.

Rita fell silent.

Nalini said nothing either.

Her eyes went to Shabnam's heels.

Again and again, the heels left the floor.

At that moment, she remembered a harmonium from thirty years earlier.

Light from the window used to fall across its black polish.

She had been sixteen then.

In the small room at Sharda Di's house, four girls practised one after another.

Nalini kept trying to reach the highest notes.

The effort arose less from her own desire than from comparison.

Her cousin Meenu could reach the upper notes with ease.

People at home used to say, "Meenu's voice opens beautifully."

By hearing this again and again, Nalini had come to believe that good singing meant reaching higher.

Sharda Di had never said that.

One winter, Nalini's voice began to change.

Notes that had once come easily began to tremble midway.

When she climbed higher, the sound grew thin and broke.

Nalini increased her practice.

The harder she pushed, the more tired her throat became.

One evening, Sharda Di stopped the harmonium.

"Enough for today," she said.

Nalini felt humiliated.

"I'll do it again," she said.

"Again tomorrow."

"Once more now."

Sharda Di looked at her face.

"Are you trying to find the note, or your old voice?"

Nalini did not understand the question.

Sharda Di changed the harmonium key.

Then she began a simple alap in a lower pitch than before.

Nalini began to sing.

This time, the note did not break.

She felt more anger than relief.

"So I am singing lower now?"

Sharda Di did not laugh.

"You are singing in your own voice."

"But this wasn't the key before."

"Your voice wasn't where it is now before either."

Nalini fell silent.

Sharda Di placed a hand on the harmonium lid.

"The instrument is for the person," she said, "not the person for the instrument."

Then she added, "The note must stay true; the key can change."

That day, Nalini understood only half of what the sentence meant.

It seemed to her that Sharda Di was relaxing the rules merely to spare her feelings.

After returning home she told Ma, "Sharda Di has moved me down to a lower key."

Ma said, "So?"

"Meenu sings higher."

Stirring the dal, Ma said, "Meenu is Meenu. You are you."

That answer did not satisfy Nalini either.

At that age, comparison feels like fact.

For the next three months she practised in the new key.

Her voice slowly became steady.

But as examinations drew near, her studies increased and the time for music diminished.

After she went to college, regular lessons stopped.

She also went to Sharda Di's house less often.

A few years later, work, marriage, children, transfers, and household duties entered her life.

Music did not leave her life in any tragic fashion.

It simply slipped gradually to the edge, the way many things do.

Sometimes, when she sang at a wedding, people would say, "You have been trained."

Nalini would laugh.

"A very long time ago."

Sharda Di's sentence remained in her memory, but not like a rule.

Sometimes only when she saw a harmonium.

Sometimes while talking with Meenu about old days.

Sometimes when her own daughter stopped singing in adolescence.

Nalini did not force her daughter to continue.

Even then, she did not know whether that decision came from Sharda Di's influence or merely from the leniency of a tired mother.

Years passed.

Nalini went for teacher training.

She first taught in a school.

After that, she moved into administration at the skills centre.

She liked rules.

Clear rules especially.

Because clear rules leave less room for argument.

How much attendance was required, how long the examination would last, how many tools there would be, how the marks would be divided - when everything was written down, work became easier.

Nalini had long taken that ease for justice.

Sometimes it was justice.

Sometimes it was not.

She understood the difference only gradually.

Once, a trainee had been absent for three days because her child was ill.

Nalini had issued a warning according to the rules.

Later she felt some guilt, but she did not withdraw the warning.

Another time, a trainer had asked for different timings for different students.

Nalini had refused - "There will be one rule for everyone."

At the time, the sentence had seemed right to her.

Today, as she watched Shabnam's heels, that same sentence sounded again.

"The examination arrangement should be the same for everyone."

Arun Babu said again, "If we give her a platform, the others will ask for one too."

Nalini turned towards him.

"If someone else needs one, we will give it to her too."

Arun Babu frowned.

"Then where is the equality?"

Before answering, Nalini looked at Shabnam.

Shabnam was not taking part in the conversation.

She was trying to tighten the end of a wire while standing on her toes.

Suddenly Nalini saw Sharda Di's hand on the harmonium key.

The memory was not clear like a picture.
 Only the movement of a hand, the black polish, and a fragment of a sentence.
 The instrument is for the person.
 Nalini said to Rita, "Bring the wooden platform."
 Arun Babu was about to say something.
 Nalini added, "The measure of the work, the time, and the marks will remain the same. Only the reach will change."
 "That is not written in the rules."
 "Nor is it prohibited in the rules."
 Nalini had not thought out that answer beforehand.
 It came into being at that moment.
 Rita brought a broad wooden platform.
 Nalini checked its stability.
 Two trainers pressed it from both sides to make sure it did not wobble.
 Then Shabnam stood on it.
 Now her elbow was at a comfortable height.
 Nalini looked at the clock.
 The time spent in the discussion was not counted as part of Shabnam's examination time.
 Arun Babu agreed to that.
 The examination began again.
 Shabnam did not hurry.
 She first switched off the main supply, then checked the wire connections, and only after that completed the circuit.
 At one point, she made a mistake.
 The test lamp did not light.
 She opened the connection again and corrected it.
 Nalini went outside.
 She felt no anxiety to know the result.
 Her decision had not been to make Shabnam pass.
 It had been only to give her an equal opportunity to reach the work.
 She heard that distinction clearly inside herself.
 At lunch, Rita asked, "How did you decide so quickly?"
 Nalini went on mixing dal into her rice.
 "Not quickly," she said.
 "Then?"
 "It took thirty years."
 Rita laughed.
 "What?"
 Nalini smiled too.
 "Nothing. I remembered something old."
 She did not explain further.
 She herself still had to put the whole story together.
 After returning home that evening, Nalini had no reason to open the old cupboard, yet she opened it.
 She was not looking for any old music files.

Nor did she remember any written advice from Sharda Di.
She only wanted to see whether the old harmonium was still there.
The harmonium was not there.

A few years after Nalini's marriage, Ma had sent it to Meenu's house.
Nalini knew this, but had forgotten it while opening the cupboard.
She was about to close the cupboard when she saw an old cloth bag on the upper shelf.

Inside it were some song sheets, two thin books, and a small notebook of musical notation.

On the first page of the notebook was Sharda Di's handwriting.

"Vocal range changed."

That was all.

No philosophy.

No grand sentence.

Nalini sat for a while with the notebook in her hand.

She remembered her anger at sixteen.

At the time, it had seemed to her that the teacher was reducing her ability.

Thirty years later, she understood - Sharda Di had changed not the ability, but the measure.

Nalini knew that even this understanding required caution.

Changing every rule to suit every person is not justice.

Some rules preserve the truth of the task.

The note must remain true.

But the key need not be the same.

The examination ended the next day.

Shabnam's result was slightly above average.

She lost marks on one question, made two connections cleanly, and followed the safety procedure fully.

Nalini signed the result sheet.

When Shabnam met her outside, she folded her hands and said, "Thank you for the platform yesterday."

Nalini said, "It was an examination-room arrangement, not a favour."

Shabnam probably did not think about the significance of that sentence.

She walked towards the next room where certificates were being processed.

Nalini did not stop her.

That afternoon Nalini called an administrative meeting.

This time the subject was not Shabnam alone.

She proposed a checklist for every practical room: adjustable and fixed heights, lighting, seating arrangements, and access to tools.

Arun Babu was not present.

Rita was.

Rita asked, "Will all the tables be changed?"

Nalini said, "Where necessary, the arrangement will change. The measure of the work will not."

In the meeting record, the reason for the decision was written in two lines.

Sharda Di's name was not there.

Nor was there any mention of music.

Nalini felt that was right.

Influence does not always travel with a name attached.

Sometimes a student forgets a small adjustment made by a teacher.

Then, years later, the hand remembers it before making a decision.

That night Nalini placed the old notation notebook back in the cupboard.

She did not sit down to sing.

Nor did she want to turn Sharda Di's sentence into a principle for life.

She understood only this much: thirty years earlier, a teacher had changed the key on a harmonium.

And today, in an examination room, Nalini had allowed a wooden platform to be placed.

The two events were not the same.

But there was a subtle note between them.

After all these years, she heard that note clearly for the first time.

A Separate Road

1986

It was the last week of Bhadon. The result slips had already been distributed in the courtyard of Simraha High School.

Malati and Sushma stood in the shade of a neem tree, looking again and again at their respective papers.

Their marks were almost the same.

But the road ahead was not.

Malati had applied to study electrical drafting at the Government Polytechnic Training Institute in Barauni.

Sushma was thinking of enrolling in the Commerce College in Darbhanga.

The school headmaster said to Malati's father, "Will you send a girl so far away?"

Malati wanted to answer the question herself, but her father spoke first. "Let us see. We will discuss it at home."

Sushma's mother, on the other hand, was worried that travelling to Darbhanga and back every day would waste too much time.

She said, "It would be good if she could get a hostel place."

The concerns of the two families were different, but both girls understood the same thing - adults discussed the future as though it were a length of cloth measured in someone's hand.

That afternoon, while returning from school, the two of them left the unpaved path on the western side of the pond and took the newly built paved road.

"Will you go?" Sushma asked.

"If they send me," Malati said.

"And if they don't?"

"Then there will be another road."

Sushma laughed. "Where do roads appear so quickly?"

Malati laughed too. "If one is not found, one will be made."

At the time, the sentence sounded very brave to both of them.

Three months later, Malati left for Barauni.

Sushma did not get hostel accommodation. She began commuting to Darbhanga every day for her studies.

In the first year, the two wrote to each other regularly.

In the second year, the letters became fewer.

In the third, both became busy with their own examinations.

The friendship did not end.

Only its daily form did.

Twelve years later, the two spent two hours together again at the paddy procurement centre in Simraha.

Malati was now a drafting assistant in the State Electricity Department. Her posting had already changed across three districts.

This time she had come to the village for her mother's eye treatment.

She stopped for a moment when she saw Sushma.

They had continued to meet after school, but every meeting had been brief - at weddings, funerals, festivals, or for half an hour in the middle of a train journey.

Today, for the first time, they stood face to face in a place of work.

Sushma was counting sacks of paddy.

She was doing temporary accounts work at the centre.

After graduating from Darbhanga, she had married in Madhubani. Two years later her husband had gone to work in a factory in Punjab.

Sushma too had lived in Ludhiana for some time.

Malati was surprised by this.

In her mind, an old picture of Sushma's life had formed - village, Darbhanga, marriage, home.

Ludhiana was not in that picture.

"You have travelled to so many places!" Malati said.

Sushma smiled. "I did not travel. I lived there. There is a difference."

Malati understood at once that the sentence was not a light one.

Sushma had lived in Punjab for three years. Her child had been born there. Her husband worked the night shift. During the day she did small bookkeeping jobs with women from other labouring families - who had received how much wages, whose advance had been deducted, whose pay was short.

"I had studied commerce," Sushma said. "For the first time there I understood that addition and subtraction were not only for examinations."

"Then why did you come back?"

"Babu fell ill. There was no one to look after the shop accounts. My husband there, me here. Now life is in two places."

Malati felt ashamed of her question.

She had assumed that when someone who lived away returned to the village, there must have been some defeat behind it.

She herself worked away from home, yet somewhere inside she had carried that simple arithmetic.

Sushma pointed towards a sack of paddy.

"Look at this. It is marked as fifty kilos, but the scale shows forty-seven."

Malati bent down and looked at the scale.

"The scale could be wrong."

"So could the sack."

They both laughed.

But for the next half-hour Malati checked the scale's joints, wires, and balance.

The fault turned out to be simple - one screw was loose.

Sushma told the centre supervisor, "From now on, everything will be weighed again."

The supervisor's face fell.

"All those sacks again?"

"As many as may have been weighed incorrectly."

At that moment Malati saw Sushma less as her old friend and more as a strict keeper of accounts standing in the middle of her work.

While returning that afternoon, Sushma asked, "Is your job going well?"

Malati wanted to give an easy answer.

Then she stopped.

"It is going. But for the next promotion there is a possibility I will have to move to Patna. I am not sure."

"But you used to like living away from home."

Malati laughed.

"What rule says that what I liked at eighteen must still be the same at thirty?"

This time Sushma fell silent.

Both of them suddenly laughed at their own old assumptions.

2011

Thirteen years later, their roads met again at a turn neither of them had foreseen.

Malati had not accepted the promotion.

She did not go to Patna.

Her mother's care, her husband's work, her daughter Ananya's studies - there were three reasons, but no single one was the whole answer.

She had applied for a posting in Darbhanga and eventually moved there.

In the meantime, Sushma had handed over the Simraha shop to her younger brother.

Her daughter Nidhi had gone to Pune for higher studies, and her husband had left Punjab to take a job in a private factory in Rajasthan.

This time Sushma was living with her husband near Jaipur.

In June, the two met in the veranda of a clinic in Darbhanga.

Malati had come for her mother's routine check-up.

Sushma had brought her mother-in-law for a knee examination.

They saw each other and laughed again.

"Why do we always meet in the middle of work?" Sushma asked.

"Because work is a large part of life," Malati said.

Hearing the answer, Sushma looked at her closely.

"You did not speak like this before."

"Before, I used to think a job and life were separate things."

"And now?"

"Now I understand that a job is one piece of life. Housework too. Caregiving too. Travel too. Some pieces are paid for; some are not."

Sushma said softly, "I understood that in Punjab."

Malati smiled. "It took me longer."

That day, for the first time, an old uncomfortable matter also emerged between them.

Sushma said, "Once you told me I had wasted my education."

Malati was startled.

"Me?"

"Before the year at the paddy centre. At some wedding. You said, 'You studied so well, and ended up doing nothing beyond household accounts.'"

Malati's face grew hot.

She did not remember the sentence.

But she could easily believe that she might have said it.

"Forgive me," she said.

Sushma immediately raised a hand. "I did not say it as a complaint. I was very angry then. Later, in Punjab, I wrote down workers' wages, managed Babu's shop, worked at the paddy centre. Now from home in Jaipur I keep the accounts of two small units. Whether my education was wasted or useful cannot be answered in one line."

Malati said, "When I gave up the promotion, some people at the office said, 'After studying so much, she still stopped because of family.' Perhaps that was the day I understood what you meant."

Sushma laughed. "So the accounts are even?"

"No," Malati said. "The accounts do not need to be even."

The clinic assistant called Sushma's name.

She stood up.

As she walked away, she turned and asked, "You did not go to Patna - do you regret it?"

Malati did not answer.

Sushma did not wait for an answer either.

Some questions do not find their answer on the day they are asked.

2026

In Simraha, the old paddy procurement centre had now become a rural enterprise training room.

In one corner inside, the old weighing scale still lay there, but it was no longer in use.

A new scale gleamed on the other side.

Malati was now past sixty. After retirement, she divided her time between Darbhanga and Simraha.

Sushma too did not live permanently in any one place. A few months in Jaipur, a few with her daughter in Pune, a few in Simraha.

The director of the rural enterprise centre had invited both of them to speak with adolescent girls.

The topic was - "Education and the Roads of Life."

Malati smiled when she read the topic.

Sushma said, "Roads again!"

There were fifteen girls in the room. Some were learning sewing, some electrical repair, some computerised accounting, some were preparing for competitive examinations.

The first question came from a girl named Kajal.

"You are both from the same village. Then how did your lives become so different?"

The director looked towards Malati for an answer.

Malati looked towards Sushma.

Sushma was looking at the old scale.

"Different?" she asked softly.

Kajal laughed. "I mean - one of you was in a government job, and the other in business accounts."

Sushma said, "Those are the final labels. Where did all the labels in between go?"

The room fell silent.

Malati leaned forward in her chair.

"I went away to study. Then I lived in many places because of my job. Then I returned to Darbhanga because of Ma. I gave up a promotion. After retirement, I again live between two places."

Sushma added, "I studied in Darbhanga. After marriage I went to Punjab. Then I returned to the village. Then I went to Rajasthan. Now I live between three places."

Kajal asked, "Then which decision was the right one?"

The two looked at each other again.

Malati remembered the shade of the neem tree in 1986.

'If one is not found, one will be made' - she recalled her old sentence.

Now the sentence seemed incomplete to her.

A road is not only something one makes.

Sometimes a road closes.

Sometimes another person's needs change its direction.

Sometimes one has to return to a road one thought one had left.

Sometimes a decision that looks like regret at one time becomes relief at another.

And sometimes even a good decision has difficult consequences.

Malati told Kajal, "I cannot give you a list of right decisions."

Sushma said, "But we can give you a list of wrong questions."

Laughter spread through the room.

"Such as?" another girl asked.

Sushma began counting on her fingers. "Who went away? Who stayed in the village? Who earned more? Who got a higher post? Who married early? With these questions, the account of a life gets made far too quickly."

Malati said, "And in an account made too quickly, many lines are left out."

The director asked, "Then how do you see your own lives?"

This time neither answered immediately.

Outside, a goods vehicle passed along the newly paved road.

The wall of the old paddy centre trembled slightly.

Sushma stood and walked over to the old scale in the corner.

"Do you remember this scale?" she asked Malati.

Malati laughed. "One of its screws was loose."

"And I had thought the sack was wrong."

"Either was possible."

Sushma ran her hand over the dust on the scale.

"That is it. In life's accounts too, we often decide too quickly whether the scale is wrong or the sack."

Malati said, "And sometimes both are right; it is simply a different thing that is being measured."

Kajal began writing the sentence in her notebook.

Malati stopped her.

“You do not need to write that sentence. Write your own question.”

Kajal smiled and closed the notebook.

After the meeting ended, Malati and Sushma went outside.

In front of the centre, the road ran in two directions.

One side led towards the main market, the other towards the new settlement across the canal.

Sushma asked, “Which way are you going?”

Malati said, “Towards the market today. And you?”

“Across the canal.”

For a few moments, both stood there.

In 1986, such a moment might have made each of them see her road as a declaration of the future.

In 2026, it was only today's direction.

Malati started walking her way.

Sushma went the other.

Neither turned back.

Because walking on separate roads was not against friendship.

And the question of which road was permanent had long since grown old for both of them.

The Lost Year

On a Sunday in the month of Bhadon in 2026, Anima Jha sat at the dining table with her granddaughter Aditi, old papers spread before them.

Aditi had been given an assignment at school to make “My Family Timeline”.

She had drawn a straight line on coloured paper and was making small circles along it, writing years inside them.

“Nani, when were you born?”

Anima told her the year.

“College?”

She remembered that too.

“First job?”

She remembered even the date.

“Mummy’s birth?”

Anima laughed. “How could I forget that?”

Aditi went on writing.

Then she asked, “What shall I write from 1998 to 2003?”

Anima opened her mouth to answer at once, but no words came.

Five years.

It was not that she remembered nothing at all from those five years.

She remembered the small rented house, whose kitchen was so cramped that if two people stood in it together, a third had to remain outside.

She remembered her daughter Nilima’s two plaits, the cloth at the knees of her son Saurabh’s trousers forever tearing, the school bell, the smell of buckets of milk in the mornings.

But if someone had asked what happened in 1999, what changed in 2000, which day in 2001 had been special, memory would grow hazy.

All the days seemed like separate pieces of the same long day.

“Write—work,” Anima said at last.

Aditi burst out laughing. “Five years of nothing but work?”

“Perhaps.”

“Something must have happened.”

Anima looked at the paper.

“A great deal must have happened. But I do not remember it separately.”

Aditi shaded those five years a pale grey.

Anima did not stop her hand.

In 1998, Anima was thirty-six.

She taught mathematics at a girls’ school in town. At that time, Devendra’s work required him to stay away from home for ten or fifteen days each month.

Nilima was nine and Saurabh five.

On the open ground in front of the rented house, women who brought milk from the surrounding villages would set down their buckets and sit there early every morning.

A private trader's vehicle came at seven to weigh the milk.

One day the trader did not come.

The next day too he was late.

By the third day, the milk belonging to five women had spoiled.

That evening, their neighbour Kamla Devi came to Anima's door.

"Didi, you understand accounts. We cannot make sense of what these people deduct when they weigh the milk."

At the time Anima was checking Nilima's homework, dal was on the stove, and Saurabh was crying because his pencil had broken.

She said, "Bring the papers tomorrow. I'll have a look."

That was all.

She remembered that for several months, by around five each morning, five or seven women would gather near her veranda.

How much milk each had brought, the fat content, the rate, the deduction—Anima entered it all in a thick register.

What happened to that register afterwards, she did not remember clearly.

Whether the women gradually learned to read the figures themselves, who kept the register, whether the trader changed or the rules did—every memory had merged into the next.

She remembered only the cold floor in the morning and the warm vapour rising from the milk.

In 1999, the number of days Devendra spent away increased.

Before leaving for school, Anima packed the children's food, checked the milk accounts, braided Nilima's hair, searched for Saurabh's socks, and very often left her own tea to grow cold.

No birthday from that year stood out clearly.

No festival stood out clearly.

Sometimes she felt that memory too was a privilege of the well-off—those who had time could give each day a separate name.

When one day lay piled upon another, all that remained in memory was the year.

In 2000, the rent went up.

She remembered this because that day, for the first time, she had written out a complete account of her salary on paper.

House rent, school fees, provisions, Devendra's travel, medicine, milk, electricity.

The amount left at the end was so small that she folded the paper and put it away.

But where that paper went, she did not remember.

In 2001, Nilima went alone by city bus to her music class for the first time.

Nilima reminded Anima of the incident many years later.

"For three days you made me memorise the entire bus route," Nilima had said.

All Anima remembered was telling the girl, "If you get off at the wrong place, don't panic. First read the name of the place."

Nilima had laughed. "I still remember the whole sentence."

Anima had been astonished.

For her, those five years were a blur; for Nilima, there were many clear lines within that blur.

By the end of 2003, the family had moved into a small house of their own.

The rented house was left behind.

So too was the veranda where the women who brought milk used to gather.

Anima thought that perhaps those five years had stayed behind there as well.

Time moved on.

In 2008, Nilima was preparing to go to another city for higher studies.

Devendra had said, "She will be living so far away on her own for the first time.

Go with her for a few days."

Anima too wanted to agree.

Nilima smiled and said, "I'll manage. You taught me how to find my way long ago."

Anima did not immediately understand what her daughter meant.

Then Nilima told her the story of the bus journey in 2001.

"You told me that if I could not remember the route, I should read the names, ask people, and if I got on the wrong bus, get off and catch another. Getting on the wrong bus is not the end of life."

Anima laughed.

"Did I really say something so weighty?"

"It wasn't weighty for you. It was for me."

That day, for the first time, Anima thought that memory was not only what survived within oneself.

Some memories are stored in other people.

In 2011, Anima injured the wrist of her right hand.

For four weeks, she was told not to do heavy work.

Saurabh was in college then.

He came home during the holidays and, without making much of it, took charge of the kitchen.

On the first day he put too much water in the rice, on the second the dal turned out well, and from the third day onwards he began making the market list himself too.

One evening Anima asked, "Who taught you to do so much?"

Saurabh laughed. "You did."

"Me?"

"In that rented house. You used to say that if Nilima could stand by the stove, why couldn't I? First you let me wash the potatoes, then pick over the rice."

The scene did not return clearly to Anima.

She remembered a small steel plate that Saurabh sometimes beat like a drum.

Perhaps he had washed potatoes in that plate as well.

"I don't remember that at all," she said.

Saurabh replied easily, "I do."

That day, for the second time, Anima understood that people do not preserve every lesson of their lives within themselves.

Some lessons remain in the hands of those who have received them.

In 2014, after a programme at the school, Anima was walking towards the market.

A middle-aged woman called from across the road, “Anima Didi!”

It was Kamla Devi.

Her hair had begun to grey, but her laugh was just as it had been before.

Kamla took her to the small milk-collection centre she now ran.

There were two new weighing scales, a refrigerated chest, and the rates were written on the wall.

Kamla said, “Do you remember the register on your veranda?”

Anima said, “A little.”

“I remember it very well.”

Kamla told her that because of that register, they had understood for the first time how much the trader was deducting, which deductions were genuine and which were arbitrary.

“But I was the one who wrote the register,” Anima said.

“At first. Later you said—why should we keep our own accounts in someone else’s hands?”

Anima did not remember saying this.

Kamla laughed. “You have forgotten. I haven’t.”

Four women’s names were written on the wall of the centre.

Kamla had written her own name herself.

No old scene suddenly returned to Anima in its entirety.

Neither the veranda came clearly into view nor the sequence of the years.

She understood only this: those five years had not been empty.

Within that haze, some people had begun learning to sign their own names.

In 2019, while sorting old papers one evening, Devendra said, “Those five years were the worst years of my working life.”

Anima asked, “The worst?”

“I was away all the time. I saw nothing of the children. I left the burden of the house on you.”

Anima remained silent for a while.

At first she thought hearing this admission would bring her some satisfaction.

But it did not.

“The whole burden was not on me,” she said.

Devendra looked at her.

“Kamla and the others came every morning. Usha next door took Saurabh to the doctor twice. Nilima did a great deal even though she was small. Shashi Didi at the school took my classes for two days. You sent money from wherever you were. I did not keep everything going alone.”

As she recited the list, Anima herself was surprised.

People were returning to her memory, not events.

The timeline of those five years was still hazy, but the relationships within it were slowly becoming visible.

Devendra said, “Then perhaps the two of us have been giving those years the wrong names.”

“What names?”

"I used to call them 'my bad job years'. You call them 'the lost years'."

Anima smiled.

"Giving things names is easy."

At the dining table in 2026, Aditi had finished shading the years grey.

She asked, "Nani, what should I write now?"

Anima looked at the paper for a long time.

On the timeline, there were five small sections from 1998 to 2003.

Within them were the milk register, Nilima's first bus journey alone, the torn knees of Saurabh's trousers, Devendra's work away from home, Kamla's signature, Usha's help, Shashi Didi's two classes.

But Anima still could not place all of them, year by year, in their exact positions.

She took the pencil from Aditi.

Across the grey strip she wrote, "A great deal happened in between; little is remembered."

Aditi asked, "Is that the right answer?"

"For me."

"But school wants events."

Anima laughed.

"Then write two events. Nilima's bus journey and the milk accounts."

"And the rest?"

"Leave the rest blank."

Aditi was startled. "Blank?"

"Yes. A blank space does not always mean an empty life."

After thinking for a moment, Aditi made only two small symbols in those five sections.

A bus.

A milk bucket.

The three sections in between remained grey.

Anima looked at those blank spaces.

They no longer made her uneasy as they once had.

She understood now that memory is not a court record.

It does not mark the attendance of every day.

Some years survive as shining events.

Some years turn into people's habits.

Some years survive in another person's courage.

Some years dissolve into the fatigue of one's own body.

And some years are understood only much later—they were not lost; their days simply did not ask for separate names.

Aditi was gathering up the timeline.

Anima looked once more at the five grey sections.

She did not turn them white.

She kept as much as memory gave her.

She left the rest of their meaning with the people who had carried some part of those five years within themselves and moved on.

The Final Journey

As the evening train pulled out of Darbhanga, Shashiprabha placed a hand against the window glass. The glass was cold. The light outside was slowly slipping backwards.

She was seventy-four, yet on a train journey she still counted her belongings herself—a cloth bag, a small handbag, a bottle of water, her medicine box, and a printed copy of her ticket.

Her son had said, “Ma, why did you come alone? I could have come to fetch you.”

She had replied, “What would be the point of coming to fetch me? Would the train leave from Darbhanga or from Delhi?”

Her son had laughed and fallen silent.

This time she was going to Delhi. The plan was to spend two or three winter months with her son. The house in Darbhanga was not shut up; a student tenant lived in the rear room, and her neighbour Sunaina kept an eye on the front courtyard.

Even so, when the neighbours saw her off, they behaved as though this were some momentous departure.

Sunaina asked three times, “Didi, you will come back, won’t you?”

Shashiprabha had replied, with a trace of irritation, “Delhi is not a foreign country.”

Now, after the train had started, the same question sounded again inside her—You will come back, won’t you?

She looked out of the window.

Beside a railway line, one sees the backs of houses first: someone’s kitchen, someone’s line of drying clothes, someone’s half-built roof. A house shows its face to the road; from a train, one usually sees its back.

Shashiprabha had always liked that.

It was as though the railway were saying—a house does not have only one form.

Before they reached Samastipur, the darkness had thickened. A young woman in the seat opposite was feeding milk to her small child. Again and again the child reached towards the glass.

“His first train journey?” Shashiprabha asked.

The young woman smiled. “For him, yes. Not for me.”

The answer brought Shashiprabha’s own first journey back to her.

She had been eighteen that day.

On the third day after her wedding, when she left her mother’s courtyard, there were so many people around that Shashiprabha could hardly hear even her own crying. Someone was wiping her eyes with the end of her sari, someone was counting bundles, someone was saying, “It is time,” someone else, “Help her aboard carefully.”

Her mother, Kaushalya Devi, spoke least of all.

Only once did she lean close to her daughter's ear and say, "You are going to someone else's home; take your own good sense with you."

At the time the sentence had seemed harsh to Shashiprabha.

She had wanted her mother to say, "Come back soon," "Do not leave me," "The house will be empty without you."

But her mother said none of those things.

The train moved. Shashiprabha put her hand out through the window. Her mother receded into the distance.

Everyone had called that journey a "farewell."

Six months later, Shashiprabha returned to her mother's home.

The courtyard was just as it had been. The same brass lota stood on the rim of the well. Her mother was winnowing paddy at dawn just as before.

The first thing her mother said on seeing her was, "Why have you grown so thin?"

Shashiprabha burst out laughing.

Then she understood—the day on which there had been so much weeping had not been the end of anything.

After that, journeys to her mother's home became ordinary. Sawan, Chhath, the birth of a child, someone's illness, someone's wedding. Sometimes two days, sometimes two weeks.

Once her mother had joked, "Your farewell took place on your wedding day, yet look at you—you arrive three times a year with your luggage."

The child in the compartment was asleep now. The young woman laid a thin cloth over his head.

Shashiprabha closed her eyes.

Another journey returned to her.

Rachna, her daughter, was fifteen. She had been admitted to a residential school in Patna.

Rachna had said, "I can manage on my own."

All the way, Shashiprabha kept checking her bag again and again—exercise books, clothes, oil, towel, needle and thread, medicines.

Rachna had said irritably, "Ma, everything is there."

At the school gate, Rachna went inside. Once, she turned and waved.

Suddenly Shashiprabha remembered her own farewell at eighteen.

She had thought—the house will change now.

The house did change.

But not in the way she had imagined.

When Rachna came home for the holidays, five new habits came back with her: leaving books spread about, reading late into the night, folding her own clothes, and not immediately agreeing every time her mother offered advice.

Within three years, Shashiprabha understood that a child going away did not merely mean an emptier house; it also meant a new person returning into it.

Rachna's journey had not been a farewell.

It had been the first lesson in distance.

The train stopped at Samastipur. People got on and off. Cries of tea rose along the platform. Shashiprabha got some hot water.

The young woman opposite asked, "Do you live in Delhi?"

"No. In Darbhanga."

"Then what takes you to Delhi?"

"My son is there. I am going to spend the winter with him."

The young woman smiled. "My mother says the same thing—I'm going for two months—and then stays for four."

Shashiprabha smiled too.

"Mothers stretch time according to their own reckoning."

As soon as she said it, one of Kaushalya Devi's journeys came back to her.

No one had cried over that journey.

No one had even called it a farewell.

Kaushalya Devi's cataracts had worsened. The doctor had advised surgery. Her younger son was living in Delhi then. It was decided that her mother would stay with him for two months, have the treatment, rest, and then return.

Shashiprabha had gone with her to the railway station.

Her mother had not taken her small iron trunk. She had only a cloth bag.

"Should I take the whole house with me for two months?" her mother had said.

Shashiprabha had asked, "You've packed the medicines?"

"Yes."

"The warm blanket?"

"Yes."

"The key?"

"Sunaina has the other key. Open the house from time to time while I'm away."

When her mother said "the house", its meaning was perfectly clear—the house with that courtyard, the tulsi altar beside the well, the house where in Magh the cot was moved to catch the sun, where in the rains the roof of the northern room leaked.

Before the train arrived, her mother suddenly said, "There are lentil seeds in the wooden box on the veranda. If I am delayed, give them to Sunaina. What is the point of letting them go to waste?"

Shashiprabha had laughed and said, "You'll be back in two months. Sow them yourself then."

Her mother had laughed too.

"Yes, that is true."

That was all.

No crying.

No crowd.

No word called "farewell".

When the train started, her mother, seated by the window, raised her hand.

Shashiprabha raised hers too.

At that moment her attention was less on her mother's face than on the bag—had she perhaps left the medicines behind in that other bag?

Two months passed.

The surgery went well, but the cold grew harsher. Her younger son said, "It would not be wise for you to return just yet."

Then, around Holi, her mother's knee began to hurt.

After that came the rains.

That year the northern wall of the house at her mother's home became badly damp. The roof needed repairs. The house remained closed for several months.

Kaushalya Devi kept saying, "We'll see next month."

Next month, and then the next.

She did not decide in a single day to settle permanently in Delhi. No one made any announcement.

Things simply began to change places, little by little.

First the medicines.

Then two saris.

Then the small prayer book.

Then the old spectacle case.

Then the brass lota, which Shashiprabha herself carried there on a later journey.

The house at her mother's home continued to be opened, but less often.

From time to time Shashiprabha went there, opened the windows, dusted, checked the grain.

The brass lota was no longer on the rim of the well.

At the time she gave no particular meaning to that small absence.

Kaushalya Devi lived another nine years.

Shashiprabha visited her many times in Delhi. They quarrelled, laughed, exchanged news of people from the old days, argued about Rachna's marriage, disagreed over a granddaughter's name.

In other words, the relationship between mother and daughter had not ended.

But that life at her mother's home—the life in which a daughter could arrive without notice and her mother would open the door from inside—never returned after that train journey.

Shashiprabha understood this only much later.

The train was running through the darkness of night. In the window she could now see more of her own face than of the world outside.

A seventy-four-year-old face.

She thought—people give names in advance to so many journeys.

The journey after a wedding—a farewell.

A child going away—a farewell.

A transfer for work—a farewell.

Retirement—a farewell.

But some true farewells remain silent at the moment they happen.

At the time, the journey looks like nothing more than a journey.

Its meaning is made later.

The young woman opposite woke. The child was still asleep.

"Will your son be at the station?"

"Yes."

"And when will you return to Darbhanga?"

This time Shashiprabha did not immediately say "two months" as she would have before.

She thought for a few moments.

"When I feel like it."

The young woman laughed. "That's a good answer."

Shashiprabha laughed too.

She felt no anxiety about her locked house. Sunaina had the key. The students were in the rear room. Before leaving, she herself had moved the two flowerpots in the courtyard inside.

There was no hurry to decide whether this journey was the last or not.

Before dawn, the train stopped at a small station.

Someone was getting off. Four family members had come as far as the door with an elderly man. Small sentences could be heard—"Phone us," "Take your medicine on time," "Let us know when you arrive."

There was not much weeping in anyone's eyes.

Shashiprabha suddenly sat upright.

She saw again Kaushalya Devi's cloth bag.

The lentil seeds in the box on the veranda.

"I'll be back in two months."

"Yes, that is true."

This time, in memory, she paid attention to her mother's face.

It had not been a sad face.

Kaushalya Devi herself had not known that she was leaving that house for the last time.

Shashiprabha had not known either.

Perhaps that was why the moment had remained so ordinary.

The train began to move again.

Shashiprabha rested her forehead against the window glass.

Many people had cried on her wedding day, but that farewell had not been the last.

Her heart had been heavy when she left Rachna at the hostel, but that had not been the last either.

Today the neighbours had asked again and again, "You will come back, won't you?"—but the future would answer today's question.

The true farewell had been the one no one had called a farewell.

That ordinary journey begun for the treatment of her mother's eyes.

There had been no special photograph of that journey, no ceremony, no final words.

No one had kept the ticket.

But after that day, the door of her mother's home was never again opened from the inside at dawn by her mother's hand.

"One city on the ground, another in people's minds."

FROM "TWO JANAKPURS"

Amresh Jha arrives in Janakpur with a paper map, a brass key with worn teeth, and his mother's last instruction: find her house — or at least the road she walked to school. But the map shows two cities on one page: one drawn in black, and another traced in faint ochre from the memories of those who lived there.

Across ninety-eight stories — of courtrooms and floods, painters and translators, weddings, dry ponds and letters never sent — Gajendra Thakur follows people into the places that survive only in the mind. Mysteries, quiet domestic dramas and parables of a changing Mithila, all pulled towards one question: what is left of a place when the ground has moved?

Translated from the original Maithili by the author himself.

Two Janakpurs · The Forgotten Disputation · The Pond of Time · The Map That Kept Growing · The Translator · The Flood Boat · The Painter's Death · The Old Photograph · The Red Trunk · The Letter That Was Never Sent · The Final Journey



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